



아카데미 자식이 되왔다

올레미 판타지 장편소설

Information

Table of Contents URL: <https://www.lightnovelworld.co/novel/academys-second-seat>

Academy's Second Seat

아카데미 차석이 되었다

Author: [Maemi Yoon](#)

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3.7

305

Chapters

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Academy's Second Seat novel is a popular light novel covering Action, Fantasy, and Harem genres. Written by the Author Maemi Yoon. 305 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

He became the villain in the possessed game, the rival of the main character, and the second seat.

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Tags

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: 1 comment on Chapter 7: Luna Railer (2)

- 4
XEragon
Reader
16d

Read with your brain turned off.

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 1
kraxzzz
Reader
1mo

Any recommendations like this ??

[Reply](#)

0 0

- 1
NikhilGupta
Reader
3mo

Why mc have to follow typical game route this novel literal trash
please don't read it.

[Reply](#)

5 1

- 1
taramAli
Reader
3mo

Boring

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 6
Devilman

Reader
3mo

I just read 10 chapters and I am getting irritated by him continuously putting himself down and making himself look stupid and evil so I just want to know if and when it changes . Someone pls reply to this I can't decide whether I should read this or drop it

[Reply](#)

1 0

◦ 12

RImuru_tempest

[Devilman](#)

Reader

3mo

read this mf... it's good

[Reply](#)

1 2

▪ 6

Devilman

[RImuru_tempest](#)

Reader

3mo

Just tell me whether his whimpy character personality changes or not

[Reply](#)

4 0

▪ 7

RandomSpaceNerd

[Devilman](#)

Reader
2mo

I guess you'll never know...

[Reply](#)

1 0

■ 6

Devilman

[RandomSpaceNerd](#)

Reader
2mo

Are you being sarcastic 😞 . Doesn't really matter I
already removed it from my library 😞

[Reply](#)

0 0

■ 7

RandomSpaceNerd

[Devilman](#)

Reader
2mo

I havent even read it, I just wanted to see if you read it.

[Reply](#)

8 0

■ 6

NamelessShadow

[RandomSpaceNerd](#)

Reader
2mo

- - -



Reply

1 0

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• 1

TheFaceOfMercy

Reader

4mo

This one kinda feels like a greasy midnight snack. It's not that good and you know you have beter stuff, but you still feel a craving for it. Still, kinda bland and the characters aren't the best by far. Good premise, bad execution.

Reply

13 1

◦ 8

TruthfulReader

[TheFaceOfMercy](#)

Reader

3mo

Cliches are there for a reason. Its because they are fun to read until you read too many of them.

Reply

9 0

• 1

Jhonrock

Reader

4mo

After reading almost 200 chapters of this one, I think I can say for sure, it's not bad, but its also not good. It's always a "warm" experience. I does not get "hot", but it also does not get "cold". Making a comparison, this one is very similar, in terms of premises, characters and narrative/development, to "The Extra's Academy Survival Guide", but, different from the latter, which has excelent "hot" moments, be it in terms of action, drama or romance, the former never gets there.

Edited: 4mo

[Reply](#)

6 1

- 1
_Rino
Reader
4mo

Peak trash.. absolute Cinema

[Reply](#)

30 2

- 1
Krishnai
_Rino
Reader
2mo

Really stupid question Do you pronounce your name like rhino the animal or ree-no?

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 1
_Rino

Krishnai

Reader

2mo

Ree-no!

Reply

2 0

○ 1

Alphanagia

Rino

Reader

3mo

It's the legend himself rino

Reply

1 0

▪ 1

Rino

Alphanagia

Reader

3mo

Praise me more

Reply

0 0

○ 6

Bobbifer

Rino

Reader

4mo

YOU... I KNOW YOU FROM SHADOW SLAVE

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 1

_Rino

[Bobbifer](#)

Reader

4mo

HIII

[Reply](#)

1 0

- [View More Replies](#)

- 13

Ace_

Reader

5mo

My sole reason for dropping this was this sentence . "Lately, Luna had been experiencing a peculiar sensation. Whenever she was in Rudy's presence, her heart seemed to have a mind of its own." . Can you get anymore cliché than that? Well if you are looking for just some cliché timepass then it's alright.

[Reply](#)

17 13

- 1

EvilHunt3r

[Ace_](#)

Reader

2mo

Every story is cliché, what changes is your point of view. If you've ever read something like this, then it's cliché. The more books you read, the more the next stories will become clichés in your eyes. It will get to a point where no story is appealing anymore, your level of demand is increasingly high, then you will have to get used to the clichés and realize that it's not that bad after all.. lol.. It's very rare to find soap operas that aren't so cliché these days. Of course, I'm not defending this story. After all, I haven't even started yet.

Edited: 2mo

[Reply](#)

2 0

o 5

disciple_0

[Ace_](#)

Reader

4mo

staple line for braindead harem

[Reply](#)

3 0

o 14

Yaksha

[Ace_](#)

Reader

4mo

What a shallow reason for dropping.

[Reply](#)

17 1

▪ 13

Ace_
Yaksha
Reader
4mo

I mean I was just joking but you can't deny that sentence is the most cliché thing someone can write.

Reply

12 6

- 1
BigDare24
Ace_
Reader
4mo

Be more forgiving. These authors have probably never even held a woman's hand and know nothing of romance. That's why everything is so childish and contrived. You can even tell that the majority of R-18 scenes come from PHub and not actual experiences. It is hard to write about things you know nothing about. Wouldn't be shocked if the majority of Asian authors are stuck in some book sweat shop with only other dudes around them. Would explain how they can write better BL/bromance than they do relationships with the opposite s*x.

Reply

19 3

- 1
GrumpyMonk
BigDare24
Reader
4mo



[Reply](#)

3 0

■ 1

Boimane

[BigDare24](#)

Reader

4mo

this is not being forgiving 🥲

[Reply](#)

11 0

■ 1

Kiwi1cat

[Boimane](#)

Reader

3mo

It's being honest.

[Reply](#)

0 0

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• 1

Wildcard

Reader

5mo

This was a good read

[Reply](#)

5 2

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Chapter 1: Prologue

Top Seat.

The highest position or rank.

In other words, it refers to the most outstanding individual in a group.

Below that is the Second Seat.

The second-best person in that group.

The world only remembers the first, not the second.

This doesn't mean that the second place isn't outstanding.

It doesn't mean that the second place lived a casual life.

It's because second place put in backbreaking effort and excruciating hard work that they could become second best.

It's already been a week since I transmigrated.

When I first transmigrated, I naturally thought it was a dream.

I pinched my cheeks and screamed like a madman to be sent back home, but nothing changed.

The initial emotion I felt was despair.

Being dropped into a world where I knew nothing made it hard to adapt.

However, humans have a reputation for adapting, and soon I accepted this reality.

I began investigating my new identity.

After investigating, I learned a few things.

From today on, I must attend an academy.

Liberion Academy.

The empire's largest academy, teaching magic, swordsmanship, and alchemy... that's the setting.

I seem to have transmigrated into the game 'The Academy's Top Wizard.'

Anyone who has played this game would know the name.

'Rudy Astria.'

Always second to the protagonist.

The second son of the Astria dukedom, and a guy who enters the academy as the top seat.

However, as the game's title suggests, the player-controlled protagonist takes the first seat from midterm exams onwards, leaving Rudy as the permanent Second Seat.

As the second son and second seat, 'Rudy Astria' receives various nicknames from players like 'perennial second-place' and 'the successor of the bean line,' but there's a reason behind this character's creation by the game developers.

The protagonist's antithesis.

He took on a completely opposite role.

The protagonist, a commoner, puts in effort to seize the first seat, while the high-ranking noble 'Rudy Astria' maintains the second seat with innate talent, showcasing a stark contrast between the two.

Thus, the story of the protagonist overcoming talent with effort is the main story of this game, 'The Academy's Top Wizard.'

However, this posed a problem.

I'm a veteran player of this game, so I know all the endings and the ways to achieve them.

'Rudy Astria' is an essential existence in all these endings.

He is the villain appearing from the very beginning and takes on an increasingly important role as the story progresses.

The protagonist's rival and a character doomed to be crushed by the protagonist.

That is 'Rudy Astria.'

And now, I have become 'Rudy Astria.'

Sigh...

I'm currently riding in a carriage on my way to the academy.

Since the distance between the Astria dukedom and Liberion Academy is quite long, I have been sitting in the carriage for an extended period of time.

Fortunately, the carriage floor is lined with soft cushions, so it's not uncomfortable. I just feel a little stiff from sitting for so long.

"Young Master, we are approaching the academy."

At the coachman's words, I slightly open the window and see the majestic buildings outside.

The very same scene from the opening of the game, Liberion Academy, unfolds before my eyes.

The academy, reflecting the slowly rising sun, is enough to send shivers down my spine.

The game boasted an impressive view, but seeing it in person was a whole different experience.

Excitement makes my heart race. This is the only time I can afford to enjoy the scenery.

Once I enter the academy, I must focus solely on surviving.

There are two endings in the game where 'Rudy Astria' dies.

First, there's a story where he turns to the dark side, joining the villains.

Some might say that since 'Rudy Astria' is already a villain, this doesn't make sense.

However, it's a bit of a stretch to call him a complete villain in the initial story.

While players might label him as a 'villain' due to his condescending attitude towards the commoner protagonist, it's actually just the demeanor of a high-ranking noble.

It's difficult to call him a true 'evil' person. The story where he fully awakens as a genuine 'evil' character comes later in the game.

I must change that part somehow.

The second ending where 'Rudy Astria' dies isn't just his death; everyone in the academy dies.

It's a bad ending where the protagonist loses the final battle.

This ending is called the 'annihilation ending.' The biggest problem with this ending is that it's easier to trigger than one might think.

The game's title, 'The Academy's Top Wizard,' gives a clue.

If the protagonist fails to claim the top spot even once during any semester except the first, the bad ending occurs.

While part of the reason is that the commoner protagonist cannot afford tuition if his grades aren't good enough, there's a more important fact.

If he continuously fails to claim the top spot, he won't be able to reach the necessary specs to defeat the final boss.

However, the main problem for the protagonist to reach the endgame specs is me.

To steer this world towards the original happy ending, it's not only essential for the protagonist to maintain his top spot, but it's also crucial for me to keep my second-place position.

The rivalry between the protagonist and 'Rudy Astria' must continue so that the protagonist feels the desperate need for growth and strives to become stronger.

But there's a problem. While I am now 'Rudy Astria,' I am not the real 'Rudy Astria.' The magic genius 'Rudy Astria' doesn't exist.

That means I must study hard to maintain my second-place position.

I didn't even entertain the possibility that I might have a talent for magic and could surpass the protagonist to claim the top spot.

I must maintain the second seat... Being second place in a normal high school is not an easy feat, let alone here at Liberion Academy, the empire's elite academy.

I knew of several geniuses in the same grade, so it was doubtful whether I could maintain the second seat.

While I was pondering, the carriage entered the academy grounds. Inside the academy, there were numerous carriages and people bustling about.

Today was the entrance ceremony, so parents and acquaintances of students were present to watch. Of course, I only brought one knight with me.

It wasn't because I was frugal, but because I was an outcast in the eyes of the duke's family.

Rudy Astria, who had always felt inferior when compared to his older brother, led a miserable life in the family.

Though he was talented in magic, his abilities still paled in comparison to his brother. It wasn't that Rudy was severely lacking; it was that the eldest son of the Astria family was exceptionally gifted.

As a result, Rudy's parents had given up on him. They saw no reason to care for a son with a poor temperament and lacking skills, so they didn't even attend the entrance ceremony.

I considered bringing a maid, but it would be a hassle to bring one just to send her back after the ceremony.

A single knight was enough to protect me.

"Young Master, we have arrived."

Upon the coachman's words, the knight opened the carriage door for me.

As I stepped out and looked around, many people were watching me.

Although I arrived quietly with only a knight, the carriage bore the white lily emblem of the Astria family, so everyone would know I was Rudy Astria.

"Ah, Young Master Rudy."

No sooner had they realized who I was, a quick-witted person approached me.

"I've heard so much about you, the new light of the Astria family."

I didn't know who they were, but they suddenly approached and started flattering me. As they began, more people approached.

"Hello, I'm the eldest son of Viscount Corwell..."

"Aren't you Young Master Rudy who entered as the top student...!"

Their sweet, honey-like words flowed as they came towards me. But I knew better.

Those who speak honeyed words often harbor venom within.

Regardless, the venom wouldn't do much harm to me. Even if I were a disfavored second son, I was still part of a central noble family in the empire.

However, being friendly with them wouldn't be helpful.

They were most likely trying to leech off me. I didn't have time to expand such useless connections.

I was too busy studying and building relationships for the main storyline.

I signaled my knight, and he began to ward them off.

"Young Master seems tired from the long carriage ride. Please greet him later."

"Y-Young Master?"

The knight blocked them, leaving the noble children who had been trying to appeal to themselves flustered.

They seemed to be checking if they had made any mistakes that upset me.

Although I could have just let them leave like this, I felt there was no need to reveal my bad reputation from the start, so I added:

"I'm tired, so let's talk later when I have more time for conversation."

As I said that, the expressions of the noble children brightened again. They seemed to think it was because I was really tired, not their fault.

"Haha. You're right. We'll visit you later."

"We'll see you at the entrance ceremony."

The gathered nobles lost interest in me and began to chat with each other.

"Let's go."

With my words, the knight began to follow me, carrying my luggage.

"Hmm~?"

In a spacious dormitory room, someone was watching the scene outside the window with interest.

"Isn't this different from what I heard?"

She tilted her head as she observed the situation. Rudy Astria's act of pushing past the nobles seemed different from the image of the young master she had in mind.

"Is he really tired?"

Although she was undoubtedly looking down from a high floor, she spoke as if she had heard the conversation taking place below.

"Well, I'll find out later."

A pleased smile formed at the corners of her lips.

Heya! Note from the future: This novel is being re-edited. You can read ahead anyway or wait, re-edits should be done by the end of the week.

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 2: Entrance Ceremony

Being the top student at Liberion Academy holds great significance.

It signifies being the most powerful individual of that age in the Empire.

The academy was well aware of this and did not skimp on investing in the top student.

They provided the largest single room in the dormitory, as well as a personal research lab.

It seems they want to show other students the clear distinction between the top student and those with lower grades.

Of course, the second-place student and those ranked lower received preferential treatment compared to those with lower grades, but not to the extent of the top student.

"Hmm..."

I entered the dormitory room provided to me.

At first, I almost exclaimed in admiration but managed not to utter a pathetic sound.

My room at the Astria Duke's residence was quite large, but this room was even bigger.

It was so big that it might feel cold when using it alone.

As I looked around the room, the knight who had carried my luggage placed it in a corner and stood idly on one side of the room.

Why was he standing like that as if he were being punished?

He would have to return to the family after the entrance ceremony anyway, so I might as well send him off earlier.

"You may return to the family now."

Upon hearing my words, the knight looked slightly surprised.

"To the family...?"

"Yes, you have nothing else to do here."

After I spoke, the knight pondered for a moment and then bowed to me.

"Knight Bellium, I shall return to the family."

"Alright, go ahead."

I gestured for the knight to leave.

After bowing to me, the knight opened the door and tried to exit.

However, he couldn't leave and just bowed his waist.

"Presenting the Empire's Star, the First Princess."

There was a blonde woman standing at the door.

A woman with fair skin and radiant golden hair.

The elegant woman gently tapped the slightly opened door with a graceful gesture.

"May I come in?"

She wore a charming smile as she knocked.

This woman was someone I knew well.

One of the main heroines of 'The Academy's Top Wizard,' the First Princess of the Empire, Rie Von Ristonia.

If I had the nickname of 'perennial second-place,' Rie was the one who always ended up third.

She entered as the second-best student but continued to rank third, pushed down by me and the protagonist.

However, she was the most influential figure at the academy.

Her mysterious smile and charisma that appeared when needed always captivated the audience.

Since she had such charisma, she always had people around her, and the princess utilized them to wield her influence.

But was there a story in which the princess came to see me?

No matter how well-versed I was in this game, I didn't know every single detail of the story.

The narrative unfolded from the protagonist's perspective, so I couldn't know everything that happened outside of his sight.

"I am honored to meet the First Princess of the Empire."

For now, I calmly greeted the princess with proper etiquette.

"You don't need to greet me so formally. We are both students here, right?"

The princess replied playfully with a smile on her lips.

Her words were indeed true.

It was stated in the academy's regulations that everyone was equal regardless of their status.

However, that didn't mean conflicts due to status differences didn't exist.

Of course, such conflicts would all be shattered when the commoner protagonist became the top student...

"I understand. But why did you suddenly visit?"

"I came to visit a fellow student I will be seeing frequently."

Although she said that, it was unlikely to be such a simple reason.

The princess wasn't the type to act without thinking.

First of all, Rie despises the Astria family.

The reason Rie came to this academy was to strengthen her influence in the imperial court.

She aimed to create her own faction and use them as her loyal followers.

The academy is not only a place for learning but also a society.

Attending it alone could easily create numerous allies.

For Rie, who came to create a faction, 'Rudy Astria' is an obstacle.

The Astria family, a duke family, holds the greatest power aside from the royal family.

As Rudy Astria tries to build a faction around himself, he inevitably clashes with the princess.

Those conflicts are stories for later and have no relevance now.

However, from the beginning of the game, the princess showed a dislike for 'Rudy Astria.'

She appeared normal in public, but behind the scenes, she often frowned.

From those scenes, it was clear that the princess had disliked 'Rudy Astria' even before coming to the academy.

But why would she seek out someone she dislikes?

"It's fine. Please tell me why you came to see me."

"Oh my, I really came because I wanted to get closer. Do you doubt my sincerity?"

My words could be considered rude, but Princess Rie only wore a playful smile.

Seeing her reaction after asking so directly, it appeared she came simply out of curiosity.

Although I'm familiar with her from the game, strictly speaking, this is our first encounter in reality.

"Young master, I will take my leave for now."

The knight, who had been standing at the entrance, thought it rude to continue listening to our conversation and bowed to both of us before stepping outside.

Princess Rie looked around the room as the knight left.

"By the way, did the Duke and Duchess of Astria not come?"

"They both have pressing matters and couldn't make it."

"Ah... I see."

Princess Rie put on a disappointed expression.

I had a feeling that this was an act.

The Duke of Astria was not an ordinary figure and was responsible for supporting the empire.

If the duke had taken action, there was no way the princess wouldn't have known.

"Isn't the entrance ceremony starting soon? I should change into my school uniform."

It was a hint for her to leave.

There was no benefit to continuing the conversation with her.

Thankfully, this person, who probably hates me the most in the academy, has yet to discover any of my weaknesses.

"Yes, we should head to the entrance ceremony soon."

The princess grinned and opened the door.

"See you later."

I watched the princess leave the room.

See you later?

Absolutely not.

Although I don't want to get involved, it's bound to happen as time goes on, but there's no need to start now.

Besides, it wouldn't be easy to meet the princess among hundreds of new students.

Cherry blossoms fluttered, filling the air with their fragrance.

The warm sunlight and scattering petals made it clear that spring had arrived.

The stiff school uniform I wore brought back memories of my high school entrance ceremony, a time filled with anticipation for new, albeit awkward, encounters.

However, the situation now was drastically different.

If I didn't pull myself together here, I could die.

Back then, studying was optional, but here it was mandatory.

If I tried to enjoy my youth without studying properly, I would end up with the annihilation ending.

I had to study as if my life depended on it.

As that pressure began to build, my excitement faded away.

I walked through the crowd towards the entrance ceremony venue.

Parents and other people were present, making the area quite lively.

As I approached the venue, I saw students who appeared to be checking identification and guiding new students.

They were also preventing non-students from entering.

It seemed like having parents and other people in the student area would make it too crowded.

I presented my identification to enter the ceremony.

"Here it is."

A black-haired female student wearing a uniform took my identification.

"Rudy... Astria?"

She looked back and forth between my ID card and me.

"Ah... You're the top of this year's class. You can sit over there."

"Over... there?"

Upon my inquiry, the student smiled and pointed to the front.

There were two seats next to the VIP area.

One of them was occupied by the First Princess I had met earlier, Rie von Ristonia.

The seats were reserved for the top and second place students.

It seemed that the princess's words about meeting later referred to these seats.

I had no choice but to sit next to the princess.

"We meet again."

The princess greeted me warmly.

I slightly bowed my head and sat down.

As soon as I did, the princess started a conversation.

"There seem to be many outstanding people among this year's new students. Locke Lucarion, the son of the Northern Marquis, or Serina Rinsburg, the daughter of the Royal Head Elementalist..."

I recognized the people the princess mentioned.

They weren't main characters but were frequently mentioned supporting characters.

I silently listened to her stories beyond that.

I didn't dislike talking with others.

However, the fact that my counterpart was a princess made this seat feel like a bed of nails.

She appeared light-hearted, but inside, she was probably sharpening her blade.

"Although there are famous people like them..."

The princess pointed at me.

"Actually, if we talk about fame, it would be you or me, who are the most famous."

With a sly smile, Rie's appearance was alluring enough to captivate any man.

It made me realize the importance of one's appearance.

Seeing the princess's stunning beauty and smile, my heart was drawn to her.

Still, I couldn't let my guard down.

After all, Rie von Ristonia was known for stabbing people in the back with that same smile.

As I listened to the princess's stories, it seemed the preparations for the entrance ceremony were complete.

"Ah, we will now begin the Liberion Academy entrance ceremony."

With the emcee's words, the ceremony started.

".....That concludes the headmaster's welcoming speech for the new students."

The entrance ceremony was no different from an ordinary high school's.

We just had to endure dull speeches from the guests of honor.

At least now that the headmaster's speech was over, the ceremony seemed to be drawing to a close.

"Next, we will have the freshman representative deliver a word of thanks."

Freshman representative?

I hadn't heard anything about who was selected for this role.

Typically, the student with the best grades is chosen, right?

"Rudy Astria, please come forward."

That's right. I was the freshman representative.

I hadn't received the news due to being preoccupied with my recent transmigration.

Or perhaps I received it before my transmigration·····.

Regardless, I needed to deal with the current situation first.

I calmly moved to the podium without showing any panic.

As I ascended the platform, hundreds of people stared at me.

I hadn't had many opportunities to speak in front of a large crowd, let alone without a script.

I couldn't make a mistake.

I am 'Rudy Astria,' a noble and arrogant individual.

If someone like me were to make a mistake here, my image would be shattered.

I took a deep breath and began to speak.

"I would like to express my gratitude to the headmaster and the honorable guests for their kind words."

The best way to avoid making mistakes here was to avoid being verbose.

It was better to be concise and clear, but I shouldn't come across as overly arrogant.

My image was already bad enough, and starting off like that would only bring me closer to a bad ending.

"I hope that everyone will study hard and enjoy their youth while at the academy."

It was a cliché statement that anyone could make.

After saying that, I stood silently as people stared at me with puzzled expressions.

There was nothing but a sudden, deafening silence.

The emcee was the one to break it.

".....Is that all?"

I responded confidently to the emcee's question, with the arrogance and assertiveness characteristic of 'Rudy Astria.'

"Yes, that's all."

".....Ahem, that was Rudy Astria, our freshman representative."

The emcee seemed slightly flustered, but he continued to lead the ceremony skillfully.

I stepped down from the podium along with the emcee's guidance. As I descended, I made eye contact with Princess Rie, and her gaze seemed to have changed.

The curious look in her eyes had transformed into a sharp, predatory one, as if she was hunting prey.

Unlike earlier, she didn't utter a single word.

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 3: First Class (1)

"Your Highness, how have you been? You look exceptionally beautiful today."

Sweet words.

"Your Highness, to be able to control magic to this extent already... You truly are the Empire's treasure!"

Honey-coated tongue.

"Your Highness, I heard you've become the Academy's second seat. As expected, you've achieved such a high rank so quickly. Soon, you'll be able to claim the top spot."

However, they were the ones I despise more than anyone.

Their kind existed within the imperial palace.

They always wore a smiling face, spouting sweet words like candy, but behind their backs, they hid blades.

They were always ready to stab me if I ever fell.

That's why I couldn't afford to make mistakes.

I always had to plan ahead and prepare for everything.

And, wearing a smile as my mask, I too had to sharpen my blade.

That way, I could parry my opponents' attacks if I ever stumbled.

"...I should change into my school uniform."

'Huh?'

At first, it was just suspicion.

"...enjoy their youth."

'...'

'Rudy Astria.'

He had been on my radar even before I enrolled in the Academy.

The second son of the Astria dukedom, a family responsible for one of the Empire's pillars.

Yet, from what I had heard, he wasn't someone I needed to worry about.

He was rumored to be a discarded child of the Astria family.

After hearing what my spy in the Astria family reported, I knew the rumor to be true.

He was immature, arrogant, and authoritarian.

As expected from the Astria family, his magical talent was outstanding, but even that paled in comparison to his elder brother.

In short, he was a bundle of inferiority.

Someone consumed by inferiority was the best prey in social circles.

The most important thing in social circles was to filter out the praise and understand the intentions behind it.

Those filled with inferiority craved praise, making them easy prey in social circles.

But who was this person standing before me?

A smile crept onto my lips.

It had been a while.

It was truly a long time since I had seen my plan go awry like this.

This person was not a bundle of inferiority.

Instead, he seemed like a bland person with no interest in his surroundings.

He had pushed away everyone who approached him.

I could understand driving away the insects trying to pick up his falling crumbs, but he even pushed away me, the princess.

He neither flattered nor challenged me, just pushed me away.

When I met him directly, he was very formal, and when I tried to engage in conversation from the seat beside him, he ignored me.

And then there was his speech, a perfect opportunity to show himself off.

He had let it end so anticlimactically.

What was this person doing? Had he been wearing a mask within his family all this time?

The 'Rudy Astria' I had heard of and the 'Rudy Astria' I was seeing now were completely different people.

His arrogance and noble attitude fit to some extent, but it was far from the label of an inferiority complex or the abandoned child of the Astria family.

I even suspected that my spy within the Astria family was a traitor.

However, there was no way a spy would betray me so easily.

If they betrayed me, they wouldn't be able to guarantee their life or even their family's safety.

If I were to think of another reason why Rudy Austria changed...

"Did he remove his mask?"

Perhaps he had been wearing the mask of a naive second son from the prestigious duke's family, and had removed it upon arriving here.

Then, there were many things to consider.

Why did he act and why did he remove the mask?

"How interesting..."

I found a huge variable in the academy, where I thought there were only immature children.

Yet, I can't help but smile.

The current situation was just a game for me.

Though free for now, they were but a toy that would soon be in my grasp.

There was no way these immature children could compete with me, who had survived in the palace full of snakes.

I thought so and walked to my dormitory.

"Why do you look so displeased?"

Princess Rie glanced at me with interest, but ultimately only greeted me and left.

Although her intrigued gaze was undoubtedly charming, it felt as if she could see right through me, making me uncomfortable.

Despite the situation diverging from the game's story, it wasn't a significant issue.

In any case, this part of the story could be changed.

Altering the image of 'Rudy Astria,' who seems unlikable, is an essential action to avoid death.

One of the causes of Rudy Astria's demise in the game was that everyone at the academy turned against him.

I was also satisfied with the speech I gave on the stage.

One of the things I hated most as a student was listening to the tedious sermons from the principal and teachers.

Simple phrases like "take care of your health" and "study hard" were stretched out to the point of irritation.

A short, blunt speech like mine would have been preferable.

I imagine the other students felt the same.

If I were a student in the audience, I would have applauded such a brief speech.

"Anyway, that's not the problem."

No matter how much attention I paid to that part, there was nothing I could do about it now.

What I needed to focus on was my growth.

'Status Window'

「Name: Rudy Astria

Age: 17

Abilities:

Beginner Magic: LV 6

Fire Attribute Magic: LV 5

Wind Attribute Magic: LV 3

Swordsmanship: LV 2

Elemental Magic: LV 2」

The game's status window appeared before my eyes.

It was the first thing I tried after realizing I had transmigrated.

The status window worked correctly, allowing me to learn about myself.

Seeing Rudy Astria's name on the status window made me hold my breath, but the fact that his beginner magic was already at level 6 brought relief.

The protagonist begins the game with level 1 beginner magic.

However, this guy had already reached level 6 in magic even before entering the academy.

He seemed to have cheat-like abilities from the start.

I wondered how the protagonist had ever defeated such a character.

Of course, it was good fortune for me...

However, even with these overpowered abilities, I still couldn't secure the top seat.

The academy offered practical classes teaching magic, but there were also theoretical classes.

No matter how talented one was, it was meaningless without good grades in theory.

I rummaged through the luggage that the knight had left behind and pulled out some books.

'Basic Magic Theory.'

'Elemental Studies.'

'Imperial History.'

And several other books were present.

"Ah..."

Seeing the thick books, I already felt a headache coming on.

But only studying could save me.

After all, I already knew what would happen at the academy, so I just needed to study well.

I tore a page from a notebook and wrote with a pen.

-Studying is a matter of life and death.

It was my determination.

It wasn't a typical student's resolution because failing to study could genuinely lead to my death.

I simply wrote down the facts.

I mustn't allow myself to become lazy.

I opened the Basic Magic Theory book.

From the very day of the entrance ceremony, I began studying.

The next day, I headed to class with my book in hand.

The classes at Liberion Academy were similar to those in a university.

There were no morning meetings like in high school, and students would apply for and attend the classes they wanted.

However, in the first year, the academy would arrange the class schedule for students.

The schedule was based on the students' entrance exam performance. For example, in magic practice, if students with differing abilities were to learn together, it would be too difficult to progress.

So, students were divided into classes based on their abilities.

Exams were the same for everyone, so there was no consideration in terms of evaluation.

According to the schedule arranged by the academy, my first class was Basic Magic Theory.

Although this subject also had different class divisions, it wasn't based on skill but rather due to the large number of students.

On my way to class, I saw someone who caught my eye.

Unlike the colorful hair of other characters, this person had familiar black hair.

It was Evan, the protagonist of the game.

He overcame various trials and became the top student of the academy through sheer effort alone.

He was the character I used to empathize with, and it was nice to see him.

But I couldn't get too close to him.

He had to think of me as his enemy so he would strive to surpass me.

With that in mind, many characters would attend this first class together. Evan entered the classroom first, and I followed him in.

"Let's begin the class," said the professor standing in front.

"I am Professor George Mcguire, and I'm in charge of Basic Magic Theory. Since today is the first day, let's start with self-introductions."

Self-introduction time.

I really disliked it.

It was an event that originally occurred in the game to introduce the characters.

However, in reality, it was an extremely embarrassing situation.

There wouldn't be anyone who had prepared a proper self-introduction like in games or novels.

"Let's start with Rudy, who ranked first in the entrance exam, and go in order," said the professor.

I had seen this situation many times before. I had to watch this scene every day to see all the endings in the game.

There was no way to skip the starting event, after all.

And there was an important point in this event.

This was the moment when Evan first viewed me unfavorably.

I sighed inwardly.

To make Evan see me unfavorably, I had to repeat the exact words 'Rudy Astria' said in the game.

It was important to proceed with the story related to Evan as it originally happened, at least for now.

In the beginning, I needed to gain Evan's dislike.

Of course, I would have to fix this unfavorable relationship later on, but it was right to act according to the story now.

Evan's initial motivation was his dislike of 'Rudy Astria.'

Feeling this animosity towards 'Rudy Astria,' Evan would strive to surpass him.

The more effort Evan put in, the faster his growth would be, allowing me to smoothly progress through the early parts of the story.

However... it was so embarrassing.

I had to utter lines that I would only say in a game.

Moreover, I had to spit out the lines of a villain or someone distasteful.

It would be better to utter the protagonist's cool lines.

Though those lines would still be cringe-worthy, at least they would be cool.

Despite grinding my teeth, I had to do it to survive.

Yes. I had to bear this level of embarrassment.

To survive.

I stood up from my seat and assumed an arrogant posture.

"I am Rudy Astria of the Astria ducal family. You filthy, insignificant beings. Be grateful just for breathing the same air in this space."

A line that sounded like a teenager going through a phase.

It felt like I should summon a black dragon from my right hand.

Although I wanted to tear my hair out in self-loathing, I didn't drop the arrogant attitude.

Looking around, I saw people frowning and glaring at me.

I made enemies out of my classmates from the very first lesson.

I needed to change this image, but there was nothing I could do at the beginning.

Especially in front of Evan...

"Ah... yes. Next student."

The professor proceeded nervously after hearing my words.

After that, I could sit down again.

If I had stood for a few seconds longer, I might have died from embarrassment...

Though my actions were to survive, they might end up killing me.

"Ah, yes! I am Luna Railer of the Railer Baron family! I know I'm lacking, but please take care of me!"

As I was panicking alone after what I said, my senses returned upon hearing the name 'Luna Railer.'

'Luna Railer.'

She was also one of the main heroines in the game, like Princess Rie.

A main heroine, but the most difficult character to win over.

And the person I needed for the plan I had set up.

Chapter 4: First Class (2)

Lunchtime arrived as class ended.

Numerous students flocked to the cafeteria for a meal.

However, among them, no one chose to eat with me.

In fact, nobody even attempted to approach me.

Before heading to eat, a few guys did approach me.

After class ended, three guys with colorful hair came up to me.

Curiously, they had red, orange, and green hair.

They appeared to be ruffians with slanted eyes and a troublemaker-like demeanor.

They didn't look like supporting characters but rather minor delinquents A, B, and C.

"Young Master Rudy, your self-introduction was truly magnificent."

"You exuded the dignity of a true high noble!"

"Indeed!"

The three of them came up to me and flattered. I looked at them with a smile and said,

"Get lost."

"What?"

"I said, get lost."

The ones I needed to avoid the most were not the main or supporting characters but these ruffians.

They ranked first on my list of people to avoid.

To some extent, I had to put up with criticizing and demeaning others like I did in class.

If I wanted to follow the plot, it was an inevitable action.

Compared to the villains that would appear later, this level of unpopularity was cute and could be washed away easily.

However, I absolutely couldn't be friends with these guys.

They might flatter me in front of me, but they were uncontrollable.

They were troublemakers who caused mischief and acted like ruffians when I wasn't around.

If they happened to harass the heroines or cause a major incident, it would be irreversible.

If I hung out with them, people would blame me more than these guys.

Even if I claimed, "I didn't do anything," nobody would listen.

If I was with these guys, anyone would think I was the leader.

Even I thought the same.

Let's say there were ruffians and a successful guy among them.

If the ruffians caused trouble and the successful guy wasn't present, what would people think?

They would probably assume the successful guy ordered the ruffians to carry out the deed.

So it was crucial not to get involved with them from the start.

Sigh...

I picked up a spoon and reluctantly shoved the rice into my mouth.

Eating alone was indeed a lonely experience, even if it was for survival.

In this world, the culture of dining alone wasn't as prevalent as in modern times.

Most people gathered together to eat their meals.

Yet, here I was, eating by myself in the cafeteria.

First-year students with red scarves around their necks glanced at me while murmuring.

It seemed that word of my actions in class had spread.

As a result, I felt even more miserable.

How could there not be a single friend among these numerous students to share a meal with me?

I wondered if I should try to find an extra character to dine with.

After hastily finishing my meal, I went outside and saw a woman drinking water in the distance.

She was a girl with plain brown hair, tied into two braids.

Compared to the vibrant hair colors of other Academy students, her hair color was unremarkable, but her pure appearance drew attention.

Her name was Luna Railer.

Luna was the daughter of a poor baron family.

Born as the only daughter in her family, she discovered her talent for magic when a wizard passed through her territory.

However, compared to the talents of other Academy students, her abilities appeared quite ordinary.

Her talent lay in magic theory, which would shine as she continued her studies.

Yet, in the beginning, her talent was not apparent.

Because of her low entrance exam scores, she enrolled in the Academy without receiving any support.

Coming from an impoverished family and not receiving any financial aid from the Academy, paying tuition was a heavy burden for her.

The act of drinking water was likely to fill her stomach, as she didn't have the money to buy food.

As someone with an abundance of money, I wanted to take her and feed her.

I felt pity for her, knowing her circumstances and watching her hold her starving stomach.

However, I couldn't do that.

Not until 'that incident' occurred.

The reason Luna Railer was the most challenging character to conquer was nothing special.

It was merely the fact that the related events happened too early in the story.

To conquer Luna, I had to pay more attention to her than to my studies from the very beginning.

I had to hover around her, gain her trust, and assess the situation.

If I devoted that much time to her, it would become too difficult to rank first in the midterm exams.

Of course, the early story related to Luna could be ignored.

Even without the protagonist's involvement, she could overcome the situation on her own.

Luna's main story would appear in the middle of the game.

In that story, I could build affection points and conquer Luna.

However, to properly conquer her, I couldn't ignore this part of the story.

It was a hidden story that occurred in the background but wasn't necessary to get involved in.

I planned to use that hidden story to my advantage.

Luna frowned and sighed, seemingly still hungry after drinking water.

"..."

Pitiful.

I turned around and headed for the school store.

"I'm so hungry..."

Luna was filled with regret.

She wondered if she had made a mistake enrolling here.

Her family was poor, but she had never experienced going hungry like this before.

"Still, I have to stay strong! Since I'm already enrolled...!"

She came to this place to revive her family's fortune.

It had been a long time since a truly talented person emerged from her family.

The Railer family could only trace their lineage back to Luna's great-great-grandfather, where their records were limited to a single line.

Now, their family was on the brink of collapse due to financial difficulties.

The family's territory was no more than a small rural village, so they couldn't squeeze money out of their subjects.

Of course, if they were as ruthless as wringing a dry squid for soup, they could have somehow extracted money from their subjects, but the Railer family head was not malicious.

While worrying about the future of her family, Luna encountered a wizard passing through their territory.

The wizard told Luna she had a talent for magic and gifted her a magic tome.

The tome contained difficult content, which was beyond Luna's beginner level in magic.

However, since it was a gift for her, she cherished it as a treasure.

She hoped that someday, she would be able to use the tome...

"But before that, I might die from hunger..."

Luna clutched her hungry stomach.

She had some money from her family, but she had to save it.

You never know when you'll need money...

So, Luna decided to have only dinner today.

"At least it's good for dieting! Hehe!"

Luna tried to think positively, but it didn't ease her hunger.

"Excuse me...?"

As Luna turned around, she saw two female students standing behind her.

"Who... are you?"

The scarves of the two girls were green, indicating they were second-year students.

"A first-year student asked us to give this to you."

The senior handed Luna a bag containing bread.

It was a basic bread sold at the store.

Though wealthy commoners might snub such ordinary bread, for hungry Luna, it was like a lifeline.

Luna looked back and forth between the bread and the seniors with wide eyes.

"Who gave this...?"

Luna suddenly started to feel anxious.

Her friends had gone to have lunch, and she had slipped away, saying she had something else to do.

Could it be that one of her friends saw her like this and gave her the bread?

But that didn't make sense.

In that case, her friend would have given it to her, not asked unknown second-year seniors to do so.

"Did they say who asked you to give it to me?"

"Uh, it was a student over there... Huh? Where did they go?"

As Luna asked, the senior pointed to the back, but there was no one there.

"Um, what did they look like?"

She had to find out who it was.

There was no benefit to rumors spreading that she had no money.

"It was a boy... Blonde with slightly slanted eyes? Something like that."

"A... a boy?"

Luna had made a few female friends at the academy, but she had never even greeted a boy.

She had grown up in a rural territory and had no immunity to boys.

Her father was overprotective, and there were few kids in the countryside.

Thus, she had never even thought about talking to a boy.

Which meant that the person who gave her the bread was not someone she knew.

"We'll be going now."

"Ah, thank you!"

Luna came to her senses and bid farewell to the departing seniors.

Then she looked at the bread in her hand.

Bread given by a stranger.

"Who could it be?"

Luna took the bread out of the bag and put it in her mouth.

"It's delicious."

And with the bread in her cheek, she smiled a happy smile.

In my dorm room, today was an incredibly exhausting day.

I stayed up late studying for tomorrow's classes and woke up early to attend them.

Despite this, I still had enough energy physically.

However, the fact that I had spoken so many cringe-worthy lines in front of many people kept haunting my thoughts, mentally exhausting me even during other classes.

"I can't avoid studying."

Being tired is one thing, but I can't put off studying. I glanced at the timetable the academy had provided.

Tomorrow's classes include Imperial History and Magic Practice.

While history is a general education course, I should prepare for the magic practice beforehand.

My magic abilities are exceptional, but I've never used magic properly.

Just as having good tools is useless if you don't know how to use them, I need to practice handling magic in advance.

I opened a magic theory book and looked at the basic spells, which were almost identical to the game.

In 'The Academy's Top Wizard,' magic was divided into three levels.

Beginner, intermediate, and advanced magic.

It could be simply divided into these three categories.

If further subdivided, magic could be divided by attributes. Beginner magic had four attributes: fire, water, wind, and earth.

These were the basic elemental spells. With intermediate magic, one could learn specialized spells like space magic and more detailed attributes like ice and wood.

However, advanced magic was slightly different.

Instead of learning new specialized attributes, the size of the magic significantly increased.

There were spells that could control nature itself, like summoning a typhoon or making it rain, and spells that could engulf an entire battlefield in flames.

Advanced magic was nothing short of a catastrophe.

A catastrophe that could destroy an entire village without a trace.

"For now, let's start with the basics..."

I looked at the basic spells I could use.

Magic that could be used without drawing a magic circle, utilizing the mana within my body.

There were also methods using magic circles, but I couldn't use them yet due to my lack of knowledge about magic.

"Let's start with this."

A spell caught my eye as I skimmed the book.

"Ignite."

As I said the word, a small flame appeared in my hand.

It was the most basic fire attribute spell.

Since my fire attribute magic proficiency was the highest, I could use it quite easily.

"Wow..."

I stared at the small flame in my hand.

Not only was the sight of the flame in my hand amazing, but the feeling of creating it was fascinating too.

It felt like something inside my body was flowing towards my hand to create the flame, similar to the sensation of drinking water.

As soon as I thought about stopping the magic, the flow I felt in my hand ceased, and the flame went out.

I practiced using the fire and wind attribute magic I could handle, getting a feel for using magic.

After gaining some sense of it, I lay down on the bed with a satisfied smile.

However, I would come to regret it the next day.

Why did I sleep?

I should have remembered that the Magic Practice professor was a real eccentric.

I should have stayed up all night studying.

Here are two chappies.

Chapter 5: First Class (3)

Magic Practice classroom.

As I entered, there was only one student inside.

"Hello."

The person was none other than Princess Rie, whom I had met before.

It was a class attended by just the two of us.

One might think it was the inefficient, but there was a reason for this.

Magic Practice had a significant gap in skill level between students with low and high grades.

What the low-grade students learned was an extension of the theory class.

This was because some of them didn't know how to use magic at all.

On the other hand, students with excellent magic skills could already use magic to some extent.

Therefore, there was no need to provide additional theory classes for high-grade students.

It was a more efficient teaching method to finish theory classes during theory class time and learn different spells during practice class time.

"Princess Rie, greetings."

I greeted Princess Rie with a polite demeanor.

"Hey, you don't have to be so formal. We're the same age, after all."

"No, I must."

"Hmm... Don't you want to be friends, Rudy Astria?"

Rie smiled at me as she spoke. However, I had no interest in getting close to her.

At present, I am the most outstanding individual in the academy.

The academy's brightest star.

However, to a princess who wants to become the sun, I am nothing but an obstacle.

A star brighter than the sun itself would only make her own light seem dim, providing no assistance.

What could be the reason for trying to befriend such an unhelpful person?

If delinquents were priority one to avoid, then Princess Rie would be priority zero.

She could bury me without anyone noticing.

The classroom door opened with a creak, and a professor entered.

He had messy hair and a rough, bearded appearance.

The professor placed the book he was holding onto his desk with an indifferent expression.

"Only two students this year, huh?"

The professor glanced back and forth between Rie and me.

His gaze was dry and emotionless, not one you'd expect when looking at the son of a duke and the empire's princess.

In a relationship between professors and students, the professor is the superior, regardless of status.

However, society isn't that simple.

If a student's status was high, the professor could be beneath them or even on equal footing.

But the way this professor looked at us seemed as if he was merely observing insignificant students.

"Call me Professor Cromwell."

Cromwell briefly introduced himself, only revealing his last name.

It was quite a rude greeting, but Rie and I could only stare at him.

"So, shall we see your skills?"

As Cromwell waved his hand, desks and chairs flew to both sides.

"Fight each other."

"What?"

Rie furrowed her brows at Cromwell's words.

"I said fight."

It was absurd.

There's no professor who would make students fight each other like this.

Normally, students were forbidden from fighting outside of formal duels or practical evaluations.

Rie and I had no intention of fighting.

Even if he was a professor, he couldn't force us to fight if we didn't want to.

A professor may rank higher than a student, but they are not above the established rules.

This was a classroom, not some back alley of the academy, so this act of violence could not be justified.

"Are you saying you'll ignore the school regulations?"

Rie said exactly what was on my mind.

I couldn't fight Rie.

Having only used magic briefly yesterday, I wouldn't stand a chance against the princess.

My true abilities would be exposed.

Even if using magic directly in a fight differs from its normal usage, both the princess and the professor would surely find it strange once they see the scope of my magic.

"Then are you saying you'll ignore the professor's words?"

Cromwell raised an eyebrow at Princess Rie's question.

"It means that, depending on the situation."

I absolutely could not fight.

If I fought the princess, I wouldn't be able to defend against her magic properly and would end up rolling around pitifully.

The rumor would spread throughout the academy.

There was no reason for the princess not to spread such a rumor.

The story of the top student who arrogantly disregarded everyone, getting trampled by the second seat, would be too sensational.

I made up my mind and opened my mouth.

"How trivial."

The gazes of both the professor and Rie focused on me.

"Do you mean to say that you must see us fight to evaluate us?"

I brought up a valid point.

"Professor Cromwell, perhaps you should be teaching mercenaries instead of students at Liberion Academy?"

This class wasn't about teaching us how to fight.

It was a magic practice class, teaching us how to use magic efficiently and exploring various applications of different types of magic.

That's what a magic practice class was about.

Magic wasn't created solely for fighting.

Fighting was just one of the many ways it could be used.

So, ordering us to fight each other in this class was refusable.

"This class doesn't seem worth attending."

I snorted arrogantly and headed toward the back door of the classroom.

"Are you saying you'll disobey my command?"

Cromwell spoke to me with a threatening tone.

"If you leave like this, there could be consequences."

However, if I were to back down pathetically here, I would just fall to the level of a third-rate thug.

I can't let that happen.

Even though I'm talking big, this is essentially running away.

Fleeing without a thought is disgraceful, but strategically retreating takes courage and wisdom.

I opened my mouth, looking at Professor Cromwell.

"Disobedience, you say?"

I opened the back door.

"Am I a dog that obeys?"

Hearing my words, Cromwell lowered his head.

"Hehehe..."

As I tried to leave, Cromwell suddenly burst into laughter.

"Hahahaha..."

He laughed out loud.

Princess Rie stared at Cromwell with round eyes.

"I apologize. You're right. You're not dogs. Come back to the classroom."

Seeing this, I furrowed my brow.

What's he trying to do?

"Don't worry, it was just a test. Come in."

A test...?

I realized the eccentric professor's intentions.

"My intention was slightly different, but you both chose not to fight, so I think that's the right answer."

Cromwell continued with a smile.

"You two are the strongest students among the first-years at the academy. Being the strongest students means you're the strongest among your peers in the Empire. Such powerful individuals should not recklessly use their strength. You always need to think about whether you're on the right path."

Princess Rie looked at me with a surprised expression.

No, I didn't think about that when I decided not to fight...

"You shouldn't use your power recklessly. If you wanted, you could kill people as easily as crushing ants beneath your feet."

Cromwell looked at me with a sinister expression, giving me a smile.

"The meaning of using one's strength was what I intended to teach in the first lesson. Even under pressure, if you think you're wrong, you shouldn't use your power. That's the basic mindset of a wizard. However..."

Cromwell gestured, and two of the desks that were put away earlier flew to the center of the classroom.

"It seems there's nothing to teach you about mindset."

"..."

Did I achieve a good outcome?

"Well, that's enough about mindset. Let's see your true abilities."

Then, Professor Cromwell handed us each a piece of paper.

"This class is a practical one, but you need a basic understanding of theory to use magic effectively. So, let's have a short test to see how much you know about theory."

Ah.

I'm screwed.

I should have just fought Rie.

I have almost no knowledge of magic in my head right now.

I'd rather fight a messy fight...

With a gloomy heart, I received the test paper.

"This test won't count towards your evaluation, so don't feel pressured."

Hearing those words, I felt somewhat relieved.

After all, only Professor Cromwell will know the score...

So it shouldn't be a problem, right?

Professor Cromwell's office.

"How interesting."

Cromwell was reading about the students after class had ended.

Rudy of the Astria duchy and Rie, the First Princess of the Empire.

There had been a few students like Rie so far.

However, it was hard to say that those students had any strong convictions. They could simply be model students who followed the school rules.

What Professor Cromwell wanted in a student was not someone like them.

He wanted someone who could refuse to comply even if the Empire's laws forced them.

Someone with their own beliefs.

In that sense, Rudy Astria was intriguing.

Arrogant and haughty.

However, that didn't matter.

Originally, talented wizards were arrogant and haughty.

No, those wizards were not arrogant.

How could they help it if the people around them were genuinely inferior and not on the same level?

It's only unfair for the lion when the ant claims it's showing off while acting as a lion should.

"...?"

When Cromwell tried to grade Rudy Astria's exam, it was completely blank.

It was not a test that affected his grades, but he hadn't written a single word.

Was the test too easy? Or was he still angry about being tested?

Cromwell simply moved on from that exam.

After all, he was the top student of the academy, so he must already know the content.

The reason for evaluating theory in practical classes like this was due to students who were bad at theory but good at using magic.

Those who simply used magic by intuition.

Such students have high practical scores but low overall grades.

The test was originally prepared for those students.

But, after all, weren't those two the first and second seats? There was no need to worry about them.

Knock knock

"Come in."

A woman holding several documents entered as Cromwell spoke.

"Professor, I came to receive a recommendation letter."

A woman with neatly tied-up red hair. She was very neatly dressed.

"You're already here for it?"

Although his words sounded slightly cold, his face was smiling.

"Isn't it better to get it done quickly?"

The woman also smiled, familiar with his tone, and handed over the documents.

What was written on them was a recommendation letter for the student council president.

"Wouldn't it be difficult to maintain the top seat while holding the president's position?"

"I just need to reduce my sleep."

She said nonchalantly.

Cromwell chuckled and signed the document, handing it back to her.

"Thank you."

She smiled brightly and accepted the document.

"Are you not having a hard time with this year's first-year students?"

"Are you worried about me?"

She playfully shrugged her shoulders.

"There's an interesting guy."

"An interesting guy?"

She asked with a slightly puzzled face.

"Rudy Astria."

Her face showed surprise, but it soon broke into a smile.

Here are two chappies. I think I'll be doing 4 chaps a week.

I'll also be going back to re-edit the previous chaps. I think they're pretty badly done compared to these two. I'm not sure yet but I might have some peeps joining me so there should be more novels.

Chapter 6: Luna Railer (1)

After the incident in the magic practice class, I was worried.

I wondered if submitting a blank test paper would cause any problems.

However, Professor Cromwell didn't say anything.

He briefly came to me and said, "Submit a proper one next time," before leaving.

I continued my life at the academy as usual.

I diligently attended classes during the day and reviewed lessons at night.

It was the life of an ordinary student.

The only slight difference was...

"50 coppers, please."

I would wake up early in the morning, go to the store, and buy some bread.

I placed the bread in Luna's locker.

This action didn't carry any special meaning.

I just knew how sad it was not to be able to eat when you're hungry.

When I was young, I once went to a church retreat.

I didn't go there because of any particular faith; I just wanted to have fun.

But the church made the students who came there practice fasting and prayer.

So there I was, unable to eat properly and praying every day at a place I went to have fun.

The sense of helplessness and shock I felt back then was beyond my imagination.

Luna came here to study, not to practice fasting and studying.

It didn't seem like a big problem since I wasn't doing anything wrong, just giving her perfectly good bread.

"Is it starting soon...?"

Luna's hidden story would begin soon.

If I were Evan, I would have had to gain Luna's affection earlier.

But Evan and I were different.

Initially, Rudy Astria had an advantage over Evan.

Compared to Evan, Rudy Astria lacked nothing in terms of money, ability, or status.

Even my grades were better than his at this point.

So, there was no need to do any groundwork as I would have to do if I were following Evan's story.

Luna's hidden story.

It starts when Luna receives high praise from a professor during her magic theory class presentation.

A theory that ordinary students couldn't think of.

Upon witnessing this, Professor Mcguire calls for Luna.

Knowing Luna's situation to some extent, Professor Mcguire offers to sponsor her.

The condition is to bring a similar achievement before the midterm exams.

He promises to cover all her tuition fees for three years if she can prove herself.

Luna started researching magic in the library from that point on.

As the deadline approached, Luna's anxiety grew.

In her desperation, Luna eventually took out her precious grimoire.

The grimoire contained a wealth of information, but among the content, there was also dark magic.

Luna unwittingly chose one of the spells in the grimoire to cast, which happened to be dark magic.

Unaware that it was dark magic, Luna cast the spell.

Dark magic possessed immense destructive power but caused mental corruption when the casting failed.

As Luna's mind became corrupted, her mana went out of control and destroyed the library, leading to her punishment.

If Evan were to intervene in this story, he would stop Luna from going berserk.

Since Luna didn't possess such great power, Evan could easily stop her.

With Evan's intervention, the incident would be resolved without much damage to the library, and Luna wouldn't face punishment, continuing her normal life at the academy.

Of course, this would result in Professor McGuire's proposal failing...

However, I plan to prevent this problem from happening at all.

Professor McGuire's proposal event occurs a few days after Luna's presentation.

Before that, I will make Luna an offer.

I'll support her tuition fees.

After all, I have more than enough money to cover her tuition.

My goal isn't Luna.

Whether Luna goes with Evan or not is none of my concern.

My goal is the grimoire.

The grimoire Luna possesses is the record of the Royal Wizard Levian's life-long research.

For some reason, Levian met Luna before his death and passed the grimoire onto her.

That grimoire is a treasure.

A treasure beyond comparison to mere gold.

I'm powerful now.

But if you ask whether I can maintain this strength, the answer is "no."

It's challenging for someone like me, who's barely a genius, to keep up with their growth.

To maintain my strength, I must seize opportunities like these.

Opportunities unrelated to Evan.

Even if the event of Luna destroying the library doesn't happen, it won't affect the story.

If Evan doesn't pay attention to Luna, it's merely an event that gets recorded in the event log.

"Everything is going smoothly."

I've been paying attention to other aspects as well.

I've been keeping an eye on Evan's actions from time to time.

Evan was fully engrossed in his studies.

He didn't seem concerned about Luna and focused on studying.

He hadn't made contact with any other characters yet, so there was nothing else to worry about.

After attending all my classes, I headed to the cafeteria alone.

Eating alone had become a familiar feeling.

"Hi there!"

A red-haired girl holding a lunch tray approached me.

"Can I sit here?"

Judging by her green scarf, she seemed to be a second-year student.

Who is she, and why is she approaching me?

I rummaged through my thoughts.

Red hair... second year...

"Sure, have a seat."

This girl was the top second-year student and student council president...

"My name is Astina Persia."

She introduced herself with a smile.

Astina had investigated Rudy Astria.

A second son overshadowed by his outstanding elder brother... but calling him that would be too much of an understatement.

It was all too easy to hear about the unfortunate incidents that had occurred within the Astria family.

This was his problem.

Usually, it was difficult to find any bad rumors about the children of high-ranking families.

Their families would try to hide any such gossip.

However, Rudy Astria was an exception.

The rumor that he was a child abandoned by the Astria family seemed to be true.

The rumors about him at the academy weren't good either.

His brief speech during the entrance ceremony.

Many of the noble children said it had diminished the authority of the nobility.

They criticized him, saying it was an attitude only befitting commoners.

Moreover, his attitude during Professor Mcguire's class was enough to make everyone feel a sense of aversion.

But despite all that, his actions were quite ordinary.

He attended classes diligently and stayed in his room without going out.

The troublemakers she had seen would go out at night to enjoy themselves.

Of course, they didn't study, and some of them didn't even attend classes properly.

Rudy Astria's actions seemed like those of a typical model student.

"What is he up to?"

Why did he personally make people dislike him?

There was no reason to do so in the small society of the academy.

Even if he couldn't inherit his family later, that attitude was the worst if he wanted to enter politics.

Politicians would tear him apart even if he lived humbly.

Yet he intentionally created trouble for himself.

"Hmm..."

A smile formed on Astina's lips.

She thought she could understand why the strict Professor Cromwell had called him an interesting fellow.

Astina decided to meet him in person.

She thought it was difficult to judge him based on rumors alone.

Discovering that he ate alone every day, she targeted that time to approach him.

"Hello?"

An indifferent expression.

"May I sit here?"

"Yes, please have a seat."

Contrary to his arrogant reputation, he showed manners.

"I'm Astina Persia."

"I'm Rudy Astria."

Rudy introduced himself indifferently.

"Do you know who I am?"

"You're the top second-year student, right?"

He knew about her.

It was expected since she was quite famous at the school.

But his attitude was intriguing.

He was polite but did not engage in any other behavior.

His short answers kept the conversation from flowing smoothly.

It felt as if he was pushing her away.

And he didn't seem like someone who had been alone all this time.

Anyone who is constantly alone would feel lonely.

When someone approached them, they would usually try to speak more.

But he was different.

"Do you know why I came here?"

"I'm not sure."

"That's because... Huh?"

Rudy suddenly stood up from his seat.

"I finished eating, so I'll be going now."

Going?

Isn't he curious?

Why did she come here?

And...

"...I haven't finished eating yet."

Comparing the empty plate in front of Rudy to Astina's, she hadn't even started eating properly, and her plate was still full.

"Then, please enjoy your meal."

"Hey... If you leave, I'll be eating alone."

Flustered, Astina stuttered.

"I eat alone every day, and it's not that bad."

Rudy coldly turned around and left the cafeteria.

"Hey... Hey!"

Astina picked up her plate and chased after Rudy.

"Astina, hello!"

"Uh... Uh, hi!"

"Hello, senior!"

"Yeah, hi."

She wanted to throw away the food on her plate and chase after him, but her friends and juniors kept talking to her.

After greeting everyone and throwing away her food, Rudy's figure had already gone into the distance.

Astina halted in her pursuit.

"...What's with him?"

All she did was stare at Rudy, who was disappearing.

This treatment was a first for her.

Born in a viscount family, she grew up without being ignored by anyone.

Even at the academy, she never let go of her top position.

People of high status, and even the academy professors, never treated her like this.

grumble-

"...I'm hungry."

Astina, like an abandoned puppy, trudged toward the snack bar.

"Why do I keep getting involved with weird people?"

I grumbled as I headed to the next class.

Astina Persia, the top second-year student and student council president.

The student council election was coming up, and she was expected to be elected as the president.

I didn't want to get involved with Astina.

Astina wasn't a particularly important supporting character.

All the main stories revolved around first-year students.

There was usually no reason to interact with students from other grades.

She only showed her face occasionally, just when you'd almost forget about her.

It made sense, as if someone like Astina from another grade got involved in the main story, it would be resolved too easily.

Compared to the first-year students, her abilities would be like a cheat code.

I was already worried about the story getting tangled, so I tried to minimize interactions, no matter how lonely it got.

Then, I felt someone touch my back. When I turned around, there was a petite woman with brown hair.

"Luna Railer?"

"Um... Hi?"

Luna looked awkward as well, making a strange expression.

She was shaking like a small animal in front of a predator.

"Th-this, this class!"

Luna tightly closed her eyes and pointed to the classroom in front of us.

"...This class?"

When I looked at her with a puzzled expression, she stumbled over her words, unable to continue.

Then, she shoved a book in front of me: [Imperial Politics]. It was the class I was going to attend and happened to be a class Luna was in too.

"Uh...!"

Suddenly, Luna rushed into the classroom ahead of us.

"...?"

Yay site is pretty much done! Ads won't be up for a while I think but everything that I wanted is here. Next would be stuff like profile pictures for comments and some loading optimizations but time to focus on some other things like this mobile video editing app I wanna try making.

Anyways, I've re-edited all of the s for all novels. I've decided to completely follow to the author's sentences and spacing. I used to simplify filler text and try to format some sentences to be more impactful or readable especially big blocks of text. But I think its better to be as close as possible to a 1:1 translation even if I think it sounds/looks better in English a certain way.

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Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 7: Luna Railer (2)

Lately, Luna had been experiencing something strange.

Every morning, when she went to her locker to get her books, she found a piece of bread inside.

The same thing happened the day before, and the day before that.

Despite having eaten the bread at lunch, there would always be another piece the next morning.

This prevented her from going hungry, but she gradually started feeling uneasy.

Who could it be?

There's no such thing as a favor without a price.

That was something Luna had heard repeatedly from her father.

Of course, he said it to toughen up his naive daughter, but Luna didn't entirely agree with the statement.

The wizard she met didn't expect anything in return for giving her his magic book.

Luna believed that people sometimes offered favors without expecting anything in return.

However, that was only sometimes. If it continued, there must be a reason.

"How strange..." Luna stared at the bread in her locker.

Someone was definitely putting it there.

If there had been bread in the locker since the first day she used it, she might have thought it was a magical locker that duplicated bread.

But the bread only appeared after she received it from someone.

A mysterious blonde man.

She suspected it could be him since the bread in her locker was the same as the one she had received that day.

But why?

Why was he putting the bread there?

To make himself look good? If he wanted to win her favor, he would have approached her directly instead of remaining unseen.

"Hmmm..."

"Luna!"

"Ah!" Luna was suddenly hugged from behind by someone. It was her friend Rika.

"Rika, good morning."

Rika was a commoner, but she got along really well with Luna.

Luna considered herself closer to a commoner than a noble since she belonged to a low-ranking noble family.

She didn't think she was like the dignified nobles.

Luna felt more similar to the commoners than people like Rudy Astria, whom she had seen in magic theory class.

This way of thinking allowed her to get along with Rika even better.

"Why are you frowning so much?"

Rika clung to Luna's back and poked her furrowed brow.

Luna looked at her and opened her mouth.

"Rika, what would you do if a stranger kept giving you gifts?"

"What?" Rika's expression soured upon hearing that.

"No, no, it's not a serious matter. It's just..."

"How do they give you the gifts?"

"It's not about me. What if something like that happens? Just what if? You got it?"

Feeling that Rika might cause trouble, Luna told a white lie with good intentions.

"Alright, alright. So how did you receive it?"

Rika dismissed the issue with a wave of her hand.

"Well... It was in my locker..."

"Ena!!!"

As soon as Rika heard Luna's words, she grabbed her wrist and rushed into the classroom.

"Rika?"

Ena, who had been reading a book in the classroom, turned around at the sound of Rika's voice.

Rika, a magic department student, was different from Luna since Ena was an alchemy department student.

"Listen, Luna said."

Rika quickly ran to Ena and explained the situation.

Ena listened to Rika's words and hesitated for a moment before speaking.

"A stalker, huh?"

"Right? Isn't it?"

"Ah... no! It's just a guess, right? A guess?"

Luna looked at the two seriously contemplating and continued her excuse while waving her hands.

"Yeah, it's just a guess. But, that person is a stalker, right?"

Rika accepted Luna's guess but went on with a rather realistic piece of advice.

"How about asking for help from the student council or the disciplinary committee?"

Ena agreed as well. Faced with such realistic advice, Luna also began to ponder.

"But still, wouldn't that be going too far...?"

"Luna! What if they suddenly attack you?"

"Attack... seems a bit extreme... but maybe it's better to be cautious?"

Rika spoke animatedly while Ena expressed her concern with a worried face.

Luna somewhat agreed with the two.

It seemed necessary to be cautious.

"Alright..."

Even though she agreed, Luna felt uneasy about suddenly labeling someone who had helped her without causing any harm as a stalker.

Before going to bed, she hugged her pillow and pondered.

"Right... I feel guilty for just receiving their help, so I should at least thank them."

However, waiting in front of her locker in the morning was a bit scary.

As Rika had said, what if they attacked her?

And if they saw her waiting by her locker, they might not approach.

"Should I... hide and watch?"

Luna decided to hide and keep an eye on her locker the next morning. She wanted to find out who that person was.

The next day, Luna woke up early and hid, watching her locker.

Her disguise was somewhat clumsy, but it was difficult to notice her unless one paid close attention.

"Huh?"

The first person to appear near the lockers was Rudy Astria.

He went to his locker and picked up a few books.

"He's up earlier than I thought..."

Luna had gotten the impression that Rudy was somewhat like a delinquent in their Magic Theory class.

She had only heard bad rumors about him from other people, so she thought of him as a troublemaker.

But seeing him getting up early and taking out books made him seem more like an exemplary student.

"Well, he is the top student after all..."

Regardless of his attitude, he was the top student.

Even if his talent was great enough to secure the top spot, it must have taken effort to achieve it.

He had even surpassed the rumored prodigy, Princess Rie, to become the top student.

"Huh?"

But there was something strange.

The small paper bag in his hand. Luna had never thought Rudy Astria could be the person giving her bread.

They had no connection.

They only shared the Magic Theory class and one elective.

Their social status was worlds apart. Grades? There was no need to think about that.

"Ah, he must have brought it for himself to eat."

The paper bag was an ordinary one given out when buying bread at the store.

There was nothing special about it.

As Luna had thought, Rudy took a book out of his locker and turned toward the classroom.

Luna shifted her gaze back to the entrance, waiting for the students to start arriving.

"Oh, right."

Rudy Astria, who had been heading toward the classroom, suddenly turned around and slowly walked towards Luna's locker.

'...'

That's right.

The culprit was Rudy Astria.

Come to think of it, Rudy Astria looked exactly like the description of the first-year student mentioned by the seniors.

Sharp eyes and blonde hair.

Luna watched as Rudy placed bread in the locker and disappeared.

She headed to her locker, maybe he had put it in someone else's locker.

However, she had seen correctly.

There was a paper bag in her locker, and inside it was a warm, freshly-made bread.

A single word floated in her mind: Why?

Why did Rudy Astria put bread in my locker? Luna couldn't understand.

"Ugh..."

She thought her worries would lessen once she found out who was leaving the bread, but they only grew.

From that day on, Luna began to pay attention to Rudy.

Rudy Astria was more ordinary than she had expected.

He listened attentively during class and didn't pay attention to those around him.

He seemed to have no friends, as he ate lunch alone every day.

After class, he immediately returned to the dormitory and didn't come out.

He was too ordinary compared to the rumors.

No, rather than ordinary, he seemed a bit pitiful.

She had been watching him for three days, but she had never seen him converse with anyone.

"Luna!"

While she was deep in thought, Rika approached her, signaling that class had already ended.

It was lunchtime. Rika and Ena had invited her to eat lunch with them every day, but she had always refused, claiming she had something to do or was on a diet.

Instead, she ate the bread Rudy had left for her in the empty classroom.

"Do you want to have lunch...?"

Despite her constant refusals, they still invited her to join them for lunch.

Lately, even their expressions seemed apologetic when they asked. Luna felt guilty for always declining and thought she should at least eat properly.

"...Alright!"

Rika's expression brightened. Luna went to the cafeteria with her friends.

Upon entering, she saw Rudy eating alone, with no one else around him.

Her eyes were drawn to Rudy, who was eating his meal quietly and all by himself.

"Luna?"

"Ah...what?"

"So, did you report the stalker?"

Luna hesitated slightly at Rika's question.

She considered saying it was just her imagination, like last time.

However, both of them seemed to not believe that.

If she said it was her imagination, they would worry even more.

Should she tell her friends that Rudy Astria was the one giving her the bread?

While saying she didn't understand his intentions.

Luna thought about it for a moment but soon gave up.

Rudy Astria's reputation in the academy was the worst.

However, the Rudy she saw didn't seem like such a bad person.

She had only seen him for a very short time, but she couldn't find anything strange about him.

Luna stared intently at Rudy, who left the cafeteria after eating alone.

Then, she made up her mind.

In the end, Luna decided to tell a white lie.

"Now, he doesn't put anything in it."

"Really? Did he hear our conversation?"

"Maybe?"

"That's creepy... Anyway, be careful for a while. He might come to harass you."

"Uh... Okay!"

Luna finished her day and returned to her room.

She didn't understand why Rudy Astria acted like that.

Luna sorted out the situation with the information she had gathered so far.

First of all, as Rika said, it was wrong to think he was a stalker.

She had been watching him constantly, but their eyes never met.

He was just studying diligently.

"Maybe... he needs a friend?"

Rudy Astria couldn't get along well with anyone.

If he had been an ordinary person, he wouldn't have introduced himself like that during class.

His words were very provoking.

An ordinary person would have known that.

Luna made an assumption.

Could it be that he lacked social skills?

As a child of a high-ranking noble, had he never made friends in an ordinary way?

He might want to make friends but not know how.

And giving her bread might be an action showing he wanted to be friends with her.

When she thought about it, the puzzle seemed to fit.

'That's right! I'll be his friend.'

The next day, Luna's resolve wavered when she saw Rudy.

Luna spotted Rudy Astria walking ahead.

And she tried to approach him, just like she had resolved the night before.

However, she had a question.

'How... do you make friends?'

Usually, they became friends without realizing it.

She never directly approached someone and said, 'Let's be friends!'

Moreover, the other person was a boy.

Luna, who had never made a male friend, wondered how to approach him.

'That's right! Let's go to

class together!'

Anyway, this class was one they took together.

She thought she could at least suggest taking the class together.

So, Luna slowly approached Rudy.

Then, she tapped him on the back.

Rudy Astria turned his head and looked at her.

'Ah!'

Contrary to Luna's plan, her body froze in place.

Rudy Astria looked at her, as if to ask what was happening.

Luna's mind turned to stone.

'What was I going to say... Ah, right!'

Luna barely managed to open her mouth.

"Um... hi?"

Yes. Start with a slow greeting...

...

What should she say next?

Her mind went blank.

As Rudy Astria's sharp gaze pierced her, she began to feel scared.

'I wanted to ask if you'd like to attend this class together.'

"Th-this, this class!"

In her panic, Luna couldn't properly articulate her words and ended up blurting out a single scream.

Rudy Astria tilted his head, looking at her with a 'What are you talking about?' expression.

Feeling the need to explain herself, Luna thrust the book she was holding towards him.

'Th... this idiot!'

Luna was shocked by her own actions, and her face began to redden.

She quickly thought of a new plan.

'Let's... let's try again next time!'

Without properly explaining herself, Luna dashed into the classroom.

Even after entering the classroom and after the class ended, Luna didn't say anything to Rudy.

She simply ran back to the dormitory as soon as the class finished.

Luna entered her dorm room and confirmed that her roommates weren't there.

"...What did I just do?"

Luna lay on her bed and pulled the blanket up to her chin.

-Thump! Thump! Thump!

Only the sound of Luna's feet kicking the blanket filled the room.

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Chapter 8: Luna Railer (3)

After Luna spoke to me,

her attitude seemed a bit odd.

Whenever I saw Luna Railer in the hallway, our eyes would meet.

However, she didn't talk to me, only looking surprised and then running away.

I wasn't exactly sure why she approached me.

The most probable reason was that she noticed me giving her bread.

There wasn't any other reason for me to be involved with Luna...

I wasn't doing anything other than studying.

More importantly, it was puzzling why Astina sought me out.

Why would someone who doesn't even interact with Evan get involved with me?

Nevertheless, I felt I managed to keep my distance.

I hadn't seen her since she visited me at lunch.

Anyway, Astina was busy with the upcoming student council election, so it wasn't a big concern.

"Today, I will give you your first assignment."

Today's first class was Professor Mcguire's Magic Theory course.

"We've been learning about magic circles, right? So, I'm going to give you an assignment to draw a magic circle."

Magic circle composition assignment.

Luna's time to shine was approaching.

"I won't ask you to create an extraordinary magic circle. Just add a few components to the basic magic circle framework."

Then, Professor Mcguire drew a simple magic circle on the blackboard.

"Let's say we have a magic circle that uses the Ignite spell. What would happen if we added acceleration to it?"

"...An explosion?"

Luna answered in a small voice.

Professor Mcguire nodded with a smile.

"Correct. The fire would appear as an explosion due to its rapid speed. To cause a proper explosion, you'd need to add a symbol for enhancement and adjust the control of mana."

After saying that, he wrote a few items on the blackboard.

1. Creativity

2. Efficiency

3. Activation Possibility

"We'll evaluate your work based on these three aspects. However, activation possibility is the most important. No matter how creative a magic circle is, it's meaningless if it can't be activated. Any questions?"

The students remained silent, so Professor Mcguire closed his book.

"There's no need to draw a magic circle that can be used in daily life or battle. Of course, it would be nice if you could draw such a magic circle, but that would be a typical one. Create an efficient and unique magic circle."

Even after saying that, the students' expressions weren't very positive.

Frankly, it was a huge burden for students who hadn't properly learned magic yet to create magic circles.

Seeing this, Professor Mcguire smiled slightly and said,

"Don't worry too much. As long as you put in some effort, I'll give you full marks. That's it for today's class."

A magic circle...

After finishing classes that day, I headed to the library.

I was worried about whether Luna could draw a proper magic circle, but first, I needed to draw one myself to get good grades.

It's possible to draw a magic circle just by looking at the textbook.

However, it would be better to have reference books as well.

Since there were barely any books other than textbooks in my dorm room, I had to go to the library to find many reference materials.

As soon as I entered the library, its magnificent appearance caught my eye.

Liberion Academy was not only the Empire's largest educational institution but also its largest research institution.

Professors here were both educators and researchers, like those in a university.

All the books needed by such researchers could be found in this library.

Of course, important materials were stored separately in the Imperial Library, but the place with the most resources was the library of Liberion Academy.

As I looked around, I saw a librarian organizing books.

I approached them.

"I'd like to find a book related to basic magic circles."

When I asked, they pointed in one direction and spoke.

"Basic magic circles can be found in Section C, bookshelf 7."

Following the librarian's directions, I found numerous books related to magic circles.

I picked one and headed to a desk in the corner of the library.

There, I saw Luna Railer studying with a few books.

Is she studying here?

Well...

Luna probably didn't get assigned to a good dormitory, so she lacks study space.

In my case, I have a single room and a well-equipped study environment.

But for students with poor grades, their dorms are shared rooms, making it difficult to study in the room.

There are students resting in the room and others chatting loudly.

I quietly pulled out a chair diagonally across from her and sat down.

Luna was so focused that she didn't even notice I had arrived.

I considered greeting her briefly, but I didn't want to disturb her concentration, so I just took my seat.

If I somehow ruined her focus and she missed out on a revelation, failing to get good results on the assignment, the story might get twisted.

No, even if the story isn't affected, my plan would be ruined.

So, I didn't bother Luna, who was concentrating, and started my own studies.

Several hours passed like this.

When I entered, the sun was still up, but now the twilight had faded, and it was dark outside.

Even though so much time had passed, Luna didn't move once and remained focused on her studies.

I stretched, feeling stiff, and fetched other books, but Luna didn't budge, immersed in her studies.

Her hands only moved occasionally to flip through pages or practice drawing magic circles on paper.

She truly excelled in the field of magic theory.

"Ugh..."

Luna seemed to be getting tired, raising her arm to stretch.

Hearing Luna's movement, I looked up, and our eyes met.

"Kyaaah!!!"

Surprised, Luna let out a loud scream.

"Why... Why are you here...!"

With wide eyes, Luna shouted at me.

Then, the librarian I saw earlier walked over.

"Excuse me..."

The librarian tapped Luna's shoulder and raised his index finger to his lips.

"I-I'm sorry..."

Luna apologized in a hushed voice to the librarian and then approached me.

"Why are you here? Could it be..."

"Could it be?"

"Stalking or something...!"

Stalking?

As I raised my eyebrows slightly, Luna flinched and stepped back a little.

I pointed at the book I was looking at.

"Didn't you see I was doing Professor Mcguire's assignment? Weren't you doing the same?"

"Ah..."

Luna glanced at the magic circle I drew and closed her mouth.

"I-I'm sorry."

Luna's face turned slightly red as she bowed her head in response to my words.

"Did you finish this assignment?"

As I changed the subject and asked, Luna nodded her head.

Already finished?

I felt a little anxious.

Could she have completed it so soon after the assignment was given?

I was taking a long time to draw an unusual magic circle.

But if she had already finished, she might have drawn a regular magic circle.

"Can I see it?"

I need to check.

"C-cheating is not allowed."

"I'm not doing that. Let's just exchange opinions on the assignment as friends. Sharing opinions could lead to better ideas."

"F-friends?"

Luna reacted to a strange part.

Is it weird to call her a friend?

Still, we're classmates taking the same course, so isn't it okay to call her a friend?

"Yeah. Friends."

"R-right. Friends."

"Right. So speak informally. There's no need for honorifics within the academy."

I spoke casually to Luna.

Although it was a bit off from my original image, I thought it was okay for Luna.

After all, I was planning to be Luna's sponsor once this assignment was over.

Then, Luna would be on my side anyway.

If Luna's grades improve and she receives a scholarship later, I don't have to sponsor her, but until then, she's on my side.

And acting casually isn't a bad thing, is it?

There's no harm to me even if people hear about it

.

Rather, it could be a gain.

Rumors that I was thought to be a bad person but turned out to be okay could spread.

Well, even if rumors of me being casual spread, it would likely be treated as a baseless rumor.

"O-okay."

Luna brought the magic circle she drew.

"Huh?"

Upon seeing Luna's magic circle, dozens of question marks formed in my mind.

"It's a square?"

Luna's magic circle wasn't round.

It had a square shape with various magic formulas inside.

"Well... I did some calculations, and to use these formulas, a square magic circle is the most efficient."

The most basic theory of magic circles.

No. Just an accepted fact.

It's about putting magic formulas inside a circle.

The circle in the magic circle represents the control field of magic.

It's a control field for managing the central magic formula.

Maintaining an equal distance between the main magic formula written in the center and the control field makes it easier to modify the magic circle.

Different shapes require multiple calculations of control formulas due to the varying distances from the central magic formula.

On the other hand, a circle has an equal distance between the center and the edge, so it only requires one calculation.

That's why magic circles were typically drawn as circles.

"Can it be set up like this?"

I raised my head and asked Luna.

Since I still don't know much about magic circles, I wasn't sure if it would work or not.

"I just thought it would work, so I tried..."

Luna's expression seemed to question why I was asking.

"What if the magic circle doesn't activate?"

Surely, submitting it like this would earn high points for creativity.

However, as Professor McGuire said, the most important thing is whether it activates or not.

No matter how unique the magic circle is, if it doesn't activate, it won't even receive basic points.

"Is it...? It seems like it would work... Should I fix it?"

Luna spoke with an uncertain voice.

"Hmm..."

If she were an ordinary student, I would have scolded them and told them to change it.

That would be the realistic approach.

Right now, that approach would be correct to get a good grade.

However, the one across from me is Luna Railer.

I wondered if such unconventional thinking made her a genius.

One reason why people say the rote learning education system in Korea is wrong is that it forces students to follow established facts and proven methods.

Adults teach children to take the safest and most comfortable path, rather than discover new facts.

When encountering unique individuals, they should teach that they are 'different' from us, but instead, they educate them as if they are 'wrong.'

So, people tend to try to think like those around them.

Because those who are different are considered 'wrong.'

"Is it... a bit like that?"

As I kept staring at the magic circle without saying anything, Luna started to gauge my reaction.

"Can you follow me for a moment?"

"Eh?"

I grabbed the magic circle and headed towards my dormitory.

"Where are we going?"

Luna half-ran to catch up with me, as my pace was too fast.

I slowed down for her and spoke.

"The laboratory given to the top student."

"Th... the laboratory? At this hour?"

I went down to the basement of the dormitory.

There were several rooms in the basement.

Ignoring the other rooms, I headed to the one at the very end.

A light was coming from the magic circle next to the doorknob of that room.

'Put your hand here, was it...?'

After being assigned to a dormitory, the housekeeper who managed it came to inform me.

She told me there was a laboratory in the basement and to place my hand on the magic circle there to open the entrance.

When I touched the magic circle, the door opened.

I entered through the opened door.

"What are you doing?"

Although I went in, Luna hesitated to enter the laboratory.

Finally, as if she had made up her mind, she widened her eyes and entered the lab.

The lab wasn't an extraordinary place.

It simply had good soundproofing and was equipped to handle impacts.

To be honest, it didn't feel like a lab.

It was just a place where magic could be used freely.

It felt more like an experimental room.

"But why did we come here?"

"To try an experiment."

I began to copy the magic circle Luna drew onto a piece of paper next to it.

This paper wasn't ordinary.

It was infused with mana, making it suitable for using magic circles.

It's a 'temporary scroll.'

Though advanced magic circles required proper 'scrolls,' basic magic circles could be activated with these 'temporary scrolls.'

The magic circle Luna drew was unique but very basic.

So it should be possible to activate it with this paper.

After copying the magic circle, I looked at Luna.

"Let's give it a try."

I immediately tore the paper.

As the paper ripped, a bright light burst out.

"Wow...!"

The magic circle was activated, and small lights spread out around us.

Then, about four or five little lights began to fly around the room.

The main magic formula in the circle Luna created was from the fire element - Light.

It was a magic spell that illuminated the surroundings.

However, it wasn't just Light; it also had the effects of persistence and duplication.

Several small lights started to circle around us.

"Does...does it work?"

Luna stared blankly at the floating lights in the lab.

Seeing her like that, I gave her a slight smile.

Luna was 'different' from us.

If she hadn't received any education, she wouldn't have doubted this rectangular magic circle.

But because she had been educated with what was 'right' and 'wrong', she doubted herself.

"You're amazing."

As I told her that, she looked at me with a bewildered expression.

"I said, you're amazing."

I smiled at her and gave her a thumbs-up.

Chapter 9: Luna Railer (4)

"Luna Railer, well done."

"Th-thank you!"

Luna's magic circle received high praise from Professor Mcguire.

Using a shape other than a circle for a magic circle is, in fact, a technique used in the magic world.

It's true that circular magic circles are easier to create.

However, when striving for the utmost efficiency, it's said that magic circles can be made with other shapes as well.

The fact that she created such a magic circle without knowing this carries significant meaning.

Genius.

Is there any other way to describe her?

If you simply look at it, you might say, "Anyone could come up with that idea."

But conceiving it without any prior knowledge isn't easy.

And she did it.

Moreover, the fact that her magic circle activates is crucial.

There may be a few other students who thought of different shapes for their magic circles, due to the hint of creativity on Professor Mcguire's grading sheet.

Hearing the term "unique magic circle," people would typically think of a visually distinctive one.

However, after a few attempts, most would give up.

For ordinary people, it's challenging to determine whether such a magic circle is efficient and to meet the activation requirements.

A regular person would find it more convenient to stick to established theories when designing a magic circle.

Luna stood out among these ordinary people.

She created her own magic circle and eventually completed it.

This was the mark of a genius, unlike ordinary individuals.

A genius isn't just someone who comes up with novel ideas.

A true genius is someone who explores and perfects their ideas.

"Everyone, let's give a round of applause."

Following Professor Mcguire's words, the students clapped for Luna.

Her face turned red, seemingly embarrassed, as she scratched her head.

Then, she caught my gaze and gave me a slight smile.

It was a different behavior from her previous avoidance.

Had she finally acknowledged me as a friend?

It was a positive change in our relationship.

Now, all I needed to do was propose my sponsorship to Luna.

The conditions for sponsorship weren't related to the magic book.

It would be under the conditions suggested by Professor Mcguire.

In exchange for receiving research results, I would provide sponsorship.

I hope to prevent the incident where Luna destroys the library.

Professor Mcguire asked Luna to produce results within a certain period.

However, I planned to make a different proposal.

I wouldn't specify a deadline; instead, I'd ask her to show me the results when they were ready.

This way, I could learn from the shared research and alleviate any time-related pressure on Luna.

This difference was crucial for Luna, who would eventually reach for 'that book' out of desperation.

Although the punishment for destroying the library wasn't severe, there was one crucial point.

The confiscation of the magic book Luna had used.

It was a natural consequence since the book had essentially caused the damage.

I intended to prevent the book's confiscation and use it myself.

There was no need to obtain the book hastily.

First, I had to reach at least the intermediate level in magic to utilize the book.

I'd slowly improve my magic abilities and borrow the book later.

I could take my time to decide how I'd borrow it.

I'd simply borrow it depending on the circumstances.

My current magic level was Beginner LV 6.

Upon reaching LV 9 and growing further, I'd obtain Intermediate Magic LV 1.

Until then, obtaining the book would be more harmful than helpful.

Moreover, borrowing the book wouldn't affect Luna's growth.

Her magic was still significantly weaker than mine.

In other words, even when I reached the intermediate level, Luna would still be using beginner magic.

It wouldn't be a problem to borrow the book for a while, as she couldn't use it anyway.

"Sigh..."

I mentally organized my thoughts and prepared myself.

I opened the notebook where I had roughly organized what I wanted to say.

As I skimmed through the pages, I saw the phrase I had written at the bottom.

"...Should I leave this part out?"

It was a peaceful day.

Not a single cloud marred the clear sky.

Luna sat alone in the garden and opened the paper bag.

As she sat on a bench beneath the shade, a cool breeze tickled her hair.

Luna brushed her hair behind her ears and took a bite of the bread from the bag.

A happy smile spread across her face as she chewed the bread.

"Hehe..."

Today was such a joyful day.

For the first time in her life, she received genuine praise for her magic.

It wasn't just an empty compliment, but high praise.

Luna's smile reached for the sky.

"...Hehehe..."

An involuntary, silly laugh escaped her lips.

Although she was eating the bread alone, it tasted sweeter than any feast she'd had at the mansion.

She owed her ability to receive such praise entirely to Rudy.

At first, she had been genuinely scared when he took her to the laboratory.

It was frightening to be led to a quiet place where no one else was around.

However, her worries had been unfounded.

Rudy was just as kind a friend as she had thought.

Luna didn't even have enough money for meals right now.

That's why she couldn't afford even a relatively inexpensive "temporary scroll."

She had considered asking Ena for help, or even switching to a regular magic circle.

But Rudy had been a lifesaver for her.

'Did Rudy know I don't have money?'

She had suspected as much when he gave her the bread.

But how did he know?

Luna's family wasn't famous.

So, there was no way Rudy would know or care about her family's financial situation.

They were just a small family in a remote region.

"...He seems kind, but also...not..."

Luna tilted her head in confusion, chewing on the bread.

"What's not?"

"Uh!"

Luna jumped in surprise at the voice coming from behind her.

Fortunately, the sound didn't travel far as she had a mouthful of bread.

"Ru...Rudy?"

Rudy stood behind Luna.

"Is the bread good?"

"Bread... Bread? Bread... Yes, it's delicious!"

Luna alternated her gaze between the bread and Rudy.

Had he never tasted it before?

He had always given it to her, but it seemed he hadn't eaten it himself.

Recalling her previous mistake, Luna tried her best to keep her composure and speak calmly.

She knew that Rudy put bread in her locker, but he didn't know she knew.

Saying, "I hid nearby and saw you putting bread in my locker!" would sound strange.

That would make her a real stalker.

"You did well in the presentation today. The magic circle seemed to be more refined, too."

"...Hehe, it's all thanks to Rudy."

Luna laughed in response to Rudy's compliment.

Feeling somewhat shy, she lowered her head and scratched her head.

Then, in a soft voice, she said once more:

"It's all thanks to Rudy..."

Luna couldn't be certain about the magic circle she created.

She wasn't sure if it was the right path.

Rudy was the one who told her it was the right way.

He gave her confidence in her path.

He infused confidence into the wandering Luna.

"If it weren't for Rudy, I might not have submitted it."

No matter how great a magic circle was, if it wasn't known to the world, it was meaningless.

It would have been nothing more than self-satisfaction.

So the magic circle could come into the world thanks to Rudy.

"Luna."

At Rudy's words, Luna looked at him standing there.

Rudy's face was utterly serious.

"I have something to say."

"Y-you do?"

Luna's eyes widened at Rudy's words.

Rudy, seriously talking to me?

Imaginations unfurled in Luna's head.

She stared blankly at Rudy with her mouth open.

Could it be... Rudy... likes me?

However, the words that came out of Rudy's mouth were truly unexpected.

"Do you want me to sponsor you?"

"Sponsor?"

"I'll support your tuition and research funds. I'll sponsor you under my name."

"...?"

Luna was bewildered by the sudden, out-of-the-blue statement.

And she felt embarrassed for her wild imagination.

'I...I was surprised.'

Luna calmed her pounding heart and slowly thought about Rudy's proposal.

It was common for nobles to support students.

Nobles would support students who struggled with tuition or who had low overall grades but excelled in one area.

It was a way to build connections with outstanding students early on.

"But... I'm still an inexperienced student, aren't I?"

However, Luna thought she was still lacking.

She had been praised in class this time, but couldn't it have been just good luck?

And she wondered.

There was no difference between her and other students.

She was just an ordinary student.

So she was curious.

"Why... did you offer it to me?"

Rudy simply said,

"Potential."

And he continued without hesitation.

"Your efforts and the results you've shown. Isn't that enough?"

"It might be a hasty decision. There's no guarantee I'll become an outstanding student."

Then, Rudy gave a faint smile.

"It would be a shame to miss out on talent right in front of me."

Rudy called me talented.

Luna felt warmth in her heart upon hearing those words.

Though she had hoped for a different confession, that confession was enough to make Luna happy.

However, Luna shook her head and regained her senses.

While she was grateful for his words, she couldn't help but wonder if there was an ulterior motive.

He had given her bread and even proposed sponsorship.

He must have expectations for her.

But no one knew what his intentions were.

Did he suggest it because he had a different idea in mind?

Could there be ill intentions behind it?

As Luna pondered, Rudy opened his mouth to speak.

"Um... and."

"Huh?"

"There's one more thing I want to say..."

At this, Luna felt a tinge of anxiety.

Was there indeed some hidden agenda behind his proposal?

Just when she was about to feel disappointed, she heard Rudy's words.

"Would you like to have lunch together?"

"...?"

"No, this isn't a condition for the sponsorship, I just thought we could have lunch together as friends."

Rudy, who usually didn't show much emotion, was visibly different this time.

His face had turned slightly red, and he frowned a little.

His expression was no longer charismatic and sharp.

Seeing him like this, Luna couldn't help but smile.

"Pfft..."

And she felt somewhat reassured.

Luna sensed that her initial thoughts about Rudy Astria needing a friend were accurate.

The concerns about the motives behind his sponsorship proposal and complicated thoughts flew out of her mind.

It wouldn't make sense for someone who said such things to sponsor her with the intention of harming her.

"Alright, I'll accept your proposal."

Luna replied with a smile.

At that, Rudy's expression relaxed.

"Then, I'm counting on you, my sponsor."

Luna grinned and reached out her hand.

Rudy grasped it and smiled faintly.

Some long blocks of text in this chappy.. Is it easier if they're split into maybe 3 lines max? or nah whatever

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 10: Student Council Presidential Election (1)

Nothing ever goes exactly as planned.

Of course, in the grand scheme of things, it may appear that it did.

However, it's impossible for every small detail to proceed according to plan.

Countless variables exist.

Sometimes luck doesn't cooperate, and at other times, predictions may be off, causing things to go awry.

"Rudy Astria."

Such variables can be addressed with adaptability.

However, the outcome may change depending on the adaptation.

Nevertheless, one must make an effort.

To achieve the best possible results.

"Could you give me a hand?"

I could hear the students chatting in the classroom.

"Evan, a commoner, fought with Baron William's son?"

"They say Baron William's brat started the quarrel."

"Evan... I've never heard of him before... Well, at least that ruffian got what he deserved. That's satisfying."

After making a contract with Luna, I devoted myself to my studies.

Even though I only focused on studying, the main story continued to unfold.

Evan caught the professor's attention during magic practice and even ended up fighting with some troublemakers.

Slowly, the protagonist began to make a name for himself at the academy.

When I heard the news, I felt relieved that Evan was growing well.

However, the news that followed made my head throb.

"Rudy Astria, could you please come to the discipline office for a moment?"

A student called out to me.

He wore a green scarf, indicating he was a second-year student.

On his arm was a badge with the word "Discipline."

The Discipline Committee.

At Liberion Academy, it was more than just an ordinary discipline committee.

Typically, students with average swordsmanship skills but lacking money for tuition would join the committee to earn some money.

However, the committee also oversaw criminal activities that occurred within the academy.

While they handled minor disputes, if a major incident occurred, the empire would dispatch investigators or professors would deal with it.

In a way, they were like local security guards with some power.

But why were they calling me?

I couldn't see a reason.

I hadn't been causing any trouble and had just been focusing on my studies.

There was no need for the discipline committee to involve me, as I hadn't done anything wrong.

With these questions in mind, I went to the office and saw the red-haired ruffian I had encountered before.

"Rudy Astria ordered it..."

"What?"

The ruffian pointed at me as he spoke.

I was puzzled by what he was saying.

"Rudy Astria, is this true?"

"I'm not even sure what's going on. What's the matter?"

When I asked, the committee member stroked his chin.

Ah...

I had a feeling I knew what was happening.

That red-headed ruffian had fought Evan and now accused me of being behind it.

This situation wasn't just my speculation.

If things had gone according to the original story, that's how it should have played out.

However, the current situation was slightly different.

"I have no idea what you're talking about."

The disciplinary committee briefly explained the situation, and I denied their accusation.

However, this was the problem.

In the game, Rudy Astria would have denied responsibility after causing trouble himself.

The game's situation overlapped with my current predicament.

Even though I didn't do anything, people thought I was trying to evade the blame.

It was simply infuriating.

How should I explain this...

"Hmm..."

The disciplinary committee members shot me suspicious glances.

But nobody openly expressed their doubts.

Instead, they just kept watching me with suspicion.

This was giving me a headache.

In the game, Rudy Astria hung out with that guy, but I told him to leave me alone.

Ever since then, I hadn't seen him, and their suspicions only made my head throb.

I felt like just leaving this place, like Rudy Astria in the game.

"Why do you keep holding onto someone who claims they didn't do it?"

A man with his hand in his pocket approached us.

He was dressed casually, wearing glasses, and had a scruffy beard that seemed to be the result of not shaving for a few days, rather than intentionally grown out.

He looked like a typical middle-aged man who might be on his way to buy soju at the local supermarket.

"Ah... Professor."

"What's the point of holding onto someone who says they didn't do it? You think you're accomplishing something by trying to maintain security in the academy? You're not even investigators."

The man, referred to as a professor, grumbled and left the disciplinary committee room.

The second-year student who brought me in then spoke up.

"Go on."

As soon as I heard those words, I followed the professor who had just helped me.

Since he'd come to my aid while I was being falsely accused, I wanted to at least express my gratitude and ask for his name.

"Excuse me... Professor?"

I tried to start a conversation, but the professor ignored me and kept walking.

"Professor."

"Professor?"

"Professor? Can you hear me?"

When I kept following and talking to him, the professor finally turned around.

"Why do you keep bothering me?"

"Thank you for your help."

I expressed my gratitude, and he waved his hand dismissively.

"Fine, now go."

"May I ask your name, sir?"

The professor then gave a short response.

"Robert."

With that, he walked away with an air of nonchalance.

"Understood. Thank you."

I didn't want to be a nuisance, so I backed off.

"Robert..."

I mulled over the professor's name as I headed towards my next class.

After all the classes had ended, I was tidying up my books.

"Rudy!"

From afar, Luna approached with a worried expression.

"Rudy, are you alright? I heard you went to the student council room."

"Ah, I think it's nothing serious."

Surely they wouldn't call me back for questioning without any evidence.

If they did, I'd have no choice but to take a firm stance.

Regardless, my anger surged at the thought of letting that red-headed brat off the hook.

He probably knew what he was getting into when he used my name.

He knew my reputation as Rudy Astria wasn't great, so he figured he could use me.

In his mind, he'd probably avoided punishment as much as possible while taking revenge for when I told him to get lost last time.

What could a third-rate punk like him be thinking?

I wasn't going to let this slide.

If I let it pass now, something like this would happen again.

"I'm glad it's nothing serious."

Luna said, her expression relaxing.

"Oh! Are you going to the library today?"

Luna asked me with a beaming smile.

Behind her, two students glared at me.

Luna seemed oblivious to this, smiling innocently.

"I don't think I can go today."

"Is that so?"

Lately, I've been studying with Luna in the library.

Of course, when it came to practicing magic, we went to separate research rooms.

However, for theory-related studies and other subjects, we headed to the library.

Since she asked me every day to join her, I couldn't refuse.

"Luna, it's time for class. Shall we go?"

"Huh? Sure! Let's go."

When we studied in the library, it wasn't just the two of us.

Luna's friends were there every day as well.

Rika was quite open about her dislike for me, while Ena tried to peer into my heart like Princess Rie.

Their gazes made me uncomfortable, but they didn't interfere with my studies or cause me any harm, so I ignored them and carried on.

After finishing all my classes, I headed to the top student research room in the dormitory basement.

"Status window."

「Name: Rudy Astria

Age: 17

Abilities:

Beginner Magic: LV 6

Fire Attribute Magic: LV 5

Wind Attribute Magic: LV 4

Earth Attribute Magic: LV 2

Swordsmanship: LV 2

Elemental Magic: LV 2」

While studying magic alone, I had acquired Earth Attribute Magic.

Frankly, I didn't think I would use it much, but it was a necessary step to raise my magic level.

My Fire Attribute Magic was at level 5, and while it would become more powerful as it grew, its growth rate was too slow.

So, I resorted to a trick.

Instead of delving deeply into one type of magic, I learned several types to quickly reach intermediate magic.

As we advanced, basic attribute magic became less useful in battle.

Of course, it could be helpful if applied well.

However, I was an ordinary modern person.

A modern person who had never fought anyone before.

I didn't have the ability to think of various ways to apply magic in a fight with someone.

So, to defeat my opponents, overwhelming them with sheer power was the best approach.

For now, my goal was to quickly advance my basic attribute magic and reach intermediate magic.

Then, I would learn dark magic among the attribute magics.

Dark magic wasn't well-regarded.

People perceived it as ominous because of the risk of mental contamination when spells failed.

But one thing was certain: the power of dark magic.

Everyone acknowledged that fact.

Dark magic boasted much greater power than magic of the same level.

It was a high-risk, high-return magic: dark magic.

"I was going to ask Professor Cromwell for a favor..."

Robert, one of the few dark magic professors at the academy, didn't have a family name, which was unusual.

I didn't know much about him since I hadn't seen him in the game.

All I knew was that he was close to Professor Cromwell, so I intended to ask Cromwell for an introduction.

"But why was he there?"

There wasn't much reason for the professor to be in the guidance room.

"Ugh... I'll think about that later."

Gathering mana in my hand, I recited the incantation.

"Water Ball."

Upon speaking, small water droplets gathered before my eyes.

"Should be good now. Status window."

「Name: Rudy Astria

Age: 17

Abilities:

Beginner Magic: LV 7

Fire Attribute Magic: LV 5

Wind Attribute Magic: LV 4

Earth Attribute Magic: LV 2

Water Attribute Magic: LV 1

Swordsmanship: LV 2

Elemental Magic: LV 2」

Finally, my beginner magic reached level 7.

It was a sweet accomplishment.

The hard work I put into Professor Cromwell's classes had paid off.

Knock knock

While I was relishing my achievement, I heard a knock on the door.

"Who is it?"

"It's Housekeeper Azela."

Housekeeper Azela was the chief administrator managing the dormitory.

I had encountered her before, but this was our first direct meeting.

"Come in."

"Hello."

Azela greeted me with a polite and upright posture, like a textbook example.

"What's the matter?"

"It's dinner time, and I noticed you haven't come out, so I thought I'd inform you."

Has it already been that long?

The laboratory had protective magic on all the walls, so there were no windows.

That's why I had been practicing magic without realizing the sun had set.

But did maids usually inform students about meal times?

I didn't know because I usually went to eat right on schedule.

Well, she was managing all the dormitory students, so it made sense.

I heard that female students received help with their hair and makeup, but as a male, I didn't need such assistance.

"And also..."

"...?"

"Miss Astina Persia asked if you would like to have dinner together if you haven't eaten yet."

"What?"

So that's why she came.

Why was that person calling for me again?

Wasn't leaving someone who hadn't finished their food a gentle refusal?

I thought she'd understand I didn't want to get closer...

I thought she had stopped paying attention to me, but apparently not.

She had a student council election next week and should be busy.

But I don't understand why she's doing this to me.

Should I tell her directly to stop approaching me?

It seemed better to meet her in person and talk since she would approach me

again even if I avoided this meal.

"Tell her I'll meet her in front of the dormitory in 10 minutes."

"Understood."

I quickly tidied up the books and went to the dormitory entrance.

A red-haired woman stood there.

"It's been a while, Rudy Astria."

"Hello."

Astina usually wore her hair up, but today it was down.

Her usual look was too prim, giving off a stifling impression, but today she appeared more relaxed.

Astina's typical image was that of a stern female knight.

Although she belonged to the magic department, her demeanor was no different from that of a serious, aspiring female knight.

"Is it alright to keep your senior waiting?"

Astina wore a slightly annoyed expression as she spoke.

"I apologize. I didn't have time to prepare since you suddenly made plans."

You're the one who asked to meet so suddenly.

I came out within the 10 minutes I said I would.

I kept the appointment.

But with her saying that, I couldn't help but feel wronged.

Then Astina revealed a playful smile and opened her mouth.

"Just kidding. Let's go grab some food."

Are we even that close?

It would have been more understandable if Astina was genuinely angry, but this friendly attitude made it even more awkward.

What pace should I follow?

"Hello, Senior Astina."

"Yeah, hello."

As Astina walked, the surrounding students greeted her.

Being the top second-year student and a strong candidate for the student council president, she was the object of everyone's admiration.

Since she approached everyone warmly and never failed to return their greetings, people couldn't help but like her.

"Let's eat."

Astina accepted everyone's greetings, causing our mealtime to be slightly delayed.

And then...

"Who's that?"

"Isn't that Rudy Astria? Why is Senior Astina with him...?"

Everyone's attention was on us.

It was a headache.

I did my best to avoid drawing people's attention.

If someone disliked you and you kept being noticed, their opinion wouldn't change.

It would only remind them of their dislike.

So, I planned to lay low until people forgot about me.

Of course, I had to provoke Evan's competitive spirit and promote his growth.

But with my abilities lacking, I didn't have time to give him encouragement.

"I heard you've been studying hard lately. How's your progress?"

Astina continued the casual conversation, as if she knew my thoughts.

I vaguely answered her questions while looking for an opportunity.

An opportunity to tell her not to approach me anymore.

"Don't you find it boring to study all the time? Don't you have any hobbies?"

"Studying is my entire life."

It wasn't a lie.

If I didn't study now, I'd die later.

"Really? So you don't have any hobbies?"

"No, I don't."

As we continued our casual conversation, a question arose in my mind.

Did she call me just to have this kind of conversation?

Astina wasn't friendless like me.

She'd have these casual conversations all the time, so why come to me?

While we were talking, Astina's expression changed slightly.

"You know I'm running for student council president soon, right?"

"There's no one at the academy who wouldn't know."

Then Astina spoke with a completely different atmosphere.

"Rudy Astria."

A serious expression.

"Could you give me a hand?"

"..."

What kind of nonsense is this?

"Without Rudy Astria here, I feel so much more at ease."

"Rika! Don't be so mean to Rudy!"

Luna and Rika were on their way to eat after studying in the library.

Ena had said she would eat separately due to an alchemy experiment, so it was just the two of them.

Lately, Luna had been having lunch with Rudy.

However, unless they made plans, they didn't eat dinner together.

"Uh...?"

While Luna was getting her food, she noticed a familiar face.

"Rudy?"

It was definitely Rudy Astria.

But he was in a rather unexpected situation.

He was eating with someone else.

And that someone was a girl.

It's getting interesting!

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 11: Student Council Presidential Election (2)

Top second-year student.

Daughter of Viscount Persia.

Next student council president.

Titles like these made Astina shine.

Although there were people more outstanding than her, they didn't ignore her.

They respected her, thinking she could catch up to them someday.

However, Rudy Astria was different.

"What on earth?"

Even after being rejected by Rudy Astria, Astina continued to investigate him.

At first, it was out of curiosity, but now it was out of resentment.

Of course, considering the reputation of the Astria ducal family, she thought they might behave this way.

The top wizard family of the empire and the most arrogant family.

Everyone knew of their fame.

But it felt terribly unfair to her that she had been treated this way by Rudy Astria.

In terms of magical ability and social life, Astina was more accomplished.

Yet, she couldn't fathom why he ignored her.

"Did he study all day today, too?"

"Yes."

Astina had the dormitory maids report on Rudy's activities.

It wasn't something the maids should be doing.

However, there was nothing money and fame couldn't achieve.

"Studying nonstop since the entrance ceremony... for a month?"

At first, Astina thought nothing of Rudy's studying for a few days.

But gradually, she sensed something was off.

Didn't he get tired?

Rudy Astria studied even on weekends without taking a break.

Of course, he was often seen shut in his room.

He might have been resting in his room, but seeing him studying at the library lately made her doubt it.

An incredibly hard worker.

That's the only thought she had.

She believed she studied diligently too, but she didn't study without a single day off for a month.

She would chat with friends, go to places like bakeries to eat sweets, or go shopping.

However, Rudy Astria had none of that.

Recently, it seemed he had become friendly with a female student named Luna Railer.

Yet, there were no sightings of them going out to have fun or chatting happily together.

They were only seen studying at the library.

I could make an educated guess at this point.

The reason Rudy Astria was abandoned by his family.

It might be due to a lack of talent.

Although he had exceptional magic skills for a first-year student, his abilities fell short compared to other members of the Astria family.

His older brother had achieved numerous accomplishments, such as becoming the academy's student council president as soon as he entered the academy and graduating as the top student.

Rudy Astria, who only managed to secure the top seat and failed to stand out in other ways, couldn't help but be compared to his older brother.

Considering the current situation, it wasn't because Rudy lacked effort compared to his brother.

Nor was there anything unusual about his behavior.

The only explanation left was a lack of talent.

Even with tireless effort within the family, he was still far inferior to his brother.

Seeing this, the head of the family decided to focus all resources on Rudy's brother and cast Rudy aside like a discarded child.

This was the story Astina Persia had imagined for Rudy Astria.

"Hmm..."

Were they kindred spirits?

Astina's reason for working so hard at the academy was to inherit her family's title.

There were currently two heirs in the Persia family.

Astina's older brother and Astina herself.

Astina's older brother wasn't particularly exceptional.

However, he was older than Astina and already held a knighthood, making him a strong contender to be the family's successor.

Astina didn't like this.

She felt that her brother would inherit the family simply because he was born before her.

She wanted to overthrow this.

To do so, she needed to make a remarkable impression.

Her magical abilities were exceptional since her first year, so there was nothing more to say on that front.

That's when she came up with the idea of becoming the student council president.

She believed that if she demonstrated her capabilities as president, she could change her father's mind.

Being the student council president of Liberion Academy held significant meaning, after all.

In this regard, she saw similarities with Rudy Astria.

Perhaps he was striving so hard to gain recognition from his family.

He seemed to be walking an even more challenging path than her.

Astina's brother was a prodigy, but Rudy Astria's brother was known as the empire's greatest genius wizard.

While she struggled to surpass someone ordinarily exceptional, what kind of path was Rudy Astria walking?

A faint smile appeared on Astina's lips.

"I want to watch."

She wanted to see the path her kindred spirit would take.

Would he meet his demise?

Or would he persevere and achieve what he desired?

And she wanted to provide a little help as well.

Because she knew what kind of path it was.

She knew it was a difficult and arduous journey.

Liberion Academy's student cafeteria.

"Could you help me out?"

Astina wanted to keep him close.

So, the method she came up with was to bring him into her student council.

It was an excellent way to watch over him and understand his abilities.

Though he was the top student, she didn't know the extent of his abilities or what skills he possessed.

She wanted to know how good he was at magic, theory, handling paperwork, and understanding politics.

"I refuse," Rudy said firmly.

This response was expected.

"Answer sheets of previous exams."

Astina had a secret weapon prepared.

Rudy Astria wanted good grades.

If he wanted to improve his magic skills, he would have stayed in the research lab.

Of course, theoretical study was important for magic, but understanding the structure of magic and using it frequently was crucial.

Rudy Astria spent time not only in the research lab given to top students but also in the library and his room.

This meant he studied to achieve good grades.

So, she prepared answer sheets of exams.

"I'll give you the answer sheets of exams from the past five years."

Astina said to Rudy with a charming smile.

Then, Rudy's eyes wavered.

Astina added one more thing.

"You won't be able to get it anywhere else. I'm the only one who's collected this many answer sheets."

The truth of this statement wasn't certain.

However, it was probably true that she had more answer sheets than other students.

Even if it was a lie, it didn't matter much.

Rudy Astria had no friends other than Luna Railer.

Not only friends but also no acquaintances among seniors or close professors.

It was natural since he didn't socialize and studied every day.

So, he had no way to obtain or know about the answer sheets of previous exams.

"How about it? If you have the answer sheet, it won't matter if you have less study time."

Rudy Astria began to waver.

Astina thought he would accept, given his desire for good grades.

Just as she was about to smile victoriously, a voice came from behind.

"Rudy! Hello!"

Astina turned around to see Luna Railer.

"Did you come to eat?"

"Uh... Luna."

Luna Railer naturally sat next to Rudy Astria.

Despite Astina sitting in front of Rudy, Luna ignored her and spoke to Rudy.

Then, Riku, who followed Luna Railer, sat down opposite Astina and was surprised to see her.

"Ahh... Astina, senior! Hello!"

"Right, hello."

Astina casually greeted Riku and looked back at Luna Railer.

Then, she smiled sarcastically.

"I'm sorry, but we're having an important conversation. Can you move to another seat?"

Astina was slightly annoyed by Luna Railer's attitude.

Why was she, from a small baron family, interrupting their conversation?

"An important conversation? Is it something I shouldn't know?"

Luna grinned at Astina.

To others, it looked like an innocent smile, but to Astina, it was irritating.

Why was she suddenly appearing and interfering when she had almost caught the fish?

"It's not that important. I was just discussing a favor she asked of me."

Rudy explained the situation to Luna.

"A favor? What kind?"

"It's related to the student council, but I haven't heard the details yet."

Hearing that, Astina spoke up.

"It's about the secretary position."

Astina tilted her head.

Her plan had been slightly disrupted.

She had intended to vaguely ask for Rudy's help and then bring him into the student council.

She planned to pressure Rudy with a significant reward and get an answer, but Luna's presence ruined the atmosphere.

Rudy asked Astina, "Are you asking me to join the student council?"

"No, I just need you to handle the tasks while the position is vacant."

Though she said that, she could keep Rudy on the hook if she left the position open.

Astina intentionally avoided mentioning proper terms, aiming to keep Rudy involved.

Later, she planned to present proper conditions and have him continue as secretary.

"How long is the period?"

However, Luna sharply questioned the details.

"...I haven't thought that far ahead. Let's decide slowly."

Astina found Luna increasingly annoying. Who did she think she was?

Rudy asked, "Do you want the answer sheets?"

"Answer sheets?"

"Astina offered to give me the answer sheets of exams from the past five years if I fulfill her request."

Rudy explained when Luna expressed doubt.

However, someone else was surprised by this fact.

"Five... Five years of answer sheets? Why not do it? You even get the secretary position—!"

It was Rika, who had been sitting nearby.

"Can you be quiet?"

"Rika, please be quiet."

Luna and Astina both spoke to Rika at the same time.

"...Yes."

Overwhelmed by their presence, Rika bowed her head and began eating her meal.

"But Rudy is busy studying. If he takes the secretary job, he'll have less time to study, right?"

Luna spoke with an innocent expression, as if she had no ulterior motives.

Her face seemed to say, "I don't have any intentions; I'm just worried about you."

"With the sheets, he can study more efficiently, reducing the time needed for it."

Astina quickly intervened.

Her face was smiling, but a vein was bulging on her forehead.

What began as a negotiation between Rudy and Astina had turned into a battle of wits between Luna and Astina.

Rudy thought for a moment before speakin

g.

"Could you give me some time to think about it?"

"That's fine. Give me an answer within this week. I'd prefer a positive response."

Astina grinned and stood up from her seat.

"I'll leave first."

As Astina returned to her room, she pondered.

Luna Railer.

Why was she interfering like this?

It was irritating.

But it wasn't a big deal. Rudy would have a hard time refusing her offer.

He was like her, after all.

Someone who wants to achieve their goals.

"Ah, Luna."

After finishing our meal in the cafeteria, Luna and I stepped outside.

"I have a magic circle I want to create. Can you help me with it?"

"Magic circle?"

Luna tilted her head, curious.

"I need it for something."

Neither Luna nor I were skilled enough to create a proper magic circle yet.

However, I thought that if we combined our powers, we could make a decent one.

"What kind of magic circle?"

"Silent."

Silent, an intermediate magic, blocked surrounding noise.

I couldn't use it now, but I could create it as a magic circle.

Magic circles didn't require proficiency; if a properly drawn magic circle was on a 'scroll,' it could be used.

"I want to make a quiet space a bit larger."

Normally, the Silent magic could only be used in an incredibly small area.

But by using a magic circle, I hoped to make it effective in a larger space.

"An intermediate magic circle... I've never made one before... But I'll give it a try."

Upon hearing this, Riku, who had been standing nearby, looked at me suspiciously and asked menacingly,

"Where do you plan to use it?"

I had a specific place in mind for that magic circle.

The red-headed...

"Education."

I slightly raised the corner of my mouth.

"I want to use it for some education."

There we go! Finally acting like a villain!

Thank you sroat for the donation! But this chappy is sponsored entirely by Thabuckshot.

Thanks guys!

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 12: Student Council Presidential Election (3)

The next day, I accepted Astina's proposal.

Honestly, it was difficult to refuse.

Of course, the arrangement was only until the end of the event that take place after midterms.

That was the maximum duration I had in mind.

And there was another reason:

I believed that I could use the student council position well when the story progressed to the extra classes.

Upon agreeing, I received the answer sheets immediately through the maid.

Receiving the sheets made me feel a bit uneasy.

Nevertheless, since I wasn't officially joining the student council and was just temporarily helping out, it didn't seem to be a big problem.

The secretary role didn't involve doing anything in front of others, and as Astina said, having the sheets could shorten my study time.

Upon reflection, I was getting a tremendous benefit from this arrangement.

However, that's what made it feel more unsettling.

What did they want from me in return for giving me this?

Thinking about it, answer sheets weren't exactly a precious item.

No matter how valuable the answer sheet was, basic knowledge was still the most important thing.

Yet, for me, it was an incredibly valuable resource.

I didn't have connections or information.

But I take pride in studying as hard as anyone, if not more.

I even spent the time I could have used to gain connections or other information studying.

If I had the answer sheets of previous exams, it would be like having wings to soar.

With increased study efficiency, I could also invest more time in magic training.

Astina was aware of this fact as well.

She knew that if she used the answer sheets of previous exams as a condition, I would likely accept any reasonable proposal.

However, Astina's proposed condition wasn't a big deal.

It was something I would have accepted even without any conditions.

If I participated in the student council during my first year, it would guarantee me a high-ranking position in the student council during my second year.

But this condition was far from ideal for me.

When I become a second-year student, Princess Rie must take the position of student council president.

In the game, Rudy Astria and Princess Rie compete for the student council president position through an election.

Of course, it was a crushing defeat for Rudy Astria.

But, if I were to join the student council, wouldn't people's perception of me change?

If I become the student council president in my second year, it would be a headache.

I wouldn't have time to study, so what kind of student council president would I be?

It was an exquisite mix of an appealing condition and a proposal I wanted to avoid.

"Maybe it's not a coincidence that she's the top student..."

It seemed like she had done her homework on me.

I started to worry.

The image of Rudy Astria I wanted to portray was unlikable but not terrible.

But now, perceptive people were starting to see through me.

At this rate, my image would become that of a hardworking high-ranking noble's child.

Should I start causing trouble in front of Evan?

The next day, I headed to the place where the student council was gathering after class.

"Oh, Rudy Astria's here?"

There were a few people inside, besides Astina.

Most of them were wearing green scarves, so they must be second-year students.

Only one person wore a red scarf.

"Let me introduce the student council members. This is the vice president..."

I half-listened and let the information go in one ear and out the other.

There was no reason to remember the names of people I wouldn't see much.

Instead, I was interested in the one first-year student present.

He had a plump body and sharp eyes.

His face looked familiar.

"And this is Locke Lucarion, a first-year student like you. Have you heard of him?"

The son of the Northern Marquis, mentioned by Princess Rie.

It was Locke Lucarion.

"Doesn't it bother you to be around such a country bumpkin, young master?"

Locke approached me and sneered.

"Locke."

Astina then reprimanded him.

"Yes, yes, I understand."

Locke casually replied and stepped back.

I recalled that Locke participated in the student council during his first year.

I smirked arrogantly.

There was no reason to appear weak to someone who started a fight like that.

"You're quite the barbarian. Is everyone from the North like this?"

"What did you say?"

Locke tried to confront me with a fierce expression, but Astina stopped him with an outstretched hand.

"Rudy Astria, restrain yourself. This is our first meeting."

Astina's face was different from usual, exuding authority.

"Understood."

Locke Lucarion.

He was one of the prominent supporting characters in the Swordsmanship Department.

In the future, he would become the vice-president of Princess Rie's student council.

Of course, he frequently stood out in other events as well.

Due to his unique, easygoing, and bold personality, he was one of the likable male characters around Evan.

Although I didn't know why he was currently in Astina's student council, it was good news for me.

For starters, he had a lot of combat experience in the north, so he excelled at swordsmanship but was quite dense.

This meant that he was easy to manipulate.

Anyway, he wasn't someone that had much influence in the story, so I could use him as I pleased.

The only problem was that Princess Rie was behind him.

"Let's end it here for today. We'll gather again on the weekend to discuss how we'll run the election campaign."

With Astina's words, everyone prepared to leave.

As I was about to leave, Astina grabbed me.

"Rudy Astria, stay for a moment."

As Astina said this, Locke grinned, seemingly pleased, and left.

After everyone else had gone, I asked Astina a question.

"What's the matter?"

"I called you to discuss the upcoming election."

There was only one thing to say about the election.

"Do you want me to stay out of it?"

Honestly, even if I were to do something here, Astina would become president.

Her opponent was an extra with no known name or face.

It didn't seem like they were that famous in the academy either.

So, it was practically set in stone that Astina would become president.

However, the biggest obstacle here was probably me.

If word got out that I had joined the student council, some people might cast votes against her just to oppose me.

It could be backlash against the Astria family or actions driven by dislike for me, but it was certain that I was an obstacle in the student council president election.

However, what I heard next was completely contrary.

"I was going to ask you to help with the election campaign."

"...Excuse me?"

"You have a valuable name, Astria. So, if you participate in the campaign, won't it help?"

Astina grinned as she spoke.

"..."

What was she trying to do?

Even the dim-witted Locke would know that this wasn't a rational decision.

"I'm leaving the first-year side to you and Locke. I don't know much about the first-years anyway."

Astina definitely knew more first-year students than I did.

I wondered what her intentions were in saying this.

"Fine... I understand."

I wanted to say it was absurd, but I held back.

Someone else would advise her, even if I didn't.

It would also be strange for me, who had only recently met her, to comment.

"Alright, see you next time."

Astina waved with a smile.

I didn't know what she was thinking, but she was smart, so I believed she would handle it.

With that, I headed to Professor Cromwell's office.

Professor Cromwell's office.

"Even though he was called a young wolf, he's just a harmless puppy."

Professor Robert spoke, half-lying on the sofa.

"Aren't puppies and wolf cubs similar at that age?"

Professor Cromwell, wearing glasses he didn't usually wear, replied while looking at some documents.

"I heard he's arrogant and rude, so I thought an interesting guy had finally arrived, but he's just a harmless pushover."

"Are you sure you saw the real Rudy Astria? Last time, he got mad at me and handing in a blank exam."

Robert protested, getting up from the sofa as he listened to Cromwell's laughter.

"Either way, do you think I would mistake someone else for him? The student council brought him, so it must be right."

"What made you so curious that you went to the student council?"

"He's from the Astria family, and his personality seemed interesting, but he's nothing special. Are siblings' personalities usually so different?"

"They grew up in different environments, so wouldn't that be the case?"

Rudy's older brother, who grew up receiving attention from everyone.

And Rudy Astria, who didn't receive any attention at all.

Cromwell thought the difference in their personalities was inevitable.

"Just looking at him made me feel bad, but not as bad as his brother."

"Why do you hate him so much? He was polite to the professors and had good social skills."

Robert shook his head as if exasperated.

"I hate those kinds of people the most. They lack humanity. Humanity."

Robert then got up and went towards the door.

"Are you leaving?"

"Of course."

As Robert opened the door to leave, someone was standing in front of it.

"Um?"

It was Rudy Astria.

"Hello, Professor Robert."

"Did you hear?"

Robert bluntly asked Rudy.

"What do you mean?"

Rudy asked back, expressionless.

"If you didn't hear, it's fine. Are you here to see Cromwell?"

"Yes."

"Cromwell, Rudy Astria is coming in."

"I see. Come in."

Robert said that and went on his way.

Rudy glanced at the departing Robert and then entered Professor Cromwell's office.

"Professor, hello."

"What brings you here? You could ask questions during class time."

"It's not related to class. It's about something I'm studying separately."

"What is it?"

Cromwell took off the glasses he was wearing and asked.

Rudy showed him a piece of paper.

"It's a Silent Magic Circle. I'm thinking of a range of about 100 meters in radius from the casting location."

Cromwell looked back and forth between the magic circle and Rudy Astria.

The magic circle was better made than he expected.

Especially the efficiency of the magic circle, meaning it was designed to use minimal mana during casting.

However, there were many flaws.

"If you draw it like this, it will activate in a smaller area than an ordinary Silent Magic Circle, let alone 100 meters."

Cromwell picked up the fountain pen in front of him and checked the problems with the magic circle.

"For Silent Magic, you should use the duplication rune instead of the enhancement rune to expand the range. If you use the enhancement rune, it will only eliminate louder noises within that space. And you can improve this part by recalculating the formula."

Professor Cromwell closely examined the magic circle while speaking indifferently.

He then asked Rudy Astria.

"Did you create this magic circle by yourself?"

"No, I made it with Luna Railer. Luna took care of the control sector while I crafted the inner magic formula."

"Luna Railer, huh?"

The student who caught Professor McGuire's attention last time.

Professor Cromwell was slightly surprised, as the magic circle's control sector and arrangement of formulas were almost at an assistant's level.

This maximized the efficiency of the magic formula.

'As for the magic formula...'

However, the magic formula that Rudy Astria had created was only at the level of an outstanding student.

"Hmm..."

Professor Cromwell handed the paper with the magic formula back to Rudy.

"It seems you need to study more about magic circles. Although my class is practical, you should put more effort into theory classes as well."

Professor Cromwell didn't hesitate to offer advice.

He appreciated seeing the discarded child of the Astria family studying diligently without becoming twisted.

He thought it was a professor's role to guide such a student well.

"But..."

He felt there was one more thing that needed guidance.

Cromwell narrowed his eyes and stared at Rudy Astria.

"Where do you plan to use that magic circle?"

Silent Magic circles were prohibited from being sold.

Even if they were sold, records of the buyers were kept somewhere.

Silent Magic itself was treated cautiously since it was so useful for criminal purposes.

However, it was also famous among wizards as a good magic to study.

Because its activation method was unique compared to other magic, it was recommended to learn at Liberion Academy.

The academy was a learning and research institution.

Thus, they allowed the use of even magic of dubious use outside for research or study purposes.

Of course, the user would be responsible if any scandalous incidents occurred.

"It's just for studying."

Rudy looked straight into Cromwell's eyes without avoiding them.

After a brief staring contest, Cromwell sighed.

"Ha... Fine. I understand."

He added further.

"I won't inquire more because you're a diligent and passionate student. So, be careful with your actions."

"I'll keep that in mind."

With no change in expression, Rudy Astria replied and walked towards the door.

Professor Cromwell called out to him.

"Rudy Astria."

"...?"

After a brief pause, Professor Cromwell said.

"Just make sure it won't cause any trouble."

"...Understood."

With that, Rudy Astria left the room.

"How could that guy be a puppy?"

A Silent Magic spell that activated within a 100-meter radius of a person.

Anyone could see it was a magic circle to prevent criminal disturbances.

"Baron Williams was it...?"

What a foolish guy.

He should have chosen his target wisely, but he messed with the wrong person.

The next day, after class ended.

"Ru-Rudy Astria?"

A guy with a red head, probably from the Baron William's family, stood before me.

Delinquents always seem to like these narrow alleys.

A narrow alley with a lone person.

The perfect situation to educate someone.

I took out the prepared scroll in advance.

As the top student, I had received a scroll with the Silent Magic engraved on it.

"What is it?"

-Tear

As I tore the scroll, a bright light leaked out.

"Wha... what's going on?"

I walked forward and opened my mouth.

"Let's get started."

Woah another one just like that! Thanks transhumanist Sykes for sponsoring this chappy!

Enjoy the chappy! Rudy going badass here.

Chapter 13: Student Council Presidential Election (4)

"R-Rudy Astria! Calm down and listen to me...!"

The red-haired student started backing away as I slowly approached.

"I-I'll use magic if you come any closer...!"

Ignoring the threat, I continued forward.

"Fire-!"

"Dig."

I cast a spell before he could use his magic.

As I cast it, the ground under the red-haired student gave way.

He fell, his face filled with fear.

"Uh... D-Don't come closer!"

"Ignite."

I uttered the incantation.

The most basic fire magic.

A spell that creates a small flame at a single point.

It had no lethal power, but it was enough to make him suffer.

I grabbed his arm and brought the flame closer.

"Aaaargh!!!"

He began to writhe in pain.

His clothes were pierced, and the smell of burning flesh filled the air.

I didn't have a perverse taste for torturing others, so I didn't enjoy it.

But this was the most effective method.

People were weak to pain.

Especially someone like him, who had never experienced real pain before.

"I'm sorry!!! I said I'm sorryyyyyy!!!"

"Are you speaking informally? Am I your friend?"

"I... I apologize!!! Aaaah!!!"

He apologized, but I didn't stop.

I just continued to sear his arm without a word.

"Aaargh!!! Haaah..."

I momentarily lifted the flame, and he gasped for breath.

Tears streamed down his face.

As I tried to bring the flame to his arm again, he yelled at me.

"Stop... please...! I had no choice... Garwel said it would be easy if I did it this way!!!"

Garwel?

The sudden mention of his name puzzled me.

Garwel Handrei.

He was the offspring of the Handrei Baron family.

In the original story, he served under Rudy Astria.

Of course, they weren't allies, and he merely held a position as a sycophantic subordinate.

However, Garwel was more than just a flunky.

Midterm Camp.

He was the mastermind behind the events that happen during the midterm camping evaluation which occurs after the exams.

"...Tell me more."

"Garwel said that if we just claim Rudy Astria ordered this, everything would be resolved..."

I frowned.

In the original story, I thought Rudy Astria merely ordered Evan to be harassed, but now it seemed different.

Garwel manipulated Rudy Astria, using the red-head student.

And Garwel must have told the red-head student that if they were honest, they could survive.

In other words, Rudy Astria in the game was simply being used by Garwel.

However, it appeared that my actions had changed the outcome.

This is insane... A baron or marquis would try to manipulate a duke?

It made the following stories a bit more understandable.

"He did it because he was scared."

"Huh...?"

"Never mind."

I released his arm and got up from my seat.

I thought Garwel might have done it.

He was part of the Rebels anyway.

Midterm Camp was the first appearance of the Rebels in the game, an essential part of the story.

Garwel was a member, and the story involved him causing a commotion and getting subdued by Evan.

The story of subduing Garwel was secondary, and the main story revolved around a heroine who was a member of the Rebels.

I could confront Garwel now, but there was no need.

Once the Midterm Camp starts, Evan will take care of him.

There's plenty for Evan to gain from the situation, so I don't need to get involved yet.

"What happened here didn't happen. If the others around you bother me, it's not you but your family that will crumble."

"Ah... I understand. I will manage it well..."

As I walked away, I thought.

Honestly, I knew about the stories of the heroines and Evan.

However, I didn't know the stories of the surrounding characters.

There must have been a reason for the events that happened.

I didn't realize that these small incidents were related to the main story.

"I need to be more careful."

Now that I discovered the small incidents were connected to the main story, I had to act more cautiously.

If Evan doesn't gain abilities from these events, it would be disastrous.

Usually, it took a tremendous effort to obtain abilities from significant events.

So, I had to ensure that all events occurred normally.

"What a headache."

I wondered if I should reconsider Astina's proposal.

There were no main or side stories related to Astina, so I decided to go along with it for the agreed-upon period.

Over the weekend,

Luna, Ena, and Rika were together in the library.

Rudy hadn't joined them, saying he had something to do, so it was just the three of them.

They were taking a break from studying for a moment.

"Rudy did that?"

"He's finally showing his true colors! That jerk..."

Rika spoke animatedly, waving her arms.

Rumors.

The three were discussing a rumor.

The rumor that Rudy Astria had ordered the son of Baron William to bully Evan.

"Umm..."

"Ena! Say something!"

Rika shook Ena, urging her to speak up.

"I'd rather not."

Ena wore an expression of disapproval.

After a moment of hesitation, Luna spoke up.

"Could it be that the rumor is spreading incorrectly?"

"No, it's true. You saw Rudy Astria being taken to the student council last time too. Everyone at the academy is now saying he did under Rudy Astria's orders."

Luna considered Rika's words.

Why would Rudy do such a thing?

There was no reason for Rudy to torment Evan.

"Just look at it! Lately, Evan, a commoner, has been gaining popularity, so the high-ranking noble must have felt uncomfortable!"

Luna remembered when Rudy introduced himself.

His dismissive remarks.

He had made statements that belittled everyone.

However, Rudy didn't favor nobles over others.

He simply wasn't interested in most people.

He had never treated anyone differently based on their social status, whether they were nobles or commoners.

He didn't seem to care about Rika and Ena, both commoners, but he never ignored them either.

"I think there might be some misunderstanding."

Luna believed in what she saw.

Rudy was a kind, caring, and a bit of a clumsy person.

"Come to think of it..."

She had seen Rudy with a viscount's son before, right after their first class.

"It seemed like he said something mean, but..."

She remembered Rudy telling the viscount's son to "get lost."

At first, she thought he was being mean to his friends, but now it seemed different.

Could it be that Rudy knew those people were bad?

And in retaliation, they trapped him.

"Rika, I saw this happen..."

Luna shared the story with Rika and Ena.

Rumors were just that—rumors.

People would interpret actions based on what they wanted to believe.

Even a harmless action could be twisted by those spreading rumors.

Not only the meaning but also the action itself could be distorted.

"Maybe this happened because it's Rudy. His reputation at the academy isn't good."

When Luna said this, Ena smiled.

"If Luna says so, it must be true."

"No... It could be wrong! Yeah... maybe Rudy just made a mistake!"

Luna, feeling she had said too much, mumbled and sat down.

Ena smiled at her and started talking.

"Anyway, Luna, you seem so busy lately."

"Busy? Do I?"

"You seem to have dark circles under your eyes, and you're not hanging out or going for walks with friends as much."

"Do... do I? I thought I was just living my life as usual."

Luna stuttered, seeming flustered.

Ena looked at her and chuckled.

"Studying is good, but don't forget to take breaks."

"Yeah... I'll do that."

Lately, Luna had been spending her days with Rudy at the library.

Of course, they were just studying there.

Luna didn't stop at the library; she continued studying late into the night.

Anticipation.

Rudy had said he was looking forward to her growth.

Luna didn't want to disappoint his expectations.

She wanted to show Rudy her impressive progress as soon as possible.

"Hehe..."

Luna imagined Rudy admiring her achievements and let out a silly smile.

"Oh, by the way, I heard that Locke and Rudy Astria will be campaigning in front of the first-year dormitory tomorrow."

"Campaigning?"

Luna tilted her head at Ena's words.

"Yeah, I just heard it, so it must be true. They're doing it in the morning."

"Hmm."

Luna thought for a moment and then smiled.

The next day.

Today, Red Head had said he would go to the student council and confess.

He was going to claim it wasn't something I had ordered, but rather something he had done on his own.

However, another problem had arisen.

"Sigh."

Right now, Locke and I were standing in front of the dormitory.

In my hand, I held a banner with Astina's name and promises written on it.

Over the weekend, Astina had negotiated that Locke and I would campaign for her in front of the dormitory.

I couldn't understand why it had come to this.

Locke, who seemed irritated by merely standing next to me, was also annoying.

Students passing by would look at me and whisper.

It was clear that my presence was detrimental to Astina.

Why had nobody stopped me?

Wasn't it obvious that Astina's reputation was being damaged right now?

A deep sigh welled up from within me.

A considerable amount of time had passed, and it was almost time to attend classes.

As I tried to pack up and leave, Locke called out to me.

"Hey, you."

"What is it?"

There was a murderous intent in his eyes.

However, it was significantly calmer than his usual aggressive demeanor.

"Why did you order him to harass Evan?"

I ignored his question and casually picked up my things, heading toward the building.

The truth would be revealed today anyway.

Wouldn't it be more strange if I were to say that I was falsely accused and that Red Head would confess today?

As I tried to leave, Locke grabbed my arm.

"What do you think you're doing?"

"Answer my question, Rudy Astria."

Why is he acting like this?

"I didn't do it. How many times do I have to say it?"

I shook off Locke's hand and walked forward.

Then, Locke spat out a curse.

"Filthy bastard."

I ignored Locke's cursing and kept walking.

"Why do you take out your inferiority complex toward your brother on others? Do you think that's something a high-ranking noble should do?"

Why is he creating an embarrassing moment for himself?

After cursing like that, it would be embarrassing for him when it's revealed I wasn't the one responsible.

I tried to ignore Locke and leave.

However, I saw someone coming down the stairs and speaking.

"What did you say?"

"Luna?"

Descending the stairs was Luna.

"What are you doing?"

Luna's usual gentle face was gone.

Her eyes, filled with murderous intent, stared at Locke.

"Luna Railer?"

Locke seemed slightly taken aback by Luna's expression.

However, Luna didn't respond to him and asked again.

"What are you doing? Why are you cursing at someone who's minding their own business?"

Locke furrowed his brow.

Seeing Locke's reaction, Luna seemed to get even angrier and spoke with murderous intent.

"Are you not going to answer?"

"I cursed him because he did something deserving of it."

Locke spoke calmly.

Wind began to gather in Luna's hand.

"So, it's okay for me to attack you did something deserving of it, right?"

The beginner wind attribute magic, Wind Ball.

However, its size seemed strange.

I knew Luna's magic level wasn't that high, but the size was similar to my own magic.

No, now wasn't the time to worry about that.

If we started fighting seriously, none of us would come out unscathed.

Luna, Locke, and I.

There was no need to fight like this.

I stood up and grabbed Luna's arm.

"Luna, it's okay."

"Rudy?"

I looked at Locke.

"You too, scram."

"What?"

"Leave while I'm letting you off."

Locke glanced at Luna and then went inside the building.

"Rudy! Is it okay to let him go like that?"

Luna looked at me, worried.

"Don't worry, it's fine. We can't just start casting magic over a few insults."

Luna's magic dissipated, and her face turned red.

"It was just... I got angry all of a sudden."

Luna seemed to have had enough, venting her anger at me.

"Besides, why didn't you say anything? You should have at least argued back!"

"Why bother with someone who won't believe a word I say?"

"You still should have said something!"

"Anyway, class is about to start."

As I tried to leave with a faint smile, Luna grabbed my sleeve.

"Are you really okay?"

"I'm fine. But why did you only come out of the dormitory now?"

To ease Luna's worry, I changed the subject.

But it was strange.

As I mentioned earlier, class would start soon.

Luna usually wasn't late.

"Ah... Today, my hair just wouldn't cooperate! I overslept a bit too. That's why I'm late!"

Luna stuttered slightly.

However, her hair looked just as it usually did.

No, it seemed even neater than usual.

Well, if Luna said so, it must be true.

I trusted Luna completely and let it go.

I walked into the building with Luna.

And we parted ways midway since we had different classes.

"Ah..."

I suddenly remembered, I had forgotten to ask about Luna's magic.

It seemed to have grown much faster than her usual pace.

The fact bothered me, but I thought it could happen.

My actions were completely different from the original work; how could every little detail be the same as in the game?

"It's probably nothing."

1/4 for the week!

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 14: Student Council Presidential Election (5)

At Princess Rie's quarters, Locke stood before her meekly.

"So, why did you do that?"

Rie glared at Locke, and the atmosphere was tense.

"I apologize."

"Did I tell you to pick a fight with Rudy Astria or to keep an eye on him? With such baseless rumors? Do you plan to make enemies of both Rudy Astria and me?"

"...I apologize."

"Wind Cutter."

As Rie chanted the spell, a lock of Locke's hair was cut off.

A wound appeared on his forehead, and blood trickled down.

"I really dislike it when my plans go awry."

Locke looked at his hair that had fallen to the floor.

"Next time, it'll be your arm. Then, it'll be your territory, and after that, it'll be your neck."

Rie irritably brushed her hair aside.

"Be careful not to cause any harm to the upcoming alliance."

"I understand."

Rie smiled at the bowing Locke.

"Great~ If you do that, everything will be fine. Do your best, okay?"

Locke left Rie's room.

He had been too foolish.

He should have been more cautious and deliberate in his actions.

He should have realized that this place was not his territory, but Liberion Academy.

The day he hurled insults at Rudy Astria, Baron William's son went to the student council and confessed.

Upon hearing the news, his head went blank.

Rudy Astria.

That person was an 'evil character' in his mind.

Someone who looked down on those beneath him, acting arrogant without knowing their own limits.

He was convinced that Rudy Astria was such a person.

However, he wasn't.

Yes, he had been too foolish.

He was clumsy when it came to using his head.

Even with great strength, it held no meaning.

He felt it was both his own and his family's limitation.

The family guarding the cold northern region was a family with strong power in such a harsh environment.

Locke's family, the Lucarion family, was one of them.

While they possessed great strength, they were not particularly gifted intellectually.

They excelled in battle strategy but were ignorant in other areas, such as politics.

In a peaceful era,

those with power felt limited.

No matter how skilled in combat, if there was no battle, their abilities were useless.

The Empire's center attracted those skilled in magic and politics.

And they found themselves pushed to the periphery.

Physically and politically on the outskirts, they began to feel threatened.

Thus, Locke made a resolution when he arrived at the academy.

To learn politics.

To get close to the best political minds and learn from them.

And to expand his connections.

So, the person Locke approached was the First Princess, Rie.

A potential future empress.

There was no reason not to get close to her.

"Rudy Astria..."

Until Princess Rie mentioned it, Locke knew nothing.

Rudy Astria seemed like nothing more than a wayward second son.

As someone living in the north, he knew that Rudy Astria was famous.

However, both Princess Rie and Astina Persia paid attention to Rudy Astria.

Ordinary people pointed fingers at him, but the academy's top students sought to get closer to him.

Upon hearing the news that Baron William's offspring had surrendered, he realized the truth.

He was foolish, not seeing the reality.

Now he could understand.

Rudy Astria was not just a wayward young man.

Those with foresight had already noticed.

Locke casually wiped the blood flowing from his forehead with his sleeve.

Having seen numerous situations in the north, such a wound was nothing to him.

The fact he had made a mistake was more painful than the wound itself.

"I need to study more."

The red-haired guy confessed as I had instructed him to.

He admitted his guilt without mentioning Garwel.

I deliberately told him to not bring up Garwel since there was no benefit to provoking him already.

When the incident properly explodes during the midterm event
, we can uproot the entire thing.

There was no need to touch upon it just yet.

When I told the red-haired guy not to mention Garwel, he repeatedly bowed his head in gratitude.

It was a little awkward since I did it for my own benefit, but he seemed so grateful.

A few days later.

"Shall we have a listen then?"

As soon as the class ended, Astina approached me.

She took me to an empty classroom.

She sat on a chair, crossed her legs, and spoke to me.

"What are you talking about?"

"Everything from your actions at home to your fight with Baron William's son."

She seemed to know it all.

"Shall we listen slowly?"

Did she mean the rumors of my idiocy at home?

I could understand the stories about home, but how did she know about the fight with the red-haired guy?

I was sure I used a silent spell, and no one was around.

"How did you know about the fight with the son of Baron William?"

However, Astina deflected my question with a question.

"Which parts of the stories spreading from your family are true?"

As I didn't answer and calmly stood there, Astina smiled.

Then she opened her mouth.

"What are you? Rudy Astria?"

"I don't know what you're talking about."

I showed no reaction and kept looking at Astina.

"The rumors are bad, but you're not really doing anything wrong."

Astina looked at me as she sat and said.

She took out some documents from the book she had been holding.

"In the family, you're a troublemaker. A second son who relies only on his talent. But looking at you in the academy, you appear to be nothing but an ordinary model student. To the point where it's hard to understand how such rumors were created."

It was a natural discrepancy since it wasn't me at home.

I had expected such a situation, but it happened faster than I thought.

"Even when Locke picks a fight, you simply try to pass by harmlessly."

She flipped through the documents in her hand one by one.

"If you cover up the name, you'd just be a kind student."

Astina looked at me and smiled faintly.

Then she put down the documents she had been holding.

"I can help you."

"Pardon?"

"I don't know why you're acting like this, but I can help you."

Astina reached out her hand to me.

"I've established my position in the academy now. There are powerful professors and children from prestigious families, but I have the power to counter them. If I take the student council president's position soon, my power will grow even stronger."

"..."

"I'll help you. Tell me your goal, and I'll help you. In return, you help me. Not as my subordinate, but as an equal partner."

Astina pushed her hand toward me as if urging me to hold it.

"Let's cooperate, Rudy Astria."

"Aren't we already cooperating as part of the student council?"

"I mean a proper alliance, not that. The student council is just temporary."

Hearing those words, I pondered for a moment.

Then, I opened my mouth.

"What do you see in me that makes you propose such a thing?"

I asked Astina.

Astina responded with a smile.

"It's just a hunch."

"Making decisions without solid evidence isn't wise."

"True for ordinary actions, but recognizing talent is different. It would be a shame to miss out on talent right in front of me."

The words he had said to Luna.

She knew everything others would never know.

She knew so much but I couldn't fathom how she found out.

"But you are strong enough without my help. If you take the student council president position, as you said, you will have even greater influence. Why make such an offer to me?"

"Hmm... That's my secret. I'll tell you if you ally with me."

I was torn.

Would joining hands with Astina be better?

Or would it be better to continue acting alone?

I weighed the two options.

Joining hands with Astina would be helpful not only within the academy but also outside.

She's a child of a prestigious family, after all.

Surviving in the academy was one problem, but so was life after graduation.

Let's skip thinking about that for now, as it's a distant concern.

However, even considering the academy alone, Astina undoubtedly had the most influence.

She was set to claim the student council president position and already held the top rank among second-year students.

Her power would definitely help me.

Just by listening to our conversation, didn't she know everything I had hidden?

There were clear advantages to joining hands with her.

The only downside of joining hands with her was dealing with unexpected developments.

While progressing the main story, I'd also have to deal with matters related to Astina.

I'd be extremely busy.

And explaining my intentions would be difficult.

No one would believe me if I said I was a person who entered the game and had to help Evan grow to prevent everyone at the academy from dying.

I struggled between the two choices.

And soon, I made a decision.

"How about a temporary alliance?"

"Temporary alliance?"

"I won't reveal everything about me. I'll only tell you what I intend to do to some extent. You can also weigh the pros and cons when helping me. If you help me, I'll provide corresponding help in return."

Hearing this, Astina smirked.

"Fine. I can accept that much."

Astina extended her hand to me, and I took it.

"Then let's hear it. Your intentions and your goals."

After a brief moment of thought, I spoke.

"I will become the academy's second seat."

"...Second seat?"

"The wall one must overcome to secure the top position in the academy.
That's the role I'll play."

Of course, the person who would surpass that wall was already determined.

"Why won't you take the top seat yourself?"

"Because responsibility comes with the position."

In the main stories Evan experiences, there are events that occur because he's the top student.

Although those stories would grant him powerful weapons or abilities, the risks are too high.

Only someone with Evan's mental fortitude and skills could overcome them.

There are stories that require special magic that only Evan can use, and there are stories where he must persevere through sheer willpower.

I knew all too well how difficult those stories were.

Even knowing every story, they're still hard to overcome.

I didn't have the confidence to take on that responsibility.

"What do you know?"

At my words, Astina's face filled with curiosity.

However, I couldn't tell her everything.

There was no guarantee that the things I mentioned would happen, and other events could occur that I didn't mention.

I only knew the predetermined stories, not the ability to read the future.

"I don't know for sure."

"Then what are you basing this on?"

"Just a hunch."

As I said that, Astina's serious expression relaxed, and she spoke.

"You tell me not to rely on my instincts, yet you do trust in yours. Isn't that contradictory?"

"We can't rely entirely on intuition. But there is some evidence behind my words."

"What's the evidence?"

"That's a secret."

With that, Astina casually organized the documents she was holding and stood up.

"So, your goal is to become the second-seat, right?"

"Yes, that's correct."

"I'm curious who could beat you with all that effort."

I asked Astina a question in response to her words.

"Now, it's your turn, Senior Astina. Why do you need me?"

At my question, Astina raised the corner of her mouth.

"I will beat my brother, Varian Persia."

I had never heard the name Varian Persia before.

But I could understand the meaning behind her words.

"Are you trying to take the position of family successor?"

Astina didn't answer my question and just smiled.

It was a more complicated issue than I thought.

"Is it possible?"

"I am more thoroughly prepared than you think. I must succeed since I'm betting my life on it."

"What if I betray you?"

"I would blame myself for misjudging you and die, I suppose."

Although her words were harsh, she said them playfully.

Her words were convincing.

I understood she wanted to take over the family, but I wondered if I really needed to be involved.

I was just a discarded child from a duke's family, unable to rely on the power of my family.

Astina would know that too.

So what she needed was not the power of the Astria family, but the power of the top student, Rudy Astria.

In that case, she probably wouldn't ask me to do anything too burdensome.

After we finished talking, Astina walked towards the door.

"Are you leaving?"

"Yeah, the election is soon. I'm busy, so I have to go."

Astina waved her hand to me and opened the door.

"See you next time, partner."

And so, the election day arrived.

As expected, Astina secured a comfortable victory.

"How did I end up in this position?"

Astina leaned back in her chair, now seated at the student council president's desk.

"Wasn't this the anticipated result?"

A woman sipping tea in front of her replied.

It was Princess Rie.

"Even so, it feels great."

Astina smiled at Rie.

"Now that I'm the student council president, it's time to start working on our families."

Astina handed some documents to the princess.

"I've gathered this much information, and I've already begun laying the groundwork."

Rie skimmed through the documents and grinned.

"Sounds good~ I'll start working on the central region as well."

"Since I've fulfilled my promise to become the student council president, sign the contract."

Rie accepted the contract Astina handed her.

It stated the following:

1. Rie Von Ristonia will assist Astina Persia in inheriting the title of viscount.
2. Upon successfully inheriting the title, Astina Persia will help Rie Von Ristonia become the Empress.

... and so on.

Several clauses were written, and both of them signed the contract.

"I never thought we'd be in the same boat, given our opposing situations. I thought you'd dislike me."

"Opposing situations make it easier for us to understand each other, right?"

It was a collaboration between someone trying to steal power from her superior and someone trying to prevent losing their power.

Astina wanted to surpass her brother and become the family's heir, while Rie strived to prevent her sister from taking her power.

Despite their contrasting situations, they understood and acknowledged each other.

"Then I'm counting on you~."

Rie put down her teacup and rose from her seat.

"Ah."

As she was about to open the door, Rie glanced back.

"By the way, did the information about Rudy Astria help?"

"It did help. I'm grateful for that."

Rie smiled.

"I was a little interested in him as well, so it was a nice gesture~. So, what happened?"

"Don't you know?"

"Hey~ I can't always listen to everything~."

Rie spoke playfully.

"We've agreed to cooperate, and I've learned his intentions to some extent. He's not an enemy."

"Oh~ really? If our president says so~."

Astina didn't particularly like Rie's playful tone.

However, it was appropriate for their cooperative relationship, so she didn't feel too bothered.

"Well, I'll be going now. Astina-senior?"

"Alright."

Rie opened the door and left.

"Sigh..."

Astina let out a sigh and loosened her scarf a little.

"But now it's time for midterms..."

She had neglected her studies while preparing for the election.

Even if she had secured the student council president position, it would be useless if she lost her top rank.

Astina took out her book and opened it.

"I won't be getting much sleep for a while."

Though she said this, Astina wore a smile.

2/4 for the week!

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 15: The Burning Library

(1)

The day had come.

The day I was most worried about.

It was midterm exam day.

Liberion Academy didn't hold exams over several days; instead, all tests were taken in a single day.

So, I had to give it my all in one day.

"Rudy, good luck on your exams!"

Luna greeted me before heading to her own exam room.

We had worked hard up until this point.

Not a single day was wasted; we thoroughly reviewed and prepared.

Since taking over, I hadn't had a proper rest day.

It was all about studying.

Sigh...

I calmed my nerves and entered the classroom.

I was supposed to aim for the second seat.

But I had no intention of settling for that.

My mind was set on the top seat.

That was the only way I could secure the second seat.

"Please put away your books and notes, and only leave your writing utensils on your desk."

The professor at the front of the room explained the exam instructions and distributed the test papers.

"Now, let the exam begin."

The exam started with the professor's words.

I began answering the questions on the test paper one by one.

It was a new experience for me.

I knew the answers to all the questions on the test.

It felt almost too easy.

I flipped through the pages and solved each problem.

I finished all the general knowledge exams.

After a short break, the most important exam began: Magic Studies.

The Magic Studies exam was lengthy, consisting of both practical and theoretical questions.

Each professor set questions according to their own style.

The most challenging questions when I was studying even with answer sheets were undoubtedly those from Professor Cromwell.

Despite being a first-year exam, the questions required knowledge of intermediate magic and were impossible to solve.

It felt like they were designed not to be answered.

I remembered this fact as I tackled the questions.

Then, I found a question that was unmistakably from Professor Cromwell.

"Ah..."

Describe the principle of Silent Magic and the characteristics of its magic circle.

He was the only professor who ended his question with a noun.

However, the question made my head throb.

"Did he put this question for me to answer...?"

I muttered quietly, so no one could hear.

I wondered if it was even allowed.

A regular student wouldn't be able to answer the question about Silent Magic.

Everyone focused on studying beginner magic, not intermediate magic.

I held my head in my hands.

Should I answer this question or not?

An ordinary first-year student couldn't answer it, but the top-ranking students might be able to.

The difficulty level of the questions this year was easier compared to other years.

Silent Magic was a peculiar magic, and someone might have heard about it at least once.

So, I couldn't leave it blank.

"Let's write... just half of it."

I decided to write only what Professor Cromwell had taught me.

Honestly, I could write everything since I had created the magic circle before, but I chose to write only what I had been taught.

"Please... Evan, write everything and turn it in."

I muttered to myself and moved on to the next question.

"Great job, everyone."

Exams have finally ended.

At the professor's words, everyone stood up and left the classroom.

'Am I going to be the top student?'

Mixed feelings of anxiety and joy filled me.

At least my efforts didn't seem to be in vain.

"Let's rest today..."

I felt utterly drained.

I had been so tense, thinking I had to study every day, that I hadn't taken a break.

But after the exam, I felt a sense of relief, as if it was finally over.

It wasn't truly over, but it felt like I had passed the first hurdle.

My legs trembled, making it difficult to even stand.

"Rudy! How did your exam go?"

As I stood up, Luna entered the classroom I had just left.

"I think it went alright."

I thought I had done exceptionally well, but there was no need to boast.

"Today, Riku, Ena, and I are going to Picassie Bakery. Want to come with us?"

Picassie Bakery was a famous café in Liberion Academy.

It was a place where commoners and lower nobles would splurge, rather than the high-ranking nobles.

The prices weren't exactly affordable, but I had heard the atmosphere and desserts were outstanding.

It was so popular that making reservations was difficult, but they managed to book a table.

"I'm planning to rest today."

I wanted to visit the bakery, but it wouldn't be right to tag along with them.

I didn't know about Ena, but Riku would surely give me a resentful look.

And I wasn't so clueless as to impose on a group of girls.

Luna might not mind, but the other two would certainly be uncomfortable with my presence.

"Really? That's a shame... Let's go together next time!"

"Sure. Have fun."

Dragging my exhausted body, I headed for the dormitory.

There wasn't a single person near the dorms; it seemed everyone had gone somewhere to have fun after the exam.

However, there was one person, just like me, dragging themselves along like a zombie.

"Rudy Astria?"

It was Astina.

She had dark circles under her eyes, and her hair looked disheveled.

Her face seemed to be weighed down by exhaustion, like a modern-day office worker leaving work at 10 PM.

Yet, her fatigue didn't diminish her beauty. If anything, it gave her a decadent charm.

"Greetings—"

"Don't... don't look at me!"

Astina abruptly turned her back to me. She tried to fix her hair with her hands, but it only seemed to get messier.

"...What are you doing?"

"Well..."

Astina covered her face with her hand and looked at me.

"I have urgent matters to attend to!"

After briefly greeting me, Astina tried to rush to the dormitory.

She then halted her steps.

"Rudy Astria! I have something for you to do tomorrow. Come to the student council room after class!"

With her face still covered, Astina spoke to me and then rushed up to the dormitory.

"...What was that?"

I watched Astina run off before heading to my room.

The next day, the exam results were posted on the bulletin board.

I couldn't believe they had graded all those test papers in just one day.

I could only imagine the amount of work the teaching assistants had to do.

Even in the modern era, where machines graded exams, it took several days for the results to be posted.

Teaching assistants must be more efficient than machines.

I checked the scores on the bulletin board.

It didn't display the exact scores, only the ranks.

"Ah..."

Evan

Rudy Astria

Rie Von Ristonia

Serina Rinsburg

Luna Railer

...

Seeing the results, I couldn't help but smile.

I was happy Evan had secured the top rank, but I was even more thrilled to be in second place.

However, I couldn't show my excitement in front of others.

I had to act as if I were extremely disappointed.

After all, I was now in second place, having been ousted from the top spot.

I did my best to control my smile as I walked away.

"Rudy..."

Luna's voice came from behind me.

"Ah, hello, Luna."

I greeted Luna while trying my best to control my smile.

My words sounded a bit mechanical, but I couldn't help it.

"Rudy... are you okay?"

Luna asked with a concerned expression.

I was more than okay; I was in high spirits.

I trusted Luna, but I couldn't tell her the truth.

"You've climbed the ranks quite a bit. Congratulations."

I said something I wouldn't normally say, but nothing else came to mind.

"Rudy..."

"I have to go."

"Wait, Rudy. Are you coming to the library today?"

"I don't think I can make it today. I have work with the student council."

Astina had told me there was something I needed to do, so I doubted I'd have time to visit the library.

It was better to tell Luna not to wait for me since I didn't know what Astina had planned.

"Ah... the student council..."

Luna's expression briefly hardened but soon returned to her usual smile.

"Alright, I understand...!"

Luna smiled and waved goodbye. As I watched her walk away, I couldn't shake an odd feeling of unease.

"Maybe I'll visit the library if I finish early?"

After class, I headed to the student council office.

I thought I had managed my smile quite well during the lessons.

Upon entering the office, I saw Astina sitting in the president's seat, reading through some documents.

"Good day."

Astina looked up when she heard my voice. She glanced at my face and frowned.

"Why are you making that face?"

"Huh?"

"You seem to have a sour expression."

"Do I look upset?"

I wondered if I had done a good job at acting.

Astina held a mirror in front of me, reflecting my face.

Upon seeing my reflection, I understood what Astina meant.

In the mirror, there was an incredibly handsome, blonde man.

A man with sharp eyes.

However, he wore an ambiguous expression, neither smiling nor frowning, that seemed to keep others at bay.

"It's quite unpleasant, even for me."

"I know."

Astina put the mirror down.

"Anyway, everything went according to your plan."

Hearing Astina say that, I couldn't help but smirk.

"Hehe..."

I had always thought I was good at controlling my expressions and acting, but today it was difficult to contain myself.

"That's a rather despicable expression..."

Astina commented while looking at my face.

"Well, at least it's better than the alternative. So, what's next?"

"What's next...?"

"Your plan worked, didn't it? Someone else took the top seat."

That was true.

"There's nothing else to do. We just have to wait until after midterm camp."

"After midterm camp?"

Astina looked at me with a puzzled expression.

"Well, if there's nothing for you to do, I guess I won't be of any help either. Let's get back to work."

"Understood."

Astina handed me some documents, and I began to process the tasks she assigned.

After finishing a fair amount of work, I stepped outside with a light gait.

"Is it too late?"

It was already time for dinner.

"I should stop by the dormitory briefly and then have dinner with Luna."

Feeling delighted, I walked on.

By now, most of my worries had vanished.

Luna hadn't destroyed the library, and I had secured second place without any issues.

My magic was growing steadily, so there wasn't much to be concerned about.

After stepping outside, I looked up at the sky.

"Why is the weather like this?"

Though my mood was good, the sky was filled with dark clouds.

A heavy feeling washed over me.

Despite things going smoothly, I couldn't shake off an uneasy feeling.

As that unease lingered...

Kwa-aaaaaang!!!

A powerful explosion resounded throughout the Academy.

"What...?"

I looked in the direction of the sound.

The source of the noise was... the library.

"The library... Luna...?"

This is 3/4 for the week! 'I Became a Third-Rate Villain In the Hero Academy' just got advance/ and this novel will too but we've got some things to sort out first. It'll most likely move to 5chaps/week as well but not sure when that will be.

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 16: The Burning Library

(2)

On the day the exam results were announced, after class had ended, Luna walked to the library alone.

Before joining the student council, she and Rudy had gone to the library together almost every day.

Now that they were apart, the empty space felt more pronounced.

"Rudy... Is he alright?"

Rudy hadn't managed to secure the top spot this time.

Luna knew him as a friend who was entirely focused on his studies, never shifting his attention elsewhere.

He must have wanted the top seat badly.

"His expression wasn't good."

Rudy usually didn't have much variation in his facial expressions.

However, today was different.

His usually sharp gaze seemed slightly blurred, and the corners of his mouth twitched.

It was a complicated expression, difficult to describe.

He was undoubtedly upset.

On the other hand, Luna's grades had improved significantly.

She had achieved good results, studying daily with Rudy.

Although she was happy about her improvement, she felt guilty.

Rudy had been supporting her tuition fees and giving her an allowance, in exchange for her research.

Yet, she hadn't been of any help.

"...You idiot! What's the point of just studying?!"

Luna roughly ruffled her hair.

She had conducted other research while preparing for exams, but she hadn't achieved any significant results.

She hadn't even managed to create the magic circle Rudy had requested.

Instead, Rudy had asked Professor Cromwell questions and provided her with various pieces of information, which helped her greatly.

"Ah..."

Professor Mcguire had given her a deadline, but Rudy hadn't.

It was because he trusted her.

He believed in her potential.

She didn't want to betray that trust.

There wasn't much Luna could do for Rudy now.

She didn't think any words from her would comfort him.

The only thing she could do was show him the results of her research.

To distract him from his thoughts by presenting him with fascinating research.

She believed that was the best way she could comfort him.

Now that midterms were over, she had plenty of time.

Rika and Ena had invited her to a restaurant near the Academy tomorrow.

But she wouldn't go anywhere unless she produced research results!

Luna made a firm resolution.

Midterms were over, and classes had ended early, so she had plenty of time for research.

"I'll...focus on my research!!"

A little later...

"Ugh..."

Luna lay sprawled across the library desk.

Beside her were stacks of books and papers.

They were evidence of her efforts.

"Is this not it either..."

Luna flipped through the research papers.

"Sigh... Should I start from the beginning again..."

Luna began skimming through the books once more.

She had already discarded three or four research projects.

Some of the research was beyond her abilities, while others were fundamentally flawed.

"Now, I don't even know where to begin..."

She had already read the beginner magic books several times.

However, these fields had already been thoroughly researched, and Luna couldn't see any room for further study.

So, she focused on intermediate magic circles.

Even someone who could only use basic magic could cast more advanced spells with a well-drawn magic circle and scrolls.

But it was much more difficult.

"There are no more books to read..."

The library had countless books, but the number of books related to her specialities and level of understanding was limited.

That's when Luna's eyes fell on the grimoire given to her by her benefactor.

"...Can I understand it now?"

When she first saw it, she had no idea what the contents were about.

However, a lot has changed since then.

She could now slowly read the magic circles related to intermediate magic.

-Open the grimoire when you can handle it properly.

Suddenly, she recalled the letter from the person who gave her the grimoire.

But she still didn't understand the meaning of those words.

When she first read those words, she was scared.

She thought something strange might happen if she opened the grimoire.

One day, out of curiosity, she couldn't resist opening it.

But nothing happened.

She just couldn't understand the contents.

Luna took out the grimoire after a long time.

For a moment, she stared at the cover and pondered.

"What's the harm?"

Luna opened the grimoire.

She started flipping through the pages, scanning them one by one.

She could understand some of the contents, but most of it was still unknown to her.

"Ugh..."

There were even parts she couldn't read at all.

"It's difficult..."

As she continued flipping through, Luna came across an eye-catching magic circle.

"...A square."

It was a square magic circle, just like the one she first drew.

"Did I come up with that magic circle after seeing this...?"

She never knew there was such a magic circle in the grimoire before.

But looking at the magic circle, she felt disappointed.

Rudy had praised her for coming up with a brilliant idea, but it wasn't that brilliant after all.

Perhaps the magic circle she saw as a child unconsciously remained in her mind, allowing her to create it.

"Was it just...good luck...?"

Luna stroked the square magic circle with her hand.

It was undoubtedly the same square magic circle, but she couldn't read it at all.

A high-level magic circle.

If only I could use such a magic circle...

Wouldn't it help Rudy too?

"Huh...?"

As she had that thought, the magic circle began to emit a bright light.

"What's this...?"

Luna's mana drained from her body.

-Crackling...!

"Ah..."

As the spark burst, her vision blurred.

-Kwaaaaaang!!!

Then, strong winds and flames erupted from Luna's body.

"Luna...!"

Flames erupted from the library.

They didn't seem to have spread outside.

I rushed straight to the library.

It had to be Luna.

She had said she would study in the library today.

But something was off.

The scale of the flames wasn't what I had seen in the game.

Had the incident been delayed?

Come to think of it, the magic I saw last time was strange too.

When I tried to use magic on Locke, it seemed more powerful than I expected.

I was able to use magic at a level similar to his.

Of course, I didn't delve deep into a single attribute, so the power of each spell was weaker.

Even so, I was still among the stronger students.

"Luna's level in magic must be higher higher than in the game."

This wasn't good.

Luna had been able to avoid punishment in the game because the situation was small.

Though there were many books in the library, protection magic had prevented any damage, and the incident had occurred late at night without

casualties.

There had been no significant damage, so she could avoid punishment.

But now, the situation was serious.

As I approached, many people were watching the scene in front of the library.

The student council members were preventing people from getting too close, and a familiar face was at the forefront.

"Astina, senior."

Astina turned around upon hearing my voice.

She had arrived before me, despite being further away.

It seemed like she had used magic to get here.

"Rudy"

Astina looked back at the library.

"The fire isn't too strong. It doesn't seem like the library itself is burning."

Astina roughly explained the situation.

She was right.

Luna's mana wouldn't be enough to burn down the entire library.

The protected library couldn't burn that easily.

Astina began to move her mana.

"I'll put out the fire."

As Astina reached out to use magic, I grabbed her wrist.

"You can't."

"What?"

Astina looked at me, her expression full of confusion.

-Thud!

"Look! Someone's coming out!"

Hearing someone's shout, I turned my gaze to the library door.

As the door opened, someone stumbled out.

"Ugh..."

Astina and I rushed over to the person.

Upon seeing their face, it was the librarian in charge of the library.

"Are you alright?"

I asked, and they gave a slight nod.

"Is there anyone else inside?"

"I...I was the only librarian... But... Luna, the student..."

"Luna? Luna Railer?"

Astina asked the librarian, who nodded.

"Yes... I saw that student studying earlier, but I haven't seen her since..."

"Oh, if it's Luna, she's fine. She was with me just a moment ago."

"What?"

Astina and the librarian looked at me.

"Ah... you're the friend who's always with Luna... In that case, there's no one left inside the library."

The librarian sighed in relief.

However, Astina wasn't convinced and stared at me intently.

"One of the student council members! Please take this person to the infirmary."

"Yes!"

Upon my shout, someone came and escorted the librarian away.

"Rudy Astria, didn't you show up just now?"

Astina asked me with a face full of suspicion.

I told her the truth.

"Luna is inside."

We started conversing in hushed tones, so no one around could hear.

"But why did you say she was somewhere else?"

"Luna started the fire."

"What? The fire? Luna Railer can only use beginner-level magic, right?"

Astina looked at the flames consuming the library.

It wasn't a fire that Luna could have caused.

However, there was a possible explanation.

"It's a mana explosion. It happened due to mental corruption from dark magic."

A mana explosion is a common symptom when using dark magic improperly.

All the mana within the body is expelled outward.

However, pure mana cannot be expelled, so all the spells the body can use are cast haphazardly.

And since she loses consciousness in the process, she can't control the magic that surges out of their body.

"How do you know this?"

Astina looked at me incredulously.

"I'll explain everything later. For now, we can't extinguish the fire immediately. If we do, the student council will enter the library to assess the situation, and we won't be able to save Luna."

"You're worried about Luna Railer being punished?"

"That's part of it, and there are other complications as well."

If such a fire occurred, they would thoroughly investigate the interior, and traces of Luna causing the incident would be left behind.

Those traces needed to be erased.

There were several other reasons, but explaining them now would only waste time.

It was crucial to act quickly.

"I'll go inside."

"What?"

Astina frowned at my words.

"What are you going to do by going in? It's better if I go."

"No. Astina, you just need to make sure no one enters. It's dangerous for a student to put out the fire, so we'll wait for the faculty to arrive."

Honestly, no student other than Astina could put out this fire.

Third-year students usually spend their first semester interning elsewhere.

So, there was no one at the academy capable of extinguishing this fire now.

Professors and teaching assistants were likely out celebrating since exams had ended.

Waiting for them would buy enough time.

"Can't we use your title as the student council president to make it happen?"

"It might be possible to stall until the faculty arrives, but you're the problem. Even if you're exceptional, isn't it difficult to handle a mana explosion?"

Astina was right.

But I had to do it.

"I'll give it a try."

If I run out of time, it's a failure.

If I fail, Luna's spellbook will be confiscated, and she'll be punished.

Considering the current situation, it wouldn't be a minor punishment.

A severe penalty, like suspension, was possible.

The spellbook was important, but I didn't want Luna to suffer such punishment.

Luna was my first friend since coming to this place.

She had been friendly to me even when everyone else pointed fingers and insulted me.

I didn't want her to suffer.

With that thought in mind, I made up my mind.

It was better to try than to waste time here pondering.

"I'll go in right away."

"Eh~ Where are you going by yourself?"

Rie appeared through the gap between the disciplinary committee members that had formed a blockade.

They tried to stop her, but Locke, who was behind Rie, stopped them.

"I'm from the student council. She is as well."

Upon hearing Locke's words, the committee members looked to Astina for confirmation.

"That's right. You don't have to stop them."

With Astina's permission, they let Rie and Locke pass.

"Can you do it by yourself~?"

I wondered what Rie was talking about.

We had only whispered our conversation and hadn't shown any actions.

Seeing my puzzled expression, Astina spoke up.

"She probably knows our conversation, so it's fine."

"...What?"

I was confused.

"Rie can handle both wind spirits and wind attribute magic, so she can hear almost any sound even from a distance."

She could hear... our entire conversation?

This ability wasn't mentioned in the game.

I knew she had a special ability to handle both magic and spirits, but I didn't know she could use it like this.

"I knew about all your actions because she told me."

"Princess Rie... informed you?"

What's the relationship between Princess Rie and Astina?

I felt a bit overwhelmed, but I quickly regained my composure.

I don't have time for this.

"So, Princess Rie, you're going to help me?"

"Yes~ I'll help you. You mean going in there, right? Where Locke is... huh?"

I grabbed Rie's wrist while she was speaking and headed toward the library.

There was no time for idle chatter.

Still, it was fortunate that Rie was willing to help.

"Wait? No, no. I'll help, but Locke is the one who should go in—."

"Quiet. Follow me quickly."

Since I was in a hurry, I dragged Rie along and briskly walked toward the library.

"No. Listen to my conditions first....."

"Tell me whatever you want."

"Well, first of all, stop using formal speech....."

As Princess Rie was being dragged by me, she continued to speak.

"Fine, I'll speak casually. Hurry up. We're running out of time. I'll listen to your conditions once everything's done."

As I kept ignoring her words and pulling her along, Rie dropped her cheeky attitude.

"Hey! I'm not going in there, okay? I'm a princess! What if I get hurt going in there?!"

Rie complained with annoyance.

"I won't make you do anything dangerous. Just follow me quickly. I need your help, not his."

"Lo, Locke!!! Locke!! Stop him!"

As I continued to pull her without hesitation, Rie stuttered and searched for Locke.

Locke then approached me.

I looked at Locke and said,

"Hey, you've wronged me before, haven't you?"

It was the time when he had insulted me.

Locke stopped in his tracks.

"I haven't received an apology for that yet. I won't make a fuss about it, so just stay put. It would be even better if you could prevent others from entering here."

Locke's expression tightened.

He was that kind of guy.

Since he made a mistake with me, he would at least do one favor for me, no matter what Rie says.

"...Understood."

"Wha, what, what? Hey! Follow my order! Hey!"

"I apologize."

Locke bowed 90 degrees to Rie.

"Hey!!!!!!!!!!!!!!"

"He won't be of any help if he goes in there. Just follow me obediently."

With that, I took the screaming Rie into the library.

4/4 for the week! I want to re-edit the novel before any advance chaps it'll be another week.

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 17: The Burning Library

(3)

"There's no use in bringing him along. Just follow me."

"Consider it your duty to protect me at all costs. I'm going to be the Empress one day."

"Don't worry. Neither of us will die here."

Rie, in contrast to her usual cunning attitude, raised her voice in anger, revealing her true nature.

That's right; this is how she should be.

I found this attitude more comfortable.

Her typical behavior might be more appealing to the nobility, but for me, who knew about the real Rie, it was disconcerting.

Eventually, we reached the library entrance after walking for some time.

Until now, we had only been in the corridor leading to the library, so there were no flames; however, the situation inside was dire.

Thick smoke billowed out.

The magnificent library was engulfed in black smoke, small flames flickering here and there.

Fortunately, the books and shelves were safeguarded by a magic barrier, which prevented the fire from spreading rapidly.

Still, other objects were ablaze, and the fire seemed to be intensifying.

"First, remove your clothes."

"...What? Have you lost your mind? Is this your true self emerging?"

Rie retorted with a sharp tongue.

"No, I meant the coat you're wearing."

I removed my academy coat and tossed it on the floor.

"The coat?"

Rie glanced at me with a perplexed expression before looking at her own coat.

"Hmm..."

She cleared her throat and took off her coat, handing it to me.

"Water Ball."

I used magic to drench the coats.

"Cover your nose and mouth with these. Though the books are safe, the burning tables and chairs can pose a danger."

"I understand."

Rie blushed as she took her own coat from me.

"Stay as low as possible and follow me."

"I said I understand."

Though Rie grumbled, she followed my instructions diligently.

Luna's likely whereabouts were fairly predictable - the desk where we used to study together every day.

I cautiously approached it.

The surrounding desks were burning, and the fire was spreading.

Fortunately, the books were still undamaged, but if the fire continued, they might be affected.

For now, I couldn't afford to worry about the books and focused solely on moving forward.

As I passed the space where librarians waited and organized books, the flames grew larger.

"Ugh..."

As I neared the location, it appeared as if Luna was there, but burning debris blocked my path.

I tried to force my way through with just my body, but it proved difficult.

Should I use magic?

As I hesitated, I heard Rie's voice from behind me.

"Wind Blaster."

As Rie chanted, a strong wind surged forward.

It swept away the burning desks obstructing our way forward.

Seeing my astonished expression, Rie gestured ahead.

"Quickly, take the lead."

Following Rie's instructions, I advanced, and Rie used magic and spirits to deflect the embers descending toward us.

We made our way deeper into the library until we reached the desks we had used every day, we found Luna lying on the floor.

Thankfully, she didn't appear to have serious injuries.

However, fire and wind swirled around her.

"Luna!"

As I called her name, a violent storm erupted from Luna's body.

"Ugh...!"

It wasn't just an ordinary wind; it was a barrage of wind blades.

Should I dodge?

No, I couldn't.

Rie was behind me.

If I dodged, Rie wouldn't have time to react and would be struck.

I shielded my face with my arms.

The wind blades flew towards me, grazing my arms and legs as they passed by.

I avoided a direct hit due to my distance from Luna, but several scratches formed on my body.

"Hey! Are you okay?"

Rie looked at me, concerned.

The wounds were minor, stinging a bit but not hindering my movement.

"Let's save Luna first."

There was a reason I took us here without relying too much on magic.

"What should we do?"

When magic went out of control like this, there were two ways to handle it.

First, endure until the person exhausts all their mana. This method was impractical since we didn't know when faculty members would arrive.

Second, give Luna a significant shock to wake her.

This was the most effective method.

Magic going out of control was dangerous because the person would continuously cast spells while unconscious.

If the person experiencing a mana rampage regained their senses, even momentarily, they could stop the situation, and their body would automatically regulate their mana.

Waking them up was simple: give a physical shock to make them regain consciousness.

However, the problem was determining how much shock was needed to wake them.

In fact, I could use magic from my current position to deliver a shock to Luna.

But a direct hit might seriously injure her.

No matter how talented Rie and I were, we were still beginner wizards.

To reach Luna, we needed to break through the magic surrounding her.

We had to penetrate the magic without causing harm to Luna, which required delicate control.

But as beginner magicians, we weren't capable of such precise control.

So, there was only one option left.

We had to approach Luna physically.

We would break through the wind and flames and wake her up.

This was the plan I came up with.

"I'll move forward while deflecting the wind attribute magic, so make sure fire attribute magic doesn't reach me."

"What? If we do that..."

Rie looked at me, surprised.

"Don't worry, I value my life too."

My number one priority is survival. I wouldn't gamble my life recklessly.

Hearing this, Rie gave me a faint smile.

"Alright. Give it a try."

With that, I dashed towards Luna.

I wanted to run faster, but the powerful wind gave heavy resistance.

However, there was a way to break through.

"Wind Blaster!"

I aimed the spell slightly above Luna.

A strong gust of wind surged from my hand, creating a counter wind from my direction.

While studying for the midterm exam, my magic had improved by one level.

I reached LV8, and my wind attribute magic had become stronger than before.

Luna's magic was currently being cast haphazardly.

Of course, she was in a mana rampage state, so each spell was more potent than mine.

However, she wasn't focusing her magic at a specific point.

That's why, by focusing my magic on a single point, I could break through.

Using magic to create a counter-wind, the resistance on my body disappeared.

I seized the opportunity to run towards Luna.

As I did so, flames surged from her body.

Since Luna could control both wind and fire attributes, I had anticipated this.

"Sylph, block it."

At Rie's command, a green light flew towards me.

It then generated a gust of wind, pushing the flames away.

I followed the path made by Sylph, pressing forward.

But as the flames and wind continued to blow, Sylph struggled to keep up, and our progress slowed down.

"Wind Blaster!!"

I used the spell again to repel the flames and wind.

However, the closer I got, the more potent the magic became.

"Wind Blaster! Wind Blaster!"

I had no choice but to continue using magic to advance.

I directed the wind upwards, and Rie used Sylph to push away the oncoming flames.

As we moved forward, I heard Rie's voice.

"Hey! Sylph can't push any further!"

Now, Luna and I were less than 10 meters apart.

At this distance...

"Water Ball!"

I used water attribute magic to drench myself.

"Rie! Push back the magic one more time!"

"Uh... Sylph! Push the magic upwards!"

Then, the green light beside me intensified.

Sylph created a powerful gust of wind, sending the flames upwards.

After generating such a strong wind, Sylph's form vanished with a 'pop!'

It had used all its power and was forced to unsummon.

Everything was sent flying upwards by the wind Sylph created. A path opened up.

Without hesitation, I dashed toward Luna.

Flames stood in my way, but I threw myself through them.

"Luna!"

I immediately grabbed Luna's shoulders and shook her.

"Luna! Wake up!"

However, this was a big mistake. I should have given Luna a proper shock.

"Ah...?"

As I shook her, an even more potent surge of magic expelled from her body

-Boom!!

"Ugh...!"

The powerful wind sent me flying backward.

I took the full brunt of the blast, and my body was hurled through the air, landing far away.

"Ouch!"

Mid-air, I collided with a bookshelf.

-Ooof.

Thankfully, the bookshelf's protective magic reduced the impact.

But it still hurt.

"Ugh..."

"Rudy Astria! Are you alright?"

Rie rushed over after seeing me being sent flying.

It felt like a punch to the solar plexus, and I struggled to breathe.

"Cough, huff huff... Hiccup..."

After gasping for air a few times, I started to regain my senses.

Pushed away, huh?

I assessed the situation as I adjusted my position.

My body's condition... it wasn't to the point where I couldn't stand.

Seeing I was somewhat okay, Rie began to scold me.

"Hey! You should have woken her up in one go! What did you think would happen if you just poked her like that?"

"Uh... I didn't know she would suddenly release such powerful magic."

"When you touch her, her body will instinctively release magic to protect itself! Isn't that obvious?"

I understood Rie's point after her explanation. She should have told me sooner.

"Ugh."

There was no point in blaming Rie, as it was my mistake.

I stood up and looked at Luna, who continued to expel flames and wind. Rie sighed as she looked over as well.

"Rudy Astria, give up. Sylph was unsummoned and can't be summoned again today. And if you try to go in there again, it could be disastrous."

Rie was right.

To stop someone experiencing a mana rampage, one usually needs someone several levels above them.

People usually can't use all their mana at once.

If they do, they would be unable to use magic for days due to the backlash, and their body would be a mess.

They might even lose consciousness during use.

However, someone in a mana rampage state doesn't consider this and pushes their mana to the limit.

That was why I was continuously pushed back even though my magic was superior to Luna's.

"One more time. Let's try just one more time."

Still, I couldn't give up.

"Ugh... If you fail this time too, I'm leaving you behind."

Rie sighed once more.

"I've figured out how to wake her up, so we just need to break through."

I tried to stand up by grabbing the bookshelf behind me.

"...Ouch!"

However, the bookshelf moved, causing me to fall once again.

"...What are you doing?"

Rie looked at me with pity as I fell over again.

I rubbed my hips and scowled. Why did the bookshelf move?

"What's this?"

The bookshelf had wheels attached, allowing it to move.

"Someone must have forgotten to lock the wheels."

Rie glanced at the wheels before refocusing on the main issue.

"Let's try again. I'll help as much as I can."

With that, Rie walked back toward Luna.

I let her be and focused my attention on the bookshelf that had shifted.

"What are you doing? We don't have much time."

"Let's use this."

"What?"

I was trying to re-edit everything (for all novels) before releasing more chaps but uhh I underestimated how long that takes... Anyways heres 1/4, the re-edit will have to take a little longer and I don't want to release any advance chaps until the re-edits are done. How long? No idea, before Monday would be nice.

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 18: The Burning Library

(4)

I pushed the bookshelf in front of us.

"Is this possible?"

Rie expressed her doubts, but it seemed plausible.

"I flew over earlier and the bookshelf wasn't pushed away. I only pushed it slightly, and it moved. The protective magic blocks major impacts but allows it to move normally with ordinary force."

"Haa... If the protective magic fails, won't all the books burn?"

"We can cover that with our pocket money. And do you think the academy would care about a few books getting burned in a fire like this?"

"I understand using your money, but why do I have to contribute mine too?"

Rie glared at me as she spoke. I looked at her and replied.

"How stingy."

"It's reasonable."

I chuckled and looked forward.

"Let's finish the task first."

"I'll block the flames from above, so you keep running forward."

I nodded and began pushing the bookshelf.

"Wind Blaster!"

Rie cast her magic upwards.

At that moment, I pushed the bookshelf forcefully and ran.

Maintaining the bookshelf's balance, I continued pushing forward.

As expected, the protective magic activated in front of the bookshelf, repelling the spells.

Using the bookshelf as a shield, I kept advancing.

One step.

Another step.

As I got closer, my speed slowed down, but the distance between Luna and me shortened.

I looked up as I moved forward.

An immense blaze was above my head. Rie was pushing back the flames with her wind magic.

If those flames fell, I'd die instantly. However, I trusted Rie. Believing she could hold them back, I kept moving forward.

"Rudy Astria! Almost there! Wind Blaster!"

Rie cast her magic while talking to me. I pushed the bookshelf with all my might.

Bang!!

The bookshelf toppled over with a loud noise, pushing away the flames and wind in front of it.

"Luna!!!"

I stepped on the fallen bookshelf and leaped towards Luna. I wouldn't make a mistake this time. I clenched my fist as I got close to Luna.

"Wake up!!!"

I struck Luna's forehead with a powerful punch.

Smack!

"Eek!"

Luna let out a strange sound as I hit her forehead hard.

But she only opened her eyes for a moment before closing them again, as if falling back asleep.

"Did... it work?"

I muttered to myself and looked around.

The surrounding magic seemed to freeze as if time had stopped.

The flames remained, but the strong winds ceased to blow. Moreover, no new flames appeared around Luna's body.

"Ugh..."

"Luna!"

Luna moaned and tossed in her sleep.

And then.

The fire and wind sustained by magic.

They began to fade away.

"Haah... Is it over...?"

As the magic disappeared, Rie collapsed onto the floor.

I checked on Luna's condition first.

Though she seemed to be unconscious, I didn't see any serious injuries.

"Thank goodness..."

I let out a sigh of relief and looked at the book lying beside her.

It appeared to be a valuable grimoire, with a soft leather cover.

"As I thought... a grimoire."

Luna's treasure.

It was a grimoire given to her by the Royal Wizard Levian.

I picked up the grimoire and opened it.

On the displayed page, a square magical circle was drawn.

It reminded me of the magical circle Luna had drawn.

"It was because of this..."

I knew about this grimoire.

It was truly the ultimate grimoire for those who dealt with magical circles.

The reason Luna became incredibly powerful in the game.

This grimoire was a scroll in book form.

Moreover, a scroll that could be used without tearing.

The disadvantage of a mage who mainly used magical circles was that they couldn't respond to sudden events.

It was impossible to carry all the scrolls for every magic, and even if they carried multiple scrolls, they were just one-time-use spells.

However, this grimoire compensated for that disadvantage.

If they wanted to use a certain magical circle engraved in the book, they could use it just by thinking about it.

Of course, they had to pay the required mana themselves, but it was an incredibly overpowered item compared to one-time-use scrolls.

Thanks to this grimoire, Luna would become one of the strongest magic users in the latter half of the game.

This square magical circle drawn in the grimoire.

She probably thought to try using it because it was similar to the magical circle she had drawn.

This incident was my mistake.

I thought Luna caused this incident because Professor Mcguire had given her a tight deadline.

However, the likely cause of this incident was this square magical circle.

It was such a trivial reason.

"It's really confusing."

I felt the same way last time.

When I heard that Garwel had been the one behind the red-headed troublemaker.

I thought I knew everything about this world because I had played the game dozens of times.

However, I only knew the results of this world, not the causes.

It was my arrogance to try to control this world with the scenes I saw in the game.

I couldn't change all the game events without knowing that.

"Let's think about this later."

I sighed at my own mistake and carried Luna.

I also held Luna's grimoire in my hand.

"What's this?"

Rie looked at me with a puzzled expression.

"I'll escape through the window at the back."

"What?"

Rie stared at me, incredulous.

"Luna can't be here, right?"

"Then what about me?"

"I have a favor to ask of you too."

"You...I've already helped so much, and you still have more to ask?"

"Use water attribute magic to flood this place."

I wanted to ask her to extinguish the fire, but Rie had already used a significant amount of mana.

I didn't want to burden her further.

However, we needed to use magic here to erase Luna's mana traces.

Although both my magic and Rie's had been used extensively, some traces might remain.

Wind attribute magic had mixed our mana traces, but fire attribute magic only had Luna's mana traces left.

To erase the traces, we had to either overlap them with the same attribute magic or cover them with opposing attributes.

We couldn't enlarge the fire with fire attribute magic, so we needed to cover the traces with water attribute magic, minimizing them as much as possible.

Rie glared at me, her face filled with anger.

"Do you think I'm your servant? Just following your orders?"

Carrying Luna, I bowed to Rie.

"Please, I beg you. I'll do anything you ask later."

Seeing me bowing sincerely, Rie sighed.

"You better know that I'll make you work your bones off later."

"Of course."

I walked towards the back of the library. Then Rie called out to me.

"Hey, if they ask where you are, what should I say?"

"Just tell them I got scared and ran away."

"Ran away?"

With that, I escaped through the window at the back of the library.

"Haah..."

Rie sighed deeply as she watched me leave.

After Rudy left the library, Rie sat in a corner.

"Sigh... Seriously."

Rie let out a deep sigh as she pondered her situation.

"I'm a princess... Damn it..."

She looked at herself, wearing her wet uniform and covered in soot. She felt dirty and uncomfortable.

She wanted to run to the bathroom and wash herself right away.

She was also annoyed.

Tell them he ran away?

Did he not know what would happen to him if she said that? It would only add fuel to his already unfavorable reputation.

Rie took a moment to collect her thoughts and then muttered to herself.

"I'll do it like this."

Rie stood up from her seat.

"Locke! Come in!"

She called out loudly for Locke, who entered the library. Locke looked around.

"Where did Rudy Astria go?"

"Forget it. You don't need to know. Just do what I ask."

"What do you need me to do?"

"Move all the books I mention from their locations to the window at the back of the library."

"Understood."

Rie spoke and cast a spell.

"Water Ball!"

"Which books should I move first?"

"Mana Reconstitution in row T, number 12, and Orwell's Mana Theory in row Z, number 16."

Following Rie's instructions, Locke continued to move the books, while Rie used magic to extinguish the flames.

"Rudy!! Rie!! Where are you!!!"

Professor Mcguire shouted as he entered the library.

He was the first professor to arrive at the academy.

Fortunately, he hadn't been drinking, so he was able to come immediately.

Of course, it took some time for him to get here from his house outside the academy.

Calling out for Rudy and Rie, Professor Mcguire ventured further into the library. He looked around.

"The fire seems to have mostly died down..."

"It appears so."

Astina followed behind Professor Mcguire and spoke up.

"I heard it was a huge fire. Did those two put it out?"

"We'll have to find them and hear the story first."

"If the two students are seriously injured, you'll have to take responsibility, Astina Persia."

"It should be fine."

Astina confidently replied.

Judging by the mostly extinguished fire, it seemed that they had succeeded in stopping Luna Railer.

Astina and Professor Mcguire continued deeper into the library.

-Splash.

"Huh? What's with all this water...?"

As Professor Mcguire went further in, he noticed the wet floor.

It was strange, as this place had clearly been engulfed in a massive fire, yet the surroundings were soaked.

"Huh?"

Professor Mcguire looked around as he moved forward and spotted Rie.

"Rie! Are you alright?!"

Rie was sitting down, leaning against a bookshelf.

Her hair was drenched, and her face was covered in soot.

"Haah..."

"Pfft..."

Astina couldn't help but laugh at Rie's appearance.

Nevertheless, looking around, it seemed like the situation had been resolved.

"Rie! What happened?"

"Ah... We just put out the fire."

Rie casually replied without her usual pretense.

Professor Mcguire was taken aback by her attitude and asked again.

"Ah... Well, where's Rudy? Where did he go?"

"Haah..."

Rie let out an even deeper sigh.

"Rudy Astria has returned to his room."

"What? To his room?"

Professor Mcguire asked with a puzzled expression.

Rie didn't say anything further but led him towards the window. There were numerous books piled up there.

"How...?"

These were no ordinary books.

They were all managed by the librarian personally.

Though they weren't treasured items, they certainly had some value as collectibles.

"Although there's protection magic on the books, Rudy Astria moved them all, fearing that the fire might damage them if it persisted. While he was doing that, I extinguished the fire."

"Rudy did?"

"Rudy Astria often comes to the library and knows the value and locations of the books, so he could move them."

"Oh, I see..."

Professor McGuire couldn't help but express a hint of admiration.

Rie continued speaking as she saw Professor McGuire's reaction.

"Then, he suffered a minor burn and returned to his room."

"A burn? Is he seriously injured?"

"No, he received proper first aid, and the situation was somewhat resolved, so we just sent him back."

"But I didn't hear about him leaving the library separately?"

With a slight hint of doubt, Professor McGuire asked.

"He went around the back because there were too many people in front of the library."

"I see... It's fortunate that no one was seriously injured. Rie, you should go back to your room and rest as well."

"Yes, thank you."

As Rie tried to walk past Professor McGuire and head outside, she made eye contact with Astina. Astina smiled and said to Rie,

"That was impressive."

"Are you mocking me?"

Rie shot a brief glare at Astina and walked toward the exit.

"Clean."

Astina cast a spell on Rie as she walked away.

Immediately, her clothes became tidy, and the soot and other marks on her face disappeared.

Rie, surprised by the sudden cleanliness, turned around to look back.

"I learned this spell just a while ago, and it seems to work well~."

Astina smiled brightly as she spoke to Rie.

Rie glanced at Astina for a moment before continuing her walk toward the exit.

That's 2/4

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 19: The Burning Library

(5)

Late at night, the sound of cricket chirps filled my quiet room.

"Haah..."

Leaving all the noise and chaos behind, I felt a sense of calm wash over me.

It seemed like everything had ended well.

Although I wasn't sure about the aftermath, I believed Rie and Astina would handle it.

I lowered Luna, who I had been carrying, onto my bed.

"Uh..."

Luna groaned and began to regain consciousness.

"Luna, are you alright?"

I sat her down on my bed, holding her head.

"Where... is this?"

Luna looked around, frowning.

"It's my room."

"You...?"

Luna raised her head to look at me standing in front of her.

"Ru... Rudy? How did you...? No, more importantly, ah...!"

As if realizing something, Luna opened her eyes wide and scanned the room.

"Huh? I was in the library, right? I was touching a book... Ah! The book? Was there a grimoire nearby where I was? It has a high-quality leather cover...!"

"Here it is."

I handed over Levian's grimoire, which I had placed beside me.

Seeing her search for the book as soon as she regained consciousness, I could tell how much Luna cherished it.

"Th-thank goodness... But, what happened? I remember touching this grimoire and then losing consciousness."

I explained the situation to the confused Luna.

I told her about Luna's mana explosion and the burning library, but I didn't go into too much detail.

If I went too deep, I would have to mention what I knew about the grimoire.

Luna would be even more confused if she knew I had information I wasn't supposed to know...

"So that's what happened... I..."

After hearing the whole story, Luna bowed her head.

I could feel various emotions from her expression, like remorse and sadness.

I didn't say anything else.

The sound of cricket chirps filled the silence.

In the midst of the quiet, Luna spoke up.

"You know, Rudy, I was a real troublemaker when I was young."

Luna, who said that, had a bitter expression on her face.

"You might not know this since you lived in the capital, but it's difficult to find friends when you live on the outskirts of the empire. Especially friends of similar status."

Luna continued.

"Because of that, I would cause mischief everywhere out of boredom. I would play pranks on the villagers' crops or ride on the animals the villagers raised..."

Luna reminisced and smiled faintly.

"One day, while I was playing like that, a wizard visited our territory."

"A wizard..."

The royal wizard, Levian, must have been the one.

"It was an old man with an enormous beard who said he would rest in our territory for a while. So, my father... no, my dad offered him a nice place to stay."

"But, that old man said there was no need for that. He would just find a place to rest on his own and asked us not to worry about him."

"So, what happened?"

As I asked, Luna replied with a smile.

"That wizard built a small hut on the outskirts of our territory and stayed there. It was a really shabby hut..."

Luna looked up at the ceiling as if reminiscing.

"And that wizard helped the people in our territory every day. He took care of the residents, made the territory prosperous, and drove away monsters."

"He sounds like a good person."

"Right? I was curious about that wizard, so I visited him every day. But every day, he drove me away."

"Being young and mischievous, I became even more determined to visit him. Of course, I played pranks on that hut every day... like I said before, I was a troublemaker."

Luna scratched her head, looking somewhat embarrassed.

"By visiting him every day, I found something the wizard treasured. It was a magic tome that looked valuable at first glance. The wizard held it in his hand even while sleeping and doing other things."

"So, I decided to play a prank with that magic tome. I wanted to fool the wizard who drove me away every day. I planned to steal the tome and make a fool of him."

"Did you succeed?"

"No, it was too difficult to steal that magic tome. It was impossible for an ordinary child like me to steal something from a wizard. Hehe..."

She continued with a laugh.

"One day, when I was trying to steal the magic tome, I encountered a monster on my way to the hut. The hut was on the outskirts, so the monster had come there."

"I cried and ran away. However, being a young child, I couldn't escape from the monster. I was caught and faced a life-threatening situation. That's when the wizard appeared."

Luna looked down with a faint smile.

"The wizard instantly eliminated the monster, and I was saved. After that, my father didn't allow me to leave my room."

"But one day, I got a chance to escape from my room. I immediately left my room and headed for the hut where the wizard was."

"And then?"

"Um... when I got to the hut, the wizard was lying down in one corner, sleeping. As a normal child, I should have thanked him, but I didn't show my gratitude and was mischievous instead. You know, young kids often play pranks as a sign of affection."

"I looked around and found the magic tome near the wizard. So, I decided to steal it. I took the magic tome and returned to my room. And then I waited for the wizard to come to our mansion."

Luna made a pained expression as she spoke.

Such an agonizing look on her face.

"But even after a day or two had passed, he didn't come to the mansion. I felt something was off because the townspeople usually came to see me the day after I caused trouble."

"I was being spiteful and decided not to give him the magic book until he came looking for me. Then one day, there was a commotion in our territory."

With a choked-up voice, Luna continued.

"The wizard... The old man was found dead in his house."

Luna let out an awkward laugh. Her expression looked as if she was about to cry at any moment.

"I later found out that he had passed away due to old age... He was so old... That powerful wizard who could defeat even the strongest monsters..."

Luna repeated herself, seemingly swallowing her tears.

"I never got the chance to thank the old man even once. Then my father handed me a letter. He said it was a letter the old man had left for me. I immediately opened it."

"In the letter, there was a lot of content. Among them was a message saying that I had talent in magic and that I should do whatever it takes to get into Liberion Academy..."

"And there was this sentence..."

Taking a deep breath, Luna continued.

"He said he was never bored, thanks to me. That's why he wanted to give me this magic book as a gift."

Luna showed me the magic book she was holding. Tears welled up in her eyes.

"How foolish, right? I just caused trouble and was a nuisance, but he wanted to give me this magic book. He said I had talent in magic... What does he know about me..."

Luna bit her lower lip.

"But he believed in me so much, and all I do is cause accidents... The real fool is me."

I looked at Luna. This was a story I had never heard before.

In the game, the story usually revolved around Evan.

Evan would console Luna by sharing his own story after Luna had burned the library.

So, I had no idea Luna had such a story.

Many thoughts crossed my mind.

Should I comfort Luna?

Should I empathize with her and pat her back?

I made up my mind and opened my mouth.

"Luna."

As I called her, Luna lifted her head and looked at me.

However, I spat out cold words at her.

"I won't empathize with your situation, nor will I comfort you."

"...?"

At my words, Luna raised her head.

"Your parents might understand your situation and try to help you in any way they can, but I won't."

I thought that harsh words were necessary.

I wouldn't comfort her for her failure.

If a person keeps receiving comfort for their failures, they'll get used to failing.

"Right now, my life is hard and burdensome. I'm too busy thinking about my future to have the leisure to worry about you."

Luna lowered her head.

"I'm sorry... I-"

"But," I interrupted Luna's words.

"Even if I can't empathize with your hardships, I can still be happy with your joy."

Luna looked at me with a puzzled expression.

"When you succeed, when you achieve something, when you accomplish something. At that moment, I can truly be happy with you. I can smile and sincerely congratulate you."

I said those words with a faint smile. I wanted to let her know how much happiness awaited her when she succeeded, even if I couldn't comfort her in her failures.

"Overcome it. You can overcome it. These failures and difficulties are for you to bear and stand up from."

People often say that the person beside you during tough times is a true friend.

But I don't think so.

My life is also harsh and painful, how could I bear someone else's pain as well?

I believe a true friend is someone who doesn't leave you during difficult times.

There's no need to stay by their side all the time. You don't need to share their pain. After all, everyone has their own life.

That's why a true friend is someone who waits for you from afar until you succeed.

Someone who waits until you're genuinely happy. Someone who can truly rejoice with you.

That person is a true friend.

Tears streamed down Luna's face. However, she was smiling. She smiled brightly.

"If this isn't consolation, then what is... You're such a fool."

Luna said that and stood up from her seat.

"You're a fool too... Can I ask a favor from such a fool?"

Luna shoved a magic book at me.

"...?"

"Take this. Keep it with you. It's my most precious possession, so handle it with care."

"Why are you giving this to me?"

"I think it's something I can't handle right now. Hold onto it, and when you think I'm ready, give it back to me."

Luna grinned.

"Please watch me succeed once. As my sponsor, you can at least have that much patience, right?"

I accepted the magic book.

"I'm looking forward to it."

I smiled at Luna as I took the magic book. Luna smiled back at me, but suddenly furrowed her brow and rubbed her forehead.

"Why does my forehead hurt so much...?"

Ah.

"Could it be a side effect of the mana explosion?"

"Is that it?"

I couldn't bring myself to tell her that I had punched her in the head in this kind of atmosphere.

Chapter 20: Intermediate Magic (1)

A few days after the incident.

"Rudyyyyyy!"

After class, Luna spotted Rudy and called his name as she ran towards him.

Ena and Rika, who were with Luna, watched the scene.

"It's strange."

Rika muttered to herself, prompting Ena to ask,

"What's strange?"

"The way Luna calls Rudy Astria. It's a bit odd."

"How?"

As Ena asked, Rika stroked her chin and looked up.

"Hmm... Luna used to call Rudy Astria 'Rudy!'"

"Right?"

"But these days, she's been calling him 'Rudyyyyyy!'"

Ena's face went black for a moment as she heard the story.

"Why?"

"Ena! Don't you see the difference between 'Rudy!' and 'Rudyyyyyy!'?"

"...I don't think anyone would understand that."

Rika thought for a moment before speaking up.

"Somehow, 'Rudy!' feels friendly, but 'Rudyyyyy!' is a bit different. It's like... something has changed."

Ena glanced at Rika for a moment and then chuckled.

"Yeah, Rika, you do have some insight."

Luna's attitude had been strange for a few days.

She had always been close with Rudy Astria, but their bond seemed to have grown stronger.

Rudy Astria didn't seem to have changed much, but Luna was different.

Their relationship seemed to be more than just close friends or colleagues.

"I wonder what happened..."

Ena looked at Rudy Astria with suspicious eyes.

Clap!-

Suddenly, Rika clapped her hands.

"Hmm?"

Ena looked at Rika, who was smiling.

"Did you figure something out?"

Rika looked at Ena and grinned even more.

"No! I have no idea!"

"...Right."

She didn't know what Luna was feeling, but she resolved to help Luna as much as possible.

After the library fire, we enjoyed a few peaceful days.

Rie was acknowledged for her efforts in extinguishing the fire and received a commendation.

And somehow, I'm not sure how, but I also received words of gratitude from the professors.

They said giving me a commendation might be difficult, but they still appreciated my hard work.

I clearly told Rie to say I ran away, but I'm not sure what happened.

Honestly, who wouldn't feel good when everyone's expressing their gratitude?

I just happily went along with it.

It didn't seem like there would be any issues with the story since rumors about me hadn't spread among the students.

I didn't care too much about Rie receiving the commendation either.

After all, Rie was the type to sweep up all the awards and certificates as the game progressed.

However, there was one problem.

It seemed like Rie had no particular thoughts about Evan.

Originally, when Evan took the top spot, Rie's gaze would be directed at him.

She would look at Evan with interest.

But she was so busy with the library incident that she hadn't paid any attention to Evan.

"Is it twisted already...?"

It was too early to judge that things had gone awry.

I decided to wait and see before making any decisions.

On a happier note, there was another piece of good news.

My Beginner Magic level had reached 9.

It was probably thanks to the real-life experience.

I had studied the theory diligently until now, but I had no practical experience.

Suddenly, having that practical experience caused my magic proficiency to increase explosively.

Looking at my current magic abilities, it seemed like I could reach Intermediate Magic with a bit more effort.

My goal was to learn at least some Dark Magic before the midterm camp.

That way, I could survive the event.

Of course, there was a problem to solve before that.

I opened the door to the student council room and entered.

"Oh, Rudy Astria, you're here?"

Astina and Rie were there.

"Rudy Astria, long time no see~."

Rie greeted me with a bright smile.

Her tone was not as aggressive as it was during the library incident, but rather her usual friendly demeanor.

I frowned and opened my mouth.

"You said to speak informally. Is there anyone here besides us?"

"Sigh..."

Upon hearing my words, Rie sighed and crossed her legs.

"Well, I guess there's no need to hide it now."

Rie spoke in a cold tone, not her usual gentle one.

It was a fierce tone, but it felt more comfortable.

"Shall we talk about 'that incident' now?"

She was referring to the library incident.

When the incident occurred, we brushed it off vaguely, but now it was time for a proper explanation.

And it was time for me to hear a proper explanation about them as well.

"First, Rudy Astria, tell us how you knew. How did you know Luna Railer would cause such an incident?"

Astina asked me.

I took a magic book from my bag.

Levian's magic book.

The magic book that Luna had handed over to me.

"Luna had this magic book."

"A magic book?"

Astina took the book and tried to open it.

"It's better not to open it. If something goes wrong, Astina might lose control too."

"...Fine."

Astina listened to me and put the magic book down again.

"So, what is this magic book?"

Rie asked me.

"The Royal Wizard, Levian's magic book."

"Levian...?"

Levian was a famous wizard for his magic circles.

Although it wasn't mentioned in the game, it seemed that he was a well-known wizard in the world of magic here.

"When Luna was young, Levian died in the Railer territory."

"What?"

According to my findings, Levian's death wasn't officially recorded.

He was merely listed as missing.

This told me one thing.

The head of the Railer family, Luna's father, didn't report Levian's death to the royal family.

"How did he die?"

"I'm not exactly sure, but it's believed to be due to aging. This part might be wrong, so just keep that in mind."

"Then how did Luna's mental contamination occur?"

I explained to Astina about how to use this magic book in response to her question.

A magic book that allows the use of magic without scrolls.

As I told them the story, both Astina and Rie frowned.

"A scroll that can be used infinitely... Why isn't this known to the world? If multiple books like this are created..."

Astina started to speak but stopped.

"...Did they run away?"

I looked at Astina as she spoke.

I had thought the same thing.

Levian created that fraudulent magic book and fled.

And to find him, he was reported missing.

The place Levian reached after fleeing was the Railer territory.

I could make that much of a guess.

"Who did he run away from?"

"It seems we'll have to find that out. The fact that he fled is just speculation, not certainty."

"Then, digging up information on Levian should be our priority."

Rie summarized the situation.

After listening to the conversation, I opened my mouth to speak.

"But do we really need to find out?"

After all, what Levian's plan was and who he was didn't matter to me.

There was no other influence from Levian at the academy besides this magic book.

"It doesn't hurt to know. Information can become a lifeline or a source of money."

Astina responded to my words.

Of course, it's not wrong to say that, but isn't there a saying that ignorance is bliss?

"Alright, I'll do a rough investigation."

So I left that for Rie to investigate.

I then asked Rie a question.

"What's the deal between you and Astina?"

"An alliance."

"I'll help Rie become emperor, and Rie will make me the Viscount of Persia. That's our plan."

Astina briefly elaborated on Rie's words.

"Is it because of Yuni?"

Yuni von Ristonia.

The Second Princess of the Empire and Rie's rival.

Rie was obviously ahead in terms of ability, but Yuni had other support.

Yuni had the support of the Astria family, the Nobles faction.

Three factions appear in this game.

The Rebels, the Nobles, and the Royalists.

The conflict between these three types of factions was the main story of the game.

When we become second-year students and Yuni enters the academy, the structure of these three factions is established.

"Can you even tell me this?"

Even if I was a discarded child, I belonged to the Astria family.

The Astria family was the leader of the nobles.

Isn't it strange to say such things?

"Don't you already know this much?"

Rie spoke as if it were absurd.

"Rudy Astria will have a hard time making a name for himself in politics.' Well, that makes you a better ally."

Astina also seemed to agree with Rie's words.

"So, what do you plan to do?"

As I asked, Rie answered.

"I'll help you become the head of the Astria family. Then all our problems will be solved."

"...What?"

I finished the conversation and returned to my room, deep in thought.

Take over the Astria family?

This suggestion was tantamount to completely twisting the story.

And it wasn't an easy task.

First of all, the gap between my brother and me was too wide.

My brother, who had already made a name for himself in politics, compared to me, who had just entered the academy and even lost the top spot.

No matter what anyone says, my brother would be the one to inherit the family.

"Haah... What a headache."

I agreed with them in that situation, but I'm not sure what they were thinking.

"Rudyyyy!"

While I was lost in thought, Luna came running, calling my name.

Luna ran up to me, looked at me, and smiled.

"Rudy, where are we going to study today?"

Since the library incident, Luna seemed more lively.

However, we had lost our study space.

The fire in the library required repairs, so the library was closed for a while.

We could borrow books, but we couldn't use the space inside for reading or studying.

So lately, Luna and I would rent a classroom to study together.

We couldn't rent a classroom alone, so we went together to rent one.

Of course, Rika and Ena often joined us.

"Today, I think I'll practice magic in the lab?"

Although I had lost the top spot, I could still use the first-place student laboratory.

The proper first place would be determined by the total score at the end of the semester.

I glanced at Rika and Ena behind me.

With those two around, they could rent a classroom without me, so it shouldn't be a problem.

"Is...is that so? I see."

Luna looked a bit disappointed.

Then she changed her expression and opened her mouth.

"Well, I guess there's no helping it... Then later—."

"Ah...! Oh, that's right! Now that I think about it, I have an assignment, so I think I'll need to go to a lab?"

Just as Luna was about to say something, Ena suddenly interrupted.

The usually quiet Ena spoke with an unusually lively voice.

"Huh?"

Luna looked at Ena for a moment.

"Ah! Ah! Now that I think about it, Rika! I think you'll need to help me! It's an assignment related to water attribute magic!"

"Water...attribute?"

Rika looked puzzled as she spoke to Ena.

"Luna... I don't think we can rent a classroom together... I'm really sorry."

"Uh...? Really? You said you didn't have any separate things to study just now..."

"I forgot, okay~. And Luna can't use water attribute magic... I think Rika will have to help me..."

Rika patted her chest and said,

"Ahem! That's right! Luna might be better at magic than me, but I'm better at using water attribute magic!"

Ena grabbed Rika's wrist as she spoke and began to lead her away.

"Eh? We're leaving already?"

"Luna sorry!! Rika, you better follow quickly."

"Ugh..."

Luna and I blankly watched Ena walk away, dragging Rika along with her.

"Uh... what should we do?"

With those two gone, Luna couldn't borrow a study space.

But she couldn't give up on magic practice for today either.

With midterm camp approaching, she needed to reach intermediate magic as soon as possible.

"...Luna, want to go to the lab with me?"

"Huh...?"

And thats 4/4!

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 21: Intermediate Magic (2)

"Luna, would you like to practice magic with me?"

'The two of us?'

That thought immediately sprang to Luna's mind upon hearing Rudy's suggestion.

Lately, Luna had been experiencing a peculiar sensation.

Whenever she was in Rudy's presence, her heart seemed to have a mind of its own.

She felt a strange warmth.

To hide these feelings, she acted more energetic than usual.

She thought that if she tried to act as usual, she'd be unable to speak.

But the idea of being alone in the laboratory with Rudy made her nervous.

It was already hard for her to focus in the spacious classroom, let alone in the smaller lab.

Even when studying and they were slightly apart, she found herself constantly distracted by Rudy.

Yet, she didn't want to distance herself from him. Instead, she wanted to be closer.

These conflicting emotions left her utterly confused.

She felt that way even now.

The top student lab was a smaller space compared to the classroom.

Imagining herself in that confined space with Rudy made her face feel like it would burst from embarrassment.

But she wanted to go.

'Yes... Let's go study magic together since Ena and Rika aren't around! Right! We're going to study magic!'

Thump, thump.

Her heart pounded as she thought about it.

"Alright! It's been a while since we practiced magic together!"

Trying to hide her chaotic thoughts, Luna spoke with enthusiasm.

Following Rudy, she headed toward the top student lab.

Though she had visited the lab once before, it felt different this time.

In her initial visit, she was still suspicious and fearful towards Rudy.

"Come in," Rudy said, opening the lab door.

"Excuse me," Luna replied.

"There's no need for formalities when it's just us."

"Is that so...?"

Luna awkwardly smiled and entered the lab.

"I'll practice magic over here. If you want to study magic circles or something, you can use the temporary scrolls over there."

"Thank you, hehe."

Luna smiled at Rudy's kind explanation. He gave her a faint smile in return before immersing himself in his magic practice.

"I should practice too..."

Luna briefly watched Rudy before starting her own practice.

Thump, thump-

'Why... Why can't I concentrate?'

Luna occasionally stole glances at Rudy, who was focusing.

The confined space.

The close distance.

Thump, thump.

'Uh... Can he hear it?'

Her heart raced even faster.

'Please, calm down...'

Luna placed her hand on her chest and took several deep breaths, but it didn't help.

She glanced at Rudy, worrying that he could hear her racing heart.

Rudy was fully concentrating on practicing magic and didn't seem to notice anything else.

Determined, Luna decided to concentrate on her practice as well.

And so, both Rudy and Luna began to focus intently on practicing their magic.

"Phew..."

Luna thought she had studied diligently and looked up.

However, Rudy remained engrossed in his own magic practice.

'Rudy really has great focus...'

Rudy always focused solely on his studies, never letting anything else distract him.

It was impressive and she admired him for it. She stared intently at Rudy as he concentrated.

'His eyelashes are so long... and his skin is incredibly fair...'

As she watched Rudy, Luna noticed details she hadn't seen before.

Recently, she had been unable to look him in the eye, so she hadn't had the chance to take a proper look at his face.

'He...he's handsome...'

At the time, it was like admiring a piece of art – simply appreciating its beauty and moving on.

But now, things were different.

Staring directly at his face, Luna felt her heart race and her cheeks flush.

'What... what's going on?'

Luna was utterly bewildered but didn't look away.

She continued to gaze intently at Rudy's face.

Gulp-

As Luna swallowed, Rudy suddenly sprang to his feet.

"Done...!"

"Ah!"

Startled by Rudy's abrupt outburst, Luna let out a small cry.

Rudy looked at her, and for a moment, she didn't know where to direct her gaze.

'D...did he notice?'

"Uh, Luna, sorry. Did I startle you?"

"Ah, no, no, no... It's... it's fine! I wasn't startled!"

Despite her obvious surprise, Luna blurted out an obvious lie.

Rudy tilted his head for a moment before speaking.

"Sorry, I finally achieved what I wanted."

"What was it?"

"I've reached intermediate magic."

"Int...intermediate magic?"

Luna was astonished.

She knew Rudy was talented in magic, but she didn't expect him to reach intermediate level so soon.

Usually, students would achieve intermediate magic during their second year, or exceptionally gifted first-year students might reach it during their second semester.

However, midterm exams had just ended.

This meant that Rudy had reached intermediate magic at an unbelievable pace.

Of course, some people reached intermediate magic quickly but were unable to progress further due to the barrier of talent.

Nevertheless, the accomplishment was impressive.

Luna looked at Rudy, who was beaming with pride.

Was that what talent looked like?

Rudy was moving ahead of her.

She admired him but also felt a tinge of jealousy.

However, her jealousy didn't last long.

Luna genuinely wished for Rudy's success.

She wanted him to do well, not only because he had helped her so much, but also because she had seen how hard he worked.

Rudy, who didn't indulge in leisure activities and studied every day.

Rudy, who stood firm and focused on his own tasks even when others criticized him.

Anyone who saw him would want to cheer him on. Luna smiled and spoke with heartfelt sincerity.

"Well done! Congratulations, Rudy!"

The next day.

Instead of having lunch with Luna, I went straight to a place I wanted to visit.

The professors' smoking area behind the academy.

"...Rudy Astria?"

There were two people there.

Professors Cromwell and Robert.

Professor Cromwell was smoking, while Professor Robert sat in front of him, not smoking.

Their images seemed reversed – I would have expected Professor Robert to be the smoker and Professor Cromwell to abstain.

"Did you come here to smoke too?"

Professor Robert asked with a sly smile.

"No."

It was an obvious answer. Academy regulations prohibited students from smoking.

"What brings you here then?"

There was only one reason I came.

I had simply heard that Professors Robert and Cromwell would be in the smoking area together when lunchtime began.

And so...

"Professor Robert, if you haven't eaten yet, would you like to join me for a meal?"

"...Me?"

Professor Robert asked with a puzzled expression.

"Robert being sought for student counseling... This must be a first. Hehe."

Professor Cromwell laughed pleasantly.

"Hey, you have a professor here who likes you so much. Why eat with me?"

Professor Robert pointed at Professor Cromwell as he spoke. I stared intently at him.

"Heh, a professor refusing student counseling would be quite something."

Professor Cromwell put out his cigarette.

"Although it's a bit disappointing that you didn't come to me, I'll allow it since he's my friend."

"What are you, his father? And who are you to allow it or not?"

Grumbling, Professor Robert stood up and walked forward.

"Haah... Follow me."

"Then I'll go eat with the other professors. Good luck with the counseling."

Professor Cromwell waved goodbye and walked away.

As I watched him leave, Professor Robert called out to me.

"What are you doing?"

"Ah... I'll follow you."

I chased after Professor Robert.

He led me to a small, shabby diner within the academy.

A rundown diner.

It seemed like it could collapse with just a touch.

"You've never eaten at a place like this, have you?"

Professor Robert grumbled.

"Robert, who is this young man?"

An old lady emerged from the back of the store.

She seemed to be on friendly terms with Professor Robert, asking casually.

"Just a student."

"Your disciple?"

"No, not my disciple. Just a student. A friend's disciple."

"I am Professor Robert's disciple. Pleased to meet you."

I greeted the old lady politely.

"Why are you my disciple?"

"Kuku... When someone volunteers to be your disciple, why not accept? He looks like a noble but seems to have some manners. A low-ranking noble perhaps?"

"Watch your mouth. He's the second son of the Astria family."

"...What?"

Professor Robert's words widened the old woman's eyes.

"Are you talking about that Astria family I know?"

"Is there another Astria family in the empire?"

"Ah... I've seen all sorts of things in my long life. I'm not sure if someone from such a family can enjoy our humble restaurant's food."

With that, the old woman went inside the restaurant.

"Should I order our usual?"

"Yes, two servings of that, please."

Professor Robert said that and took a seat. Then he spoke to me.

"What are you waiting for? Sit down. Do I need to pull the chair out for you?"

"No, sir."

I sat down across from Professor Robert.

"You grew up in a duke's household, yet you're very polite. Is that how you normally treat commoners?"

"I'm just being respectful to my elders."

Even in this fantasy world, respect for one's elders was a basic courtesy.

Of course, it wasn't essential for those with high status and capabilities, but it was a good thing to do.

"So, why did you call me here?"

True to Professor Robert's easy-going nature, he went straight to the point. I preferred it that way.

I didn't like to observe and analyze my opponent like Rie.

I spoke directly to him.

"Please take me as your disciple."

"Disciple?"

Professor Robert looked incredulous. I repeated my request.

"Teach me dark magic."

"Ha...!"

Annoyance began to show in Professor Robert's eyes.

"Do you even know what dark magic is?"

"It's the most powerful magic among all magics."

"And where does that power come from?"

That power came from...

"Risk."

"Right, well-learned. Dark magic involves taking risks to use it. Normal magic follows an equivalent exchange, using mana. The amount of mana used determines its power."

"I know that."

"Then, is dark magic equivalent exchange?"

"No."

Dark magic differed from normal magic. For one, there was mental contamination when it failed.

This was merely a fraction of the risks associated with dark magic.

It required the user to sacrifice their health, parts of their body, and in extreme cases, even their soul.

"I don't want to be killed by your father."

"My family doesn't care about me."

"Your family may have abandoned you as an heir, but I doubt your father has abandoned you as his son."

I couldn't refute that statement, having never met my father.

The Duke of Astria might have given up on me as his successor, but it was uncertain whether he had given up on me as his son.

"Why would the son of the Astria family want to learn dark magic? You should go to Professor Cromwell and learn telekinesis instead."

Professor Cromwell's telekinesis was indeed versatile and useful in battle. However, it wasn't enough to survive.

Being versatile meant it couldn't focus on a particular area. It was similar to the saying that there's a fine line between being a jack-of-all-trades and a master of none.

Moreover, dark magic had many applications, much like telekinesis.

Naturally, the reason was the associated risks.

"Already trying when you haven't even reached intermediate magic..."

"I have reached intermediate magic."

"...What?"

Professor Robert asked with a baffled expression.

"You've... reached intermediate magic?"

Such a reaction was expected.

Even grinding in the game wouldn't allow someone to reach intermediate magic at this pace.

It was the result of Rudy Astria's already high magic level, the incident with Luna, and relentless practice whenever he had spare time.

It took luck, effort, and talent to achieve such results.

"...That's an absurd amount of talent."

"I've simply put in the effort."

After a brief moment of contemplation, Professor Robert spoke.

"Alright, I'll give you a test."

"A test?"

"Learn Abyssal Flame by midterm camp. Then, I'll teach you dark magic."

Abyssal Flame - the most basic dark magic spell. It wasn't impossible to achieve, and the given time frame was perfect, lining up with my initial plan.

"So, will you take me as your disciple?"

"Disciple? I'm just saying I'll teach you. Why would I take a novice like you as my disciple?"

"Understood."

I accepted Professor Robert's proposal.

"I'll learn it quickly."

"Heh... go on, give it a try."

Professor Robert laughed with a meaningful smile.

"Ah, the food is here."

Our conversation continued as the food arrived. Upon seeing the dishes, dozens of question marks popped up in my head.

"Huh?"

"There's no other food, so eat this gratefully."

A savory aroma wafted through the air, accompanied by familiar bowls.

"Here's your meal."

The server handed over a bowl of white rice. The dish served at the restaurant was none other than a bubbling pot of cheonggukjang (Korean fermented soybean stew).

While the other side dishes were unfamiliar, the comforting smell of the stew was unmistakable.

"What do young masters like you... Huh?"

I immediately began devouring the meal, spoon in hand.

"You... Why are you eating so well?"

I didn't bother responding to Professor Robert and continued to stuff my face with rice.

After eating only Western-style meat and vegetables every day, this Korean dish was incredibly touching.

Who would have thought I'd find cheonggukjang in a fantasy world?

The experience was almost tear-jerking.

"It's so... delicious... sniff."

Even when I had defeated the game's final boss after 20 attempts, I never felt this moved.

Cheonggukjang in a fantasy world seemed impossible, but today, I was grateful for this out-of-place development.

"One more bowl, please."

"Uh... sure."

The restaurant's elderly owner, taken aback, handed me another bowl of rice.

Overwhelmed with emotion, I ended up eating three bowls of rice that day.

That's 1/4! advance chapter tiers are up! on my kofi link below, up to 15 chapters ahead will be posted Sunday at 9pm PST!

Also I made a change, I originally thought there was another separate exam after midterms but it was rather an 'evaluation' not an 'exam.' The evaluation is in the style of a survive in the wild camp, so I decided to name it midterm camp over midterm evaluation/event.

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 22: Intermediate Magic (3)

After parting ways with Professor Robert, I immediately headed to the library.

"What book are you looking for?"

"Basic Dark Magic."

"Ah... Books on Basic Dark Magic can be found in Row T."

I easily acquired a book on Basic Dark Magic.

Although obtaining more advanced books required the permission of a professor, this was not the case for basic ones.

With the book in hand, I began to read slowly, taking in the fundamental theories of dark magic.

There were theories I was familiar with, and others that were entirely new to me.

Then, I came across a particularly notable section.

"Mental contamination..."

The phenomenon that had happened to Luna.

Mental contamination was the most representative risk of dark magic.

The risks of dark magic could be divided into two categories.

One was the use of some part of oneself, an object, or a being as a sacrifice.

This wasn't an immediate concern, as it required a higher level of magic to use.

The second risk was mental contamination, which had various types.

Mana explosion, like the one Luna experienced, was one of them, and there were cases of curses resulting from backlash.

These adverse effects occurred because the methods of using dark magic were entirely different from those of other magics.

Basic magic typically was like requiring a container to hold water.

When using the magic, one would decide how much to use and pour mana into the container.

When the container was full, the mana would automatically stop flowing.

It was akin to a modern automatic system.

However, dark magic was different.

When using dark magic, there was a predetermined container, and I had to personally pour the mana into it.

I had to manually control the mana.

If the mana overflowed, it would lead to mental contamination, and if there was not enough mana, the magic would not work properly.

This was the biggest drawback of dark magic.

"Is it a matter of... control?"

Dark magic was, therefore, magic that relied on control.

Those who had used a specific dark magic spell many times could handle it skillfully, treating it like ordinary magic.

However, those who had not would repeatedly struggle with mental contamination as they practiced, until they developed the necessary control.

But that was not the only drawback.

Even those who had frequently used a specific dark magic spell could falter depending on the circumstances.

In a sudden situation, they might fail to control the amount of mana due to panic.

That was why many people shied away from dark magic.

Nevertheless, dark magic had powers that overshadowed all its drawbacks.

It boasted exceptional adaptability compared to other types of magic.

Overwhelming power and adaptability – that was the essence of dark magic.

The following day, during the magic practice class.

"Today's lesson ends here," announced Professor Cromwell as he closed his book.

As I began to gather my belongings, the professor approached me.

"Rudy Astria, I heard you made a bet with that Robert fellow?"

Upon hearing his question, Rie turned to look at me.

Ignoring Rie, I answered Professor Cromwell's question.

"Yes, sir. He demanded a condition in exchange for teaching me dark magic."

"Dark magic?" Rie reacted to my response once more.

Rie suddenly seemed embarrassed by her reaction and turned her head away, coughing to clear her throat.

Professor Cromwell glanced at her briefly before returning his attention to me.

"Well, it's your choice. You can handle it as you see fit. All right then, give it your best shot."

"Thank you, sir."

With that, Professor Cromwell left the classroom. As soon as he was out of sight, Rie scowled and spoke up.

"Hey! Dark magic?!"

That was just fine. I needed to ask Rie for a favor anyway.

"Well, that's how it turned out."

"Even now, just say you can't do it!"

"No," I replied firmly, causing Rie to clutch her head.

"I thought it'd be fun not knowing where you'd pop up, but it's quite annoying now that you're my ally..."

"I don't think I have that kind of erratic personality, do I?"

"Enough about that. Why do you want to learn dark magic? If you want to learn intermediate magic, just study ordinary spells. The Astria family has their own magic, doesn't it?"

That was true.

The Astria family had developed their own magic, passed down through generations.

But how long would I have to wait for that? It wouldn't matter how powerful my abilities became in the end if I died before acquiring them.

And there was no guarantee that I would inherit the Astria family magic.

In the original story, I might have learned some of it, but there was no certainty I would in this world.

"Since I've decided to learn it, I'm going to give it a try. If it doesn't feel right, I'll stop at that point."

"Fine... Just be careful not to suddenly die while using magic."

I stopped Rie as she tried to leave.

"...What is it?"

"I need your help with something."

"Me?" Rie stared at me incredulously.

I led Rie to the top student's laboratory.

"...What are we doing here?"

"You've dealt with people affected by mental corruption before."

I pulled out the Basic Dark Magic book from my bag.

"Wait, hold on... Hey..."

"What?"

"Are you saying you're going to use dark magic right here?"

"Yes, and if anything goes wrong, I need you to help me out."

For a brief moment, silence enveloped us.

Rie and I stood facing each other, neither of us saying a word.

It was Rie who broke the silence first, stealthily reaching for her bag.

There was only one reason for this movement.

Escape.

"Ah!"

Rie immediately bolted from the top student's laboratory.

I chased after her right away.

"Where do you think you're going?!"

"No! Wait until I send for Locke! Just wait until then!"

And so, after a short chase with Rie...

"Huff...huff..."

"I told you...whew...why run away?"

After about 10 minutes of pursuit, I finally managed to catch Rie. She took deep breaths, having been caught by me.

Regaining her composure, Rie shouted at me.

"No! Why do you always ask me to do these things?! I'm not an expert at this!"

"We're allies, aren't we? Help me out a bit."

"I told you last time, I'm a princess!"

"You said we were allies on equal terms."

Rie sprawled on the floor like a child demanding a toy from a department store.

I dragged her back to the top student's laboratory.

Truthfully, I wanted to ask Astina for help as well. But lately, she was so busy preparing for the midterm event that I couldn't bring myself to bother her.

Since the event was for first-year students, there was nothing I could do to help, so all I could do was offer my support.

That left me with only two people I could ask for assistance.

Luna and Rie.

I considered asking Luna for help but shook my head. My magic had surpassed Luna's by a significant margin.

If a mana explosion were to occur, Luna might not be able to handle it.

However, Rie was not only skilled in magic but also knew how to deal with elementals. That meant she could handle various situations.

I figured it didn't matter if I bothered her once or multiple times. I could make it up to her in a big way later.

"I don't want to go through all that trouble again."

Rie complained as she was being dragged.

"The magic I'll be using isn't that difficult, so the chances of a mana explosion are low."

Honestly, the backlash from mana explosions was quite rare. At most, a minor curse would be inflicted upon failure, or the mana would flow back, causing a slight pain.

"I hate it when things don't go according to plan!"

"Plan?"

"I have things to study and tasks to complete!"

I let go of the yelling Rie.

"Fine. I guess there's no helping it."

"...What?"

Upon releasing her, Rie gazed at me with a puzzled expression.

As urgent as I may be, I wouldn't be so cruel as to force someone who dislikes the idea to assist me.

However...

"But you should know one thing," I said.

"What now?" Rie retorted.

"From now on, I'll be practicing dark magic on my own."

"Fine. Go ahead!"

"However, there's a chance that something unsavory might happen. Dark magic is risky, after all..."

"Okay."

"Wouldn't that affect your grand plan?"

When I said that, Rie glared at me. I ignored her piercing stare and continued speaking.

"If I were to lose control of my mana while using dark magic... The dormitory would be turned upside down... My reputation would plummet into the abyss... And then..."

"Ugh... Don't you have any friends? You could ask someone else for help, you know!!!"

"Well, I don't have many friends, but you're trustworthy. The academy's third-best."

Hearing that, Rie sighed.

Although her face showed irritation, she seemed slightly pleased.

"Fine, I'll help."

"Thank you."

I smiled faintly.

"Urk..."

I had already attempted to cast the Abyssal Flame over ten times.

Not once had I succeeded.

And each failure came with backlash.

"Ugh... Water... Water..."

"My whole body...! It's itching...!"

I suffered through various curses and all sorts of pain.

"Haah... Haah..."

"Are you going to give up yet? It's agonizing just watching you."

"Could you at least look at me when you say that...?"

Rie had watched me cast magic once or twice, but she had since stopped observing me and focused on her own studies.

"I have no reason to learn dark magic. Watching you is just a waste of time."

"Fine... Go about your business."

I got up to try casting the spell again. At least I felt like I was getting the hang of it. The sensation of filling a vessel with mana had initially felt strange and unfamiliar.

However, after failing several times, I thought I began to understand the feeling.

I imagined a vessel before my eyes...

And slowly poured my mana into it. I had to handle my mana carefully.

Pouring it in too fast or too slow wouldn't work.

Just the right amount.

"Gah...!"

"What's wrong? Why are you making that face?"

"Cough... Cough... Uh... It's just a normal backlash."

Another failure. I thought I had gotten the hang of it, but success was still out of reach.

"Hmm..."

Rie glanced at me for a moment, then checked the time.

"It's about time for us to go, isn't it?"

It had already grown dark outside, and the hour was getting late.

"Yeah, I suppose so."

As I quickly tidied myself up, pain coursed through my entire body.

It felt like the aftermath of an intense workout I hadn't done before.

However, while that pain was more of a dull ache, this felt like being stabbed by a knife.

"It's not easy..."

I sighed. I had thought I'd be able to learn it today...

I had planned to learn dark magic as quickly as possible and prepare a few things before the midterm camp.

That was overconfidence on my part.

Lately, everything had been going according to plan, and I had grown overly confident. The real challenge would be from now on.

I had managed to persuade Rie to help me today, but I felt guilty asking her to do so again tomorrow.

Rie gathered her things and walked toward the door. She paused for a moment, glanced at me, and spoke up.

"Are you doing this again tomorrow?"

"What?"

"You said you needed me."

As I stared at her with a dumbfounded expression, Rie turned her head and opened the door.

"Come to the lab right after class tomorrow."

With that, she left the laboratory.

"... She's kinder than I thought?"

Initially, I had planned to plead with her, maybe even beg a little.

But her offer to help voluntarily made me even more grateful.

"I should treat her to something delicious later."

That's 2/4! I hope the explanation on magic being a container made sense :p

New version of the site is up. Might need a refresh if it's not there on the initial load. Biggest thing is light mode, it's a sun icon next to the navigation bar.

-Gotta fix google translate formatting, update should be tomorrow.

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 23: Intermediate Magic (4)

"Good morning."

The next morning, I briefly stopped by the student council room.

I didn't have any particular business there, but it was my habit to visit once every morning.

"Ah... Rudy Astria..."

Astina greeted me. However, she wasn't the only one in the student council room. A silver-haired girl stood before Astina.

"Hello."

The girl slightly bowed her head in greeting to me.

"Ah, yes."

I returned the gesture with a slight nod of my own, and Astina began to speak.

"This is Yaniel, who transferred to the Swordsmanship Department today."

Yaniel... It seems the midterm camp is about to begin.

The story starts with the arrival of transfer student Yaniel.

The Rebels.

The Rebels were a group of individuals united against the corrupt nobles.

They sought to overthrow the emperor and his nobles to create a new world.

They were already moving outside the academy, though their actions had not yet caught the public's attention.

However, that did not mean they were idle. The first event that would bring their existence to light would occur during the midterm camp.

They planned something within the midterm camp—a declaration of war against the nobles' leader and the emperor.

This involved the assassination of the Astria family's second son, me, and Rie Von Ristonia, the first in line for the imperial throne.

This event would mark the beginning of the main story, where Evan would become involved with Rie and Yeniel, and the world's greater currents would start to shift.

"The class will start soon. You know where the classroom is, right?"

"Yes, I'll be on my way now."

Yeniel bid Astina farewell and left the room. Astina then turned her gaze to me.

"You should go too. There's nothing for you to do here."

She said there was nothing to do, but there was a massive stack of documents piled on her desk.

It was probably work I couldn't do, so she said there was nothing. I looked at Astina with sympathy and opened my mouth.

"Take it easy. Don't overwork yourself."

"Hehe... I'd love to rest, but I have to finish my work first."

Astina laughed, but her words held a hint of bitterness. I glanced at her for a moment, then realized it was time to head to the classroom.

"Rudy Astria."

Astina called out to me as I was about to leave.

"And by the way, are you going to continue?"

"...Pardon me?"

Continue?

"The student council."

"...?"

"What's with that clueless expression?"

"Wasn't our agreement until the end of the midterm camp?"

Isn't that obvious?

Even though I know Astina is currently swamped with paperwork, there's no particular reason for me to continue being on the student council.

Once the midterm camp is over, the proper storyline will progress, and I won't have the time to devote to the student council.

I need to focus on my studies and improving my magic skills.

"We've already formed an alliance, so is there really a need for me to be on the student council?"

"You need to work. On student council matters."

"Aren't there plenty of others who would love to do it?"

There are countless students who would jump at the chance to be on the student council, shedding tears of joy.

So, why do I have to do it?

"Those kids are difficult for me to manage. And among those who want to do this kind of work, are there any normal ones? It's the ones who don't want to do it that do it well."

I glared at Astina as she spoke.

"Then, what about Locke? You can just boss him around."

"He's no fun."

So, am I fun...?

Astina casually crossed her legs as she leaned back in her chair.

"Well, if you're going to be like that, I have no choice but to force you."

"Force me?"

Force me to continue being on the student council?

"I helped you out in the library, remember? You can repay that debt by extending our agreement."

"...So that's how you're going to play it."

Of course, I knew I owed Astina a debt.

I had thought I would be able to repay it later, but I didn't expect her to bring it up like this.

"Trust is important in an alliance, you know?"

Astina said with a sinister smile.

"Can't you accept something else as repayment?"

"Nope."

"I'm really busy."

"So am I. Cut back on sleep."

Astina grinned, acting like a wicked supervisor. What should I do...?

I contemplated for a moment.

The best solution would be for me to help Astina in return.

Then Astina would owe me, and there would be no need for me to repay my debt.

However, the problem was whether such an opportunity would arise.

Many things happen during the midterm camp, but it wouldn't mean anything if I were the one to resolve them.

After all, it's Evan who needs to handle those situations and grow from them.

I glanced at the clock.

The start of class was drawing near.

This discussion won't end anytime soon, so I decided it was best to head to class.

"...Let's discuss this matter later. We'll renegotiate after the midterm camp."

"Fine, think about it carefully. See if there's any way you can avoid doing it."

I left the room with Astina waving her hand and smiling behind me.

After school.

"Phew..."

Rie was sitting at her desk, reading a book, while I practiced dark magic.

Now, even when I suffered from the backlash, Rie continued doing her own thing, only checking on me when I seemed to be particularly struggling.

At least today was better than yesterday.

Yesterday, I faced backlash every time I attempted to cast a spell.

But today, I had managed to cast a few spells successfully.

The problem was that they weren't complete spells - I had only used them with less mana, resulting in an incomplete casting.

"Once more..."

As I tried to cast the spell again, Rie spoke up.

"Hey."

She looked at me with a pitiful expression.

"Do you really want to learn dark magic that badly?"

Rie closed her book and stared at me directly.

"Honestly, if you've reached the level of intermediate magic at this point, you could learn any intermediate spell faster than others. But why are you so fixated on dark magic?"

"..."

Rie had a point.

I could have learned other types of magic by now and achieved great results.

However, whether I would be able to survive in the academy by learning other magic was a different question.

Could I fend off every threat that came my way?

Could I adapt to every situation, even if the story had changed?

I didn't think so.

In that case, I had to endure this pain and draw out my potential.

Though I already possessed outstanding abilities, I had to bear this to acquire even greater ones.

"I need to learn it to survive."

"To survive?"

Rie's expression turned sour.

I truly meant to survive, but it seemed Rie interpreted it as surviving in politics or within the Astria family.

"Sigh... Fine, do as you please. By the way, do you even know anything about Professor Robert?"

"Professor Robert?"

I wondered why she suddenly brought up Professor Robert.

"Isn't he the only dark magic professor at the academy? And from a commoner background..."

"He is the only dark magic professor, but he's not from a commoner background."

I furrowed my brow at Rie's words.

"What do you mean, he's not from a commoner background? Then why doesn't he have a title?"

It was a bit odd.

Even if he was a professor specializing in dark magic, he was still an exceptional wizard.

Usually, someone like him would at least be granted a noble title, even if they didn't possess any lands.

But that wasn't the case for Professor Robert.

"Professor Robert was originally a wizard from a noble family with land."

Rie continued her explanation at a measured pace.

"However, he offered his own son as a sacrifice to save himself. Because of that, the empire stripped him of his territory and noble title."

"...His son?"

He offered his own son as a sacrifice?

"Isn't that just a rumor?"

Professor Robert didn't seem like that kind of person.

Judging by how well he got along with Professor Cromwell, he didn't appear to be a bad person.

"Are you suggesting my information is on the same level as mere gossip?"

Rie spoke as if she were offended.

Her words held true.

Although she was currently attending the academy like an ordinary student, she was, after all, the Empire's First Princess.

Her information was far beyond mere rumors.

If such a rumor existed, I should have discovered it while investigating Professor Robert.

However, I hadn't found any such rumors.

In other words, Rie's information was high-level intelligence, not just ordinary gossip.

"Think carefully. About learning dark magic and becoming Professor Robert's apprentice."

A few days later, during lunchtime.

"By now, he must have learned it," mused Robert, reclined on a garden bench, gazing up at the cloudless sky.

The warm sunlight bathed his face, casting a gentle glow.

He contemplated Rudy Astria as he lay there.

The young man's talent was undoubtedly extraordinary, so much so that Robert, a professor, desired him as his disciple.

However, that was all.

Dark magic was not ordinary magic.

It was a magic learned by chiseling away at one's bones and burning one's flesh.

It was not a magic befitting a young master like Rudy.

There was even a saying that dark magic was a magic learned by those without talent.

Those who could not bridge the gap in talent with others resorted to sacrificing their own bodies to make up for it.

Rudy Astria had no need for such measures.

Exceptional talent.

An illustrious family.

Aside from his social skills, there was nothing lacking.

Thus, there was no reason for him to endure the pain of learning dark magic.

That was why Robert had made the proposal.

In truth, Robert could have taught him Abyssal Flame in just one day.

He possessed the necessary techniques and tricks.

However, he deliberately refrained from doing so.

Rudy Astria must have felt it - the immense pain that accompanied learning dark magic.

Robert made this proposal to let him feel that.

For someone of Rudy Astria's caliber, learning basic dark magic was only a matter of time.

He would master it in the blink of an eye.

However, he would also realize there was no need to endure such pain to learn this magic.

Moreover, Robert had heard that lately, Rudy Astria had been getting close to Princess Rie.

"In that case, he's even less likely to come," he thought.

Most people at the academy were unaware of Robert's past.

Cromwell knew, having grown up with him, but apart from the headmaster and Cromwell, nobody knew.

Yet, Princess Rie might.

It was an incident that most people didn't care to dig into, but if she wanted to find out, she could easily do so.

-Ah... Dad?

Memories of the past suddenly surfaced, and Robert furrowed his brow.

"Ah~ the weather is bloody lovely," he muttered.

"Why would you say it's bloody when the weather is nice?" a voice asked.

"Damn! You startled me!" Robert looked in the direction of the voice.

"Hey, make some noise when you approach. You're not an assassin or anything..." he grumbled.

It was Rudy Astria, standing there with a book in hand.

"I simply walked up normally. I couldn't exactly sprint toward you while shouting your name, now could I, Professor Robert?" Rudy said calmly.

Robert glanced at Rudy for a moment, sighed, and got to the point.

"Alright, enough of that. What do you want?"

"I've learned Abyssal Flame," Rudy announced confidently.

"Alright, and so what?" Robert retorted.

"What do you mean?"

Professor Robert was baffled by Rudy's statement.

He had assumed that Rudy would, of course, refuse to learn dark magic.

"Didn't you say you would teach me dark magic?"

"...What?"

Robert looked at Rudy with a dumbfounded expression.

"Ah, do I need to show you?"

With that, Rudy Astria looked at his own hand.

"Abyssal Flame."

As Rudy's mana flowed, a black flame sprouted from his hand.

It was the basics of dark magic, the Abyssal Flame.

It had been cast precisely, with no backlash, and the size of the magic was just right.

"Is this sufficient?"

Robert stared at the magic.

It didn't feel like Rudy had succeeded only once or twice.

Amateur magic had a certain quality, but this spell seemed to have been honed and practiced numerous times.

"Did someone teach you about dark magic?"

"...? Is there someone who could teach me dark magic?"

Rudy responded to Professor Robert's question with another question.

He had a point.

There were a few individuals at the Academy who knew how to use dark magic, but they were not ones Rudy Astria would know.

If Rudy had learned it alone and was using it so proficiently, then...

"When did you first use it?"

"Perhaps... two or three days ago. I could use it, but it seemed a bit clumsy, so I practiced a bit before coming."

"Ha...!"

Professor Robert was astonished.

While he had expected Rudy to learn quickly, he hadn't imagined that he would practice on his own.

What kind of resolve drove this young man?

"Good grief."

Robert rose from his seat and walked forward.

As Rudy watched him with a puzzled expression, Professor Robert briefly turned his head.

"What are you doing? Let's go eat."

"What about the dark magic?"

"What do you mean, 'what about'? You asked to learn, so I'll teach you."

At Robert's words, a faint smile formed on Rudy's lips. He followed and spoke up.

"Shall we go to that restaurant we visited last time?"

Hearing that, Professor Robert looked at Rudy Astria and laughed incredulously.

He liked the food that other professors and students wouldn't even bring near their mouths.

And he wanted to learn dark magic from Robert.

"...You're truly an enigma."

"I've been hearing that a lot lately. They say I'm an unpredictable guy."

Thats 3/4!

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 24: Midterm Camp (1)

The carriage rattled as it traveled through the dense forest.

Aboard the carriage were the students of the academy.

Midterm Camp.

It was not only the game's first event but also the first event experienced by the first-year students after joining Liberion Academy.

Liberion Academy's midterm camp was quite different from the typical modern camp event.

It was not a mere event where they would make curry and laugh together with friends.

The apparent objective of midterm camp was survival.

An event where students were dropped off in a dense forest and had to survive for a week.

That was Liberion Academy's midterm event.

Of course, after enduring a week, the last day was spent gathering at a mansion in the middle of the forest to relieve the students' fatigue.

Everyone struggled for a week, eagerly awaiting the final day.

There was only one intention behind organizing such an activity at the academy.

Cooperation.

Competition was the norm within the academy.

Each student's rank was determined for that reason, and all other activities were nothing but competition.

However, there was no rule that stated they must always compete when they entered society.

There would be times when they needed to cooperate with someone and times when they needed to coexist.

That was why such events were designed to teach students the value of cooperation.

"Haah..."

"Rudy, are you alright?"

As I sighed, Luna, who was sitting beside me, looked at me with a worried expression.

"Ah, I'm fine."

However, there was a problem.

The original game's story had already been twisted.

The reason cooperation was necessary during the midterm event was that four teammates had to survive together.

The four had to work together to withstand the magical beasts for a week, securing food and living space.

But, the teams had changed.

"Hehe..."

In front of me, Rie was smiling happily, while Locke sat with an emotionless expression.

In other words, my current team consisted of Rie, Luna, and Locke – four of us in total.

However, the original story wasn't like this.

Rie should have definitely been in the same team as Evan.

I should have been placed with the delinquents.

But, I had no idea how this combination was formed.

Upon further thought, it was an absurd combination.

I was currently the second seat of the academy, Rie ranked third, and Luna was fifth.

Although grades were not everything in survival, it was a fact that in a forest where they had to withstand magical beasts' attacks, better grades were advantageous.

Overbalance.

That's how one could describe our team.

Even if our group was arranged like this, a single question lingered in my mind.

Just who was in Evan's group?

Originally, Evan's group consisted of the transfer student Yeniel, Rie, and the spirit mage Serina Rinsburg.

Together, the four of them formed a group.

With Rie missing from the original four, someone must have taken her place.

However, the identity of that person wasn't particularly important.

The problem was that Rie was sitting right in front of me.

Her meaningful smile was suspicious from the start.

I stared at Rie intently before speaking.

"Rie, you did this, didn't you?"

"What do you mean~? I honestly have no idea."

Rie replied with a sly expression.

It was almost certain that she was the culprit.

In the game, when she was in the same group as Evan, she would make cryptic remarks as though she had intervened in the group formation.

I knew this fact, but I never imagined she would use it like this.

Had getting closer to Rie lately caused this problem...?

It was a bit strange.

Rie and Evan hadn't interacted much.

Rie should have shown some interest in Evan, but she showed none at all.

In truth, I was somewhat aware of this situation.

Since I hadn't seen Rie interacting with Evan, I casually asked her what she thought of him.

-Evan? I don't know. I'm not interested.

I thought that even if she said this, she would at least investigate and keep an eye on him.

It was surprising that someone with no background had suddenly become top of the class, so wouldn't she be at least interested?

But she genuinely had no interest at all.

This was no small issue.

The incident that would take place during the midterm camp.

Not only did it involve an assassination attempt on me, but there was also one on Rie.

And both attempts would be thwarted by Evan.

Although the incidents occurred at different times, it wasn't a good thing for the two of us to be together like this.

Because we were both targets, they might try to attack us at the same time.

In Rudy Astria's case, he was alone when the assassination attempt occurred, but in Rie's case, the incident happened while she was with Evan.

But if they were not in the same group, then there would be no reason for Evan to be with Rie.

The more I thought about it, the more my head hurt.

I had prepared enough power to protect myself, so I was relatively safe.

However, Rie was not.

Moreover, Evan needed to save Rie to receive a significant reward, and that was another problem.

"Ah..."

"Rudy, are you really okay? Should I call a professor?"

Luna took a stone out of her pocket.

That stone was a summoning stone capable of calling a professor.

It was an item distributed to all members to summon professors or student council members in case of an emergency.

I looked at Luna and smiled faintly.

"It's really alright. I just have a few things on my mind."

"Oh...?"

Suddenly, Luna reached out and placed her hand on my forehead.

"Huh?"

Seeing this, Rie's eyes widened. I was taken aback by Luna's unexpected action as well.

"You don't seem to have a fever..."

Luna tilted her head as she kept her hand on my forehead.

"...Huh?"

As we all stared at Luna with bewildered expressions, she seemed to realize what she had done.

"Ah, I'm sorry! I was just worried, and...um...!"

Luna hastily drew back her hand and grew flustered.

Just as she was about to offer an explanation...

Thud.

"We've arrived. You can disembark now."

The coachman's voice echoed from outside.

We stepped out of the carriage and into the open air.

The first thing we saw was a tree, followed by more trees.

We were in a dense forest.

However, the place where we stood wasn't completely forest, but a suitable spot for a camp.

Was this barren landscape where we were supposed to survive?

"I'll be off now."

The coachman left, guiding the carriage back down the road. Once the situation had settled, Luna approached me with an apologetic expression.

"Rudy, about that..."

I reassured her, saying, "No, it's not like you did anything terribly wrong.

Friends do that sort of thing, right? It's my fault for causing you to worry."

"Friends..."

Luna mulled over my words, gazing at me.

"Hey, Rudy!"

Rie called out to me while Luna and I were talking.

"Yeah?"

"Let's go check out the surroundings."

Rie pointed towards the forest. Her sudden suggestion caught me off guard.

"...Right now?"

"Follow me if I say follow."

Though I was baffled, I moved nonetheless, suspecting she must have something important to say.

"I'll go with Rie to explore the area for a bit."

"Alright..."

I left Luna behind and walked towards Rie.

She said nothing more and headed into the forest.

After a short walk, Rie turned around to look at me.

"Hey, what's your relationship with her?"

I frowned at her abrupt question.

"What are you talking about all of a sudden?"

"What's your relationship with her?"

"Luna? We're friends."

Luna and I were naturally close friends, weren't we?

Best friends.

She was my only friend in the Academy.

Of course, I was also friendly with Rie, but our relationship felt more like a business arrangement than a friendship.

However, I merely referred to Luna as a friend, fearing that calling her my best friend might make her uncomfortable.

"Hmm..."

Rie stroked her chin and eyed me with a hint of suspicion.

More than that, I was curious about something.

"Hey, what's the deal with these group members?"

"Ah, the group? I talked to senior Astina about it. Honestly, it's uncomfortable to be with strangers."

Rie spoke as if it were a matter of course.

"Is that allowed?"

"Even if the midterm event evaluation affects our grades, it's only a small part. No one really cares about this kind of thing as it's just a formality."

Rie snickered at my concern.

"You're more timid than I thought. Shaking just because of this."

"There's no harm in being cautious, right?"

I worried that a misstep could lead to disciplinary action and a headache.

"Don't worry. I heard there are other students who requested similar arrangements. Even the professors turned a blind eye."

Rie's words eased my concerns a bit.

However, it was surprising to learn that there were others who had made similar requests. Did they just ask to be with their friends?

"So, you arranged this entire group?"

"Yep, I just picked people I'm comfortable with."

Her response took me by surprise.

"Were you friends with Luna?"

I hadn't seen Rie and Luna interacting in the game, so it was unexpected that Rie found her comfortable.

"Well, she's the girl I saved, so we have some kind of bond."

Rie spoke nonchalantly. It was indeed more comfortable for me to have the group arranged this way.

I wished Rie had been in Evan's group though, but that was a minor regret.

Still, being in the same group, I thought I might be able to create events similar to the game.

"Ugh...!"

Rie stretched her arms.

She took a deep breath, inhaling and exhaling, and then opened her mouth.

"Coming into the forest like this does feel healing."

Rie looked at ease, which was palpable to me.

She usually played the role of the kind princess, hiding behind a mask.

Today, however, her face seemed genuinely relaxed.

"But it doesn't seem like we'll always be this comfortable."

Rie gestured towards my back.

"Grr..."

Behind me, about three kobolds were scouting the area.

"Shall we relieve some stress?"

With that, Rie summoned her elemental.

"Sylph, cut them down."

In a shadowy chamber, two men stood.

"So, what have we decided to do?" asked one, his face concealed by a hood.

"For now, we'll proceed as planned. We'll take care of Rudy Astria first, and then target the princess amid the ensuing chaos."

"Very well, I'll tell Yeniel to move on the fifth night."

"No, Garwel is with Yeniel. Relay the message to him instead."

The other man nodded. "I shall do as you say."

"For the cause."

"Yes, for the future."

With that, the first man vanished, leaving the hooded figure alone in the darkness.

"How convenient it is that our targets are together," he murmured with a sinister chuckle.

4/4! Picking up finally!

Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 25: Midterm Camp (2)

While Rudy and Rie were surveying the surroundings, Luna and Locke prepared the campsite where we had stopped.

They gathered nearby branches to build a campfire, and Luna went to collect fruit, while Locke went to hunt for game.

Luna collected a decent amount of fruit from the area and set it aside.

As a child, she had often picked fruit from nearby trees, so it was easy for her to identify which ones were edible.

"Is this enough?"

Luna gazed at the fruit she had gathered with a satisfied smile.

"I wonder when Rudy will be back..."

Among their group, Luna felt a bit awkward with everyone except Rudy.

She found it difficult to approach Princess Rie due to her high status and the somewhat intimidating aura she emitted.

Though the atmosphere was different from when they were at the academy, it was still hard to take the initiative and engage with her.

Furthermore, being in the same space as Locke was incredibly awkward due to their previous conflict.

As Luna absentmindedly stared in the direction where Rudy had disappeared, she suddenly thought of Ena and Rika.

"I wonder how Ena and Rika are doing...?"

She was worried about them.

Her own group felt a bit uncomfortable, but they were all skilled individuals.

There was hardly any chance they would fail.

Honestly, having Rudy, Rie, or herself in a group would almost guarantee success, and having all three together made it a certain.

Ena and Rika should have also been in good groups...

"But, did they do this on purpose...?"

Luna tilted her head in thought.

She wondered if they had deliberately placed the high-achieving students in one group to compare the lower-performing ones separately.

In reality, if a group had even one outstanding student, their chances of surviving a week would be much higher, making it difficult for lower-performing students to be fairly evaluated.

That's why she suspected they had grouped the top students separately from the others.

This arrangement was good for Luna in terms of grades.

Though it was uncomfortable having awkward relationships, she would have been paired with strangers anyway, so this group was still preferable.

"Still, I'm glad Rudy is here..."

Rudy was as comfortable to be around as Rika and Ena, if not more so.

With a faint smile, Luna gazed at the fruit she had gathered.

"There's nothing to do..."

As I waited briefly, various voices reached my ears.

"How could you do that?!"

"What does it matter? They would all end up dead anyway."

Looking in the direction of the voices, she saw Rie and Rudy bickering as they approached.

Luna was about to greet Rudy warmly but stopped upon seeing them arguing.

'Uh...'

Rudy noticed Luna first and greeted her.

"Ah, Luna, we're back."

"Uh, yeah! Good job!"

Luna smiled in response to Rudy's greeting.

"What are all these fruits?"

Rie's attention was immediately drawn to the fruits behind Luna.

"Oh, I found a few familiar fruit trees nearby, so I picked some."

"Wow, you know about these?"

Rie asked Luna in a friendly manner.

"Yep... I ate them when I was little, picking them straight from the trees."

"You've picked and eaten fruits straight from trees?"

Rie looked at Luna with a surprised expression.

'Uh...'

Seeing Rie's astonished face made Luna feel a bit awkward.

It made sense since Rie and Luna came from different worlds.

There was no way the Empire's princess would have ever picked and eaten fruit from trees.

"There are many fruits I've never seen before."

Rie looked at the fruits curiously.

Rudy seemed interested too, as he examined the fruits from behind.

They were grown on trees in the forest, so they weren't high-quality fruits.

As a result, Rie was seeing all of them for the first time.

She had rarely eaten them herself, aside from when she was young.

"Ha...haha..."

Luna laughed awkwardly, realizing the difference between her and Rie.

Well... it was surprising that she had become this close to Rudy. Rudy's world was also different.

"Wow, I haven't seen this in a long time."

"Do you know this fruit too?"

At that moment, Rudy leaned down to pick up a small fruit.

"Is this a cherry?"

Luna's eyes widened in surprise.

"Rudy, how did you know?"

"Huh? I just saw a tree nearby when I was little... Ah."

Rudy suddenly stopped talking, then paused to think for a moment before speaking again.

"...I saw it in a book."

Rudy quickly changed his story.

"...You suddenly saw it in a book?"

Rie stared at Rudy with a bewildered expression.

"Anyway, I saw it in a book."

Rudy insisted, then immediately popped the cherry into his mouth.

"Uh...? Rudy, you should wash it before eating... And the pit is quite big...!"

For those eating cherries for the first time, biting into the pit could damage their teeth.

Luna tried to warn him of this fact.

"Hm?"

However, Rudy skillfully picked out the seed and spat it onto the ground.

"...You said it was your first time eating it."

Realizing what Rie had said, Rudy paused to think.

"I thought that might be how to eat it. So I just went for it."

"You just guessed on your first try?"

As Rie asked this, Rudy made a cheeky expression.

"Isn't human intuition amazing?"

Seeing his grin, Rie sighed as if giving up.

"By the way, where did Locke go?"

Rie asked Luna as she scanned the area.

"Um... he said he went hunting..."

"Hunting?"

As if on cue, they heard the sound of something being dragged from far away.

Locke walked towards them, his face smeared with blood.

"What's he up to now..."

Rie muttered to herself, but Rudy and Luna were thinking the same thing.

In one hand, Locke held a bloodstained sword, and in the other, he dragged a dead boar.

"It's dinner."

With that, Locke sheathed his sword at his waist.

"You caught a boar with just a sword?"

Rudy's incredulous expression was shared by Luna.

How could an ordinary person catch a boar with a sword?

Seeing their expressions, Rie spoke up with a smile.

"Tonight, we can have a feast. We might eat even better than at the Academy, right?"

Luna couldn't find the words to continue.

It truly felt like they would eat better than at the Academy.

Although they were all nobles and surviving would be easy, she thought there would be issues related to actual survival skills.

Surprisingly, they seemed to be more suited for this kind of survival than anything else.

"I'll prepare the boar."

Locke carried the boar behind some trees.

"Let's start a fire and prepare to cook."

"Right!"

Just as Rudy and Luna were about to start, Rie sneakily stepped back.

"I fought the monsters, so I'll take a break."

As Rie tried to head into the forest, Rudy grabbed her collar.

"You didn't do that much. Go make a place to store those fruits."

"Ugh..."

Rie glared at Rudy while he held her collar.

"Got it?"

"Grrr..."

Rie clenched her teeth and replied to Rudy.

It was the first time Luna had seen Rie react like this.

She was always confident and outspoken, but in front of Rudy, she couldn't even budge.

It was intriguing.

"Luna, let's prepare the fire and get ready to eat."

Hearing Rudy's words, Luna grinned.

"Alright!"

It was night,

Summer was approaching, making the weather warmer, but the forest still had a slight chill to it.

Nonetheless, it wasn't cold enough to catch a cold, and it wasn't uncomfortable either.

We had even prepared a campfire, so there shouldn't be any problems.

We tidied up our surroundings and gathered around the campfire.

"Since it's our first day and we're tired, let's go to bed early."

"Alright. Wake me up later."

Rie and Locke laid down on the ground after saying that. We decided to take turns keeping watch at night. If everyone fell asleep, we wouldn't be able to respond to a sudden monster attack, so a night watch was essential.

If only we had learned alarm magic that would alert us when monsters approached, it would have been more convenient.

However, since no one knew how to use alarm magic yet, we had no choice but to keep watch.

For now, since it was the first day and we were unfamiliar with the forest's conditions, Luna and I decided to keep watch together.

When we got tired, we would wake up Rie and Locke to take over.

Rie and Locke laid down in their spots.

She shifted her body, seemingly uncomfortable with the ground.

"Ugh... It's so hard. How can anyone sleep here?"

Despite her grumbling, Rie fell asleep within ten minutes, though tossing and turning.

It hadn't even been a full day, but after riding in the carriage for so long and preparing the base camp, she must have been exhausted.

I quietly stared at the crackling fire.

Like I had mentioned when we went out to explore with Rie, coming to this place felt refreshing.

I had only studied at the academy, so I had never felt this relaxed...

My body and mind felt drowsy, with the tension released and a warm campfire in front of me.

Earlier, my guard had been down, so I ended up talking about cherries.

I remembered picking and eating cherries from a tree near my home when I was young, so I had instinctively acted on it.

I made an excuse, thinking 'Rudy Astria' wouldn't have eaten cherries, but no one seemed to care, so we moved on.

I made a mental note that letting my guard down could create such slip-ups.

But I couldn't always be on edge.

I was constantly on guard at the academy, so shouldn't I occasionally allow myself to relax?

Of course, in a few days, I would need to be on high alert again, but right now, I wanted to enjoy this moment without worrying.

As I was lost in thought, Luna spoke up.

"They seem like nice people, better than I expected..."

"Huh?"

Luna sat with her legs crossed, looking at me and smiling.

"Rie and Locke, they both seem like good people. Even though they're of high status, they're kind..."

She was right.

Rie had done as I asked, and Locke, on the other hand, had taken the initiative to get things done without being told.

Moreover, Locke seemed familiar with this kind of lifestyle and shared his experiences, explaining what needed to be done.

As a result, I didn't have much to do, and I could finally relax.

"Ah... of course, I think Rudy is the kindest!"

"Ha ha... thank you."

I gave Luna a faint smile as I spoke.

"When I first came to the Academy, I thought people of high status would be on a different level than me."

"Really?"

"Yeah, but it turns out everyone's just like me. Hehe..."

Luna tilted her head and rested her face on her arm. I looked at her and smiled softly.

"Well, people's lives are all pretty similar."

There was no big reason for the lives of high-ranking nobles to be drastically different.

Of course, there might be some small differences, but if you looked at the big picture, they would all be quite alike.

Similar experiences, childhood stories...

"By the way, it looked like there were some cherries left earlier. Want to eat them together?"

"Sounds good."

Luna brought the cherries over and sat down near me.

We each picked up a cherry and popped it into our mouths.

"It's so sweet... hehe."

Luna kept eating cherries as she spoke.

Watching her, I smiled faintly and reached my hand out toward the bonfire, muttering to myself.

Seeing this, Luna also stretched her hand towards the bonfire.

"It's warm..."

"Yeah..."

Relying on the warmth and light of the bonfire, the night deepened.

Chapter 26: Midterm Camp (3)

It was the fifth day of our wilderness training.

Rie looked around, stroking her chin.

"Living out here wouldn't be so bad, huh?"

I agreed with her statement.

The remnants of a roasted wild boar and eaten fish skewers littered the ground, and a makeshift bed made from gathered grass caught our eyes.

Various other tools and contraptions had been made for our convenience.

Crude as they were, these devices served their purpose well.

Locke had been responsible for creating all of these.

When preparing for wilderness training, we had the option to bring a few tools with us.

I had never been camping before, so I had only brought a few books to study and a couple of temporary scrolls.

Luna had done similarly, while Rie hadn't brought anything at all.

But Locke was different.

He had packed an array of tools necessary for survival, from mundane items like rope to more advanced tools such as a hammer.

As a result, our experience felt more like a relaxing camping trip than a test of survival.

Rie glanced at the various tools before looking at Luna.

"Luna! Let's go wash up by the river."

"Uh...? Oh, sure! Let's go together!"

Luna, who had been reading a book, looked up with a bright smile in response.

One notable change during our camping adventure was that Rie and Luna had become much closer.

It was nearly impossible not to bond after spending five days together in a place like this.

I watched Luna and Rie head towards the river, then stood up.

"Hey, Locke. I'm going to take a walk around the area."

"Alright."

With that, I rose and headed into the forest.

It was time to start preparing.

Yeniél would be coming to assassinate me soon. I wasn't sure how it would happen.

In the game, the events unfolded from Evan's perspective, so I didn't know the process leading to the assassination attempt.

However, I did know one fact.

When Yeniél tried to assassinate Rudy Astria, Evan discovered the plot and stopped Yeniél.

As a result, the assassination failed.

Instead, Evan defeated Yeniel and uncovered her true identity.

For the subsequent events to proceed correctly, this storyline needed to play out.

All I needed to do was hold out until Evan arrived.

As long as I kept that in mind, there shouldn't be any major issues.

But I absolutely could not lose.

Defeat would mean certain death. My goal was to hold out until Evan arrived, then feign defeat.

Evan would then step in and win against Yeniel.

With these thoughts in mind, I surveyed the surroundings, familiarizing myself with the terrain.

I needed to find a spot that was good for holding out during a fight, with minimal variables, and easily discoverable by others.

I searched for such a location.

"Hmm... This seems like the best spot..."

I found a sunny area with few trees as I looked around.

There weren't many trees, so it would be difficult for people to hide, and the lack of slopes made it less prone to surprises.

"Should we settle here then..."

"What are you settling here for?"

I quickly turned my head at the sudden voice and prepared to cast a spell.

"Who's-

When I looked behind me, I saw a familiar face.

A woman with her red hair neatly tied up.

"Astina, senior?"

Astina was smiling behind me.

"You seem to be doing better than I thought. You look fine."

Astina joked with a smile, and I responded with a faint smile.

"Thanks to Locke, I've been able to live comfortably."

"Locke... that guy grew up under the Northern Marquis, so he has plenty of experience in situations like this. He's probably been through worse."

The Northern Marquis?

Is she talking about Locke's father?

"Do you know the Northern Marquis?"

"I've only heard stories. What about the others?"

"They're resting at the base camp over there. Would you like to see them?"

"No, I didn't come to see their faces."

Then, I couldn't help but wonder.

"But how did you get here? Shouldn't you be in the center of the forest?"

Normally, second-year student council members would be waiting in the building at the center of the forest.

They were usually just hanging out there, but they were also prepared for any unforeseen circumstances.

"I had to deal with an unpleasant situation."

"An unpleasant situation?"

As I expressed my curiosity, Astina answered.

"Someone has infiltrated the forest."

"Infiltrated..."

"It was just one person, but some of the student council members and professors are currently investigating."

Upon hearing this, I could feel danger approaching.

The tension that had loosened for a while started to tighten around me again.

However, part of me felt relieved that the story was progressing just like the game.

"There haven't been any major issues, so we're continuing as planned. But if anything happens, we're ready to stop immediately. You guys should be careful too. If something happens, use the summoning stone to call the professors."

"Understood."

I nodded in response to Astina's words.

"It doesn't look like there's anything here, so I'll be going. Good luck."

With that, Astina waved and disappeared into the forest.

"Intruder..."

It must have been a member of the Rebels.

At least, it seemed like things were unfolding as expected.

I couldn't let my guard down tonight.

With that thought in mind, I returned to where everyone was.

As night fell,

"Rudy, Rie, I took a long nap today, so if you're tired, wake me up early."

Today, Rie and I were assigned the first night watch, followed by Locke and Luna.

Once Locke and Luna had fallen asleep, Rie looked at me.

"Hey, I'm going to sleep too. If anything happens, wake me up."

Rie said that before lying down, but I grabbed her wrist and forcibly pulled her up.

"Get up."

"Ugh! Nothing's going to happen! Even if a few monsters show up, you can handle them alone."

"Get up now."

I continued to pull her up and pester her until she grumbled and sat back down.

"Sigh, I should've paired up with Locke for tonight's watch. If I left it to him, I could sleep peacefully."

"Don't try to cut corners."

I wouldn't have minded letting her rest a little under normal circumstances, but today, I couldn't allow it.

In the current situation, when we didn't know what threats might come, it would be too difficult to protect everyone on my own.

After some bickering, we silently stared at the fire. Then, Rie opened her mouth.

"Luna's a good kid."

And she smiled.

"She's so kind it's almost foolish. I'm glad we rescued her."

Rie wore a contented smile as she looked at the sleeping Luna.

"I never thought I could make a friend. But somehow, I did."

Rie echoed Luna's sentiments.

Luna, who thought she couldn't be friends with those of higher status, and Rie, who couldn't make friends because of her high status.

They had opposite yet similar situations.

"Things will be more fun when we return to the Academy."

Rustle-

While Rie was talking, we heard movement from the bushes behind us.

However, we couldn't see anything from where we were.

"Is it just an animal?"

Rie tilted her head and asked. I slowly began to feel a sense of danger.

Was it Yeniel?

"I'll go take a look."

"Alright, be careful~."

Rie cheerfully waved at me.

"Don't fall asleep. Keep your eyes wide open."

"Yep~ Got it~."

I approached the playful Rie and grabbed her shoulder, speaking seriously.

"Stay alert. If anything happens, shout loudly and use the summoning stone to call the others."

"...Why are you suddenly like this?"

As I spoke seriously, she frowned, sensing that the atmosphere was unusual.

"Right now, there's an intruder in this forest. I'm worried about potential dangers, so follow my instructions."

"An intruder...?"

Rie's expression darkened abruptly.

"Should we wake up Luna and Locke and have them come with us?"

I shook my head at Rie's suggestion.

That scenario shouldn't happen.

First, it was essential to create a connection between Evan and Yaniel.

Later, the key to stopping the rebels would lie in that relationship.

So, I had to go on an adventure to help establish a connection between Yaniel and Evan.

Of course, it wasn't a life-threatening adventure.

I wasn't that weak, and with the summoning stone, I planned to use it if things got too dangerous.

"I'll just scout the situation and come back. If something happens, I'll shout for help, and you can come to my aid."

"How about taking a spirit with you?"

"Then you won't be able to protect yourself. Just have the spirits guard the perimeter for now."

When I said that, Rie nodded slightly and opened her mouth.

"...Be careful."

I listened to Rie's farewell and slowly walked towards the bushes.

"Ignite."

I used magic to create light, brightening my field of vision.

If someone attacked from a blind spot, I'd be powerless.

So, it was crucial to make it as bright as possible to improve visibility.

Then, I cautiously moved to the location I had seen earlier.

Astina said there was only one intruder.

This meant that not all the rebels around here had moved yet.

In the game's current state, numerous rebels were lurking around this forest.

They were planning to assassinate me and, amid the chaos, ambush the students and professors as they fled the forest.

Assassinating Rie through a surprise attack.

That was the grand scheme they had in mind.

Rustle-

I reached out in the direction of the moving sound.

I saw a rabbit passing through the bushes.

"A rabbit...?"

I immediately made a judgment upon seeing the rabbit.

There was someone here.

I suddenly noticed a black object approaching.

I quickly threw my body to the side to avoid it.

"Ugh...!"

Rabbits aren't nocturnal creatures.

It's unusual for them to be active at dawn like this.

I quickly stood up and focused on the dark figure approaching me.

A masked individual with a slender build.

There was no doubt; it was Yeniel.

The person gave me no chance to react, charging towards me again.

However, I had prepared something this time.

"Wind Cutter!"

I instantly cast my spell at the attacker.

They ducked swiftly to avoid my magic.

Immediately after, they leaped forward.

Such a large movement was bound to leave openings.

Charging right after dodging my attack was the exact response I had anticipated.

I hadn't been wasting my time even after midterms.

I also studied how to counter Yeniel.

Locke had been my training partner.

Though assassins and swordsmen were undoubtedly different, I believed their fundamental movements were similar, so I asked him for a duel.

After a few matches, I had a decent grasp of the fundamentals.

To gain the upper hand against my opponent, I needed to induce their carelessness and predict their movements.

Since the assassin was in the dark, they'd likely feel at an advantage and be off guard.

The question was, how could I predict their next action?

After much thought, I came to one conclusion.

There was no need to predict.

All I had to do was lead their movements myself.

To manipulate their actions, I relied on this tactic: dodging small spells and baiting a charge towards me.

It was the easiest movement to provoke.

Especially when the opponent was in a hurry, it was even easier to induce.

I recalled my practice sessions.

Magic I had practiced while enduring pain.

I shouted at Yeniel as she charged at me.

"Abyssal Flame."

A black flame shot from my hand.

"Argh!"

Yeniel tried to dodge the flame, but she couldn't avoid it completely.

The flame hit her arm squarely, and she rolled on the ground, severely injured.

"Ugh..."

Yeniel let out a faint groan.

Gritting my teeth, I got back on my feet and reached out to the fallen Yeniel, preparing my magic in anticipation of his return.

"...?"

But Yeniel didn't move.

"Huh?"

I looked at the fallen Yeniel with a baffled expression.

"What... what's going on?"

I was flustered.

I didn't let my guard down and continued to watch Yeniel.

But there was no movement.

No way, right?

Could it be?

I stared at Yeniel like that for a few minutes.

Finally, I came to a conclusion.

That's right.

I had defeated Yeniel in one move.

No, I had used this combination technique against Locke too, and he had handled it well.

Even when he was attacked, he had been prepared to counter immediately.

Of course, the magic I used then wasn't Abyssal Flame.

But still... even so...

It wasn't supposed to end after just one hit, was it?

I didn't come here thinking I'd win.

But somehow, I won in a single round. I was dumbfounded.

"Is... is she dead?"

As I approached Yeniel, it seemed she was still breathing, her back rising and falling.

"..."

I stood silently, staring at the fallen Yeniel.

What should I do now?

Of course, I had put in tremendous effort to become stronger and adapt to this situation.

That's why I learned dark magic.

I heard that dark magic was powerful, but I didn't know it would be this strong.

The difference between Abyssal Flame and ordinary fire magic was the amount of pain inflicted.

While ordinary fire magic caused burns, Abyssal Flame inflicted immense pain upon the person hit.

Although it didn't cause severe physical damage, it was a technique that delivered a mental shock due to the pain.

It seemed Yaniel had fainted from the agony.

"Yaniel!"

Suddenly, a voice rang out from somewhere.

It was Evan's voice.

He must have been searching for the suddenly vanished Yaniel, just like in the game's story.

Hearing that voice, I made a decision.

"Let's run away..."

Leaving Yaniel behind, I returned to where everyone else was.

I hope Evan finds her...

2/4 Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 27: Midterm Camp (4)

That dawn.

"Ugh..."

Yeniel regained consciousness and tried to sit up.

"Where am I...?"

"Yeniel, are you okay?"

Startled by the sudden voice, Yeniel turned her head toward its source.

"E-Evan?"

At the edge of her vision stood Evan.

In that moment, Yeniel noticed her attire.

It wasn't a typical school uniform but rather clothes resembling those of an assassin.

Touching her face, she realized she wasn't wearing a mask either.

Then, memories started flooding back to her, one by one.

She had been defeated by Rudy Astria and had lost consciousness.

But why was Evan here in front of her?

She should have been in jail. There was no reason for her to be here.

"Yeniel, how are you feeling?"

In response to Evan's concern, Yeniel nodded, indicating she was fine.

Yeniel had never been alone with Evan like this before, nor had they ever conversed. The situation felt awkward and confusing.

Although they were in the same group, they never had a real opportunity to talk.

She always held back while her groupmates, Serina and Garwel, chatted with Evan.

Yeniel fell into deep thought.

Did this guy know the current situation?

For now, it would be difficult for him to know that she was a rebel.

However, judging by her attire, he could guess that she was involved in something shady.

As Yeniel contemplated this, Evan spoke up.

"Yeniel, I'm not sure what situation you're in."

Evan said so and stood up from his seat.

"I don't expect you to tell me just because I asked. So..."

Evan gave a faint smile.

"When you feel like you can trust me a little more, I hope you'll share it with me."

Yeniel stared at Evan, dumbfounded.

Evan pointed in a direction with his finger.

"Over there, you'll find the others. Go change your clothes then join us."

Then he walked in the indicated direction.

"...He's too kind."

Yeniël snorted as she watched Evan disappear.

To make such a remark when even the professors or the student council were not enough to meet her demands?

All without even knowing what she had been planning to do?

Yeniël pondered on this as she rose to her feet.

"Naive..."

While saying this, a question arose in her mind.

After her defeat against Rudy Astria, how did she end up here with Evan?

Shouldn't Rudy Astria have called the student council or the professors after defeating her?

And how was it that Evan had been the one to find her?

No matter how much she thought about it, it didn't make sense.

Things didn't add up.

"I need to return first."

She needed to inform Garwel about this as soon as possible.

Yeniël gritted her teeth.

Directly telling Garwel would put her neck on the line.

She would have to mix some truth with lies.

Muttering these thoughts, she uttered a single statement.

"Rudy Astria..."

A member of the Astria family, an incompetent individual.

A guy who even had the top seat stolen by a commoner without any support.

Thinking this, she had initially considered it an easy task.

But it wasn't.

Yeniel remembered the look in Rudy Astria's eyes when they faced each other.

Indifferent and sharp.

A person who maintained such a gaze when ambushed...

Even though Yeniel had grown up as an assassin since childhood, she had never encountered someone like that.

She thought it could be possible if the person was strong.

However, the fact that an ordinary student reacted so calmly to the surprise left Yeniel bewildered.

"What is he up to...?"

Sensing that something was amiss, Yeniel changed into her school uniform and headed toward her groupmates.

The following morning.

"Hehehe... Did he really do that?"

".....It's understandable to be concerned if you heard something like that last night."

Rie laughed heartily, clutching her stomach, as she chatted with Luna.

They were discussing the events of the previous night.

I intentionally didn't tell Rie the truth.

I wanted to brush it off as mistaking a rabbit for a person.

But Rie wasn't the type to let things go easily.

Since the morning, she had been recounting how I was so nervous that I was trembling.

I was indeed nervous, but I wasn't trembling...

And the truth was, I had almost been assassinated.

Honestly, it felt unfair, but there was no point in dwelling on it now.

"Ah..."

Instead, I wondered if Evan had found Yeniel collapsed.

In the original story, Yeniel, who wanted to kill Rudy Astria, should have fought against Evan and been defeated.

Then Evan would realize that Yeniel was the assassin, but he wouldn't report it to the professors or anyone else.

That's how the relationship between Yeniel and Evan should have started.

But instead, I emerged as the victor.

It was something I never anticipated.

So what should I do now?

I had two options.

The first option was to reveal Yeniel as the assassin and bring this story to an end.

But I dismissed that immediately.

If I exposed Yeniel as the assassin, she would be swiftly arrested.

Then dealing with the rebels would become much more difficult later on.

As the story progressed, Yeniel would provide Evan with information about the rebels.

She was essentially a double agent.

There was no reason to let go of this opportunity.

So, I had to choose the only other option.

And this option was simple.

Follow the original story.

There were two bosses in this story.

One was Garwel, and the other was Andrei, a knight from the rebels.

So, if we followed the original story, the rebels would attack this forest, and Garwel and Andrei would ambush Evan one after another.

Evan would easily deal with Garwel, but not with Andrei.

Evan couldn't defeat Andrei.

So, he would make Rie flee and hold off Andrei by himself.

It would be a story of Evan fighting Andrei and holding out until others arrived.

That would be the final battle of the midterm camp in the game.

If he succeeded in holding out there, Evan would receive a reward.

Andrei's magic sword.

It was an incredibly powerful weapon, suitable for Evan to use or trade.

Moreover, Andrei was a knight with a reputation among the rebels, entrusted with the task of assassinating the Princess.

I couldn't precisely gauge his influence since he died early on, but considering the performance of the magic sword, Andrei must have been formidable.

So, I had to deal with him here.

If I reported this to the professors, I could prevent this incident from happening.

If that happened, that guy could interfere in other stories, and I wouldn't be able to get his sword.

That would be a big problem.

Thus, I decided to let the incident happen.

"Assuming I do that..."

I had to make other preparations.

Garwel and Andrei would attack to eliminate Rie.

It was clear they would target our group instead of Evan's.

With the failed assassination and my presence, it was almost guaranteed.

I looked at Rie and Luna, who were chatting and having fun.

"I can't just let them die."

I had to prepare a countermeasure in advance.

No one would die.

Touching the summoning stone in my pocket, I walked towards Locke.

Garwel, Yeniei, and another man were conversing in a deserted place.

Yeniei explained what had happened.

But she didn't reveal all the details.

If she mentioned that she had been defeated and fainted during the fight, and Evan discovered her identity, she knew her head would roll.

So, she cleverly concealed the situation.

She didn't mention anything about Evan, only that she had been defeated by Rudy Astria and had fled.

Smack!

"You useless girl... How did you fail?"

Garwel slapped Yeniei's cheek, leaving a red, swollen mark.

Yeniei felt the sting on her cheek, but she thought the punishment wasn't too severe.

The man standing beside them remained unresponsive, simply observing the situation.

"I heard they brought in an excellent assassin, but it seems you're just a failure," Garwel taunted Yeniei with a haughty gaze.

The observing man calmly spoke up.

"In that case, we should revise the plan."

"What if Rudy Astria reports to the professors? Won't everything be ruined then?"

"It's difficult to determine immediately. The academy will conduct its own assessment, and considering how well she managed to escape, it will be challenging to find concrete evidence."

"Hmm, I see."

As the man spoke in a composed manner, Garwel reluctantly accepted the explanation and settled down.

"Alright, then we need to resolve this tonight. Inform Andrei. Let's eliminate both Princess Rie and Rudy Astria tonight."

Garwel uttered those words with a malicious laugh.

He continued, "After that, Yeniel and I will take care of Serina and that Evan, and then we'll head over there."

"Serina and Evan?" Yeniel asked, surprised by Garwel's statement.

"We'll raise suspicion when we flee amidst the chaos, won't we? It's better to eliminate them. Besides, I never liked either of them. Just send a few soldiers. We'll dispatch them quickly and depart."

"Understood. I will inform Knight Andrei."

Yeniel felt uneasy about the command.

Although she believed it was necessary to kill Evan, who knew her true identity, he was the one who had covered for her.

She felt guilty at the thought of killing someone who had shown such kindness.

"We'll carry it out tonight," Garwel declared.

The moment Garwel spoke those words, the man in front of them disappeared without a trace.

On that fateful night.

The atmosphere was peaceful, no different from any other night.

Luna and Rie engaged in a quiet conversation, while Locke focused on practicing his swordsmanship.

Suddenly, breaking the tranquility, a loud explosion echoed through the air.

BANG!!!!!!

"Huh?"

"What was that?"

Startled by the explosion, Luna and Rie abruptly stood up from their seats.

Has it begun?

Could it be the Rebels' attack?

In the game, the Rebels didn't target just one location.

They simultaneously attacked students dispersed across various places.

That way, they could divert the attention of the professors and student council.

Sensing something amiss, Rie retrieved a summoning stone from her pocket and began calling out to anyone.

"Hello? Can anyone hear me? Is anyone there?"

However, the summoning stone remained eerily silent.

"What's happening?" Rie furrowed her brows in concern.

Luna, too, voiced her worry. "Is something wrong?"

"It seems that way," I responded, noting the growing unease.

Recognizing the gravity of the situation, Rie swiftly rose from her seat. "Let's head towards the main building, just in case."

Her calm demeanor mirrored my own thoughts, and I felt grateful for her initiative.

Leaving behind everything but the essentials, we set off towards the center.

"What could be happening?" Rie led the way, her expression filled with concern.

We ventured into the dark forest, avoiding any magical fires that would expose our presence. As our eyes adjusted, the path ahead became discernible.

Through the dense undergrowth, the faint silhouette of a person emerged.

It was not a figure clad in our school uniform, but rather someone donning lightweight chain armor.

Locke took a step forward, sword drawn, while the rest of us prepared our magic.

"Sylph!" Rie summoned her wind spirit, standing guard against the stranger.

"Identify yourself! If you don't, we will attack!"

Her voice carried authority.

The stranger slowly raised their head to meet our gaze.

Their eyes, cold and brimming with intent to kill, sent a shiver down my spine and caused goosebumps to rise on my skin.

Reacting to this unsettling sensation, we unleashed our magic spells without hesitation.

"Sylph! Attack! Wind Cutter!"

"Fireball!"

"Abyssal Flame."

Our spells were launched, aimed at the intruder.

Yet, to our astonishment, the enemy did not evade our assault.

With one swift motion, they raised their sword and effortlessly sliced through our spells.

"What the...?"

Rie stared at the scene, disbelief etched on her face.

A single strike was all it took. Even though we were novice wizards, our magic was not weak enough to be shattered so easily.

As we were taken aback by the unexpected turn of events, the stranger spoke.

"Attack."

In response to their command, hidden figures emerged from the grassy undergrowth, swiftly closing in on us.

Their target was not all of us; they focused solely on one person.

"Rie!"

I called out, pulling her arm.

"Ah!"

Startled, Rie instinctively moved closer to me, evading the impending attack, while Locke confronted the approaching assailants.

"What the hell...?"

"Rie, run."

"What?" Rie looked at me, puzzled.

I calmly grasped her hand and began running.

"Hey! What about Locke and Luna?"

"Just run! Didn't you see? You're their target!"

"What?"

Just as I had said, the figures dressed in black were pursuing us relentlessly from behind.

"Locke, take care of Luna!"

With a resolute shout, I sprinted towards the central building.

Chapter 28: Midterm Camp (5)

As Rudy grasped Rie's hand tightly, they dashed forward, pursued by the others.

"Rudy...!"

Luna was taken aback by the sight.

If they ran away like that, she and Locke would have a chance to survive.

However, Rudy and Rie would be in even greater danger.

If the number of targets decreased from four to two, the assassins would have fewer people to worry about.

"We have to help...!"

As Luna tried to run in the direction Rudy and Rie had fled, Locke blocked her path.

Luna glared at Locke, her expression fierce.

"Move..."

"We're heading elsewhere."

Locke's words were met with Luna extending her hand.

Directly aiming for Locke's head.

"If you obstruct me, there will be consequences."

She was resolute, her lips tightly pressed together as she stared Locke down.

However, her hands were trembling.

Anxiety.

And fear.

Her eyes reflected a mixture of emotions.

"Luna Railer."

Despite the dire circumstances, Locke remained calm.

Luna couldn't comprehend Locke's behavior.

How could he remain so composed in such a situation?

Even though they'd only spent a few days together, weren't they comrades?

As she thought that, her emotions intensified.

"Move. Rudy and Rie are being chased right now."

"Haah..."

Locke sighed as he looked at the yelling Luna.

"Everything has unfolded exactly as Rudy Astria anticipated."

"...What?"

"Rudy Astria predicted this would happen and made arrangements."

Luna frowned.

What was he talking about now?

As Luna pondered this, Locke provided further explanation.

"Rudy Astria foresaw this situation and tasked me with something. There's something we must do."

"Do... what?"

Locke didn't offer a separate response; instead, he began walking.

Luna followed him, asking:

"What is it that we need to do?"

As Luna asked, Locke briefly turned his head and replied:

"We're going to help Evan."

"Ugh...!"

Gasping for breath, I clung to Rie's hand as we sprinted onward.

Branches and grass obstructed our path, but we employed magic to clear them, maintaining our speed.

I could hear the sound of pursuit from behind.

However, it seemed like their numbers had decreased somewhat.

The darkness of the forest made it difficult for them to accurately locate us.

But there was one person, a lone figure, who relentlessly pursued us.

It was likely Andrei.

And the sound of his footsteps drew nearer and nearer.

We had to run faster.

"Huff... huff..."

Yet Rie was reaching her limit.

As a wizard, physical training was a luxury, and stamina naturally suffered as a result.

"Rie, hold on just a little longer."

No matter how agonizing it was, she had to endure.

We couldn't afford to stop running.

Unlike when Evan fled with Rie, the area wasn't restricted by the game.

We didn't have to fight like they did; we could simply run.

We had to take advantage of that.

With that in mind, we pressed forward.

The current circumstances were not a game governed by fixed rules; this was reality.

As Rie's steps gradually slowed, I could feel our pursuer getting closer.

Footsteps pounding the ground.

"...He's closing in."

Swiftly, I turned around and extended my hand behind us.

"Wind Blaster!"

A powerful gust erupted from my outstretched hand, parting the grass in its wake.

And there, at the other end, stood the person we had initially encountered.

Andrei.

With a single stroke, he cleaved through my magic once again.

Andrei propelled himself off the ground, sprinting toward us.

Observing this, Rie exhaled with effort and called out.

"Sylph...!"

At Rie's command, multiple gusts of wind homed in on Andrei.

He halted momentarily, slashing away the winds rushing toward him.

Seizing the opportunity, I raised my hand skyward.

"Wind Blaster!"

Boom!

A fierce gust of wind raged, rustling the surrounding foliage as countless leaves descended like a shower.

Those leaves provided ample cover, obscuring our figures.

"Rie, keep running!"

"Ugh..."

Struggling to regain her breath, Rie followed me once more.

But her forced sprint would not last long.

"Haah... Haah... I can't... run anymore..."

Rie came to a halt, gasping for air.

I grasped Rie's shoulder and spoke.

"Rie, you can't stop. Just a little bit more."

"You... go. They're after me anyway. I'll... Haa... try something, so you go."

Rie collapsed onto the ground as she spoke.

She had reached her limit.

Her breaths were shallow, making it even difficult for her to speak.

This was not a situation that could be overcome through sheer willpower or any other means.

"...Huh?"

I turned my back on Rie as I spoke.

"Get on."

"...What?"

"Hurry up and get on my back. We don't have much time."

Blocking their view earlier bought us some time, but they would catch up soon.

We had to run as fast as possible.

"...Hey, we'll both die like this. You should run and get help."

Rie's voice remained calm, her fists clenched tightly.

However, her tightly clenched fists were trembling.

She was scared too.

To resist assassins in her exhausted state was nonsensical.

She knew it, and yet she still said it.

For my sake.

How could I abandon her like this?

I had no intention of giving up. Strengthening my resolve, I approached Rie.

"Hey... what... what are you...!"

I forcefully grasped Rie's arm and lifted her onto my back.

"Don't try to be a hero. Save that performance for the academy. Just listen to me now."

"Let... me go. We'll both die if you do this..."

Rie struggled to free herself from my back, but she lacked the strength to do so.

I held Rie, who was now on my back, firmly.

"I won't let you die."

"Huh?"

"I won't abandon you and run away. Never. We'll both survive. Trust me."

For a moment, Rie gazed at me with a bewildered expression.

Then she bit her lower lip hard.

"If you die... I really won't forgive you."

I wasn't entirely sure how she wouldn't forgive me if I were dead, but there was no time for hesitation.

Rie tightly held onto me.

The strength in her embrace felt like trust.

It felt like she believed in me.

With Rie on my back, I resumed running.

"Huff... huff..."

After running for about ten minutes, my stamina began to wane.

I regretted not working on my physical fitness while practicing magic.

"I should start exercising once this is over..."

Fortunately, I had a plan...

I slowly came to a halt.

As I stopped, Rie spoke with a panicked voice.

As I came to a stop, Rie's voice sounded startled.

"Ru... Rudy?"

I surveyed our surroundings.

"Rudy, we haven't reached the center yet..."

"I know."

I acknowledged Rie's words while continuing to assess our environment.

This seemed about right.

"Rie, we need to hold out now."

"...What?"

"Just 5 minutes. We only have to hold out for approximately 5 minutes."

"What are you talking about?"

They're coming.

"Wind Blaster!"

I used magic behind me before I had a chance to answer Rie's question.

Bang!

"Ugh!"

A figure was sent flying by the force of my magic.

"Uh... Sylph!"

Rie stopped questioning and joined the fight.

"Wind Blaster!"

"Sylph! Push them back! Wind Cutter!"

Back to back, we stood against the assassins.

However, we were merely buying time.

After several clashes, the assassins' movements gradually came to a halt.

"Ignite."

I employed magic to illuminate our surroundings, revealing the assassins lurking in the shadows.

We were surrounded.

Numerous figures became visible, their count exceeding ten.

And among them, Andrei stepped forward.

"It seems it's all over now."

He removed his mask, revealing a smirk.

"Why are you weak wizards running around like this? It would be easier if you simply died."

Andrei drew his sword and approached us.

I threw a question his way.

"Where did Garwel go?"

"...What?"

Andrei furrowed his brow.

"What are you talking about?"

"I thought that Garwel guy would be here too, but I don't see him. Is there a problem?"

I spoke teasingly.

Andrei emitted a strong killing intent in response.

Naturally, he remained on guard.

There was no way I should know that Garwel was a rebel.

My question was meant to cause confusion.

As I anticipated, Andrei, who was approaching us, stopped and threw a question.

"Who the hell are you?"

Without hesitation, I dangled another piece of bait.

"Or perhaps, did he betray you? Maybe he's aiming for your throats?"

I grinned maliciously.

The provocation hit its mark.

A vein in the shape of a cross bulged on Andrei's forehead.

"It seems unnecessary for someone like you, who will soon die, to know."

"Is that so? Aren't you curious about how Yeniel survived and returned after failing in the assassination?"

"....."

Andrei gritted his teeth and glared at me.

He must have had concerns in his mind as well.

A mixture of lies and truth.

He didn't have the luxury to distinguish between them right now.

It just got under his skin.

"Rudy...?"

Rie tugged at my sleeve, her expression filled with worry.

I gave her a faint, reassuring smile.

"I wonder what Yeniel and Garwel are up to now?"

"Ha... Kill him."

Rather than extracting information from me, Andrei opted to kill me.

He charged toward me.

It was a good choice.

Killing me quickly and then searching for those two would be a better decision than trying to extract information from me.

I watched Andrei approach.

Yet, I remained motionless.

His sword couldn't reach me.

Because she had already arrived.

I once had a thought.

What would happen if a second-year student interfered with the dangers faced by first-year students?

What if she, the top student in her grade and the student council president, stepped in?

The conclusion was simple.

The balance would collapse.

Someone descended rapidly, tearing through the foliage above us.

With her red hair fluttering, she came down from above.

It was Astina.

Thud!-

With the momentum from her descent, she goomba stomped on Andrei.

Astina's foot connected precisely with Andrei's back, sending him crashing into the ground.

Blood spurted from his mouth.

"Cough!!"

Astina triumphantly stepped on Andrei and taunted him.

"Where do you think you're going?"

She extended her hand toward the sky.

Then, she turned her head slightly to glance at me.

"Rudy Astria, you did well."

Astina's mana surged.

Surrounding leaves trembled, and gentle winds gathered around Astina's hand.

The area trembled due to the massive movement of mana.

Astina's magic.

Her magic surpassed the capability of all these individuals combined.

"Crush."

The mana amassing in her hand expanded forcefully around her.

"Gravity."

Whoosh!-

Bang!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!

"Ugh!!!"

"Argh!!!"

Leaves littered the ground, while even the slender trees snapped in half.

No ordinary person could withstand such immense power.

Everyone, except us, crumbled to the ground.

Astina's overwhelming strength.

These fools stood no chance against her.

Andrei might be strong, but he was someone who needed time to win against Evan.

No matter how many troops they had, they were mere pawns.

Confronting Astina head-on, victory was an impossibility, let alone being caught off-guard as she descended from the sky.

Astina after crushing the surroundings and looked at us.

A bright, smiling face.

With a playful grin, she said,

"Am I late?"

Returning Astina's smile, I responded.

"You've arrived right on time."

Uhhh I might've added some goomba to Astina's stomp.. I couldn't resist

4/4 Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 29: Midterm Camp (6)

"Ugh..."

Evan let out a groan.

However, someone else appeared more anxious.

"Why can't you finish him off faster? Just kill him quickly!"

Garwel shouted at those around him, stomping his foot in frustration.

"I should have brought stronger guys..."

A girl with sleepy eyes spoke lazily.

Beside her stood Clay, an intermediate earth elemental. It was Serina, the daughter of the Chief Elementalist.

Despite their outnumbered position, Serina and Evan managed to fend off all the assassins' attacks.

Yet, Evan's stamina was becoming an issue.

He was nearing his limit in using magic.

"Finish him off swiftly!"

Garwel stomped his foot and shouted again, but the composed assassins around him didn't falter.

"What's the plan, Miss Yeniel?"

"If we keep this up, it will turn into a battle of attrition. If we rush them, we risk losing a fight we could win."

The assassins trusted Yeniel more than Garwel's words.

Despite her youth, they had faith in her due to her extensive experience.

"Yeniel! End this swiftly!"

Yeniel ignored Garwel's shouts from behind.

That guy knew nothing.

He was an ignorant young master who had no understanding of battle.

Yeniel felt her annoyance growing.

She wanted to silence him and then focus on the fight, but she couldn't.

The Handrei family, to which Garwel belonged, played the role of financial backer for the Rebels.

She couldn't simply dismiss the son of such a supporter.

Although Garwel wasn't part of the original plan to assassinate Princess Rie, he insisted on participating.

Regardless, since Andrei would be directly responsible for the assassination, Yeniel thought there wouldn't be any issues.

Yeniel sighed and gave orders to those around her.

"For now, let's continue wearing them down like this. Exploit our numerical advantage."

"Understood."

The assassins smoothly moved, following Yeniel's command.

Yeniel found herself in a rather challenging situation.

"I should have just ignored them and moved on..."

The situation was dragging on for too long.

But there was no chance to end it.

If they rushed in as Garwel suggested, they could be wiped out. Yeniel couldn't make such a reckless decision.

Ignoring Evan and Serina from the start would have been the correct choice.

This damn Garwel messed up the plan by deciding to kill those two.

Yeniel observed the situation, and her eyes met Evan's.

Evan let out a tired exhale, glancing at his own condition.

"....."

It was the most logical judgment to make at that moment.

Targeting Evan was the right move.

Evan was stronger than Serina.

However, he was worn out and injured from shielding Serina during the initial ambush.

This was the moment.

It was common sense to strike when the strong one was fatigued.

But it was a challenging decision to make.

Whether it was due to the brief moment they had, or some other reason...

It was still a decision they had to make to survive.

"Everyone..."

Just as Yeniel gathered her determination,

"Wind Cutter."

"Ugh!"

"What the? Argh!"

Blades of wind soared from the bushes, and a man charged into the midst of the battle.

A man who swung his sword and struck down the assassins.

Behind him, a woman with brown hair wielded magic.

"Luna Railer and Locke Lucarion, huh."

Yeniel clenched her teeth at the sight of them.

How did they end up here?

Aren't those two part of Rudy Astria's team?

Moreover, how did they know Evan was under attack?

Yeniel quickly wracked her brain, but she couldn't make sense of the situation.

"What...who are those guys!"

Garwel stumbled back in astonishment upon seeing the duo.

"Huff!"

"Ugh!"

"Clay, assist them."

As Locke took the lead and swept away the assassins, Serina and Evan also joined in to support him.

The assassins were caught off guard.

Yeniël observed for a few seconds and swiftly made a decision.

"Retreat!"

Yeniël called out and leaped onto a tree.

As she attempted to flee, a shout reached her ears.

"What? Who says?!"

It was Garwel.

Garwel grumbled and argued against Yeniël's command.

"Kill them all!! I thought you guys were exceptional, how can you be struggling against these weaklings?"

Yeniël felt a throbbing headache at Garwel's words.

Even among the exceptional, there are hierarchies.

The students of Liberion Academy are not just ordinarily exceptional.

It's a place where only the most outstanding individuals in the empire are gathered.

Even if they're assassins, they are exceptional only among ordinary people.

It was obvious that they would be no match.

"We must retreat."

Yeniël told the angered Garwel.

However, Garwel seemed unwilling to heed Yeniel's words.

"I suppose I have to step in."

Garwel confidently stepped forward.

"These guys are just... Huh?"

As Garwel advanced, Locke dashed toward him with incredible speed.

The assassins had formed a protective ring around Garwel, but his advance had left an opening.

"Huff!"

"Ugh!"

With his swift speed, Locke struck Garwel's face with his fist.

Garwel was knocked down without even a chance to react.

"Uh...."

Seeing this, Yeniel felt a throbbing pain in her head.

That useless brat.

He was of no help at all.

First, they needed to rescue Garwel.

Even though he may be utterly useless, saving him took priority.

"Everyone, save Garw-."

Gulp!

As Yeniel was about to speak, she heard the sound of paper tearing below.

Yeniel immediately recognized the sound.

In this situation, there was only one reason why the sound of paper tearing would be heard.

The sound of a scroll being torn.

"Haah...."

Yeniel sighed.

It was a sigh of resignation.

Then, from where the tearing sound originated, green tendrils spread out.

The tendrils extended, ensnaring each of the scattered assassins one by one.

"Don't move."

Standing where the magic from the torn scroll was activated was Luna, her eyes glaring fiercely.

All the assassins attacking us were successfully subdued by Astina.

Soon after, others arrived and bound the assassins, taking them to the center of the forest.

"Sigh..."

Rie and I sat near the central building, utterly drained. Leaning against a tree, we were too exhausted to exchange a single word.

Thankfully, it all worked out.

It was a relief.

Now, if only Locke and Luna returned safely, everything would be resolved.

With Evan and Serina there, I honestly didn't think there would be any issues.

Moreover, we had coordinated with Astina in advance, ensuring the safe return of the others as well.

"Hoo..."

I observed the break of dawn in the distance.

As the sun began to rise, and with no sounds of commotion, it seemed that the situation had somewhat stabilized.

While gazing at the emerging sunlight, Rie spoke up.

"Why didn't you leave me behind?"

"Huh?"

I looked at Rie, puzzled by her sudden question.

"You should have left me behind, dummy. If you had known Astina was nearby, you should have gone alone to fetch her. Both of us could have died. You weren't acting rationally."

Rie spoke to me matter-of-factly.

I couldn't argue with her logic.

If I had rushed alone to bring Astina, at least one of us would have undoubtedly survived.

If things went well, there was a chance that both of us could have made it out alive.

However, I had my reasons for the choices I made.

If I had brought Astina and faced the assassins head-on, there was a chance we would have lost.

By provoking them and leading them to the predetermined location, I allowed Astina to launch a surprise attack successfully, resulting in our

victory.

From that perspective, I thought it was a reasonable decision.

As I pondered on that, Rie spoke quietly.

"Thank you..."

"Huh?"

"Thank you."

Rie looked at me with a faint smile.

"You could have abandoned me. If I were in your position, I might have left you behind and fled. Even though we're allies, I believe that my own life is the most important."

She calmly expressed her sentiments.

It was a typical Rie-like statement.

Rie was a calculative and rational individual.

"If our positions were reversed in the same situation, I would have tried to leave you behind and run."

Rie rose from her seat and stood before me.

"But if my life isn't in danger, I would have done everything I can to assist you."

The rising sun cast a radiant glow on Rie, enveloping her figure in an orange hue.

Her smile was as fresh as the morning dew, pure and untainted.

"You deceitful, filthy nobles!!!!"

Suddenly, a loud noise reverberated in the distance.

"...What?"

Upon hearing that, Rie returned to her usual self.

The atmosphere had been somewhat emotional, but it was ruined by that strange outburst.

Turning our gaze in that direction, we saw Andrei, bound and screaming.

Astina stood before him, her expression filled with disdain as she observed Andrei.

Rie and I approached them.

As soon as he caught sight of us, Andrei clenched his teeth.

"Ah, the offspring of those who exploit the Empire have arrived."

Exploit the Empire?

Perhaps that's one way to describe the Astria family.

But Rie...

Referring to the daughter of the Emperor as an exploiter of the Empire? I couldn't help but chuckle at the absurdity.

"You two wouldn't understand..... The suffering of the common people. If you relinquished even a fraction of your privileges, hundreds, no, thousands of commoners could live in prosperity. But what do you do?"

Andrei spat out his words like a madman.

"How unfortunate! We should have eliminated all of you. Only then would the commoners have found happiness.....!"

He continued his rant.

"Someday, your kind will crumble before us. We, who bear the weight of a noble cause, will one day overthrow you!"

Well...

To some extent, I agree that nobles exploit the common people.

It's the nature of this world.

But what?

Do we have to die for the commoners to be happy?

Rather than assassinating corrupt nobles, he's attempting to kill students attending the Academy, all while claiming it's for the sake of the commoners?

There was no reason to listen to such nonsense.

"Rie, we don't need to listen. Let's go--"

As I attempted to tell Rie to leave, I glanced back.

Rie held a stone in her hand.

"Huh?"

Rie lightly pushed me aside with her hand and swung the stone as it was.

Thwack!!!

"Ack!!!"

The stone struck Andrei's head precisely, causing blood to gush out.

"Hurgh....."

The onlookers gasped at the sight.

Rie paid no heed to their reactions.

"Trying to justify your attempted assassination? You murderous bastard."

Despite her discerning eyes, Rie didn't conceal her nature and acted without hesitation.

"Motive? Justice? You're nothing more than a killer. No, not even that. You haven't taken anyone's life, so you're merely a lowly bug incapable of reaching the status of a murderer. You worthless bug."

She attempted to strike Andrei once again with another stone in her hand.

Immediately, Astina grabbed hold of Rie.

"Hey...."

"Let go! Someone like him deserves to be hit!"

Rie struggled while being restrained by Astina.

Andrei, a skilled knight, possessed a sturdy physique. He wouldn't die even if he were hit again.

He was still alive after taking Astina's attack, after all.

However, we need to intervene for Rie's image.

"Let me go!!"

"Rie, calm down...."

Astina, in an attempt to soothe Rie, led her away.

There might be some damage to Rie's image, but it was a somewhat gratifying act.

After a brief moment, individuals emerged from a distance, returning with several tied-up assassins.

"Rudy!"

Among them, Luna waved her hand at me.

So, Luna's group succeeded as well?

I smiled and waved back at Luna, my heart filled with joy.

1/4 Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 30: Midterm Camp (7)

"The Rebels, huh..."

Inside the central building, a middle-aged man listened to a report.

That man was McDowell Cliver, the headmaster of Liberion Academy.

As the face and representative of the academy, he had personally come to this place.

"Has the report been sent to the central authorities?"

In front of him stood the professor in charge of the midterm event.

"We've used a magic tool to send it immediately, and His Majesty the Emperor is aware. We informed him that Princess Rie is unharmed."

"It's fortunate that Astina acted quickly."

McDowell brought the coffee on his desk to his lips.

"By the way, Astina just made a few requests."

"Requests?"

"She asked if we could give her Andrei's sword, the ringleader of this incident."

McDowell shrugged nonchalantly.

"We can do that much. After all, it was Astina who caught him."

"Yes... I thought that wouldn't be a problem, but..."

"What else is there?"

McDowell casually took another sip of his coffee.

"She asked not to hand over Yeniel, one of the assassins and a student of the academy."

"An assassin?"

"She wants to use her as a double agent."

"A double agent..."

McDowell fell into brief contemplation.

He wondered if it would be possible.

If news of the captured Rebels had already reached the palace, the Rebels would be aware of it too.

Sending an assassin back to the Rebels so blatantly would surely arouse suspicion.

"Have you sent any other information about the assassins to the royal family?"

"No, nothing. We haven't even finished sorting out the situation yet, so we couldn't do that much."

After some deliberation, McDowell spoke.

"Call Astina and the assassin here. Let's hear their plan and decide."

"Understood. What will you do about the students now?"

The event wasn't entirely over.

There was an afterparty left.

However, it was unclear whether it should be held in this chaotic situation.

"I'll stay with the students."

"...You mean, Headmaster, you'll stay here?"

"Everyone must be tense and scared. Sending them back to the academy like this, they wouldn't be able to go on as normal. It would be better to laugh and chat with those who had the same experience here. I'll handle any unforeseen dangers."

"Understood."

The professor bowed to McDowell and left the room.

Luna spotted me waving my hand and hurried over.

"Rudy! Are you hurt anywhere? Where's Rie?"

She immediately scanned me for injuries and searched for Rie.

"Rie went with Astina for a moment."

"Then, nothing serious happened?"

I nodded with a faint smile at Luna's question.

"Thank goodness..."

Luna let out a sigh of relief.

She must have been very worried.

"Rudy, that's not fair."

"Huh?"

Luna put her hands on her hips and glared at me.

Her stance seemed to say, 'I'm mad at you!'

"You talked to Locke but didn't tell me anything!"

"Uh..."

"And you tried to handle such a dangerous situation alone!"

"..."

"You did wrong, didn't you?"

"Yeah..."

"Lower your head."

"Lower my head?"

Luna gestured with her fingers for me to bow my head.

I did as she asked, lowering my head.

Thump!

A gentle impact was felt on my head.

Luna had flicked my forehead with her small hand.

It wasn't painful, nor did it leave a bad feeling.

"You're getting one flick today. Next time, it'll be two. Be prepared. And..."

Her warm hand gently patted my head.

"You did well... I'm so glad you came back alive..."

I slightly raised my head and saw Luna smiling faintly.

"Rudy Astria."

Hearing someone call my name, I turned around.

Locke was approaching with Rie in tow.

She was still fuming.

"Are you still upset?"

I looked at Rie disdainfully.

"That guy should have been hit a few more times with a rock."

"He's going to be taken to the palace and tortured far worse than that.
What's the point of being so angry?"

Attempting to assassinate the princess and openly declaring themselves as rebels meant they would face severe torture.

It was only natural to eliminate the root once the sprout was discovered.

Though they weren't exactly the type to be easily uprooted.

"That's not my job. I want to be the one to beat him."

"Right..."

I also had some annoying feelings towards Andrei, but since he was going to die soon, I thought it didn't matter much.

During our conversation, Luna asked Rie a question.

"Rie, are you hurt anywhere?"

Luna examined Rie's body as if she were her mother.

"No, I'm not hurt, just a bit tired."

Normally, Rie would have brushed her off, but she seemed to like Luna, so she just gave her a faint smile while being inspected.

While we were chatting, a professor's voice could be heard from a distance.

"Attention, students!"

Behind the professor stood several student council members.

"We're truly sorry about this incident. Due to our negligence, this disgraceful event has occurred. We sincerely apologize."

The professor and student council bowed to us in apology.

"The situation has been resolved, and the headmaster has personally come to inspect the premises. There's no need to worry about your safety."

The professor continued.

"Accommodations and a banquet are provided inside the building. Those who are tired may return to their rooms to rest, while those who are hungry can proceed to the dining hall! If any students are injured, please head to the infirmary!"

It seemed the rebel situation had been somewhat resolved.

With the headmaster present, there was no need to worry too much.

If they thought there were still rebels nearby, they wouldn't let the students rest here; they'd send them back to the academy.

After the announcement, students gradually entered the building.

Once I saw people moving, I turned to Rie.

"Rie, do you want to go in and rest?"

Since she said she was tired, it seemed best for her to rest in her room. She had survived in the wild for five days and had been running around tense,

so she must have been exhausted.

However, her response was different.

"No!"

Her stomach growled.

Grasping her hungry stomach, Rie's eyes lit up as she declared,

"I'm going to eat."

After finishing our meal, we went outside to let our stomachs digest.

The sky had already darkened, leaving only the moonlight and the dim glow from the building.

"Ugh... I'm so full..."

"You should've eaten in moderation. Suddenly eating that much could make you sick."

Rie seemed to be in pain from overeating.

On the other hand, Luna's eyes sparkled with excitement.

"I... I've never eaten food like this before... I can't believe such dishes exist in this world..."

Luna was still reeling from the splendid feast.

She wasn't the only one.

I, too, secretly marveled at the meal.

I thought I was fed up with Western cuisine and needed to eat Korean food.

However, I was wrong.

I was tired of low-quality food, not Western cuisine.

The steak, salad, and stews had all been divine, melting in my mouth.

I experienced a sense of wonder for food I had never felt even in the modern world.

However, I couldn't show my amazement outwardly.

As a noble, I had to act as if I had tasted such food before.

"Oh, right!"

As we walked, Luna suddenly clapped her hands and stopped in her tracks.

"I have something to show you."

"Something to show?"

Upon my question, Luna nodded and quickly dashed to where she had left her bag.

She rumwizardd through the bag and pulled out a scroll.

"A scroll?"

Rie cocked her head at the sight.

Luna grinned and ran back to us, unfurling the scroll.

"Hehe... Ta-da!"

Rie and I scrutinized the scroll.

A square magic circle.

It looked similar to the one Luna had first created but was more intricate and featured a few additions.

"Hmm... Light magic, and... duplication..."

Rie slowly read the magic circle.

"I'll show you what it does! Sit down here!"

Luna told us to sit in front of a tree, then stepped back slightly.

She attempted to tear the scroll when Rie asked, her head tilted.

"...Is it okay to use a scroll like that?"

I somewhat agreed with her statement.

Considering Luna's financial situation, even though the scroll didn't appear too expensive...

I had been giving Luna a considerable amount of money for her research, but it still bothered me.

"It's a reward for our hard work!"

Luna cheerfully replied and tore the scroll.

Immediately, countless lights spread from the scroll.

The number of lights was incomparable to Luna's initial creation.

The lights dispersed around us and began to rise into the sky.

Like releasing lanterns, countless lights soared into the heavens.

"Wow..."

Rie couldn't help but marvel at the sight.

"Wow, what's that!"

"Whoa...!"

Similar sounds of admiration echoed from others who saw Luna's magic.

Luna quickly came to my side and gazed up at the sky, then asked me,

"Pretty, right?"

"...Yeah, it's beautiful."

The black sky, embroidered with colorful lights, was stunning.

The fatigue that had been building up seemed to dissipate as we watched.

We stared at the sky, lost in its beauty for several minutes.

A few minutes later...

Thump-

Rie, who had been gazing at the sky beside me, rested her head on my shoulder.

"What's up?"

I glanced sideways and saw Rie, snuggling closer.

"She must be really tired."

Luna smiled at the sight.

"Should we head in now?"

As I said that, I tried to carry Rie.

"Wait a moment!"

Luna reached out to me.

"...Why?"

"No, no! You can't do that! Not when a girl is sleeping!"

Luna stuttered out her words.

I was confused and glanced back and forth between Luna and Rie.

"What should we do, then?"

When I asked Luna, she hesitated and seemed to be deep in thought.

Finally, she made up her mind.

"I, I'll carry her!"

"...You?"

Rie was shorter than Luna.

She should be enough to carry her...

Well, if she wants to do it, no need to oppose her.

"Alright, go ahead."

"Y-Yes!"

Luna started walking with Rie on her back.

Her struggling figure was pitiful to watch.

Having carried Rie before, I knew she wasn't particularly heavy.

After watching Luna for a while, I opened my mouth.

"...Do you need help?"

"No! I... uh... can do it!"

And so, Luna carried Rie to the room, groaning under her weight every step of the way.

Heya! I made a change to Serina, I originally thought she was a 'spirit mage' but then realized she controlled 'elementals' so I think calling her an 'elementalist' is more appropriate.

Chapter 31: Midterm Camp (7)

It was a warm sunny weekend afternoon.

Some people were still sleeping, while others had left the academy to visit their homes, creating a relaxed atmosphere on campus.

During this peaceful time, a lively tea party was taking place.

"It must have been so frightening..."

Rie was drinking tea at the bakery with a few students.

Socializing.

With a forced smile, she spent her weekend afternoon drinking tea with people she wasn't particularly close to.

"Thanks to Astina senior, we were able to escape safely."

She recounted the incident from the midterm camp.

Even though a few days had already passed since the event, everyone listened intently.

Except for Rudy's group, the other students were immediately rescued by the student council and professors, so nothing major happened to them.

Therefore, the other students were unaware of what had transpired during the incident and eagerly listened to Rie's story.

"And that's how we managed to escape."

After sharing some details about the midterm camp, Rie brought up the main topic.

"By the way, aren't your parents worried about the incident?"

"Everyone is quite concerned. They even told me to return home once to show my face."

"Really? In that case..."

As Rie gestured, a servant standing behind her brought forward a box.

"What... is this?"

The students in front gaped at the sight before them.

"Ah~ I heard that many exquisite things came from the Lotein territory this time. So, I thought of offering this as a token of our friendship~. When you return to your respective territories, it would be nice to present this as a gift to your parents. It will alleviate their worries as well."

The students couldn't help but admire the gift.

Inside the box lay beautifully crafted rubies.

"Can we really accept these...?"

"Don't worry about it. Between us, these are just small gifts. Please, accept them without any burden."

Rie smiled as if it was no big deal, but her expression and inner thoughts were differed.

'How much are these worth... Sigh...'

Even Rie felt overwhelmed by the expensive jewels.

Nonetheless, she gave them away because the students in front of her belonged to noble families near the Handrei family's territory.

After the recent incident, the Handrei family claimed that Garwel's actions were solely his and had nothing to do with their family.

But how absurd was that?

Garwel had never left the family's territory since he was young and had only left it to attend the academy.

When could he have encountered the rebels?

'You think you can escape?'

No matter how much they tried to disassociate themselves from Garwel, their lies would eventually be exposed.

However, she remained silent due to the lack of evidence.

But it wouldn't be long until some was found, the Handrei family were just buying time.

But why?

Rie quickly figured it out.

The family head was trying to embezzle the assets and flee.

Rie became more certain when she heard about numerous merchants loitering around the Handrei territory.

So, Rie decided to apply pressure before they escaped.

The Handrei territory was at a considerable distance from the central region.

Thus, it was more efficient for the nearby lords to exert pressure rather than sending forces from the central area.

Rie smiled and looked at the students in front of her.

Once these students brought the rubies home, the nobles would understand the meaning behind them.

If they accepted the rubies and took no action...

Well, the lords receiving them would know the consequences better than anyone else.

"Well then~ I'll be counting on you~."

"Yes, of course!"

All of them replied, unable to take their eyes off the rubies she gave them.

Rie found their behavior pathetic, almost enough to make her sigh.

However, she swallowed her sigh for now and proceeded with the tea party as planned.

"Now, for today's dessert—."

"Excuse me..."

As Rie was about to speak with a smile, a servant bowed and whispered into her ear.

"Um... Young Master Rudy Astria is outside..."

"...Rudy?"

Rie paused to think for a moment before asking the employee.

"Why did he come?"

She had indeed mentioned that she would be having a tea party with some nobles at the bakery today.

She said they would chat after the tea party, but she didn't expect him to come here directly.

"I'm not sure... He said he would wait inside and come when you're finished..."

Hearing that, Rie contemplated for a moment before letting out a laugh.

She then turned to the students in front of her with a bright smile and said,

"I'll pack today's dessert for you separately~. Enjoy it at home~."

"...Eh?"

The students who had been seated in front of her looked at Rie with puzzled expressions.

It had been less than 30 minutes since the tea party had started.

Desserts hadn't been served yet, but the organizer was already telling them to go back to their rooms.

As everyone stared at Rie with bewildered faces, she feigned ignorance and smiled.

"Is there... a problem?"

Though her smile appeared sweet and innocent, her words carried a certain firmness.

"Ah... No! It's the weekend! It's better to rest in our rooms early!"

"Ha...ha...! Yes...yes, that's right!"

The students awkwardly laughed and agreed.

Rie, satisfied with their reactions, stood up from her seat.

"Well then, I'll leave it to you."

With that, she left the room.

Outside, she saw Rudy Astria admiring the desserts.

"Hey."

Rie called out to Rudy.

"...What? Weren't you in the middle of a tea party?"

Rudy looked at Rie with a puzzled expression.

"I just came out for a moment."

"No... I didn't mean for you to come out right away. I was planning to wait while enjoying some dessert."

Rudy held a few desserts in his hands.

"Then let's eat."

"What?"

Rie looked around and picked a few desserts for herself.

"The egg tarts here are delicious. You should try one too."

"...Really?"

Rie casually chose some desserts and handed them to Rudy.

"...What's going on?"

"Your treating. You're the one who wanted to meet, remember?"

"Didn't you say during the back then..."

Rie pretended not to know and made an innocent face.

"Huh? I don't know what you're talking about?"

Rudy sighed at her reaction.

"Fine, I'll buy it. How much is this...?"

"I'd like a coffee too~."

Rudy glanced at Rie for a moment, shook his head, and went to pay.

Despite his reaction, Rudy paid for the desserts Rie had given him and the coffee.

"You really do listen well."

Rie watched Rudy pay with a pleased expression.

After the incident at the midterm camp, Liberion Academy appeared peaceful on the surface, but turmoil was brewing within.

The main issue was the infiltration and assassination attempt by the rebels.

Although the incident occurred outside the academy, the criticism for the inadequate response was severe.

In contrast, Astina's reputation soared.

She received high praise for saving Rie and for effectively leading the student council to minimize injuries among the students.

Of course, this was only possible because I had whispered some advice to Astina.

Under the guise of apprehending the intruder, Astina had the student council patrol the area while she waited at the designated location I had disclosed.

The outcome was flawless.

The student council, strategically positioned, confronted the assassins and managed to hold their ground until the professors and teaching assistants arrived.

Astina received all the credit for this well-executed response.

"But it's become difficult to meet her."

I rested my chin on my hand.

Seeing Astina was challenging as she was busy meeting with the headmaster and various high-ranking individuals for the past few days.

Moreover, she seemed to be absent from the academy now.

"I hope everything went smoothly..."

I had entrusted two tasks to Astina.

One was to deliver Andrei's sword to Evan, and the other was to ensure Yeniel remained at the academy.

Obtaining Andrei's sword would be easy, but I wondered what had happened to Yeniel.

Lately, Yeniel hadn't been seen anywhere in the academy.

However, when I asked other students, they said Yeniel had been injured at the camp and was currently hospitalized.

The fact that the students didn't see Yeniel as an assassin was a positive sign.

I'd have to meet Astina to know the proper conclusion.

And after midterm camp ended, my life underwent some changes as well.

I began dedicating myself to the study of dark magic under the guidance of Professor Robert.

"Ah, you're here."

After class.

When I arrived at Professor Robert's office, I found him lying on a couch in his tracksuit.

"Are we continuing today as well?"

"Yes. If you're not up for it, just say so."

"No, it's not that."

I wasn't exactly learning dark magic.

- What do you believe is the fundamental aspect of dark magic?

- I'm not sure.

- The basis of dark magic is physical strength.

Upon hearing those words, I started running laps around the sports field.

Meanwhile, Professor Robert reclined under the sunlight, peacefully dozing off on the grass.

Initially, I assumed that Professor Robert had changed into his tracksuit to run alongside me, but he simply claimed that his suit was uncomfortable.

Although it felt somewhat unfair, I had no choice but to follow his instructions.

"Huff... huff..."

In this manner, I ran for two hours every day.

Although the exercise proved irksome at times, I found great satisfaction once it was over.

I had faced issues with my lack of physical strength, so I had intended to start exercising like this anyway.

And now, not only did this exercise benefit me, it also helped with my dark magic studies, and I was being personally trained by Professor Robert, killing two birds with one stone.

After some time had passed, I stopped jogging around the track and exhaled.

"Whew..."

As I wiped the sweat off my brow with my sleeve, Professor Robert spoke up.

"Since we have a visitor today, let's wrap it up here."

A visitor?

At Professor Robert's words, I turned to see Rie standing there.

Rie casually tossed a water bottle in my direction.

"Hey, catch."

The water bottle was filled with cool water.

"What's this for? You didn't have to do that."

"It's payback for the dessert you got me last time. And this."

Rie threw a bundle of papers at me.

"Astina says she's too busy to meet with you these days. This is a report of the current situation and how things are progressing written on it."

"Thanks."

I had asked her to arrange a meeting with Astina while buying her dessert, but I didn't expect a response so quickly.

I unfolded the papers Rie had given me.

In summary, everything was proceeding as planned.

Yeniel was able to attend the Academy as usual through a contract with Headmaster McDowell, and Andrei's sword was passed on to Evan.

It was presented as a reward for capturing Garwel.

Evan had been able to win because Luna and Locke had helped him, so he intended to pass the sword on to them.

However, Luna and Locke received separate rewards and so he finally accepted the sword.

"Hmm..."

Rie stared intently at me as I wiped my sweat.

She scrutinized me, assessing me from head to toe.

"Why are you giving me that look?"

Rie cupped her chin and continued to examine me.

"Your physique isn't as impressive as I imagined."

"Well, what do you expect from a wizard?"

After observing me for a while, Rie turned around.

"I've delivered the message. I'm heading off now."

"Alright. Take care."

I waved at Rie as she walked away.

Heya! I made a change to Serina, I originally called her a 'spirit mage' but then realized she controlled 'elementals' so I think calling her an

Elementalist is more appropriate.

Chapter 32: A Cup of Tea (2)

Luna was studying in the library with Riku and Ena.

Ever since the midterm camp concluded, the library had been partially repaired and made accessible to the students once again.

So Luna returned to her usual routine of studying in the library with her friends but there was one noticeable absence—Rudy.

Due to his recent rigorous training under the guidance of Professor Robert, Rudy hadn't been able to join them in their studies.

Luna couldn't help but feel a twinge of disappointment, but she found solace in the fact that they still ate together every day.

"Ugh..."

As the hours ticked by, Luna's hunger began to gnaw at her, causing her to yawn and glance at the time.

Ena, noticing her restlessness, also checked the clock and spoke up.

"Shall we head to dinner now?"

Luna nodded wearily, her stomach rumbling in agreement.

Ena gently nudged Riku, who had been dozing off, to awaken her from her slumber.

"Uh...hmm?"

Riku, still groggy, looked around in confusion as she raised her head.

"Awaaaaahh... What's happening?"

Ena explained with a smile, "Let's go grab dinner."

Surprised, Riku glanced at the time and exclaimed, "Oh... Is it already that late? I haven't even started my assignment..."

"That's because you doze off as soon as the lecture begins," Ena chided, voicing her dissatisfaction.

Riku, now wearing a gloomy expression, responded, "Heu... I feel so sleepy..."

Luna peered at the book spread out before Riku and asked, "Is this the assignment for the political science lecture?"

Riku sighed and replied, "Yeah... I don't know anyone in the class, so I'm completely lost..."

"If you paid attention during the lectures, this wouldn't have been an issue," Ena remarked.

Riku's expression grew even more forlorn, and she lamented, "It's not my fault... It's the professor's fault... I can't understand a single thing, no matter how much I try to listen..."

Ena, slightly exasperated, retorted, "Then why don't you ask the professor for clarification during the lecture?"

"Ena! You don't understand!" She objected, standing up abruptly to express her disagreement.

"What don't I understand?"

"Only those who possess some knowledge can ask questions! Those who truly don't know anything can't even formulate the right questions! In order to ask questions, I'd have to admit from the start that I don't understand, but I can't bring myself to do that! No, it's fundamentally wrong! If he were a professor worth his salt, he would explain things in a slow and easily

understandable manner for the students. But instead, they always assume that we know what they know! And then..."

Riku's anger stemmed from the difficulty of the assignment, but it spiraled into a discussion about the fundamental attitude a professor should adopt.

Ena understood it all too well—Riku needed someone to direct her resentment towards.

"Uh... This seems familiar," Luna remarked, her eyes focused on Riku's book as she read it slowly.

"Do you want me to help you after dinner? It's a different subject, but it seems similar to what I've studied," Luna suggested.

"Really...? Luna!!! You're my savior!" Riku exclaimed, rushing towards Luna and enveloping her in a tight embrace, her face nestled against Luna's chest.

Ena sighed at the sight before her. "Luna, don't spoil her too much. You already helped her with the magic theory homework last time."

"Hehe..."

"Let's go eat first," Ena suggested.

"Alright~," Riku replied, her voice filled with excitement.

"Ah, by the way, Rudy said he'll join us for dinner today, so I'll go and get him," Luna added.

"Okay, we'll be waiting for you in front of the restaurant," Ena confirmed.

With that settled, Luna prepared to head elsewhere.

"Oh, Luna."

"Hm?"

"You seem to be getting along well with Rudy these days, don't you think?" Ena asked, catching Luna off guard with her sudden question.

Luna's face turned a shade of red, her eyes darting around in confusion. "W-Well?"

Ena raised an eyebrow.

"I-I don't know what you're talking about???? I-I'll go and find Rudy quickly! Ah!"

And just like that, Luna dashed off in the direction she was originally heading.

"Hmm..." Ena mused, watching Luna's hasty departure. "I'm genuinely concerned..."

She stroked her chin, deep in thought. When she had heard that Rudy and Luna had formed a team for the midterm camp, she had anticipated progress in their relationship.

Yet, there had been no news at all.

Ena recalled Luna preparing a magic circle to show Rudy and heard about her showcasing it during the conclusion of the camp.

And yet, nothing seemed to have changed. Or was it possible that there were changes, but they were simply going unnoticed? or maybe in places far from her eyes?

She quickly dismissed the thought.

Ena knew that Luna and Rudy Astria weren't like that.

"Will they work out...?" Ena mused quietly to herself.

With Luna's shy demeanor and Rudy's singular focus on magic, progress was akin to hiking up a mountain.

Grrr-

"Ah... I'm hungry," Riku absentmindedly muttered to herself.

Ena felt her temper flare at this sight.

Whack!

"Ouch!"

Ena's anger got the better of her, prompting her to deliver a swift smack to Riku's head.

"What... what's the matter!" Riku exclaimed, rubbing the spot where she had been hit.

Staring back at Riku, her innocent victim, she shouted, "You've been receiving all this help from Luna, and this is how you behave!"

"...?????"

Riku's eyes filled with question marks as she gazed at Ena, utterly bewildered.

Unaware of the situation, Riku could only feel wronged.

"It should be around here..."

Luna made her way toward the sports field, scanning her surroundings. In the distance, she spotted Rudy engaged in a series of push-ups, in exercise attire.

While his upper body was covered by a white short-sleeved tee, it was drenched in sweat, revealing his physique.

"Hmm... Hmm!"

Luna turned her head away, her cheeks reddening. "No... Why, why should I feel embarrassed...!"

After all, Rudy was simply exercising in an open sports field, where anyone could witness his actions. There was no reason for her to avert her gaze.

Reaching this realization, Luna sneakily turned her head and stole another glance at Rudy.

"Oh..."

Luna found herself captivated, her gaze fixed on Rudy.

Observing him focused on his exercise routine presented a completely different image compared to when she saw him studying.

"I... I should stop staring."

Shaking herself out of her reverie, Luna regained her composure and attempted to approach Rudy.

As Luna descended the stairs to approach Rudy, she noticed a set of clothes and a water bottle left nearby. It was a training top, and judging by the color, it was likely Rudy's.

"...."

An overwhelming impulse surged within upon seeing the top.

However, her rationality held her back.

This wasn't right.

There were boundaries to respect.

She absolutely could not.

And so, Luna's sense of right and wrong battled within her, like an angel and devil in eternal conflict.

I finished my push-ups and stood up.

Is it almost time to wrap up?

Just as the thought crossed my mind, Professor Robert approached me.

"Let's call it a day. Your friend is here," Professor Robert informed me.

At his indication, I looked in the direction he pointed. In the distance, I spotted a figure sitting on the stairs.

Ah... I had made dinner plans with Luna.

Though the wall next to the staircase obscured her figure, I could see her brown hair fluttering—it was likely Luna.

"Thank you for your guidance."

"Alright. You can go."

I bid farewell to Professor Robert and made my way towards Luna.

"Luna, have you been waiting long...?"

"Eeek!!!"

As I approached the staircase and began speaking to Luna, she let out a startled scream.

"You scared me..."

Observing Luna, I noticed she was clutching my clothes, her face flushed as red as a beet.

".....Did you see?" Luna asked, her eyes welling up with tears.

What was she talking about? Why was she acting this way?

".....See what?"

"N-No... No! Nothing! Really! It's nothing!"

"So, what's 'nothing'..." I questioned, perplexed by Luna's behavior.

What on earth was she referring to?

"Didn't you come for dinner?"

I posed the question, to which Luna nodded vigorously.

"Y-Yes! That's right! We should go have dinner! You must be hungry after your workout!"

Luna hastily rose from her seat, and I extended my hand toward her.

"Uh, uh, uh?"

"I'll take the clothes. I took them off during the workout, so they might have a bit of a smell..."

Since I had removed my clothes halfway through the workout, it was likely that they were slightly sweaty.

They wouldn't be too damp, but they might still have a slight smell, so I offered to hold them.

However, Luna's response was a little unusual.

"Smell! Ah, ah ah....."

".....?"

I stared at Luna with a puzzled expression.

Her face turned red once again, and she seemed flustered, her eyes darting around.

...?

When I reached out my hand again, Luna snapped back to her senses and handed me the clothes.

"H-Here....."

I took the clothes, tilting my head slightly in confusion.

"Let's go have dinner."

Casually, I put on the clothes Luna had handed me.

"Hmm?"

However, instead of my usual scent, I noticed a different fragrance coming from the clothes.

It smelt like Luna...

As I instinctively sniffed the clothes, Luna's eyes widened in surprise.

"Don't... Don't smell me!!!"

Suddenly, Luna tried to stop me from sniffing.

"Ah... it's my clothes, though?"

"Don't smell them anyway!"

Luna grabbed my clothes and shook them vigorously.

"Shower! Go shower! Change your clothes!!!"

"...Won't the others be waiting?"

"Uh... Uh-uh....."

Upon hearing my words, Luna's pupils shook.

"Alright, I won't smell it. Let's eat first; the others must be waiting."

"Ah... Okay."

Luna nodded, agreeing with me.

"Hmm....."

A voice came from behind, I turned and saw Professor Robert.

Professor Robert furrowed his brows as he observed us.

"What are you staring at....."

"It's nothing. Keep it up."

Professor Robert nodded a few times and began walking away.

What was he talking about?

"Shall we go now?"

"Y-yeah, let's."

We made our way towards the cafeteria, where Ena and Riku were sitting on a bench.

"Why are you guys so late?" Riku asked as soon as she spotted us.

Late?

Had Luna been waiting for a long time while I was exercising?

Feeling apologetic, I glanced at everyone.

"By the way, did you come straight here after exercising? You're filthy. You should have showered."

Riku complained.

Was that so?

Well, I did work up a sweat.

"So, shall I shower first?"

"No! We came all this way, let's eat together!"

Luna stopped me as I attempted to leave.

"Yeah, since we've already waited, let's eat first, and then you can shower. You don't seem to smell that much," Ena said, smiling.

Upon hearing that, Riku approached me and took a sniff.

"Hmm?"

"Rikuuuuuuuuu!"

As soon as Riku got close to me and sniffed, Luna rushed towards me in surprise.

Luna swiftly picked up Riku, who was near me, and moved her away.

Then Riku, clinging to Luna, started sniffing Luna's scent.

"What's going on?"

Riku had a confused expression on her face.

"Why?"

Eyes gleaming, Riku asked,

"Why does he smell like you.....uh!"

Luna quickly covered Riku's mouth.

"...Shall we go eat then?"

"Mmm!! Mmmmmmm!!!!"

Luna walked away, still keeping her hand over Riku's mouth.

"...?"

I smell like Luna?

I sniffed my clothes once again.

There was a faint trace... but...

I thought it was a mistake earlier, but looks like it wasn't.

Could it be because Luna had held onto me earlier?

Lost in thought, I felt a hand on my shoulder.

Turning to the side, I saw Ena smiling like a proud father.

"Our Luna! Take good care of her!"

With those parting words, Ena hurried after Luna.

Then she called out to Riku.

"Riku! You're useful after all!"

"...???"

Still perplexed, I followed them, trying to make sense of their conversation.

Should've mentioned it but I updated Rika's name to Riku. Didn't realize it'd be that noticable.

4/4! That's all for the week. Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 33: A Cup of Tea (3)

A carriage was making its way towards the Academy.

Within the carriage sat Astina, who had just finished her duties among the nobility and was now returning.

"The academy is the most comforting place at the moment."

Astina's face showed signs of weariness due to exhaustion.

After the incident during the midterm camp, Astina attracted significant attention, leading to a very tiring schedule.

She had discussed the incident with esteemed nobles and even received personal words of gratitude from the emperor.

Now, not only did she hold a prominent position within the academy, but she had also established a firm footing in central politics.

There was nothing left for Astina to fear.

Having accumulated such remarkable accomplishments, it was only a matter of time before she inherited the title of viscount.

Through her visits to various territories in the central area, Astina had laid the groundwork necessary for her to succeed as the head of the household.

The retainers of the Persia family, had changed their stance to support her due to the incident and the accumulation of achievements over time.

All the preparations had been completed.

"Ugh..."

Having accomplished so much, Astina felt utterly drained.

"Politics is truly exhausting."

Astina grumbled in frustration.

However, she couldn't relax now.

Only by enduring such arduous tasks and giving her all could she secure her position as the head of the viscount's household.

"There shouldn't be any problems."

Astina thought of Rudy Astria and couldn't help but smile.

It was all thanks to Rudy Astria.

After all, it was he who provided all the intel during the incident.

That young man possessed extraordinary abilities.

An immense wealth of information.

The same was true during Luna's library incident and now during the midterm camp.

During Luna's incident, his judgment may have been based on Luna's magic book.

However, during the midterm camp, Yeniel attempted to assassinate Astina.

With that alone, Rudy had deduced the entire situation.

It's not something an ordinary person could do in such a limited space and with such little information.

Naturally, questions arose.

How much does he know?

However, she didn't pry.

Everyone had secrets and their own private lives.

She was simply grateful that he was on her side.

"We'll be arriving soon."

"Okay."

Astina replied to the coachman with a smile.

After finishing my classes, I began tidying up my books. After quickly organizing them, I prepared to head to lunch.

"Rudy Astria."

Just as I was about to step out of the classroom to search for Luna, I heard my name being called.

"Hmm?"

Turning towards the voice, I saw Locke standing there.

It was a bit puzzling since Locke, who usually had little to no interaction with me.

"What is it?"

While we had grown closer during the midterm camp, we didn't have many chances to interact at the academy.

Since we were in different departments, there was no reason to see each other unless it involved Rie, and neither of us seemed interested in becoming close friends.

"Astina senior is looking for you."

"Astina? She's back?"

"She's currently in the student council room with Princess Rie. You should go see her."

"Is that so?"

I was about to make my way there when I realized something.

If I went straight to the student council room, Luna would be waiting for me, wouldn't she?

Since we always had lunch together, she would probably be looking for me.

I stared intently at Locke.

"...What?"

Hmm...

After a moment's thought, I figured out a use for Locke.

"Hey, could you do me a favor?"

Upon hearing my request, Locke furrowed his brows.

"If it's something similar to what you asked at the camp, I decline."

"No, it's a simple task."

Locke glared at me before speaking.

"What is it?"

"Could you please inform Luna that I might not be able to join her for lunch?"

A messenger.

Locke was the perfect candidate for such a role.

"Ah, Rudy Astria. You've arrived?"

"Why are you so late?"

Upon entering the student council room, I was greeted by Astina and Rie.

Rie's words had a slightly different undertone, but I accepted it as her unique way of showing hospitality.

"Did you handle everything well?"

Astina responded with a pleasant smile.

"Perfectly."

Seeing Astina in such high spirits brought me relief.

"Take a seat for now and have some tea."

Astina gestured towards the tea set on the desk.

I settled down and spoke.

"So, what comes next?"

"Now that the groundwork has been laid, it's merely a matter of executing the plan."

Astina's plan.

It was simple but challenging.

To overthrow her older brother, the current heir of the Persia family.

Replacing someone who had already established themselves in that position was no easy feat.

"Do you think you can do it?"

"We'll simply have to try. If it doesn't work out, we'll need to explore other avenues."

Though she said that, it seemed like she had received favorable responses from the noble families.

The process of becoming an heir varied from family to family, but there was a common element in most cases.

If the head of the family and the vassal families supported a particular heir, it was sufficient. There was no need for further competition.

While some families adhered to certain traditions, this approach was prevalent in most cases.

"Soon, the other families will propose the idea to my father—to change the heir."

Astina's family, the Persia family, had already chosen an heir.

To alter such a decision, they needed the surrounding vassals.

I believed that Astina had handled it well, so it didn't seem like something I needed to worry about.

Besides, there was no part where I could offer assistance.

However, there was a concern.

Astina was still in her second year at the academy.

Although she surpassed the average abilities of third-year students and seemed to be on par with a teacher's assistant.

The timing is much faster than any of us anticipated.

The dilemma lay in whether it was the right time for Astina to assume control of the family.

Originally, Astina was meant to take over a bit later.

However, we've accelerated the process greatly.

I couldn't help but worry about the potential side effects of Astina inheriting the family at an earlier stage.

But it'd be a waste to go against the natural flow of events.

This opportunity really couldn't get much better.

So, I came to a conclusion.

I would support Astina in inheriting the family and we'd have to use her newfound authority to take care of any resulting uncertainties.

With the authority of the dukedom at her disposal, it would be much easier to address any unpredictable circumstances.

"And, as you've likely heard from Rie, I've taken care of everything concerning Evan."

"Ah, thank you."

There was a reason why Astina needed to grow stronger.

Astina never questioned my actions.

She had doubts, but she refrained from voicing them.

She simply acted as I requested.

I wasn't sure whether to label this trust or something else, but it certainly created a comfortable dynamic between us.

I wasn't sure if Astina's compliance stemmed from trust or just favorable circumstances, but it worked in my favor nonetheless.

Thus, I could freely manipulate the situation as I saw fit.

While I knew I would need the help of others to steer the story in the best direction, not everyone would be as accommodating.

I needed to empower Astina and make the utmost use of her capabilities.

"Shall we proceed to the main point now?"

"...The main point?"

Hadn't we been discussing the main point already?

It seemed important enough.

Astina crossed her legs and spoke up.

"You were already anticipating this much, weren't you?"

Astina flashed a sly smile.

She wasn't mistaken.

Astina wouldn't let such an opportunity slip by. Her abilities spoke for themselves.

So, what was the main point?

I felt a sense of unease.

Had I missed something?

I honestly thought there were no major issues so far.

Although my actions had slightly altered the plot, the overall framework remained unchanged.

I still hold the second seat, and I've dealt with the incidents in a similar manner.

Could the concern revolve around Evan?

Since I haven't had a proper conversation with him, I don't know if he views me as a rival.

However, if he sees me diligently studying,

Wouldn't he perceive me as a contender?

In that case, Evan would also strive to secure the first seat.

I believed there wouldn't be a major problem since I handed Evan the sword of Andrei, which he was supposed to obtain this time.

"So, what is the main point?"

I asked, still feeling tense.

But the answer I received left me dumbfounded.

"Will you continue with the Student Council?"

"The Student Council?"

I stared at Astina, caught off guard by her sudden question.

"I helped you, didn't I? During the midterm camp."

"Didn't you also benefit thanks to that, Senior Astina....."

I had no intention of continuing with the Student Council.

Didn't we make a promise?

To help only until the conclusion of the midterm camp.

I didn't need to be in the student council since we had already formed an alliance.

Moreover, with Professor Robert's training occupying my schedule, adding the responsibilities of the Student Council would be too much.

"Well, I guess there's no other option."

Astina glanced at Rie, her lips curving into a smile.

Rie silently sipped her tea.

"Hm?"

I shifted my gaze between the two.

What was this ambiguous atmosphere?

As I stood there confused, Astina smiled and spoke.

"If you don't continue with the student council, Rie said she would join instead."

"...Rie said that?"

When I turned my attention to Rie, she was sitting quietly, fixated on her teacup, serenely savoring her drink.

"Honestly, you're more fun, but I thought this situation could also be fun, so I decided to do it this way."

Astina beamed at me.

Upon hearing that, Rie set her teacup down.

"Well, if that's the case, I should be going."

"Why? Won't you join us for lunch? Rudy Astria seems to have a lot of questions, doesn't he?"

Rie's brows furrowed slightly as she glanced at me.

"It's a matter of life and death."

With those brief words, Rie opened the door.

Just as Rie was about to depart, she stopped in her tracks.

From outside, a familiar voice reached our ears.

"Oh! Rie! Hello!"

"Huh...what?"

"Hm?"

I turned my gaze toward the entrance, and there stood a familiar brunette.

"Luna?"

When I called out her name, Luna peered inside.

"Oh, Rudy, are you finished? Then let's go and eat!"

"Luna Railer?"

Upon hearing Astina's words, Luna appeared somewhat taken aback.

"Oh, hello."

Astina regarded Luna, then spoke up.

"Who's behind you?"

Behind?

From my vantage point, the door obscured my view of the figure behind Luna.

Who could be standing there?

I slightly inclined my head to catch a glimpse.

And there, behind her, a girl with blue hair came into sight.

Someone who shouldn't be here.

In the game, her nickname was Stray Cat.

The top elementalist among the first-year students.

It was Serina Rinsburg.

"What are you thinking, bringing her here?!"

...I nearly shouted.

Her sudden appearance caught me off guard.

She should never get involved with us.

She exclusively associates with Evan, never mingling with others.

Someone who should remain detached from everyone else.

That was Serina Rinsburg.

This is giving me a headache.

As we silently observed Serina, Luna spoke up, perplexed.

"Um... I saw Serina eating her lunch alone on a bench, then all of her food was taken by animals... so I felt sorry for her...."

It wasn't that her food was stolen, but rather she likely shared it with the animals...

One of the most important conditions for a elementalist is their affinity with nature.

In this sense, Serina's act of sharing food and bonding with the animals was to increase her affinity with nature.

As I found myself clutching my head, unable to utter a word, Astina summed up the situation.

"Well, this is fate as well. Let's all go and eat together."

"I won't...."

"Huh?"

Rie was about to protest, but her eyes met Luna's.

Unable to continue her sentence while gazing into Luna's innocent eyes, Rie let out a sigh.

"Sigh... let's eat somewhere other than the school cafeteria...."

Rie reluctantly gave in and sought a compromise.

Of course, I agreed with her.

I wanted to eat somewhere that wouldn't draw attention.

The student council president, the princess, the top elementalist...

Such an unbelievable combination.

If anyone caught sight of us, rumors would circulate for weeks like wildfire.

We needed to find a restaurant without people...

"Ah, right."

I just remembered a restaurant that people rarely visited.

A place with great food, too.

Robert engaged in small talk with Cromwell before he leisurely made his way to have lunch.

Since Professor Cromwell was too 'noble' to eat at a shabby restaurant, he walked alone to 'that restaurant.'

"Hmm...?"

As he neared the rundown establishment he often visited, he caught snippets of noise.

It was unusual to hear someone else's voice in a place where he was the sole regular customer.

Curiosity piqued, Robert pushed open the door to the restaurant.

"...How do you even eat this?!"

"Hmm... Its rather delicious."

Upon glancing inside, Robert spotted familiar faces.

"Why are you all here?"

Rudy Astria, Luna Railer, Princess Rie, and the others who spent time with Rudy Astria—they were all present.

One of them was a face Robert hadn't seen before, but he paid little attention to that.

The fact that there were so many people proved more bothersome.

And on top of that, one man amidst a group of women...

"Oh, Professor, hello."

As the spokesperson, Rudy Astria greeted Robert.

Robert acknowledged the greeting and rubbed his temples.

"...I have a headache."

What exactly is he doing?

It was surprising enough to witness him alternating between Princess Rie and Luna Railer during workouts, but this... This was something else.

He thought he should finish teaching Rudy magic as quickly as possible and avoid getting involved.

1/4! New update of the site is up and is looking pretty stable not bad. Ads are working... kind of... something to fix as usual but I'll be posting chappies for the weekend and work on that next week.

I haven't completed reviewing all the ads but I have completed the first few hundred, please remove ad block for this site. Google does a good job in making sure they're not harmful. I'll be looking out for these as well.

No popups and I'm blocking some are that too inappropriate or stupid or oogly(disturbing). Like that one webtoon one where there's usually a girl going "Wow it's so big." or this one dental one. Was gross.

Oh last thing, for people who didn't see my message last chap, I changed Rika to Riku. It was actually Riku the very first time, I'm not sure when I accidentally called her Rika and it just somehow stuck.

I'm going to stick with Riku but in the future I'll leave small stuff like that be since it really doesn't matter.

Sorry for the long note. Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 34: Homecoming Day (1)

After returning to my room, I flopped onto the bed and muttered to myself.

"I cannot shake this feeling of unease..."

Serina Rinsburg.

The daughter of the esteemed Royal Head Elemental, possessing an overwhelming power in the early stages of the story.

But why does she wield such formidable power early on?

The answer lies in the nature of elemental magic.

Magic, in its entirety, demands numerous elements such as comprehension to understand concepts and one's responsiveness to mana.

All these factors were not entirely related to talent.

Certain aspects can be compensated for through diligent effort or financial means.

Naturally, a modicum of talent is essential for such growth, but the majority of individuals possess that minimum threshold.

Yet, when it came to elemental magic, the dynamics changed.

For elementalists, talent was everything.

A prodigious elemental wizard can be distinguished from an average one from birth.

This is because elemental affinity, paramount to an elementalist, is determined from the beginning.

Elemental affinity denotes the degree to which an elementalist can establish contracts with elemental beings.

Should one possess low affinity, summoning an elemental becomes an insurmountable challenge.

With high affinity, it is the opposite.

Of course, summoning high-ranking elementals necessitates a sufficient mana pool to accommodate.

So high affinity is merely one of the requirements.

Elemental affinity doesn't change much no matter how hard you try.

Living in places like forests and getting along with animals could increase affinity.

However, it only gave slight improvements at most.

Moreover, investing substantial sums of money never gave returns of the same value.

Rather than trying to increase affinity, it is more common to explore methods of optimizing the utilization of the elementals already under one's command.

In that regard, Serina possessed an extraordinary aptitude.

Since birth, she exhibited a remarkable affinity for elemental magic, enabling her to summon high-ranking elementals as long as she had the necessary mana.

"The story will start soon."

However, the fact that Serina was a bully in the early stages did not help us.

Rather, it was a headache.

Because she was the boss of the story that was about to start.

The story that was swiftly approaching—Homecoming Day.

Homecoming Day was an occasion where alumni returned to the academy, fostering a gathering of graduates and current students where they enjoyed various festive activities.

However, there was a problem with this event.

The entry of outsiders into the academy.

Although they were academy graduates, from the moment of graduation, they were practically strangers.

Moreover, most of these graduates hailed from esteemed backgrounds, inevitably bringing along entourages and escorts, expanding the influx of outsiders.

While it was true that only those with valid connections were granted entry, the event still rendered the academy's security vulnerable.

The watchful eyes of the academy's guards were divided, and their focus diverted away from the students while their attention was focused on the outsiders.

Thus, Serina saw an opportunity at this moment.

The Elemental Sword, Priscilla.

Within its hilt resided a special elemental—an ice elemental named Priscilla.

However, there was a hidden truth about Priscilla.

Priscilla had once been under the control of Serina's mother.

In short, after Serina's mother's demise, Priscilla went berserk, and the sword was used to seal her.

Now, the sword resided within the academy, serving as a subject of research.

This was the precise reason behind Serina's entry into the academy.

She sought to steal the sword, release Priscilla, and form a contract with her.

Of course, this was not the only way to encounter Priscilla.

An alternative approach involved pursuing a career as a researcher devoted to the study of Priscilla, a path accessible only after completing the academy's curriculum.

However, Serina opted not to spend her time in that manner.

Her choice was driven by the desire to free Priscilla at the earliest opportunity.

"Well, Evan will handle it anyway..."

This matter was one that Evan had to confront on his own.

A significant event unfolded on Homecoming Day.

The saint graced the academy with their presence, imparting a prophecy regarding the academy's future.

It is given to the Student Council President.

Homecoming Day began this way.

There were several prophecies.

One of which urged caution regarding Serina.

Thus, Astina promptly relayed this information to others.

People from the academy start looking for Serina, but in the end, it is Evan who finds Serina.

Evan meets Serina like this, fights with her, and eventually wins.

There were various stories in the process, but they were not particularly important.

The prophecy concerning Serina was the only one worth paying attention to.

Many interpreted it as a warning that Serina sought to steal Priscilla.

But in fact, that was not the case.

It was just that the timing coincided well, the warning to be careful of Serina had a different meaning.

It was actually unrelated to it.

"I hope I won't need to intervene this time...."

If the story goes as it is, there was no part where I had to step in.

I might have to exert some effort when an incident related to the prophecy arises later, but there was nothing for me related to this incident itself.

The only possibility would be checking whether Evan could beat Serina or not?

But, I didn't think I really needed to do that either.

From the rumors about Evan, it seemed that he was growing well.

"I need some rest...."

I've been working hard, so I can take a break for one story, can't I?

In this incident, I'm never even mentioned, so I think I can stay still.

"Besides."

I rose from the bed and settled into the chair.

My gaze fell upon the desk, where a lone book lay.

The magic book of Levian that Luna had given me.

"I guess it's time to start using it?"

This tome held significance in itself, but the spells contained within held great importance as well.

A compendium of a royal wizard's lifetime, it possessed a wealth of extraordinary knowledge.

Amongst its pages, what I would take were the dark magics that had not been revealed to the world.

The unexplored realm of dark magic resided within these pages.

Mainly dwelling in the shadows, dark magic had long been stigmatized as an art practiced solely by villains.

As a result, individual practitioners guarded their findings closely.

The dark magic that Levian researched, were in this book.

However, these spells were not solely reliant on the confines of the magic circle.

Magic circles served as instruments of modification, granting alterations to magic you can use.

For example, in the case of the magic circle that Luna used last time, it was a magic circle that gave a modification to the light magic.

There was a normal magic, Light, which could be used normally, and that magic was transformed through a magic circle.

Pondering my next course of action, I clasped the magic book in my hands.

"Should I show this to Professor Robert....."

I've been observing Robert for several weeks.

He struck me as a reliable individual.

Though he appeared lazy in most matters, he was more diligent than anyone in his research on dark magic.

I didn't see any significant issues in terms of his character.

Also, I could tell that Robert, despite his constant complaints to the people around him, cared for them.

He treated Professor Cromwell well, and he seemed to be on friendly terms with the old lady at the shabby restaurant.

"But just in case....."

Even though I thought he was a good person, I figured there's nothing wrong with being cautious.

I decided to show him just one magic circle before showing him this magic book.

I opened the magic book Luna gave me and pulled out a piece of paper.

Then I began to draw the magic that Luna had failed at in the library last time, using the paper beside me as a reference.

I didn't have to draw it perfectly, just showing the general idea would be enough.

"...It's more challenging than I anticipated."

However, it was nearly impossible for me, who lacks artistic skills, to draw it perfectly.

The main pattern itself was complicated, becoming more so for higher level magic.

"Um....."

After roughly tracing the pattern, I scrutinized the paper.

A sincere realization struck me: proficient drawing skills were essential for a wizard who relied primarily on magic circles.

"But...isn't it somewhat similar?"

I looked at the magic circle in the magic book and the one I drew.

It might be a bit skewed, but it was somewhat similar.....

The next day, I visited Professor Robert's office and handed him the paper.

Robert stared at the paper intently before asking me,

"What is this?"

I responded calmly,

"It's a magic circle."

Robert took the paper, looked at it for a moment, and handed it back to me.

After that, he held it up to the sunlight, shook it back and forth.

I stared at Professor Robert's strange behavior.

"What are you doing....."

".....Isn't it a code?"

"It's a standard magic circle. Frequently used on scrolls for practical applications."

"....."

Professor Robert took the paper and made his way toward his desk.

Without a second thought, he discarded the paper into the wastebasket nearby.

"What kind of magic circle is this? What do you think a magic circle is?"

".....I put effort into drawing it."

I did my best.

I tried my best to replicate it, but my drawing skills were lacking.

"Even a seven-year-old child could draw better than this. How do you manage to draw magic circles in Magic Theory class?"

"Hmm..."

Initially, I attempted to draw them myself, but as the tasks grew more complex, I began relying on Luna's help.

Since Magic Theory class covers more than just magic circles, opportunities to practice drawing them were limited.

Besides, my intention wasn't to study magic using magic circles, so I sought help wherever I could.

To be honest, I only drew them for the sake of submission, and Luna would then redraw them for me.

Whenever I thought I had done a decent job and was about to submit it, Luna would always reject it.

Like a caring mother who redoes her child's drawing during an assessment, she would take over and create a new one for me.

I felt sorry for constantly burdening Luna, but according to her, it didn't take much time since she was merely copying an existing magic circle.

Observing her recreate my magic circle in less than 10 minutes, I had to admit she was right.

After discarding the paper, Robert seated himself on the sofa and inquired,

"So, what is this? What kind of magic is it?"

"I'm not entirely sure myself."

When I admitted that, Professor Robert gave me a disbelieving look.

"...Did you just give me a circle from your imagination?"

"No, it's a real magic circle that exists."

"But why don't you know? If you saw it in a book, there should be an explanation."

How should I explain this...

After pondering for a while, I made up my mind.

"I'll return another time."

"...Alright."

With that, I departed from Professor Robert's office and made my way to the library.

All I needed to do was show Luna the magic book and ask her to draw it for me.

I just checked but my 3 novels are #3, #13, #14 weekly and not that far off monthly. It's much higher than I thought it would be...

Is it because of regular updates? I think that's the biggest difference when I checked the other novels out. Pretty interesting, I'm only reading Genius Warlock, Instant kill and recently Damn Reincarnation. Those all have regular updates so I never realised.

Oh and Surviving the Game as a Barbarian. But thats on an official reading app, a little different I think.

2/4 Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 35: Homecoming Day (2)

The wind blew, carrying the fragrance of blooming white lilies with it. The sweet scent wafted through the garden and gently permeated the mansion through the open windows.

The elegant white mansion stood adorned with vibrant lilies, presenting a picturesque sight.

Amidst this scene, a carriage made its way towards the mansion.

Prominently engraved on the carriage was the lily emblem, representing the Astria family.

"We have arrived," declared the coachman as a man descended from the carriage.

It was Ian Astria, the eldest son of the Astria family.

Stepping out of the carriage, he was greeted by a middle-aged man who emerged from the white mansion.

Every step the middle-aged man took exuded a dignified air. He was Perrian Astria, Rudy's father and the head of the Astria family.

Perrian cast a stern gaze at Ian, yet his words were laced with warmth.

"Son, it has been some time since I last laid eyes on you."

"I apologize, Father. The recent Rebel issues have made it difficult for me to visit the territory," Ian replied.

Perrian offered a faint smile as he regarded his son. Then, gesturing towards the mansion, he suggested, "Let us go inside and have a meal."

The two entered the mansion and engaged in conversation over a meal, discussing recent events.

"By the way, have you heard any news from Rudy?" Ian inquired.

"Well, no news is often considered good news, isn't it?" Perrian responded.

Ian couldn't shake off a peculiar feeling.

No news from Rudy?

The Rudy he knew would have inevitably caused some kind of trouble by now. It seemed odd that there was no news at all.

"Hmm..." Ian pondered.

The Rudy he knew was notorious for his mischievous nature. He would humbly submit to those stronger than him but showed no mercy when exerting power over weaker individuals.

Emotions and fists often took precedence over reason and words for him.

It surprised Ian that such a person hailed from the prestigious Astria Duke family.

The reason for his surprise stemmed from the fact that he knew his father well.

Perrian must have had conversations with the professors at the academy, even if he didn't particularly take an interest in Rudy. To some extent, he should be concerned about his well-being.

Yet, he claimed there was no news, indicating that nothing noteworthy had occurred.

"People undergo transformations when their environment changes, don't they? It's about time for Rudy to mature, huh," Perrian chuckled cheerfully.

However, Ian held a different opinion. He believed that people weren't so easily swayed by circumstances.

"I've received an invitation from the Academy, so I think I'll go and witness it myself."

Ian had also been invited to Homecoming Day. Initially, he hadn't planned on attending due to his busy schedule, but he had decided to make an appearance.

While Rudy lingered in his thoughts, another matter also troubled him—Astina Persia, the daughter of the Persia family.

Following the rescue of Princess Rie and the capture of the Rebels, the Persia family's actions had been rather peculiar.

Nobles associated with them were returning to their territories, back to the Persia family's domain. Their intentions were evident to anyone who paid attention—they sought to change their successor.

Hence, Ian concluded that he needed to meet with Astina.

When she last visited the capital, he was preoccupied with other affairs and couldn't interact with her separately.

Naturally, those around him met Astina and shared their impressions, but he considered those accounts mere hearsay. To truly comprehend the kind of person she was, he had to meet her himself.

If Astina had indeed saved Princess Rie, she would undoubtedly align herself with the Royalists, becoming his adversary.

"Well then, I shall attend to a few other matters," Ian announced.

"Yes, return once more before you depart for the capital," his father replied.

With a farewell to his father, Ian rose from his seat.

Meanwhile, in Professor Robert's laboratory...

"...So this time it's pretty garbage, isn't it? Who created this for you?" Robert inquired.

"Luna assisted me. And it's not garbage. It's an authentic spell."

"The magic circle itself appears to be the work of a skilled wizard, but what's the significance of this pattern?" Robert pointed towards the center of the magic circle.

The central symbol of the magic circle caught Robert's attention.

"What kind of spell is this?"

With confidence, I responded to his question. "I brought it because I don't know. What if I use it and something significant happens?"

"So, you're suggesting that I give it a try?"

"...Well, not exactly."

In truth, that was my intention.

But would it be too harsh to say it so directly?

Robert fixed his gaze on the magic circle and began manipulating his mana.

"Are you planning to use it here?"

I was taken aback as he suddenly started casting the spell. I had assumed we would relocate to a safer location.

Robert remained silent, continuing to manipulate his mana.

"Huh..."

As Robert moved his mana, a sigh of exasperation escaped his lips.

He halted the movement of his mana and stared at me.

"Where did you obtain this magic circle?"

"I stumbled upon it," I confidently lied.

"I see, you stumbled upon this magic circle, you little..."

After uttering those words, Robert resumed moving his mana.

And the magic was unleashed.

Bang!

A black pillar emerged from the laboratory floor, reaching up towards the ceiling. It resembled a towering spire, sharp at the top and thick at the base.

"What the!"

A voice echoed from the hole in the ceiling.

Ignoring the voice, Robert approached me.

"What kind of person are you?" his eyes and voice bore a stark difference from usual.

They brimmed with a fierce, murderous intent.

"Have you met Levian? Where is he now?"

He knows Levian?

The sudden mention of Levian caught me off guard. While I had suspected he might be aware of Levian's existence, the fact that he recognized this spell posed a problem.

"Do you know Levian?" I asked.

"I won't answer that. Where did you find this magic?"

A shiver ran down my spine.

Robert's murderous intent, infused with mana, stabbed sharply at me.

I calmly pondered the situation.

Levian and Robert.

An unexpected connection.

Robert was able to cast the spell with ease after a brief examination. However, it seemed he was unaware of the meaning behind the symbol in the magic circle.

"I won't answer either. But there is one thing..."

I met Robert's gaze, looking directly into his eyes.

"I am not an enemy," I declared.

"Not an enemy..."

My words held a dual meaning. It signified that I was not an enemy to Professor Robert, nor to Levian.

Upon hearing this, Robert fell into contemplation.

Observing the pensive professor, I sincerely spoke up.

"Master, please calm down and let's talk. There's no benefit in resorting to this."

"...Sigh."

Robert let out a sigh in response to my words and relaxed. He then flung himself onto the sofa before him and took a seat.

"Sit."

Pointing to the spot opposite him, Robert invited me to join him.

As I settled down, Robert began to speak.

"First of all, I am not your master."

What is he talking about now?

"Then what am I?"

"Just a student attending the academy. I am a magnanimous professor."

"...You're teaching me, so I'm your student and you're my master, aren't you?"

"Nonsense. It's ten years too early for you to be my student."

What is he even...

Absurd as it may be, there was nothing I could do if he insisted. I decided to leave it at that.

"What is your relationship with Levian?"

To that question, Robert offered a brief reply.

"A master who taught me for a while and a nemesis."

Then he turned the question back to me.

"And what about you?"

"I'm a stranger. I just happen to know someone who has a relationship with him."

Professor Robert scrutinized me, and I met his gaze without flinching.

"So, what do you possess?"

"His grimoire."

Our conversation was brief. On the surface, it seemed like an ordinary exchange, but to me, it felt like a duel of swords.

It seemed like if I gave the wrong answer, I would be struck down.

"One final question."

A small query.

"Whose side are you on?"

I could answer this question without hesitation.

"I am on the side of the survivors."

Survival was my goal.

There was no need to align myself with those destined to perish.

I simply walked in the direction that held the best chance of survival.

Upon hearing my response, Robert let out a sigh.

Then he displayed a serene expression.

"Well, if that's the case....."

Bang!

"Robert!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!"

In the midst of our conversation, someone abruptly burst into the room.

"Huh?"

Professor Robert appeared on the verge of uttering something warm, but his eyes widened upon seeing the unexpected visitor.

It was Professor McGuire who had stormed into the lab.

His usual composed demeanor had vanished, replaced by a visage distorted by anger.

"How dare you make a hole in my lab?????? You??????"

"Oh, hold on a minute... There was a reason for that."

I gazed at the lingering black pillar, a reminder of the ceiling it had pierced.

Realization struck, and I turned to Robert, my expression filled with shock.

With widened eyes, Robert motioned for me to leave.

"You caused quite a mess last time, and Cromwell let it slide, but now you've made a hole??"

Carefully avoiding Professor McGuire's attention, I rose from my seat.

"You! Let's settle this with a fight to the death today, you brat!!!!"

Silently, I exited the room.

Decided to block most of the dating ads as I go through the ad list... sorry guys no meeting asian singles here.

3/4 Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 36: Homecoming Day (3)

Persia Family, Conference Room

Seated at the head of the conference room was the head of the Persia family, with about ten people gathered in front of him.

Among them was Harpel Persia, Astina's older brother.

He was there not as the heir, but as the captain of the Persia family knights.

"So it has come to this..."

The head let out a deep sigh, his eyes filled with regret as he looked at Harpel.

Observing the head's expression, the person standing next to him spoke up.

"The decision to change the heir has been approved by 8 members, with 1 abstaining and 1 objecting."

Upon hearing this, the head rose from his seat.

"Thank you all for attending. Food has been prepared at the mansion, so please have a meal before you depart."

With a weary countenance, the head left the room.

The others in the room turned their attention to Harpel, awaiting his reaction.

Harpel glanced at them and asked, "What are you looking at?"

Then he made his way towards the door, taking slow steps.

"I won't be joining for dinner. I'm sure it would ruin everyone's appetite, so I'll leave now."

Harpel spoke these words before departing from the room.

As he walked a short distance, a knight approached Harpel.

"Captain, what happened?"

The knight was Eric Richard, vice-captain of the Persia Knights.

"I've been dismissed."

"Dismissed..."

Anger flared in Eric's eyes.

"Those bastards...! How much have you accomplished, only to be dismissed?"

Eric expressed his agitation.

He was the son of the former captain of the Persia Knights and a friend who trained in swordsmanship alongside Harpel.

He had witnessed all of Harpel's actions and efforts thus far, which fueled his anger even more.

"Eric, calm down."

"No, how can I stay calm right now...?"

As Eric spoke, he gazed at Harpel but couldn't continue his words.

It was because Harpel's face reflected a myriad of emotions.

His teeth ground together, and his fists clenched tightly.

The one who was most angry about this situation right now was Harpel.

'What... did I do wrong...'

He had dedicated himself to the family, pouring his efforts into compensating for his shortcomings and sacrificing sleep to make up for lost time.

But all he received in return was indifference and now they were plotting to strip him of his position as the heir.

"Ast... ina."

Harpel gritted his teeth, repeating Astina's name.

She was born from the same mother, no doubt about it.

Yet, why did he lack the same abilities she possessed?

He could accept his own shortcomings, but it was difficult to bear losing the only thing he had.

"Are you... alright?" Eric asked, observing Harpel.

Harpel turned his gaze towards Eric.

"Eric."

With eyes burning with anger, he spoke.

"Where is the invitation from the Academy?"

The temperature was gradually rising, signaling the arrival of Homecoming Day and the impending final examinations.

In the meantime, several events have taken place.

First, I showed Professor Robert the magic book Luna had obtained.

Robert began researching the book, and I was able to learn a few simple spells from it.

Meanwhile, Astina smoothly succeeded in securing her position as the heir.

Her success stemmed from the solid foundation she had laid beforehand.

Astina skillfully persuaded the nobles, and Rie had previously dealt with the nobles of the capital to prevent any potential rebellion.

Although there were some minor objections, they were virtually non-existent.

In other news, Yeniel had returned to the Academy.

According to Astina, she had taken care of all issues.

I had full confidence in Astina's abilities to handle such matters, so I didn't worry too much.

The most exciting news for me was that Evan had begun learning swordsmanship.

Evan, now in possession of Andrei's sword, started his training.

This was good news, the story will progress more smoothly.

Andrei's sword was no ordinary blade.

It possessed the ability to slash mana.

Usually, to achieve such a feat, one would need to create a sword aura.

However, this particular sword had the capacity to store mana within itself, allowing for mana slashing without the need for a sword aura.

Of course, utilizing this ability required the expenditure of one's own mana. But for a wizard, who possessed ample mana compared to others, it wasn't an issue.

With this sword in his possession, facing Serina wouldn't be difficult for Evan.

Serina had never encountered a swordsman with a sword aura, nor had she ever faced a magic swordsman.

If Evan could combine his swordsmanship to cut through the elemental and unleash magic attacks, the chances of her being caught off guard were high.

It was the same in the game.

"Come on, give it your all. Isn't this what you trained for?"

"Ugh..."

Rie and I were walking together now, transporting props for the upcoming Homecoming Day.

She whistled merrily as she led the way, while I struggled with the heavy load.

"Why are you making me do this? Why not ask Locke? Why me?"

"It's your responsibility. I'm handling all the paperwork, so you can handle the manual labor."

I couldn't argue with that logic.

Rie had taken on the role of the student council secretary, relieving me of my paperwork duties.

Initially, Astina wanted me to continue as the secretary, but I refused, and in the end, Rie volunteered to take on the task.

"And Locke is busy with Astina. That's why she asked you."

I wished she had asked someone stronger than me...

The words lingered on the tip of my tongue, but I refrained from uttering them.

She had, after all, taken on the role of secretary on my behalf.

I felt a sense of pride as I carried everything.

I wouldn't have been able to lift this in the past.

My strength and stamina have greatly improved due to my consistent training.

"Hello?"

Someone called out to the both of us.

"Hmm?"

A woman stood before us, her eyes concealed by a black cloth, dressed in the attire of a nun.

She drew nearer to us, her cane gently tapping the ground.

A beautiful rosary adorned her neck, its brilliance suggested she was a person of high status.

"...Huh?"

Rie's eyes widened upon seeing the woman.

There was only one individual in the empire who possessed such distinct features.

"The Saint?"

The woman before us offered a somewhat awkward smile.

"Um... are you students? Could you perhaps tell me where the headmaster's office is?"

Both of us stared at her, wearing expressions of confusion.

Why was the Saint alone here?

I decided to respond to her question for the time being.

"If you head towards that large building over there and go to the third floor, you should find it."

"Oh, thank you."

The Saint responded with a radiant smile to my words.

She was about to depart but hesitated for a moment.

Then, she fixed her gaze intently on me.

"By any chance, are you Rudy Astria?"

What?

Why was my name suddenly brought up?

"Do you know me...?"

The Saint was a character who rarely appeared in the game.

Even without her presence, the story wouldn't be affected much.

The events she was involved in didn't revolve around her, nor was she at the center of them.

Hence, I knew nothing about this person.

"Well... no. I was just curious and asked. Well then, take care."

The Saint uttered those words and walked away nonchalantly.

"What was that?"

As I was about to leave, Rie tugged at my sleeve.

"Hey... doesn't that seem strange to you?"

"What do you mean?"

"Wasn't the Saint supposed to be blind?"

I tilted my head in confusion at Rie's remark.

Wasn't that obvious?

She had black cloth covering her eyes.

And since she was tapping the ground with her cane, I naturally assumed she was blind.

"But she knows where the largest building is and heads straight for it?"

"Huh?"

Observing the Saint's back, I noticed she was proceeding toward the main building with remarkable ease.

"What's going on?"

Both of us stared at her, thoroughly bewildered.

The following day.

The Academy's interior was adorned like a lively festival.

It wasn't setup like a real festival, with little shops side by side.

It was simply decorated more than usual.

Additionally, there were various activities scattered around that the graduates could enjoy.

It was a gathering that had the atmosphere of a festival where both graduates and students could have fun together.

"Rudy!"

Luna approached with a radiant smile.

Originally, everyone seemed to be occupied, so he had planned to explore on his own.

This was his first time attending such a festival, and he had hoped to run into Evan and Serina.

But then, Luna had come to see him the day before.

-Um... Rudy, what are you planning to do tomorrow?

-Are you going to explore? Yeah?

-I have something I want to do... but it feels a bit awkward to go alone...

-Ah! Riku and Ena said they were busy because they wanted to meet some seniors... If it doesn't work out, I'll ask someone else...

-Really? You'll come with me?

How could he refuse when Luna asked in such a way?

However, it seemed that Luna had been fighting with Riku and Ena lately.

Why were those two so busy?

Every time Luna wanted to do something, they always seemed occupied.

Honestly, Luna, who was always studying, should be the busy one, not them.

Were they excluding her?

But whenever he wasn't around, the three of them were always together.

"Rudy, is something bothering you?"

While he was pondering, Luna gazed at him innocently.

Looking at her face, his worries vanished.

There was no way they would ostracize someone as kind as her, right?

"No, not at all. Actually, it's about to start soon. Let's go."

"Okay!"

The two of them made their way to the central auditorium to witness the event that marked the beginning of Homecoming Day.

Decided to block most of the dating ads as I go through the ad list... sorry guys no meeting asian singles here.

4/4 Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 37: Homecoming Day (4)

Astina was slowly making preparations to leave the student council room.

"Rie, do you know where the Saint is?" she asked.

"I heard she's in the central auditorium talking with others. But I don't need to stick around here any longer, right?" Rie responded with a hint of impatience.

"That's fine. Go enjoy yourself. There shouldn't be any significant problems."

"I'm not going to 'enjoy' myself. I'm going to work~."

With that, Rie was the first to leave the student council room.

Astina watched her leave, then tidied up the documents scattered across her desk and exited the room as well.

She strolled towards the central auditorium without any particular worries.

Today was a less demanding day compared to most.

The only tasks were to receive a mandate from the Saint and converse with the graduates.

There were no specific documents to deal with.

Receiving the mandate wasn't a complex matter either.

It merely involved obtaining a blessing from the Saint and communicating the contents of the mandate to the people.

And despite its name, it wasn't as though she was hearing the voice of God directly.

It was merely echoing the facts the Saint had informed her of.

Typically, it contained only ceremonial content.

Conveying that everyone in the academy was doing well and that the academy would continue to prosper shouldn't be problematic.

It had always been that way.

They hold this event annually; how could anything change?

It would be odd if the future changed every year.

As she mused about this, she reached the central auditorium.

Graduates and professors were already gathered near the auditorium, engaged in conversations.

The Saint was at the center of the largest group.

As Astina approached, the graduates greeted her. "Isn't that the Student Council President?" one remarked.

"Yes, I'm Astina Persia, this year's Student Council President," Astina responded with a smile.

The graduates laughed and approached her.

Their talk was simple—comments about the demanding job of the Student Council President and her hard work—but there was a deeper meaning to it.

Now that Astina had assumed the role of the heir, it was essential to make her presence known.

As they conversed, the Saint approached Astina. "Hello. I am the Saint, Haruna."

"Ah, I am Astina Persia, the heir to the Persia family and the current Student Council President."

Astina confidently introduced herself, making her presence known among the people surrounding her.

As she briefly greeted the Saint, a sound indicating the start of the event began to resonate.

The Saint, with a smile, gestured towards the back of the auditorium.

"Shall we go in now? It seems like it's about to start."

"Yes, let's do that."

Accepting the Saint's suggestion, Astina walked alongside her towards the back of the auditorium.

As they entered, the Saint handed Astina a note.

"It's a note about the future."

"A prophecy?"

"Most people refer to it that way."

She frowned at the Saint's cryptic words.

"So, should I look at it now?"

"Yes~. If you wish to read it, you can."

Astina was somewhat apprehensive but opened the note regardless.

The contents were mostly ordinary.

It noted there might be various hardships at the academy, but that everyone could overcome them—something anyone might say.

As Astina read, her eyes stopped at the last item.

"What is... this?"

The content was not something to be overlooked lightly.

"Are you saying this is going to happen?"

"I never specified what is going to happen, did I?"

The Saint playfully answered Astina's question.

Indeed, there was nothing specific mentioned in the note. Just a word of caution.

But, that cautionary note itself implied something was going to occur.

"So is this the will of the gods? Do you expect me to announce this to everyone?"

To utter such content in front of them all wouldn't go unnoticed.

The audience wasn't just academy students and professors, but also outsiders.

If she mentioned this, rumors could spread both within the academy and beyond.

Upon Astina's statement, the Saint tilted her head, seemingly puzzled.

"The will of the gods... I'm not certain about that. And I've never told you to announce the future I revealed to everyone, have I?"

".....What?"

What was she talking about?

The more Astina heard the Saint's words, the more doubts arose.

These doubts were fundamental to the ritual of receiving a prophecy from the Saint.

"I merely reveal the future I see to the student chosen by the academy."

"So... You're saying I don't have to mention the content in this note?"

"Whether or not you announce it is up to you, President."

Astina clenched the note tightly, staring at the Saint.

"Are you saying that handling this is my responsibility alone?"

It seemed an irresponsible thing to say, but Astina considered the possibility.

After all, she was the one who had been handed the choice so casually.

"Are you suggesting I go against the will of the gods..."

As Astina said this, the Saint regarded her with a smile.

She slightly lifted the veil that covered her eyes, revealing her right eye.

".....?"

Astina was met with a direct gaze from her right eye.

It was a vibrant eye that hadn't lost its color, unlike the eyes of the blind.

"Do you really believe this is the will of the gods? Or rather..."

The Saint posed a question to a puzzled Astina.

"Do you believe in God?"

After a moment, the announcer's voice resonated, marking the beginning of the ceremony.

The Saint covered her eyes again with the black veil she held and spoke.

"Now it's time for you to go up."

At the Saint's words, Astina moved to ascend the stage.

And she continued to contemplate.

Should she reveal this truth?

Or should she keep it hidden, bearing it alone?

Astina's mind turned these questions over and over as the event proceeded.

"Next, we have the baptism ceremony."

Was it really correct to choose to hide it?

"This baptism not only signifies a blessing for the student council president but also serves as a blessing for the entire academy."

Would it be better to reveal it to everyone?

Applause erupted!

Having received the baptism, Astina rose from her seat and moved forward.

"Next, we will proceed with the prophecy."

Now it was time to pass on the prophecy to the people.

Astina stood in her position and looked out at the crowd in front of her.

"I will now pass on the prophecy."

In front of her stood noble children, some of whom had already inherited their family's status.

There were researchers who specialized in specific fields and those who held professorships.

Knights, wizards, and alchemists alike were present.

People from all walks of life stood before Astina.

"Liberion Academy has faced many crises so far, but we have always overcome them."

Astina remembered the contents she had read and slowly began to recite them.

"There will always be dangers, but we will overcome them all."

The speech was formal, much like the prophecies that had come before.

As she recited what she had seen, her eyes met with someone in the crowd.

Rudy Astria.

He was watching her alongside Luna Railer.

"...that concludes my speech."

Internally, Astina sighed.

'Alright, you figure it out yourself this time.'

Astina swallowed hard, leaving the last prophecy unspoken.

She made her decision.

She chose not to reveal that final prophecy.

The content of that prophecy was...

"...that concludes the content of the prophecy."

It read, 'Be wary of Rudy Astria.'

At that moment, carriages began to pull up at the academy's front gate.

The event was already underway, but it was not uncommon for some to arrive late due to pressing schedules.

Two guards rushed towards the arriving carriages.

One held a list of the academy's graduates, while the other approached a carriage, knocked on its door, and asked, "Who's there?"

There was a process in place to confirm identities, as impersonators could potentially pose a risk.

A man inside the carriage opened the door.

Presenting the invitation from the academy to the guard, the man announced, "I am Harpel Persia."

The guard who had knocked accepted the invitation, while the other guard referred to the list.

Upon receiving a nod from the guard with the list, the guard at the door greeted the man in the carriage, "Welcome to Liberion Academy. Please, proceed."

Harpel re-entered the carriage and proceeded into the academy grounds.

"The next one may proceed."

Following the previous routine, the next carriage stopped in front of the guards.

And the door of the carriage swung open.

As soon as the door opened, the individual inside inquired of the guard, "Was the person who just entered Harpel Persia?"

“Uh...?”

Upon seeing the man's face, the guard who had knocked froze, momentarily unable to respond.

The guard clutching the list looked at the man before him with puzzlement.

Then, the man in the carriage reiterated his question.

“I asked if it was Harpel Persia.”

“Ye... Yes, it was!”

At the man's insistence, the guard standing before him responded loudly.

“Alright, got it.”

Subsequently, the man extended his invitation.

As the guard at the back was preparing to cross-reference the list, the guard in front halted him with his hand.

Then he exclaimed loudly.

“Welcome to Liberion Academy!!!”

With that, the man shut the carriage door, and the vehicle proceeded into the academy.

After observing the carriage enter the academy grounds, the guards returned to their posts.

Curiosity piqued, the guard holding the list asked the guard standing in front.

“Senior, why didn't we check? Don't we need to verify his identity?”

Then, the guard standing in front glared at him sharply.

“Have you lost your senses? Didn't you recognize him?”

“Who was he?”

“That was Ian Astria. We were instructed to remember the faces of such distinguished individuals.”

The senior guard explained, frustration evident in his tone.

“Ah... That person is...”

“Let's discuss this later.”

The junior guard checked the list; the face of the man who had just departed was depicted right above the name Ian Astria.

One of the people helping me with third-rate villain and my 6★ Gacha Character novel is picking up 2 novels! After we sort that out I'm hoping to increase the releases to 5.

I've always planned for 5 releases but there's just too many things to work on.

1/4 Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 38: Homecoming Day (5)

"...that concludes the prophecy," the words hit me hard.

Had the prophecy changed?

Did Astina change her mind?

I didn't see this coming at all.

Serina and Astina were unrelated.

That's why Astina could name Serina in the prophecy without hesitation.

But why did she choose differently now?

I recalled the time they had lunch together.

Could that be the cause?

Was the simple act of sharing a meal an issue?

It seemed insignificant.

But seeing the consequences unfold, it was disturbing.

Could one meal have swayed Astina's choice?

However, this wasn't the worst-case scenario.

The change in the prophecy hadn't affected Evan.

He was likely alone, training by the Elementalist Department building.

That building wasn't for events; it was a quiet space, perfect for training.

Evan wasn't the festival type, nor did he have friends to celebrate with.

His usual companions in the original were Rie, Serina, and Yeniel.

With Luna's hidden route, she could've been among them as well, but I stepped in.

With the story of the midterm camp changed, Rie is excluded as well.

That meant Evan's companions were now only Serina and Yeniel.

"Will things go according to plan...?"

If these two were his only companions, Evan wouldn't be anywhere else.

Serina was probably off securing Priscilla, while Yeniel had other worries.

There was no reason for Evan's actions to differ.

For now, Serina should be carrying out her usual plan.

Priscilla was in the Elementalist Department building.

If Evan was training near there, he'd easily spot Serina entering. There shouldn't be any problems.

"Rudy, should we start leaving? I think we've seen everything," Luna suggested, looking my way.

Looking around, I saw others were leaving the auditorium too.

"Luna, I apologize, but could I meet Senior Astina for a moment?"

"Huh? Senior Astina? Sure, there's no hurry."

With Luna's consent, we headed straight to the back of the auditorium.

Meeting Astina was the top priority.

I needed to understand the situation and act quickly.

As we moved towards the back, the atmosphere became quiet, contrasting the bustling outside.

Not a single soul was around, I presume everyone had left already.

Entering the waiting room, I saw Astina, seated on a chair, deep in thought.

"Astina, senior."

"Hello!"

Luna and I greeted Astina with cheer and approached her.

"Um... Luna and... Rudy Astria."

Astina sounded subdued as she acknowledged us.

"Is something wrong?"

I asked, scrutinizing her demeanor.

She might be worried about Serina.

Her dull expression clearly indicated that something was off.

But it felt strange.

Astina wasn't the kind to let emotions overpower her.

She had even casually overthrown her own brother.

However, she was fond of those close to her.

Even then, the time she had spent with Serina was too short for them to be friends.

I was puzzled as to why she would make such a decision.

"Oh, it's nothing. I'm just a bit tired."

Astina offered a weak smile in response.

She then stood up and started to tidy up what appeared to be student council items before addressing us.

"So, why did you two come here?"

"I came to see how you're doing. You didn't look well during the announcement."

This was true.

Knowing the prophecy from the game, Astina's expression visibly dimmed when she uttered those final words.

"Hmm, is that so? The workload has been making me feel exhausted lately. I didn't realize it showed."

Astina shrugged it off as trivial and continued packing.

She didn't seem eager to discuss the prophecy either.

Luckily, the prophecy didn't significantly alter this storyline.

After Evan defeats Serina, those who heard the prophecy start to gather at the site.

These people attempt to capture Serina, but Evan defends her.

As Evan blocks their way, the headmaster steps in and defuses the situation.

Even if this incident doesn't occur, it wouldn't cause major problems, so I was considering letting it go.

"Would you like some help since you're tired?"

Luna offered to help Astina, who was packing up.

"Um! Thank you, Luna."

I joined Luna in cleaning up the room.

As we were doing so, we heard approaching footsteps.

The clack of a man's dress shoes filled the air.

Both Luna and Astina sensed the unusual atmosphere.

"Is someone supposed to be here now?"

"I only know about the person responsible for the hall."

The sound grew louder.

I noticed the footsteps weren't alone.

It seemed like two people were approaching.

The footsteps stopped right outside the waiting room we were in.

Knock, knock.

"Is the student council president in?"

"Who's there? Please, come in."

The door swung open, revealing a man in a suit with a knight by his side.

"Uh..."

I was completely taken aback at the sight of the man.

There, standing before me, was my older brother, Ian Astria.

"Um...? Rudy?"

Luna looked at me as I recoiled in surprise.

"Why didn't you tell me you were coming? I would have come to meet you."

"No, if I announced my arrival, it would have stirred unnecessary chaos."

Ian replied calmly, then shifted his gaze towards me in the back.

"I didn't anticipate Rudy being here. I was hoping to see you, even if just for a moment."

"Who is he?" Luna whispered to me.

I swallowed hard and replied quietly, "He's my older brother."

Luna looked surprised and glanced back and forth between me and Ian.

Before I could dwell on Luna's reaction, I had something important to decide.

How should I address my older brother?

In the game, there were very few scenes where Rudy Astria and Ian Astria interacted.

So, I was unsure about how I should treat or address my older brother.

Naturally, I knew that their relationship wasn't especially close.

However, I couldn't be disrespectful to my brother here.

First things first, I greeted him.

"It's been quite some time, brother."

I kept my tone courteous.

Rudy Astria was submissive towards the strong and domineering towards the weak.

Therefore, he wouldn't have been rude to his older brother.

Observing my behavior, Ian gave a slight smile.

"You seem to be doing better than I expected."

"Haha..."

Ian didn't react further and turned to Astina.

"Looking around, I can tell you've put in a lot of effort in your preparations."

"Thank you. We did our best to make a good impression on our guests."

"I can see that. I was once the student council president myself, so I understand."

Ian struck up conversation with Astina.

He asked her about her experiences as the student council president and even provided a few pieces of advice.

It was a somewhat unexpected development.

Would my presence here cause any issues?

Regardless, I decided to stay alert.

While talking, Ian gestured to the knight standing behind him.

"Oh, by the way, allow me to introduce someone."

"This is Thomas, the captain of the Astria family's knights."

"Pleasure to meet you," said the knight named Thomas, extending his hand for a handshake.

Astina reciprocated by reaching out and shaking his hand.

"Hmm?"

As Thomas and Astina shook hands, a subtle glow emitted from the glove he wore.

It was a faint shimmer, visible only from where I stood.

Raising my gaze to Ian, I was met with a small smile.

What was he planning?

Suddenly, a voice echoed within my mind.

-Stay quiet.

Ian's voice?

Heeding his directive, I stayed silent, my eyes fixed on him.

Then, Ian started speaking while looking at Astina.

"I believe it's time for me to depart. I've extended my greetings and seen my younger brother."

"Don't you want to greet the professors?"

"They wouldn't be comfortable with my presence, so it would only cause inconvenience. Well, I should be on my way. It was a pleasure meeting you."

Ian turned to leave.

"Ah."

He paused briefly to look back at Astina.

"By the way, I noticed a slight issue at the Elementalist Department building on my way here."

"Oh, I'll make sure to check on that."

"Good. Take care then."

Leaving those words behind, Ian exited the room.

The Elementalist Department building...

Evan was at the training ground by that building.

With the change in the announced prophecies, a complication has come up.

It's unlikely that everything would proceed smoothly.

Ian strolled towards the carriage, a smirk gracing his lips.

"What a serious young man," he murmured to himself.

His gaze drifted towards the Elementalist Department building.

"It's quite entertaining to watch siblings at odds..."

Upon his arrival, Ian had been watching Harpel for a while.

Exiting the carriage, Harpel made his way towards the Elementalist Department building with a knight in tow.

The only building excluded from the event.

Ian could already guess what they were up to.

This place was no different from Astina's stronghold.

Trying to gain political leverage here would be nothing short of suicidal.

There was only one other plausible reason.

Revenge.

"I had thought of Harpel as a reasonably good friend," Ian chuckled.

Given Astina's nature, she would personally look into any problems that came up.

That's why he hinted at the Elementalist Department building, where Harpel was headed.

Even if he hadn't mentioned it, Harpel would have found a way to draw Astina there.

He had merely guided Astina in that direction.

To set the stage for their clash.

And he had prepared a little gift for Harpel.

He had cast a spell on Astina, one that wouldn't leave a discernible trace.

Given Harpel's competence as a knight, he would be able to handle the situation well given the opportunity.

"It would be delightful if they each lost an arm in the fight."

And Ian had one more reason to be happy about.

Rudy Astria.

He had assumed Rudy to be a fool, but it seemed like he had been forming connections.

It felt as though a useful tool had been forged.

"It was a good idea to come here."

With a wicked smile, Ian stepped into the carriage.

2/4 Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 39: Homecoming Day (6)

Near the Elementalist Department's building...

"Astina..."

A voice gritted out, scanning the area.

It was Harpel Persia.

Beside him, stood Eric, concern etched on his face.

"No turning back now."

Harpel's fist clenched.

"Losing to her... what's left for me?"

His goal? Assassinate Astina.

Yet, killing Astina without a trace was far from easy.

He had no choice.

If he could kill Astina unnoticed, he'd have his revenge and restore his status as the successor.

This thought consumed him.

His plan was reckless, his loathing for Astina had fogged his sight, blinding him to anything else.

"Haaah..."

A sigh escaped Eric.

Harpel was once an intelligent and well-mannered friend.

Now...

He'd lost his rationality and was incapable of making sound judgments.

Despite numerous attempts to discourage him, Harpel was deaf to his words.

Still, Eric couldn't desert his friend.

This man was not only his friend but also his chosen lord.

Since he had made this choice, Eric planned to stick with Harpel until the bitter end.

Even if it led to their ruin.

Fortunately, there were no problems so far.

They'd thought up ways to move without drawing attention, but thankfully, Ian Astria showed himself.

It became simple to get to this point.

"Eric, take me to the spot you mentioned."

"...Alright."

As an academy alumnus, Eric was familiar with the nearby amenities.

Close to the Elementalist Department building, there was an indoor training field.

The facilities were decrepit, attracting few visitors.

This training field, more like a hall, had limited windows and poor air circulation. Its location at the academy's far end made it less accessible.

However, these elements were perfect for their plan.

If they lured Astina here and killed her, it would be some time before anyone found her.

One would have to go through the Elementalist Department building first.

And being situated at the academy's edge, they could easily make it outside.

"Huh?"

As they neared the location, they spotted a boy focused on sword practice.

Sweat dripped from his brow as he swung his sword.

Seeing someone train amid the ongoing event brought a pang of nostalgia.

It reminded him of his own training sessions with Harpel at the academy.

"First things first..."

Although he sympathized with the boy, their mission was the priority.

"Hey, student."

"Yes...?"

The boy was Evan.

Unable to find a proper training site, he had picked this isolated location.

"I need to use this space. Could you clear off?"

Eric's request made Evan cock his head in puzzlement.

"I thought this area wouldn't be used during the event..."

"Ah, the academy thought it would difficult to keep everything in the main building, so they reassigned a part of it here."

"Oh... I understand."

Without any doubts, Evan gathered his sword and items.

"Alright. Good luck with your task."

"Right, thank you."

Eric watched Evan depart and placed his bag down.

He pulled out the scrolls he had prepared, bracing himself for Astina, a formidable opponent.

Central Auditorium.

The moment Ian exited, I turned to Astina and said,

"Show me your hand."

"What are you talking about?"

I seized Astina's hand and examined it from all angles.

There had certainly been a peculiar glow earlier...

"What... What are you doing?"

As I inspected Astina's hand, she regarded me with a baffled look.

"Rudy!!"

Luna flailed her arms wildly.

"That's not allowed!"

Luna's reaction brought a blush to my cheeks.

"I'm sorry."

"No, it's okay."

Letting go of her hand, Astina withdrew hers and cleared her throat.

"Um... Are you feeling alright? Any issues with your body? Since the handshake..."

"Handshake?"

Astina appeared puzzled as she stared at me.

She examined her own hand with keen interest.

"I don't notice anything odd."

"Um..."

What did he do?

It didn't seem like a spell that would be helpful to us.

Given he used a transmission spell to keep it concealed.

"Anyways, we should inspect the Elementalist Department building."

"In that case, I'll investigate the building."

"You will?"

"You seem tired, Astina, and it doesn't look like there's anyone else to ask."

There was no one else in sight we could ask.

However, this was merely an excuse.

I needed to confirm if the storyline was unfolding as expected.

In the original game, it was an event no one else could interfere with, so I thought everything would be okay.

But I had miscalculated.

Given things were already straying from the game, I shouldn't have expected a straightforward trajectory.

"Wouldn't it be wiser to consult the Student Council?"

"The Student Council is swamped, so I'll just go and check. If there's trouble, I'll call for assistance."

As I shared my thoughts, Astina pondered briefly before nodding.

"No, I'll accompany you."

"...Excuse me?"

I was surprised.

"Who can tell what might happen, and if something does, we'd be better equipped to handle it swiftly, right?"

"Well... I guess so."

"Then, we should go together."

Astina put her belongings aside and took the initiative.

Her ambiguous expression concerned me, but I couldn't read her thoughts.

Then Luna, who was behind me, tugged at my arm.

"Um... Rudy...!"

Turning to Luna, I saw a frown on her face.

"I thought we were going to explore together."

"Ah... right..."

"You're always so focused on work! You need to take a break sometimes!"

Luna placed her hands on her waist and lectured me.

Feeling guilty, I shot Luna an apologetic glance, and she replied with a gentle smile.

"I'll overlook it this time as you're handling important business. I'll help too, so let's wrap this up quickly and have some fun."

"Alright, thanks for your concern."

"No worries!"

A faint smile tugged at my lips.

Seeing Luna worry about me in this way...

I should resolve this quickly and make some time for relaxation.

It wouldn't take much time.

I only needed to investigate the perimeter of the buildings and the training field.

My objective was to check whether Evan was at the training field.

"Let's get going, then."

We moved towards the Elementalist Department building.

The surroundings appeared normal.

There was no reason for event participants to venture into this area.

"...Something doesn't feel right?"

Astina knitted her brow, scanning the vicinity.

Luna and I didn't detect anything out of place, so we glanced at Astina.

"What's the matter?"

I asked, and Astina surveyed the area before responding.

"Someone activated a scroll nearby. I sensed the presence of two... I believe."

"A scroll?"

There was no sensible reason for a scroll to be deployed here.

Neither Serina nor Evan used scrolls for battle.

They favored trusting their own senses rather than gaining a tactical advantage with scrolls.

A vague feeling of unease started to trickle in.

"Do you know where it was triggered?"

"I can't provide that detail. I merely detected a faint mana fluctuation."

Mana fluctuation...

"Should we make our way to the training ground then? It seems we haven't checked that location yet."

We had performed a cursory search of the area, but we had yet to explore the training ground.

Being located in a remote area, it was rarely visited by students from the magic department.

"Shall we head there?"

We moved towards the training ground.

my heart plummeted at the sight that greeted us.

Only two men were inside.

Evan... was conspicuously absent.

When the two men noticed us, they gave off ominous chuckles.

One of them advanced, moving closer to us.

"Hehe... We didn't expect you to wander here alone."

"Why are you here?"

Astina leveled them with a penetrating glare.

"Rudy, Luna, go fetch the others."

As Astina issued her command, the second man ripped the scroll he held in his hand.

Instantly, a transparent barrier materialized, obstructing the entrance.

"Once you're in, there's no escape."

Astina heaved a deep sigh and fixed her gaze on the man before her.

"Do you really believe this will change anything?"

"Whether it does or not is yet to be determined."

The two stood in a standoff, an air of hostility pervading the space.

Amidst this tense situation, my mind was preoccupied with another worry.

Where had Evan vanished to?

"Astina, you could never understand. You've been spoon-fed since your birth."

Why were these men here?

Did Evan run into Serina?

"I loathe you, Astina. Despite the fact we share the same blood..."

"Pardon me..."

I chimed in, interrupting the man's rant.

I didn't have the luxury to listen to the petty stories of an extra at this moment.

"Was anyone training here?"

At my question, the man who had been spouting nonsense sneered.

"Heh... You're fearless, aren't you?"

"No... Was anyone training here?"

I need an answer urgently.

There would be problems if Evan didn't stop Serina.

Even with someone safeguarding Priscilla, I doubt they could hold her off for long.

Evan had managed to win against Serina but most of the guards were currently stationed at the main building, leaving no one in the Elementalist Department building competent enough to handle her.

The professors would also be busy meeting graduates at the main building.

However, if Serina secures Priscilla and forms a contract... It'll be a disaster.

"It's impolite to interrupt."

The other man frowned, visibly annoyed.

His attitude made me clench my teeth.

"Haa..."

And I gathered mana in my hand.

This wasn't the moment to be bothered by these idiots.

If they wouldn't respond...

"Then shut up and come at me."

I spat out at them and unleashed my magic.

3/4 Enjoy the chappy!

Chapter 40: Homecoming Day (7)

"Finger of the Demon."

A towering pillar of black surged, engulfing Harpel and Eric.

Astina was taken aback.

She had intended to talk to her brother, but Rudy was wasting no time at all.

Astina wasn't the only one caught off guard by this.

"Argh!"

"Huff!"

Thanks to their combat experience, Eric and Harpel flung themselves aside, evading the unexpected magical assault.

Harpel exclaimed in shock,

"What...what is this! Eric, didn't you use a scroll to weaken magic?"

"A single scroll can't block all magic. It only weakened Astina's telekinetic magic."

Seizing the opportunity, Rudy continued casting magic.

"Abyssal Flame."

"Harpel! It's dark magic! Don't attempt to block it, dodge it!"

"Argh!"

In their frantic state, they struggled to evade.

"Wind Blaster."

Harpel failed to fully evade Rudy's magic and was sent flying sideways, struck by the spell.

"Harpel!"

Eric cried out, his voice filled with concern.

However, he couldn't rush to his aid.

He knew that if he hurried over, he would become the next target.

"Ugh...!"

Harpel groaned, struggling to rise from the ground.

But he had to keep rolling to avoid Rudy's continuous barrage of magic, unable to regain a stable footing.

Astina stared in disbelief, her eyes wide.

Harpel and Eric were no pushovers.

Both were skilled knights capable of wielding sword aura.

Widely recognized as exceptional knights.

Yet, they were being overwhelmed.

While Rudy's surprise attack played a part, the main reason was dark magic.

Astina hadn't seen much dark magic until now.

Users of such magic were scarce, and she held no interest in magic that carried risks.

But observing the current situation, she realized her prejudice against dark magic might need to be reconsidered.

"Ugh...!"

Eric swiftly charged toward Rudy.

In response, Rudy took a step back, swiftly casting another spell.

"Spikes of Hell."

Small, sharp spikes emerged from the ground, causing Eric to hesitate and ultimately step back.

Seizing the opportunity, Rudy unleashed another spell.

"Fire Wall."

A towering wall of fire erupted in Eric's direction.

Astina watched the battle with pure admiration.

She had heard of the versatility and power of dark magic.

However, what impressed her now was its unpredictability.

When Eric approached, if Rudy was using conventional magic instead, Eric might have been able to break through.

Swordsmen often enhanced their bodies with mana, giving them the ability to withstand most magical attacks and press forward, ignoring the weaker spells.

Hence, in small-scale battles, swordsmen held a significant advantage over wizards.

Yet, Rudy's dark magic nullified that advantage.

Both Eric and Harpel were well-acquainted with dark magic.

To swordsmen, dark magic was an absolute threat that they couldn't afford to underestimate.

To the untrained eye, it didn't appear different from other forms of magic, except for its darker hues.

This very aspect made it difficult to read.

If it contained an effect that restricted movement, they would lose the battle.

They couldn't risk taking a hit from dark magic.

"Luna."

Rudy called out Luna's name, his focus still fixed ahead.

"Huh, yes?"

Like Astina, Luna was also blankly watching Rudy's fight, so she responded in a fluster.

"Astina senior said those guys put a restriction on her, can you help me instead?"

"...Yes! I understand!"

Rudy didn't let the opportunity slip away while he maintained the upper hand.

"Wind Ball!"

Luna joined the fight when Rudy was already holding his own.

"Haha... truly impressive," Astina chuckled dryly at the scene.

The ease with which Rudy wielded dark magic and his astounding rate of growth took her by surprise.

Astina possessed exceptional talent herself, but she had only reached the level of intermediate magic towards the end of her first semester in the first year.

Meanwhile, Rudy was already capable of using intermediate magic effectively in actual combat.

"This is the Astria family..."

Astina expressed her genuine admiration.

"Phew..."

I released a breath I had been holding.

I was completely zoned in.

Using dark magic like this was dangerous.

Especially for someone like me who was not yet used to it.

However, I couldn't afford to hold back right now.

I needed to locate Serina as quickly as possible.

The elemental, Priscilla.

It was an immense threat.

Particularly to Serina.

Elementals can be classified into two types.

Regular Elementals and special elementals.

Regular elementals encompass the typical four elements: fire, water, wind, and earth.

These elementals are further categorized as beginner, intermediate, advanced, and supreme.

Individuals with a strong affinity for nature can form contracts with these elementals.

However, special elementals are different.

While some can be contracted and summoned through affinity and mana, others operate under completely distinct principles.

In the case of Priscilla, it doesn't require any affinity.

Instead, this elemental feeds on a person's mental and life energy.

If someone with weak mental fortitude were to form a contract with Priscilla, they would lose control as their mind crumbles.

Even after establishing a contract, there are other complications.

Using Priscilla after forming the contract continuously depletes one's mental strength.

The individual's mind will eventually collapse.

This is what led to the demise of Serina's mother.

While her mother had no issues with the contract initially, her mental deteriorated over time and her mind eventually collapsed.

No longer able to control Priscilla, the elemental went on a rampage.

Serina wouldn't be able to withstand her either.

Her mental strength is still weak.

Even later when she befriends Evan and becomes stronger mentally, she couldn't control Priscilla, let alone now.

The prophecy was a foretelling of the destruction that soon follows if we allow her to contract Priscilla.

“This damn kid.....”

The two in front of me were slowing starting to counter my attacks.

I had taken them by surprise using the advantages of dark magic.

But, there was something I lacked.

A decisive blow.

I didn't have magic that could finish them off.

They would soon take control of the situation.

Although I currently have the upper hand, those guys are knights who have real experience.

What should I do now?

Both of them have already adjusted their positions, ready to counter my attacks.

In such a situation, the only thing I could do was keep firing magic.

And when my mana hits rock bottom, I'll be attacked in turn.

It's the worst situation.

I don't have the time, nor do I have the power to crush them.

Then.....

"Rudy."

"What...?"

Astina stepped forward, pointing at the man who was constantly blabbering.

"Let me take over now. You just focus on that guy."

"Huh?"

I'm sure they blocked telekinetic magic with a scroll...

Then she smiled as if she knew what I was about to say.

"Just don't use telekinetic magic, right?"

Mana gathered in Astina's hand.

"Earthwave."

The ground split and stones soared up.

"What.....?"

Harpel looked at the scene in surprise.

Eric quickly pushed Harpel aside and deflected the incoming rocks with his sword.

Harpel stumbled and fell to the ground.

"Ugh!"

"Kuh!"

A regular sword wouldn't have been able to withstand the impact, but his sword, infused with aura, managed to slice through the rock.

After parrying the attack, Eric turned to Harpel, who was still on the ground.

"Harpel! The scroll only blocks telekinetic magic! She can use other magic!"

"Abyssal Flame."

While Harpel was still on the ground, I took advantage and directed my spell toward Eric.

"Fireball!"

Luna also sent her magic toward him.

However, Eric swiftly maneuvered his body and swung his sword, slicing through the incoming magic with a powerful arc of aura.

"Ugh...!"

Nevertheless, he couldn't completely neutralize it.

Fragments of magic scattered and landed on his body.

The Abyssal Flame caused him pain, but he still stood strong.

Astina gazed at Eric with a mix of pity and determination.

"Eric, I apologize for having a weak brother."

Her next words carried a sharp edge.

"But I can't let this go."

Eric looked back at Astina, a smile on his face.

"I would have been disappointed if you had done otherwise."

He tightened the grip on his sword and amplified the aura pulsing through it.

Astina glanced at me, standing beside her, and spoke.

"Rudy, watch closely."

The mana in Astina's hand continued to gather, growing in intensity.

"This is how you use magic."

The spell that escaped Astina's lips was a simple one.

"Ignite."

It was the most fundamental magic of the fire attribute.

However, this was no ordinary flame.

Kwaaang!!

The circular flame unleashed by Ignite exploded magnificently.

Though it didn't possess the same force as Astina's signature telekinetic magic, it held overwhelming power.

Astina observed the explosion, a smile forming on her lips.

"If you wanted to defeat me, you should have brought the entire knight order."

Supposed to have posted this on Sunday, but I decided to do it after the site update today instead.

4/4 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 41: Homecoming Day (8)

When Astina's flames vanished, the two figures appeared before us, their bodies charred and scorched.

"Are... Are they dead?" Luna asked, her face filled with shock.

Astina responded with a smirk, "They'll probably be fine. They've fortified their bodies."

Upon closer examination, it became clear that they were merely unconscious, still breathing.

Deciding that the two were no longer capable of combat, I turned to Astina.

"I have somewhere to go, so I'll be leaving first."

"Somewhere to go?"

Luna frowned at me.

"I have something to confirm."

"Something to confirm?"

BOOM!!

Astina seemed puzzled, but the distant explosion provided the explanation on my behalf.

"What was that?"

Could it be Serina?

A feeling of unease surged within me.

"I'll go and check it out."

BOOOOM!

Another explosion reverberated.

Thud...

Then came the sound of rocks tumbling onto the roof of the training ground.

Rocks falling on the roof.

Which meant...

Astina also realized this and opened her mouth.

"No need to go."

CRASH!!!!!!!!!!!!

Someone crashed through the roof of the training ground where we stood and descended.

The figure of a person appeared, riding on the shoulder of Clay, an intermediate earth elemental.

It was Serina.

Following her descent, a green hawk pursued her.

Sylph, the intermediate wind elemental.

The hawk clutched a black bag in its beak.

From its size, it seemed perfectly suited for carrying a sword.

She had successfully stolen Priscilla.

I thought that the two of them might have run into each other before arriving at the training ground.

But it seemed that wasn't the case.

The story had changed due to these two who came to kill Astina.

These two had taken control of the training ground, preventing Evan from reaching Serina.

And with no one to stop Serina from stealing the sword, she ended up with it.

"Haah...."

I sighed.

The silver lining was that she hadn't formed a contract with Priscilla yet.

There was still hope.

"What are you doing?" Astina asked as she approached Serina.

"Last time... I saw you all."

Serina glanced at us as she spoke.

"I don't want to harm you."

"Ser... Serina."

Luna looked surprised, her gaze shifting between us.

I placed a hand on Luna's shoulder and offered her a reassuring smile.

"Luna, it's alright."

I stepped forward and faced Serina.

"Just return Priscilla. You're not ready to use it yet."

"...You know about Priscilla?"

Serina's eyes widened at my words.

"Yes. If you give us the sword now, we can resolve this without any trouble."

I tried to persuade her slowly.

I thought we could solve this through conversation.

"You'll have the chance to meet Priscilla in due time. But if you run away with the sword now, everything will be ruined. Both for you and Priscilla."

"What are you talking about...? Why would I be ruined by taking the sword?"

Serina tilted her head, questioning.

"Because you can't handle Priscilla. So, take it slowly, grow stronger, and make a proper contract. It will be better for both of you."

Astina approached me and whispered, "What do you know?"

I didn't answer her question, simply gazing ahead.

"Serina, if you listen to me now, we can make it as if you never stole the sword or attacked the guards."

We could shift all the blame onto the two unconscious individuals.

Serina stared at me.

I didn't know what she was thinking behind her stoic expression, but the fact that she hadn't attacked us yet was a positive sign.

"Hand over the sword."

I reached out towards Serina.

She hesitated for a moment before responding, "No, I won't make the same mistake again."

Serina reached out towards us.

"I won't... lose my family again."

"Astina! Luna!"

At that moment, Sylph, who stood beside Serina, released a blade of wind, while Clay struck the ground.

"I know."

Astina moved her mana in response to the sudden attacks.

"Psychic Barrier."

A white shield materialized around us.

The shield began repelling the wind blades launched by Sylph.

However, it couldn't fend off every attack.

A large boulder emerged from the ground, shattering the floor beneath us.

"Ugh!"

"Aaargh!"

"Luna!"

Luna stumbled, struggling to maintain her balance.

I hurried over and caught hold of Luna's hand.

Then, I pulled her into my arms.

"Luna, are you alright?"

"Ah, ah, ah! I'm okay... but Astina senior!"

Looking at Astina; she had sustained injuries from Sylph's attack.

She had lost her balance when the ground shifted and couldn't maintain her magic.

I firmly gripped Luna's shoulder and spoke up.

"Luna, go and call for help. Astina senior and I will hold our ground here."

"But..."

I extended my hand towards the wall.

"Finger of the Demon."

Bang!

As I incanted the spell, a black pillar shot forth, breaking through the outer wall of the training ground.

Releasing my mana, the black pillar vanished, leaving an opening in the wall.

"There's no time to hesitate... I'm counting on you."

".....Okay. I'll bring help as soon as possible. Please stay safe."

I smiled at Luna's words and replied.

"Got it."

As soon as Luna began to run, Serina noticed her and Sylph unleashed blades of wind in her direction.

However, Astina expanded the size of her barrier, successfully repelling all the wind blades aimed at Luna.

I turned my attention to Serina.

"Wind Blaster!"

"Clay!"

In response, Clay dragged a large rock from the ground, obstructing Serina's path.

Although the rock managed to deflect most of my magic, some of it broke through.

"Damn!"

The magic shattered the rock, and its fragments flew toward Serina, causing minor injuries.

I unleashed a barrage of spells.

Serina, however, did not passively endure the onslaught; she used her elementals to fend off the attack.

We fought, the two of us dividing our roles into offense and defense.

Yet, Serina, single-handedly managing both roles, held her ground without faltering.

Under normal circumstances, we should have been gaining the upper hand.

Looking at Astina's expression, I thought I understand why.

"Can you keep using telekinetic magic?"

"...Honestly, it's difficult. I can sustain the telekinetic magic, but it's hard to use other spells at the same time."

The lingering effects of Harpel's scroll were still affecting her.

Even so, we couldn't afford to retreat.

If we were to escape, it would give Serina a chance to run away.

"Then, let's just hold on until help arrives."

".....Understood. Haaah... once this fight is over, I need to learn other intermediate magic."

Her strength lay in her adept utilization of telekinetic magic, renowned for its versatility.

However, she couldn't use other intermediate-level spells effectively enough for practical use.

Her outstanding proficiency with telekinetic magic had led her to be complacent.

While she excelled in basic magic as well, such spells had limitations.

It was impossible to counter all of Serina's attacks with just basic magic.

As our standoff continued, Serina furrowed her brow.

If help joined in, it would result in her loss.

Her gaze then fixated on Priscilla.

After contemplating for a moment, Serina seemed to reach a decision.

"Ah..."

Sylph passed the sword over to Serina.

A sword radiating a blue glow.

It was an exact match to the Priscilla I had seen in the game.

"Astina senior! We must stop her!"

"What?"

Serina is planning to form a contract right here.

She's using it to bring an end to this stalemate.

"Finger of the Demon!!"

"Ack!"

A black pillar jutted up from Serina's position.

Seizing the opportunity, I dashed forward.

"Astina senior! Pull that sword towards me!"

"Sylph!!"

As I shouted, Sylph redirected its focus toward me.

"Rudy!!"

A multitude of wind blades hurtled towards me.

"Wind Blaster!"

As I ran, I used magic to deflect as many attacks as possible, but it wasn't enough to intercept them all.

The blades inflicted cuts on my arms and body, but I didn't stop running and continued towards Serina.

"Clay!"

Serina tried to impede my progress with Clay, but Astina was not just standing by and watching.

"Gravity!"

Astina employed gravity to suppress Clay's movements.

"Grasp."

Without delay, Astina cast another spell.

In an instant, Priscilla was wrenched from Serina's grasp.

The sword soared towards me, and I reached out to claim it.

"I've got it....."

As the sword made contact with my hand, a sensation coursed not through my hand, but my abdomen.

"Ah....."

A wind-formed spear had impaled my stomach.

In the brief moment I had stopped moving, Sylph had launched a powerful attack.

"Cough....."

I felt intense pain, but I kept my focus and clung to the sword.

I crumpled to the ground, sword still in hand.

"Rudy Astria!!!"

Astina cried out, her expression one of astonishment.

And she began to run towards me.

"Sylph, Clay."

Serina took advantage of Astina's confusion and issued commands to her two elementals.

Astina also tried to respond by using magic.

"Psychic Barrier....."

Zap!

"Ah.....?"

Astina abruptly stopped in her tracks.

"The magic didn't activate.....?"

Could it be.....

Was it Ian's magic?

Astina looked at the incoming attack, her expression filled with surprise.

Unable to use any magic.

"At a time like this....."

I tried to use magic, but it was too late.

By the time I get up, the attack would've already landed.

It was my mistake.

I failed to understand Ian's magic.

I placed too much trust in Evan.

I created too many variables and didn't account for them.

Even after altering the storyline, I grew complacent.

It was all my fault.

"Ah....."

The attacks flying toward Astina seemed to be moving in slow motion.

As if time was moving slowly.

I had heard that during a crisis, time could appear this way.

It's even more traumatic as a result.

The sight of someone getting hurt because of my mistake.

It was a desperate situation.

But, I felt something strange.

The elementals' attacks were slowing down, and stopping near Astina.

I stared blankly, unable to understand what was happening.

"Hey, kiddo?"

Then, I heard a somewhat androgynous voice.

"Hey, kiddo~~."

The voice carried a playful tone.

I tried to turn my head to find the owner of the voice, but I couldn't move.

I was Immobilized, I couldn't make the slightest movement.

And then the voice echoed again.

"Kiddo, don't you want to save that lady?"

Yet, I couldn't respond.

My mouth refused move.

"You don't have to voice it. Say it in your head."

Immediately I thought the words.

I want to save her.

Please, I want to save her.

"Is that so? Then let's make a contract."

Ah.....

When I heard those words, I knew who the owner of the voice was.

The sword I held.

"If you make a contract with me, I'll save that lady."

It was Priscilla.

Chapter 42: Homecoming Day (9)

Priscilla.

An elemental with the power to freeze an entire city.

A force that was impossible to ignore.

The full extent of her power hadn't been revealed.

Each of her contractors had failed to fully harness Priscilla's power.

But I'd seen her full might before.

In the later parts of the story, Serina successfully taps into all of Priscilla's power—an overwhelming sight of her standing alone against thousands of soldiers and dozens of wizards.

It was overwhelming.

"So, will you enter a contract?" Priscilla's voice echoed in my mind.

Given her immense power, it was tempting.

But remembering the havoc she had wreaked in the past, her offer seemed more like the devil's whisper.

"Hmm... What's there to consider? Why are you so hesitant?"

Would you jump at the chance if you were me?

I could lose my mind if I messed up.

Even if I could save Astina from Serina's attack, losing control would endanger not just Astina, but everyone else too.

"Come on, agree to the contract. When else will you get such a chance?"

But, if I refuse the contract, I lose the chance to protect Astina.

She'd have to bear the full brunt of the attack herself.

Though she wouldn't lose her life from just it, she'd be incapacitated for the rest of the fight.

I was already severely injured.

My only choice was clear.

'Can I control you?' I asked Priscilla.

"Control? What do you mean? Even with a contract, you're the one using the power, not me."

'Will my sanity hold on if we form a contract?'

At that, Priscilla burst into laughter.

"Control? Huhu... Do you see me as a ticking bomb? I don't know where you got that idea, but I'm not some sort of pervert."

I knew otherwise from many scenes.

However, I didn't have all the details.

I only knew that neither Serina nor her mother could control Priscilla.

"Do you think I enjoy watching my contractors perish? I'm a kind elemental, you know?"

'I can't believe that an elemental that consumes the mind would say that.'

"Hmm... consumes the mind..."

Upon hearing my words, Priscilla pondered for a moment.

"Sure, you need mental fortitude to wield me, but isn't that a small price for the power you gain?"

'You could drive a human mind insane, and you call that a small price?'

"To master other abilities, you need to invest time and effort, but I grant immense power instantly. Isn't that a risk worth taking?"

"And..." Priscilla continued, a note of annoyance in her voice.

"I only provide power. The contractors are the ones who lose control. I never approach those who can't handle me. They're the ones who get drunk on power and destroy themselves."

Realization dawned as I listened.

'So, what if someone unable to handle you wishes to form a contract?'

"Are you talking about Serina?"

I didn't respond, so Priscilla continued in a regretful tone.

"If she genuinely wishes to challenge herself, I will give her the opportunity. But not now."

With that, a hidden part of the story seemed to reveal itself.

Serina must have tried to form a contract with Priscilla, despite not being able to handle her.

Serina's mother had done the same.

And the emotion embedded when she spoke of Serina just now.

Priscilla doesn't want to form a contract with Serina at this time.

That's why she was now trying to form a contract with me.

'So, you're saying the contract can be canceled later?'

"If Serina grows to that extent, I'll break it."

This was rather good news for me.

"Now, has the misunderstanding about me cleared up a bit, kiddo?"

I made up my mind.

'Yes.'

And I told Priscilla my decision.

'Let's form a contract.'

Astina raised her arms, preparing to absorb the impact of the incoming attack.

She closed her eyes tightly, knowing that her arms alone wouldn't be enough to withstand it.

"Uh..."

Bang!

A loud crash rang out in front of her.

It was the sound of a collision.

She opened her eyes and looked ahead.

A blue-furred wolf stood in front of her.

"What..."

She turned to Rudy and saw him using the sword to prop himself up.

"Pri...Priscilla?"

[It's been a while, Serina.]

Priscilla greeted her.

"How..."

[I formed a contract with that guy.]

Priscilla pointed at Rudy, who was barely managing to stand.

"Why...? Why him..."

[I simply formed a contract with someone capable.]

"But... me? You refused to form a contract with me earlier..."

[Serina, you're not ready to handle me yet.]

Priscilla asserted.

"But... without a contract, Priscilla..."

Serina's voice trembled.

[Aren't all your worries resolved at this point?]

"Huh...?"

[I no longer need to be confined to that sword. If the kid allows it, I can meet you whenever.]

"But still..."

[Serina, now is not the time.]

Priscilla calmly walked over to her and placed her right front paw on Serina's head.

Priscilla's touch was soft, as if she were patting it.

[Grow more and return.]

With those words, Priscilla vanished, dissipating like smoke.

Serina dropped her gaze and collapsed on the spot.

Rudy, too, began to lose his balance.

"Rudy!"

Astina raced towards Rudy, catching him just as he was about to fall.

"Uh..."

Rudy, falling into unconsciousness, let out a low moan.

Blood was steadily seeping from his abdomen.

"Rudy Astria!"

Astina frantically covered Rudy's wound with her hand, trying her best to staunch the bleeding.

But if it continued like this, she couldn't even imagine what might happen to him.

Astina was at a loss for what to do next.

"Heal!"

She channeled her mana and attempted to cast a healing spell.

But, there was no change in Rudy's wound.

"We need to get him medical attention fast..."

In a state of panic, Astina attempted to lift Rudy.

They couldn't remain here...

Then, someone gripped Astina's arm.

"Huh?"

"Lay him flat on the ground."

Turning to the voice, Astina found Professor Cromwell standing there.

"Pro...Professor."

And following him were more professors and guards.

The guards detained the fallen Harpel and Eric, while a few professors surrounded Serina, who was recalling her elementals.

"Don't worry, help has arrived," Professor Cromwell reassured Astina as he gently took Rudy from her arms.

Due to the commotion near the Elementalist Department building, most events in the main building were canceled, plunging the entire place into chaos.

Amidst all this, Saintess Haruna was slowly preparing to depart.

She had met everyone she had planned to, and with such a disturbance, there was nothing else to do.

Haruna moved away from the hubbub and towards the carriage sent by the church.

"Hello?"

At the sound of the voice, Haruna turned around.

There stood the First Princess, Rie.

"Ah, Princess Rie. Hello."

Haruna greeted Rie with a warm smile.

"The situation seems quite serious right now, shouldn't you check on things?"

"Hmm... I should, but it looks like things have somewhat settled. More importantly..."

Rie began with a sly smile.

"Why do you keep your eyes covered?"

Rie observed Haruna's reaction as she posed the question.

When Haruna showed no immediate response, she asked again.

"You don't seem to make much effort to hide it?"

Haruna held Rie's gaze.

Rie continued.

"Indeed, you go around with your eyes veiled, leading to many rumors that you're blind. However, upon seeing you now, you hardly seem visually impaired."

Rie stroked her chin as she recounted the rumors she'd heard.

"In the Church and other places, there's little information about you. Your origins, your day-to-day life..."

"Do you mean to suggest that you've been prying into the Saintess' life? That doesn't sound like a good rumor to go around, does it?"

Haruna retorted, a smirk playing on her lips.

"Well, spreading rumors won't do much."

Rie countered, her gaze piercing Haruna sharply.

"What could a Saintess, who abstains from worship and wields no influence within the Church, possibly do to me?"

"You claim to have found little, yet you seem to know quite a bit."

"Regardless, I am the heir to this Empire."

While Rie maintained an aggressive stance, Haruna's remained unruffled, and she responded calmly.

"I'm neither blind nor the Saintess. I'm merely a naïve girl with the ability to glimpse the future."

"What?"

She furrowed her brow at Haruna's sudden revelation.

Haruna spoke too easily.

It was suspicious.

Nonchalantly, Haruna brushed off Rie's wary gaze.

"If you've already delved so deep into my past, you'd have eventually discovered this. What could an ordinary person like me possibly do against a princess?"

Haruna untied the cloth obscuring her eyes and met Rie's stare directly.

"I cover my eyes because I foresee my future blindness."

"Your future?"

"I'm destined to lose my sight. I don't know when or how it will happen... I'm simply undergoing an early adjustment period."

Haruna stated, her smile teasing.

"As for being the Saintess... where to begin..."

Haruna mused, her hand supporting her chin.

Suddenly, as if a realization struck her, she clapped her hands together.

"Oh! Perhaps it's best to withhold that information."

"...What?"

Rie stared at Haruna, bewildered.

"It seems to be the smartest choice. It's better if you remain in the dark."

With that, Haruna made her way toward the carriage.

"Wait! Saintess?"

"You'll discover the truth in due time. Don't fret. As one who can glimpse the future, I can assure you. All you need to know is that I'm not the Saintess."

As Haruna climbed into the carriage, she left Rie with a final remark.

"Gaining knowledge too quickly... can do more bad than good."

Chapter 43: Final Exam (1)

My eyes fluttered open.

I was stuck in the heart of a storm.

Surrounding me were familiar faces like Luna, Rie, and Astina.

I held their hands tightly, pushing through.

Even as the storm tore at me, leaving scratches and bruises, I didn't back down.

A streak of light appeared at the end of the storm.

I strained to reach for it.

But then, I was faced with a choice.

To touch the light, I had to release the hands I was holding.

But, if I didn't grab the light, I felt I would lose it forever.

Suddenly, a cold sensation touched my face.

Cold?

"Uh... huh?"

The chilly touch roused me, causing me to open my eyes.

Was it all just a dream?

"Oh! Rudy!"

As my eyes opened, I saw Luna wiping my face with a damp cloth.

"You're awake!"

Her face was bright as she greeted me.

"Luna, where am I...?"

I looked around.

A fruit basket was perched on a shelf.

I was lying on a white bed, dressed in a patient's gown.

And Luna was sitting beside me.

It appeared to be a hospital room.

"Have I been out for days?"

"You were out for a day. Don't worry."

Luna's calm smile was reassuring.

I was relieved that only a day had passed.

The final exams were nearing, and being out for longer would've caused problems.

"Uh...."

I tried to sit up, only to be met with a sharp pain in my abdomen.

"Rest, Rudy. You're not completely healed. The doctor recommended natural healing over magic, so you might still have some injuries."

The idea of healing everything with magic seemed more appealing given the pain I was in.

With my current state, attending classes at the academy seemed impossible.

"Can't we just use magic to heal?"

"No, we can't."

The door swung open as I said this, and Astina walked in with a doctor in a white coat.

"A wizard's natural healing ability is their lifeline. If the body's healing speed slows down, the speed at which your mana regenerates also slows down."

"Can it get any slower? I need to attend class."

Sure, natural healing is important, but classes are my main concern.

Without attending classes, it's hard to keep up with the studies, and getting good grades becomes a challenge.

Since I didn't have any friends to share notes with, self-study was out of the question.

If I had to take the finals in this state, failing was a certainty.

Astina looked at me, a smile playing on her lips.

"Seems like you're well enough to complain."

The doctor standing next to her chuckled at this.

"Better to rest. This isn't the student council president speaking, but a doctor. You should trust it. Let's check your wound, shall we?"

After inspecting my injury, the doctor assured me that I was healing well and should be able to leave within a week. He then exited the room.

Once the doctor left, I turned my attention to Astina.

"What happened?"

I wasn't overly concerned about Astina's brother, but the situation with Serina did concern me.

"Everything has been sorted out."

Astina replied, a broad smile adorning her face.

"Sorted out...?"

"Yes. Serina was expelled and is being transferred to the capital for trial."

"...What?"

"Hmm?"

I was greatly taken aback.

"Everything has been resolved 'nicely'. Serina will 'nicely' face the consequences of her actions."

"Wha...."

I was at a loss for words.

Things weren't sorted out, things were messed up.

More than messed up.

I still needed Serina for numerous things, but expulsion...

Well, if she was still at the academy, we might've been able to reverse the expulsion somehow.

But the fact that she had already been expelled and even taken to the capital left me reeling.

Taking a deep breath, I asked another question to Astina.

"What...what were the charges...?"

"Don't worry! They've covered everything thoroughly. Attempted murder, theft of a treasure-grade artifact, and more."

Attempted murder? Theft of a treasure-grade artifact?

Had the charges been minor, I could've pulled some strings to get her out.

But with such serious allegations, it was out of my hands.

These were charges that could see her incarcerated for several years at least.

"Ah..."

I'm screwed.

A few days later.

I was lying alone in the hospital room.

It was a weekday, and unlike the weekend when Luna was able to keep me company, she had classes to attend, leaving me on my own.

Still, I wasn't bored.

I discovered I could converse with Priscilla without having to summon her.

I immediately questioned her.

"Serina has been arrested. Aren't you concerned?"

[Why should I worry about her facing the consequences of her actions?]

"But you don't know how she's going to pay for them. And if she ends up in jail, you don't know when you'll see her again."

[It's part of growing up. And if she wants to see me, she'll find a way. I believe Serina has learned a lot from this incident.]

Priscilla's words led to a sigh escaping my lips.

In the game, Serina's growth was always linked to Evan.

She relied more heavily on Evan than the other heroines.

She grew mentally through all the incidents they go through together.

But with her expulsion from the academy, that will no longer be the case.

The prospect of jail was concerning, but the question remained whether she could achieve mental growth independently.

"What a headache."

I stared blankly at the ceiling, deep in thought.

The issue was that there was a significant change in the story.

All incidents involving Serina could be a problem now because of her sudden absence.

However, those related to Priscilla were fine.

Those incidents were not important to the main storyline but were more about Serina's personal growth.

The problematic ones were those that were originally resolved by Serina.

With her sudden absence, there was a huge loss of manpower.

It was like being outnumbered.

The abrupt disappearance of a figure as skilled as Serina means more preparation is needed.

"What a headache..."

This incident has taught me much.

I was now thoroughly entangled in the main storyline.

Backing out is no longer an option.

While the main story's structure remained intact, minor incidents had been drastically altered.

All these events were changing due to the ripple effect of my actions.

The Butterfly Effect.

My seemingly insignificant actions were causing major shifts in events, much like the butterfly effect.

This incident was no different.

Serina's disappearance would likely lead to an even greater butterfly effect.

And since I caused this butterfly effect, it was my responsibility to address it.

"When will Evan actually do something..."

My frustration began to bubble up.

The protagonist merely buried himself in studies, not helping whatsoever.

I was changing the story to survive, I suppose it can't be helped...

But he should at least contribute something.

"This... so-called protagonist..."

[What are you grumbling about?]

"It's nothing you need to worry about...."

I said to Priscilla, sighing heavily.

"But it's nearly vacation time..."

Exams weren't yet over, but the holidays were coming up.

Ah, sweet vacation...

In the game, vacation truly was a period of rest.

A time free from incidents, ideal for comfortable training.

If I could just manage the exams well, I too would have a break.

I could train in dark magic... I could learn to handle Priscilla... and other magic too...

It was a 'break', but most importantly it was a period devoid of life-threatening situations.

But I couldn't exactly relax.

"But what's really troubling are the final exams..."

-Knock Knock

"Hey Rudy, I'm coming in."

The person behind the door entered even before I could respond.

"Why bother knocking if you're just going to barge in?"

The uninvited guest was Rie.

"You seem to be doing better than I expected? Luna made it sound like you were on death's door."

"Try getting stabbed in the abdomen. Then you'll understand."

Each time I tried to sit up, a sharp pain coursed through my belly, making it impossible to assume a comfortable position.

At this, Rie chuckled and settled herself in the chair opposite me.

I glared at her as I began,

"Why are you here on a weekday when you were nowhere to be seen over the weekend?"

At that, Rie sported a broad grin.

"Hmm~? Did you miss me because I didn't visit?"

"Yes, I did miss you."

I was slightly annoyed.

Not having many friends, and with Rie failing to show up, had made me feel a little lonely.

At my candid admission, Rie's eyes widened in surprise.

"You missed me even though you have Luna and Astina?"

"What?"

I narrowed my eyes at Rie.

Why were Luna and Astina suddenly part of the conversation?

Before I could pose the question, Rie crossed her arms and smirked.

"In that case, I'll make it a point to visit first next time."

Seeing her delighted expression, I refrained from saying anything more.

While I would have probably felt the same if Luna or Astina had failed to visit, I didn't think it necessary to spoil Rie's mood by mentioning that.

"So, why didn't you visit earlier?"

At that, Rie pulled out papers from her bag and handed it to me.

The papers contained information related to Serina.

"I couldn't just sit idle when unpleasant things were happening at the academy, being a part of the student council and all."

In essence, she had dealt with the matter herself.

The document listed charges against Serina, all meticulously detailed.

Judging from the gravity of these crimes, it seemed highly improbable that Serina would ever return to the academy.

"Haah... good job."

"That's it?"

Rie retorted, a frown forming on her face.

Her disgruntled appearance made me feel a bit uncomfortable.

She seemed to have exaggerated various crimes as if to take revenge for me, so should I be grateful...?

Looking somewhat irritated, Rie began rummaging through her bag again.

"Here, you'll probably appreciate this more."

Rie produced a few more documents.

"And what are these?"

"Notes from the classes you missed."

A chill ran down my spine.

Suddenly, Rie appeared to be wreathed in a halo, like a messiah descending from the heavens.

"Ri... Rie you...!"

"Yes, I thought you'd appreciate something like this more. Consider it a get-well gift."

Rie chuckled as she handed me the papers.

Though it was rather unconventional to receive lecture notes as a get-well gift, they were precisely what I needed at the moment.

I had been worrying about how to catch up with the classes after being discharged, so it was a great relief.

"If you stumble upon anything you don't comprehend, don't hesitate to ask. I'll assist if I can."

"Rie...! You truly are the best friend!"

With a thumbs-up, I expressed my gratitude.

I agree Evan is absolutely useless.

Another chap later today.

3/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 44: Final Exam (2)

The wind danced on a clear day.

If it were a bit cooler, it would've been a nice breeze.

But the day was heating up, so the wind felt warm rather than refreshing.

In this hot weather, many students were training hard in the training hall.

They swung their swords, pausing only to wipe the sweat off their brows.

The indoor training hall buzzed with the intensity of students practicing swordsmanship.

Among these diligent students, one stood out.

A girl with silver hair, swinging a gleaming rapier with speed.

Her movements were unpredictable, with no excessive movements to them.

She seemed to target only the essential points of a person's body.

Her swordsmanship was beyond ordinary student standards.

"Wow... Is that the skill level required to get into the academy?"

"It's as if she's wielding moonlight."

As her silver hair whipped through the air with her movements, she seemed to be dancing in a cascade of moonlight.

Other students stole glances at her, awe-struck by her skill, while practicing their own swordplay.

Of course, most didn't realize that her movements were those of a trained assassin.

They simply saw an exceptional swordswoman.

"Haah...."

The girl, Yeniei, put down her sword and started wiping off sweat, aware of the increasing gazes around her.

'I'm overdoing it.'

She hadn't planned to draw so much attention.

She just wanted to train like any other student, but as her thoughts wandered, her body moved of its own accord.

What had Yeniei so deep in thought was none other than Rudy Astria.

Rudy Astria's standing in the academy was changing.

Not only had he repelled outsiders who plotted and infiltrated the academy on homecoming day, but he also thwarted Serina's attempt to steal a priceless sword.

The academy was buzzing with the news.

If asked who the strongest first-year student was, everyone would point to Serina, who consistently ranked first.

The Elementalist Department students were stronger than others in their year because of their unique abilities.

And so, Serina, undoubtedly the top of the Elementalist Department, was thought to be the strongest.

But Rudy Astria had stopped her.

Given these events, everyone began to reconsider their opinions of him.

A student excelling not just in academics but also combat.

And now, they had to rethink his character, given how he repelled the intruders.

-Actually, isn't Rudy Astria a nice guy?

Upon reflection, he hadn't done anything notably bad.

The bullying incident had been a misunderstanding.

-But... what about the rumors from the family...

The majority of the students started to see Rudy Astria in a more positive light.

While some still felt uneasy due to his past reputation, it was clear that the public opinion of Rudy Astria was improving.

This change sparked Yaniel's curiosity.

When she was trained as an assassin for the rebel faction, she was taught about her enemies and the activities of certain nobles.

When they taught her about the Astria family, Rudy Astria's name came up.

They described him as a careless young master.

A man who would be nothing without the Astria family.

They told her that he was merely a pawn for the Astria family to use and discard.

But the reality in front of her eyes was different.

He was now the talk of the academy.

He was in the spotlight during the midterm camp and again on homecoming day.

Once could be due to luck, but twice was a pattern.

And she heard that he had a hand in the library fire incident as well.

However, besides the homecoming day event, the other incidents didn't draw much attention to Rudy Astria.

All the praise went to others.

The common thread was that all those people were close to Rudy Astria.

Yeniel felt like she was onto something.

Could Rudy Astria be a low-key powerhouse?

A hidden puppet master, who keeps a low profile.

Seeing things that way, it all seemed to make sense.

He gives his own merits to those around him and helps them grow.

Then, he hides in their shadows and pulls the strings.

Hidden from the world.

Yeniel remembered something her master said when she was an assassin.

-Yeniel... The truly powerful do not reveal themselves. Those who manipulate from behind the scenes, they are the real power.

-Eh? What about emperors and dukes? Are they weak?

-...Why are you asking questions?

Back then, she thought her master was just rambling. But now, his words seemed to make sense.

Rudy Astria seemed to be living proof of her master's teachings.

He was influencing the world without making his presence known.

Rie becomes the emperor, and Astina inherits the Persia family.

These two will then become the focal points of the Royal faction.

And Rudy Astria is from the Astria family, which is on the opposite side.

Considering that Ian Astria, who usually didn't show up, attended this homecoming day, it seemed that he and Rudy weren't on bad terms.

So, he might be in a position to influence both the Royal and Noble factions, without holding any title himself.

"A fearsome guy..."

Perhaps his effort to blend into the academy crowd was also part of his plan.

Masking his true nature...

Yeniell's mind wandered back to the midterm camp period.

The image of Rudy, unflinching even in the face of a surprise attack.

As if foreseeing the ambush, he overpowered her with a single move.

The memory sent shivers down her spine.

Who could dare label such a man a fool, or a disposable pawn of the Astria family?

Such rumors wouldn't have spread without deliberate action.

Could the spread of those rumors have been Rudy Astria's doing?

Yeniël shivered, her brows furrowing.

"How far ahead has he planned...!"

But even with these suspicions, she was powerless.

She was bound to Astina.

The magic binding her heart could end her life.

"Should I consider myself fortunate to be under his wing?"

Yeniël was an assassin affiliated with the Rebels, but she had no grand purpose driving her actions.

She simply did what she did because it was the only path available to her.

So, even if Rudy Astria was orchestrating a sinister scheme, she didn't care as long as she remained unaffected.

However, knowing such an individual existed within the same academy...

"I should warn Evan to be careful."

Evan wasn't connected to Rudy Astria, but he was the only person aware of Yeniël's circumstances.

Initially, Serina was also in the loop, but she had been taken to the capital.

So, Evan was the only person Yeniël could confide in.

If, by any chance, Evan made a misstep with Rudy Astria and he vanished without a trace...

Yeniël wiped away her sweat and cleaned her sword, lost in her thoughts.

Then, she left to study for the final exam with Evan.

"Huh? Rie already brought them?"

Luna, unloading a stack of notes she had gathered from friends, was taken aback by the news that Rie had already delivered some yesterday.

She had gathered these notes by asking her friends for their help.

However, hearing that he had already received the same set of notes, dampened her spirits.

"Oh, looking at them closer, these notes are different. Thank you so much, Luna."

"No, no! It's only natural for me to help as a friend."

After exchanging a few words with Rudy, Luna left the room.

"So he already had them..."

Luna muttered to herself, her expression crestfallen.

Luna felt a great deal of guilt towards Rudy.

While her recent research had been progressing well, and she had been sharing her results with Rudy, it felt like it wasn't enough.

The opportunity to attend the academy was thanks to Rudy, and the fact that she couldn't help him when he got injured fighting Serina last time still gnawed at her.

'If only I were stronger, there wouldn't have been a need to involve others...'

Luna felt a strong desire to do something more for Rudy.

However, she couldn't come up with any ideas.

"Hmm..."

Just as she was about to head to the library with a dejected expression.

"Ah, young lady. You're a friend of Rudy's, aren't you?"

The nurse managing the ward addressed Luna.

The nurse recognized Luna, as she was often at Rudy's bedside when he was unconscious.

With a somber expression, Luna responded to the nurse.

"Can I truly call myself a friend of Rudy..."

".....What?"

Caught off guard by her own words, Luna hastily waved her hands.

"No...No! Is there something you need?"

"Oh, could you give this to Rudy? It's his hospital bill, and the academy has requested immediate payment."

"Ah, thank you."

"No, I should be the one thanking you."

The nurse handed Luna the bill and walked away.

As Luna examined the bill, she noticed Rudy's student details.

The details were not extensive, just the basic information.

"Huh...?"

Among these details, one piqued her interest.

Rudy's birth date was noted there.

His birthday was the same day as the final exam.

"Birth...day?"

Luna started counting the days remaining until the final exam.

"So there are 10 days left...!"

Luna clenched her fist.

Her motivation sparked anew.

"A birthday gift!"

The day the final exams conclude.

That's when she would present him with a gift.

She believed that a post-exam gift would be genuinely appreciated by Rudy.

"But...what should I give him?"

In truth, there wasn't much she could offer as a gift.

Anything she bought wouldn't hold much value for Rudy.

With all her money going into research fees, she had none left for herself.

Rudy was also wealthy enough to support her financially.

Although the sentiment behind a gift outweighs its price tag, a cheap gift might be disappointing.

So, she needed something more unique.

And only one option came to mind.

"Should I make it myself...?"

If it's a handmade gift... it would hold a value that money can't buy...

"But...would it be too much?"

Various scenarios played out in Luna's mind.

From Rudy joyfully accepting the gift to him discarding the awkwardly crafted item...

While Rudy probably wouldn't outright discard the item, she was still worried.

After an internal struggle, Luna reached a decision.

"I'll make him a gift!"

She believed it would be fine if it was a gift filled with her gratitude.

I forgot I said I would post this later yesterday... Whoops.

Thanks to your comments, I only just realized Rie got friendzoned... Dunno how that slipped over my head.

4/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 45: Final Exam (3)

A few days later.

Finally, I was well enough to leave the hospital.

Originally, the doctor suggested a few more days of rest.

But I begged for an early discharge, tired of being cooped up in the hospital room.

Then it was time for magic practice class.

"Oh, Rudy Astria. Are you sure you should be out of the hospital so soon?"

Professor Cromwell looked at me, concern etching his features.

Rie mirrored him, her expression just as worried.

"I couldn't bear to stay cooped up in there any longer."

The truth was, it wasn't that bad.

In fact, I'd slept a lot and enjoyed a well-deserved break.

Yes, I did study some, but without my regular training and the books I needed, it wasn't as productive.

I thought about asking Rie and Luna to bring me books, but they had already been kind enough to visit.

I didn't want to trouble them further.

In the end, I had just rested.

A touch of anxiety lingered, but my body welcomed the rare break.

Professor Cromwell gave a soft chuckle.

"You're a bit like Robert, surprisingly."

"Professor Robert? How?" I asked, furrowing my brows.

I couldn't understand the comparison.

"You're similar in that aspect too. Let's start the class."

With that, Cromwell kicked off the lesson.

Following the class wasn't too hard.

Rie had given me the notes from the classes I missed and explained them well, helping me catch up fast.

And, with only two students in the class, Professor Cromwell could easily answer any questions I had.

"Let's wrap up for today."

"Thank you for your hard work."

Rie and I expressed our gratitude to Professor Cromwell and began to gather our books.

"Hey, Rudy."

"Yeah?"

She turned to me.

"Do you know what Luna has been up to lately?"

"Luna?"

I was about to say that she was obviously preparing for the final exams when I remembered something Luna had said.

She said something unexpected when I suggested we go to the library together today.

-Sorry! I have something else to do.....

Although I've declined her offers before, Luna turning me down was a surprise.

Even when I asked Riku and Ena, I didn't get a clear answer.

All they told me was she was busy with something.

I was slightly puzzled by the sly grin on their faces, but I shrugged it off.

"She mentioned she was occupied with something else."

Upon hearing this, Rie thought for a moment before gathering her book.

"I see. I better head out, then."

With that, Rie exited the classroom, a knowing look on her face.

"Rie, I hate to ask, but could you do me a favor?"

Days earlier, Luna had approached Rie with a request.

"A favor? What kind?"

"Well... could you help me find a mana stone? A friend from the alchemy department said they're tricky to find...."

"A mana stone? What do you need it for?"

Rie tilted his head, puzzled.

"I'm trying to make a magic tool... Is it too much?"

Luna asked hesitantly.

'A magical tool...? But finals are around the corner.'

Rie thought.

Acquiring a mana stone wasn't tough in itself.

However, Luna's sudden mention of crafting a magic tool was suspicious.

There was nothing about magic tools in the finals, right?

She knew Luna wasn't overly worried about her grades, but she wasn't one to mess around before an exam either.

She was a very dedicated friend.

It meant there was something else.

Rie wondered if Rudy had something to do with it.

But on second thought, that didn't seem likely either.

If Rudy needed it, he would've approached her directly, not Luna.

"Alright, I'll get it to you tomorrow."

"Really? Thank you, Rie!"

Luna's face lit up with a bright smile.

Rie felt there was more to it.

She subtly asked Rudy, but he seemed just as clueless.

Walking down the corridor, Rie mulled it over.

"Luna's crafting a magical tool..."

Luna wasn't particularly close to many.

Her classmates liked her, but she was only close to a few.

And she wasn't close to the professors either.

As far as Rie knew, no one around Luna would ask her to craft a magical tool.

"So, she's doing it on her own..."

Why would she choose to make a magic tool during finals?

There must be a reason.

That day, Rie tasked Locke with finding out why.

"Find out why Luna is making a magic tool."

"... Luna Railer?"

Locke stared at Rie.

"Yes, Luna Railer. Is there another Luna here?"

Rie grumbled, her brows furrowed.

It was out of concern.

When Rie heard Rudy had been injured, her heart dropped.

She realized how upsetting it was to learn someone she cared about had been hurt.

Such an emotion was new to her.

At the royal palace, she had no close friends.

Just like Rudy, Luna might be in trouble, right?

So, she thought it necessary to be prepared.

The following day.

"Luna appears to be planning a birthday present for Rudy Astria."

"...What?"

Rie's eyes widened at Locke's words.

"Rudy... his birthday is coming up?"

"Yes, the day of the final exam coincides with Rudy Astria's birthday. She also bought a gift box."

Rie abruptly rose from her chair.

"Locke."

"Yes."

"From now on, your task is to determine the most suitable birthday gifts for a friend."

Locke paused before responding.

"...For a friend?"

Rie shot Locke a stern look.

Her face started to flush, and she held her lips tightly together.

After a moment, she spoke, her voice barely above a whisper.

"That... Yes, we are...we're friends, so what..."

"Understood."

With a nod, Locke left the room.

"Professor, how have you been?"

I paid Professor Robert a visit after a while.

"Ah, you've returned to the land of the living."

He greeted me with a wave, chewing on a piece of bread in his other hand.

"How does it feel to have your gut stabbed? Your experience with dark magic must've made it easier, right?"

"Does dark magic backlash really compare to a stab to the stomach...? Also, why didn't you come to see me even once?"

"Why would I visit you? It's not like your injury was my fault."

"But, I'm your dear student, aren't I?"

"Dear student, huh... You're far from being dear or a student, you rascal."

I couldn't help but chuckle at Professor Robert's blunt retort.

Most people at the academy avoided such language to preserve their dignity, so hearing such cursing was a breath of fresh air.

"Now, why are you here? Aren't you supposed to be studying?"

"I just came to check in. Thought I'd share how demanding training has been."

"Alright, ease off the training for a bit and avoid using dark magic. If you're reckless, your wound could reopen. And here, take this."

Professor Robert tossed a book my way.

It was Luna's spellbook.

"I've extracted almost everything of importance."

I had entrusted Luna's spellbook to Professor Robert for a while.

Since I needed to return the grimoire to Luna, I planned on making a copy of its contents.

Though I was concerned about handing the book over to Professor Robert, I gave him the benefit of the doubt.

I trusted a professor at the academy wouldn't do such a thing.

Robert paused, pondering, before he began to speak.

"The book's owner is Luna Railer, correct?"

"Yes, that's correct."

"Make sure you never reveal that book to anyone else."

"What?"

I wore a puzzled expression.

"I won't restrict you from using it, but never hand it over to anyone else. This book isn't created in a conventional way."

"Isn't it expected, given its unique nature?"

If it were possible to mass-produce infinite-use scrolls in a conventional way, they would've already flooded the market.

Professor Robert sighed.

"That's not what I'm saying. If Levian created such an exceptional book and then vanished, there has to be a reason."

His words reminded me of a conversation I had with Rie and Astina previously.

The cause of Levian's disappearance.

Actually, Rie told me she would find the truth, but she hasn't given any updates.

Rie usually has a knack for speedy investigations, but even after months, there's been no information on Levian.

Someone is deliberately concealing facts, making it difficult for even Rie to discover them.

Professor Robert carried on.

"I've been studying that grimoire, and it contains several formulas and ingredients I've never seen before."

"Unknown ingredients....."

"Steer clear of trouble if you can. You've been in a lot of strange events recently; this will only cause more trouble."

I chuckled lightly.

His concern for me was unmistakable.

"Why didn't you come to visit if you're so concerned?"

"Haa... wouldn't a squabble over who gets to play nurse cause you more distress?"

"....Huh?"

I questioned Professor Robert's sudden odd remark.

"There's such a thing."

Are people finding it trendy to randomly say things nowadays?

Rie also did the same.

Given I'm not one to pry into matters that others clearly aren't willing to share, I simply nodded and returned to my studies.

5/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 46: Final Exam (4)

"I'm leaving."

Locke had finished his business at the student council office and now needed to prepare for upcoming exams.

He was no exemplary student but he did what was necessary.

"Locke, wait."

Astina called out to Locke.

He pivoted to face her, brow arched in question.

"What's up?"

Astina seemed to hesitate for a moment, her gaze fixed on him.

Then, as if she had made up her mind, she opened her mouth.

"Um... can I ask you something?"

"Go ahead."

"What's a guy's reaction when an upperclassman asks him out for a meal?"

"On what day? What kind of meal?"

A sense of déjà vu washed over Locke.

He had seen this scene play out before - with Rie.

Whenever she asked such questions, the typically decisive Rie would transform into a timid girl.

It was similar with Astina now, though she seemed to manage better than Rie.

"Suppose it's on a birthday... at a restaurant. No specific reason, just thought of treating him on his birthday."

Locke's suspicions were confirmed.

His detective work, under Rie's orders, had pointed to one conclusion: the only upcoming birthday was Rudy Astria's.

The situation was complicated, however.

Recently, Rie had been trying to figure out the perfect gift for Rudy Astria.

The issue was the timing of the gift - was it during a birthday dinner or just a casual handover in the evening?

If Rie intended to also have dinner with Rudy, things could become complicated.

After some thought, Locke came up with a reply.

"That sounds fine."

He decided to let Rudy Astria make the choice.

Locke didn't want to meddle in someone else's romantic affairs.

Besides, he was hardly qualified to give advice in such matters.

He figured it was best they resolved their issues on their own.

The day of the final exams arrived.

Final exams didn't bring the same stress as midterms, but I couldn't shake a sense of unease.

Before the hospitalization, I'd spent much of my study time practicing dark magic.

I couldn't avoid feeling a bit anxious, knowing I hadn't prepared as thoroughly as before.

However, with the answer sheets I received from Astina and a post-hospital cramming session, I was hopeful about earning a decent grade.

"Evan must have been studying hard, right?"

While I'd been struggling, he'd been focused on his studies.

It would be a real injustice if he wasn't the top student after that.

Evan was in a far better study environment than in the game.

I did all the hard work and gave the rewards, like Andrei's sword, to him.

The nobles hadn't troubled him, and he could focus purely on his studies.

The only difference from the game was he didn't resent me since I hadn't done anything wrong.

I don't think the protagonist would dramatically change just because there was no one to hate.

Evan was not a character fueled by hatred, and it didn't align with his personality.

"Still, I should check on him later."

This semester had been busy, and I hadn't paid much attention to Evan.

He was doing well independently, but as time passed, I needed to involve myself a bit more.

Being a fair rival would help stimulate his growth.

"Haah... let's stop thinking about other things and start focusing on the final exam..."

I shook my head and whispered to myself.

I quickly glanced over my notes, recollecting what I had committed to memory.

"Rudy Astria."

It was Astina's voice. I looked around.

This was definitely the location for the first-year exams.

The second-year exam hall was some distance away.

"Senior Astina, shouldn't you be heading to your exam?"

"Ah, I wanted to talk to you about something."

"To me?"

Astina hesitated for a moment, then finally spoke.

"How about dinner together tonight?"

Dinner?

"There's a restaurant I've been wanting to try. Maybe we could talk over dinner..."

"Sure, I don't mind."

With exams ending today, I didn't see a problem.

"Great! Let's meet at the dormitory around 5 in the afternoon."

"Got it."

I nodded and headed towards the examination hall.

I entered the room where the exam would be held and took my seat.

I hadn't been studying much lately, but I'd put in significant time before that.

My routine had been relentless — training, studying, managing the story without a break.

There's no way my efforts would betray me.

I'm anxious, but I know I'll be fine once I have the test questions in front of me.

Even during the last exam, I was extremely anxious until the test paper was in front of me.

Despite that, I managed to solve all the problems smoothly.

Success breeds a unique kind of confidence, an assurance that you won't fail.

A smirk playing on my lips, I muttered to myself, "I'll prove it through the results."

"Ughh...."

The exam hit me harder than expected.

It didn't just break me; it trampled me.

The malicious professors had outdone themselves.

"What, what? Isn't this extreme?"

The exam had surpassed the difficulty level of the midterms and exceeded any I had ever taken.

What grudges did these professors hold against us to set such brutal exam questions?

Still, the struggling students around me offered some relief.

But I couldn't be sure if the top students felt the same.

The top tier is, quite literally, a different world.

As soon as the exam was over, I rushed to find Luna.

Luna was a prodigy who'd placed fifth in the last exam.

Her reaction would be a good indicator of how the top students found the exam.

"Luna....!"

I flung open the door to Luna's exam room and rushed in.

I knew instantly how difficult it was.

"Luna, it's okay... you'll do better next time."

"Luna... I know the exam was tough. But it's okay."

Ena and Riku were near Luna, trying to comfort her.

The usually animated Luna was in her seat, her face blank.

Her vibrancy was gone, her color faded to gray.

She was pale, white as a sheet.

Even Luna wasn't immune to the professors' tyranny....

Seeing Luna's distraught state left me at a loss for words.

I didn't need to ask about her exam.

As I was about to close the classroom door, a familiar voice rang out.

"I must be insane.... I should've studied more...."

I turned to find Rie.

Rie was pacing the hallway, murmuring to herself with a wild look in her eyes.

"Rie."

She jerked as I called her name.

"....."

Rie stared at me. Then...

"You! This is all your fault!"

She seized my collar, shaking me vehemently.

"Hey! What! Why me!"

Rie was shaking me around, her grip tight on my collar.

Rie wasn't particularly strong, so it didn't hurt, but it was a bizarre experience being shaken so vigorously.

Her loud exclamations began drawing attention.

I hastily tapped Rie's shoulder.

"Hey, people are watching."

"Aaaaah!"

She ignored my words, continuing her howling.

"Huh? Rudy? Rie?"

Luna noticed us as Rie continued to cause a commotion.

"Lu... Luna, help--."

"Aaaaahhh!!!"

Rie wouldn't stop shaking me.

"Why is she doing this...?"

"I-I have no id-id-idea."

I didn't intend to stutter, but due to the constant shaking, my words came out jumbled.

Watching us, Luna let out an awkward chuckle.

Then, with caution, she spoke.

"Ah, Rudy... Are you free tonight?"

"...!"

Rie abruptly stopped shaking me at Luna's words.

"Tonight?"

"Yes! How about dinner together?"

Rie swiftly raised her head, locking eyes with Luna.

Feeling a tension crackle between them, I grew even more perplexed.

"What's happening...?"

Bewildered, my gaze darted between them.

Chapter 47: Final Exam (5)

"How did it end up like this?"

Astina, frowning, posed this question to me.

"Wouldn't it be nicer if we all ate together?"

I knew well that it wasn't the plan.

But still, wouldn't it be strange if we left out the others?

The exams were over, the semester was done.

It was a time to unwind over a meal.

Rie, cutting her steak with a stoic face, took a bite and mumbled.

"This steak isn't all that great."

Upon hearing this, Luna, mouth full of steak, tilted her head.

"It's tasty... um...?"

Her words were muffled due to her full mouth, but I grasped the gist of it.

Rie and Astina appeared slightly dissatisfied, chewing on their steaks.

Luna, on the other hand, was thoroughly enjoying her meal.

As was I.

This wasn't the high-end meal I had during midterms.

However, it was still a quality meal.

Clatter, clatter.

Luna was a bit clumsy with her knife, making clattering sounds as she cut her steak.

Watching Luna, I noticed her mouth smeared with oil.

Watching her eat, with smears of oil around her mouth, reminded me of a child.

Oddly, it wasn't an unpleasant sight.

Doesn't it warm your heart to see a young child eating heartily?

"Luna, here."

I picked up the napkin next to me and offered it to Luna.

"Hmm?"

Luna looked puzzled, unsure of what it was for.

"Here."

I leaned towards Luna and wiped the oil off her mouth with the napkin.

Luna's eyes widened, and she grabbed the napkin,

"I-I'll do it!"

"Sure."

She seemed embarrassed at having gotten oil on her face while eating.

She quickly wiped her mouth, her face blushing.

Clatter, clatter, clatter, clatter.

Beside me, Rie began to cut her steak as if she meant to cut through the plate itself.

She gave me a piercing look, as if she had a bone to pick with me.

"And what's your deal?"

"It's none of your business. Brat."

Wasn't she the one who grabbed my collar and shook me earlier...

I feel wronged.

What did I do to deserve this?

Our meal was slowly winding down.

We had finished the main course, and now coffee and dessert were being served.

Luna, having finished her dessert, stood up.

"Oh, that reminds me, Rudy, I have a present for you."

"...A present?"

Luna then took out a small box from her pocket, presenting it to me with a bright smile.

"...?"

Baffled, I took the gift.

Rie too rose from her seat and produced a paper box from somewhere.

"Here...take this."

"What's this for?"

"We-well, it's a gift."

Rie handed me the gift, not expressing another word. She seemed shy.

I stared at Rie, puzzled.

Why was she giving me a gift?

What's special about today?

Astina, observing my confused expression, chimed in.

"Happy birthday, Rudy Astria."

"...?"

"Happy birthday, Rudy!"

"...???"

Rie gave me a strange look.

"You didn't know today was your birthday, huh."

With that, everything fell into place.

Today is my birthday.

I was taken aback.

A typical noble wouldn't be ignorant of their birthday.

Nobles would usually throw grand parties on their birthdays.

These celebrations were also networking opportunities with nobles from neighboring territories.

There's no way I could forget a day marked annually by a grand party.

Organizing a grand party takes months of preparation.

It's not a date one easily forgets.

If you prepare late, it's a subpar party.

Now, how do I explain my forgetfulness without being suspicious?

I glanced around cautiously.

To my surprise, everyone seemed unfazed.

"Well, that's so typical of you." Rie chided me.

I frowned. Sure, I was relieved they weren't suspicious, but their knowing looks made me feel annoyed.

"What did you even do back at home?"

Rie's gaze was pitiful as she asked.

"Haha....."

Honestly, I'm curious too.

How did I live in the mansion?

All I could do was laugh awkwardly.

"Rudy, open the gift."

Upon Luna's prompt, I placed the gift on the table.

I started by unwrapping Luna's gift.

Inside was a ring with a black stone set in it.

"I made this ring myself! Hoho!"

Luna beamed, puffing out her chest in pride as she explained about the ring.

"I crafted a protective spell using Wind Ball magic!"

"You applied Wind Ball magic?"

"Yes! I'll show you the magic circle later!"

"Thank you, Luna."

"Hehe....."

She giggled, scratching her head.

Next, I unwrapped Rie's gift.

Inside was a bottle of men's cologne.

"Hmm... It's a fine cologne. Make good use of it."

"Uh... Thank you."

Though the wrapping was a bit peculiar.

It was filled with heart patterns.

I wondered if heart-patterned wrapping was a typical choice for a birthday gift.

When I glanced around, both Astina and Luna looked shocked.

"...What? Why?"

Rie looked puzzled at their reactions.

"Rie... Giving cologne as a gift..."

Luna cautiously began, and Astina continued.

"Gifting cologne to a man is something typically reserved for lovers, especially a high-end fragrance like this."

Rie was visibly taken aback.

"Ah, ah, no! Locke told me it was an appropriate gift! He said it's a popular gift in the Empire!!"

Rie abruptly stopped talking, her eyes widened as she came to a realization.

"That jerk Locke tricked me."

Saying that, she shot me a look.

Her expression was a mix of dismay and surprise, her lips sealed in tight determination.

"It's not like that. I genuinely didn't know."

I couldn't help but chuckle.

"What did you even do at the Royal Palace?"

It's only fair, right?

Give and take, that's how the world works.

Rie glared at me, her cheeks puffed out in anger.

Meanwhile, Astina shifted her attention from a fuming Rie to me.

"Rudy Astria, I couldn't prepare a separate gift."

"Ah, that's fine. I didn't even know it was my birthday."

Astina had reserved this restaurant, which was a gift in itself.

"Instead, I'd like to discuss something else."

"Oh? What is it?"

"It's about the incident with my older brother."

I frowned at the mention of it.

"Was there a problem?"

Astina smiled reassuringly.

"No, not at all. He is facing severe punishment. In fact, my father is pushing for an even harsher sentence."

I felt a wave of relief.

"That's good to hear."

Astina continued, "However, that's not why I brought it up. My father wanted to apologize and thank you. He was quite worried about you getting hurt."

"I wasn't injured because of them, tell him not to worry."

I was unharmed, so there was no reason for Astina's father to feel guilty.

And after all, it wasn't the parents who were at fault, it was Harpel himself.

Considering Astina's usual behavior and her parents' reaction now, they seemed to be decent parents.

Harpel was the anomaly.

Astina, hearing Rudy's words, smiled and proposed an idea.

"Why not convey this message yourself when you visit our territory?"

"Me...?"

"My father is keen on meeting you as well. You've piqued his interest."

I contemplated the proposal for a moment.

I had planned to spend the holidays training at the academy, but perhaps a short visit wouldn't hurt.

Besides, training non-stop would drive me mad.

"Sure, I'll visit during the holiday."

Rie suddenly jumped in.

"When? When will you go?"

"... Why do you want to know?"

Rie looked sullen at my response.

Astina chuckled at the sight.

"Just let us know when you plan on coming."

"Yes, I'll let you know a week prior."

With that, we finished our meal and headed back to the dormitory.

2/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 48: Final Exam (6)

The chirping of birds echoed in the early morning air.

The recent days had been hot, but a cool breeze prevailed during the mornings.

Yeniel was warming up in the sports field.

A sigh escaped her as she prepared for her daily workout routine.

Her day started at dawn.

A ritual from her time as an assassin involving stretches and meditation to condition her body and mind.

Over the years, this routine had become second nature.

Skipping it would make her feel sluggish all day.

So she continued her exercises, then took a shower.

Fresh and rejuvenated, she headed towards the classroom.

On the way, she noticed teaching assistants updating a board.

They were posting rankings—likely the newly announced grades.

Though grades weren't her priority, Yeniel was curious about her rank, since Evan had been teaching her.

She moved closer to examine the rankings:

Evan

Of course, Evan held the top spot. It was predictable, given his diligent studying habits. Her gaze scanned the rest of the list.

Rudy Astria

Yeniel

Rie Von Ristonia

...

".....?"

Puzzled, Yeniel scrutinized the grades. She blinked and double-checked the bulletin board. It remained unchanged.

"Oh! Isn't this Yeniel, the pride of our Swordsmanship Department!"

A burly professor from the Swordsmanship Department strode towards her, his booming laughter resonating in the corridor.

His massive muscles were a testament to his hard work.

"Hello."

Politely, Yeniel greeted him and gestured towards the board.

"It seems.....the grades are a bit strange...."

"Heh heh heh! Modesty, eh? Fitting for the pride of the Swordsmanship Department!"

Bewildered, Yeniel looked at the professor.

"With your top score in swordsmanship and you aced the general knowledge exam, that rank is no surprise! You even surpassed that so-called wise princess! Truly, you're our department's pride. Ha ha ha!"

The professor chortled, walking away after adding, "Can't wait to see Cromwell's face!"

".....???"

Meanwhile, in his office, Professor Cromwell was staring at the grade report, sighing.

"Haaah... These kids..."

Professor Cromwell stared at the grade sheet spread across his desk.

The top students' scores had taken a serious hit.

It wasn't a matter of one or two students; the average score had dipped significantly.

While Evan's performance was stable, both Rudy and Rie's grades had plummeted.

"This is a disgrace to the Magic Department....."

The Magic Department was traditionally at the top of the academy's academic leaderboard.

Not so much a tradition as an inevitable fact.

Excelling in the Swordsmanship Department or other fields required physical training.

Students who opted for the Swordsmanship Department came not to study, but to train.

Naturally, they didn't have as much time to hit the books.

But Yeniel was an exception.

As a former assassin, she was already proficient in swordsmanship and martial arts.

All she needed was to polish those skills and develop her sword aura.

High grades in swordsmanship, combined with ample study time, resulted in her stellar performance.

Unaware of this, Professor Cromwell was left puzzled.

"But this student..."

Cromwell glanced at the lower part of the report card.

Luna Railer

"Why has her score fallen so much?"

"Haah...."

Luna walked aimlessly, yawning.

Upset over the previous day's exam, she had cheered up after a delightful dinner with Rudy.

She figured everyone found the test tough, Rudy and Rie included.

"It can't be that bad, right?"

Just as Luna thought that, her spirits took a nosedive.

"No, this can't be."

From a mid-term rank of fifth, she had plummeted to thirty-fifth.

"What... what should I do?"

Despair washed over Luna, but she soon started to rationalize.

"Does... does it really matter, these grades?"

She nodded, trying to convince herself.

"Exactly! These numbers don't mean anything!"

"What do you mean they don't mean anything?"

The voice startled Luna.

"Pr...Professor Cromwell?"

Behind her stood Cromwell, arms folded, staring at her.

"Come with me, Luna Railer."

"Eek."

Luna trailed after Cromwell, a gloomy expression on her face.

They headed to Cromwell's office, where Rudy and Rie were already seated, heads bowed.

"You've really messed this up."

Cromwell showed them their grades, all lower than the previous exam.

"Considering that Rudy Astria was hospitalized, that's understandable. But what about you two? Why the drop?"

"I'm sorry....."

Luna mumbled, head still bowed.

Rie, on the other hand, spoke with conviction.

"The exam this time was tough. Isn't that why everyone's scores dipped?"

Her tone was confident but respectful.

Professor Cromwell responded by presenting them with the top students' scores.

"Take a look."

Evan's grades remained unchanged—perfect scores on both midterms and final exams.

The same held true for other top performers.

"Lower-ranking students did see their scores drop, but the top-ranking students' performance held steady. You three are the exception."

"Eh....."

"Huh...."

Rie and Luna were taken aback by their scores.

Comparing their own scores to the rest, they realized how much they had slipped.

"Yes, as Rie and Rudy's scores were already high, a slight drop didn't affect their ranks much."

Having said this, Professor Cromwell turned to Luna.

"Luna Railer."

"Yes...?"

"What are your plans for the holidays?"

Luna fiddled with her fingers, her eyes darting.

"I, I intended to go back home..."

"So, you're free."

Next, Professor Cromwell offered Luna a sheet of paper.

"It's an invitation to a special lecture by Professor McGuire over the break."

Luna accepted the paper, scanning its contents.

The lecture focused on magical circle theory, a topic Cromwell knew Luna was keen on.

"Attending this lecture could help cut down your regular study time."

While Luna found the lecture appealing, there was one glaring issue.

"I... I don't think I can attend..."

The issue was the cost.

The lecture fee, written at the bottom of the paper, was beyond Luna's means.

She had some funds from Rudy for research, but she couldn't use them for a special lecture.

Asking Rudy would probably result in him happily footing the bill, but she was uncomfortable with that.

She was already relying on him for tuition, living expenses, and research funds.

She couldn't ask for more.

Cromwell glanced between Rie and Rudy.

"You two may leave."

"...Understood."

Rudy and Rie, concern etched on their faces, glanced at Luna before exiting.

Watching them leave, Cromwell leaned back in his chair.

"I will cover the lecture's cost."

"...What?"

Luna's eyes widened at Professor Cromwell's words.

"I can manage that. Learn from Professor McGuire, improve your grades."

"But... Professor, you don't have to..."

"On the contrary, Luna. I do."

Professor Cromwell declared, gritting his teeth, fists clenched.

"I can't bear those swordsmanship department brutes belittling my magic department any longer...!"

"...Huh?"

Luna's head tilted in confusion as Cromwell veered off-topic.

Cromwell rose from his seat, his grip firm on Luna's shoulders as he locked eyes with her.

"Luna, study hard, and show Yeniel or whoever she is your strength. Don't let those muscle-brained guys stand tall."

His gaze held an intense fervor that made Luna chuckle awkwardly.

It was strangely heartening to see the usually grouchy Cromwell so fired up.

"Ahahaha....."

"Then I'll assume there are no objections. I'll arrange the special lectures with Professor McGuire."

"Ah.....Thank you!"

Bowing deeply, Luna offered her sincere gratitude. Cromwell responded with a warm smile.

As Luna exited his office, Cromwell returned his attention to her exam paper.

Luna's answers in the magic theory section were all correct—she even correctly answered some questions that both Princess Rie and Rudy Astria had missed.

Only Evan and Luna had correctly answered these particular questions.

"Rie will figure it out."

Rie, ever prideful, would use this setback as a lesson to drive her own improvement, but Luna was a different story.

Her scores had dropped since the previous test, and Cromwell suspected she would rationalize her performance.

She might have convinced herself that her recent score reflected her actual ability and that her midterm success was merely luck.

"Why did her scores drop?"

Cromwell furrowed his brow.

He couldn't imagine that her grades had dropped because she was busy preparing for Rudy's birthday.

3/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 49: Summer Vacation (1)

I stepped outside to say goodbye to Rie, as she hopped into her carriage.

The holidays had started and everyone was heading back to their homes, one after the other.

Astina had already taken off, and Rie was on the verge of leaving after spending an extra day at the academy.

"Remember to write to me often. Don't forget."

"I know. Now off you go."

Before she took off, Rie reminded me several times.

She was planning on sending me updates about the political situation and other news, so she wanted me to write back if anything went down at the academy.

I questioned if that was really necessary, but she was pretty adamant.

She argued that since odd incidents happened at the academy all the time, we needed to be ready for something to happen during the break as well.

She piled up so many reasons that all I could do was nod in agreement.

After all, writing a letter wasn't too hard.

"Rudy, should we head back in now?" Luna asked, standing by my side.

She had joined me in seeing Rie off.

Luna also chose to stay at the academy over the break.

I suggested she take a trip home before the special lectures held over the break started, but she said no.

She felt it was best to focus on her studies.

"Then I'm off to get some exercise. See you later."

"Sure! I'll meet you at the cafeteria later!"

Luna headed for the library, and I set off for the field.

Now that my injuries were on the mend, it was time to get moving.

I had been laying off physical activity for a while and I could feel my body getting sluggish and my energy levels dropping.

"Well... let's get this started."

And so, I began my run on the field.

It felt odd to be running after such a long break.

My joints ached, my breath was short, and my body was screaming for me to stop.

But I pushed all that aside and ran on.

After a while, the pain just sort of fades away.

I found myself running in a kind of trance.

During my run, I noticed someone watching me.

A muscular man was eyeing me from a bench, a huge double-bladed axe by his side. If I had to describe him, I'd say 'barbarian.'

A fearsome-looking barbarian, bloodthirsty, lethal.

But the real shocker was that he was wearing the academy's uniform.

He had rolled up the sleeves of his unbuttoned shirt.

Looking at his biceps, I wondered if those buttons ever stood a chance.

The idea of a student with that face and those muscles gave me chills.

Was he a part of the Swordsmanship Department?

Did all students in that department turn out like this?

"Huff..."

Once I finished my workout, I wiped away my sweat.

It felt like I'd been exercising for quite a while.

Still, the barbarian was watching me.

Now, I was starting to feel uncomfortable.

What was his deal?

Why was he staring at me like that?

Sure, some people would glance my way during their workouts, but no one had ever gawked at me quite like this before.

While I was busy trying to figure out his intentions, the man rose from his spot and started walking in my direction.

Was he planning to jump me?

I quickly dismissed the thought.

If he wanted to ambush me, he wouldn't just sit in plain sight; he would've hidden somewhere.

So what was he up to?

Before I could puzzle it out, he was standing right in front of me.

I thought he might simply walk past, but he stopped, looking down at me.

Then he started talking.

His question took me by surprise.

"Do you study under Professor Robert?"

"...What?"

"Are you a student of Professor Robert? You're Rudy Astria, right?"

He had a deep, booming voice that matched his build.

"Yes... But why?"

Then, he extended his hand toward me.

"I'm Borval, a second-year student in the Magic Department."

I stared blankly at his outstretched hand.

"Do you not shake hands with commoners?"

"No, that's not it."

Caught off guard, I took his hand and shook it.

"You run well. I heard you had been bedridden for a while."

"Ah, yes. Thank you."

Following our brief exchange, an awkward silence fell between us.

I guessed he must have had a reason for approaching me, so I asked.

"Did Professor Robert send you?"

"Not exactly. But it's related."

That response left me more confused.

"We'll talk more later."

With that, Borval left.

"But... He's in the Magic Department?"

A guy with that face and physique is in the Magic Department?

And why does he carry around that massive axe?

It felt like my image of the Magic Department was crashing down.

"You're here?"

When I entered Professor Robert's office, I found Borval and Robert waiting for me.

Professor Robert, seated at his desk, began to talk.

"I hear he sought you out of his own accord, though I didn't ask him to."

"Huh?"

"Just wanted to see what kind of person he is."

Borval responded to Professor Robert's comments.

With an irritated look, Professor Robert kept talking.

"Well, you met this guy earlier, right? I've taught him a bit."

"So... he's senior?"

At that, Professor Robert grimaced.

"What do you mean, senior? Neither of you are my students."

The criteria Professor Robert uses to determine his students remains a mystery.

Does he even officially have any students?

Nonetheless, after hearing it repeatedly, I've gotten used to hearing it.

"Why did you call on Borval senior?"

"He's going to be teaching you for a while."

As I asked, Professor Robert passed me a book.

"This is..."

"The contents of that book. Research related stuff on your own."

The book was filled with information about Luna's book.

"Isn't this what you were studying, Professor Robert?"

"Don't worry, there's another copy."

After giving me the book, Professor Robert gestured at Borval.

"I've got to head out in a week, so you'll be learning from this guy. Until I leave, I'll supervise as well."

"Where are you heading?"

As far as I'm aware, Professor Robert doesn't have any family, and I didn't think he had other commitments.

"Don't pry too much. Just know that I have somewhere to be."

Acknowledging Professor Robert's words, I turned to Borval.

"But, Borval Senior, you're about to become a third-year. Won't you be busy?"

"I'm aiming to be a professor, so it's not an issue."

"Ah..."

Aiming to be a professor.

In other words, he was on track to become a graduate student, a teaching assistant.

Upon hearing that, I couldn't help but feel a lump form in my throat.

Walking into hell on his own.

"Well... hang in there."

"...What are you implying."

"Quit the small talk and start teaching him magic."

At Professor Robert's command, Borval nodded and turned to me.

"I've heard your magic skills are impressive. How proficient are you?"

"Well... I can use about 3-4 kinds of black magic. I know how to use various kinds of beginner magic, but my proficiency is low."

"That's remarkable for a first-year."

Borval pulled out a piece of paper and pitched a question at me.

"Do you have a considerable understanding of magic, then?"

"I do have a good grasp of basic magical theory."

I said, filled with confidence.

I've been studiously learning the theoretical aspects since joining the academy.

I considered myself among the top tier of first-year students when it came to theory.

At the start of the semester, I was casting spells without any understanding of the underlying principles.

But as I continued practicing magic, it was natural that I became curious about its mechanics and started noticing the areas where I was lacking.

Theoretical knowledge filled in those gaps.

Diving into the theory, one learns about the limitations of magic and efficient methods of use.

These theories greatly boosted my learning speed.

So, I had been enhancing my magic skills through a balanced combination of theory and practice.

"Let me put a question to you, then. What distinguishes the mana of a knight from that of a wizard?"

"...A knight?"

"I misspoke. It isn't exclusive to knights. It encompasses all who wield weapons."

I fell into a moment of thought.

This was not something I had studied.

Usually, we learn theories that can be easily applied to practical situations rather than explaining such fundamental aspects.

Nevertheless, based on what I had learned so far, I could formulate a guess.

"...They are the same?"

The mana employed couldn't be different.

Otherwise, entities like Evan, a magic swordsman, couldn't exist.

"That's correct. The mana used is identical. So, what distinguishes a knight from a wizard?"

"A knight wields sword aura, and a wizard wields magic."

The contrast between a knight and a wizard.

The biggest difference is that wizards cast magic while knights utilize sword aura.

However, there was a strange point.

The existence of a magic swordsman.

A magic swordsman is a being that can use both.

This implies wizards could wield sword aura, and knights could cast magic.

Still, something felt off.

Why don't wizards use sword aura?

The field of magic is vast and complex.

It's understandable to think knights would forgo learning it.

Using basic magic would likely be less efficient in actual combat than an additional sword swing.

If one truly wanted to incorporate magic into combat, utilizing scrolls would be more advantageous.

Before I could answer, Borval posed another question.

"There is one more thing that's different."

Another difference...

I sank into thought.

The only knight I was acquainted with was Locke...

Ah.

Come to think of it, I had seen another knight.

Harpel and Eric.

"Body reinforcement?"

The reason they survived Astina's onslaught.

It was due to body reinforcement.

However, a knight's body reinforcement differs from a wizard's body reinforcement magic.

"You're certainly talented. These aren't topics typically taught in the first year. You're correct. This is the most significant difference between wizards and knights."

Borval sketched a human figure on the paper in front of him.

"So, why is there such a difference?"

I mused for a moment before responding.

"I... I'm unsure."

Borval dotted the heart of the figure he sketched on the paper.

"Wizards amass mana in their hearts."

He then drew another figure and dotted various parts of the body.

"Knights, on the other hand, distribute mana throughout their bodies."

Borval proceeded with his explanation.

"This discrepancy arises because the usage of sword aura and magic differs. Let's take dark magic as an example. How do you cast dark magic?"

"In my case, I envision a container and fill it with mana."

"Exactly, you conjure that image to extract a specific amount of mana. Forming such an image simplifies the process."

Borval traced a line on the figure with the marked heart.

"A wizard must manage a precise amount of mana to cast spells. It's far more accurate and efficient to use mana concentrated in one place rather than gathering it from all over the body as a knight would. Hence, this method is preferred."

I nodded in understanding.

But why is he telling me this?

"You said you wanted to learn powerful magic from Professor Robert. Magic that can be used as a finishing blow."

Perhaps my thoughts were obvious because Borval spoke first.

A finishing move.

The lack of a finishing move was a disadvantage I felt during the last fight.

So, I requested Professor Robert to teach me, and it appears he relayed my request to Borval.

"Frankly, given your current skill level, there's no magic that I can teach that could be called a finishing move. Your current level is simply too low."

"Is that so?"

Although I was a bit disheartened hearing this, knowing that I had only been attending the academy for a year, I nodded in agreement.

"However, it's not like there's absolutely no way. This technique will also be helpful with dark magic, and it's my specialty, so I'll explain in detail."

Upon hearing that, my expectations rose.

"I'm looking forward to it."

4/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 50: Summer Vacation (2)

Once Rudy's training wrapped up, only Borval and Professor Robert remained in the lab.

"What do you think?"

"He seems more ordinary than I thought."

There are plenty of geniuses in the world.

These geniuses usually have little quirks.

Maybe they're obsessed with a specific topic, or they have unusual habits.

Though these quirks differ, one trait is common among them all.

Pride.

Rudy had potential that went beyond Borval's.

Given more time, Rudy would outdo him.

Yet he wasn't looking down on him.

Instead, it felt like Rudy held him in high regard.

And for a prodigy, his learning pace wasn't especially quick.

Like any average person, he made mistakes while trying to put what he'd learned into practice.

So, he didn't appear extraordinary.

Still, Borval noticed something.

Rudy's determined expression as he raced across the field.

Despite it being his first physical session after a long period of rest, he didn't stop.

Borval came to a realization.

Rudy Astria wasn't a natural-born prodigy of the Astria family.

His accomplishments so far weren't due to innate talent.

You could see it in his eyes when he learned something new or trained.

A young man filled with ambition and determination.

It was thanks to his drive that he is where he is now.

"He's interesting," Borval said, to which Professor Robert responded with a small smile.

"I think so too."

After learning from Borval, I grabbed lunch with Luna and then headed to my lab.

Even though I couldn't use the lab from the next term onwards, it was mine until the end of the break.

I reflected on what Borval had taught me.

"Controlling mana..."

Borval taught me about mana control.

Physical enhancement spells only amplify things like muscles, unlike the complete enhancements knights undergo.

Borval offered a new perspective.

Could wizards distribute mana throughout their bodies like knights, and achieve complete physical enhancement?

It was possible, but very challenging.

The fundamental difference between a wizard and a knight was in the mana flow.

Also for knights, the form of mana was important, not the amount.

The Sword Aura of a Knight.

When knights use sword aura, they don't worry about the amount of mana they're using.

Sure, they can adjust it.

But sword aura doesn't demand precise control over the amount of mana.

Knights focus not on controlling the amount of mana, but rather on the form of the mana.

They roughly draw out a certain amount of mana and then refine it.

Sharpen it to the point it can slice through anything.

Knights are those who perfect the form of the mana.

But wizards are different.

Wizards emphasize managing the amount of mana, not its form.

They construct a spell, a kind of container, and inject the right amount of mana into it.

When filling a container with water, you don't worry about the shape to pour it in.

After all, the water will naturally take on the shape of the container.

So, they only need to measure the exact amount.

Wizards find it almost impossible to use physical enhancement because of this.

To spread mana throughout the body like a knight, a wizard must learn to maintain mana in a form that fits the human body.

But while a wizard knows how to send mana to areas like the hands or feet, they struggle to control the form of the mana.

This led me to a question.

Why not see the body as a container and only fill a certain amount?

-A human body cannot be a vessel. If mana is not controlled to the shape of the human body, it keeps trying to move.

-Then the mana would either try to leave the body or return to the heart.

There were several other reasons as well.

But in short, wizards do not enhance their bodies for the same reason knights do not use magic.

It's more efficient to use magic than to learn to finely control mana to enhance the body.

-What if there is a way to strengthen the body in a way only wizards can do?

-Knights spread mana all over their body, enhancing everything. They're not skilled in gathering mana at one point.

-But wizards are different.

-Collecting mana in one place is a wizard's specialty.

Borval lifted one arm.

-What if you only strengthen this one arm without strengthening the rest of the body?

Hearing that, my eyes lit up.

Since wizards already gather all of the mana in their heart, things changed if they only thought about strengthening one arm.

Fill the arm with mana, then explode it out through the arm.

No need to continuously maintain it in your arm like a knight would, but expend all of it alongside a swing.

Then, you could use an unbelievable amount of power explosively.

It's literally a special move.

A technique used to land a decisive blow.

It requires delicate mana movement.

You must be able to move mana at least enough to make it the shape of an arm to exhibit this ability.

And since such delicate mana movement was necessary, it also helped with dark magic.

Dark magic is a kind of magic that requires an exact amount of mana for each spell.

By learning how to delicately move mana, you also increase dark magic proficiencies.

"Shall we start now?"

A week later.

"Then I'll be off."

As Professor Robert had mentioned earlier, he said he was heading off somewhere and left.

By now, I could somewhat control mana.

I hadn't yet succeeded in creating a shape like an arm, but I could channel mana into my fist.

However, when I used it in just my fist, it didn't feel very powerful.

Even if my fist became stronger, it couldn't generate a lot of explosive power.

After my morning workout and learning from Borval, I walked to the practice field.

A reinforced training dummy was set up.

It was a tool to estimate the force of a technique.

Striking the dummy didn't give an exact measure of the force, but it did provide a rough estimate.

Lately, I've been practicing mana control by hitting this dummy.

When I infused the same amount of mana into my arm and hit the dummy, if the force was strong, it meant the mana was properly distributed. If the force was weak, it was the opposite.

Since it was difficult to tell if mana was properly distributed normally, this was the method I adopted.

That's how I began to familiarize myself with the feeling of correct distribution.

When I entered the training ground, I noticed someone else was already there.

A figure with familiar black hair stood there.

It was Evan.

"Oh..."

I suddenly remembered that Evan, too, was spending his holidays at the academy.

I had completely forgotten about him.

But I quickly compose myself and move forward.

Casually, I picked up the training dummy and cast a sidelong glance at him.

He was focused on his sword practice, occasionally incorporating magic.

"No need to be so cautious..."

I murmured softly, too low for Evan to hear, then focused.

I channeled mana into my arm.

I didn't flood it with a vast amount of mana right from the start.

Controlled mana distribution.

After all, the day was still long.

If I exhausted my mana in a single burst and ended up tired before the day was over, it would be counterproductive.

"This should do..."

I positioned my arm and struck the dummy.

-Thud

"Ah!"

A sharp pain shot through my fist, as if the mana hadn't reached it properly.

Tears sprang to my eyes, and my hand throbbed, but I clenched my teeth and endured it.

I couldn't let Evan, who was behind me, see me squirming in pain.

Honestly, it wasn't just because of Evan.

The mere thought of someone seeing me punch a dummy and then roll around in pain was so embarrassing that I was simply fighting the discomfort.

I swallowed the threatening tears and drew a deep breath.

"Ugh... Huff!"

Bracing myself, I began hitting the dummy again.

This cycle repeated several times.

Sometimes, I controlled it just right; other times, it was far from it.

"Sigh...."

Perhaps I should try this a couple more times and then leave.

A significant amount of time had passed, and I couldn't spend the entire day here.

I turned my gaze to Evan.

He was showing no intentions of leaving.

"He's diligent...."

Watching him, I felt great relief.

He seemed to be progressing well on his own.

Redirecting my attention, I focused on channeling mana into my arm.

Infusing my arm with mana...

I needed to remember that feeling.

The feeling of mana permeating every muscle...

This time, it felt like things were falling into place.

Like I could hold more mana.

I channeled a larger amount than usual.

Eyes fixated on the dummy, I lifted my fist.

And then, I swung.

Unleashing all the mana contained within my arm...!

-Kwaaaang!!!!

"Huh...?"

I stared at the dummy in disbelief.

My fist had gone right through it.

Furthermore, extensive scars marred the ground before it.

"....."

Dumbfounded, I stared at my own fist.

Then, I cautiously lifted my gaze to Evan.

His face was a picture of astonishment, his eyes wide and mouth agape.

"....."

Keeping my cool, I casually collected my stuff and left the training ground.

Despite maintaining my composure on the outside, inside, I was flustered.

So much so that I practically sprinted out of the training ground.

".....That's not going to be a problem, right?"

Even if Evan had seen it, there should be no consequences, right?

Instead, demonstrating my growth could kindle Evan's own development, I rationalized.

Just then, I heard the sound of someone racing behind me.

"Rudy Astria."

It was Evan.

Evan was calling out my name as he gave chase.

What's going on?

Keeping a calm façade, I turned to face him.

"What is it?"

At this, Evan returned an awkward grin and began to speak.

"Well... the Swordsmanship Department's professor has been asking about you. Seems he's trying to identify the person who broke the training dummy..."

"Ah...!"

So, that's how I ended up being escorted to the professor...

"What, you're the one who destroyed the training dummy? Who are you?"

"I, I'm sorry..."

After telling them my name and apologizing several times, I was finally allowed to exit the training field.

Hope I explained everything fine here...

5/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 51: Summer Vacation (3)

On a bright afternoon, with flowers in full bloom, Professor Robert walked along a sunlit path.

His destination: two lonely graves.

When he arrived, he greeted the graves with a small smile.

"Are you both doing well?"

Standing alone, he gently placed the flowers he'd brought before each one.

"I apologize for not visiting more often."

His smile remained, but a subtle sadness tinged its edges.

"Being a professor isn't as relaxed as you might think."

He confessed to the graves, his voice laced with bitterness.

"I've been teaching a young one from the Astria family these days."

He continued.

"He reminds me of Richard's younger days."

A sigh slipped from him.

"Do you remember how you were as a child, Richard?"

The question hung in the air, unanswered.

Overcome with emotion, Professor Robert sank to the ground, his head cradled in his hands.

"I should have never taken you on as my student, Richard..."

"I'm coming with you," Luna stated, her eyes fixed on me as I packed my belongings.

The journey to the Persia territory was scheduled for tomorrow.

I just told Luna about it today.

We often shared meals, but somehow I'd never found the right moment to bring it up.

Now, the situation had caught her off guard.

"I want to join you!" Luna stood with her hands on her hips, feigning anger.

I tried to reason with her.

"What about your classes with Professor McGuire?"

For me, I had already told Borval and, in the absence of Professor Robert, I was free to roam around, but Luna wasn't.

The special lecture she attended was closely managed by Professor McGuire.

Luna, usually an impeccable student, would risk upsetting him if she decided to leave for a trip out of the blue.

I've seen his explosive temper once and I have no desire to provoke it again.

I couldn't ask Luna to lie about it.

Not only was she terrible at lying, but it wouldn't have been helpful in this situation.

If it had been more of a vacation, I would've been more than happy to take Luna along.

But since this was a brief visit to the Persia family's residence and nothing more, I thought it was better for her to remain at the academy.

"I promise I'll get you something. Stay here at the academy, okay?"

Luna's face fell.

"I don't want to, I want to come with you..."

Despite understanding the difficulties, Luna's protest continued.

Perhaps the academy was taking a greater toll on her than I'd thought.

"I'll be back before you know it. Just focus on your studies."

Luna fidgeted with her fingers, her eyes on me.

Seeing her like this, a faint smile crossed my face.

"Luna, you'll be okay on your own, right?"

"I'm not a child," she huffed, but her face was undoubtedly that of a little girl's.

Her stubborn nod was so reminiscent of a puppy soaked from the rain that I had to stifle my laughter.

I knew an outburst would likely upset her, so I kept my amusement to a mere smile.

The following morning arrived, and I was up at the crack of dawn.

I boarded a carriage bound for the Persia territory.

The early start was tiring, but I managed to catch up on some sleep during the journey.

By the time we reached our destination, it was late lunchtime.

"Welcome, Rudy Astria," greeted Astina as I stepped off the carriage.

Seeing her in such informal clothing was an unfamiliar sight; I was used to her school uniform.

"What have you been up to?"

"Do you think I would have been doing anything other than studying?"

"Well, that sounds like you."

Astina said, laughing.

"My father is waiting inside. Have you eaten yet? We were waiting for you."

"You could have eaten earlier."

"How could we have started without our guest? Let's go inside and chat."

With that, I followed Astina into the building.

The Persia family mansion was astonishingly luxurious.

Instead of the white lilies of Astria, here, vibrant red roses were the prominent feature, perhaps in representation of the family's emblem.

The mansion was comparable in size to the Astria's.

Being closer to the capital, Astria's size was to showcase the family's power.

A mansion of this scale was a rare sight.

Inside, we were greeted by a middle-aged man.

"Is this Rudy Astria?"

He was Philip Persia, Astina's father and the head of the Persia family.

A renowned figure, he held the rank of a viscount, wielding considerable political and commercial power, even without any prowess in magic or swordsmanship.

"Hello. I'm Rudy Astria."

I responded politely, managing to conceal any surprise at the informal greeting.

"I'm Philip Persia, head of the Persia family. Please, take a seat. We'll chat over lunch."

At Philip's invitation, a servant guided me to a chair.

Philip sat at the head of the table, with Astina and I on either side of him.

We dined, engaging in light-hearted conversation.

As the meal progressed, Philip's demeanor shifted to one of seriousness.

"I'm very sorry about what happened with Harpel. I heard you were seriously injured. How are your wounds now?"

"I've recovered. It was not Harpel who hurt me, and there's no need for you, as the head of the Persia family, to apologize."

I answered with proper respect.

"Regardless, he was a part of our family, it's only right that I, as the head, offer an apology. More importantly..."

Philip cleared his throat a few times before proceeding cautiously.

"Calling me 'head of the Persia family', doesn't it create a sense of distance?"

"... Is that so?"

I was puzzled.

According to my understanding, my form of address was appropriate.

It would be correct to call him Viscount Persia if we were peers, but I am an academy student, with no rank to my name.

"So, how should I address you?"

"Uh... You could call me, 'Father'."

Astina's fist hit the table with a resonating thud at her father's words.

She shot him a fiery glare.

"Father?"

"Uh, well..."

Caught off guard by Astina's response, Philip dodged the issue and played it cool.

"Rudy Astria, don't worry about it."

"Ah, yes."

Once we finished the meal, maids escorted me to a guest room.

After freshening up, I set about organizing the luggage I brought along.

It felt like I was really on vacation... It felt good.

There was a knock at the door.

"Rudy Astria, may I come in?"

It was Astina's voice.

"You may come in."

Astina walked in, dressed in light, comfortable clothes that one would typically wear indoors.

Her hair was let loose, which looked refreshing.

"Did you enjoy the meal?"

"I did, very much so."

"And you didn't find it uncomfortable?"

"Since the head of the family treated me comfortably, I was able to eat comfortably as well."

"I see... Um..."

She asked some unusual questions.

When those questions ended, there was a brief silence.

In the silence, Astina hesitated for a moment before opening her mouth.

"How about taking a walk together? The night air is nice."

The garden was beautifully lit by magic tools, creating a great view under the night sky.

"The roses are breathtaking."

I said as we walked through the garden.

"Uh...Yes, they are."

I had thought Astina wanted to talk about something, since she suggested going for a walk.

But, she just walked with me, not saying anything and keeping her head down.

So, I just looked around.

The garden was pretty, filled with the gentle fragrance of roses.

It was romantic.

"Um... Rudy Astria."

Astina broke the silence tentatively.

"Did you really form a pact with Priscilla..."

At the sudden mention of Priscilla, I cocked my head.

Astina kept her gaze fixed on me as she continued.

"I heard that she's an elemental known for consuming human minds..."

A faint smile spread across my face as I responded.

"It's alright. She doesn't seem to be such a peculiar elemental, and forming a pact was the best decision I could make under the circumstances. Had it not been for the pact with Priscilla, I wouldn't have been able to protect you."

Astina's face was etched with regret.

"I'm sorry. I was just too inexperienced..."

"It's alright. Without you, Astina, things could have been much worse. And I appreciate all the effort you put in for us. So, this is nothing."

It was not just empty words; it was really nothing.

Besides her student council duties, Astina often helped us with our studies and also freely gave important information.

Compared to what Astina, what I had done didn't seem like a big deal at all.

"Thank you for your kind words."

Astina murmured before she lapsed into thoughtful silence, and then hesitantly resumed.

"Rudy Astria, about what my father mentioned earlier..."

I mulled over her words.

"Are you referring to Harpel?"

"No...no. The thing he said right after that."

If it was right after that...

"Do you mean his suggestion to call him 'Father'?"

"Yes... exactly! It's not as weird as it sounds, it's just my father getting worried as I'm growing older and so, saying such unusual comments. But it's not that I... I mean, it's like a parent's concern about their children finding a suitable partner? So, you don't have to worry too much about it."

Astina rambled on.

"I think it's natural for parents to have such worries."

I nodded to Astina's words.

On second thought, it wasn't uncommon for someone of Astina's age to be engaged.

It was even an age where marriages were not unheard of.

So it wasn't strange that Philip was worried about that.

"But, I don't plan to get married early.Unless I find a good partner."

With that, Astina began fanning herself.

"It's a bit hot."

At that moment, a maid from a distance was seen rushing toward us.

"Miss Astina, the royal family has sent a message via magic orb...!"

The magic orb was an enchanted tool that could transmit brief messages.

It was a high-quality tool, typically reserved for extremely urgent situations.

The sudden usage of it visibly stiffened Astina's face.

"...Via a magic orb? To me?"

"It's not directly for you, Miss, but it's relevant to you..."

Astina cast a brief glance my way before questioning the maid further.

"What's the message about?"

"Well..."

The maid paused for a moment, then began.

"The first princess has reportedly run away."

"...?"

At her words, both of our eyes widened.

Rie ran away?

"Well...she suddenly said she was going to the Persia territory and left the royal palace."

"...It's not really running away if she mentioned her destination. But why is she coming here..."

"I'm not sure about the situation but the royal palace said to please take good care of her..."

"Okay, understood. Tell the servants to prepare a room and a good meal for the princess."

"Understood."

Astina blankly watched the back of the maid before frowning.

"A troublemaker is on the way."

"Huh?"

"It's nothing! Let's just continue our walk."

Astina said with a bright smile.

Chapter 52: Summer Vacation (4)

TL/Editor: Raei

Illustrations: Here

Morning came.

"Welcome, Princess Rie."

As expected, Rie had made her way to the Persia territory.

Philip greeted her with respect.

Seeing Philip greet her formally felt odd, given that we students usually interacted with her casually.

"Thank you for the warm welcome."

"Always. The Persia territory is open to you anytime. Feel free to visit."

After a brief exchange with Philip, she approached Astina and me.

"Rudy, it's been some time."

"Why are you here?"

At my question, Rie just shrugged as though it wasn't a big deal.

"Friendship? Promoting good relations with the Persia family? Isn't it a good time now that you're here?"

Rie seemed particularly happy about something.

Was this why she'd asked when I was visiting the Persia family in our letters?

She had been constantly asking about it in our letters.

But what about the 'running away' part...?

Astina, who was next to me, eyed Rie skeptically.

"Hmm...."

In response, Rie gave a sly smile.

"I'm hungry?"

"Ah... Okay, got it. Let's eat, Princess?"

Looking slightly irritated, Astina led Rie into the mansion.

Rie joined us at the dining table.

Unlike the previous day, though, hardly anyone spoke.

The only noise was the clatter of silverware.

Philip broke the silence during the meal.

"Do you have any plans after we finish eating, Princess?"

As I munched on my salad, I thought about his question.

She was here to hang out, what plans could she have?

"I think I'll tour the territory. I heard it's been a while since the Persia territory was last inspected."

Rie answered Philip, a smile creeping onto her face.

It was surprising to learn that she had an actual purpose.

I had assumed she was here just to hang out...

"Hmm... If you're going around the territory, I can arrange for our knights to accompany you."

"No need. I'll take him."

With a wide grin, Rie pointed at me.

"Me?"

I stared at Rie, bewildered.

"Yes, you. Join me later. Wear something comfortable."

"Um... Princess?"

Philip interjected cautiously.

"Rudy Astria is our guest, and he might not know our territory well. I think it would be better if Astina went with you instead."

Wow!

Philip's words moved me.

I came here to unwind.

Running errands for Rie would be annoying.

"Hmm... Then, let's switch things up. Let's just go out and have fun."

Rie looked at me and announced.

Her face said, 'you can do at least this much, right?' making it difficult for me to say no.

"Okay. Let's explore a bit after we eat."

"Wonderful~."

Rie's grin stretched from ear to ear, clearly delighted.

Philip watched the scene unfold, his chin resting thoughtfully in his hand.

"Daughter..."

"Yes?"

Astina responded to Philip's call.

With a grave tone, Philip spoke to Astina.

"Try harder."

"...."

With a small bag in tow, I stepped out, draped in a dark-colored robe to help obscure my face.

"Hey! Check out my wares!"

"The fruits are fresh today~!"

"Wow."

I marveled at the cityscape.

The Persia territory was a lively trade city.

Large wagons rolled by, and the air was filled with lively bargaining in the shops.

The city's vibrancy was a stark contrast to the usual quiet of the academy.

It was like stepping into a fantasy world.

"Why do you look like you've never seen a city before?"

Rie teased.

But her face was lit up with joy too.

"Rudy, let's try that."

"Sounds good."

Like excited kids, Rie and I sprinted towards a stall selling skewers.

"Don't run..."

Astina sighed, trailing behind us like a dutiful guardian.

"Rie! Look at that!"

"Oh... That's interesting..."

Today, I was brimming with excitement, exploring here and there with Rie.

It felt like being a child again.

Kind of like going to an amusement park when I was little?

Also, knowing that Astina was watching our backs made me feel even more at ease.

So, Rie and I spent the day exploring and playing freely.

"Ah..."

In the middle of all the fun, a thought crossed my mind.

I had promised Luna a gift.

I had intended to buy something nice when I got back to the academy, but since I was in the city, I decided to buy it now.

I initially considered a simple gift, but the fun I was having made me feel a little guilty.

While I was out having fun, Luna would be studying at the academy.

I would have invited Luna if I knew it would be this fun.

"Rie, let's go over there."

"Where?"

I gestured towards a magic tool shop.

Ding-a-ling.

"Welcome."

We entered the magic tool shop.

The shop was packed with different tools.

Not only magic tools, but also alchemical supplies and various other items.

"Are you looking for something specific?"

Rie asked as she browsed through the shop.

"I want to buy a gift for Luna."

"A gift?"

Rie looked puzzled at my words.

"She's stuck at the academy all the time. Isn't that a bit sad?"

"Hmm... I see."

After saying that, I started exploring the magic tool shop.

To be honest, the quality of the items seemed a bit low.

The magic tools at the academy were clearly of higher quality.

It wasn't even worth comparing.

I glanced at the ring on my right index finger.

The ring Luna had given me for my birthday.

Too many items here paled in comparison to this ring.

I wonder if it's acceptable to sell items inferior to magic tools crafted by students.

"Oh...."

One specific item caught my eye.

It was a wizard's robe that took up a significant portion of the shop.

The robe looked ordinary, but its conspicuous placement with no items surrounding it sparked my interest.

"Does this item possess special properties?"

"Oh, are you interested in that robe?"

The shopkeeper hurried over, rubbing his hands together.

"This piece is the pride of our store."

"Huh?"

"It's a robe made from wyvern skin. The skin is impressively durable, magic-resistant, and can withstand sword strikes."

I examined the robe.

The design wasn't particularly intricate, but it looked functional for combat.

"I'll take this."

My declaration took the shopkeeper by surprise.

"Well... it's quite expensive..."

"Oh, I didn't ask about the price. How much is it?"

He hesitated before revealing,

"Well... it's 10 gold."

10 gold?

I didn't know prices well enough to know how much that was, but it was an amount of money I could easily afford.

"Okay, I'll take it."

"Ar-are you sure?"

"Yes, please wrap it neatly."

"Th-thank you!"

The shopkeeper grabbed the robe and scurried to the back of the store to wrap it.

As the day wore on, the city began to quiet.

Shops began closing, and the traffic of carriages dwindled.

"Hmm...."

Rie looked at the sky, scanning the area.

Seeing her, I proposed,

"Hey, let's head back."

"No, wait a bit."

Astina and I exchanged confused glances as Rie continued to scan the area.

What was she waiting for?

My stomach rumbled, signaling that it was time for dinner.

After a while, my curiosity got the better of me.

"Hey, what are you waiting for?"

Rie looked at me, her head tilted to one side.

"That's strange."

"What's strange?"

"When are they going to launch the fireworks?"

She asked innocently.

".....Fireworks?"

"Yes. Shouldn't it be time for them?"

I stared at her, surprised.

"That's odd...."

Rie looked at the sky, her brow furrowed in confusion.

I quietly moved closer to Astina.

In a whisper, I asked her.

"Is today a special occasion?"

"No, it's just a regular weekday."

"Then why does Rie expect fireworks?"

"I have no clue."

I stroked my chin, deep in thought.

Could Rie possibly believe there was a festival today?

Given the city's bustling atmosphere, it seemed reasonable.

After all, we had spent the day as if we were attending a festival.

Could this be a case of blissful ignorance?

"Hmm...."

I could tell Rie that today was not a festival day and that there would be no fireworks.

However, it felt like doing so would shatter her childlike anticipation.

It was like telling a child who stays up all night on Christmas that Santa isn't real.

"Could we possibly arrange for fireworks at this hour?"

"That's absurd. It's impossible with gunpowder, and equally impossible with magic."

Astina stated firmly.

"Impossible with magic?"

"Yes, orchestrating a fireworks display isn't doable with just one or two magic scrolls. If you try with such limited resources, the outcome would be more pitiful than impressive."

I glanced at Rie, whose hopeful eyes were fixed on the sky.

"But shouldn't we strive to preserve innocence?"

"Huh?"

"Please obtain one or two of those scrolls for me."

I opened the small bag I had with me.

Inside was Luna's spellbook.

I was hesitant to leave it at the academy, and equally hesitant to give it to Luna.

While it would be safe at the academy, I felt uncomfortable leaving it unattended.

And giving it to Luna was complicated because of the promise I had made with her.

Luna had asked me to give it to her only when she was ready.

"Please etch the magic circle on this page. I'll take care of the rest."

Gradually, a look of disappointment began to surface on Rie's face.

Rie was no fool, she was bound to realize something was wrong.

"Hey, let's head back."

"Why? Isn't this what you wanted to see?"

I smirked, holding Luna's spellbook in my hands, channeling mana into it.

My mana was absorbed into the spellbook, and a magic circle materialized in mid-air.

And.....

-Whooosh!

-Bang!

Fireworks burst from the magic circle, soaring into the sky, exploding into a vibrant kaleidoscope of colors.

"Huh?"

"We're just getting started, sit back."

I channeled a considerable amount of mana into the spellbook, generating dozens of magic circles in the air, firing a multitude of fireworks into the night sky.

"Ugh...."

It drained a lot of my mana.

Making me cough in pain.

However, as I watched the sky, the pain seemed to dissipate.

Compared to a grand fireworks display, it was modest, yet captivating.

As though dozens of flowers were blossoming against the vast, inky canvas of the sky.

The floral blossoms were sparse, insufficient to fill the canvas, but enough to create a sense of ethereal beauty.

"Wow...."

Rie gasped in awe, her eye fixated on the sky.

"This is... what you wanted to see, right?"

As I said with a smile, Rie looked at me, her face a mix of surprise and wonder.

"You... did this?"

I didn't answer, only returned her surprise with a smile.

".....Thank you."

Rie, her face aglow with sheer joy, thanked me with heartfelt sincerity.

Damn Rudy has game. Though he's painfully oblivious to it...

Also doubt anyone should be allowed to use magic within cities but let's just ignore that part.

2/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 53: Summer Vacation (5)

TL/Editor: Raei

Illustrations: Here

Academy training ground.

"What just happened..."

Evan sat alone, deep in thought.

The moment when Rudy Astria punched the scarecrow to pieces.

How did a wizard break a scarecrow with just a fist?

Evan couldn't make sense of it.

No matter how many times he swung his sword at it or launched spells, the scarecrow remained unscathed.

But Rudy Astria had shattered it with a single punch.

"Could I survive that punch?"

Shaking his head, Evan knew he couldn't.

Not that he'd willingly receive such a blow, but it was overwhelming even with his defensive skills.

"Rudy Astria..."

Evan mumbled to himself.

He was indeed the top student.

That was confirmed as the first term concluded.

And Rudy Astria was second.

Yet, why did he feel like he couldn't win in a fight against Rudy Astria?

What Evan saw was merely Rudy breaking a scarecrow.

He had only witnessed that one act, but it felt like Rudy was already one step ahead.

Of course, Evan was learning not only magic but swordsmanship as well.

But, even when combining both fields, he felt he was trailing Rudy Astria.

Rudy was moving too fast.

Too fast for him to keep up.

"I can't... let this go on."

Evan clenched his fist.

Being first in academics wasn't everything.

He was ahead in grades but lagging in other areas.

If he only focused on academics, he'd lose to Rudy overall.

Evan began to train harder than ever.

To truly surpass Rudy Astria.

The following day.

Morning arrived in the Persia territory.

Rie, Astina, and I were enjoying breakfast at a restaurant.

"You're leaving today?"

At my announcement, Rie wore a puzzled expression.

"I need to get back. I was only planning to meet the Head of the Persia family and then leave."

"Why not stay and enjoy yourself a bit more?"

"Is this your place?"

Astina responded to Rie with a surprised look.

Rie shrugged off Astina's remark confidently.

"After all, we're all subjects of the Royal Family, so I have the right to speak my mind."

"Even so, I'm returning to the Academy today. I've packed my things, and a carriage is already waiting."

At this, Rie fell silent, thinking.

Then, she flashed a playful smile.

"Then, should I head to the Academy too?"

"The carriage is..."

"I can share it with you."

"It might be a tight fit. It only seats one."

"Then I'll sit a bit closer. It's fine. A little close contact is inevitable..."

As we carried on our conversation, a servant entered the room and whispered something to Astina.

Then, Astina glanced at Rie and smiled.

"It seems you don't have to worry about that."

Rie tilted her head, not understanding.

"What do you mean?"

"If you've left home without permission, you should return."

".....What?"

Rie's expression tensed at those words.

As Rie's face grew stern, a knight in golden armor entered the dining room.

The golden armor symbolized the Royal Knights.

Two more knights trailed behind him.

Rie's eyes widened at the sight.

"Why are you here?"

"We're here to bring the princess back. We have orders from His Majesty the Emperor to retrieve the princess who left without permission."

"I didn't run away! I let everyone know where I was going!"

Despite Rie's protest, the knights grabbed her arm without hesitation.

Their practiced ease suggested this wasn't their first time handling such a situation.

"You... Astina...! You betrayer!!"

"I can't ignore the Royal Knights, can I? After all, I'm a subject of the Royal Family too."

Astina shrugged off Rie's outburst with a smug grin.

"I, I want to go to the Academy!!!!"

"That's not an option. You need to return to the Palace."

"No! Noooooo!!!"

Rie was hauled off by the Royal Knights.

Is it really okay to treat royalty this way...

Wouldn't they face consequences later?

Well, if it's the Emperor's order, I guess it's not a problem.

I watched as Rie was led away.

Then the first knight turned to Astina, giving his respects.

"Thank you for your help."

"When the Royal Knights ask, I'm obliged to assist."

Astina responded to the knight with a bright smile.

That look felt odd.

Usually, she wore a forced smile in such situations, but today it was genuinely happy.

Was she happy about Rie being taken away.....

"Well, till we meet again."

The Royal Knights saluted Astina, and they took Rie away.

The room felt empty, like a storm had just passed through.

"So, Rudy Astria. Are you returning to the Academy?"

"Yes. There's nothing else for me here."

"Alright, then I will see you off."

With that, I climbed into the carriage with Astina's farewell.

Professor McGuire's Laboratory.

"Strengthen the control field further... maybe etch a reinforcement rune here?"

"Hmm... that might work. Then focus on the control rune over here and calculate."

"Yes! Understood."

Professor McGuire was guiding Luna in magic circles.

'The more I see, the more amazed I am...'

Professor McGuire had mentored many students and disciples.

Among them, some were hailed as geniuses, and some wizards made their mark in research.

However, Luna was unlike any student he had encountered before.

She possessed an intellect and aptitude uniquely suited for magical circles.

While theoretical knowledge was important in magic circle creation, one particular aspect was crucial.

That was mathematical ability.

Luna's aptitude for mathematics was beyond that of an average person.

She calculated control equations in her mind and can quickly compute the various probabilities.

Possessing superior problem-solving abilities, she factored in all exceptions when crafting a magic circle.

These skills marked Luna as a wizard completely optimized for magic circles.

Magic circles constructed by Luna were of unprecedented mana efficiency.

However, as a young student, she occasionally made errors due to a lack of fundamental understanding on magical theory.

They were basics that anyone could master with time.

Professor McGuire couldn't afford to let such a student slip through his fingers.

So, he put his plan into action.

"Luna, is there anything you'd like to eat?"

"Huh? No... I just had lunch..."

"Luna, do you enjoy chocolate?"

"I do like it... but I just brushed my teeth..."

"Luna, would you like a cup of tea?"

"I'm fine..."

However, Luna's unwavering focus tested Professor McGuire's patience daily.

There was a single motive behind McGuire's persistent offerings.

He wished to secure Luna as his laboratory assistant.

Though still a student, if the professor had the authority, he could appoint her as his assistant.

While her role would be as an assistant, she was still a student, so he couldn't delegate her academy-related tasks.

It was purely a position to aid with research.

Of course, Luna would undoubtedly be invaluable in research assistance, but enlisting her as an assistant now bore another implication.

It was about securing her in advance.

Once a year passed, then two, it would become evident that by the time Luna graduates from the academy, she would be extraordinary.

At that point, all professors would vie for Luna.

That's why he wanted to take her as an assistant now.

Designating Luna as his assistant at present wasn't about tasking her with responsibilities from this point forward, but about working with her even after graduation.

The aim was to secure her early, preventing other professors from poaching her later.

"Huu..."

Then, a nearby assistant approached Professor McGuire and asked.

"Professor, no luck today either...?"

"Nothing today."

At Professor McGuire's words, the assistants too felt a sense of disappointment.

"Haah..."

"Sigh..."

When an exceptional individual joined the lab, it wasn't just the professor who felt it.

The research assistants in the same lab did as well.

So, all members of McGuire's lab were united by a single concern.

How could they entice Luna to join their lab...?

What in the world was Luna partial to...?

How could they convince Luna to accept the role of an assistant...?

The individuals in Professor McGuire's lab were consumed by these worries once again today.

While the lab members were focused on their predicament, Luna too had her own concern.

'Rudy's back today... should I invite him for a delicious dinner?'

Luna was drawing a magic circle with such a concern in mind.

3/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 54: Summer Vacation (6)

TL/Editor: Raei

Illustrations: Here

Academy conference room.

Most professors gathered around a central table, with Dean Oliver at the head.

Oliver, wearing round glasses and a smart outfit, took the lead, a rare sight.

Headmaster McDowell's absence didn't surprise anyone.

Usually, McDowell ran these meetings.

However, he often got busy during holidays, leaving Oliver in charge.

"Did everyone enjoy the break?"

Oliver asked his colleagues, flashing a polite smile.

The break hadn't ended yet, his question was merely a formality.

The purpose of this gathering was to finalize the academic calendar for the upcoming semester.

While they typically followed a standard schedule, they adjusted dates for exams and other events to suit various factors.

This time, due to numerous happenings from the first term, the agenda was packed, prompting serious looks from the professors.

"Let's start," Oliver announced, initiating the session.

"The first item up for discussion is limiting first-year students' outside activities due to the unfortunate incident during the midterm camp."

At this, Professor Cromwell raised his hand.

"Please, Professor Cromwell, go ahead."

"I don't see the need for such restrictions. The incident wasn't a result of first-year students' actions."

Following Cromwell's statement, Professor McGuire also lifted his hand.

"I agree. The occurrence was due to our oversight as professors. We need to pay more attention, instead of limiting the students, which seems somewhat unfair."

With both of them speaking up, no one objected.

No one wanted to argue with Professors McGuire and Cromwell.

These two had significant sway within the academy due to their consistent research contributions, admirable character, and ethical conduct.

Additionally, Cromwell hailed from a renowned family and was often seen as a potential future dean.

However, his passion for teaching and studying magic was greater than his desire for the position.

"Does anyone object to continuing with the first-year schedule as planned?"

Even as Oliver asked once more, the professors stayed silent.

"Then we'll follow Professors Cromwell and McGuire's suggestion. We'll proceed with the joint practical of the 1st and 2nd years, along with the rest of the schedule, as usual. The next item up for discussion is...."

With that, the meeting moved forward under Oliver's guidance.

Once all topics were addressed, Oliver left the academy grounds.

Hidden beneath a hooded cloak, Oliver stepped beyond the academy walls.

He scanned his surroundings, then navigated towards a dimly lit alleyway.

Tucked in the alley was a small, unassuming shop.

Inside, there were no customers, just a single bartender cleaning a glass.

"You're here."

The bartender seemed to be expecting Oliver.

"How is Count Fred faring these days?"

Oliver settled into a seat, pulling back his hood.

Count Fred's family owned a respectable territory near the capital and held a reputation for their work with magical tools.

They were notable backers of Princess Yuni, the second princess.

Although traditionally seen as rivals to Garwell's Handrei family, they'd recently gained more power due to the Handrei's downfall.

"The count is as well as ever. But..."

"But?"

A strained smile appeared on the bartender's face.

"Princess Rie's investigations have been rather bothersome."

"Princess Rie... She's been staying out of the spotlight, hasn't she?"

"Not recently, no, but she's been investigating into past affairs."

"Past affairs?"

The bartender set down the glass he was cleaning, and, leaning closer, whispered to Oliver.

"It's about Professor Levian."

Oliver's brow furrowed at this.

"Why would the princess suddenly become interested in Levian?"

"We're not sure. We've done our best to hide any damning evidence, but considering it involves Levian, there might be undiscovered traces. We're just staying cautious for now."

"Sounds troublesome."

Upon hearing the bartender's tale, Oliver let out a sigh of annoyance.

"But enough about that, how did the meeting pan out?"

The bartender handed Oliver a piece of paper while posing the question.

Taking the paper and a nearby pen, Oliver started to write a letter.

"It was smooth sailing. Professors Cromwell and McGuire suggested we stick to the original schedule."

"That's certainly good news."

The bartender chuckled at Oliver's words.

After Oliver finished his letter, he passed it back to the bartender and rose from his seat, adjusting his robe.

"Leaving so soon?"

"I should get going. Linger here won't do me any good."

As Oliver prepared to depart, the bartender spoke up.

"Oh, one more thing, Count Fred told his child to keep a close eye on Princess Rie. Apparently, he's shared some information concerning Professor Levian."

Oliver's brow creased again at the bartender's words.

"Anton? I can't see how that would help."

Anton, a second-year student at the academy, was Count Fred's eldest son and a magic department student.

While his grades and magic skills were good, he wasn't extraordinary.

"Count Fred seems to want Anton to acquire some experience...."

"Doesn't look like any grand plan is at play, so it should be harmless."

With a casual shrug, Oliver brushed off his initial worry.

Even if Anton knew the details concerning Levian, unless he completely lost his mind, he wouldn't reveal such information.

Doing so would inevitably spell disaster for the Fred family.

"I'll be heading out now."

With that, Oliver strode towards the shop's exit.

"Astina, how could you!"

Rie's outcry made it sound like she had been personally wronged.

"And what, I should've been at odds with the Royal Knights for you...? I just came to play for a while. I just had fun and left, that's all."

Astina snorted as if it were natural, scoffing at Rie's outrage.

On the other hand, Luna murmured, her expression sinking.

"I couldn't even go... it sounds like you all had such a good time..."

"Ah."

Astina and Rie were flustered at the sight and began to comfort her.

As the holiday slowly came to an end, the academy's inhabitants started to trickle back in.

Both Rie and Astina had returned, their chit-chat echoing through the corridors.

"Sorry, Luna. I didn't know Rie was planning on going... If I'd known, I would've invited you."

"No, no, Rudy, it's not your fault! You even brought back a gift."

We continued our casual conversation as we strolled through the academy grounds.

"I need to move out first."

"Alright, see you tomorrow then!"

I waved them goodbye and headed towards the dormitory.

Having transitioned from Top Seat to Second Seat, I had to relocate my belongings to the Second Seat's designated room.

I had spent the holidays focused on studying black magic and mana manipulation, improving my proficiency in the latter.

Whether it was fortifying my arm or specific body parts, it was no longer a challenge.

But the rewards of mana manipulation extended beyond physical enhancements.

My control and usage of black magic had significantly stabilized as well.

Much like my own progress, my friends too seemed to have improved greatly.

While Rie and Astina's progress was less clear, Luna's had grown tremendously.

Each time she showcased her research findings, the complexity of her magic circles amplified, making them increasingly difficult to understand.

My struggle to keep pace hinted at Luna's rapidly accelerating growth.

Sure, I hadn't dedicated much time to studying magic circles, but that didn't mean I'd completely ignored magic theory.

Despite my skills in creating magic circles lagging behind, I was quite good at understanding their type and function.

However, lately, deciphering Luna's magic circles had become a very difficult task.

While Luna's rapid development was amazing, it also sparked a worry that I might struggle to keep up with her.

Aside from Luna, another individual had exhibited noticeable growth - Evan.

We'd incidentally bumped into each other at the training grounds, and it was clear that he had evolved since our initial encounter.

His magic had gotten stronger, and his swordsmanship had become very stable.

"Well... school is about to start."

Seeing these developments made me happy, but I was worried about the events coming up.

After school starts, there were two immediate events.

An individual skills assessment and a joint practical for the first and second-year students.

The individual skills assessment was an examination designed to assess each student's progress during the holidays.

Given our varying abilities, we would be subjected to numerous types of assessments.

Among these, the power assessment was the most highly anticipated event.

As implied by its name, this was an assessment designed to measure the level of power one could harness with one special blow.

Though it was challenging to assess an individual's abilities solely based on this aspect, the spectacle of executing such a powerful move made it the most dramatic of all evaluations.

It received the undivided attention of both professors and students.

Although I hadn't developed a special move specifically for this assessment, the thought was still bouncing around in my mind.

The outcomes of this evaluation significantly influenced our grades, so it was better to get a good score.

What I was most interested in about this assessment was who would outshine the rest among the first-year students.

Astina was expected to comfortably clinch the top spot among the second years, but no clear front-runner emerged from the first-years, especially since the winner in the original is currently absent.

Originally, the top scorer was Serina.

However, in Serina's absence, it wouldn't be surprising if the likes of Rie, Luna, or Evan emerged victorious.

More important than this assessment was the joint practical for the first and second-year students.

I'd had several discussions with Professor Cromwell regarding this.

As a result, I was able to persuade him to carry out the event properly.

While I knew that Dean Oliver would have managed things even if I hadn't intervened, I took the initiative, in fear of more changes to the story.

"But it seems to have proceeded without a hitch."

I smiled and moved my things.

And so, as the holidays drew to a close, a new semester was about to start.

4/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 55: Individual Skills Assessment (1)

TL/Editor: Raei

Schedule: 5/Week Wed-Sun

Illustrations: Here

"Is this a lab or a tea house? Why is everyone lounging around?"

Professor Cromwell scowled, his glasses perched on his nose.

His desk was a mountain of paperwork, and the dark circles under Cromwell's eyes extended down to his chin.

"I didn't expect there to still be so much paperwork with the semester starting tomorrow."

McGuire and Robert sat at a guest table, sipping tea and chatting.

Robert, a dark magic professor without much administrative responsibility, had less paperwork, while McGuire, with more assistants, had already delegated his work.

"Did you prepare for the individual skills assessment next week?"

"I have, but organizing the joint practical for first and second-year students is a nightmare."

In response to McGuire's question, Cromwell took off his glasses and spoke.

McGuire nodded at Cromwell's words and responded.

"It's a bit rushed this time."

"But we've laid the groundwork, so there shouldn't be any major problems."

Robert, listening to their conversation, scowled and shook his head.

"Just do it as usual, why complicate things?"

"We have an unusually talented batch of first-year students, and given the recent incident, we need to be cautious."

Professor McGuire shifted the topic after hearing Robert and Cromwell's conversation.

"Speaking of which, isn't the individual assessment interesting?"

"What's there to expect? It's just some kids scribbling magic circles."

At Professor Robert's remark, McGuire laughed.

"Just wait and see. Let's see who takes the first place."

"Remember, scrolls aren't allowed in individual assessments. And for magic tools, students can only use those they've crafted themselves."

"Cromwell recommended a student this time, Luna Railer. She's impressive, isn't she? Even without a scroll, she's bound to rank high. Second-year top spot is probably Astina's, but the first year's a mystery."

Then Robert smirked.

"Astina is the second-year top spot?"

"So, you're saying there's another contender?"

At that, Cromwell reacted.

"Astina may be an all-rounder in academics and combat, but the individual assessment is a little different, isn't it?"

Robert spoke with a confident smirk.

However, his point was valid.

Individual assessments weren't about judging combat skills or academic performance, but about measuring a person's power when they exert their utmost strength.

Even if someone excels in academics, combat skills, or intuition, without that one decisive move, they would not score high.

"The ones under me might be novices, but this assessment might be different?"

"You mean that Borval guy you've been mentoring lately?"

"Well, there's Borval and Rudy Astria."

Cromwell chuckled at Robert's comment.

Robert, who'd never taken on a disciple before, seemed to have changed his tune.

He didn't directly say 'disciples,' but he was virtually nurturing them, which was no different.

Considering 'that incident' Robert had gone through, this was substantial progress.

"Well, let's say the second year is like that, but the first years are the most eye-catching."

At Cromwell's words, both McGuire and Robert nodded in agreement.

"This time, we've got Luna Railer, nurtured by McGuire, top student Evan, Princess Rie von Ristonia, and Rudy Astria. Each one a contender."

-Bang!

Just as Cromwell finished his sentence, the lab door flew open.

A muscular man stood in the doorway.

It was Jackson Pumpkin, a swordsmanship professor.

"Heh heh...You lot seem to be having quite the chat!"

As he sauntered in, the three Magic Department professors scowled.

They'd been finding Jackson increasingly irksome lately.

Ever since the final exam, he'd been continually bringing up Yeniel, which was getting annoying.

"You might not know! We can't forget our Yeniel and Locke!"

"We're talking about the Magic Department. Why are their names coming up?"

"Well, we all do the assessment together, don't we!"

"So you're saying your students might take the top spot?"

"Of course! Maybe not the second years, but the first years are exceptional!"

Robert smirked, as if he'd caught Jackson in a trap.

"How about a wager then? Among the professors here."

"A bet?"

McGuire looked puzzled at Robert's proposal.

"We'll predict the first-year top spot."

"Alright! What's the wager?"

At Jackson's question, Cromwell grinned and produced a piece of paper.

Written on the paper was a new system.

"What's this?"

"It's a weekend duty system starting next week."

"I heard about this. Due to recent complaints about public order, it's a system where a professor is on standby in the academy until 10 PM on weekends."

McGuire added more detail to Cromwell's explanation.

"What a strange and annoying thing that has come up."

"So that's what we're going to do."

As Robert scowled and spoke, Cromwell elaborated.

"How about the rest of us cover the duty of the person who predicts right?"

"Oh."

"That sounds good!"

When Professor Cromwell spoke, the other three professors also reacted positively.

Then, Professor McGuire was the first to chime in, tapping the desk for emphasis.

"I'm going with Luna Railer."

"I'll go with Rudy Astria."

Robert, ever so casual, crossed his legs and stated his choice. All eyes then turned to Jackson.

Jackson had a daily routine of singing Yeniel's praises, but in a individual evaluation that hinged on a single powerful move, Yeniel was at a disadvantage.

After all, Yeniel was a female swordswoman who favored the rapier.

"Hmm..."

"Make up your mind, Jackson."

Jackson's eyes then lit up as if he'd reached a decision.

"I'll pick Locke Lucarion."

"Really? You spend all day boasting about Yeniel, yet you pick a different kid?"

"Given the circumstances and the wager, I've made the most logical choice."

"Alright, Cromwell, who's your pick? You can't choose Rudy Astria; that's a duplicate."

Robert turned his gaze to Cromwell, the last to decide, and laid down the rule.

"Don't fret."

Without a moment's hesitation, Cromwell voiced his choice.

"Evan. My pick is Evan from the Department of Magic."

As I stepped out into the morning, I was greeted by a refreshing breeze.

The scorching summer had passed, and the cool embrace of autumn was settling in.

The sky was a clear blue, typical of autumn, and dotted with fluffy clouds.

While I admired the sky, a vibrant voice greeted me.

"Rudy! Good morning!"

"Oh, Luna."

I returned Luna's greeting with a wave.

Despite it being the first day of school, with students around us looking worn out, Luna was radiant.

I didn't feel particularly drained either.

Luna and I had maintained our routines even during the holidays, so the start of the semester didn't feel like an abrupt change, more like a continuation of our usual routines.

"Rudy, what's your first class today?"

"It's Professor Cromwell's magic practice."

"Really? I have a general subject class on the first floor, so let's meet up in front of the dining hall afterward!"

"Sure, see you later."

Having made lunch plans with Luna, I made my way to class.

All things considered, the transition from the first to the second semester was seamless.

Life at the academy seemed to be progressing peacefully.

However, that illusion was quickly dispelled.

Upon entering the classroom, I found two students already present: Rie and Evan.

Momentarily startled by Evan's unexpected appearance, I almost retreated, thinking I'd entered the wrong room.

But seeing Rie's familiar, scowling face, I sighed and stepped inside.

As soon as I entered, Evan turned to me.

"Hello, Rudy Astria."

His sudden greeting caught me off guard.

While Evan and I had shared the same training ground on multiple occasions, we hadn't even exchanged glances, let alone a greeting.

Why this sudden change?

Without warning, Evan rose from his seat and extended his hand towards me.

"I look forward to working with you this semester."

This was... unexpected.

I frowned at Evan's sudden move.

It was a behavior I would normally pass by in the game, but it was confusing when it actually happened in front of me.

Casting a confused glance at Rie, I found her equally baffled, shrugging in response to my unspoken question.

Not wanting to leave Evan hanging, I offered a forced smile and shook his hand.

"Well, let's get along."

Still shaking Evan's hand, I took my seat.

I had a rough conversation with Rie through eye contact, but honestly, I didn't know what Rie wanted to say, so I just brushed it off.

If it's an important matter, we'll talk later.

Moments later, Professor Cromwell entered the classroom.

Upon noticing Evan, the professor spoke up.

"Did everyone greet each other? Meet Evan, who will be in class with us starting this semester. I won't say get along well, just don't fight."

Professor Cromwell then brandished a piece of paper.

"There's an individual assessment next week. I presume you're all aware of it?"

As he spoke, his gaze drifted across the classroom, finally resting on me.

"Rudy Astria."

".....Yes?"

"An assessment is just an assessment. The result of the assessment is not that important."

Did this man eat something wrong in the morning?

What had happened to the professor who had chastised us for poor results?

Noticing my furrowed brow, Professor Cromwell seemed to understand my confusion and nodded in acknowledgment.

"I mentioned before that your grades were not great. But what I want to say is that you don't necessarily need to pour all your energy into such a trivial assessment. Just use enough force so it won't greatly affect your grades."

I was a bit convinced upon hearing his words.

After all, I hadn't planned on pouring all of my energy into this assessment in the first place.

As long as I maintained a reasonable ranking, my grades would not suffer.

"I see your point... I understand."

"Good, take it easy."

"Understood."

Although I felt that there was an ulterior motive, I couldn't really understand it so I just let it slide.

5/5 Enjoy the chappy!

Coming soon!

Chapter 56: Individual Skills Assessment (2)

Individual Skill Assessment.

Given to first and second-year students.

This test, more like a health check-up than an exam, gauged individual capabilities.

"Next student, please step forward."

At that invitation, I walked into a room where a small glass bead and a woman awaited.

"This is the mana measurement room. Rest your hand on the glass bead and take some deep breaths."

As I followed her instruction, placing my hand on the bead, a light bloomed from within.

The brightness was gentle, not enough to blind, but it snuck through the crevices between my fingers.

"Alright, you're done. Please proceed to the next station."

Once finished, I exited the room, joining several other ongoing tests.

Wizards were primarily assessed for mana, but there were also evaluations for physical strength and endurance.

Unique screenings were conducted by the Alchemy and Elemental Departments.

The last test was the maximum output test, giving this series of tests its "assessment" label.

It measures the maximum amount of power one can exert.

This power is precisely quantified and it's this grading that gives the evaluation its name.

Yet, despite the precision of the measurements, it was a stretch to label the evaluation entirely objective.

Everyone had their unique style of fighting—some packed a powerful punch with each strike, while others preferred a barrage of weaker attacks.

The purpose of this assessment was to highlight these individual capabilities ahead of the joint practical for first and second-year students.

Mixed teams of first and second-year students would face off against one another.

So, the assessment was an opportunity to impress and secure a good team.

But the scores from this assessment also factored into our overall grades, so the aim was to balance showcasing skills with securing a respectable score.

I waited for my turn at the maximum output test, proceeding through the preliminary tests one at a time.

The maximum output test took place at the center, under supervision, and was not bound by the order of the other exams.

If you were summoned in the midst of another test, you had to report to the center immediately.

While I waited, a familiar name echoed through the room.

"Student number 73, Rie Von Ristonia, please report to the center."

The announcement, amplified by magic, sounded throughout the space.

"Hey, it's the princess's turn. Should we go watch?"

With Rie's name called, whispers stirred among the students.

As the murmurs grew, everyone broke away from the line, converging toward the center.

Joining the flow of students, I headed toward the center, curious about Rie's progress.

Over the vacation, I'd only seen her once.

"Rie Von Ristonia, signal when you're ready."

When I reached the center, an open field stretched out before me.

There stood a scarecrow, with Rie its only company.

Professors and students watched from a safe distance.

Rie drew in a deep breath, standing before her straw opponent.

This scarecrow was a bit different from those at the training grounds, mainly due to its angry expression.

I suspect it was fortified with various spells for this test.

"Sylph," Rie's voice echoed in the open field.

Suddenly, a hawk-shaped wind elemental, Sylph, materialized behind her.

Whispers of awe rose from the crowd.

A 1st-year magic department student using an intermediate elemental was a sight to behold.

However, instead of admiration, worry gnawed at me.

Rie, although having a promising future with Sylph, was still in the Magic department.

Would she have had enough time to refine her magic while also training with elementals during the break?

Rie was well aware of the limits of her elemental talents.

That was why she had joined the Magic department in the first place.

However, putting too much focus on elementals might hinder the growth of her magic later on.

My gaze rested on Rie, filled with concern.

Seemingly tense, Rie took a few calming breaths before staring intently at the scarecrow and extending her hand.

Mana surged from her palm.

It looked she was going to use magic.

Was she planning to use both elementals and magic simultaneously?

As the question flitted through my mind, a small flame ignited from Rie's hand.

At first glance, it seemed like a basic Ignition spell, the most elementary of fire-attribute magic.

But everyone present knew better.

It wasn't a basic spell.

It was Explosion magic, the evolved intermediate version of fire-attribute magic.

This was Rie's signature spell, known more for the shock it delivered rather than burns.

When the spell sparked into existence, a wave of anticipation washed over me.

Rie's leap in progress, summoning an intermediate elemental while simultaneously reaching the intermediate magic level, was a testament to her tremendous effort.

Yet, her shaky mana control betrayed her limited proficiency with intermediate magic.

Raising the small flame, she declared, "I accept the challenge."

-We now begin the evaluation of Rie Von Ristonia.

The wizards present readied their staves, preparing to shield from any debris caused by the explosion.

"Sylph."

At Rie's call, Sylph stirred, gathering wind.

A vortex formed, swirling toward the elemental's beak.

Rie raised the explosion spell to Sylph's beak.

Carefully positioning it, she waited until the wind swirled around the magic, the activity eventually ceasing.

In the ensuing silence, she uttered a single word: "Fire."

With a loud bang, Sylph unleashed the explosion magic, resembling a gunshot.

Like a bullet, the magic raced towards the scarecrow.

An instant before impact, it detonated.

A thunderous roar echoed across the field as the minuscule flame transformed into a ferocious inferno.

Amplified by Sylph's wind, the explosion was far stronger than usual.

"Barrier!"

The surrounding wizards hastily erected barriers against the spreading blast.

Despite their efforts, the explosion stubbornly persisted.

As it dwindled, Rie let out a sigh of relief.

The spectators resumed their chatter.

"Remarkable for a first-year—skillful application, plus high levels in both elemental and magic..."

"Truly a princess's performance."

The crowd buzzed with approval.

From my perspective, too, Rie's display was impressive.

Simultaneous use of an intermediate elemental and magic was uncommon, even among upperclassmen.

However, that was all it was.

Frankly, for this assessment that required a concentrated force to a single point, her widespread explosion wasn't the best choice.

"Rie Von Ristonia. With 2430 points, you are first in the first grade."

Nonetheless, her power was unrivaled amongst the candidates So far.

Naturally, Rie's first place standing was due to the absence of any strong competition so far, and the score was far from unbeatable.

Still, what she demonstrated was impressive.

"Rudy Astria."

Professor Robert's voice drew my attention.

I found him striding towards me, hands casually in his pockets.

"You can surpass that, right?"

His question left me pondering.

"I suppose I can."

But I had no intention of pushing myself to such an extent.

While my power was great when I put everything into a punch, my body wouldn't be able to withstand it.

A body like Borval's might, but mine, yet to be fully developed, wouldn't hold up.

"Then claim first place."

"What?"

I was taken aback by his sudden instruction.

"Secure first place, then return."

Suddenly deciding that I should claim first place?

It was definitely out of the blue, but for some reason, It felt good.

Robert has never pushed me to achieve anything specific.

But his bold statement to get first and come back gave me a sense of how highly he thought of me.

"If I secure first place, does that mean I become an official disciple?" I asked playfully.

"...I'll consider it."

At that, I lifted the corners of my mouth.

I had been feeling a little competitive lately.

I will make him acknowledge me as a proper disciple.

"Understood," I nodded, grinning.

Professor Cromwell did say to take it easy, but that must've been a joke.

I doubted the professor would seriously tell me to take it easy.

The announcer's voice echoed.

-Student number 74, Luna Railer. Please proceed to the center.

Luna was up next...?

Nearby, Luna promptly moved towards the center, her expression notably more serious than usual.

Extracting a small cube from her pocket, she declared softly, "Luna Railer, I accept the challenge."

Chapter 57: Individual Skills Assessment (3)

A few days prior, within Mcguire's lab.

"Hmm..."

Luna studied a piece of paper in Mcguire's lab, brow furrowed in thought.

The paper bore a magic circle.

A circle she intended to use for her individual assessment.

There was a problem, though.

Scrolls weren't allowed in the assessment.

With scrolls out of the question, she had to make a magical tool using mana stones.

The amount of mana stones Luna could get, however, was limited.

Using low-quality mana stones reduced the amount of mana you could inject into the magic circle.

This meant you had to pick between using a subpar magic circle or maximizing the circle's efficiency.

Since using a low-grade circle was out of the question, the only option was to maximize efficiency.

The problem was, even the most efficient magic circle Luna could create with the available mana stones would struggle to make an impression during the assessment.

With no other alternatives, all she could do was make her magic circle as efficient as possible.

"Ugh..."

The lab assistants glanced towards Luna.

They wanted to help Luna, but how could they understand when Luna was simply staring at the paper, groaning in frustration.

"Hmm!"

Suddenly, a female assistant rose from her seat.

She slowly approached Luna.

"Um... Luna? Do you need help?"

Luna turned her head at the voice behind her.

She responded with a smile.

"Well, I'm having a bit of trouble with this magic circle..."

Hearing this, the assistant's face lit up.

"Really? Can I help you then? What's the issue?"

"No, it's fine. I appreciate your concern."

"Um... what part are you stuck on? I might be able to help..."

"No, thank you! I'll figure it out!"

With Luna's polite refusal, the female assistant, feeling defeated, returned to her seat.

Her defeat, though, signaled an opening for the other assistants.

'A problem with a magic circle?'

'It looks well-made to me, what's wrong with it?'

They all stared, unflinchingly, at the magic circle before Luna.

Yet, they couldn't pinpoint any issues.

This magic circle was near perfect, activating smoothly and demonstrating excellent efficiency.

The only issue was Luna's limited mana stone supply.

Luna groaned once more, striving to squeeze even a fraction more efficiency.

However, the magic circle, already operating at peak efficiency, offered no room for improvement.

"What's everyone doing?"

Just then, Professor McGuire entered the lab.

He frowned at the sight of his assistants squirming in their seats, scrutinizing Luna's magic circle.

"Oh, Professor. Hello!"

Hearing McGuire's voice, Luna jumped up from her seat and greeted him with respect.

McGuire's face warmed into a smile at Luna's response.

It was refreshing to see such an earnest young student, a welcome change from his worn-out assistants and arrogant colleagues.

Mcguire approached Luna with a friendly tone.

"So, how's your preparation for the assessment going?"

"Ah... well..."

Luna responded with an awkward smile, lifting the paper that held the magic circle.

"So this is the magic circle for your individual assessment?"

"Yes..."

"Alright, let's have a look."

Mcguire sat down and took the paper from Luna.

He scrutinized the circle carefully.

There seemed to be no issues.

Luna had maximized the efficiency to the best of her knowledge, and the runes controlling the magic circle were well-placed.

The magic circle's harmony with the other runes was also well-done.

Luna seems to have a good grasp of the individual assessment, playing to her strengths nicely.

Mcguire looked up at Luna.

Despite presenting a well-crafted magic circle, Luna was nervously fiddling with her fingers.

'Something must be bothering her.'

His quick observation led him to this conclusion.

His instincts, sharpened over years of teaching at the academy, surpassed those of the assistants.

Mcguire paused to think.

What could be the issue?

The magic circle was fine.

The issue must be external.

Mcguire then remembered Luna's biggest problem.

Money.

He recalled that Professor Cromwell had footed the bill for Luna to attend his special lecture.

After a few sessions with Luna, recognizing her potential, he returned Cromwell's money and continued teaching her for free.

Still, Luna's financial troubles remained.

Mcguire rubbed his chin.

In this situation, he could offer her a mana stone, but he knew Luna would decline.

Whenever he offered to pay for her meals or other items, she always politely refused.

He needed to find a way around this.

"Hmm..."

Mcguire frowned, trying to devise a clever plan.

"Your magic circle isn't quite up to par."

Luna's mouth fell open at Mcguire's words.

"...Huh? Really?"

She hadn't thought there was anything wrong with her magic circle.

Naturally, she was taken aback by Mcguire's sudden critique, especially as he had always praised her work before.

However, a spark of hope ignited in her eyes.

Could there be a way to further optimize the circle's efficiency?

Setting the magic circle aside, Professor Mcguire pointed to its center.

"It's too weak."

".....I beg your pardon?"

"It's too weak."

Mcguire rummaged through a drawer and fetched a mana stone.

"This won't cut it. You need to aim for the top."

Mcguire placed the mana stone in front of Luna.

"I've made a wager with the other professors."

Mcguire smirked, revealing his gamble.

"I bet on you securing first place."

"M-me?"

Surprised, Luna pointed to herself, eyes wide with shock.

"Correct. With this magic circle, securing first place is next to impossible, don't you think?"

Truthfully, her magic circle had somewhat a chance of success.

But he wanted to challenge Luna, to spur her growth.

"Take this mana stone. Create a stronger magic circle and return as the winner."

He understood Luna's character quite well.

With this approach, Luna would not decline the mana stone.

If he simply gifted her the stone, she would have rejected it.

Mcguire's intuition was correct.

Luna's determination flared to life.

A sparkle appeared in her eyes at the prospect of helping the professor.

And she decided.

"I'll... return as the winner!"

With that, Luna gripped the mana stone firmly.

Mcguire couldn't help but smile.

"Luna Railer, let's begin."

With his words, Luna activated the cube she'd withdrawn from her pocket.

The cube expanded, and the black mana stone at its heart gleamed brilliantly.

'Activate the cube and.....'

Having done so, Luna focused on the scarecrow.

She carefully determined the coordinates of her target.

As she did so, Luna's gaze drifted towards the spectators.

To Rudy in particular.

'Rudy, I won't back down this time.'

She saw him there during Rie's performance.

But she didn't approach him.

It would distract her focus.

Her resolve to claim first place would waver.

Professor Mcguire had entrusted her with a mana stone and placed his faith in her.

She refused to let him down.

"Hmph!"

Having set the coordinates, Luna activated the cube.

The mana stone at the cube's core erupted with intense light.

The magic circle Luna made...

This circle housed a spell that overlapped several times on a single point and is then activated all at once at the pinpointed coordinates.

The main spell within the framework was a basic fire spell.

She had chosen it for its efficiency.

But with Mcguire's mana stone, she could pick a much more potent spell.

Luna considered her options.

What spell should she choose?

Then, she recalled a certain magic.

Professor Cromwell's telekinetic magic.

This type of magic was iconic within the Academy.

Only a select few among those of remarkable talent were chosen by Cromwell to learn it.

And it was magic with overwhelming power.

Although she could not cast it herself, she could incorporate it into the magic circle.

Inwardly, Luna shouted a single word.

'Gravity.'

-KWAGAGAGAGAK!!!!

An immense force exerted itself on the small area housing the scarecrow.

Tiny pebbles surrounding the scarecrow disintegrated into sand, and the scarecrow itself began to bow under the gravitational pull.

"What... what is happening?"

Spectators stared, taken aback by the unfolding spectacle.

The scarecrow, unaffected by Rie's magic, now bent under Luna's spell.

-KWAHAAAK!

"Uh... uh!!!"

Luna groaned.

Though the mana stone was responsible for activating the spell, Luna was responsible for setting the coordinates.

So, Luna's mana continued to funnel into the mana stone.

She kept her focus, eyeing the scarecrow.

And gradually, the cube's operation stopped.

-PAKAK!

The black mana stone within the cube flared red, and only then did the cube retract, dropping into Luna's grasp.

"Hoo....."

She took a deep breath, then looked at the scarecrow.

The bottom had been shriveled and pressed down, its body bowing as if in reverence.

A wave of elation swept over Luna.

Then, she heard the announcer's declaration.

-Luna... Railer, with 4520 points, claims first place!

"—Hmm!"

Hearing the announcement, Luna pumped her fist, her face lit up with joy.

Her score nearly doubled Rie's.

She was the overwhelming first place.

"What just happened....."

And the crowd couldn't conceal their astonishment.

She had used telekinetic magic, said to be wielded exclusively by Cromwell's chosen few.

She used that spell as if to mock those chosen geniuses.

Of course, that hadn't been Luna's intention.

Nevertheless, it was enough to instill both shock and inspiration in the spectators.

Joyful, Luna departed the field.

She headed in Rudy's direction.

Beside Rudy stood Rie, her face contorted oddly.

"Rudy!"

As Luna called his name, Rudy returned a beaming smile and a thumbs up.

"Well done."

"Hehehe....."

"Uh..."

Rie, standing adjacent, eyed Luna with apparent annoyance.

Then, Luna beamed confidently and voiced her achievement.

"I secured first place in this assessment."

Luna confidently declared first place.

Rie frowned, but Rudy just chuckled.

"Do you want to watch me? I'm number 80."

"Huh? Absolutely!"

After nodding, Luna watched the assessment for a while.

Before long, the announcer's voice echoed again.

-Number 80, student Rudy Astria.

Upon hearing his name, Rudy turned to Luna and Rie, declaring,

"Luna, sorry, but I'll return after claiming the top spot."

"Huh?"

With that, Rudy briskly made his way to the field.

"Rudy Astria, let's start."

Without even properly positioning himself, he called for the start while still moving.

Luna and Rie exchanged puzzled glances, watching Rudy.

Not just them, but the surrounding spectators also stared at Rudy, perplexed.

Unfazed by their gazes, Rudy continued advancing.

He walked until he was near the scarecrow, and with about five steps remaining, he gripped his right wrist with his left hand and balled up his fist.

He twisted his waist, pulling his fist back as far as it would go.

In this stance, he launched towards the scarecrow.

"Huh?"

"What?"

Everyone looked on, shocked by his actions.

After all, it was a student from the magic department, charging with his fist raised.

And then...

-KWAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAANG!

Rudy's punch connected squarely with the scarecrow's face, toppling it over.

The scarecrow's face was slammed into the ground.

"This...can't be."

"What just happened?!"

Where the scarecrow's face had smashed into the ground, an indented and cracked patch marked the spot.

"Hoo!"

Rudy exhaled, loosening his shoulder and wrist.

His face showed neither joy nor surprise, just a matter-of-fact expression.

-Ru...Rudy A-a-astria!!!! He's scored 9510 points!!!!

The announcer's voice, filled with excitement, echoed throughout the academy grounds.

Chapter 58: Individual Skills Assessment

TL/Editor: Raei

Schedule: 5/Week Wed-Sun

Illustrations: Here

"Ouch..."

My arm and hand throbbed.

The rebound was now spreading throughout my body.

This is why I should've taken it easy....

"No working out for me."

I couldn't imagine doing any strenuous activity for at least two or three days.

Maybe a gentle run, but definitely no lifting.

-Please wait a moment... Maintenance is required. The next student in line, please stand by.

As the announcement ended, a few teachers approached the scarecrow.

They planned to switch out the scarecrow whose face I'd bashed in.

Ignoring them, I walked back to the crowd.

I saw Luna and Rie, their faces shocked.

"You said you were number one, right?"

"Rudy...!"

At my words, Luna beamed and shouted my name.

"You're incredible, Rudy!"

Luna wasn't upset about losing.

She was just happy for me.

But Rie looked rather annoyed.

"Where'd you learn that weird technique?"

At Rie's question, I smirked and answered,

"It's all thanks to dark magic."

"You're saying it's dark magic? Your body is hurt again, is that what dark magic is? Let me look."

Rie grumbled, examining my arm.

My veins stood out, colored in a strange light.

"Why are you hurting yourself for first place?"

"It meant something to me."

Despite the pain, I felt content.

With a score like mine, only someone like Astina could beat me.

There wasn't a first-year student who could top me now.

Then, the announcer's voice filled the air.

-Student number 85, please step forward and stand by! We'll resume the assessment shortly.

Hearing that, I turned to Rie and Luna.

"I have one more test left. I'll go and take that."

"Alright! Be safe!"

"I have my test too."

Leaving Rie and Luna behind, I went to take my test.

After finishing the test, I returned to the center.

-Student Riku, you've earned 220 points.

"Ugh..."

"Riku! Good job!"

Rie was gone, so Luna and I watched the assessment.

"How did you score almost 10,000 points?"

Riku asked, walking over to us.

"Effort."

She gave me a suspicious look.

So we were slowly moving towards the end.

Yet no one had surpassed my score, not even Rie's.

I watched the rest of the assessment, feeling relaxed.

Student number 102, Locke Lucarion, please step forward.

At that, Locke's name was called, and he walked from the crowd towards the center.

As Locke stepped forward, I focused my attention on him.

Locke was someone worth watching.

He played a significant role in the story, a potential ally when needed.

To make the most of him, I had to understand his strengths.

And I was curious.

Both Rie and Luna had progressed quicker than in the original story.

I wondered if Locke, being around them, had accelerated his growth too.

Locke gripped his sword, took his stance, and began to speak.

"Locke Lucarion, I'll start—"

"Locke Lucarion!!!! Go for the gold!!!!!!!"

A muscular man suddenly yelled from behind.

It was Jackson Pumpkin, a Swordsmanship Department professor.

He cheered for Locke like a dad rooting for his kid at a sports match.

What's he up to?

I wondered as Locke looked at Jackson, seemingly puzzled as well.

Noticing the vein popping on Locke's forehead, he looked really irritated.

"Locke Lucarion... Let's get started."

Gritting his teeth, Locke said to start again.

He started to walk towards the scarecrow, sword in hand.

"Uh....?"

Typically, the students would charge the scarecrow, their swords glowing with power.

But Locke was just strolling up to the scarecrow, making Professor Jackson tense.

"Locke!!! You brat!!! Run!!!"

-Professor Jackson, we're in the middle of an assessment.

As Jackson yelled, the announcer reined him in.

"No, this is not acceptable!!!"

-Professor Jackson!

Locke kept walking until he reached the scarecrow.

He glanced at Jackson and smirked.

"This kid!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!"

Poke.

With a treacherous smile, Locke jabbed the scarecrow with the tip of his sword.

-Uh....

The crowd stared, speechless at the scene and Jackson's outburst.

-Locke Lucarion. That's 1 point.....

"Locke!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!"

Jackson's anguished cry echoed around the field.

"Haha....."

I chuckled awkwardly, watching Jackson turn pale.

Even if Locke didn't do well here, Rie would still include him in the joint practical with the first and second years.

Locke's score was just a bit low.....

After Locke, it was Evan's turn.

Evan was last.

-Lastly, student Evan, please come to the center.

"Whew!"

Evan walked onto the field, taking a deep breath, his sword in hand.

"Hmm.....?"

I tilted my head at his choice.

As far as I knew, Evan didn't wield a sword for this test.

Evan's sword was a tool to block magic.

His primary attack was magic, the sword was just a defensive tool.

So why did he bring a sword?

There was no reason for that.

"Evan, begin."

With that, Evan dashed towards the scarecrow, sword in hand.

He ran like a seasoned warrior.

A faint aura of mana encased his blade.

"What is that....."

It wasn't a sword aura.

It was something altogether different.

Evan continued his charge.

As he neared the scarecrow, his sword swiped through the air.

It was a cleanly executed horizontal slash.

Then.....

"It's sliced....."

The scarecrow was perfectly bisected along the path of his sword.

Cut as smoothly as a radish.

I leapt to my feet in surprise.

"Why does he already have....."

It was clear what it was.

Andrei's sword.

A sword capable of severing mana.

A sword that projected its own mana to cut through an opponent's.

However, this description was somewhat inaccurate.

The sword could sever materialized magic.

It severed materialized magic with its own mana.

That was its power.

But there was a drawback.

The sword was unable to sever unmaterialized magic.

It could cut through elemental magic like fire or water, but telekinetic magic, unmaterialized, remained untouched.

However, Evan had later overcome this limitation.

Magic that sliced through the intangible, unmaterialized magic.

He had developed this magic himself.

The theory was easy enough to explain.

In essence, it was about materializing intangible magic.

But any fledgling wizard would understand the complex and near-impossible nature of such a feat.

Though this magic was dependent on Andrei's sword, it was undeniably incredible.

How is he using it already?

To use that magic, Evan experimented on the scarecrow in the training field for hundreds of hours.

To have acquired it already, and to be using it now.....

What could have brought about such a change.....

Was it because of before when I punched a hole into the scarecrow?

Did he train to destroy it as well?

But this brought about new concerns.

If he'd learned this technique now, it would cause issues during the combined first and second-year practical.

It was a technique he shouldn't have learned yet.

Silence.

The field fell quiet.

-That..... Student Evan.....

The announcer's voice cut through the silence.

What followed was even more shocking.

-0.....You score 0 points.

".....What?"

Evan, seemingly in disbelief, questioned the announcer.

-That..... It's a 0 point, right?

Ah.....?

Hearing that, something clicked.

The scarecrow contained both magic that quantified impact and enhancement magic.

Yet when Evan severed the magic, it seemed he had inadvertently destroyed the magic that quantified the impact.

-That..... Please hold. We will discuss with the assessing professor and re-announce the score.

Following the announcer's pause.

-We will now announce the score of student Evan.

-Student Evan's score is 0 points.

-We have decided to award 0 points, judging a lack of understanding of the assessment. So, we will not include it in the ranking. However.....

-The purpose of this assessment is to display superior skills, and we acknowledge there was a flaw in the assessment. Therefore, we will grant you the maximum score.

"What....."

I listened to the announcer's words with a sense of disbelief.

So, was I first?

Or, was I second?

It seemed I wasn't alone in my confusion.

The other students were also murmuring amongst themselves.

I recalled a wizard-themed movie where a certain dormitory was suddenly stripped of their first-place status.

Was this a case of being stripped of the top spot?

I sat in my seat, feeling oddly deflated.

Even though I had achieved first place in the assessment, the bitter feeling lingered.

No, it wasn't merely Evan being granted first place in the assessment, but more so the ambiguity of the results that left a bad taste in my mouth.

While I was lost in thought, the students around me began to gradually disperse.

"Rudy, aren't you leaving?"

Luna tilted her head and asked me.

"Ah, I'm staying to watch the second-grade assessment."

The first-grade assessment had ended, but the second-grade assessment was still to come.

Yet, everyone else was leaving.

There were a few reasons for this.

Firstly, the capabilities of the second graders were widely recognized.

Having spent over a year at the academy, their skills were well known.

So, there was no need to watch them again.

Additionally, it was a given that Astina would secure first place.

Given this predictable outcome, many lost interest and left.

Most likely, those who remained were eager to see just how remarkable Astina's abilities were.

"You're staying to see Astina's assessment?"

"Well, I want to see Astina's assessment, but there's someone else I want to watch."

-First up, student Borval. Please approach the center.

After all, I needed to observe the performance of someone who shared the same teacher as me.

Borval, with a colossal ax slung over his shoulder, made his way onto the field.

Chapter 59: Individual Skills Assessment (5)

"-20810 points! Amazing! Student Borval!!"

The announcer's voice rang out in excitement.

Borval had outperformed me by a huge margin.

"Wow..."

Borval's axe had cleaved through scarecrow's head, continuing through its body.

It was a sight showcasing the might of a barbarian warrior—or maybe, a barbarian wizard?

Regardless, his power was undeniable.

An unexpected talent had risen to the spotlight.

Borval, not a particularly distinguished student academically, nor notable in other activities, had been quietly sharpening his abilities.

And today was his day to shine.

The few spectators couldn't help but express surprise at this unexpected show of talent.

After propping up the scarecrow with his foot, Borval yanked out his axe, hoisted it onto his shoulder, and looked up.

His gaze landed on Astina.

With a look of challenge in his eyes, he left the square.

"Great job, Borval," I greeted Borval as he walked away.

"You, are you okay?"

"Well, I'm not dying."

"Use only as much as your body can handle. It could lead to big problems otherwise."

Borval gave me advice, perhaps knowing that I had used abilities beyond my limits.

Despite his rugged exterior, his words were caring.

"Thanks," I responded with a small smile.

Luna, standing next to me, also smiled at Borval.

"Hello! Great job!"

After a moment's stare at Luna, Borval turned to me.

"...Is she your girlfriend?"

"Excuse me?"

"Eh? What? Huh?"

Luna and I blinked in surprise at Borval's unexpected question.

"I think I'm getting in the way here. I'm going to see Professor Robert."

"No, it's not..."

But before we could correct him, Borval was gone.

What were we supposed to do when he disappeared like that?

"Luna, he's not usually like that....."

I said, trying to dispel the awkwardness.

"Ye-yes, he seems nice!"

Luna stammered, flustered.

"Le-let's go check the scores! Wow! I, I'm excited! For the seniors' matches!"

As Luna tried to change the topic, I nodded.

"Ye-yeah, sure."

So we returned to checking the scores.

"Gi-girlfriend..."

Luna muttered, like a broken doll.

I could only respond with an awkward chuckle.

Astina, due to her role as the student council president, observed the assessment from a separate seat.

"Why is everyone acting so strangely during this assessment..." Astina frowned, murmuring to herself.

After Luna and Borval had completed their turn, both glanced her way.

The other students continued to showcase their abilities, each one more impressive than the last.

"In this situation, how am I supposed to control myself?"

Astina hadn't prepared for an assessment of this kind.

Truthfully, there was no need for her to flaunt her skills in a competition like this.

Her abilities were well-known within the academy, so there was no point in proving them again.

Furthermore, a good performance wouldn't enhance her reputation—she had already claimed the position of successor and was also the student council president.

Her status was as high as it could possibly be.

"-Astina Persia, please step forward."

"Ugh..."

Astina let out a sigh as she walked onto the square.

The first-year students and Borval had set the bar incredibly high with their impressive abilities.

The audience had high expectations for her assessment.

Astina took her place and whispered to herself.

"I suppose I need to meet their expectations."

Meeting expectations was also part of her role.

"Astina Persia. Let's begin."

With that, Astina extended her hand towards the scarecrow.

Her mana began to fluctuate.

The air started to vibrate in response to her immense mana.

"Gravity," Astina murmured, directing her mana.

-Crack!

A strange sound resonated from the scarecrow, reminiscent of a death knell.

"What..."

The spectators watched, mouths agape.

The scarecrow had been crushed as if it were made of tin.

Her magic was not as flashy as Rie's, not as shocking as Borval's or Rudy's, and not as unique as Evan's.

She had simply crumpled the scarecrow.

That was all.

It was a brief spell, seemingly mocking the extravagant spells of others.

It also demonstrated what could happen when Luna's Gravity spell was used correctly.

-Astina Persia... 42100 points...

It was pure, overwhelming power.

Astina's assessment met everyone's high expectations.

It demonstrated who was the strongest and most exceptional individual in the academy at that moment.

That evening, the professors who had placed bets met in Professor Cromwell's lab.

Sitting quietly, sipping their tea, no one spoke a word.

The room was as serene as a still lake.

"...So who won?"

Professor Jackson was the first to disrupt the peace.

"Obviously, it's Rudy Astria. Weren't we betting on who would rank first in the assessment?"

Professor Robert said with a smirk.

"But, considering grades, Evan is at the top," Cromwell pointed out, staring at Robert.

"Weren't we just basing this on the assessment?"

"But the assessment determines the grades."

Tension sparked between Robert and Cromwell.

Professor Jackson quietly interjected at that point.

"But... didn't Evan actually rank lower than our Locke?"

Upon hearing Jackson's remark, McGuire smacked him on the back of his head.

"You be quiet. This is all because of you."

"Ugh..."

The full story was this:

Professor Jackson had been blabbering about the bet to other professors.

Consequently, the professor in charge of the assessment, half jokingly and half seriously, separated the assessment and the grades.

He awarded Evan the highest grades and Rudy the top assessment score.

So, the bet became muddled.

What started as a light-hearted wager had evolved into a significant matter for the professors, who prided themselves on their students.

These professors, who devoted their free time to research and did not mind being on duty, could just stay within the academy and focus on their research.

But this was a question of pride.

When on a duty shift, how much teasing would they receive from other professors?

"You don't care about your students," or "You should have better trained your disciple."

Rather than hearing such remarks, professors would rather bite their tongues.

Professor Robert spoke with a smirk.

"By the assessment, Rudy Astria was first. However, that oddball managed to get top grades using some strange technique."

At this, Professor Cromwell chuckled.

"That's because there was a flaw in the assessment, as the overseeing professor admitted."

Just as it seemed the bet would reach no resolution, Professor Jackson voiced his frustration.

"Argh! Let's have a rematch!"

"That sounds like a great plan, Jackson."

McGuire clapped as if he had made an extraordinary discovery.

At this, both Robert and Cromwell looked flabbergasted.

"That's ridiculous."

"If you're going to say that, we two will decide it, so you both can leave."

"Hmph."

Cowed by the firm words of Professors Cromwell and Robert, the pair fell silent.

After contemplating for a moment, Professor McGuire proposed.

"So, you're saying either of them could have been first if they had been evaluated properly?"

"Of course."

"Obviously."

At their confirmation, Professor McGuire chuckled.

"Then let's determine the winner based on the higher score in the joint first and second-year practical. That seems fair, right? Besides, Cromwell and I will oversee that assessment to ensure there are no mishaps."

At McGuire's suggestion, Cromwell laughed.

"That's an excellent idea."

"I agree."

Robert also rose from his seat, voicing his agreement.

"Then let's go with that."

While the professors were having such a conversation.....

"Haah..."

In her room, Rie sighed.

She was deep in thought, absentmindedly twirling a pen on her desk.

The performances of Luna and Rudy, who scored higher than her, echoed in her mind.

The pair had displayed an overwhelming mastery among the first-year students.

They seemed to have grown tremendously over the break.

"No.... That was just a simple assessment."

Rie spoke, her gaze cast downward.

She thought this assessment was really nothing.

It didn't provide a proper evaluation of an individual but scrutinized a single skill.

Therefore, she reasoned, her low grade didn't reflect her true capabilities.

Really, she didn't know what to do when she saw the others who were running ahead of her.

Rie had been diligent in her own way.

She summoned elementals, and her study of magic remained consistent.

Yet, despite her efforts, it seemed as though the others were outpacing her.

This unfamiliar situation was very confusing for Rie.

"That's right, I didn't make a mistake."

She didn't lose.

She was merely adopting a different approach.

All she has to do is prove it in a proper assessment.

Rie clenched her fist resolutely.

Picking up her calendar, she drew a bear's face on the date of the joint first and second-year practical.

It meant it was very important.

Rie's eyes burned with determination.

Chapter 60: Joint Practical (1)

Days flew by since the end of the individual skills assessment.

Now, the first and second years were gearing up for their joint practical.

Every year, depending on who was in charge, it would change a bit, but the overall structure remained the same.

Hearing about the updated rules, I headed to the bulletin board.

There, I ran into Rie.

"You're here," I greeted, lifting my hand slightly.

"It's been a while."

I hadn't seen Rie much lately.

Despite being at the same academy, I had no idea where she spent her time.

She didn't stand out.

We used to bump into each other during magic practice, but since the end of the assessment, those classes were on hold.

"Did the rules come out?" I asked.

Rie simply nodded and pointed to the bulletin board.

The notice read:

[

Battle Royale

- Each student must find two members to form a team of three.
- The team members are not restricted by grade. (However, those who achieved ranks 1-3 in the individual assessment cannot be in the same team as the top three in the same grade.)
- Anyone from the first and second grades can be the captain.
- The location is Mount Malt.
- Teams compete against each other on the mountain, earning points by defeating other team captains.
- Points depend on the number of teams the defeated team has beaten. (If no teams have been beaten, it's counted as one point.)
- The practical lasts for 5 hours. Ranks are determined by total points earned.

(Note: Second-grade top scorer, Astina, due to her student council duties, is excluded from the activity and given a score equal to the first place in this assessment.)

(Note: Evan, a first-year magic department student, is treated the same as ranks 1-3.)

]

The rules were simpler than I expected.

But one part caught my eye: students ranking 1-3 in the assessment can't be on the same team.

It looked like a response to the unusually high scores of the top-ranking students.

Mulling over this rule, I realized that Rie, Luna, and I couldn't be on the same team.

The rule also mentioned Evan, but that wasn't important.

None of us were planning to team up with him.

But the key phrase here was 'in the same grade'.

That meant top-ranking students from the first and second grades could join forces.

This must've been introduced to avoid reducing the grading variance if top students from the same grade teamed up.

"If only Astina could join..."

Astina was barred from this event, for good reason.

The balance would shatter if she participated, probably taking down everyone single-handedly.

That's why everyone agreed to this special rule, happy to hear that someone would get the same score as Astina.

But even without Astina, I had another potential teammate—Borval, the second place ranker in the second-year assessment.

Teaming up with Borval seemed like a good idea.

Just as I was about to head over, a troubling thought crossed my mind.

How would student safety be ensured during this event?

With each participant having potentially lethal skills, it seemed likely injuries, or even deaths, could happen.

When I voiced this concern to Rie, her response surprised me.

"There are teaching assistants, right?"

"Teaching... assistants?"

In a world without surveillance tools like CCTV, it appeared teaching assistants filled that role.

I could almost hear their distant cries of despair.

Making my way towards Borval, I decided to secure my spot in his team before anyone else could.

"Alright. I can trust you," he quickly agreed to my proposal.

However, there was one issue.

"Borval, I need to operate alone. Please work with the other team members."

He looked confused.

"Acting alone... Is that confidence? You think you can beat teams by yourself?"

"I have some personal matters to attend to."

"Oh... personal matters."

Borval chuckled, muscles twitching with curiosity.

"So you're saying you have someone to fight personally?"

"Something like that."

His face lit up.

"That's what I like to hear. Well, there's no other opportunity for students to fight like this. Good. Just don't lose."

With Borval's hearty laugh ringing in my ears, I excused myself.

"Then I'll get going. There's a lot to prepare."

"Alright. Prepare well."

As I moved away, my mind was racing.

The joint practical of the first and second years was approaching, and there was something I had to do—stop Evan.

During this joint practical, there was one person Evan should not encounter—Anton Fred, a second-year student.

He was the son of a family working with the dean, Oliver.

If Evan met Anton, there'd be repercussions, a hidden story intertwined with the dean.

And that was something I needed to prevent.

If Anton meets Evan during the joint practical, Anton suffers a great defeat.

Anton, humiliated by such a loss to a commoner, would seek revenge after the event.

But his own power was not enough.

He'd resort to leveraging his family's influence, leading to an orchestrated accident that Dean Oliver takes advantage of.

If the story goes on normally, Oliver would fall without anyone knowing.

However, if this hidden story unfolds, you would have to fight him, as he tries to manipulate the situation.

That's why I had originally planned to focus my efforts on preventing Evan's involvement in the joint practical—to stop this hidden story from occurring...

The issue, however, was Evan's new technique.

This technique disrupted the existing balance.

It wasn't merely the power to sever intangible magic.

If applied correctly, this skill could set the mana of anyone it touched into disarray.

An ordinary wizard might manage to some degree, but for someone like me, who must finely manipulate mana, Evan was the worst possible opponent.

Ideally, I would have partnered with Borval to face Evan, but then my grades would be at risk.

Battling Evan would be time-consuming, and to achieve high marks, we would need to take down numerous teams.

Challenging Evan alongside Borval just wasn't a time-efficient strategy.

Therefore, Borval needed to take care of my grades for me.

"I'll need to do a lot of preparation...."

I headed to the library first.

I had promised to study with Luna, and planned to prepare weapons for the practical while reading books.

"Ah, Rudy. You're here?"

Luna sat amidst a mound of books, dark circles highlighting her fatigue.

"Luna, you seem quite worn out."

"Really? I don't feel that tired..."

Luna countered, her hand instinctively reaching up to touch her face, even as fatigue painted her features.

Luna was clearly preparing intensely to get good grades.

The second semester's joint practical for the first and second years held as much weight as midterms or finals.

Students worked themselves to their limits to get a higher score.

"But take some breaks in between. You'll collapse before the practical starts."

"Alright! Thanks for your concern, Rudy," she responded with a warm smile.

Then, as if something had just occurred to her, Luna asked, "By the way, have you figured out your group members yet?"

"For now, I'm teamed up with Borval."

"Borval? You've picked a great team member! Wouldn't a group with you and Borval be nearly guaranteed victory?"

I gave an awkward smile and shook my head, knowing the battle ahead would be far from simple.

While Borval and I might excel at individual assessments, the joint practical was a completely different beast.

Our techniques were good for demonstrating explosive power against a stationary target.

They weren't sustainable in the long run.

The difference between fighting a human opponent versus a straw doll was big.

After all, no one in a real fight would simply stand still and take a hit.

"What about you, Luna? Have you teamed up with Ena and Riku?"

"Yes! I don't have any seniors I know."

Despite Luna's words, the reality was that most seniors would jump at the chance to partner with her.

Luna was well aware of this.

Yet, in keeping with her character, she wouldn't abandon the people she spent every day with, Riku and Ena, for a chance at better grades.

Looking at Luna like that, I opened my mouth with a smile.

"Well, I won't go easy on you when we meet."

"I won't go easy on you either, so be careful~"

Luna retorted, a gleam in her eye.

Our laughter echoed through the library.

In the middle of it all, a thought crossed my mind.

"Ah, Luna."

I began, recalling the second purpose of my visit to the library.

"Don't you have something to tell me?"

Her gaze faltered at my question.

Considering Luna's grouping with Ena and Riku, scoring high might prove a challenge, given that the practical involved second-year students too.

Even for Luna, who was an outstanding first-year, might not succeed.

So, Luna needed a 'weapon'.

"No, nothing," she replied, her voice a mere whisper.

Seeing her evade my question filled me with regret.

Luna had been skittish ever since vacation ended.

Despite my repeated attempts to approach the topic, she remained the same.

Luna needed Levian's magic book now more than ever, for her grades and for others.

Despite my indirect hints, she seemed terrified of something.

With a gentle smile, I said, "Then whenever you have something to tell me, just say it. I'll be waiting."

Chapter 61: Joint Practical (2)

Books were scattered untidily across the desk, pens were rolling about, and papers with magic circles were pinned about haphazardly.

This was Luna's workspace.

After achieving impressive grades last semester, she'd been rewarded with her own desk in a study room.

Typically, the room would be bustling with other students, but since it was late, she found herself alone.

She sat at her desk, deep in thought.

"Just about two weeks left..."

Luna murmured, her eyes landing on the words 'Joint Practical' marked on the calendar.

"Can I become stronger by then...?"

Luna already knew the answer.

Conventional methods wouldn't bring about dramatic improvements in such a short period.

She could consolidate her existing abilities through studying and training, but two weeks was hardly enough to explore new avenues.

Yet, there was an option - Levian's spellbook.

If she reclaimed the spellbook she'd given to Rudy, she could wield a new, unconventional weapon alongside her original skills.

But Luna was scared.

Memories of the library engulfed in flames, panicking students, Rie and Astina working tirelessly to control the situation, and Rudy nursing his wounds swirled in her mind.

The chaos caused by that spellbook had hurt many, either directly or indirectly.

The thought of such an incident recurring made her apprehensive about using the spellbook again.

"Can I control that spellbook in my current state?"

Luna questioned, clutching her head.

Her desire for strength could harm those around her.

Ena and Riku, who would be in her group for the joint practical, could be in danger if she used the spellbook near them.

She might ruin the assessment, or worse, hurt her friends.

Luna was terrified of this.

She was frightened of the prospect of losing everything just for the sake of gaining strength, of causing harm, and of being abandoned by everyone around her.

"Is it right for me to make this choice just because I want to become stronger?"

Luna yearned for strength but not at the expense of her friendships.

She hated the idea of causing harm and didn't want to be a burden.

But at the same time, she yearned for greater grades and more powerful magic.

Luna found herself thinking back to Rudy's playful challenge.

-I won't go easy on you when we meet.

Even though they had both joked about it, she wondered if she could truly do her best if they crossed paths in the practical.

To secure top grades, Luna realized she might have to compete against her friends.

They'd always competed for ranks during exams, but directly fighting a friend felt distinctly different from merely outscoring them.

Could she bring herself to hinder her friends for her own benefit?

As she wrestled with this question, the night deepened around her.

The following day found Luna in Professor Mcguire's lab, looking over a scroll with a magic circle.

She had bought the scroll specifically for the joint practical.

Yet, progress was slow, the worries from last night still casting a shadow over her thoughts.

Watching Luna, Professor Mcguire eventually rose from his seat and approached her.

"Luna, is your preparation going well?"

Startled, Luna looked up. "Ah, Professor."

Sensing her struggle, he suggested, "If you're finding it hard to concentrate, perhaps you could use a break, maybe some fresh air?"

Luna shook her head, fists clenched with determination.

"No! I'll try to concentrate."

Mcguire observed her for a moment, then pulled over a chair and sat across from her.

"Luna, do you realize that worries only grow if you bottle them up? The more you dwell on them, the more they expand, like bubbles."

He offered a gentle smile.

"But even if you don't find a solution right away, speaking about them can help you shake them off."

He gestured to himself.

"Why not think of me as a wall and try to shake off your worries?"

Luna hesitated, her fingers fiddling anxiously.

After glancing between the floor and Mcguire, she cautiously spoke.

"What do I want to do?"

"What?" echoed Professor Mcguire, his smile warm and encouraging.

"I joined the academy because I wanted to learn magic. But now, I'm not so sure. I just want to enjoy my time with my friends."

In response to Luna's confession, Mcguire gently probed, "Can't you do both? Learn magic and maintain your friendships."

"I want to do both, I can. But if I use certain methods to get ahead, it might not work out that way."

"Why?"

"I'm worried I might upset my friends..."

Upon hearing this, Mcguire took a moment to ponder before asking, "So, you fear your friends will leave you?"

Luna nodded.

"In that case, would you leave your friends if they upset you?"

"No! I...."

Luna started, taken aback by the question, but she faltered, unable to continue.

"Do you believe your friends would abandon you if you upset them?"

"...No. They're all really kind and good friends..."

Seeing Luna's response, Mcguire smiled and opened his mouth to speak.

"Isn't it alright then? Nobody's perfect. We all make mistakes that may inconvenience or even upset others. But nobody holds that against you. We've all been a burden to someone else at some point. Rather than fretting over being a burden, wouldn't it be more constructive to focus on how you can help them?"

At Mcguire's words, Luna just stared.

"But... I could hurt my friends, ruin their grades."

"But it's also possible that you won't, right?"

"...."

Mcguire rose from his chair.

"Think about it carefully. Is your choice truly a hindrance to others? Or, just an opportunity for you to grow."

Later that night.

"You have a thoughtful friend."

Professor McGuire mused aloud as he gazed out his window, savoring his wine.

Yesterday, he'd had a visitor.

It was Rudy Astria.

"Luna seems troubled these days," Rudy had informed him.

"Oh, really? What seems to be bothering her?"

"I'm not entirely sure."

Rudy had then asked McGuire a favor.

"Could you lend her your ear?"

"You want me to listen, so you can find out what Luna's concerns are?"

Rudy shook his head.

"No, I simply want you to hear her out."

McGuire had frowned at that.

"Why not lend her your ear then?"

"It's a worry that I'm not able to listen to."

"Do you have an inkling of what this concern might be?"

Rudy hadn't answered.

McGuire sighed and conceded, "Alright, I'll do as you asked."

He raised his wine glass in a solitary toast.

"Reminds me of the old days..."

Mcguire, Cromwell, Robert— they'd all had such worries back then.

Matters that felt of immense significance yet were somewhat trivial in retrospect.

They had grown through sharing troubles and also through suffering alone.

He saw echoes of those days in Luna and Rudy.

But their relationship was slightly different.

Rudy seemed to act as Luna's sponsor.

Certainly, he officially held that role, but Mcguire observed that it was often Rudy guiding Luna, providing subtle answers to her concerns, clearing her path.

"Is this the right way..."

When a bear raises its cub, it doesn't only give it fish but also teaches it how to catch them.

This ensures the cub's survival when it's on its own.

However, looking at Luna and Rudy's relationship...

"If Rudy were gone, would Luna be able to stand on her own..."

Rudy possessed the strength to forge his path, even without Luna.

But for Luna...

Mcguire looked up at the moon.

His tenure as a professor had been long, and he considered himself an adult with plenty of experience.

But facing this situation, he was reminded of his own inadequacies.

"I wonder what tomorrow's weather will bring."

Mcguire gazed skyward, muttering to himself.

Several days later.

I found myself in an academy laboratory, preoccupied with a series of experiments.

This was the 'weapon' meant for the upcoming joint practical.

With the joint practical drawing nearer, this marked the final experiment before its was completed.

What nagged at my mind, though, was that Luna hadn't yet come to see me.

Only a handful of days remained...

I thought it best to hand it over to her before the joint practical.

But it seemed Luna wasn't quite ready.

I could just pass over the spellbook to her, but that would be meaningless.

I believed she could grow the most when she felt the need and became desperate for it.

"Ha... I hope this works out."

Just as I was about to start the experiment, there was a knock at the door.

"Come in."

A voice sounded from outside.

"Rudy, may I enter?"

The voice belonged to Luna.

"Of course, come in."

At my reply, Luna swung the door open and stepped inside.

Her face held an air of unwavering determination.

Seeing this change in Luna, I couldn't help but smile.

"Do you have something to say?"

At this, Luna nodded slightly.

"Could I have it... returned now?"

I moved over to the bag I had stashed to one side and took out Luna's spellbook.

As I placed the spellbook firmly into Luna's hand, our eyes locked.

"Give it everything you've got."

With these words, Luna's face lit up with a vibrant smile as she replied,

"...Yes!"

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Chapter 62: Joint Practical (3)

We were standing somewhere in the mountains.

It was ablaze with the colors of fall, tinted in hues of red.

A cool wind rustled the trees, making the autumn leaves flutter to the ground.

Borval swept away the drifting leaves with a casual wave of his hand.

Then, he turned to me and said,

"So, you're going solo."

"Yes, I'm off right away."

"Well then, I guess I'm stuck with this fellow."

Borval gestured towards the man standing next to him.

"Pl, ple, please take care..."

"Sure, I got it."

Borval interrupted him, leaving him mid-sentence.

He didn't seem very reliable.

Seeing Borval like this, I felt a twinge of guilt.

I had been scrambling to find another partner besides Borval before the joint practical started.

However, finding just one person was challenging.

Given that the exercise involved teams of three, many groups were formed from familiar faces.

When three strangers teamed up, their individual strengths only added up.

But when well-matched people joined teams, their power multiplied, even squared.

Hence, the stronger students paired up with those who complimented their abilities.

I felt the limit of my social circle since I couldn't partner with Rie, Luna, or Astina.

While I was busy worrying and looking around, I spotted a familiar face.

It was the red-haired guy who had given me trouble at the start of the first term.

"Hey, what was your name again?"

"My, my name is Jet William!"

"Right, Jet, give it your all."

Jet, whom I had 'educated' a bit at the start of the term, shivered every time he saw me.

Even when I told him to drop the formalities, he kept them up anyway.

I just looked at him with a smirk.

After Garwel left, Jet was left aimless at the academy.

The mischief-makers he hung out with were all lower nobles.

Without a leader, their group fell apart.

These days, he seemed to be quietly attending his classes.

I wasn't sure how competent he was, but with Borval on our side, even if three first-year students attacked, we could handle it.

So, this guy was just to make up the numbers.

Moreover, since I had instilled a decent amount of fear in him, he would probably obey without question.

This meant I could direct him as I saw fit.

"It's about to start soon."

As Borval spoke, a firework lit up the sky.

-Bang!

The firework signaled the start of the event.

"Shall we move then?"

At Borval's words, I sprang into action.

"Aaaargh!!!"

"She should have just handed it over."

Rie chuckled, watching the person tumble down, amused.

Locke stepped forward and plucked a small gem from the pocket of the fallen participant.

The gem Locke held was a marker for scoring points.

Everyone was given one, and if you managed to attach the captain's gem to your own, you could snatch all their accumulated points.

"Indeed, it's Rie."

Said their third teammate.

He hailed from the Petro family, well-known for their prowess in alchemy.

"Yes," Rie acknowledged.

She didn't know him too well, but as an alchemy student, he was useful.

"Hmmm...."

Rie mused while walking.

Points were slowly stacking up, but securing first place seemed a tough feat at this pace.

Truthfully, Rie was confident in her own abilities.

Even without Astina, she was a formidable opponent.

And having Locke made them a terrifying team, making other participants wary.

However, this made it challenging to clinch the top spot.

Most teams would bolt at the sight of Rie, instead of facing her head-on.

So, a chase ensued, which wasted precious time.

"Locke, from now on, you'll operate independently," Rie declared.

"Independently?"

"Yes, don't waste time hunting the strong ones. Pick off the ones you can easily beat."

Keeping Locke by her side was a misuse of his swift movement.

Rie and the kid from the Petro family couldn't move as quickly.

It was best for him to go solo, taking down the weaker teams.

"Got it. I'll head south."

"Good, we'll take the north."

Upon hearing Rie's words, Locke sprang into action.

I was alone, meandering through the woods.

I encountered several teams, but none were a challenge.

The clever ones fled at the sight of me, but most chose to face off, seeing me alone.

Borval was our team captain, but those we ran into had no way of knowing.

They assumed that I, with my high assessment scores, was the captain and fought with me.

"They should at least try to recognize teams with high-ranking players."

There was nothing to gain in fighting me, a mere team member.

They were like moths drawn to a flame.

I needed to reach Evan quickly, but the constant interruptions were testing my patience.

After covering some distance, I fished out a scroll from my bag.

As I tore it open, a map materialized in the air.

A single dot marked the map.

"Hmm... Hard to track when it keeps moving."

That dot represented Astina's magic energy.

More accurately, it pointed to Yeniel, who was linked by Astina's magic.

In this exam, Astina was part of the safety committee, stationed outside the test area.

So, tracking down Astina's magic would lead me to Yeniel.

The day after learning about Astina's absence from the exam, I sought her out.

I had prepared a magic search circle using Astina's mana, confident that Evan would be on the same team as Yeniel.

"Hmm... Southwards, it seems."

Evan's team was constantly moving within the southern region.

The floating map dissolved into thin air once its duration expired.

"Time to get moving," I murmured.

As I prepared to set off, a figure in the distance caught my eye—someone was swiftly advancing toward me.

"What's going on?"

The individual bore a sword at his hip and was running at an impressive speed, a clear sign of belonging to the Swordsmanship Department.

His lone figure suggested he wasn't just another participant.

As he drew closer, he began to slow down.

"Huh?"

He slowed to a stop, hopping in my direction.

"What are you doing here?"

"Locke?"

I recognized him.

"Oh, what a pleasant surprise," I greeted Locke.

Neither of us felt compelled to fight.

If Rie had been in his place, conflict might have broke out, but Locke, like me, was merely a team member.

He knew I wasn't the captain; confrontation between us was pointless.

"Why are you alone? Where's Rie?"

"Rie can handle herself. She's decided to go alone to accumulate more points."

"Is that so?"

A smirk crept onto my face at his words.

"Hey, could you do me a favor? I have some valuable information to share."

"Information?"

"Yes. Don't you want to score big?"

I proposed, cleverly weaving in a touch of deceit.

I've decided to use Locke to my advantage.

Meanwhile, in the northern reaches of the forest.

"Luna, you're incredible! Well done!"

Riku sprinted into Luna's arms, praising her.

"Yeah! Ena and Riku, you both did fantastic too!"

Luna beamed at Riku.

"What did I do exactly?"

Ena approached, curious.

"Hey, the amount of useful potions you brought made our fight much more manageable!"

Luna's words coaxed a smile onto Ena's face.

"But what's with the robe? It's remarkably durable."

Luna was sporting a black robe.

"Hehe, it's a gift," she replied, clutching it tightly.

Rudy had given it to her, a sturdy piece fashioned from wyvern skin.

Luna's team consisted of members from the Magic and Alchemy Departments, leaving them without a frontline.

Consequently, Luna often bore the brunt of the attacks, facing several dangerous situations.

However, her robe was strong enough to deflect all attacks.

Even when she did get hit, the attacks barely left a dent.

Besides, Ena's stock of healing potions offered a safety net, but the defensive strength of the robe allowed Luna to act more bravely.

"Our score is steadily rising."

"Do you think we have a shot at first place?"

Ena examined the score and asked.

Riku pumped her fist energetically in response.

"I hope so."

Luna shared a smile with the two.

She adjusted the small bag on her back; it was housing a spellbook.

Frankly, she hadn't had much use for it since getting it back, but she decided to bring it along as a precaution.

However, there's been no need it for so far.

Most battles were won using pre-prepared scrolls or the cube she made for the individual assessment.

"Shall we continue?"

As Luna was about to go forward, she caught sight of a familiar face in the distance.

"Ah....."

It was a face she was happy to see, but one she couldn't afford to engage with right now.

"Riku, Ena.....! We need to hide!"

Luna whispered urgently to her companions.

Following her command, Riku and Ena immediately crouched.

Despite their efforts, their location was far from inconspicuous.

This mountainous region bore many clearings where trees were sparse.

Their attempts to camouflage themselves in the open were futile.

"Ena, Riku, stay low and let's head towards those trees....."

"Why are we hiding?"

Ena asked as she saw Luna's hurried actions.

However, the answer became apparent almost immediately.

"I saw your fight."

They approached with grins plastered on their faces.

Riku and Ena tensed, their expressions turning rigid at the sight.

"Ah....."

And the face of the figure approaching them also stiffened.

"Lu.....Luna?"

That person was none other than Rie.

Chapter 63: Joint Practical (4)

"So, we plan to take on a strong guy and grab his points in one go?"

"Exactly. And it's no big deal if we lose."

Since we weren't in charge, a loss wouldn't risk too much.

Locke appeared to agree, nodding in understanding.

"Can we win this fight?"

I shot Locke a sly grin.

"Doubting yourself? We aren't picking a fight with Astina."

At this, Locke stared at me, his eyes like daggers.

"I'm not doubting. It's just that you're not strong."

"Who are you calling weak? You only earned one point in the individual assessment."

Locke clenched his teeth at my words.

"So, who's our opponent?"

"I won't spill. You might betray me if I do."

Locke's desire to win flared, just as planned.

I figured he only agreed because he thought he'd gain something from it.

After making up his mind, Locke broke the silence.

"How will we split the points?"

"Fifty-fifty."

I replied with a smile.

"You'll get half."

"Luna...."

Rie leaned over as Luna attempted to slip away.

"Oh... Hi, Rie."

Luna got up and acknowledged Rie.

She looked shocked.

Rie's expression mirrored her surprise.

She thought she might encounter a familiar face, but seeing one in person was still a shock.

Rie stared at Luna.

"That robe...."

She mumbled, quietly enough for no one else to hear.

It was the robe that Rudy had bought from the Persia region.

"Hmm...."

Rie sighed and shook her head.

Just then, Luna cautiously began to speak.

"Rie... I don't want to fight you...."

Luna's voice trembled.

Her hesitation didn't stem from Rie's strength or the fear of defeat.

She simply didn't want to fight with a friend.

She preferred to compete for ranks without resorting to a fight here.

Rie was a cherished friend to Luna.

"Luna."

Rie's voice was firm.

"I'm sorry. This is a test. To rank high, this is the right choice."

A Sylph materialized behind Rie.

Suddenly, Riku yelled from Luna's back.

"Luna!!! Get ready to fight!!!"

"Ah!!!"

Startled, Luna hastily grabbed a scroll from her bag.

Rie didn't waste a second.

"Sylph."

A powerful gust of wind emerged.

The wind morphed into a blade and hurtled towards Luna.

The blade was fast, reaching Luna before she could tear the scroll.

"Eek...!"

She quickly bent over and shielded herself with the robe.

The wind blade struck Luna's robe.

The force pushed Luna back, but fortunately, she wasn't severely hurt.

While she had no injuries, she noticed...

"My... my robes...."

Luna saw the scratches on her robe from the blade.

Although her robe had shielded her, it hadn't fully deflected the direct hit.

She glanced back at Riku and Ena.

Thankfully, they didn't seem to be injured.

But, if the fight went on, they would definitely get hurt.

They'd be injured because she couldn't fight effectively.

This wasn't right.

"Rie, if you keep attacking like this, I can't stand by."

Despite her words, she still looked hesitant.

"Then let's fight."

Rie said, channeling mana into her hand.

"Fire Sphere."

A small sphere of fire appeared in Rie's hand.

This was the magic she used during her individual assessment.

It was the magic that triggered a powerful explosion.

Seeing this, Luna tore the scroll in her hand.

Instantly, multiple small fireballs appeared before Luna.

All these fireballs zoomed toward Rie.

Upon seeing this, Rie moved diagonally.

When the attack aimed for her, she tried to dodge.

But, the fireballs didn't fly straight as normal ones would.

As soon as Rie started running diagonally, all the fireballs began to trail her.

'I expected this.'

Rie didn't believe it would be simple, given that it was from a scroll.

When the fireballs trailed Rie, the Sylph behind her dispatched wind blades toward them.

Seeing this, Luna fetched a cube from her pocket.

"Gravity Cube.... Activate."

Like in the assessment, the cube unfolded.

However, it looked slightly different.

Noticing the unfolding cube, Rie bit her lower lip.

'She can't hit me, can she?'

The cube from the assessment.

It was a magical device that accurately aimed and attacked a specific point.

The downside of this device was as definite as its power.

Since it targets a narrow point, it's tough to hit a moving target.

However, the fact that Luna unfolded it meant something had changed.

"When this happens...."

Rie stopped and stood still.

"Hey! Toss me the potion."

At Rie's shout, the student from the Petro family behind her threw a glass bottle her way.

Rie caught it and immediately downed its contents.

"Hmm...."

Inside was a mana amplifier.

It was a potion that accelerated mana movement for a brief period.

Then, the small fireball she'd created earlier started to grow.

Even as it grew, the flame, initially the size of a finger joint, only expanded to a size smaller than a fist.

But, this magic technique was to detonate the compressed flames.

Even a slight increase in size multiplied its power.

"Go."

Then, the magic bolted towards Luna.

Since Sylph was intercepting Luna's fireballs, she couldn't use the move she'd used during the assessment.

Luna frowned upon seeing Rie's magic.

Hitting Rie with the cube was tricky, and if Rie's magic exploded, they would sustain significant damage.

Luna swiftly made a decision and redirected her magic.

"Gravity....!"

Luna triggered the cube.

To prevent herself from being targeted, Rie moved.

Despite such maneuvers, the cube activated in an entirely different spot.

-Kwaah...Kagak!

Intense gravity crushed the Fire Sphere that Rie had thrown.

Since the Fire Sphere wasn't moving at a high speed, its trajectory was somewhat predictable.

Gravity was applied to the spot where it was flying and the moment it entered the gravity effect, it exploded.

The explosion tried to expand, but due to the gravity, all the flames were pushed to the ground.

"Uh....!"

While wielding the cube, Luna let out a small groan.

Rie didn't overlook this instant.

"Sylph!"

Sylph had already neutralized the fireballs Luna had launched and was ready to attack.

"Ah...."

Luna gasped upon seeing Sylph.

If she stops operating the cube now and evades the attack, the flame will scatter.

Its force would be somewhat reduced since the explosion was partially suppressed.

Luna, with her robe, could minimize the damage, but not Ena and Riku behind her.

They would get hurt.

The best decision here would've been to fold the cube and dodge Sylph's attack, but Luna couldn't make that choice.

"Uh...."

Instead, she was prepared to get slightly injured rather than hurt Riku and Ena.

Luna tightly shut her eyes.

Then, a sound arose beside Luna.

"Luna! Don't close your eyes!"

"Huh?"

Suddenly, Riku was rushing towards her.

"Stone Wall!"

As Riku yelled, a wall of stone sprung up from the ground.

It appeared much sturdier than Riku's usual magic.

-Kagak! Kagak!

The wind blades Sylph had unleashed at Luna were stopped by it.

The scratching sound of stone could be heard, but it couldn't penetrate the wall.

"Luna, take this!"

Riku tossed a potion to Luna.

Luna caught the potion.

"Drink it!"

Riku shouted and aimed her hand at Rie.

"Waterball!!"

"Sylph."

The magic flying towards Rie was effortlessly blocked by Sylph.

However, because she had used Sylph to block it, she missed another opportunity to attack Luna.

"Uh....!!!"

Within that fleeting moment, Luna had already downed the potion and discarded the empty bottle onto the ground.

And she exerted more force onto Rie's Fire Sphere.

-Fsss...

Eventually, the flames almost disappeared completely.

"Darn...."

Rie grimaced when she noticed her magic wasn't producing much power.

Seizing this moment, Riku used her magic once more.

"Waterball!"

Visibly irritated, Rie signaled Sylph.

Sylph launched wind blades and shattered the Waterball magic Riku had cast.

"Huh?"

However, it differed from the previous magic.

When the water droplet burst, some liquid spurted out, dousing Rie.

"Uh...."

Rie grimaced at the sudden splash of liquid on her face and wiped it off with her hand.

'Is it a mana-disrupting potion?'

But, no student could have concocted such a potion yet.

Feeling an odd sensation, Rie squirmed.

"What's this... huh? Uh... huh?"

After getting doused with the liquid, Rie sensed something peculiar.

Her body was growing warmer and something felt off.

It was a sensation she hadn't experienced before... something...

Then, Ena, who was standing behind Luna, grinning, appeared.

Ena smiled and began speaking.

"I'm not knowledgeable about making potions that harm people. I'm a good person who only knows how to help others."

"That... what's this? Uh... huh...."

Rie writhed, her body increasingly feeling peculiar and warmer.

"That potion is a love potion~."

"What is..."

Rie's cheeks slowly flushed.

It was a strange sensation.

"Hehe...."

The potion that Ena had told Riku to throw.

It was a potion that amplified desire.

It makes the body burn and induces various desires...

It was a potion she had made, thinking she might use it someday for Luna and Rudy, who were always so frustrating.

"I didn't expect it to be used like this."

Seeing Rie squirming, Ena let out a sly laugh.

Sorry I've been busy preparing for a friend's wedding.. after party? I dunno what they're called. 2am crocheting flowers was fun.

Chapter 64: Joint Practical (5)

A powerful gust of wind slapped against my face.

Locke was sprinting forward with me riding on his back.

"How far are we going?"

"Quit asking and just run."

I realized that walking would only delay us.

So, I decided to ride Locke.

Our goal was simple: reach Evan as fast as we could.

As I'd hoped, Locke kept a swift pace despite my extra weight.

He seemed somewhat strained, but that wasn't important.

All that mattered was our speed.

Suddenly, the distant sounds of conflict reached my ears.

The clash of weapons, shouts of struggle.

I squinted, focusing on the direction of the noise.

There, caught in a beam of light, was a shimmer of silver hair.

Yeniel.

It had to be Yeniel.

Seeing a black-haired man with a sword nearby confirmed it.

It was Evan's group.

I tapped Locke's back, pointing out the sight.

"Look, over there."

"Evan's group."

Locke must have noticed as well since he changed course towards them.

"Listen, from now on, do as I say..."

But Locke had already taken off, running.

"Hey, wait a minute!"

He continued to ignore me, dashing straight into Evan's group.

"You stubborn..."

With a mighty leap, Locke tossed me into the sky.

My body soared upwards, against my will.

This wasn't part of my plan...

I hadn't planned on fighting.

My only aim had been to stop them from meeting Anton Fred.

Of course, confronting Evan's group might have ended up being inevitable.

But a fight wasn't necessary right off the bat.

Evan was the protagonist, a tough opponent.

Judging whether or not I could defeat him was a challenge in itself.

Assessing the enemy's strength before a fight was always the right move.

As I floated in the sky, I glanced downwards.

Only two figures were standing below, Evan and Yaniel.

Weren't they supposed to be three?

Where was the third person?

I dismissed the thought - now wasn't the time.

Evan and Yaniel's eyes widened as Locke and I suddenly descended from the sky.

Taking them by surprise, I cast a spell.

"Abyssal Flame!"

While still airborne, I launched my magic towards Evan, and Locke charged at Yaniel.

Evan seemed surprised but blocked my magic skillfully.

As his sword made contact with my spell, it vanished like dust in the wind.

Simultaneously, Locke and Yaniel locked swords.

Locke tried to overpower Yaniel with sheer force, but Yaniel deflected his attack, shoving him forwards.

She then aimed her sword at Locke's exposed neck.

Locke lurched forward, falling intentionally, and rolled away from Yaniel's range.

Falling from this height would be painful.

Locke might be unscathed, but I wasn't made of the same stuff.

Reacting quickly, I cast a spell.

"Finger of the Demon!"

A black column rose from the ground, catching me mid-air.

As I hung from the pillar, I shouted at Locke.

"Hey! Locke! If you plan an ambush, do it properly! What was that all about?"

"Does it matter? Isn't the point to fight and win?"

Locke responded nonchalantly.

His casual attitude only made me annoyed.

"I'm beginning to question why I even brought you along."

Evan and Yeniel, suddenly thrust into a skirmish, stared at us, baffled.

"Rudy Astria, were you aiming for us?"

Evan questioned, eyes locked on me.

Well, what's done was done.

'Isn't it enough to fight and win?'

I gave Evan a mischievous smirk.

"Come on, let's go, top seat."

Mana surged into my hand as I prepared for the battle.

Meanwhile, Rie, cheeks flushed, was dodging Luna and Riku's relentless assaults.

Seeing her desperately clinging onto her skirt was heartbreaking.

Her eyes welled up with tears, her cheeks ablaze with redness.

"Please...the...antidote..."

Rie stammered out.

Her words left the Petro family's son clueless.

"I...I don't know anything about this potion...I've never heard of it..."

Rie whimpered in response, her face showing clear signs of tears.

Luna and the others were at a loss.

They were in a battle, yes, but attacking her in this state felt... like they were crossing a line.

Suddenly, a potion soared in from behind Rie.

"Um... here, take this!"

"If you had it... why didn't you give it sooner?"

Rie managed to mutter, trying to hold back her tears.

She immediately guzzled down the potion as she received it.

"After hearing..."

Petro started, but was cut short by Rie's scowl.

"What is it?"

"It temporarily suppresses the effects of poison or drugs in the body, but they return stronger later," he explained.

Rie flashed a wry smile at this revelation.

"Well, in that case, it doesn't matter. I just have to wrap this up before then."

Despite her words, she was still under the influence of the potion.

Her cheeks retained their flush.

But now, she was at least capable of focusing.

"Luna, let's have a proper fight now," Rie announced.

Luna was taken aback.

She had thought they had been fighting seriously up until this point.

Despite being in an abnormal state, Rie had been successfully blocking all incoming attacks with Sylph.

With a dexterity that was hard to match, she managed to evade most of the attacks by artfully maneuvering her body and casting Sylph to block any critical attacks.

Luna's hand slid into her bag, counting the remaining scrolls.

Around ten were left, though only a handful of them would serve as effective attacks against Rie.

Luna fingered the cube in her pocket, its warmth still lingering from prior use.

She needed time before she could use it again.

It would've been a good move to use it when Rie was in a weakened state, but that window had slipped away.

Luna didn't dwell on it.

As Rie readied another spell, Luna's hand tightened around the cube.

It would be ready for one last use soon.

With Rie's clear intention to wrap up the battle quickly, Luna had to consider this the final deployment of the cube.

Should she target Rie or counter Rie's attack with it?

Despite such considerations, Luna reached a conclusion - it had to be used offensively.

"Riku, Ena. Don't focus on blocking Rie's attacks, instead impede her movements."

"Understood...!"

"Yes!"

Luna extracted two scrolls from her bag.

With a swift motion, Luna ripped both scrolls simultaneously.

A fireball materialized and surged towards Rie, just like before.

'The same attack as before...?'

Rie momentarily questioned the tactic, but she quickly dismissed the thought.

Two scrolls were torn, one was a fireball attack, the other unknown.

Rie smirked.

"Fire Sphere."

A flame sprouted from Rie's palm.

Despite the incoming fireball, she held her ground.

"Sylph."

As Rie began to assemble wind from Sylph, Luna was momentarily perplexed.

She wasn't moving, even as the fireball reached dangerously close.

The sound of another scroll being torn echoed in the field.

But Rie was busy with her own spellcasting.

The sound originated from somewhere else, most likely from her teammate who had been hiding behind her.

"I can use scrolls too."

Scrolls might be the creation of wizards, but usage wasn't exclusive to them.

A forceful jet of water collided with the fireball mid-air, smothering it completely.

Water-based magic was not Rie's forte.

Among fundamental magic, she excelled in harnessing the attributes of wind and fire.

With intermediate magic, she also largely leaned towards fire.

The notion of them countering with magic of a different attribute hadn't crossed their minds.

The tiny flame in Rie's hand darted towards Sylph's mouth.

Luna's body sprung into action instinctively.

If she was to take the full brunt of Rie's attack, it would spell disaster.

Riku and Ena too would be caught in its path.

Whirling the bag from her back to the front, Luna yanked out her spellbook.

All fears, anxieties, and stray thoughts were shoved aside.

Her sole focus now was to safeguard Riku and Ena.

"Sylph...." Rie whispered.

Luna furiously flipped through the pages of her spellbook.

Where was it?

Where...where.

Even though Luna hadn't used this spellbook, she had skimmed through its content.

There was certainly a spell hidden within its pages that could deflect this.

"Shoot!!!"

Rie's voice rang out just as Luna stumbled upon the desired spell.

Her finger brushed against the page.

"Ugh...!"

Luna grunted as a light burst forth from the book.

Mana drained from Luna's body, the spell taking effect.

"Fortify!"

An ethereal radiance enveloped Luna, Ena, and Riku.

The spell that was once used on the scarecrow.

A spell that fortified the body.

It essentially granted resistance against all impacts.

"Ah!!!!" Luna gasped as Rie's magic neared and detonated right before her.

Despite the fortification spell, Luna could feel a scorching sensation searing through her.

"Grrraaaah!!!!!" she roared.

"Luna!!!!"

Yet Luna didn't stop.

"This... is nothing...."

She managed to say through gritted teeth.

Her body screamed in pain, but she pushed through.

Rie, who had been watching, furrowed her brows.

It wasn't pleasant seeing Luna in pain, but if things went wrong, one of the teaching assistants would step in to save her.

Then, a clinking sound echoed from behind.

"Huh?" Rie glanced back.

It was Luna's cube.

"Ah...."

Rie realized what one of the scrolls Luna had used was.

It was a spell of invisibility.

Luna had concealed the cube using the invisibility spell and had released it alongside the fireball.

She had used the spell where the cube had been, rendering the need to pinpoint coordinates for the cube's magic.

Rie was taken aback.

The potion concealed in the water ball earlier, and now the cube, hidden and sent within the fireball.

"I got tricked the same way twice."

If you're fooled twice by the same trick...

As this thought crossed Rie's mind, she felt an odd sensation beneath her feet.

"Sylph!!!!"

she cried out in alarm.

Suddenly, gravity collapsed on Rie.

Chapter 65: Joint Practical (6)

"Panting..."

"Huff... puff..."

Luna and Rie's labored breaths echoed in the forest.

Both were a sight, roughed up and on their last legs.

Rie had endured a strong blow from Luna's cube.

Naturally, she had done all she could to hold off with Sylph.

Guardian Spirit.

It's a trick where the elemental infuses itself into the elementalist, shielding them from harm.

It's the strongest defense an elementalist has.

Still, even this could only hold up for so long.

Sylph took a major blow and was consequently sent back.

Luna had just about survived Rie's attack with the fortify spell.

She was still a rookie with her spellbook and had failed in controlling her mana efficiently.

But, the battle was far from over.

Shaking, Luna tried to pull out a scroll from her belt.

"Up, Wind Cutter...!"

Rie attempted to stop her with magic.

"Ah...!"

Luna tried to fend off the attack with her robe, but it was already in tatters.

"Ugh..."

It failed to stop Rie's magic, and Luna took a direct hit in her stomach.

"Uh..."

Seeing this, Rie winced.

Even though she wasn't on the receiving end, Luna's pained expression stirred something unpleasant in her.

"Luna...!"

Suddenly, Riku dashed forward.

"Waterball!"

Rie tried to evade the magic.

However, her body was feeble, and she could only dodge clumsily, almost tripping.

"Ugh!"

Rie dropped to the ground to dodge the attack.

That's when Petro came running from behind.

"Rie! A potion...!"

"Ugh..."

Without a second's delay, Rie pressed the potion Petro handed her to her lips.

"Luna! Potion!"

Ena quickly sprinted over, trying to offer Luna a potion.

"Fire Arrow!"

Even while drinking the potion, Rie promptly cast her magic.

"Wha! Stone Wall!"

However, Riku was quick and blocked the magic.

"Ugh..."

"Huff...!"

They both downed the potion, but their conditions weren't equal.

While Rie rose, Luna couldn't even prop herself up.

Luna's injuries were graver than Rie's, and she had burned through more mana.

Even if they were both healing, their recovery rates wouldn't match.

"Fire s..."

Rie, without even rising to her feet, attempted to cast her magic.

The most powerful magic she could use.

She planned to end the match in one swift blow.

That's when it happened.

"That's enough."

Out of nowhere, a hand clamped down on Rie's wrist.

"The match is over. Luna has lost. I won't allow any more fighting."

It was a teaching assistant.

The teaching assistant, who was also the match referee, stepped in and stopped Rie.

"Sigh..."

Hearing these words, Rie sighed.

And she staggered towards Luna.

Rie was on the edge of crying.

"Luna... I'm sorry..."

Standing in front of Luna, Rie apologized.

At the same time, Luna's eyes welled up too.

She bit her lip and sat down where she was.

Then, she turned her gaze towards Rie.

As she looked at Rie, Luna's lips tightened.

Rie was nervous.

She was worried that their friendship would suffer because of this.

Seeing Rie's worried face, Luna shook her head.

Then she wiped away the tears pooling in her eyes.

With a weak smile and a note of determination in her voice, Luna declared.

"Next time... I won't lose next time...!"

As Luna uttered these words, relief washed over Rie's face.

Luna instead challenged her for a future match.

She declared her intent to win if they were to fight again...

Just as Rie had done herself after losing in the individual assessment.

For Rie, it felt like a worthy rival had emerged.

Just like soil hardening after rainfall, she felt a new bond forming between Luna and herself.

Rie extended her hand to Luna.

"I'll win next time too."

As Rie said this with a smile, Luna returned a weak smile.

Then Luna tried to rise, accepting the hand Rie offered.

"Kyack..."

When Luna grabbed her hand, Rie let out a strange whimper.

An odd sound...

The noise signaled the potion's effect kicking in, and the delayed-effect drug had fully run its course.

Actually, Rie's body had started to heat up earlier, but her survival instinct had been stronger than her desire, so it had been somewhat suppressed.

However, as the tension eased, the effects of the potion began to resurface.

"Uh..."

Rie started to look around at the others.

"I'm... not that kind of person..."

Tears brimmed in Rie's eyes.

"Can I get an antidote..."

"Ah, here it is..."

Reacting to Rie's desperate plea, Ena began to dig through her bag.

"You can't."

But, the teaching assistant blocked her action.

"Luna's already been disqualified. You can't interfere with the practical."

"H... what?"

Rie stared at the teaching assistant, more shocked than when the cube had sprung open beneath her.

"Please. I..."

Rie pleaded with the teaching assistant, desperation written across her face.

The teaching assistant then posed a question to Rie.

"Then, are you willing to forfeit?"

"Uh..."

That was out of the question.

She had just defeated Luna's team.

How could she forfeit now?

"Uh... Ugh..."

All Rie could do was stand there, tears filling her eyes.

"That... I'm sorry."

Ena scratched her head.

Someone had been observing the entire situation from the start.

"Hmm..."

Those hidden amidst the trees, observing the duel between Luna and Rie, belonged to Anton Fred's team.

Anton concealed his large frame behind a tree, watching the fight unfold.

Noting Rie's staggering figure, his teammate turned to him.

"Anton! What's our move? Princess Rie seems in poor condition. Should we strike?"

Ignoring his teammate's question, Anton found himself deep in thought.

An idea tickled the edges of his mind, elusive and evasive...

Anton murmured under his breath.

"Where have I... seen this before?"

Luna's spellbook.

The strong, radiant light of magic bursting forth from the book.

Casting magic through a book...

"Where did I come across this..."

"Anton!"

"Huh, yes?"

Anton snapped out of his reverie as his teammate tugged at his clothes.

"We should seize this chance to attack Princess Rie! After such an intense battle, she's..."

Anton studied Rie.

She was visibly tired, but something didn't quite add up.

Anton spoke up.

"We retreat."

"What? This is our chance..."

"No!"

Anton smacked his round belly for emphasis.

"We're dealing with Princess Rie here. That Princess Rie."

"Yes..."

"Do you honestly believe Princess Rie would leave herself so vulnerable?"

Anton's teammate glanced between Rie and Anton.

"It's a trap!"

"Huh?"

"She's feigning weakness to lower our guard! There's no way Princess Rie would be this distressed after a fight with a nobody from a no-name family!"

Anton's teammate gave a sheepish smile.

Luna Railer, who was Rie's opponent, is a top-tier student at the academy.

Even for someone as formidable as Princess Rie, defeating Luna would not have been an easy feat.

Looking at Rie's expression, it wasn't a pretense.

She genuinely seemed exhausted.

However, for the time being, his teammate decided to trust Anton's instincts.

"Ah, as expected, it's Anton!"

"Hmm hmm!"

Anton heaved his body into motion.

"Let's move on."

"Right..."

His teammate fell in step behind him.

As they went elsewhere, Anton continued to murmur to himself.

"Where did I see it..."

"Damn it."

I swiftly sidestepped Evan's sword.

Even a mere graze from it could be lethal... or more precisely, it could cause my mana to fluctuate.

That wouldn't just result in critical injury; it would be defeat.

"Huff!"

"Finger of the Demon!"

I cast my spell just as Evan's sword seemed poised to strike me.

In response, Evan retracted his blade, evading my magic.

"Ah, I didn't expect it to be this tough."

In the game, as I experienced it from Evan's perspective, I failed to understand how formidable that ability was.

After all, his sword only needs to make contact with the magic to nullify it.

I had considered it somewhat flawed.

But now, I understood the difficulty in targeting the body.

If magic so much as grazed the sword, it would disintegrate like dust.

Why did such an overpowering ability exist...?

Evan persistently lunged at me with his blade.

The classic strategy of a swordsman against a wizard.

Forcing close-quarters combat was the most effective approach.

Evan raised his sword to strike once more.

I smirked knowingly.

"Why play the swordsman when you're truly a wizard?"

I continued casting spells while maintaining distance.

So, Evan relentlessly tried to bridge the gap.

His aggressive forward push was bound to create an opening.

Rather than dodging outwards, I stepped into Evan's inner circle.

Evan's eyes widened at my manoeuvre.

I channelled mana into my clenched fist.

"Huh..."

While swiveling my body to the left, I aimed a right punch at Evan's flank.

-Boom!!!

"Huh!"

My fist connected with Evan's side.

A resonating thud echoed from Evan's flank as he was hurled sideways into a tree.

"Kuh!"

"I'm closer to a swordsman than you'll ever be."

Evan might have trained his physique and handled a sword, but at his core, he was a wizard.

On the other hand, I'd adopted the discipline of a swordsman to master the techniques imparted by Borval.

That was a different level compared to an amateur in swordplay.

Hence, I held the upper hand in agility and bodily coordination.

"Ugh..."

Evan hauled himself up, nursing his side where my punch had made its impact.

Despite the powerful blow, he managed to get back up.

It felt like his ribs had given way...

"I feel like the antagonist now..."

The antagonist who strikes at the hero, and the hero who overcomes it.

Thinking that this was inside a game made me a little more anxious.

Evan stood upright, leveling his sword at me.

"I won't be defeated..."

I scowled at the sight.

"Awakening events are not welcome..."

Evan started accumulating mana in his free hand, the one devoid of the sword.

Simultaneously, the surrounding trees began to rustle.

Evan's unique mid-tier magic.

A spell that manipulated the environment, animals or plants.

Eco-magic.

The trunks of the trees started to shift, homing in on me.

"Ugh...!"

I maneuvered my body to evade the animated plants.

The plant stems were swift, albeit lacking flexibility.

Their movements overlapped, twisting around each other.

However, that wasn't the problem.

"Huff!"

Once again, Evan brandished his sword and charged at me.

The plants and Evan.

Avoiding both seemed impossible.

I amassed mana in my fist.

Crack.

As I snapped the incoming plant stems with my fist, I dodged Evan's blade, contorting my body.

As I continued to channel mana into my fist to deflect the plants, the energy consumption was immense.

At this pace, I'd deplete my reserves before Evan.

I began hunting for an opening in Evan's defenses again.

I'd landed a hit once before; there was no reason I couldn't do it again.

With narrowed eyes, I scrutinized Evan.

Evan steadied his sword, aiming for my shoulder.

A big move.

I didn't miss this gap and put power into my fist.

Taking a hit to the shoulder to deliver a significant blow to Evan seemed a worthy trade.

Sacrifice flesh to gain bone....

It was at that moment I clenched my fist and lunged.

I felt something snagging my ankle as I propelled forward.

"Ah..."

A tree root emerged, expertly tripping me up.

Seeing this, Evan flashed a triumphant grin.

That's when I realized that Evan had intentionally created this opening.

Regardless of my training, my body remained that of a wizard.

A regular human body.

So, with my ankle already ensnared by the tree root, I was unable to make any additional maneuvers.

Had I known, I could have infused my foot with mana and snapped the root on my way, but my body was already tumbling forward.

"Damn it..."

My ankle was tangled in the root, pitching me forward.

And Evan's blade swooped towards my shoulder.

In that split-second, I made a rapid decision.

"Priscilla!!!"

Chapter 66: Joint Practical (7)

-Clang! Clang!

Yeniel and Locke crossed swords from afar.

They kept fighting, gradually moving further away from where Evan and Rudy were locked in their own battle.

"Your attacks are too straightforward, aren't they?"

Yeniel taunted as she blocked Locke's sword.

Locke's sword was simple.

It stabbed when it said it would, and it swung where it said it would.

That made it easy to dodge.

But, these straightforward attacks left no big openings.

It was easy enough to evade Locke's attacks, but finding a chance for a counterattack was impossible.

So, Yeniel decided to act calm and provoke him.

"Do you really think you can keep this up?"

Yeniel dodged Locke's sword and spoke.

"You saw Evan's skills during the evaluation, right? As a swordsman, shouldn't you have fought him instead?"

Even with these provocations, Locke just kept pressuring Yeniel silently.

"If we keep fighting like this, Evan will come to help—"

"Enough."

Locke slashed his sword with force.

Taken aback by Locke's sudden attack, Yeniel quickly retreated out of Locke's range.

'Did it work?'

Yeniel thought for a moment, then shook her head.

Locke's expression was still neutral.

As they put more distance between them, Locke pointed his sword at Yeniel.

"I made my choice. It's not too late to regret it when that guy actually loses."

Locke got into position again.

"Rudy Astria is strong."

Yeniel frowned at those words.

"I heard you two didn't get along? You seem to know more than I thought."

"That's right. That's why I know. I often study Rudy Astria."

Yeniel looked disgusted.

"What are you, a stalker? Into guys, are you?"

Locke, who had been nonchalant all along, showed anger at these words.

"Don't be ridiculous. I'm not doing this because I enjoy it."

But his anger, too, faded quickly.

"I'm just keeping tabs on him."

At Locke's words, Yeniel grimaced.

'This guy doesn't seem to be shaken by anything.'

Thinking so, Yeniel gripped her sword tightly.

She decided she had to get serious.

Best to meet the straightforward with straightforward.

If she tried any weird strategies, she might just hurt herself.

"Alright then..."

Yeniel took a deep breath and prepared to charge at Locke.

"Everyone!! Fire!!!"

Just when she fully prepared herself, she heard an unusual noise.

A mix of magic and shouting.

Suddenly, magic surged out from between the trees.

"Haah!"

Locke and Yeniel swiftly dodged.

It wasn't just a single spell.

The attack came from a group of three, not just one person.

Locke and Yeniel sprinted to take cover behind a large tree.

-Boom! Bang!

"What are they up to?"

"It isn't strong. Seems like the weaker ones have teamed up."

At Locke's words, Yeniel nodded.

She'd anticipated this.

Weaker teams struggled to get high rankings on their own, so they often grouped together.

A tactic of the weak.

Yeniel flashed a thin smile and proposed to Locke.

"Should we join forces for a bit?"

Locke eyed Yeniel skeptically.

Yeniel pointed her sword at Locke and said,

"Do you want to keep fighting?"

Locke thought for a moment and observed the enemies.

Only a few of them had shown themselves.

About five were visible.

But there would be more.

Maybe two teams, or even three....

Locke turned to Yeniel and agreed.

"A temporary alliance."

Yeniel chuckled softly and dashed into the crowd.

When I called Priscilla's name, a silver-furred wolf appeared behind me.

Priscilla formed icicles and aimed at Evan.

Caught off guard, Evan stopped his sword mid-strike.

And in that moment, Priscilla rushed to me and pushed me aside with force.

"Cough!"

I was thrown to the ground by Priscilla's enormous body.

Evan shifted his grip on his sword, focusing on deflecting the icicles.

Many icicles flew, but none could stand against Evan's sword.

They crumbled to dust and vanished.

I hadn't wanted to summon Priscilla...

Priscilla is a powerful yet dangerous force that exceeds my abilities.

Just summoning her drains a lot of mana, and it chips away at my mental strength too.

"Gasp....."

Feeling my mana rapidly depleting, I gasped.

But I couldn't send her back now.

Since I already used some many in summoning her, I had to make use of Priscilla.

"Priscilla! Keep him under pressure!"

Biting my lip, I forced myself to stand.

I channeled mana into my fist and charged forward.

Evan was pelted with icicles, and I dove into the fray.

I swung my fist.

I threw several punches, but each narrowly missed.

The icicles, however, managed to land minor hits on Evan.

These minor wounds weren't significant, but the fact that Evan was on the defensive was a good thing.

I kept swinging my fist.

Evan dodged as best he could, my fist kept slicing through the air.

I maintained constant pressure on Evan, not allowing him a moment's respite.

My breath became ragged.

My mana was depleting.

A creeping dizziness began to cloud my senses.

When I focused my senses, Evan came into view.

Evan, also struggling for breath.

He was suffering as much as I was.

I wasn't done yet.

"Spikes of Hell!"

I channelled my remaining focus, infusing dark magic into my fist.

"Arghh!!"

Evan was suddenly jabbed in the side by an emerging spike.

He'd been unable to keep track of my magic while focusing on my fist and Priscilla's attacks.

I smirked.

"Got you right there. You little bastard."

Both Priscilla's and my direct attacks are strong.

Evan knew this.

So, he decided to bear the hit of my dark magic while dodging the other attacks.

However, this was a poor decision on Evan's part.

Dark magic doesn't just inflict pain upon the enemy.

It possesses other effects.

Just as the Abyssal Flame has the capacity to inflict excruciating pain, there's another ability nestled within it.

That was its true power.

As Evan was pricked by the thorn, his movements stopped.

The ability contained within Spikes of Hell was immobilization.

The power to stop the opponent's movements.

It didn't last long, but it offered ample time to land a powerful strike on Evan.

"Haaah!"

I pulled back my right fist to the full.

And charged it with mana.

I unsummoned Priscilla, and the mana previously used to sustain her was channelled into my fist.

"This fist carries the sorrow of being second."

Sure, I chose that second seat, but it came with its share of sorrow.

I also want to be first, to be the protagonist.

I didn't want to be second forever.

But, the protagonist's responsibility was heavy.

Although I've been helping people till now, I've been doing so with a self-defense mechanism.

If I can't save this person, it's not my fault.

It's Evan's responsibility, it is Evan that made a mistake. I am not the one at fault.

I didn't want the responsibility, but I also didn't want to give up.

So, I used Evan in that way.

But every time I harbored such thoughts, I felt frustrated.

How great it would have been if I had reincarnated as Evan, not 'Rudy Astria'.

If I had been the protagonist...

If I had Evan's abilities...

But such thoughts were useless.

Because I'm already Rudy Astria.

The opportunity to land a punch on Evan...

There aren't many such opportunities.

If Evan progresses further, I might not stand a chance, and we might not ever again find ourselves in a fight like this.

This could be the last time.

So, I'm about to release everything I have pent-up on you.

As much as I've helped the story, take a hit for not progressing it like you should be.

-Kwaaaaaaang!!!!!!!!!!

"Arghh!!!"

I landed my fist squarely into Evan's gut.

Evan was propelled into the air, hurling far away.

It was only after colliding with a distant tree that he plummeted to the ground.

"Haa...."

A wave of dizziness washed over me due to the abrupt expenditure of a massive amount of mana.

I held my throbbing head and sunk down to the ground.

"Uh....."

I immediately lifted my gaze to Evan.

He was unconscious, his eyes rolled back.

Seeing this stirred a sense of exhilaration within me.

"Haha....."

I chuckled.

That's the punch of the second seat... you brat...

I tried to get up from the ground.

But suddenly, my legs gave way, and I found myself back on my knees.

"Uh....."

My head pounded painfully.

It was the backlash of summoning Priscilla.

Having recklessly used dark magic and Priscilla, my mental energy was severely drained.

I shot Evan a fleeting glance.

Evan's gem.

I could take his gem and add it to mine to steal his points, but I didn't.

Because Evan had to be on top...

Even though I won now, there was no guarantee that I would be stronger later.

There are things that I can do and things that only Evan can do.

Evan hadn't been particularly helpful so far, but I hope that one day he would.

Even though he was unconscious, I addressed him as if issuing a warning.

"I'm giving you a chance."

So far, I have not interfered with any opportunities that Evan could have.

I was giving all the elements that could make Evan stronger to him.

But I wouldn't stand idly by if Evan only grew stronger without contributing to the story.

"Grow stronger, Evan."

I spat out those words and concealed my presence.

A shrill noise reverberated throughout the mountains.

Then, the teaching assistants called a stop to all the participants locked in combat.

-The joint practical of the first and second years has now concluded.

With that, it came to an end.

Professor Cromwell monitored the score situation from the mountain's entrance.

[

Rie Von Ristonia

Evan

Borval

.....

]

Evan beat Rudy Astria.

Professor Cromwell wanted to cheer like a child, but he held back his emotions.

"Hmm, hmm....."

With a smirk, Professor Cromwell guided the students emerging from the entrance.

Chapter 67: Joint Practical (8)

The sun was setting on the mountain, turning the world dark.

Students, their faces bathed in relief, began to make their way off the mountain.

They were the ones who had survived the day, not falling to elimination.

To them, just enduring till the end felt like a victory.

Some bore low scores, but the joy of surviving outshone their disappointment.

Their faces were lit with smiles as they descended, all except for one individual, who limped painfully down the trail.

"Ugh..."

That person was Rie, her condition deteriorating by the minute.

"Luna... Where's Luna..."

Staggering, Rie scanned the area for Luna, or rather Ena, who should have been by her side.

But Luna's group had already made their way back to the academy, far from the practice field.

"Uh... Ugh..."

The sight of the usually composed and confident Rie, now in a pitiful state, drew the attention of her fellow students.

One male student hesitantly approached her.

"Are... you okay?"

"Get lost..."

"What?"

"I said, get lost..."

Rie spat out the words with a scowl.

Even if Rie was overflowing with lust right now, she hadn't lost her mind.

It's just that she dealt with things that she would normally deal with softly in a rather sharp manner.

As Rie stumbled onward, she ran into the last person she wanted to encounter.

"Oh, Rie. You made it through."

Rudy greeted Rie with happily, but seeing him appear out of the blue, Rie couldn't help but scream.

"No... Don't come! Don't come! Don't come!"

Rudy watched her outburst, his face etched in confusion.

Meanwhile, Rie's mind started racing.

'Why is he here!'

As her thoughts whirled, her physical condition took a turn for the worse.

Her body heated up at Rudy's sight, making it hard for her to even control her expressions.

Doing her best to avoid Rudy's gaze, she stole a quick glance at him, only to find his face inching closer.

"Don't, don't come!"

"You... approached me."

Rudy's statement, laced with confusion, made Rie assess her position.

'Did I... move?'

Realization dawned on her.

She had unknowingly drawn closer to Rudy.

She was losing control over her body, her legs taking her right up to Rudy.

"Huh?"

Her mind stopped racing and just gave up on thinking.

She just moved on instinct.

"Hey, hey! What... What's happening!"

"Uh...!"

Ignoring Rudy's startled yelps, she wrapped her arms tightly around his body.

"Hehehe..."

Her face buried in his body, she laughed goofily.

"You've gotten a lot stronger..."

Her hands explored Rudy's body as she held on to him.

"Hey! Have you lost it? You, hey! Hey!"

Rie's hands roamed across Rudy's back, stomach, and even his chest.

"Hehehe...."

'Rudy, Rudy, Rudy.'

Rudy's name echoed continuously in Rie's mind.

Having examined Rudy's body thoroughly, Rie tilted her head up.

She was met with Rudy's face.

"Hehehe... Nice blond hair, just like mine..."

"Hey!!!"

Rie reached out, her fingers entwining with Rudy's hair.

Then she saw Rudy's lips...

She slightly closed her eyes and was about to stand on her tiptoes.

"Enough."

Suddenly, Rie felt someone grabbing the back of her head and pulling her away.

"Huh? What... Who... Who is this..."

She spun around, her eyes meeting the person who'd intervened.

"Ah... Astina...!!!"

Astina was holding her as she thrashed around.

"Rudy!!! Rudy!!! Help me!!!"

Calling out Rudy's name, Rie writhed in Astina's grasp.

Astina let out a sigh and glanced at Rie.

"How much will you regret this when you recover..."

"Rudy...! Help me...!"

Rie's plea was like a kitten mewling for its mother's aid.

Rudy was left unsure, not knowing how to react to Rie's behavior.

Should he intervene since Rie was asking for help, or should he trust Astina who was the one holding her back?

"She's not in her right mind because of some odd medicine. You shouldn't worry."

"Oh... okay."

With Astina's words, Rudy awkwardly nodded, a strained smile on his face.

Meanwhile, Rie whimpered in a heartbreaking tone, tears pooling in her eyes.

"Rudy...!!"

Rie was led away by Astina, her sobs trailing behind them.

Exhaling in relief, Astina muttered to herself.

"That was a close call."

The next day.

"Uh... my head...."

Rie groggily sat up in bed.

Her head was throbbing with pain.

"Huh... Rie, are you awake?"

"Who...?"

Rie turned to the source of the voice, a familiar face greeted her.

"Ena?"

A woman with a comforting smile was seated by her side.

It was Ena.

"How do you feel?"

Ena extended a warm cup of tea towards Rie.

"Huh? Well... my head's a bit sore, but other than that, I think I'm alright..."

Rie accepted the tea, her face etched with confusion.

"I'm sorry about yesterday... I didn't realize the potion would affect you so intensely."

Ena offered her apologies to Rie.

"No, it's okay, considering the circumstances..."

Rie brushed off the apology with a casual wave of her hand.

Her mind soon wandered off.

She mulled over what attitude she should take.

She was the one who had defeated Luna.

It'd be dumb to assume Ena held only goodwill towards her.

Moreover, her interactions with Ena were minimal compared to Luna.

She had only seen Ena and Luna talk from a distance.

So, what attitude should she take?

Rie always wore a mask.

She had dropped that guise long ago around Rudy and Locke, and even to Luna, she had shown a glimpse of her true self.

But she was wondering whether she could show herself to Ena or to keep their relationship strictly professional.

While Rie was lost in her thoughts, Ena gingerly spoke up.

"Do you... remember what happened yesterday?"

"...Yesterday?"

Rie tilted her head.

Yesterday...

She remembered everything up until the announcement of the joint practical's completion.

And... how she frantically searched for Ena while descending from the mountain.

People tried to approach her, and she became irritable...

Irritable?

Now that she thought about it, she was perpetually irritable...

"Ah...!"

A certain 'incident' suddenly flashed into Rie's memory.

She had rushed into Rudy's arms the moment she spotted him... and...

"Ah...! Ah!!! Ahhhhhhhh!!!"

The sheer embarrassment caused Rie to clutch her head, screaming.

Her face flushed beet-red, she was at a loss for what to do next.

"I, I, I've lost my mind...!!!"

As Rie spiraled into panic, Ena soothingly patted her back.

"No... I'm sorry... I felt terrible the moment I found out..."

Ena continued, squeezing Rie's hand sympathetically.

"I'm truly sorry... You could have been attracted to someone else in the academy, yet you ended up in the arms of someone you're not particularly fond of..."

At Ena's words, Rie was taken aback.

"Uh..."

Disagreeing would create issues, as would agreeing.

Rie was somewhat aware of her feelings for Rudy, though she was reluctant to acknowledge them.

But, she didn't want to confess these feelings yet.

If Rudy were to express his feelings for her, she thought she might consider it.

However, to confess first... Rie's pride wouldn't permit it.

"Umm..."

Rie merely pouted, not replying to Ena's statement.

She was adamant about keeping her feelings a secret, not just from Rudy but from everyone.

However...

'Huh?'

Ena noticed something strange in Rie's reaction.

The awkwardness she felt was because she didn't know Rie very well.

Rie always appeared confident and natural in front of others.

This awkward side of Rie was something Ena wasn't used to, and it made her uneasy.

Ena cautiously spoke up again.

"You're a princess... You'll have numerous responsibilities, including marriage and other matters... You'll have to be very mindful of them."

"That...is true?"

"Then I'll tell Rudy. Rie will never!!! never!!! have such feelings, so don't misunderstand. And I'll tell him to stop the other kids from spreading strange rumors."

"No, no, no!"

Rie hastily waved her hands, flustered at Ena's suggestion.

"Huh? Why?"

Ena looked at Rie, her expression innocent.

"That... If you say that, wouldn't Rudy feel embarrassed? No... why would Rudy be embarra... no, that..."

Though Rie didn't want to confess her feelings to Rudy, she was curious if he might have similar feelings for her.

A subtle desire to see Rudy's reaction to this started to seep in.

However, if she told him that outright, wouldn't she be shutting the door on any potential development with Rudy?

With Rie's gaze darting around in disarray, Ena flashed a knowing smile and threw out a question.

"So? What are you trying to say?"

Rie blushed at her words.

"Huh? That's right! Oh! You're right! I'll tell you! It was my mistake and I should explain and apologize myself! I'm not a kid!"

She latched onto that question like a drowning person clutching at a lifeline.

However, that lifeline was nothing more than bait on Ena's fishing line....

'This is a serious matter...'

Ena rubbed her chin thoughtfully.

Until now, Rudy had been consistently overlooked at the academy.

Everyone turned a blind eye to Rudy, dismissing him with scorn.

Except Luna.

She admired Rudy, respected him, even adored him.

Ena assumed Luna was the only one who felt this way.

No one had challenged that assumption until now.

However, seeing the situation at hand, Luna wasn't alone.

The first princess of the empire!

The heir!

That person likes Rudy.

'Since when...'

Ena racked her brains, but the answer eluded her.

The students of the academy, and others, were unaware of the dynamics within the school.

Everyone believed that it was Astina who had come to Rie's rescue.

No one could have imagined that Rudy was the true hero behind the scenes.

'How to handle this...'

Indeed, the usual authoritative image of Rie, who appeared to rule over everyone, was absent.

Only the shy countenance of a smitten girl was on display.

If Rie intended to exploit Rudy for political gains, it might have been okay.

Judging from Rudy's behavior so far, he seemed immune to such manipulations.

However, the affection of a bashful girl was not something Rudy would easily overlook.

'Luna... We have a serious issue on our hands...'

Thinking of Luna, Ena sighed and changed her expression.

First, she needed to get out of here.

"Then, I should get going! I've already administered the antidote and other medications, so you should recover quickly! Let me know if anything changes."

"Uh...yes! Thank you!"

Rie exhaled in relief, watching Ena depart.

"A tough kid to deal with..."

If it had been a discussion about work or politics, she wouldn't have felt so flustered.

Yet, having Rudy involved had left her flustered.

"Ugh..."

Rie then curled up, gripping her stomach.

"Warm..."

And she remembered the time she was in Rudy's arms.

".....hehehe."

Rie's expression softened, replaced by a foolish smile that no one had ever seen before.

Chapter 68: Responsibility (1)

Cromwell's Lab.

"So, I've won the bet since Evan technically won."

Cromwell declared his victory, but his face was far from happy.

In contrast, it was Robert who sported a grin and started talking.

"It must be nice to get out of guard duty."

Robert teased Cromwell, humming a playful tune.

Even though Cromwell was the victor, it was Robert who mocked him.

That was because he'd heard the full story about the incident from the teaching assistant.

The clash between Evan and Rudy.

More than a couple of teaching assistants had watched this fight.

They were ready for any issues, knowing it was a battle between reputedly strong students.

As the teaching assistants anticipated, it was a fierce battle.

Their fight resulted in damage to the surrounding trees and landscape.

At the fight's end, Rudy landed the final hit, sending Evan flying far away.

The teaching assistants were on high alert, ready to intervene even in the final moments.

Usually, students at the end are so thrilled that they often launch a huge attack, even when the opponent can no longer fight back.

They were prepared to stop the fight if Rudy tried to attack Evan further, but what Rudy did next was unexpected.

He didn't just refrain from attacking; he didn't even take the gem from Evan.

The teaching assistants were puzzled and reported it to Cromwell.

And now.

The bet had started over 'who has a better eye for students' and 'who has trained their students better'.

But they couldn't outright order the students to fight each other.

So they wagered on the scores.

Even if Rudy had directly fought with Evan and won, it was fine to lose the bet.

Scores weren't important.

They just wanted to prove that their judgment was correct.

"Wow~ Professor Cromwell sure knows how to pick students who score well."

Robert didn't dispute when knowing the reason for the bet.

He simply accepted his loss cheerfully and shrugged it off.

Robert was happy just proving he had taught Rudy well and that his judgment wasn't off.

"Whoever taught Rudy has trained him well in combat. Hahahaha!"

Robert exited Cromwell's lab, his laughter filling the air.

"Hmm....."

Cromwell watched Robert leave, a frown on his face.

"The top first-year student this year is Rudy Astria, right?"

Cromwell had chosen Evan after much consideration.

After all, he was the one who kept taking the Top Seat among the first years.

He had bet on Evan's potential.

However, the highest-ranking first-year student this year was unusual.

Despite consistently scoring top grades, he didn't draw attention.

The professors' focus was on different students.

McGuire, Robert, and the other professors all focused on one unusual student.

"He seems pretty capable..."

Nobody doubted Evan's superior skills.

Yet, if asked whether they could mentor him well, they would shake their heads.

The method Evan used in his individual assessment.

None of the professors knew such a technique.

Given the professors' abilities, it was far more effective to overpower than to use such a method.

"Will this be a curse... or a blessing..."

Evan's unusualness was an advantage, but the absence of any mentorship was a significant drawback.

He had to chart his own path, without help.

Of course, they could help with intermediate magic like eco-magic, but even that wasn't ordinary.

"I have no clue..."

Cromwell would have thought more about it if Evan was his official disciple, but he decided to let it go, figuring Evan had his own plans.

He simply grabbed the calendar on his desk and erased all his scheduled guard duties.

"I should just be content that I won't have guard duty."

Cromwell sighed, finding some satisfaction in this ambiguous victory.

He had been defeated.

Thoroughly defeated.

He had done his best, but it was still not enough to reach him.

Evan was alone in his room, lost in thought over his sword.

"Did I choose the wrong way.....?"

Was it a mistake to use a sword, being a wizard?

Then again, Rudy Astria was too unusual to be considered a typical wizard.

A wizard who employs fists, magic, and even elementals.

He was versatile, if that's the term you want to use, or a jack-of-all-trades.

"But... what about me?"

No matter how much he thought, he had no particular color.

He wasn't exceptionally strong in any one area, nor could he freely handle a variety of skills.

All he did was create a new magic.

This might surprise some, but it wasn't anything spectacular.

Others might argue, but at least to Evan, it was so.

"What do I want to do.....?"

He had clinched the Top Seat.

If you only consider this, he could be said to have beaten Rudy Astria, but it felt like an empty victory.

The joint practical was no different.

Clearly, he had been beaten and lost consciousness.

But Rudy Astria didn't steal his gem.

"Intentionally....."

He was unsure what Rudy was aiming for, but he didn't take his score.

Because of this, he felt even more defeated.

As he thought more, he felt like Rudy Astria was giving him the Top Seat.

Evan shook his head when this thought crossed his mind.

Why would Rudy Astria surrender the spot to him?

In this aspect, he firmly believed he was a step ahead of Rudy Astria.

"I will...never concede first place."

A fight?

He could tolerate losing once in a while.

But he couldn't lose in the assessment that evaluated his semester-long efforts.

Evan clenched his fist tightly at this thought.

Following the training, the Academy granted the first and second-year students a break.

It appeared to be a chance for the students injured during the training to comfortably receive treatment and refocus on their studies.

After such a sweet break passed.

"Ah....."

I found myself looking at the report card posted on the notice board.

Evan, precisely in the second position.

And Rie, who had secured the first place.

".....What is this?"

This was already a point of concern.

The growth of those around me.

They were progressing too quickly.

Whether it was Rie or Luna.....

While I did predict such a situation to some extent, I genuinely didn't consider it a significant problem.

If it helps in the fight against the enemy, it's a boon.

I never thought it could be a hindrance.

"Still, I didn't expect this to happen....."

There was only one reason for this outcome.

The fight between Rie and Luna.

If that fight hadn't taken place, Evan would have comfortably claimed first place.

However, because Luna and Rie fought, Rie claimed all of Luna's points.

I reflected slowly.

The influence joint practical has on the total score and the impact of midterms and final exams.....

While the joint practical indeed accounts for a large portion of the score, it didn't carry enough weight to invalidate the results of other exams.

"If Evan...continues to score perfectly....."

But on calculation, it was really a narrow escape.

Evan naturally had to receive perfect scores, and Rie had to underperform on the tests.

It was a fact that a minor score difference has a substantial impact on top-ranking students.

"Sigh....."

I sighed after musing for a while and turned around.

Then I saw Astina trailing behind me.

Her usually noticeable dark circles and fatigue were visible.

Astina, with a vacant expression, held documents in her hand and sighed as she walked past me.

"Astina, ?"

When I called her name, Astina was startled and looked at me.

It appeared she hadn't even noticed that I was next to her.

"Ah...Rudy....."

"Do you have something on your mind? You look quite exhausted."

Astina gave an awkward smile and gestured towards the documents.

"Paperwork to be done. It's more than just a few."

".....Are there that many documents?"

Seeing the documents in Astina's hands, I regretted asking the question.

At first glance, the sheer volume of paperwork was daunting.

"Um... I'll help you carry them."

".....Okay. Thank you."

I took Astina's documents and directed our steps towards the student council room.

I paced alongside her.

Then, Astina broke the silence.

"You've done something peculiar again."

"Peculiar... what?"

I asked Astina, my face a mask of confusion.

"Evan mentioned that you didn't take his points."

"Ah....."

Astina chuckled softly at my response.

"I thought you didn't want to be the top student to not draw attention with such noticeable behavior?"

I chose not to answer Astina's statement.

But, Astina insisted.

"You said before that you opted to be the runner-up because you dread the responsibility that accompanies being the top student."

I gave a slight nod in response to her words.

"Don't be afraid."

Upon hearing those words, I met Astina's gaze.

Astina appeared serious.

But then, her expression relaxed, and she laughed lightly.

"I must be out of my mind because I'm tired. I'm talking nonsense."

Afraid.....

I had no regrets about the decisions I've made so far.

Gradually, I was becoming certain of my survival, and I was also contributing to Evan's development.

Evan's growth.....

Evan's top rank.....

That was the most efficient survival strategy in the end.

Amongst various alternatives, I was selecting the one with the highest probability for everyone at the academy to survive.

And I knew the result.....

"I understand. I'll handle it."

As I was deep in contemplation for a moment, the student council office materialized before my eyes.

Astina unlocked the door to the student council office and attempted to take the documents I was holding.

Then, suddenly, Astina swayed a little, losing her balance.

"Are you alright?"

"Uh....."

Fortunately, she didn't tumble, having rapidly regained her balance, but something was wrong.

I studied her and suggested cautiously.

"Wouldn't it be better to take a brief rest?"

I was concerned she might suddenly collapse.

"I can't... I've got a pile of work these days....."

"Nevertheless, you should take a break."

Then the student council office door swung open, and Rie emerged, declaring,

"Hand it to me, I'll take it."

Rie naturally attempted to take the documents I was holding.

I recalled how Rie appeared after the practical.

She had been staggering and clinging to me.

I expected Rie to shout at me, "It was because of the medicine!" when we meet again, but she was surprisingly calm.

"Rie, you seem to have recovered now?"

As I handed over the documents to Rie, I voiced my thoughts.

Then, as Rie accepted the documents, her hand lightly brushed against mine.

"Huh!!!"

With that, Rie was startled and retreated swiftly, clutching her hand.

"....."

I observed Rie in her current state.

Then, Rie curled up defensively and stammered,

"W-w-what!!! What! G-g-give me the documents! Quickly!"

".....Here you are."

I was dumbfounded by her reaction, which was so different from her initial calm approach.

If she was going to react that way, she should have done so from the beginning.

Rie quickly grabbed the documents and ran into the student council room without saying anything else.

"What was that about....."

I mumbled to myself and shifted my gaze to Astina.

"Well, Astina, health comes first. You should take care of your health while working."

Astina gave me a smile before disappearing into the student council room.

Chapter 69: Responsibility (2)

Ena, dressed in her pajamas and wrapped in a blanket like a cloak, opened her mouth.

"Let's start the meeting now."

"Woohoo!"

Riku cheered with an excited voice, clapping her hands.

And in front of her sat Luna, looking puzzled.

Luna stared blankly at Ena for a moment before speaking.

"Um... wasn't it supposed to be an all-night study session tonight?"

A few days ago.

Luna was certain that she had heard plans for an all-night study session.

So Luna borrowed many books from the library and stacked them in one corner of the room, waiting for Riku and Ena.

But the moment Riku and Ena showed up, they slipped into their pajamas and started fooling around.

Luna watched them blankly for a moment before regaining her senses.

She couldn't just let this happen!

For the sake of their grades, she had to stop them!

With that thought in mind, Luna nodded her head as if she made a resolution and spoke cautiously to Riku and Ena.

"Guys... we have less than two weeks until the midterms. We need to study."

At this, Ena held up her index finger and clucked her tongue.

"Tsk, tsks, Luna! Good rest leads to better studying! When it's time to play, we should play properly!"

"..."

Luna closed her mouth for a moment.

And then she made a decision.

"Okay! We're only playing today!"

Luna quickly surrendered.

Usually quiet, Ena's words easily persuaded Luna.

Also, they had never had a pajama party together, so Luna wanted to try it at least once.

And now.

"I've prepared something for you."

Ena gave a sly smile and nodded at Riku.

Then Riku picked up the sketchbook behind her and turned the page.

"Huh?"

When she turned the sketchbook, all that appeared was a blank white background.

"Riku, you've got it upside down!"

"Huh?"

She looked at the page she opened and seeing the blank white background, she made a puzzled face.

"Again!"

Upon Ena's command, Riku quickly flipped the sketchbook around and held it correctly.

"Riku, turn the page!"

"Okay!"

When she turned the page, there was a nicely decorated phrase.

"Love... Successful Love Committee?"

As Luna quietly recited the words, Ena tapped the sketchbook with her hand.

"That's right, Luna! You can't just stay like this! Do you know what's going on right now?"

"What... is going on?"

Luna looked at Ena with a confused face.

No matter how much she thought about it, there was nothing going on.

Was it just that she hadn't scored well because she had lost to Rie during the joint practical?

"Luna, let's be honest."

Ena stared at Luna.

"You like Rudy."

"...!"

Luna was taken aback and began to play dumb.

"Ru-Ru-Rudy? What... what are you talking about?"

But no matter how much Luna lied, she was in Ena's hands.

Although it was a lie that even an ordinary person could detect, Ena knew Luna's psychology even better.

"Recently, there's been a lot going on, and it seems like Rudy's been busy too, right? You've been feeling upset about it."

As Ena smoothly continued, suggesting she already knew everything, Luna's eyes widened.

"How did you know..."

Ena was an authority in Luna psychology, having the chance to study in close proximity for a good 7-8 months.

It only took her 3 seconds to read her.

"I've been just watching you two push and pull each other because it was fun, but you can't do that anymore!"

"What do you mean... I can't?"

At that, Ena nodded at Riku again.

As the page of the sketchbook turned, a drawing of an angry Rie appeared.

There were horns above Rie's head and the background was drawn with fire.

Although it was depicted as a devil, the cute drawing didn't make it look too bad.

"Did you draw Rie? Ena, you draw well."

Upon seeing the drawing, Luna smiled brightly and complimented her.

"No! That's not the issue!"

Ena tapped the sketchbook.

"We have a competitor now!"

"A...competitor?"

As the page of the sketchbook turned again, there was a picture of Rie and Rudy with their arms folded together, and Luna was drawn in a corner.

"Princess Rie is going to steal Rudy!"

"...Huh?"

Luna tilted her head at the sudden statement.

And then she burst into laughter.

"Hehehe, Ena, you read too many novels! Why would Rie suddenly show up!"

Ena stared blankly at Luna, who was laughing.

Seeing Ena like that, Luna stopped laughing, realizing something was off.

Luna hardened her expression.

"Is...is that true?"

Ena flapped the blanket on her back with a whoosh.

"I don't joke about my friend's love life! That's who I am!"

"Uh..."

Luna looked at Ena with a puzzled face upon hearing those words.

And then she stood up abruptly with a gloomy face.

"So, Rudy likes Rie?"

She felt a strong negative emotion.

A negative emotion that Luna had never felt before.

It was a mixed feeling of jealousy and something else.

Ena immediately shook her head and waved her hands at that sight.

"Luna! It's not like that! Rudy doesn't know anything! He's just a kid who only thinks about studying and magic, right?"

At Ena's words, Luna blushed and sat down.

And she bowed her head as if she were embarrassed.

"That's right, isn't it? Hahaha... Yeah, yeah..."

Although Luna bowed her head to hide her flushed face, her blush had already reached her neck, so she couldn't hide it.

"Anyway! The problem is not Rudy right now, but Rie!"

"Rie?"

Ena nodded and scrunched her eyebrows.

"As a 12-year veteran of romance novels, this is a certainty."

At Ena's stern voice, Luna nodded in confusion.

"If Ena says so..."

Then Ena pointed at Luna with her index finger.

"So, Luna! You have to win over Rudy before Rie does!"

"Win over!"

At that, Luna clenched her fists tightly.

Ena nodded with a satisfied smile.

"Did you hear about what Rie did to Rudy when she took that medicine?"

"Yeah..."

Luna's expression darkened for a moment at those words.

"A physical attack like that doesn't work on Rudy."

"What!?"

At that, Luna brightened again.

"But we can't say that a man can completely resist physical advances."

"..."

"Though Rudy... he's a little different."

Ena continued, stroking her chin.

With every word, Luna's expression fluctuated between despair and happiness.

Then Luna realized that Ena was teasing her and glared at her.

"So what am I supposed to do...!"

"Okay, okay. But it's clear that you're at a disadvantage right now."

"Is that so..."

"What have you done with Rudy?"

"Do...done what!?"

"Nothing?"

After a moment of thought, Luna quietly opened her mouth.

"Like having dinner together on his birthday?"

"But Rie and Astina were there too."

When Ena said that, Luna drooped like a puppy being scolded by its owner.

"Rie's already hugged him. And she's also a princess with a great position, and she's good at studying."

Upon hearing that, Luna's face turned pale.

And she quietly spat out the words.

"Can't, can't I win?"

Ena looked at Luna like that and smirked.

"But! We're here to overcome such a disadvantage!"

Ena confidently thumped her chest.

"Just trust me!"

"Ena...!"

At Ena's words, Luna was greatly moved.

"I..."

Then Riku quietly opened her mouth.

"When can I put down this sketchbook..."

Looking at Riku, she was holding the sketchbook the whole time, unable to join in on the conversation.

"Oh... sorry..."

"So, sorry! It was just us..."

"I want to join too..."

So Ena and Luna pacified a disheartened Riku and discussed Luna's future and her romance strategy.

"What's all this..."

I was watching the incredibly crowded carriages flowing into the academy.

"These are magical tools coming from the Fred family."

Rie was holding a sheet of paper, looking at the carriages.

I came out to help Rie.

It was originally something I didn't have to do, but...

-Hey, help me out a bit.

Rie suddenly came to me and asked for help, so I just came out, confused.

Well, I didn't have any complaints about helping Rie.

Since Astina's condition didn't look good right now, I wanted to help Rie, so that Rie could help Astina.

Helping seemed the right course of action, as Astina's collapse wouldn't benefit me or the academy in any way.

"But, why are so many magical tools coming in?"

When I asked, Rie sighed.

"With the principal away, his subordinate is playing king. He probably wants to invest in his favorite family."

I frowned at Rie's ominous words.

The principal is not here?

"Where did the principal go?"

"I don't know? I only know that he's not at the academy. He was busy after the holiday and went somewhere else?"

The principal isn't here...

"Well, let's get to work first."

Rie held the documents and approached the carriage.

And pointed her finger inside the carriage.

"Go in."

".....What?"

Then Rie showed me the documents.

"You need to check the quantity."

"....."

I was at a loss for words.

Rie had called me to help her with the loading and unloading.

"I can't go in and count, can I? I'm a princess."

I felt rebellious at that.

I'm the son of a duke, right?

Even if I was of lower rank compared to Rie, I had a position where I didn't have to do such things.

".....Why."

Rie seemed to realize this too as she hesitated for a moment.

I stretched my fist out to Rie.

"Ik.....What."

As I held out my hand, Rie hunched her body a bit and spoke.

"Rock, paper, scissors."

".....What?"

"Let's do rock, paper, scissors for the carriages. However, I will do it if I lose once, and you will do it if you lose twice."

And then...

"Aaaargh!!!"

"Is that 3 magic lights?"

"This..... huh..... why is it so..... heavy....."

"Are you sure it's 3 lights?"

"Yes, yes!!"

I watched Rie struggle with the load, grumbling and groaning, and couldn't help but grin.

Uhh I changed headmaster to principal, then I changed dean to vice-principal.

I just finished the design for the comment system revamp. Not starting on it till later next week it's niiiiice.

Chapter 70: Responsibility (3)

"Anton! Long time no see!"

"Yes, is my father well?"

Anton, a big, burly man, made his way towards the academy entrance.

He was there to inspect the magical tools delivered from his family.

These tools were part of an agreement between his father and Oliver, the academy's vice-principal.

There was no sign of corruption in this process.

Everything was bought at market price, and the quantity matched the agreement.

However, the purchases were made exclusively through Anton's family, avoiding competition, and raising questions.

Nonetheless, since they supplied the academy with much-needed tools, it wasn't an actual problem.

Seeing Anton, the family butler spoke up.

"Your lordship is well, as always."

This man wasn't your average butler.

Trusted by Anton's father, he was more of a close confidant.

"Hehe, didn't my father say anything specific?"

At Anton's question, the butler paused briefly before replying.

"Ah, your lordship asked if there was a problem with what he mentioned last time."

"What my father mentioned?"

Anton tried to recall, but most of his father's naggings were usually forgotten quickly.

He thought for a moment, his eyes widening as he remembered.

"Oh...!"

It was about Levian.

Levian's spellbook, and the experiments carried out by the Fred family.

"Luna... Railer..."

He remembered Luna Railer's spellbook from the practical.

On second thought, her spellbook shared an uncanny resemblance to the one his father had shown him.

Immediately, Anton gave his orders.

"The Railer family."

"Yes?"

"Tell my father to investigate the Railer family."

A sinister smile spread across Anton's face.

Four days to the midterm exam.

"Ah, when will he get here..."

Sitting in the library, Luna kept stealing glances at the entrance.

Rudy should be coming in any time now.

She hadn't seen him much lately because he'd been helping out the student council.

But she'd heard he would be at the library today.

-Luna, it's time to bring out your secret weapons!

Even though Ena wasn't physically in the library, her words echoed in Luna's mind.

'Ena... can I really do it...'

Luna shook off the doubt.

Ena didn't say 'can you' but 'you must'!

Just then, she spotted Rudy entering the library.

'Here goes!'

With a faint smile at the sight of Rudy, Luna raised her hand, flicked her hair back, and turned her head.

"Ru, Rudy h-hi!"

Luna tried to put into practice one of Ena's dating techniques.

These techniques were all from romance novels, but Ena was so sure of them that Luna thought it must be right.

The first step was to casually flick her hair back, revealing her neck and ears, a supposedly alluring gesture.

Her greeting, however, came out a bit stuttered, and the gesture seemed somewhat forced.

"Uh... Hi."

Rudy greeted her back, looking slightly puzzled.

'Uh...'

Luna felt her cheeks heat up a bit, but she couldn't let that stop her.

This was only the start.

Once Rudy sat down, she would move to the next step.

As Rudy sat down and started to take out his books, Luna initiated her next move.

"Ah~ Rudy, isn't it hot today?"

She fanned herself with her hand, trying to play up the heat.

Rudy looked at her, even more puzzled.

"Hot today...?"

Even Luna found her comment out of place.

It was fall, and the temperature had been dropping lately.

Despite this, she pressed on.

"Ah... It's so warm."

She untied the ribbon from around her neck, placed it on the desk, and started to unbutton her shirt, revealing her collarbone and the fair skin underneath.

This was Ena's second technique.

Unbuttoning.

Apparently, men found it intriguing when a usually well-dressed person loosened their attire a bit.

Luna could understand that.

She often found herself feeling a bit flustered when she saw Rudy in his sweaty shirt after a workout.

"....."

Rudy glanced at her briefly before focusing on his book.

Her face turned even redder.

'Ugh....'

Her embarrassment was becoming unbearable, making her feel genuinely hot.

"Ah... it's really hot...."

But Luna wasn't done yet. She had one more trick up her sleeve.

As she pretended to study, she kept a close eye on Rudy.

'Okay....'

Taking a deep breath, she spoke up.

"Um... Rudy."

".....Yes?"

"I'm having trouble with this. Could you help me?"

She showed him a book on black magic, a subject she knew he was well-versed in.

The fear, though, was that Rudy might not know the answer.

"Ah... I know this one."

Hearing that, Luna brightened up.

"Really? Can you show me how it's done?"

"Sure, it's about—."

Before Rudy could start explaining, Luna stood up.

"Huh?"

Rudy seemed confused, but Luna held her ground.

She walked around the table, positioning herself next to him.

Luna took a seat next to Rudy, her heart pounding.

-This is the real secret weapon.

This was her secret weapon, a gift passed onto her by Ena - a subtly fragrant bath soap.

She had bathed with it just before coming to the library, giving her a sweet, comforting scent.

"Um..."

Moving a little closer to Rudy, Luna nudged the book towards him.

"Could you explain this part?"

"Uh... sure."

'Is this... is this right?'

Her secret weapon seemed to have little effect.

According to Ena, when you ask for help, you create a sense of dependency that stimulates the man's protective instincts.

Being close and smelling good should then disorient him.

But Rudy's face remained focused, utterly absorbed in explaining the answer.

Luna felt a pang of disappointment at his lack of reaction.

'It's guaranteed to work on anyone of the opposite sex!'

'Could it be... Does Rudy not see me as a woman....'

With this thought echoing in her mind, Luna found herself staring at Rudy's face.

Suddenly, Rudy turned to her.

"Eek...!"

Caught off guard, Luna jumped.

Rudy looked slightly puzzled.

"Did you understand?"

"Yes, yes, yes! You're such a great teacher, Rudy!"

She hadn't really followed any of his explanations.

But she could hardly tell him that she'd been too distracted looking at his face!

"Thank you."

He smiled, making Luna's heart flutter.

Rudy was usually so serious, always absorbed in something.

But she adored these fleeting moments when his warm smile broke through.

And speaking of warm smiles...

"Uh, Luna...."

Suddenly, Rudy leaned in closer.

They were already quite close, and his movement startled her.

His face was getting closer and closer.

'What is happening....!'

Without thinking, Luna shut her eyes as Rudy's face drew nearer.

Before she could make sense of what was happening, she felt a gentle touch on her face.

'What on earth....!!!!'

She flinched, eyes still tightly shut.

"It's done."

Rudy's voice pulled her back to reality.

"Huh?"

Opening her eyes, Luna saw Rudy holding out his hand, a broad smile on his face.

He was holding a small eyebrow hair.

"It was stuck near your eye. I thought it might prick you, so I removed it."

"Uh... ah."

Her face turned a deep shade of red as she looked at Rudy's broad smile.

In a panic, she sprang up from her seat.

"Huh?"

"Ah, thanks for the help! I need to use the, the restroom!"

With that, Luna practically fled the table, hoping Rudy wouldn't notice her blushing face.

Rudy watched in puzzlement as Luna rushed out of the library.

"But... I wasn't finished explaining?"

His gaze flickered between the empty space where Luna had been and the book they'd been studying.

"Was that the only part she didn't understand?"

Scratching his head, Rudy slid the book towards Luna's belongings.

Meanwhile, Astina found herself alone in the student council room, sifting through mountains of paperwork.

"That damned...."

Astina had made several trips to vice-principal Oliver, complaining about the unending stream of paperwork.

He'd apologize with a grin, promising to rectify the situation.

Yet nothing changed.

The vice-principal's tasks continued to pile up, with Astina bearing the brunt of it all.

She suspected he was dumping the majority of the work onto the student council to avoid the backlash he'd receive if he delegated it to the professors.

Astina contemplated staging a protest but dismissed the thought.

This was a crucial time for her, having recently assumed the role of an heir.

She didn't want to stir controversy.

Besides, her term as student council president was nearing its end.

Reluctantly, she turned her attention back to the paperwork.

That's when she noticed a crimson drop staining the document she was reading.

"Ah...."

It was a nosebleed.

Astina quickly tilted her head back and rummaged for a handkerchief.

It was becoming a regular occurrence, her nosebleeds.

She'd lost count of how many times it had happened this month.

"I want to run away."

Yet, she had responsibilities to consider.

The responsibility of being the student council president and the responsibility of being the heir to the Persia family.

"Rudy Astria...."

His confession of fear towards such responsibility resonated with her now.

But she couldn't afford to back down.

Power came hand in hand with responsibility, and with power...

"I can achieve what I want...."

What exactly that was, she wasn't sure.

But she knew that without preparation, she wouldn't stand a chance when the time came to seize what she desired.

Astina sighed and set aside the blood-stained documents.

She plunged back into the paperwork, knowing that once she was done, she would have to hit the books for the midterms.

"Just a little longer..."

With another sigh, Astina refocused on her work.

Chapter 71: Responsibility (4)

"The exam's finished," the professor announced, signaling the end of our midterm.

I couldn't help but smile.

"This has to be a record..."

I hadn't held anything back during this exam.

After the joint practical, there was no reason for me to do so.

Rie had claimed the top spot, and to keep my second rank, I needed to excel in this exam.

I knew Evan would do well.

He always does.

I had to focus on my own performance, not his.

And now, after giving my best shot, I felt like I had achieved an unprecedented score.

"But the exam wasn't that tough."

In comparison to the challenging final exam last semester, this one seemed relatively straightforward.

I had an inkling that it would be easier when I reviewed the past exams.

Given the joint practical, most students were short on study time.

In response, the professors had seemingly toned down the exam's difficulty.

Feeling good about my performance, I headed back to the dormitory.

"Time for some rest"

Maybe I should go out for a meal...

Lost in my thoughts, I spotted Astina in the distance.

"Oh, there's Astina."

I made my way towards her.

Suddenly, Astina wobbled, losing her footing.

"Astina?" I called out, alarmed.

She was headed for a nasty fall, her head aimed directly at the ground.

"Damn."

Pooling mana in my feet, I sprinted towards her.

I lunged, reaching for her head which was perilously close to the ground.

Please...!

Astina hit the ground, but my hand slipped between her head and the hard earth, softening her fall.

"Phew..."

I sighed, relieved.

Astina's body had hit the ground, but I managed to shield her head.

Still, I couldn't relax just yet.

"Astina, Astina!" I called, quickly rising to check on her.

Blood trickled from her nose.

She was unconscious, eyes shut tight.

Groaning, Astina fluttered open her eyes, clutching her head. "My head..."

What happened?

She tried to gather her thoughts.

She had been heading back to the dormitory when suddenly, her head had started spinning.

Then, everything had gone dark.

A voice snapped her back to reality.

"Are you okay?"

Astina turned to see a familiar face.

"Rudy Astria...?"

She murmured, recognizing him.

"What... happened?"

"You collapsed while walking."

"I... collapsed?"

Astina sighed.

She'd been feeling tired lately, but she hadn't expected to faint.

"How long was I out?"

"An hour or two at most. You should get more rest."

"Really...?"

Astina sighed, visibly relieved.

Then, she tried to get up.

Rudy quickly tried to stop her.

"Don't stand up yet. You need to rest."

Ignoring him, Astina made another attempt to rise.

"I'll rest in my room."

Rudy pressed his finger against her forehead, pushing her back down gently.

"What are you doing?"

Astina asked, startled.

"If you go back to your room, you'll go back to work tomorrow, won't you?"

Rudy reasoned.

Astina didn't have a rebuttal.

"Just stay in the hospital for a week or two. I'll talk to the hospital."

"What? No way."

"Yes way."

Rudy insisted firmly.

His stern expression softened into a smile.

"Don't worry about the student council. I'll help out."

"But... there are things... I need to do..."

"I'll bring anything you really need to do. I'll handle the small stuff. I've been helping you all this time, so I know a thing or two," Rudy assured her.

Astina smiled wryly.

"Thank you, Rudy."

She was grateful to Rudy, but also felt a pang of guilt.

Astina looked at Rudy and confessed, "I told you not to shy away from responsibility, and look at me now..."

She'd been the one to advise Rudy about responsibility, yet she hadn't managed to take care of her own health.

It was embarrassing.

Rudy offered a slight smile.

"I admire you, Astina."

"Eh?"

Astina looked puzzled.

"Even when I'm avoiding responsibility because I'm scared, you always step up. Isn't that true, Astina?"

"But what's the point... I've ended up collapsing because I couldn't look after myself."

"Doesn't that just show how dedicated you are?"

Astina chuckled lightly at Rudy's comment.

She felt a warm sensation in her heart.

Someone acknowledged and appreciated her efforts, and it made her feel proud.

Astina always tackled challenges with full effort, but this also meant she never took it easy even with minor tasks.

She was always ready to face problems head-on, believing it was the right thing to do.

But it was because of this belief that today's incident happened.

But she realized that it was okay to take things easy sometimes.

Then Rudy said he admired her.

His words wrapped around her heart, acting as a soothing balm.

Much-needed words.

Words she longed to hear.

Words that warmed her.

"No one tried to stop you before you collapsed?"

Rudy asked.

"A lot of people did try. But I was too stubborn to listen."

Rudy fell silent.

Yes, many had tried to caution Astina, but she had stubbornly persisted.

"You should start listening to those around you. They're all just worried about you, Astina."

Astina gave a small smile at Rudy's words.

"Alright, Rudy. If you see me pushing too hard, you'll be the one to stop me."

She had more to say, but she swallowed the words.

Now wasn't the right time.

Rudy picked up his bag from the floor.

"I should get going. I don't want to keep you from your rest."

"Eh?"

Astina had reflexively grabbed his sleeve as he turned to leave.

"Ah..."

She too seemed surprised by her own action.

It was as if her body had reacted before her mind could process what was happening.

Astina looked at Rudy, her face flushed.

"Can you... stay a little longer?"

Rudy blinked, looking surprised at her words.

"I just... I just want to talk. I haven't had a proper conversation in a while. I've been so busy with paperwork..."

At her words, Rudy grinned and sat back down.

"Alright, I'll stay a bit longer. But just an hour. After that, you need to get some sleep."

Astina smiled, grateful.

"Thank you."

While the two were chatting, someone was eavesdropping outside the infirmary door.

"Hmm..."

Rie was listening to Rudy and Astina's conversation, a strange look on her face.

She had come to visit the sick Astina, but when she saw that she was busy, she decided to wait.

But as she listened, she couldn't help but feel something twist in her chest.

Something akin to jealousy.

At the mansion of the Fred family, a man sat in the office, laughing to himself.

"Haha..."

He was large in size, with a shiny, oily face that wasn't exactly pleasant to look at.

"Very good..."

The man was the head of the Fred family, Anton's father.

He was seated in a chair, reading a letter.

Although the chair was not small, it looked quite the opposite with him sitting in it.

If Anton could be likened to a small pig, then the head of the Fred family was a colossal pig.

"The Railer family..."

After hearing Anton's story from the butler, the head of the Fred family had immediately sent people to the Railer territory.

Naturally, they had done this covertly, under the guise of being travelers, without making their intentions known to the Railer family.

What they found was intriguing.

Levian had been to the Railer family's territory.

Upon showing the locals a portrait of Levian, there were a few who recognized him.

"Who would have thought he'd hide in such a remote place..."

The Railer family had a relatively small and insignificant territory located at the fringes of the empire.

The head of the Fred family was hearing about this family for the first time.

He hadn't expected Levian to seek refuge in such a disconnected place.

More interestingly, the locals also mentioned that Levian had supposedly died some time ago.

The head of the Fred family recalled Anton's message.

The story about the Railer family's daughter possessing a mysterious spellbook.

A spellbook that bore a resemblance to Levian's.

It wasn't something that could be dismissed lightly.

"I need to make a plan."

The head of the Fred family chuckled ominously and rang a small bell.

Shortly thereafter, a maid entered the office.

"Did you call for me?"

"Yes."

The head of the Fred family held out a letter.

"Deliver this to Oliver..."

And he selected another from the stack.

"And this one to the Astria family."

The recipient of the second letter was none other than Ian, Rudy's older brother.

Chapter 72: Responsibility (5)

"Rudy Astria, would you mind handling this?"

"Yes, of course."

After Astina was hospitalized, I started spending a lot of time in the student council room when I wasn't studying.

I'd planned on exercising, but helping out with the student council took priority.

The council was struggling without her since she typically shouldered a considerable amount of the work.

That's why when I offered to help, the members warmly welcomed me.

With time, as I helped, I started getting closer to the other council members.

Initially, they were somewhat wary around me, but after watching me for a while, they seemed to get a better understanding of who I was.

However.....

"It feels like we're piling too much work on someone who isn't even a council member, Vice President," Rie pointed out.

Her interference became a frequent hurdle, even in my conversations with others.

"Rudy Astria, why don't we have lunch together?"

"Rudy, let's go for lunch."

Before anyone could respond, Rie would butt in and derail the conversation.

While I had gotten closer to the council members, I could never hold a proper conversation with them because of Rie's constant interruptions.

"Hey, let's go," Rie nudged me, ready for lunch.

I looked at Rie, then at the pile of work on the desk in front of me, "We're all about to eat, why don't we all go together?"

Rie frowned at my suggestion, "I don't want to."

I shot Rie a glare, but she held my gaze defiantly, creating a tense atmosphere.

The council member who'd initially invited me to lunch awkwardly chimed in, "Ah, we have somewhere else to go! Sorry, Rudy. Maybe you could go with Rie first?"

"What?"

I looked at the council member, confused.

"We can go after you've eaten..."

"No, no, it's something we need to do right now!"

He glanced at Rie, nervously waving his hands.

"Well, if you're busy, what can you do?"

Rie smirked, feigning sympathy.

"I, I'll go!"

"Alright~ Take care~."

The council member hurriedly left the room.

"...Why is he like that?"

"What did I do~?"

Rie shrugged, a sly grin on her face.

She had an annoying face, but soon I sighed and nodded.

"Alright, let's go eat."

At my words, Rie's face lit up with a smile, "Sure!"

So, we ended up heading to the cafeteria together and finding a seat.

"What are you doing after this?"

"After eating?"

I thought for a moment before replying, "I think I'll go check if the magic tools have arrived."

I couldn't help but wonder just how much Vice Principal Oliver had been exploiting his position.

Despite ordering a massive quantity of magic tools last time, more were still due to arrive.

"Ah, from the Fred family...."

Rie mumbled to herself and seemed lost in thought for a moment.

She hesitated briefly before she carefully spoke up.

"Rudy, I didn't plan on bringing this up, but..."

"Yes?"

Rie looked at me seriously.

"There's something suspicious about the Fred family's recent activities."

"The Fred family?"

I was puzzled.

The Fred family, where Anton is from, was brought up out of nowhere.

I was aware it was about time for Anton's secret story to unfold, but hearing about their suspicious activities made me uneasy.

"Recently, the Fred family has been investigating Levian."

"...Levian?"

That name coming up now seemed out of place...

"Actually, it's not too odd. The Fred family was originally tasked with the investigation into Levian's disappearance."

Rie rubbed her chin thoughtfully.

"But it's odd that they're reopening the investigation after so long. They essentially left it as a cold case."

Her explanation made me furrow my brows.

Then, Rie reassured me with a smile.

"Don't worry, we're trying to figure out what's happening. But just to be safe, you should warn Luna."

I nodded in response to Rie's advice.

Suddenly, Rie's eyes widened.

"Ah...!"

She glared at me, saying, "I, I'll tell her. I'll be the one to warn Luna."

"What?"

"I'll do it."

Rie looked at me as if she was flustered, but also as if she was pressuring me.

"Let me do it."

Rie leaned in closer as she spoke.

I sighed in response.

She's been acting so strange lately.

"Alright, you tell her."

I agreed, but still I thought I should warn Luna myself.

"Six carriages..."

I stood in front of the main building, watching the approaching carriages.

But something seemed off.

Five were cargo carriages, but one was a standard passenger carriage.

"What's going on?"

The paperwork had stated there would be six cargo carriages.

I couldn't help but be suspicious about the unexpected carriage.

"Excuse me."

I approached and stopped the carriages.

The coachman appeared puzzled.

"What's with the carriage in the back?"

"Huh? We have no idea."

The coachman shook his head, clearly clueless.

Then, a man stepped out from the carriage at the back.

He was a butler, neatly dressed in a suit.

"Who are you?"

The man bowed and responded.

"Good day. I am Carol, a butler from the Fred family."

I cut to the chase without any formalities.

"What's with the carriage in the back?"

Carol replied with an awkward smile, looking apologetic.

"I apologize. We failed to ready six cargo carriages, so one passenger carriage was arranged instead."

Upon closer inspection, that carriage indeed bore the Fred family's emblem.

They used a family carriage because they didn't have enough cargo carriages?

I was skeptical.

I walked directly over to the carriage and swung the door open.

Inside, small boxes were stacked up.

"Ah, we transported fragile items separately in this carriage."

Carol, coming up behind me, laughed and explained.

His smile was undoubtedly amiable, but it gave me a bad feeling.

"Alright for now. However, I will report this to the other professors."

"Haha... Okay."

I shut the carriage door and surveyed my surroundings.

I noticed the mercenaries who were hired to escort the carriages.

Then, I glanced at the documents again.

"There seem to be more mercenaries than listed, aren't there?"

Carol scratched his head at my statement.

"I apologize. Recently, due to rebel activity, we felt compelled to hire more mercenaries. It's for added security."

His explanation made me frown.

"Please send them away."

"Huh?"

Carol looked at me, baffled.

"Send the mercenaries away. This is an academy. No matter how many extra you hired, you cannot bring them inside. They should be waiting outside."

"Well...."

As I voiced this, I noticed a vein bulge on Carol's forehead.

While grinding his teeth, Carol asked a peculiar question.

"But... aren't you Rudy Astria...?"

"That's correct."

I replied to Carol's question matter-of-factly.

Was he hoping to just push and brush the matter under the rug?

But I was not some ordinary student.

What could they possibly do to me?

"But... why..."

Carol seemed frustrated and stopped mid-sentence.

He stared at me.

His attitude began to irritate me.

They were in the wrong, yet they were giving me such a look?

I spoke assertively.

"Get them out."

"...Excuse me?"

Then, Carol reacted with an even more shocked expression.

"Didn't you hear me? Get everyone out. Do you think I'm easy because I'm a student?"

At my stern words, Carol bowed his head in surprise.

"I-I'm sorry. We will all leave."

"Guard."

I signaled for a nearby guard.

"You called?"

"Expel all these people and reprimand the guards at the entrance who let them in without proper checks. I will submit a written report regarding this incident."

"Ah, understood."

Following my orders, the guard escorted all the mercenaries, save for one or two, towards the academy entrance.

After confirming this, I glanced at Carol who was still bowing his head.

I replied haughtily.

"Don't overstep your bounds just because the principal isn't here."

At that, Carol looked up at me in surprise.

Ignoring him, I walked towards the cargo carriages and announced.

"I'm going to check the items."

While I was examining the goods, Carol disappeared.

I didn't care where he went; he had been granted permission to enter.

"Hmm..."

I paused for a moment, lost in thought.

The look in Carol's eyes from earlier.

Despite my aggression, his gaze didn't falter.

Instead, he looked at me even more sharply.

"How cheeky..."

I felt a twinge of irritation.

However, the irritation faded quickly.

A smirk took its place.

"I really am becoming like a noble."

Carol was walking through the academy.

"What on earth?"

The Fred family and the Astria family had a fairly cordial relationship.

Rather, they were close to being comrades on the same boat.

Yet, the plan was starting to derail.

He had sent a letter to Ian Astria, assuming that Rudy Astria would also be informed, but it seemed that he had miscalculated.

"Did he not relay the message?"

Carol frowned and muttered to himself.

"Sigh... I don't know."

It was infuriating that he had been challenged by a mere student, but given the difference in their statuses, he couldn't protest.

"I have to do what I was told to."

Carol stopped his steps as he reached a specific room.

He knocked on the door.

"It's Carol. May I come in?"

A voice from inside answered.

"Yes, come in."

Carol opened the door and entered.

Vice Principal Oliver was sitting inside.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 73: Responsibility (6)

"Levian's spellbook... has been found?"

Surprise etched onto Oliver's face.

Carol responded to Oliver's astonishment with a nod.

"A student named Luna Railer has it."

Oliver rubbed his chin and adjusted his glasses.

"Luna... Railer..."

"But why wasn't there any news? Something unique like that, word should have spread..."

Carol's statement made sense.

Typically, if professors find something unique, they'd usually document or share their research about it...

"Who's been keeping this quiet..."

A few names came to mind.

Notably, Cromwell and Mcguire.

These professors tended to act as they pleased.

They neither conformed to the Academy's rules, nor heeded the advice of the Vice Principal or their peers.

They pursued research in their own way and reveled in their eccentricities.

Still, the reason these professors were tolerated despite such behavior was due to their exceptional results.

As the Vice Principal, Oliver couldn't simply dismiss these professors.

Moreover, Principal McDowell favored these professors, giving them considerable influence within the Academy.

"Could it be them..."

Oliver rubbed his chin, furrowing his brows.

Now was not the time to worry about this.

Whether Cromwell or Mcguire had suppressed the information could be determined later.

The task now was to acquire Levian's spellbook.

It would surely cause a stir in the academic community.

A magical book that activates a magic circle with one's own mana.

It was an unprecedented invention and discovery.

He planned to exclusively control this technology, a technology that could revolutionize academia, with the Fred family and himself.

He can leverage this achievement to secure the position of Principal.

The he could deal with the problematic professors after assuming the Principal's role.

"So, what's the plan?"

At Oliver's question, Carol let out a sigh.

"...That's the issue."

"What is?"

"We initially planned to kidnap Luna Railer today."

Oliver frowned at Carol's words.

"Kidnap?"

The thought of abducting a student from the Academy wasn't a decision to be taken lightly.

The Academy was responsible for its students' safety.

The students were the Empire's future and the offspring of nobles.

If word got out that the Academy couldn't protect a student, it would lose credibility.

It was this trust that enabled the Academy to receive substantial support from the nobility.

This wasn't a trivial matter.

"Why not just steal the item?"

At Oliver's suggestion, Carol shook her head.

"We barely know anything about the spellbook. If Luna has a unique ability, and only people with this ability can use the spellbook, the research process will be significantly more complicated."

Oliver nodded in understanding at Carol's explanation.

That made sense.

If the item couldn't be used by an average person, numerous tests would be needed to figure out the unique attribute.

Such experiments wouldn't just be expensive, they'd also be time-consuming.

"So, what was the initial plan?"

"We thought to use mercenaries."

"Mercenaries?"

"The plan was to hire mercenaries to start a fire at the dormitory and create chaos. In the confusion, we'd take Luna Railer. It would appear as though Luna Railer died in the fire."

But there was an issue with this strategy.

"Luna Railer is a top-notch wizard. Even other professors notice her. And you think she would die from just a fire?"

Carol responded to Oliver's question with a smug grin.

"Isn't Principal McDowell absent?"

"You expect me to handle it?"

Oliver tightened his fist.

He was hinting that he should bear all the responsibility.

"Who do you think you are to make that decision?"

Carol smiled at Oliver.

"Have you forgotten who put you in your position?"

Upon hearing this, Oliver's eyes widened.

"You're not suggesting... the Astria family is involved, too."

Seeing Oliver's reaction, Carol grinned and clapped his hands as if he had an idea.

"Oh, but Rudy Astria messed up our plan. Why wouldn't he cooperate, being part of the Astria family?"

"You mean that kid? Isn't it obvious? No matter how capable he is, there's no way Ian Astria would tell him about it."

"Huh?"

Carol voiced his confusion, but Oliver didn't elaborate.

"Well... you don't need to know that."

Carol frowned at his words, but he continued.

"So, should we rehire the dismissed mercenaries?"

Oliver wasn't a fan of this plan, but since it was an order from the Astria family, he had to comply.

If he failed to follow the Astria's instruction, his downfall would only be a matter of time...

And if Astria were involved, the disappearance of a mere baron's daughter would be hushed up without any fuss.

"Proceed as planned."

A little while passed.

"Yaaawn...."

Robert yawned in his lab.

Today was Professor Robert's day on duty.

That's why he was still at the academy, well past his usual leaving time.

However, it was about time to go.

Being on duty just meant he had to stay at the academy until 10 pm.

Feeling hungry, Professor Robert rubbed his belly.

"Hmm... I might indulge in a drink tonight, for a change."

However, it was late.

He could go to a bar for a drink, but no liquor stores would be open at this hour.

He was also concerned about the potential hangover the next day if he drank at a bar, not to mention the extra cost.

"I just want a few drinks...."

Robert licked his lips.

"Now that I think about it..."

Robert clapped his hands as if he'd remembered something.

"Cromwell must have some hidden booze in his lab...?"

Cromwell was a family man now.

And his wife despised alcohol.

He had a tendency to act strange when he drank, which was why she didn't like it.

However, Cromwell wasn't the type to quit drinking.

For him, alcohol and cigarettes were essential.

"He already left for the day...."

Robert smirked.

"I'll sneak in after my shift."

Sure, he could go steal the booze right now, but he was worried that others might look down on him if he was seen walking around with alcohol while on duty.

Even Robert, who usually didn't care about others' opinions, had a certain line he wouldn't cross.

"Hmm~."

Robert started humming a tune, excited about the prospect of pilfering Cromwell's expensive alcohol, as he continued his paperwork.

"Ugh...."

I yawned while studying in the library.

Then I checked the time.

The clock was slowly moving towards 10:30.

"Oh, it's already this late."

But something felt off.

"....Why isn't Luna here?"

The reason I was in the library was to give Luna at least a heads-up.

I assumed that if I just sat and studied, she would eventually show up.

But she didn't.

What's going on?

Luna was usually in the library. She would say something otherwise.

She always told me if something was up.

But not today.

"Is something wrong?"

I muttered to myself as I began to organize the stack of books.

"Huh?"

Then I heard a voice behind me.

When I turned around, I saw Riku and Ena.

"Oh, you're here. Welcome."

I greeted them cheerfully, but Ena looked around with a puzzled look.

"Uh, but... where's Luna?"

"Huh?"

I was taken aback.

"Luna... didn't she have something else to do?"

"Huh? No... She definitely said she would be studying in the library with us..."

A sinking feeling started to form in my chest.

Something wasn't right.

"Huh? Hey! Where are you going!"

Ena called after me, but I didn't look back and began to run.

Then I thought calmly.

The carriage of the Fred family is currently inside the academy.

The carriage was supposed to stay at the academy for a day.

Considering the distance from the academy to the Fred family's estate, the plan was to provide accommodation at the academy, they stay for the evening, and then leave.

Therefore, under normal circumstances, the carriage should only be leaving tomorrow.

That's how it was written down.

However, there was a slight discrepancy.

Six carriages.

Among them, there was one ordinary carriage.

No matter how I looked at it, it seemed suspicious.

The absence of Astina.

The sudden error in the documents.

The odd behavior of the Fred family.

Finally, the disappearance of Luna.

When I put it all together, a terrifying picture began to form.

Were they after Luna's spellbook...?

Or even Luna herself?

They had manipulated the carriage list, allowing an extra one to leave at night...

With that thought in mind, I decided on a course of action.

At this hour, the professor on duty would have already left.

It was too late to ask for their help.

So the first priority was to prevent the carriage from leaving.

The time of departure for that particular carriage was already recorded.

However, if the Fred family used their influence to quash this issue, the guards would be powerless to stop them.

I had to hurry.

I sprinted towards the main gate.

That's when I heard students screaming.

"Fire! Fire!"

Soon, smoke began to billow from the dormitory.

"Ah."

Hearing that, I became certain.

I had to move faster.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 74: Responsibility (7)

"Fire!"

The shout echoed through the dormitory.

Evan stepped outside his room, his thoughts racing.

'A sudden fire?'

Something wasn't right.

The chance of a fire in the dormitory was very low.

Students from the Magic department were always prepared to put out fires, and alchemy students always kept fire-extinguishing magic scrolls nearby when concocting their volatile potions.

So, an actual fire was unlikely.

Moreover, the quick reaction of students to the shout of 'fire!' raised more doubts.

'What's happening?'

In the absence of a professor, students would normally try to put out the fire themselves.

But now, everyone was heading outside without hesitation.

As though under a spell.

Evan wasn't the only one sensing this.

Others felt the strangeness too.

But seeing everyone else hurry out, they chose to follow.

Evan hesitated briefly, looking towards where the supposed fire was.

'Should I check it out?'

He thought for a bit and then decided against it.

He didn't need to get involved.

If he went to the reported fire's location, he might face a situation he wasn't ready for.

In doing so, he might get hurt, which could impact the rest of his semester.

With that thought, Evan began to head for the exit again.

As he was about to leave, a familiar face appeared, moving against the flow of students.

"Yeniël?"

"Oh, Evan."

Hearing Evan's voice, Yeniël stopped and rushed to him.

Seeing her, concern appeared on Evan's face.

"Yeniël, where are you headed? There's word of a fire, you should be evacuating."

Yeniël shook her head.

"It's strange. All this chaos over just a fire?"

"Ah, there was a big fire before you arrived here. Maybe it's the same now, which is why everyone's leaving."

Evan said lightly, thinking it wasn't a big deal.

But Yeniel didn't like his casual attitude.

Her face showed her disagreement.

"Everyone's leaving over a mere fire? The students of Liberion Academy?"

Yeniel's strong words and look caught Evan off guard.

He was used to seeing Yeniel happy or neutral around him.

Her sudden anger was surprising.

Looking annoyed, Yeniel spoke.

"I want to see for myself. What will you do?"

Despite her words, Evan was firm.

"I don't need to go... I can't help with the fire... Let's leave, Yeniel."

"Really, Evan..."

Yeniel seemed ready to express her anger.

But suddenly...

"What?"

Confusion appeared on her face.

And then...

"Oh... No!!"

With wide eyes, Yeniel raced out of the dormitory.

Evan watched Yeniel with confusion.

"Did she change her mind?"

He followed after her.

"Phew..."

Carol wiped his brow with his sleeve.

Luna was motionless at his feet.

Next to Carol, Anton stood, with a satisfied smirk.

Anton, arms crossed, said,

"That took more time than I thought."

"I'm sorry. I misjudged her because she mainly uses magic circles."

Luna was a wizard known for her use of magic circles.

Without a pre-prepared magic circle, she was as vulnerable as anyone else.

Yet, Luna was one of the best at using circle magic and was skilled even in basic spells.

But she was no match for both Carol and Anton.

"We should get the spellbook now."

Following Anton's words, Carol moved to Luna and grabbed her bag.

He began searching for Luna's room key.

"What's this...?"

Carol stumbled upon something unexpected.

"Anton, is this...?"

It was Levian's spellbook.

Luna always had Levian's spellbook on her.

Not as a weapon for emergencies, but because she feared someone might steal it from her room.

Thus, she never thought to use it when they ambushed her.

Anton smirked.

"This is quite the lucky find."

Carol glanced at Anton and grinned back.

"I'm taking Luna Railer with me."

"You've told the mercenaries to move as soon as possible, right?"

Carol glanced at a pocket watch.

"Yes, they're on it."

Anton nodded in response.

"Good, let's get her on the carriage."

With that, Carol lifted Luna and walked to the carriage with Anton by his side.

After putting Luna inside, Carol said his farewells to Anton.

"I'm off."

"Alright, say hi to your dad for me."

With a quick nod, Carol started the carriage.

As he watched, Anton turned to go to the flaming dorm.

"What?"

Suddenly, he saw someone sprinting towards him from the distance.

The person was closing in fast.

"Who... who's that?"

The night's darkness only revealed the individual's shadow, making it hard to tell who it was.

But one thing was clear.

A strong desire to kill.

This person was overflowing with it and was heading straight for Anton.

Anton braced himself.

He had to face this unknown person.

Even if he didn't know their motive, but anyone releasing such a strong wave of killing intent undoubtedly had a reason for it.

Anton pointed the ring on his finger at the charging figure.

"Activate!"

Right away, several ice spears appeared around him.

It was a magical tool.

"Fire!"

The ice spears shot towards the figure quickly.

But, it was useless.

Crack.

The figure slowed down for a moment and broke the incoming ice spears with his hands.

The ice spears broke apart, and the figure started running towards Anton again.

"What...what the hell is going on?!"

Fear rose in Anton, pushing him to back away.

Who was this man coming at him?

He was frightened, but now wasn't the time for fear.

Anton clenched his teeth and held his necklace tight.

"Activate!"

Now, three fire sparks flew out.

It was magic like the explosion magic Rie used.

"I didn't want to use this...!"

Anton threw the magic at the speeding figure.

"Die!"

Without thinking about what would happen next, Anton released his explosion magic.

Then, a voice echoed from the figure's direction.

"Priscilla. Guardian Spirit."

-KWAAAAAAAAAAA!!!!

The explosion magic blew up on touch.

A huge flame burst out, sending a wave of force all around.

Black smoke poured out from the blast.

Holding back his breath, Anton focused on the rising smoke.

He couldn't see through the dark smoke, but he felt a bit relieved.

With such a big explosion, not many could have lived through it.

"Ha... haha... who could've made it through that?"

Anton whispered to himself, looking around cautiously.

"I should get out fast..."

An explosion like that would surely draw eyes.

He had to leave, and fast.

Thinking that, Anton began to move.

-Thunk!

Suddenly, a noise rang out behind him, like someone had stomped the ground.

"Huh?"

Anton slightly turned his head to find where the sound came from.

What he saw was a hand.

-Crunch!!!!

"Arghhhhhh!!!!"

After spotting the hand, Anton's face was forced right into the ground.

The hand he saw had grabbed his face and slammed him to the ground.

Blood started pooling from behind Anton's head.

Then, a terrifying voice sounded.

A voice full of anger and the desire to kill.

"Hey, quiet down."

Hearing that voice, Anton shuddered, and reality hit him.

And the hand gripping his face.

Through the gaps between the fingers, he saw a face.

It was... Rudy Astria.

There was no emotion on Rudy Astria's face, but deep down, he was boiling with rage.

"Uh... Ru... Rudy Ast-."

Trying to say his name, Rudy lifted Anton's face with one hand and crashed it back to the ground.

-Thud!!!!

"Aaaarrrrgggghhhhh!!!!"

Sharp pain surged through the back of Anton's head.

Rudy put his hand over Anton's mouth.

"Hey, you're too loud."

Rudy looked at him sharply.

"It's night. What if you wake people up?"

Rudy Astria's stern face sent chills down Anton's spine.

His face turned pale, and his knees felt weak.

Shaking with fear, Anton tried to speak.

“Mm... hmm... mmm...”

But with Rudy's hand over his mouth, his cries were barely heard.

Seeing this, Rudy quickly asked,

“Luna Railer.”

“Mmm?”

“Where's Luna?”

Anton quickly pointed to the academy's main gate.

Rudy then let go of Anton's mouth.

“How long ago?”

“S-sniff... just a little while ago.”

Anton remained on the ground, crying.

Rudy Astria rushed towards the academy's main gate.

A pain pulsed in the back of Anton's head, but the terror he felt overshadowed it.

He wanted to flee, but his legs were too shaky.

“Hmm... hmm...”

He then heard someone approaching.

The sound of fast breathing and running steps.

To Anton, these seemed like the steps of a rescuer.

Through his tears, Anton begged.

“P-please... help... me... hmm...”

Hearing his plea, the steps grew louder.

Soon, a figure stood over him.

“Please help...”

The person looked at him, pausing.

Looking up, teary-eyed, Anton recognized the face.

“Ah...?”

“Hey, did Rudy Astria pass by here? Which way did he go?”

It was Rie looking down at him.

---Toggle New Ads

Another one later ヽ(•ω•`)o

Chapter 75: Responsibility (8)

In the dormitory, Locke emerged from his room, a puzzled look etched across his face.

"Fire?"

He couldn't believe it.

The idea that all the students were scattering because of a mere fire seemed absurd.

The existence of the fire itself appeared to him as an absurdity.

With a half-smirk, Locke leisurely began his stroll.

Yet, his path deviated from the rest.

He was advancing towards the fire.

As he approached the burning area, an odd spectacle met his gaze.

"What's this?"

There were smoldering ashes.

Yet they hardly generated more than wisps of smoke; it didn't feel like an actual fire.

Looking at this, Locke was certain.

Someone had intentionally created this situation.

But who? And why was everyone leaving?

Without even properly investigating?

Locke didn't have the answers, not yet.

"I'll find out when I get there."

That was his train of thought as he continued his stride.

Gradually, the answers began to reveal themselves.

"What's he doing?"

The lounging mercenaries were startled to see Locke.

Locke unsheathed his sword.

This was an outcome he had somewhat anticipated.

Without a moment's hesitation, Locke launched his attack.

"Cough!"

His sword, gleaming under the light, brought down the mercenaries one after the other.

Caught off-guard, their weapons set aside.

They didn't stand a chance against Locke unarmed.

And so, in a brief instant,

"Whew..."

Locke cleaned the blood off his blade.

Most of the mercenaries now laid sprawled on the floor, victims of his sword.

"Two of them, huh..."

There were those who abandoned their comrades and fled.

Two of them.

Clutching their wounds, they were making their way up the stairs.

"There are more, is that it..."

Had they descended, it would have meant they were retreating.

Then, a groan emanated from a fallen mercenary.

"Ugh... save me..."

Locke walked over to him and crouched down.

He stared the mercenary in the eyes.

Seeing Locke, the man trembled in fear.

"P-Please, let me live..."

Locke held his gaze, then asked,

"Who gave the order?"

The mercenary hesitated, trembling.

If he exposed the mastermind, he was doomed.

He had loved ones he had to guard.

But that was a concern for the future.

The present demanded survival.

Finally, the mercenary spoke in a hushed tone.

"It... it's the Fred family."

Nodding, Locke seemed pleased and continued his interrogation.

"How many of you are here, and who's the toughest among you?" Locke pressed.

The mercenary shuddered as he answered, "There are 13 of us... The toughest... he can defeat six to seven mercenaries effortlessly..."

Locke rose from his crouched position as the mercenary finished speaking.

"H-huh...! Don't...don't hurt me!"

A fallen man whimpered, recoiling from Locke's sudden movement.

Locke didn't even acknowledge him.

'Four down... two hurt... and the strongest can take six to seven...'

Locke's thought process was interrupted by the sound of approaching footsteps.

The sound steadily grew louder, and shadows began to take shape.

Leading them was a hefty man, obviously the head of the group.

"We've got a visitor," he sneered smugly.

Locke dismissed him, continuing with his train of thought.

'How many are left?'

Even though he'd learned complex mathematical concepts like differentiation and integration at the academy, Locke hardly ever attended these classes.

Doing calculations in his head was beyond him.

He was a warrior, not an academic.

"What are you doing?"

The leader asked, irritation creeping into his tone.

Nonchalantly, Locke replied. "And who are you?"

Visibly frustrated, the leader growled, "Ugh...! Annoying."

His features twisted into a smirk.

"Alright, since you asked, let me introduce myself. I am the symbol of freedom, admired by even knights. I am the Mercenary King, Cedric!"

His proclamation startled the other mercenaries.

"Ce, Cedric?"

"Is...is he really Cedric?"

Their whispers were soon swallowed up by Cedric's self-satisfied laughter.

"Time to give up—"

"Pfft."

Locke suddenly started laughing, provoking Cedric's anger.

"Are you mocking me?"

All Locke did was chuckle.

Eventually, his laughter died down.

"I'm not sure who you think the Mercenary King is, but...."

Locke unsheathed his sword, pointing it towards Cedric.

"The Mercenary King is a fool. He's just a guy who spouts about freedom. He's not someone to look up to."

Locke's words left the mercenaries stunned.

"I suppose I'll have to take care of you all then."

The numbers were irrelevant.

All he needed to do was cut everyone down.

"Huff... Huff..."

I ran as fast as I could, focusing my mana into my feet for speed.

She couldn't have gotten too far.

Soon, I caught sight of a carriage darting away in the distance.

"Luna...!"

Her name slipped from my lips as I continued to chase after the carriage.

The carriage picked up speed as I got closer.

I could've easily brought it to a stop with a punch or a spell, but I held back.

Luna was probably inside.

If I attacked the carriage, Luna could be hurt along with the enemies.

"First, I need to stop it..."

With renewed resolve, I continued my pursuit of the carriage.

Our gap between us diminished quickly, and before long, I was on it.

"Hup!"

With a swift jump, I found myself on top of the carriage.

"Ugh..."

The wind lashed at my face as the carriage kept its rapid pace.

I held on tightly to the carriage.

The driver, sensing an anomaly, twisted around to see me on the roof.

"What...What the!"

He blurted out, taken aback.

"Stop the carriage," I ordered.

Caught off guard, the driver stumbled and stuttered.

I shouted at him once again.

"Stop the carriage...ugh!"

-Whack!

Suddenly, a sword sliced through the roof of the carriage.

The blade brushed past my cheek.

Had it been just a smidge closer, it would've pierced through my jaw.

A voice echoed from inside the carriage.

"Keep running."

It was a voice I recognized - it was Carol, the butler.

"Ye, Yes!" The driver answered nervously.

"Huff..."

I took a deep breath.

"Ready for a round?"

I raised my fist, slamming it onto the carriage roof with a mana-infused punch.

The roof gave way, revealing Carol's sword inside the carriage, aimed straight at my throat.

It appeared he predicted my drop from the roof.

I grinned, raising my left arm.

-Clang!

"What?"

As my arm collided with the blade, the clashing of metal filled the air.

Carol's sword couldn't penetrate my arm.

Feeling proud, I mustered strength in my right hand.

"Is it my turn now?"

Before Carol could respond, my punch connected.

-Bang!!!

"Ughhh!"

My punch hit Carol's stomach.

The impact sent him flying backward, crashing through the back wall of the carriage.

"Phew!"

A voice echoed in my mind.

[Ugh, 'Guardian Spirit' means I absorb the hit instead. Be careful.]

It was Priscilla, complaining about the collision.

"Sorry, endure it for a bit."

I spoke to Priscilla, then shifted my focus to Luna.

"Luna, are you alright?"

She appeared to be unconscious.

First, I needed to get her off this carriage.

Carrying Luna, I jumped off the moving carriage.

Upon landing, I noticed a figure moving towards me.

It was Carol.

Despite being directly hit by me, he seemed to have recovered.

Perhaps, physical enhancement.

Considering he was likely a swordsman, the odds were high.

Gritting his teeth, Carol approached me.

"You damn brat..."

I gently placed Luna on the ground behind me.

Then, holding my ground, I locked eyes with Carol.

"I didn't like you from the moment I saw you."

I rolled my shoulders a few times, trying to alleviate the tension, then moved forward.

"Let's get this over with."

Carol, his gaze filled with venom, ran towards me.

"I'll crush you!"

But before he could reach me, a known voice echoed.

"Sylph. Shoot!"

"Huh?"

I stopped in my steps at the sound of that voice.

A voice I recognized uttering familiar words.

-Bang!

Following that, the sound of whipping wind filled the air and a tiny flame hurtled towards Carol.

"Ah."

Carol managed a startled gasp as he saw the flame bearing down on him.

-Kwaaaaaaang!

The flame mushroomed into a conflagration, surpassing the magic Anton had cast earlier.

Explosion magic.

The ferocious flames engulfed Carol.

"Haah... Haah..."

Heavy panting echoed from behind me.

I spun around.

A well-known face greeted me.

"Rie?"

As her name slipped from my lips, Rie exhaled and offered a small grin.

"Huff... Huff... I... came first, didn't I?"

Though Rie was struggling for breath, she still found the energy to laugh.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 76: Responsibility (9)

"Phew... I thought I was going to die from exhaustion."

Rie caught her breath a little and muttered to herself.

I opened my mouth, looking at Rie.

"How did you get here?"

The information that could have led Rie here was severely lacking.

I was able to quickly figure it out because I knew about the Fred family, but Rie wasn't the same.

Even as a student council member, it would be impossible for her to know every detail about the academy.

When I asked that, Rie opened her mouth with a smile.

"Well, with Luna's sudden disappearance, you rushing off, and the dormitory fire, I put the pieces together with the information I had, and made a rough guess."

Puzzled, I stared at Rie.

"How did you learn Luna was missing?"

At this, Rie frowned.

"Didn't I tell you at lunch? I said I'd go warn Luna. But no matter how much I searched, I couldn't find Luna anywhere. Even Professor Mcguire was clueless."

That made sense.

Seeing me nod, Rie smirked.

"However, it looks like everything worked out without any major problems."

Just then, a loud cry came from where Carol had been.

"Damn brats...!!!!"

Rie and I looked his way.

The place was shrouded in dense smoke and fire due to Rie's explosive magic.

However, Carol was slowly emerging from the flames.

"Wow, he's sturdy~"

Rie snickered as she watched Carol.

Infuriated by her words, Carol gritted his teeth and shouted at us.

"Do you think I'll lose to brats like you!!!"

Upon hearing his cry, I walked forward.

"He's really tenacious."

His vitality was something even a cockroach would admire.

Normally, I would be irritated by it.

But not now.

Instead, I smiled.

"Actually, that's good."

I would be upset if it ended with just this.

Luna's abduction.

What would've happened if Luna was indeed kidnapped?

I didn't even want to think about it.

Just thinking of it made my teeth grind together.

I had no intention of forgiving that guy who attempted such an act, and the ones behind him as well.

Of course, if the situation ended like this, the royal family would handle it well, but I was not satisfied.

The feeling of defeating someone with my own hands is clearly different from someone else doing it for me.

I felt like I could only be relieved if I personally beat that guy up.

I glanced at Rie for a moment.

"Rie, take a rest. Look after Luna."

Rie glanced at me.

"Don't get hurt."

Rie said that, but she didn't seem too worried, maybe she had faith in me.

After smiling at Rie, I walked forward.

"Arghh!!"

Carol lifted his sword and started to charge at me.

"You're too slow."

I concentrated mana on my feet and stomped on the ground.

My body shot forward, and in an instant, I lunged towards Carol.

Using the momentum of my rush, I struck his abdomen.

-Thud!

"Ugh.....!"

Without a moment to react, Carol took my hit, flew backwards and rolled on the ground.

His already burnt, disheveled clothes and hair became more chaotic as they rolled in the dirt.

"Cough! Cough!"

Carol spat out a cough while lying on the ground.

I walked towards the fallen Carol and opened my mouth.

"Stand up properly."

"This brat.....!"

Carol glared at me as he struggled to his feet.

However, I wasn't scared at all.

I stomped on the ground again.

And kicked Carol, who was trying to get up.

-Smack!

"Ugh!"

Carol rolled back once more.

I opened my mouth again.

"I said, stand up properly."

"This damn psycho brat.....!"

I stomped on the ground again.

This repeated several times.

Carol's body was in shambles.

Not to mention the several broken ribs, his face was covered in blood.

I carefully controlled my strength.

Enough to keep the opponent from fainting, to keep him in a state of pain.

I maintained that level.

Then Carol's eyes began to lose focus and his words changed.

"Please..... Stop..... Please stop....."

-Snap!

"AAAAAAHH!!!!"

I stomped hard on Carol's leg, who was begging for mercy.

I spoke with fury in my voice.

"You tried to kidnap a young girl, but you can't handle a few hits?"

"Ughh..... UGHHH!!!!"

"You don't think of the pain others feel yet you're so conscious of your own?"

"AHHHH!!!! Please!!! Please!!!!!!!"

I continued to step on Carol's leg.

"Ugh.....Ugh....."

Carol shed tears and screamed.

However, seeing Carol begging for his life, I couldn't contain my anger and failed to control my strength.

Carol lost consciousness and collapsed right there.

His body lay there, covered in blood, unconscious.

However, seeing his chest rise and fall, it seemed like he was still alive.

"Hoo....."

I let out a breath.

A sigh of relief.

I've saved Luna, and the enemy was down.

The situation was mostly under control.

Now, all that's left is to handle the dormitory situation.

But I wasn't too worried.

The students were not weak, and it seemed the Fred family's main goal had been to kidnap Luna.

“Let's head back now.”

Just as I muttered to myself and turned towards Rie, I saw someone running from far away.

Seeing the figure, I assumed a combat stance again.

The speed of the approaching person was unusual.

"Huh?"

As the figure got closer, I could start to see the person's shape.

I tilted my head slightly.

It wasn't just one person.

There was someone riding on the back of the approaching figure.

And both had long hair fluttering in the wind.

I recognized who the person running was by the fluttering of their silver hair.

"Yeniël?"

Yeniël's silver hair was reflective in the moonlight.

It was easily identifiable at a glance.

But why was she suddenly here, and who was the person on her back?

Then I heard a voice.

"Rudy Astria!"

My eyes widened at the sound of that voice.

"Astina?"

No matter how I heard it, the voice belonged to Astina.

As they got closer, my suspicion turned into certainty.

The person being carried was dressed in the attire of a patient from the infirmary.

And the fluttering red hair.

It was Astina.

As Yeniel approached me, she gradually slowed down.

While being carried by Yeniel, Astina asked me.

"Hey, are you okay? No injuries anywhere?"

Astina looked me over.

"Ah, I'm fine. The situation is also somewhat under control..."

I said so, looking at Yeniel.

"Huff... huff... why do this to me really..."

She huffed and puffed with an aggrieved expression.

Astina then slapped Yeniel's back.

"Do you have a problem?"

Yeniel twisted around to look at Astina.

"I can help if it's a fight, but why call me just to carry you around?"

"I've been feeling faint from anemia recently, so running makes me dizzy. Plus, I'm much stronger than you, aren't I? It's better if I just use you as a mount and do the fighting myself."

Astina and Yeniel started bickering.

I awkwardly smiled as I watched them.

After watching their argument for a while, a question came to mind.

"More importantly, Astina, how did you know to come here?"

Astina stopped her bickering with Yeniei, gave me a smile, and said,

"Your friends, Ena and Riku, told me. They said you might need some help."

"Ah."

Now that I think about it, I had forgotten about Ena and Riku.

They must have gone straight to Astina.

I felt a mix of gratitude and a bit of guilt.

"But it looks like the situation is already over."

Astina said, looking around.

"Of course, since I arrived first."

Then Rie came walking from behind.

Behind Rie, Sylph was carrying Luna.

"So, Astina, you're second place? Second place? Hehe..."

Rie said, smiling.

She seemed oddly fixated on the ranking.

Technically, I was the first one to arrive here.

Doesn't that make me the first?

We all laughed and chatted for a while.

It seemed like everyone became talkative after the tension had dissipated.

After sorting out the situation a bit, I opened my mouth.

"Let's go back now."

I said, grinning at them.

Upon hearing this, Rie, Astina, and even Yeniell's expressions hardened.

Rie yelled out.

"Rudy, be careful!!!! Behind you!!!!"

"What?"

Surprised by her shout, I turned around.

A colossal sword was flying towards me from behind.

"Damn it...!"

Priscilla's Guardian Spirit had already been used up.

But, it was too close.

I raised my arm to block.

If I'm hit like this...

"Gravity!!!"

Then, Astina's voice came from behind.

The sword's movement stopped abruptly.

Astina had stopped the sword.

I stared at the suspended blade, a hair's breadth from my face.

"What... is this?"

It was an enormous sword, many times larger than my own body.

But how did such a sword fly towards me?

While I was pondering this, Astina quietly spat out.

"Vice Principal Oliver...."

"...Ah."

Upon hearing that, I understood what this sword was.

Oliver's metal magic.

It was the magic of Vice Principal Oliver, who can manipulate metal at will.

The sword in front of me disappeared and a man walking from a distance came into view.

That man was the vice principal of the academy.

It was Oliver.

Chapter 77: Responsibility (10)

Just a little while ago, Oliver was patiently waiting outside the academy gate, his hood drawn up.

Even though he thought there would be no major issues with the plan, one could never be too certain.

Every incident came with its own variables.

However, he couldn't afford to monitor the situation from within the academy itself.

If he remained idle while various incidents took place inside the academy, everyone would inevitably grow suspicious of him.

Hiding near the academy's main gate, Oliver watched the events unfold inside.

Suddenly, he spotted a carriage approaching from a distance.

Yet, the state of the carriage was far from satisfactory - it was visibly damaged.

The face of the coachman was drained of color.

"Did they fail?"

He clenched his fist in frustration,

"Can't they even manage to sneak out one single student?"

His mind flitted to Carol - that overconfident butler from the Fred family.

From the start, Oliver had not taken a liking to him.

Oliver took off his hood and continued to watch the scene unfold.

When the carriage reached the main gate, the guards blocked its path.

"Who goes there!"

One of the guards pointed his spear at the coachman,

"The gate cannot be opened without permission, neither for entrance nor exit."

This threw the coachman into confusion.

Carol, who should have been in the carriage, was not there.

The coachman had been driving forward simply out of the desire to survive.

"I, I, umm..."

He stuttered, unable to explain himself.

"Identify yourself! Who are you!"

The guard shouted at him.

Just then, there was a sound of someone knocking on the iron gate from outside.

The guards, startled by the noise, turned towards the source of the sound.

"Isn't it a bit excessive to threaten like that? You might scare someone into silence."

Came a familiar voice.

"It's Vice Principal Oliver!"

The guards saw a man dressed impeccably in a suit.

It was Oliver.

The sight of the Vice Principal left them taken aback.

Oliver smiled amiably and lightly knocked on the closed iron gate.

"I've left something in the Vice Principal's office. Could you open the gate for me?"

"Ah, yes! Understood!"

The guards, setting aside the issue with the carriage for the moment, began to open the gate.

As long as the academy staff logged their entry in the records, they could freely enter and exit.

As the gate creaked open, Oliver's smile vanished and he began to channel his mana.

The spear tips of the guards melted away.

"What...?"

The guards were left dumbstruck.

The molten spear tips transformed into bullets and flew straight towards the guards' heads.

"Gah!"

"Argh!"

The guards were caught off guard, without proper helmets.

They had no choice but to take the direct hit.

Rendered unconscious by the impact, they crumpled to the ground.

The coachman gaped at the scene, shocked.

Oliver turned his icy gaze towards him.

"Where is Carol?"

Oliver trudged his way into the academy.

As he moved deeper inside, voices started to reach his ears.

The noise originated from Rudy Astria and a few others who were chattering away.

Sighing heavily, Oliver cast a stern gaze in their direction.

"Haa....."

He had just finished searching the carriage, but there was nothing left inside.

Neither Luna, nor Levian's spellbook, not even the letter he had written was there.

A letter with his seal, meant for the Fred family.

If others were to discover this letter, the whole truth behind this incident would be exposed.

Yet, it was already in the hands of those students ahead.

He had no other choice.

He would knock those kids down.

And seize the letter from them.

Even so, the fact that he instigated this matter couldn't be hidden.

Once he had set foot inside, he had braced himself for at least that much.

But, he had another goal in mind.

Oliver intended to flee with Levian's spellbook and Luna.

The Astria family was already aware of that spellbook.

Undoubtedly, they would be searching for him.

Knowing the Astria family, they would understand its value.

"Hmm..."

His gaze fell on Astina.

And he looked over the others by her side.

Rie Von Ristonia, Rudy Astria, Luna Railer and... the silver-haired brat whose name he didn't quite remember.

"I can't kill them."

If even one of them were to die, the Empire would be shaken.

None of them could be touched.

Though he could do something to the silver-haired brat, she was currently carrying Astina.

In attempting to kill her, he might accidentally kill Astina as well.

So he couldn't act recklessly.

However...

"Perhaps I can handle that Rudy Astria."

Ian might be a bit troubled, but if he secured Levian's spellbook, they might think it was worth it.

Oliver started to gather mana in his hand.

The surrounding iron bars and various metal objects melted away.

These metal pieces gathered together, forming a massive sword.

Oliver gestured with his hand.

The massive sword flew towards Rudy.

With a resounding thud, the gigantic black sword hit the ground.

Ignoring the fallen sword, our eyes were solely focused on Vice Principal Oliver standing far away.

Yeniel broke the silence,

"Running seems like a good idea, don't you think?"

I had to agree with her.

Our opponent was the Vice Principal.

He was not someone we could confront.

"What a shame...It's just one mountain after another."

I sighed.

The problem was that the mountain we were facing now was insurmountably steep compared to the ones we had climbed so far.

We stood absolutely no chance against Vice Principal Oliver.

Even if we were far superior to an average student, it made no difference.

Students were students, professors were professors.

And Oliver was a Vice Principal, leading even among the professors.

We couldn't possibly win.

So, should we choose to flee?

That wasn't a solution either.

Rather, fleeing might be the worse option.

Because after running for a while, we would inevitably get caught.

I looked towards Oliver and asked Astina,

"What should we do?"

"I don't know. Since there's a fire in the dormitory, the professors will come eventually."

"So you're saying we should hold out until then?"

"We have no other choice."

Astina clenched her teeth.

"The problem is, we don't know when the professors will arrive."

I took a quick glance at Astina's face.

Her expression held a hint of subtle despair.

Despair for an unbeatable entity.

But we had to fight even if we knew we would lose.

"Why don't you stop whispering among yourselves and speak with me instead?"

Oliver slowly walked towards us as he spoke.

"Hand over Luna Railer and the spellbook she carries. If you do so, I'll let you go."

I stepped forward and retorted,

"Please don't talk nonsense, Vice Principal."

"What?"

I looked Oliver in the eye as I continued,

"What do you plan to do by taking away a young girl like this? Haven't you already risen high enough? How far will your greed go?"

I could feel my fist clenching.

"Do you truly believe a position earned through such disgraceful means would hold any worth?"

Upon hearing my words, Oliver's face, initially brimming with rage, gradually relaxed into a smirk.

"You understand nothing."

He said, pointing to the sky.

"Those who don't strive to rise are simply bound to fall to the ground."

Then, he pointed to his own eyes.

"I've seen it with my own eyes, their fall and despair, their crumbling forms."

Oliver's eyes bore a certain fire.

They were filled with various emotions, but there was one emotion that stood out to me.

Rage.

Rage ignited by a thirst for revenge.

"Those who don't reach the sky are destined to fall to the ground."

I was taken aback.

There was only one reason they had fallen.

"Isn't that because they are blinded by their ambitions?"

Could they have been truly satisfied once they reached their desired destination?

Would they have stopped there?

"Have you not considered the possibility of another sky above the one you see?"

I said to Oliver.

"Let's stop this now."

I suggested, glancing briefly at Astina and Rie.

"Hahaha. You're telling me to stop here?"

Oliver burst out laughing, like a man unhinged.

"How about suggesting I end my life since it's all over anyway? Or perhaps, assassinate the Emperor? Is that what you're hinting at when you mention a sky beyond the one we see?"

With these words, mana began to gather in Oliver's hand.

Sparks crackled and hissed on the massive sword that Astina had deflected, melting it down.

The molten metal began to gather towards Oliver.

Oliver quietly opened his mouth.

"Seems like we've sidetracked a bit."

As soon as Oliver uttered these words, Rie and Astina stretched out their hands.

"Gravity!!!"

"Fire Sphere!!!"

Both of them cast their magic simultaneously.

We never had the illusion that Oliver would change his mind.

The conversation was merely a distraction, a strategy to induce his carelessness.

Upon seeing their spells, Oliver curtly uttered,

"Barrier."

At his words, a transparent shield appeared around him.

-Zzzzzzt!!!!

"Uh...!"

Their magic collided with the transparent barrier Oliver had created, producing an eerie, spine-chilling noise.

I watched the scene unfold, blocking my ears.

"What...."

The barrier Oliver created.

Rie and Astina's magic was easily deflected by that single barrier.

And when the magic was mostly dissipated, Oliver released his barrier and opened his mouth.

"Well, I appreciate your efforts."

-Zzzzzp!!!!

"Kyaa!"

"Eek!!!"

From behind me, screams erupted from Rie, Yeniel, and even Astina.

Alarmed by the noise, I turned around to see dozens of blades emerging from the ground.

With a slight movement, we could be sliced by those blades.

Within an instant, we were pinned in place.

"What...."

As I turned to look at Oliver, there was no sign of the liquefied metal.

While he was defending against Rie and Astina's attack, all the molten metal had already seeped into the ground.

As I stood there dumbfounded, Oliver spoke again.

"Rudy Astria."

I looked at Oliver, and in front of me, the molten metal rose, slowly taking the shape of a sword.

Oliver smirked.

"Cut off your arm with this, and I'll spare the others."

"...What?"

"To make up for the annoyance you caused, I think it's fair to take your arm."

I stared at the sword.

An absurd proposition.

Even if I cut off my arm with this sword, our lives still hang by his whims.

A one-sided loss.

However....

I found myself fixated on the sword.

And so, I bent over to reach for the sword on the ground.

-Clang!

"Why are you listening to such nonsense?"

Someone next to me kicked the sword lying on the ground.

There was no sign of him, no sound, but there he was, right beside me.

"Ah, damn it. I was about to head home and have a drink."

I looked to the side.

An unkempt man with a scruffy beard, looking like a thug.

His hair was in a mess.

He wore a suit befitting a professor, but his buttons were undone, and he wore it casually.

But still, when it came to teaching, he did so with sincerity.

"You're taking this fight with the kids too seriously, aren't you?"

It was Robert.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 78: Responsibility (11)

"Hey, hold this for me."

Robert tossed me a bottle he had been holding.

"What is this..."

I examined the bottle.

A transparent bottle containing a brown liquid.

It was a very finely crafted bottle.

"It's liquor. It's pricey, so be careful with it."

Suddenly, liquor...?

I was a bit confused, but given the situation, I quickly regained my composure.

"Look who we have here. If it isn't the Empire's outcast, Robert."

Robert loosened the tie casually tied around his neck and threw it on the floor.

"It beats being a disposable asset. At least I wasn't abandoned because of my abilities."

Upon hearing that, a vein pulsed on Oliver's forehead.

"Is that right?"

Oliver reached out and began to manipulate mana.

"Then try blocking everything."

With a flash, electricity sparked from the blade aimed at Astina.

The blade attempted to move.

However, Robert moved his hand first.

Then, the blades shattered into pieces and fell to the floor.

"What...."

Astina opened her eyes wide at the sight.

Robert definitely didn't manipulate mana.

Yet, he shattered the blade.

I, too, found it hard to understand what happened.

Despite my studies in dark magic, I had never seen such magic before.

Robert calmly spat out a command.

"Guard the kids."

Suddenly, the ground started to rumble.

"What... what is this!"

Then, a massive figure started to rise from the ground.

"Ah!!!"

I gazed dumbfoundedly at the sight.

It looked like an elephant.

However, the energy it emitted was anything but ordinary.

A very sticky black aura.

I felt an uncomfortable yet familiar aura from it.

Seeing this, Oliver laughed.

"Do you think you can fight properly while protecting these brats?"

Robert responded to Oliver's pathetic taunt with a laugh.

"I am different from someone like you who was stuck in the academy doing only research."

"Heh..... Why did such an experienced person like you leave your son to die?"

Left his son to die?

The story I heard from someone else was that Robert had killed his son.

But hearing something slightly different, my eyes widened in shock.

No, more than that, if Robert heard that, he would definitely react badly....

Contrary to my fears, Robert was just calmly manipulating mana.

"It's surprising that you have reached this far and yet you know nothing."

He didn't show much reaction, but one thing was clear.

Robert was extremely angry.

Robert usually talks a lot, fussing about this and that.

But the current atmosphere was very different.

A murderous aura was emanating from him, that could slice anyone it touched.

“But you're prepared since you brought it up, right?”

As soon as Robert said that, a red gleam started to glow in his eyes.

"Defier of the Divine, descend."

A swirling black energy began to rise behind Robert.

This energy started to form the shape of a demon.

A figure with black skin and two horns on its forehead.

It was not human in appearance.

It resembled a beast more than anything.

The demon floated up behind Robert, as if it lacked legs like a ghost.

As the demon revealed itself, Oliver did not simply stand by watching.

As Oliver clenched his fist, the surroundings began to tremble.

-Kuugooong.

All the iron in the vicinity began to melt, breaking down into sharp fragments like shards of glass.

Thousands, hundreds of these shards.

No, even more shards began to appear around him.

"Steel Control."

Zzzzzzt! As he said these words, the iron shards sparked with electricity and began to fly towards Robert.

However, Robert did not move at all.

He simply uttered one word calmly.

"Demon Howling."

Then, the demon floating behind Robert looked up at the sky.

[illegible]

The demon let out a roar.

The roar was no ordinary sound.

As the demon roared, the movement of all the iron shards around it stopped.

"Urgh.....!"

A powerful shockwave also resonated towards us.

However, that shockwave was blocked immediately.

The elephant standing next to us was blocking that shockwave.

Feeling that something was wrong, Oliver immediately cast a spell.

"Ugh.....! Barrier!!!"

Oliver quickly cast a spell to block the shockwave.

However, all the iron shards flying towards Robert were sent flying far away.

Seeing this, Oliver quickly began to gather mana in his hand to cast another spell.

Before Oliver could cast his spell, Robert calmly uttered a phrase.

"You're too slow."

Robert reached Oliver in an instant.

"You might be a superior researcher compared to me....."

Robert raised his fist.

"But you're not a fighter."

As he swung his fist, Robert cast a spell.

"Punch of Ruin."

"Ba, barrier!!!!!!!"

Seeing Robert's fist, Oliver quickly cast a spell.

Robert's fist connected with Oliver's barrier.

Crack.

"Wha...What."

A crack appeared in the barrier.

Robert exerted more force into his fist, pushing forward.

Crunch... Snap... Crackle.

"Thi..."

Slowly, the entire barrier began to crack.

And then it shattered.

"This crazy....."

Oliver couldn't hide the shock on his face as he watched the scene.

And when the barrier shattered, Robert's fist continued to move, making contact with Oliver.

"Cough!!!!!!!!!"

Robert's fist accurately struck Oliver in the stomach.

With the impact of Robert's punch on Oliver's stomach, a huge flame burst forth.

-Kwooooooooooom!!!!!!!!!!

"Wha... What....."

Black flames.

They were enormous.

The flames resulted in an explosion so vast that it covered the surroundings.

The magnitude was unlike anything we had seen in our previous battles.

This was not on par with Rie's explosive magic.

It was far beyond.

Engulfed by the flames, Oliver was thrown into the air.

However, he didn't lose consciousness.

“Kuh...!”

From within Oliver's clothes, a concealed necklace emerged.

The necklace shattered, preserving his life.

“It's not over...!”

Midair, Oliver extended his hand once more towards Robert.

Immediately, the nearby fragments of metal rushed back towards Robert.

Robert calmly uttered a spell.

“Demon Barrier.”

Behind him, a phantom demon overlaid his figure.

The hazy form of the demon combined with Robert, and the oncoming shards of metal started to embed themselves into the demon's body.

However, the demon didn't flinch.

While the demon and Robert shared the same body, shielding him from the iron onslaught, small contusions formed where the iron pieces deeply lodged into the demon.

But these scratches couldn't inflict any harm on Robert.

“Do you really think you can achieve anything with just some metal manipulation magic?”

Robert spat out cold words.

The limits of a researcher.

A magic researcher paves new paths, acting as a trailblazer.

However, Robert was closer to a combatant than a researcher.

A person who comprehends multiple fields, devising strategies for confronting opponents.

Even though Oliver had higher authority in research, he was no match for Robert in battle.

After all, combat was Robert's expertise.

Robert reached out his hand towards Oliver, who was falling from the sky.

“Demon Fury.”

The demon overlaid with Robert also stretched its hand towards Oliver, mimicking Robert.

From the demon's hand, a black sphere emerged and ascended into the sky.

That black sphere headed straight for Oliver.

“Barrier!!! Barrier!!!!!!! Steel Control!!!!!!”

Upon seeing the sphere, Oliver yelled in desperation.

All the metal shards flocked to Oliver, forming a protective cover around his body and layers of barriers emerged around him.

Looking at this, Robert scoffed.

“Just that?”

The black sphere kept rising and Oliver kept falling.

Oliver, encased in a spherical shield made of barriers and metal.

And the black sphere created by Robert.

Inevitably, the two spheres collided.

-Crash!

As the black sphere touched Oliver, it emitted a column of black energy.

The column, resembling a long spike, penetrated through Oliver's barrier, the protective layer of metal, and extended into the sky.

“Keuk...”

The spike precisely impaled Oliver's abdomen.

Then, the demon and Robert, who had been extending their hands, simultaneously clenched them into fists.

At that moment, spikes sprouted from the original spike.

Dozens of branching spikes penetrated Oliver's entire body.

"Cough...!"

Vice-Principal Oliver's last words.

He spat out blood with such a sound.

"Hu...!"

Robert exhaled sharply, watching the scene unfold.

Immediately, the demon overlapping with Robert dissipated like smoke, and the spikes piercing through Oliver also disappeared.

Oliver dropped straight from the sky, hitting the ground with a thud.

Following this, the elephant that had been protecting us also vanished into thin air, like dust.

Robert, wavered for a moment, coughing.

"Cough..."

"Professor Robert!"

I rushed over to him without hesitation.

Blood was mixed in with Robert's cough.

Even though he didn't seem to be severely injured, he was coughing up blood.

"Are you okay?"

I ran to Robert and propped him up.

Seeing this, Robert frowned at me.

"Don't ruin the cool ending..."

At Robert's grumbling, I couldn't help but smile.

Robert also mustered a weary grin.

"You were amazing, teacher."

I told Robert with a grin on my face.

---Toggle New Ads

Ahh people in disc know me no like when they say move names like this as they fight. But it wasn't the worst, I enjoyed it regardless.

I was also supposed to post this last night I guess I forgot... my bad.

Chapter 79: Winter Ball (1)

"Still, the situation is somewhat under control."

After Oliver collapsed and some time had passed, various professors, including Professor Cromwell and Professor McGuire, hurried into the academy.

They quickly took control, subduing the violent Oliver and apprehending Anton, who had been acting with him.

However, it didn't seem necessary to do so.

Oliver had already suffered such significant injuries that he was as good as dead.

And Anton was...

"Ah...Uh..."

His eyes were rolled back, and he was in a half-conscious state.

He was so broken down that he could not even hold a proper conversation.

Certainly, he was not in this state when I spoke to him.

But, looking at his severely wrecked state, I tilted my head.

How did he end up like that?

It was not the time to worry about this for now.

I had to get to the dormitory.

I suspect that these guys are behind the fire at the dormitory as well, and I had to protect the students.

However, the situation there was already over.

"Ah, Rudy Astria has arrived."

Borval greeted me as I arrived in front of the dormitory.

Beside him, Locke scowled as if he didn't like something.

"What happened?"

Professor Cromwell took the lead and asked Borval.

Then, Borval pointed to a corner with several professors watching.

In that corner, there were people tied up, unconscious.

Borval handed a pouch to the professors.

"It seems they used this magical tool to chase the students away."

Inside the pouch was a large bead.

It was a magical tool containing guidance magic.

Borval explained the situation while showing the bead.

To summarize, they had staged an incident to drive the students out of the dormitory.

They burned dry twigs to make it look like a fire had broken out.

Then they used this bead.

This bead induced the students to leave the dormitory.

Of course, the magic tool was not powerful enough to control the students at will.

It merely instilled the notion that they had to escape from here, and drove all the people who did not doubt it out of the dormitory.

This notion was more readily accepted because of the previous library fire.

However, Locke was skeptical of this and shook off the magic.

This magic can be easily dispelled with a single doubt, so it didn't work on Locke.

So, Locke was the first to go upstairs and start fighting with those mercenaries.

While he was fighting the mercenaries, Borval arrived and swept the rest away.

So that's why Locke was making that face...

He wore a sulky expression, like a wolf that had its food stolen.

Still, everyone relaxed, knowing the situation was completely under control.

However, there was just one person who frowned.

It was Cromwell.

"It's going to be chaotic for a while."

Predicting the troubles that would arise in the absence of the Vice-Principal and Principal, he let out a sigh.

A few days after the academy attack incident.

At the heart of the empire, the Royal Palace.

Many people had gathered in the Royal Palace.

Among them, the one that stood out was Ian Astria.

These days, Perrian Astria, the head of the Astria family, had been absent.

Rumors circulated that he was gradually preparing for retirement and leaving all matters to his successor, Ian Astria.

And today.

Today was the day of the conference regarding the incident at the academy.

This was not a trivial meeting.

The academy was where the children of the nobles representing the empire were.

The news that such a place had been in danger meant that the empire's future had nearly faltered.

And there's a possibility that such a danger could happen again.

Rie, the heir to the empire, was also at the scene, making it impossible for the incident to be dismissed lightly.

Therefore, the empire deemed this meeting of great importance.

With Ian Astria at such a place, people couldn't help but focus on him.

Essentially, the head of the family not appearing at such an important place meant nothing short of passing on the position to his heir.

Inside the Royal Palace, in the conference room.

A multitude of nobles were present.

Despite the Emperor not having entered yet, no one dared to utter a word.

They all recognized the gravity of the situation and refrained from making casual remarks.

A man broke the silence.

"Ian Astria, it's been a while."

The man standing closest to the emperor's seat.

The prime minister of the empire.

It was Jason Ophillius, the head of the Duke Ophillius family.

Although he looked old enough to have a full head of white hair, his dignity was so impressive that no one could dismiss him.

Jason, in this serious atmosphere, spoke with a smile.

"Is your father doing well?"

However, no one shushed him.

If the Astria family is said to possess independent power, then the Ophillius family was the symbol of the empire.

A family that boasts of endless loyalty to the emperor.

No one could tell the head of such a family that the situation was serious and to exercise restraint.

Ian frowned at Jason's question and responded.

"Yes."

"Hoho, so he told you to attend the meeting and see some faces instead? I was hoping to share a drink with Perrian after so long..."

Jason said with a hearty laugh.

"Then, would you relay a message?"

As Jason spoke, the laughter disappeared in an instant.

He opened his mouth with a look that had completely lost its laughter.

"Manage your people properly."

At Jason's words, all the nobles present felt a chill.

No one had dared to say this.

The Fred family, who had caused the accident this time, was an unquestionable 'dog' following the Astria family to anyone's eyes.

However, no evidence against the Astria family emerged from this incident.

So, the incident was seen not as a conspiracy by the noble faction but as a plot between the Fred family and Oliver, their associate.

Despite the situation, all the nobles were aware.

They were certain that the Astria family was involved as well.

It was implausible for the Fred family to single-handedly instigate an event that could overturn the Empire.

Jason pointed out this part in a public place.

So, the other nobles had no choice but to be flustered.

Upon hearing Jason's words, Ian opened his eyes sharply.

Then, Jason let out a pleasant laugh.

"Just a joke, a joke. Heh heh. This old man gets scared when young people stare at him like that."

While he was laughing, the guard at the door shouted.

"Entrance of the Empire's sun, the Empire's light, His Majesty the Emperor."

At that, all the nobles in the meeting room bowed their heads towards the door.

The door opened and the Emperor with a long beard appeared.

Behind him was a middle-aged man with a sizable stature, wearing glasses.

The Principal of the Academy, McDowell Cliver, was there.

The Emperor walked through the nobles and ascended to the throne, while McDowell found a place among the nobles.

"Now, let us start the conference."

"It's been a while, McDowell."

As soon as the meeting ended, Duke Jason Ophillius approached McDowell.

"You've been busy these days, haven't you? The Academy demands a lot of your time."

"Not at all. If anyone is busy, it would be you, Duke Ophillius."

McDowell replied, his head bowed toward Jason.

"Ho-ho, what could an old man like me be doing?"

Jason spoke, his cheerful laughter ringing out.

"Hasn't it been a while since you visited the academy yourself?"

"Ah, yes. I've had some things to attend to recently regarding the rebels."

"Oh? The rebels you say."

Jason stroked his chin at McDowell's words.

Once McDowell confirmed that no one else was around, he carefully opened his mouth.

"I've been tasked with overseeing someone involved with the Rebels, which has me quite concerned."

At this, Jason clapped his hands and responded.

"Ah, His Majesty the Emperor did mention something about it."

McDowell simply nodded.

The fact that McDowell was in charge of Yeniel was a secret known to almost no one other than the Emperor.

Anything related to the Rebels was a matter the Emperor was intently focused on.

So, it was the right decision to keep as much information as possible hidden.

The reason why they didn't explicitly inform Jason and used McDowell instead was also to hide these affairs.

Most nobles had an easy time tracking schedules, but McDowell's was difficult to discern and few paid it much attention.

Being the principal of the Academy always required a certain level of mystery.

For the safety of the Academy, his power and activities must remain unknown.

That way, no one would dare invade the Academy casually.

After a moment's laughter, Jason cautiously broke the silence.

"So...have you found a vice-principal yet?"

McDowell awkwardly smiled before replying,

"There is someone I have in mind."

"Oh, good to hear. Who is it?"

"Well, I can't be certain. The person in question might not accept."

"...They would decline the vice-principal's position?"

Jason questioned, his face showing confusion.

"Well, this friend is not too ambitious... and also..."

"And?"

McDowell scratched his head.

"His wife is rather strict, she might not allow it."

"...Hoho, I see. A caring wife, it seems."

"I suppose so."

"So who is the poor man? Do I know him?"

McDowell nodded.

"It's Cromwell, Charles Cromwell."

In a dark space.

"Cough."

The death rattle of a man echoed.

And then, a cold voice rang out.

"Pathetic creature."

It was a beautiful voice.

However, it was difficult to consider it a pleasant voice as it was laced with hostility and sharpness.

"Just for failing to capture a single person, you're in such a state."

The man who voiced those words swept back his glossy black hair in what appeared to be annoyance, his brows furrowing.

"That one seems to have been quite a challenge."

The man with black hair dusted off the blood on his sword and took a seat.

Then he called out to someone nearby.

"Bring Yeniel. Fetch Yeniel for me."

"Y-Yeniel, sir? But Yeniel is currently on a mission at the academy..."

The man with black hair looked up, his gaze falling upon the one who answered.

"I-I'm sorry!!! Very sorry!!! I'll... I'll fetch her right away!!!"

With just one glance from the man, he quickly bowed his head in fear.

With a sigh of discontent, the black-haired man pulled a cigarette from his pocket.

After taking a puff, he opened his mouth.

"Go fetch her."

"Understood!!!"

The man responded loudly and ran out.

The black-haired man took another puff from his cigarette, gazing up at the ceiling.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 80: Winter Ball (2)

Student Council Room.

I was having a conversation with Yeniel and Astina.

"So you're saying Yeniel has been summoned?"

I asked, my face showing surprise.

"Yeah, a letter arrived through a bird yesterday."

So far, there had been no word from The Rebels, so their movements were unknown.

Yeniel had merely been biding her time by sending useless information to The Rebels.

After all, Yeniel's reason for coming to the academy was to assassinate Rie and me.

Since that plan had already failed, there was nothing they could ask of Yeniel.

As a result, all Yeniel heard was to hide in the academy without revealing her affiliation with them.

But when she was just twiddling her thumbs, finally, a new instruction came.

A letter carried by a bird.

That letter was a command from the leader of The Rebels.

"Why would the leader suddenly call for you?"

"I'm not sure either. Since they asked me to come, I guess I should."

At my words, Yeniel shrugged her shoulders.

The leader of The Rebels.

She said that she doesn't know exactly who he is.

Of course, I knew who he was.

A man with black hair who breaks and kills everything that stands in his way, slicing people apart with his absurd swordsmanship.

He's a man known as the Tyrant of the Battlefield.

There's no need to meet him now, but it was about time something happened.

"However, the sudden summons could mean they've discovered your double-agent status, couldn't it?"

Astina looked at Yeniel with a worried expression.

Astina wasn't one to be overly concerned about Yeniel, but it seemed she'd grown fond of her after spending some time together.

Yeniel relaxed her expression as if to say it was okay and opened her mouth.

"I doubt that would happen. Considering his character, if there were a traitor, he wouldn't call them aside but kill them instantly."

I agreed with her thoughts.

That tyrant wouldn't have left a traitor alive.

Upon hearing this, Astina asked,

"Then why is he calling you?"

"There must be some business. I'll have to go there to know exactly."

Yeniél said this and took out a sheet of paper.

"This is a document stating that my parents are in critical condition."

Astina accepted the document.

It seemed like she was going to apply for a leave of absence with this document.

"So, we won't see you for a while."

Even though we hadn't spent much time together, it was still sad to hear her leave without a definite return date.

At my words, Yeniél faintly smiled and responded,

"I guess I won't be back until the final exams are over."

But there was something else that concerned me.

"Did you tell Evan?"

Evan.

Recently, I hadn't seen Yeniél and Evan together.

Usually, I'd see them together once in a while, but recently, they were only seen separately.

"Ah, I've been fighting with that guy recently..."

"Fighting?"

I expressed my doubts at Yeniél's words.

"Sometime ago, I started to feel like he was changing. We had a bit of a quarrel."

"Evan has changed?"

At my question, Yeniel paused for a moment before speaking.

"He used to feel so foolishly considerate towards those around him... but nowadays, it seems a bit different...."

Yeniel said and gave an awkward laugh.

"Well, it might just be my misunderstanding. I'll go check on him."

Yeniel paused as she headed out, stopping to look back at me.

"Rudy Astria. Be careful while I'm away. The Rebels despise nobles, especially the Astria family, who can be considered the leaders of the nobility."

I nodded in understanding.

The meaning behind her words was clear.

Ian of the Astria family, or its head, is not someone the Rebels could touch.

But I was a different story.

I'm still weak.

So in Yeniel's absence, it was possible that the Rebels might target me.

"Well, I'm off now."

With that, Yeniel walked out of the room.

Watching her retreating figure, my gaze then turned towards Astina.

"Have you been feeling better lately?"

It had been a while since Astina was discharged from the hospital.

Her complexion was much better than when she had fainted, but I couldn't help but worry.

"With the principal back, my workload has lightened up, so I'm fine. Thanks for your concern."

Astina smiled at me.

Seeing her like that put me at ease.

As she put away the documents Yeniel had given her, she asked me a question.

"Are you preparing well for the final exams?"

"I've been studying as usual."

I shrugged my shoulders.

The final exam period was approaching quickly.

With so many major events happening, it felt like it was coming faster than usual.

Although I said I was studying as usual, I was actually paying quite a bit more attention to these final exams.

The midterms we had before didn't differentiate much and some subjects didn't even have exams, so they didn't weigh heavily.

Because there were subjects that didn't even have exams, our midterm grades weren't even posted.

Since I didn't know my ranking based on the midterm grades, the final exam was really important.

"Alright, then I'll be watching this time."

Astina said seriously.

It seemed like she was referring to the 'responsibility' she mentioned before.

In other words, she was telling me to come in first place.

"...I'll consider it."

I couldn't give a definitive answer to Astina's words.

All I could do was contemplate her words.

I was worried about Evan's changes that Yaniel mentioned, and about the things that might happen next.

The recent actions of the vice-principal.

I've known since before that the future was changing, but most things still went as they originally did.

However, this time was different.

I had certainly manipulated things so that Anton and Evan wouldn't meet during the joint practical.

So originally, there shouldn't have been any opportunity for the vice-principal to interfere.

But an incident did happen.

The future had been twisted.

Of course, the cause was different.

Levian's Spellbook, in Luna's possession.

Because of that Spellbook, the incident occurred.

From what I knew, this Spellbook was merely a magical tool that gave Luna strong abilities, without knowing the backstory.

Because it wasn't mentioned anywhere.

But, through this incident, it became clear.

This Spellbook wasn't something that people could simply leave alone.

It was an item worth enough to risk their own families.

And its past was intricately intertwined with many people....

My goal was survival, but I tried to survive without causing harm to others.

However, now the people around me started to get hurt due to the future I've changed.

I felt a sense of responsibility.

Astina, who had collapsed, Luna, who almost got kidnapped.

They were the ones who got hurt due to the changed story because of me.

Of course, someone might say there's no need to feel this way.

Since I didn't intend to harm anyone directly.

But I didn't want to use such a defense mechanism.

For a while, I could be comfortable, but I was afraid of what would follow.

The failure to prepare for incidents by avoiding them, and the people around me suffering significant harm.

I was too afraid of these things.

So instead of resorting to such a defense mechanism, I wanted to face the situation head-on.

I looked straight at Astina.

"Even if I can't secure the first place..."

Smiling softly as I looked at Astina, I said.

"I will take full 'responsibility'."

In Professor Cromwell's lab.

Though everyone felt relieved when Principal McDowell returned, one person was even more troubled than usual.

That person was Cromwell.

"Ugh..."

'Hey, I've marked my duty shifts on the calendar in my lab. Take care of them for me. Also, do my paperwork.'

The words Robert had said from his hospital bed.

Robert suffered severe injuries from his previous fight with Vice Principal Oliver.

Robert's magic has overwhelming power, but it wears away at his own body.

Even without receiving direct damage, his internal injuries were severe.

Now that Robert had been hospitalized, his responsibilities and duties fell onto Cromwell.

Of course, McDowell, who felt sorry for him, took some of the work, but there was an even bigger problem.

The words that Principal McDowell said to him in person:

'Professor Cromwell, could you take on the role of Vice Principal?'

"What... that's preposterous!"

Cromwell recalled that moment, and let out a cry as he stared at the ceiling.

He continued to think.

'If you decline, I understand... In that case, could you at least act as Vice Principal for now? Also...

Try it for a bit and let me know again in a month. There will probably be... a faculty meeting to allocate the annual research fund in about a month...'

"This... this is blatant blackmail...."

But he could not refuse.

The privileges that Principal McDowell had been granting him all this time.

Professor Cromwell received a much larger research fund than the other professors.

Of course, he brought appropriate research results every year.

However, it was undeniable that McDowell had been giving Cromwell preferential treatment.

"The research fund..."

If cigarettes and alcohol were Cromwell's soul, then research was his lifelong friend.

Being unable to research properly was like losing his best friend.

"Ughh!!!"

Surely, if he is promoted to Vice Principal, his free time will be reduced.

And then...

"Sophie will scold me..."

Sophie was Cromwell's wife.

More than losing his personal time, Cromwell was afraid of the scolding he would get from his wife.

"Haah....."

Cromwell let out a sigh and glanced at the shelf beside him.

"Should I have a drink...?"

His hidden stash of alcohol.

He had kept just one bottle hidden in a corner, in case Sophie came to the lab.

Alcohol reserved for stressful days like today.

After a moment of hesitation, Cromwell stood up and began rummaging through the shelf.

"Hmm...?"

However, there was no way the alcohol could be there.

That's because Robert had taken it for himself.

"This...this is odd."

Unaware of this fact, Cromwell could only search the shelf in confusion.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 81: Winter Ball (3)

"Hmm..."

Luna sat on her dorm room bed, deep in thought.

"A ball..."

A short while earlier, she had been chatting with Ena.

In their conversation, she discovered something new.

- Luna, you know there's a ball after the finals, right?

This was news to Luna.

A ball that is held after all the academy's schedules are over.

Luna, who was focused solely on her studies, did not know of this.

- And you absolutely must be the first to dance! With Rudy!

"But..."

Luna had never danced before.

She hadn't had a chance to attend a ball because she hadn't been properly introduced to society.

She had learned to dance, sure.

But she'd never danced with a partner before.

"Dancing with... Rudy..."

She began to picture it.

Underneath the sparkling chandelier, she and Rudy danced, both of them dressed elegantly.

They exchanged smiles and held each other close, feeling the warmth of one another's bodies.

Then, she felt Rudy's breath and their faces were close...

"Uh..."

She stopped her imagination and looked at her reflection in the mirror nearby.

It showed her flushed face.

"Pervert..."

She muttered, covering her red cheeks with her hands.

Despite this, she kept thinking about Ena's last words.

-The couple who dances first at the ball is said to promise eternal love.

This claim was based on a romance novel set in the Liberion Academy.

"Eternal love..."

Just as Luna was about to sink into a daydream inspired by Ena's words,

Knock, knock.

"Yes, yes, yes, yes!!!!"

The knock startled Luna, causing her to yell out.

"Luna, can I come in?"

It was Rudy's voice from outside.

"Uh, uh, uh!!! Come on in!!"

Hearing Rudy, Luna quickly tidied her hair.

As Luna was getting ready, Rudy entered the room with a puzzled expression.

He looked around.

"What happened?"

In response to Rudy's question, Luna waved her hands.

"Ah, ah, no! Nothing at all!"

He sensed something odd, he shrugged anyway and sat down on a chair next to the bed.

"Then let's study."

After Luna was hospitalized and woke up, many people came to visit.

At that time, Rudy offered to tutor her.

He insisted, wanting to return the favor for when Luna had helped Rudy during his own hospitalization.

She didn't mind Rudy's suggestion to study at all.

She was simply thrilled to have more time with Rudy.

He began pulling out some handouts,

"Well, let's start with the liberal arts subjects."

"Okay!"

And so, he began explaining, using his own notes as reference.

His explanation was clear and easy to follow, breaking down complex concepts and demonstrating them with examples from his extensive notes.

But despite having such a capable tutor, Luna found herself unable to concentrate.

'Ugh....'

Leaning towards him as he spoke, she could smell Rudy.

A fresh, warm scent, like he'd just stepped out of the shower.

As Luna found herself blanking out, Rudy asked,

"Do you understand?"

"Huh?"

Rudy saw Luna with her eyes half-closed and her mind seemingly elsewhere.

".....What are you doing?"

Startled, Luna snapped out of her daze and lifted her head.

"Oh.....ahhh....."

Her face blanched as she started panicking.

'What does he think of me?'

A pervert, shameless.....

Quickly, Luna thought of an excuse and began to speak.

"Rudy, that's-"

However, just as she was about to voice her excuse, Rudy spoke.

"Feeling tired? Do you want to take a break?"

From his perspective, it seemed like Luna had been dozing off, eyes shut and head drooping.

Luna paused, taken aback by Rudy's words.

"Huh? Oh, yes!"

Then, she quickly regained composure and responded.

"I-I'm fine! Let's continue!"

Rudy gave her a concerned look, but upon seeing her bright smile, he continued the lesson.

As their study session continued, day gradually turned into night.

"Ugh.....!"

At the end of Rudy's lecture, Luna stretched towards the ceiling, letting out a massive yawn.

Rudy chuckled lightly at the sight of it.

"You did well, Luna."

Luna shook her head at Rudy's praise, startled.

"No, no! Rudy, you're the one who worked hard, not me."

Luna, saying that, opened her mouth carefully with an apologetic look.

"More importantly..... Did I disrupt your studying, Rudy? Finals are coming up soon."

Rudy dismissed her worries with a shake of his head.

"It was actually helpful explaining things to you. It helped me organize my thoughts. I find that I understand things better when I explain them to someone else."

Seeing Rudy's smirk, Luna let out a soft chuckle.

She then found herself filled with a playful spirit.

"Then, thanks to me, you'll score well! You should be grateful to me!"

Luna strutted around, hands on her hips, while Rudy laughed in response.

"Thank you very much~."

The two of them, caught in a lighthearted moment, burst into laughter together.

After their laughter faded, Rudy spoke up.

"Then, I guess it's time for me to go."

"Oh, you're leaving?"

"I need to go eat dinner."

Rudy explained as he began to collect his things.

Luna watched Rudy packing, her mind racing.

-You must! You have to ask Rudy first! Before someone else beats him to it.

Ena's words echoed in her mind.

So, how should she say it?

'Do you have someone in mind to dance with at the ball?'

She shook her head. This was too direct a question.

'Do you want to be my partner at the ball?'

Ball partner.

In this context, partner refers to the man who escorts the woman.

But this also seemed too forward to just blurt out.

'First, I have to bring up a topic...!'

As Rudy methodically packed up his things, Luna tentatively spoke.

"Rudy, do you know what's happening after the exams?"

At her words, Rudy, who was in the process of packing his things, paused with a confused expression.

'Why, why would I ask such a question!!!!'

Luna inwardly chastised herself, seeing Rudy's confused expression.

But it was too late for regrets. She had to quickly switch to the next topic.

"Ah, you know there's a ball coming up soon, right? The ball... It'll be really fun, won't it?"

'Aghhhhhhh!!!!'

Though she maintained a calm façade, Luna was internally panicking.

She felt like hiding somewhere, embarrassed by her awkwardness.

Rudy wore a puzzled expression before it shifted into a frown.

Seeing his reaction, Luna's heart sank.

'Ah, ah, ahhhhhh!!!!'

Rudy, his brows furrowed, pointed at Luna.

However, the words that tumbled out of Rudy's mouth were unexpected.

"Luna. Final exams are coming up soon. You should think about your exams before you think about having fun."

"Ah....."

At Rudy's words, Luna bowed her head.

"A student's duty is to study. You should focus on your studies."

Rudy's words hung heavy in the air as Luna silently nodded.

And so, Rudy's lecture continued.

"I'm... sorry."

Only when Luna murmured an apology did the reprimanding speech come to an end.

After his lecture, Rudy exited the infirmary.

"Come to think of it... there's a ball coming up...."

Rudy pondered aloud about the upcoming event.

"I don't think anything special will happen... maybe I won't attend...."

He casually muttered words that would have made Luna despair had she heard them.

Then he shook his head.

"Well, I'll think about it later."

With that, he headed towards the cafeteria.

"Yeniel has arrived."

As a man announced the visitor, a black-haired man seated inside nodded and spoke.

"So, Yeniel is here."

The man in the chair greeted Yeniel arrogantly.

"I am honored to meet the leader."

Yeniel bent one knee in reverence to the black-haired man in the chair.

She slightly lifted her gaze to meet the man's face.

Black hair, red eyes.

Despite a casual gaze, the man seemed to emit an almost radiant glow.

The leader spoke, his eyes trained on Yeniel.

"We need to find a person."

"Just give me the order, and I will immediately find them."

Yeniel bowed her head in response.

"I don't know who they are. Just bring me the one who is watching us."

".....Understood."

Yeniel responded quietly.

The one keeping tabs on The Rebels.

Yeniel had a fair idea who this observer was.

Before she had arrived at The Rebels' location, Yeniel had run into someone.

The Principal of the Academy, McDowell.

-I have been watching The Rebels recently. They seem to have some idea of this as well. I don't know why they've reached out to you, but if anything happens, use this bead. If you use the bead, I will come immediately.

Yeniel recalled McDowell's words.

However, it didn't seem like it was something she needed to be overly concerned about.

The leader didn't appear to have any specific plans for her, and anyway, she wasn't sure if McDowell was an enemy himself.

McDowell was also currently at the Academy, so Yeniel thought that she should just lay low and prepare for the final exam.

Chapter 82: Winter Ball (4)

Inside Rie's room,

"This isn't it..."

"Ah, understood! Go fetch something else!"

At the head dressmaker's words, the servants hurriedly ran off.

Rie was trying on dresses to wear to the ball.

Her room was crowded with people and was piled with bags full of dresses.

She kept trying on and removing them.

The visitors were high-end dressmakers from the capital.

Originally based in the capital, they had been providing services to Rie since her childhood, even traveling to the academy to tailor her dresses.

But Rie's behavior was different today.

Typically, Rie would select dresses and accessories quickly.

She'd swiftly choose a dress fitting the mood of the ball and select the matching accessories.

Her choices were always spot-on.

But... today was different.

She kept trying on and taking off dresses, and it became clear that at this rate, there wouldn't much left to try on.

Rie frowned at the sight of the dresses the servants brought.

"Why don't any of these suit me..."

The shop owner standing before her turned pale at her words.

Rie was important to his clothing store.

The marketing effect of Rie wearing a dress from his collection to events was massive.

So, if Rie stopped being a customer, the losses would be unimaginable.

"Quick, bring me the most beautiful dress in the world!"

The shop owner yelled at the assistants.

The assistants, wanted to ask 'What does the world's most beautiful dress look like?' but couldn't.

So, they had no choice but to bring dress after dress from their collection.

Seeing Rie's expression, the shop owner carefully spoke up.

"Um... Princess Rie? Aren't you tired? How about a break with a cup of tea?"

"Hmm... Okay."

Upon hearing the shop owner's suggestion, Rie settled down on the sofa.

The shop owner subtly directed the employees and stood beside Rie.

"Ah, today's dresses seem to be lacking. I've told the staff, and they'll bring a better one."

Rubbing his hands, the shop owner gave an uneasy laugh.

"Hmm... I think they're as usual..."

Rie commented casually as she sipped her tea.

What Rie casually mentioned was a shock for the shop owner.

'Wait, has she been finding our dresses disappointing all along...???'

The shop owner had been serving Rie for about 7-8 years.

Rie had been a customer since she was a child.

With her support, the scale of his shop had grown much larger than when it started.

'Of course, Princess Rie's taste would evolve as she matures...'

'Is this as far as we go...'

"Hmm..."

Just as the shop owner was about to wallow in despair, Rie cleared her throat softly.

"There's something I wanted to ask..."

Hearing Rie's words, the shop owner's eyes widened.

This was a chance.

A chance that could be his last.

"Ask anything! I can answer anything for Princess Rie!!!!"

Rie shrank back a bit at the shop owner's sudden enthusiasm, but then relaxed her expression.

"Well, um... what kind of dress do guys usually like?"

"You mean, men...?!"

The shop owner began to think rapidly.

Then, he clapped his hands.

"Fetch dress number 21 and 23 from bag 5, and dress number 6 from bag 12."

As soon as the shop owner commanded, the employees rushed to bring the dresses.

"These are the trendiest dresses. They're fashionable and I believe they would suit Princess Rie perfectly."

Rie stared blankly, alternating her gaze between the dresses and the shop owner.

"Isn't this... a bit short?"

Rie pointed to the skirt of one of the dresses.

"That's the beauty of it!"

"Huh?"

"Men are extremely sensitive to visual stimuli! So, if you wear such a flowy dress!"

"...If I wear it?"

"Then no man will be able to look away!"

Rie rolled her eyes.

"Is that so...?"

At first, she thought the dresses were bold, but the more she looked, the more attractive they became.

"Then... I'll choose this one..."

Rie pointed at one of the dresses as she spoke.

It was winter.

Winters at Liberion Academy were freezing.

The biting wind turned my cheeks icy, and each time I exhaled, a puff of white breath rose into the air.

"Whew..."

I warmed my chilled hands with my breath.

"The first year's final exams are already over..."

After finishing all my exams, I was taking a short walk.

I was lost in thought.

With everything that's happened, the year had flown by quickly.

My abilities had considerably developed, and I had learned much from my new experiences.

While I was focused on such thoughts, someone tapped my shoulder.

"Did you do well on the exam?"

Behind me, Astina stood with a smile.

"How did you know I was here?"

"I saw you walking around and decided to come down."

Astina pointed to a window above.

That window appeared to be from the student council room.

"So, how was the exam?"

I responded to Astina's question with a faint smile.

"I think I did pretty okay on the test."

I wasn't certain about my score, but I had given my best.

Due to Robert's hospitalization, I had neglected dark magic, but I still studied more than usual.

There shouldn't be a problem since nothing should happen for a while.

Now it was vacation time.

However, there was still one more event left.

A ball before the holiday.

I felt a flicker of interest when Luna mentioned it last time.

But I had mixed feelings about whether to attend or not.

After all, it would be a gathering of people sporting artificial smiles and hidden intentions.

Seeing me lost in my thoughts, Astina, with a shrug of surrender, posed another question.

"Do you plan on going home during the break?"

"Um... probably not."

Although I said 'probably', it was practically decided.

The current me and the previous 'Rudy Astria' were entirely different individuals.

Certainly, there must have been specific habits or behaviors that he possessed.

However, I knew nothing about them.

If I went home, people around me would undoubtedly notice something wrong.

To avoid arousing suspicion, it was better not to return home.

"So... you're saying you'll attend the ball?"

"...Huh?"

I tilted my head in confusion.

I don't understand how she came to that conclusion.

Astina frowned at my reaction, clearly displeased.

"What else would you do if you stay at the academy? You should go to the ball."

"...Hmm."

"It's good to show your face in such social circles sometimes. And well..."

Astina's voice trailed off, and she slightly turned her head away.

"I have something to say... so, you should go..."

"...Something to say?"

I looked at her, puzzled.

"Why not just say it now?"

Astina scowled at me.

"I have some things to talk about, so just go..."

"...Okay."

In the academy's principal's office.

McDowell was reading a letter from Yaniel.

"Those Rebel scoundrels...."

In the end, Yaniel couldn't return to the academy before the final exams.

Although the letter said there were no issues, it was still somewhat worrisome.

McDowell always cherished those under his wing.

Even though Yaniel was recruited through a somewhat unconventional route, the fact she was a student of McDowell's didn't change.

He wished he could help Yaniel return to safety as soon as possible.

However, if someone of his status intervened, the Rebels would likely go completely dark.

It was hard to give up the recently discovered location of their leader.

At least, since he had provided Yaniel with a magical tool capable of sending a distress signal, McDowell believed that Yaniel wouldn't be in too much danger.

"Hmm...."

McDowell set the letter aside and glanced at the documents beside him.

These documents were about those who had been in close contact with Yaniel.

He had them prepared in case anyone grew suspicious due to Yeniel's sudden disappearance.

The faces that appeared in the documents were all familiar.

Rudy Astria and Astina Persia.

They both were aware of Yeniel's circumstances, so there wasn't an issue there.

However, there was one person that could pose a problem.

One person who had been particularly close to Yeniel.

That person was Evan.

"That's not good...."

Having gone through the documents related to Evan, McDowell found that Evan also knew Yeniel was a member of the Rebels.

However, he was unaware of the details.

This was not the main issue.

The most significant problem was Evan's current state.

"Spends all day without speaking to anyone, completely focused on studying...."

McDowell quietly muttered the details outlined in the documents.

Evan's state.

It was not normal.

It wouldn't be surprising if it led to a mental breakdown.

He had to keep his position as the top student while dealing with those lurking below, greedily aiming for his spot.

All this pressure and there was no one by his side.

In the beginning, at least Yeniel had been there, but now he was all alone.

It was a challenging situation.

"I need to check on him."

Having finished reading the documents, McDowell stowed them away in a drawer.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 83: Winter Ball (5)

The Academy's Winter Ball was an annual event held at the end of the year, meant to celebrate academic achievements and wash away the fatigue.

A party that professors and students alike enjoyed.

Of course, it was hard to say that this ball was a simple and fun event.

Inside, there were those who hid a blade behind false smiles.

While there were people purely enjoying the ball, no one could deny that it was a hotbed of Academy politics.

This ball marked both the end of one year and the beginning of a new one.

It set the stage for academy politics for the coming year.

The outcome of the ball greatly influenced the coming year's events, hinting at who might become the next student council president or who might garner attention.

Personally, I despised this sort of atmosphere.

If I had been ordinary, I would have ignored the political plays happening at the ball.

But now, even if I wanted to, I couldn't ignore it.

I am the child of a Duke's family.

There would undoubtedly be people who wanted to get close to me.

So I made a plan.

“Ugh, it's cold.....”

I was standing before the ballroom in a black suit and overcoat.

To my surprise, I had more clothes packed than I initially realized.

Among them were a variety of suits, ranging from ostentatious to comfortable.

A black suit seemed appropriate for a ball.

As soon as the maids in the dormitory heard about the ball, they rushed to help me.

They were a group I seldom interacted with, but for the ball, they eagerly offered their help.

They provided a variety of grooming services, including facial massages, hair styling, and makeup.

It felt peculiar to receive such attention for the first time, but I couldn't deny that I looked better than usual.

Despite that, it felt strange.

I kept adjusting the stiff suit, and fiddled with my neatly combed hair.

At that moment, a familiar voice called out.

"Rudy!"

It was Luna.

Turning, I saw her in a long coat. I couldn't see what she wore beneath it, but her usually messy hair looked remarkably neat.

Behind her, Riku and Ena were approaching.

"Hehe...."

"Gruhh...."

Riku was innocently smiling as if she knew nothing, while Ena next to her was frowning as if something was not to her liking.

"Rudy, have you been waiting long? It must be very cold."

"Huh? No. I haven't waited long."

I responded, my gaze fixed on Luna's face.

Luna's appearance was so commonplace to me that it hardly registered.

But tonight, dressed for the ball, she seemed different.

More beautiful.

"You look pretty, Luna."

I found myself saying with a warm smile.

Luna's eyes widened in surprise, her arms flailing at the unexpected compliment.

"Uh, th, thank you! Rudy...!"

Luna said that and raised her thumb at me.

"Ru, Rudy also looks cool!"

"Haah....."

Ena sighed dramatically behind Luna at her flustered response.

I mirrored Luna's thumbs-up gesture with a light smile.

"Thank you."

"Hehe..." Luna laughed, scratching her head sheepishly.

Ena suggested we head inside, but I held them back.

I couldn't enter the ballroom just yet.

My plan.

I intended to keep anyone from coming near me.

With only a small group like us, there was a concern that others might approach me.

So, I needed the right people.

While I was thinking about that, some familiar faces were coming our way.

"Have you been well?"

"Ah, yes, it's been a while. Rudy."

It was Borval and Locke.

I planned to use these two as my shields.

Locke, despite being unremarkable in our company, was still a member of the respected Lucarion family.

And Borval, a talented individual who had distinguished himself in both the individual skill assessment and joint practical, was also aspiring to be a teaching assistant.

His influence in the academy was something that couldn't be ignored.

Originally, I should have also met with Rie and Astina, but Rie, due to her position as the first princess, said she would arrive a bit later, and Astina was in the middle of preparing her end-of-year speech.

If people of such status were gathered together, I figured unknown individuals wouldn't dare approach us.

"Now, shall we go in?"

I looked at everyone and spoke.

Things were beginning to get a little odd.

"Rudy! Look at this! This cookie is so pretty!"

Luna, radiant in her white dress, waved a cookie in her hand, her innocent eyes sparkling.

Her childlike excitement drew a fond smile from me, but therein lay the issue.

"Excuse me....."

A man began, approaching Luna.

".....Yes?"

She answered, a puzzled look on her face.

Seeing this, I intervened,

"Do you have something to say to Luna?"

"N-No, not at all! I'm sorry!"

The man quickly retreated upon my intrusion.

"Hehehe..... Thank you, Rudy!"

"No problem....."

Luna laughed and thanked me, a scenario that was becoming all too familiar.

Luna, with her innocent charm, was attracting quite a lot of attention at the banquet.

Each time Luna's innocent laughter rang through the room, more men seemed to become entranced by her.

Those with political motives didn't bother us, but Luna seemed to be a magnet for a particular type of unwanted attention.

Even with the presence of Locke, and Borval, men kept flocking to Luna.

I realized then that I had overlooked something crucial.

Luna was a woman of undeniable allure, and men are often courageous in the presence of someone they find attractive*.

Tonight, Luna shone brighter than any star, and that was the problem.

The banquet hall was a battleground of political maneuvering and hidden agendas.

Every smile was contrived, every gesture calculated.

Everyone concealed their true motives, speaking in coded and metaphorical language.

Unlike these people, Luna was genuinely enjoying herself, her smile pure and joyful.

She felt like a fresh flower among artificial ones.

Since things had already gone this far, I couldn't just stand by and watch.

Luna had just come here to have fun, so I wanted to make sure she could enjoy herself without feeling uncomfortable.

If I kept a protective presence near Luna, it would discourage these men from approaching her.

So, I ended up following Luna around like a bodyguard.

Time flew by, and the real ball was about to begin.

“Huh.”

With someone's voice, everyone's eyes were drawn to the entrance.

It was as if the person was the protagonist of this ball, making a last-minute entrance just before it began.

It was Rie.

“Hmm?”

I tilted my head as I looked at Rie's outfit.

A dazzling dress mixed with red and black.

And it was short in length.

Rie seemed conscious of her dress being short as well; she kept touching her skirt, trying to pull it down slightly.

Her golden hair combined with the red dress attracted everyone's attention.

But it was different from Rie's usual style.

A short skirt and vibrant colors.

Rie, who usually dressed in a simple style that suited her, had come today in an outfit that was both striking and glamorous.

I was suddenly taken aback by her appearance, losing my appetite.

It wasn't that her style was strange.

It was quite beautiful, capturing the attention of those around her.

I was just puzzled by the changed from her usual attire.

With that, Rie slowly walked into the banquet hall, and numerous people approached her as she entered.

"You look absolutely beautiful, Princess."

"Oh... isn't this dress a trend in the capital?"

They showered Rie with compliments.

"Yes, I had it specially brought from the capital," Rie replied, her smile slightly awkward but her tone as graceful as ever as she began conversing with them.

It seemed difficult to approach her at the moment.

Rie had told me she would mingle for a bit and then come over to where I was.

Well, she would come over on her own, I supposed.

I wanted to ask Rie about her outfit, but seeing her surrounded by so many people, I turned away and looked at Luna.

Luna was staring at Rie, mouth agape.

"Luna?"

"Eek!"

Luna made a strange noise in response when I called her name.

"What's going on?" I asked, looking at her intently.

"N-nothing at all!" Luna waved her hands dismissively.

As she did so, she suddenly stopped and looked at me.

Her eyes fixed on my face, she quietly opened her mouth.

"Rudy... there's something I want to ask you...."

"Hm?"

I stared back at her.

"What is it? You can ask me anything."

"Is Rie... pretty...?"

Luna tilted her head slightly, pointing at Rie.

I nodded at Luna's question.

"Yeah... pretty, right? Even though she's usually so casual, when you look at her from afar, she really does seem like a princess."

Rie is beautiful.

This is something no one can dispute.

The attention she was receiving was enough proof of that.

Even now, everyone looked up at her, trying to get closer to her, hoping to exchange more words.

They were all mesmerized, like insects drawn to a captivating flower.

"Rudy, you said I was pretty too, right?"

"Huh?"

"So...."

She took a step closer, her eyes meeting mine as she asked,

"So, am I pretty, or is Rie pretty?"

Luna spoke, her hands gathered at her chest.

---Toggle New Ads

Luna's bolder than I thought. Also men getting bolder when they find someone attractive? Maybe when they're drunk...

Chapter 84: Winter Ball (6)

"Uh..."

I was at a crossroads.

Luna was looking at me with her round eyes.

Luna and Rie.

These two were completely different.

Objectively, it was difficult to compare the two, and even subjectively, it was hard to decide who was prettier.

Luna, who gives off a pure and warm vibe.

Rie, with her captivating aura and an allure that draws people in.

Their personalities, appearances, and pursuits were all different.

As such, it wasn't possible to rank them like grading at the academy.

So, what choice should I make?

However, people often overlook one thing with difficult problems like this.

The answer was already predetermined.

I immediately made my decision and opened my mouth.

"I think Luna is prettier."

Rie was far away and couldn't hear this.

So, the right choice was Luna, who had asked the question and was right in front of me.

"Huh..."

Upon hearing my words, Luna suddenly turned her head.

Without showing her face to me, she quietly opened her mouth.

"Th-th-thank you!"

Seeing Luna in such a state somehow made me feel shy.

"Hmm... O-okay."

I also turned my head, cleared my throat, and responded.

Just when an awkward silence seemed to be settling in, something happened.

The magical lamps illuminating our surroundings began to turn off one by one.

And only the lamp at the very top stayed lit.

The light from it was cast on one side where Astina stood.

Astina was wearing a dress that was a mix of a moderate blue and white, giving off an elegant vibe.

"Are you all enjoying yourselves?"

Astina asked with a smile.

And then she continued.

"You've all shown incredible dedication this past year. It's been eventful, both for me and the academy."

Astina spoke with emotion, as if reminiscing about the past year.

"Despite my shortcomings as the student council president, I'm eternally grateful to all the professors and council members for their help during my one-year term."

Astina went on sharing her thoughts about the past year.

Seeing her like this stirred many emotions in me as well.

While I was watching Astina, she turned her head and our eyes met.

Astina paused, looked at me, and gave a sweet smile.

"Thank you... really."

And she spoke her final words of thanks, looking in my direction.

Because the lights where I was were off and it was dark, I wasn't sure if she recognized me, but I felt as if she was looking at me.

Astina turned her head and spoke to everyone.

"Now, please enjoy the last party of the year."

As Astina said this, the lights in the banquet hall turned back on.

"This is kind of touching."

As I said that, Luna, who seemed to agree, nodded her head.

"Rudy."

Just then, someone called my name.

"Ah, Rie. Finished with what you were doing?"

I could see Rie walking towards me.

However, something was off.

Her brow was furrowed, eyes glaring in my direction.

".....?"

I looked at Rie with a bewildered expression.

“Uh.....”

Rie approached me with what appeared to be an irritated expression.

Once she got close, she suddenly began to thump my stomach.

“Hey, why! What's going on!”

Her punches didn't hurt that much, but the sudden attack was startling nonetheless.

“Just take it!”

Rie shouted at me with a glower.

I blocked her punches with my arm in surprise.

“You dare, block?”

As soon as I blocked her with my arm, Rie started to hit me wildly.

“.....????”

All I could do was to wear a bewildered look and take the hits from Rie.

“What are you two up to now?”

Astina approached us with a sigh upon seeing me and Rie.

Rie, with a smug look, spoke to Astina.

"There's a reason."

Her words only added to my confusion.

"What...?"

What did I do wrong.....?

“Anyway, I will be taking Rudy Astria with me for a bit.”

Astina suddenly reached out, her hand grabbing my arm.

“Oh, no way!”

“No way!”

Luna and Rie shouted at Astina in response.

“Sigh..... It's only for a moment. I need to discuss something. It's about work.”

Astina's words seemed to dampen Luna and Rie's spirit a bit.

With my arm still in Astina's grasp, I asked her.

“Is it about what you mentioned before?”

Astina nodded subtly and let go of my arm.

“Follow me.”

I silently obeyed and followed her.

After a short walk, a terrace located in a corner of the banquet hall came into view.

A curtain hid it from view, making it look like a private conversation area.

As Astina approached, the servant who was blocking the entrance opened the curtain, allowing us to enter.

“Come in.”

“Did you arrange for this space separately?”

Astina answered my question with a nod.

"What's this all about?"

As I questioned Astina, she hardened her expression for a moment and sat down on a chair on the terrace.

“Where should I start.....”

Astina murmured to herself and slowly began to speak.

“I'll be returning home tomorrow.”

Astina continued.

“You are aware that I won't be at the academy next semester, right?”

“Ah.....”

The first semester of the third year.

This period was an internship period.

A time to experience what one would do after graduating from the academy.

Of course, if one didn't have a decided career path, they could continue studying at the academy, but Astina had a clear career path ahead.

The successor of the Persia Viscount family.

“I will be returning home next semester and will be taking succession classes.”

Although I vaguely knew, it felt odd hearing it directly from Astina.

Astina would be gone for more than half a year starting tomorrow.

The thought of someone I saw every day suddenly disappearing left me with an impending sense of emptiness.

"Sit down for a moment,"

Astina pointed at the chair next to me.

I took a seat and turned to face her.

She responded with a faint smile.

"Honestly, I believe that you, Rie, Luna, and the others all have promising futures. Not because of your status, but due to your prowess in magic and other tasks."

Upon hearing this, I scratched my head,

"Thank you..."

Astina shook her head at my gratitude, continuing her thoughts.

"But, you all are too often caught up in strange incidents. Beyond Luna's abduction, there have been countless other incidents, right?"

"Ahh... Yes,"

I replied with an awkward smile.

"No matter how exceptional your abilities, there are many in this world stronger than you, and you all are still so young. It's quite possible for things to happen that you can't handle."

Astina sighed heavily,

"I feel like I'm leaving a child at the market, especially knowing I'll be away for a while."

I grinned at Astina's concerned expression.

"There were a lot of things, but didn't we overcome them all?"

"Well, that's true,"

she agreed.

I patted my chest reassuringly.

"There's no need for concern. Whatever happens, we'll survive and grow. When you return, you'll find us even better than before."

At this, a smile crept onto Astina's previously worried face.

"I see, hearing you say that makes me feel somewhat relieved."

We exchanged smiles, making eye contact.

"But more than that, I have something else to tell you."

"...Yes?"

Astina glanced toward the terrace entrance briefly, ensuring that no one was nearby before continuing.

"Do you recall Homecoming Day, when I received the Saint's prophecy?"

At Astina's words, my eyes widened.

The Saint's prophecy.

It was meant to be a prophecy about Serina...

But Astina hadn't said anything about it then.

"At that time, there was another prophecy that came down."

"Ahh...,"

I had completely forgotten about it.

Was it something related to Serina?

However, what she said next was something I hadn't anticipated.

"The prophecy I kept hidden was to be wary of you."

"...What?"

I cocked my head, puzzled.

Be wary of me?

The prophecy that should have descended was to be cautious of Serina.

But... the prophecy changed?

"Originally, I had planned to protect you if something happened, but now that I won't be at the academy, I can't do that."

I was too taken aback to respond.

I never imagined the prophecy could change.

"Rudy Astria, I don't know how this prophecy will come into play, but take care of yourself. Be prepared in case something happens to you.

Ask Rie, or ask Luna, and prepare a plan in advance."

Her intense gaze bore into mine as she firmly stated,

"Never, never allow yourself to die."

Astina spoke with utter sincerity.

If I were ignorant of the circumstances, I might have joked, asking 'How can anyone die in the academy?'

However, knowing the future as I did, I could not afford to be so relaxed.

All I could do was respond with equal sincerity.

"I won't die."

Just as I made this pledge, music began to echo from outside.

At that, Astina carefully rose from her seat.

I watched her intently.

"Then, shall we dance a song?"

Astina extended her hand towards me, like a gentleman inviting a lady to dance.

I chuckled softly at the sight.

"I'm no good at dancing."

"Just give it a try."

Astina glared at me as she spoke.

There was no real anger in her gaze.

She was more playful than anything else.

"Very well."

Rising from my seat, I accepted Astina's outstretched hand.

She placed her other hand on my shoulder, and I moved mine to her waist.

The dance was a little clumsy, but I found that by mirroring Astina's movements, I could manage something that resembled dancing.

Astina looked up at me, a smile lighting her face as she saw my awkward expression.

"When I get the chance, I'll come and see you."

Her smile was warm.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 85: Winter Vacation (1)

The day after the ball ended.

I woke up early in the morning to meet Astina.

It wasn't specifically for Astina that I woke up early.

It was merely a combination of my morning exercise routine and the opportunity to see her.

"I'll come by whenever I have the time."

"You'll return in half a year anyway. There will be a lot to learn, so you don't have to force yourself to come."

At my words, Astina gave a faint smile.

"I'm coming because I want to. I'm not forcing myself, don't worry."

With those words, she stepped into the carriage.

"Ah."

Suddenly, as if remembering something, she opened the carriage window to glance at me.

"You seem to have put in some effort this time."

Confused by Astina's comment, I tilted my head.

"What are you talking about?"

Astina gestured towards the main academy building.

"The final exam results are out, aren't they?"

".....Ah."

With that, Astina departed, leaving me to rush towards the academy's main building.

“What’s this?”

[

1. Evan, Rudy Astria

2. Rie Von Ristonia

3. Luna Railer

...

]

I stared blankly at the rankings.

Evan and I.

We were tied for first place.

"How on earth..."

I was at a loss for words.

Up until now, I had taken care of every incident.

Sure, that gave me plenty of practical experience, but it also meant sacrificing time for theoretical learning and other academic studies.

Not to say that I slacked off on my studies.

I had also been diligently studying and had given up on other extracurricular activities to focus on academics.

"This shouldn't be happening, should it?"

Evan had more time on his hands than I did.

Why then did we receive the same score?

I just couldn't understand.

If I had scored perfectly, it might have made some sense.

But that wasn't the case.

There were definitely questions I didn't know, and I had submitted partial answers for some.

Yet, receiving the same grades as Evan in these finals implied neither of us scored perfectly.

"This is just..."

I ruffled my hair in frustration.

"This is annoying."

All the sacrifices I've made so far.

All the things I've given up.

It felt as if they were all going to waste because Evan hadn't put in the effort.

Of course, these rankings were based on final exam scores, so Evan could still be the top student overall.

However, I can't be sure of that either.

Since Rie had taken first place in the joint practical, she could potentially outscore him.

It was unpredictable.

I had always assumed Evan would consistently produce top results.

But that wasn't the case.

“Sigh...”

The reason I had pushed Evan to grow until now was because of the skill he had shown in the final scene.

A skill only Evan could use.

The magic Evan would acquire once he completed his growth in the academy.

But now, doubts began to plague me.

Should I truly trust Evan in this manner?

Can Evan truly master 'that skill'?

Evan's skills are growing at a rate faster than I expect.

But, was this necessarily a good sign?

Would Evan be able to maintain this pace of improvement?

"Hmm....."

My mind was in turmoil.

The shifting futures, and Evan's unpredictable behavior.

Thinking about the impact of these on the world felt overwhelming.

Yet, one thing was certain.

I couldn't simply trust Evan.

I couldn't leave everything to him.

I had to find a new path.

Both to prevent the unforeseen events along the way, and to ensure that everyone in the academy survives in the end...

At the heart of the Empire, within the Astria family mansion.

Tap, tap, tap, tap....

Ian sat behind his office desk, rhythmically drumming his fingers on the table.

Before him lay a document.

A report detailing the incidents at the academy involving Vice Principal Oliver and the Fred family.

Among the names in the report, one stood out.

Rudy Astria.

The biggest factor in the incident.

Indeed, Rudy Astria was that very person.

While it was Robert who ultimately resolved the issue, it was Rudy Astria's initial intervention that provided him the opportunity, making Rudy the hero of the whole event.

This fact offered Ian both discomfort and advantage.

The Astria family was spared scrutiny primarily because of Rudy's actions.

Wouldn't it seem strange that a family member had caused the incident and another from the same family had stopped it?

Of course, those familiar with Rudy's position in the Astria family believed such a scenario was plausible.

With no incriminating evidence against the Astria family and Rudy's actions working as their defense, there were no grounds to investigate them.

"Hmm...."

Yet, despite this advantage, Ian was not pleased.

Actually, had Rudy not intervened, their family wouldn't have attracted any suspicion at all.

Everything would have proceeded smoothly, bringing greater benefits.

They would have acquired Levian's spellbook and Luna Railer, making significant strides in their research.

But now, that had been ruined.

All their plans have been disrupted, including the loss of Vice Principal Oliver and the downfall of the Fred family as collateral damage.

And the one who caused this upheaval was Rudy.

No matter how one spun it, the main disruptor of all their plans wouldn't be viewed favorably, even if he brought some benefits.

It was irritating.

"What on earth is this guy trying to do?"

Ian's initial intention was to merely use Rudy and then discard him.

But if Rudy was going to jeopardize his plans, there was no reason to stand idly by.

The head of the family had already lost interest in Rudy.

And Ian never truly felt that he needed Rudy.

Regardless of Rudy's talents, if he wasn't an asset to the family, then he was a liability.

Given his recent actions, he seemed more like a threat to Ian's position as the family head rather than an asset.

Rudy Astria.

Had all his past behaviors in the family so far been mere pretense?

And was he now revealing his true colors?

If that were the case, Ian was ready for a confrontation.

Ting, ting.

Ian tapped the bell on his desk.

A butler soon entered the office.

"You called for me?"

Looking at the butler, Ian instructed,

"Fetch me some stationery."

The butler cautiously asked,

"Which stationery would you like, sir?"

"Just a regular one will do."

He then added,

"I'm going to send a letter to Liberion Academy."

Ian decided, it was time to call Rudy back to the family.

Luna and Rudy were studying alone in the library.

The disappointment at the ball.

Astina had taken Rudy away, so Luna couldn't dance with him.

But she found solace in the thought of spending the upcoming break with Rudy.

Just the two of them...

As she was lost in her daydreams, a problem arose.

".....You're not going back to the capital?"

Rie unexpectedly appeared, bringing a stack of books to the library.

Rie, who usually didn't visit the library, was now here to study.

"It's not that I won't go at all, I'll just go slowly,"

Rie replied cheekily, taking a seat next to Rudy.

"Wha...!"

Luna's eyes widened.

It was a significant problem.

When two people sat at a table, it was natural to sit across from each other.

That was common sense.

But with three?

The seating arrangement changed.

One could sit next to someone else.

Luna wanted to sit next to Rudy.

If Ena or Riku had been there, she could've sat next to Rudy, but when it was just the two of them, she couldn't.

Although she could brazenly sit next to Rudy, Luna didn't have the audacity to do so.

Rie's smug smile only intensified Luna's annoyance.

Lost in thought, Luna was pulled back to reality by Rudy's voice.

"So, you're planning to stay in the academy for a while?"

"Um... Yeah, why?"

Rudy then slid a book between Luna and Rie.

"Rie, Luna," he pointed to the book, "Can you help me?"

"Huh?"

"Wha?"

Rie and Luna stared at Rudy in confusion.

Until this moment, Rudy had always seemed to shoulder his challenges alone.

Usually, when he asked for help, it was to assist someone else, not himself.

But today, Rudy was different.

"Can you help me?"

The book Rudy pointed to was about elementals.

Specifically, it described how to subdue them when they go berserk.

It detailed various methods related to the topic.

"I'll explain everything about what's to come,"

Rudy said, his expression serious.

"My elemental, Priscilla, and....."

His finger tapped the book,

"What's going to happen to me, in the future."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 86: Winter Vacation (2)

The Saint doesn't simply guess at the future.

While the future changes based on our choices, her prophecies don't.

When the Saint says something will happen, it inevitably will.

In essence, her words are the result, a declaration of a fixed outcome.

No matter how much we struggle, that event will happen.

This is why the Saint doesn't specify the cause leading to her predictions.

Because she knows, in one way or another, the events she has seen will unfold.

Furthermore, she doesn't discuss the aftereffects of her prophecies.

She only knows that it will take place.

That's why she often gives general advice: to be cautious of someone or to watch something closely.

She might not know under what circumstances or in which manner these events will happen.

Nor what changes they may bring about.

But one thing was clear: the prophecy centered on the rampage of Priscilla.

While I wasn't sure what the Saint saw, I was certain that the announcement meant for Homecoming Day was about Priscilla.

Preparing for this became my priority.

"Priscilla will go on a rampage someday."

I shared, looking between Rie and Luna.

"I don't know whether it will be today, tomorrow, or a year from now, but it will inevitably happen."

"Then... what should we do? If an elemental goes on a rampage...."

Luna's voice held a hint of fear.

"How do you know that?"

Rie, eyebrows knitted, asked.

"Astina received a prophecy on Homecoming Day."

At this, Rie nodded.

"For now, I'm preparing for it."

"But if an elemental goes on a rampage...."

Luna looked at me, her face filled with worry.

Rie shared her concern.

They probably both know very well.

"There is a way for the user to survive even if an elemental goes on a rampage,"

I said, aiming to calm them.

Though this concept wasn't widely studied yet, I had a rough idea.

After all, in the game, Serina caused Priscilla to rampage and still survived.

And the method was relatively simple.

"When the elemental rampages, you just need to reverse summon it and calm the user's mana."

"That's exactly why it's a problem; it's not possible."

Rie argued, her face still scrunched up in a frown.

She wasn't wrong.

"Yes, the problem is that it's considered impossible."

A rampaging elemental.

It's like the mana explosion Luna caused in the library.

A mana explosion simply involves the user's mana surging out uncontrollably, and calming the user down is enough.

However, with an elemental rampage, you must soothe both the user and the elemental.

"That's why I'm reading this this."

I pointed to the book in front of me.

It detailed spells related to mana control and mental purification—magic that could potentially control an elemental rampage.

But they were merely theories.

They weren't results of proven research, but mere conjectures.

Merely suggesting, "Couldn't it work this way?"

It wasn't a well-established thesis.

That's why I couldn't tackle this on my own.

Researching this alone would take too much time.

Proving this theory correct through experimentation wasn't something I could achieve by myself at my current level.

"Rie, Luna, could you help me?"

Their reactions were immediate.

"That sounds fun."

"If Rudy needs our help, of course we'd help!"

And so, our research began.

The next day, I received a letter.

"A letter from... my brother?"

I tilted my head in surprise at the unexpected mail.

The name written on it:

Ian Astria.

I carefully opened the letter and began to read its contents.

Most of it seemed like small talk.

Inquiries about my well-being that I wasn't particularly interested in.

As I skimmed through, the main point emerged towards the end.

"Return to the family...?"

Not our family home, but the bustling capital.

Ian wrote about wanting to catch up and asked me to visit during the holidays.

“I’m definitely not going....”

I thought.

The Astria family's home and the capital residence were not the same in many ways.

The residence in the capital was where Ian Astria stayed.

It was more of a temporary lodging for him while he dealt with various affairs in the capital.

On the other hand, the primary residence of the Astria family, where my father, the Duke, resided, was our ancestral home in the Astria territory.

Visiting the capital meant it would just be Ian and me.

I doubted that would end well.

Ian was probably suspicious of me.

After Homecoming Day, rumors about me began to spread throughout the empire.

I've defeated Harpel, outsmarted Serina, achieved success at the Academy, and recently opposed Vice Principal Oliver and the Fred family.

I doubt these went well with him.

So, visiting a place where only Ian was present could only spell trouble.

There was no upside to it.

After thinking it over, I made up my mind.

“I’ll just pretend I didn’t receive the letter.”

If I send a reply saying I won't come, Ian would find a way to drag me to the capital.

Instead, by not responding and showing no reaction, I could buy some time.

When the holidays conclude and another letter appears, I can claim the upcoming semester as a reason to stay away.

With the semester beginning, what could Ian possibly do?

Bang! Bang!

A sudden forceful knocking interrupted my thoughts.

"I got it, I'm coming."

I tossed the letter into the trash and opened the door to see Rie with a multitude of books.

Luna was behind her, equally burdened with various books and stacks of papers.

Rie grumbled, her face scrunched in displeasure,

"Ugh, these are heavy."

"Thanks for bringing them."

I helped Luna and Rie stack the materials in a corner of my room.

Looking around my room, Rie asked,

"Wouldn't it be better to get a separate room for this? Do we have to do it in your room?"

"There's no need. Renting a room outside the academy would only lead to more issues."

We start our research from today onwards.

And the chosen location was none other than my room.

The room was spacious enough for three people, and since it was mine, I felt more at ease.

Initially, I considered reserving one of the academy's laboratories or renting a room outside the academy.

However, I didn't like the idea that our research might get leaked, and the cost of renting a room seemed unnecessary.

Even if I had plenty of money, there was no need to spend unnecessarily.

"Shall we begin?"

We began attaching the magic circles we had designed the previous day to the walls.

We discussed two main plans yesterday.

The first aimed to counteract the elemental.

By focusing on Priscilla's vulnerabilities and the nature of elementals, we intended to gain control.

Rie was in charge of this because she was the most knowledgeable about elementals among us.

The second strategy centered on controlling my mental state and mana.

This task was Luna's.

If I were to lose control, Luna's plan was to use a magic circle to stabilize both my mind and mana.

While Luna and Rie each took on these two tasks, I would assist them.

Honestly, I wanted to take on one of these roles myself, but it's not practical.

If a magical circle had an aspect only I knew about and I went berserk, Luna and Rie wouldn't be able to modify or repair it.

So, I settled into a supportive role.

"Rudy, bring that over."

"Ah, got it."

But something felt wrong.

"Rudy! Can you help me with this?"

"Yeah, like this?"

I responded immediately to Luna's request, too.

Gradually, I felt...

"Rudy. Can you give my shoulder a rub?"

"Rudy! Could you brew some warm tea for me?"

There seemed to be sparks flying between Rie and Luna.

Helping with minor tasks was no problem, but it seemed they were intentionally finding or creating tasks for me to do.

"....."

Regardless, it was my duty to assist them, so I followed their directions.

"Rudy."

"Rudy!"

"....."

In the heart of the Empire lies the Royal Palace.

The Emperor walked slowly down a corridor, his eyes settling on a part of the Palace.

This section had once been the living quarters of the First Princess, Rie.

But now, it seemed deserted with only servants moving about; Rie was nowhere to be seen.

Seeing this, the Emperor addressed his attendant.

"Has Rie not returned yet?"

"Yes... Princess Rie said she has some research at the Academy and will be returning a bit later."

"Hmm... She should come back."

The Emperor looked up to the sky.

Snowflakes began to drift down from the heavens, settling softly in the palace gardens.

"It seems the snow is beginning to fall..."

The Emperor mused, stroking his beard.

"Tell her to return before the snowfall intensifies."

"Yes. I understand."

As the attendant replied, another voice sounded from behind.

"Don't you think my sister can take care of herself?"

It was a voice similar to Rie's, but unlike her calm and mature tone, this one was bright and spirited.

Turning his gaze, the Emperor smiled,

"Hoho, Yuni, you're here."

Speaking was the Second Princess, Yuni von Ristonia, Rie's younger sister.

"Don't you have me by your side, father?"

With a bright smile, Yuni approached the Emperor.

Hearing her, the Emperor chuckled and gently patted her head.

"If you also decide to attend the Academy, what joy will remain for this old man?"

"Even if I decide to attend the Academy, I'll make sure to visit the palace often~"

Yuni responded playfully.

However, considering the rigorous schedule of the academy, frequent visits to the palace would be quite a challenge.

"Even if it's just words, I appreciate it."

The Emperor looked at Yuni with a warm smile.

In response, Yuni's laughter filled the corridor.

Chapter 87: Winter Vacation (3)

Crunch. Crunch.

I was on my way to the library to fetch some materials.

The freshly fallen snow on the ground compressed with a delicate crunch under my feet.

Given it was the holiday break, the academy was deserted, with only the impressions of my steps marring the pristine snow.

Lost in thought, I glanced downward.

Bending over, I reached down and scooped up a handful of snow.

"It's cold."

With my hands, I shaped the snow into a perfect ball.

"Hmm..."

Staring at the round snowball, I made up my mind.

Today, let's have some fun.

With a bounce in my steps, I approached Rie and Luna.

Pushing aside the tasks I had originally planned to do, I immediately went to them.

However, the response I got was unexpected.

"...I don't want to, it's cold."

"Hehe... Rudy, are you still a child?"

"...Huh?"

Their response caught me off guard.

"You... don't have snowball fights?"

For the past two weeks, the two of them had been deeply focused, doing nothing but research.

While I occasionally went out for some physical activity, these two barely moved.

They would hastily eat whatever was available in the room and focus entirely on their research, with no other distractions.

That's why I believed they needed a change of pace.

Two weeks had already passed since we started this project.

At this point, it'd be normal for one to feel stuffed and less productive.

Though it looks like they haven't reached that point.

At first, they would give me peculiar tasks, which was a bit frustrating, but that only lasted a day or two.

Once they truly delved into their research, things progressed smoothly and quickly.

However, I was concerned for them.

Being locked up in a room continuously is detrimental to both physical and mental health.

Even a short walk can make a huge difference in keeping one's mind sharp and alert.

These two hadn't even taken that short walk or any other activity.

I couldn't help but worry.

So, I decided to take action.

I thought that by using the snow as an excuse, I could get them outside, even if just for a little while.

"How about making a snowman then?"

"Rudy! We're not kids. Why would we make a snowman?"

Luna remarked, placing her hands on her hips.

"No... I didn't..."

I was genuinely surprised to hear Luna's comment.

Though Luna wasn't particularly childish, her behavior and mindset were closest to that of the youngest among us.

"Don't go outside, it's cold. Let's stay inside and have some warm tea. We won't ask you to do anything anymore."

Rie said dismissively.

I felt a tad upset.

Was I saying all this for my own sake?

I was just concerned since they were always inside.

Of course, I do love snow.

Seeing the academy grounds blanketed with untouched snow evoked a certain wave of nostalgia.

Especially since the snow at the academy was mostly untouched.

To see this and not build a beautiful white snowman felt almost sinful.

"Fine then..."

I sighed and headed towards the door.

While I rarely ever felt a strong desire to play, I couldn't resist the allure of snow.

But then again, these two weren't just lazing around, they were researching for my sake.

So, suggesting something like this might have been inappropriate.

My excitement got the best of me, what with the snow and all.

Considering the situation, it might've been a bit too much...

"Rudy...?"

As I tried to leave the room, Luna called out to me.

"Yes?"

She hesitated for a moment before speaking.

"Want to play outside for just an hour?"

I stared wide-eyed at Luna's proposal.

"But only make a small snowman and then come back inside, okay? We might catch a cold if we stay out for too long."

"Luna...!"

I was deeply touched by her words.

"Ah..."

Upon hearing that, even Rie put down her pen.

"Alright. But just for a little while."

I suddenly felt a surge of pettiness at Rie's words.

So, she wants to join now that Luna's agreed to it?

I looked at her with a kind smile and began,

“Actually, Rie, if you don't want to come out, you can just stay inside.”

"...What?"

Rie's eyes widened in surprise.

"It's cold outside. We'll play for a bit and come back."

As I said that, Rie began to look flustered.

"No, I mean..."

"Just have some warm tea inside. You can rest until we come back. I won't say anything."

"What... what are you saying!"

Rie was so taken aback she couldn't continue her sentence.

I smirked mischievously, observing her reaction.

Then, turning to Luna, I said,

"Let's just make one snowman and come back, Luna."

"Huh? Oh... okay! Sounds fun!"

Luna seemed initially surprised, but then she responded with a bright smile.

"Ugh... Ugh...!!"

All Rie could do was glare at me with clenched fists, unable to say a word.

"Luna, it's cold outside, so bring a scarf and gloves too."

"Yeah! I brought them just in case when I came to your room earlier!"

"No, wait..."

Rie reached out towards me.

"What? What's wrong?"

I teased Rie playfully.

"I... I want..."

Rie hesitated, unable to ask to join us.

Normally, she would've brushed it off as a joke and just joined, but not today.

"What did you say? I couldn't quite hear you."

I smiled cheekily at Rie.

With pursed lips, Rie glared back.

"What? Have something to say?"

"I... I want to join you guys."

Finally suppressing her frustration, Rie raised her voice at me.

Seeing this, I responded with a bright smile,

"Alright, let's all go together."

“Rudy! Is this how it's done?”

“Yeah! That size looks about right.”

We headed straight out to the Liberion Academy's sports field.

Rie and I began rolling up a massive snowball.

“Do we really have to do this?”

Rie spoke to us with a slightly annoyed expression.

“I mean, sure, we're all dressed up for it, but did you have to wear so many layers?”

I looked at Rie with a mocking glance.

She had bundled up in so many layers that she resembled a snowball herself.

If her clothes were white, they would've blended perfectly with the snowballs we made.

“It's cold. I absolutely despise the cold,”

Rie grumbled, turning her head away.

“But doesn't rolling the snow with your bare hands hurt? Why don't you just let me do it?”

“No way! I even enjoy the sting of the cold on my hands.”

In truth, when we first arrived, there was already a snowman standing.

Rie had quickly conjured one up by using elemental magic to gather snow.

However, I immediately destroyed it.

“That's not a real snowman!”

I felt like a master craftsman witnessing factory-made ceramics—completely artificial and void of soul.

“Rudy! I’ll move this over there!”

“No, no, let me roll it over to you.”

I rolled my larger snowball towards Luna’s smaller one.

“And now, like this…”

I began placing Luna’s smaller snowball atop the one I made.

And just like that, our snowman was complete.

“Phew!”

“Wow!!”

Both Luna and I gazed upon our snowman, wearing proud smiles.

Thankfully, the snow was of good quality and untouched, allowing us to make it quickly.

“Now, let’s…”

I was about to get the bag containing sticks and tools I had prepared for decoration when Rie interrupted.

“Hey, it’s been an hour already.”

“...What?”

I stared at Rie in surprise.

“That’s right. We only agreed to play for an hour, remember?”

Luna nodded in agreement, casting a glance my way. But then...

“Our snowman isn't completely finished yet...”

I looked utterly crestfallen.

Luna then waved her finger at me, adopting a reprimanding tone.

“Rudy! Are you planning to break our promise?”

From the side, Rie smirked mischievously.

“Or would you like me to quickly finish it up for you?”

“Absolutely not!”

I immediately reached out, signaling her to stop, and turned to Luna.

Her stern gaze told me she wasn't going to budge.

Realizing this, I finally gave in.

“Alright... let's finish it another time.”

However, just because I gave up on completing the snowman didn't mean I had lost my playful spirit.

With a swift move, I scooped up some snow, pressed it into a ball, and threw it right at Rie.

“Huh?”

With a soft thud, Rie made a peculiar sound as the snowball struck her.

Because of her tightly-fitting clothes, Rie couldn't evade the incoming snowball.

“So cold!!!”

Rie's eyes widened in surprise as the snowball hit near her neck, and she frantically tried to shake it off.

She reached up to her neck to remove the snow that had found its way inside her collar.

Watching her, I couldn't help but let out a chuckle.

“Hehe... This is what you get for coming out here and not expecting a snowball attack.”

I felt satisfied, having finally managed to hit Rie with a snowball.

“Well, now that you’ve gotten what you deserve... I should head in...”

I said, smiling at Rie.

But I stopped midsentence upon seeing Rie's expression.

Beside Rie floated Sylph, the wind elemental.

And next to Sylph, a massive amount of snow hovered in the air.

“Not satisfied yet?”

Rie stared at me with fierce determination.

“...No, I’m satisfied.”

I backpedaled, my voice edged with nervousness.

However, Rie challenged my statement.

“No, you’re not.”

Whoom.

All the snow that Sylph held suddenly rushed towards me.

“Aaargh!!!”

Caught off guard and unable to conjure any magic in response, I was pelted by the flurry of snow.

“Rudy!!!”

Luna's voice rang out in alarm.

“...It's cold.”

I shivered as I walked towards the dormitory.

“Who told you to do that in the first place?”

Rie said that, but seeing my discomfort, she took off her coat and draped it over me.

Watching this, Luna remarked,

“Rudy, you kind of look like a puppy.”

I looked straight at Luna,

“...Is that a compliment?”

“Hehehe...”

Luna didn't answer, but gave an awkward laugh.

“Good grief...”

Rie sighed, looking at me with a mix of amusement and exasperation.

As we slowly approached the dormitory, a commotion arose.

“Princess Rie!”

The housekeeper, Azela, who managed the dormitory, was rushing towards us.

“Yes?”

Rie tilted her head, noticing Azela's urgency.

“What happened?”

Catching her breath, Azela exclaimed,

“Huff... Huff... His Majesty, the Emperor, has sent a carriage for you!”

“...What?”

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 88: Winter Vacation (4)

A carriage adorned with the royal emblem of a dragon arrived at the front of Liberion Academy.

"No, I said I'm not going."

Rie voiced out defiantly, a frown etching her face.

"Um... His Majesty insisted on bringing you back...."

The knights, visibly bewildered by Rie's refusal, replied.

Despite their attempts to persuade her, Rie held her position.

This standoff between Rie and the knights continued for about ten minutes, and soon Rie began to shiver visibly.

From earlier, Rie seemed to really despise the cold.

Though she was wrapped snugly, she could only fend off the chill for an hour or so in the open, where the wind bit harder.

"Why don't you go inside since it's cold?"

I suggested, guiding Rie gently.

Rie appeared momentarily surprised by my intervention but soon offered a warm smile.

"Ah..."

With my words, the knights seemed to snap out of their stupor, lowering their heads in apology.

"We're sorry. Let's talk inside."

Together, we made our way towards the dormitory.

I went to my room briefly to change out of my wet clothes and then made my way to Rie's room.

The discussion, or rather the argument, between Rie and the knights was still ongoing.

"No, I said I'm not going now, okay? I'll go on my own later."

"But a snowstorm is coming soon, won't it be hard for you to go then?"

"Then I simply won't go."

Arms crossed, Rie stood her ground.

"Oh, Rudy's here?"

As I entered the room, Luna, who had been at the back, greeted me.

"Hm?"

Hearing Luna call my name, the knight, seated, glanced up at me.

"By any chance, are you Young Master Rudy Astria?"

"Ah, yes."

At my confirmation, the knight greeted me warmly, rising from his chair.

"Oh, nice to meet you. I've heard a lot about the Oliver incident."

He extended a hand, cordially shaking mine, although it seemed out of place in our current situation.

But I shook back anyway.

"I really look forward to your future. When the Young Master enters politics and starts active work, I wonder what kind of figure you will show... Haha, the future of the empire is bright."

He chuckled merrily, but even though it was nice to be praised...

As the knight's eyes shifted from me to Rie, understanding dawned on me.

This was a plea for assistance.

He wanted me to persuade Rie to return to the royal palace.

But honestly, I wasn't inclined to help this knight.

Rie's wishes should be respected, and I didn't feel it was right for me to push her, especially when it wasn't my place to interfere.

Frowning, I addressed the knight,

"Nothing will come out of you saying that to me."

The knight seemed to understand and scratched his head in an apologetic manner.

"Ah...I'm sorry."

With a nod at the knight's regret, my eyes found Rie, now settled on the sofa.

"Anyway, I'm not going back. I have things to do."

"...Things you have to do?"

The knight's interest piqued at her words.

"I'm researching magic right now, so I can't go back until it's done."

Rie's voice carried a tone of unwavering determination.

"Sigh... Your Highness... If it's research, can't you get help from the Royal wizards?"

Yet Rie remained unaffected.

"What's the point of that. And I feel more comfortable researching with my friends than those old men."

"And isn't it very cold here..."

"It's not cold at all?"

Rie rebutted the Royal knight's words point by point.

The knight's words gradually faded away.

Then a knock was heard.

"Um, Young Master Rudy, are you in there?"

"...Me?"

I was confused.

After all, this was unquestionably Rie's room.

"Come in."

Following Rie's invitation, a maid walked in.

She was the same maid who had hurried to Rie's side earlier.

The current situation eerily mirrored that one.

"Um, Young Master Rudy... A carriage has arrived."

"...What?"

I was taken aback by her words.

Rie had been receiving countless letters from the Emperor, but for me to get one...

Then it clicked.

"Could it be brother..."

"Yes. Lord Ian Astria sent a carriage."

I clenched my teeth at the news.

A carriage without even a prior letter?

The letter Ian had sent didn't mention anything about sending a carriage at all.

He had merely said let's meet face to face.

It seems he took action when I didn't respond.

Following the maid, a knight stepped into the room.

He was Thomas, the knight I had met on Homecoming Day.

"Young Master Rudy. I've come to escort you."

"..."

Thomas offered a warm, friendly smile.

He appeared pleasant, but remembering what they did to Astina on Homecoming Day, I couldn't think too highly of him.

"Why are you here?"

I asked with a hint of annoyance.

"Ah, didn't you receive the letter from Lord Ian?"

"No, I got it."

With a carriage already sent, I couldn't use the absence of a letter as an excuse.

"I'm doing some magic research right now so I can't go."

"Magic research?"

Thomas echoed my words.

"It looks like I won't be able to leave until I finish my research."

"Ah, I don't think that will work."

"What?"

I narrowed my eyes at Thomas' rejection.

However, Thomas appeared unfazed and continued.

"Right now, the head of the family is also at the Astria mansion in the capital. It was decided that the family members and related people would have a meal together. That's why Lord Ian is looking for you, Lord Rudy."

Hearing this, I gritted my teeth once again.

While I found Thomas irritating, what he said made me pause.

Such a gathering was not mentioned in the letter.

However, I had already discarded the letter, and even if I hadn't, challenging his claim would be difficult.

"Sir... if you don't return, the Duke might get upset... Will that be alright?"

Thomas's words may have sounded like he was looking out for me, but essentially, it was more like a veiled threat.

I took a moment to think.

Was his statement true?

I doubt it.

Would the Duke and Ian genuinely invite me to a family gathering?

Really?

But, on the off chance that it's true...

After a bit of thought, I made my decision.

"Understood. I'll go."

This was a situation I was bound to face sooner or later.

But first, I needed to make some preparations.

Wouldn't I need my own protective measures?

Upon hearing my agreement, Rie and Luna looked at me, their expressions full of surprise.

"Rudy, are you going?"

"Rudy?"

I didn't respond to Rie and Luna's questions and instead turned to Thomas.

"Just give me a moment. I need to organize the research materials I've been working on."

"Ah, that much is possible."

"Luna, can you help me for a moment? I have some things I need to bring."

Luna tilted her head in confusion.

The truth was, I wasn't really bringing any research.

That was because I was only an assistant.

"Yep! Got it."

For now, Luna held off on further questions and approached my side.

Together, we went to my room.

After Rudy announced he would retreat to his room and then vanished.

Rie turned to Thomas,

"If Rudy's going to the capital... Does that mean the Astria mansion there?"

"Ah, yes, that's correct."

Responding to Rie's words, Thomas gave a nod of confirmation.

Upon hearing this, Rie swiftly turned her head towards the Royal Knights.

"I'll be heading back too."

"...Huh?"

"Considering things, getting assistance from the royal wizards seems best for my research. It's also cold here, so I should rest at the palace."

"But... you said researching with friends is best... and that it wasn't that cold..."

"Is there a problem with me leaving?"

"No, no! I'll prepare the carriage immediately."

The Royal Knight appeared a bit taken aback, but he promptly left.

Meanwhile, in Rudy's room, Luna entered, looking rather bewildered.

Rudy, without expressing a word, walked over to a drawer in the corner.

He pulled out a piece of paper from the drawer.

"Rudy, what's that?"

Luna asked, but Rudy didn't reply and instead tore the paper.

Riiiiip

"Huh?"

Luna was startled by Rudy's sudden action, but seeing no change in the room, she tilted her head, puzzled.

"Luna, listen closely. I've activated silent magic. So, no sound will be heard from our surroundings."

"Wh...what?"

Luna couldn't conceal her shock at Rudy's unexpected words.

"Anyway, my relationship with my brother isn't great. It probably got worse after the Oliver incident."

Upon hearing Rudy's words, Luna gave a nod.

"And when I return home this time, it's hard to predict what might happen. So, you need to write a letter and send it to the Astria mansion in the capital."

"A...a letter?"

Luna tried to remain calm.

She had many questions, but it didn't seem like the right moment to ask them.

For now, she focused on the urgent facts Rudy was sharing.

"Also, in 5 days, if you don't receive a response or if I don't return, please ask Professor Robert or Professor Cromwell for help."

With that, Rudy gripped Luna's shoulders.

"I'm counting on you."

"Y-yes!"

Then, Rudy quickly collected a few scrolls and books from his drawer.

"I'm sorry I can't help with the research... I'll be back soon."

With a hastily packed bag, Rudy prepared to depart.

"Ru... Rudy."

At that moment, Luna called out to him.

"Please be careful... don't get hurt..."

Hearing Luna's words, Rudy offered a soft smile.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 89: Winter Vacation (5)

The sound of the wheel catching on rock echoed.

Inside a carriage, I sat alone.

Through the window, I could see Thomas riding beside the carriage on his horse.

"Hmm..."

I stroked my chin, lost in thought.

The reason Ian had called for me.

There seemed to be only one answer when I thought about it.

That I had disrupted Ian's plans.

That I had constantly drawn Ian's attention.

That my potential power was being evaluated very highly.

And...

"..."

On further thought, it wasn't just one reason.

There were a considerable number of them.

I scratched my cheek in thought.

Nevertheless, I felt wronged.

The only time I truly caught Ian's attention was recently.

Prior incidents had other individuals in the limelight, not me.

While I suffered because of those incidents, I wasn't the one who reaped the credit for resolving them.

However, this time was different. All the credit had come to me.

I assumed both Robert and Astina had testified in my favor.

Their words carried weight within the academy, and they had been witnesses to the entire incident.

Because of their testimonies, all the credit came to me.

To be honest, I felt I hadn't done much.

Had Robert not appeared, all my efforts would have been in vain.

So, to be honest, I felt a bit uneasy about it.

A few months ago, I might have been flustered by receiving such credit.

But now, it was different.

Handing everything over to Evan felt like a gamble.

There's a saying about not putting all your eggs in one basket.

If I continued to channel all credit towards Evan and he didn't turn out as I envisioned, it would all be for naught.

In that situation, I would have no choice but to calmly accept my fate.

So, I prepared even for unforeseen circumstances.

I brainstormed ways to survive.

To do that, I needed achievements, power, or even involve myself in the politics around me.

Then, a voice came from outside.

"Young Master Rudy, we are almost at the mansion."

I looked outside upon hearing Thomas's words.

A grand mansion came into view.

Unlike our family home filled with lilies, this mansion exuded elegance and tidiness.

I stepped out of the carriage and stared at the mansion.

"..."

Something felt off.

There wasn't a single person around.

Despite the carriage's arrival, nobody came out to greet us.

I spoke quietly.

"There's no one around."

"Ah, they might be inside, preparing for a meal."

Thomas spoke as if it were nothing.

However, his words didn't sit right with me.

"A meal? Just an ordinary meal?"

"Ah... Well..."

Thomas hesitated as I questioned him.

If it was an ordinary meal, there would be no reason for all the servants to be there.

And if it was a meal with the family, many carriages should have been parked in front of the mansion.

But neither was the case.

I had wondered about it ever since Thomas came to the academy, but I was already sure of what they intended to do.

I was fearful, at first.

But now I was merely curious.

For starters, Ian couldn't kill me.

He sent me here in front of many people.

If he suddenly killed me, even Ian wouldn't be able to get away with it.

So, what was he planning?

I glanced at Thomas and began to walk.

I had taken precautions. It was time to see how these guys would act.

I walked toward the mansion, and Thomas followed.

Upon opening the mansion door, I was met with the sight of a typical mansion interior – stairs and a carpet stretched out below.

I stepped inside.

However, I stopped immediately.

Something felt off.

Clearly, inside the mansion, I should have felt the soft texture of the carpet underfoot, but what I felt was the rough texture of stone.

"...What is this?"

Perplexed by the disparity between what I saw and felt, I looked at Thomas.

Suddenly, I saw Thomas's hand lunging towards me.

"Ugh!"

Thomas forcefully pushed me.

I was shoved further into the mansion.

No, to be precise, it wasn't inside a mansion at all.

"What is this?"

Pushed down by Thomas, I scanned my surroundings.

Before me were iron bars.

Bars that looked like they belonged in a prison.

The floor was bumpy and cold stone.

"What's going on?"

The once-present Thomas had vanished.

I tried to stand up, hoping to get a clearer view outside the bars.

That's when I heard a familiar male voice.

"Have you arrived, Rudy?"

I looked in the direction of the voice.

There stood Ian Astria, my brother.

“What is the meaning of this?”

I said, my gaze fixed on him.

"I didn't want it to come to this."

Ian replied, shrugging.

“I don’t understand why you're doing this.”

I stated flatly.

Ian's eyebrows furrowed in annoyance.

"I truly despise those who act irritatingly before me."

Ian continued.

“That’s why I really liked it when you were being a fool. Thanks to your antics, I always seemed the better one.”

Ian said, seemingly annoyed as he gripped the bars and glared at me.

“But why did you suddenly change your behavior? If you've always acted the fool, why not continue? Did you think someone at the academy would protect you?”

While Ian spoke, I discreetly observed my surroundings.

Honestly, I wasn't particularly interested in such talk.

It wasn't like there was any useful information from it.

First, I decided to focus on the problem in front of me.

How did I end up in a prison?

Illusion magic?

But then, I should have realized as soon as I stepped out of the carriage.

I only realized when I set foot inside.

So, it wasn't as if I was brought here from the start.

I tried to continue the conversation to gather any information while looking around.

"Why are you doing this? Even if I'm an inconvenience, if others find out, they won't just let it slide."

"Well, I don't intend to keep you here forever. I have no intention of hurting you either."

At Ian's words, I frowned.

Ian slid a piece of paper through the bars.

"Sign this document."

I looked at the paper.

It was a withdrawal form from the academy.

"Leave the academy and live quietly in the family's estate. I promise no harm will come to you if you do so."

Withdrawal?

My eyes widened at that.

Then I thought.

Isn't this... not a bad option?

The 'annihilation ending' in the end involves the massacre of students, professors, and others within the academy.

While there might be consequences for those outside the academy, the impact wouldn't be as bad.

I wasn't sure what would follow after that event, but at least I could save my life.

I chuckled at such a thought.

Why was I thinking like this?

Of course, I want to save my own life, but I've already formed deep friendships with the people at the academy.

Could I bear it if they all died? I might go mad in such a situation.

Even if I survived, I would regret that choice.

And there was no guarantee of survival anyway.

Ian of the Astria family was almost like the final boss.

And with Ian's actions, the entire Astria family would be held accountable.

Because of the power Ian possesses, people...

Ah.

I realized what happened.

Ian's power.

No, more precisely, the Astria family's space magic.

The reason the Astria family was recognized and respected in the empire.

It was because of the magic passed down through generations in the Astria family.

And the events that would happen later were largely due to this power.

I asked Ian,

"Did you transport me here using spatial magic?"

Spatial magic.

A ridiculously overpowered magic that can create, tear apart, and destroy space.

The only ones who can wield this formidable magic are the Astria family.

Ian didn't respond to my words.

"I will provide you with a meal once a day. If you decide to listen to me, let the one who brings the meal know."

He simply stated his terms and began to walk out.

I stared intently at Ian's retreating figure.

"Sigh..."

A sigh escaped me, but deep down, I felt slightly relieved.

Just the fact that Ian wasn't guarding this place meant there was a chance I could escape.

However, there was a problem.

"Where on earth am I?"

I did ask Luna to come and save me, but there was no way to tell her about this location.

The person bringing the food is obviously one of Ian's men.

So, I couldn't ask them for any help.

"But can they just leave me like this?"

Upon thinking, the only barrier in front of me was a set of iron bars.

In this situation, I could easily escape using magic.

And yet they just leave me like this?

I clenched my fist.

There's probably some sort of mechanism in place given how confidently he left me.

I looked at the iron bars.

And began to gather mana in my fist.

I don't know what mechanism they've set up, but there's a difference between trying and not trying.

"Phew..."

Gathering mana in my fist...

I swung.

My fist made direct contact with the bars.

And then...

-CLANG

"Ah... AAAAAAAAAAAHH!"

It hurt.

The sound from my fist was like bones breaking.

"Ugh...Hic..."

Holding the hand that struck the bars, I wiped away the tears that trickled down.

It hurt so much.

So much...

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 90: Winter Vacation (6)

Three days had passed since Rudy and Rie left the Academy.

Alone, Luna was doing her research in Rudy's room.

"Hmm...."

Despite Rudy's absence, Luna was able to continue her research in his room since he had left his keys behind.

Luna stared intently at a piece of paper on which she had drawn a magic circle.

"It seems like it's somewhat complete...."

A magic circle to calm the user when an elemental rampage occurs - magic that restores one's mind and mana to their normal state.

Luna had managed to create such a magic circle.

However, there was a problem.

The magic circle could be activated, but she didn't know how effective the magic circle was.

She couldn't test it by herself.

Of course, even if Rudy or Rie were present, she wouldn't be able to use them for experimentation either.

Still, it needed to be tested somehow.

There was a significant difference between a spell whose effects have been confirmed and one that hasn't.

She couldn't declare it complete even after creating it.

"Five days, huh...."

The time Rudy had told her to wait.

Luna was worried.

The words Rudy spoke when he was going to the capital.

He told her he didn't know what would happen to him and if something did, she should ask for help from the professors.

"Hmm...."

Luna rose from her seat.

"I've done quite a bit, maybe I should take a break."

Muttering to herself, Luna walked towards her own room.

As she returned to her room and was about to open the door, she took a quick glance at the wall next to the door.

Attached to the wall next to the door was a mailbox for each student.

She could see a single letter in the mailbox.

"Is it from Rudy?"

It had only been three days, but if Rudy had written a reply as soon as he received her letter, it would have arrived by now.

Luna took the letter out of the mailbox and looked at the sender's name.

The sender's name was clearly written as Rudy Astria.

"Oh...!"

Though she had not seen him for only three days, she was overjoyed to see his name.

Luna quickly took the letter into her room.

She then picked up the letter opener on her desk and opened the letter.

"Let's see...."

As Luna read the letter,

"...."

Her expression grew darker with each word she read.

"What... what is this?"

The letter explained that he would have to stay at the mansion for a while, and he would probably only be able to see her after the break.

Luna read the letter again.

The content did not change, no matter how many times she read it.

However, she could understand one thing.

"...this isn't Rudy."

Luna had seen Rudy for a year.

Not just his face, they had been studying together continuously for a year.

So, she often saw Rudy's handwriting and was familiar with his writing habits.

Of course, this letter showed those habits.

But, it wasn't perfect.

The reason Luna could tell was that Rudy's handwriting was distinctive.

Rudy's handwriting wasn't blocky and straight. It fluttered around freely like cursive.

That was a distinctive feature of Rudy's handwriting.

Rudy's handwriting was so bad that there were times when even he couldn't recognize his own writing.

But this letter...

"It's too legible...!"

Well-written text is usually easy to replicate.

Most of the time, if you tried your best to write neatly, it would somewhat resemble the original.

However, bad handwriting was impossible to mimic.

A scribble so terrible that no one else could replicate it.

Rudy was at that level of penmanship.

Luna abruptly stood up from her seat.

She reached a conclusion.

This letter was not sent by Rudy.

Something had surely happened to him.

Luna didn't waste any time and immediately left the room.

There was no time to delay when Rudy was in potential danger.

".....Vacation?"

"Yes, Professor Cromwell is taking over as Vice Principal, so he won't be at the academy during the holidays."

Luna's eyes widened at the assistant's words.

"Oh...."

The words Rudy had said.

The suggestion to seek help from either Professor Cromwell or Professor Robert.

However, neither of them were currently available.

Typically, professors, despite the holidays, are required to be at the academy at least once, either in the morning or afternoon on weekdays.

Being a professor is not just about teaching students, but also conducting research, so they often stay at the academy even during the holidays.

But, as Luna just learned, Professor Cromwell was on vacation, and for some reason, Professor Robert was in the Fred territory.

Even if she accepted Professor Cromwell's absence, Luna never imagined that Professor Robert would be unavailable as well.

"Ah....Thank you."

"Yeah, take care."

After bidding the assistant goodbye, Luna stepped outside.

She then stood still, looking up at the ceiling.

"Oh...."

None of the people Rudy had suggested to ask for help were available.

And going to the capital alone was problematic.

Infiltrating the Astria household alone, without knowing Rudy's condition, was practically suicide.

"Oh, what should I do?"

Luna frowned where she stood.

She slowly considered who else she could ask for help.

Astina?

Astina would definitely help, but it could take too long, and there were various constraints.

Astina was a talent that the entire empire was currently focusing on.

If such a person suddenly visits the Astria family, it would draw everyone's attention.

Once people's attention is drawn, there would be no opportunity to rescue Rudy.

The Astria family was not an easy target to begin with.

Then....

"Maybe Rie...."

Rie seemed most suitable.

Firstly, being in the capital already gave her a geographical advantage.

However, just herself and Rie would be insufficient.

If Rie was there, they could flee towards the royal palace while escaping with Rudy, so safety was assured if they could just rescue him.

But the rescue itself was the problem.

It was nearly impossible to infiltrate the Astria family with just herself and Rie.

While Luna was lost in thought, a voice came from the side.

"Luna, it's been a while."

Luna turned her head towards the voice.

"...Oh! Professor?"

The owner of the voice was Professor McGuire.

"I thought you had gone home since I haven't seen you recently, but it seems that's not the case."

Professor McGuire said, giving Luna a slight smile.

Seeing him, Luna's face lit up.

And then she spoke up.

"Professor!!!"

"Hm?"

Taken aback by Luna's sudden exclamation, Professor McGuire tilted his head.

That's when Luna asked him.

"Could you please help me?"

In Professor McGuire's research office.

"Here, Luna, it's a warm cup of tea. It must have been cold outside. This tea is quite famous in the north..."

"Luna! I baked these cookies myself! Give them a try!"

"Oh, thank you...!"

Luna had followed Professor McGuire into his office.

But as soon as Luna entered, the assistants who had been wearing haggard expressions widened their eyes in surprise.

Suddenly, their faces lit up, they began rummaging through their bags or sprinting off in various directions.

Soon, they began offering gifts to Luna.

From cookies and desserts to warm tea, and even magical tools.

Various items were presented to her.

Luna scratched her cheek with an awkward smile.

"Ahaha..."

She was wondering how to handle this situation and why they were behaving like this in the first place.

While Luna was lost in thought, Professor McGuire took a seat across from her.

"I'm sorry, I had something to take care of."

"No, not at all! It's not like we set up an appointment."

Looking at Luna, Professor McGuire smiled and then glanced at the assistants who were peering at them from a distance.

"Everyone, out. I have something to discuss with Luna."

"Understood, Professor!"

Upon McGuire's order, the assistants quickly left the office.

McGuire watched them leave and chuckled as if he found the situation absurd.

"They should be that energetic when conducting research..."

"Hmm?"

"It's nothing. So, how can I assist you today?"

At Professor McGuire's question, Luna nervously fiddled with her fingers.

"Well... a friend of mine is in a bit of trouble..."

"Trouble?"

Professor McGuire furrowed his brows at Luna's words.

"If it's dangerous, wouldn't it be better to ask the security personnel or the investigators for help instead of me?"

"Well... the situation is a bit complicated for that..."

Listening to Luna's response, McGuire crossed his legs and leaned back in his chair, stroking his chin in contemplation.

"I take it you're talking about Rudy."

"Huh! How did you know?"

Luna was taken aback by McGuire's insight.

He chuckled at her surprised reaction.

"Heh, with age comes wisdom."

McGuire picked up a cookie from the pile in front of Luna and popped it into his mouth.

"What kind of help are you hoping for?"

Listening to McGuire, Luna began to explain the situation, including her concerns about Rudy who seemed to be in trouble after going to the capital.

As he listened to her story, McGuire continued to stroke his chin thoughtfully.

"That's quite a headache."

"Yes... It's all based on circumstantial evidence, so we don't really have any concrete proof..."

Luna's voice trailed off as she lowered her head.

"Well, you're not one to make things up, and you must have some level of certainty to have sought my help."

"Yes... I may not know much, but I'm sure something has happened to Rudy."

At Luna's words, McGuire nodded in understanding.

"However, I can only provide indirect assistance. If I confront the Astria family head-on, it's not just me; many people around me will be troubled too."

"I understand...."

"But."

Professor McGuire wore a sly grin.

"I am an expert in such indirect assistance."

McGuire stood up from his seat and grabbed the coat hanging on the rack.

Luna cocked her head at McGuire's actions.

"What are you doing?"

"Hmm?"

McGuire gestured towards the door with his chin.

"You said it's urgent, didn't you? We should leave right away."

"What... what do you mean...."

Luna spoke as if she didn't quite understand.

"Let's leave for the capital immediately. Pack only the essentials."

Luna's eyes widened at his words.

"Really? Thank you! Professor! I will never forget this kindness!"

"Yes, make sure you never forget~."

Professor McGuire said, his face lit up with a playful smile.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 91: Winter Vacation (7)

Luna hastily packed her belongings and set off for the heart of the empire with Professor Mcguire.

The heart of the Empire.

The Royal Capital.

Luna had never been there before.

Frankly, there was no reason for a child from a minor noble family like Luna to visit the capital.

She might have visited once or twice if she had relatives in the capital, but there was no one in Luna's family living there.

The idea of going to the capital for the first time made Luna's heart flutter, but she focused first on her purpose of going there.

She had to save Rudy.

Anxiety welled up at the thought of possibly having to fight against Ian Astria, the current greatest talent in the Empire, if things went awry.

However, while she was anxious, she was not afraid.

The fact that Professor Mcguire was by her side gave her a strong sense of security.

Lost in her thoughts, Luna's eyes drifted towards the bag that Professor Mcguire was holding.

This wasn't a typical leather bag; it was a metal one with locks.

Unable to curb her curiosity, Luna voiced her question.

"Professor, what's in that bag?"

"Oh, it's a bag containing magic tools and a few scrolls."

At this, Luna tilted her head.

Wouldn't a standard leather bag be more practical?

A metal bag would be heavy and limiting in mobility.

Still, considering its contents, the sturdiness of a metal bag made sense.

She let the thought pass.

"Oh, right."

Luna clapped her hands and rummaged through her bag.

"Professor, could you take a look at this magic circle for me?"

"Magic circle?"

At Luna's words, Mcguire showed interest.

Luna took a piece of paper out of her bag.

The magic circle she had completed today was drawn on that paper.

It was a magic circle related to mental purification and mana stabilization.

Mcguire looked closely at the magic circle.

And a satisfied smile crossed his face.

Typically, looking at a complicated magic circle might evoke feelings of inadequacy or even despair.

However, that wasn't the case with Luna's magic circle.

Luna's magic circle was one that could make any wizard who researched magic circles feel good.

The runes drawn on the magic circle gave a round and gentle aura, reminiscent of Luna herself.

Additionally, despite the circle's seemingly simple design, the underlying formulas were precise and thorough, making it pleasant to analyze.

However, it wasn't without its issues.

There were still many things Luna lacked.

"You need to rework this part and this control formula. If you rearrange the circuits that could become obstacles inward while maintaining the overall structure, it will be a better magic circle."

Mcguire pointed out the details of the magic circle with his finger and said.

"Oh...."

Luna looked in awe at Mcguire's detailed feedback.

Mcguire smiled at her, saying,

"But you've improved a lot. The overall structure of the magic circle is much better than before. As always, the internal formulas are written best."

"Hehe.... thank you."

Luna scratched her head shyly.

"Well, it seems like it only needs a little modification. I could fix it here, but then your skills won't improve. Try doing it yourself."

"Yes! I got it!"

Luna replied in a cheerful voice.

"Oh, but shouldn't we start writing a letter to Rie soon."

"Oh! Right."

Inside the carriage, Luna and Mcguire came up with a plan.

Rie's help was essential for that plan.

Without Rie, the plan itself could collapse, so they needed to ask for help quickly.

Luna took out the letter paper she had brought and began to write.

In Rie's room,

"Hmm...."

Rie was grappling with a magic circle.

The magic circle she was working on was for sealing elementals, specifically designed to suppress rampaging ones.

However, there was a problem.

There were various methods to suppress an elemental.

One could reverse summon it, or revert it to its original sane state.

Of all these methods, the first she opted for was the reverse summoning technique.

Considering Luna's likely approach to crafting the magic circle, reverting the elemental to its original state would have been the best.

But doing so was extremely challenging, especially for beings that were not human.

For both Rie and Luna, this was a field that was still difficult to grasp.

"This is frustrating...."

Rie groaned, still holding the magic circle.

No matter how she looked at it, she wasn't satisfied.

Neither the magic circle itself nor the elemental control formula within met her expectations.

As Rie was mumbling to herself, there was a knock on her door.

"Ah, come in."

At Rie's words, the maid opened the door and entered.

"Your Highness, some letters have arrived."

Rie glanced at the maid at her words.

The maid held numerous letters.

It was almost the end of the year, so many were sending letters with well-wishes for the upcoming one.

Others were invitations to balls held at the beginning of the new year.

Without paying much attention to the letters, Rie's gaze returned to the magic circle.

"Just tell me who sent them, roughly."

"Yes, understood."

The maid naturally began to read out the names of the families on the letters.

"This is a letter sent by the eldest son of the Zeki family."

"Next."

"A letter sent by the head of the Ribal family..."

"Next."

"...Family's--"

"Next."

Like this, Rie kept on calling out 'next' without listening properly.

"A letter sent by the eldest daughter of the Railer family..."

"Next."

"And then..."

"Hold on."

Rie set down the magic circle she was looking at and turned to the maid.

"Who sent it?"

The maid, looking a little confused, checked the letter again.

"It's from the Railer family."

"Let me see that."

Rie said, rising from her seat.

The maid handed over the letter, though she was puzzled.

She had never heard of the Railer family before.

Several question marks popped up in her head.

Rie, noticing her perplexed expression, extended her hand.

"Huh?"

The maid tilted her head at Rie's sudden gesture.

"A knife, give me a knife. I need it to open the letter."

"Ah, ah."

The maid was surprised.

She hadn't brought a letter opener since Rie had never shown interest in reading the letters before.

"I-I'm sorry!!! I'll bring it right away!!!"

The maid bowed several times and ran out of the room.

"Hmm...."

Rie's expression soured as she watched the maid's frantic exit.

To be honest, there was nobody who would fault her for punishing that maid, but she didn't particularly want to.

She soon shook her head.

"Sylph, please neatly open this letter."

She thought it would be better to just bring out an elemental and have it open the letter.

Sylph delicately brought out a blade of wind and sliced the letter.

Rie carefully pulled out the letter contained in the torn envelope.

And she began to read it slowly.

A moment later,

"Your Highness! I apologize!!!"

"No, it's fine."

Then Rie casually collected the magic circle she had been agonizing over.

"I have somewhere to go for a bit."

"Wha-, where to?"

The maid was greatly surprised.

"I'm just going to step outside for a moment."

"Are you visiting one of the noble families? Should I arrange a carriage and some knights...?"

"No, I'll be going discreetly. Don't make a scene."

"Oh, understood. Then I'll call some of the other maids..."

Assuming Rie was leaving, the maid naturally thought to call others to help Rie get ready.

"No, I said not to make a fuss."

However, Rie rejected this as well.

"I'm...I'm sorry."

Looking at the maid, Rie let out a sigh and walked towards the closet.

"Just help me out a bit. I won't be dressing up much since I'll only be out briefly."

"Yes! Understood."

At that moment.

"What on earth is this?"

Bandaging my hand, I banged against the iron bars.

A few days ago, I had pounded on these bars with my fists and had ended up rolling on the floor in pain.

After a few hours of moaning in pain, a person in a hood came with food.

However, seeing my fist swollen red, they treated me and said,

"You should avoid such pointless acts. There's no escape from here."

This comment provoked me even more.

Who are they to tell me about whether I can get out or not?

Thus, I started studying the confines of this cell.

And I reached a conclusion.

"Mana cannot form properly here."

Within this space, mana dissipates constantly.

Whether trying to use any magic, or attempting to physically strengthen myself.

There was no way to handle mana within these bars.

In desperation, I even tried to summon Priscilla.

"Huff... It's been a while since I've been in the real world... what the?"

She materialized but then vanished instantly.

Even though Priscilla is controlled by my mental strength, she uses the mana within me to manifest.

Thus, she materialized and then instantly disappeared.

I muttered to the Priscilla within me.

"Priscilla, what do you think we should do?"

[You, who always told me not to speak, are now asking for my opinion?]

Priscilla retorted as if annoyed.

"I regret that as well, but it's just how it is."

To converse with Priscilla, I had to speak out loud.

Her voice, however, was unheard by those around.

As a result, when I talked with Priscilla, it looked like I was a madman talking to myself.

And since most of the time I was alone was spent studying, I told Priscilla I wouldn't be able to respond to her most of the time.

Initially, she would speak to me often, but after being continuously ignored, she stopped addressing me altogether.

"I have my own circumstances too."

And now, I am completely alone.

Feeling lonely by myself, I began to chat with Priscilla more.

[Haa... If I knew it was going to be like this, I would've contracted with Serina instead. This is truly the most regrettable decision of my elemental life.]

But every time I tried to talk, Priscilla would grumble at me.

She seemed upset, perhaps because I hadn't paid her enough attention in the past.

It was understandable.

"I... I'm sorry. I promise I'll call upon you more often."

[That's if we can get out of here.]

"Haa... Yes, if we get out...."

I stared hard at the iron bars.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 92: Winter Vacation (8)

The following day.

Rie's room was bustling with maids from the morning.

The previous night, Rie had secretly ventured somewhere and upon her return, she instructed her maids,

“I will visit the Astria House tomorrow. Make sure everything is prepared.”

Her words had greatly surprised the maids.

It was well-known that Rie and the Astria family were on bad terms.

Although the students at the academy knew that she got along quite well with Rudy, such a rumor had not yet spread to the capital.

Rie, dressed in her finest, walked out.

As she exited the palace gates, a carriage awaited her, and beside it stood knights in full uniform.

“Alright, let's go.”

Rie said, and escorted by the knights, she climbed into the carriage.

A carriage with the royal crest etched on it and the knights in uniform signified a formal visit to the Astria household.

Though it was somewhat rude to announce a visit just a day in advance and then arrive with such fanfare, Rie didn't seem to care.

Those around her were puzzled by her actions, but since Rie had decided on this course, they went along, ensuring everything proceeded without a hitch.

After some time passed.

The Astria mansion in the capital.

They were preparing a lavish banquet upon hearing the sudden news of Rie's visit.

In the midst of the chaos, Ian was lost in thought.

"Is she visiting because of Rudy?"

Rie was present when Rudy announced he was returning to the family.

In addition, he had heard rumors that Rie and Rudy were quite close at the academy.

Considering these facts, Ian had somewhat predicted this event to happen.

It was inevitable since they were close to the royal palace in the capital.

Still, imprisoning Rudy in the distant Astria territory, where their father resided, wasn't an option either.

"My Lord Ian,"

Thomas approached, interrupting Ian's thoughts.

"Princess Rie has arrived."

Ian nodded slightly at his words.

"Understood. Let's go greet her."

With that, Ian walked towards the front of the mansion.

There, he saw Rie, who had arrived in a splendid outfit.

Ian approached Rie first and greeted her.

"Princess, welcome to the Astria mansion."

"Ah, Ian Astria. It's good to see you,"

Rie responded with a faint hint of disdain.

Few dared to show such an attitude toward the heir of the Astria House.

Though he was taken aback, Ian suppressed his discomfort.

For now, he was still only the Astria heir.

He could not treat the princess casually.

Not yet, at least.

"Well, shall we go inside?"

Ian spoke, but Rie did not move and tilted her head.

"Where's Rudy?"

"Ah, you are asking about Rudy."

At this, Ian smirked.

"Right now, Rudy is feeling unwell and is resting in bed."

"Ah, is that so?"

Rie responded, feigning ignorance.

She then added,

"In that case, I should at least pay him a visit. Can you guide me?"

A moment of silence followed Rie's request.

She watched Ian closely, keen on observing his reaction.

However, Ian didn't show any signs of being flustered.

“He's contracted a contagious illness. I'm concerned that if you get too close, Your Highness might also fall ill.”

Rie frowned at his words.

“So, you're saying I can't even see his face?”

“I apologize. Based on the doctor's advice, even the servants are currently advised against approaching him.”

Rie nodded in understanding.

It would be somewhat unreasonable to insist on visiting if the doctor had given such instructions.

She chose to show understanding instead.

"Then, let's proceed inside."

Guided by Ian, Rie entered the mansion and headed towards the dining area.

A lavish feast was spread out in the dining area.

Rie and Ian took their seats and began their meal.

During the meal, Rie was the first to speak.

"Rudy, he's a nice friend."

Ian grimaced at Rie's comment.

Rudy, nice?

What an absurd statement, he thought.

Of course, the Astria family had tried their best to educate Rudy properly.

But despite their efforts, Rudy was still a mess.

Even if he didn't show it at the academy, Ian thought it was only a matter of time.

Nevertheless, he flashed a smile and responded.

"He is of the Astria family, after all."

Ian seemed to agree with Rie, but his tone implied that it was thanks to the Astria family's efforts that Rudy could present himself well.

Rie chuckled at his response.

"Well, receiving good guidance doesn't always equate to absorbing good lessons."

She gave Ian a teasing smile and continued,

"Just like how two people can receive the same education but they might not learn the same lessons."

A vein popped on Ian's forehead at her comment.

It was an implied criticism - 'While Rudy learned well, why haven't you?'

Ian was well aware that his achievements far surpassed Rudy's, a fact recognized by everyone.

Yet, here was Rie, implying that Rudy was superior to him.

Ian was about to retort, but swallowed his words.

Her indirect criticism would only put him in a difficult position if Rie chose to play innocent.

"Well... I am thankful that you think so highly of Rudy."

Ian gritted his teeth and forced a response.

Rie looked at him and giggled.

It was a smile of victory.

"Excuse me, I'll be right back."

Rie excused herself, a polite way of saying she needed to use the restroom.

Leaving her seat, she strolled around the mansion.

A maid followed her, but Rie didn't pay any mind to her.

"Oh, Princess Rie? This is...."

The maid guided Rie to the restroom, but Rie didn't stop there.

She kept walking.

"Princess Rie?"

Rie paused her steps for a moment and scanned her surroundings.

There was no one else around.

Rie looked at the maid with a smile.

"Well, can you tell me where Rudy's room is?"

After intimidating the maid in this manner, Rie began to run.

She was wearing a dress, which made it inconvenient to run, so she held up her skirt to prevent it from touching the ground.

"Is it there?"

After a quick run, she arrived near Rudy's room, pointed out by the maid.

As Rie reached the door, a voice called out from behind her.

"Princess Rie, where are you headed?"

Turning around, she saw Ian.

He greeted her with a knowing smile.

"Let's go back. Didn't I tell you about Rudy's condition earlier?"

Rie gave Ian a fleeting glance before abruptly making her way into Rudy's room.

"Rudy!"

She exclaimed as she pushed the door open.

But what met her eyes was...

"Huh?"

Rudy, soundly sleeping on the bed.

Ian walked up behind Rie, who was blankly staring at Rudy.

"Princess, what are you doing? What if you catch his disease?"

"This is..."

Before Rie could react further, Ian interjected,

"Look, Rudy is asleep. Let's not disturb him. Please, let's go back to the dining area."

Ian grinned knowingly.

The figure of Rudy she saw was an illusion—a magic Ian had prepared in advance.

The individual sleeping there was just a regular maid, temporarily put to sleep.

Ian had altered her appearance using illusion magic.

Ian had showcased this to the staff to make them believe Rudy was resting at home due to illness.

They all believed Rudy was recovering at the mansion.

Rie briefly looked at the illusion of Rudy before exiting the room.

"What made you act so recklessly?"

"Uh..."

Rie frowned deeply, clearly not pleased.

Ian looked content.

It would take at least 10 minutes for someone of Rie's level to realize it was illusion magic.

"Let's go back."

Ian took the lead and guided Rie back to the dining area.

She followed, a hint of frustration evident.

And then, a sly smile graced Rie's lips.

Everything seemed to be going according to plan.

"Professor, Rie has set off."

Luna reported, eyeing the carriage bearing the royal crest.

"Alright, let's get started as well."

Opening his iron suitcase, Professor Mcguire pulled out and tore a scroll.

With that action, a dove enveloped in a bright light appeared.

"Show us where Rudy Astria is."

At his command, the dove slowly ascended, circling in the sky as if beckoning them to follow.

"Let's go, Luna."

"Yes, Professor."

The plan of Luna, Rie, and Professor Mcguire wasn't to confirm whether Rudy was at the Astria manor.

They already knew that Rudy was not in the manor.

The reason Rie went to the Astria mansion was to lure Ian into complacency.

They aimed to make it appear as if even those close to Rudy still weren't aware of his whereabouts.

That's why she headed to the mansion.

But in truth, they had a general idea of where Rudy was.

While they didn't know his exact location, they were certain he wasn't at the Astria mansion.

Among the various magical tools in Professor Mcguire's possession, several could locate a person.

This included the dove they just utilized, and other tools that could confirm the direction of the person sought.

So, the moment they arrived in the capital, they knew Rudy wasn't at the Astria mansion.

While they had a rough idea of Rudy's location, there was a problem.

There was a risk that Ian might find out they were trying to rescue Rudy.

Even with Professor Mcguire with her, a direct confrontation with Ian wasn't an option.

Even if Mcguire were to truly engage in battle, there was no guarantee of victory over Ian, and any fight would assuredly result in heavy losses.

They orchestrated a plan where Rie would divert Ian's attention, while Luna and Professor Mcguire would rescue Rudy.

If Rie officially visited the Astria family in the royal carriage, Ian couldn't casually leave his position.

And there, while Rie was pretending to be ignorant of Rudy's whereabouts.

They'd use the opportunity to rescue Rudy.

It was a diversionary tactic.

"Luna, this way."

"Yes, Professor!"

With that, Luna and Professor Mcguire sprinted towards where Rudy was.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 93: Winter Vacation (9)

The glowing dove pointed towards the outskirts of the capital.

A remote area devoid of people.

Luna ran alongside Professor Mcguire.

“Huff... Huff...”

Luna was out of breath from running for so long.

“Luna, we're almost there. Hang on just a bit longer.”

“Huff... Okay!”

Luna replied energetically to Mcguire's encouragement.

They approached a small forest located on the outskirts of the capital.

But the forest gave off a somewhat eerie vibe.

Perhaps because of winter, there were no leaves on the trees, just bare, withered branches.

Navigating through the trees, they spotted a decrepit hut that looked almost abandoned.

The glowing dove circled above the hut.

“Is this the place?”

Professor Mcguire reached out towards the sky.

The hovering dove flew into his hand and vanished.

Swallowing hard, Luna slowly approached the hut.

Just then, Mcguire extended his hand to stop her.

“Luna, wait for a moment.”

“Yes?”

Luna tilted her head in response to Mcguire's statement.

“Hmm...”

Mcguire intently observed the hut.

"A magical alarm, huh."

There was a magic setup.

However, it wasn't just one spell.

There were others as well.

The entire hut felt like it was enveloped in a magical circle.

It seemed to function like a magical artifact itself.

Mcguire reached out to feel the mana flowing within the hut.

He could discern two or three distinct magic circles inscribed within, but the mana flowing within was unusual.

“Hmm...”

Mcguire pondered.

If they entered the hut, Ian Astria would likely become aware of it.

And they didn't know what the interior of the hut looked like, but if they fought inside, it would be a greatly disadvantaged battle.

But the hut itself didn't seem to pose a danger.

Mcguire made up his mind.

“Luna, you should go in alone.”

“Huh?”

Luna looked at Mcguire, surprised.

"There is nothing inside that would threaten your life. There are no people inside either. So, you don't need to worry too much."

"But, Professor..."

"I will block the one who will come here."

Professor Mcguire opened his briefcase and took out several magic tools.

"Don't worry about me, once you find Rudy, escape quickly."

Luna found herself at a loss for words.

The only person she could think of who might approach the hut was Ian Astria.

Was Mcguire saying he'd fend off Ian?

Silent, Luna trusted Mcguire, but the idea of him taking on such a risk for her sake left her speechless.

Seeing Luna's conflicted expression, Mcguire grinned.

“Luna, what's the advantage of a wizard who uses magical circles?”

“Pardon?”

Luna was taken aback by McGuire's sudden question.

“Understanding your opponent, knowing oneself, and preparing accordingly—that's where our true strength lies,”

McGuire commented, gently tapping Luna's head.

"I'm in the best position to maximize that advantage right now. So don't worry."

Luna clenched her fist, looking up at him,

“Professor, please be careful. I'll see you later.”

She bowed gracefully, bending her waist in a neat 90-degree angle as a sign of respect, and then dashed into the hut.

Watching her retreating figure, a fleeting smile crossed Professor McGuire's face, but it soon turned somber.

He began to take out one, then two magical tools.

Ian Astria.

He had observed the young man's abilities and temperament a few times when he was attending the academy.

Of course, at that time, he couldn't use space magic, but it didn't matter.

Even with the usage of space magic, there wouldn't be much difference.

After all, he wouldn't let Ian get the kind of environment where he could fight effectively.

Armed with his array of magical tools, McGuire slowly rose from his seat, murmuring,

"Maybe it's time to deal with that brat."

At the Astria mansion in the capital, Ian was blissfully unaware of the unfolding events, enjoying tea with Princess Rie.

Their conversation seemed casual and relaxed.

Still, Rie looked somewhat uneasy.

Ian believed he had flawlessly hidden information about Rudy.

Rie, inside, was smiling, deeply satisfied.

She knew everything Ian was trying to hide.

She was merely putting on an act, a performance filled with her utmost dedication.

But Ian, oblivious, responded with a smile of his own.

"Heh..."

As he moved to take a sip from his tea cup,

Thud.

The noise wasn't from their surroundings.

It was a resonance of his own mana.

The cabin where Rudy was imprisoned.

Someone had intruded.

Who could it be?

Ian's gaze met Rie's, who appeared just as bothered as before.

Ian was perplexed.

How could this happen when Princess Rie, who should be searching for Rudy, was sitting right here clueless?

But he quickly made up his mind.

The fact remained that someone had intruded on the hut, and regardless of their connection to Princess Rie, they had to be dealt with.

Normally, Ian would have sent Thomas or someone else, but something felt off.

The unexpected visit from Rie combined with the intrusion of the cabin felt too contradictory, increasing his sense of unease.

Ultimately, Ian decided he needed to personally investigate.

"Princess, I must step out briefly."

"You have to leave?"

Rie asked, as if clueless.

"Yes, a small matter has come up."

"Why would you leave me alone here?"

Rie frowned, clearly displeased.

Leaving a guest unattended, even for a bathroom break, was obviously considered rude.

"I apologize. Can I ask for just a moment of your patience?"

Annoyed, Ian bowed slightly.

"Is it something within the mansion you need to attend to?"

When Rie posed the question, Ian paused for a moment before nodding,

"Yes, I just need to briefly visit my office."

"Well, please be quick. I'll wait."

After giving a brief bow to Rie, Ian exited the room.

"What a hassle."

He muttered under his breath.

He couldn't leave Rie alone for too long.

However, Ian figured a brief check wouldn't hurt.

"Teleport."

Ian's space magic.

It allowed him to instantly move to a desired location.

With this spell, he believed he could quickly check on the cabin and return quickly.

No matter who the opponent might be, all Ian needed to do was suppress them forcefully and quickly return.

Ian's body emitted a faint light and attempted to teleport towards the hut.

No, he tried to move towards the hut.

"Huh?"

However, the place he found himself in was a white room.

There was no sign of the hut, nor any trees.

Even looking up, there was no sight of the sun.

He was simply surrounded by white walls.

An entirely empty, white room.

"What's going on?"

Ian's brow furrowed.

He had clearly intended to move in front of the cabin, there was no issue with that.

There was absolutely no reason he would've ended up in this peculiar room.

Then there was only one explanation.

"An illusion?"

Ian let out a sarcastic laugh.

With a low voice, Ian muttered,

"Just what are you trying to achieve with this kind of illusion?"

He then slowly approached one of the walls.

"Who's behind this? Are you with Princess Rie?"

As he approached the wall, something began to materialize from it.

A familiar face appeared before him.

"Principal McDowell?"

Suddenly, the image of Principal McDowell appeared and glared at Ian.

Taken aback by the unexpected appearance of McDowell, Ian's expression darkened.

McDowell looked at Ian and spoke with a hint of pity.

"You really haven't changed, have you?"

His gaze seemed a mix of pity and regret.

Ian clenched his fists in response.

"Who are you to say that?"

Ian's voice was thick with anger.

"I have changed. I've become strong enough to fight and defeat someone like you."

McDowell shook his head in response.

"Ian Astria. You may have grown stronger. But, that's not what's important."

Ian continued to glare at McDowell, fists clenched tight.

He was about to retort, but then he paused, a smirk forming on his lips.

"Sigh..."

Taking a deep breath, Ian quickly realized the situation.

This was an illusion.

This McDowell wasn't the real Principal McDowell he knew.

Ian came to a conclusion.

"A well-crafted illusion indeed. Created by someone who knows of my conversations with McDowell..."

Ian reached out his hand.

"However, an illusion remains just that."

Ian's mana surged powerfully, and magic erupted from his hand.

"Let's see if this illusion can withstand my magic."

Ian smirked confidently.

"Space Rift."

With a loud crack, the space around McDowell seemed to fracture.

Not only that, but the fracture began to spread, causing the surroundings to crack and split.

As if it was about to shatter the space itself.

It was a spell that directly damaged the very fabric of space.

The fracture continued to expand, tearing apart the image of McDowell and leaving significant cracks in the white room.

"Ha!"

Looking at the torn image of McDowell, Ian let out a triumphant laugh.

However, that brief moment of laughter was fleeting.

Something was wrong.

Only the illusion of McDowell had been shattered, and the surrounding environment remained unchanged.

Ordinarily, if such a powerful spell was used, the surrounding illusions would disappear.

Yet, they stayed.

"What's going on?"

Ian was puzzled as he saw the space rift gradually mending itself.

And then he noticed something even more peculiar.

The magic he had used, the space rift, had paused halfway through its mending process.

"Why is this happening?"

Ian frowned deeply.

The space rift spell, as its name suggested, momentarily caused a crack in space.

Even if this rift was made, the recuperative power of space was immensely strong, healing almost immediately.

Of course, anyone caught within this rift would have been torn apart by it.

Yet, the magic he'd just used seemed to be mending slower than usual, until it stopped, leaving a visible crack in space.

With a furrowed brow, Ian approached the crack, reaching out with a finger to touch it.

Crack.

"What the...?!"

Upon his touch, the crack expanded rapidly.

The entirety of the white room Ian was trapped in began to fracture.

The entire space trembled violently.

"Gah...!"

The ground and ceiling started to sway and shake drastically.

Ian, unable to maintain his balance, stumbled.

And then the ground beneath him began to fracture.

"No way...!!!"

The ground beneath Ian started to crumble, breaking apart from the center outwards.

Ian, disregarding the illusion and everything else, rushed towards the edges of the white room.

However, the ground was crumbling faster than he could run.

"Aghhh!!!"

Ian began to fall, plunging into a vast abyss of darkness.

Meanwhile, amidst this chaos...

"Phew..."

Around the area, broken trees littered the scene.

Next to it, Professor McGuire let out a sigh of relief.

He had narrowly escaped being engulfed by Ian's spatial magic.

"That was close."

McGuire smiled.

Lying around him were countless magic tools besides the shattered trees.

These were the tools he'd used to deceive Ian.

Fighting head-on would have risked his identity being exposed, and the damage could have been significant.

So, McGuire's plan was to deceive Ian using illusion magic.

A very meticulous plan.

McGuire had a rough idea about Ian's space magic.

He knew it could allow for instant long-distance travel, and create a crack in space.

So, he decided to counter the 'Teleport'.

Mcguire had set up a magic tool that directed surrounding coordinates to one specific location.

To utilize the 'Teleportation' spell, one first designates spatial coordinates to specify the destination.

It's essentially magic that sets coordinates.

While space magic can set such coordinates, there are countless other magic that can do the same.

So, there's no shortage of magic tools designed to counteract such spells.

Next, he decided to counter 'Space Rift' magic.

To trick Ian into using this spell, he decided to project an illusion of Principal McDowell.

Ian held immense pride in his strength.

However, Ian had once been shocked when McDowell told him at the academy that strength alone would get him nothing.

It was a traumatic experience for Ian.

If the illusionary McDowell said something similar, it would provoke Ian.

Then Ian would use his strongest spell, as if to refute the notion that power alone wasn't everything.

And everything went as predicted.

In the end, Mcguire, activated a previously set magic tool.

This device was placed at the center of the area where the illusion spell was being cast.

It was a straightforward tool, engraved with the basic earth magic spell, 'Dig', designed simply to excavate the ground.

When Ian used his space magic, Mcguire would activate this device.

In an instant, the earth was dug up, and Ian found himself plummeting into the darkness.

"Little brat. What's the use of just being strong?"

Mcguire laughed, peering down into the pit.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 94: Winter Vacation (10)

"What's this?"

Luna looked around with a puzzled expression as she entered the cabin.

Upon stepping inside, she saw a completely ordinary household interior.

A kitchen and a dining table were present, just like any typical home.

However, the place looked as though it had been abandoned for years.

Spiderwebs spanned the shelves in the kitchen with rats scurrying about.

The dining table was broken, its wooden fragments scattered all over.

"Rudy...?"

Luna cautiously scanned the cabin's interior.

A cursory glance revealed nothing suspicious.

"Could there be a secret passage or something?"

There was no immediate sign of anything like that.

So how was she supposed to find it?

Luna recalled a method she had learned when she was about ten years old, during her mischievous days.

It was about finding hidden things.

"Wind Cutter!"

Bang!

“Wind Blast!”

Crash!

The method was quite straightforward: simply break everything in sight.

If something was hidden, destroying things would reveal it.

It was like tipping a basket to find something at its bottom rather than searching through its contents.

As she was wreaking havoc inside, Luna noticed something.

"Huh?"

A random spell hit the bed, breaking it and revealing a hole beneath it.

Luna smiled.

It was such a cliché hiding spot.

“Rudy...!”

She quickly cleared the debris from the bed to get a better view of the hole.

Stone steps leading downwards came into view.

“Ignite!”

She conjured a flame with her magic to illuminate the passage.

While the magic did shed some light, she couldn't see all the way to the bottom.

“I guess... I have to go down?”

Luna was apprehensive, but she had no other choice.

Using the flame to light her way, she began her descent.

A few steps in, Luna sensed something was off.

Flick!

“Huh?”

Suddenly, her spell extinguished with a soft sound.

“Why did that happen?”

Luna tried to use the spell again in panic, but nothing changed.

“Ignite!”

Flick!

No matter how many times she tried, the outcome remained the same.

“Ugh...”

In the dark stairwell, where she couldn’t see even an inch ahead, and with her magic rendered useless, fear began to grip her heart.

Placing one hand on her chest and the other against the wall, Luna carefully continued her descent.

"_____."

Suddenly, she began hearing faint whispers.

“Wha...?”

It sounded like a human voice.

Luna remembered Professor McGuire’s words: He had mentioned that no one else was here except Rudy.

So why was she hearing voices?

A feeling of dread washed over Luna.

“Who... who's there?”

She asked cautiously.

However, her voice was so faint from fear that it barely came out.

“Don’t do that ——!”

Suddenly, a louder voice echoed, as if someone was in conversation with another.

"Who...?"

Even if it was Rudy's voice, there was no one for Rudy to talk to here.

Because there was no one else in this place.

Could it be...

Luna thought.

It had been about three days since Rudy disappeared.

Being alone in such a dark space could slowly deteriorate one's sanity, or so she had heard.

For one's mental well-being, it was essential to see some light and interact with people.

However, the current situation was incredibly bleak, devoid of any stimuli.

Due to its underground location, the air was also damp and carried a musty scent.

In that case...

Alarmed by her realization, Luna began to descend.

"Ru-, Rudy! Rudy!"

Luna hurriedly made her way down the staircase.

As she did, a voice grew clearer and more distinct.

It was unmistakably Rudy's voice.

"No! That's not how the rules work!"

Rules?

The words she heard made no sense to her.

Then, his voice rang out again.

"That's the fun part! The process of overcoming your opponent!"

The tone sounded agitated.

Hearing Rudy's voice like that, Luna felt tears well up.

Rudy... Rudy...!

She rushed down the stairs.

Suddenly, instead of another step, the ground leveled out.

"Ah!"

Luna's foot caught on the unexpected flat surface.

She lost her balance and, with a thud, landed on the ground.

"Ouch... That hurts..."

Rubbing her wounded hand, Luna looked up.

"Luna...?"

Then she heard Rudy's voice.

As her eyes adjusted to the darkness, she recognized shapes in the dimness.

"Rudy!!"

Rudy was confined behind a set of iron bars.

And surprisingly, he was sitting there, looking relatively fine.

"...Huh?"

However, what he was doing seemed strange.

Holding a small stone in his hand, he was scribbling something on the floor as if he was writing.

It appeared as if he was marking scores, almost like he was playing a game.

"Ru-, Rudy..."

Seeing this, Luna's face fell.

"I'm so sorry...!!! I should have come sooner...!!"

With teary eyes, Luna approached the bars.

Rudy, seeing her emotional state, looked bewildered.

"Lu-, Luna! What's wrong? Calm down!"

"Sob... I'm sorry, Rudy..."

"What are you talking about all of a sudden?"

Locked behind the bars, Rudy could only look on with a stunned expression, unable to console her.

"So, this game is called 'Number Baseball'."

[Baseball? What's that?]

"Ah, the name isn't that important."

I was preparing a game to play with Priscilla.

Fortunately, I found a small pebble on the ground and thought of a few games that could be played with it.

Initially, Priscilla and I just chatted, but there's only so much you can talk about.

"So, you write a number here..."

I began to slowly explain the rules of the game to Priscilla.

However, the response I got was entirely unexpected.

[Why go through such a process?]

"Huh? Because it's fun?"

[Do humans find that amusing? Why not just tell each other the answers from the beginning? That way, you can enjoy more games quickly.]

I was taken aback by Priscilla's perspective.

Trying to persuade her, I explained,

"If we do that, we can't determine a winner or loser. It's fun when you beat your opponent."

[Is that so? Then I'll just tell you my answer. I doubt I'll find much joy in winning anyway.]

"No! That's not how the rules work!"

It was at that moment that I deeply felt the difference between elementals like Priscilla and humans.

[Sigh, you humans and your tedious games.]

I could sense a hint of exasperation in Priscilla's voice, but I continued,

"That's the fun part! The process of overcoming your opponent!"

[Sigh... Alright.]

Why couldn't she understand?

Suddenly, I heard hurried footsteps approaching, the sound echoing as if someone was quickly descending the stairs.

Was someone coming?

I paused my conversation with Priscilla and turned to look at the stairs.

As I did, a figure rushed down the steps.

"Eek!"

The person descended swiftly but tripped on the last step, tumbling to the floor with a thud.

I focused on the person's face and clothes, recognition lighting up my face.

"Luna...?"

"Rudy!!!"

Luna burst into tears.

"I'm so sorry...!!! I should have come sooner...!!!"

"Lu-Luna! Calm down! What's going on?"

... A brief moment of chaos ensued.

After consoling Luna, I updated her about my situation, and she filled me in on hers.

"Aha... You were talking to Priscilla, the elemental...?"

Luna chuckled awkwardly, a hint of embarrassment on her face.

"Yeah... I usually avoided speaking with her in public because of how people might react..."

[Humans really do worry about the strangest things.]

"It's the elementals who are peculiar, not humans."

I retorted, slightly annoyed by Priscilla's comment.

"Huh?"

Luna tilted her head, looking at me with curiosity.

"Ah, never mind. Priscilla just made a comment."

"I see."

Luna nodded understandingly.

"For now, let me get you out of there!"

With that, Luna extended her hand towards the iron bars.

"Wind Cutter!"

With a whoosh, a sound reminiscent of air escaping from a balloon echoed.

From Luna's hand, instead of a blade of wind shooting forth, there was only a feeble gust.

“Sigh...”

“Huh?”

Luna looked confused.

Seeing her like this, I spoke up,

“Luna, listen closely. Magic can’t be used here.”

“Can't use magic...? Oh right, when I was descending...”

Luna, as if she had realized something, clapped her hands together.

“So... how do we get out of here?”

Luna stared at me intently, seeking an answer.

“In truth, the best way would be to bring something from outside to cut through these iron bars...”

However, that was nearly an impossible option.

In this world, using magic was the most efficient method to cut through such iron.

So, finding a tool to cut these bars would take a very long amount of time.

We didn't have that kind of time.

According to Luna, Professor Mcguire was outside, holding Ian.

We needed to escape, and fast.

“...Luna, I've...”

While being trapped here, I’d thought of a way to get out on my own.

In my contemplation, along with Priscilla, we reached a conclusion.

We could induce Priscilla to go on a rampage.

A rampage, in this context, referred to raw mana bursting out uncontrollably.

I could use Priscilla this way regardless of this room's unique ability to disrupt one's ability to control mana.

The problem was that doing so might destroy me.

“By any chance... how far along is the magic circle for calming the mind?”

“Huh?”

To be honest, it was a shameless question.

Asking about its progress just two weeks in could be considered impolite.

Yet, I believed in Luna's potential and so I asked.

“It’s mostly complete, but...”

Luna trailed off.

“There are some parts I need to modify. I did get some help from Professor McGuire when I came here, but...”

Her gaze shifted back to me.

“Should we... try it here?”

I met her eyes.

“I told you before, it was going to happen at some point.”

I had been thinking a lot since then, especially while I was alone.

The elemental rampage was an inevitable occurrence.

But what if I intentionally triggered it?

Wouldn't that change the events to come?

If the future where the elemental goes on a rampage is set, then that future won't change.

But if there's a way to alter that eventuality?

If I personally set it off, then wouldn't that prevent it from happening afterward?

That was the thought I clung to.

I initially planned to test this once both Rie and Luna had finished their magic circles, but there was no time for that now.

“Luna, can you make it as quickly as possible?”

Luna pondered my question for a moment.

Then, lifting her head, she looked at me with determined eyes.

“I'll try, Rudy.”

Luna said with a confident voice.

Chapter 95: Winter Vacation (11)

Thud!

From the deep pit, a hand emerged.

A figure then clambered out.

It was Ian.

"Damn it..."

Ian cursed as he pulled himself out of the pit.

Once he found stable ground, a realization hit him.

He had been played.

And once he fully regained his senses, all the illusions that surrounded him disappeared.

All that remained was a single magical tool next to him, frantically digging into the ground.

Ian then tried to use teleportation magic to escape, but it failed immediately.

It was due to a device previously set up by Professor McGuire, designed to obstruct spatial coordinates.

Ian gritted his teeth.

He had always relied on the overpowered teleportation spell and hadn't bothered to learn other forms of movement magic.

But now that teleportation was sealed, there was no quick way out of the pit.

So he chose to use physical enhancement magic to crawl his way out.

It would undoubtedly take time, but it was his only option.

After what felt like an eternity, Ian managed to crawl out.

Eventually, Ian managed to crawl out, covered in dirt, looking anything but the successor to a dukedom.

Once he was out, he noticed a piece of paper laid out in front of him.

Written on it was a single word:

-Pathetic

"This damn..."

Ian crumpled the paper in frustration.

Looking around, he spotted various magical tools scattered about.

Who had done this?

However, he had no time to figure that out.

He had to make his way to the hut.

Had they already rescued Rudy?

Rescuing someone from that place wouldn't be easy.

Judging by the magical tools that had fooled him, this person was an experienced wizard, one who firmly believed in their abilities.

These wizards tend to be overly confident in their abilities.

Rescuing Rudy from inside the hut would be even more challenging due to this.

Magic couldn't be used inside and cutting through the bars would take a long amount of time.

Ian recalled the magic circle he had prepared in advance.

It was a combination of space magic and various others, designed to nullify any magic within its boundaries.

If he could get inside the hut in time, there might still be hope.

"Rudy..."

Who could he possibly have asked for help?

As Ian tried to head towards the hut, he suddenly stopped in his tracks.

A rumbling sound echoed.

The ground vibrated, almost like a seismic event.

"What now?"

The illusions had surely faded.

But then, what was causing this rumble?

Crash!

A colossal, furry, silver hand burst through the hut.

The hand, covered in sharp fur, resembled that of a beast.

As the hand emerged, the ground shook even more, revealing the creature the hand belonged to, as it tore its way out from beneath the earth.

The ground upheaved, sand flowing away like it was being stripped from the very form of existence.

A creature sprinted on four legs, its eyes ablaze with crimson fury.

Its appearance resembled that of a wolf.

"Krrrrraaaaaa!"

The wolf bared its entirety and let out a howl, head tilted to the heavens.

“What on earth is that?”

Ian stared at the creature, disbelief written all over his face.

Did such a monster just emerge from that shack out of nowhere?

'Am I still in an illusion?'

All sorts of thoughts crossed Ian's mind.

“Huh?”

Something cold touched Ian's face.

He looked up.

Dark clouds began to shroud what was once a clear sky.

Snow started to drift down from above.

Thud!

The wolf, now closer, took a step toward Ian.

As the wolf's foot touched the ground, the spot froze over rapidly.

Its overpowering presence made Ian involuntarily step back.

Ian looked down at his retreating foot.

"Did I just... back away?"

He was taken aback that he felt fear against such a creature.

Gritting his teeth, Ian reminded himself there was no reason to be afraid of it.

Just a mere...

Ian reached out towards the giant wolf.

"Space Rift."

Crack!

He unleashed his spatial magic.

The space around the wolf distorted.

The wolf's head and body seemed to separate, its legs shattered, looking like a broken glass bottle.

Ian smirked, reveling in his accomplishment.

"Thought I had a reason to be scared, did you..."

But before Ian could finish, the shattered wolf started to melt, as if it were made of liquid.

Soon enough, the wolf began to reform itself.

"...It's regenerating."

Ian's gaze sharpened.

"Then I'll make sure to destroy you until you can't recover."

Drawing even the deepest reserves of his mana, the trees around Ian swayed violently and a fierce wind swirled around him.

At that moment.

"Rudy, are you okay?"

"Cough..."

Luna, supporting Rudy, was making her way through the forest.

She had succeeded in creating the magic circle as advised by Professor McGuire.

But, there was a problem.

Even if she could heal Rudy, she couldn't stop the elemental, Priscilla, from rampaging.

As soon as the elemental rampage began, Priscilla would rapidly drain Rudy's mana, and she wouldn't stop until all of his mana was exhausted.

When Luna expressed her concerns, Rudy smiled weakly and said,

-It's okay. Isn't there someone who can stop her?

The person Rudy was referring to was Ian.

And indeed, things played out just as Rudy had predicted.

Priscilla and Ian began to fight fiercely.

Luna seized the opportunity to quickly escape with Rudy.

"Rudy..."

Rudy's current condition was dire.

Having triggered Priscilla's rampage and sustained significant injuries, Rudy was bleeding profusely, especially since he had summoned Priscilla in an underground dungeon, causing him to be scraped by jagged rocks.

As a result, even walking with support seemed to be a struggle for him.

"Rudy, I'll carry you. Let me."

"Ugh..."

Luna made this offer, but Rudy couldn't respond properly.

Without waiting, Luna gently lifted him up.

"Physical Enhancement."

After using the physical enhancement magic, Luna carried Rudy on her back.

He was much taller than her, so she had to hold him awkwardly, but it didn't hinder her movement.

"But where to..."

She looked ahead, contemplating.

"Where should we go...?"

She wasn't sure where Professor Mcguire was, and there wasn't a designated safe spot to head to.

The ideal place would be the Royal Palace, given its central location in the capital.

It would be safe, especially with the presence of Princess Rie.

But there was a problem.

Without notifying Princess Rie, who would receive them at the Royal Palace?

That was the issue.

Still, there was no other place to go.

"Rudy, for now, we'll head to the Royal Palace."

Rudy, in his unconscious state, couldn't reply.

"Please hang in there, just a little longer..."

Still, hoping to comfort Rudy even a little, Luna whispered to him.

As Luna tried to move swiftly out of the forest, distant noises gradually became audible.

"Huff..."

Luna quickly took cover behind a tree.

She then peeked toward the source of the noises.

Among the few soldiers, she recognized Thomas from the academy.

"The Astria family..."

For reasons she didn't know, he, accompanied by several soldiers, were approaching the forest.

"Ugh..."

Luna pondered on their next move.

It didn't seem like a good idea to reveal themselves.

'Rudy...'

Luna looked at Rudy's face, which was deathly pale, devoid of any vitality.

Anyone could tell that the situation was dire.

If she were alone, Luna might have been able to escape.

"Should I... distract them...?"

Luna considered hiding Rudy behind a tree and diverting their attention elsewhere.

But then, there would be no one to look after him.

"How can I..."

She anxiously bit her nails, racking her brain for a solution.

But she couldn't think of anything.

While she was deep in thought, something slowly descended in front of Luna.

It was a rope.

"Huh?"

A rope, inexplicably dropping from the sky.

Confused, Luna looked up at the tree from which the rope had descended.

A masked individual, clad in black, stood there.

"Wh...who are you?"

At Luna's whisper, the figure gestured towards the rope.

"Grab on?"

In response to Luna's question, the masked figure nodded.

Who could this unexpected savior be?

"Check over there."

It was Thomas's voice.

The footsteps of soldiers grew closer.

Closing her eyes tightly, Luna gripped Rudy and the rope.

The rope swiftly lifted them, allowing Luna and Rudy to reach the treetop safety.

"There's no one here."

"Alright, let's move on."

Luna watched with relief as the soldiers who were searching their previous location moved on.

Turning, she looked at their unexpected rescuer.

Behind the person floated Sylph, an Intermediate Wind Elemental.

An Elementalist.

But why the mask and dark clothing? An assassin or some kind of covert agent, perhaps?

Regardless, Luna bowed her head in gratitude.

"Thank you. I don't know who you are, but you've saved our lives."

Who this mysterious helper was didn't matter at the moment.

All Luna knew was that this person had saved them.

"Princess Rie sent me. Said you might need some help."

Hearing the voice, Luna was taken aback.

It was a woman's voice.

Upon closer inspection, the mysterious helper was delicate in stature, and tufts of blue hair peeked out from beneath the mask.

The casual tone caught Luna off guard, but she brushed it off as a part of the woman's personality.

Carefully, Luna spoke,

"I promise to repay this favor someday."

The masked woman shook her head.

"No need. I'm just here to apologize for my mistake."

"...Mistake?"

The woman removed her mask.

"...Se...Serina?"

A striking blue-haired Elementalist.

The shining star of Liberion Academy's Elementalist Department.

Yet, the same Serina who had been imprisoned on charges of attempting to murder Rudy.

Seeing Serina's face, Luna wasn't sure how to feel. After all, Serina had once severely injured Rudy.

'However, you did save us now...'

"You don't need to make that face. I only want to make it up to Rudy Astria and the others, nothing more."

Serina smiled faintly.

"And I can't afford to harbor ill feelings. If I did, I might just end up dead."

"Dead?"

Luna was full of questions.

However, before Luna could voice any of them, Serina hoisted Rudy onto her back and rose to her feet.

"We'll talk more about it when we get back."

"Get back?"

"To the Royal Palace. Princess Rie asked me to take you there."

Serina flashed a warm smile.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 96: Winter Vacation (12)

The capital was in an uproar.

Suddenly, a wolf monster appeared, and Ian was the one who confronted it.

It was an incident that occurred on the outskirts of the capital a few days ago.

At first glance, the situation painted Ian as a hero.

However, an additional event overshadowed that.

The kidnapping of Rudy Astria.

Ian had kidnapped his younger brother, Rudy Astria, and confined him.

When news of this spread throughout the capital, Ian Astria's reputation began to plummet.

Despite saving the capital from a massive beast, he started being seen more as a villain who imprisoned his brother than as a hero.

And now, within the royal palace of the capital, Rie was walking somewhere from her chambers.

"Oh, long time no see, sister."

While Rie was walking, Yuni approached and greeted her.

Yuni's attire suggested she was either attending a ball or some other formal event.

Rie looked at Yuni disdainfully.

"Aren't you starting school soon? Shouldn't you be studying?"

At Rie's words, Yuni chuckled.

"Come on, I can't just be studying all the time. Taking walks, having tea — it helps me study better."

"So, you're saying that by taking walks, drinking tea, hanging out with friends, and attending every ball, you study better?"

Yuni shrugged nonchalantly in response to Rie's sarcastic comment,

"I have my own way of doing things~."

"Then stick to your way~. And don't bother me with it."

Rie spoke coldly.

Despite Rie's icy words, Yuni waved her hand cheerfully and teased,

"Why so harsh, sis?"

Any average person might've been hurt by Rie's words, but Yuni was accustomed to her sister's sharp tongue.

Rie was about to continue on her path and ignore Yuni when Yuni suddenly clapped her hands, as if remembering something.

"Oh right, I didn't approach you for idle chit-chat."

But Rie didn't stop and continued walking.

"Where are you off to?"

Yuni followed closely behind.

"Don't follow me. I have somewhere to be."

"Going to meet 'him'?"

At Yuni's words, Rie stopped in her tracks, taken aback.

Seeing Rie's reaction, Yuni widened her eyes.

She had never seen her sister so easily thrown off by a simple statement before.

'Him' referred to a guest Rie had brought in.

"I heard a bit about it. He's a man, isn't he?"

"You don't need to know."

Rie quickly regained her composure and answered Yuni flatly.

"Hmm... is he your boyfriend, then?"

"What, what, what???"

Rie stared at Yuni in shock.

Yuni smirked, seeing Rie's reaction.

"Is that it?"

"No! How did you jump to that conclusion?"

Rie exclaimed, then looked around to ensure no one was within earshot.

"Either way, stop prying. If you keep digging, I won't let it go easily."

With that, Rie resumed walking.

Yuni stared intently at Rie's retreating back.

"Hmm... who could he be?"

Yuni mused aloud, tapping her lips thoughtfully.

While she was curious about the identity of the man, Yuni knew that her father, the Emperor, was ensuring his safety and privacy.

Even Yuni couldn't defy the Emperor's wishes.

"I'm so curious."

With that thought, Yuni went on her way.

"Rudy, how are you feeling now?"

Rie asked.

"I think I'm all better now."

Sitting on the bed, I gave her a reassuring smile.

We were at the Royal Palace, specifically in one of its guest rooms.

These rooms, splendidly decorated, were intended for honored guests of the palace.

"The doctor will be visiting again later, just so you know."

"I feel like I don't really need any more treatment."

It had been about three days since I arrived at the palace.

For a whole day, I was unconscious; the next, bedridden and sleeping.

But after receiving treatment from the royal physicians on the third day, I was able to move around again.

Once I could move again, I paid my respects to Rie and the Emperor.

The Emperor acknowledged me, promising protection.

While it might be a political move to counter Ian Astria, I was still grateful since he guaranteed my safety.

Luna was also staying in the palace.

She wasn't injured, so she didn't require treatment; they just provided her with a place to stay.

Though we could meet, it wasn't always easy to find a private moment.

At the moment, I am under the direct protection of the Emperor.

It made spending time together difficult.

Thankfully, through Rie, we could pass along messages to each other.

I heard that Professor McGuire met separately with Rie.

After hearing that Luna and I were under the protection of the Royal Palace, he quietly returned to the academy.

I wanted to thank him immediately, but I decided to wait until I returned to the Academy.

As these thoughts crossed my mind, there was a knock at the door.

“It's Serina. May I come in?”

“Yes, come in.”

Rie responded.

Serina?

It had been a while since I heard that name.

I assumed it was just a coincidence.

There are many people with the same name in this world, after all.

"Huh?"

However, to my surprise, the woman with blue hair who entered was the Serina I knew.

Although she wasn't in the usual school uniform, there was no mistaking it.

"What... is going on?"

Confused, I looked between them.

Rie noticed my expression and spoke,

“Oh, didn't Luna tell you?”

I shook my head.

My meetings with Luna were short, and her concerns for my wellbeing often took precedence over other topics.

“Serina has become a member of the Royal Secret Service. I did oppose it initially, but...”

Rie admitted, casting a slightly disapproving glance at Serina.

But Serina just bowed her head modestly.

"I received assistance from ‘Ling’."

"'Ling'?"

"It's the code name for the head of the Secret Service,"

Rie explained, answering my question.

"When Serina asked to become an undercover agent, that person came to me directly to request it. They wanted Serina to take on that role."

Oh...

I was genuinely impressed by that.

"So, her crimes were pardoned?"

"No, instead of being in prison, she works undercover to atone for her sins."

I nodded at Rie's explanation.

"That's great news. Work hard."

When I said this with a smile, Serina approached and bowed her head.

"I deeply regret not properly apologizing for my mistakes that day. I sincerely apologize for everything. It was entirely my fault..."

"Ah, it's alright. It's been some time since then."

I assured her, smiling.

Yet, Serina kept her head down, refusing to look up.

"I'm really... really sorry..."

I looked at her intently.

I had a feeling that no matter what I said, her attitude would be the same.

"Serina."

I decided to take a different approach, because, regardless of my feelings, she still had a life to live.

"Look, I won't forgive you. You almost killed me, and you tried to kill Astina too."

"I understand. I don't expect you to forgive me for the rest of your life."

I continued after hearing her response.

"Instead of seeking my forgiveness, live your life trying to make amends for the mistakes you've made."

I said with a light-hearted smile.

"Save many people and bring salvation to many. With your abilities, you can do it, right? Live with the purpose of atoning, always."

As I said this, Serina slowly lifted her head.

"I promise... I will."

I scratched my cheek.

It felt a bit awkward.

Just a few months ago, we were on casual terms, and now she was addressing me so formally.

Rie broke the slightly uncomfortable silence.

"But you said you won't forgive her?"

"Huh?"

"Serina saved your life. If it weren't for her, you might have died. Isn't that why you are here?"

My eyes widened at Rie's words.

Serina saved me?

Suddenly, I felt embarrassed about the things I had just said.

Realizing my mistake, I immediately apologized,

"I'm sorry. I'll forgive you. Thank you for saving me..."

"No, it's me who should apologize more!"

After that slight hiccup,

"Priscilla! It's been so long!!"

"Serina, I've missed you!"

Feeling guilty about my earlier words to Serina, I summoned Priscilla.

I remembered how upset Priscilla had been the last time we talked in prison.

I thought letting her see Serina might ease her resentment.

But to my surprise, Priscilla started grumbling to Serina,

"I missed you, Serina. I should have just formed a contract with you. He's worse than a demon."

"Just hang in there, you already made the contract."

Serina gently stroked Priscilla as if comforting a puppy.

And Priscilla, despite her wolf-like appearance, gleefully responded to Serina's touch.

It was almost like watching a playful pup.

I even wondered if I should take her for a walk later.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 97: When Winter Ends, Spring Comes (1)

"Do you enjoy this sort of thing?"

"Experiencing freedom is the greatest pleasure for those who lack it. Those who are always free wouldn't understand this exhilarating feeling."

I stared intently at Priscilla.

Despite her words hinting at something profound, when I actually looked at her, she seemed like nothing more than a 'dog' taken out for a walk.

Priscilla was joyfully hopping around in the snow-covered garden.

After seeing her play with Serina, I thought to treat Priscilla like a 'dog' and decided to take her for a walk in the garden.

It seemed to be the right decision.

She panted excitedly, much like a delighted dog, sniffing around.

I watched her for a while, then wandered around the garden myself.

"It's cold..."

The biting chill was sharp, but it wasn't entirely unpleasant.

I enjoyed the sensation of snow crunching underfoot, and taking a deep breath filled my senses with the crisp winter air.

"Hmm... Perhaps it's time to head back to the academy?"

My injuries were healing, and I no longer felt discomfort while moving.

From the whispers I overheard, Ian likely doesn't have the time to be focusing on me.

So, the likelihood of him attacking me again seems slim.

It felt like the right time to return to the academy.

While Rie made sure I was comfortable here in the Royal Palace, I had to return to the academy eventually.

I had to get back to my studies.

Just then, a voice called out from behind me.

"Feeling better now?"

Turning around, I faced an elderly man with deep wrinkles and a long beard.

Recognizing him, I promptly bent one knee in reverence.

"Your Majesty, the Emperor, it's an honor."

The man in front of me was the ruler of this empire, Rie's father, the Emperor.

"Heh, rise. I didn't come here to make you uncomfortable."

The Emperor spoke with a gentle smile.

Looking at him, he seemed to be dressed casually, possibly out for a walk himself.

As I stood up, the Emperor, still smiling, said,

"Care to walk with me for a bit?"

"Of course."

He gestured to the maids behind him to stay back.

"Is the palace to your liking?"

"Thanks to your kindness, Your Majesty, my stay has been very comfortable."

The Emperor glanced at me with a gentle smile,

"I'm glad to hear you've been well."

I laughed awkwardly, and silence ensued.

I wanted to escape this situation quickly.

Despite him being Rie's father, he was also the ruler of the Empire.

I had to be cautious; any misstep would be disastrous.

In situations like this, it seemed best to stay silent and stand still.

With that, the Emperor began to speak gently.

"How is Rie faring at the Academy?"

I bowed my head and replied,

"Yes, Rie is doing quite well at the Academy. She's doing great both in the student council and in other aspects."

"Heh, that's a relief to hear. I've always been a bit concerned given her fiery temperament."

"Ah, yes..."

Like the time she fiercely struck down an assassin's head with a stone at the midterm camp...

While I was lost in such thoughts, the Emperor posed another question.

"What do you think of her?"

"Pardon?"

"I mean, not Rie as the First Princess or a member of the student council at the Academy, but just Rie as herself."

I was taken aback by the question.

My opinion of Rie?

After some contemplation, I responded sincerely,

"Rie... is a dear friend."

I continued,

"She can sometimes be naïve, and her impulsive actions can be startling. But she's someone I deeply trust and have high hopes for."

Hearing my response, the Emperor smiled warmly.

"That's a wonderful assessment."

I smiled back, albeit awkwardly.

The Emperor looked at me, then turned his gaze to the sky.

"I don't have many days left to live."

"...?"

This sudden proclamation made me tilt my head.

The Emperor indeed seemed aged, but he still appeared healthy and strong.

"However, knowing that someone like you stands beside Rie eases my concerns."

"...Thank you."

I bowed to the Emperor's words.

The Emperor gave me a gentle smile.

"I have a favor to ask of you. Would that be alright?"

"Of course. Please, tell me."

The Emperor's expression grew serious.

"I'm not too worried about Rie. She's strong and surrounded by many who care for her."

His face shadowed with concern.

"But Yuni isn't the same. No one truly looks out for her, they only see the power she wields."

The Emperor met my gaze.

"I won't ask you to do anything specific for Yuni. Just prevent the two of them from fighting. If they clash, Yuni might..."

He couldn't complete his sentence, but I understood the gravity of his words.

I was well aware of both Rie's nature and the kind of person Yuni was.

"I understand. I'll do my best."

"Heh, I trust you will. But..."

The Emperor wore a playful smirk.

"Who confessed their feelings first?"

"Pardon?"

"Hmm, as Rie's father, I believe I have the right to ask that."

"...?"

I found myself growing increasingly flustered.

In the northern region, within the territory of the Lucarion family, the Lucarion estate was buzzing with activity.

A meeting was in full swing.

"...The Rebel's influence continues to grow, and we're struggling to find a way to curb it."

The harsh climate of the north was riddled with monsters and was notorious for its scarcity of food supplies.

The head of the Lucarion family, along with his heir, Locke, had much to discuss.

Certainly, the conflict between Rudy Astria and Ian Astria in the central region was concerning, but for them, there was a more pressing issue at hand: The Rebels.

These rebels, who had once been active in the south, had now made their presence known in the north.

Furthermore, these rebels were winning over the locals by distributing food.

Such gestures, although temporary, were undoubtedly effective in swaying public sentiment.

The Count of Lucarion, Locke's father, was well aware of this tactic.

He had long-standing experience dealing with the complexities of the northern region and was not ignorant of these strategies.

However, the reason the Lucarion family refrained from such acts was because they only provided a momentary boost to public sentiment.

A lord should prioritize the sustainable development of his territory.

A short-term spike in popularity achieved through food distribution wouldn't solve any long-term issues.

Therefore, investing the same resources in strengthening the foundation of the territory was a far better decision.

Such an approach was ideal for a lord, but not for the rebels.

The rebels' immediate priority was to quickly secure the loyalty of the majority and shift the balance of power.

Given this, countering the rebels, who were freely distributing food, was challenging.

The Count of Lucarion finally spoke up,

"First and foremost, we need to apprehend these rebels as soon as possible."

A knight present at the meeting cautiously replied,

"However... for now, all they've done is distribute food. They haven't caused any harm or committed any crimes."

The Count nodded in understanding.

"Regardless, we must arrest them. If they possess any food, don't bring it to the castle. Distribute it among the people instead. It's the best we can do right now."

The knight seemed to disapprove of this command, but he bowed in acknowledgment.

"Understood. We'll carry out your orders."

The Count then turned his gaze to Locke,

"Locke, do you have a different opinion on this matter?"

Locke, who had been seated next to the head of the family, deep in thought, responded cautiously,

"May I ask a question?"

At the Count's nod, he continued,

"It's strange that merely distributing some food would so drastically shift public sentiment. Hasn't our family protected these people from monsters for decades? Haven't we helped them during famines?"

The Count stroked his chin, acknowledging Locke's point.

"You're right. Even considering the winter food shortages, this sudden shift in loyalty seems unusual."

Rising from his seat, the Count of Lucarion gazed out of the window, lost in contemplation.

Outside the window, the agitated citizens of the territory could be seen.

Even with the food distribution, it made no sense for the citizens to react this way.

"I'll investigate this matter as well."

At the knight's words, Locke nodded.

"Thank you."

After hearing Locke and Count Lucarion's words, the knight walked out of the mansion.

Once outside, he glanced around.

Making sure no one was nearby, he walked towards a dark alley.

In that alley stood a man.

"Have you been well?"

"As always, I'm doing fine."

The man, raising his hood slightly, greeted the knight with a smile, a notable scar evident on his eye.

The knight spoke, looking at the man.

"Still... will you continue like this? Don't you know what kind of family the Lucarions are?"

However, the man with the scar on his eye shook his head.

"I apologize to Count Lucarion, but it's necessary for the greater good."

"Understood."

The knight bowed slightly and walked out of the alley.

---Toggle New Ads

Another chappy tonight!

Chapter 98: When Winter Ends, Spring Comes (2)

"As expected, this place feels the most comfortable..."

I stepped down from the carriage and stretched.

"In the Royal Palace, you were given many such conveniences too,"

Rie pointed out with a sharp gaze.

"Well, there's a difference between being provided with comfort and actually feeling at ease,"

I replied teasingly, shooting her a playful grin.

Luna chuckled awkwardly at our banter.

We had just returned to Liberion Academy from the Royal Palace.

Initially, only Luna and I planned to return.

However, out of the blue, Rie declared she'd join us back to the academy.

Some knights looked displeased by her decision, but I decided it wasn't my place to worry and simply smiled it off.

For the time being, we went our separate ways to our respective rooms.

Given the long tiring journey, I didn't think it'd be smart to dive straight into my studies.

I entered my room.

Considering I had been, in essence, kidnapped and returned, I had no belongings to unpack.

“Sigh...”

Without anything to put away, I flopped onto my bed.

Even though I rested well in the Royal Palace, nothing beats the relaxation of one's own home.

Turning my head, my gaze landed on the calendar.

"A kidnapping episode, and the year has slipped by."

While under treatment at the palace, the year had changed.

I wasn't planning any special celebration for the New Year, but realizing the year had slipped by gave me a sense of loss.

More importantly, a new semester awaited.

Fresh first-year students, altered futures, and futures I would need to change.

Looking back, none of the incidents from the original game had happened as they should.

Still, I clung to the futures I knew.

But now, I couldn't afford to.

“Evan...”

While I was able to handle the altered incidents, Evan's very character seemed changed, and I was powerless against that.

First Seat.

During the final exams, Evan and I had tied for the top spot.

That wasn't supposed to happen.

No matter how hard I tried, Evan was supposed to be the prodigy, always one step ahead.

“Yet now...”

Having seen Evan’s limits, I couldn’t place my trust in him.

“I need to change things...”

I had to take charge.

I bore the responsibility for the altered future.

Not just to ensure my own survival, but to save everyone at the academy.

Several days later.

In the main building of Liberion Academy, on the third floor's women's restroom.

"Hmm...!"

A woman, dressed in a tailored suit, had her hair tied up in a ponytail.

She was tidying herself up in front of the mirror.

"Ah... I'm so nervous."

She playfully tapped her cheeks with her fingers.

She was Gracie Lifegold, a wizard who came for an interview for a new teaching position.

Originally, she had been a teaching assistant at the academy, but after an offer from the royal palace, she worked as a Royal Wizard for three years.

The title of Royal Wizard was a highly prestigious position one could achieve as a wizard without a formal title.

It was impressive that Gracie, a commoner, had been given the Lifegold surname during her tenure as a royal wizard.

However, she had a dream.

"I just want to relax a bit now...!"

Gracie wasn't fond of hard work.

Even magical research, which most wizards adored, didn't appeal to her.

Such research was okay only when done in a relaxed leisurely manner.

Even if one loved their work, doing it constantly without a break would inevitably lead to burnout.

Then came an opportunity for Gracie.

Vice Principal Oliver had been relieved of his duties

Professor Cromwell was forced into the position of Vice Principal, leaving his previous post vacant.

This led to an open recruitment for a new professor at Liberion Academy.

Believing she was fully prepared, Gracie exited the restroom.

"But... why does it seem so deserted?"

Gracie muttered to herself.

It felt strange.

She had assumed that the open recruitment would attract many applicants, but she saw no one around.

"My mentor did say the professor's position is highly sought after... that the competition would be fierce..."

Her mentor was none other than Professor Cromwell.

Before taking on the duties of Vice Principal, Cromwell had taken a vacation.

During this period, he met with acquaintances, spent time with his family, and wasn't just idling around.

He realized that with his promotion to Vice Principal, a position in the magic department would become vacant.

And if it wasn't filled soon, he'd have to juggle both roles.

With the determination to prevent that, Cromwell had searched for a suitable candidate.

And he had chosen Gracie.

"This is odd..."

Puzzled, Gracie continued walking down the corridor.

At the end of her path stood the principal's office.

Yet, even as she approached the office, she didn't encounter a single soul.

"Just what..."

Gracie felt something was wrong.

Before she could further ponder, the door to the principal's office swung open.

"Ah, Professor Gracie. You've arrived."

Principal McDowell greeted her warmly as he stepped out.

"Pro... Professor?"

Gracie looked baffled. She hadn't even had her interview yet, nor had any announcements been made regarding her selection.

However, Principal McDowell referred to Gracie as "Professor."

"Haha, come on in for now."

"...Yes."

Gracie hesitantly stepped into the Principal's office, feeling the tension in the air.

Gracie forced a smile and took a sip of tea.

A singular thought dominated her mind.

I need to escape.

I must find a way out of here as soon as possible.

A job with no other applicants.

An interviewer who implies you're hired even before the interview starts.

Clearly, it's the worst job scenario.

"Hmm, should I address you as 'Professor Gracie'? Or do you prefer being called by your last name?"

"Oh, just 'Gracie' is fine."

Gracie was clearly bothered by the continued addition of the title "Professor."

"Right. Some people don't like being addressed by their first names."

"Ah, you mean Professor Cromwell?"

Cromwell greatly despises being called by his first name.

That's why, even when introducing himself, he only reveals his surname, 'Cromwell.'

"Yes, you, being a Liberion Academy graduate, must know about Cromwell, right?"

"Yes, Professor Cromwell has been of great help to me."

"It's been about 6 years since you graduated... That means you entered as a freshman when I just assumed the position of principal?"

"Yes, I heard you assumed the position during my first year."

McDowell and Gracie chatted amiably.

For a while, Gracie wore a genuine smile.

Suddenly, McDowell checked his watch.

"Oh, look at the time."

Gracie, seeing McDowell's reaction, tilted her head curiously.

"Do you have somewhere to be?"

"Yes, I have plans with my family. I apologize."

"No worries. It was fun reminiscing about my academy days."

Lost in their conversation, time had flown by.

McDowell grabbed his coat and headed for the door.

"Just leave the teacup. My secretary will handle it. See you at work tomorrow, Professor Gracie."

"...What?"

Before Gracie could understand the situation, McDowell had vanished.

In shock, Gracie stared at the door where McDowell had disappeared.

"No, wait. I didn't say I'd..."

But McDowell was long gone.

There was no reply in the empty room.

Suddenly, a voice came from the side.

"Professor Gracie, here are the documents detailing your duties as a professor."

"Eh?"

A woman stood beside her.

Gracie took the documents the woman handed to her and said,

"Ah, you must be the secretary..."

Without acknowledging her realization, she asked,

"May I clear the teacup?"

"Yes, but..."

Gracie wanted to return the documents and decline the job offer.

But she swallowed those words.

After all, confronting the principal directly seemed more appropriate than using the secretary as a go-between.

Refusing the job through her would be impolite.

‘I need to speak to Principal McDowell first thing tomorrow.’

With that in mind, Gracie rose from her seat.

The very next day, as soon as she arrived at Liberion Academy, Gracie went straight to the Principal's office.

"...Is he on vacation?"

"Ah, yes. Didn't he mention he'd be out with his family?"

Principal McDowell did mention he had plans with his family, but Gracie hadn't realized that meant he was taking a few days off.

"When will he be back?"

"He should return in about four days."

"Four days..."

With that, Gracie turned her attention back to the documents she had received the previous day.

She then headed toward the research lab listed on the papers.

Four days wasn't too long to wait, after all.

"I guess I'll have to wait a bit longer..."

However, after those four days...

"Ah, Principal McDowell has other commitments and seems like he will be away from the academy for a while."

Sighing in disappointment, Gracie walked out of the Principal's office.

"Now what should I do?"

She hadn't yet been properly briefed on her responsibilities, so she had nothing to do.

Yet, no one seemed to mind her just hanging around the lab.

After several days, her mind began to waver.

“Maybe I should just...?”

However, she quickly shook her head, dismissing the thought.

“No, something feels off. It's as if they're trying to lure me into something...”

“Hey, isn't that Gracie?”

She then heard a voice behind her.

“Oh? Professor McGuire?”

“Hey~! It's been a while!”

Professor McGuire, who wore a broad smile, was one of the professors Gracie had been quite close to during her student years.

“Ah! You're a professor now? Should I be calling you Professor Gracie?”

“No! Absolutely not. I can't have you calling me ‘professor.’”

Gracie emphatically gestured with her hands as she spoke.

Seeing this, Professor McGuire chuckled,

“Haha, alright then! How about we grab a drink later? A heart-to-heart between two professors.”

“Sure! I'll drop by your lab after I'm done for the day!”

A little while later, Professor McGuire and Gracie found themselves at a local bar...

“Hehe, Professor~! I promise~! I'll follow your advice to the letter~!”

“Good, you better!”

Under the influence of the strong drinks and McGuire's silver tongue, Gracie committed herself to taking on the role of a professor.

Without knowing this had all been a scheme orchestrated by the academy's staff.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 99: When Winter Ends, Spring Comes (3)

A month passed swiftly.

I had learned new intermediate spells, and my dark magic had significantly improved.

Both Luna and Rie made impressive progress in their own ways.

Luna can now effectively use Levian's spellbook, while Rie has not only improved her explosive magic but also learned other intermediate spells.

Even though we've changed a lot, the academy itself hasn't changed much.

However, it wasn't entirely the same.

The most noticeable change was...

Professor Robert's laboratory.

"Gracie, take care of these."

"Yes, Professor!"

The difference was that Robert now had an assistant.

To be precise, she wasn't just Robert's assistant but served all the professors in the magic department.

The youngest professor, Gracie Lifegold.

She's talented and very efficient, almost like a top-tier "slave" in the academy.

Teaching assistants, due to their limited capabilities, couldn't always be trusted with certain tasks.

And if they were overburdened, they might break under pressure.

When an assistant reached their breaking point, they would typically quit and run.

So it was important to moderate the workload.

However, professors didn't have that luxury.

No matter how overwhelming the workload, they couldn't just abandon their duties.

Being a professor often implied being older and experienced, so losing their position would leave a stain on their reputation.

It would be a significant setback.

As a result, especially for Robert, Gracie became a go-to for various tasks.

"Ugh..."

"Would you like me to help?"

I offered to Gracie, who was receiving a pile of documents from Robert.

She looked at me cautiously and asked,

"Are you Professor Robert's assistant?"

"No, I'm just a student learning under Professor Robert."

"A student?"

Her eyes widened in surprise.

"Would you like to be my assistant? I promise I'll treat you really well! Truly!"

"Haha... I'm sorry, I'm quite busy at the moment."

"I see."

Gracie looked disappointed.

I felt sorry for her.

If she's the youngest professor now, how long would she remain in that position?

From what I gathered, Professors Cromwell and McGuire had tricked her to join.

One could argue that she made a poor choice, but I heard that the professors essentially made it impossible for her to refuse.

They announced public recruitment for a professorship but didn't consider applications aside from Gracie's.

McGuire constantly spoke of the benefits of being a professor, almost brainwashing her.

Who could resist under such circumstances?

I felt sorry for her.

Helping her out, I carried her documents to her lab.

"Thanks! I'll treat you to something delicious later!"

"It's alright. I should be going."

"Wait!"

Gracie stopped me,

"By the way, what's your name?"

I calmly replied to her question.

"It's Rudy Astria."

As I stated my name, Gracie's expression stiffened, and her hands began to tremble.

"I'm so, so, so, so sorry!!!!!!!"

It took me several reassurances that I was just a student for Gracie to finally calm down from her upset state.

"She seems really overwhelmed..."

On my way out from Gracie's lab, I ran into Luna and Professor Mcguire.

"Ah, Professor Mcguire, it's been a while."

"Oh! Is that you, Rudy?"

As I greeted him warmly, Professor Mcguire responded with a bright smile.

There was genuine happiness radiating from his grin, a side of him I hadn't seen before.

"Yes! Anyway, Luna, you can start coming to the lab from tomorrow!"

"Understood, Professor! I'll see you tomorrow!"

Huh?

I watched the retreating back of Professor Mcguire as he returned to his lab, somewhat puzzled.

Luna then tilted her head, posing a question.

“Rudy, are you headed to study?”

“Well, yes, but... what’s this about coming to the lab?”

Something felt off.

“Ah~ Professor Mcguire asked if I was interested in working as a teaching assistant.”

“Oh.”

I sighed upon hearing that.

“Wait... you agreed to it?”

“Yes! The other teaching assistants are very kind, and I’ll get paid too! Plus, I can study at the same time, so it seemed like a great opportunity.”

Luna was so naïve.

She didn't realize that such great conditions always come with a catch.

The academy wasn’t a charity...

Well, in some ways it was, but the professors certainly weren't philanthropists.

“Did you... sign a contract or something?”

“Yes! I just did.”

“...”

Now I understood why Professor Mcguire looked so elated.

I felt a bit of pity for Professor Gracie, but I hadn’t expected someone to take advantage of someone close to me the same way.

For a moment, I considered confronting Professor Mcguire.

But I quickly dismissed the idea.

Luna should learn through experience.

It'll prepare her for the realities of life.

It's better for her to understand society through hardships, just like Professor Gracie.

“By the way, Rudy, did you hear about the freshman assessment in a few days? It reminds me of the old times.”

Luna spoke, reminiscent of the past.

I hadn't taken the entrance exam, so I didn't share her nostalgia.

Still, I responded,

“I agreed to help with the exams.”

“Really? Why would you do that?”

Assisting with the exams involved supporting the supervising professors.

It was primarily a way for students to earn a little extra money.

However, I had my own motives.

To assess the new students.

To identify potential talents for the next semester.

“Should I help out too?”

“No, Luna, you already have the teaching assistant role... you should rest.”

I looked at Luna sympathetically.

“...?”

Luna simply looked back, puzzled.

“Ugh...”

Ian exhaled a weary sigh.

The incident involving Rudy Astria.

The aftermath of that event was almost over, but he was very tired from it all.

Fortunately, Rudy's kidnapping went by without much hassle.

However, it undoubtedly had a significant impact.

For one, the evaluation of Ian had taken a considerable hit, while Rudy's reputation in the capital had skyrocketed.

Where Rudy had once been seen negatively, the tide of public opinion had turned in his favor.

The rumor that he was a failure was now falsely attributed to Ian, and Rudy was now seen as the poor younger brother who had been oppressed under such a brother.

From Ian's perspective, this was deeply unfair.

It was a well-known fact that Rudy had been the black sheep of the family.

Ian had done nothing wrong.

Yet to have these rumors attributed to him was nothing but unjust.

Moreover, the stories that were initially confined to the academy had now spread to the capital.

The charming nobleman who got along well with both aristocrats and commoners alike.

Rumors of how he was close to Rie, the Royal Princess, despite his family being part of the nobility.

The brave student who risked his life to protect others.

Such tales spread like wildfire.

Though Ian was too preoccupied with his own reputation to understand why these rumors were circulating, the cause of their spread was Astina.

Astina had started to take proper successor lessons and began to harness the power of the Persia family.

With her influence and due to recent events, once the stories spread, all of the nobility quickly came to know of them.

From Ian's perspective, these rumors were poison.

He even started to think that his almost assured position as the heir could be in jeopardy.

In the world of politics, a secured position was often anything but.

Currently, Ian held power and influence over Rudy.

The Astria family held the backing of the noble faction.

The foundation of that noble faction was rooted in the Astria family.

The families under them also had their vulnerabilities tied to the Astrias.

Given that Ian was currently acting as the Head's representative, he already held the power to influence them at will.

Still, Ian didn't dismiss the thought of 'what if'.

There's no harm in being prepared for any eventuality.

“However...”

The Rudy kidnapping incident had just passed.

If he stirred up another issue now, and it led to complications, it might be too much for Ian to handle.

“I’ll have to start with minor things.”

The kind of actions that wouldn’t raise eyebrows.

That level of discretion was important.

“The minor details...”

Ian sank deep into thought.

Areas that might seem petty.

He needed to exploit those areas.

Areas where even if Rudy tried, he wouldn't easily expose to the public...

A few days later, a letter arrived for me.

It was from Ian.

I had half-expected an apology from him, thinking perhaps he felt remorseful.

In a way, my assumption was half right, but also half wrong.

"Seriously, this guy..."

While there was an apology in the letter, that wasn't the main content.

"He's cutting off financial support?"

I was dumbfounded.

The reasons he listed were petty, ones anyone could nitpick.

Apparently, he wanted me to stand on my own feet.

However, there was no clear way for me to object.

If I were to oppose my own brother telling me,

'You should become independent. I'll reduce your allowance,'

Wouldn't I just appear like a spoiled child?

"What a tricky move."

I thought Ian would either apologize sincerely or stay silent. But this was unexpected.

Now, I had to figure out how to earn money to pay for tuition and living expenses on my own.

Tuition wasn't as much of a concern since I had a scholarship for being second in the rankings.

But the real issue was...

"How will I handle Luna's sponsorship?"

Moreover, other financial matters all became burdensome.

"Ian, you petty bastard...!"

Cursing Ian wouldn't change the situation, but I couldn't help it.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 100: When Winter Ends, Spring Comes (4)

"Alright, everyone, put away whatever you're looking at!"

The entrance examination for the new students had begun.

All the freshmen sat in their seats, looking forward.

A tense silence filled the room.

Assisting Professor Gracie, I began distributing the exam papers.

As I did so, murmurs started spreading through the hall.

"Is that Rudy Astria...?"

"Shush, keep it down..."

Given the events I've caused, it seemed I had inadvertently become a bit of a celebrity.

Before, few recognized me on sight.

Only when I introduced myself as Rudy Astria, or when it was clear I belonged to the Astria family, did they recognize me.

But lately, more and more people seemed to recognize me at a glance.

It made sense.

I heard that recently, I am the most talked-about figure in the capital.

Blocking Vice Principal Oliver, being the object of Ian Astria's jealousy, and being cherished by the Royal Court.

The rumors were quite exaggerated.

All twisted tales.

Robert had stopped Vice Principal Oliver, not me.

Ian Astria wasn't jealous; he merely wanted to cut down any potential nuisance.

And as for being the most cherished figure in the Royal Court?

I had no idea where that came from.

Sure, I was on good terms with Rie, but being the most cherished figure?

Thump, thump.

As the students continued their whispered discussions, Professor Gracie tapped her podium a few times and spoke.

"Everyone, stop chatting with your neighbors. If you continue to talk, it will be treated as cheating."

Hearing Professor Gracie's stern words, everyone stopped their conversations and focused ahead.

I took a moment to watch Professor Gracie, then resumed distributing the exam papers.

Once I finished handing out the papers and returned to Professor Gracie's side, she quietly asked,

"So, when do we start the exam?"

I sighed.

How could a professor not know this?

That was Professor Gracie for you.

Exceptionally skilled in magic, but lacking in almost every other area.

Gently, I informed her,

"Professor Mcguire will announce the start soon."

Upon hearing this, Professor Gracie nervously nodded.

"Oh, right. Understood."

The reason I was assigned to assist Professor Gracie?

Initially, I was supposed to enter the exam hall with Professor Robert.

-Why am I paired with Professor Gracie?

-Well, Gracie is a bit clumsy, so you should help her out. You're pretty familiar with this, aren't you?

I scratched my head.

What exactly was I familiar with?

I'm just a regular student, and I've never supervised an exam...

All I had was the experience of taking midterms and final exams.

But, what choice did I have?

I prayed that nothing would go wrong as I entered with Professor Gracie.

The clock began to glow.

Professor Mcguire signaled the start of the test with a magic tool.

"....."

Tap, tap, tap, tap, tap.

However, Gracie didn't even glance at the clock, merely tapping her fingers on the podium.

I stared at Gracie with disdain before speaking up.

"Alright, the test will now begin."

"Huh?"

Gracie looked at me with a surprised face upon hearing my words.

I gestured toward the clock with a tilt of my head.

"The... manual..."

Gracie spread out the paper with the instructions on it, letting out a sigh of realization.

"Ah..."

She gave me an awkward smile.

"Ahaha... Times have really changed... Back in my day, the teaching assistant in the hallway..."

I cut off Gracie's words with a stern look.

"Please be quiet. The test is in progress."

"Yes..."

Gracie, deflated, took her seat as the supervisor.

"Alright, well done everyone. You can have your lunch now and return to your original seats afterward."

With those words, Professor Gracie announced the end of the first exam.

I approached her, asking,

"Did you gather all the test papers properly?"

"Of course!"

Professor Gracie confidently replied, handing me the envelope filled with exam papers.

However, as she began to turn away, I walked past her and pointed,

"Then what is this?"

"Huh?"

A stray exam paper lay on the floor.

It was smaller in size compared to the others.

Since students took multiple tests during the first examination, the sizes of the papers varied.

In the process of collecting and organizing them, it was common for a few sheets to get lost in between and fall.

Clearly, this fallen test was one that Gracie had accidentally dropped while collecting them.

"If you had missed this, it could've been a problem..."

I commented.

"I'm sorry..."

Professor Gracie replied with a defeated expression.

With a sigh, I picked up the stray paper and placed it inside the envelope.

"Let's go and submit these papers."

"Yes, let's..."

As we exited the classroom, I saw Professor McGuire chatting with Luna.

"Hello, Professor McGuire!"

Professor Gracie greeted with a smile.

He turned to acknowledge her, asking,

"Ah, Gracie. Did supervising go well?"

"If it weren't for Rudy here, there might have been a slight hiccup. Ahaha..."

Walking over, Gracie began chatting with Professor McGuire.

Luna approached me with a bright smile,

"Rudy! How was supervising? Wasn't it a bit fun? Reminded me of the old days!"

"It was interesting, I guess."

Seeing Luna's cheerful face, I couldn't help but smile in return.

Luna had taken up an assistant role beside Professor McGuire.

Given the limited student volunteers for the supervising role, and since Professor McGuire was also participating, Luna filled in.

Some might view it as unfair, but Luna seemed quite content with the arrangement.

And looking at Luna recently, I had to admit, she seemed to be doing well.

She was earning money and receiving valuable lessons from Professor McGuire.

It seemed like a win-win situation.

It might not be the same in the future, but for now, it looked promising.

Still, I thought,

“If I were in her shoes, I might not feel the same way...”

"Hm? What do you mean?"

"Ah, it's nothing."

Luna tilted her head curiously but soon flashed a playful grin.

As we followed behind Professors Mcguire and Gracie, Professor Mcguire glanced over his shoulder,

"You two should grab some lunch and return soon."

"Yes! Understood!"

Luna cheerfully responded.

I gave a slight nod in acknowledgment, and we headed to the cafeteria.

The dining hall was bustling with new students.

"It's been a while since I've seen the cafeteria this packed,"

I remarked.

"Yeah. By the way, where's Rie today?"

"Oh, Rie said she'd sleep in. She finds it tiring to come out when it's this crowded."

It made sense.

If Rie had come to the cafeteria, she would undoubtedly have been the center of attention for all the freshmen.

Just like over there.

Upon entering the cafeteria, a group of students immediately caught my eye.

Right in the center was Yuni Von Ristonia, Rie's younger sister.

A face similar to Rie's.

While Rie had long hair, Yuni sported a short bob.

I wondered why they were all huddled together like that, but it was good for us.

Everyone's attention was diverted from us, allowing Luna and me to eat in peace.

We casually got our meals and settled in a corner of the cafeteria, chatting as we began to eat.

However, the murmuring around us gradually grew louder.

And when I looked up, the reason became clear.

"Rudy, what's going on?"

Luna tilted her head in confusion as she saw my frown.

I had a reason to frown.

That person was approaching our table.

"Hello there?"

Yuni.

She walked over with a gentle smile and greeted us.

As Yuni approached, not just her but even the people around her started moving towards us.

In an instant, we were surrounded by a crowd.

"Wha... What's this all about?"

Luna looked around, clearly taken aback.

"Rudy Astria, right?"

Yuni leaned in slightly, speaking in a playful tone.

It reminded me of when I first met Rie.

Seeing my silent stare, Yuni continued.

"Pleased to meet you. I am the Second Princess, Yuni Von Ristonia. May I join you for a meal?"

Her introduction was impeccable, radiating dignity and grace.

After being accustomed to the more casual Rie, seeing her younger sister's formal demeanor made for a stark contrast: the carefree older sister and the courteous younger one.

Of course, Rie also acted gracefully when she needed to.

"Sure, have a seat."

"Yes, then..."

As Yuni began moving with her tray from Luna's side towards me,

Thud.

Luna pulled out a chair next to her.

"Why not sit here?"

“...Excuse me?”

Luna responded with a smile.

While it looked like her usual smile, there was an uncanny edge to it.

Yuni locked eyes with Luna.

"Why are you going all the way there? Here is closer, isn't it?"

“I wanted to sit next to Rudy.”

"Just sit here."

At Luna's words, Yuni frowned.

"Who are you, exactly?"

Before Luna could reply, I intervened.

"She's my friend, Luna Railer. Do as Luna suggests. Why would you want to sit next to me anyway?"

Wouldn't it be better to face someone directly if you wanted to talk with them?

Yuni responded with a sly smile.

"You see, I have a crush on Rudy."

“...What?”

“Huh?”

After making her declaration, Yuni briskly walked over and sat next to me.

And once seated, she spoke again.

"I fell for you at first sight, Rudy. Will you go out with me?"

Luna sat on the bench, looking up at the sky.

-I have a crush on Rudy

She confessed.

-I fell for you at first sight, Rudy. Will you go out with me?

She said, wearing her heart on her sleeve.

Of course, Luna knew.

She knew Yuni most likely had ulterior motives.

Still, hearing someone else confess to the person she liked weighed heavily on her heart.

"Sigh..."

While she could somewhat cope with the shock of Yuni's confession, Rudy's response was even more jarring.

-I'm sorry, but I can't accept your feelings. Let's remain as senior and junior.

Such a practical and gentle rejection.

Luna would have preferred it if Rudy had been more blunt in his rejection; it might have lessened the shock.

The reason this felt so jarring to her was that she believed Rudy might respond in the same manner if she ever confessed her feelings to him.

She could vividly imagine herself in Yuni's shoes, confessing... only to be met with the exact same words from Rudy.

Luna imagined it.

Her confession... and Rudy rejecting her with those exact words...

It played in her mind like an echo.

"Rudy..."

With a heavy sigh, Luna whispered Rudy's name.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 101: When Winter Ends, Spring Comes (5)

Flowers are beginning to bloom.

The seeds that were buried in the snow are slowly sprouting, stretching their tiny shoots towards the sun.

Leaves were starting to sprout from trees, adding vibrant colors to the academy.

I was taking a stroll, admiring my surroundings.

"The weather's nice."

"It truly is! I usually prefer winter, but now that we're outside, spring doesn't seem too bad!"

I glanced at Priscilla who made that comment.

Right at my feet, in the form of a wolf, was Priscilla.

I was taking a walk with her, upholding a promise I made while we were in prison: to show her more of the outside world and to take care of her.

Perhaps because of that, I've felt that Priscilla has been in high spirits lately.

But, in contrast to her joy, my own worries have multiplied recently.

To be exact, it's not that I have more concerns, but one particular worry that's been bothering me immensely: money.

The ways to earn money while living at the academy are few and far between.

Occasionally, the academy would hire students for short-term contractual jobs and pay them, but that pay was nowhere near what I needed.

To continue to grow and improve, I need to do my own personal research and experiments.

However the funds needed are beyond what an average student can afford.

For now, I'm managing with the money given by my family, but that amount will soon be exhausted.

My current research especially requires a significant amount of money.

Dark magic often uses catalysts; magic that requires a sacrifice.

I've been delving deep into studying this kind of magic.

With Professor Robert's help, I've been making good progress, and on my own, I've been purchasing various materials to practice.

However, practicing alone has become increasingly challenging.

When learning with Robert, he'd simply toss me the ingredients he had in his lab.

On my own, I had to buy them. I now understand why Evan might have struggled to maintain the top rank, unable to reach the required specs.

For now, my immediate need is to earn money that would sustain me for a while.

But the ways to earn it are limited.

The most obvious option is to become a teaching assistant.

In fact, it's perhaps the only viable option for me.

"Becoming a teaching assistant, huh..."

I began contemplating it earnestly.

Of course, I had no intention of becoming Robert's assistant.

He already had a few assistants, and given Robert's personality, if I became his assistant, he'd definitely dump all his work on me.

The professor I was considering was Gracie Lifegold.

Despite being a professor, she was quite lenient.

She doesn't even have a proper assistant right now.

I'm sure Gracie would eagerly welcome me.

"But..."

There's a catch...

If I were to go by my plan...

"Senior? Hello?"

I heard a voice from behind me.

I turned with a frown, recognizing that voice.

Behind me, Yuni was standing with a smile.

"Out for a stroll again today?"

The semester hadn't begun yet.

Although it was about to, the freshmen hadn't arrived.

Typically, noble students would arrive accompanied by their families for the entrance ceremony.

However, unlike them, Yuni had already moved into the dormitory.

Honestly, I didn't mind her moving in early, but the real issue was her constantly following me around lately.

Like when I would take morning walks with Priscilla or when I studied at the library, she'd always show up just to say hi.

Even when I asked her to stop, she would merely smile and say,

"I'll come by again."

At first, it was very bothersome.

She would constantly hover around, staring intently, making it impossible for me to ignore her.

But, recently, I found a solution.

"Yuni, what are you doing?"

From behind, Rie, dressed in comfortable sportswear, approached.

She came over with a bright smile.

"Tsk..."

Seeing Rie, Yuni frowned.

"Senior! Then, I'll come back later."

"You don't have to."

Despite my words, Yuni just smiled and left.

Yuni's natural enemy.

That was Rie.

Whenever Yuni sought me out, Rie would find me soon after.

And she would promptly chase Yuni away.

After numerous repetitions of this routine, it became a new normal.

Especially during morning walks with Priscilla, Rie joining us became a part of the routine.

Rie, seeing Yuni's retreating figure, turned to me with a broad grin.

"Shall we get going?"

"Sure."

I began jogging through the academy grounds with Rie.

Priscilla, too, gleefully followed.

Of course, we weren't running at full speed.

If I ran too fast, Rie wouldn't be able to keep up.

I adjusted my pace to match hers.

At first, even at this pace, Rie struggled.

She wasn't used to exercising.

But lately, she's been managing to keep up, keeping her breathing steady without breaks.

"Whew... Whew..."

After a while, we were nearing the end of our usual running route.

"Rudy."

Rie, slowing down a bit, started to speak.

"Hmm?"

I glanced at her, tilting my head.

"What's up?"

It didn't seem like she was tired or wanted to stop.

Rie stared at me intently for a moment, then began to speak softly.

"Do you want to join the student council with me?"

"What?"

"I plan to run for student council president. I'd like you to be my vice president."

Rie's sudden proposition caught me off guard.

"We haven't properly organized the student council since we haven't seen the first-year students yet, but I'd really like you to take on the role of vice president."

Rie continued her proposal.

"I've been watching you since you started working in the student council. You're good at what you do... you're approachable... someone I trust..."

"Hold on."

I interrupted Rie as she spoke.

"There's... a slight problem."

"Huh?"

Rie's eyes widened in surprise at my words.

I gave an awkward smile.

"I'm also running for student council president."

"What?"

Rie looked completely taken aback by what I had just said.

"Oh, I'm not saying I won't participate in the student council... I'll just be running for the position of president."

I nodded.

Taking the position of student council president was the beginning of my plan for this school year.

To completely alter the narrative centered around Evan.

I needed to shift the entire flow of this academy.

And for that, I needed power.

The kind of authority that could sway the academy.

The first step to gaining such power was to secure the student council president's seat.

It was the only position that provided vast information access, and the legitimate authority to influence the academy.

Of course, I knew that Rie intended to run for the position.

That's why I was hesitant to tell her.

We'd become opponents after all.

Still, it was a conversation we had to have eventually.

"So... have you decided who you'd want in the student council if you win?"

Rie stumbled over her words, still processing the situation.

“I haven’t finalized it yet. But I have a few in mind.”

The entrance exam for freshmen.

That was why I was there.

After the exam, I approached a freshman named Kuhn.

He was an alchemy student with a remarkable talent for both magic and alchemy.

A prodigious talent held back by his commoner status.

I met him and asked him to join the student council I was planning to form.

He left without saying much, but I was set on bringing him into the council.

Apart from him, I didn’t have anyone else in mind.

If it didn't work out, I even thought of placing Luna in a Vice President kind of role.

“Ugh...”

Rie was deep in thought.

And then, with a frustrated expression, she blurted out.

“Just take the Vice President position! Let me be the President!!!”

“I don’t want to.”

“It’s almost the same thing anyway!!!”

“Then why don't you become the Vice President?”

“Ugh...!!!”

Rie glared at me, fuming.

The conversation felt childish.

Like a squabble between little kids.

No matter what Rie said, I wasn't going to change my mind.

Of course, things would be more comfortable if Rie were the student council president.

We got along relatively well, and she respected my opinions.

But that didn't mean there were no issues.

In the end, if I wanted something done, I would have to ask her.

The decision to act on it would be hers.

Having the position of student council president allowed me to act freely and do as I pleased.

"So, let's have a fair competition for the student council presidency."

I offered my hand to Rie.

However, Rie stared at my hand for a moment before opening her mouth.

"I don't want to..."

"Huh...?"

"I said, no."

I was taken aback by her response.

"So, you're saying you're not going to play fair and rig the election?"

"That's not what I'm saying!"

Rie protested, giving my stomach a playful jab.

"Then what is it?"

"..."

Rie lowered her head, continuing to jab at my stomach.

"Hey, that's starting to hurt."

Upon hearing this, Rie stopped and looked up.

And then she spoke.

"I'll be the Vice President..."

"...What?"

Rie exclaimed with a frown.

"I said, I want to be the Vice President!!!"

"...???"

What was she talking about?

I looked at Rie with surprise.

It was completely unexpected.

I never asked Rie to be Vice President because I knew she'd never want to be beneath anyone due to her personality.

Or at least, that's what I thought.

Rie shook her head, seemingly irritated.

"In one of our assessments, I realized that competing with someone you know is really unpleasant. I already have enough opponents; why would I fight against someone who's supposed to be on my side? I absolutely hate it."

Rie said with determination.

"Let's do it together. The student council."

I stared at Rie, completely taken aback.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 102: When Winter Ends, Spring Comes (6)

Robert's Laboratory.

With an uncharacteristically serious expression, Robert stared at the document in his hand.

This was a report about the Fred family territory, a place Robert recently visited.

Although he had initially approached them for something else, it unexpectedly led to a more significant discovery: the connection between Levian and the Fred family.

The Fred family had been crafting magical tools since ancient times.

Naturally, crafting such tools requires magic circles.

In this process, a link to Levian, a master of these circles, was discovered.

Among the findings was Levian's research material stored within the Fred family's archives.

And this wasn't just any regular research.

"Damned fiends..."

Robert muttered under his breath.

Prominently mentioned in the documents was something deeply unsettling: human sacrifices and experiments related to magic tool creation.

Instead of conventional methods, they had tools crafted by sacrificing humans.

Details revealed that Levian's name was involved, indicating his participation in this disturbing research.

The timeline of this research began approximately three years before Levian's disappearance and concluded precisely on the day he vanished.

Robert thought deeply.

The magic book that Luna possessed from Levian.

Could it possibly be a result of this research?

However, there was no definitive proof.

The essential parts of these research materials were encrypted, making it difficult to understand the exact nature of the work.

From what he could piece together, after fleeing, Levian ended up in the Railer family territory without anything other than the magic book Luna now holds.

Meanwhile, the Fred family aggressively looked for him.

Piecing all of this together, the only plausible conclusion was that Levian had run away with the results of his research.

"But something doesn't add up..."

Assuming Levian had run away with the research results, why didn't the Fred family have their own copies?

The research logs showed that Levian wasn't working alone; there were traces of the Fred family's involvement.

Logically, the Fred family should've been able to reproduce the research results on their own.

Yet, they hadn't.

Instead of pursuing the research independently, they only pursued Levian.

While it was understandable they might be wary of Levian potentially leaking the research, it was strange that the Fred family hadn't created anything themselves.

Even if Levian held some unique knowledge, he'd disappeared almost 7-8 years ago.

With the resources and expertise at their disposal, the Fred family should've been able to continue and possibly complete the research.

But they didn't.

They abandoned the research the moment Levian disappeared.

Robert wondered: why would they make such a choice?

And then...

"Why did he say that to me?"

'You, who couldn't overcome your curiosity and greed, using human lives for magic. You cannot be my disciple.'

The words Levian had once said to him.

Right after the funeral of his own son, he said those words.

That moment was roughly a month before Levian disappeared.

Levian wasn't the only one who dabbled in the forbidden magic that took human sacrifices.

Robert had also tried his hand at it.

As a result, Robert lost his noble title, his mentor, and his son.

In a short span, he lost everything.

To live and to shake off his grief, he wandered battlefields.

There wasn't a battlefield teeming with monsters where Robert wasn't present, anywhere blood was spilled, he was there.

In such dire times, it was his friend Cromwell who came to his aid.

Thanks to Cromwell's suggestion, Robert could join the academy as a professor, allowing him to stay there till now.

With McDowell's help, he managed to keep his past a secret.

But the widely-known incident involving his once-famous son couldn't be kept a secret.

Still, Robert accepted this calmly.

He knew he was to blame for his actions.

"Haah..."

Robert set down the documents with a heavy exhale.

Levian's face flashed in his mind.

His mentor, who had once abandoned him.

To think that he did something similar...

No, something even worse than what Robert had done, made anger course through him.

"That damn fool..."

Robert's words were filled with anger, sorrow, and a profound sense of loss.

The day before the entrance ceremony.

"Senior~."

Yuni approached, calling out my name.

"How do you always know where I am?"

I frowned as I addressed Yuni.

I was at a training ground on the outskirts of the academy.

A place seldom visited.

I had chosen this secluded spot, thinking it would be spacious enough to practice magic.

But, as always, Yuni effortlessly found me.

"Well, I have my ways,"

Yuni said with a playful smirk.

I stared at her, then looked around.

"Why do you keep coming here if you're just going to run away when Rie shows up?"

"Ah, I won't be running today."

I narrowed my eyes at her statement.

Yuni, noting my expression, pointed towards the academy's main building.

"Sis is meeting with Cromwell right now."

I frowned at her casual tone.

"Regardless of how close you are, refer to him as 'Vice Principal.' Calling him without his title is a bit disrespectful, isn't it?"

She pouted,

"What's with 'Vice Principal'? His name is Cromwell, so I call him that."

While I felt her point was somewhat valid, it still felt proper to show respect.

"But shouldn't you at least use an honorific? Rie addresses him formally, you know."

"Nah, I like my way."

She stuck her tongue out slightly.

Though I was tempted to give her a gentle knock on the head, I held back, considering the repercussions of handling a royal body in such a manner.

"But I'll keep calling you 'Senior*' since you seem worthy of respect!"

"Thanks," I said.

I wanted to ask, 'What do you know about me to deem me more respectable than Professor Cromwell?' but refrained, realizing it would only lengthen the conversation.

"Anyway, stop visiting so often. You always come and just... watch."

I grumbled at Yuni.

Lately, her frequent visits meant I developed a habit of postponing tasks until after she left.

It was more efficient that way, given how distracting Yuni could be.

"Can't I just come to see someone I like?"

She tilted her head, wearing a mischievous grin.

"Stop lying. It's obvious."

As I said this, Yuni slowly walked towards me.

Stopping right in front of me, she looked up directly into my eyes.

"What does 'liking' even mean? Isn't it just what one feels?"

She asked with a playful smile.

I just shook my head.

"It's not that simple."

"Can you define love, Rudy?"

"I can't define it, but I'm sure what you're feeling isn't love."

Upon hearing my words, Yuni pouted and stepped back.

"You're quite the heartbreaker, aren't you? Even when a girl expresses her love like this, you continue to reject her."

"Think whatever you want."

As I tried to end the conversation, Yuni stopped pressing the issue, seemingly losing interest.

Regardless of whether Yuni was watching, I returned my focus to my original task.

After a while, Yuni, looking slightly tired, took a seat on a nearby bench.

From there, she attentively watched my every move.

After a significant amount of time had passed,

"Phew..."

I finished preparing the magic.

A spell that uses mana stones as a medium.

Although it's an expensive spell—consuming one mana stone for a single use—its effectiveness is undisputed.

I was in the midst of testing it out.

Typically, all you needed for this spell were a mana stone and your own body.

However, I brought along some protective gear and some items just in case, causing the preparation to take longer than expected.

Having completed all preparations, I stole a glance behind me.

Yuni was on the bench, curled up with her legs folded.

Despite yawning and wiping away a tear, probably out of boredom, she remained in her spot, continuing to watch me.

I doubted the magic would affect Yuni, given the distance between us.

After all, this was a summoning spell.

I began to channel my mana, wrapping the mana stone with it.

The mana stone was encased once, then twice, and again and again.

Soon, the multi-layered mana stone began to emit a radiant glow.

But as it grew brighter, cracks started forming on its surface.

Timing it perfectly, I chanted,

"I Summon thee, Behemoth."

Just as the sea has Leviathan, a demon governing the waters, the earth has Behemoth, a demon governing the land, capable of utilizing abilities related to all minerals, soil, and terrain.

Behemoth was one of the higher-ranking demons that could be summoned through dark magic.

With Professor Robert's guidance, I managed to get a rough understanding of it.

However...

"Ugh..."

A powerful gust of wind suddenly blew, and the ground cracked open to reveal Behemoth emerging from the rift.

The figure of Behemoth emerging from the torn ground...

"Pwoo.."

"Oh my, how cute."

...was a tiny elephant.

The very elephant that had protected us during our battle with Vice Principal Oliver.

Its true identity was none other than Behemoth.

But instead of the colossal form that Robert had previously summoned, what stood before me now was an elephant no bigger than the fist of a grown man.

"...Is this considered a success?"

"Pwooooh~~~!!"

However, the elephant's reaction seemed off.

It appeared to be stomping its foot as if it were angry.

I slowly approached the behemoth.

And then I spoke.

“What's bothering you?”

“Pwooooh! Pwooooh!! Pwooooh!!!”

What is it saying?

“How dare such a weakling summon me! Someone of your caliber has no right to call upon me!”

From behind, Yuni spat out these words. I turned to look at her.

“...What are you doing?”

Yuni didn't respond to me but just kept staring at the elephant... no, the behemoth.

“Pwooooh! Pwooooh!”

“Summoning me, of all beings! It's a disgrace to our lineage!”

Yuni seemed to be interpreting the behemoth's cries.

Rubbing my chin, I looked at Yuni and asked,

“You can understand what it's saying?”

I pointed at the behemoth as I spoke.

Yuni looked at me with a puzzled expression.

“No? I just tried guessing. How could anyone understand what ‘pwooooh pwooooh’ means?”

Yuni replied as if it was obvious.

“...”

All I could do was stare blankly at her.

---Toggle New Ads

Another one later. ('-*∩

*hmm I decided that when she calls 'Senior Rudy' it'll just be Rudy, but when she calls him by just senior but no name, I'll have it as senior.

Chapter 103: Student Council Election2 (1)

Typically, research labs were quiet.

There was hardly any chatter.

Everyone was too swamped and exhausted to chat.

However, this particular research lab was even quieter than the rest.

There were no sounds of footsteps or rustling papers, save for one individual.

“Ugh...”

This was Professor Gracie's lab.

Compared to other labs, it was almost empty, devoid of people or clutter.

The only thing present in this barren lab was an enormous pile of papers.

Gracie slouched dejectedly at her desk.

"I need an assistant..."

After becoming a professor, Gracie had tried fervently to recruit one.

However, the number of students who applied to be her assistant?

Zero.

Not a single one.

The potential teaching assistants knew all too well.

Joining Gracie's lab meant facing tremendous difficulties...

Why would they willingly enter Gracie's understaffed lab, when they knew they'd be swamped with work without any perks?

In other labs with more assistants, at least tasks were distributed.

But here, it was obvious that one would be overwhelmed without even the chance to leave work on time.

And it wasn't just the first-years who were reluctant.

Even the second and third-year students declined Gracie's offers.

By their second and third years, students had generally adapted to the academy's environment.

As a result, they saw no reason to join Gracie's new lab, especially when they could join more established professors.

“Should I try to lure in some freshmen...”

This year, Gracie was in charge of first-year students.

To be exact, she was teaching the top class of the first-years for practical magic.

The top class of practical magic was initially handled by Professor Cromwell.

Which meant Gracie had no choice but to take over.

While one might think that the top class should be managed by a more experienced professor, these were still first-year students.

Regardless of how exceptional they were compared to their peers, they were still novices.

Teaching them wasn't the issue.

However, recruiting them as teaching assistants was a different story.

Even the brightest among the first-year students were still just that – first years.

"Maybe I can just ask them for a little help with the paperwork..."

While first-year students might not be able to assist in the more complicated research, they could still handle routine paperwork.

Gracie glanced at a paper bag beside her and picked it up.

She opened the bag and began sifting through the papers inside.

These were documents detailing the entrance exam scores of first-year students and also listed the names of her students – those in the top practical magic class.

[

Practical Magic Class

Yuni Von Ristonia

Diark Verde

]

There were only two students in the top class.

And unfortunately, both were individuals she couldn't easily approach.

Yuni would never consider taking on the role of a teaching assistant, being the princess of the empire.

As for Diark...

"Why would a top student from a prestigious family even consider joining my lab?"

Diark is the sole heir of the Verdès family.

The Verdès family owns fertile farmland in the southern plains and has served under the empire for generations.

However, before Diark, the Verdès line hadn't produced any notable talents.

Given the prosperity brought by their fertile territories, the family never felt the need to excel.

Emerging from such an environment was their sole heir, Diark Verdès.

It was unlikely that such a cherished noble offspring, raised in luxury, would have any interest in joining her laboratory.

"Ugh..."

Gracie sighed deeply.

The new term had begun.

Freshmen had completed the entrance ceremony and were now officially part of the academy.

Now in my second year, I've started attending various new classes.

"Rudy, what's our next class?"

"Introduction to Dark Magic. It's Professor Robert's class."

Luna and I chatted as we walked toward the cafeteria.

Today marked the beginning of the new academic term, and there was much to discuss about our classes.

We exchanged information about which classes we liked, which professors taught well, and started planning potential changes to our schedules.

In our first year, we couldn't freely choose our class schedules, but from the second year onward, we had the freedom to customize them.

For instance, those in the Magic Department could choose which intermediate magic courses they wanted, including classes in magical tool creation, advanced rune studies, and practical magic applications, tailoring their classes according to their career path.

For me, I leaned towards dark magic and practical magic classes, while Luna focused on courses related to magical tools and runes.

Of course, there were other mandatory courses we had to sign up for - the general education courses.

While you'd choose general education courses based on personal interest, there was one crucial thing to consider: which classes had fewer assignments, easier exams, and more lenient professors.

Frankly, while general education courses were designed to broaden one's horizons, they shouldn't be the main focus.

As a student of the Magic Department, my main priority should be magic.

Dedicating too much time to general studies would only be detrimental.

So, Luna and I aimed to choose the ones that demanded the least amount of our time.

"Shall we go for 'Royal Politics' then?"

"Yeah, sounds good."

While Luna and I were deep in conversation on our way to the cafeteria, we noticed a commotion ahead.

"Sigh... Just because you were lucky enough to be born a noble, you think you can talk so much."

I frowned at the scene.

A male student, known as a commoner, stood defensively with a female student hiding behind him, confronted by a noble student.

And that commoner boy was someone I knew.

Letting out a sigh, my expression changed, and I began walking towards them, calling out to the commoner student.

"Kuhn, how have you been?"

Kuhn.

He was the guy I spoke to during the freshman entrance exam.

And here he was, already in a conflict with another student so soon into the new term.

Seeing my approach with a smile, Kuhn's face twisted in discomfort.

"Ugh..."

When I called Kuhn's name, the noble student facing him looked at me, his eyes widening in surprise.

"Ah... Rudy Astria..."

I cast a side glance at the girl hiding behind Kuhn.

It was Emily, Kuhn's childhood friend.

After briefly meeting her gaze, I turned back to Kuhn.

"Kuhn, don't you think we have some things to discuss?"

With that said, I smiled at the noble student standing opposite Kuhn.

“Can I take this guy with me for a moment?”

At that, he looked taken aback and nodded vigorously.

“Do as you wish! Please, take him!”

Hearing this, I turned my gaze to Kuhn.

“Let's grab a meal together.”

Hearing my invitation, Luna tilted her head and asked from behind me,

“Who is he?”

I gave a faint smile,

“A junior I've taken a keen interest in.”

With that, I led Kuhn and Emily to the cafeteria.

Luna took a seat beside me, while Kuhn and Emily settled down across from us.

As soon as they were seated, Emily bowed her head towards me,

“Thank you for saving me...”

“It's nothing,”

I brushed off her gratitude and looked at Kuhn.

His black hair obscured his eyes, giving him a rather brooding appearance.

Directly, I posed my question to him,

“So, Kuhn, what have you decided about my proposal?”

Kuhn hesitated before speaking,

“You probably already know what I'm going to say.”

His words referred to our previous encounter.

I had approached Kuhn before and suggested that we work together in the student council.

He scoffed and walked away.

A clear rejection.

Yet, I had my reasons for asking again.

“Umm... I’m sorry,”

Emily began hesitantly,

“But what are you talking about?”

Emily was the reason.

During the freshman entrance exam, I had spoken only to Kuhn.

Even though I knew he would refuse, I decided to give it a shot.

As expected, he turned me down.

So I decided to bring it up again but in Emily's presence.

As I explained the situation to Emily, she turned to Kuhn with a smile,

“Kuhn?”

“I said no. I'm not doing it.”

“Kuhn???”

"I... I won't do it..."

The usually brusque and prickly Kuhn was visibly flustered when Emily pressured him.

To Kuhn, Emily was his greatest vulnerability, yet also his greatest strength.

They had grown up together in an orphanage and shared a bond that was both a deep friendship and a budding romance.

If it was Emily, he would inevitably relent.

After all, the only reason he was refusing was because of my noble status.

Luna watched their playful banter with a warm smile,

“You two seem really close. Hehe.”

Hearing this, Emily, who was busy glaring at Kuhn, glanced at Luna and replied with a light laugh,

“You two seniors also seem to have a good relationship!”

“Huh??”

“Hmm?”

Both Luna and I looked at Emily with bewilderment.

Emily's eyes widened in realization, her face showing a hint of regret,

“Oh... Were you two not...? I'm so, so sorry!!”

As Emily bowed her head in embarrassment, Luna waved her hands dismissively,

“No, no! There's no need to apologize. It's fine.”

“Ah, so you are dating... or, not...?”

Emily's gaze darted between the two of us, her face filled with confusion.

At the training grounds on the outskirts of the academy.

Yuni strolled leisurely toward it.

"Why do the people I'm looking for always prefer such secluded places?"

Grumbling, Yuni stepped inside.

Inside, a man was focused on his sword practice.

"Hello?"

Yuni greeted the man with a warm smile.

Hearing her voice, the man turned his head.

"You're Evan, the top student of the second year, right?"

"I am Evan, yes. But who are you?"

In response to Evan's words, Yuni introduced herself politely.

"I'm Yuni Von Ristonia, a first-year student here."

And with a playful grin, she added,

"How about teaming up with me?"

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 104: Student Council Election2 (2)

"In the North, every four years, a massive magical beast attacks the fortress. Significant support is provided from the center, and our Liberion Academy also lends a hand."

During the second-year general elective class on Magical Beast Studies, the professor spoke.

"These beasts possess no rationality and are void of emotions like fear. Given that such an attack is anticipated this year, some of you might even be dispatched there."

As I listened to the professor, I tapped my desk with my fingers.

"Now, don't worry too much. The academy wouldn't put the students in too much danger. While students undoubtedly provide assistance, the main purpose of your involvement is to gain experience. After all, we have numerous veterans experienced with these beast attacks."

The professor seemed to think our grim expressions were due to fear.

He couldn't be more off the mark.

Noticing something was wrong, the professor glanced at the clock.

Class had already exceeded its scheduled time by over 15 minutes.

Seeing the students' frustrated faces, the professor chuckled,

"Ah, look at the time. My apologies, we'll conclude today's lesson here."

At his words, a collective sigh of relief spread throughout the class.

On the first day, we already had an extended lecture.

"This just won't do..."

I mumbled to myself.

I contemplated dropping this course and taking another elective.

Besides the Royal Politics course that Luna and I planned to sign up for, there were a few other electives to consider.

But this one just didn't seem right.

After all, my real opponents aren't monsters; they're people.

There's no point in learning extensively about monsters.

With that thought, I began to walk.

The afternoon following the end of the class was bathed in the gentle warmth of spring.

However, I had an errand to run.

I exited the Academy and headed towards a certain bakery.

"Ah, you're here?"

Rie, sipping her tea, greeted me at the bakery.

"Why meet outside? Couldn't we have just met inside the academy?"

The student council presidential elections were gradually approaching, and it was time to start preparing.

While sipping her tea with a sly smile, Rie responded,

"This place is delicious, right? Discussing matters over something tasty might lead to better ideas."

This was the bakery where Rie and I had tea after school.

Although we didn't have tea that time, I recalled the delightful snacks we had enjoyed.

I took a seat opposite Rie.

"Do we even need 'better ideas'?"

Frankly, there wasn't much to worry about for the upcoming election.

There weren't any second-year students capable of running, and with Rie's reputation, the student council president's position was practically guaranteed.

She smirked,

"True. So, do you dislike having tea with me? Or are you planning to pick a fight?"

"I apologize. I'll just quietly have my tea."

I yielded, wilting under Rie's playful tease.

Rie had decided to become the vice president, but I never saw her as someone subordinate to me.

If Rie had truly run for the student council presidency, even I wouldn't be certain of victory.

But Rie stepped back out of consideration for me.

"So, when should we get the recommendations from the professors?"

"It's easy to get the recommendation letters. Just get them from Professor Robert and Professor McGuire. I'll take care of the rest."

"What about the other student council members?"

"For the first year, that guy you mentioned, Kuhn, and a couple others should do. For higher positions, it's best to go with familiar faces like Locke and Luna. Luna has her teaching assistant duties, so she might be busy, but it's always better if someone we know fills the higher roles."

I was comforted by Rie's confident attitude.

It seemed she had already thought through all the parts I was still wondering about.

While we were on the topic of second-year students, Rie suddenly clapped her hands and asked,

"Speaking of which, why hasn't Yeniel come back?"

"Huh?"

Yeniel hasn't come back?

Caught off guard by the unexpected question, my expression turned bewildered.

I hadn't thought about Yeniel at all.

She wasn't the type to stand out much anyway.

Plus, since Astina had been overseeing matters related to Yeniel, I hadn't paid her much mind.

"You don't know either? I thought you'd know something."

Could she still be with the Rebels?

Or something else...

Seeing my worried face, Rie sighed.

"Maybe I shouldn't have mentioned it. If anything had happened, Astina would have told us. Since we haven't heard anything, let's just wait a bit longer."

"Mmm..."

Despite Rie's words, I couldn't shake off the unease.

Still, Yaniel, being a former assassin from the Rebels, I expected her to return somehow.

But when I thought of the leader of the Rebels, I couldn't help but feel anxious.

Noticing my frown, Rie waved her hands dismissively.

"Let's leave that topic. I've been curious about something else."

"What are you curious about?"

Rie then leaned forward, giving me a probing look.

"Is Yuni still flirting with you?"

"...Flirting?"

Describing Yuni's actions towards me as 'flirting' made me chuckle.

Of course, Yuni has blonde hair*, but that's hardly relevant here.

"You said she confessed and you turned her down. So why does she keep sticking around you?"

"I'm not sure about that either. I'm actually more curious."

The fact that Yuni had confessed to me.

Everyone at the academy knew about it.

It was bound to spread since the confession took place in front of so many people.

“Stay away from her. She's really shady and weird. Never, ever, EVER! get close to her,”

Rie warned me about Yuni with great emphasis.

“But she's your family...”

“Oh my, what does being family have to do with anything?”

Just as she was about to respond, someone suddenly interrupted from behind.

I turned to see a beaming Yuni.

Rie jumped up from her seat, startled.

“Why are you here?”

“It’s not like I can’t be here. Right, Rudy?”

Yuni glanced at me cheekily.

“Well, I suppose so, but...”

Rie's brow furrowed.

“Wait, Rudy, are you siding with her?”

“I’m not really taking sides. She just...”

"It's just stating the obvious, right, Senior?"

Yuni interrupted with a teasing tone.

“Ugh...”

Rie clenched her fist, glaring at me, while Yuni watched with a mischievous grin.

However, Yuni then changed her tone, clapping her hands,

“I didn’t come here to discuss that. I have something else to say.”

Rie narrowed her eyes, giving Yuni a displeased look.

"What do you want now? If you're heartbroken, stay in your room and cry like a tragic heroine. Why do you keep showing up?"

"Mind your own business. This isn't about you. What are you to him? His lover?"

“Lover?!”

Caught off guard by Yuni’s words, Rie stepped back hesitantly.

“I might like him, but what are you to him? Nothing, right?”

Yuni’s rapid-fire questions clearly flustered Rie.

I stood up, approaching Yuni.

Without holding back, I thumped Yuni on the head.

Thump!

"Ow!"

Yuni clutched her throbbing head, tears forming in her eyes, and looked up at me in disbelief.

“Senior?”

I frowned at her.

“What are you doing? If you came to cause trouble, leave.”

“But...”

Seeing her hesitation, I snapped,

“If you won't leave, then we will.”

I walked over to Rie and grabbed her wrist. “Come on.”

“Wait, what?”

As I led Rie towards the exit, Yuni suddenly grabbed Rie's other wrist, stopping us.

"Don't go!"

I responded firmly,

“We’re leaving.”

“Please stay!”

“We’re going.”

Yuni and I began to pull on Rie’s arms in a tug-of-war fashion.

“Ow! Why are you suddenly doing this with me in the middle?”

Caught in between, Rie's arms were being yanked from both sides.

With a quick tug, I pulled Rie towards me.

“Ah!”

In doing so, Rie stumbled into my embrace.

I steadied her, our eyes meeting.

“Are you okay?”

“Huh?”

She appeared a bit dazed but didn't seem hurt.

I gently let go of her and we continued walking forward when Yuni's voice rang out.

“I'm sorry!”

I turned to face Yuni, who had raised her voice.

“I apologize! Please, just hear me out for a moment!”

Yuni said with a somewhat embarrassed look.

I let go of Rie's wrist and crossed my arms, staring intently at Yuni.

“Go on.”

“I mean...”

Her voice trailed off as she cast a frustrated glance at me, and I couldn't help but see a resemblance in her expression to Rie's.

I had to suppress a chuckle, but I kept my stern demeanor.

If I showed weakness now, I'd end up being pushed around by Yuni.

I waited for her to continue.

“I didn't want to bring this up like this, but... um...”

Her gaze dropped, and she murmured something under her breath before looking back at me.

“I'm planning to run for student council president.”

“...What?”

I raised an eyebrow at her sudden announcement.

She's considering the role of student council president? As a first-year?

It wasn't against the academy's rules for a first-year to run, but it was unconventional.

While the academy prided itself on its liberal environment, there were still traditions.

Typically, a second-year student would run for president.

On the rare occasions that a first-year did run, their chances of winning were slim.

“I have a strategy to win, the right people to help me, and I’m confident,”

Yuni said with determination.

“But if you, Rudy, were to date me, I won’t run. If I don't enter the race, it would be much easier for you to secure the president’s position.”

With that, Yuni extended her hand towards me, flashing a captivating smile.

"So, what do you say?"

Chapter 105: Student Council Election² (3)

“I don’t need that.”

I glared arrogantly at Yuni.

“You can't beat me.”

Hearing that, Yuni smirked.

“Is that so? From what I see, I think otherwise.”

Yuni responded before heading towards the entrance.

"Well, if you change your mind, come see me anytime. I can give someone like you a couple of chances."

I watched as Yuni's figure receded towards the entrance.

Then, turning to Rie standing beside me, I smiled playfully.

"Looks like things are about to get busy, huh?"

Rie stared intently at me, posing a question.

"Why... did you refuse her offer?"

"Am I crazy? Why would I accept such a proposal?"

It was an obvious choice.

I wasn't entirely sure of the exact reason Yuni wanted to date me, but it was clear she had some political motives.

It made no sense to accept an offer with such blatant intentions.

I might have considered it if she had been honest about what she wanted.

But accepting an offer without knowing her real intent was foolish.

And there was another reason I declined: Rie.

Rie had given up the position of student council president for me, choosing to be the Vice President instead.

We never explicitly stated a hierarchy between us, but it's obvious what it would look like to the public.

It was a risky move for Rie, someone who aspires to be the next Emperor.

If rumors spread about Yuni dating me in such a situation, it could jeopardize Rie's standing.

With her younger sister being my lover – an equal partnership – and Rie working under me, it would surely damage her reputation.

Rie trusted me.

She trusted me enough to take on the role of Vice President.

Accepting Yuni's offer just to get an easy path to the presidency would be betraying Rie's trust and expectations.

I have to earn that position with my own efforts.

It's the least I can do to repay Rie's trust.

Although the Emperor had asked me to stop any fights between the two, this couldn't be helped.

It wasn't a petty feud.

If someone challenges me, they need to be put in their place.

Seeing my smile, Rie nudged me slightly.

"So, why did you refuse again?"

Not wanting to explain everything in detail, I joked in a light-hearted tone.

"She's not my type."

"...What?"

"She's too childish. I don't want to date someone like that."

Rie looked at me, seemingly bewildered.

Then, she hesitantly asked,

"So... what is your type?"

"Huh?"

I was only joking earlier, but her serious reaction caught me off guard.

"Uh... I haven't given it much thought?"

"You must have a rough idea, right?"

"Is that important?"

As I tilted my head inquisitively, Rie answered with a stern face.

"It is."

"Uh..."

After a moment's hesitation, I spoke.

"Like a 'virtuous wife*'?"

"What?"

"Kind, wise, beautiful... something like that?"

Upon hearing that, Rie chuckled.

“Like me?”

“...”

I wanted to tease her, but it wasn't entirely wrong.

I did think Rie would make a good wife.

“Hehe, I am quite perfect, aren't I?”

Seeing Rie puffing up with pride, I instantly regretted my words.

As time passed, the student council president election applications were closed.

There were two candidates: my name and Yuni's.

I quickly scanned the list of members in Yuni's proposed student council.

Two names stood out: Diark Verdes and Evan, the top students from the first and second years, respectively.

I wasn't surprised by Diark, knowing his ambitious nature.

But seeing Evan's name puzzled me.

Why did Evan join Yuni's student council?

Why did Yuni invite Evan to the council?

These questions quickly vanished from my mind.

I soon realized Yuni's motive for including Evan, as well as her strategy.

Yuni aimed to divide and conquer.

As I walked around the academy, I overheard whispers about me.

"Just how power-hungry are those nobles?"

"Aren't those guys set for life even after graduating from the academy?"

"It's always the ones who have everything who want even more."

Yuni and Evan shared something in common.

Evan, despite being the top student, was a commoner.

And Yuni, while the second princess, was further down the line of succession.

On the other hand, our council had Rie and me.

Although I had been overshadowed in the line of succession, I was gaining public support.

Plus, Rie was already being heralded as a potential future emperor, showcasing great promise.

We already held significant power and influence, which in turn, made it hard for us to gain the empathy of the people.

Logically, capable and influential people should lead the student council, but votes often aren't driven by logic.

Yuni's council exploited this.

This was the narrative they were pushing: our student council was already powerful.

Us taking over the student council would be a monopolization of power.

We already have everything, why hold onto the student council as well?

"Why should Rudy have all the power?"

Voices echoing such sentiments started spreading across the academy.

"Why is everyone being so unfair to Rudy?!"

Luna had heard various rumors while working as a teaching assistant, and she seemed deeply upset by them.

"Both Rudy and Rie earned their positions through hard work! They've worked even harder than the rest!"

Indeed, Rie and I had put in immense effort to be where we are today.

Asking us to step down from the student council election just because of our current positions, felt rather extreme.

I let out a sigh,

"That's how the public sees us; there's not much we can do about it right now..."

"But still..."

As Luna's voice began to rise, someone suddenly covered her mouth.

"Mmph...!"

Turning around, I saw Ena holding her hand over Luna's mouth, while Riku stood beside them.

Ena spoke softly,

"There are many people around."

Many people were in the cafeteria right now.

Speaking so openly like this is risky.

"It's unfair, but what can we do?"

Ena said as she placed a tray next to Luna.

"That's just how it is these days."

she added.

"What do you mean?"

Luna tilted her head, looking at Ena.

"Recently, the opinion on The Rebels has been favorable. Both inside and outside the academy..."

I nodded, recalling the stories I had heard from Rie.

The reasons why such an atmosphere could form were largely due to The Rebels.

According to Rie, Yuni's recruitment of Evan was also for this reason.

"The Rebels claim that they want to break the system where only the powerful monopolize everything... It seems many have embraced that idea."

The academy wasn't just for the nobility.

Surprisingly, many commoners were present.

Of course, these commoners were children of wealthy merchants and the like.

However, it's difficult for them to achieve a noble's status.

Merely having wealth doesn't grant you a spot among the nobles.

It requires ability — in magic, swordsmanship, or politics — to rise above one's station.

The class limitations.

The Rebels targeted this frustration.

Nobles monopolize power, and the higher-ranking nobles hoard it even more.

Therefore, this system should be overturned.

That was the logic of The Rebels.

I was bewildered.

A position earned through hard work, maintained through continuous effort, and yet they talk about monopolization of power?

While I don't particularly understand, not everyone actually agrees with their logic.

Some might feign agreement for their own gain, while others might genuinely agree with that perspective.

It's an unavoidable situation.

The real issue is that this sentiment cannot be ignored in the current elections.

Evan, a commoner, managed to outshine the Royal princess and a duke's offspring, securing the top rank.

To the commoners, Evan was nothing short of a hero.

On the other hand, Yuni represented the face of the noble faction.

If the Astria family was at the heart of the nobility, then Yuni was its face.

Even if Yuni didn't hold much sway among the noble faction, she was indispensable to them.

Her presence validated their cause.

She was the only figure within the noble faction who could potentially occupy the emperor's seat.

This fact earned Yuni the support of many in the noble faction for the student council elections.

To some within the noble faction, I seemed like a traitor, and there seemed to be a lingering resentment toward that.

Yuni's student council received support from both the noble faction and the commoners.

However, our faction didn't have such a solid base of supporters.

We seemed to have taken a somewhat naive approach to politics.

Even if Rie tried to assure me with a smile that everything would be okay, I couldn't help but worry.

"So, what are you all planning to do?"

Ena asked, looking at me.

Both Ena and Riku, having known me for some time, wore expressions of concern.

I responded quietly to the concerned Ena.

"I've been considering a few things, but I haven't come to a plan of action yet."

Luna then looked at me and smiled.

“Rudy can do it! Especially with Rie by his side. If there’s any way I can help, I’ll give it my all.”

“Thank you, Luna.”

For now, the responsibility Rie entrusted to me was to carry on with the election campaign as usual and not to be fazed by this situation.

I did my best to fulfill the tasks Rie had asked of me.

In terms of politics, she had always been a step ahead of me.

She had managed to overcome the challenges of various factions in the Royal Palace and confidently forge her own path.

Given the trust Rie had in me, I decided to trust and wait for her in return.

While doing the best I could...

Rie was on her way to the library with a book in hand, as Rudy and Luna had proposed they study together today.

Although the student council elections were important, she couldn't neglect her studies.

With midterms approaching right after the elections, it was important to prepare in advance.

While walking down the corridor, she spotted Yuni standing in the middle of the hallway, looking directly at her.

Instead of acknowledging her, Rie chose to walk past.

"Big sister."

Yuni's voice stopped Rie.

Without turning to face her, Rie replied,

“I have nothing to discuss with you.”

Yuni gazed at Rie with an arrogant look.

"Do you think just because you and senior are working hard, you can win this election?"

Ignoring her, Rie continued to walk.

However, Yuni continued,

"It's no big deal. Just hand over senior to me. If you give him to me, then..."

Hearing that, Rie stopped in her tracks and turned to face Yuni.

"The election? Let me ask you. Do you think we'd lose to someone like you, someone who isn't even taking this seriously?"

Rie took a step, then another, moving closer to Yuni, and added,

"And..."

She said, her eyes burning with anger,

"Rudy isn't an object."

---Toggle New Ads

*virtuous wife here is more an informal/cultural term that is later explained that it doesn't exist in this world. She just thinks his type is 'Kind, wise, beautiful....' but doesn't know it's all that + 'wife'.

And I will say uh, I personally found Yuni annoying at the start, but it does get better!

Chapter 106: Student Council Election2 (4)

“Luna, Rudy.”

Rie greeted us with a gentle wave as she entered the library.

“Oh, Rie, you're here?”

Luna cheerfully greeted Rie in response.

I also lifted my head slightly and raised a hand in greeting.

Rie looked at both of us and smiled warmly.

“You two are studying hard.”

“We have to. It's midterm season,”

I replied, shrugging as if it was only natural.

Rie chuckled.

“Are you aiming for second place again?”

I frowned at Rie's joke.

“Don't you remember? I ranked first during the last final exam.”

“But you only tied for first place, right?”

I shot Rie a slightly annoyed look.

A tied first place is still a first place.

She felt the sting of my look, then turned her gaze to Luna, tilting her head slightly.

“By the way, Luna, shouldn't you be busy with your teaching assistant duties?”

“Oh, I've already finished all my tasks.”

“...You finished them all?”

Rie looked at Luna with a puzzled expression.

It was unheard of for a teaching assistant to finish all their work.

Normally, as soon as one task is completed, another one is assigned.

However, Luna claiming she had completed all her work was indeed curious.

“Did you just run away from your tasks?”

Rie questioned jokingly.

“No, not at all! First Rudy, and now you too, Rie?”

Luna responded, waving her hands in protest.

Seeing Rie's baffled expression, I spoke up in Luna's defense.

“Rie, it seems Luna is even more competent than I initially thought.”

“What do you mean?”

It turned out she genuinely had finished all her tasks.

I initially thought that, as a student, Luna was given less work.

But that wasn't the case.

Luna's efficiency surpassed everyone else's.

She wrapped up tasks at an incredible speed, to the point where she ran out of things to do, even outpacing the graduate teaching assistants.

Considering Luna's diligent nature, she wasn't the type to shirk her responsibilities.

This meant she had indeed completed all her assigned duties in the lab.

"Professor McGuire must be over the moon,"

Rie remarked.

"More than the professor, the other teaching assistants are probably crying tears of joy,"

I chuckled, imagining the scene.

I understood now why Professor McGuire was so fond of Luna, and why the other teaching assistants always spoke so highly of her.

Luna giggled modestly, brushing off the praise,

"Hehehe..."

But I had something more important I was wondering about,

"Rie, how are things with the student council elections?"

The current election campaign was proceeding with the help of others, and although we were maintaining our momentum, the situation had not changed much.

Yuni's student council had a solid support base that was becoming more consolidated.

The student council president election was just 10 days away.

Although the elections were just a few days away, Rie still hadn't done anything to counter Yuni.

However, Rie behaved confidently, as if everything was normal.

"You don't trust me? I'm a 'Hyunmoyangcheo*'. "

"...What?"

Hearing that, my eyes widened in surprise. Luna, who was standing next to me, tilted her head and asked,

"What's a 'Hyunmoyangcheo'?"

I inwardly groaned upon hearing the question.

'Hyunmoyangcheo' was not a word that existed in this world.

"Rudy briefly explained it to me. It's a term referring to someone wise, kind, and beautiful."

"Oh, that sounds nice."

I laughed awkwardly in response.

Originally, 'Hyunmoyangcheo' meant a good mother and a good wife.

Sure, it encompassed the notion of someone being wise and such, but that wasn't its precise definition.

I was taken aback to see the term being misinterpreted this way.

"Then I want to be a 'Hyunmoyangcheo' too! I'll work hard, Rudy!"

"No, no, that's not exactly..."

Flustered, I was about to wave my hands and clarify.

But I eventually decided against it.

After all, no one here really knew the true meaning of 'Hyunmoyangcheo'.

It might be alright to let it slide and allow them to use it in this way.

Although hearing such a term directed at me did feel a bit odd.

Noticing my slightly uneasy expression, Rie gave a faint smile.

"Don't worry. I've deliberately been waiting for the elections to draw closer."

"Huh?"

I tilted my head in confusion.

Rie seemed to think my earlier bewilderment was about the upcoming election.

"Supporters gathered hastily often scatter just as quickly."

Rie smirked.

"Ugh... How did I end up in this mess?"

Kuhn leaned against the corridor wall, frowning deeply.

From the start, Kuhn never intended to join the student council.

Neither when he first entered the academy nor when Rudy suggested it.

If he joined, he'd have less time to spend with Emily.

Ever since he was young, Kuhn had made a promise: to protect Emily.

If he became part of the student council, his time with her would diminish, and he couldn't protect her as he wanted.

That's why he was against joining.

But what Kuhn hadn't considered...

"Wait... you get these benefits from the student council?"

"They offer this even after graduation?"

"No way!"

Instead of persuading Kuhn, Rudy approached Emily.

And Emily was easily convinced.

When she learned about the benefits and privileges of joining the student council and what lay in store for members afterward, her eyes widened in astonishment.

"Kuhn, we absolutely have to do this. There's no other option!"

Emily is usually quite reserved.

But she's always had a strong survival instinct; whenever money or benefits were involved, she'd become uncharacteristically eager.

Once Rudy successfully persuaded Emily, Kuhn found himself without a counterargument.

“What kind of person does that?”

Rudy Astria knew too much about him and Emily.

Watching Rudy speak to Emily, occasionally shooting him mischievous glances and smirking, Kuhn couldn't help but feel he'd been duped by a con artist.

But Rudy wasn't the only one.

"Hey, aren't you free?"

A few days after joining the student council, Kuhn was summoned by Rie.

"Make this potion for me. Once you're done, tell me. I'll let you know what you have to do next."

Kuhn looked at the vial in his hand. It was the potion that Rie had instructed him to make.

He sighed deeply, leaning against the wall, and glanced down the hallway.

From afar, he spotted Diark Verdès, chatting with a few others as they approached.

Kuhn took another deep breath, "These sly foxes..." picturing Rie and Rudy sharing a sinister laugh.

With another sigh, he poured the prepared potion into his coffee, making sure not to inhale the potion's fumes as he did.

As he prepared himself, Kuhn heard snippets of Diark's conversation,

"...So, with Princess Yuni..."

As Diark's voice grew louder, Kuhn suddenly darted out from his hiding spot.

Wham!

"Ugh!"

"Tch."

As Kuhn emerged, Diark couldn't react in time.

They collided, and Kuhn's coffee, now mixed with the potion, splashed all over Diark.

The coffee stained Diark's uniform a dark hue.

“What the...”

Diark stared at Kuhn, the freshman now part of Rudy Astria's student council.

Recognizing him, anger bubbled within Diark.

"Diark, are you okay?"

People nearby approached Diark with concern.

Diark suppressed a curse and responded,

“Ah, I'm fine. Accidents happen.”

Thump...

Suddenly, Diark felt his heart pounding heavily.

He felt heat rising to his forehead.

‘What’s going on? Why am I...?’

Diark glanced at Kuhn, who had bumped into him and now lay sprawled on the ground.

That commoner who was part of Rudy Astria’s student council.

A mere commoner.

To anyone watching, it simply looked like an ordinary accident.

However, Diark felt an inexplicable surge of anger.

Even though it was a minor incident and there were people around, he was boiling with rage.

Kuhn brushed himself off and stood up, looking at Diark with a smile.

"Are you okay? Sorry about that."

Seeing Kuhn's smile, Diark felt his anger reach its peak.

The innocent smile seemed like a mockery to him, as if Kuhn had deliberately spilled coffee on him.

Diark retorted sharply,

"Watch where you're going, will you?"

"Di... Diark?"

Hearing Diark's response, the surrounding students started murmuring in surprise.

But Diark didn't care about the situation or their reactions.

"I apologized, didn't I? It wasn't just my mistake. You weren't paying attention either, right?"

"What's with this guy?"

Diark's face turned red with fury as he glared at Kuhn.

Kuhn narrowed his eyes and muttered quietly,

"This is why I dislike nobles..."

It was a soft comment, but it was audible enough for everyone to hear.

Hearing Kuhn's remark, Diark's eyes widened in disbelief.

"You think you have the right to talk back, a mere commoner?"

Diark approached Kuhn, poking him in the forehead.

"Do you think we're on the same level just because we're both in the academy, or because our student councils are competing? Do you see us as

equals?"

Poking Kuhn's forehead, he continued,

"Without Princess Rie or Senior Rudy Astria, what do you even have?"

Kuhn glared back, his voice cold,

"And without your family name, what do you have?"

"What did you just say?"

Diark grabbed Kuhn by the collar, his voice icy.

"You sure have a long tongue for a commoner."

"Enough, Diark!"

Other students rushed forward to intervene.

"Diark, look around you..."

Only then did Diark look around and notice the crowd that had gathered, all of whom had witnessed his public belittling of a commoner.

Recollecting his words, the realization struck him.

He had insulted a commoner in front of many who supported the student council, which was largely backed by commoners.

Diark released Kuhn, his face pale.

Straightening his clothes, Kuhn gave a sly smile.

"You should be careful with your words, my friend."

Chapter 107: Student Council Election2 (5)

In a room filled with silence, Evan heaved a sigh as he sat.

"Why don't you want to climb higher?"

Yuni's words echoed in his mind.

She had sought him out while he was training.

But Evan, uninterested in power, had immediately declined her offer.

At his response, Yuni chuckled.

"Oh, do you think the student council offers just power? How naive,"

She teased.

"From observing you, it seems you crave strength. With the student council, you gain not just power, but also influence and resources."

Evan was skeptical.

What was she up to?

"All I need is your name,"

Yuni admitted.

"To defeat Rudy Astria, I need various tools. I don't need anything else from you."

Hearing this, Evan nodded, but considering the current situation, he began to regret it.

"I'm, I'm sorry,"

Diark apologized, lowering his head, while Yuni sighed deeply beside him.

From the start, Evan had believed that uniting nobles and commoners was a flawed idea.

Neither the emperor, the Astria family, nor even the rebels had managed it.

How could a young princess like Yuni achieve such a feat?

Especially against an opponent like Rudy Astria, who was no pushover.

Perhaps it would have been better to firmly side with either the nobles or the commoners, emphasizing one over the other.

As a princess with two top seats in the student council, they had a lot to show off.

It could only be said that Yuni hadn't thought things through.

Even if they had secured votes through deception or favoritism, maintaining continuous support would have been difficult.

A student council without the students' backing is nothing but a figurehead.

The academy depended heavily on student cooperation.

Most of the student council's tasks were carried out with their help.

And the students did so with a deep-rooted trust in their chosen candidates, believing that supporting them would enhance their academy life.

Once the student council loses that trust, its downfall was only a matter of time.

"It can't be helped now. What's done is done,"

Yuni shrugged, without any visible anger.

"I've got some studying to do. I'll be on my way."

She waved and swiftly left the room, leaving everyone around visibly confused.

Due to Diark's blunder, the academy's opinion was swaying.

Though the final outcome was yet to be determined, their side was clearly on the losing end.

Comparing Rudy's scandal-free council to Yuni's controversy-ridden one, the victor seemed clear.

Yet, Yuni's expression remained unchanged, and she showed no signs of strategizing a countermove.

It was confusing.

Evan rose from his seat, speaking up.

"Let's disband for today. There's nothing we can do right now."

The student council members around nodded in agreement.

The next day.

"I'm resigning as student council president."

Yuni stated this without any noticeable change in her expression.

"What... What are you talking about...?"

Diark was so taken aback he couldn't continue.

"We lost anyway, didn't we? We can't suddenly change our strategy now."

"Do you really think that makes sense?"

Evan, unable to contain his anger, blurted out,

"Everyone here gathered to make you the student council president."

"You probably gathered out of desire for the student council's privileges rather than truly wanting me as president."

Yuni's face contorted in a frown.

"Yes, maybe some were drawn to the privileges. But the main goal was to make you the president, regardless of the reasons,"

Evan's voice was filled with frustration, but Yuni looked as if she couldn't understand.

"So, who ruined our plan? Is it my fault?"

Stunned, Diark looked at her, not knowing how to respond.

"I don't understand why you're all angry with me,"

"Wasn't your goal to become the student council president? Can you give up on that so easily?"

"My goal wasn't to be the student council president."

"...What?"

The surrounding people started murmuring.

"My goal was to get Rudy Astria on my side. If Rudy had agreed to support me, I was prepared to resign,"

Evan looked at her in disbelief,

"Then you should've joined Rudy's student council. Why did you even attempt to create one?"

Yuni, still frowning, opened her mouth,

“Then I'd have to work under my sister.”

It was truly a childish reason.

“Let's stop...”

Evan gave up trying to reason with her.

Arguing would change nothing.

Motivating someone without the drive was harder than anything else.

“I'm leaving,”

Evan declared, his face red with anger, and stormed out.

Yuni watched Evan's exit with a puzzled expression, then relaxed and smiled.

“So, I'll resign. Any objections?”

“...She resigned?”

I looked at Kuhn in disbelief.

“Yes, that's what I heard. Professor McGuire asked me to relay the message.”

“Well, that sounds like something she'd do.”

Rie commented nonchalantly.

I couldn't wrap my head around it.

Does all this drama just end like that?

Seeing my confusion, Rie began to explain.

“She told you from the start. She wasn’t after the student council presidency. You were her primary target.”

“To... date me?”

“She probably wanted something out of dating you.”

Rie shrugged.

I doubted she had genuine feelings for me.

But if she didn't like me, then what had she hoped to gain from this?

I was curious.

Turning to Rie, I asked,

“Do you know where Yuni is right now?”

“You want to confront her directly? You might just get even more upset.”

“What are you talking about?”

“Yuni, she’s still a child. She knows nothing of the real world.”

A child...?

“Still, I want to talk. Can you tell me where she is?”

With the information Rie provided, I headed to Yuni’s location.

It turned out to be her room.

Knock, knock.

“Yuni, are you in there?”

A faint sound echoed from within, and soon the door opened, revealing Yuni in her pajamas.

“What a surprise. To what do I owe this visit at such an hour?”

“...Your attire.”

“Oh, it’s fine since it's you. What brings you here?”

What did she mean, 'since it's me'? I was taken aback, but I quickly steered the conversation back on track.

“I wanted to talk about your resignation from the student council presidency.”

“Oh, that?”

She opened the door wider.

“Shall we sit and talk?”

Without hesitation, I stepped inside.

“What would you like to drink? Coffee? Tea?”

“I’m good, thanks.”

I found it weird to see her so cheerful.

She had confidently declared her intentions, and yet she lost to both Rie and me.

Of course, since she willingly resigned, she might not feel too down about it.

But I expected at least a little bit of emotion.

Yet here she was, welcoming me with such brightness.

“In that case, just some coffee.”

Calling over a servant, she ordered,

“Two cups of coffee, please.”

While waiting, my eyes wandered around her room.

A pink-frilled bed, a teddy bear on the side, and books scattered all over her desk which indicated her dedication to her studies.

But something caught my eye.

“Is this a portrait?”

A frame about the size of my arm displayed a picture of the Emperor, Rie, and Yuni, all smiling together.

“Oh, it’s a portrait drawn using magic.”

Yuni, holding two cups of coffee, walked over.

“Weren't you on bad terms with Rie?”

"... Well, somewhat."

Yuni looked uneasy for a moment, but her expression relaxed as she replied,

"You said you had something you wanted to ask?"

“Yes, why did you resign?”

With a playful pout, Yuni teased,

"I thought you came to console me."

When I didn't respond and just looked at her, Yuni sighed,

“It was a battle I couldn't win, wasn't it?”

"You don't know until you try. There's a difference between losing a battle and running away without trying."

“Well, that's true. But for me, it wasn't about the battle or its outcome.”

“Did you genuinely think I'd date you?”

“If I was overwhelmingly winning, I thought you might.”

Now I understood what Rie had meant.

Yuni really was just a child.

“What would you have done if we didn't turn the tables, and I hadn't asked for your help?”

“I would have still resigned. Being the student council president is tough. And I hate anything that's hard.”

It was a battle where she'd win, no matter the outcome.

The effort I made to defeat her felt pointless, and I started to get frustrated.

What about the people who worried and supported me?

What about those who supported her?

Were they fighting a losing battle from the start?

It wasn't even a battle.

Yuni never intended to fight in the first place.

Everyone involved in this election was just toys in Yuni's game.

“You're insufferable.”

I felt an urge to set her straight.

“Let's make a bet. If you win, I'll date you.”

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 108: Student Council Election2 (6)

I spread out a mat on the training area.

"Rudy, what are you up to? Why did you suddenly ask me to wear comfy clothes?"

Yuni showed up, grumbling in her casual sportswear.

It was around the time when the sun was beginning to set.

A reddish twilight hue bathed the training area.

Complaining was understandable, given that it was dinner time.

"Nothing special. Just thought we could play a simple game."

"A game?"

I tapped the mat laid out on the ground.

"Feel it. Doesn't it seem soft and safe, even if you fall on it?"

I looked at Yuni with a smile.

She shot me a suspicious look.

"What are you trying to do?"

"Nothing much. So, up for a challenge?"

"Hmm... I'll hear it out first."

It already seemed like she was up for whatever, having come this far.

"The goal is simple: knock your opponent down. The win is confirmed when their back touches this mat — not just a bit, but the entire back."

"Wait, how... using magic?"

"No, magic would give me an advantage. We'll do it with just our physical abilities."

Yuni stared at me, incredulous.

"Do you really think I have the same strength as you?"

"But."

I held up two fingers.

"You only have to do it one time, while I have to do it two hundred. You only need to knock me down once."

"...Two hundred times?"

Yuni's eyes widened in surprise.

"How about it? Not too hard, right?"

Seeing my smirk, Yuni covered her mouth, pondering.

"...And if I lose?"

"You'll have to do something for me. I can't think of anyone else but you for that particular task."

"For you? Only me?"

Yuni pondered for a moment, then broke into a sly grin.

"Well, if that's the case, I have no choice. It does seem simple and fun, after all. I just have to knock you down, right?"

With that, Yuni stepped onto the mat.

"I'll win in no time."

Diark heaved a sigh.

He made a mistake.

Unable to contain his anger, he blurted out words he shouldn't have.

"That commoner..."

Diark thought of the smirk Kuhn had shown at the end.

An expression so annoying that he couldn't bear it.

He nearly threw a punch upon seeing that smirk but, with immense self-control, he hastily retreated from the scene.

Yet, reflecting on the current situation, he felt he should've just thrown that punch.

He never thought Princess Yuni would relinquish her student council presidency so readily.

No, it was even more shocking to hear she had never desired the position from the start.

There had always been many rumors surrounding Princess Yuni.

From being labeled a talentless princess and the disgrace of the royal lineage, to the clueless princess and others, she had been given numerous peculiar nicknames.

But having spoken to her personally, Diark realized these rumors didn't hold up.

She was knowledgeable in various areas, her grades at the academy were among the top, and she was skilled enough to be in the elite class.

Yet, every time he watched her, something seemed wrong.

Despite her apparent depth, there was an emptiness about her.

And with what happened recently, he pinpointed what it was.

It was ambition.

Most of the discussions between Diark and Yuni centered around the student council presidency.

But from the beginning, Princess Yuni showed no genuine interest, hence the lack of enthusiasm.

That said, it didn't mean she lacked enthusiasm in other areas.

When attending classes, she was always listening with full concentration.

"Ugh..."

Diark sighed again and rose from his seat.

While Yuni might have had thoughts of giving up from the start, had he not made a mistake, she might have changed her mind.

In the end, the reason they lost the election was due to his mistake.

That didn't mean he wasn't irritated with Yuni.

Though he acknowledged his error, he was genuinely angered by her words.

Such thoughts only increased his frustration and concerns.

"Maybe I should train a bit..."

Diark picked up the sword beside him and headed to the training area.

With midterms around the corner, he needed to refocus and get back to studying.

Though Diark enrolled in the magic department, being a magic swordsman, he occasionally trained by himself.

As Diark approached the training area, he began to hear an unsettling noise.

"Kyaaaaa!!!"

A woman's shriek.

But it didn't end there.

"St-stop!!! I admit defeat!!! Keeeek!!!"

Diark, with his sword lowered, cautiously moved towards the training area.

He wasn't sure about the specifics, but it was clear someone was in distress.

To save that person, it was essential to approach cautiously and silently subdue the perpetrator rather than rushing in.

A hasty move might turn the victim into a hostage.

Diark carefully opened the door and peered inside.

Inside, he saw a man and a woman.

“Kiyaaaaaaaa!!”

Thud!!!

The man forcefully slammed the woman onto the ground.

'Is that... Rudy Astria?'

The woman on the ground was Yuni.

The two had once vied for the position of student council president.

But what were they doing now?

"I admit defeat alreadyyyyyyy!!!"

Thud!!!

Rudy seized Yuni's arm, causing her to trace an arc in the air before crashing back down.

Looking at Yuni on the ground, Rudy remarked,

"That's the 87th time."

While Yuni wore comfortable sportswear, Rudy was dressed in the academy's uniform.

Rudy removed his tie and threw it to the ground.

"Get up. Let's finish this quickly."

"Can we... can we end this now? I've had enough..."

Rudy gently helped Yuni to her feet.

His grip, though firm, didn't seem harmful.

It was as if he was merely assisting a younger sibling to stand.

However, his next move showed no mercy.

"I've had enoughhhhhhhhhhh!!!"

Thud!!!!!!!

"....."

Multiple mats cushioned the floor, reducing the impact.

But being continually thrown into the air like that must have been disorienting.

Still, seeing Yuni repeatedly crash onto the ground evoked an inexplicable satisfaction in him.

For a moment, Diark watched the scene, feeling a rush of joy.

It was as if he was relieving stress without having to undergo any training himself.

After observing for a brief period, a contented smile formed on Diark's face and he returned to his room.

"Rudy... that's too much. Seriously... how could you do this to me!!!!"

"It seems you still have the energy to complain."

The match didn't feel like much of a contest anymore.

Around the time I slammed Yuni to the ground for the tenth time, she had lost her enthusiasm, but I was committed.

200 times.

I had a sense of obligation to keep to the 200 throws I had promised.

Eventually, I achieved it.

Wiping my sweat, I felt a sense of accomplishment.

Around the 100th throw, Yuni had yelled for me to stop.

But by the 150th, she simply got up on her own, signaling for me to continue.

She probably decided it was better to finish quickly than to resist.

"We're finally done."

I picked up my school uniform and tie from the floor.

"So, I won, right?"

"Yes~ Yes~ You won."

Yuni raised her hand in a sign of defeat.

I chuckled at her reaction.

"Rudy!"

Suddenly, the door burst open, and Luna dashed in.

"Rudy! You skipped dinner and didn't study... what have you been doing?"

Entering the training area, Luna's eyes darted between Yuni and me.

Seeing our disheveled state, Luna looked at us with a mix of shock and confusion.

"Huh? Luna?"

Confused by her abrupt reaction, I tilted my head.

Why was she reacting like that?

I glanced over at Yuni and myself.

The floor was wet from our sweat, Yuni's clothes were disheveled, and I had casually unbuttoned my shirt.

Yuni was sitting on the floor, seemingly too drained to stand, gasping for breath.

"Luna... You're not thinking something weird, are you?"

"Ah, ah..."

Luna's eyes widened, and she began to step back.

"Hey, it's not like that."

Though the scene might have looked a bit peculiar, who in their right mind would do anything indecent here in the training area?

Sure, this place was on the outskirts, a place not frequented by many.

Someone might assume something might have happened, but...

Just then, Luna seemed about to scream.

"Ru-Rudy...! Rudy has become...!"

"Shh, quiet!"

From behind, Rie appeared with a smile, covering Luna's mouth.

"There's no problem here, so don't worry."

"Mmm...?"

I awkwardly smiled at Luna, who was looking baffled.

Lately, Luna seemed to find herself silenced quite often.

"Rie..."

Yuni looked intently at Rie.

Rie released Luna and walked over to Yuni, squatting down in front of her.

"You do realize you were in the wrong, right?"

"...Yes."

"Why did you do it? You weren't like this before."

Rie spoke in a soothing tone.

Initially, I had thought they didn't get along well, but seeing them now, they seemed closer than I had assumed.

".....I'm sorry."

"You don't need to apologize to me. You should apologize to those who had faith in you."

Rie extended her hand to Yuni.

I tilted my head, wondering.

So why did she do all this?

I was curious, but it didn't seem like the right time to ask.

"Come on, get up. You haven't eaten, right? Let's go eat."

Yuni, with a gloomy expression, took Rie's hand.

Rie looked at her and smiled gently.

"Oh, by the way, Rudy, what was that thing you bet on?"

As Rie helped Yuni to her feet, she glanced at me.

"Oh, that?"

I chuckled lightly.

Then the next day.

"I'm... I'm to be a teaching assistant?"

I walked with Yuni towards Professor Gracie's laboratory.

"Yes, you'll be a teaching assistant."

"But I'm a... princess, aren't I?"

"It was the result of our bet. You do what I tell you."

"But you never mentioned anything about being a teaching assistant!!! You said it would be something only I could do!!!!!"

I just shrugged in response.

I smiled as I opened the door to Professor Gracie's laboratory.

"Professor, hello."

I stepped inside.

---Toggle New Ads

That ends the mini Yuni arc!

Chapter 109: Student Council Election2 (7)

Professor Gracie looked utterly exhausted.

She had been busy with class preparations, organizing various research materials, and handling academy paperwork.

To top it all off, midterms were approaching.

Her workload seemed endless.

"If it keeps going like this, I might die...!!!"

Her once radiant complexion from her initial days at the academy had faded.

Her skin looked dull, and dark circles had formed under her eyes.

She appeared so drained that if she collapsed, no one would be surprised.

"At least after the midterms are over..."

She tried to find solace in that thought, but even after the midterms, the pile of work seemed endless.

Despair set in.

Gracie's face turned somber.

"Mom... I've been tricked..."

Despite her age, Gracie found herself looking up, as if seeking her mother's guidance.

Knock, knock.

"Professor, may I come in?"

A knock echoed from outside her lab.

"Ah, yes? Sure, come in."

Upon Gracie's response, the door opened, and two figures entered.

Rudy Astria and Yuni Von Ristonia.

A duke's son and a princess.

She was surprised to see them suddenly in her lab.

"Hello, Professor."

Rudy greeted with a gentle smile.

Gracie, puzzled, wondered why these two had come to her lab.

She was sure this was her lab.

There seemed to be no obvious reason for them to be here.

"Um... You do know this is my lab, right?"

Gracie shifted her gaze between Rudy and Yuni.

She wondered if they had mistakenly come to the wrong room.

"Yes, we're here to see Professor Gracie."

Rudy replied with a slight tilt of his head.

Taken aback, Gracie quickly stood up.

"Oh, right! Of course! Please sit down! Would you like some tea or snacks? I can get them right now!"

Gracie swiftly guided them to a table.

These two were significant figures in the academy.

Though she was a professor, this wasn't the time to act distant.

If they were to speak highly of her, perhaps she could get a teaching assistant... or if she was lucky, even two.

She had to make a great impression.

"I'd like black tea, please~ with lots of sugar."

Upon Yuni's request, Gracie nodded enthusiastically.

"Alright! Rudy, would you like something?"

"No, I'm good, thank you."

Gracie hurried to boil some water.

As she was boiling the water, she occasionally glanced at Rudy and Yuni.

Yuni, while calmly observing the room, swiped a finger across the table in front of her.

"Eek."

"Ah."

She realized she hadn't cleaned that table since she started using this lab.

That was a problem.

She couldn't start off on the wrong foot.

"Boil!"

Using her magic, Gracie instantly brought the water to a boil.

She poured the hot water into the teacup and cast a spell inside the room.

"Clean!!!"

As the spell took effect, the surrounding dust and stains began to vanish.

Gracie added a few sugar cubes to the cup filled with black tea, extending her hand toward her desk.

"Reposition."

At her command, the scattered documents lifted into the air and neatly arranged themselves.

In an instant, the room was spotless.

"Now, have you been waiting for a while?"

Gracie smiled warmly, taking a seat across from Yuni and Rudy.

She had tidied up using magic in just an instant, but she phrased her question playfully, as if she'd taken her time.

Observing Gracie, Rudy remarked,

"You're quite skilled with everyday magic."

At Rudy's comment, Gracie chuckled awkwardly.

"Ahaha... It just became a habit after living alone for so long."

Gracie wasn't of noble lineage.

After her graduation from the academy, she joined the ranks of the royal wizards at the lowest tier and became a noble in name only.

Thus, she found it uncomfortable to ask others to clean for her, and usually tidied up on her own.

But, her proficiency in these spells wasn't solely for cleaning.

Being at the lower tier among the royal wizards meant she'd often been tasked with tidying up the labs of her senior colleagues.

Being the kind-hearted Gracie who struggled to say no, she often ended up cleaning up by herself.

That's how she came to master these everyday spells.

These spells were Gracie's unique tools for survival.

"Anyway, why have you come to see me? Preparing for midterms? Having difficulty with some problems?"

Gracie asked in the kindest tone she could muster.

"Professor, do you need a teaching assistant right now?"

Rudy asked, a teasing smile on his lips.

Gracie's eyes widened, and she was suddenly enveloped in anxiety.

She recognized that smile.

It resembled the one people wore when they were about to scam her, especially when they dangled a bait she couldn't resist.

Having been tricked by numerous scams and temptations before, Gracie could sense something suspicious.

"Um... well..."

She hesitated, feeling as if acknowledging his words would lead her right into a trap.

Then Rudy, placing a hand on Yuni's head, spoke.

"Both Yuni and I can serve as your teaching assistants."

"...What?"

The proposal caught Gracie off guard.

But then, she realized it might be a wonderful opportunity.

Having Rudy, the likely future student council president, and Yuni, a royal princess, in her lab was an incredibly enticing prospect.

She could already envision many assistants eager to join just for a chance to connect with them.

In her excitement, Gracie slammed her hand on the desk.

Bang!

"What should I do to make this happen?"

Hearing Gracie's enthusiastic response, Rudy replied with a gentle smile.

"No, you don't have to do anything. Just..."

"Just what?"

"I'm set to become the student council president, right? So, I'll be quite busy."

"Yes, that makes sense."

Gracie began to feel a growing unease.

"And if I'm to be the student council president, it means the academy students and professors recognize my abilities. Additionally, I hold the Second Seat."

Rudy, saying all this, looked her squarely in the eyes.

The more he laid out his credentials, the more her unease turned to certainty.

"So, there should be some extra conditions for me, right?"

"Anything you want! I'll give you everything!"

But Gracie was already reeling.

Indeed, Rudy was a talent anyone would covet.

Not just her or other teaching assistants, but even the nobles of the capital would lose their minds over someone of his caliber...

The individual who had even swayed Ian Astria, known as the head of the noble faction.

Someone bearing the esteemed Astria name.

This wasn't just any talent.

He was a monumental figure.

And Gracie would be overwhelmed if things stayed the same.

It felt like making a deal with a demon.

But doing nothing might mean death.

She was sure of it!

To survive, she could bear with these demands.

Rudy probably wasn't worse than a real demon.

"For starters, you can pay her salary to me."

Rudy indicated Yuni as he spoke.

"...What?"

Yuni looked at Rudy, clearly taken aback.

"You don't need money, right?"

"Well, that's true."

Taking a colleague's salary.

"And I'd like my salary to be at least five times higher than others. After all, my presence alone will promote the lab and offer various benefits, won't it?"

An outrageous salary proposition.

"Oh, and occasionally, I'd like you to carry out the research I'm interested in. I'll only suggest meaningful research projects, so you don't have to worry."

The audacity.

"And also..."

"Wait a moment..."

Gracie wondered,

'Am I actually dealing with a demon here?'

She couldn't hide her shock.

She had thought his demands might extend to a higher salary or some help with academy assignments.

But as the list grew, it was clear these weren't ordinary demands.

He seemed to be aiming to take control of the very foundation of the lab.

The most heartbreaking part for Gracie was that even knowing this, she couldn't refuse his irresistibly sweet proposal.

"May I continue?"

"There's more?"

"Oh, it's nothing much."

Rudy shrugged it off.

"I just need some materials for my research, so I was thinking of using what's in the lab."

"That... That's fine."

She could accept that.

Many assistants in other labs used the research materials for their work.

Having said that, Rudy took out a sheet of paper.

It listed all the conditions he had just mentioned.

"So, can you accept all of these conditions?"

With a sly smile, Rudy tilted his head slightly.

He seemed devilishly charming.

Rudy swiftly pushed the paper toward Gracie.

After staring intently at the contract, Gracie clenched her eyes shut and picked up a pen.

"Thank you. It's a wise decision."

Extending his hand, Rudy offered a handshake.

After this whirlwind meeting in the research lab,

"Oh... Mom, did I make the right decision...?"

Gracie collapsed onto her desk, letting out a distressed cry.

The day before the student council president elections.

Though I was the only candidate, the students still had a choice.

To abstain.

If a certain percentage abstained, that year would pass without a student council president.

Still, I didn't believe that would happen.

I was confident.

But, confidence aside, there were things that needed to be done.

I walked slowly up to the podium.

Before the student council president elections, a speech.

It was customary before officially taking the position.

“Ah, ah.”

I touched the magic tool placed before me.

After a quick test, I could hear my voice echoing from behind.

I looked outwards.

Countless faces stared back.

Some familiar, others not.

Both professors and students stood in front of me.

This was my first such experience since my entrance ceremony speech.

Though back then, it wasn't really a proper speech.

“Dear students, hello. I am your student council president candidate, Rudy Astria.”

I greeted them with a smile.

“Winter has passed, and spring has arrived. Flowers have bloomed, and new students have joined us. The friends we saw just yesterday have matured into second-year students, while our seniors are forging their own paths.”

When I first entered the academy, all I wanted was to survive.

I didn't pay much heed to those around me.

“Since entering the academy, I've had many experiences. They've led me to form many friendships and experience joyous moments.”

Luna's library incident, Rie's assassination attempt, Harpel's intrusion during Homecoming Day, and the Serina incident.

Life in the academy brought numerous challenges.

But through those events, I made friends.

Real friends, not just characters from a game.

“Though facing these challenges was tough, and at times I wanted to give up, I often thought it might be easier to just let everything go.”

It was risky.

Every rescue attempt carried a risk – that I could lose my life.

There were moments when I wished to abandon these challenges and live a normal life.

Especially since watching my life and those around me constantly at risk was agonizing.

“But I couldn’t give up. I knew a sweet reward awaited. When I look back in the future, I’ll be able to say enduring those hardships was worth it.”

Lately, I’ve been imagining.

Imagining a time post-graduation, surrounded by close friends.

We would share stories.

Discussing the hard times.

Joking about times we narrowly escaped danger.

Sharing laughter over our adventures.

“I wish for all of you to taste such sweet rewards. Even if the journey is a little tough, never give up. Embrace your youth. Embrace the shining present.”

That's why I couldn't give up.

The very reason I stand on this stage today.

I now face the future head-on.

Not just relying on the future I know.

If need be, I'll reshape the future.

Because I can.

“A wonderful academy life awaits all of you.”

I'll embrace the present and challenge the future.

If the future seems bleak, I'll reshape it.

Break it and rebuild it.

And then, I'll confront the consequences of my choices.

“I am Rudy Astria, your candidate for student council president.”

Chatter filled the air.

“Should we treat ourselves to something tasty today?”

Luna mused as she tidied up some books.

“A celebration party sounds perfect.”

Rie replied with a chuckle.

“Can we invite Emily too?”

Kuhn asked as he placed some documents beside me.

“Start organizing these first.”

Locke, who had been absent lately, was present today.

I glanced at the nameplate in front of me.

Student Council President. Astina Persia.

Gently, I wiped off the thin layer of dust from the nameplate using a handkerchief nearby.

“You forgot your nameplate, Astina.”

“Ah, seems so.”

Rie shrugged nonchalantly.

I opened a desk drawer and carefully placed the nameplate inside.

Then, I set my own nameplate where Astina's had been.

Student Council President. Rudy Astria.

A smile crept onto my face as I looked at the nameplate.

Then, addressing everyone, I proposed,

“How about a party today?”

Today, I became the student council president.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 110: Northern Invasion (1)

Up until now, I've been like a blunt sword.

A blade with no edge.

A sword that can't cut its opponent.

But now, things are different.

I've sharpened my blade, and it stands keen and ready.

"The midterm exams are over."

This was my first midterm since becoming the student council president.

To be honest, since I hadn't been in this role for long before these midterms, the responsibilities hadn't really been much of a problem.

I was also serving as an assistant for Professor Gracie, but I was still in the learning phase, so there wasn't much work to do.

Thus, I had ample time to study.

I felt like I studied harder for this exam than any other before.

Now as a second-year student, the volume of my studies and the complexity of the content had increased.

It was only natural that I worked harder than in my first year.

But the me of now is different.

I was a blade, sharpened to cut Evan.

A sword honed to perfection.

So, there should be nothing I couldn't cut...

No.

There shouldn't have been.

The next day.

[

Evan 2. Luna Railer 3. Rie Von Ristonia 4. Rudy Astria

...]

"Huh?"

I tilted my head.

"What??"

Something was off.

No, this was wrong.

How could this have happened?

I blinked several times in disbelief.

"Rudy... Are you okay?"

Luna, who sat next to me, asked with a concerned look.

"Ah, um... Yeah... I'm... I'm fine."

Surprisingly, I ranked lower than when I had deliberately tried to score below Evan.

It was ironic, I had been closer to Evan when I was a 'blunt sword'.

Of course, I knew Luna and Rie had studied diligently.

But seeing a rank lower than usual after promising myself the top spot was quite a blow.

As I gazed at my score sheet, disheartened, a voice called out.

"Hey! Luna! Professor Mcguire wants to see you!"

It was someone calling out to Luna.

"Oh, um... Rudy! I'll be right back! I promise I'll be quick!"

"It's okay... Take your time..."

"I'll be super quick! Wait for me in the student council room!"

Luna quickly dashed towards Professor Mcguire's office.

I watched Luna's retreating figure and slowly trudged to the student council room.

"Ah, senior."

A voice called out to me.

It was Yuni.

I looked at her with weary eyes.

Yuni's eyes seemed to question, "What's wrong with him?" before she spoke.

"Professor Gracie said she has something later and asked you to come."

"Oh... Is that so?"

I responded weakly.

Yuni tilted her head, puzzled.

"Why do you look so down?"

"It's just something that happened..."

"What is it?"

"It's just... something."

"What is it? Tell me!"

Yuni shook me lightly, trying to get an answer.

I sighed and shared my concerns about the exam results.

"Pffft! You're sulking over a low score? The mighty Rudy is upset about that?"

Yuni held her stomach and laughed as if she found the situation hilariously absurd.

On any other day, I would've snapped at such a petty taunt, but today, I just wasn't in the mood.

"So, what rank did you get? You're laughing, but where did you place?"

The Yuni I knew wasn't particularly sharp.

She often came across as naïve.

To put it nicely, she was straightforward, but sometimes seemed a tad clueless.

Also a little unpredictable.

That's the kind of person she was.

“I ranked second.”

“...What?”

I stared at Yuni in disbelief.

“Second place.”

“...”

She claims to be 2nd.

The second seat of the first year.

This very girl.

I wanted to slam my fist on the ground and ask how that was even possible.

“Heh... And you, senior? What's your rank?”

With a mischievous grin, Yuni looked up at me, waiting for an answer.

“Ugh...”

Her question was like a dagger to the heart.

Though we're from different grades, I had nothing to say in return.

I was consistently the second seat during my first year as well.

In that aspect, I wasn't any better than her.

I sighed.

“Fine... Just go and tell Professor Gracie I'll be a bit late due to student council stuff.”

“Okay~!”

With a bright smile, Yuni walked off.

I then entered the student council room.

No one else was there.

It seemed I was the first to arrive.

"Ah..."

I slouched into a chair.

'I can't give up just because of this.'

The first midterm of the second year just ended.

But there were still many exams ahead.

The first semester of the second year wasn't over.

There were also the final exams, so there was still a chance to top the class.

However...

"The problem is, it's almost impossible..."

Evan had nearly scored perfect marks.

But this time, I ranked fourth.

To surpass him, not only would I need to be perfect, but Evan would also need to slip.

Reaching the top in the usual way seemed almost out of reach.

I ran my fingers through my hair, then lifted my head.

"Guess I should process these documents..."

There was no point in pondering now.

I had to do what needed to be done.

I started sorting through the pile of papers on the desk.

While skimming through them, a particular document caught my eye.

"Northern... support..."

I recalled a lecture from Magical Beast Studies.

The monster attacks that happen every four years.

Reading the document, one detail stood out:

Students who volunteer for the Northern support will receive bonus points added to their academy grade.

My eyes widened.

A way to boost my grades.

There's always a way out, even in the direst situations.

And it seemed I had just found mine.

McDowell found himself in a damp, uncomfortably sticky, confined space.

It felt rather ironic that the Academy's renowned principal would be in such a place.

Nevertheless, he maneuvered with an air of familiarity.

From his vantage point, McDowell looked down.

Below him was a man with black hair — a man known as the leader of the Rebels.

In front of this leader lay a woman, covered in wounds, blood spilling from her mouth, suggesting she had been tortured.

She was still conscious.

"Hmm... She's quite resilient,"

The leader of the Rebels mused, seated comfortably as he stroked his chin, observing the woman.

The bloodied woman was none other than Yeniel.

With a subtle nod from the leader, a burly man beside him fetched a red-hot iron.

"To think you've become a pawn of the nobility... How pitiful."

As the leader spoke, another man pressed the heated iron against Yeniel's back.

"AAARGHHH!!"

Yeniel let out a heart-wrenching scream.

Regret surged within McDowell, wishing he hadn't sent Yeniel back to The Rebels.

Concerned over her prolonged absence, McDowell had briefly visited the Rebel's hideout.

Yet, as soon as McDowell arrived, the Rebel leader, seemingly anticipating him, summoned Yeniel to his side.

And the torture began.

It was a trap.

Anyone could see that.

But why had this trap been set?

McDowell couldn't understand.

'Did he know I was coming?'

How did they find out that Yeniel was acting as a double agent?

There were many aspects that didn't add up.

Once the iron was removed from Yeniel's body, she gasped for air.

The leader, with an impassive gaze, pulled out a pocket watch from within his robes.

He sighed after glancing at it briefly.

"Perhaps slitting her throat will do..."

The leader mumbled as he stood up and drew his blade, slowly advancing towards Yeniel.

Letting out a sigh, McDowell extended his hand.

From his bracelet, a radiant light emerged, forming a golden staff in his hand.

The staff.

An instrument that enhanced a wizard's mana several folds.

If a swordsman's weapon was the sword, for a wizard, it was the staff.

Raising the staff above his head, McDowell intoned,

"Radiance."

Bright light shot from the staff's tip, striking the ground.

Kwaang!

The emitted light burst outwards in a blinding explosion.

Flash magic.

McDowell's signature spell.

A unique magic possessed almost exclusively by McDowell.

This magic was challenging to control, and each casting was massive in scale.

Hence, the mana consumed was significant, making it a spell not just anyone could wield.

The moment the light touched the ground, McDowell burst out from his concealed spot.

He quickly moved forward.

"Body Enhancement."

McDowell chanted.

A strong gust of dust rose from the light's explosion, and he dashed through it, heading straight for Yeniel.

The light began to consume everything, and McDowell tried to save Yeniel before it could reach her.

However, she was gone.

Yeniel, who had been lying on the ground, had disappeared.

"You finally show yourself."

To his side, a black-haired man holding a sword appeared – the Leader of the Rebels.

McDowell's expression hardened upon seeing him.

As the Leader prepared to swing his sword, McDowell quickly extended his staff.

"Lightning Shock."

ZZZZAP!

Lightning Shock was a basic spell of lightning magic.

However, McDowell's casting was far more powerful than most spells of its kind.

As the lightning was about to strike the Leader, an unexpected word escaped his lips.

"Barrier."

Zing!

The lightning was effortlessly deflected by the barrier that formed in front of the Leader.

With a swing of his sword, the leader dispelled the surrounding dust clouds, allowing McDowell to get a clear look at him.

A young man with jet-black hair.

In one hand, he wielded his sword, and in the other, he clutched a pocket watch.

"Tch..."

McDowell clicked his tongue.

He had assumed the man was a swordsman because of the sword, but he was a wizard.

And a highly skilled one at that...

McDowell glanced at the Leader's feet.

Yeniel lay there, pinned under the Leader's boot.

"Did the esteemed academy principal really think he could hide like a rat?"

He taunted with a smirk.

"I apologize for that. But could you lift your filthy foot? My daughter might find it uncomfortable."

The Leader, with a look of confusion, responded,

"...Daughter? Since when did Yeniel become your daughter?"

"Once they enter the academy, all students become like sons and daughters to me."

McDowell declared.

The Leader paused, seemingly taken aback by McDowell's statement, then burst into laughter.

McDowell, staring intently at the laughing Leader, spoke again.

"I asked you to move your foot. Should I cut off that leg?"

With a hint of amusement in his eyes, the Leader replied,

"Then, I suppose I'll have to cut off your arm in return."

McDowell pointed his staff forward.

In anticipation, the Leader pressed a button on the pocket watch he held and raised his sword.

"Let's see what you can do."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 111: Northern Invasion (2)

The North.

In a barren environment lies a territory on the frontier of the empire.

Due to its northern location, it has a dry and cold climate.

Yet, a notable characteristic of this territory is the prominent presence of beasts near its borders.

The lord of the northern territory, Lucarion, hunts these beasts every year.

If the northern territory were breached, the surrounding areas would descend into chaos, so preventative measures are taken.

To aid in these situations, central territories and others regularly send reinforcements.

While they deal with the beasts annually, every four years there's a significant attack.

This attack is, in reality, the beasts' final act of desperation.

As humans hunt them, their population diminishes, and with a scarcity of food, they lash out in one last desperate attempt.

Staving off this onslaught ensures a period of peace.

"Hmm..."

I was slowly going through documents regarding the beast attacks in the North.

These beasts typically attack just before summer, after enduring hunger and near madness during the winter.

The exact day of their attack was never certain, only a general timeframe was known.

"The support from other territories isn't specified yet..."

There were no concrete plans for this upcoming attack.

Given that this event has been experienced several times before, there seemed to be a laid-back approach to preparations.

Reading through the manual, I noticed systematic documentation related to student involvement and reinforcements.

The meticulously crafted manual made me think,

"There's no reason not to..."

The safety of the students was guaranteed, and there were plenty of experienced veterans.

If I were to join the reinforcements, my role would be to ensure the safety of the citizens from within the fortress, providing rear support.

It was a sweet deal.

Of course, even providing rear support had its risks.

But considering all I'd been through, this hardly ranked as dangerous.

I've faced life-threatening situations more than once, so this was manageable.

"This is definitely..."

Bang!

"Rudy! I'm here!"

Luna burst in, panting heavily.

"Shall we go for a walk outside? Or maybe visit a bakery to unwind?"

Her words trailed off as she noticed the North-related book I was reading.

I awkwardly smiled and tucked the book into a drawer.

"Oh, it's alright. Professor Gracie summoned me earlier. I'll pay her a brief visit."

There were things to consider if I was going North.

The responsibilities of a student council president and those of a teaching assistant.

In my absence, someone would need to handle these roles.

As for the teaching assistant role, I had a plan in mind.

"I'll be back in a bit."

"Mm, okay."

Luna responded with an awkward smile.

I then headed towards Professor Gracie's office.

Gracie's research lab.

"...What?"

Gracie widened her eyes in surprise.

"It seems like it could be fun~."

Yuni, standing beside me, smiled mischievously.

"No way! I absolutely refuse! Why would I go there and put myself through that?!"

Gracie vigorously shook her head, expressing her disapproval.

I had made a proposal to Professor Gracie.

The proposal? To head to the northern region together.

Thinking of the lab work and how to manage it, an idea struck me.

If the tasks in the lab simply disappeared, that would solve the problem.

If Professor Gracie went to the North as the supervising professor, the lab work would naturally vanish.

Professor Gracie's lab consisted of just three of us: Yuni, Professor Gracie, and myself.

Two of us were students.

Without Professor Gracie, there'd be no one to delegate the work to.

The lab would essentially go on hiatus.

"You... You're trying to kill me, aren't you? Moreover, what did you do with the Remblin flowers? They were just brought in recently!"

"Oh, I used them well. They were quality herbs."

"You used... all of them?"

Despair flooded Professor Gracie for another reason.

"How could you use them all?!"

Gracie lamented, her face contorted in distress.

I feigned ignorance at her outcry.

"Setting that aside, let's head to the North together. Imagine the praise from the other professors if their junior took the initiative."

"I don't need their praise... There'll be so many nobles there. If I go as the representative, they'll make sure I suffer the most."

"Hmm... I have a feeling you're going regardless..."

Yuni said with a smirk, tapping her cheek playfully.

"What are you talking about? Hahaha... just a joke, right?"

Both Gracie and I, even Yuni, knew a certain fact.

Whenever there was tough work, the professors always dumped it on Gracie.

Even we, who recently joined the lab, were aware of this.

Initially, I had planned to accompany Professor Gracie without even telling her.

However, respecting the lab's traditions, I felt she should be the one to formally apply first.

With an awkward smile, Professor Gracie's expression turned solemn as she lowered her head.

"Of course... I'll have to go, won't I?"

"That seems likely."

Yuni grinned, her smile devilish.

"Why did I even join this place... Perhaps I should've stayed as a Royal Wizard. But then again, that place is hell... But is this place any different? Am I cursed?"

Realizing the truth, Professor Gracie seemed to break down, muttering to herself in a daze.

Seeing Gracie in that state tugged at my heartstrings.

Sighing, I picked up a stack of documents.

“So, I'll take it you're going then?”

“Ah, you're leaving?”

"I've got student council paperwork to deal with, so I'll handle it in the council room."

“Alright then, take care.”

I opened the lab door, taking in Yuni's words as I left.

While Rudy was in his lab,

"Ugh..."

Luna intently examined the documents Rudy had been looking at.

"The North..."

To Luna, the North was synonymous with danger.

Her father's fairy tales from her childhood often spoke of the North as a place laid to ruin by beast attacks.

Beneath the main text of the document, the words 'extra credit' caught her attention.

Rudy, who had underperformed in the recent exam, seemed deeply distressed.

Although Luna had come in second place, her joy was overshadowed by concern.

She had never seen Rudy so despondent, his complexion a shade paler than usual.

She even wished she could give him her own scores.

"So Rudy plans to go there..."

Luna found herself deep in thought.

She wanted to help Rudy.

But if she decided to go to that place herself, her grades would benefit as well.

So, what about Rudy...

"No, no."

Luna momentarily entertained the thought of consistently outperforming Rudy.

But she immediately dismissed it.

Such arrogance, to believe that just because she surpassed Rudy once, she could always do so.

That's why she shook the thought away.

"First, let's consider what I can do for Rudy!"

Seeing Rudy so heartbroken made Luna's heart ache.

It felt as if needles were pricking her.

The worry that the ever-confident and selfless Rudy might crumble weighed heavily on her.

She cherished that bright, self-sacrificing side of Rudy.

Luna made a decision: she would ensure Rudy had the right conditions to travel to the North.

Regarding the student council responsibilities,

Surely, during his time in the North, someone else would temporarily handle the duties of the student council president.

But if she could sort out everything beforehand, it would make Rudy's journey smoother.

With this in mind, she decided to settle all pending tasks.

And also her own responsibilities.

She readied herself to manage all the assignments of Professor McGuire's lab.

Considering the North's perilous reputation, Rudy would undoubtedly need assistance.

While students typically operated in safe zones, the inherent danger of the North was undeniable.

Luna took off the ribbon around her neck, settled at a desk in the student council room, and spread out the research papers and other documents before her.

"Well, let's begin,"

She whispered.

Determined and focused, Luna, the paperwork powerhouse, set into motion.

Cromwell walked purposefully down the corridor, holding an assortment of documents in one hand.

“Hmm...”

His steps led him toward the principal's office, intent on processing the paperwork and securing the final approval.

However, McDowell had been conspicuously absent lately, a fact that had escaped most of the staff.

McDowell had a habit of disappearing without a trace or word to anyone.

Although Cromwell wasn't entirely sure why, he hadn't probed into it, trusting that if it were essential, McDowell would certainly inform him.

The pressing issue at hand was the pending final approval for these documents due to McDowell's absence.

Despite constantly leaving them in the principal's office, the paperwork remained unattended for quite some time.

Typically, if McDowell planned to be away for an extended period, he would inform the Vice Principal to act on his behalf.

But this time, there had been no such communication.

As he approached, Cromwell caught sight of the principal's office.

"I wonder if he's returned."

Just as this thought crossed his mind, a powerful wave of mana surged from the principal's office.

Thud!

A sound, as if something had fallen, echoed.

“Principal?”

Reacting immediately, Cromwell dashed into the office.

Inside, he found two figures.

One was Yeniel, blood-soaked and disheveled.

The other was Principal McDowell, cradling the injured Yeniel in one arm.

However...

"Ah... Is that you, Cromwell?"

McDowell's right arm was missing, cut off at the forearm, blood still pouring out.

"Principal McDowell!!!"

In alarm, Cromwell rushed to McDowell's aid.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 112: Northern Invasion (3)

"How did this happen...?"

McDowell lay on the bed, his expression heavy.

Standing before him was Cromwell, gazing intently at McDowell's arm.

Specifically, where McDowell's forearm should have been, but wasn't.

The elbow was cut clean off, and a bandage was wrapped around the stump.

"Haah..."

For a wizard, hands were of utmost importance.

Of course, they were essential for swordsmen and ordinary folks as well, but to a wizard, they had a unique significance.

A wizard's hand was a conduit, a focal point for spells.

Most spells required the caster to gesture with their hand in the direction they intended the magic to take effect.

Although there were a few exceptions, the majority of spells relied on this directional cue.

Therefore, losing a hand meant more than just physical loss.

It symbolized the inability to wield magic as they once did.

Yes, McDowell still had his left hand intact, but it wasn't as simple as just switching hands.

People have habits, and switching dominant hands for casting was not easily done.

"Heh, at least I managed to save the child."

He referred to Yaniel.

Yaniel's condition had been dire, but thanks to Cromwell's quick application of healing spells and first aid, her life was no longer in immediate danger.

The real concern now was McDowell, with his severed arm.

"Principal..."

"I wasn't the only one who got hurt. Don't worry about me."

Cromwell exhaled deeply.

Then, with a grave expression, he asked,

"Was it The Rebels?"

"Yes. I faced off against their leader. He wields time magic."

"...Time magic?"

McDowell gave a nod, then continued,

"Let's first go over the situation. Given my current state, can you draft a report and send it to the palace for me?"

He gestured with his severed arm, hinting at his inability to write.

"...Understood."

And so, McDowell began recounting his confrontation with the leader of The Rebels.

After deciding to head to the North, I immersed myself in paperwork.

I spent most of my time in the student council room, diligently working through the piles of documents.

Surprisingly, the pace of processing was faster than I anticipated.

This was thanks to Luna.

"Rudy, I've finished all of it!"

"Already?"

Next to Luna was a towering stack of paperwork.

The volume of which would have taken me two to three days.

Yet, Luna managed to finish it all in just one day.

And she did this while also serving as an assistant in Professor Mcguire's research lab.

I knew Luna was quick with paperwork, but witnessing her efficiency firsthand was something else.

It wasn't as if she was being careless either.

Whenever I checked the papers Luna processed, everything was perfectly organized.

And so, a week went by with us immersed in paperwork.

"What's all this...?"

Rie looked at the mountain of papers stacked in the student council room.

That wasn't a pile of pending tasks.

Those were all the documents we had processed.

Various reports and forms were piled up, occupying a corner of the room.

"Ah, Rie's here?"

I looked at Rie with tired eyes.

Rie sighed after seeing my worn-out state.

I had been so focused in the paperwork for a while now that I looked utterly drained.

While I knew heading North would also be challenging, my current workload made me long for the open expanses of the North.

But I wasn't the only one feeling this exhaustion.

"Ru... Rudy, this is the last document..."

Luna was also hard at work in the student council room.

Even when I told her she didn't have to, Luna stayed, tirelessly sorting out the papers.

I wasn't sure what she meant by that, but seeing Luna gradually wear down was heartbreaking.

For a week, from the end of our classes until nighttime, we processed documents together.

But having Luna by my side made it more bearable.

"So, are we almost done with the paperwork?"

I mumbled to myself as I looked around.

"Heh... Finally, it's over."

Luna seemed relieved, practically melting in her chair, her energy completely drained.

Rie sighed as she observed both Luna and me.

"So, are you finally going to tell me? Why all this paperwork?"

"The North."

I replied with a faint smile.

"I'm going to apply to go to the North."

"And what about you, Luna?"

"... I'll be heading to the North too."

I stared at Luna in surprise.

Avoiding my gaze, Luna cleared her throat awkwardly.

"From the looks of it, it doesn't seem like you two plotted this together."

Rie crossed her arms and looked at us.

"So, you're planning to dump everything on me and disappear? All three of you going off to have fun?"

"...Three?"

I looked at Rie with a confused expression.

"Locke is there, too."

"...Oh?"

I then remembered, Locke was indeed with us.

Locke was the son of Count Lucarion.

In retrospect, Locke's participation was pretty much a given.

I hadn't taken that into account.

So, I was essentially leaving everything to Rie.

"Um... I'm sorry..."

"You just realized?"

Rie squinted at me.

Luna and I guiltily bowed our heads, sneaking glances to gauge Rie's reaction.

For a while, Rie silently stared at the two of us before finally speaking.

"Alright, go on then. You're going because of the grades, right?"

I blinked in surprise at Rie's unexpected approval.

"...We can go?"

"You were already planning on it anyway, weren't you? And all the paperwork is done."

Rie sighed and sat down on a chair.

"I figured you might do this, so I've already found a few people to take over."

"You knew we'd be heading north?"

"At this time of year, and seeing how hard you two have been working, it was obvious."

I was genuinely impressed with Rie's foresight.

Indeed, while we had most of the paperwork ready, there were other responsibilities.

The mid-term camp for first-year students.

An event we'd attended ourselves.

We needed people to handle that in our absence.

I'd been scouting potential candidates, but hearing she'd already done so impressed me even more.

"Rie...!"

I was deeply moved by Rie's words.

Luna seemed equally touched, mirroring my expression.

"You're incredible, Rie! Always thinking a step ahead!"

As I praised Rie, Luna gathered her hands, chimed in,

"You truly are the best, Rie! So smart and beautiful!"

"Hmm..."

Rie, trying to hide her slight blush, turned away.

Clearly, our flattery wasn't entirely unwelcome.

"The prettiest Rie in the world!"

"The wisest Rie in the entire empire!"

Luna and I continued showering Rie with compliments.

"Okay, okay, enough!"

Blushing, Rie backed away, waving her hands dismissively.

As our praises continued, the door to the student council room opened.

"Ah."

Luna and I froze, spotting the newcomers.

They probably heard our enthusiastic compliments.

"Um, hello?"

"...What are you doing?"

Emily and Kuhn entered the student council room. Emily gave an awkward, flustered smile while Kuhn looked at us with disdain.

"Ah..."

After an awkward silence and a series of explanations, we finally cleared up the misunderstanding - which wasn't really a misunderstanding at all.

Persia Territory.

In the main office of the estate, Astina was processing some documents.

Her father, the current head of the family, stood before her.

"Heh, at this rate, I might as well hand over the family affairs to you."

It had been quite some time since Astina began handling the responsibilities of the family head.

For the first month, she simply observed her father's work, but after that, she took over, managing the family affairs on her own.

Even without guidance, she was capable of handling everything.

Her inherent charisma made her popular among neighboring families, and she consistently represented the family at central* meetings, displaying all the qualities of a proper heir.

Because of her impeccable work, other nobles had begun to see her as the rightful successor of the Persia family.

The fact that her older brother Harpel was no longer around also solidified her position.

Astina smiled gracefully.

"It's all thanks to the guidance you've provided, Father."

The head of the Persia family looked at her with pride, a warm smile on his face.

He chuckled as he walked out of the room,

"Alright then, I'm off to rest. Take care of those documents."

"Yes, Father. Rest well."

Once her father left, Astina continued her work, processing the documents one by one.

As she did, she found herself gazing absentmindedly out of the window.

"I wonder how everyone is doing at the academy."

Not long ago, she heard that Rudy had become the student council president.

Rie was elected as the vice president, and Luna had also joined the council.

Hearing that news made her long to see Rudy's face.

It had been months since their last meeting.

She had been too busy before to miss him, but now, with things a bit more relaxed, she found herself wanting to revisit the academy, curious to see Rudy in his new role.

Just then, her secretary entered the office.

"Miss Astina, a letter has arrived."

"Oh? Let's see."

Astina took the letter from her secretary.

Upon seeing the royal seal stamped on it, her eyebrows furrowed.

Though termed a 'letter', it resembled more of an official document.

Typically, letters with such a prominent royal seal were for official matters, not personal correspondence.

Drawing a letter opener from her desk, Astina carefully opened the envelope.

The contents related to the northern region, specifically about an impending beast invasion there, with a request for support.

"The northern region..."

Upon hearing 'northern region', she immediately thought of Locke.

Though they hadn't spoken much, he had been a part of the student council during her tenure as president.

He was a diligent worker, dedicated to his duties.

While they weren't too friendly initially, by the end of her term, she had grown quite fond of him.

"It's his territory. I must provide proper support."

Astina pondered deeply, contemplating the best way to assist.

She finally made a decision.

“Riche.”

“Yes?”

Astina called her secretary and flashed a sly smile.

“Could you ask my father something for me?”

“What would you like to ask...?”

Astina lightly tapped the letter she was holding.

“Ask him if it’s alright for me to personally go there.”

Astina was becoming quite impatient.

She had been enduring the same daily tasks and putting on insincere smiles for months now.

She longed for a break to relieve her stress.

The letter mentioned that students from the academy were helping, so perhaps Locke might also return to his territory.

If that was the case, she could ask how Rudy has been doing lately.

She chuckled, all while being completely unaware that Rudy was headed to the North.

---Toggle New Ads

*it was said before that the palace/capital are located in the central territories. So central, is just a faster way to reference that.

Chapter 113: Northern Invasion (4)

The weather was clear.

People could be seen walking around the territory.

It was a lively atmosphere with an abundance of both sellers and buyers.

The territory wasn't particularly large, but with the number of people present, you'd think there wasn't an impending magical beast invasion.

"Rudy! Let's go over there!"

I'm currently in the North.

The Northern region, Lucarion territory.

Luna and I were able to come to the north through proper procedures.

Our supervising professor is Professor Gracie.

Most 3rd-year students were on their internships, so none of them were present.

The first-year students were also absent due to midterm camp.

At first, Yuni tried to skip the midterm camp to join us here.

-Wait, wasn't I supposed to come too?

-Why would you go? You should be at the midterm camp. It affects your grades, after all.

-But we're lab comrades! Are you leaving me out?

Yuni vehemently argued her case.

She truly wanted to ditch the midterm camp and come here.

-Do you think this is some kind of field trip?

-Isn't it?

While Yuni and I were having this back-and-forth,

Rie came into the lab.

-Don't worry about the midterm camp.

...What?

Rie said she had already excluded Yuni from the midterm camp attendees.

In exchange for a perfect score, Yuni would assist with student council duties.

Such an arrangement would usually be impossible, but when I expressed my wish to visit the North, they made it work.

The reason for the extra credits for the Northern visit?

Simply because few students apply.

The academy's assurance of safety to students visiting the North is due to the same reason.

However, when the student council president, which is me, wanted to go, the academy seemed to bend over backward to make it happen.

Yuni looked baffled, wondering how it went through without asking her first.

But Rie just shrugged and smiled, saying it was done.

Yuni simply nodded back.

It was curious how Yuni just accepted it obediently, but the matter was resolved for the time being.

"Luna, that looks fun too!"

"Oh, really? Let's check it out!"

And so, we arrived in the North.

The students treated us with honored guests, making sure we were comfortable.

After that, they let us do as we pleased.

Technically, it was Professor Gracie who decided to give us free rein.

On our arrival, Professor Gracie announced she would rest, leaving the students to explore on their own.

Her behavior wasn't surprising.

Before arriving here, Professor Gracie, like Luna and me, had been swamped with work.

Although most tasks were handed over to other labs, there were still some that Professor Gracie had to complete.

She had completed all of them before coming here.

She probably worked without getting any sleep.

We left a worn-out Professor Gracie at the lodgings and stepped outside.

Outside, there was plenty of food and attractions.

I had initially planned to just tour the territory, but I couldn't resist this.

"Could I get one of those skewers, please?"

"Of course! Thank you!"

Luna handed over some money and bought a skewer, taking an eager bite.

"Rudy, this tastes amazing."

She spoke, savoring every bite of her skewer.

Seeing her like that naturally brought a smile to my face.

Lately, we haven't had much of a chance to unwind and enjoy ourselves.

This felt like a refreshing change.

"But, why are there so many people here?"

After finishing her bite, Luna looked around curiously.

"They're probably here because of the magical beasts."

Upon hearing my explanation, Luna tilted her head in confusion.

"But everyone looks rather cheerful, don't they?"

She's right.

I thought the locals would be trembling in fear, knowing that numerous magical beasts could attack the castle at any moment.

Yet, despite that, the people in the territory were spirited.

"Ah, it's because they all trust the Lord of the territory."

The skewer vendor in front of us chimed in.

"The beasts have never made it inside the castle. Our Lord has always guarded it like an impenetrable fortress."

"They trust the Lord, you say?"

That made sense.

From the perspective of the ordinary residents, if the magical beasts couldn't penetrate the castle, it would make them think everything was safe.

The massive influx of people into the territory every four years was good for business, and considering the valuable materials obtained from slain beasts, the entire event felt more like a festival for the locals.

However...

My gaze turned to the Lord's mansion.

"The Lord needs to come up with a solution!"

"Think of your people, Lord!"

In front of the mansion, a surprisingly large group of people was protesting.

"There's a reason for that..."

"What reason?"

"There was a food shortage last winter."

I had heard stories about it.

In the harsh North, winter always brought with it food shortages.

Even with money, the main issue was transportation.

When heavy snowfalls occurred, it was impossible to transport food to the North using carriages.

Especially in the North where it snowed heavier than the other regions.

Storing large quantities of food in advance also wasn't feasible.

While magic could extend the food's shelf life, the cost of using wizards or magical tools often exceeded the food's value.

So, the North always had food-related issues.

"Ugh, it's those rebels. Only our kind Lord suffers."

I didn't respond to that remark, merely watching the crowd in front of the mansion.

A typical Lord wouldn't have tolerated such a gathering outside their mansion.

The Lord was surely working on solutions for the food crisis, and yet, the citizens were protesting.

Any other Lord would have surely acted out of injustice, but the head of the Lucarion family, the Lord of this place, merely observed in silence.

It was as if he considered their complaints as just another opinion.

"More importantly... the rebels..."

I still haven't received any news about Yaniel.

I once headed to the principal's office out of curiosity, but only found Cromwell there.

I heard that Principal McDowell is currently away on a business trip, making it difficult to meet him.

"Rudy, is something bothering you?"

"No, it's nothing."

"Shall we head that way then?"

"Yes."

I smiled gently, following behind Luna, and momentarily turned to gaze at the Lord's mansion.

"Hmm..."

"Ugh... I just want to rest..."

Dragging her weary body, Gracie made her way to the Lord's mansion.

She was heading for a dinner with the nobles who came from the central region, the head of the Lucarion family, and herself, representing the academy.

Even though Gracie would have preferred to skip dinner and just sleep in her room, she couldn't miss such an important gathering.

It wasn't in Gracie's nature to make such excuses.

"Heh..."

As Gracie sighed and was about to enter the mansion,

"Hello?"

Someone called out to her.

"Hmm?"

Gracie turned to see who it was.

A woman with fiery red hair.

She radiated an aura of grace and her poised demeanor was truly remarkable.

“Oh, you are?”

Not many in the empire had such red hair.

Especially not as vivid and blood-red as this.

A dignified woman with such hair could only be...

“Could you be... from the Persia family?”

“Yes, I am Astina Persia.”

Gracie blinked in surprise.

“I've heard a lot about you. You're Professor Gracie, aren't you?”

“Yes, that's... correct.”

Gracie hesitated, searching for the right words.

She was a professor, and Astina, a student.

But Astina had served as the student council president even before Gracie's tenure began, and this was their first face-to-face meeting.

Gracie's thoughts raced.

Should she address Astina as a student or as a noble from the central region?

Astina was the heir to the Persia Viscount family, holding a status higher than the local Lord, Lucarion.

Though she hadn't officially inherited the family name yet, it was widely believed it was only a matter of time.

So, should Gracie treat her like a Viscount?

However, as Gracie wondered this, Astina smiled faintly.

“How is Professor Cromwell?”

“Pr, Professor Cromwell?”

That's when it hit Gracie.

She remembered the person who had told her about Astina.

It was Cromwell.

The connection between Gracie and Astina:

Both were disciples of Cromwell, having learned telekinetic magic from him, sharing a deep bond of master and disciple.

“I've heard much about you, senior.”

Astina's respectful address warmed Gracie's heart.

Senior...

Such a title brought back fond memories, erasing the sorrows of her days as a royal wizard and a professor.

How wonderful were her student days?

She was the top of her class, constantly praised by the faculty, and everyone looked up to her with respect.

It was a memory as radiant as a jewel.

"Yes! Astina, I've heard so much about you too!"

With Gracie's cheerful words, Astina's mood visibly brightened.

Being too stiff with each other would only make things uncomfortable.

"What are the other students up to right now?"

"Oh, they're probably wandering around. They were told they could explore the area."

"Did Locke go as well?"

"Locke? Ah, I believe he might be at the castle."

Upon hearing this, Astina nodded.

She had initially wanted to inquire about Rudy, but hesitated, thinking it might be rude to abruptly bring him up.

However, as if Gracie sensed Astina's thoughts, she spoke up.

"Rudy and Luna said they'd be outside, so excluding them and Locke, the others should be at their accommodations."

Gracie said this offhandedly.

Astina's eyes widened in response.

"Rudy... you mean?"

"Yes, Rudy Astria."

"Right..."

A look of surprise spread across Astina's face.

Seeing her reaction, Gracie tilted her head in confusion.

Astina seemed like the type who wouldn't easily show their emotions.

But seeing her shocked expression, Gracie couldn't help but wonder the reason for it.

Gracie cautiously tried to gauge Astina's thoughts.

"Did something happen between the two of you?"

"No, not at all. Absolutely not."

Astina quickly waved her hands in dismissal and then swallowed.

"After the meeting, could we possibly go together?"

"Together? Where to?"

"To where the students are staying."

Astina said, her voice a mixture of excitement, surprise, and anticipation.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 114: Northern Invasion (5)

Luna and I explored the territory, taking in the surroundings.

Initially, we were enjoying the local delicacies and shops.

Now, we were inspecting the surrounding walls.

“Wow...”

I gazed at the walls, awestruck.

It felt as if I was looking at the Great Wall of China, standing as an unyielding fortress.

Soldiers patrolled the walls, standing guard. Nearby, we could spot military equipment, likely prepared in anticipation of beast attacks.

Luna and I continued our leisurely stroll along the wall.

The place was barren, devoid of anyone but soldiers.

However, the guards seemed more focused on the area outside the walls and paid little attention to us.

This was a restricted area, only accessible to authorized personnel.

We, visiting students, were granted access. But it wasn't open to the general public.

With only authorized individuals around, the soldiers primarily kept their eyes fixed beyond the walls.

“Hey, Rudy?”

While I was lost in the view of the wall, Luna gently tugged on my sleeve.

“Yeah?”

“That person... Don't they seem out of place?”

I followed Luna's gaze.

An individual wandering around, looking out of place.

The attire wasn't typical of the soldiers guarding the wall.

And their cautious, sneaky movements were unmistakable.

Their demeanor practically shouted, ‘I'm up to no good!’

“What's going on?”

“Who knows? What could they be up to?”

Luna and I exchanged glances after observing the individual for a moment.

“Should we keep an eye on them?”

Someone wandering so aimlessly in such a desolate area surely had a reason.

More puzzling was how they managed to get in here.

It was rare for non-soldiers to gain entry.

A thought crossed my mind.

The story we had heard.

The Rebels.

Could they be related?

Of course, there was a chance they weren't.

But instead of ignoring a suspicious person, we decided it was best to observe them a bit longer.

We discreetly trailed them.

They headed towards the outer edges of the wall.

There, they loitered as if waiting for someone.

“Who could they be waiting for?”

“I have... no clue.”

We both took cover next to the stairs leading to the top of the walls, keenly observing the situation.

“Hmm...”

Leaning against the stairs, I pondered.

The Rebels?

Or something else?

Lost in thought, I noticed a soldier from atop the wall gradually approaching the stairs.

“Ah...”

I looked over at Luna, who was peeking out just slightly from the stairs.

I immediately pulled her into hiding.

"Ugh!"

Luna made a peculiar sound as I suddenly drew her towards me.

Ending up right before me, I quickly silenced her.

We both hid, pressing ourselves against the wall.

The muffled sound of footsteps approached.

Although I couldn't clearly see who it was, I could tell they were descending the stairs.

I held my breath, intently focusing on the footsteps.

Gradually, the sound faded into the distance.

Releasing a sigh of relief, I turned to Luna.

She was staring back, her eyes fixed intently on mine.

"Hmm?"

"Huh?"

When our eyes met, Luna swiftly sidestepped, breaking our gaze.

"Oh, I mean... I just didn't know where else to look."

She flailed her arms, seemingly embarrassed by her own explanation.

"It's okay, it was sudden."

I smiled, trying to ease the tension.

"Hehe..."

Luna chuckled uneasily, diverting her gaze.

"Hm?"

She then pointed to a spot where we had noticed someone earlier.

I followed her gesture.

The guard who had just passed was now chatting with the man who had been lurking nearby.

But there was an issue.

We were too far away to hear their conversation clearly.

I frowned, contemplating our next move.

"Should we move closer?"

Luna shook her head in response.

"We might get caught, and there's nowhere else to hide."

She began rummaging through her bag, pulling out Levian's Spellbook.

Flipping through its pages, she remarked,

"There's a spell perfect for this!"

After browsing for a while, she settled on a specific page and began channeling her mana.

The spellbook emitted a soft glow.

-Hey, I really appreciate what you did yesterday.

A faint voice sounded from the spellbook: it was their conversation.

Luna beamed with pride.

Although I didn't understand the spell she used, I gave her a thumbs up in appreciation.

We both tuned in, focusing on the conversation.

-Thanks to you, I got some fine liquor.

Liquor?

Nothing seemed too unusual at this point.

I was suspicious of the man we had followed, but maybe he was just an off-duty soldier.

-And that lady, she was really something.

-Heh, looks like you enjoyed her company.

"Enjoyed?"

Luna tilted her head, puzzled.

-That woman... what a beauty.

My eyes widened in disbelief.

Doubting my ears, I caught Luna's equally surprised gaze.

Her face was gradually turning red.

Reacting quickly, I covered Luna's ears, urging,

"Don't listen."

"W-what?"

Luna's eyes darted in confusion as I blocked her hearing.

-Ugh, seriously—.

I couldn't help but frown.

I hadn't come here to listen to such vulgar talk.

While covering Luna's ears, listening to their indecent chatter made me feel oddly embarrassed as well.

"R-Rudy, is it over now?"

Luna stared at me, her expression puzzled.

However, the two of them hadn't stopped their crude conversation.

I tilted my head slightly, forcing an awkward smile.

Seeing my reaction, Luna couldn't help but smile too.

-More importantly, did you bring it?

It?

I quickly focused on their changed topic.

-Do you have any idea how hard it was to get this?

-‘That person’ probably got it, right? Why are you trying to make it a big deal?

I released Luna's ears.

-Whatever, just handle it with care. The blast radius is surprisingly large, so be cautious.

-Understood. Any word from the rebels?

-As usual. They're counting on us.

The two exchanged pleasantries before parting.

Watching them leave, my frown deepened.

The matters unfolding in the shadows:

Explosives.

Rebels.

And 'that person'?

Who is 'that person'?

"How did the meeting go?"

"Meeting? It was just a meal."

Locke's father, the head of the Lucarion family, Darren Lucarion, said with a chuckle.

Locke looked at his father and posed a question.

"I heard Astina was there."

"Yes, she's quite assertive. One shouldn't underestimate her because of her young age and gender."

Darren was a seasoned veteran from the North.

In front of him, Astina confidently voiced her opinions without faltering.

She didn't blindly accept Darren's views just because he was a veteran.

She critically evaluated the validity of his suggestions logically, accepting them if they were sound and refuting them if they were not.

Darren appreciated Astina's forthright attitude.

Even if Astina was the promising successor of a viscount family, she was still relatively inexperienced.

He had assumed she would mostly be in a learning position during the beast invasion.

He had underestimated her.

"It seems the empire is slowly transitioning to a new generation."

Darren had been through so much that it was difficult for him to think as flexibly as Astina.

He often relied on his past experiences over logical judgment, favoring consistency over change.

Yet, seeing how Astina approached things, he felt it might soon be time to hand the reins over to the younger generation.

Seeing his father smile, Locke opened his mouth.

"Why didn't Cedric attend this time?"

"Cedric, you say?"

Cedric.

He was known as the Mercenary King.

Cedric always returned to the North whenever there was threat of a beast invasion.

But he was absent from today's gathering.

A place where someone of Cedric's stature should've certainly been present.

It was a meal to which many notable figures and those with extensive northern experience were invited.

This gathering was meant for sharing information, primarily about the north and the impending beast raid.

But Cedric was nowhere in sight.

Cedric hailed from the North.

Everyone affectionately called him the 'migratory bird'.

A bird that returns to its homeland whenever magical beasts loom.

However, this year, there was no sign of Cedric.

"He might be busy. Maybe he's settled in another territory."

Cedric was a mercenary, a free spirit.

Even if the North was his birthplace, he was beyond any lord's control.

"As they say, no news is good news. He's probably doing well on his own."

Still, Darren's expression showed traces of concern.

Cedric was a close comrade who had stood by Darren through thick and thin.

A trusted ally especially during beast invasions.

His absence naturally worried Darren.

"We still have some time before the beast invasion. Let's wait and see."

Darren remarked with a warm smile.

"...Huh?"

I blinked in confusion.

Was I especially tired today?

I must be seeing things.

I had been wandering around the village for quite a while.

Seeing Luna tilting her head and murmuring,

"Hm? What?"

I guessed she might be feeling the same.

"It's been a while."

A woman with fiery red hair greeted, giving a casual wave.

She sat confidently, her legs crossed on a chair, wearing a broad smile.

"...Astina?"

I stared at her, my expression a mix of surprise and confusion.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 115: Northern Invasion (6)

Luna and I looked around and eventually returned to our accommodations.

Walking so much after such a long time had taken its toll on my legs, and my mind was filled with thoughts.

Rebels and soldiers.

If one soldier could be bought out, it raised the possibility that other soldiers might have been as well.

The question was, how?

From the stories I had heard while eating skewers at a stall, one could infer the level of loyalty the local citizens had for their lord.

Something seemed odd here.

It made no sense for the soldiers to revolt against their lord when the local citizens had such a favorable opinion of him.

A few possibilities came to mind.

An enemy from within.

Someone related to the soldiers or local citizens had betrayed their lord.

Otherwise, it was unlikely that each soldier would individually betray their lord.

Perhaps someone of significant influence was behind turning the soldiers against him...

Lost in these thoughts, I started to get a headache.

"I'm so tired..."

"Same here... Let's go in and rest."

It seemed Luna's legs were aching too.

She rubbed them as we walked.

Shortly after, we arrived at our lodgings.

It was a magnificent place, clearly meant to host esteemed guests.

The moment we stepped in, we saw a luxurious lounge furnished with high-end sofas and tables.

Two individuals were seated on one of the sofas.

"...Isn't that Professor Gracie?"

Professor Gracie was talking with someone.

The person sitting opposite her had their back to the entrance, making it impossible to see their face.

However, a hint of fiery red hair was visible.

That hair instantly reminded me of Astina.

During the winter break, I received letters from Astina a few times.

But at some point, I lost contact with her.

She probably got too busy.

Being in line to inherit would undoubtedly keep her occupied.

I had wanted to share the news about becoming the student council president with her.

Still, not wanting to bother her, I eventually dropped the idea.

"Ah! Rudy, Luna, you're here?"

Suddenly, Professor Gracie, with a beaming face, waved at Luna and me.

Feeling it would be appropriate to greet her companion, I walked towards them.

The person opposite Professor Gracie turned to face us.

"...Huh?"

I stared at the individual.

Then blinked.

And stared again.

I shot Luna a puzzled glance.

Luna seemed just as taken aback as I was.

"It's been a while."

The woman with fiery red hair.

It was none other than Astina.

"Astina?"

Astina, with a smile, rose from her seat.

"It's been a long time, Rudy, Luna."

Seeing her greet us, my eyes widened in astonishment.

"...What?"

With a smile, Astina responded,

"I came to see you."

"...What?"

I was left dumbfounded by her unexpected statement.

Astina flashed a playful smile.

"Just kidding. I didn't even know you were coming. I only heard from Professor Gracie, so I came to see you."

"Ah..."

I didn't know who was being sent from the central region.

As the student council president, I naturally knew more than other people, but it was hard to get accurate news about the northern region.

Sending support from the central region to the north involved mobilizing troops.

It was confidential.

Of course, it wasn't a massive secret, but still, confidential information wasn't easily accessible.

Perhaps Astina found my surprised face amusing because she giggled.

I narrowed my eyes and stared back.

"Astina, you seem to have become even more cunning."

"Have I?"

Astina smiled.

There was something different about her since her time at the academy.

She seemed more poised and mature.

The outfit she wore might have contributed to this.

Most times I'd seen Astina, she was in casual clothes or the academy uniform.

But now, she wore formal attire, exuding an aristocratic aura.

"I heard you became the student council president."

Astina approached me slowly, placing her hand on my head.

"Seems like you're quite determined."

"I did say, didn't I? That I'd take responsibility."

"Good, keep that attitude."

Astina teased, tapping my head.

"Do you see me as a child, patting my head like that?"

Technically, it felt more like she was just touching my hair rather than patting it.

It didn't feel bad.

Regardless of what others thought, at the academy, Astina was at the top.

It was an honor to be acknowledged by someone like her.

"So, Astina, are you here representing the central support troops?"

"Exactly. I'm here as the representative."

I nodded in understanding.

Typically, when a region offers support, it's rare for the Lord to come personally.

Usually, they'd just send a knight from their family if they wanted to establish a good relationship with the North.

Being here meant she had some leeway in her training as a successor.

If she's recognized as the representative of the central region, it indirectly means that they acknowledge her as the future head of the family.

It's virtually the same as inheriting the family title.

It was just a matter of timing.

This might be the perfect opportunity.

Successfully defending against the monsters this time could earn her full recognition from the central nobles.

Up till now, most of Astina's achievements were from her time at the academy.

But there's a distinct difference between the academy and the outside world.

She couldn't just rest on her laurels from the academy once she was out in society.

Achievements in the academy were undeniably important.

However, if someone who shone at the academy couldn't produce any notable results once outside, then those achievements became meaningless.

It's a fairly straightforward concept when you think about it.

Even if someone had stellar grades at the academy, if they couldn't apply it in real situations, they were pointless.

Considering this, there wasn't much to worry about Astina, as she seemed capable in real-life situations as well.

She'll surely prove her worth in the upcoming beast attack.

"Since you're here as a representative, where will you be staying?"

"Ah, we were just discussing that."

"...Pardon?"

Gracie then interrupted our conversation.

"Astina has decided to stay here!"

"Is that so?"

"...Here?"

While I reacted nonchalantly, Luna's response seemed slightly strained.

Astina, noticing Luna's reaction, smiled faintly, leaning in to whisper something into Luna's ear.

Luna's eyes widened in surprise at whatever Astina whispered.

After sharing her secret, Astina took a step back.

Luna glared at Astina, clenching her fists.

"You... never!"

I tilted my head in confusion, puzzled by Luna's behavior.

Although Luna and Astina weren't particularly close, they weren't on bad terms either.

It was puzzling to see Luna react this way.

I looked at Astina,

"What did you tell her?"

"It's a secret between us girls,"

Astina playfully placed her index finger on her lips.

I wondered what it was that needed to be kept a secret.

"If you're staying here, we'll have plenty of time to chat."

"That's true. There are things I'd like to hear as well."

"Sounds good."

Then Luna grabbed my sleeve.

"Rudy! Aren't you tired? Yawn~ We walked around so much today; I'm exhausted."

Luna exaggerated a yawn while addressing me.

"Am I tired? ...Maybe a little?"

"See? Why don't we go in and sleep? We can chat tomorrow; it's not too late."

After a moment of thought, I replied,

"But, it's been a while since we've seen Astina. I'd like to catch up for a bit."

"Hehe..."

Astina responded with a pleased smile.

"Why don't you head to bed, Luna? I'd like some private time to chat with Rudy. Just the two of us."

Luna looked shocked at that.

“Alright, Luna. If you’re tired, you should get some rest.”

I thought it was a reasonable suggestion.

However, Luna's reaction was completely unexpected.

“No! Actually, I’m not tired at all! I just said that because I was worried about you, Rudy~.”

Luna confidently raised her arm to show off her biceps.

It was a pose to showcase her muscles, but Luna's biceps looked soft, lacking any muscle definition.

She had the muscle strength typical of a wizard.

We settled into the lobby and began to chat.

From the incident where I was kidnapped in Astina's absence to the story of how I defeated Yuni and became the student council president, I shared everything.

I detailed it slowly and thoroughly.

Once I'd shared everything, a question nagged at me.

"Speaking of which, do you know anything about Yeniel?"

"Yeniel?"

Astina tilted her head in thought.

"Yeniel hasn't returned from the Rebels."

"I don't know her exact whereabouts."

I pondered, stroking my chin.

"Speaking of which, even in the northern region..."

"Hmm..."

Just as I was about to delve into the topic of the Rebels in the northern region, I heard a rustling sound nearby.

Looking over, I saw Luna, leaning and seemingly dozing off by the sofa.

Seeing her in such a state, I couldn't help but smile.

"If you're tired, you should go to bed instead of sleeping here."

As I mumbled that to myself, Astina giggled softly.

"Please, take good care of Luna."

Astina's voice was warm.

I replied confidently.

"Isn't that a given?"

Luna had always been a great help to me.

It was only right I repay her kindness.

"Also, observe closely."

"...Pardon?"

"Pay close attention to your surroundings."

Astina smiled faintly.

"You'll see so much more if you do."

A man donned a hood.

His muscular physique was evident, even beneath the cloak, and his gait radiated confidence.

His appearance clearly hinted at him being a knight.

Despite his attempt to hide it, the aura he exuded was undeniable.

The knight knocked on the door of a humble shack.

“Is anyone home?”

The door opened to reveal a man with a prominent scar over one eye.

The knight greeted the man with a nod.

“Cedric, it's been a while.”

“It hasn't been that long since we last met.”

“The last time we spoke, it was still chilly. Now the weather's turning warmer, hasn't it been a while?”

Their last meeting had been during a gathering hosted by the Lord of Lucarion, Darren, concerning The Rebels.

The hooded knight entered the shack, and then asked a question.

“Is everything progressing as planned?”

“It's going so well that it's unsettling.”

Cedric said with a chuckle.

"If there's any bad news, it's just that our leader had a bit of trouble."

“The Leader?”

“Yes. He fought with the Principal of Liberion Academy.”

“Was he badly injured?”

“He lost a leg.”

The knight furrowed his brows.

"That's very unfortunate."

“For now, the Leader has decided not to come here.”

“Hmm... Is that a good idea? The new recruit from central seems competent.”

Cedric laughed dismissively.

“She's just a kid.”

“Also, there’s talk about Professor Gracie from the Academy...”

“Enough.”

Cedric cut him off.

“Don’t worry. I’ve heard that the rebels are sending a skilled wizard our way. You just focus on your duties.”

“...Understood.”

The knight nodded, heading back towards the door.

“Just so you know, I'll be quite busy soon, so I might not be able to visit.”

“Alright, let's meet on ‘that day’ then.”

‘That day.’

It referred to the day of the beast's invasion.

And also, the day they would commence their grand plan.

The day that would mark the true beginning of the rebellion.

The knight gave a slight bow before leaving the shack, swiftly disappearing from sight.

He swiftly left the area, trying not to draw attention, but someone was already watching.

“Hmm...”

Locke, with his hood pulled low, observed the shack.

Locke clearly saw everything.

The knight, hooded, sneaking around to avoid being noticed, and inside that shack, there was no mistaking Cedric's face.

The prominent scar across his eye.

Locke clearly recognized that scar as Cedric's.

Heaving a sigh, Locke muttered to himself.

“Things are getting complicated...”

He then gazed up at the sky.

---Toggle New Ads

I can't remember if I explained this already but in case it wasn't clear, central just refers to the central region, like the North and the South. The capital resides in the central region

Chapter 116: Northern Invasion (7)

Locke came to see us early in the morning.

"A traitor."

"I've briefly discussed it with my father already. I thought Astina should know, so I came."

Saying this, Locke glanced to the side.

"Why are you two acting like this?"

Locke looked at us with narrowed eyes.

Luna and I looked back at him, giggling.

The reason for our laughter?

Astina gave a soft smile.

"I've already heard a bit from them."

"...Already?"

Last night.

After I took Luna back to her room, I had a short conversation with Astina.

The topic was about an enemy within our ranks.

And the scene we witnessed.

A traitorous soldier, and speculation that someone was orchestrating it all.

I relayed everything to Astina.

"Well, these two might not know all the details, but they did know some key pieces of information."

"Key information?"

I responded, seeing the questioning look on Locke's face.

"Magic tools."

As I said this, Luna, who was beside me, took out a notebook and showed it to everyone.

"There's a magic tool installed on the city wall."

In the notebook Luna presented, there was a drawing of the magic circle carved onto the magic tool.

Of course, it wasn't the complete magic circle detailing all its functionalities.

Extracting the exact magic circle from the tool is almost impossible.

The only discernible part was the central rune.

Just enough to understand the magic circle's capability.

But that was enough.

"What kind of magic is it?"

To Locke's question, Luna replied.

"It's explosive magic."

"They probably aim to bring down the city wall."

I added to Luna's statement.

"The city wall...?"

"Yes, that magic tool is currently installed on the wall."

We followed the soldier who had received the magic tool.

That soldier, holding the tool, went back towards the wall.

He checked his surroundings and then removed a brick from the wall.

When the brick was taken out, an opening was revealed, into which he placed the magic tool.

After he left, we inspected the magic tool.

A round-shaped magic tool.

A bomb meant to destroy the wall.

"But, why did you leave the magic tool there?"

"In case they check it and find it missing."

I said with a smirk.

"We have to get rid of them all at once."

When dealing with pests, you can't just pick them off one by one.

You need to be swift and thorough.

That way, they won't have time to react or hide.

So, you need to eliminate them entirely without leaving a trace.

"So, the issue is that 'Mercenary King' and one of your knights?"

I gestured a slashing motion across my throat.

"Now that we know their plan, let's take them out."

At my words, Astina also chimed in.

“Central can help since it's related to the rebels.”

Yet, Locke's face didn't seem hopeful.

“What do you plan to do with the beasts if we deal with them now?”

Seeing Locke's expression, Astina quietly spoke.

“...Are many soldiers involved?”

“The knight in question holds a significant rank, and he has many soldiers under him.”

At Locke's words, Luna cocked her head.

“...Why? Can't we just get reinforcements from Central?”

In response to Luna's question, I shook my head.

“The beast attack will happen soon. It would take time to bring in additional soldiers, and the beasts could strike before they arrive.”

Mobilizing a large group of soldiers isn't simple; many factors must be considered.

Especially now, when we're uncertain about the rebels' next move.

It's not feasible to withdraw a large force from just one territory.

We'd need to pull small numbers from multiple territories.

If we waited for Central to oversee these movements, it would be too time-consuming.

So, the only help from Central was the soldiers Astina brought, along with a few knights and nobles.

But they weren't weak.

After some thought, Astina spoke in a low voice.

"When the beasts attack, the rebels might use a different strategy."

If we preemptively strike the rebels, they might retaliate in an unexpected manner.

If they have hidden troops nearby for a surprise attack, we'd be dealing with an enemy of unknown strength.

"So, are we waiting until the beasts attack?"

Locke remained silent, seemingly in agreement with Astina's point.

Facing them as the magical beasts attack...

It's a risky strategy.

Dealing with both beasts and rebels simultaneously wasn't easy.

Even if we knew most of their plan, it was a dangerous operation.

However, I found myself somewhat agreeing with Locke.

If many soldiers were purged before the beasts attacked, morale would plummet.

During the skirmish with the beasts, the idea that someone might stab them in the back would take root.

It's hard to make a move with a significant battle looming.

"Can't we at least capture that knight?"

"That's doable. That's the plan, in fact."

"But if he goes missing, wouldn't the others notice?"

“I've thought of that too. Capturing him is the priority. We don't want our own men fighting each other during the battle.”

In the midst of this conversation, Professor Gracie, who was beside us, raised her hand.

“Let's say the war goes well.”

She tilted her head, asking,

"Who will guard our rear?"

All of us turned to look intently at Professor Gracie.

A figure who had no specific role in the battle with the beasts and would be positioned in the rear.

She's highly regarded in the academy and became a royal wizard at a young age.

Such a talent that Professor Cromwell personally scouted her.

"...Why are you all looking at me?"

"I've heard quite a lot about Professor Gracie from Professor Cromwell."

Astina said with a smile.

"I'm counting on you."

Lucarion Mansion.

A choked gasp echoed.

Darren Lucarion, the head of the Lucarion family, was wielding a sword.

Before him lay a knight, covered in blood.

Darren wiped the blood from his blade.

"Lord... I beg your forgiveness... Please... spare my life..."

In what seemed like an invitation for dinner and conversation at the mansion, Darren unexpectedly attacked the knight.

Caught off guard, the knight couldn't defend against Darren's sudden onslaught.

He was overwhelmed even before he could draw his own sword.

Of course, even fully armed and prepared, the knight would never have been a match for Darren.

There were only a few who could hope to challenge the seasoned Darren in a duel.

"I won't kill you right away."

Upon Darren's signal, Locke stepped out from the shadows, approaching slowly.

"You'll likely end up begging for death."

"My Lord...!!!"

"Tell me everything you know. If you do, I promise a swift, painless death."

"Lord!!!!!!!!!!!"

The knight was then dragged away by Locke.

Darren sighed heavily.

The pain of betrayal from someone he had trusted was a heavy blow.

It was agonizing to realize he had been backstabbed by someone he'd trusted so deeply.

Moreover...

"Cedric... Why did you make this choice..."

Darren had always considered Cedric as close as a brother.

Having fought life-threatening battles together every four years, their bond was even deeper than that of siblings.

They'd celebrated victories and shared drinks after the battles.

To think that Cedric, who was like a brother, was now plotting against him was a devastating revelation.

"Since you aimed for the lives of me and the people of the territory..."

Darren stared at his bloodied sword.

"I won't stand by idly."

He had set explosive magic on the walls, lured in the rebels, and then planned a major offensive during the magical beast invasion.

If Cedric's plan had come to fruition, not just Darren, but his son Locke, his wife, and all the people of the territory would have faced annihilation.

Darren couldn't forgive Cedric for orchestrating such treachery.

Had Cedric targeted only him, Darren might have listened, perhaps even sympathized.

But this was a different matter.

Darren couldn't find it in himself to forgive.

Time passed quickly.

Inside a tent where a meeting was in full swing.

A soldier rushed in.

"My Lord... They are approaching."

Darren let out a sigh.

As he stood up, the expressions of those around him tightened.

The magical beasts.

They had come.

"Proceed as planned."

Upon Darren's order, those seated began leave the tent.

Once everyone had left, only two individuals remained.

"My Lord."

Astina and Darren.

Only the two of them.

"Then, I'll proceed as planned."

Darren nodded in acknowledgment.

"Please ensure the safety of my son and our people."

"I entrust the front lines to you."

"Don't worry about those creatures; holding them off is my specialty."

Instead of following the others, Astina exited through the back of the tent.

Darren, after watching Astina leave, stepped outside himself.

He was clad in black armor.

And he gripped a long sword in his hand.

His presence commanded the attention of those around.

With every step, his armor clanked, drawing the gazes of nearby soldiers.

Darren moved with deliberate slowness, heading to the command post atop the city gates.

Ascending with each step, he reached his destination, taking in the view beyond the walls.

Outside, a vast plain stretched out.

A barren land with not a single blade of grass or tree in sight.

Darren's gaze settled on the distant horizon.

At the end of his sightline, a horde of beasts loomed.

Swarming dark masses.

Their numbers were staggering, well into the tens of thousands.

"My Lord, here is your helmet."

A soldier beside him handed Darren a helmet.

A black helmet that matched his armor.

Darren surveyed his surroundings.

There were soldiers filled with fear, while others swallowed, their faces tense.

Darren took the helmet, and then spoke up.

"Warriors, are you afraid?"

"If we let fear control us, everything behind us—our homes, our families—will be lost."

"They will be overrun and taken from us."

"But if we muster just a bit more courage, such a fate will not come to pass."

Darren donned the helmet.

"Warriors of the North, our allies who've come to aid us."

"As it has always been, as we've always shown,"

"Only victory lies before us."

Darren, with the helmet on, raised his sword high.

"Bring death to the enemy!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!"

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 117: Northern Invasion (8)

"Aaaaaahhhhhhhh!!!!"

The entire castle echoed with a piercing scream.

That was the signal that the battle had begun.

But outside the castle walls, another group was stirring.

"Is everyone ready?"

A man with a prominent scar on his eye.

Cedric had his sword at the ready.

He was not alone in the dimly lit space; many others stood by his side.

They were mercenaries.

Men who'd do almost anything if the price was right.

However, even for a good sum, there were tasks they'd refuse, especially those with high risk to their lives.

No amount of money could make them undertake missions with a high probability of death.

Yet, they were gathered here for a dangerous task.

If they failed, they would all face a grim fate.

And the reason they'd gathered despite such odds?

It was because of Cedric.

The mercenaries trusted him, drawn by his reputation as the 'King of Mercenaries'.

They believed in him and his cause.

With sword in hand, Cedric took the lead.

"We march towards freedom, towards equality, one step at a time."

What Cedric desired was freedom.

What he yearned for was equality.

A brilliant and beautiful ideology.

He was like a moth drawn to this radiant flame.

He believed in this path, in this ideal.

He thought that granting freedom to everyone was the answer.

The sacrifices made along the way, he believed, had value.

Despite all obstacles, he relentlessly pursued this path, this belief.

With that, Cedric led his band from the darkness towards the light.

Their hideout was in a cave nearby.

The castle's forces were currently occupied by beasts at the main gate.

That left the rear gate almost unguarded.

Moreover, the few soldiers there had already been bribed.

"Let's move forward, towards freedom,"

Cedric declared.

Exiting the cave, they made their way towards the woods.

A forest lay between the castle and the cave.

Unlike the dense northern woods, this was merely an area with evergreens.

As they were about to enter the forest, a figure stumbled out, looking as if they had been pushed.

"Uh... ah..."

"Who goes there?!"

Cedric pointed his sword at the figure.

At his command, the mercenaries behind him also drew their weapons.

"Ah... it's just that..."

It was Gracie.

"Ahaha... seems I might've lost my way a bit."

"Professor, please, show some dignity."

Another figure emerged from behind her.

"...Locke?"

Cedric looked in surprise at Locke.

His close friend's... Darren's son.

Seeing his face brought a rush of emotions.

"Locke, you shouldn't be here."

Cedric lowered his sword as he spoke.

He didn't want to harm Locke.

Darren had been his close friend, but he had to be a stepping stone for freedom.

For the rebel's plan to proceed, it was unavoidable.

But Locke was a different matter.

He was still young.

It was a time in his life meant for joy and exploration.

Cedric thought that, in the future, if Locke chose to seek revenge for his father, it would be justified.

He was sure that if he killed Darren now, he would become Locke's enemy, and Cedric was prepared for the retribution that would follow.

But that would be after freeing the world.

Now wasn't the time.

"Locke, flee now while you still can. I won't chase you."

He advised.

At this, Locke drew his sword.

"What are you talking about? Can't you see I'm here to stop you?"

Even towards Cedric, a mere commoner, Locke addressed him with respect.

It was the minimum courtesy he owed.

A courtesy for the man who was a close friend of his father.

Cedric's expression darkened as he gazed at Locke,

"If you try to stop me, even you won't be spared."

Locke replied with a smirk,

“Didn't you used to call us the ‘foolish father-son duo’?”

Cedric frowned deeper upon hearing Locke’s words, reminded of the past.

Conversations he had shared with Darren’s family over meals.

"Why bring that up now?"

"I'm not sure, perhaps because I'm a fool? I just have a feeling I won't be the one dying today."

Locke said, corners of his mouth turning up, and then glanced at the woman behind him, Gracie.

"Professor, shall we begin?"

“...Sigh, I didn't become a professor to do these kind of things.”

Gracie murmured, gathering her mana.

Her voice held a hint of reluctance.

Yet, in stark contrast to her words, the swirling mana around her was eerily powerful.

Mana surged around Gracie, her hair flying in the tumult.

"...What is this?"

With her eyes closed, Gracie directed her mana.

Sparks began to emit from the ground around her.

zzzt...!

The sparks multiplied, affecting the nearby vegetation and the ground itself.

Then, Gracie opened her eyes.

Her eyes were now tinted in a striking shade of blue, and her hair gradually turned white.

The mercenaries watching were wide-eyed with shock.

Their instincts told them one thing.

This was dangerous.

The experienced mercenaries could feel it.

Chills ran down their spines, their hair standing on end.

But it was already too late.

Their only mistake?

Overconfidence.

They had greater numbers, facing just a boy and a woman.

Cedric cried out,

“Everyone... everyone run...!!!”

“Lightning Strike.”

With a swift motion, Gracie released her spell.

Bolts of powerful electricity emerged from the ground and the sky, striking them down.

A chain reaction of electricity.

It overturned the ground and consumed them.

Zzzzp!!!

“Argh!”

"Help... Ahhh!!!"

Screams filled the vicinity.

"What is this... Ugh...!!!"

Even Cedric couldn't escape the electric onslaught.

But unlike the helpless fallen mercenaries, he held on.

Watching Cedric's struggle, Locke spoke,

"We have Professor 'Lightning Gracie', after all."

Gracie responded to Locke's teasing comment with a grunt.

"Ugh."

Lightning Gracie.

That was the nickname Astina heard from Cromwell and shared with everyone about Gracie Lifegold.

A moniker Gracie held back during her academy days.

Despite being under the tutelage of Professor Cromwell, Gracie never practiced telekinetic magic.

Well, to be precise, she learned it but chose not to use it.

It was simply a matter of preference.

Gracie just didn't resonate with telekinetic magic.

To her, it felt as ill-fitting as wearing clothes not suited for her.

However, it's not like the telekinetic magic was of no use.

She created many utility spells with it.

But she never used it in combat and other things.

Instead, she focused on lightning magic.

That's how she earned her nickname.

Rejecting Professor Cromwell's teachings and harnessing lightning.

A mage who swept everyone in academy duels using lightning magic.

Among her juniors and peers, she gained the moniker 'Lightning Gracie.'

That very Gracie Lifegold was now a novice teacher in her first year at the academy.

"It's started."

"Seems so."

Luna and I were inside the castle.

Not a single sign of movement could be observed within its walls.

Though it was daytime, there was no sign of anyone.

All the inhabitants seemed to have taken shelter in their homes.

"It feels eerily quiet like this."

It was odd.

Despite being in the midst of a usually bustling area during broad daylight, we couldn't sense a single presence.

The distant sounds of combat were unmistakably clear, making the atmosphere even more unsettling.

Luna seemed to agree with me, nodding in response.

After observing Luna's expression for a moment, I rose from my seat.

“Shall we get going?”

Our reason for being here, without even a single soldier accompanying us, was for The Rebels.

Three groups participated in this uprising.

One consisted of Cedric's mercenaries, another of betrayers from the noble families, and the last was The Rebels.

Initially, the leader of The Rebels was supposed to personally bring troops here.

Their plan was to destroy the castle gates, unleash monsters upon the territory, and in the midst of the chaos, Cedric would assassinate Darren Lucarion, the lord.

This would send the central and northern troops into confusion, leaving the citizens exposed to the monster threat.

Then the Rebels would appear, exterminate the monsters, and emerge as heroes.

That was their narrative.

However, that storyline was already disrupted.

Firstly, we received the good news that the leader of The Rebels had been gravely injured and couldn't make it here.

So, it promised to be an easier battle than anticipated.

We moved slowly, but with a sense of purpose.

Towards the slums.

That's where we were headed.

According to a traitorous knight, The Rebels had already infiltrated the castle.

They had been distributing food to the citizens and manipulating public opinion.

It seemed like the Rebels were preparing to make their move.

But they might just keep preparing forever.

Because the signal for action might never come.

Cedric, The Rebels, and even the knights who were supposed to be battling monsters—all were waiting for a signal.

The signal was the sound of a magical device that would bring down the castle walls.

But that device had already been removed from the walls.

Most likely, the Lord had it now.

Luna and I located a particular house in the slums.

It was the one Locke had previously identified for us.

It was originally where Cedric was hiding, but now, we'd heard, someone else occupied it.

“Luna.”

“Yes!”

Luna opened her spellbook.

She then cast a silence spell.

This ensured that no sound would escape from near the shack.

So they thought they could ambush us?

Did they think we would just sit back and let it happen?

Not a chance.

An eye for an eye, a tooth for a tooth, an ambush for an ambush.

“Let’s do this.”

I channeled my mana.

And reached out towards the shack.

It had been a while since I last used dark magic.

Drawing upon the mana within me, I released an appropriate amount.

The perfect amount.

Measured precisely.

It felt right.

Perhaps because I was in such good form, the mana within me moved as if it were a part of my very body.

Slowly, I raised my hand, pointing it at the shack.

A large circle appeared on it.

Soon after, a light emanated from the circle.

I uttered the incantation.

“Flame of Destruction.”

BOOOOM!

Where the shack once stood, a pillar of black flames surged upwards.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 118: Northern Invasion (9)

A pillar of black flames erupted from beneath the cabin, shattering it into fragments.

I gazed at the flaming remains.

Emerging from the flames was a figure in a robe, a girl wearing a pointed hat resembling those worn by witches.

She appeared quite young.

In her hand, she held a staff adorned with a large gemstone.

"What is this?"

Shielding herself with a barrier, the girl, with a furrowed brow, stepped out from between the flames.

"Hmm..."

She had clearly been hit with dark magic, yet she walked out from the flames without a single scratch.

"Who are you people?"

The girl asked, narrowing her eyes at us.

Instead of answering, I asked back,

"Who are you?"

The girl looked at me incredulously.

"Really?... You attacked without even knowing who I am? Is this how youngsters behave these days?"

I was taken aback by her words.

She looked younger than us, but she referred to us as 'youngsters,' which was quite absurd.

First, I gathered my thoughts to grasp the situation.

She had been ambushed and directly hit by dark magic, but the girl emerged unscathed.

Either she was overwhelmingly powerful, or she specialized in defensive magic.

As I pondered the situation, the girl alternated her gaze between Luna and me, then spoke.

"If you attacked out of the blue, I assume you're enemies?"

With a swift motion, she swung the staff in her hand.

Mana began to swirl.

From her, figures emerged as if she was made of smoke.

"...What's this?"

The smoke-like entities transformed to look exactly like the girl.

The smoke-clones then emitted more smoke from their bodies, replicating themselves in what seemed like a cloning technique.

Luna urgently shouted,

"Rudy! It's illusion magic!"

The scene was now filled with dozens of figures resembling the girl.

They all reached out their hands.

"Fireball."

Dozens of fire orbs hurtled towards us.

"Barrier."

I uttered the word calmly.

The fire balls collided with my barrier.

Yet, only two impacts were felt on the barrier.

This meant that not only the girl but also the fire balls were illusions.

"Hmm..."

The only offensive spell she used freely amidst the illusions was fireball.

It seemed more likely now that she primarily focused on defensive magic.

But I couldn't be sure just yet.

For now, I needed to deal with these illusory duplicates.

"Priscilla."

Behind me, blue droplets started to gather.

These tiny droplets combined, growing larger, and began to take on the shape of a wolf.

That wolf was Priscilla.

Surveying the surroundings, Priscilla spoke,

"What should I do?"

I responded firmly.

"Eliminate them all."

"As the contractor wishes."

Priscilla spoke with an unusual sense of authority.

Immediately after, a chilling wind began to blow.

Despite it clearly being a time when spring transitioned into summer.

Countless ice spikes formed around Priscilla.

These spikes soared towards all the girls in the vicinity.

Crack!

All the girls except one were impaled by the ice spikes.

One of them erected a barrier to repel the ice, while the others looked like mirages, their forms wavering where the ice had struck them.

That one girl, seemingly intrigued, rubbed her chin and remarked,

"Oh? An elemental?"

Her tone was oddly reminiscent of an old person's.

"For a young one, you seem to possess quite a formidable elemental, don't you?"

Though she had the appearance of a young girl, her speech was that of a wise old sage.

Her demeanor also showcased her experienced nature.

"Shall we have a proper battle then?"

The girl let out a sly grin.

"Let me show you the power of the great sorcerer Jefrin."

...Jefrin?

"Huh?"

Luna, standing next to Rudy, looked perplexed.

However, there was no time to ask further.

"Let's see whose ice magic is superior."

The girl who introduced herself as Jefrin raised her hand skyward.

"Spear of Severe Cold."

Just as when Priscilla cast her spell earlier, blue orbs began to gather above the girl's head.

The surrounding temperature plummeted, even colder than when Priscilla had used her magic.

"Rudy, that magic is..."

"Yeah, I know."

It was one of the most potent ice spells.

I had studied about ice magic before, particularly to understand the abilities Priscilla could harness.

And that spell, the Spear of Severe Cold, was among the trickier ones in the domain of ice magic.

If that ice spear struck the ground, everything around would freeze instantly, turning even a summer day to feel like the depths of winter.

"But, there's no way that's real, right?"

We had just confirmed that she uses illusion magic.

If she was truly proficient in ice magic, she would've begun with that instead.

It's common to lead with one's primary magic.

"But still..."

Luna's concerns were understandable.

The cold we were feeling felt very real.

Even if the rest was an illusion, her mastery over illusionary magic was undeniable.

I had once heard a story: A person felt cold and even froze to death in a warm place simply because the thermometer indicated below freezing.

It was a matter of perception.

However, we were aware that this was an illusion.

Yet, the cold was palpable.

If that spear descends, we might feel an even more intense cold.

"Hehe..."

Jefferin let out a chuckle.

And with that, she swung her arm downward.

The blue spear floating in the sky began to fall.

I must stop it.

"Priscil..."

"I'll handle it!"

Just as I was about to block the spear with Priscilla, Luna shouted.

A spellbook was already open in Luna's hands, emitting a radiant glow.

Bang!

The surrounding air seemed to explode with a resounding echo.

Sonic Boom.

A technique that emits a powerful soundwave.

Though usually, it doesn't inflict major damage unless it hits directly.

However, Luna's magic was enhanced with a magic circle.

It was potent enough to strike everything around.

The weakness of illusion magic:

If the core of the illusion magic is struck in any manner, the illusion disappears.

For illusion magic typically employed via a magical tool, one simply needs to strike that tool.

If the wizard themselves conjures the illusion, they become the core.

In other words, if the wizard is hit, the illusion vanishes.

Perhaps that's why Jefrin was adept at using defensive magic.

But this time, Jefrin couldn't defend against Luna's spell.

Sonic Boom is a spell that strikes with the speed of sound.

Furthermore, Luna's spell isn't one where she has to chant an incantation.

She merely infuses mana into the spellbook to activate it.

Jefrin had no time to react.

She was directly hit by Luna's spell.

“Ugh!”

“Huh?”

Though the attack landed successfully, something seemed off about where the sound came from.

Jefrin's voice came from right behind us.

The girl's figure that was before us and the spear hovering in the sky shimmered and disappeared.

I quickly channeled mana into my feet, attempting to spin and counterattack.

"It's already too late."

Jefrin's staff struck my head faster than I could complete my kick.

No, it wasn't so much a strike as it was a gentle tap.

"Eternal Sleep."

Before I could fully execute my move, my consciousness began to blur.

It felt as if a switch was flipped off in my head.

Before my eyes, I saw Jefrin smiling.

"Sweet dreams~."

I lost consciousness.

Astina quickly made her way towards Rudy.

Their strategy was for Rudy to ambush the rebels first, and then for Astina to join in and finish them off.

They had originally planned for Astina to join the initial assault, but they decided on a surprise attack led by Rudy, thinking that Cedric and the rebels with him might have a means of communication.

However, this turned out to be a mistake.

"Rudy?"

From a distance, she saw Rudy falling, struck down by a staff wielded by a young wizard.

Fury welled up inside Astina.

How dare they hurt...?

Astina began to harness a vast amount of mana.

Even while she had been receiving her heir lessons, Astina never neglected her magic training.

During her second year, she was already as strong as, if not stronger than, the third years.

Now, she had grown even more formidable.

"What the..."

Jefferin felt the overpowering surge of mana and turned to see its source.

Her eyes landed on a woman.

A woman with fiery red hair.

She was hovering in the sky, glaring down at him.

She looked extremely... extremely angry.

With Astina moving such a vast amount of mana, even the rebels, who had been previously oblivious due to the silencing spell, began to emerge one by one.

Even ordinary soldiers, typically insensitive to magic, could feel the magnitude of this mana.

In a calm voice, Astina uttered,

"Gravity Field."

“Ah...”

Jefferin let out a sigh of resignation.

---Toggle New Ads

another one lataaa

Chapter 119: Northern Invasion

(10)

The scene looked like a devastated slum.

Shattered homes lay around, pieces of wood strewn everywhere.

All around, people lay unconscious or dazed.

"Why are you here, of all places? Don't you have anything better to do?"

Jeffer found herself overpowered by Astina, who had taken away her staff.

She was taken aback by Astina's capabilities.

With such power, Astina could easily be seen as one of the top talents anywhere.

Judging by her youthful appearance, she could potentially become the empire's most formidable wizard in the future.

Why was someone of her caliber in the Northern region?

Even with the invasion of monsters, someone of her stature wouldn't typically be here.

Jeffer was confident that in a fair fight, she could take her on.

But circumstances weren't in her favor.

She had already sustained damage from Rudy's surprise attack.

Her illusion spell was interrupted precisely at its most vulnerable moment.

As if that weren't enough, Astina appeared right after she cast a major spell.

It was the worst-case scenario.

The spell Jefrin used was called 'Eternal Sleep' – a magic spell to trap someone in an endless slumber.

It was a hallucination spell that consumed an immense amount of mana.

Right after casting it, Astina launched her attack, right when she was defenseless.

Astina looked down at Jefrin, her eyes cold and calculating.

Jefrin was pinned to the ground by Astina's magic.

Astina pressed her foot against Jefrin's back.

"Who are you?"

Astina's expression was one of confusion.

She had clearly sensed a massive amount of mana when Jefrin had swung her staff.

Seeing that massive amount of mana enveloping Rudy, Astina was overwhelmed by a rush of emotions, fearing that something dire had happened to him.

But, when she arrived...

"Rudy, wake up!"

"Uh..."

Luna was fervently shaking Rudy, who lay unconscious on her lap.

He just seemed to be sleeping soundly.

So, Astina was left wondering.

What was that immense mana that enveloped Rudy?

It clearly passed through him, but all he did was fall asleep.

There were no visible injuries, and he looked peaceful.

Astina turned her attention back to Jefrin, pressing her harder under her foot.

"What did you do to Rudy?"

"Heh..."

Jefrin looked up at Astina with a smirk.

"You're asking pretty arrogantly, aren't you?"

Astina chuckled at her comment.

"Oh? Was I too arrogant for you?"

Seeing Astina's expression, a chill ran down Jefrin's spine.

Despite her smiling face, there was an overwhelming aura of menace and terror.

Astina reached for Jefrin's staff, which lay beside them, and brought its gem-end close to her mouth.

"If I set off a few fireballs inside your mouth using this, would I come across as more polite?"

"What...?"

Astina firmly grasped Jefrin's face.

“Ugh!”

Holding both her cheeks, she forced open her mouth and inserted the gem at the end of the staff inside.

“Mmmph!!! Mmph!!!”

Muffled screams escaped Jefrin, the gem trapped between her teeth.

Her garbled words were unintelligible. Her face, however, clearly displayed sheer terror.

“Why the fuss? Shall I let one off just for a start?”

Astina taunted, her grin ever widening.

“Mmph! Mmph!!!”

Jefrin, stricken with fear, squirmed and thrashed.

‘She’s seriously going to do it...!!!’

The rage was evident in Astina's eyes, even amidst her smile.

Those eyes suggested she might actually unleash the magic.

Given her expression, she wouldn't put it past her.

As Jefrin struggled, Astina's face soured.

“Stay still.”

“Mmph! Mmph!”

Even at her command, Jefrin moved desperately, as if begging for her life.

Astina studied her pitiful state for a moment before removing the staff from her mouth.

A slimy string of saliva stretched from the staff.

Astina grimaced at the sight and then refocused on Jefrin.

“Ready to talk now?”

“I-I’ll talk. Just release me when I do.”

“You want to be released?”

“Yes. I need some assurance of my safety.”

Astina brandished the staff again.

“Do you even realize your position?”

“I need a chance of survival too! Only then can I answer you!”

Jefrin's voice held a note of desperation.

‘I can't back down now...!’

She realized that even if she provided every answer she wanted, she might still die.

Astina looked down at her, weighing her options.

“Fine. Talk. What did you do to Rudy?”

Relief evident, Jefrin began,

“I used a magic called Eternal Sleep.”

“...Eternal Sleep?”

“Just as the name suggests, it puts one into an eternal slumber.”

“...What?”

The spell was unfamiliar to Astina.

She surmised it might belong to the category of illusion magic.

Pointing at Rudy, Astina demanded,

“Then undo it. If you release him, I’ll let you go.”

“I can't undo it.”

At her admission, Astina smiled eerily.

“Is that so?”

Seeing her reaction, Jefrin flinched, panic evident in her movements.

“Oh, no! Seriously, I can't undo it!”

“Well then, you should die. If you can't break it.”

Astina gathered mana in her hands.

Jefrin exclaimed hurriedly.

“Wait, wait!!! I can't, but you might be able to!”

“What?”

Astina narrowed her eyes suspiciously at Jefrin.

Could it be true?

Can someone undo a spell even when the original caster can't?

Especially someone who isn't well-versed in that particular magic?

"Let... Let me explain what Eternal Sleep is first..."

According to Jefrin, Eternal Sleep was a spell that made the recipient experience dreams.

Dreams.

Specifically, incredibly sweet dreams...

It would create the happiest moments of their life and lure them to remain within that dream.

The ones affected by the Eternal Sleep would willingly stay lost in their dreams.

And if they stayed in that dream state, their mind would deteriorate over time, and their body would fail from prolonged inactivity.

Thus, the magic led them into an eternal slumber.

That was the nature of Eternal Sleep.

“So, how do we break it?”

After hearing the story, Jefrin grinned awkwardly.

“Well... There are two ways to break the Eternal Sleep spell... One is by destroying the spell’s core...”

“The spell’s core?”

“The spell is implanted within that boy, constantly keeping him asleep. We need to get rid of that core.”

Astina looked at Rudy.

The core of the magic...

“That method won't work unless you're an expert.”

Astina frowned.

“Then? What’s the other way?”

Jefrin smirked at Astina.

“You need to enter his dream yourself.”

“What?”

“You have to go in and persuade him to end the dream. The spell's true nature is that if the person truly wishes to break free from the dream, they can.”

A loophole in the magic.

If one wishes to escape the dream, they can.

But this very loophole made the spell even more potent.

Who would want to leave such a dream?

Jefrin laughed.

“Think you can persuade him?”

It was Jefrin's trap.

It was nearly impossible to convince someone immersed in their happiest memories.

If Astina entered Rudy's dream, she would become trapped.

Only Rudy could end that dream.

Jefrin was trying to trap two birds with one stone.

After a brief moment of contemplation, Astina asked,

"How do I enter the dream?"

“Astina, wait!”

Luna shouted in response to Astina’s question.

"It's a trap... Please don't... Let me instead..."

Astina shook her head.

"I know."

However, she couldn't refuse.

And she couldn't let Luna take her place.

"Luna, if you enter into Rudy's happiest moment, can you be certain you won't get lost there?"

"..."

If Luna entered, there was a hundred percent chance she would also become trapped in that dream.

Because to her, Rudy was everything.

But Astina felt differently.

She cared for Rudy, but she had no reason to stay in a dream.

She had reasons to return to reality.

Astina smiled at Luna, saying,

"I'll be right back. If I don't wake up in 2 hours, send the pre-arranged signal."

The pre-arranged signal.

It was a signal to notify Professor Gracie and Lord Darren.

A signal requesting help.

She said this because she didn't know what might happen if she fell asleep.

Astina then turned her gaze to Jefrin.

Jefrin grinned and spoke up.

"So, you'll release me if I help you enter his dream?"

"I'll release you if you promise not to play any tricks and simply run away."

Jefrin chuckled,

"Of course~."

Astina dispelled the magic restraining Jefrin and helped her up.

"Then let's make a pact."

Astina lay beside Rudy, taking his hand in hers.

Luna watched over Astina, while Jefrin gently placed a hand above Astina's head.

"Come back soon, Astina."

Luna whispered.

A smile graced Astina's lips upon hearing Luna.

Jefrin stifled a chuckle, casting a glance at Astina.

Though Jefrin wanted to plant a strange spell in Astina for revenge, she was bound by a magic contract with Astina.

Breaking it would cause her heart to burst, so she dared not act on her impulses.

Jefrin began to channel her mana.

"When the spell is cast, you'll lose consciousness and enter the dreams of the person next to you. When you wake up, you'll find yourself within that

dream."

Her mana fluctuated increasingly.

"When you open your eyes, he'll be right there. How he appears depends on his desires, probably in the way he desires to be seen."

Jefferin explained, laughing lightly.

And then, she chanted.

"Dream Intervention."

Jefferin's mana surged, emitting a brilliant light.

It entered Astina's mind, with a glow also emanating from the hand of Rudy that Astina was holding.

Grinning, Jefferin spoke.

"Have a pleasant dream."

As her words echoed, Astina felt her consciousness fading.

"Please come back safely..."

And then, Luna's voice was heard.

With that, Astina's awareness snapped, and everything went dark.

"Ugh..."

She groaned, feeling a throbbing headache.

Slowly, Astina sat up, looking around,

"Where is this..."

According to Jefrin, she'd be in a dream, and Rudy Astria would be in front of her.

Scanning her surroundings, she mumbled,

"Huh?"

A loud horn blared.

"Wow, look at her! Is that some sort of cosplay?"

"Check out her hair color!"

Murmurs filled the air around her, accompanied by the sounds of horns.

She spotted towering... structures?

Her eyes widened in surprise,

"Where... am I?"

Just then, a voice from in front of her spoke,

"...Astina?"

"Rudy?"

Astina called out Rudy's name and looked in the direction of the voice.

The tone was unmistakably Rudy's.

But...

"...What?"

Astina stared in disbelief.

Before her stood a tall adult male with black hair... dressed in a suit.

With a dazed expression, Astina asked,

"Who are you?"

In this unfamiliar place, confronted with this unfamiliar person, numerous questions swirled in Astina's mind.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 120: Dream (1)

Ever since I was young, I excelled academically.

People around me called me a genius, and I even won various competitions.

However, this was only true during my childhood.

As I entered middle school and high school, I realized I was nothing more than ordinary.

Yet, I couldn't just stand still and accept it.

I believed that even without innate talent, through sheer effort, I could surpass those who had it.

If I put in multiple times the effort as someone talented, surely I could outshine them.

Otherwise, wouldn't it be too unfair?

However, contrary to my naive expectations, the world proved to be unfair.

Despite my efforts, I failed.

No matter how painfully hard I tried, I couldn't achieve my goals.

I was broken.

"Hey! You made it to Korean University Law School! Congratulations!"

"...Huh?"

I snapped back to reality.

Where am I?

Just moments ago, I was with Luna, facing off against Jefrin.

I looked around.

The bustling environment, several tables, and a glass with a green bottle of alcohol in front of me.

A familiar sight.

It's been a while...

This was a Korean bar.

"Hey, what's wrong?"

I looked up.

Sitting across from me was a friend I'd hung out with often.

Although I was busy studying every day, whenever he called, I'd come out for a drink.

This very pub...

It was where we met after I received my LEET* scores.

I had bombed the test and drowned my sorrows in alcohol, weeping bitterly.

"Hey, what's wrong?"

But now...

"...You're saying my scores qualify for Korea University's Law School?"

I was bewildered.

Korea University is the top institution in our country.

Just moments ago, I was focused on my life at the academy...

Noticing my confusion, my friend frowned.

"Are you drunk?"

Was everything I experienced just a dream?

Am I drunk?

I glanced at the bottle in front of me.

It was freshly opened, with only a small amount consumed.

The glass in front of me was filled with soju.

I hesitantly took a sip.

If this is a dream, it wouldn't have a taste, but...

"Ugh..."

"What's wrong?"

As always, the taste of soju was repulsive.

Its distinctive alcohol scent lingered around my lips.

Was this not a dream?

I hastily grabbed a spoon and dove into the side dish, shoveling it into my mouth.

The pot in front of me.

Its spicy, tangy red broth.

The taste tingled on my lips.

"Pork kimchi stew?"

"Oh... oh, oh, oh..."

Regardless of my current situation, one thing was clear.

This spicy, savory sensation...

Ah, this is definitely pork kimchi stew.

"Ma'am! One bowl of rice, please!"

"Alright~!"

As I frantically started eating, the friend sitting opposite me looked at me in disbelief.

"Have you lost your mind...?"

Whether this current situation was a dream or everything before it was, it didn't matter.

All I was grateful for was the white rice and pork kimchi stew in front of me.

The next day.

"Ah... my head..."

I groggily sat up.

My head ached, a clear sign of a hangover.

Yesterday, after having kimchi stew, I ordered various other dishes like spicy pork stir-fry, boneless chicken feet, and fried chicken gizzards.

It was inevitable that alcohol accompanied the meal.

The first sip of soju was harsh, but as I drank more, its taste became unnoticeable.

It reached a point where I couldn't tell whether the alcohol was consuming me or I was consuming it.

Sitting up, I blankly stared ahead, mulling over the memories still sharp in my mind.

"What was all that about?"

I recalled my poor performance on the exam and how, despite applying to several places, I faced rejection at every turn.

And so, to escape, I immersed myself in a game.

Sure, there are games where talent matters, but I never played those.

I preferred games where consistent effort, rather than innate skill, determined the outcome.

One such game was 'The Academy's Top Wizard', which I played obsessively, especially after my exam results.

Playing it allowed me to forget the real world.

Lost in the game one moment, the next, I found myself inside it, with no warning whatsoever.

From then on, I encountered various characters and experienced countless events.

"I remember everything that followed, but why can't I remember what happened before?"

And which reality was true?

Was I Rudy Astria or was the person here, now, the real me?

These thoughts swirled in my mind, reminiscent of the philosophical musings of Zhuangzi's butterfly dream*.

Just then, a vibration interrupted my thoughts.

My phone was ringing.

I reached for it.

Despite it being familiar, it felt oddly alien in my hand.

The caller ID displayed 'Elder Uncle'.

"...Hello?"

"...Yes?"

"Yes?"

"Oh... I'll, I'll be right there!"

I dashed to the bathroom.

Today was my cousin's wedding.

Having lost my parents at age seven, I was raised by my uncle.

While all my other relatives turned their backs on me, my uncle had always been there.

His daughter, who was like a real sister to me, was getting married, and I was running late.

Quickly, I washed my hair, threw on the suit I wore for interviews, hastily tied a necktie, and bolted out the door.

"Damn fool..."

A resurfacing memory reminded me how, after failing the exam and drowning my sorrows in alcohol, I had once missed my close cousin's wedding due to a hangover.

I was such an idiot then.

But now, there was no reason.

At least back then, there was the sorrow of failure.

Now, I had just carelessly drunk and passed out.

I hurriedly ran out.

I had no time to discern whether this was reality or a dream.

“Which bus should I take...?”

Rapidly, I searched for the route on my phone's map app as I ran.

While I was doing so...

“Huh...?”

Suddenly, a light descended from the sky.

It resembled the light that would emanate when UFOs abducted people, or when angels descended from heaven.

Amidst that light, a figure began to descend.

A figure plummeting while lying down.

With red hair...

“Astina...?”

Even as Astina descended from the sky, the people around seemed oblivious.

Once Astina touched the ground, the light vanished.

“Oh, who's that?”

Only after the light disappeared did the crowd start noticing Astina.

I stood still, staring blankly at Astina.

“Uh...”

Slowly, Astina tried to stand, clutching her head as if experiencing a headache.

She then glanced around.

Her eyes widened in shock.

She looked like someone who had just arrived from another world.

“Where... am I?”

Seeing the usually composed Astina looking so bewildered made me chuckle.

And then, realization dawned upon me.

This is a dream.

It's not where I was before.

All the muddled thoughts started to clear up.

Smiling, I called out to her.

"Astina?"

Astina turned to look at me.

Recognizing my voice, Astina's face lit up momentarily, but her expression soon stiffened.

“Who are you?”

I reached out my hand.

“Get up, senior.”

“Rudy...?”

"That's right."

Astina took my hand and stood up.

“What's going on? And why do you look...?”

I gave her a wry smile, wondering how to explain the situation.

Should I fabricate a story? Or tell the truth?

All these thoughts raced through my mind.

Then, my phone rang.

It was my granddad.

“Hello?”

“Ah, yes. I’ll be there soon.”

“Yes, yes. I’ll take a taxi.”

After responding, I hung up.

Seeing this, Astina's eyes sparkled.

“Rudy, I might not fully understand where this is, but everything here is an illusion. We need to escape from this place...”

I laughed as she rambled on.

"Yes, seeing your face, I think I understand."

Suddenly, a past memory flashed before my eyes.

It was of a wizard named Jefrin striking my head.

And the memory of being told to have a pleasant dream.

Piecing those memories together...

"Am I... dreaming?"

Hearing my words, Astina confirmed with enthusiasm.

"Yes! We need to escape from here."

"How do we get out?"

"If you genuinely want to leave, I've heard you can do so instantly. Just think about wanting to go back!"

"You mean...want to escape?"

I rubbed my chin thoughtfully.

Then, I focused.

I want to escape.

I want to get out...

I must leave...

"..."

"Why... are you hesitating?"

Astina looked at me with growing concern.

That same anxiety started creeping into me.

"I... can't?"

"Please, try more desperately!"

Astina and I stood in the street, trying everything we could think of.

We shouted for someone to send us back and even clasped our hands in desperate prayer.

Yet, there was no change.

I came to a realization.

Was I not feeling desperate enough?

I gazed intently at Astina.

Perhaps she felt uneasy in this unfamiliar world as she tapped her foot nervously.

Outside, she gave off the aura of a dependable senior, but here she looked just like any other girl.

In the outside world, Astina and I were about the same height.

Of course, I was still growing, so over time I would surpass her, but for now, we were similar.

Yet here, as she tapped her foot with an anxious look, she just seemed like an ordinary girl.

"Why are you staring like that..."

Astina's voice wavered as she noticed my gaze.

"It's nothing. I'm just trying to think of a way out."

“Right...”

Astina and I began brainstorming together.

But answers didn't come easily.

“Hmm...”

I realized this was all a dream.

I had a reason to escape from here.

But I didn't feel that urgency.

Why was that?

After some reflection, I made up my mind.

"Astina, can we go somewhere for a moment?"

---Toggle New Ads

*from the author: The term 'LEET' refers to the aptitude test one takes to enter a specialized law school.

By joining the said school, one can acquire qualifications to become a lawyer, prosecutor, or judge.

*'Zhuangzi's butterfly dream is one of the most famous anecdotes from Daoist philosophy, and it originates from the writings of Zhuangzi (or Chuang Tzu), an influential Chinese philosopher.'

Chapter 121: Dream (2)

"What... What is this?"

"It's called a car."

"How can it move this fast? What kind of magic is used?"

"It's not... exactly magic..."

I was in a taxi with Astina, heading to the wedding venue.

I knew the engine ran on fuel and did something to make the car move, but I didn't fully understand the mechanics behind it.

I just gave an awkward smile.

I thought I'd feel embarrassed saying that, but seeing Astina looking around in wonder, it didn't feel so bad.

Usually, Astina was the one explaining things to me.

It was a rare moment for me to share knowledge, even if it wasn't something I invented.

I felt a sense of pride.

As Astina glanced between the taxi and the outside world, she turned to me with a question.

"So, where are we?"

"Ah... It's complicated to explain..."

I scratched my cheek, wondering if she'd believe me.

Where should I start and how much should I tell?

I cautiously began,

"This is where I originally came from."

"Originally?"

Astina tilted her head in confusion.

That's when the taxi driver chimed in,

"We're here!"

"Ah, thank you."

As I exited, Astina followed, pressing me with her question again.

"What do you mean by 'where you originally came from'?"

Seeing her like this, I smiled.

"I'll explain everything slowly. But first..."

"First?"

"Would you like to meet my family?"

I pointed to the building in front of us.

"Wh-What is this place...?"

The massive building, even impressive by my standards, was the venue where my cousin's wedding was being held—a grand hotel in a part of Seoul.

Astina looked up at the building, her mouth agape in awe.

"Let's go in."

"Y-Yeah, okay."

She followed with an air of bewilderment, sticking close behind me, occasionally glancing around.

She clung to my coat with a timid grip.

It was a side of Astina I hadn't seen before, and I couldn't help but smile.

But I could empathize; I'd probably act the same way if I were suddenly dropped into an unfamiliar world.

"Ah! Is that my son arriving?"

As we entered the wedding hall, a cheerful middle-aged man greeted us.

Astina, hearing his words, widened her eyes in surprise.

"Ru-Rudy? Son?"

Her face showed evident confusion.

Seeing her reaction, I smiled and replied,

"It's been a while, father."

Astina immediately tugged on my sleeve, seeking an explanation.

Astina tiptoed closer to whisper into my ear.

"Rudy, that's your father?"

"He's my elder uncle."

Hearing my response, Astina heaved a sigh.

"Once everything is over, you better explain everything to me."

Until now, Astina had always shown me great consideration.

Whenever I asked her to do something, she never questioned the reasons behind it.

She would proceed without asking, always hinting that she wanted answers someday.

But now, it seemed she wouldn't step back any longer.

She looked at me, expecting a full explanation.

"Understood."

I replied, nodding at Astina.

She had risked her life coming here.

It didn't make sense to keep her in the dark any longer.

I had delayed for too long, but I intended to tell her everything now.

"My boy! Do you think it's acceptable to be late for your sister's wedding?"

Boomed my elder uncle, approaching with a hearty laugh.

A middle-aged man with a muscular build, that's how I remembered my elder uncle.

Even when I made mistakes, he would forgive and cherish me, always treating me warmly with a touch of playfulness.

I barely remember my real parents since they passed away when I was young.

I never really missed them.

But I always felt apologetic towards my elder uncle.

He had always cared for me, and in the end, I could only show him my broken self.

The regrets and feelings of guilt welled up within me, but for now, I faced the present.

I wanted to let go of these regrets and move forward.

Smiling at my elder uncle, I said,

"I apologize, Uncle. I drank a bit too much last night."

His eyes widened in surprise.

"What? Our little bookworm had too much to drink and came late?"

He laughed heartily,

"Well, if that's the case, can't help it then! Hahaha!"

Watching him laugh so genuinely, I too broke into a smile.

As his laughter subsided, he squinted towards something—or someone—behind me.

"But... who is she?"

He asked cautiously, seemingly referring to Astina.

Stepping forward slightly, Astina introduced herself,

"Greetings. My name is Astina."

Astina greeted my uncle with respect.

"Um..."

He switched his gaze between Astina and me.

From his perspective, he had never seen me with someone else.

I didn't have many friends.

Because for me, studying had always been my only companion.

I felt I knew what my uncle was thinking.

After all, I had suddenly brought a girl, so what else could it be?

And I wanted to live up to that expectation.

"Yes, she's my girlfriend."

"...What?"

"Wait... What did you just say?"

Astina's eyes widened in shock, and my uncle stepped back, clearly flustered.

"Hey, what... what does that mean...?"

Astina stammered, looking at me.

I smiled at her reaction.

"I'm sorry. Can you please play along?"

Even though it was just a dream, I wanted to show my uncle my best side.

I wanted to present the successful version of myself that he had always hoped for.

Saying that, I took Astina's hand.

And I held it out as if to showcase it to my uncle.

"She's beautiful, isn't she? My girlfriend."

My uncle stared at me with his mouth agape.

For a moment, he was speechless.

But soon, a proud smile formed on his lips.

"Yes, she truly is beautiful."

I continued,

"And now I have many friends, and have some skills to boast of as well."

"Did you get your test results back?"

At my uncle's question, I couldn't help but smile.

"It's not about that."

Right now, I wanted to express my true feelings, my resolve.

The reason I couldn't leave this place.

To be honest, I wanted to return to my world.

I was scared.

In the new world I found myself in, everyone around me was in danger, and my life was always on the line.

That world terrified me.

That's why I depended on the future I knew.

Even though I realized that future had changed, I still clung to it.

I wanted to depend on the story I knew.

Because it was a story where everyone found happiness.

A story where I didn't have to take action.

In my own way, I was avoiding reality.

But now, I've made up my mind.

I've decided to venture onto a new path.

To carve out my own path.

"To be honest, I don't know what the future holds, but I'll give it my all.
Everything I've got."

My uncle looked deep into my eyes.

Then he smiled.

He spoke,

"I've always believed in you."

It was something he always said, whether I was going to college without money, preparing for law school, or when I felt down.

He always supported me.

I know this isn't reality; it's a dream.

But hearing my uncle's voice, I wanted to hear him say those words.

I looked at my uncle and smiled.

"Just watch me."

On the rooftop of the hotel.

After the wedding of my cousin, Astina and I had walked up to the rooftop.

Astina stared intently at me.

"So, where are we?"

Instead of answering her question, I replied,

"I am not Rudy Astria."

Hearing this, Astina's face hardened with surprise.

"Then, who are you?"

"Just an ordinary person borrowing his body."

"Since when?"

"Since the entrance ceremony."

Astina seemed to relax a bit at my response, gracing me with her signature warm smile.

"So when I first met you, it was actually you,"

She mused.

"Yeah..."

She lightly tapped my chest,

"Then, to me, you are Rudy Astria. At least, I and those around me never knew the Rudy Astria before."

A smile formed on my face,

"Thank you for saying that."

"Why? You merely stated who you are."

She shrugged,

"So, where are we?"

"This is a place called Korea. It's probably a city that doesn't exist in your world."

I then proceeded to explain how I became Rudy Astria, delving briefly but in detail about her world being from a game.

"So... our world is a game? You've seen our future?"

While it was challenging to fully explain the concept of a game to Astina, she seemed to grasp the idea to an extent.

"However, that future has already been disrupted. Things are progressing very differently."

"Hmm..."

Astina touched her cheek, lost in thought.

After a moment, she looked up sharply.

"I might know about this..."

"What?"

My eyes widened.

"I can't be sure just yet, but I'll look into it."

How could she know about this?

I was about to ask her another question when a portal-like void appeared next to us.

Astina gestured toward the black void,

"To figure this out, we'd need to go back, right?"

She flashed a reassuring smile.

---Toggle New Ads

And that's the dream! I had honestly hoped for much more, but this isn't too bad.

Chapter 122: Handling the Remnants (1)

"So, it's time for me to go now?"

Jefferin said, a smile on her face as she looked at Luna.

Astina and Rudy lay asleep on the ground, with Luna seated next to them.

"Yes."

Hearing Luna's reply, Jefferin pondered the terms of the contract she had with Astina:

Neither Astina herself nor Jefferin can engage in combat in this place.

Once Astina falls asleep, Jefferin must leave this place immediately.

By 'place,' it refers to inside the castle.

However, there was a loophole in this contract.

Technically, after leaving 'this place', they could engage in combat outside the castle.

While this seemed like mere wordplay, contracts often hinge on specific phrasing.

That's why it's crucial to specify terms to prevent such manipulation.

'You shouldn't make agreements hastily.'

Astina had quickly entered Rudy's dream.

Considering that, she might have missed this loophole.

"Well, take care then."

Jefferin said to Luna, then discreetly made her way out of the castle.

Luna watched her intently until she was out of sight.

Once she had disappeared to a certain extent, she opened her magic book.

"This must be what Astina mentioned..."

Recalling Astina's words:

If we don't wake up within 2 hours, inform those nearby.

Yet, Luna felt that there was a deeper intention behind those words.

If Astina had meant just that, she would have discreetly relayed it to Luna, ensuring Jefferin didn't overhear.

Additionally, Luna had watched the agreement Astina made.

But something felt off.

The usually meticulous Astina was somewhat careless in finalizing the contract.

At that moment, Astina had given Luna a meaningful look, seemingly suggesting she should pay close attention to the contract's details.

"This must be it..."

Luna activated a magic circle from the book.

The book emanated light, and a small flame rose from it.

The flame shot up into the sky.

Bang!

It burst like a firework, pointing in the direction Jefrin had gone.

It was a faint flare, hardly noticeable unless one was looking for it.

After setting off the flare, Luna clasped her hands together.

"Ugh..."

Suddenly, a soft noise came from the side.

"Huh?"

Although Astina had just fallen asleep, Rudy began to stir.

Luna rushed to his side, asking,

"Rudy, are you alright?"

Rudy, clutching his head as if in pain, furrowed his brow.

Then he spoke,

"Luna..."

Glancing around and seeing Astina still asleep, he said,

"Seems I'm back."

Luna, observing Rudy's state, let out a sigh of relief.

"Thank goodness..."

Luna couldn't help but worry.

In the end, both of them could have been in a situation where they could die.

Even though Astina had stepped in, the uneasiness didn't completely dissipate.

Still, seeing Rudy in good health brought a smile to her face.

Rudy glanced around.

"How much time has passed?"

"Not much, I think. Probably less than 10 minutes."

"...Does time flow differently in dreams and reality?"

Rudy picked himself up from the ground.

"If it hasn't been long, then that guy hasn't been gone for too long either, right?"

"Huh?"

Luna tilted her head in confusion.

"We can't let her escape. After all, we've captured a rebel."

The conversation Astina and Rudy had before waking from the dream went as follows:

-Rudy, once we're outside, we can't be certain about how much time has passed or who will wake up first, but we must capture that rebel immediately upon waking.

Jefrin.

When Luna first heard the name Jefrin, she reacted as if it sounded familiar.

And there was a reason for that.

-That guy is a renowned wizard for illusion magic. The Eternal Sleep spell, which you experienced, was a widely-discussed spell in research papers.

-We can't let her slip away. She's a big deal.

Rudy stretched his body and got to his feet.

"Which way did that guy go?"

Jefrin swiftly utilized her body enhancement magic to escape the area.

‘If I can just get a little further and meet ‘him’...’

The rebels hadn't stationed all their forces within the castle.

They had dispersed troops outside the castle.

These weren't the ones planning to fight directly but were reserves, waiting to intervene if the situation got messy.

Above all else, with ‘his’ magic, they could assuredly turn the tides of battle.

Because in this war, ‘he’ was even more skilled than Jefrin.

As Jefrin was rushing out, the sky seemed wrong.

A rumbling resounded.

“What’s going on? Why’s the weather suddenly...”

Dark clouds began to move ominously.

Though it had been clear, the surrounding clouds turned a dark shade, especially close to where Jefrin was.

Sparks then began to erupt from these clouds.

The sparks congregated and struck the ground.

“What the...!”

Caught off guard, Jefrin reflexively dove to the side without even thinking to use a protective spell.

“Ah...!”

BOOM!

A bolt of lightning crashed down.

As befitting its reputation as a heavenly flame, it incinerated its surroundings.

The ground where the lightning had struck was scorched black, with faint currents still evident nearby.

Jefrin stared, wide-eyed, at the charred earth.

She quickly surmised this was no coincidence.

Where on earth was this coming from?

Jefrin struggled to determine if this was a result of magic, elemental usage, or some other technique.

An unseen assailant.

A one-sided attack.

She grunted in frustration.

How did they know to target her?

She had made a swift exit right after encountering Astina.

Considering the ambush from those kids earlier, it felt as though they were well-aware of the rebels' plans.

Logically, skilled individuals would be stationed at critical locations, especially with the need to fend off magical beasts.

They surely couldn't afford to divert any extra hands.

'How did they know I was fleeing?'

Focused in her escape, Jefrin failed to notice the spell Luna had shot into the sky.

The surrounding noises of battle with the magical beasts and soldiers' shouts drowned out the sound of the spell.

Even for an experienced wizard like Jefrin, the situation made it hard for her to think clearly.

"For now... I need to escape quickly..."

BOOM!

"Kieek!"

Another lightning bolt struck right in front of Jefrin's path.

Had she acted a split second sooner, she would've been caught in it.

In her current state, she couldn't defend against such powerful magic.

It seemed even stronger than the magic wielded by Astina.

"I need to hide."

Rather than fleeing, Jefrin decided to conceal herself first.

"What is this...?"

The arrogant demeanor Jefrin had displayed in front of Rudy's group earlier was nowhere to be found.

Only fear remained.

She hid beneath a massive rock.

Given the vast, barren landscape typical of the northern region, the only available cover was scattered boulders.

"Mist of Illusion!"

Jefferin invoked her spell.

Almost immediately, the surroundings grew hazy, as if engulfed by a thick fog.

Hidden behind a stone, she shrank back.

The Mist of Illusion spell spread a mist, filled with mana, which rendered the caster undetectable.

It was clear someone was targeting her from a distance without revealing themselves.

Being targeted from afar meant someone was using a detection spell to pinpoint her location.

So she decided to hide using the Mist of Illusion and wait for a moment.

BOOM!

CRACKLE!

Ugh...

The sound of continuous lightning strikes echoed nearby.

Fortunately, the lightning, which had seemed so accurately aimed at her, appeared to strike randomly.

She waited for a few moments.

"Is it over now?"

The onslaught stopped.

"They couldn't possibly spam such a powerful spell indefinitely. Heh..."

Though Jefrin managed a smirk, her legs trembled uncontrollably.

Using the boulder for support, she staggered to her feet.

"I should flee for now..."

Thud, thud.

Footsteps approached Jefrin from the side.

"What...?"

Due to the Mist of Illusion, the fog made it challenging to identify the approaching figure.

"Who... who are you?"

She yelled in the direction of the sound.

The rebels were rumored to be lurking outside the castle.

Given the persistent lightning and the thick fog, she figured they might have noticed the anomalies and sent someone to investigate.

Straining her eyes, Jefrin tried to get a clearer look.

Thud.

The footsteps stopped momentarily.

Thud, thud, thud...

The pace quickened.

Thud, thud, thud, thud, thud, thud!

Suddenly, the person broke into a sprint, charging right at her.

"Huh?"

And then the figure came into Jefrin's sight.

"You're too late."

It was Rudy Astria.

"How... how did you...?"

Jefrin was speechless.

Even if Astina had entered that dream, she couldn't fathom how they'd managed to emerge from it so quickly.

And then Rudy swung his fist.

"Whoomp!"

Jefrin swiftly dodged to the side.

Rushing in, Rudy's punch squarely hit the rock where Jefrin had been hiding.

It was a massive rock.

A rock more than five times the size of a human.

Crack...!

However, the rock began to fissure upon taking Rudy's blow.

A rock of that monumental size, shattered by a wizard's punch...

Boom!!!!!!!

And then, the rock crumbled to pieces.

"Ah..."

Bits of the destroyed rock fell around Jefrin.

Rudy, staring intently at the shattered rock, turned his gaze towards Jefrin.

And then he spoke.

"Found you."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 123: Handling the Remnants (2)

I looked down at Jefrin, who was sprawled on the ground.

With a mischievous grin, I teased,

"Come on, young one. Follow me if you don't want to die."

"Y-young one?"

Jefrin scowled at me, her anger evident.

In our first encounter, she had always referred to us with that belittling term.

It always seemed as though she was flaunting her age, as if it were some kind of trophy.

Despite looking like a young girl, according to Astina, she was an aged wizard.

So, I figured that such provocation would be quite effective.

"You still haven't learned your lesson, young one?"

Just as I had anticipated, Jefrin retorted with a face flushed in fury, trying to lift herself off the ground.

"Finger of the Demon."

Without missing a beat, I unleashed a spell upon him.

Dark columns erupted from the ground beneath him.

“Ah...”

Jefferin quickly tried to dodge, but due to her vulnerable position, her cheek was grazed by the razor-sharp pillar.

Smiling confidently, I approached the wounded Jefferin,

"Ready for another round?"

By now, I had a fairly clear understanding of her abilities.

She excelled at illusion magic, had a knack for defensive spells, but her offensive capabilities were somewhat lacking.

And those who relied on illusion magic often tried to mislead their adversaries, catching them off-guard.

But the drawback was, once they revealed themselves, they became significantly weaker than other wizards.

Given that I could discern whether her magic was an illusion or not, it made countering her moves relatively simple.

It was clear that taking on Jefferin now would be much easier compared to our previous encounters.

“Ugh... Blind Fog!”

At her command, a black smoke-like mist rapidly spread around us.

It had the semblance of smoke but felt eerily different.

“An illusion?”

Just a visual distraction, a subset of her illusion magic.

“Behemoth.”

With my command, the ground rumbled and split open, revealing the Behemoth, a creature resembling a baby elephant in size.

Jefferin's scream echoed as the illusionary fog dissipated almost instantly.

I could see him stumbling and falling, probably tripped by the split earth.

The illusion, fragile to even the slightest disruption, must've faded when she tripped.

"Punch of Ruin!"

I slammed my fist into the ground, causing a much more significant quake than when the Behemoth had appeared.

The ground around the spot where I struck shattered, scattering rocks and debris everywhere.

The spot I stood on had sunk, while the surroundings rose in jagged protrusions.

"Agh!!!"

A scream echoed from behind me.

The previously visible figure of Jefferin, who had been lying ahead, started to blur and fade away.

As I looked in the direction of the scream, I saw Jefferin, dagger in hand, stumbling and rolling on the ground.

"It's obvious now."

I had roughly figured out Jefferin's personality by now.

Given my earlier taunt calling him a child, there was no way she'd simply flee.

"Behemoth, bind him."

"Pwooooh!"

Upon my command, the scattered rocks around us moved, converging toward Jefrin.

Jefrin, seemingly unwilling to be captured so easily, furrowed her brows and began channeling her mana.

“Invisible Exit!”

With a sharp 'bang', she invoked her magic, her figure disappearing as if concealed by an unseen force.

The rocks that had been heading for Jefrin collided with each other and fell back to the ground.

“Didn’t I tell you it wouldn’t work?”

I smirked.

Reaching into my pocket, I pulled out a mana stone.

A dark magic spell I had been practicing, using a sacrifice.

My mana began to swirl, enveloping the mana stone.

“Haaa...”

I felt my mana start to absorb the stone, drawing in its energy.

Closing my eyes, I deeply felt the presence of the stone, absorbing all its power.

Mana pulsed within my hand, gathering with intensity.

Channeling it, I mixed it with my inner reserves.

With this combined power, I cast my spell.

Black flames, originating from me, spread outward in all directions.

It resembled a hazy, smoke-like fire.

These black flames advanced, casting a shadowy blaze across the ground.

“What... is that...?”

Jefrin seemed baffled by the situation.

No matter how skilled a wizard she might be, it appeared she wasn't well-versed in dark magic.

Panicking, Jefrin tried to escape the encroaching flames, running desperately.

I just stood there, watching him, confident.

She was bound to be ensnared, not by me, but by the flames.

The flames, which had been spreading evenly before, now seemed to chase after Jefrin specifically.

It was as if a shadow was hungrily stalking its prey, stretching across the ground.

The flames sped up, soon outpacing Jefrin's frantic escape.

Realizing the imminent threat, Jefrin stretched out her hand toward the flames and shouted.

“Barrier!”

An attempt at a defensive spell by Jefrin.

It seemed strong.

However, this magic was unstoppable.

Jefrin had already consumed a lot of mana and had been rolling around, sustaining injuries.

And so...

The flames following Jefrin enveloped the barrier in a circular fashion.

I stared intently at the scene and raised my hand.

"Ah."

Suddenly, something occurred to me.

"Thanks for the dream? It was a pleasant one."

Upon hearing this, a fierce anger flashed in Jefrin's eyes.

"You son of—"

Before Jefrin could curse, I clenched my fist.

Boom!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!

The flames that had surrounded the barrier soared upwards.

Hellfire.

A spell that pursues its designated target and detonates upon impact.

A magic that could be invoked by offering a mana stone as a sacrifice.

Given that this dark magic required the sacrifice of a mana stone, its destructive power was different from ordinary spells.

The black flames rising from Jefrin's direction seemed to touch the sky.

After a while, the flames began to settle.

"Phew....."

Once the flames had vanished, I looked below.

Jefferin was lying there, charred and motionless.

"Is she still breathing?"

Noticing Jefferin's back moving up and down, it seemed like she was alive.

"It's better if she survived."

If she's alive, it means we can extract information about the rebels from him.

I slowly approached Jefferin.

"Roarrrr!!!"

At that moment, Behemoth let out a roar from below.

It's strange to describe it as a roar, but it certainly made a loud sound.

"...What's the matter?"

"Roarrrr!!!"

Behemoth stomped its feet, seemingly protesting, and let out a sound.

Narrowing my eyes, I looked at Behemoth,

"What are you trying to say....."

Tilting my head, wondering if it wanted me to listen, I picked up Behemoth into my embrace.

Despite resembling an elephant, its size was like a small dog, fitting snugly in my arms.

"Roar!"

Behemoth then patted my chest with its foot.

"Not this either?"

What does it want...

Then, Behemoth, looking frustrated, pointed its trunk toward a certain direction.

"Over there? Why?"

It pointed to the sky.

"Ah?"

Above the sky.

Something was there.

It was hard to see, but looking at it...

"Bones...?"

Bones of something were descending from the sky.

This felt unusual.

"What's..."

The bones were getting closer.

And they weren't just any ordinary bones.

"Why is it so big..."

I took a step back.

It kept approaching.

As it came closer, I could make out what it was.

"A... dragon?"

A dragon made of bones.

It was a Thunder Dragon.

Riding on its back was a figure.

The Thunder Dragon approached closer and closer to me.

A gust of wind swept forth.

I raised my arm to shield against the gust.

Thud!

The Thunder Dragon landed right before me.

Its immense size felt even more overwhelming up close.

Its body was larger than most houses.

Standing before it, I felt an intense pressure.

This pressure pressed down on me, even though the Thunder Dragon wasn't doing anything in particular.

It was the fear of its mere presence.

With heightened alertness, I glared at the Thunder Dragon.

Then, from atop its back, a man leaped down.

He wore a robe, characterized by dark circles under her eyes and unkempt hair.

Using magic, he landed safely on the ground.

Without even sparing me a glance, he walked toward Jefrin.

I was torn.

Should I stop this man?

But considering this Thunder Dragon...

In the brief moment, I doubted if I could defeat the dragon or its wizard rider.

Would it be wise to just stand still since they're ignoring me?

The man, now picking up Jefrin, began to walk back to the Thunder Dragon.

As he casually proceeded, he suddenly turned her head to look straight at me.

Then he spoke.

"The Leader has taken an interest in you."

"...What?"

My eyes widened in shock.

Suddenly, the Rebel Leader is interested in me?

But wasn't the Leader gravely injured...?

"Now is not the time. Later, I'll come with the Leader to see you."

"What do you mean by that?"

He ignored my questions and began to mount the Thunder Dragon.

I have to stop him and get some answers!

"Finger of the Demon!"

Upon my spell's incantation, black pillars sprouted from the ground, aiming to stop the Thunder Dragon.

The man atop the Thunder Dragon voiced the same spell.

"Finger of the Demon."

Crash!

Identical pillars to mine emerged, colliding with my own.

Dark magic.

I scowled.

"If you cast another spell, I won't stand by idly."

He warned.

Heeding his words, I refrained from making another move.

He was stronger than me.

But not just strong; he wielded the same magic as me.

There was no way for me to gain an upper hand.

No advantages in attribute differences or using lesser-known aspects of dark magic.

"Sigh..."

With a heavy sigh, I continued to watch the Thunder Dragon.

Powerless, all I could do was witness the unfolding scene.

The man, astride the bone dragon, glanced my way before giving the creature's head a gentle tap.

At his gesture, the bone dragon began to flap its wings.

"Ah..."

The forceful gust of wind made me squint.

And then, the bone dragon ascended into the sky, gradually disappearing from sight.

I gazed after it, murmuring to myself,

“Why is the leader interested in me?”

Why indeed?

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 124: Handling the Remnants (3)

In a rush, a man raced through the forest.

"What the hell is happening?"

Cedric was sprinting with a pressing need to reach the castle.

Though he believed he had a purpose, in truth, he was fleeing.

He knew he stood no chance against Gracie and thought it better to rally and fight at the castle.

As Cedric dashed on, the mercenaries who had gathered around him scattered in all directions.

These soldiers were just a group brought together by their trust in Cedric.

But seeing Cedric unable to confront Gracie and instead fleeing, they lost their anchor, becoming disorganized.

Many of the mercenaries fell to Gracie's lightning magic.

Those who managed to withstand it saw Cedric running away and began to flee as well.

Within moments, Cedric found himself bereft of his mercenary force.

He decided his best course of action was to make his way to the castle.

'I must reach the castle... Start the rebellion.'

Cedric thought, although deep down, a part of him contemplated fleeing entirely.

He knew he couldn't handle Gracie.

Despite his title as the Mercenary King, Cedric was still just a mercenary, unable to match a prized talent of the empire.

"Damn it..."

Grimacing, Cedric swiftly left the scene, with Gracie and Locke on his tail.

Time passed as he continued his escape, and he began to feel something was wrong.

"Why isn't she using her lightning anymore?"

He recalled the continuous electric attacks she had launched as they pursued him.

He had taken several hits, but his robust physique allowed him to endure the shocks and continue his escape.

However, the magic assaults had stopped, though he was sure they hadn't lost track of him.

He could still see Locke pursuing him in the distance.

Cedric made a realization.

"Has she exhausted her mana?"

This could be his chance.

Decisively, he headed for the castle.

There, he knew he'd have the backing of the rebels and the soldiers that might betray their posts.

Even if the wizard was formidable, he was certain that he would have the upper hand once inside the castle.

Suddenly, a loud alert resonated through the air, sounding like a warning siren.

Immediately after...

BOOM!

A massive explosion echoed, coming from the direction of the main gate – where the monsters were attacking.

The warning he had just heard was undoubtedly the one the rebels had spoken of – a signal from the magical device on the castle walls, indicating it was about to detonate.

Cedric's previously tense face lightened up a bit.

"Did... did it work?"

Hope welled up in Cedric.

All he needed to do now was get to the castle.

With renewed vigor, Cedric increased his pace.

As he ran, a light appeared before him, signifying that he was nearing the edge of the forest.

Following the guiding light, a castle came into view.

Cedric ran with all his might.

He sprinted tirelessly until he emerged from the forest, and before him stood the grand castle.

Cedric was about to rush towards it when suddenly, he froze in his tracks.

Emerging from the forest, not only was the castle in sight, but there stood a man in black armor.

The distinctive black armor. An armor unique in all the world.

It was the very same worn by his once close friend, Darren, when facing monsters.

"How... is this possible?"

Cedric stammered, staring at the figure in disbelief.

The soft clinking of the armor's joints echoed subtly in the air.

Darren slowly lifted his head, locking eyes with Cedric.

"It's been a while, Cedric."

Cedric stumbled back, caught off guard.

He hadn't expected a face-to-face confrontation.

His plan had been simple: to ambush Darren while he was distracted fighting the monsters, swiftly and without exchange.

But standing here, face to face, he felt utterly disarmed.

"I was sure of it... the magical device had been activated."

Cedric murmured.

Darren replied in a calm, measured tone,

"You mean this? I had instructed it to be used against the monsters."

Before Cedric's arrival, almost all the monsters had been dealt with.

As the cleanup was nearing completion, Darren handed the device to a trusted lieutenant.

He had given clear instructions: detonate it amidst the monsters when the time was right.

"Given the explosion I heard, it seems it served its purpose well."

Having the device detonated when the situation was almost resolved surely sent shivers down the spines of any soldiers plotting betrayal.

The explosion wasn't from the castle walls collapsing but from dealing the finishing blow to the monsters.

"Now, only you remain."

Darren unsheathed his sword,

"Why did you resort to this? You of all people should know better..."

Cedric gritted his teeth, drawing his own blade,

"What would you know?"

He spat, voice filled with anger and resentment.

"Do you have any idea what I've endured? What I've been through?"

"I've saved subjects from their lords, freed slaves, tried to make the world a better place. But nothing ever changes. You wouldn't understand, sequestered up north. What could you possibly know?"

"I've seen the world, Darren. A world far uglier than you could ever imagine."

Listening to Cedric's passionate outburst, Darren finally spoke,

"Is that all you have to say?"

"What?"

"Is your rant over?"

Cedric's eyes blazed with fury.

"After hearing all that, you feel nothing?!"

Darren looked at Cedric with a mix of pity and disappointment.

"So, are you implying that my territory and I have done something wrong?"

"Ah..."

The North was blameless.

Despite facing a constant onslaught of monsters and barren conditions, its inhabitants supported each other, striving to make their territory as prosperous as possible.

They were innocent.

"However... for a greater cause... for freedom... this land must..."

"Don't spout such nonsense."

Darren stepped forward.

"I might not understand what you seek, but don't impose it on those who are living good lives. Every territory has its problems. If something is lacking now, start with the small changes. There's no need to endure significant sacrifices without reason."

There was no guarantee that such sacrifices would bring about a better outcome.

Cedric shouted back,

"What do you know...!"

Darren replied,

"The world is already changing, shifting from our old generation to the budding new one."

Darren smiled.

"I'll trust and wait for those young ones. I believe they will grow like great trees and change the world."

He then took a stand in front of Cedric.

"To let a good tree grow, you should at least weed out its surroundings."

Assuming a ready stance with his sword, Darren fixed his gaze on Cedric.

In response, Cedric too unsheathed his blade.

From their blades, an intense aura surged.

Darren slightly lifted his head.

At the edge of his sight stood Locke, who had followed Cedric.

Locke, waiting at the forest's entrance.

Darren called out to him,

"Locke, watch closely. This is the swordsmanship of the North."

Locke intently observed.

The way his own father wielded his sword...

"The Sword of the North..."

The Sword of the North – cold, resolute.

A blue aura circled around the sword.

Blue Flame.

The hue of the aura depends on the nature of one's mana and their swordsmanship training.

The distinctive feature of the sword aura from Northern families was this blue color.

However, this blue aura was intense.

The Northern swordsmanship, known for its disciplined and precise movements, was often likened to ice.

Yet, the energy it exuded was fiery.

It was an icy technique with a contrasting fiery aura.

Darren swung his sword horizontally.

His unwavering blade seemed to mirror his disposition, moving straight and true.

"Blue Blossom."

His blade drew a simple line in the air.

However, the energy slicing the surroundings was different.

A vast blue aura, sharp and incisive, lunged at Cedric, almost like a wave.

Cedric, releasing his own energy, attempted to parry the incoming wave.

His energy wasn't weak.

But it paled in comparison to Darren's.

"What...?"

Cedric stared intently at Darren's sword.

He had seen Darren wield his sword many times, but he had never witnessed such a powerful sword aura.

In all their battles, Darren had never unleashed an aura of this magnitude.

KWAAAAAAAAA!!!

Darren's sword aura swept across the surroundings, hurtling towards Cedric.

Blue flames scorched the ground as they raced by.

The ground was stained with the blue hue from the flames.

It looked almost like a meadow adorned with blue flowers.

"Ha..."

Seeing this, Cedric lowered his sword.

He realized that this wasn't a sword aura he could parry.

Darren's blue inferno engulfed Cedric, and all he could see was a world dyed in blue.

"Is it over?"

After waking from her dream, Astina used her telekinetic magic to soar into the sky.

The academy's main entrance lay below, littered with the corpses of numerous magical beasts.

The back entrance was blanketed with blue flames.

And there was Rudy, slowly walking in from outside the academy grounds.

Everything seemed to have been handled well.

"What a relief..."

Her only regret was that they had failed to capture Jefrin.

When Astina took to the sky, she spotted the silhouette of a distant dragon vanishing.

But pursuing it was out of the question.

Heading in that direction would mean storming the enemy's headquarters.

She couldn't infiltrate the heart of the rebels alone.

“Ugh... What is this?”

There was someone trembling with fear in Astina's embrace.

It was Luna.

Luna clung to Astina like a damsel, holding onto her neck tightly and burying her face in Astina's bosom.

“Ah, Astina... aren't you scared?”

Luna asked with a quivering voice.

“At first, I was a bit scared too, but as things went on, I got used to it.”

Astina said with a playful smile, looking at the petrified Luna.

“Shall we go to Rudy then?”

“Wha- What? Can't we just... land?”

Luna, despite her fondness for Rudy, resisted the idea of flying towards him.

But Astina, paying no heed to Luna's protests, flew straight to Rudy.

At an astonishingly rapid speed.

"KYAAAAAAAAAAA!!!"

Luna screamed at the top of her lungs.

Her scream echoed throughout the fortress.

With that scream marking its end, the battle of the North came to a close.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 125: Rie Von Ristonia (1)

"Alright, the Midterm Camp will now come to a close."

Rie's voice echoed throughout the mountains where the camp was being held.

The previous camp had been thrown into chaos by an invasion from the Rebels, but this time it ended without any major incidents.

Relief washed over the faces of the tense faculty members.

During the last camp, the academy had to issue a mass apology to the students.

Even Principal McDowell had personally come to protect them.

It had been a deeply embarrassing situation for the academy.

So, this time they prioritized student safety and made extensive preparations.

They thoroughly scouted the surrounding areas, sealed potential hideouts in the forest with magic, and positioned teaching assistants nearby to prevent any unforeseen incidents.

Even with all these preparations, nothing out of the ordinary happened.

But that wasn't necessarily odd.

The previous camp was the anomaly; a camp typically concluding without incidents was the norm.

Their preventative measures might seem like an unnecessary effort in hindsight.

However, when it came to ensuring the safety of students, no effort was considered too much.

The faculty might feel their efforts were wasted, but they were just grateful everything concluded peacefully, and their faces broke into smiles.

"Professor, thank you for your hard work."

"Not at all. Professor McGuire, you've worked even harder."

With that, the professors exchanged cheerful greetings.

While most were exchanging pleasantries, one person seemed notably displeased.

"What's wrong?"

That person was Rie.

Yuni looked quizzically at her, tilting her head.

In truth, Rie had been looking distressed for some time now.

It probably started around the time Rudy Astria departed for the North.

Yuni, who had been assisting her sister, was well aware of this change.

However, she didn't understand the reason behind Rie's demeanor.

Initially, Yuni assumed that preparing for the Midterm Camp was wearing on Rie, but seeing her like this for so long made it clear something else was going on.

Tap, tap, tap.

Despite the camp's conclusion, Rie sat at her desk, drumming her fingers on its surface.

Yuni observed her sister's peculiar behavior.

"Aren't you going to rest, sis?"

Rie briefly looked at Yuni, sighed, and responded,

"I should rest."

She then attempted to rise from her seat to leave.

Tripping over her own feet, Rie stumbled.

With a thud, she found herself sprawled on the floor.

"..."

Such a move was uncharacteristic for the usually graceful Rie.

"What are you doing...?"

Yuni began, taken aback.

Rie hastily picked herself up, dusted off her attire, and commented, trying to play off her stumble,

"I'm going to take a break. If there's anything, just call me."

Her attempt to act nonchalant failed as her cheeks flushed with evident embarrassment.

Yuni stared intently at Rie, who was now quickly heading out.

"Why is she acting like this?"

Night at the Liberion Academy.

Within the buildings of Liberion Academy, freshmen were laughing and chatting while enjoying a feast.

Rie thought back to her own memories of the midterm camp.

The moment she held hands with Rudy and they ran away together.

Despite the life-threatening situation, he never let go of her hand.

When she could no longer run, he carried her on his back.

The memories brought a smile to her lips.

Shaking off the memories, Rie walked towards the entrance of the academy, then looked up at the sky.

The night had enveloped the surroundings, turning the sky pitch black.

"Is everything coming to an end now?"

She thought of Rudy.

It had been nearly two weeks since she last saw his face.

To Rie, these two weeks felt longer than two months.

When something new comes into one's life, one adapts quickly.

But when something familiar disappears, the void feels incredibly large.

Rie had hoped she would get used to it.

Yet, she couldn't.

His image kept flooding back to her.

Sometimes he appeared in her dreams; sometimes, she found herself unknowingly murmuring his name.

The past few days were especially hard.

She often found herself staring out of the window, lost in thought, feeling listless.

This was unlike Rie, who was usually meticulous and focused.

She was very aware of her own state, which only deepened her frustration.

Rie had always prided herself on being rational and calm under any circumstance. But now...

"Ugh!"

She lightly slapped her cheeks.

"Why am I like this?"

She wandered slowly in front of the academy building, deep in thought.

Deep down, Rie already knew the reason for her unrest.

"Yes, I... I like..."

She paused, unable to utter the full sentiment.

Her fists clenched tight, and her cheeks turned a shade of deep red.

"Never!"

She couldn't voice her emotions out loud.

Her pride wouldn't allow it.

Admitting her feelings first would feel like defeat.

Yet, she didn't want to give up on Rudy either.

There was only one solution.

'Make Rudy confess first.'

Make him so infatuated that he wouldn't know what to do without her.

So much so that he'd have no choice but to confess...

However, there was a problem.

How was she to do that?

Rie had never been in love before, let alone tried to make someone fall in love with her.

She used to believe that such emotions were nothing but fictional constructs from novels.

But now, faced with these genuine feelings, she was utterly confused.

She didn't know who to ask for advice, and the very idea of discussing this with someone else made her cringe.

Rie looked up at the academy building, feeling defeated.

"What should I do?"

“Aaargh...”

Inside the carriage, a woman screamed in distress.

It was Professor Gracie.

Luna and I, along with Professor Gracie, were traveling together by carriage.

But why was Professor Gracie making such a noise?

It was because of the alcohol.

After holding back the monsters in the North, the people were in high spirits and held a festival.

From the ordinary citizens of the territory to the reinforcements from the central region, almost everyone was celebrating.

Except for the lord and Locke who had post-battle responsibilities, everyone was drowning in merriment.

“Are you alright...?”

Among them, of course, was Professor Gracie.

Professor Gracie had made quite a name for herself in this battle.

She had fended off Cedric, the Mercenary King, and from a distance had taken shots at Jefrin.

However, an even bigger topic of discussion was the fact that Luna, Astina, and I, all students of the academy, had actively participated in the battle.

While others were dealing with monsters, academy students were confronting the rebels.

This surprising fact was spreading like wildfire.

As a result, the fame of the academy soared.

The talk of the town was that the academy was producing extraordinary talents.

And the curiosity regarding this topic meant that all eyes were on Professor Gracie.

As we were still underage and couldn't drink, the only person at the banquet talking about the academy and indulging in alcohol was Professor Gracie.

Consequently, she found herself moving from group to group, receiving and downing glass after glass.

And now.

While the others who came from the central region to the north were planning to stay for a few more days, we were on our way back.

The academy had its own schedule, so it was essential for us to return as soon as possible.

As a result, Professor Gracie was suffering from a hangover.

Suddenly, with a jolt, Professor Gracie opened her eyes wide.

In a panicked manner, she began tapping Luna beside her repeatedly.

“Urgh...!”

Taking a deep breath, Professor Gracie made Luna jump with surprise.

“Coachman, sir! Please stop the carriage!”

“Ahaha...”

The carriage stopped, and she rushed out.

Then, a rather direct sound could be heard.

“Blaargh!”

The thumping sounds that followed were of Luna patting Professor Gracie's back.

“Sigh...”

I let out a sigh.

I was feeling a bit out of sorts, returning to the academy after such a long time, but seeing Professor Gracie in this state made all those feelings evaporate.

Still, I wasn't exactly in a bad mood.

The matters in the north seemed well-resolved, and no one was hurt, which was a relief.

However, there was just one thing.

The problem was the last words I heard.

- Later, I'll come with the Leader to see you.

Why is the leader interested in me?

The only thing I can guess is...

"No... It must be because of Rudy Astria."

"Hm?"

While I was muttering to myself, Luna, supporting Professor Gracie, walked towards the carriage.

Seeing me, Luna tilted her head with a puzzled look.

"Rudy, what's going on?"

"...Nothing, it's nothing."

I responded with a smile and shook my head dismissively.

Deciding to think about it later, I climbed back into the carriage.

"Let's head back and rest. Professor Gracie looks exhausted."

Luna, noticing my concern, smiled warmly and nodded in agreement.

After a short while, we approached the academy around lunchtime.

The carriage entered the academy grounds, and I opened the window to take a look outside.

I noticed someone standing near where the carriage was coming to a stop.

I leaned forward a bit to get a clearer view.

"Is that Rie?"

"Oh! Looks like it. She must've come to meet us."

The sight of Rie brought a smile to my face.

I felt sorry for leaving her with all the work, and seeing someone you're used to seeing every day after a few days apart made her presence even more welcoming.

As the carriage came to a stop, we disembarked.

"Ugh... I'll be heading off now."

"Alright..."

Professor Gracie, looking as worn out as a zombie, was the first to leave.

We exchanged awkward smiles, watching her walk away.

Then, our attention shifted to Rie.

"...?"

Something felt off.

Rie, who usually greeted us with a confident smile, seemed hesitant.

I was slightly puzzled but still approached her with a friendly wave.

"Rie, you must've had a tough time while I was gone. How have you been?"

Rie hesitated before replying.

"It's been a while, Rudy..."

...?

"The weather's nice today, isn't it?"

Rie's awkward tone caught me off guard.

I looked at her, slightly bewildered.

Chapter 126: Rie Von Ristonia (2)

Liberion Academy's main building, inside a student laboratory.

I was renting one of the labs, focused on an experiment.

"Senior, is this how it's done?"

Click.

"Damn it... Run!!!"

"Huh?"

The magical tool in Yuni's hand began to glow a fiery red.

"Ouch, it's hot! What's this?"

"Damn it, Yuni! Get out!"

I initially tried to flee the lab alone but quickly turned back to grab Yuni's wrist.

Pulling her along, we rushed out of the laboratory.

Once outside, I swiftly shut the door behind us.

Whirr...

Boom!

An explosion echoed from inside.

"What just happened?"

Sigh...

Yuni and I were conducting dark magic research.

Due to my inability to draw magic circles well, I needed help to create the magical tool.

After all, these tools are based on magic circles.

Initially, I wanted Luna's help.

However, Luna was swamped with her own lab work.

While my work hadn't piled up, since my trip to the North was with Professor Gracie, Luna didn't have the same luxury.

She seemed so overwhelmed that I couldn't bring myself to ask.

Thus, I turned to Yuni for help.

"Hey! What do you think you're doing touching that mana stone? Ugh..."

"You didn't tell me not to touch it."

"When did I not? I said it at least three times."

"Did you? I don't recall."

Yuni shrugged, responding nonchalantly.

I let out a sigh.

Maybe I should've asked someone else.

While I composed the magic circle, Yuni was in charge of drawing it out.

It should've been simple.

But, despite her exceptional drawing skills, she constantly caused mishaps.

Whether it was her inserting something into the magic circle out of curiosity or playfully messing with the mana stone.

These blunders led to continuous accidents.

"Ugh, enough."

Our research was a part of the broader studies conducted within the lab.

A few days ago, after returning from the North, Professor Gracie was utterly furious.

-Even the youngest professor deserves respect!

Yuni and I assumed that she'd calm down eventually and continued with our tasks.

But Professor Gracie didn't stop there.

Before we knew it, she had stormed off to see Cromwell.

-Vice Principal! I can't take it anymore!

The declaration of Professor Gracie's strike was an unprecedented event at the Academy.

Although Cromwell appeared taken aback by her outburst, he managed to calm her down and made a proposition.

He suggested she take a two-week break.

Considering the fatigue from her northern trip and her accumulated work, this generous offer seemed like an apt compensation.

Upon hearing this, tears of joy streamed down Gracie's face as she repeatedly bowed to Cromwell in gratitude.

She never once considered that it was Cromwell who had put her in that situation in the first place.

Regardless, Gracie went on her well-deserved vacation.

However, there was a problem.

Even if Gracie took a vacation, there was still work left in her laboratory.

And now, I was the one designated to take charge of that work.

"Rudy Astria, if Professor Gracie tells you something, you should handle it."

Professor Cromwell... or rather, now Vice Principal Cromwell, informed me of this.

Upon hearing this, I clenched my teeth in frustration.

She takes a break because she doesn't want to work and leaves the tasks to others?

I couldn't just let that slide.

First, I prepared to handle the lab's tasks.

What's done is done.

I believed it was right to address the work that awaited.

We'd be the ones suffering if everything was left as is until Gracie returned.

Of course, Professor Gracie would face some difficulties as well, but I despised the idea of procrastinating and dealing with it later.

So, the first thing I decided was to increase the lab staff.

I was temporarily in charge now; shouldn't I be able to expand the lab team as I saw fit?

"That's not possible. Absolutely not."

"Come on, Kuhn. If a senior asks for a little help, you should give it."

The people I approached were Kuhn and Emily.

Among them, it was Emily I particularly wanted.

Of course, Emily being a 1st-year student did make me a bit apprehensive.

Still, I didn't expect a huge amount of assistance from her, so I simply asked for her help without dwelling on it too much.

"She's already been assisting with student council duties in your absence. But..."

"10 gold coins."

"...Excuse me?"

"I'll give you 10 gold coins if you work for two weeks. I can even draft a contract."

This money came from the lab's allocated funds.

Research grants that we could utilize at our discretion.

Once Professor Gracie returned, we couldn't just spend it as we pleased, so I decided to use it generously.

Hearing the mention of 10 gold coins, a spark ignited in Emily's eyes.

"Let's go now. Should I start with cleaning?"

"Uh... Emily?"

"Kuhn... It's 10 gold coins! Ten!"

Seeing Emily's elation made me feel quite pleased as well.

The next thing I did was to determine the kind of research we'd conduct in the lab.

The focus was on the fusion of dark magic tools.

Research to create a staff beneficial for dark magic users.

The ideal staff would incorporate a mana stone that suits both the specific magic and its user.

More precisely, the magic circle inscribed onto that mana stone was crucial.

Each magic type had distinct characteristics, so selecting the right magic circle was essential.

In my case, enhancing my fists with magic, using dark magic, summoning elementals, and other diverse features meant I needed a staff that complemented all of them.

Thus, I decided.

To pivot Gracie's research towards creating a staff tailored to my needs.

Students typically craft their own staff as they graduate from the academy.

Of course, not everyone does.

Some don't make one simply because they lack the funds.

Crafting a staff perfectly attuned to oneself requires a considerable amount of money, resulting in many without a proper staff of their own.

However, I was determined to craft it myself.

Even though Ian had cut off my funding, I wasn't one to give up so easily.

The main reason staffs were expensive was not just because of the materials but also because everyone required something different from their staff.

Hence, the magic circle engraved on a staff must be unique to its owner.

It should be a magic circle that suits the owner the best.

To achieve this, one needs to research magic circles, and the cost of such research is no small amount.

I decided to tackle this issue head-on.

My solution was to conduct research related to my staff in Gracie's lab.

Simple enough.

So, after Gracie went on vacation,

Yuni and I began our research on the relationship between dark magic and staffs.

A field completely different from Gracie's expertise.

But that didn't matter.

After all, who's in charge now?

Gracie's vacation was set to last for two weeks.

Typically, getting approval for a research project takes about a week.

So, we'd have everything settled before Gracie returns.

Why did she run off by herself like that?

It's her own doing.

I never wanted things to be this way.

But what can you do?

If you leave a fish store in the care of a cat, you should expect the fish to be gone.

And now, Yuni and I rented a lab to conduct research on magical tools.

"Whew... We should call it a day."

"Yes, that might be best."

I glanced around the lab, which was in chaos because of an accident Yuni had.

Magical tools had exploded, leaving iron fragments everywhere.

Some of the papers on the desk were on fire.

Thankfully, the lab was protected by defensive magic, preventing the explosion from reaching the outside.

"Water Ball."

Using a basic water magic spell, I hurriedly extinguished the flames.

"Let's start by cleaning up."

With the state of the lab, there was no way we'd get any more research done today.

And so, Yuni and I began tidying up the devastated lab.

As we cleaned, I quietly started a conversation.

"Yuni, there's something I've been wanting to ask you."

Honestly, the news of Professor Gracie running off was irritating, but given our situation, it might be a blessing in disguise.

But there was something else bothering me more.

"Did something happen to Rie while I was away?"

Lately, Rie's behavior seemed off.

She kept acting strangely.

It's like... she was doing something... unusual.

"I'm not sure? I didn't notice anything."

Yuni shrugged.

"If nothing happened, then never mind."

I brushed it off, thinking it might just be my imagination.

Although Rie's behavior was a bit unusual, it wasn't affecting our work.

Once we tidied up the lab, Yuni and I headed out.

"If we leave the windows open, the burnt smell should be gone by tomorrow."

"Will you be heading to the student council room?"

"I have to. There's work to be done."

"Alright then. See you tomorrow~."

Waving her hand, Yuni headed in a different direction.

Soon, I arrived at the student council office.

I opened the door and stepped inside.

"Oh, you're here?"

Inside was Rie.

"Where are the others?"

"I'm not sure."

Rie answered my question nonchalantly.

"....."

Rie, sitting and scanning through some documents, sipped her coffee and responded, appearing rather laid back.

To some, it might seem normal.

However, knowing her usual behavior, something felt off.

I calmly walked over, set my bag on my seat, and sat down.

"Oh, by the way, what about the documents related to the upcoming Homecoming Day?"

"They're right here."

Rie stood up and walked over to me.

I observed her intently.

Avoiding my gaze, Rie looked down as she approached and placed the documents in front of me.

Then, she tried to return to her seat.

"Rie."

I called out to her.

"Hm?"

Rie turned her head, glancing my way.

"Ah....."

Upon meeting my eyes, she quickly averted her gaze.

I sighed deeply.

"...Why are you acting like this?"

"What, what, what do you mean?"

Rie said, avoiding my gaze.

"We haven't had a proper conversation since I returned from the North."

"We...we talk all the time!"

I stood up, grabbing Rie by the head, forcing her to look me in the eye.

"Conversations involve looking the other person in the eye."

When I forced Rie to meet my gaze, her eyes widened in surprise.

"I, I've been looking at you while... while talking, haven't I?"

Indeed, she makes eye contact initially.

But she becomes extremely flustered after doing so.

She tried to maintain a casual demeanor, but her pupils continuously darted around.

I narrowed my eyes and asked,

"Have you done something wrong?"

"No, there's nothing like that!"

"Then why can't you look at me properly?"

"I can!"

Defensively, Rie stared into my eyes, as if she was trying to win a staring contest.

And then...

"...Why are you laughing?"

"I, I'm not laughing!"

The corners of Rie's mouth started to twitch upwards.

She tried to force her smile away, but it was evident she was struggling.

That silly smile kept trying to break through.

"That's enough! I have things to do; I'll leave first!"

Rie quickly grabbed her bag and freed herself from my grasp.

"Alright, take care."

"Y-yeah....."

She replied and quickly left the student council room.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 127: Rie Von Ristonia (3)

"Why on earth am I so flustered?!"

Rie exclaimed upon returning to her dormitory.

"Ugh...!"

She threw the teddy bear that was beside her onto the bed.

Then, she began to fiercely pummel the stuffed animal with her fists.

"Rie Von Ristonia, you idiot!"

Her plan.

To woo Rudy.

It had been ruined a long time ago.

Now, her concerns were entirely different.

"How did I act around Rudy again...?"

Rie hadn't seen Rudy's face for two weeks.

And so, she had forgotten how she used to interact with him.

Before, everything had felt so natural, but after not seeing him for so long, it felt strange.

A certain discomfort, a prickling sensation.

She wasn't used to this feeling.

Still, Rie had stayed in the student council room, trying to get accustomed to it.

She assumed this feeling would be temporary.

But seeing herself still feeling out of place even after several days made her feel utterly foolish.

Rie picked up the teddy bear lying on the floor.

Gazing deeply into its button eyes, she muttered as if speaking to a person.

"What should I do? What should I possibly do..."

She pouted and complained.

It looked as if she was throwing a tantrum at the teddy bear.

With a sigh, she embraced the stuffed animal once more.

"Ah... I feel like I have more work coming up..."

Lately, Rie had been juggling her thoughts about Rudy and her student council duties.

The upcoming Homecoming Day.

There was a lot to prepare for the event.

Additionally, she had another investigation ongoing.

The Saint, Haruna.

She had been investigating her.

Yet, no matter how deep she dug, she couldn't find anything.

Where Haruna came from, how she entered the temple, and why she held the position of the Saint.

Other than the fact that she could see the future, there was little else known about her.

Even using the royal secret service yielded barely any information.

She had momentarily let go of her investigation, but upon hearing about the upcoming Homecoming Day, she resumed her pursuit of Haruna's background.

This time, not only was she using the secret service of the royal family, but she also employed the resources of the student council.

She even sought help from Astina.

Rie thought that since Astina had conversed with the Saint during the last Homecoming Day and had gained her trust, Astina might know something.

With that investigation ongoing and her responsibilities as the vice president for the Homecoming Day preparations, her plate was full.

But thoughts of Rudy kept invading her mind, making her even more melancholic.

She didn't want to be apart from him.

The two weeks without him had been torturous.

She didn't want to endure that again.

Hugging the teddy bear close, Rie lay down on her bed.

"Sigh... What should I do?"

Between investigating the Saint and preparing for Homecoming Day...

"Ugh... What am I even doing?!"

Frustrated, Rie flung the teddy bear aside and abruptly sat up on her bed.

"Right, moping around like this just isn't like me. Yes."

Rie clenched her fist.

Wallowing in solitude was not her style.

She believed in facing problems head-on.

Confronting them squarely and breaking through.

That was the First Princess of the Empire, Rie Von Ristonia.

"Yes, everything will eventually be alright if we're together! Just the two of us!"

Rie made up her mind.

To tackle everything at once.

The preparations for Homecoming Day and the awkwardness of being with Rudy.

She was determined to address both these matters simultaneously.

"Dessert?"

"Yeah, let's pick out desserts for Homecoming Day."

On Homecoming Day, a place is provided for graduates to gather and drink tea.

The academy couldn't prepare the desserts needed for the occasion.

There was a lot to prepare, and given that many of the academy graduates were of high status, there was concern over the potential embarrassment if the quality was poor.

So, they made an arrangement with a bakery outside the academy to supply the desserts.

Hearing Rie's suggestion, Rudy tilted his head.

“Why don't we just send someone else? Emily seems fit for the job. She's good with such tasks.”

From beside Kuhn, Emily interjected,

“Should I handle it?”

However, Rie gently shook her head.

Although she acknowledged Emily's capabilities, especially when it came to financial matters, this wasn't the task for her.

“Emily isn't part of the student council. We can't always rely on her.”

Rie said, patting Emily's back, as if feeling sorry for her.

Emily was always in the student council room as if she was one of them.

She often worked at the student council office with Kuhn, especially when Rudy was there, even if she had her research to attend to.

But that wasn't the real reason.

Rie simply wanted to go out with Rudy.

“Let's just go out for a while. It's been some time since we had a break.”

Rie suggested.

Rudy gave her a puzzled look.

Both Kuhn and Emily alternated glances between Rudy and Rie.

Sensing the tension, Emily stood up.

“Seniors, take a short break! You must be feeling a bit stiff from being in the student council room all the time!”

With a soft smile, Rie said.

“Alright, Rudy, let's step out for a bit.”

After a moment's thought, Rudy agreed.

“Fine. I had some things to buy anyway. A short break won't hurt.”

“Things to buy?”

“Yeah, I've been working on something recently.”

Rie paused in thought, then muttered to herself,

"Whatever."

"Well, we'll be back in a bit."

“Take care!”

“See you soon.”

Kuhn and Emily watched the pair leave the student council room.

Once they were out of sight, Emily turned to Kuhn,

"By the way... Weren't Rudy and Luna dating?"

“I'm... not really sure,”

Kuhn replied.

The two delved deep into thought, scratching their chins.

Rie and Rudy left Kuhn and Emily in the student council office and slowly walked outside the academy.

But there was a problem.

Although Rie had confidently invited Rudy out, she hadn't spoken a word since.

‘What... what should I say?’

She pondered over various topics:

The correlation between magic and alchemy.

The geometric magic principles of Liberion.

The mana circuit analysis of magic swordsmen...

Yet every topic felt oddly out of place.

A topic more fitting for a debate hall.

Not between a man and a woman... No, it wasn't a topic worth discussing between friends.

Rie pondered.

'What exactly did I usually talk about with Rudy?'

Ironically, the more she pondered the topic of their conversation, the more tongue-tied she became.

Rudy looked intently at Rie.

She was lost in thought, gazing up at the sky as she walked aimlessly.

No matter how one looked, she seemed off.

Rudy was the first to break the silence.

"So which dessert shop are we heading to? The one we always go to?"

"Huh?"

Rie responded, caught off-guard by Rudy's sudden question.

Rudy frowned at her reaction.

"Did you come out without a plan?"

At Rudy's words, Rie raised an eyebrow.

"Do you think I'm you?"

Rudy smirked at her response.

"Why not that place then? It's delicious there."

"It's too pricey there. Doesn't fit our budget."

"Weren't we preparing for some premium desserts?"

Rie shook her head.

"I said we need to prepare premium desserts, not that we have to buy them from a premium shop."

Rudy narrowed his eyes at her explanation.

"What do you mean?"

"In short, even if the taste is a bit lacking, as long as it looks luxurious on the outside, that's enough."

"...Is that okay?"

"No one is going there specifically for the desserts."

"Is that so...?"

"If we prepare a lot of delicious desserts, most will go to waste. Collaborating with such bakeries is a waste of money."

Nodding, Rudy seemed to see the logic in Rie's words.

"How do you know all this even though you're a princess?"

"Because I've done this before."

"You have?"

At this, Rie smirked.

"Did you think being a princess meant I was some sheltered flower?"

"Well, not exactly."

Rudy paused for a moment and then looked intently at Rie.

"Come to think of it, it's odd. Yuni always has someone else do even the smallest tasks for her, right?"

"You're comparing me to her?"

Rie tossed her hair back, answering with confidence.

"...So what's different?"

"Yuni grew up pampered by those noble brats. That's why she turned out that way. I pushed all those disgusting guys away."

"Oh..."

Rudy let out an admiring whistle.

"So everyone becomes an enemy. Makes you care even about small things."

"I've had my fair share of enemies too, you know?"

At Rudy's words, Rie gave him a sharp look.

"You never seem to care about any of it."

"What don't I care about?"

"Do you even know how many enemies you've made that Astina and I have had to deal with?"

"...?"

Rudy furrowed his brows.

Though he said he had enemies, no one significant came to mind.

At the beginning of the term, he remembered that red-headed guy.

However, when he had that incident with that guy, he had only just met Rie.

"I can't recall anything specific. I don't particularly dislike anyone either."

"Rudy, people can harbor resentment over the most trivial of actions."

Rie remarked, clicking her tongue.

"Is that so?"

"You don't realize it, that's why you're not bothered."

Rudy, looking puzzled, shook his head lightly and continued walking.

Rie watched him and chuckled softly.

'Hmm...?'

Suddenly, Rie realized something.

They were talking quite comfortably.

She wondered, tilting her head, why their conversation was flowing so naturally.

Then, she glanced at Rudy ahead of her.

Rudy still seemed lost in his thoughts.

Observing him, a small smile crept onto Rie's face.

“Whatever.”

She then hurriedly caught up to Rudy and playfully patted his back.

Thud!

"Ow! What the—?"

Rudy, startled by the sudden slap, turned to Rie with a puzzled expression.

“Not this way. The place I've got in mind is over there. Let's go,”

Rie said, flashing a pleasant smile.

---Toggle New Ads

had some things to do last week, had to push tl-ing back. But I'll be posting the rest of the chaps later today and tomorrow!

Chapter 128: Rie Von Ristonia (4)

"Should we wrap it up for today?"

I set down the mana stone I was handling and spoke to Yuni.

Hearing my words, Yuni, who was deeply focused on drawing a magic circle, raised her shoulders and responded.

"Huh? Already?"

Her lips twitched in mild disappointment.

Lately, Yuni has been deeply invested in staff-making.

Maybe out of genuine interest, she often came in early to prepare for our experiments, even without me asking.

Thanks to her enthusiasm, our research was progressing smoothly.

Yuni stopped drawing her magic circle, rose from her seat, and asked,

"You're finishing up a bit early today?"

"Ah, I have some tasks at the student council."

I recalled placing an order at the bakery, which had informed me that they'd be sending dessert samples to the student council.

Rie and I had planned to go through them, maybe even conduct a tasting session.

I'd already sampled some desserts from that bakery, but Rie had pointed out a few adjustments, and I needed to check on those.

"In that case, I'll stay and study a bit more before heading out,"

Yuni said.

"Alright. I'll be on my way."

"Oh! Rudy."

As I was about to exit the lab, Yuni's voice stopped me.

"Ena mentioned she might drop by later?"

"Ah, Ena?"

I had made a request to Ena.

It was about crafting the frame for the staff.

Typically, wizards create the mana stones for staffs, but alchemists often craft the rod part of the staff.

Alchemists generally split into two fields: potion-making and metallurgy.

They don't solely focus on one domain like wizards do; they just have areas they're better at.

Many tend to be proficient in both fields.

Lately, Ena had shown an increasing interest in metallurgy.

Since she was the most approachable among the alchemy department students and her current interest seemed to align with my request, I had approached her.

"Got it. Keep up the hard work."

"Yes~ Do your best with your tasks, senior."

With a wave to Yuni, I headed towards the student council room.

"Ah, you're here?"

Entering the council room, Rie greeted me, and a spread of over ten different desserts lay before me.

"Wow... That's a lot."

"Yeah, they prepared every variety I had asked for."

Displayed on the table were cakes, tarts, and cookies, making my mouth water.

They'd undoubtedly be delicious, but tasting each one might just be a bit overwhelming.

"Should we have some tea while we taste?"

Normally, cold milk would be perfect with these desserts.

However, the idea of having milk here felt somewhat odd.

While lukewarm or warm milk was fine, cold milk – the ideal companion to such snacks – was hard to come by.

Firstly, the ice magic required to cool it down was an advanced spell.

Moreover, the weather was getting hotter, so naturally producing such chilled milk was nearly impossible.

"I knew you'd want some, so I boiled it in advance."

Rie said with a smile, bringing over a tea kettle.

“Oh~.”

It seemed Rie had the same idea as me.

Truthfully, Rie wasn't the type to indulge much in desserts.

She wasn't particularly fond of sweet things, so when she visited a bakery, she'd usually sip on tea and perhaps sample a dessert or two.

She only truly went for desserts when meeting someone.

This was in stark contrast to Luna, who frequently enjoyed desserts on her own.

Accepting a cup of tea from Rie, I approached the spread of desserts.

“Shall we try them one by one?”

I noticed that there was a fork placed next to each plate where the desserts were laid out.

Without much thought, I picked up a fork.

And then, I moved my hand towards the strawberry cake in front of Rie.

I chose it because I thought if I started with something too sweet, I might not be able to eat the other desserts.

“Wait a moment.”

Rie stopped me.

“I placed a fork for each plate to prevent the flavors from mixing. Use the fork next to each dessert only for that particular one.”

“Oh, really?”

Without thinking much of it, I set down the fork I was holding.

But as I reached for the fork next to the strawberry cake, Rie swiftly snatched it up.

I shot her a glare.

"Give it to me. I want to eat that."

Rie laughed teasingly.

"But I want some too."

Without hesitation, Rie used the fork to cut a small piece of the strawberry cake and popped it into her mouth.

"Mmm! It's delicious!"

She exaggerated her delight, clearly teasing me.

"Alright... Hand it over. My turn."

I reached out for the fork.

"Hm?"

Rie tilted her head, playing coy.

"There's only one fork beside the dessert, isn't there?"

Holding the fork in her mouth, she scanned the dessert selection.

"...Seems so."

She looked down as if she had just realized it.

"Give it, I want to eat too."

And as I reached out, she glanced between the fork she held and me.

"...You want to use this?"

"You started this."

I frowned.

As I said that, Rie hesitated to hand the fork over.

"You're not suggesting things like an indirect kiss or saying it's dirty, are you?"

"What, what?"

I smirked at Rie's reaction.

"Surely our esteemed Princess Rie isn't acting like a little child over something like this? Besides, it's just between us."

I emphasized the words 'little child' and 'between us.'

Of course, sharing a fork like this wasn't proper etiquette, especially for nobles.

But when have Rie and I ever been particular about such things?

I intentionally mentioned that aspect to prevent Rie from making any excuses.

Regardless of how carefree Rie might be, she is still a princess.

It was clear that sharing a fork would definitely make things awkward.

Since Rie teased me with the cake first, I decided to playfully tease her back in the same manner.

Rie shot me a piercing glare.

"You want to try it?"

"Try what? I just want to eat my cake."

I replied cheekily, and Rie chuckled.

"Okay~ then eat~."

Rie then took her fork and approached the strawberry cake with it.

“Give me the fork.”

When I asked, Rie took a piece of the strawberry cake and held it out to me.

“Eat.”

“...What?”

Rie shook the fork as if encouraging me to take a bite.

“Why bother exchanging forks? It’s just between us.”

Rie looked at me with a victorious smile, as if she'd won the round.

I usually don't care about such things, but there's a difference between sharing a fork and feeding each other.

They are entirely different realms.

Feeding each other is something couples do, right?

But I had my pride.

I won't be defeated so easily.

“Ah.”

I opened my mouth, hinting for Rie to feed me.

Seeing this, Rie's eyes widened and her cheeks turned red.

“Ugh.....”

Rie pursed her lips and hesitantly brought the fork towards my mouth.

“Hmm.”

I bit down on the fork and tasted the cake.

The sweet taste of the fresh cream in the strawberry cake should have been memorable... but I couldn't savor it properly.

The awkwardness of our actions overshadowed the taste.

Feeling the atmosphere getting tense, I loosened my tie slightly.

Yet, the game wasn't over.

Let's see who wins this round.

I glanced at the tart in front of me.

I took another fork and cut a piece.

“Now, you eat.”

I said with a mischievous grin, offering the tart to Rie.

“Uh-uh-uh...”

Rie's face reddened further, and she took a small step back.

“What? Not eating?”

I smirked.

“I-I will eat!”

Rie shouted back defiantly, her eyes wide.

She pushed her hair behind her ear and brought her mouth closer to the fork.

“Uh... Ugh.”

I stared intently at Rie, feeling both a rush of warmth to my cheeks and a pang of guilt.

I thought only the person being fed would feel embarrassed, but I realized feeding someone could be just as awkward.

As Rie was about to bite the fork, my face flaming red...

Suddenly, the door to the student council room opened.

“Oh, Rudy. You asked for...”

It was Ena.

She entered and dropped the sticks she was holding with a clatter.

Rie and I were caught in the act – me feeding Rie a piece of tart and both of us blushing.

“S-sorry!!! I should've... I should've knocked! Ah! I didn't knock! Oh, the professor sent me on an errand! Right, right. I'll come back later? Sorry? I'll go now.”

Ena spoke in a rapid-fire manner and ran out of the room.

She didn't even think of picking up the items she dropped.

She just dashed off.

“Ena? Hey, it's not what you think! Hey!”

I called after her, but she was long gone.

“Ah... oh no...”

Rie looked in the direction Ena had vanished, a despairing look on her face.

Then, she turned to me with teary eyes.

“You idiot! This is all your fault!”

“You started it!”

I retorted, feeling unfairly blamed.

Persia family mansion.

"Another dimension, huh..."

Seated in her study, Astina crossed her arms and gazed up at the ceiling.

Before her lay a fairytale-like book.

Though termed a fairy tale, it was more a tome on myths — myths about the creation of this world.

[God commanded space to exist, and then time.]

[That space and time birthed multiple worlds, termed dimensions.]

Astina mulled over this passage multiple times.

"A different... dimension..."

Undoubtedly, the place Rudy came from was distinctly different from here.

Another dimension.

While one might argue it's a tad unusual, it wasn't utterly bizarre.

After all, there were tales of others who hailed from different dimensions.

Astina's eyes shifted to the empire's historical record placed beside the fairy tale.

Written within were accounts of:

[The First Saint, an individual from another dimension, foresaw the future and brought prosperity to the people.]

This referred to the very first saint, revered since antiquity.

However, Rudy's case seemed slightly different.

She distinctly proclaimed she came from the future.

Given that this claim was also documented in the Royal records, it likely held truth.

Astina clicked her tongue, murmuring to herself.

"I assumed it was a mere scam..."

The tale of the First Saint was renowned throughout the empire.

A mere illusion spun by the church.

A deceiver who fabricated miracles.

Given that the church wasn't a particularly powerful faction, seen more as just a band of swindlers extracting wealth from the masses in the name of God's will — such rumors flourished.

In an empire that was not particularly religious, the church held such a reputation.

However, Rudy's testimony and evidence began to lend some credence to the tale.

"Hmm..."

Lastly, Astina glanced over Rie's letter.

[Investigate the Saint.]

It was a brief message.

At some point, Rie had taken to speaking to her in a less formal manner.

Still, it didn't particularly irk Astina.

"Maybe it's time to shake the church up a bit?"

With Rie's request in mind and her own suspicions about the church, there was no reason to delay.

After all, even if Astina were to create a ruckus at the church, they wouldn't dare utter a word.

The church's influence had waned long ago.

Had it not been for the Saint who claimed to foresee the future, the church, already teetering, would have collapsed by now.

They clung to life by the barest thread.

"Well then, shall we?"

With a sly smile, Astina rose from her seat.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 129: Rie Von Ristonia (5)

“Luna!!!”

“Ugh...”

Luna sat in front of Ena as if she had committed a crime.

Having witnessed the behavior between Rie and Rudy, Ena approached Luna.

Luna, who had been working diligently in the lab, was deeply shocked by the story.

The two decided to step outside to discuss further, settling on a bench in the academy garden.

After saying everything, Ena decided not to say anything more.

She figured the person who must be feeling the most frustrated right now would be Luna.

“What on earth happened?”

Ena was at a loss.

The person who had gone to the north with him was Luna.

If anything, it was his and Luna's relationship that should have improved.

“I don’t really know either...”

Luna said with a dejected face.

Were Rie and Rudy dating already?

Luna's mind swirled with confusion.

When Luna last visited the student council office, there was no hint of any such atmosphere between them.

To comfort Luna, Ena spoke up,

“For starters... they don’t seem to be dating.”

“But...”

“Sure, it’s not the greatest situation.”

“So, it's really like that, isn't it...?”

Luna sighed deeply, looking down.

“But remember, crises can turn into opportunities.”

“Huh?”

Luna looked up in surprise.

“Do you know what made it difficult to approach Rudy?”

“To approach Rudy?”

Luna tilted her head, thinking.

“Because he’s the son of a Duke?”

It was a realistic point.

Rudy belonged to the empire’s Ducal family, making him nearly inaccessible.

Luna had naturally gotten closer to him and developed feelings, but for most others, he was a distant figure.

But that wasn't the only thing bothering Luna.

She was the daughter of an ordinary noble.

Even if she inherited her family's title, breaking through those social boundaries wasn't easy.

"Well, that's one factor. But honestly, that's not the main issue."

"Huh?"

"If Rudy falls for you, would titles or statuses matter? Love knows no such barriers!"

"But... isn't that only in romance novels?"

"No! Those novels are all based on reality!"

Ena declared firmly.

It wasn't incorrect.

The empire had a more relaxed view on status than one might assume.

While there were distinctions between ranks, love and relationships tended to be free from those constraints.

High-ranking nobles, even emperors, often took commoner spouses.

Love was typically the foundation for marriages, with strategic marriages being a rarity.

"So... am I lacking compared to Rie?"

Rie.

She was the princess, the vice-president of the student council, and she shone brilliantly in every aspect.

With that, Ena reached out and gently cupped Luna's cheek.

"Why so down?"

Ena grinned, playfully pinching Luna's cheek.

"You're this adorable and pretty, aren't you? Plus, you're academically better than Rie. And in both the lab and the student council, everyone acknowledges your abilities."

"Really?"

"Of course."

Ena then took a seat beside Luna, their arms brushing against each other.

"And, compared to Rie, you have... this."

Ena sat down next to Luna and playfully poked at Luna's rather prominent chest.

"Ena!"

Blushing profusely, Luna quickly covered her chest.

Watching Luna's flustered reaction, Ena let out a mischievous laugh.

"I wonder how much our Luna has grown?"

"You're such a pervert..."

Ena chuckled, relaxing her expression.

"The point is, you're not lacking in any way!"

"I... I guess."

Luna responded and fell into deep thought.

Still, nothing else seemed to come to mind.

"So, why is it hard to approach him?"

At this, Ena chuckled and pointed at Luna.

"It's because he doesn't see a girl as a girl. Just as a friend."

"Huh?"

"Luna."

Ena looked straight into Luna's eyes, questioning.

"Have you ever seen Rudy act shy?"

After pondering for a moment, Luna couldn't recall any specific instance.

Noticing Luna's reaction, Ena continued,

"Or, has he ever stared at a girl passing by, maybe at her legs or chest?"

"Rudy would never do that!"

Luna's defensive outburst brought a smile to Ena's face.

Usually, Luna would just laugh it off, but her reaction now clearly showed how much she cared about Rudy.

"But most guys typically look at those places, you know."

Hearing this, Luna furrowed her brows, giving Ena a concerned look.

"Well, I don't think he does."

"See?"

"Wait, is Rudy... like a girl? Now that I think about it, he does have some pretty features..."

"What are you even saying..."

Their conversation was going well, but Luna's unexpected comment made Ena sigh.

"Anyway, the important thing is that Rudy needs to recognize the dynamics between men and women!"

"Dynamics between men and women!"

Luna repeated Ena's statement as if having an epiphany.

"So, what should you do?"

Pumped up by Ena's words, Luna clenched her fist and declared,

"Make him see me as a woman!"

Hearing this, a proud smile appeared on Ena's face.

"All the advice I've given over the years has finally paid off!"

Ena pointed towards the student council room window.

"Go on, Luna!"

"Yeah! But..."

"Hm?"

Luna gave an awkward smile.

"I've got a ton of work piled up right now... I should probably finish that first..."

"Oh..."

Confronted by this realistic concern, Ena just nodded.

"Right, work is important, after all..."

"Senior, are you dating my sister?"

"Ack... Cough, cough..."

I coughed, caught off guard by the sudden question.

"Why... would you think that?"

"Well, Ena asked me about it yesterday."

I blushed, recalling the scene where I shared cake with Rie the day before.

"Wait, is it true?"

Seeing my reaction, Yuni's expression turned cold.

A fierce look crossed her face.

"No! There was a misunderstanding. I've spoken with Ena about it."

I did talk about it.

More of a clarification than a conversation, really...

Regardless, the incident was water under the bridge.

"Did you get the sticks from Ena?"

I meant the rod used for the staff.

Instead of answering, Yuni fixed me with an icy stare.

"Don't change the subject."

I was taken aback by this unfamiliar side of her.

"...Yes,"

I replied, my voice lacking any confidence or authority.

Why was she acting this way now?

I hadn't seen this kind of intensity from her, not even during the student council elections.

"You didn't mess with my sister, did you?"

"Mess with...?"

Yuni let out a chuckle, but it was devoid of warmth.

"Many men have tried to woo my sister."

"I... I see."

"Do you know what happened to those men?"

"I'm not sure..."

With a mischievous glint in her eye, Yuni said,

"I'll leave that to your imagination!"

"..."

"But since you say it's a misunderstanding~"

Yuni's demeanor shifted back to her usual cheerful self.

"You're not like them, right? I want to be on good terms with you, Senior."

"Yeah, sure."

Her sudden change left me reeling, but I managed a response.

What was going on with her?

Yet, something became clear.

The fate of the men who showed interest in Rie...

"You really care about your sister, huh?"

"Of course. She's family, isn't she?"

"Huh?"

I was taken aback by her unexpected response.

"Then why did you interfere in the student council elections? Rie was aiming for the vice-president's position."

"When did I ever interfere?"

Yuni tilted her head in confusion.

"You wanted to win. But we..."

I stopped, recalling a memory.

When I had confronted Yuni before, she had said:

-I would have still resigned. Being the student council president is tough.
And I hate anything that's hard.

Realization dawned on me.

She was never interested in the presidency.

Her sole objective had been to date me.

"Realized my innocence now?"

Yuni leaned back, grinning at me.

Come to think of it, it was odd.

Why did she want to date me?

I never got to hear that story.

"So why did you want to..."

"I'm not telling."

Yuni interrupted before I could finish.

"Everyone has secrets they wish to hide, don't they? But!"

"But?"

"If you agree to go out with me now? I might be willing to share~. So, will you date me?"

I sighed at Yuni's words.

"Just some friendly advice from a senior: stop saying things like that."

"We both know it's just a joke, right? I know you're not interested in dating. And you know I don't have feelings for you."

She said it so casually, no hint of deception.

I let out another sigh.

But seeing Yuni this straightforward, I no longer felt threatened by her.

Granted, Yuni sides with the aristocrats and aims for the throne, so competition is inevitable someday.

However, I doubted it would escalate to life-or-death levels.

"Speaking of which, did you get those sticks from Ena?"

"Yes, I did. You're planning to merge it with the mana stone, right?"

"No, I lack the skill for that... I have someone else in mind to do it."

"Oh? Who might that be?"

Shortly after.

"What is this now?"

An older man, still groggy from sleep, squinted at us.

"How does a respectable professor end up sleeping in such a place?"

Robert, placing aside the book that had been carelessly covering his face, settled into his seat.

"What's with you? Haven't seen your face in a while."

"I may have been busy, but I haven't neglected my studies in dark magic. Anyway, I need a favor."

"Huh, always coming to me when you need something. Am I just a tool to you? And who's she?"

"Wow... Is this person really a professor?"

Yuni was genuinely astonished.

Truth be told, I felt similarly when I first met Professor Robert.

But to hear Yuni voice it out loud was quite something.

Robert frowned deeply.

"I break out in hives whenever I'm near someone like her."

"You've conversed with Rie a few times, haven't you?"

"She's sharp. This one, not so much."

"Wow, watch your words. How uncouth~."

"What did you say?"

"Pro, Professor! My apologies!"

I hurriedly intervened between Robert and Yuni.

Did I make a mistake introducing them?

In many ways, they were polar opposites yet oddly similar.

Yuni, despite her noble demeanor and adherence to etiquette, was oblivious and often blurted out whatever came to mind.

Robert, on the other hand, had long abandoned any semblance of etiquette and lived life in a rather unrefined manner.

They're opposites, yet there's a weird similarity.

"Anyway, we three have to work together for a while, so try to get along."

"If Rudy says so."

"I'd rather not, especially with this brat."

I leaned in and whispered to Professor Robert.

"She's currently working as an assistant to Professor Gracie. And I hold authority over that."

No further explanation was needed.

It was simply the dynamics between a professor and an assistant.

That was all he needed to know.

Robert smirked and gave me a thumbs up.

"Sounds good."

"Since it's assistance between our labs, I'll discuss the details about compensation and any other aspects separately."

"Just take care of it however you want. It's a hassle for me. Let Borval know. He'll handle it."

Come to think of it, I haven't seen Borval recently.

I used to frequently see him training on the sports field, but I haven't seen him since he became a full-fledged teaching assistant in his third year.

Probably busy with teaching assistant duties.

I should catch up with him soon.

"Understood."

I nodded.

Professor Robert then stood up from his seat.

"Have you eaten?"

"Not yet."

It was about dinner time.

"Let's go to that place, along with this youngster."

My eyes widened in surprise.

"That sounds great. I've been so busy lately and haven't been able to go."

"...Where are you talking about?"

I smiled at Yuni.

"A restaurant with the taste of heaven."

"Oh..."

Yuni grinned contentedly.

"Do you think they can satisfy my palate? I fancy myself a bit of a foodie."

"Absolutely."

I replied with confidence.

And so...

We headed to the fermented bean paste stew restaurant.

Chapter 130: Preparation (1)

I walked down the corridor.

Recently, with my busy schedule, I hadn't been able to focus on other matters.

But now, I was starting to sense something wrong.

It was about Yeniel.

It felt like an eternity since she was supposed to return.

There hadn't been any news of her either, which was concerning.

I made a decision.

I needed to meet someone who knew about Yeniel.

And that person was none other than Principal McDowell.

He, along with Astina and me, knew that Yeniel was affiliated with The Rebels.

Among us, he was likely the one with the most information.

If Yeniel's status as a double agent for the rebels was exposed...

She might be subject to severe torture.

To protect Yeniel's identity, the number of people in the know was kept to a minimum.

That's why McDowell was my only option for information about her.

Also, I needed to discuss something with McDowell.

The leader of the Rebels had mentioned wanting to meet me.

I pondered over this for a while.

Why did the leader want to see me?

I wasn't completely sure of the reason.

However, there was one thing.

Something originally happened at this point in time with the rebels.

Rudy Astria's sudden change of allegiance.

He unexpectedly joins the rebels and attempts to kill Evan during a joint exercise.

However, that incident wasn't going to happen now.

The problem was around this time was when the Rebels made contact with Rudy.

"Rudy Astria here. May I come in?"

So, I planned to talk with McDowell about this.

If the leader of the Rebels is seeking me out directly, surely there's a way to use this to our advantage?

Moreover, I'd heard that the leader was injured.

Approaching at a time when he's weakened felt like an opportunity.

An opportunity to capture the leader.

A mix of unease and hope bubbled within me.

Without the leader, the dreaded 'annihilation ending' where everyone in the academy perishes might be avoidable.

A chance to end all this and live happily might be within reach if we could eliminate the leader, Aryandor.

"Come in,"

A voice beckoned from inside the principal's office.

"...?"

It wasn't McDowell's voice.

Feeling confused, I entered nonetheless.

Opening the door, my suspicion was confirmed.

"Professor Cromwell... No, Vice Principal. Why are you here?"

There he was, donning glasses and handling some documents.

Cromwell sat in the principal's chair, processing paperwork.

"Ah, the Principal had to step out for a bit, so I'm handling some of his duties,"

Cromwell replied nonchalantly, removing his glasses.

"Do you have something to say to the Principal?"

"Well, I do, but..."

I was lost in thought for a moment.

When will the Principal return?

It wasn't just a simple matter to just pass on.

It could be a golden opportunity to capture the leader of the rebels.

"Excuse me... Do you know when the Principal will return?"

Cromwell crossed his arms and stared intently at me.

"Are you looking for the principal to cause more trouble?"

"Ahaha... not exactly trouble..."

I said with an awkward smile.

However, I felt slightly wronged.

Have I ever caused any trouble?

Aren't I always bringing good things like a lucky charm?

Cromwell pointed his finger towards the door.

"Huh?"

Suddenly, I was drawn inward, and the door I was holding shut with a loud bang.

It seemed Cromwell used telekinesis magic.

"Silent."

He then cast another spell, preventing sound from escaping our vicinity.

After using the spells, Cromwell sighed and spoke.

"You seem to have something important."

Cromwell looked quite serious.

"Go ahead, tell me."

Seeing him like this, I felt there was no use in hesitating.

"Can we discuss it together with the Principal? It's important."

"The Principal won't be here for a while."

"...What?"

It wasn't uncommon for the Principal to be absent for a while, but he often visited the academy when needed.

Seeing my bewildered expression, Cromwell elaborated.

"The Principal is seriously injured."

I was taken aback.

Principal McDowell, injured?

He wasn't just any person.

In terms of strength in the empire, he was among the top five.

The highest-ranking wizard of flash magic.

Who could harm such a person...

"Was it the leader of the rebels?"

At my words, Cromwell's eyes widened.

"How do you know that?"

I began to understand the situation.

There were only a few who could hurt the leader or the Principal.

And if those two clashed...

I decided to explain everything to Cromwell.

"I came because of the rebels."

I began to lay out everything to Cromwell.

I also asked.

How did McDowell get hurt?

"He was injured trying to save someone named Yaniel."

"Ah..."

I sighed.

Knowing McDowell's nature, it made sense.

He was the type to risk his life for anyone in the academy.

But it was reassuring to hear.

"The good news is, neither of their lives are in danger. They can't move right now though..."

I nodded in response to Cromwell's words.

"So, what will you do now? About the rebels..."

"Even if the leader of the rebels is injured, we can't be reckless. It seems he isn't as hurt as the Principal."

Considering McDowell fought while protecting Yaniel, this was expected.

"However, we must take measures to protect you."

Cromwell stood up and patted my shoulder.

"Don't worry. We'll prepare as best as we can. If we do it right, we might even be able to eliminate him."

With a troubled heart, I headed toward Professor Robert's laboratory.

McDowell isn't at the academy.

And in such a place, the leader of the Rebels arrives.

If he came alone, we might stand a chance.

No matter how potent his time magic is, it has its limits.

Time magic.

Its power is incomparable, almost on par with the Astria family's space magic.

But it doesn't possess the destructive force of space magic.

However, the real issue is the user.

The leader of the Rebels, Aryandor.

He's not just any ordinary wizard.

He's a wizard swordsman.

A rare individual who wields both magic and the sword.

A unique case that's hard to come across in a lifetime.

A talent that is said to emerge only once in a millennium.

Someone capable of handling two forms of mana.

Normally, magic and sword aura can't coexist, but he has the ability to meld them seamlessly in battle.

A realm often considered beyond human capabilities.

Of course, there's someone within the academy with similar potential...

Perhaps with that person's help, we can find the wizard swordsman's weakness?

With these thoughts in mind, I entered Professor Robert's lab.

"Incredible. What kind of training have you undergone...?"

"...?"

As I entered Robert's lab, there was a guy I hardly recognized.

A man, gazing at Borval with shining eyes.

"Ah, Rudy Astria has arrived."

Borval noticed me and spoke up.

"Yes... Professor Robert called me to his lab..."

My voice trailed off as I looked at the young man beside him.

He met my gaze with a twinkle in his eye.

"Hello! I'm Diark Verdès, a first-year student in the Magic Department!"

With a burst of enthusiasm, Diark greeted me, making me frown a bit.

Diark... Diark...

"Oh?"

Diark Verdès.

A talent rare as once in a millennium.

A being that transcended human limitations.

Someone who has a similar ability to the leader of the Rebels.

He was the top student in the Magic Department, a first-year student, renowned for having the talent of a wizard swordsman.

Of course, while the leader of the Rebels wielded both the sword and time magic, Diark would be considered much below him.

Come to think of it, I've met him before.

I believe he participated in Yuni's student council.

I looked directly at Diark standing before me.

However, there was something off about his gaze.

His eyes sparkled as he looked at me with admiration.

I wasn't used to such intense gazes and felt slightly uncomfortable.

"Why are you here?"

Feeling uneasy under his gaze, I took a step back as I questioned him.

"Ah...! I've been learning a thing or two from Borval!"

Diark responded, standing straight like a new recruit brimming with pride.

"From Borval?"

I was puzzled.

Is he implying he's learning dark magic?

From what I know, Diark belongs to a quite renowned family, doesn't he?

While I had a grasp on most of the main characters' backgrounds, my memory about this particular fellow was fuzzy.

Originally, he was a one-off antagonist who went after Evan.

A clichéd story about a freshman, the most powerful in his year, challenging the top second-year student.

It was a predictable outcome.

His easy defeat didn't need any elaboration.

Thus, I didn't know anything more about him.

"I didn't come here to learn dark magic. Out of nowhere, they said I had the talent of a magic swordsman and began talking to me about it."

Hearing his story, I knit my brows.

"I've been thinking that maybe someone like Borval could also be a type of magic swordsman! That's why, as someone on the same path, I wanted to observe and learn from his journey!"

At Diark's words, I gave him a baffled look.

You could argue that, in some ways, Borval, who uses magic and wields an axe, could be considered a magic axeman.

But there was a distinct difference from a magic swordsman.

The inability to harness sword aura.

Even if one could enhance their physique, if they couldn't use sword aura, they couldn't truly be on the same path.

"Moreover, I've heard Rudy Astria is also on a similar path!"

Diark spoke with such fervor, as if deeply moved, closing his eyes and nodding.

"The way Rudy Astria has achieved so much, tackling monumental tasks and yet still pioneering a new path... It's truly inspiring! It's remarkable!"

I aspire to be like you!"

“Could you... maybe lower your voice a bit?”

Why on earth was he behaving like this?

I was taken aback by Diark's fanatic admiration.

What had I done to him?

I couldn't recall interacting with him at all.

Nevertheless, there was no reason to reject someone's admiration.

I was trying to find a magic swordsman to understand their abilities better.

If someone like that genuinely admired and approached me with such enthusiasm, why wouldn't that be a good thing?

A grin formed on my face.

“Right, you should also give it your best.”

Seems I've found a promising acquaintance.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 131: Preparation (2)

The next day.

I gathered people at Gracie's lab.

First, Yuni, responsible for the mana stone.

Then, Ena, who was responsible for creating the staff's shaft.

And Professor Robert, who would merge the mana stone with the staff.

Lastly...

"Hehe..."

"Luna, I'm counting on you."

"No, no! I should be the one saying that!"

It was Luna who would supervise the entire process.

There were several reasons why Luna, not Professor Robert, was overseeing the process.

Firstly, Professor Robert was the only one who could merge the mana stone and the staff.

Secondly, aside from Professor Robert, Luna was the only one around me who had knowledge in this area.

I had considered overseeing it myself, given how busy Luna seemed lately, but Ena mentioned Luna was free, so I asked her for help.

Thankfully, Luna readily agreed.

There was a problem with me taking on the role of the supervisor.

The supervisor was responsible for checking the magic circle's overall design.

If I, the one who designed the circle, supervised, it would lack objectivity.

Knowing Luna would handle this put me at ease.

"Shall we begin then?"

Professor Robert suggested.

Everyone nodded, their gazes fixated on him.

We had gathered today so that as Professor Robert merged the staff and the mana stone, he could receive immediate feedback.

The balance between the mana stone and the staff was critical.

We needed to observe how Robert would blend the two, to determine the staff's balance and effects.

We couldn't afford multiple trials given our limited resources and time.

It was important to identify and address any issues in this session.

"Let's get started,"

Robert announced.

"Yes,"

Yuni and Ena responded.

Luna, standing beside me, asked,

"What magic circle did you engrave on the mana stone?"

"Oh, I added a circle to increase mana efficiency and effect amplification."

The reason why a staff's effect changed depending on its user was because of the unique magic circles engraved on each staff.

Unlike standard magic circles that had a central main magic symbol, these had a hollow center surrounded by mana circuits.

Once the staff was crafted with this circle, the central area would repeatedly get inscribed and erased.

In essence, any magic that passed through the staff would go through this circle.

A staff acted as a conduit between the mana stone and the wizard using it.

Mana traveled through this conduit, reaching the mana stone, passing through its magic circle, and then being released.

This process could either amplify the magic, hasten its casting, increase its speed, or add various other effects.

"You used a rather ordinary magic circle, didn't you?"

"Yes... It's common, but in a way, it's an uncommon magic circle..."

I responded with a slightly awkward smile to Luna.

The magic circle I engraved, as I had explained to Luna, was designed to enhance the efficiency and effect of magic.

Certainly, there were effects attached even to a common staff.

The issue was the magic I used.

My primary magic was dark magic.

However, dark magic requires precise mana control.

But improving mana efficiency or amplifying its effects, in a way, interfered with the amount of mana needed.

When inscribing dark magic into a magic circle, one would typically select one particular spell.

Thus, you could manipulate it to accept only the exact amount of mana needed.

But a staff wasn't like that.

You would continuously use different spells and input varying amounts of mana.

Hence, many who used dark magic either had staffs with additional effects or simply didn't use staffs at all.

Even without a staff, the effects of dark magic were definite. If one offered a sacrifice to cast the magic, they could achieve similar effects even without a staff.

Nevertheless, my intention to use a staff was to become as strong as possible.

Soon, I would have to face opponents several times stronger than me.

Those who have lived years longer than me, who have studied magic for a much more extended period.

To defeat such individuals, I needed to be prepared in advance.

Being well-informed about them, devising counter-strategies, and amplifying my magic strength through a staff or sacrificial magic were all essential.

Only then could I hope to overcome them.

Lately, I had been feeling the limits of my efforts.

The difference between talent and hard work.

Some say hard work can never surpass talent.

If someone with talent also works hard, wouldn't they always win?

I agreed with this to some extent, but I didn't think it applied to every battle.

Whether in fights or exams, it all boils down to a single confrontation.

Someone loses, someone wins.

In such confrontations, I believed several factors came into play.

Luck might play a part, as could extensive preparation or possessing more information than others.

Even if someone had superior magical talent, I still stood a chance in a battle.

Seeing my awkward smile, Luna nodded in understanding.

She must have felt it odd for someone using dark magic like me to choose such a staff.

"Let's take a closer look for now."

I decided to observe the situation closer.

Robert inserted a mana stone into the rod that Ena had created.

As he did so, light began to emanate from the mana stone.

It reacted with the mana circuit within the rod.

"Now then,"

Robert nonchalantly began pouring mana into the rod.

Ena and Yuni swallowed nervously.

Even so, it felt odd seeing Yuni so tense, considering she had worked diligently on that mana stone.

But I was the most anxious.

After all, I had designed the magic circle engraved in that mana stone, and I had set up the mana circuit in the staff.

Luna was watching both the mana circuit and the magic circle.

At that moment, Professor Robert spoke to Luna.

"The mana circuit in the staff is blocked. It's not an issue with the intricate parts, look at the main circuit."

"Yes, the mana seems to be cut off at the 3rd circuit,"

Luna quickly checked the staff and informed him.

"The response from the mana stone side is also delayed."

"I've noted that."

"The amount of mana touching the mana stone isn't consistent."

"Yes..."

...

When the trial run ended, Professor Robert, his face creased in annoyance, turned to me,

"What kind of magic circle design is this?"

Luna jumped in to defend me,

"I mean, the attempt seems innovative, and it does seem to function to some extent..."

"And what good is that? You intend to use this in actual situations?"

Professor Robert held up the damaged mana stone.

"You can't do it this way. The staff is more problematic than the mana stone. The magic circle might be usable in some way, but these staffs? Never."

Professor Robert seemed irritated, but he did mention specific issues.

"How can a staff with such a mana circuit withstand a magic circle where mana flows back and forth? It absolutely can't. If used multiple times, even the mana stone wouldn't hold up."

The method I used to improve the efficiency of dark magic was somewhat like a calculator.

When using dark magic, if its efficiency increases, the amount of mana to be channeled changes.

Hence, I had to be aware of the fluctuating mana quantity.

Once I used the staff extensively, I'd get a feel for it, but there was an immediate issue.

The method I adopted involved feeding the dark magic into the magic circle of the staff and calculating the necessary amount of mana.

After that, I would properly use the magic.

However, the problem with this method was the reflux of mana.

Typically, the mana circuit in a staff flows in one direction: from the user to the mana stone.

But in this setup, the mana had to flow back to me once.

Of course, I could create a separate return circuit, but designing the circuit in such a way would make the staff too heavy and large to handle, not to mention the cost implications.

That's why I had to rely on a bidirectional circuit.

It wasn't my first time using such a circuit, but configuring it wasn't easy since it's not a commonly used one.

I asked Professor Robert,

"Then how should it be done?"

"How should it be done, indeed,"

Professor Robert mused, looking at me.

"The mana flow through the bidirectional circuit leads to some mana leakage, and the circuit itself is experiencing wear and tear. What should we do about this?"

I was at a loss for words.

"Additionally, the magic circle embedded in the mana stone requires too much calculation. While the idea of calculating the amount of dark magic mana and sending it to you is admirable, the mana stone can't sustain it."

Luna suddenly raised her hand.

"Oh, I've made a rough note on that part!"

"A note?"

Luna handed a paper filled with extensive notes to Robert.

Though he only glanced at it momentarily, the paper was densely filled with her notes.

Robert looked at Luna with a puzzled expression.

“By making these changes, we might reduce the overload on the mana stone. Of course, we'd still need to use a superior mana stone, but...”

“This will work,”

Robert interjected.

Luna's eyes widened in surprise.

“Professor Mcguire would certainly be impressed. To think she's my disciple...”

Robert trailed off midway.

I couldn't believe my ears.

“Disciple? Did you just call her your disciple?”

“No.”

“You did say it.”

“I did not.”

With that, Robert threw a broken staff in my direction.

“Focus on this instead of dwelling on inconsequential things.”

"I've been managing quite well."

I responded.

With a sigh, Robert said,

“Then pay attention to what's happening around you.”

“Around me?”

I looked at Robert, puzzled.

Robert briefly glanced at Luna beside me and then turned away.

I recalled hearing similar advice back in the North.

Astina too had told me to be more aware of my surroundings.

Hearing the same piece of advice from different people made me even more curious.

What did they mean by that?

“Regardless, reflect on your overconfidence in thinking that a single practice session would be enough.”

“Yes, understood...”

I had many questions, but I decided to focus on the task at hand.

I didn’t know when the Rebel Leader would make a move, but time was of the essence.

“Luna, shall we head out...”

As I turned to Luna, I noticed her face was flushed, her eyes fixed on Robert in surprise.

“Luna?”

“Uh, uh, yes??”

She exclaimed, startled by my voice.

“What's wrong?”

“N-nothing! Well, shall we go over what happened?”

I nodded in agreement, following Luna's lead.

---Toggle New Ads

I'll be honest, I think I got it down, but it's a lot of mumbo jumbo

Chapter 132: Preparation (3)

Pay attention to the people around you.

It's easier said than done.

How can one possibly know every thought between individuals?

One person might hide their feelings, while the other might not be perceptive.

So no matter how much you pay attention, the information you can grasp is limited.

"Rudy?"

But when someone says this to me, especially those I've been with for a long time, it means they've seen something I haven't.

Paying attention means noticing things.

Things I never considered before.

What could that be?

I always thought I was quite observant.

But were there things I missed?

"Rudy!"

"Huh?"

Suddenly, I saw Luna standing before me.

"Rudy, are you okay?"

"Oh, yeah..."

I nodded in response to Luna's question.

"If you're not feeling well, should we continue this later? You seem distracted."

"No, let's keep going. I'll focus. Sorry."

Luna looked intently at me, then turned her gaze to Ena and Yuni sitting in front of us.

"Let's stop here for today. Just check the parts I mentioned. Let me know if you need anything else."

"Huh? Now...Wait!"

As Yuni tried to argue with Luna's statement, Ena covered her mouth.

"Alright! We can do it later. We should get going."

"Uh...?"

I stared at Ena as she abruptly left the room.

Watching her leave, I shifted my gaze to Luna.

"Uh, yes?"

When I stared intently at Luna, she looked away, seemingly flustered.

I broke the silence.

"Luna, shall we go for a walk?"

Luna said, slightly pushing her hair behind her ear.

While listening to her, my mind wandered to another thought.

People around me.

The ones I consider close are only people like Luna, Rie, and Astina, who have been with me from the beginning.

Of course, there were a few people I got to know recently through student council activities, but Astina knows nothing about them.

Also, the ones Robert recognizes as my acquaintances are limited to just a few.

I recalled the situation earlier.

The moment when Robert spoke to me while looking at Luna.

Did his gaze on Luna mean something?

I turned my head and looked at Luna.

Luna, holding a book delicately in her hands, looked back as if asking what was on my mind.

I saw Luna in detail.

The timid Luna, always giving her best in everything she did.

Beyond that image of Luna, I saw her - just as she is.

Brown hair, flawless skin.

A naive face with a gentle smile.

Her feminine grace was evident.

Details I noticed when we first met, but overlooked as we grew close, were now clear to me.

"Luna."

I spoke softly.

"What's your ideal type of person?"

"...Huh?"

My question was filled with more than just pure curiosity.

The conclusion I'd reached.

This conclusion might just be my misunderstanding.

I might have jumped to a bizarre deduction.

But I was merely entertaining the thought.

Remarks from Astina and Robert.

The peculiar behavior of Ena and Riku.

I considered it just an ordinary speculation any man might have.

'Could she like me?'

Isn't such a thought normal?

It might have been an excuse or truly my genuine feelings.

Confronted by my sudden question, Luna pondered deeply.

"Um, ideal type is..."

Seeing her think so earnestly, I began to feel a bit embarrassed.

Was I too arrogant?

Hadn't Robert just pointed out my arrogant behavior earlier?

I wondered if my question was too presumptuous.

Then Luna softly spoke,

"Someone kind... who only looks at me... and is admirable when it matters?"

I let out an awkward laugh at her words.

"Is that so... Pretty ordinary, huh?"

While responding, I wondered if I fit her description.

If asked if I've lived kindly, I'd say I was average.

Currently, I was plotting against Professor Gracie and scheming to use others, hardly the deeds of a kind person.

However, I always tried to save people, so maybe I was a bit kind.

Next, someone who looks only at her.

I never lived life fixated on someone else.

If I were to focus on just one person, it would be myself.

After all, every incident I've caused was an act to ensure my own survival.

Moreover, being kind and loyal is a universally desired trait.

But 'someone who is admirable when it matters' isn't that common.

I had something to say about that.

Nevertheless, didn't I show up when it mattered?

But... that very assertion had its issues.

To get a clearer picture, I posed another question.

"Then, at the academy... who comes closest to your ideal?"

"Huh?"

I barely held back an embarrassed grin.

It was an odd question, the type you'd ask just before confessing feelings.

Luna's face began to turn red, seemingly understanding the implication of my question.

Luna and I turned our heads away from each other.

Why did I say that?

What if this makes things awkward between Luna and me?

Whether Luna liked me or not, it was a problem either way.

I tilted my head, feeling dejected.

Recently, my mind's been flooded with so many thoughts that I asked without thinking.

But after saying it, I immediately regretted it.

I sneakily glanced at Luna.

She turned away, her ears slightly red.

Seeing her ears, I could guess the shade of her face.

"Um... well..."

Luna hesitated, probably wondering how to respond.

It felt like a Pandora's box that shouldn't be opened.

Nevertheless, I stared intently at Luna.

Slowly, Luna began to lift her head and looked up at me.

Her cheeks were pleasantly flushed.

"In the academy... my ideal type is... probably... Rudy."

She said.

Silence.

The world seemed to stop.

No.

Everything around me seemed frozen, but my heart raced incredibly fast.

What just happened...

It was a feeling I'd never experienced before, a whirlwind of emotions.

"Ah... I see... uh..."

Dumbfounded, I just stared at Luna, unsure of what to say.

Seeing my silence, Luna, flustered, began to wave her hands.

"Rudy as my ideal... type? Uh... How should I put this... It's not that I dislike Rudy, but... um...?"

However, her reaction only confirmed my beliefs.

All the actions Luna had taken up till now started to make sense, fitting together like pieces of a puzzle.

I pondered.

What should I do now?

I questioned myself.

Do I like Luna?

I had never considered the idea of dating those around me.

I hadn't even imagined it.

I was always preoccupied with the thought of survival.

A situation where one misstep could lead me off a cliff.

Of course, I sought fleeting pleasures, but I never aimed for true happiness.

If I could just survive, I thought that was enough...

"Luna."

At my words, Luna jolted, startled.

"Ah... um..."

Luna hid slightly behind her book, her face turning red.

To anyone's eyes, she was an adorable girl.

No man could possibly resist her.

But that very fact made it impossible for me to speak.

I couldn't tell her that I liked her.

So many events awaited me.

The risk of losing my life, of everything collapsing around me.

I couldn't promise her everything.

Also, I needed time to think.

I couldn't answer Luna based on a fleeting emotion.

I couldn't pursue a relationship with her here.

Not just because of Luna as a woman, but because I valued Luna as a person too dearly.

I carefully began,

“Can we revisit this conversation later, much later?”

“Later?”

Luna looked straight at me, hiding her lips behind the book.

“Yes, later. Can you wait until then?”

For a moment, Luna stared blankly, then her face flushed deeply as she nodded.

“I’d, I’d like it if our talk then could be more... positive...”

“Oh, oh... Yes, yes...”

Her words took me by surprise.

It was surprising to hear Luna say something like that.

“Well, then... later!”

With that, Luna started to run off.

I watched her retreating figure.

Luna sprinted ahead.

She ran without a clear destination in mind.

"Ugh... ah..."

She'd said it.

Luna felt a mix of embarrassment and shame.

How could she have so openly implied that her ideal type was Rudy?

And then even mention Rudy's name after that?

It wasn't the feminine charm that Ena had talked about that she had shown, but rather a foolishness that made her cheeks burn with embarrassment.

"Ah, but..."

Luna began to slow down until she eventually stopped.

She squatted down on the spot and covered her face.

"Ughh..."

Luna let out a strange sound, neither crying nor laughing.

Surely, surely, surely Rudy had recognized her feelings.

If he hadn't, he'd be a fool, an idiot, a total blockhead.

But Rudy wasn't at that level.

The fact he had suggested discussing it again later made it clear he had noticed.

But, more than that, Luna had a question.

How did he suddenly find out about her feelings?

However, what Luna had overlooked was:

The only one who hadn't noticed Luna's feelings was Rudy.

She had made it too obvious, anyone observing for a short while could tell.

Given that Rudy had received hints from others, it was only natural he'd figure it out.

Luna, of course, had no knowledge of this.

Most who knew the situation didn't tell Luna.

Only Ena had told Luna directly.

Ena claimed to be a love expert, so Luna assumed Ena was just perceptive enough to have caught on.

Pushing all these stray thoughts aside, Luna focused on one thing.

"When, when will it be..."

Could she expect a positive response?

Or, was it right to even have this conversation now?

These thoughts danced back and forth in Luna's mind.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 133: Saint Haruna (1)

"Ah, you've arrived."

A chubby priest rushed out and greeted with a bow.

"I am Pheron, the Head Priest. It's a pleasure... Whew..."

"Hello. I am Astina Persia."

The priest, having introduced himself as Pheron, caught his breath and looked at Astina.

Astina Persia.

Her fame was widely recognized throughout the empire.

The position of Head Priest held some prominence and power.

However, one couldn't act recklessly before such talent who bore the name of the Persia family.

Even now, despite her young age, she held both power and fame.

It was unpredictable how influential she would become in the future.

Thus, making a good impression was essential.

"It seems this is my first visit since becoming the heir. I had always intended to visit at least once; apologies for the delay."

"Hehe... No need for apologies. Given your busy schedule, we are just grateful for your visit."

This was a temple located in the Persia territory.

A temple dedicated to the deity, Karua.

In the empire, they worshipped only one god.

The deity believed to oversee and create the world, Karua, was revered, while other gods were deemed heretical.

Of course, this didn't mean those worshipping other deities faced persecution.

It was just the general belief.

One of the reasons for this was the relatively weak influence of religion within the empire.

The empire relied on the power of magic.

They revered the tangible and boundless power of magic, not relying on something like religion.

Therefore, even if the temple of Karua deemed others as heretical, there wasn't much they could do.

"Shall we proceed inside?"

Pheron gestured towards the temple as he spoke to Astina.

Astina looked at him and smiled.

'Hmm, was it good that I came out?'

Pheron, seeing Astina's smile, breathed an inward sigh of relief.

Astina's reputation was lofty, but she was still young and had only recently become the heir.

Before receiving her inheritance, she hadn't been in the spotlight much.

The Head Priest had personally come out, hoping that this kind gesture would favorably influence her perception of the temple.

However, contrary to Pheron's expectations, Astina was quite displeased.

When you observe someone long enough, even in silence, their true nature becomes evident.

Someone who flatters the strong and is deceitful.

He seemed like a corrupt priest.

Of course, having already researched this Head Priest, she might have been biased.

Still, Astina did not show her discomfort.

After all, her current visit wasn't to confront this man.

Normally, temples were affiliated with the central temple in the empire.

However, temples located in territories were, in effect, no different from businesses under the territories.

As the acting lord, Astina could easily deal with these people with a flick of her wrist.

She didn't want to show displeasure from the start and give them an opportunity to respond.

Astina followed the high priest Pheron into the temple.

The inside of the temple was adorned with lavish decorations.

Huge windows stood out, and the ornaments on the ceiling made one wonder how they were installed.

Astina exclaimed in admiration as she observed the interior.

This exclamation was not because the inside was beautiful, but because she could imagine how much money was poured into it.

'It seems they've really splurged.'

The power of the temples might be waning now, but during times when magic hadn't advanced, their power was immense.

Even now, they were living off the wealth amassed during those times.

However, they couldn't foresee the future even with all this wealth.

Even during the rise of magic, they were just busy taking money from their believers, and this behavior continued until now.

They were soon left behind.

People began to praise magic, not the gods.

They tried to catch people's attention with their lavish buildings, but the masses weren't swayed by mere appearances.

As a result, temples held a lower position within the empire.

There wasn't anything a temple without any special power like magic could do.

"The architecture is beautiful."

Astina praised it without mentioning these thoughts.

"Hehe, isn't this what one must do to house our God?"

Pheron responded with a pleased smile.

"Now, shall we go in?"

Pheron led Astina to a reception room inside the temple.

The interior of the reception room was even more luxurious than what typical nobles used.

But by now, nothing could surprise her.

Why would priests need such a luxurious reception room for entertaining guests?

Astina, tired of such thoughts, just let it go.

"Over there, bring some tea. Since Lady Astina is here, it must be made well. Hehe..."

"Yes, understood."

Pheron jokingly said to the nearby priest.

As soon as the priest left, Pheron turned to Astina.

"Hehe, lately, Lady Astina's reputation is so great that it's all I hear about."

He immediately started to butter up to Astina.

"Enough of that."

Astina waved her hand dismissively.

"I'd like to get straight to the point."

"...The point?"

Pheron's eyes widened at Astina's words.

He had heard that Astina was coming, but he hadn't heard why.

He had assumed she was just checking the temple's status, so he hadn't given it much thought.

However, when she mentioned getting to the point, Pheron's expression hardened.

'What is she talking about? There have been rumors lately about increasing taxes... Could this be related to that?'

The political climate was chaotic lately due to various issues with the rebels.

As a result, most territories increased their tax rates.

Amidst this, the temple's situation began to become more challenging.

Originally, temples benefited from tax exemption and didn't need to pay any taxes.

However, recent laws began to impose some taxes on temples.

This has become a significant concern for the temple.

'We absolutely cannot pay these taxes...!'

Pheron shouted internally.

The donations which were already dwindling, if it was taken away by the territory, he would have even less money.

Pheron had no intention of sitting by and watching this happen.

But, as someone who has been in the clergy for a long time, he quickly regained his composure and smiled again.

"If you're talking about the main issue..."

Pheron pretended to be oblivious.

It wouldn't be beneficial to bring up the tax issue first.

Nevertheless, being a clergyman, he tried his best to hide his worldly concerns.

Astina, noticing Pheron's behavior, crossed her legs and said,

"I want to know about the Saint."

"The... Saint?"

Pheron looked baffled by Astina's question.

It was completely unexpected.

"Why are you suddenly asking about the Saint...?"

"Oh, just personal curiosity. Is it difficult to share?"

Pheron pondered for a moment, then smiled and shook his head.

"Heh, what secrets could there be between you and me?"

At that, Astina's expression slightly soured.

'What does he think our relationship is?'

However, she quickly changed her expression and moved on.

"I've been reading the empire's history and the holy scriptures of Karua."

"Oh, you're interested in theology?"

To Pheron's question, Astina nodded.

"You could say that."

"So, what about the Saint...?"

Astina grinned as she began to speak.

"In the historical records, it's said that the Saint is a being from another dimension."

"...Dimension?"

"Yes, they say that God created not just our world but multiple worlds..."

"Ah..."

"...?"

At Astina's words, Pheron burst into laughter.

"Hahaha! Dimensions? What are you talking about! Hahaha... The Saint coming from another dimension? Lady Astina, you're so naive!"

Astina's expression darkened at his words.

"What are you talking about?"

Pheron laughed heartily, patting his large belly.

"The Saint is from our empire. She's not an entity from some other place!"

"... What about the first Saint?"

"I wasn't alive during the early days of the empire, but as far as I know, she was just a regular citizen of the empire. Moreover, she was a commoner..."

Astina narrowed her eyes.

"How can you be so sure?"

"I've had many conversations with the Saint, Haruna. Being the head priest of a significant territory, I had many chances to speak with her. Through these, I was able to gather more information about her."

Pheron continued,

“However, there was nothing unusual about her. Her background was clear, and there was no indication that she came from another dimension or any peculiar place. The same was true for the previous Saint.”

Astina rubbed her chin and replied,

“From what I've heard, she has this peculiar ability to see the future?”

Pheron shook his head at Astina's comment.

“Do you truly believe that the Saint can foresee the future?”

Astina didn't reply.

Many know and have experienced that the Saint isn't always accurate in her predictions.

In the past, there were many instances where the areas the Saint deemed dangerous experienced no issues at all.

While similar events have occurred, there was never a time when an exact prediction came to fruition.

Most of her prophecies were vague, hinting at outcomes without clear details.

‘However, based on what Rudy said...’

She recalled a conversation she had with Rudy in the North.

Rudy mentioned that he avoided danger during the Winter Ball based on the information she provided.

He overcame danger based on the future the Saint mentioned...

‘Just who is this Saint, really?’

“Heh, still, it's refreshing to see your innocent side, Lady Astina. It feels like a return to simpler times.”

Astina shot a glare at the slightly teasing Pheron.

"Is it alright for us to discuss this?"

"It's alright. Those who need to know, already know. Besides, while the Saint is technically affiliated with the temple, she is somewhat separate from it."

"Separate, you say?"

Pheron chuckled, rubbing his hands together.

"The one to appoint the next Saint is the previous Saint. As to how and why the role is passed on, even we aren't quite sure. But it's always handed down by the previous Saint."

"Hmm..."

Astina rubbed her nose, deep in thought.

She came seeking information about the Saint, but ended up with more questions than answers.

Then, she remembered something Pheron said earlier.

"Didn't you say earlier that the background of the Saints are clear?"

"Yes, that's right. We know exactly where they come from and who their parents are."

Astina smirked.

"Then, can I meet the current Saint's parents?"

-Hello, are you Haruna? I came to see you.

-Have you ever considered becoming the Saint? It would be a good opportunity for you.

-You want to become the Saint? Great choice!

-This is the essential knowledge you need to become the Saint.

-The essential... 'magic' the Saint must learn.

“Ugh...”

Haruna held her head as she sat up in bed.

After getting up, Haruna sat still for a moment and sighed.

“It's been a while since I had that dream...”

It was about the time she inherited the role of the Saint.

Haruna looked at the blindfold placed beside her.

“Sigh...”

Picking up the blindfold, she let out another sigh.

“It's about time to leave.”

She got out of bed and stretched.

“Ugh!”

Then, she pulled back the curtain to look outside.

“Ah, what lovely weather!”

She commented, admiring the sunlit, vibrant trees.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 134: Saint Haruna (2)

Student Council Room.

I was going over some documents when I heard Rie's words and looked up.

"The Saint is coming?"

Rie casually shrugged her shoulders.

It was roughly four days before Homecoming Day.

We still had some time.

"Why is she coming so early?"

"Who knows? But remember, she came early last time too."

"That's true, but..."

While Rie might have a point, I couldn't help but be concerned.

I recalled the letter that Astina sent not long ago.

She mentioned researching dimensions and was asking about the Saint.

However, she hadn't found anything significant yet.

I found it curious.

I'd never heard of a relation between the Saint and other dimensions, not during my studies at the academy, at least.

For now, I knew Rie was also looking into the Saint, but progress seemed slow.

Speaking of which, Astina did mention something for Rie.

"Astina won't be attending Homecoming Day, will she?"

"Really? Hmm..."

Rie appeared lost in thought, probably pondering over the Saint again.

I knew it wouldn't yield an answer, so I subtly changed the topic.

"Anyway, have all the supplies come in as expected?"

Taken aback by the sudden question, Rie hesitated.

"Uh, well, I believe Kuhn and Locke are handling that."

"That's good to hear."

I smiled, feeling that our Homecoming Day preparations were on track.

Through this process, my admiration for Astina grew immensely.

How did she manage to shoulder so many responsibilities on her own?

Even with my best efforts, I felt short on time.

Fortunately, with Rie helping with the council duties, we seemed to be keeping up.

Rie smiled briefly, then looked around and spoke,

"Speaking of which, why haven't we seen Luna lately?"

"Huh?"

I was taken aback by the mention of Luna's name.

At my reaction, Rie narrowed her eyes, staring intently at me.

"...What did you do?"

"What do you mean 'what did I do'?"

Well, I did do something...

I hadn't spoken privately with Luna for a while now.

We did meet occasionally as a group for council-related matters but hadn't spoken privately.

After the incident, I'm unsure how to face Luna.

Even though I promised her an answer, I still hadn't settled on one.

With so many pressing matters, including the rebel issue and Homecoming Day preparations, I decided to address our personal matters later.

As I sank into my thoughts, Rie finally said,

"If you have worries, I can lend an ear, you know..."

"Huh?"

Rie blushed slightly, turning her head away in apparent shyness.

"I... I might be able to help, you know."

I looked at Rie strangely, then chuckled awkwardly.

"Haha... No, it's just something I need to think about on my own."

At that, Rie shot me a sharp glance.

"Don't mope around then. You look like a puppy that's been scolded by its owner, especially when we're so busy."

Why is she acting like this?

I stared intently at Rie, trying to understand her sudden change in mood.

Is she on edge because of all the work lately?

But considering that, Rie seemed to be in great spirits.

“Anyway, everything is being handled well, right?”

I said casually to Rie.

Rie relaxed her furrowed brows and sighed.

“Yes, things are under control now.”

"I'm going to pop by the lab for a bit,"

I said.

I heard that recently, Luna was learning about staff synthesis from Professor Robert.

It was a technique for fusing the staff's shaft with a mana stone – a complex skill known to be quite challenging.

But during our last practice session, it seemed Professor Robert took a liking to Luna and decided to pass on this knowledge to her.

"Alright, take care,"

Rie replied with a faint smile.

I left the student council room, and as I did, a familiar face came into view.

A girl was hesitating outside the student council room.

It was Yuni.

"Why are you here?"

I asked, slightly surprised.

"Oh, senior,"

Yuni, whom I expected to be in the lab, said, clearly caught off guard by my presence.

"I... um..."

She seemed embarrassed, avoiding my gaze and acting quite awkwardly.

Did she eat something odd today?

This doesn't seem like the Yuni I know.

I looked at her, puzzled.

"Is it me you're here to see?"

Yuni shook her head.

"I could've easily met you at the lab."

Right.

"Is it Luna, then? She's not here right now."

Considering Luna has been involved in manastone-related tasks recently, maybe she came looking for her.

It would make sense; Yuni might still feel awkward around Luna.

But the name she mentioned was unexpected.

"Ah... I came to see my sister,"

She said, referring to Rie.

This puzzled me further.

Why would she act so shy about meeting Rie?

Their last conversation didn't seem awkward.

Filled with questions but deciding not to press further, I moved to open the student council room's door for her.

"Then, I'll let you in..."

"W-wait!"

Yuni quickly intercepted, stopping me from opening the door.

Holding onto my wrist, she looked up at me with an earnest expression.

"Wait a moment..."

Every time I met with Rie, they usually just chatted casually with a bit of teasing.

I was curious as to why she was acting this way.

"Um, senior... can I ask you something?"

"Hm?"

Yuni fiddled with her nails before speaking.

"I heard... there's a bakery... my sister likes..."

"Oh, that place? It's the bakery right next to the academy when you go out."

"Wow!"

Yuni's face lit up at my answer.

"Thank you. I'll buy you something nice later!"

She smiled warmly at me.

Did I say something that impressive?

Still, seeing her cheerful made me feel good too.

"So, you're heading to the lab after finishing up here?"

"Yes, I'll be there shortly."

With that, Yuni and I said our goodbyes, and I moved on.

However, I shouldn't have headed to the lab.

I should have just gone to the student council room with Yuni.

And... I should've just stayed put.

I began walking towards the lab.

"I need to handle... some staff-related stuff... and then..."

"Ah... Ah..."

Suddenly, I heard strange noises coming from inside the lab.

"Hm?"

Who could it be?

I looked at the lab door, puzzled.

I had just met Yuni, and I knew that Kuhn and Locke were organizing things.

Emily should definitely be there too.

Then, why were there voices from the lab?

I leaned in closer to the lab door, listening intently.

"What on earth... is this..."

A woman's voice.

It sounded familiar, but...

Someone I know?

It would be incredibly rude for someone I know to enter the lab without permission.

The lab had valuable research, and there were many things someone might want to steal.

Of course, leaving the lab unlocked was a mistake Yuni and I often made.

But still, it's not polite.

But why does the voice sound familiar?

Regardless, I decided to open the lab door and enter.

"Who is..."

Upon entering, I immediately recognized the person.

Gracie Lifegold.

Professor Gracie had returned from her vacation.

"Ah..."

Seeing Professor Gracie's face, my expression stiffened.

I was sure Professor Gracie was scheduled to return on homecoming day.

Why so soon...

However, before I could think further, my body reacted on its own.

I have to run.

I've started too many experiments.

My plan was to get some results before Gracie returned and greet her with some good news.

But, the results weren't out yet.

The research was still ongoing.

"Sigh."

I need to escape.

Clearly, she had just returned to the academy.

Yuni was in the student council room earlier, and she hadn't mentioned Professor Gracie's return.

That was clear enough.

Human anger, at first, flares up like a flame.

However, given a bit of time, that anger fades.

There's a saying that if one can endure thrice, even murder can be forgiven.

Perhaps this is similar.

I believed it was right to give Professor Gracie some time to think.

Quickly, I tried to move and escape from the room.

But this escape wasn't for my sake.

It was for Professor Gracie to have time to think...

"Arrange Room."

Without even glancing at me, Gracie cast a spell.

BANG!

Immediately, the door shut, the scattered documents around the room neatly arranged themselves, the windows closed, and the curtains were drawn.

The room became dark in an instant.

"..."

I was trapped in the room before I could even attempt to leave.

"Rudy?"

Gracie looked at me with a smiling face.

However, it wasn't a kind smile.

It was filled with intensity and hostility.

"What might this be?"

Picking up one of the neatly arranged documents with her magic, Gracie waved it at me.

I tried to respond swiftly.

"It seems like Yuni has been studying something like this lately,"

I said, forcing an awkward smile.

It was a feeble excuse.

"Really?"

Gracie then picked up another document from the side.

It was an official document granting permission for our research at the academy.

"...What is this?"

I stared intently at the document, scratching my head.

"I'm not sure? What document is that?"

"..."

Gracie gazed at me sharply.

The surroundings began to tremble slightly.

It was due to Gracie's mana moving intensely, affecting everything around.

Gracie lowered her head slightly, her shoulders shaking.

After a brief moment, she suddenly raised her head, exclaiming,

"You damn fool!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!"

"What do you think?"

There was a sudden noise, reminiscent of the movement of armor joints.

"Not bad."

Aryandor, the leader of The Rebels, said with a smile.

He was adjusting the prosthetic attached to his leg.

"While it may not move like before, you should be satisfied. It's the best prosthetic made with the current magical technology we have."

Remarked the black-haired man in front of him, adjusting his glasses.

"Thank you, Raven."

Aryandor expressed his gratitude, then rose from his seat to test the mobility of his new leg.

After a few steps around the room, a grin appeared on his face.

"Seems decent enough."

"However, are you sure you should be moving around so soon? Perhaps it's best to wait until you've fully adjusted,"

Raven advised.

"Why worry? Despite his injuries, he's still our leader,"

Jefferin interjected, sucking on a candy.

Raven cast a disdainful glance at her.

"You might look younger, but your behavior sure hasn't matured."

"What can I do? The mind naturally follows the body. Don't you know that? This is why I can't stand magic technicians. Tsk."

Jefferin responded with an annoyed tone, and Raven, not wanting to prolong their argument, busied himself tidying up.

Aryandor picked up his sword from its resting place.

"Jefferin, are the others ready?"

"Yep, yep. They're all waiting,"

Jefferin responded, removing the candy from her mouth with an exaggerated nod.

Aryandor sheathed his sword and declared,

"Then, let's get going."

As Aryandor stepped out of the building, he was greeted by a massive bone dragon and a group of individuals.

A woman wearing a wide-brimmed hat and holding a broomstick.

A muscular man with numerous scars on his face and body, a greatsword strapped to his back.

Another man with pronounced dark circles under his eyes and disheveled hair.

Each of them had a unique presence.

“Everything's prepared as instructed,” said the man with the dark circles, standing next to the bone dragon.

Aryandor nodded in response.

“Then, let's set off.”

The bone dragon lowered its head, allowing Aryandor easy access to mount it.

He climbed up, and the others quickly followed suit.

Raven, watching them depart, voiced his concern,

“Travel safely.”

Aryandor glanced back momentarily before stating,

“We're heading to Liberion Academy.”

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 135: Saint Haruna (3)

“Didn’t you get scolded by Professor Gracie yesterday?”

Rie, while carelessly stuffing documents into her bag, spoke to me.

I let out a sigh, thinking about it.

“I now understand what they mean when they say it’s terrifying when someone who’s usually silent gets angry.”

Indeed, yesterday I was reprimanded by Professor Gracie.

It was somewhat expected.

The research I’m currently working on nearly exhausted all of the lab funding.

Of course, when we first signed the contract, she did say I could pursue a project of my choosing.

But even by my standards, it felt like I might’ve spent a tad too much.

But what could I do now?

The money had already been spent...

“Alright, I better get going.”

“So soon?”

Rie had only just arrived, not even ten minutes ago.

I was surprised she was leaving already.

Seeing my reaction, Rie chuckled,

“Yuni invited me for some tea today.”

I remembered Yuni asking me about it yesterday.

Judging by Yuni's attitude, it didn't seem like there was any malicious intent behind the invitation.

So, it should be fine.

I shrugged,

“Alright, take care.”

As I waved goodbye with a smile, Rie advised in a playful tone,

“Try not to work too hard.”

With those words, she left.

That cheeky concern of hers made me smile.

I began to sift through the documents Rie left behind.

All the paperwork related to Homecoming Day seemed to be in order, but I was double-checking just to be certain.

As I was going through the documents, there was a knock on the student council office door.

I looked up, perplexed.

Who would visit at this time?

Everyone mentioned being busy, so I assumed it might be just another student.

“Who is it?”

A voice replied,

“It’s Haruna.”

Haru...na?

My eyes widened in surprise.

“Yes?”

My surprised reaction led to the door opening and a woman stepping in.

She wore nun’s robes and had a rosary around her neck.

However, something about her was different from the last time I saw her.

“The blindfold...”

The last time I saw her, she was wearing a blindfold, as if she were blind.

But now, she entered the student council office confidently, without it.

I had already heard from Rie that she wasn’t actually blind, but seeing her so boldly walk in caught me off guard.

“Hello, Rudy Astria.”

She greeted with a smile.

I stood up from my seat, still in shock, looking at her,

“What brings you here?”

I could understand her being in the academy, but her sudden visit to the student council office left me bewildered.

As I posed the question, she responded with a kind face,

“Rudy Astria, I came to meet you.”

“...Me?”

I hadn't completely ruled out the possibility of the Saint coming here.

After all, if you visit the student council office, you'd naturally meet the student council president.

However, the real question was why she had come to see me.

It would have made sense if she was here to meet the principal or some other professors.

They are the representatives of the academy, so it would be natural to exchange greetings.

But, the fact that she chose to meet me before them was puzzling.

Then, the Saint stated calmly,

“The rebels are coming.”

I widened my eyes in shock.

Only a few people, including Cromwell and myself, knew the rebels were on their way to meet me.

Yet hearing such words from her lips was utterly baffling.

I fixed a stern look on her and asked,

"How do you know this? Why would the Rebels suddenly come to the academy.....?"

“There's no time for idle chatter.”

“Excuse me?”

She pointed to the clock.

“Within an hour, the rebels will be here.”

I frowned at her unexpected statement.

"How do you know this?"

She replied, as if it was the most obvious thing in the world,

“Because I can see the future.”

Gently caressing the rosary around her neck, she quietly added,

“I need your help, Possessor.”

Cromwell was in the principal's office, handling paperwork.

Juggling the duties of both the vice principal and the principal left him with no room for relaxation.

Of course, it wasn't all paperwork.

It was important to keep things running smoothly at the Academy.

Currently, Principal McDowell was absent.

It wasn't a brief absence; he had suffered a severe injury and was under treatment.

To keep this situation under wraps, it was essential that academy operations appeared seamless.

If word got out about McDowell's precarious condition, there would surely be complications.

After all, the previous incident orchestrated by Vice Principal Oliver happened because Principal McDowell had been away for an extended period.

Cromwell sighed.

Moreover, there were other matters mentioned by Rudy that needed addressing.

While he had requested assistance from central authorities regarding this issue, it was hard to expect much without an exact date.

Having top talents linger for too long in the academy could, in some respects, be seen as a waste of resources.

So, Cromwell believed that it was important to prepare as much as possible using the academy's current resources.

He had reached out in advance to trustworthy professors like McGuire and Robert to ensure heightened security at the academy and requested an early return from Professor Gracie.

He had prepared as best he could.

While Cromwell was reviewing documents, an assistant came from behind with a cup of coffee.

"Vice Principal, perhaps you should take a break and have some coffee."

This assistant originally worked for McDowell, but since McDowell was absent, he was assisting Cromwell.

"Ah, thank you."

Smiling, Cromwell extended his hand to receive the coffee from the assistant.

Just as he was about to grip the cup:

"Ah!"

Clang...!

Cromwell fumbled, dropping the coffee cup, his mouth agape in surprise.

"Oh, Vice Principal, are you alright?"

The assistant was visibly startled.

While the coffee cup shattered on the floor, thankfully, no one was scalded.

As the assistant was about to clean the broken shards,

"I'll take care of it..."

Cromwell stopped him.

The assistant looked at Cromwell with a confused expression.

Suddenly, Cromwell's expression turned icy cold.

"Immediately tell Professor Gracie to come up to the rooftop. And notify Robert and Mcguire."

"Wha...?"

The assistant tilted his head, puzzled by Cromwell's abrupt order.

"Go. Now."

Then, Cromwell got up, opened the window of the principal's office, and said,

"Tell the professors that if I act strangely, they'll understand. For Professor Gracie..."

Cromwell pointed upwards.

"The highest point of the academy building. Tell her to go there."

Suddenly, using magic, Cromwell soared into the sky from the window.

"What is happening...?"

The assistant was baffled by Cromwell's sudden action, but he took off to carry out the instructions.

The sky was bathed in the glow of the setting sun.

Darkness began to encroach upon the surroundings.

Right under that sky stood Cromwell.

On the highest spire of the academy.

"These damned fools."

Cromwell spat out a curse.

From the distance.

Madmen were approaching.

The Rebels.

It wasn't just one or two rebels.

Several rebels emitting a massive amount of mana were coming.

The mana emanating from each one of them was formidable.

They all looked like top-ranking members within the Rebels.

However, amidst them, one mana fluctuation stood out the most.

A presence that was overwhelmingly greater than the ones next to him.

He was likely their leader.

He had supposedly been injured, but judging by the mana he exuded, he was a genuine monster.

However, they were not yet visible.

Thanks to the detection magic previously set up by Professor Mcguire, Cromwell was aware of their approach.

Still, even without that detection magic, he would have known.

They did not hide their mana.

They openly showed their approach.

Almost as if challenging anyone to stop them.

Cromwell gazed at the horizon, where the sky met the land.

Although they weren't yet visible, it was clear they were flying towards him.

Suddenly, from below, a woman awkwardly flying up was seen.

"Gracie, you've arrived."

Professor Gracie, not skilled in using telekinesis, couldn't fly as naturally as Cromwell.

But she managed to float up to where Cromwell was.

Upon reaching the adjacent spire, she landed and looked at Cromwell.

"Professor... What on earth is happening...?"

Cromwell glanced down from the sky.

The academy was becoming increasingly chaotic.

The students seemed to be evacuating, moving hastily.

Professor Mcguire must be handling the situation well.

Cromwell then turned his gaze back to Gracie.

"Gracie, can you feel that?"

At Cromwell's words, Gracie, with a puzzled face, looked in the direction Cromwell pointed.

"I... I don't understand."

Gracie responded with confusion.

There was nothing visibly there.

Cromwell then frowned and lightly smacked Gracie.

"Ouch!"

"Don't use your eyes. Sense with your mana."

"Ah, okay..."

Gracie focused and sensed in the direction Cromwell indicated.

Her eyes widened in shock.

Feeling the storm-like surge of mana overwhelmed her.

"What is this..."

"The Rebels. They're coming."

At Cromwell's words, Gracie gasped.

"So what should we do now...?"

"Given how they are approaching, asking for reinforcements would be pointless. I did send a distress signal, but for now, we need to handle this ourselves."

"Should we all run away then..."

"Do you think that makes sense? It's right for the students to flee, but why would a professor need to run?"

"...They look too strong."

At Gracie's words, Cromwell sighed...

"Still, we must try to fight."

Cromwell descended from the sky and landed on the spire where Gracie was perched.

"There's something you need to do first."

"What is it?"

Cromwell pointed again towards the rebels.

"Intercept those guys."

"Intercept? They're moving extremely fast though...?"

Gracie looked at Cromwell with disbelief.

"Stop being so dramatic."

Cromwell remarked with a chuckle.

"You can do it. After all, whose student are you?"

Hearing this, the gloom on Gracie's face began to lift.

Hitting targets moving at that speed was a difficult task.

Yet, the mentor she knew since the days she was ignorant of magic had told her so.

His casual confidence bolstered her own.

Even though she had learned something else instead of mastering her mentor's techniques, the fact that Cromwell acknowledged her brought a mix of joy and pride.

“I’ll... I’ll give it a shot.”

Gracie clenched her fists and looked up to the sky.

“Whew...”

Sparks began to sizzle around Gracie.

“Descent of the Lightning God...”

A powerful electricity started to radiate around her.

Gracie's hair started to turn white, and her eyes shifted to a bright blue hue.

The fragile girl she once appeared to be was no longer in sight.

Gracie took aim at where the rebels were.

“But, even if I hit the rebels, I don’t know where they'll fall.”

“Don't worry about that. I'll handle it.”

Gracie nodded, reaching out with her hand as Cromwell soared back into the sky.

Gracie closed her eyes, focusing intently.

She aimed precisely at her target, accounting for the speed of the enemy, the location they would reach at that speed, the time it would take her to cast her spell, and where they could dodge to.

She made no room for error.

Once she finished all her calculations, she channeled her mana and released it.

"Flames of the sky, fury of the gods since the beginning."

In the distance, dark clouds converged in unison.

The clouds in the sky obeyed Gracie's command, aligning precisely.

"In this moment, strike down my enemy."

Gracie opened her eyes, taking aim at the massive emission of mana.

She whispered softly,

"Lightning bolt."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 136: Saint Haruna (4)

"What is that...?"

I watched as an immense beam of light fell from outside the window.

Even though it seemed to be happening at a distance, it was clearly visible.

"That was a quicker response than I expected."

Haruna, looking at the light, spoke to me.

The echoing voice of McGuire throughout the school.

The enormous light falling from the sky.

Professors rushing to evacuate the students.

Just as she said, the Rebels are approaching.

However, I had a question.

"Why didn't you warn us about the Rebels coming earlier? If you had, we could've prepared..."

"I couldn't do that. I wasn't certain this future would come to pass."

"What?"

"You might be familiar with the concept of dimensions, especially since you're from another one."

At Haruna's words, I frowned.

"Dimensions can refer to entirely different worlds, like the one you came from. But they can also mean the same space at a different time, like the future or the past."

Haruna smiled.

"I can see all those dimensions. The future, the past, and other worlds."

"...What?"

I looked at Haruna in disbelief.

"So, even when I see the future, I can't always tell if it's the future of this world or another."

A power to see other worlds?

What kind of power was that?

Then...

"So, did you learn about me through that power?"

Unless she could read minds, there was no way she could know I had taken over this body.

While my actions might have been peculiar, they weren't definitive proof that I had come from another dimension.

"Regarding you, Rudy... I didn't find out through my powers..."

Haruna smiled with a hint of sadness.

"I heard it from my predecessor, the former Saint Beatrice."

My mind began to whirl.

And I glanced out of the window again.

"Everyone, move this way!"

"Is anyone else left in the building?"

"What's going on?"

The chaos outside suggested that it wasn't the best time to hear Haruna's story.

I fixed my gaze on Haruna.

"So, what do you want from me?"

Haruna smiled brightly.

"It's good to get straight to the point."

Saying that, she slowly approached and showed me the rosary she had untied from her neck.

"I'm going to use magic."

"...Magic?"

I frowned and examined the rosary Haruna held.

Several gem-like structures were embedded in the rosary.

But upon closer inspection, they weren't gems.

Mana crystals.

Tiny mana crystals were embedded in that rosary.

I turned to look at Haruna again.

"I will summon a future version of you. Specifically, your body."

My eyes widened at Haruna's words.

"We need you at your strongest, from every possible timeline. For the present, and for the future."

A beam of light descended from the heavens.

More precisely, a small orb of light burst through the clouds, heading straight for the distant Bone Dragon.

As the orb approached the dragon, those riding it scattered in all directions.

Only one man stood his ground, attempting to deflect it with his sword.

That man was Aryandor, the leader of the Rebels.

The moment his blade made contact with the light orb, a massive explosion ensued, obscuring all vision.

'It begins now.'

Observing from a distance, Professor Cromwell reached out a hand.

Circling light manifested around it, and a long staff materialized – Cromwell's own magical staff.

He then turned his gaze to Gracie.

Gracie seemed slightly out of breath.

"Can you still fight?"

"I can."

Despite her weariness from using a powerful spell, Gracie appeared to be in relatively good condition.

Cromwell desperately needed her assistance.

Even though she was his disciple, she had achieved significant accomplishments in another field and was recognized as a professor.

Despite being a junior faculty member, she was a formidable wizard.

While Cromwell's telekinetic magic was incredibly versatile, it wasn't specifically tailored for combat, especially against a single opponent.

Thus, facing the leader of the Rebels, he needed Gracie's support.

"We need to draw the leader closer,"

Cromwell murmured.

Though Gracie's spell had affected their enemies, it was far from over.

Had the leader been so easily defeated, Principal McDowell wouldn't have received such grievous injuries.

Taking a deep breath, Cromwell released his mana, not concealing it but letting it radiate visibly all around, as if flaunting its overwhelming presence.

'Lure him out'

Calling out the rebel leader.

No one else was fit to confront this leader.

Cromwell knew it had to be him.

In the distance, a large figure emerged, making its way towards the academy after emerging from the smoke caused by Gracie's explosion.

It was the Bone Dragon.

Atop the dragon stood a man, looking seemingly unscathed.

However, the Bone Dragon itself was charred black.

It wasn't flying.

In fact, it was plummeting straight towards Cromwell.

The leader, as if challenging the academy to stop the crashing dragon, stood atop it, glaring intently at the institution.

The dragon was hurtling towards the academy's spire.

Cromwell quickly glanced below.

The students hadn't yet fully evacuated.

If the dragon crashed now, the spire would crumble, and the students below would be harmed.

"Professor!"

Gracie, realizing the imminent danger, called out.

Nodding, Cromwell responded,

"We have to stop it."

He then looked back at the leader, who met his gaze with an impassive expression.

Cromwell raised his hand.

"Gravity."

Yet, nothing seemed to happen around him.

A confused expression crossed Gracie's face.

Slowly... steadily... the approaching Bone Dragon.

Its descent was accelerating.

Cromwell, with a stoic expression, merely held his hand aloft.

"Professor, if you don't act now..."

"Stay put."

"Pro... Professor!!"

It was almost upon them.

Gracie tried to draw on her mana, intending to cast a spell herself.

Seeing this, Cromwell turned his head with a frown.

"I told you to stand still."

"But, soon...!"

That's when a strange noise reached their ears.

Whoosh...!

It wasn't the sound of the descending Bone Dragon.

Gracie turned her head towards the sound.

"Huh?"

What was flying toward them was a massive rock.

A colossal stone.

Boom!!!!!!

The stone collided squarely with the Bone Dragon.

It had been summoned from the mountains behind the academy.

Cromwell had drawn this massive rock from there.

The stone, having traveled at great speed from the mountains, crashed into the Bone Dragon, forcing it towards a vacant lot in the academy.

While the Bone Dragon was effectively stopped, it wasn't over.

From the distance, Aryandor, having witnessed the flying rock, leaped towards Cromwell.

Drawing his sword as he descended, Aryandor greeted,

"Hello there."

In response, Cromwell raised his staff.

"Gravity Hand."

Cromwell's spell clashed with Aryandor's blade.

Near the academy dormitory.

"What a mess."

Robert had seen everything.

Luna stood beside him.

With trembling hands, Luna tried to steady herself as she looked ahead.

Robert was in the middle of instructing Luna about staff synthesis.

However, suddenly, the principal's assistant arrived with a warning of impending danger.

Professor Mcguire was swiftly evacuating the students, and Robert was moving Luna to a safer location.

But, a man descended in front of them.

He descended on a wyvern made of bones.

His hair was unkempt, and dark circles marred his eyes.

A face Robert had never seen before.

It was instantly clear that this man wasn't an ally.

Seeing the skeletal wyvern beside him, Robert cautiously asked,

"Necromancy?"

It's a type of dark magic.

However, it slightly deviated from the conventional categories of dark magic.

It had its own established framework.

Despite being a dark magic, its structured nature was due to it being the most advanced among dark magics.

So advanced, in fact, that it was banned.

"I didn't expect to encounter someone who wields necromancy."

Robert subtly positioned Luna behind him for protection.

The man slightly lifted his head and spoke,

"Someone who was punished for using necromancy shouldn't be talking."

At this, Robert smirked,

"You recognize me?"

"Among those who know of necromancy, who wouldn't know you?"

The man responded without a hint of emotion,

"Those who practice necromancy consider you both a mentor and an enemy."

The man's words echoed what Robert had once said to Rudy about Levian.

Yet, Robert couldn't refute what the man said.

In the past, while secretly researching necromancy and serving as a Royal Wizard, he was discovered.

All those associated with him either died or were imprisoned.

The only reason he was spared was thanks to his mentor, Levian, and his contributions as a Royal Wizard.

"You're from Ephomos, aren't you?"

Ephomos.

A group once connected to Robert.

A place where the underprivileged, vagrants, and the impoverished gathered.

If the empire's capital was the light, this place was its shadow.

It was a haven for the fallen, where they tried to start anew.

However, after his necromancy research was exposed, the place vanished.

Erased by the empire itself.

"So, you're here for revenge now?"

Robert slowly channeled his mana.

The man nonchalantly shrugged,

"Revenge is too grand a word for what I intend, I'm just doing what needs to be done."

The man with pronounced dark circles under his eyes stamped his foot on the ground.

Immediately, the ground began to rumble.

“Uh...”

Luna, taken aback by the sudden quake, stepped back and looked around.

“Oh...”

Crack!

From the ground around them, skeletal hands began to emerge.

Skeletons.

Skeletons started to crawl out from the ground all around them.

And it wasn't just one or two.

So many that they completely surrounded Robert.

“Hmm.”

Robert smirked, rubbing his chin.

“More than I expected.”

Robert stretched, cracking his neck.

"Quality over quantity, though."

Then, a much louder rumble shook the place.

Robert's mana surged, causing the earth to upheave.

“Come forth, Behemoth.”

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 137: Saint Haruna (5)

“Come forth, Behemoth.”

The ground upheaved, revealing the massive form of the creature, Behemoth, vastly different from the smaller one Rudy once summoned.

As Behemoth rose, the skeletons that had stood upon the ground crumbled and were flung away.

Others were crushed under its massive feet.

With just its emergence, hundreds of skeletons were shattered.

Robert chuckled, saying,

"You shouldn't use necromancy like this."

Necromancy wasn't meant to be used so carelessly.

While one could argue that having the power to conjure such an army at will was incredible, it wasn't that simple.

While necromancy can instantly create an army, it requires proper preparation to be effective.

These hastily created skeletons were so fragile that even an ordinary person could shatter them.

To craft formidable skeletons, one needed to hand-pick corpses and bones, then imbue them with magic or treat them with special potions.

Since these skeletons skipped this process, they collapsed very easily.

The man with the dark circles under his eyes observed for a moment before channeling his mana.

"Bone Spear."

Suddenly, the nearby skeletons transformed into spears made of bone, flying rapidly towards Behemoth.

Thud!

"Roaaaaar...!"

Dozens of these spears lodged themselves into Behemoth, making it cry out in pain.

The opponent, having momentarily stopped Behemoth with the spears, channeled mana to the ground once more.

"Undead Rise, Lich."

A skeletal hand suddenly sprouted from the ground.

"While preparation is important for necromancy, skillfully summoning the right undead from available corpses on a battlefield is a talent in itself."

Beside him, a skeleton slowly rose, its eyes glowing a sinister red.

"Undead Rise, Death Knight."

He cast another spell, and beside the newly risen Lich appeared a skeleton clad in old armor, wielding a sword.

The aura surrounding this undead felt unnaturally ominous.

Robert then realized what the man meant.

The Academy was ancient, housing the remains of numerous talents from times past.

It wouldn't be surprising to find powerful remains buried here.

If anything, the academy was more likely to have the remains of these gifted beings than ordinary corpses.

Robert glanced momentarily at Luna standing behind him.

Luna, assessing the situation, began to pull out a spellbook from her bag.

But as she attempted to open the spellbook, Robert held it shut.

"Eh?"

Luna looked at Robert in confusion.

"I'll pave the way. You should join the other professors."

"But I can help fight..."

Robert shook his head.

"Do as I tell you."

Something felt off.

The spellbook Luna uses belongs to Levian.

The period when he was expelled for using necromancy, the period when those handling necromancy in Ephomos were massacred, and finally, the period when Levian's spellbook came into existence.

Was all of this just a coincidence?

To Robert, it seemed like the dots were connecting.

Of course, it might not be the case, but Robert felt there was no particular need to show that man Levian's spellbook.

"Behemoth."

"Pwooooh."

Then, Behemoth began to move.

Using its large trunk, it swiped away the skeletons before it.

It also targeted the Lich and Death Knight ahead.

"Hmm."

The Death Knight, holding the man, leaped upwards.

Thanks to that, he was able to avoid Behemoth's attack, but numerous skeletons were swept away.

"Go."

Robert ordered Luna.

Overwhelmed by Robert's aura, Luna nodded,

"Okay."

And she ran along the path that Behemoth had cleared.

The man stared intently at the retreating Luna.

"Are you sure you want to let her go alone like that?"

Robert felt slightly uneasy.

He wasn't sure how many enemies were out there, but if Luna encountered another while fleeing, she would undoubtedly be in danger.

Still, he had instructed her to flee because he believed in Luna to an extent.

Robert moved his mana with a slight smile.

"How about you worry about not dying yourself?"

‘Should I summon Mephisto?’

The demon he summoned during the last fight with Oliver, Mephistopheles.

It was the demon Robert handled best and was the most powerful.

However, summoning it now wasn't a good idea.

He didn't know how many enemies there were.

Given the large sword strike and the explosion of Cromwell's magic earlier, the leader of the rebels had also arrived.

It was necessary to pace his mana properly.

"What's your name?"

Robert asked the man before him.

"Daemon."

Robert looked at him with slight surprise.

He had expected a rebel to hide their identity, but Daemon had responded openly.

He might be someone who didn't care about such things.

"Well, now that introductions are out of the way."

Robert raised his hand to the sky.

"Let's have a proper fight this time."

Then, a large magic circle was drawn in the sky.

"Giant of Gluttony, Nephilim, show yourself."

Then the magic circle turned black, and a massive foot began to emerge from within.

A giant.

The giant that consumes everything, Nephilim.

While it was quite weak when facing fewer enemies but it showed tremendous power against larger numbers like a horde of skeletons.

With a smirk, Robert commanded,

"Devour everything."

"Uoooooh....."

Nephilim began grabbing and swallowing the skeletons on the ground.

And swallowed them.

A giant that becomes stronger as it consumes its enemies.

That was Nephilim.

“Ugh...”

At the main entrance of Liberion Academy.

Two girls were quickly making their way through: Rie and Yuni.

They were on their way back from having tea outside the academy.

However, as soon as they arrived at the academy, it started to become chaotic, and large explosions occurred around them.

Yuni was particularly in high spirits today.

Whether in the royal palace or at the academy, there were hardly any moments she spent with Rie.

Because Rie disliked her.

Even if Yuni occasionally saw Rie, there was no real time spent together.

Whenever Yuni suggested having tea, Rie would decline.

Whenever their eyes met, Rie made it blatantly clear that she disliked her.

But today was definitely a good day.

She went outside the academy, had tea with Rie, and now...

“Hold on tight, Yuni.”

Rie firmly grasped Yuni’s hand, leading her forward.

‘Isn’t this rather nice?’

Yuni felt like she had returned to her childhood.

The days when Rie would hold her hand, hiding in the royal garden, came flooding back.

Looking ahead, Rie asked,

“Sylph, what's ahead?”

A green-tinted hawk, Sylph, appeared in response.

“There's a man holding a large sword. He's not from the academy.”

Rie frowned at this.

“Can we sneak past him?”

"I'm not sure. I don't know to what extent he can sense our presence.”

Rie nodded at Sylph's words.

“Alright. If there's anyone in the main building who can help, call them. If not in the main building, then anywhere else.”

“Understood.”

With that, Sylph vanished like a wisp of smoke.

“A man with a large sword... a swordsman...”

Rie pondered, her hand on her chin.

Typically, men wielding large swords were swordsmen.

Of course, there was Borval, who carried a massive axe but was a wizard.

However, he was an exceptional case.

“What's he doing there?”

With a serious expression, Rie peeked out from the bushes near the academy's entrance.

Currently, both Yuni and Rie were hiding in these bushes.

The mysterious man stood in the pathway leading from the bushes to the main building.

Turning her head, Rie looked at Yuni.

When their eyes met, Yuni tilted her head with a slight smile.

“Sigh... Aren't you worried at all?”

Yuni shrugged, replying,

“Why should I? I'm safe with you, aren't I? Hiding here seems safest. The professors will surely protect the others.”

At Yuni's words, Rie sighed.

Indeed, staying hidden here might be the safest until the situation is resolved.

Still, the man's actions up ahead were unsettling.

That man wasn't there from the start.

As Rie and Yuni were fleeing, he suddenly descended from the sky.

Upon landing, he surveyed the area before gradually walking towards the main building of Liberion Academy.

"What is he up to?"

Upon reaching a certain distance from the building, he unsheathed his sword, positioning himself to strike the structure horizontally.

"He intends to cut the building?"

Rie furrowed her brows.

Sure, an ordinary building might be cut, but not here, not at Liberion Academy.

Particularly that main building, which housed countless magical and alchemical tools.

It was like a powder keg.

As a result, dozens of protective spells blanketed the building.

If it were destroyed, the surroundings would be devastated, a fact well-known to the academy's officials who had placed those protections.

"It feels somewhat ominous, doesn't it?"

But, there's no way that man didn't know this fact.

He, after all, had infiltrated the academy.

And yet, he was making this attempt.

A dark aura swirled around his greatsword, steadily intensifying.

"Ha...!"

The man was serious.

He was genuinely aiming to cut down the building, especially at a moment when the professors were busy evacuating the students.

Turning her head, Rie noticed Yuni, huddled beside her.

Gently grabbing Yuni's shoulders, she instructed,

"Yuni, no matter what, stay here and don't come out."

Yuni's eyes widened in response.

Looking at Yuni, Rie spoke once more.

"Promise me, you absolutely cannot come out."

Being a mere first-year, Yuni hadn't even learned intermediate magic yet.

The responsibility fell solely on Rie.

A brief distraction was all she needed, just enough to alert the professors of the intruder's presence.

Once the professors arrived, they would handle the situation.

She had already sent a Sylph, so a professor was bound to arrive soon.

She just needed to hold on for a little longer.

As Rie was about to make her move, Yuni suddenly grabbed her wrist.

"Don't go. It's too dangerous. Please, just wait with me here."

Usually, Yuni was always composed, even during sudden peculiar events.

But now, she seemed genuinely distressed, desperately trying to stop Rie.

But she couldn't just stand by.

If the man managed to slice through the building, the consequences would be dire.

Even if the professors survive, the students around them...

Rie thought she had to act.

Even if she was the Imperial Princess, destined for the Emperor's throne, even if she was more valuable due to this, she couldn't just stand by and watch.

Rie gently freed her wrist from Yuni's grasp.

"I'll be back soon."

She said, flashing a reassuring smile before dashing out of the bushes.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 138: Saint Haruna (6)

"It might be a foolish..."

Rie thought as she emerged from the thicket.

She had already assumed that her opponent was strong enough to attack the main building of the academy.

Naturally, it meant confronting someone she might not be able to defeat.

Still, she didn't stop her steps.

"Am I becoming more like him...?"

Rudy Astria, who would act selflessly when others were in danger, prioritizing them over his own safety.

At first, Rie found such behavior incredibly foolish.

How could one risk their life so readily for the sake of others?

She couldn't understand it.

Yet, there she was, now moving without hesitation.

As these thoughts swirled in her mind, Rie let out a soft chuckle.

'Even in a situation like this, I'm thinking of Rudy...'

It felt ridiculous to her, even amusing, that she was pondering about Rudy when the circumstances were so dire.

Taking a deep breath, Rie shook off her distractions.

Thinking of Rudy was comforting, but now wasn't the time.

She could indulge in such reflections once everything was over.

Rie crouched, approaching the man stealthily, making sure not to make a sound.

He seemed to be focused on gathering his sword's energy, unaware of Rie's approach.

'I need to interrupt him first...'

Mana began to gather in Rie's hand.

She needed a conspicuous and potent spell.

Though Sylph was searching for help, there was a chance they wouldn't find any.

Hence, a noticeable spell to catch others' attention was crucial.

A massive explosion would surely draw someone's attention.

Rie took precise aim at the man holding the sword.

The first move was important.

His attention was elsewhere, so this was perfect opportunity.

If he started to move properly, it would be much harder to land a spell on him.

She only had one shot.

The most potent magic Rie could harness.

"Let my mana turn crimson..."

Despite her busy schedule with political matters and student council duties, Rie hadn't neglected her magical training.

She didn't want to fall behind Rudy.

Rudy, who always moved forward, had shown remarkable growth.

If she hesitated even slightly, the gap between them would widen significantly.

To support him, she had to advance, even if just a bit.

And now was the time to showcase the fruits of her rigorous training.

"To incinerate even the traces of my opponent."

Rie's explosive magic.

The most potent spell among them.

A deep red hue began swirling around Rie's hand.

"Rage Flare."

Upon completing her incantation, the sword-wielding opponent turned his head.

But it was too late; the spell was already cast.

Red dots began to appear around his body.

They multiplied, and soon, those dots started glowing brilliantly.

Like rising embers, one by one, they began to ignite.

The opponent, seeing this, readied his sword again.

But not at the building – he aimed for Rie.

"It's already too late."

Rie clenched her outstretched hand.

Crack.

The dots surrounding the opponent cracked, and from those cracks, light poured out.

"Explode."

The dots began to detonate in a chain reaction.

A series of explosions sent flames soaring into the sky, wrapping around the entire area.

The opponent was engulfed by the flames.

“Ha...!”

However, that was all.

The flames from the explosion were abruptly split in half.

A black sword aura, appearing seemingly out of nowhere, effortlessly sliced through Rie's flames.

This storm of sword aura didn't just slice the flames, it hurtled towards Rie.

“Huff...!”

Rie ducked her head, narrowly avoiding the oncoming storm.

"Huh?"

A strand of her hair, lightly tossed in the wind, was cut by the blade's aura.

It was a blade aura that, even without proper preparation or trajectory, was remarkably sharp.

Rie glanced at her fallen strand of hair on the ground.

Raising her head slightly, she looked ahead.

A man walked out from between the flames.

His upper clothing appeared to have been partially burned away.

Burn scars were visible through the remnants of his clothes.

He had dozens of scars on his body, making any she'd seen before seem insignificant.

However, these weren't wounds inflicted by Rie.

They weren't burns, but sword wounds... and they had already healed over.

With a scowl, the man continued to approach Rie.

"Who are you?"

"Eh...."

There wasn't a single wound on him.

She was sure she had used her most powerful magic, and yet he walked towards her without a significant injury.

The difference in their abilities was vast.

But this was within her expectations.

The large explosion had surely alerted others to the commotion here.

All she needed to do was hold out.

If she could restrain this man and hold out for a while...

"I asked who you are."

He looked at Rie with a haughty gaze.

Rie straightened up, meeting his gaze squarely.

"Rie Von Ristonia."

Regardless of his strength or seemingly insurmountable power, she wouldn't back down.

That unyielding spirit, that drive to always move forward, was Rie's greatest strength.

"First Princess of the Empire..."

She paused, lowering her head briefly, then raised it with a confident smile.

"Vice-President of Liberion Academy's Student Council."

"Hmm..."

The man frowned at Rie's audacious demeanor.

"So, you're the Royal princess."

Upon hearing Rie's name, he pointed his sword at her.

"I am Venderwood, a slave."

Despite introducing himself as a slave, his demeanor was undeniably confident.

But something was wrong.

How could someone in the position of a slave possess such power?

Of course, there were slaves skilled in combat, but none with such overwhelming strength.

"Still, you seem a bit better than those trashy nobles. So, you're the one standing atop them all?"

"Trashy?"

Rie frowned at the word.

Venderwood simply shrugged.

"Never mind."

Venderwood straightened his giant sword, pointing it at Rie.

It was a colossal blade, just a tad shorter than Rie herself.

"Prepare yourself."

Rie moved her mana in response.

She'd hold on as long as possible.

Until someone comes to her aid.

Yuni watched Rie from the bushes.

Rie's magic was devastating.

If Yuni had been at the epicenter, she felt she wouldn't have survived.

Yet, Venderwood withstood it effortlessly.

She couldn't fathom just how monstrous he truly was.

"Sister..."

Yet, even so, Rie stood her ground, fearlessly confronting Venderwood.

Bam!

"Ugh..."

And she was still doing so, evading Venderwood's relentless attacks, standing firm and fighting, no matter how dire it seemed.

Wounds of varying sizes marked Rie's body.

But still, Rie's gaze never wavered.

Her spirit remained unbroken.

She refused to give up.

"Huff... Huff..."

Yuni noticed Rie's ragged breathing.

Though she evaded attacks, she never fled.

Rie had always been like that.

While Yuni had cooperated with the noble faction and taken the easy path, Rie had always resisted them.

No matter the harassment or temptation they offered, Rie stood firm.

Despite having an easier path before her, she stood tall with dignity.

Yuni couldn't understand the pain that must have taken.

She only admired it.

Wondering what it felt like to stand where Rie stood.

So, Yuni had a thought.

She wanted to stand beside Rie.

However, she didn't want to pull down or manipulate the sister she admired.

She just wanted to compete with her fair and square for the successor position.

This is why Yuni considered using Rudy.

Someone with the potential to even surpass Ian, the favored successor of the Astria family.

With him by her side, she believed she could be a proper successor, backed by the Astria family, rather than just a puppet.

But now, she wasn't so sure.

Seeing the battle unfold, she felt she wasn't even in the same league.

Rie's resilience, even in the face of such overwhelming power, made Yuni hesitant to even think of following in her footsteps.

She realized that even if she rose to a similar position, she wouldn't become like her.

Then, a strike flew towards Rie.

It was in a hard-to-evade position.

Rie tried to use a barrier to block the attack.

"Damn..."

With her mana nearly exhausted and her body worn out, Rie's attempt to block Venderwood's attack with a barrier was barely sufficient.

"Ugh..."

In the end, Rie's barrier shattered under the force of the sword strike, and she sustained a cut to her leg.

Rie fell.

With her leg injured, escaping was now impossible.

Yuni watched the scene unfold before her with wide eyes.

A man with a greatsword approached the sister she looked up to.

Yuni's shaky gaze turned to the main academy building.

“Why... Why is no one coming...?”

She was sure Rie had called for help from the academy.

Though Yuni wasn't sure how long Rie had held off, it felt like an eternity to her.

Her sister was in danger, and she could do nothing about it.

She could only watch, feeling utterly powerless.

The man closed the gap.

As he neared Rie, she tried to use magic while dragging her injured leg, but it didn't affect him in the slightest.

He just kept advancing.

And when he was almost upon Rie,

“No.”

Yuni moved.

She had to protect her sister.

“Wind, Wind Blaster...!”

Emerging from the bushes, Yuni cast her spell.

A powerful blade of wind hurtled towards the man, whose name she now remembered as Venderwood.

But just as Rie's magic had no effect on him, neither did Yuni's.

Even a surprise attack couldn't penetrate the reinforced body of such a skilled swordsman.

Venderwood, unfazed by Yuni's magic, turned his head to look at her.

“Yu...Yuni...!”

Rie's voice rang out in alarm.

Yuni, her legs shaking as if she was a newborn deer, reached out towards Venderwood, her eyes fixed on Rie.

She opened her mouth.

“Sis...”

Fear was evident in Yuni's voice.

Yet, she managed a faint smile and said,

“Run...”

In an instant, Venderwood was upon Yuni.

She couldn't even react.

And then.

“Ah.”

Venderwood's hand, surrounded by a mana glow, pierced right through Yuni's abdomen.

His mana-infused hand was more than enough to pierce the delicate frame of Yuni.

Holding Yuni with her abdomen impaled, Venderwood looked into her face.

“Just a kid.”

“Guh...”

Yuni let out a rough breath, tears that had been pooling in her eyes now flowing freely.

“Yu...ni?”

Rie watched in horror, her eyes widening.

Tears filled Rie's eyes.

Though Yuni sometimes acted peculiarly, she was still her sister.

They had grown up together; she had always looked after Yuni, finding her annoying at times but never disliking her.

Now, that very sister had been impaled by a man's hand.

“Ah... No... No...”

Rie sobbed, tears streaming down her face.

“No... Please...”

Struggling, Rie tried to get up and shouted.

At that, Venderwood withdrew his hand from Yuni's abdomen.

Yuni crumpled to the ground.

“You’re next.”

With an air of indifference, Venderwood, with his sword in hand, moved towards Rie.

“Heuu...”

Rie let out a mournful sound, her eyes widened in alarm as she glared at Venderwood.

She attempted to use her mana.

“Ah.”

But, her mana was almost depleted.

No magic emerged.

Seeing this, Venderwood quickly charged at her.

"This is the end."

“My, feet...”

Closing her eyes tight, Rie braced herself.

Suddenly, an unexpected sound echoed.

“What...? Who are...”

“Spatial Slash.”

The voice was familiar.

A slicing noise.

“Kuk...! What is this...”

Startled by Venderwood's sudden scream, Rie cautiously opened her eyes.

But Venderwood was nowhere in sight.

Instead, someone's back was in her view, standing protectively before her.

“Huh?”

Recognizable golden hair.

But this wasn't the blond-haired person Rie knew.

This person was slightly shorter.

And he hadn't used such magic before.

Rie, having observed him frequently, knew this well.

The person shielding Rie then turned his head.

“Ah.”

A face she recognized.

But, something was slightly off.

“Rudy?”

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 139: Saint Haruna (7)

Academy Main Building, Student Council Room.

"Then, let's begin."

Haruna, in front of me, closed her eyes and raised her hand above my head.

In her other hand, she tightly gripped a rosary, assuming a prayer-like posture.

"Once I activate the magic, your body will transform into another. You will remain in this transformed state for only two hours, during which you must resolve everything."

Light began to emanate from Haruna's rosary.

"But just because my body changes doesn't mean I can use its abilities, right?"

Surely, if my body changed, aspects like my mana might increase, but the real issue was knowledge.

To use magic, you need to understand its theory and also develop a certain intuitive feel for it.

Haruna shook her head in response.

"It's not just a body switch. Essentially, your consciousness will enter that person, so you'll be able to access all the knowledge that the future you possesses."

Being able to access knowledge...?

"Does accessing the knowledge mean I can see how I grow in the future?"

"Yes. You will know everything from the path that person has walked, to what abilities they can use, and even how to use those abilities."

The future me.

The me from the strongest timeline.

It's practically an answer key.

A guide indicating where I should head.

Is this what Haruna meant by doing this for the future?

"Then, I'm ready."

As I agreed, intense light spilled from the rosary.

I closed my eyes and surrendered to the light.

Suddenly, my body felt like it was swept into some space.

My body jolted, feeling strange, and I opened my eyes.

Haruna was nowhere, and only darkness greeted me.

"Ugh.....! What....."

Then, suddenly, my body started to move rapidly.

My head is spinning.

Being swept somewhere.

Into the darkness.

I kept going into it, falling endlessly.

"What is this...!"

I tried to get a hold of myself, but the dizziness made it hard to grasp the situation.

As I was pulled further into the darkness, I saw a distant light.

My body started moving towards it.

I tightly shut my eyes against the overwhelming brightness.

I felt the light weakening and blinked my eyes open.

“Ah.....?”

Before my eyes, an unbelievable sight unfolded.

Collapsed buildings.

The surroundings looked like ruins.

Only the sight of a vast wasteland, consumed by flames, was visible.

I stood in the center of it all.

"Where is this....."

With a baffled expression, I surveyed the surroundings.

Something was odd.

Despite the devastation, the place felt familiar.

Weirdly... the surroundings felt familiar.

The mountain visible in the background...

The positions of the collapsed buildings.

And then.....

“Ah?”

The clothes I was wearing.

It was Liberion Academy's uniform.

There was only one place where I'd wear this uniform.

"Ah.....Academy?"

This was Liberion Academy.

And then.....

When I tried to look elsewhere, my body began to be swept away just like when I came here.

"What is this.....!!"

I tried to shout, but it felt as if something was choking me.

Then... I lost consciousness.

"Ugh..."

I slowly started to regain consciousness.

"Are you alright?"

I heard Haruna's voice beside me.

"Uh... I think I'm okay..."

I spoke to Haruna while slowly lifting my body.

"How do you feel? Does it seem like you came back normally?"

"Normally.....?"

How would I know if the one who used the magic doesn't know?

I looked at Haruna, wondering what she meant.

Seeing Haruna's face, I felt something was off.

Even though she had her eyes open, her focus was not right.

Empty pupils.

Despite me standing in front of her, it was as if she wasn't seeing me.

As if she couldn't see anything at all...

"Haruna, are you okay?"

"Yes, I'm fine. I just can't see in front of me, but everything else seems fine."

And that's okay?

"We need to treat you right now..."

"No."

Haruna spoke firmly.

"We have more pressing matters at hand."

"That's right. We don't have time to take it easy."

Then, a voice was heard from behind me.

A green-colored magic creature was sitting behind me.

"...Sylph?"

The intermediate wind elemental, Sylph, was sitting behind me.

"Rie and Yuni are in danger."

"Rie is...?"

Then, Haruna, who was next to me, also spoke.

"Just now, there was a large explosion sound in front of the building."

Sylph continued.

"Since Rie is there, something has happened."

Hearing that, my eyes widened.

"I'll go check it out. Haruna, you stay here. I'll be back soon."

Then, Haruna smiled.

"Understood."

I got up and looked forward.

However, what abilities do I have...?

As I thought for a moment, a flood of knowledge started pouring in.

Like speed-reading through a book, countless pieces of information entered my brain.

"Huh?"

Then... I began to understand the world I had just seen.

This future me... had gone through the same developmental process as the current me.

"What is this..."

I opened my mouth in astonishment.

However, panicking wasn't an option.

I closed my mouth and clenched my teeth tightly.

The present is more important than the possible future.

I shook my head and used magic.

"Teleport."

Space magic.

A magic only the Astria family can learn.

The future me was able to use this magic.

The scene before me changed.

In front of me, there was a man holding a large sword, and further away, Yuni was seen bleeding.

"Ah."

Seeing that, I let out a sigh.

Turning my head for a moment, there was Rie, tightly closing her eyes and shedding tears.

The once strong and resilient Rie was now in tears.

I turned my head and reached out my hand.

"Who are you....."

I used magic before the other person could respond.

"Spatial Slash*."

Then, as if a sword was being swung, a line was drawn in space.

"Ah."

A line appeared on the arm of the other party.

The arm holding the sword was severed.

"Ugh.....!! Who are you? What is this....."

The opponent screamed in surprise as the arm holding the sword was cut off.

I looked at the person with a cold face.

The one who made Yuni like that and tried to kill Rie.

Looking at him, my anger surged.

My anger boiled as I looked at him, making my face even more impassive.

“Ah.”

Then, a voice came from behind.

It was Rie's voice.

I slightly turned my head and looked at Rie.

Rie was looking at me with a surprised face, tears streaming down her cheeks.

“Rudy?”

Seeing Rie like that, my expression softened a bit.

I gave a faint smile.

"I'll finish this quickly, Rie. Just wait a moment.”

I then moved my mana again.

"Ha.....!"

The man looked at me and let out a laugh.

Despite his arm being cut off, it was unbelievable.

“Will cutting off your head stop that laughter?”

"You can't kill me."

Then, something strange happened to his arm.

The severed surface swelled up, and the swollen part took shape, recreating the form of an arm.

Does he regenerate even after death?

Seeing that, I thought I understood what he meant.

"Hmm, is that so?"

I lifted the corner of my mouth.

"Then I won't kill you."

I stretched out my hand.

"Spatial Rift."

Crack.

I aimed a rift at his core.

A direct impact on the very fabric of space.

His body seemed to fracture, much like cracks in a windowpane.

However, he had already seen the technique.

He didn't just stand there and take it.

"Ugh....."

He moved his body quickly and escaped from the rift.

As he escaped from the rift, he rushed toward me.

I grabbed Rie's hand behind me.

"Huh?"

"Teleport."

In an instant, Rie and I moved.

The opponent, running toward me with his sword, opened his eyes wide as our figures suddenly disappeared.

"What the....."

I had teleported near Yuni.

Rie, suddenly relocated, was very surprised.

Also, seeing Yuni collapsed below, she screamed loudly.

"Yuni.....!"

Rie immediately bent down and grabbed Yuni.

"She's still breathing!"

Rie said to me as she looked up.

I held Rie's shoulder, reassuringly, and quietly opened my mouth.

"I'll finish this and be right back."

I stood up again and looked at my opponent.

I walked towards him.

"Huh!"

He gripped his greatsword, dark energy swirling around it, and approached me quickly.

It was undoubtedly threatening.

If it could emit sword aura to that extent, the original me would have never won.

Given his enhanced physique and regenerative ability, there was no way my past self could've defeated him.

But now, it's different.

From what I knew, a space magic user was a swordsman's worst nightmare.

When you slice through space, you can cut through even the most solid objects.

A swordsman's physical enhancement ability would be practically useless.

If I use the other abilities I have on top of that.....

The opponent swiftly approached and opened his mouth.

"One Slash."

He lifted his sword and slashed it down from above.

"Dark Flame."

A massive sword strike flew towards me.

A tremendous sized sword strike.

It was something I can dodge, but Rie and Yuni were behind me.

"Priscilla."

As I spoke, a large wolf appeared behind me.

A wolf with a mix of blue and silver fur.

It was the Ice Elemental, Priscilla.

"Freeze it."

"Grrrrr....."

As I spoke, Priscilla stretched her leg forward.

As Priscilla took a step forward, the dark sword energy gradually slowed down and began to freeze.

From the ground up, all of the sword energy began to freeze.

It was Priscilla's ability to freeze even mana.

"Hah.....!"

The opponent, seeing this, looked at me as if in disbelief.

"Shall we finish this then?"

I looked at the frozen sword aura and slightly raised the corners of my mouth.

Then, Priscilla spoke from behind me.

"What's gotten into you?"

Priscilla spoke to me as if she didn't understand.

"Oh, Priscilla. We'll talk later..."

"Why did you summon me?"

"Huh?"

I opened my eyes wide.

Priscilla seemed different.

The Priscilla of the future...

"I'm sorry, Priscilla. It seems like now is not the time for conversation."

I smiled awkwardly and spoke to Priscilla.

"Can you freeze that guy for now?"

"...Fine."

Priscilla glanced at me with a slight glare and nodded.

The opponent attempted to swing his sword again.

But before that, Priscilla's mana moved, and his legs slowly began to freeze.

"Kuh....."

He looked at his freezing legs and scowled.

In a bold move, he cut off his own legs with his greatsword.

Blood splattered, and he collapsed to the ground.

It was meaningless.

Without legs, he couldn't move.

Freezing him was an action meant to immobilize him, so it didn't matter.

"Spatial Rift."

"Ah."

The opponent opened his mouth when he heard my words.

A rift formed in the center of his collapsed body.

"I... will... not... die...!"

"Sure, you won't."

I clenched my fist tightly.

Then, bits of his flesh splattered around.

From his face to his body, he was fragmented into pieces.

The opponent couldn't even scream properly and turned into small flesh lumps.

A technique that inflicts a shock to the space itself, tearing everything in that place into pieces.

Its power was, needless to say, immense.

However, the opponent's body was extremely bizarre.

The fallen flesh slowly gathered.

Like a split slime rejoining, it wobbles and regenerates.

"I... will... not... die..."

He spoke again as he regenerated.

I could continue to inflict pain in this way, but that would be time-consuming.

I had limited time with this body.

However, that wasn't the real issue.

Yuni, lying down.

I have to treat Yuni quickly.

If it gets any later, it might become serious.

"Space Creation."

Then, a black circle was drawn, and a new space emerged.

"Swallow him."

I put mana into that space and sucked the opponent into it.

"Ah..."

The opponent's body began to be sucked into the space before it could regenerate again.

"Kuaaak... The master will...!"

The opponent tried to shout something, but he was sucked into the space.

"Whew..."

I exhaled deeply after watching that.

---Toggle New Ads

*I originally tl'd this as spatial slice, but I think spatial slash sounds better.

Chapter 140: Saint Haruna (8)

"Quickly, let's move! There are people over there who can use healing magic!"

"Yes! Understood!"

I used space magic to transport Rie and Yuni to a safe location.

It was a place where people were gathered.

It appeared to be a training ground where students were hiding.

Mcguire seemed to have gathered the students and evacuated them to that training ground.

"What on earth happened?"

Mcguire looked at me with a serious expression.

He's probably asking about why Yuni was in such a state.

"She was attacked by one of the rebels."

"What? And the opponent?"

"I took care of him."

Mcguire's eyes widened at my words.

"You defeated the rebel... yourself?"

His response seemed to question how I did it.

It was natural.

It seemed I had taken on someone at a high rank within the rebels.

"Speaking of which, you look... different."

"Oh."

Had my appearance changed too?

I hadn't looked in a mirror yet, so I haven't seen how I've changed.

The future me seems to have grown noticeably more than my present self.

Judging from my slightly elevated viewpoint, I seemed a bit taller...

I casually noted this, shrugging my shoulders.

"There was a bit of an incident."

Then, someone pulled at my sleeve from behind.

It was Rie.

Tear streaks were still vivid in Rie's eyes.

Rie, tightly gripping my sleeve, looked at Mcguire.

"Will Yuni... be okay?"

Upon hearing this, Mcguire gave a faint smile and nodded.

"There might be a scar on her stomach, but it's not life-threatening. Of course, she will have to stay in the hospital for a while though..."

"Haah..."

Rie, seeming to relax, sat down on the floor and exhaled a sigh of relief.

She scrunched her nose as if she was about to cry again.

I crouched down in front of Rie like that and smiled.

"Don't worry. It's okay now. Why are you about to cry again?"

I tapped Rie on the head as I said that.

"Huh..."

Upon my words, she glared at me.

"I'm...not going to cry."

Rie spoke with a slightly choked voice.

Even though they often seemed at odds, Rie truly cared for her sister.

"I'll be right back."

"What? Where to..."

I pointed my finger towards the tower.

The magic and sword auras that have been visible since earlier.

I had a rough idea who might be there.

The continuous lightning falling from the sky was likely Gracie, and the sword aura, Aryandor.

The stones and various items floating around were most likely Cromwell.

"I'll be back in a flash."

"Haa... Haa..."

Professor Cromwell, panted heavily.

Behind him was Professor Gracie.

"How can he have such a fraudulent power..."

Aryandor, unscathed compared to the injured Cromwell and Gracie, wore a mocking smile.

"Why not spare yourself this struggle and hand over Rudy Astria?"

Cromwell glared at Aryandor for making such a suggestion.

"We will never hand him over."

At the same time, Cromwell thought to himself.

'So this is what it meant to use time...'

He had heard a rough explanation from McDowell, but the method he used this time differed slightly from what McDowell had told him.

It felt like a more advanced application of the concept.

'But... at this rate, we won't win.'

He had to fight differently from how he usually fought.

To defeat that guy...

"Professor, what should we do?"

Gracie spoke from behind him at that moment.

Cromwell licked his lips slightly and opened his mouth.

"...For now, we can only continue to fight."

There must be a weak point.

"There is always a solution to magic used by humans."

Magic is a tool of mankind.

It's a technique that creates countless miracles, but because it's human-made, it has its flaws.

"Puhaha..."

Aryandor burst out laughing at those words.

"This is not the domain of humans."

Aryandor raised his hand to the sky and spoke.

"It's magic that approaches the realm of the gods. The power of time is the first ability created by them."

At that, Cromwell lifted the corner of his mouth.

"But the user is human, right?"

"Can a being that can use this power be called a human?"

Aryandor spoke as if to counter Cromwell's words.

Seeing Cromwell frown at those words, Aryandor snorted and moved his sword.

"Alright, then keep trying to block it."

Aryandor took a posture to swing his sword.

"See if I am human, or one who has approached the domain of the gods."

"Hoo..."

Cromwell also prepared his magic.

"Huh?"

A person's figure appeared in front of Cromwell.

A person standing with their back turned to him.

At the sudden appearance, Cromwell's brow furrowed.

It seemed like a stranger.

He knew most of the blondes in the academy, given how few there were.

However, none had such capabilities or height.

A rebel?

But looking at the clothes the person was wearing, confusion set in.

The uniform of the Liberion Academy.

The person was wearing a school uniform.

Then Aryandor opened his mouth, laughing.

"Oh, he came on his own. Rudy Astria."

Aryandor spoke with a laugh.

"Rudy Astria... is that so?"

Cromwell widened his eyes.

The energy he felt, even the boy's height, was different from Rudy Astria.

Then, the man in front turned around slightly and opened his mouth.

"Professor, are you okay?"

Seeing his face made it clear.

It was Rudy Astria, but the slightly naive demeanor was gone.

"What? How..."

Cromwell stared at Rudy with a bewildered face.

"Now doesn't seem like the time for explanations."

Rudy turned his head back to look at Aryandor.

Aryandor opened his mouth with a smile.

"Rudy Astria, nice to meet you. I am..."

That's when Rudy moved quickly.

No, rather than moving, he teleported using magic.

"Teleport."

"Huh?"

Aryandor, suddenly attacked by Rudy, opened his eyes wide.

In an instant, Rudy, who had reached in front of Aryandor, raised his fist.

"Ha!"

Then, he gathered mana in his hand, and struck down.

Kwa-aaaaang!!!

"Cough...!"

A punch far more powerful than any he'd thrown before.

Aryandor took the punch and was sent flying far away.

He crashed into the ground far away.

Just one hit.

It was just one punch.

Rudy, watching Aryandor crumpled on the ground from just one hit, furrowed his brow.

"...What?"

"Whew... whew..."

A woman was running hastily inside the academy.

A woman with brown hair.

She was running, clutching a magic book tightly to her chest.

Luna caught her breath, briefly glancing over her shoulder.

"I wonder if Professor is alright..."

She had fled because Professor Robert had told her to, but she couldn't help but worry.

"Sigh..."

Luna had not yet understood the situation.

She needed to find the others first to truly understand what was going on.

Regaining her breath to some degree, Luna tried to move her legs again.

"Hmm~."

At that moment, a humming sound came from somewhere.

"Huh?"

Luna quickly hid herself.

In a seemingly empty hallway, no student would be humming so carefree.

It had to be a rebel.

Luna held her breath and crouched down, her back against the wall.

"Well, this place is done~."

‘Huh?’

The voice sounded vaguely familiar.

Still leaning against the wall, Luna cautiously peeked toward the source of the voice.

A girl, wearing a witch’s hat, was fiddling with something.

It was Jefrin.

‘What... is she doing there?’

While everyone else is fighting fiercely, what is she doing all alone...?

Luna looked towards her with a puzzled expression.

After messing with something in the corner for a while, Jefrin got up from her spot.

“Shall we go somewhere else then~.”

Jefrin flung the broom she was holding.

The broom then floated in the air.

She mounted the broom.

“Where to next~ hmm~.”

Singing, Jefrin rode her broom and flew to another place.

"...What?"

Luna stared blankly at Jefrin then turned her gaze.

Where Jefrin had been, an object was left behind.

Luna got up and walked over to it.

A square box lay on the floor.

She felt mana emanating from it.

"A magical tool...?"

Luna furrowed her eyebrows and tapped the box lightly.

"Why leave this here?"

No matter how much she thought about it, it was suspicious.

A wizard busily installing something while everyone else was fighting.

It obviously looked like she was up to something.

Luna unfolded her magic book.

"Activate."

She spread a page of the magic book and infused it with mana.

A light emitted from the magic book and the light entered the magical tool Jefrin had set up.

Analytical magic.

A magic to understand what kind of structure the magical circles inside the magical tool formed.

"There are two magic circles?"

Luna slowly read the appearing magic circles.

"One is... explosion magic."

It was predicted to be a spell that would explode the surroundings if the box was opened.

Luna had roughly anticipated this, so she had deliberately not opened the box first.

"Then the other one is....."

Luna turned her head and looked at the magic circle next to her.

"Um....."

She frowned and tried hard to read the magic circle, but it was difficult to know the exact content.

It was a magic circle she was seeing for the first time.

"What is..... this....."

Luna fell into thought, touching her chin.

Soon, Luna shrugged her shoulders.

"Well, it's fine."

After that, Luna confidently lifted the box.

The usual way to deal with such a tool was simply to move it to another place.

A straightforward solution.

Yet, it was a reliable one.

Whoever created this device likely took into consideration the potential for incorrect installation, so merely moving it would not cause an explosion.

Given how Jefrin had been fiddling with the box earlier, shifting its position, Luna felt reasonably certain about this.

"I should ask the others about this."

After giving the box a final glance, Luna stowed it in her bag and set off towards where the others were.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 141: Saint Haruna (9)

"...What?"

I stared at the cloud of dust rising from the floor.

The fight started with a punch, but it left me somewhat bewildered that I was able to drive him into the ground in one move.

Then, a voice sounded from behind me.

"What's this?"

"Huh?"

The voice was neither Cromwell's nor Gracie's.

Aryandor.

It was decidedly Aryandor's voice, the one who had surely been slammed to the floor.

Aryandor was right behind me.

However, he did not attack.

"Huh!"

I swung my fist towards my immediate rear.

Aryandor lightly stepped back, avoiding my attack with ease.

"Surely, you look like Rudy Astria, but..."

Aryandor spoke, rubbing his chin thoughtfully.

I squinted, looking at him intently.

What just happened?

I was sure I saw him hit the floor...

"Rudy Astria, it's time magic!"

Cromwell, who was a distance away, spoke as he cast a spell.

Cromwell's gravity magic targeted Aryandor, but Aryandor dodged the attack with ease.

After effortlessly evading Cromwell's attack, Aryandor continued to gaze at me.

"Who are you?"

"What?"

"You're not the Rudy Astria I know."

I frowned at Aryandor's words.

"Do you know me?"

This was certainly a guy I had never met face to face.

Yet, his words were inexplicably incongruent.

"What are you to say whether I am right or wrong?"

I spoke, manipulating my mana.

Aryandor locked eyes with me.

"I might know more about you than you think. However..."

Aryandor tilted his head slightly.

The slight tilt of his expressionless head gave off a slightly eerie vibe.

It felt like he was peering through me.

"The current you is completely different. Not the Rudy Astria I've seen."

It didn't seem like he was referring to my current form being from the future.

It felt like he was indicating that I was possessed.

He didn't seem to have precisely figured out the fact of 'possession', but it appeared he had somewhat caught on.

At least when he harbored such doubts, I had to inflict some damage, somehow.

"Spatial Slash."

I cast the spell at a rapid pace.

Upon my casting, Aryandor's eyes widened.

A large slice appeared in the space where Aryandor was.

Seeing this, Aryandor bent his body significantly.

Even if a slice was made, it took time for the space to be severed.

Of course, that time wasn't long, but Aryandor was able to avoid the slash by moving in that brief moment.

"Space... magic?"

He seemed to have just caught on now, even though I had used space magic just a moment ago.

Aryandor looked at me, seemingly bewildered.

"Who are you?"

I kindly responded to Aryandor's question.

"I'm Rudy Astria."

Upon hearing my response, Aryandor furrowed his brow.

"This is absurd."

Aryandor seemed puzzled, and I too found the situation strange.

What exactly does this guy know?

When thinking about it, since it involves time magic, he should be able to know about the past and future.

However, seeing Aryandor's reaction, I couldn't help but feel perplexed.

He doesn't know me.

It seemed like he knew Rudy Astria before my soul took over the body.

But what was it about Rudy Astria before I took over that led him to come here for me like this?

The Rudy Astria I knew wasn't a talent that the rebels would covet.

Certainly not worth mobilizing the rebels' forces to come and fight like this.

Yet, him being here meant that he saw something.

What did he see that prompted this action?

While I was thinking, a voice rang out from afar.

"Indeed, everyone is gathered here."

A man with a patchy beard, Robert, stood there.

He was riding on the back of Behemoth, approaching us.

Robert scanned us quickly and then focused his gaze on Cromwell.

"Cromwell, you still haven't beaten him? He looks like a greenhorn."

Irritated by Robert's teasing, Cromwell gritted his teeth and spoke.

"...You try fighting him. He's a headache."

"I've already caught one."

Robert pulled up a man by the scruff of his neck.

"Hey, is this one your comrades?"

A man with severe dark circles under his eyes.

He was the one who had ridden the Bone Dragon last time.

He seemed to be unconscious or at least unable to gather his wits.

"How can you treat a necromancer like this?"

Robert looked at Aryandor with disdain as he spoke.

"The power of the rebel guys lately is no joke~ That's what I heard. It was slightly interesting, but was it all just a rumor? They said they were fighting for some great cause, but....."

At those words, Aryandor shot him a fierce look.

"Do you want your tongue cut off?"

"Oh~ scary~."

Robert mocked Aryandor with his words.

While laughing mockingly, Robert suddenly shifted the atmosphere as he began to speak.

"What kind of cause is it when you can't even look after one person by your side. It's almost sad for those around you."

I looked at Robert and scanned the surroundings.

The situation was hugely in our favor.

He was alone and we were numerous.

Moreover, I was in a state where I could use space magic.

It was a situation that he could never win.

From his perspective, it should be a hopeless situation.

Aryandor, glaring at Robert, shifted his gaze back towards me.

"Hmm, this is as far as I should go."

Aryandor smiled at me.

"It was a pleasure meeting you, Rudy Astria. Some unexpected events unfolded, which were somewhat startling, but it was fun in its own way."

Aryandor spoke to me as if bidding farewell.

I immediately opened my mouth upon hearing those words.

"Professor."

"I know."

Cromwell, Gracie, Robert, and I began to manipulate our mana.

It seemed like our opponent was trying to flee.

We must stop him.

It's a prime opportunity to capture the leader of the Rebels.

"Priscilla."

I rapidly summoned Priscilla.

I judged that Priscilla would be more effective at halting the opponent's movements than space magic.

I'm unsure how to utilize time magic, but if it's Priscilla, who can even freeze mana...

Not only that, but the other professors also used their magic.

Clearly, our magic was trying to envelope Aryandor, but he did not move.

He just smiled and slightly raised his hand.

With his hand raised, Aryandor snapped his fingers.

Click!

"Time Back."

A bright light flared, enveloping Aryandor.

Time Back.

It was a spell that rewinds time.

Although he had continually used this magic while fighting with McDowell and Cromwell, he used it this time on a different scale.

He had arranged for Jefrin to set up magical devices in advance to prepare for the spell.

From the very beginning, Aryandor had no intention of fighting seriously.

He merely intended to retrieve Rudy Astria and retreat.

Aryandor slowly opened his eyes.

Before him stood the Bone Dragon.

Next to it, in order, were Jefrin, Daemon, and Venderwood.

It was before they departed.

However, it was a dark night.

While the moment had been reset, absolute time had progressed.

Aryandor opened his mouth, observing the scene.

"We're not going to the Academy."

"Huh?"

Upon hearing this, Jefrin's eyes widened.

"Bu, but surely... just a moment ago... we were at the Academy..."

"...What?"

Aryandor, who was about to enter a building behind him, turned his head at Jefrin's words.

Aryandor looked at Jefrin, then glanced at Daemon and Venderwood next to him.

The two also seemed to share Jefrin's surprise, their faces showing astonishment.

Even though time was rewound, they all retained their memories.

Something that should not have happened.

Aryandor turned his head again, gazing at Jefrin.

“Jefrin, how were the magical devices set up?”

"What? I did as you instructed, exactly..."

Aryandor frowned.

Although time seemed to have been rewound correctly, the fact that their memories remained intact meant something went wrong with the devices.

Time magic was a magic fraught with loopholes.

Even now, time hasn't reverted correctly.

While the time they originally departed was during sunset, it was now deep into the night.

In reality, the duration they spent there had already passed.

Everyone outside the Academy experienced time as usual.

However, for those inside the Academy, only their timeline had been altered.

To be precise, the events during that span seemed to have been erased.

But for some reason, the magical device had not activated properly.

While things like their physical locations were reset, their memories remained intact.

This meant...

The people of the Academy would remember this.

Including his abilities and the abilities of the people in front of him.

Of course, he had not revealed all of his abilities, but still, he had displayed most of them.

“Sigh.....”

Aryandor clasped his head and let out a sigh.

Then Jefrin, unable to stand still, looked at Aryandor anxiously.

"I-I'm so sorry! It must've been a mistake on my part... My apologies..."

“No. It’s okay.”

Aryandor sighed and spoke to Jefrin.

"It's my fault for not accounting for the variables."

Aryandor said that and then looked at the others.

"Take a good rest. I'm heading in as well."

With those words, Aryandor walked into the building.

Aryandor went into his room and clutched his head.

His initial plan was to manipulate Rudy Astria, retain only their shared memories, and reverse time.

After that, he intended to utilize Rudy Astria at the academy.

But not only was the Rudy Astria at the academy a different person than he remembered, but the magic also didn't execute properly.

If only the time-reversal spell worked correctly, he wouldn't have been this frustrated.

Knock, knock, knock...

Then, there was a knock on Aryandor’s door.

"Come in."

Then, Jefrin slowly entered his room.

"I... I apologize."

Aryandor shook his head.

"No, it was my mistake. Don't worry, go and rest."

Jefrin, having faced continuous failures since the North, felt shameful in Aryandor's presence.

However, Jefrin had something to bring up.

"I... but..."

"Hmm?"

"As I was going around installing the magic tool... I saw a boy."

"A boy?"

At Jefrin's words, Aryandor furrowed his brow.

"Yes, a boy... seemingly overwhelmed by feelings of inferiority and defeat."

Jefrin, a wizard who uses hallucination-type magic, was extremely sensitive to people's emotions.

"But, as far as I know, that boy surely isn't one who would be like that..."

"What?"

"The boy who you said was the most dangerous... that boy was like that."

"...Evan?"

Aryandor's eyes widened.

"Yes, that was his name."

Aryandor stared at Jefrin for a moment and then slowly smiled.

"Care to elaborate?"

In a headache-inducing situation, Aryandor felt as if he'd found a glimmer of hope.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 142: Saint Haruna (10)

"What just happened....."

Evan looked around, puzzled.

He was sure that he had been in front of the training ground where people had gathered.

However, the place he was now in was his dormitory room.

He had definitely been talking to a young girl.

"You, you have very nice eyes, don't you?"

The words she said to him with a smile.

"I know your feelings very well."

"No matter how hard you try, no matter how you struggle, it seems like the gap only widens, and you feel increasingly powerless watching yourself."

"I know it very well..."

At the girl's words, Evan drew his sword.

"There's no need to be so defensive."

"My name is Jefrin."

"I can help you."

After those words, a bright light suddenly enveloped him, and it brought him to this moment.

"Jefrin....."

It was a name he'd heard somewhere before.

"Haa....."

Evan sighed while sitting on the bed.

He watched closely.

The sight of Rudy, standing proudly with the professors.

While all the students were evacuating, Rudy boldly confronted the enemy with the professors.

Something he himself could not do.

Rudy was bravely doing all of those things.

Perhaps it was natural to feel powerless.

In fact, he thought it might be arrogant to consider himself a rival to Rudy Astria.

"Was it a dream?"

However, it was too vivid to be a dream.

Too vivid.....

So..... was it reality?

"No..... I....."

It was Evan, who confidently held the top position at Liberion.

There wasn't a significant difference between him and Rudy Astria in the last exam.

He still had the upper hand.

At least for now...

1st floor of the academy main building, in front of the entrance.

"Huh?"

Rie opened her eyes with a confused face.

Where she was supposed to be was.....

Rie looked beside her.

"Hmm?"

Next to her, Yuni was making a puzzled face.

"What's going on?"

Yuni tilted her head, looking at her body up and down.

Despite having certainly been pierced through the abdomen, Yuni's body was now perfectly fine.

"Y-Yuni?"

".....Hmm? Sis?"

Yuni, who had been staring intently at her stomach, lifted her head to look at Rie.

"What's this? Where are we? Did I have a dream?"

Yuni said, tilting her head.

The Yuni who had been trembling in fear just moments before was gone, and only the usual Yuni was there.

Rie narrowed her brows and said,

"Yuni, is your stomach okay?"

"Huh?"

At Rie's words, Yuni touched where she had been pierced through before.

"What? Isn't this a dream?"

When Rie mentioned her stomach, it felt like being pierced through had really happened.

However, with her stomach being fine, she could only be puzzled.

As she pondered, Yuni clapped her hands and spoke.

"Is this, like, the afterlife or something?"

Yuni, who had been tilting her head in thought, narrowed her eyes and glared at Rie.

"If this is the afterlife, did you die too, sis?"

"What?"

Confused, Rie made a baffled expression at Yuni's words.

However, Yuni, unbothered by it, heaved a sigh.

"I told you to leave me and run away, didn't I?! You struggled again because of your weird obstinacy! Really....."

"Huh?"

"Really, since a while back! When there's an easy way, just take it! Why do you always choose the hard way! That's why this happened!"

Yuni spoke to Rie as if scolding her.

"I'm relieved."

Hearing those words, Rie, smiling a weary smile, tightly hugged Yuni, who was in front of her.

Yuni, suddenly being hugged by Rie, opened her eyes wide.

"What, what is it!"

Yuni struggled in Rie's embrace with a surprised face.

"Just stay still."

Rie held Yuni tightly, preventing her from moving.

After struggling for a moment, Yuni smiled at Rie's words and buried her face in Rie's chest.

"It feels like it's been a while since I've hugged sis..... it's nice to hug sis since we died~."

Yuni spoke to Rie, who had suddenly hugged her, in a teasing manner.

As she spoke, Yuni felt something strange.

The clothes of Rie, who was holding her.

They were definitely the uniform of Liberion Academy.

".....But, do you normally wear the same clothes when you die?"

Something was strange.

Yuni slightly moved away from Rie's embrace and looked around.

"The place too... seems familiar?"

Anyone who looked at the surroundings would recognize it as Liberion Academy.

“Huh?”

Rie, having somewhat regained her senses, also looked around.

"Why am I here?"

"What is this!!"

Then, a noisy sound came from the surroundings.

Students, looking around with surprised voices.

Their reactions were similar to theirs.

Then a voice echoed through the academy.

[Students, this is Professor Mcguire. The situation you just saw was real, and we are currently assessing it. We will inform you immediately once we understand what has happened. That is all.]

Professor Mcguire's magic echoed the sound around them.

"What is it?"

Rie frowned as she spoke.

At that moment, the sound of hurried footsteps rushing into the academy's main building could be heard.

It was Professor Gracie.

“Uh, Professor?”

Professor Gracie turned her head for a moment at Yuni's voice.

"Oh, oh! Yuni! Sorry, I'm in a hurry right now!"

Yuni grabbed the back of Gracie, who was about to run away in a hurry.

Gracie, whose clothes were being held, opened her eyes wide.

"Huh, Yuni? I'm busy right now!"

Gracie, whose clothes were grabbed by Yuni, flusteredly spoke.

Holding the back of the professor's clothes tightly might be considered impolite, but Gracie made a face as if she wanted to be sent quickly, not caring about such matters.

"Yuni, I'm really..."

"Yuni."

Rie pulled Yuni away from Professor Gracie.

Yuni, grabbed by the neck by Rie, tilted her head while looking at her sister.

"Sister?"

"Thank you, Rie! Then I'll!"

This time, when Professor Gracie tried to go, Rie held onto her.

"Gah!"

Startled, Professor Gracie looked at Rie with surprise as she was grabbed again.

"I didn't say you could go, did I?"

Rie spoke to Professor Gracie with a sly smile.

After all, Gracie was the most manageable professor compared to the others.

So, she couldn't just let her go.

She needed to understand the situation, after all.

Gracie mumbled quietly, making a sullen face.

"Why are you doing this to me....."

Rie asked with a smile.

"What happened? Why are we like this?"

Professor Gracie hesitated for a moment, then quietly opened her mouth.

"Well, it's complicated to explain....."

Rie slightly tilted her head.

Professor Gracie, thinking she would find out anyway, opened her mouth.

"I'm not sure if you'll believe me, but it seems like time has reverted. For now, I think we need to discuss the exact details among the professors... Can you let go of this?"

Gracie spoke to Rie as if coaxing a child.

Rie nodded as if she understood and let go of the clothes.

"Thank you."

"Yes, yes! See you later!"

Gracie started to run again.

"Time?"

Rie murmured to herself, furrowing her brow slightly.

Come to think of it, right now was before she went to have tea with Yuni.

The students around them too.....

Rie took Yuni's hand.

"Yuni, will you follow me for a moment?"

"Yep!"

Yuni smiled cheerfully and spoke when Rie took her hand.

So, the two hand-in-hand arrived at the student council room.

"Rudy, are you there?"

Surely, if it was the situation when they were going for tea, Rudy should have been in the student council room.

Rudy went to meet the leader of the rebels after being with her.

She thought he might know something.

However, someone else was in the student council room.

"Hm? Who is it?"

"Huh?"

A girl wearing a nun's outfit.

"The Saint?"

But something was off.

Her eyes were vacant.

As if they were empty.

"Ah, is it you, Rie?"

But that cheeky way of speaking.

It was undoubtedly the Saint, Haruna.

"Why are you here?"

Rie spoke, her eyes wide.

After a moment of contemplation, Haruna tilted her head and opened her mouth.

"Hmm... There must be a reason, right?"

"....."

She sighed at the Saint, who made an incomprehensible statement.

This was how she had been speaking last time too.

Thus, she thought there was no point in continuing the conversation.

"By the way, wasn't Rudy here?"

"Ah, may I ask a question first?"

Rie slightly furrowed her brow at Haruna's continual deflections, a vein almost popping on her forehead, but she managed to keep her composure.

".....What is it."

"Could it be, has time reversed?"

"What?"

Caught off guard by Haruna's sudden statement, Rie's eyes widened.

For now, she didn't understand Haruna's intentions.

So she thought it was right to conceal it.

"No, I....."

“Yes, that’s right.”

When Rie hesitated, Yuni spoke up.

“Yu, Yuni?”

“What’s the use of hiding it? This isn’t important, right? So, where did Rudy go?”

Haruna smiled.

“If time has reversed..... he might be in a different place. Don’t worry, he’ll be here soon.”

“.....A different place? Did he go to see the professors?”

Rie spoke, frowning at the incomprehensible statement.

However, Haruna simply smiled kindly and shook her head.

“No, a different place.”

Haruna gently touched her rosary.

“He went to witness how the best decisions can sometimes yield the worst outcomes.”

“...What?”

I opened my eyes.

I remembered a blinding light enveloping me.

Along with the words 'Time Back.'

Thinking about the term 'Time Back,' it seemed like magic that reversed time.

So, he would have used it to avoid my attack and that of the professors.

“But.....”

I looked around.

“Where is this?”

A ruined academy stretched before me.

What I saw before I obtained my future body.....

The world where I possess the strongest power.

A world where everyone is dead.

That world was right before my eyes.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 143: Saint Haruna (11)

The scent of char filled the air.

As I stepped on the crumbled debris on the ground, a strange feeling arose within me.

"Why am I here?"

I scowled, glancing around.

This place is the future.

Memories of the actions of my future self surface in my mind.

Everyone in this world is dead.

From those I was close to like Luna, Rie, and Astina, to Professors Robert, Cromwell, and Gracie.

Everyone in the academy is dead.

However, those outside the academy survived.

We won the battle.

But, can this truly be called victory?

Tap... Tap...

I gaze up at the sky.

"It's raining."

Raindrops fall, touching my head.

With the rain, amidst the ruined buildings, I stand alone at the center.

It was a pitiful sight.

I can't imagine what it would feel like for my future self.

If after defeating the enemy, all that remains are ruins...

If everyone is dead and you are left alone,

Even without experiencing it, my heart aches just thinking about it.

“Why... did it end up like this?”

It's confusing.

The scenes play in my head, but what I was thinking while fighting doesn't come to mind.

Just vague emotion surfaces.

Hatred.

A hot fury surges in my chest.

A colossal rage towards Aryandor, the leader of the Rebels, filled my heart.

Of course, this emotion is merely felt indirectly.

It's like reading a book.

It doesn't strongly resonate with me.

I know Aryandor must be eliminated, but when asked if he's the object of hatred, I can only tilt my head.

However, as I process information about my future self, hatred gradually emerges.

How did this happen?

Where did it start to go wrong?

All the situations draw themselves in my head.

“Astina...?”

Astina's death.

She died a year before this fight, this final battle, by Aryandor's hand.

That's what the memories inside me showed.

My future self walked a path almost identical to mine.

From the time I possessed this body to now, the path is nearly identical.

But, after Astina's death, my future self became completely different from my current self.

During my second year winter break, Astina was killed by Aryandor.

That's the timeline of this world.

After Astina died, my future self resolved,

I must become stronger.

I must become stronger to protect everyone.

Although it might seem like a similar thought to my current self, it was a vow of a slightly different shape.

In the future, I began to grow stronger by any means necessary.

After Astina's death, the future me directly went to the Astria family.

And I pushed Ian out.

I ousted Ian without hesitation, took over the family, and not only that, I began to seize all the powers around me.

In this process, the people around me were neglected.

I moved forward no matter what others did.

I thought it would be fine as long as I protected everyone.

However, the result of doing so turned out like this.

While I was dealing with other people... while defeating other enemies... everyone died.

The people at the academy couldn't hold out.

It was an absurd result.

No matter how strong I became, there was nothing I could do when multiple enemies appeared in different places.

And after everything ended.

The future me decided.

To go back.

To forget all this and return to my original life, where I should be.

".....I'm going back."

As I mumbled to myself, a voice came.

"You're going back in the end, huh."

"Ah..... Priscilla?"

A silver wolf revealed itself behind me.

It was Priscilla.

"It's been a long time since we've had a conversation like this."

Priscilla spoke to me in a somewhat bitter tone.

Now, I knew why Priscilla reacted that way.

The abilities I had when Astina died were not much different from now.

Of course, they were a little more developed, but the range of the abilities were the same.

When Astina was in danger, I entrusted Astina to Priscilla and went to fight Aryandor.

Of course, the result was defeat.

There was no way I could beat Aryandor.

The result not only gave me a sense of defeat.

The defeat took Astina away from me.

Seeing Astina's death like that, I couldn't stand still.

I felt a feeling of revulsion towards myself who had barely survived.

My mind was nowhere near sane.

Eventually, all arrows of resentment pointed at Priscilla, and it seemed like Priscilla and I became estranged.

Priscilla stared at me intently and quietly opened her mouth.

"What on earth happened earlier?"

The fight with Aryandor.

Priscilla couldn't understand what happened.

But I also questioned the surprisingly calm demeanor of Priscilla.

In the memories of my future self...

It felt like I said something I shouldn't have.

Priscilla appeared nonchalant, gazing at me without concern.

Well, it was easier for me if Priscilla came out with this attitude.

It was much better than awkwardness.

"Hmm..."

I gazed intently at Priscilla, pondering.

Where should I begin explaining...

As I was thinking, Priscilla spoke first.

"It's fine. It's not the first time I've failed to understand your actions."

With that, Priscilla looked straight at me.

"You look better than I thought, though. Have you come to some realization... or... Sigh... Whatever. If you're going to go back, go back quickly."

I tilted my head slightly at Priscilla's words.

"Go back where?"

“Didn’t you say you would go back once everything is done? To the world you were living in.”

“...What?”

What did the me in this world... do, exactly?

To be honest, even though various memories existed in my head, it felt as if they were pages in a book, so I couldn't know everything.

I could only read down through the parts I wanted.

I pondered over the phrase ‘going back.’

Then, a particular magic came to mind.

A space magic that the future me could use.

This wasn't just a simple teleportation spell.

That's what my future knowledge told me.

“Could it be...”

I began to channel mana.

Brushing my damp hair, soaked from the rain, aside, I reached my hand forward.

“Portal... create...”

Then, a small vortex began to form in front of me.

The black swirl gradually widened, and a small gap began to emerge.

The dark space, dim from the rain, began to brighten with the light emanating from the small gap.

“Ah...”

Beyond the portal, a familiar scenery peeked through.

Tall, modern buildings.

A clear sky.

Numerous cars moving along the roads.

...It was Earth.

"...I can actually go back?"

I stared at the landscape in disbelief.

Priscilla, watching me, spoke.

"Yeah, so go on. I pray you never experience such events again."

"Priscilla?"

I turned my head and looked at Priscilla.

Priscilla bowed her head to me.

"On behalf of the world, I thank you. You were a hero."

I blankly stared at her solemn farewell.

Clearly, the future me had saved the world.

But I hadn't saved the people of the academy.

How would I have felt receiving this gratitude here, in the future?

With my friends and teachers dead, and nothing left, I return to Earth after a farewell from the one I fought with.

I hear the words that I am a hero.

How would it feel?

I felt like being in this place might not be a good thing for my future self.

I couldn't say anything as I looked at Priscilla, who was still bowing her head.

"Priscilla....."

Still, I thought that the remaining person needed as much consideration as possible.

"You really worked hard too. I'm going to leave now, so take care."

Saying so, I headed towards the portal.

As I stepped towards the portal, a bright light enveloped me.

"Huh?"

"Rudy.....?"

Upon opening my eyes, Rie, Yuni, and the saint, Haruna, were in front of me.

The student council room of the Academy.

It seemed like I had returned to reality.

"Ugh....."

Suddenly, dizziness struck me, and I vomited.

"Rudy!"

Rie rushed toward me with a startled expression.

Then, Haruna laughed.

Rie, supporting me, looked at Haruna.

"Hey! What's happening...!"

"You may feel dizzy for a moment. It will pass soon, so don't worry."

Haruna cut off Rie's words, as if she knew she would say that.

I regained some of my senses and lifted my head.

And, surveying the surroundings, I spoke.

".....What happened?"

"Uh..... I want to ask that."

Rie, while supporting me, who was about to collapse, seated me in a chair.

Seated, I looked at everyone.

"Yuni.....? Are you..... okay?"

Yuni, who was surely injured before, was perfectly fine in front of me.

Yuni, folding her arms and looking at me indifferently, said,

".....You seem to be in a worse condition than me."

That was true.

I felt nauseous and dizzy, and my mind wasn't fully clear.

Still, I could manage a conversation.

"Time has gone back."

Haruna uttered abruptly.

It was brief, but no further explanation was needed.

"Ti.....me."

It was roughly as I expected.

I had had a rough idea since Aryandor mentioned Time Back.

I nodded and threw out a question.

"So, why did I go there?"

"Aryandor only turned back time, and you went back to the future because you were inside your future self."

"So your eyes. Time has gone back, so why are your eyes in that condition."

"I didn't merely lose my sight. I violated a taboo, and so I received that punishment."

".....Wait a minute."

Rie interrupted my conversation with Haruna.

".....I can't follow the conversation, what's going on?"

Rie spoke, placing a hand on her temple as if asking what on earth we were talking about.

Also, Yuni next to us looked at Rie with a bright smile.

"Oh, me too. I thought I was the only one who didn't know, but it seems not."

"No, that..... sigh....."

Rie glared at me.

I awkwardly smiled back at her gaze.

"Why....."

"You, I ask only one question."

Rie, placed her hand on the desk and leaned close, opening her mouth.

"You had time to explain to me, and you didn't, or you couldn't."

"I couldn't... I just heard about this situation too..."

Rie stared at me intently.

I gave her the most pitiful, unjustly accused expression I could muster.

".....Really?"

"Really."

Rie stared at me hard and then sighed.

"Ha... okay, I got it. Then explain everything when this is over."

"Of course."

I smiled at Rie and turned my gaze back to Haruna.

There was something I was most curious about.

"How much have you interfered in my life?"

Haruna knows everything.

From the fact that I am a possessor, to the events of the future.

She was the one who knew all of it.

So, has that person been playing with the world and me from the start to the end?

Then Haruna quietly opened her mouth.

"I've done exactly two things."

Haruna smiled as she spoke.

"One was telling Astina about your future, and the other is what I just did. It applies to the present, the future, and any time."

Haruna spat out meaningful words and laughed.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 144: The Eve of the Storm...! (1)

"It's a nice day."

"Indeed, the weather is lovely."

I shaded my eyes with my hand and looked up at the sky.

Next to me, Priscilla clung closely like a puppy.

I gently stroked Priscilla's head as she sat beside me.

"You've been so busy that you couldn't summon me, what's the occasion?"

"No matter how busy, one must take breaks now and then."

The reason for such leisure was because Homecoming Day had been canceled.

The preparations for Homecoming Day were already complete, and essentially, since time had been reversed, there were no issues at the academy, but Vice Principal Cromwell boldly canceled it.

Homecoming Day was a venue for bonding between juniors and seniors.

Also, it was an event where graduates returned to the academy to see the faces of their professors.

However, after experiencing an attack from the rebels, neither students nor professors could possibly enjoy such an event.

The graduates might be disappointed, but holding the event despite that all that would be problematic.

Perhaps Cromwell thought the same, as he boldly canceled the event.

"Indeed, the professors must be busy as well....."

The attack by the rebels and the reversing of time.

All of these events were known not only to those inside the academy but also publicized throughout the entire empire.

The Emperor and numerous nobles were furious, and orders to apprehend the rebels were issued across the empire.

Though they spoke of capture, it was essentially a kill-on-sight order.

Even the fragmented empire had united like this because the academy had been messed with.

So, the professors at the academy began to pass information about the rebel leaders to the empire.

Daemon, who uses necromancy.

Jefferin, who utilized illusion magic.

Vanderwood, who could regenerate infinitely.

Aryandor, the swordsman who used time magic.

Portraits of these individuals were drawn and distributed across the empire.

I wondered if there was any point to this.

Could they really be caught just by searching for them?

Having faced them, I knew their power well and was fully aware that they could not be caught by ordinary means.

However, seeing the empire unite over this issue made it seem like a not-so-bad situation.

"Now, I suppose it's just up to me to do well....."

With a slightly disheartened smile, I stroked Priscilla's head.

Priscilla smiled comfortably, seemingly pleased.

"Well then, I'll leave this part to Professor Mcguire."

"Okay. What else?"

"Yes... there's the matter of repairing the training grounds..."

Kuhn glanced slightly as he reported to Rie.

"...Don't worry about her."

This place was clearly the student council room.

However, a girl who wasn't part of the student council lay on the room's sofa, giving Kuhn a slight glare.

"Hmm~ It seems like it's about time to wrap this up~."

The girl, lounging on the couch with cat-like grace, was Yuni.

Yuni slightly adjusted her position and spoke.

"Sis seems a bit tired~."

Yuni's tone was subtly teasing.

Kuhn briefly glanced at Rie.

"I'm not tired. Keep reporting."

"Yes, then....."

"Hey! Just leave it to him and play with me!"

Yuni spoke to Rie, pouting her lips.

She was whining like a little child.

“Ahem.....”

Kuhn coughed awkwardly at Yuni’s typical behavior.

It felt as if he was intruding on a family conversation.

“Sigh.”

Although Rie sighed, the corners of her lips twitched upward slightly.

It didn’t seem like she minded Yuni’s playful whining.

“I’ll play with you tomorrow, so go home for today.”

Hearing those words, Yuni’s lips curled into a grin.

“Is it a promise?”

“Yes.”

Seeming pleased with Rie’s response, Yuni exited the student council room with a spring in her step.

“Alright, let’s continue.....”

As soon as Yuni closed the door behind her, it opened again.

“What’s up with her?”

Rudy entered the student council room, looking in the direction Yuni had disappeared to.

“Oh, Rudy, you're here?”

Rie greeted Rudy with a smile.

It was a casual, everyday sort of greeting.

“Is there any problem with the work?”

“Nah, now that Homecoming Day is gone, there's pretty much nothing to do.”

“Did the professors say anything?”

“Nope. I think we can just keep doing what we were doing?”

As Rudy moved to his place, Rie passed him some documents without a word, and Rudy accepted them as if it were a matter of course.

Kuhn just stared blankly at the two of them.

“What? Is something wrong?”

“No..... Then, I'll continue the report.”

And so, Kuhn resumed his report.

Rudy did his work, and Rie listened to Kuhn's report.

“.....Umm?”

“Huh? Ah, go on.”

Kuhn continued his report, sweat beading on his forehead.

“Hmm.....”

Rie, however, seemed lost in thought.

Although Rie had been focused and asking various questions while Yuni was there, now she was neither looking at the documents nor at Kuhn.

At the end of Rie's gaze was Rudy.

Kuhn couldn't help but feel bewildered.

Even though he had sensed a strange atmosphere between these two before, it felt like that level of tension could exist between any man and woman.

However, now it felt entirely different.

It wasn't usually like this, but whenever the two were working together separately, Rie seemed to malfunction.

Continuing to stare blankly, and quite openly, she just kept gazing at Rudy.

Her face seemed to be immersed in some profound contemplation.

This situation began after Rie visited the Royal palace.

Due to the rebel invasion incident, Rie and Yuni had both visited the Royal palace together.

Although it was officially a situation report called by the Emperor, it was a well-known fact that he called them after hearing that the two princesses had encountered some unpleasant incidents.

After the two princesses visited the Royal palace, Rie and Yuni became quite close.

However, something about Rie's state was...

"...strange."

Kuhn, thinking further discussion would be pointless, roughly summarized and moved on.

However, Rie, perhaps unaware that the conversation had ended, continued to stare at Rudy.

Kuhn cautiously opened his mouth.

"...Senior?"

"Hm?"

Rie, startled, turned to look at Kuhn.

"Ah, oh, right. Good job. Continue handling it that way."

Rie offered a casual smile and brushed it off.

"...I will take my leave then."

Kuhn, thinking that stepping back might help the two, retreated for the moment.

"...? Alright, good job."

Rie offered a puzzled face and a greeting as she watched Kuhn hastily disappear.

Rie didn't understand why Kuhn vanished so quickly.

She hadn't fully realized that she had been staring at Rudy.

There was a specific reason why Rie was gazing at Rudy so blankly.

The conversation she'd had at the Royal palace.

Rie had talked a lot with her father.

About how Yuni had almost died.

About how Yuni had thrown herself in harm's way for her.

That conversation had taken place, and there was also a discussion about how Rudy had saved them both.

Talking so openly with her father after so long felt good.

It felt like she was talking to a father, not the emperor who ruled the empire.

Having such a conversation, Yuni, with a smile, said to Rie,

-I don't want to be anything like an emperor. Sis, you can do all that.

Rie was greatly surprised by Yuni's words.

Yuni, who had been competing with her for the throne all this while.

Despite having many deficiencies compared to Rie, the effort and study Yuni put in to attain the emperor's position had always been genuine.

Thus, hearing Yuni willingly relinquish the throne was nothing but shocking.

-I don't think that position suits me.

A relief was visible on Yuni's face as she spoke with a smile.

Although it wasn't an official declaration, it felt like she had shaken something off by telling Rie.

-So. Starting today, we're going to get along even better. Now, not as competitors, but as sisters!

Rie smiled at Yuni, who spoke thus.

Through their conversation, Yuni and Rie resolved various misunderstandings.

Misunderstandings that have been followed since childhood.

Rie, who faced harassment opposing the noble faction, and Yuni, who nonchalantly sided with the noble faction because it was convenient.

Yuni simply accepted them because things were bothersome and tough.

The misunderstanding that accumulated between Rie and Yuni was entirely because of the noble faction.

The noble faction pitted Rie and Yuni against each other, creating a confrontational structure.

Once such misunderstandings were resolved, the relationship between Rie and Yuni strengthened.

Thus, after concluding with Yuni, Rie faced the Emperor alone.

Although she was a bit bewildered when the Emperor suddenly called only her, she met with the Emperor alone as it was her father's call.

And the words of the Emperor:

-Uh... my daughter...

-So... are you... dating that Rudy Astria?

-How about thinking about marriage?

Because of these words, Rie kept thinking.

While Rudy was reading documents, he felt a gaze and lifted his head.

When he looked to the side, Rie was staring at him intently.

Rudy looked at Rie with a puzzled face.

"...What are you doing?"

"Hmm...?"

Rie, suddenly realizing Rudy was calling her, snapped to attention.

"Ah..."

Realizing she had been blankly staring at Rudy, Rie blushed.

"Oh, it's nothing! Nothing at all!"

Rie stood up abruptly from her seat and shouted.

"Ah... okay."

Rudy nodded his head with a puzzled face at Rie's intense reaction.

Somehow, that reaction was even more embarrassing.

Rie turned her head and tightly closed her lips, frowning.

However, on one hand, she continued her thoughts.

-How about thinking about marriage?

She recalled the Emperor's words.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 145: The Eve of the Storm...! (2)

"It was all in vain."

Astina let out a rueful smile as she read the letter.

It was a letter about the Saint Haruna.

Astina had gone to great lengths to gather information about the Saint, but by the time she had done so, matters regarding Haruna had already concluded.

The Haruna that Astina had discovered was just an ordinary girl.

A common girl that could be found in any empire.

However, it is said that she changed after meeting the former saint, Beatrice.

"Rudy was called here by... the former saint..."

That's what was written in the letter to Rudy.

There was not much written about the depth of the matter.

Such content was not something to casually discuss in a letter.

The exact reason was that too much other information was written down.

But, there was one point that lifted her spirits as she read a bit of the content.

"No one else knows..."

A content smile appeared on Astina's face.

The start of the letter, which discussed Haruna, felt somewhat disappointing.

Only Astina had come to know the fact that Rudy was a possessor.

Astina had seen several scenes by entering Rudy's dreams.

Sceneries that could never be seen in this world.

Scenes that she could not even imagine.

Such scenes were secrets known only to Rudy and herself.

Stories that could not be shared with anyone.

No one would believe such stories even if they were told.

However, she had gone directly into Rudy's dreams and learned about this.

She had seen a different side of Rudy and had also witnessed strange food and culture.

It felt like a precious secret just between the two of them.

Astina thought this fact had come to light through his meeting with Haruna and felt a pang of sadness.

But seeing that even Rie and Luna weren't told made her chuckle.

"Oh, really..."

Astina tapped her cheek.

It was to prevent a constantly forming silly smile.

"Well... aside from this..."

In order to divert her mind slightly, Astina read through the other content of the letter.

However, the remaining content did not seem so important.

She already knew the information that the leader of the rebels, Aryandor, seemed to have turned back time, thanks to the information received from the capital.

Truly crucial details were omitted from the letter.

"This letter feels a bit lacking..."

Most of it outlined the flow of events that had occurred, but the important details were missing.

"Well, it doesn't matter."

Astina muttered to herself as she stood up from her chair.

"Where... will you go?"

The maid in front of her asked cautiously as Astina rose from her seat.

"It's about time to go back."

Astina said with a smile.

The semester was nearing its end.

It was time for Astina to return to the academy.

Although the final exams for the first semester were not held yet, Astina had a reason to return to the Academy a bit early.

Astina spoke as she glanced at the calendar.

A day marked with a star on the calendar with the schedule, but without any specific details.

It was Rudy's birthday.

Astina couldn't forget the embarrassment from Rudy's last birthday.

Luna and Rie had unexpectedly joined them for a meal, adding to her humiliation.

And yet, Rudy didn't celebrate her birthday.

Astina's birthday was in winter.

Though she was away during winter break and couldn't help it, she was still disappointed.

"Shall we go then?"

With a grand plan in mind, Astina started heading towards the Academy.

The scent of chemicals filled the research lab.

Poles responsible for holding the staffs were scattered around, and various documents and mana stones were also strewn about.

If one were to sell the materials scattered here, it would be enough for a commoner to eat and live for three generations, given their value.

"Hmm....."

While the scattered items were valuable, the environment inside was stifling and oppressive.

This place was the Alchemy Department's laboratory.

The room, where stacked items blocked the windows preventing proper sunlight, was a lab.

Yet, there was a person cheerfully laughing and researching.

Her laughing was to a degree where others might wonder if she wasn't insane, as she was in such a good mood.

"Luna... are you struggling these days by any chance?"

"Eh?"

Ena asked Luna, who was happily laughing.

Luna tilted her head with a puzzled expression.

Recently, every day had been joyous for Luna.

Of course, there were bad incidents like the rebel attack.

However, that incident turned out to be a bit of a good thing for Luna.

The magical tool that Luna had secured.

The incident where she stole that magical tool that Jefrin had installed.

That incident had a huge impact on Luna and everyone else.

In a very good way.

The reason why everyone didn't lose their memories.

It was because Luna had stolen Jefrin's magical tool.

When time reversed for everyone in the academy, only Luna remained unaffected.

Because she held that magical tool.

Of course, Luna did not intend this, but when Professor Mcguire disassembled the tool, it turned out to have that capability.

They were still determining exactly what abilities the tool had.

However, Mcguire was certain that the tool was related to time magic.

Specifically, it was a tool related to the mental aspect of time magic.

That was the magical tool Luna had stolen.

The truth was that time had reversed, and everyone was left puzzled.

Why did people's memories remain?

The magical tool that Luna had snuck away provided a clear answer.

Luna, who hadn't even fought, became the biggest contributor to the Rebel incident.

While Luna was pleased with this, in reality, this was a very minor matter.

The reason Luna was smiling was due to an earlier event.

The time Rudy threw a question that seemed like a confession.

When he finally said he would answer later.

That was the biggest reason that made Luna smile.

This also made Luna anxious.

What if Rudy simply apologizes and ends it?

However, amidst this anxiety, she thought more about what it would be like if Rudy accepted.

"Hehehe... No, I have to quickly finish the task Rudy asked me to do."

"Hmm..."

Ena never expected such a thing.

Even though Ena knew Luna well, she didn't know much about Rudy.

It was unimaginable that the usually stoic Rudy would say such things.

Of course, Ena, who occasionally says positive things to Luna, thought that it was still a positive event when she saw him feeding Rie.

But she couldn't think of this as a positive thing.

"Luna..."

Looking at Luna, Ena wore a pitiful expression.

To the unknowing Ena, it seemed like Luna was trying her best to be positive.

Rudy, that guy, was always with Rie while working in the student council, and Luna seemed to be left behind.

After hearing about the rebel incident, didn't they say Rudy saved Rie and Yuni?

Rudy, who saved not only Rie but also Rie's family... there was no way this was flowing in a good direction.

"Luna... I'm always on your side..."

Upon hearing Ena's bitter words, Luna tilted her head.

"...Huh?"

Luna, who knew nothing, just smiled warmly.

"I'm always on your side too, Ena!"

"Uh..."

Seeing Luna like that made Ena feel even more pitiful.

Holding such a pitiful heart, Ena, while on the verge of tears, lifted her head.

"Riku...!!!"

"Hm?"

"Where did Riku go! She definitely said she was going to bring tea and snacks earlier!!"

"...Ena?"

Right now, Luna and Ena were in the midst of conducting a staff research led by Rudy.

Riku was not originally needed for that research but...

-Don't leave me out!!!

However, feeling unjust about doing different work alone, she ended up participating in the research.

For no pay, of course.

Then, the door to the research room opened.

Riku, with a broad smile, held a bundle of snacks in both hands.

"Hey, guys! I brought snacks!"

"Riku!! Why are you so late!!"

"...Huh?"

"Luna must be hungry since she has to use mana!!"

Luna was in the process of combining her staff and a mana stone.

An act that consumes a lot of mana.

It was certainly a valid point.

"Ah... so... I tried to be... as quick... as possible...?"

"You should bring it faster! Hey! When I do that kind of thing, I run so fast you can't even see my feet!!"

"Ho, how can you not see your feet..."

"That means you should try harder! Try! Eehhh?"

Ena, with her hands on her hips, spoke to Riku.

Poor Riku was the target of Ena's venting.

Riku, not understanding the situation, stared at Ena with a bewildered face.

"Ahaha..."

Luna, observing this scene, awkwardly chuckled while scratching her cheek.

Thus, Riku, in the midst of being the target of Ena's ire, sat down in a corner.

"Hmmp....."

Once Ena's venting was done, a girl peeked her face into the lab.

"Oh, everyone's here?"

"Yuni...! Ena is bullying me...!!"

Riku, with a crying face, threw herself into Yuni's arms.

"Hmm? Ena did?"

"Yes...! Ena did...!"

"It's okay~ It's okay~."

Yuni patted the back of Riku, who nestled into her arms.

Riku and Yuni.

While they seemed an unlikely pair, they surprisingly matched and they had been getting along well lately.

Recently, Luna and her group were assisting with the staff that Rudy had requested help with, and since Yuni was in charge of the mana stone-related research for it, they spent a lot of time together.

"Oh! Is it snack time?"

Yuni, while comforting Riku, spotted the snacks laid out in front of her, her eyes lighting up.

"Do you want to eat with us, Yuni?"

"Of course~."

When Luna asked, Yuni pushed Riku away from her embrace and walked towards Luna.

"Yu, Yuni?"

"Oh, there's cake too?"

"Yu, Yuni??"

"Heeey! This is delicious."

"Yuni!!!"

"Riku, you should come quickly too. It's delicious."

Nonchalantly deserting Riku, Yuni began eating cake.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 146: The Eve of the Storm...! (3)

Kuhn had been feeling something unusual lately.

He looked at just one girl and loved only her.

It was common sense for Kuhn.

Though the empire's law allowed for multiple wives, the widespread convention was to have just one.

Being a commoner, Kuhn was naturally rooted in this convention.

Though there were nobles with multiple wives, Kuhn had never witnessed such a scene, so it felt natural to him.

"Kuhn, what are you thinking about?"

And Kuhn already had his partner.

Emily.

A girl he had grown up with since they were children.

She was like his other half.

There were times Kuhn took care of Emily, and times Emily took care of Kuhn.

The two of them would look out for each other's shortcomings like they were of one mind.

If they were to spend their lives together, Kuhn thought this kind of relationship was natural.

Humans typically view the world based on their own experiences.

Given the life Kuhn had led, it was no wonder he couldn't think any differently.

"Emily."

"Hm?"

While moving student council materials, Kuhn looked over at Emily next to him.

"Do you think Rudy Astria likes Rie?"

It was an unexpectedly innocent question, unlike the usually thoughtful Kuhn.

Emily was surprised at the sudden question but pondered it seriously.

"Uhm... judging by their interactions... but... um..."

Emily couldn't give a definite answer.

When Emily and Kuhn first saw Rudy, he was with Luna.

At first glance, they seemed like a young couple, but upon closer inspection, it wasn't the case.

Then what about Rie, who was the vice-president?

Apart from when Rudy went to the lab, he was always with Rie.

Rie was the senior that Kuhn and Emily saw most often.

Rudy and Rie seemed like very close friends.

They played playful pranks and occasionally bickered, just like good friends.

Of course, there were couples who acted like that, so it wasn't easy to just see them as friends.

Were these two in a romantic relationship?

Not exactly.

Judging by the recent atmosphere, it seemed like Rie had feelings for Rudy.

However, if one were to ask Rudy if he felt the same, the answer would likely be no.

Still, it didn't give off the impression that Rudy disliked Rie or that their relationship couldn't develop into something more.

Rie was a good colleague who filled Rudy's gaps.

While Rudy led the overall flow, she was the reliable colleague who filled in the gaps behind him.

If it were a typical relationship, one could just see them as good colleagues, but in some ways, it also looked like a wife supporting her husband.

After contemplating for a while, Emily shrugged her shoulders.

"I don't know... I really don't."

"Hmm..."

After hearing Emily's response, Kuhn nodded and murmured to himself.

"What could Rudy Astria be thinking...?"

I sat at my desk, twirling my pen, deep in thought.

I had worries about the upcoming final exams, but the current dilemma was completely different.

Astina Persia.

The fact that she would die.

Is it a good idea to tell her?

When I wrote to Astina recently, I didn't mention such a thing.

Aside from concerns about the letter's security or other thoughts, my biggest dilemma was how to convey this possible reality to Astina.

Astina is strong.

She possesses a power that is unmatched by anyone else.

It is a fact acknowledged by Professor Cromwell, the Academy, and everyone in the Empire.

But if I were to tell her about her possible death, would she survive?

Someone strong enough to kill Astina.

Aryandor.

His power was beyond imagination.

A force capable of turning back time for everyone at the Academy.

It wasn't something a typical wizard could fathom.

Someone close to the realm of the gods.

That was the conclusion reached by professors who had faced him.

In this world, it's believed that only gods can control the realm of time.

Space isn't much different.

According to this world's creation myth, time and space were the first things created and dealt with by the gods.

Having witnessed magic of both time and space, I truly believe it's a domain of the gods.

The Astria family's position as the top ducal family of the Empire is also due to this reason.

Along with that magic, their swordsmanship skills were also outstanding.

I didn't think Astina could handle such an opponent on her own.

If they clashed, Astina's defeat seemed certain.

The best way to change this outcome?

For me to become stronger.

I may have glimpsed the future, but I didn't know the specifics.

All I had was a vague sense of the events from memories of my future self.

Given that, I couldn't naively think of asking others for help.

I had to become stronger.

"Then..."

I looked at the papers beside me.

The gradually emerging outline of my staff.

"Will this be enough...?"

Having a staff would surely amplify my abilities, but something felt wrong.

“Can it... evolve further... Ugh...”

I sighed, setting down my pen.

There’s so much to think about.

“Still, I can’t just sit here like this.”

The final exams are fast approaching.

These exams can't be taken lightly.

The privileges given to the top student:

Access to a research lab, research funding, and even the additional provision of magic tools.

I couldn't afford to miss out on any of them.

Of course, I was somewhat concerned about Evan.

In the past, I thought that if Evan didn't grow, the academy would be annihilated.

Even when I looked into the future, I felt the same way.

The future me held the top spot and completely overshadowed Evan's growth.

Could it be that everyone died because of me?

That thought crossed my mind.

But even with these uncertainties, I moved forward.

It was already the path I had chosen.

It was already something that had happened.

So I just had to do what I needed to do right now.

That's all there was to it.

So, what should I be doing now?

"Of course, I should be preparing for the final exam..."

"Hmm..."

Just as I tried to concentrate on my book again, I heard a voice in front of me.

I lifted my head and looked forward.

"...Why are you here?"

"I came to study."

Rie stood in front of me.

I slightly furrowed my brows and looked around.

This is the academy's library.

A place bustling with people, not exactly the ideal study environment.

So, seeing Rie here made me wonder.

I naturally assumed the voice belonged to Luna.

There was no one else in the library who was usually in the library that would come up to me like this.

Of course, Riku and Ena were there too, but they usually came with Luna, never alone.

Rie casually took a seat in front of me and opened a book.

"Is it strange for me to come here? I've been here before, you know?"

Rie said, pouting her lips at me.

It wasn't her first time coming here, but it wasn't a common occurrence either.

I stared at Rie for a moment and then spoke.

"Do you have something to say?"

"Not really? Ah, there is something I'm curious about though."

Rie clapped her hands as if she had just thought of something.

I wasn't sure if she genuinely just thought of it or was pretending to, but it didn't really matter.

"What are you curious about?"

"What will become of the Saint now? She lost her eyesight, right?"

"Oh, Haruna?"

I had a somewhat private conversation with Haruna.

Although Rie was a good friend, I had a little apprehension about discussing possession-related matters.

Astina accepted it well, but Rie might not be so accepting.

"She said it doesn't matter. She knew she was going to lose her sight anyway."

Haruna had been living like a blind person all this time.

She lost her vision overnight, but since she had been mentally prepared for it, it wasn't a huge shock.

She had intended for this to happen.

Summoning his future self to this place.

The Saint said that it was a forbidden magic.

Crossing different timelines could cause physical damage like Haruna experienced, and in extreme cases, could cost one's life.

Haruna said that this was a rule of the world and she was punished for not adhering to it.

"Don't you have anything else to say?"

"What else?"

I told Rie almost everything except the fact that I'm a possessor.

I didn't share personal stories like the question she just asked, but I did thoroughly explain important matters, like Astina's death.

"It wasn't your idea to summon your future self, right? Plus the future might not go that way."

"That's true, but Haruna said it was necessary."

"Then, don't you owe her something in return?"

Rie stared intently at my expression.

However, I just tilted my head at the idea of compensation.

Haruna never brought up such a thing.

If she needs something, I can give it, but...

"If there's nothing, then forget it."

Seeing that I had no particular reaction, she smiled meaningfully and opened her book.

It seemed she came just to ask that question.

Perhaps she came to see me since I've been neglecting student council work lately due to my studies.

I looked at Rie focus on her book then started studying again.

After several hours of concentration,

"The library is closing now."

A librarian announced.

Upon hearing that, Rie and I began packing up our books.

"You're going to continue studying when you get back, right?"

Holding her bag, Rie asked me.

"I have to keep studying."

With finals approaching, there's no time to relax.

"Then how about taking a walk? Your head will hurt if you keep studying like this."

"...Hmm, okay."

She had a point.

Sitting in one place and studying all day can make it difficult to concentrate, and it's sometimes necessary to take a break.

That's also a reason why I came to the library.

With that, I walked with Rie toward the garden.

The path Rie led me to was somewhere I hadn't been to in a while.

"Ah..."

The place where I had said something peculiar to Luna.

The place where I left ambiguous words of confession, saying I would give her an answer later.

After saying that, I hadn't seen Luna's face recently.

Our overlapping classes were on break due to the upcoming exams.

"Hey, is there any food you want to eat or something?"

"Food I want to eat?"

While I was contemplating such thoughts, I raised my head in surprise at Rie's sudden question.

"You must have foods you're craving."

Naturally, when I thought of food I was craving, it was Korean cuisine.

Sometimes I would go to Professor Robert's favorite restaurant and enjoy a dish called 'Cheonggukjang*.'

There were other dishes I was craving as well.

However, I couldn't say such things, so I was in a dilemma.

"Speaking of which, the food I had at the midterm camp was delicious. I loved those dishes."

It was the farewell dinner after finishing the camp.

Rie nodded in agreement.

"Oh, it was really good there. The Academy's cafeteria food never really suited my taste, so I didn't expect much, but I was satisfied there."

"Yeah, me too. The Academy's cafeteria doesn't quite work for me either."

Rie probably didn't enjoy the cafeteria food because she was used to high-end ingredients.

As for me, I wasn't a big fan of Western cuisine, so it didn't suit my taste.

But we did find common ground on this.

Rie continued with a satisfied smile and posed another question.

"So, anything you want or wish for?"

"Why are you suddenly asking me this?"

I narrowed my eyes, curious about Rie's sudden question.

"Well, is there really nothing like that?"

A thought came to mind after some pondering.

My birthday was coming up soon.

I didn't even know it last year, but now I had it in mind.

It was said to be nonsensical for a noble not to know their own birthday.

I remembered to avoid any odd behavior this year.

Seeing Rie's expression, I could somewhat guess her thoughts and chuckled lightly.

"Hmm... I don't really have materialistic desires or anything, so there's not much I want."

I gave an ambiguous answer to tease Rie a bit.

However, strangely enough, Rie smiled again, this time with a satisfied look.

Rie smiled and blurted out something strange.

"I know all about family ties and all... So, let's skip that..."

Family ties?

"What are you talking about?"

"Well, it's really nothing."

Rie raised her head and stared at me intently.

When our eyes met, Rie opened her mouth.

"Do you want to get engaged to me?"

*Cheonggukjang is a type of Korean fermented soybean paste stew and uh that cliff LOL

Toggle New Ads

Chapter 147: The Eve of the Storm...! (4)

Always think rationally.

Decide with cold reason, not following the heart's desires.

This was always a phrase Rie kept close to her heart.

Lately, she hasn't been able to adhere to it well, but she always tried to apply it in her daily life.

So, Rie thought rationally.

What would happen if she married Rudy?

First... Rie herself liked him.

No, she shouldn't jump to conclusions with such words.

She decided to think rationally, efficiently, and calculatedly.

Let's think about Rudy.

For starters, he wasn't particularly tall.

A height around the mid-170 cm.

Average.

However, when she saw the future version of Rudy, he seemed taller than he is now.

Probably around 180 cm...

Among adult men, that was considered on the taller side.

And when considering his face... it was decent, not bad.

That meant the genes he'd pass onto their children wouldn't be bad either.

Now, let's consider other aspects.

Rudy's family is the Astria family, the largest ducal family in the empire.

Could there be a better family in the empire?

Of course, as the leader of the noble faction, they stood on the opposite side of Rie, who would become the Empress.

Depending on the perspective, they could be star-crossed lovers.

But it's also an opportunity to strengthen the empire.

The current successor of the Astria family, Ian, is hostile to the emperor.

He showed an even more hostile attitude than the current head of the Astria family.

But Rudy is different.

His actions so far and his words have been very friendly towards the emperor.

His attitude was so favorable that it made one wonder if he really grew up in the same house.

If that's the case, marrying Rudy would be politically advantageous as well.

If Rudy forges ties with the royal family, his political standing would elevate.

Considering Rudy's current skyrocketing reputation, if he properly forms a connection with the Royal family, he would be on par with Ian, if not surpass him.

In other words, it meant he wouldn't fall behind when competing for the position of the successor.

This marriage acts as a robust support for Rudy to inherit the duchy.

If Rudy inherits the Astria family, they would support the emperor, making it politically beneficial.

Also, it's important to consider if he has any debts or personal issues.

Although there were rumors that he lived a reckless life in the past, it was clear they were just baseless rumors.

The only other issue was the noticeable number of women around him, but that didn't concern her.

She just had to hold onto him tightly.

She just had to ensure he couldn't escape her charm.

Now, let's consider their life together as a married couple.

Is she compatible with him?

There wasn't much to say on that matter.

They were already in a good relationship, and their personalities seemed to match well.

Though they bickered from time to time, it wasn't genuine fighting; it was more like playful teasing.

Moreover, when deciding on most matters, their styles were so compatible that they resolved issues without much disagreement.

Some say that couples should have at least one major fight before getting married, but why?

There was no reason to fight.

That left only the question of personal preferences.

When you get married, you spend a lot of time together, so it's essential that tastes, especially in food and hobbies, match to some extent.

With that in mind, Rie went to find Rudy.

But, as expected, there were no issues.

"As I thought, we have no problems."

Their preferences in food, hobbies, and even their ways of thinking were similar.

It was a perfect match.

That's why Rie confidently asked:

"Do you want to get engaged to me?"

Beating around the bush or acting shy wasn't Rie's style.

She preferred a direct approach.

That's how Rie lived her life.

Rie stared intently at Rudy.

Rudy, with a surprised face, looked back at her.

Seeing his expression, Rie's face began to flush.

She realized the implications of what she had just said.

A confession.

Rie had confessed.

Marry me.

It wasn't uncommon for women to confess, but it still felt embarrassing in its own way.

Especially when they hadn't been dating or even discussed their feelings before.

"W-wait, I mean... we should talk about getting married...?"

Rie, with flustered gestures, tried to elaborate on what she meant.

Rudy was taken aback by Rie's reaction.

"Why are you panicking after saying all that?"

Rie couldn't disagree with that.

Rie thought that pushing forward without explaining in detail would be more effective than rambling on with explanations.

"W-well, a-anyway, let's... let's get engaged for now!"

Rie said, looking up at Rudy with her face turning even redder.

"N-no... how can you suddenly bring up something we've never even talked about before... and it's marriage."

"What's there to think about?"

Rie said, placing her hand on her chest and puffed it out with pride.

"A beautiful person like me is offering to become your wife! I have skills! And a good family background!"

But, despite her confident attitude, her face was turning crimson.

Rie shifted her gaze away, unable to maintain eye contact with Rudy.

She genuinely believed her confession was a logical decision.

But, after saying it out loud, she realized she acted more emotionally than she had intended.

Having already viewed Rudy through rose-colored glasses, Rie's thoughts weren't exactly logical or objective.

Rather, she had already come to a conclusion and was simply rationalizing her actions.

In reality, Rie had confessed to Rudy simply because she liked him.

"But... why are we talking about marriage all of a sudden?"

Rudy was taken aback and blushed with embarrassment.

"We're not kids, so why just date? Let's... let's just... get married,"

Rie said confidently at first, but her voice trailed off shyly at the mention of marriage.

"Let's... think about this later..."

"No! I want to hear your answer now!"

Rie firmly told Rudy.

"I have to go study, and it'll bother me if I don't know the answer now!"

Of course, regardless of Rudy's answer, Rie would be too distracted to study that night.

But she still wanted to hear his answer now.

Knowing Rudy's personality, it was obvious he wouldn't give a straightforward answer.

Lately, he seemed busy and lost in thought.

Rie knew that if she let this pass, the topic would drag on.

So she had to push forward.

It was advantageous to strike when the opponent appeared vulnerable.

This strategy was basic for Rie, who had studied the art of war.

However, one thing concerned her: What if Rudy rejected her outright?

Despite all her planning, she hadn't anticipated this possibility.

The usually assertive Rie quietly looked for signs in Rudy's expressions, then asked in a small voice,

"Um... do you... not like me?"

"No, no, I like you..."

Rudy replied quickly, hearing the uncertainty in Rie's voice.

Hearing that, Rie's eyes widened in surprise.

"Oh."

Rudy realized the implications of what he had just said.

He recognized the weight of his words and the potential consequences.

"Still... I mean, a sudden marriage..."

"Not marriage, but engagement."

Rie corrected him.

"We'll get married after graduation. That sounds good to you, right?"

"Well, yes, but beyond whether it's good or not—"

"The wedding can be a small, intimate one, with delicious food prepared just for us."

"That's not the point."

"Having a big wedding isn't really necessary, right?"

"W-well, that's true. But the issue is the very premise of marriage—"

Suddenly, Rie stepped closer and grabbed Rudy's tie.

Due to the height difference, Rudy had to tilt his head down.

Rie brought his head down to her level, looked straight into his eyes, and began to speak.

"Just tell me. Do you like me or not?"

"Well... I do, but..."

"That's enough."

As Rudy tried to say something, Rie cut him off.

Rie moved closer and pressed her lips against Rudy's.

And so, under the dim moonlight, their lips met.

After some time had passed.

In Rie's room.

After kissing Rudy, Rie had retreated straight to her room.

She knew that if they had started talking, Rudy would have begun to ask all sorts of questions.

Not knowing what to say, she had simply bolted.

"Hehe...heh..."

Lying on her bed, Rie had a silly smile on her face.

Her confident demeanor had completely disappeared, leaving behind only an innocent girl.

Despite the approaching final exams, she lay on her bed, hugging her teddy bear tightly.

Rie continued to roll around her bed while hugging her teddy bear.

Late at night.

Robert was in an academy laboratory, going through various documents.

"Hmm..."

The papers were about Daemon, the necromancer of the rebels.

The central authority had identified and located everyone who had previously infiltrated the academy based on their appearances and names.

Jefrin, for instance, was quickly identified since he was already a famous wizard in the central region.

Of course, the odd thing was that Jefrin had originally been an old man*, but Robert didn't dwell on that.

The magic used was similar, and after analyzing the magical tool that Luna had stolen, it was found to be similar to the ones Jefrin had created.

There was a possibility he had an apprentice, but there were too many similarities between Jefrin's appearance when he was young and now.

People speculated that Aryandor had done something with time magic.

Perhaps through some agreement, Aryandor had granted Jefrin youth, and in return, Jefrin is helping Aryandor.

It was a plausible guess, especially since a wizard of Jefrin's caliber had suddenly joined the rebels.

However, traces of others were not easily found.

It was impossible to find out about Venderwood, who had been a slave, and Daemon, who hailed from the underground city Ephomos, left no trace after the disappearance of Ephomos.

Still, remnants of their past were present, and Robert could somewhat piece things together.

He continued reading the related documents.

"A sister...?"

Robert leaned back in his chair after reading the document.

"It's clear that he's up to something."

Robert reclined, creaking his chair.

"If such a person exists... I can't just sit still and wait anymore."

Robert stared at the drawer in front of him.

The drawer contained documents related to Levian, the owner of the magic book Luna had.

Robert had been waiting on an investigation regarding Levian's magic book, but there had been no progress on the matter lately due to his busy schedule.

"It's good timing. That guy owes me a favor..."

That guy.

He was referring to Luna.

He had recently taught Luna about mana stones and staff synthesis, so he felt she owed him a favor.

What Robert needed was information.

How the magic book came into Luna's possession.

And the events that happened before that.

Luna didn't know much when asked.

However, her father might know something.

Luna was quite young when she received the magic book.

He thought all of this needed to be investigated.

"That guy Rudy... that girl... If the three of us go..."

Robert muttered to himself roughly and immediately sat down in his chair.

Then he got up and began writing a document.

It was a document related to leave.

He planned to apply for leave during the summer vacation after the final exams.

"There shouldn't be any problems."

Robert thought so and continued writing the document.

---Toggle New Ads

*I called Jefrin a she since he looked like a little girl but looks like that was a mistake.

Chapter 148: The Eve of the Storm...! (5)

"Haaah..."

I let out a sigh, running my fingers over my lips.

This idiot.

I should have done something, whether it be accepting or rejecting.

I inwardly lamented, grabbing my head.

All of this was because of Luna.

Promising to answer Luna later, then getting engaged to Rie?

What a trashy move.

I couldn't study properly last night, nor could I sleep.

It was thrilling to think I had kissed Rie, but it was difficult to explain how things ended up like this.

Should I just accept this?

Or should I go there right now...

I shook my head.

I didn't have the confidence to reject.

"Seriously..."

Another sigh escaped me.

"Just give me some time to think..."

Suddenly confessing, and even sealing it with a kiss.

It was as shocking as a truck with broken brakes coming at you.

As I was wandering, lost in thought.

"Rudy Astria, why are you walking like that?"

Hearing my name, I turned my head.

"...Astina?"

In my line of sight, Astina was smiling.

"It's been a while."

Astina greeted me with a warm smile.

"Why are you... Wait, what?"

Astina was in her school uniform.

It didn't seem like she came for just a short visit.

"I'm allowed here, aren't I? Why are you making that expression?"

"I thought you were busy with something else... When did you arrive?"

"Just now. I saw you and called out."

Astina should have been undergoing her 3rd year practical period.

She was supposed to be receiving education as a successor.

I was expecting her around the start of the second semester.

Astina leaned slightly forward, narrowing her eyes.

"You must be busy with student council work and preparing for the finals. You have dark circles under your eyes."

"Yes... I guess so."

The reason for the dark circles was more because I didn't sleep properly last night.

But being busy was part of the reason, so she wasn't entirely wrong.

"So, how's your studying going?"

"It's not bad, just the usual."

"Then you must be working hard."

Astina said with a bright smile.

It made me happy to hear such a positive evaluation even when I said it was just the usual.

This feeling of complete trust wasn't bad.

"Where are the others?"

"...Others?"

"Luna and Rie. You're always with one of them, aren't you?"

"L-Luna and Rie..."

"Let's go see them. We can at least take a short break from studying for finals to see each other, right?"

I couldn't answer that.

How can I face Luna and Rie in this state?

Astina looked at me with scrutiny.

"...What have you done?"

"W-What do you mean... Why would you say that..."

"Hmm..."

Astina stroked her chin, pondering.

"Well, let's head to the student council for now."

"Yes... I understand."

Good.

The student council was a safer bet.

Rie had mentioned that she's been busy studying and hasn't been to the student council lately.

Luna rarely attended student council meetings, so the chances of them both being there were slim.

I headed towards the student council room with Astina.

Astina, returning to the academy after a long time, looked around with a pleasant smile.

"It feels familiar, even though it's only been half a year."

"Well, half a year isn't that long, after all."

"True, but it felt longer to me."

I chatted with Astina as we walked down the corridor.

Then, from afar.

"Oh, isn't that Rie?"

Spotting Rie at the end of the corridor, I gasped.

Why was she there?

"Rie."

Astina called Rie's name with a smile and approached her.

Rie turned her head at the sound of her name.

"Astina?"

She looked at Astina with wide eyes, as surprised as I was to see her.

Just as her expression began to soften into a friendly smile, our eyes met.

"Ah."

Rie looked more shocked seeing me than when she saw Astina.

And then...

"Rie?"

Rie quickly turned around.

She began to run as soon as she turned.

"Huh?"

Without looking back, Rie sprinted away into the distance.

Astina, stunned by the sight, looked at me.

Avoiding her gaze, I pretended to be clueless.

"What did you do?"

"I-I didn't do anything."

"..."

Astina looked at me suspiciously.

She soon turned her attention away and said,

"Alright, let's head to the student council."

We continued walking and soon arrived near the student council room.

Voices could be heard from inside.

"So... I think Rie has a better chance. She has a good status and they tease each other a lot."

"You think? But I feel Rudy Astria might prefer Luna. Just from watching Rudy..."

It was an odd conversation.

Why were they discussing this?

Astina, listening at the door, turned her head.

"Oh... What an interesting conversation. Rudy Astria?"

Her eyes were sharp.

Astina wore an expression I'd never seen before.

She gritted her teeth, glaring at me.

"I, really... I didn't do anything..."

It wasn't true that I didn't do anything.

I brought up the topic first to Luna.

The issue was that it was between me, Rie, and Luna.

So why were other people talking about it?

Astina, with a fierce expression, opened the student council office door.

"Whoa..."

"Who's...?"

Inside, there were Kuhn, Emily... and even Locke.

I'd heard Kuhn and Emily's voices from outside, but I hadn't known Locke was there too.

Upon seeing Astina, Locke's eyes widened.

"...Hello."

Locke greeted Astina politely.

Astina gave a smirk and nodded.

Her smirk held the fierceness I'd seen earlier.

The atmosphere was so tense, it felt like walking on thin ice.

Any outcry wouldn't have been surprising.

"Who, who are you...?"

Kuhn asked Astina with a confused look.

Anyone would be taken aback if a stranger showed such hostility.

I followed Astina into the student council office.

"Oh, Rudy...?"

"Ah."

Emily and Kuhn were visibly shocked upon seeing me.

Of course they would be.

They were in the middle of conversation.

They probably never imagined I'd suddenly appear.

Considering both Rie and I had mentioned we might not visit the student council for a while.

"Guys, greet Astina."

I said, glancing sternly at them.

Both Emily and Kuhn avoided my gaze, looking around uneasily.

Their wandering eyes finally settled on one person.

Locke.

They looked at the silent Locke as if pleading for help.

Noticing Emily and Kuhn's cues, Locke carefully spoke.

"...Did you perhaps hear?"

"Hmm... What are you talking about?"

"Ah."

Though her words suggested ignorance, Astina's gaze turned ice-cold.

Locke quickly deduced the situation.

"Astina, it's a pleasure to meet you, but I have other matters to attend to. I need to urgently meet a professor who's called for me."

Normally, Locke wasn't very talkative, but today, he spoke rapidly and at length.

"It's curious how, as soon as I arrive, you suddenly have something urgent?"

Astina looked at Locke, her head tilted, as if intrigued.

"It was something I had planned to do. I just dropped by to help some juniors. Now, I must..."

"Lo... Locke?"

Both Kuhn and Emily desperately called after the swiftly departing Locke.

Ignoring their calls, Locke disappeared like the wind.

"...Hmm. If they're gone, then so be it."

"...Ah, hello. My name is Kuhn..."

"I'm Emily, a first-year student. I'm not from the student council... I just came to help with some work..."

Kuhn and Emily hesitated on how to greet Astina.

It was understandable.

They already knew about Astina.

After all, they had occasionally asked questions about her to me and Rie.

We had described her as a good and charismatic person.

But seeing Astina now, she exuded even more charisma than before.

The two first-year students were too overawed to show their spirit.

It wasn't that they had done anything seriously wrong, but they had been talking about the student council president behind her back, which must

have felt a bit unsettling.

In this situation, seeing Astina made them even more terrified.

Astina alternately looked at the two, who were losing their composure.

"The main instigator seems to have already run away... So, it's settled."

Astina relaxed her gaze and gave a gentle smile.

"Yes, I'm Astina Persia."

Seeing her expression, Kuhn and Emily seemed to relax.

It appeared they concluded she wouldn't cause them any trouble.

I knew Astina's personality well.

Such an expression meant...

"Alright."

Astina walked over and sat down in the president's chair.

"So, what were you two talking about?"

Emily and Kuhn's faces turned pale.

"It's like leaving a fish store to a cat."

Astina sighed.

Not that she thought she should be neglecting her heir studies and sticking around the academy.

Studying to be the successor was necessary.

What was more frustrating was Rudy, who stood confidently.

He seemed to be giving off an air of innocence, as if he had done nothing wrong.

He wasn't entirely wrong.

The two had debated whether Rudy suited Rie or Luna.

The problem was that such a conversation had taken place.

There was no reason for such a conversation to happen.

No smoke without fire.

Astina was certain that something had happened.

Especially the incident where Rie ran away just now.

Her face looked happy when she saw Astina.

Which meant, after seeing Rudy behind her, Rie chose to flee.

Astina assessed the situation coolly.

She had spent a long time away from Rudy.

They were in different grades, so they didn't spend much time together.

This couldn't continue.

Rudy was so oblivious that she had let things slide.

She hadn't anticipated the situation developing this way.

"Rudy, what are you doing after the finals?"

Astina turned her head and looked at Rudy beside her.

"Nothing special."

"Then clear your schedule."

"What time?"

"Let's have a meal."

Astina said that and was about to leave the student council room.

Something suddenly came to her mind.

Rudy's last birthday party.

Astina turned around and glared at Rudy menacingly.

"If you bring everyone like last time... I don't know what I might do."

"Oh, understood..."

Emily, who was next to them, widened her eyes in surprise.

Turning her head to look at Kuhn, she saw that he too had a shocked expression.

The two exchanged glances, thinking,

'T-There's no way... right?'

'T-That couldn't be.'

The two felt uneasy.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 149: The Eve of the Storm...! (6)

The shining sunlight.

Rather than a pleasant feeling, it gave a strong sense of summer.

It was a scorching sun, enough to make one's skin feel hot.

This meant that summer vacation was approaching.

Before vacation, there's something every student must face.

Final exams.

A time most students dread.

Although students prayed for it to never come, such wishes rarely come true.

That day eventually arrived.

Despite the scorching heat, the students were studying diligently.

This year's first and second-year students were exceptional, and their hard work created an atmosphere of academic enthusiasm.

As everyone worked hard, the day of the final exam finally came.

While most students, tired from studying through the hot night, dragged themselves to the exam, there was someone who walked with a bright smile.

"Hmm~ Hmm~."

Rie walked with a smile, weaving through the hot sun rays.

She left the dormitory, crossed the sunlit garden, and headed towards the main building.

Although there was some distance between the dormitory and the main building, Rie never lost her smile.

She was even humming a tune.

Despite having studied all night and not getting proper sleep, Rie was surprisingly energetic.

This level of enthusiasm was rare for her.

She found the intense sunlight pleasant and the chirping of birds around her felt like soothing music.

"The weather is nice~."

Indeed, the weather was nice.

The floating clouds and the shining sun felt wonderful, even if it was a hot day.

The heat didn't bother her.

"Now, I just have to do well in the exam."

Rie grinned, muttering to herself.

The weather was perfect, and she was in great condition.

Now, all that remained was to showcase her skills.

However, there was a problem.

Rie hadn't properly studied for this exam.

While studying and right up until falling asleep, Rie's mind wandered.

She thought it was foolish and embarrassing, but she couldn't stop her daydreaming.

Those daydreams scattered her focus.

She couldn't hold her pen properly while studying and she couldn't sleep well either.

Normally, such distractions would frustrate her, but for some reason, she constantly found herself smiling.

Even now.

She might not have studied properly, but she was still smiling.

As Rie continued walking with that smile, she glanced into a nearby classroom.

"Oh?"

It was Rudy's exam room.

Rie took a brief peek inside.

Faces were visible from inside the classroom.

It was Rudy.

"Ah..."

Upon seeing his face, her face started to turn red.

She had been thinking a lot about Rudy, but lately, she had been avoiding him.

She wanted to approach him, tease him, and chat with him, but it was difficult to approach him.

Was it because of the imaginations she had at night?

Whenever she saw him, her face would flush.

Rie clenched her fists.

She couldn't continue like this.

Also, today was Rudy's birthday.

She wanted to wish him a happy birthday and suggest having a meal after the exam.

Rie began to step forward but then stopped in her tracks.

"...Should I just talk to him after the exam?"

It was just a few minutes before the exam.

If she suddenly talked to him, it might disrupt Rudy's concentration.

Although she thought it was important to have a meal together, the exam was more important.

Rie stared intently at the back of Rudy's head but turned her head away.

"I can tell him later."

"Phew...!"

I'm in great condition today.

I slept well, and everything I studied was clearly etched in my mind.

I could recite everything as if reading from a book.

My research, the battles I fought, and the things I studied on my own are all swirling around in my mind as knowledge.

I was fully prepared.

"I'll do it. I'll be the top student."

I muttered to myself, reaffirming my determination.

Leaving the dormitory, I walked while going over what I had studied.

The students around me were all carrying notebooks or studying materials.

Everyone was working hard.

But I was confident.

I put in a tremendous amount of effort.

Although Rie's sudden confession had distracted me, I quickly pulled myself together.

I can worry about that after the final exam.

Afterwards, I can...

Thud—

Suddenly, a gloomy man brushed past my shoulder.

"...?"

I looked around, confused.

Instead of apologizing, he just walked on.

"What was that?"

I was irritated, but not particularly angry.

I couldn't let my mind wander in a place like this.

I needed to focus again.

I must concentrate on the final exam.

"...But, he seemed familiar."

A man with inconspicuous black hair.

He was already far ahead, so I couldn't see him clearly.

However, he reminded me of someone.

"...Evan?"

There weren't many with black hair.

One of them was Evan.

"No way, it can't be him."

I shook my head.

Although I hadn't seen him lately, that wasn't the Evan I knew.

The Evan I knew was someone who focused and worked hard in everything he did.

He wasn't someone with such a gloomy atmosphere.

"Never mind."

I went back to reviewing my studies while heading towards the exam room.

"Then, let's start the test."

Professor Robert announced at the front of the examination room.

It felt somewhat odd seeing Robert standing at the front.

Usually, it was someone more serious, but now it was Robert, who had always had a rather casual demeanor.

I'm getting nervous.

My hands were tingling from the anxiety.

"Phew..."

As I exhaled to calm my nerves, someone touched my shoulder.

It was Robert.

As he passed by, he patted my shoulder reassuringly, as if encouraging me to do my best.

I found his gesture surprising but comforting.

It was just like him.

"Let's do this..."

I muttered to myself, soft enough for no one else to hear, and began going through the exam paper.

"The exam is now over."

Robert's voice echoed in the classroom.

I rested my head on the desk.

I wasn't sure if I did well or not.

I had been so focused that I lost track of time and didn't realize how quickly it had passed.

But I was confident that I answered every question.

As soon as I finished reviewing my answers, the test ended.

All my tension was gone, and I felt drained.

"Everyone, enjoy your summer vacation."

Robert said as he prepared to leave the classroom.

"Oh."

He stopped on his way out and looked at me.

"Rudy Astria, come to my office tomorrow morning."

"...Yes?"

I raised my head in confusion.

"I have something for you to do."

Something to do?

I couldn't think of anything Robert would ask me to do.

"What do you mean by that?"

I asked him, lifting my head to meet his gaze.

"We'll talk about it tomorrow. For now, just go and rest."

"But if you tell me to rest without..."

Before I could push further, Robert gestured behind me with a nod of his head.

"Hmm?"

Behind?

I turned to find all the students looking outside.

Outside the window, there was a woman.

Knock, knock—

She was tapping on the window from the outside.

"Ah, Astina?"

I looked at her in surprise.

We were on the 4th floor.

A height that could be deadly if an ordinary person were to fall.

So it was natural for people around to be surprised when she was outside the window.

As I approached to open the window, Astina smiled.

"Why are you suddenly outside..."

As I opened the window, Astina grabbed my hand.

"Let's go."

"What?"

Astina pulled my arm and pulled me towards the outside.

I could see the ground below.

The ground far below.

I looked back at Astina.

"No, what, what is this? Astina, I..."

"It's fine. I'll use magic."

Astina smiled and channeled her mana.

"Ah."

Suddenly, her expression changed.

"Let's just go like this."

"Huh?"

Astina suddenly lifted me, as if embracing a princess.

"No... What are you doing?"

"Food."

Astina chuckled.

"Didn't we decide to go eat?"

Well, going to eat is fine, but...

Why like this?

"Ugh...!"

With me in her arms, Astina soared into the air.

Although I'm a man and Astina is a woman...

What in the world is she doing?

"If we exit through the main gate, there'll be too many interferences."

"So, if we eat together...!!!! Ahhhhh!!!!"

As I tried to argue, Astina began flying at an incredible speed.

"We'll talk about the rest while we eat."

Luna hurried her steps.

The place she was rushing to right after the exam:

The classroom where Rudy was.

Until now, she had been waiting for Rudy.

Since he promised to give an answer, she thought she could just wait.

But she couldn't just wait for an answer indefinitely.

She'd been busy with research and studies, and Rudy was also busy, so they hadn't seen each other much.

"Today...! I have to go see him!"

Today was Rudy's birthday.

The answer is one thing, and the birthday is another.

As his friend, she should at least celebrate it.

Excited at the thought of seeing Rudy's face after so long, Luna hurried to the classroom where Rudy had taken his exam.

Arriving at the classroom where Rudy had his test...

"Hmm?"

"Huh?"

Luna and Rie ran into each other.

Luna tensed up.

Rie.

According to Ena, she was the top person to be wary of.

She met such a person in front of Rudy's classroom.

'Did... Did I come a bit late...?'

Luna flinched when she saw Rie.

'Right, right. Rie is a friend! A friend!'

Luna hid her surprised expression and smiled.

"Rie, what brings you here?"

"Ah, well..."

Rie looked at Luna with a troubled expression.

But then, her face changed.

A confident expression...!

"I came to see Rudy!"

Luna stepped back, startled by her declaration.

She was so direct...

In response, Luna clenched her fists.

"Oh, really? I came to see Rudy too."

Luna stated confidently.

'Right, there's no need to back down!'

Luna and Rie exchanged glances, each full of bravado.

It was as if they were sizing each other up; both stood tall, shoulders back.

Neither felt inferior to the other.

They didn't know about each other's affairs, so it was only natural.

"Um... Ah..."

Then, murmurs of confusion arose from around them.

For a while, the two exchanged glances before gradually coming to their senses.

The test had ended, and people were milling around.

Since they were posturing at the entrance of the classroom, people couldn't pass by.

"Ah... I'm sorry. Uh..."

"Oh, ah..."

Rie and Luna stepped aside to let others pass.

"Shall we go inside?"

"Yeah, let's."

Gone were their confident demeanors; now they both spoke cautiously.

They entered the classroom.

"Huh?"

"What?"

As they entered the classroom, they both made bewildered expressions at the same time.

Rudy was not there.

The students hadn't left yet.

But Rudy was nowhere to be found.

They would have surely seen him leave since they were right outside the classroom.

"Where did he go?"

"What's going on?"

They looked around the classroom, confused.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 150: The Eve of the Storm...! (7)

"Where is this...?"

The place Astina had brought Rudy to was her room.

"Didn't you say we were going for a meal?"

"Yes, we came to eat."

Astina had two concerns while making plans for a meal with Rudy.

The first was what to do with Luna and Rie.

She didn't want to bring them along like last time.

Weren't Luna and Rie the ones who were always with him when she wasn't around?

Astina had a desire to have Rudy all to herself.

That's why she thought of having the meal not in a public restaurant, but in the privacy of her room, where Luna and Rie would never suspect.

Who would think to have a meal in a dorm room on one's birthday?

Astina decided on the location and began preparations.

The rooms for seniors in the dormitory were quite spacious.

Large enough to accommodate a big dining table.

Astina asked people to bring a dining table into her room.

Her second concern was about the food.

She could have prepared a regular meal, but she didn't want to.

She wanted to prepare something memorable and special.

The problem was that it wasn't easy to prepare something special with food.

If she made something unique, it might not suit Rudy's taste.

But if she prepared just delicious food, it wouldn't fit the criterion of 'special'.

After much thought, Astina came to a conclusion.

Why not prepare the food she saw in Rudy's dream?

Astina had entered Rudy's dream and visited a wedding hall.

There was a buffet at the wedding venue, with dozens of dishes.

After finishing a conversation with an elder, Astina had asked if it wouldn't be a problem to eat a little bit of the food.

Astina didn't taste all the dishes but sampled a few.

She tried to recreate those dishes from her memory, both in taste and appearance.

It wasn't easy.

She didn't know the ingredients used and couldn't be sure if the flavors were accurate.

Then she remembered the restaurant in front of the academy that Robert frequented.

It was a restaurant that served bean paste stew.

A dish that Rudy was unusually obsessed with, a dish Astina had never seen in her life.

She speculated that it might be related to the food from Rudy's world.

So Astina sought advice from the grandmother who was the owner of that restaurant.

"Alright, I'll prepare a few dishes for you. Oh, and tell that Robert fellow to pay his tab. That jerk owes me a lot of money."

Thanks to the elderly lady's generous help, Astina's plan proceeded smoothly.

She couldn't fill the table solely with dishes from Rudy's world, so she combined a few delicious regular dishes, dishes she researched from Rudy's world, and dishes prepared by the elderly lady, resulting in a rich and varied menu.

"Take a seat."

Astina reached out her hand to Rudy and spoke.

"I've prepared some food. I'm not sure if it'll suit your taste."

"It doesn't matter. I'm not picky."

Even though he said that, his face didn't seem too hopeful.

"Come in."

As Astina spoke, the door to the dormitory opened, and the food was brought in from outside.

"...?"

Upon seeing the dishes, Rudy widened his eyes in disbelief.

He couldn't trust his eyes.

Not just his eyes.

The familiar aroma wasn't something he expected in a place like this.

"I tried to prepare dishes you might like. That one is 'Jeyuk Bokkeum', a stir-fried pork dish, and there's 'Japchae', a dish you seemed to like at the buffet, and over there, 'Dwaeji Galbi', that's pork ribs..."

Astina listed the names of dishes she had heard from Rudy or remembered from the grandmother.

"How did you...?"

Rudy stared at Astina, utterly surprised.

"Didn't I tell you not to bring the others?"

Astina smiled.

The others wouldn't understand these strange dishes, not knowing Rudy's background.

This was a special event only Astina could prepare, and it gave her a reason to be alone with him.

"Now, let's eat."

Rudy looked at Astina with touched eyes.

In truth, Rudy had done a lot of research trying to recreate these dishes.

However, finding similar ingredients was a challenge, and there wasn't much information available.

Even if he knew how these dishes should taste, he was unfamiliar with this world's ingredients.

He had even asked the grandmother at the restaurant...

-Choose from the restaurant menu! Why are you making this old lady work more? Once that Robert pays his debts, I'll do it! Bother your master for me!

The grandmother grumbled and refused.

The reason she had honored Astina's request was actually because of Rudy.

-You're getting this for that little Astria kid, right?"

The reason the old lady at the restaurant turned down Rudy wasn't due to laziness but her health.

She couldn't stand for long periods, so she could only cook simple dishes.

However, for Rudy's birthday, she decided to show off her skills.

"Thank you... I'll enjoy the meal."

"Yes, eat well."

Astina nodded with a proud smile.

Meanwhile.

"Hey, where is he?"

"Where could he have gone?"

Luna and Rie.

The two had formed an alliance to search for the missing Rudy.

Together, they scoured the school.

Starting from the student council room to the professors' labs.

While rummaging through the labs, they discovered something.

"Rudy? Astina took him," Robert said.

Rie and Luna exchanged surprised glances.

"I knew Astina was here, but how did she take him?"

Robert didn't provide a direct answer to that.

If they were to find out that she had claimed Rudy first using magic, he didn't know what these two would do.

Until now, it had been a cute love squabble, but using magic would escalate it into a potentially bloody conflict.

"Anyway, you should leave. I'm going home since I'm done here."

Robert said, gesturing towards the door.

"Yes... Thank you."

"Goodbye."

"Oh, Luna Railer,"

Robert called out just as they were about to leave.

"Help me tomorrow. I have some work."

"Tomorrow...?"

Luna tilted her head, a bit confused.

She didn't have any specific plans.

"Aren't you on leave tomorrow, Professor?"

Luna asked.

She remembered seeing Robert's name on the list of professors on leave.

If he was starting his vacation tomorrow, there would be no reason for him to come to the academy.

Yet, he said he had work to do tomorrow, which confused her.

Robert looked at Luna, who had her doubts.

"I'm heading to the Railer territory tomorrow. I need you to guide me."

"You're coming to our territory, Professor? If you come unannounced..."

"I'm just dropping by. No need for any formalities. Just guide me."

"But, so suddenly..."

Luna wasn't sure how to respond.

'Then... what about Rudy...!'

Luna felt a strong urge to protest to Robert.

If she went to her territory, Rie and Astina would be left with Rudy at the academy.

Anything could happen.

Seeing her hesitation, Robert glanced at Rie.

'I better not mention Rudy Astria now.'

Robert had initially intended to call Rudy to accompany him with Luna tomorrow.

Rudy had no idea, but Robert knew that Rudy would go if he asked him to, considering Rudy's personality.

Robert hadn't planned on keeping it a secret.

He had intended to discuss it after the exams, but Astina got there first.

If Rudy left, Astina would definitely follow, just as she had today.

If Rudy and Luna went together, Rie would undoubtedly want to join as well, which complicated things.

"Just do as I say. Think of it as a repayment for helping you with the mana stone synthesis."

"...Okay, I understand."

Luna replied, her face downcast.

She couldn't even celebrate Rudy's birthday and now she would be separated from him.

Her shoulders slumped.

'Professor Robert...'

She cursed Professor Robert internally.

Though the curse would turn into overwhelming gratitude the next day.

“Whew!”

Rudy let out a satisfied chuckle, patting his belly.

It had been a long time since he had eaten so happily and felt so good.

“That was delicious. Thank you so much.”

"It's your birthday, so I had to do something special."

Astina said with a smile.

“If you ever want to eat this again, just let me know. I know all the recipes, so I can ask the family chef to make it anytime.”

“The family chef?”

“Who else, besides someone from our family, could prepare such dishes? The chef is usually at the academy, so just tell me whenever you want to eat.”

“Astina...!”

Astina had thought long and hard about how to win over Rudy.

Usually, they said the best way to woo a man was through looks.

However, that was for ordinary men.

Rudy Astria was different.

If he had been an ordinary guy, he would have surely been smitten with Luna or Rie, given they were some of the most beautiful girls in the academy.

So, what should she do?

Astina decided to captivate Rudy's palate.

Win over his taste buds then win over his heart.

That was Astina's plan.

Astina, with her smile, opened her mouth to speak.

“More importantly, tell me about the Saint and the future.”

“Oh.”

Astina had come to the academy early not just for Rudy's birthday, but also to discuss the future.

About Saint Haruna and the events to come.

Astina only had a rough idea of these things, so the doubts in her mind hadn't disappeared completely.

“Understood.”

Rudy nodded, his expression turning slightly serious.

“So, Astina, you've discovered that the Saint has some relationship with dimensions, right?”

“Yes?”

“The reason I came here is because of the former Saint, Beatrice.”

“Beatrice?”

Upon hearing about the former Saint, Astina tilted her head in confusion.

“Do you know when former Saint Beatrice died?”

“...Wasn't it around the time the current Saint took her position?”

“Yes, it was about a year before I came.”

About a year before Rudy entered the academy.

Saint Beatrice had died under mysterious circumstances, and Haruna, who had been designated as her successor, took her place.

Despite the Saint's death, the church didn't do anything big.

They merely held a funeral and did not investigate the mysterious death.

People were suspicious and protested, but the church remained silent.

Eventually, as time passed, the incident was forgotten.

“That incident wasn't buried by the church.”

“What?”

“Former Saint Beatrice personally buried it.”

“Why would she do that?”

“Did you hear that the Saint has lost her vision?”

“You told me about it.”

“Yes, she lost her sight as the price for summoning my future self across dimensions.”

“Oh... So, by summoning you here...? But the timing doesn't add up?”

“A year before I took over this body...”

Rudy let out an awkward laugh.

“Actually, around that time... That's when I started to learn about this world.”

“What?”

The timing was impeccable.

The moment Rudy, in his original world, encountered this world through a game, and the date of Beatrice's death.

“The price for summoning me across dimensions. The price for letting my other-dimensional self know about this world. For that, the former Saint paid with her life.”

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 151: The Eve of the Storm...! (8)

"Haruna, please take care of things here. I'm sorry for going ahead like this."

These were Beatrice's last words.

Dimensional magic.

The ways to use this magic were diverse.

Seeing the future, turning back time, observing other worlds, or visiting them.

It was truly a miracle that made the impossible possible.

However, every miracle has its price.

That day, Haruna lost the most precious person to her.

The one who raised her, instilled values in her.

To Haruna, that person was Beatrice.

She wanted to stop her.

To ask her not to leave, to stay.

To stay together and find another way.

At these words, Beatrice shook her head.

"It's my responsibility for what happened. I believe you can manage on your own, Haruna."

Beatrice disappeared, leaving Haruna alone.

The lone Haruna resolved to carry on Beatrice's will.

To aid Rudy Astria, whom Beatrice had brought into the world...

"To stop Aryandor..."

Haruna muttered to herself.

"Aryandor..."

"He didn't reveal his exact intentions."

At Rudy's words, Astina nodded.

"The good news is that Aryandor can no longer see the future."

"He can't see the future?"

Rudy thought for a moment before speaking.

"Didn't I explain a bit about dimensional magic?"

"About space and time magic merging?"

"Yes, but it's more of an advanced combined magic."

"Advanced combined?"

Astina tilted her head in confusion.

Seeing her reaction, Rudy continued.

"In my case, I came from a different dimension, right?"

"Yes?"

"While Aryandor can see all timelines, he can't see the one I came from. Even if it's time magic, if it's related to space, he can't see it. The issue is that space magic is somewhat similar."

"Hmm... that's complicated."

Astina held her chin, pondering.

Space and time.

The barrier between them.

For Astina, it was an unexplored domain.

"That's all I found out for now."

"I see, Aryandor and... Beatrice..."

"Haruna told me not to worry about it, but wouldn't it be better to find out?"

"Yes, I'll look into it on my end."

Astina smiled.

"More importantly, how was the future you saw?"

"...It's not a pleasant story to hear."

Even Rudy didn't know much about the future.

He only knew the cause and the result.

"Astina."

"Hmm?"

Rudy looked at Astina with a straight face.

He carefully opened his mouth.

"Please, don't be surprised and listen..."

"Don't be surprised?"

Astina tilted her head.

What's so surprising about talking about the future?

It's a completely different future.

It's just something to acknowledge and move on from. There's no reason to be overly concerned.

"Go on."

Astina said to Rudy with a relaxed demeanor.

"The future I saw was a world that was already halfway destroyed."

"Oh, is that so?"

"In that world, I was very powerful, but I couldn't protect anyone."

"Right, right."

Rudy took a quick glance around.

Even after telling her this much, the lack of reaction from Astina was puzzling.

Rudy continued.

"I took others' abilities and grew without caring about my surroundings. I only believed in becoming stronger."

"Quite the opposite of now."

"But despite that, future me still failed."

Astina smirked, seemingly unimpressed.

"If you've seen that future, you just need to do better from now on."

"That's not the issue."

Rudy said seriously.

"The reason I changed so suddenly is... after you, Astina, died during this winter break."

"...What?"

Upon hearing this, Astina's expression darkened momentarily but then brightened up.

"After my death? Why? Why did you change just because I died? What... were we to each other?"

"What...?"

Rudy looked utterly confused at Astina's question.

He assumed she would take the news of her impending death seriously, but she seemed even more cheerful than usual, leaving him confused.

Astina pondered for a moment.

"If I died... and the current Rudy changed completely..."

She was deep in thought.

The death of a close person is naturally shocking.

But, for someone to change completely due to that death is a bit strange.

Such a change doesn't happen unless it's the death of a truly close individual.

So then...

Astina half rose from her seat, leaned on the table, and stretched towards Rudy.

"By any chance... were we in a romantic relationship?"

"Pardon?"

"Did we date or... oh."

Astina stopped herself quickly and regained her composure.

She cleared her throat and sat back down.

"Ahem... no, forget it. I was just curious."

"I didn't see the future in great detail, so... I wouldn't know about that. I can't look into it again either..."

Rudy gave an awkward smile.

"Anyway... I need to prepare well if I'm going to die. So, Rudy, have some tea..."

BANG—

As Astina was about to say something, a loud noise echoed from the door.

"...Would you like some tea?"

Ignoring the noise, Astina smiled.

Rudy glanced between the door and Astina.

"Um... what was that noise?"

"Don't worry about it. Now, let's have tea..."

BANG BANG BANG—

"...Let me prepare it."

"Maybe you should check outside..."

Ignoring Rudy's suggestion, Astina calmly went to prepare the tea.

"Astina!!! I know he's in there!!! Rudy!!"

Rie's voice came from outside.

Astina paused from preparing the tea and shot a glance towards the door.

"Sigh... How did she find out?"

"Senior...?"

Astina walked to the door and opened it.

Sure enough, outside stood Rie and Luna.

Behind Rie was Sylph.

"What's going on?"

"Is Rudy inside?"

Rie boldly asked.

Astina looked at Sylph.

"Isn't it against the rules to use a spirit to look inside dorm rooms? Did the rules change while I was away?"

"Regardless! Rudy's in there, isn't he?!"

Astina gazed cheekily at Rie.

"He's not."

“He is!”

Astina and Rie bickered like children.

“Ahaha...”

Luna, standing to the side, chuckled awkwardly and tried to peek inside.

Astina quickly moved in front of Luna.

“That's an invasion of privacy. Why are you trying to look inside?”

“Then give me Rudy!”

“What does it matter if Rudy is here? He's just where he wants to be.”

Rie glared straight at Astina, fuming.

“Uh... Rudy~. Are you in there?”

Luna called softly into the room.

“Um... I'm here...”

“He's not.”

Just as Rudy tried to respond from inside, Astina loudly drowned out his voice.

“He is!!!”

“Astina...”

Contrary to her usual dignified demeanor, Astina was acting quite childish.

Realizing this, she sighed.

“Yes, Rudy is here. But he's here because he 'wants to be' in this 'place', with the 'person' he 'wants to be with'. What business is it of yours? Do you

even have the right to behave like this?"

Astina emphasized that Rudy was with her of his own volition.

Of course, Rudy had been somewhat coerced by Astina to come, but the truth wasn't important.

She just needed to deflate these overzealous kids.

"We do care! We have every right!"

Rie shouted back at Astina.

Astina frowned.

"What?"

Rie clenched her fist tightly.

Her face turned redder, and she hung her head.

Then she shouted loudly.

"He's, he's my husband! I can worry about what my husband is doing, can't I?"

"...What?"

"Huh?"

Both Luna and Astina looked at Rie with bewildered expressions.

Rudy, with a greatly surprised face, rushed towards the door.

"No, no. Hey! Uh..."

Astina and Luna stared coldly at Rudy.

"Rudy Astria. What is all this about?"

"Rudy? What's that supposed to mean?"

Sensing the tense atmosphere, Rudy took a step back.

"Hey! What are you talking about..."

"He even took my first kiss!!!"

"Rudy?????"

"Rudy Astria?"

Under the cold gazes of Luna and Astina, Rudy's face turned pale blue.

"Haah..."

When the commotion subsided,

Astina remained alone in her room, deep in thought.

She never imagined Rie would confess like that.

She hadn't expected the proud Rie to take the initiative.

Fortunately, it wasn't a set in stone yet.

From Rudy's explanation, it didn't feel like he had accepted her confession.

After all, Rie had blurted out about their engagement and then ran away.

Still, the situation was dangerous.

"Damn..."

She hadn't expected such an event after being away for just half a year.

It was brushed off casually now, but later on, it might become an established fact.

"I can't just stand by."

Astina clenched her fist.

With a sigh, Astina murmured and then chuckled.

"He feels quite different from before."

The old Rudy Astria felt like he was from a different world.

He was swept up in major events, always at the center of it all.

However, his usual demeanor was quite contrasting.

He seemed more like a spectator.

A spectator observing how situations around him unfolded.

And that Rudy, who was like a spectator, always jumped into action during crucial moments.

"A game, he said?"

She had a vague understanding of it after hearing Rudy's story earlier.

Experiences and stories from another medium, not reality.

They were mere characters in that narrative.

However, Rudy now felt a bit different.

The feeling of him being distant and strange had vanished.

He began to genuinely look at and acknowledge his surroundings.

Was it because he had seen his old world within a dream?

Or because Rie had sincerely confessed?

Maybe due to several other events that occurred before.

It was hard to pinpoint the exact reason.

All she knew was that the once passive Rudy was no more.

The walls that stood between them had already crumbled, and now whoever took the initiative would be the owner.

"If I had known this would happen, I would have made my move first."

Astina muttered to herself.

Still, Astina believed she had a chance.

Rudy from the future had clearly said he changed because of her.

This held some significance.

It meant she had enough influence on Rudy to change him.

It signified that Rudy valued her to that extent.

"Let's give it a shot."

Astina said with a confident smile.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 152: Railer Territory (1)

Awkward silence filled the air.

The only sound I could hear was the creaking of the carriage.

Robert, who was sleeping next to me, looked pitiful.

I lifted my head slightly and glanced ahead.

Luna was sitting across from me.

She had her arms crossed and was staring at me intently.

I couldn't bring myself to meet her gaze.

We were currently heading to the Railer Territory.

How did this happen?

This morning, as Robert had mentioned yesterday, I went to the laboratory.

Luna was there.

I wanted to flee.

What happened yesterday.

I tried to explain, but the misunderstanding wasn't completely cleared up.

It wasn't a good situation.

With things like this, I couldn't just casually talk to Luna.

Of course, I knew that if I didn't speak, nothing would change.

But speaking to her right the next day was difficult.

So I tried to avoid going to the laboratory where Luna was.

I spotted Luna, but she hadn't noticed me yet.

Running away seemed like the best option.

"Where are you going?"

Just as I attempted to move, Professor Robert, who was behind me, grabbed the back of my collar.

I looked at Robert, who had detained me, with pleading eyes.

"I have... a real reason..."

Robert snorted at my response.

"What kind of reason...? Nevermind. You have to go anyway."

"Excuse me?"

"Go pack your things."

I stared at Robert, confused.

"We're heading to the Railer territory right now. Pack your stuff and meet me in front of the main building in 20 minutes."

And that's how I was 'kidnapped' by Professor Robert.

Actually, I felt positive about going somewhere with Professor Robert.

I thought that being away from the academy for a while to gather my thoughts would be good.

The issue was that the person accompanying us was Luna, and we were heading to her hometown, the Railer territory.

And now, silence.

Only the sounds of horseshoes and rolling wheels could be heard.

It felt as if I was walking on thin ice.

Luna just looked at me, saying nothing, while Robert fell asleep as soon as he got into the carriage, complaining of a hangover.

I try to gauge Luna's mood.

The usual warmth in her eyes was gone; they were cold.

Arms crossed, her expression seemed to say, 'If you have something to say, say it.'

In such a situation, who could open their mouth?

I had taken the initiative to confess something to Luna.

And in that situation, out of the blue, Rie came saying I was engaged to her.

Even if I had a hundred mouths, I wouldn't have an explanation.

If I were in her shoes, I'd be just as flabbergasted.

Of course, nothing was set in stone about the engagement.

It was just a topic of conversation for now, nothing definite.

Still, it weighed on my conscience.

Imagine how shocking it'd be if someone you liked suddenly announced they might marry your friend.

“.....”

“Hmm.....?”

I kept my head down, lost in thought.

“Ah.....”

After a while, Robert woke up.

“I had a good sleep.”

Robert stretched lazily and alternated his gaze between the two of us.

“What's with this mood?”

“It's nothing.....”

“...Yes, it's nothing.”

Luna responded as if taking a cue from my words.

Robert narrowed his eyes at us, then seemingly brushed it off with a shrug.

“Hey! How much longer?”

Robert shouted out the window.

He was addressing the coachman.

“We're almost at the Gotram territory!”

“...Gotram?”

As I looked confused, Robert explained.

“Going straight to the Railer territory would be too far, so we decided to stop at a territory on the way. I have someone to meet there too.”

I felt relieved hearing this.

Being in the carriage for so long was hellish.

Especially with Luna's icy stares and my reluctance to even speak.

“Thank you.....”

“...? No need for thanks.”

“We'll arrive at the territory soon!”

I sighed with relief at the coachman's words.

‘Rudy is such an idiot.’

Luna grimaced and shot Rudy a glare.

Rudy said nothing, hanging his head as if he'd done something wrong.

Seeing him like that only added to Luna's frustration.

Normally, Rudy handled things straightforwardly, but he was always awkward when it came to matters involving women.

‘Damn it... seriously...’

Luna brooded over the situation.

The carriage they were in entered Gotram territory.

Gotram wasn't a particularly large territory.

It was just an average territory.

The most peculiar thing about it was its utter lack of peculiarities.

The carriage stopped at a moderately-sized inn in Gotram.

Then all disembarked in front of the inn.

Upon stepping out, Rudy let out a sigh of relief, his face showing a hint of life.

“We can rest here for now. Rudy and I will stay in room 305, and Luna, you'll be in 306 alone.”

Robert tossed keys to Luna and Rudy.

“I have somewhere to be, so just relax. And don't get into trouble.”

With that, Robert left the inn.

Rudy, watching Robert leave, sneaked a glance at Luna.

Seeing this, Luna pursed her lips in annoyance.

"Annoying."

“...!”

"Why don't you say something? Did I ever tell you not to say anything?"

"...No, it's not like that."

"What's the matter? We're going to be together for a week, are you not going to talk to me the whole time?"

“...No.”

Luna stared at Rudy, who looked completely deflated.

This morning, Luna had been thrilled when Professor Robert said he'd be taking Rudy with him.

Even though something strange had happened yesterday, the news of a trip with just Rudy had been very exciting for Luna.

She had expected it to be a fun trip, but Rudy's demeanor made her feel upset and frustrated.

Seeing Rudy looking so regretful and not saying anything was infuriating.

She actually wanted him to come out with confidence.

It was an incident caused by Rie and it wasn't actually a big deal.

How great it would be if he could just say that.

If he had, Luna might have been willing to forgive him.

However, Rudy did not show such an attitude.

"So, you're saying that's how it's going to be?"

Luna, seeming to have made up her mind, glared at Rudy as she spoke.

The incident caused by Rie.

It happened all of a sudden without any warning.

There was no reason why Luna couldn't do something like that.

Rie was the one who had crossed the line first.

"Rudy!"

Luna pointed her finger at Rudy.

Rudy looked at Luna with a puzzled expression.

"I'm going to make you fall in love with me by the time we go back to the academy."

"What?"

"You'll be so into me that you won't even look at anyone else. So, be prepared!"

Though she spoke with confidence, Luna's face gradually turned red.

"Ah..."

Rudy blankly stared at Luna.

Luna, with one hand on her hip, pointed at herself dramatically.

“Tr, try to resist! Try to fight it!”

With that, Luna turned to run into her room.

“Ah.”

But Luna paused, sneaking a glance back.

“Ac, actually, it might be better if you did fall for me. So, don’t resist too hard...”

With her face turning as red as a tomato, Luna shyly said this before rushing into her room.

“Rudy is gone?”

Astina had made a big resolution last night.

And now, Rudy was missing.

“Suddenly? How? Someone plotting something?”

“...It doesn't seem like that. I heard Professor Robert took him somewhere.”

Rie replied with a serious face.

Astina and Rie were in a very serious situation.

Both Luna and Rudy had disappeared.

The only information they had was that Professor Robert had taken them somewhere.

Neither the destination nor the reason for taking them was known.

Of course, Rie knew where the two had gone.

She had heard the story Robert told Luna while looking for Astina with her yesterday.

However, she cleverly hid this fact from Astina.

Astina was a formidable competitor.

There was no reason to provide her with such valuable information.

Astina, unaware, frowned.

"I'm finally here and Rudy disappears."

"What will you do?"

Rie, looking at Astina, spoke.

In her hand, she held a bag.

"Are you going to search for him?"

"If my husband disappeared with another woman, of course, I should follow."

Astina narrowed her eyes at Rie's confident demeanor.

"You're not even engaged yet, what do you mean 'husband'?"

"Ah, anyway. He's my husband! Don't you dare look down on me!"

Rie proudly stated, showing no embarrassment about calling him her husband.

Astina didn't like it, but she didn't comment further.

"Hmm..."

Astina pondered.

Should she go with Rie to find Rudy?

She had no information.

All she knew was that Luna and Rudy had been taken.

They deliberately didn't tell anyone, to the point where even Borval, who was closest to Robert, didn't know where he went.

"Where are you going then?"

"Why, are you going to follow me?"

Rie glared at Astina.

"No, I'll go separately."

"Separately?"

Rie was surprised to hear that Astina was going separately.

In fact, if Astina were to follow, she had prepared several strategies to shake her off.

'I guess it's better this way?'

Rie laughed inwardly at Astina's words.

She knew where Luna and Rudy had gone, but Astina didn't.

"Well then, I'll go ahead."

Astina waved her hand to Rie.

"Sure, I hope we don't meet."

"I hope the same Astina~."

Rie made a "tch-" sound, sticking her tongue out playfully as she walked away.

Watching Rie's retreating figure, Astina murmured to herself.

"Then let's search."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 153: Railer Territory (2)

"Man, what a day!"

"Here, bring me a pint of lager!"

The tavern buzzed with activity.

Though it wasn't very spacious, it was filled with people.

This wasn't your average tavern.

It also served as a gathering place for mercenaries, so it was bustling with mercenaries who had just finished their jobs.

Into this establishment walked a man.

While his clothes were tidy, the sparse and unkempt beard he sported didn't make him stand out amongst the mercenaries.

He walked slowly and took a seat at the counter.

"What can I get you?"

As he settled into his seat, a young girl approached and asked him.

"A pint of lager and call the owner over."

"Pardon?"

The girl looked puzzled at his request.

This place was a gathering place for mercenaries.

If he was asking for the owner, he was essentially asking for the master of this place.

This wasn't someone who'd just come out because he was asked.

"Um... I'm not sure if I can get the master to..."

"You don't have to force him to come. Just tell him Robert is here."

The girl eyed Robert up and down.

His attire seemed somewhat upscale, but he himself didn't look too impressive.

He gave off the aura of an ordinary man.

If she wanted to call the owner, she could.

However, she wasn't the type of person who would call the owner for someone she didn't even know.

Would the owner move just because someone called him, without knowing their identity?

'Drunkard, perhaps?'

Yet he seemed too sober for that.

After some thought, the girl remembered the name Robert.

Among mercenaries, Robert was a name one couldn't possibly not know.

A demon who masked his face and dominated the battlefield.

Despite possessing immense magical abilities, he acted as a mercenary.

This legendary figure hid his identity and always remained behind a mask.

Before his true identity was revealed.

The owner occasionally spoke of him.

He claimed to be friends with Robert, but no one ever believed him.

Everyone dismissed it as the owner's drunken nonsense.

The problem was that because of the owner's words, there were people who occasionally came pretending to be Robert.

The girl briefly looked at him, then turned away.

‘He must be another imposter.’

"I'll pass on the message for now..."

Robert didn't respond.

The girl gave Robert another glance before moving on, not to fetch the owner, but to continue her tavern duties.

After Luna made her bold declaration.

She sat in her room, hugging a pillow, lost in thought.

"Oh, what have I done..."

Just what kind of confidence did she have to say such a thing?

Luna gripped her head and screamed.

Although she had declared it so confidently, Luna hadn't really prepared anything.

Without anyone like Ena nearby, there's no one to ask for love advice.

She had to figure it out on her own.

"How could I possibly charm Rudy..."

She had nothing.

When Ena offered her a love potion, she should have accepted it.

"No... What's the point of relying on something like that?"

She wanted Rudy to like her for who she is, not for superficial reasons.

Luna shook her head several times and looked out the window.

Smoke rose from the chimneys, and the sunset painted the horizon.

It was the calm atmosphere of a peaceful city.

Though there were many people for a rural domain, it wouldn't be considered bustling.

It felt similar to the atmosphere of other domains near the Railer territory that could be called cities.

"At least I know a bit about a place like this..."

She could take the lead when going on a date.

It meant she could naturally take Rudy along with her.

However, Luna didn't think of it as something anyone could do.

After daydreaming about her date with Rudy, Luna clenched her fists.

"Yes, let's be bold. Really bold."

Luna immediately got up from her seat and headed towards Rudy's room.

"Rudy, hello..."

When Luna knocked, Rudy came out.

"Oh, uh... Luna?"

Rudy greeted her with a seemingly flustered face.

It hadn't been long since Luna declared,

'I'm going to make you fall in love with me!'

Having made such a declaration and then immediately coming to see him must have surprised him.

"Well... we should... have dinner, right?"

"Yes?"

"Why don't we go out instead of eating at the inn? Just a quick stroll around..."

After pondering for a moment, Rudy nodded.

Seeing Rudy's agreement, Luna broke into a broad smile.

"Then, in 20 minutes! Let's meet in front of the inn!"

"Okay, I'll change my clothes and come out."

It hadn't been long since they entered the room, so they were still in their school uniforms.

Walking around in uniforms would draw too much attention.

Academy students were always the center of attention, so changing was a good idea.

With that, Luna returned to her room and looked at the clothes she had laid out on her bed.

"Will this do?"

It was an outfit she had prepared before going to Rudy's room.

It wasn't flashy, but it was a pretty dress.

It was perfect to showcase Luna's cuteness and innocence.

"Yes! I'll give it a try!"

Luna nodded and muttered to herself.

Quickly changing, Luna immediately went to the front of the inn.

Maybe because she changed so fast, Rudy wasn't out yet.

"Phew..."

Luna, who always took appointment times seriously, let out a sigh of relief.

However, she suddenly remembered what Ena had said.

A promise with a man is always 10 minutes late.

She said a woman's charm was in playing hard to get.

"Ah..."

Luna recalled those words and let out a regretful sigh.

"Should I... go back in?"

As she pondered this and took a step towards the door, she saw Rudy descending the stairs.

She couldn't go in now.

The inn was small, and there was only one staircase.

There was no other entrance.

"I... I should hide first!"

Luna spotted a small patch of bushes next to the inn.

They were short bushes.

Quickly, Luna moved to hide in them.

Once inside, a concern crossed her mind.

“How do I get out from here?”

She had agreed to meet Rudy in front of the inn and now she was hiding right there in the bushes.

If she came out of the bushes, she'd surely be seen by Rudy.

She couldn't let that happen.

She couldn't show such a pathetic sight when she was supposed to display her charm.

Luna swiftly emerged from the bushes.

“Ah.”

“Huh?”

As she bolted out, Rudy was right there in front of her.

The two locked eyes and stood in stunned silence.

Luna was wearing a dress adorned with pretty floral patterns, but in her rush from the bushes, leaves had gotten caught in her hair and on her dress.

Rudy, alternating his gaze between the flowers and leaves, rubbed his chin and said,

“...Decorations?”

“No, not at all!”

At Rudy's comment, Luna brushed off her dress.

“I dropped something in the bushes and went to pick it up!”

Luna said this, thinking it was a good excuse.

At that, Rudy smirked mischievously.

“What did you drop?”

"W-What did I drop?"

Luna was caught off guard by the unexpected question.

“Um... well...”

She couldn't answer and just shifted her eyes around.

She hadn't brought anything that she could've dropped.

She didn't need to bring money since Professor Robert had given it to Rudy, and the only valuable she had was her magic book, which she had placed in her small bag.

She was wearing the bag over her shoulder, so she couldn't have dropped it.

While Luna was deep in thought, Rudy chuckled.

“Why were you hiding there?”

Rudy brushed the leaves off Luna's hair.

Luna stared intently at him.

Rudy was wearing clothes that seemed too lavish to be ordinary but didn't have the boots that nobles usually wore.

However, anyone could tell he was of noble birth by looking at his face and hair.

Seeing Rudy in different attire than usual and brushing off her clothes made Luna's face turn increasingly red.

"Uh..."

Luna lowered her head, trying to hide her flushed face.

Rudy gently tapped Luna's head and spoke up.

"I'm hungry. Let's go eat."

With that, the two walked into town and entered a nearby restaurant.

They didn't go in with a specific place in mind but simply chose the one that looked the most appealing in the area.

Since they had Professor Robert's money anyway, they wanted to eat the best.

"Rudy, what will you have?"

"Um... I don't really mind, anything is fine."

"In that case! I'll have this pasta, and would you like a steak?"

"Why?"

"Because I want to taste both! We can share!"

Luna said with a chuckle.

Her plan was simple.

Order two dishes, then when she wants to try Rudy's food, she would ask him to feed her.

Or, she could feed her dish to Rudy.

If either of the two scenarios played out, she would consider it a win.

"Excuse me."

However, Rudy, having had a similar experience with Rie before, spoke up.

"I'll have one sirloin steak and this pasta here..."

Rudy sneaked a glance at Luna before continuing.

"...And could you bring us individual plates for sharing? Like two sets of tableware."

"...What?"

Luna stared in surprise.

"Yes, understood. We'll get it ready right away."

"Oh, no..."

Luna stammered, prompting the server to look at her curiously.

"Is there a problem?"

"Um..."

It wasn't like she could ask them to prepare only one set of tableware now.

"No, it's okay..."

Looking a bit dejected, Luna watched the server leave.

"So, what's the matter?"

Rudy teased with a playful grin.

"You... You did that on purpose!"

"You said to resist, so I thought I'd resist as best I could."

"I said it'd be better if you did fall for me..."

Luna murmured shyly.

A short while later, they finished their meal and left the restaurant.

"You could have let me feed you just once!"

"No."

"Ugh..."

Luna was fervently protesting to Rudy.

She hadn't even expected Rudy to feed her the steak or pasta.

She just wanted to try feeding him once.

However, Rudy rejected the idea, dodging her attempts with determination.

Rudy was firm in his refusal.

He said if she could charm him, he'd let her feed him a hundred times, but until she did, it was a no-go.

"You're so mean..."

Luna muttered, glaring at Rudy, when suddenly -

CLANK!

"Hm?"

"Huh?"

A loud noise echoed nearby.

It sounded like something had been shattered.

The sudden noise captured the attention of the peaceful town's residents.

"What was that?"

Both Luna and Rudy moved towards the source of the sound.

It came from a tavern.

People were rushing out of the tavern, and loud noises continued from within.

Crash—

"Ah, there's someone inside..."

"Watch out!"

The voices of the people around sounded panicky, but the situation didn't seem that dangerous.

The building wasn't on fire, and the walls weren't broken down.

There was just a loud noise coming from inside.

"You've grown quite a bit, haven't you?"

Then, a voice echoed from within.

Upon hearing it, Rudy and Luna exchanged glances.

"This voice..."

"...Sounds like Professor Robert."

Having said that, the two slowly walked into the building.

"Hey, kids! If you go in there...!"

Someone tried to dissuade them from entering.

However, they paid no mind.

Having gone through countless battles, they didn't feel much danger from a situation like this.

As they entered, the intact interior of a tavern was in sight.

Apart from some chairs knocked over by people evacuating, there wasn't much damage to the tables or other areas as one might have expected.

"What's going on?"

Rudy said so and looked up at the second floor.

Since the first floor had a clear view of the second floor, they could see it just by raising their heads.

There stood Professor Robert, pinning a sturdy-looking man beneath his feet.

Despite the man's imposing build, he was unable to take any action and could only struggle beneath Robert's feet.

"...Professor, what are you doing?"

Rudy asked with a baffled expression.

"Oh, is that you, Rudy?"

Robert responded while adjusting his sleeves.

"Just disciplining this guy a bit. You can head back to the inn first."

"Please, please spare me!!"

The man below let out a loud scream.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 154: Railer Territory (3)

The Mercenary Guild typically serves as a bridge between mercenaries and others in need of their services.

If a task is entrusted to the Mercenary Guild, they match the job with a suitable mercenary who's currently available.

It was a beneficial arrangement for both the person assigning the task and the mercenaries themselves.

However, the commission taken by the guild was quite a lot.

It was often said that while the mercenaries did the work, the guild took the money.

The reason the guild could operate and take such a high commission was due to the masters of the Mercenary Guild.

Each region has its own master of the Mercenary Guild, and these masters are highly skilled.

They are usually the top mercenaries who have made a name for themselves in that region.

The master of a region's Mercenary Guild is not someone to be trifled with.

They have the backing of the guild, wield significant influence in their region, and possess formidable personal power, making them untouchable even by the nobility.

So, it was no wonder that people fled when Robert hit one of these masters.

"I apologize..."

The master of the Mercenary Guild, with his swollen face, was apologizing to Robert.

He was so badly beaten that his original facial features were hardly recognizable.

Robert, flexing his wrist, began to speak.

"You've grown arrogant."

The master coughed in response.

Here's what happened:

Robert called for the master and was downstairs having a drink.

Somehow, a mix-up occurred, and the message never reached the master.

He then personally went to see the master.

The master's room was on the second floor of a bar.

Robert boldly walked up and knocked on the master's door.

However, the master treated him like an impostor and hurled insults at him.

That's when Robert lost his temper.

"What's the history between you two?" I asked.

"Worthless scum."

"W-Worthless scum...? Weren't we comrades?"

"What else do you call someone who just carried my luggage and followed me around from behind?"

The man, known as the master, couldn't respond to Robert's words.

"When did Professor Robert associate with such people..."

"Wait... Robert, you became a professor?"

Robert gave the master a cold stare.

The master quickly covered his mouth with his hand.

Robert turned away,

"I had some wandering years. I got involved with these types."

I didn't ask any further and kept my mouth shut.

Perhaps this was before he joined the academy?

I heard that before Professor Cromwell brought him to the academy, Robert had quite an eventful past.

Robert turned his attention back to the master.

"Jack, you have a task to do."

"A task?"

"Find someone for me."

Robert threw a scroll he was holding to the man named Jack.

"Find out by tomorrow night."

Jack unfolded the scroll Robert had thrown to him.

"This, by tomorrow night? Ah, no, I can't do it. Besides, I'd go to jail for doing this!"

"So, you're more afraid of jail than me now?"

"Hmm..."

Jack covered his mouth with his hand again.

He was a large man, but he couldn't move a muscle out of fear.

"Well, why don't you come inside and talk for now..."

Jack said this and then looked outside.

"Ahem! Business ends here for today! An important guest has arrived, so I'm closing the shop!"

Jack shouted outside with a dignified attitude, different from when he was dealing with Robert.

People were puzzled, but seeing the master saying so, they figured it must be the case and started to leave.

"By the way... who are you?"

"Oh, we are disciples of Professor Robert."

"Disciples? He took in disciples?"

Jack looked at Robert with a bewildered face.

"They're just some guys I taught a few spells under me."

"...Isn't that called a disciple?"

Robert then gave him a sharp look.

Avoiding Robert's gaze, Jack looked at us.

"Ahem, well, you guys come in too."

With that, we entered the room of the Mercenary Guild Master.

Jack opened the scroll Robert had given him on the desk.

The content written on the scroll was related to investigating Ephomos.

"Do you not realize that investigating matters related to Ephomos is illegal?"

"That's why I asked you. Mercenaries like you might know better."

Ephomos.

A city underground known as the underbelly of the capital.

The empire's capital is highly sophisticated and beautifully decorated.

People dress well, and it's so clean that not a single piece of trash can be found.

The reason for its maintenance is the existence of this underground city.

Ephomos was once an underground city where the poor of the capital lived.

Because of this city, the empire faced headaches.

With Ephomos around, public order in the capital deteriorated, and the poor, protecting each other, made it harder to catch criminals.

During such troubling times, the empire discovered something.

Dark Wizards in Ephomos were researching necromancy.

In the end, the empire used that as an excuse to wipe out Ephomos entirely.

"How do you research a vanished city now... The empire should have all the related materials."

"The empire doesn't have the materials."

"...What?"

"I went to the empire myself and asked people of the empire to investigate, but all the materials are gone."

Hearing this, my eyes widened.

"I have a rough idea who might have done it..."

Robert said, sneaking a glance at me.

The Astria family?

Why would they?

Although I was puzzled, I continued to listen.

"The Empire has only just realized the data is missing and is frantically searching for it. You should look into it as well."

"How am I supposed to find something even the Empire can't?"

"Mercenaries will do anything for the right price, won't they?"

Robert took out a pouch and threw it to Jack.

Thud—

The pouch landed heavily on the desk.

Jack looked at Robert as if questioning what it was.

Robert casually replied,

"Gold coins."

"Excuse me?"

Even though it was a small pouch, it was larger than a grown man's fist.

If it was filled with gold coins, there would be at least a hundred or more.

An amount that would strain even the nobility, and for commoners, it was enough to live comfortably for a lifetime.

"That amount should suffice, right?"

"...Leave it to me, Sir. I, Jack, will do my utmost to find out!"

Seeing the amount, Jack hastily stood up and said that.

However, he quickly changed his expression to a more pleading one, glancing around.

"But... one day might be too tough... Can I have some more time...?"

"Alright, 5 days."

He probably intended to give him 5 days from the start.

It would be enough time for us to visit the Railer Territory.

He said it as if he was showing mercy.

"I will serve you faithfully!!!"

Jack replied with a loud voice overflowing with gratitude.

"So... who are you two?"

Jack sat in front of Luna and me, asking.

Robert sat on the other side of the room, eating his meal.

While we had already eaten, Robert hadn't, so he was eating separately.

"We're academy students."

"Ahaha..."

"Students? So, you use magic, handle elementals, and such?"

"Yes, we're from the magic department, so we know how to use magic."

There's no need to mention Priscilla...

It didn't seem like he was asking out of genuine curiosity.

It felt more like a casual question, so I kept my answer brief.

"Wow! So, you'll probably become nobles in the future. But shouldn't you be studying? Is it okay to roam around like this?"

"It's our vacation, so we have some free time. Our teacher wanted us to go, what could we possibly say against it?"

"Oh... Your circumstances seem similar to mine."

Jack looked at us with a sympathetic gaze.

"To be under someone like that at such a young age... But still, he's become much milder compared to before."

Jack said, looking up as if reminiscing.

I didn't miss that and immediately spoke up.

"How was Professor Robert in the past?"

That was precisely what I had been curious about.

Even if I asked professors like Robert or Cromwell, they never answered this question.

But this Jack person seemed like he would spill everything if he got a little excited.

"Heh... Back in the day, Professor Robert was like a real devil... No, he summoned demons, so he was a devil, right?"

"Oh? How long have you known Professor Robert?"

"Professor Robert? Maybe... since he was expelled from the empire?"

Upon hearing that, my eyes widened in surprise.

They've known each other for quite some time, haven't they?

I thought they might have met once or twice, but this was unexpected.

"Thinking back to those times... I was quite brave."

Jack shivered, making a face as if recalling something terrifying.

"But, back then, even Professor Robert was young... and so was I."

"Hmm... I see..."

"Did I say something weird in front of the kids? Heh heh..."

Jack got lost in his memories for a moment, then laughed it off.

Seeing him like this, he didn't seem like a bad person.

"But seeing him take on a disciple, he has changed a lot... Back in the day..."

"You talk too much."

Professor Robert interjected while eating, glancing back slightly.

This was a chance to learn Robert's secret, and it was a bit disappointing.

How much does this man hide about himself?

I could understand to some extent, but it was frustrating as someone close to him.

"Hmm. Let's talk about something else then. Right, I didn't catch your names. What are your names?"

At Jack's question, Luna and I exchanged glances.

This was a tricky question.

It would be better not to reveal our names if we wanted information from Jack...

"So, what's the name of the pretty one here?"

"Uh... I'm Luna Railer..."

"Hmm...?"

Jack furrowed his brows upon hearing Luna's name.

"What? You're a noble, aren't you?"

"Ahaha... I'm just a noble in name."

"Where can you find a noble who is just a noble in name? If you're a noble, then you're a noble."

Jack commented, stroking his chin.

"Railer? Are you from that region?"

"Yes... it's a countryside territory..."

"Ah, that place... Hmm..."

I tilted my head, curious about his reaction.

What was the status of the Railer territory to elicit such a response?

I had a rough idea since it was a rural area, but I wondered how low of a level.

Jack then turned his gaze to me.

"So, what about you?"

"Rudy... Just call me Rudy."

I deliberately left out my family name.

It would be awkward for both of us if the name 'Astria' suddenly came up.

"Rudy? Hmm... Not a very masculine name, but it suits you nonetheless."

"Ahaha... Thank you."

"But you seem to be quite athletic! Your physique is quite manly!"

Jack playfully punched me as he commented.

"Did you work out to protect your girlfriend?"

"No, not really..."

"What do you mean, 'not really'? Especially with such a pretty girlfriend."

Jack gestured towards Luna standing next to me.

At that, Luna's expression brightened.

"Are you shy? This is the moment to score points with your girlfriend! Just say you worked out because of her."

"No... It's not like that..."

"Do we look good together?"

Suddenly, Luna, with sparkling eyes, asked Jack.

"Oh, um? Yes, you both are a perfect match!"

Luna smiled slyly and looked at me.

"Rudy, we look good together."

"..."

I responded with an awkward smile to Luna's statement.

"Well, let's get going."

At that moment, Robert stood up to speak.

Jack also rose, bowing his head at a 90-degree angle.

"Then, until next time."

Robert looked at Jack and then at me.

"Hmm..."

Seeing no response from Robert, Jack lifted his head slightly to look at him.

"Do you have something to say?"

Robert hesitated for a moment before moving away.

"It's okay. I'm leaving."

"Yes! Take care!"

Receiving a hearty farewell from Jack, we exited the store.

The next morning.

Knock, knock—

There was a knocking sound at the door.

"Ugh... What now?"

I sat up and looked beside me.

Robert, who should have been sleeping on the adjacent bed, was nowhere in sight.

Knock, knock, knock—

Another series of knocks echoed.

"Ahem. Who is it?"

Still groggy from sleep, I cleared my throat and shouted.

"Open the door."

"...Yes?"

"Open it, Rudy Astria."

"..."

An authoritative, commanding tone.

A woman's voice.

Slowly, I got up and opened the door.

"Why are you here...?"

Outside stood Astina.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 155: Railer Territory (4)

“Ugh...”

“Mm~ This food is delicious.”

There were four people at the table, having breakfast.

Luna was eating, her demeanor much like that of a frightened puppy.

Opposite her sat Astina.

Robert and I alternated glances between the two as we ate our own meals.

Seeing this, Robert quietly asked me,

“What exactly happened here?”

I could only respond with an awkward smile.

Astina had suddenly shown up.

I wonder how she had managed to find us.

Even when I asked Astina how, she only smiled without giving an answer.

"This... shouldn't be happening..."

"Hmm~? What's wrong, Luna?"

"...Ugh. It's nothing."

At Astina's question, Luna looked disheartened.

Though she had declared her intentions to charm me during the trip, Astina's sudden appearance seemed to have thrown her plans into disarray.

Professor Robert observed Astina in silence for a moment before speaking.

“Astina, it doesn't matter that you've come, but I won't be providing you with meals, accommodation, or transportation.”

Though Robert spoke firmly, Astina merely responded with a slight smile.

“That's fine. I didn't come expecting any of that.”

Saying so, Astina cast a fleeting glance my way.

"Is everyone ready then?"

We nodded in response to Robert's question.

Two carriages stood before us.

One was for Luna, Robert, and myself.

The other, parked a distance away, was the one Astina had arranged for herself.

“Alright, get on.”

With Robert's words, I got into the carriage.

As I took my seat, Luna also entered.

“Hmm?”

Luna then moved closer to me.

As I looked at her in confusion, she simply took the seat next to me without a word.

“Luna?”

In response, Luna snuggled up to me, holding onto my sleeve.

“Why...?”

She looked at me as if questioning what the problem was.

“...Never mind.”

It seemed she wanted to make some kind of move, given that Astina wasn't in this carriage.

But then...

“...?”

Robert climbed into the carriage and looked in our direction.

For some reason, Luna was snuggled up right next to me.

“Hmm.”

“Ugh...”

When Robert stared intently, Luna, perhaps feeling a bit embarrassed, shifted a little away from me.

There was no way Luna could do anything when Robert was in the carriage with us.

Luna was already quite shy even in front of me, so how could she openly cling to me in front of Professor Robert?

Robert observed the two of us for a moment before taking a seat opposite us and starting a conversation.

"Should I get off?"

"Oh, no! That's..."

As Robert spoke, Luna extended her hand and said.

Her face reddened and looked unsure of what to do.

Still, she pouted her lips and looked at me with a disappointed expression.

Her eyes hinted that she might do something even in Robert's presence.

It was a gaze like that of a predator eying its prey.

While Luna might be looking at me with such intentions, to me, it just looked like an innocent puppy giving me a threatening look.

I couldn't help but chuckle.

"Let's set off."

"Understood!"

With Robert's words, the carriage began to move.

As time slowly passed,

The carriage started to shake heavily.

The roads near the academy were reasonably well-maintained, so it didn't shake this much, but as we approached the Railer territory, the carriage's shakes intensified.

Just how underdeveloped was this place...

I was both concerned and excited.

The places I had seen so far were more developed areas like the capital and the academy.

The capital and the academy were in an excellent state due to magic.

So it felt slightly different from the typical fantasy feeling.

Of course, I had been to the north and other places, but I hadn't been to the outskirts of the kingdom, so I couldn't experience that feeling.

Aren't these rural villages the real essence of a fantasy world?

A village that truly gives off a fantasy vibe.

Most of the people were farmers, and it was a small territory without even a proper castle.

The thought made me anticipate even more.

The carriage shook.

Thud-

Luna's head touched my shoulder.

Turning my head, I saw Luna, who earlier was staring with an intense gaze, now sound asleep.

Sleeping with an innocent, childlike face.

Why on earth is this girl trying to make me fall for her?

But, looking at Luna's innocent actions, my heart was inexplicably moved.

Seeing Luna's innocent actions always swayed my heart.

She acts determined when she needs to be, but when I see her innocence in her daily life, I always find myself unknowingly smiling.

Not that Luna knows about it.

"Umm..."

Luna seemed uncomfortable in her position and shifted.

She leaned more comfortably against my shoulder and soon gave a satisfied smile.

I gently brushed her hair aside, thinking it might tickle her.

That's when Robert, who was in front of me, spoke.

"What will you do?"

"I thought you were sleeping..."

"Are you just going to leave them like this?"

I couldn't answer Robert's question.

Unable to respond, I just looked away.

"Tsk tsk... you're so indecisive."

Robert clicked his tongue and folded his arms in annoyance.

I didn't expect him to be paying attention to us like this.

For someone who seemed so indifferent about everything, I assumed he would just ignore it.

Yet, it looks like he knows more about the situation than I thought.

Wasn't it Robert who advised me to pay close attention to my surroundings last time?

Robert stared at me for a moment before speaking.

"When you're learning dark magic or making other decisions, you act decisively. Why do you hesitate now?"

"Wouldn't my choice hurt someone else?"

"Do you not realize that by dragging this out, you could cause even greater harm?"

I couldn't argue against his words.

Certainly, making a choice now might be better for everyone involved.

Choosing now, even if it's late, could minimize the pain.

But I felt like things have already gone too far.

Their feelings and mine were already deeply intertwined.

"Rudy Astria."

As I was lost in thought, Robert spoke seriously.

"There's a good law for you in the empire."

"A good law?"

As I tilted my head in confusion, Robert nodded.

"Polygamy."

"Excuse me?"

"The empire allows polygamy."

"Professor?"

"What would you do after chasing after several rabbits? You can't let them all slip away. The only option is to catch them all."

Robert clenched his fist.

"If you leave things as they are, they might end up fighting amongst themselves. You need to take action."

I just stared at Robert blankly.

Robert nodded several times as if understanding everything.

“It's surely a difficult path! But what can you do? Give it your best shot!”

“Luna.”

“Mm... Yes?”

“Luna, wake up.”

“Huh...?”

Slowly opening her eyes to the sound of her name, Luna saw Rudy right in front of her.

“Eek!”

She exclaimed in surprise and backed away.

‘What's happening? What's this?’

She was confused.

Luna had been deep in thought.

With Professor Robert in front, she had been thinking about what could be done in such a confined space.

Though she was thrilled just by being close to Rudy, it wasn't enough.

‘Should I link arms with Rudy...?’

‘Perhaps sneakily hold his hand without Professor Robert noticing?’

Luna had all sorts of wild thoughts.

However she had fallen asleep.

Luna had stayed up the previous night, devising plans to charm Rudy.

After exams, the rocking of the carriage and her lack of sleep, she couldn't help but drift off.

The problem was Luna's current situation.

"Luna, we're almost there."

At Rudy's words, Luna cautiously looked at his shoulder.

Wondering if she drooled in her sleep, or if her head was too heavy on his shoulder, or if she had sleep-talked and said something strange.

Many worries flitted through her mind.

'Oh no!!!'

She had already felt threatened by the sudden appearance of Astina.

'I made such a mistake...!'

Luna thought it fortunate that Astina hadn't boarded the carriage with them.

However, when such an opportunity was given, instead of seizing the moment, she fell asleep.

"...Rudy."

"Hmm?"

"Did I... do anything weird? Like..."

"Like?"

"...you know."

Rudy then chuckled.

It was a laugh as if finding her behavior amusing.

Seeing Luna's puzzled face, Rudy placed his hand on her head.

"You slept peacefully. Don't worry."

Luna felt the warmth of Rudy's gentle touch on her head.

It was even more affectionate and warm than usual.

Relieved by Rudy's words, Luna let out a sigh and laughed.

"We're almost there, so get ready to disembark."

"Ah! Really?"

Luna looked out the window.

This was Railer territory.

Her hometown.

A farming landscape spread out, and mountains were visible in the distance.

Seeing the familiar and comforting view, Luna brightened up.

It had been about a year since she last visited her territory due to her studies at the academy.

Although she hadn't come here of her own volition, she had missed it.

Looking outside, Rudy then turned to Luna, smiling.

"It's beautiful."

"Right?"

At Rudy's comment, Luna beamed.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 156: Railer Territory (5)

The Railer Territory exceeded my expectations.

It had a distinct countryside feel.

The surrounding mountains and fields swayed in the wind, and I could see farmers resting under the shade of trees.

It was the very essence of a peaceful, tranquil countryside.

Our carriage continued deeper into the Railer lands.

The territory itself didn't have that feel overly rural feel.

Houses were clustered closely, but there seemed to be all the essential shops.

However, this wasn't the most noticeable aspect.

"Why is the atmosphere like this?"

Before entering the village, the fields gave off a very tranquil atmosphere.

There was hardly any noise except for the wind and the occasional chatter of a few people.

"Right? The village is a bit noisy."

Luna, also feeling something was off, looked outside.

Outside the carriage, people appeared to be tidying up.

The ground was scattered with flowers, and various ornaments adorned the village.

The villagers were busy organizing these decorations.

Luna tilted her head and remarked,

"Did someone important visit?"

"What do you mean?"

When I asked, Luna began to explain slowly.

"Whenever someone of high stature visits our territory, we have done such things a few times. Not just any high-ranking person, but someone very influential..."

However, it didn't feel like they were preparing to welcome us.

They had already used the flowers and ornaments and were now cleaning up.

"We'll understand once we go in."

The carriage moved forward, stopping in front of the largest mansion in the village.

Even though it was a countryside village, the mansion was as pristine as those in the capital.

It likely belonged to the Railer family, who governed this territory.

True to an aristocratic mansion, there were fences and an exterior garden.

Everything seemed a downscaled version of mansions in the capital, but it still screamed 'noble mansion'.

As the carriage came to a stop, we stepped out.

Noticing the carriage's stop, a butler rushed out from the mansion towards us.

"Who might you be?"

Approaching us, his eyes widened upon seeing Luna.

"...Lady Luna?"

"Oh! Alfredo! It's been so long!!"

Luna greeted the butler, clearly delighted to see him.

"What brings you here? You came without any notice!"

"Hehe, I have some business!"

Luna and Alfredo, the butler, engaged in cheerful conversation.

Meanwhile, I turned to look at Robert.

"Professor, did you really come here without telling them?"

The courtesies between nobles.

Before arriving, it's customary to notify the host so they can prepare.

It gives the host time to arrange a proper reception.

Regardless of how noble a family was, there was a difference in the state of cleanliness and the overall condition of the house when they were receiving guests and when they weren't.

It was a basic courtesy.

Unless they were very close friends, one shouldn't visit in such a manner.

Robert then spoke with a nonchalant expression,

"I am not a noble."

"...I am."

"Then did you come here without sending notice?"

Robert looked at me sternly, making a tscking noise.

I looked back at him in disbelief.

"...Haah."

I walked towards the butler, who was with Luna.

Upon seeing me approach, the butler asked Luna in a low voice,

"Who is this gentleman?"

I offered the butler a polite greeting,

"I am Rudy Astria, the second son of the Astria family. I apologize for visiting unexpectedly."

"You are Rudy?"

Alfredo looked at me with wide eyes.

I felt something odd about his reaction.

Was he surprised not because of the Astria family name but because of the name 'Rudy'?

It felt strange, but I continued,

"Well, our professor didn't send any notice. I apologize for the inconvenience."

I sighed with a hint of embarrassment.

"Oh... You can come in. We are already prepared, mainly because of Princess Rie."

"What? Rie?"

I looked at Alfredo in confusion.

"Princess Rie stayed at the mansion just a moment ago. She was looking for Lady Luna and Sir Rudy."

The opulent decorations in the village, and the residents who were cleaning up, were all because of Rie?

"Wait, why did Rie come here?"

"I'm not sure... She simply stayed for a day while searching for Sir Rudy and Lady Luna."

Did Rie travel all the way to the Railer territory while we were in the Gotram territory?

I had predicted Astina might come, but I never thought Rie would reach Railer territory first.

I don't know when Rie left the academy, but if she came straight to Railer territory, she must have had a long journey.

"Do we need to go find her?"

"Yes... We probably should."

It's absurd that a princess of a nation is roaming around looking for someone.

"In that case, I'll send notifications to the neighboring territories."

"...Thank you, that would be helpful."

The butler gave an awkward smile and then looked at Robert standing behind me.

"Are there three of you?"

The butler seemed to inquire about the number of people for accommodation purposes.

"No, there are four of us..."

As I said that, I noticed a carriage approaching from the distance.

"Ah... then who is that person?"

The butler looked at me as if he intended to report to Luna's parents.

"That's Astina Persia. You might recognize her from the Persia Viscount family."

"..."

Upon hearing the name, Alfredo frowned and stared intently at Luna.

"Young lady... causing such a fuss all of a sudden..."

"It's, it's not a fuss! They're just friends! There's no need for a grand preparation!"

After a brief moment of chaos.

"The mansion looks better than I expected, Luna. It shows that care was put into it."

"Hahaha... Thank you."

We proceeded into the mansion.

Astina glanced around with a satisfied smile.

"Many places in the capital don't maintain this level of care. Your parents must really pay attention to the details."

"Is that so? I think they might have tidied up after Rie visited..."

"This doesn't look like a rush job. It's probably the result of consistent care and effort from the staff."

Astina was right.

If a mansion isn't regularly maintained, it becomes a mess.

Right after I was reincarnated, I noticed that the Astria mansion, particularly my room, was a total mess.

Neither the servants nor Rudy Astria himself seemed to care about maintaining it.

Of course, I didn't fully realize this at first.

It's a fact I learned after seeing many other mansions.

"Luna, you should be proud. This speaks volumes about how well your parents treat their staff and how diligently they uphold the values of nobility."

Values of nobility.

Astina was referring to setting a noble example and maintaining dignity even in the rural territories.

"Th-thank you."

Seemingly flattered by Astina's compliment, Luna shyly lowered her head.

"By the way, is this the dining room?"

"Yes, it is. Shall we go in?"

Luna opened the door, and we entered.

Inside, a middle-aged man and woman sat at a dining table.

"Welcome. Luna's friends and... you said a professor, right? Pleased to meet you. I'm Luna's mother."

"I'm Luna's father."

Luna's mother bore such a striking resemblance to Luna that no introduction was needed.

Despite appearing somewhat older, her beauty hadn't faded in the slightest.

Compared to Luna, her father did not resemble her at all.

He was a somewhat muscular man with a solemn demeanor.

His aura was quite different from Luna's lively one.

He exuded a noble's dignity and had his own charisma.

Then, Robert stepped forward and greeted Luna's parents.

"I am Robert, in charge of dark magic at the academy. I apologize for visiting without notice."

Robert greeted them with a courteous demeanor.

"Pleased to meet you, Professor Robert."

Luna's father nodded sternly in response, then turned to look at us.

Astina was the first to speak.

"I am Astina Persia, the successor of the Persia Viscount family."

"I've just heard from the butler. Rest well during your stay."

Luna's father exchanged the necessary pleasantries and then turned his gaze to me.

It felt as though his attention was focused more on me than the entire group.

Just like Robert and Astina, I greeted him with formal courtesy.

"Hello, I am Rudy Astria, the second son of the Astria family."

I placed my hand over my chest and slightly bowed my head in greeting.

However, there was no response from him.

It's considered rude if one does not acknowledge a greeting, so I held my posture for a moment before slightly raising my head.

That's when I noticed Luna's father staring intently at me.

"Hmm..."

He continued to observe me with a solemn look.

Both Luna and her mother then looked at him.

"Dear?"

"Dad."

At the words of the mother and daughter, Luna's father cleared his throat.

"Ahem! My apologies! Please, take a seat."

"...Ah, okay."

I felt puzzled as I took my seat.

The meal was delightful.

The vegetables served were fresher than those at the academy, and the meat was to my taste.

Seeing Astina and Robert describe it as a home-cooked meal made me think it had a Western-style homemade touch.

After the meal, Luna provided each of us with a room.

We had an early dinner, and since it was summer, the sun had not set yet.

Despite this, I headed to my room.

Due to exams and then immediately coming to Railer's territory, I felt very tired.

Just as I was about to rest in my room,

"Rudy Astria."

A deep voice.

Luna's father called out to me.

"Did you call for me?"

I replied to Luna's father with a slightly awkward expression.

His quiet, solemn demeanor felt alright in group conversations, but it was somewhat uncomfortable when talking one-on-one.

Luna's father approached me, staring intently before speaking softly.

"Do you drink alcohol?"

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 157: Railer Territory (6)

Railer family mansion, the Study.

"Hmm..."

Trickle—

"Thank you."

I received a glass of alcohol from Luna's father.

Though I was young, I had no problem drinking alcohol.

While drinking and smoking were prohibited within the academy, they were not legally prohibited in the Empire.

It was my first time drinking since I came to this world, and while I was worried about making a mistake, the anticipation of enjoying alcohol after a long time rose in me.

Luna's father extended his glass to me.

I took my glass with proper etiquette.

Even though my status might be higher, I showed respect to my friend's father.

Luna's father drank from his glass, and I followed suit.

"Ah...ssp."

The alcohol was strong.

A subtle fragrance lingered in my mouth, and when I swallowed, I felt a tingling sensation.

Also, a warm feeling spread through my insides.

I could definitely tell it was a high-quality drink.

“Let’s have another glass.”

Luna’s father refilled my glass, and I gladly accepted.

After pouring the drink, Luna’s father quietly spoke up.

“What do you think is more important, family or work?”

I lifted my head to look at him.

With no particular change in his expression, Luna’s father was simply looking at his glass as he spoke.

It was a somewhat abrupt question.

I thought we would talk about Luna, but this sudden change of topic made me curious.

“Both are important, aren’t they?”

“But still, one must come before the other.”

After pouring, Luna’s father looked at me.

I took a moment to ponder the question before responding.

“I think family comes first.”

“Why do you think that?”

"Just as running a family requires focusing on both the internal and external aspects, work can only be taken care of when the family is at peace, right?"

Upon hearing my answer, Luna's father nodded.

His expression didn't change, so I couldn't tell exactly what he was thinking, but it didn't look like I had given a completely wrong answer.

Without saying much else, Luna's father took another sip from his glass.

"I heard you are emerging as a prominent successor of the Astria family."

I swallowed hard at his words.

"Yes, I am working hard towards that."

"It is a challenging path."

"Still, I believe it's necessary to protect those around me."

The power of the Astria family.

Apart from space magic, it's a family with tremendous power, wealth, reputation, and strength, lacking nothing.

I believed that as long as I had the family's power, I could protect those around me.

"Don't you think challenging Ian Astria might endanger those around you?"

"It might, but the people around me aren't the type to be easily bullied. I trust them, and I will prevent such a situation from happening."

After I spoke, Luna's father smiled contentedly.

"Here."

Although I'd had quite a bit to drink, I was still in control, so I accepted.

"There's something I've been wanting to do."

Luna's father said this as he poured me a drink.

"What might that be?"

"We don't have any other men in our family, do we?"

"Yes...?"

"So, I've always thought it would be nice to have a son."

Luna's father said, slightly swirling his glass.

"To drink with my son, talk about the empire's situation, have honest conversations like this. I've always wanted to have that experience. So, I've always been envious of those with sons."

"...Oh, I see."

I felt a bit uneasy.

"But having a son-in-law doesn't seem too bad either. Hahaha. Having a drink and a chat like this with my son-in-law is quite fun."

"...Huh?"

My mind froze at his words.

Son-in-law?

Why am I suddenly a son-in-law?

"I was a bit upset at first about someone taking Luna away..."

"Uh... Sir?"

I knew it was impolite, but I interrupted him.

Luna's father laughed at my words.

"Ha-ha, just call me 'father'."

"Oh, no, it's not that..."

I cautiously opened my mouth.

"Why am I considered as a son-in-law...?"

"Hmm?"

Luna's father looked at me, puzzled.

"...Wasn't that the case?"

"Uh..."

"There was talk of marriage in the letter, wasn't there?"

"What?"

Right at that moment, the door to the room burst open, and Luna's mother and Luna herself were there.

"Dad!!!!"

"L-Luna. H-Honey."

Her father stiffened at their appearance.

"H-How did you find your way here?"

The once dignified father of Luna had now gone pale.

"Oh dear, you!"

Luna's mother strode towards us and hit her husband on the back.

"Ah, honey. I was just trying to have a brief chat!"

"I told you to stay put!"

"H-Honey!"

Her father cringed as he got smacked on the back by his wife.

Luna hurried over to me and asked urgently.

"He didn't say anything weird, did he? Didn't ask you to do anything strange?"

She said this and then glanced at the glass in my hand.

"H-He made you drink?!"

"Uh... I did drink, but..."

"Dad!!!"

Luna turned and glared at her father.

"L-Luna. It's, it's not like that."

Her father stuttered, waving his hands.

I quickly said to Luna,

"Luna! I said I wanted to drink! Your father didn't really say anything strange, so it's okay!"

"Father?"

Luna looked surprised as I referred to him as 'father'.

In a hurry to speak, I used an odd form of address, but for now, it was more important to defuse the situation.

"I haven't been here for long! Nothing really happened, so....."

When I clarified the situation on behalf of her father, Luna's mother approached me with a smile.

"Rudy, I'm sorry. He's somewhat immature..... even when I tell him to stay quiet in front of others. Ha ha....."

"Oh, not at all....."

I responded with an awkward smile.

After nodding her head, the mother smiled at me.

"It's getting late, you can go back to your room."

"Yes..... I understand."

After saying this, I looked at her father and walked out of the room.

Expressing his gratitude, he gave me a thumbs-up.

The next day.

I woke up early in the morning and stretched my body.

Having drunk alcohol, I had fallen asleep early and enjoyed a deep sleep.

So, despite having slept well, I woke up early in the morning.

I left my room and, while stretching, reminisced about the conversation from the previous day.

A letter, huh...

What on earth could this letter be about?

Thinking it through, the only answer seemed to be a letter from Luna.

After all, she is the only person related to me from the Railer family.

But then, what could possibly be in the letter that Luna sent, which made her father react that way?

Thinking about it, it was a bit strange.

Even when I met the butler in front of the Railer mansion, he reacted to my name, Rudy, rather than the name of the Astria family.

I thought it was no problem that people in the capital knew about me these days, but it was strange that he reacted to my name when I introduced myself.

“Hmm...”

It didn't make sense that Luna would send a strange lie to the mansion.

That was not in her character.

“Rudy?”

When I turned my head, I saw Luna.

She was wearing a thin shawl over her shoulders and a simple white dress.

The dress, which looked like sleepwear yet was quite ordinary, suited Luna very well.

“You're up early?”

Luna spoke to me with a gentle smile.

Seeing her like that made me smile as well.

“I went to bed early, so I woke up early.”

“Oh, did you fall asleep right after getting back yesterday? Well... I was tired too, so I went straight to sleep.”

Luna nodded understandingly as she said ‘Yes! Yes!’

“More than that, I'm sorry about what happened yesterday with my dad...”

“No, it’s fine. Nothing happened.”

As I shrugged my shoulders, Luna took a quick glance at me and opened her mouth to speak.

“That... Dad didn’t say anything strange, did he?”

I pondered upon hearing her question.

Should I tell her about this...?

It seemed like her father might have misunderstood something, so it might be good to let Luna know.

"He called me a son-in-law..."

“...What?”

Luna’s eyes widened.

“My dad? Why would my dad suddenly...”

Luna spoke with a puzzled expression on her face.

“He mentioned something about a letter?”

“Le...letter?”

Luna furrowed her brow in confusion.

Seeing her reaction, as if she knew nothing about the letter, I tilted my head in confusion.

“You don’t know about the letter?”

“Oh... that...”

Luna stammered before lowering her head and speaking.

"I... sometimes exchange letters with Mom... but I specifically told her not to show the contents to Dad... Did Dad talk about the letter?"

"He didn't exactly say it outright... When I asked why I'm the son-in-law..."

"My mom wouldn't say something like that..."

Luna muttered to herself, looking embarrassed.

I looked at Luna, who was in such a state, and smiled faintly.

"So, what did you write in that letter?"

"Uh, what?"

Luna, taken aback by my question, looked up.

I spoke in a playful tone.

"You didn't write something like a lie, did you?"

"No! Absolutely not!"

Luna shook her head vigorously.

I didn't think she would lie, but I just wanted to tease Luna a bit.

"Then, what did you write that made your father misunderstand?"

As I continued to ask, Luna glared at me with her face turning red.

"Well, I wouldn't know what that is!"

"You don't know?"

As I continued to tease her, Luna frowned and opened her mouth.

"I wrote about how much I like Rudy."

"Huh?"

“How I came to like Rudy, what I like about him, and what I want to do together with him!”

It seemed that my continued teasing had upset her as she talked about the letter.

“I even talked with my mom about what it might be like if we got married later on! Why!”

Although Luna spoke boldly, her face turned red as if she was about to burst into tears.

Hearing such words from Luna right in front of me made my own face feel like it was turning red.

I didn’t expect to hear such words right in front of me...

It felt like I had been the one played, even though I was the one trying to tease Luna.

I couldn’t look Luna in the eyes and slightly turned my head away.

“There... wasn’t a need to say all that...”

“You told me to say it!”

Luna, unable to meet my eyes either, turned her head to the opposite side.

For a while, we both just sat there, faces red, unable to look at each other.

---Toggle New Ads

*Uhm a lot of the honorifics/formal/informal language... sorry if I messed any.

Chapter 158: Railer Territory (7)

Blond-haired Rie stepped out of the carriage, her face etched with resentment.

"Ahahaha..."

"Didn't you say you'd go ahead? Why are you just arriving now?"

"Rie, you've worked hard..."

We all greeted Rie with a mix of reactions.

Her face clearly displayed the fatigue from her journey.

"Really... you all..."

She gritted her teeth, glaring at us.

"Come on, let's go inside and rest."

Alfredo, Luna's butler, gestured for Rie to follow him into the mansion.

"Ugh..."

Rie, though clearly having more to say, was too tired to speak and followed Alfredo inside.

"Let's rest up and meet later..."

With that, she bid us a temporary farewell and disappeared into the mansion.

"They all eventually arrived..."

Robert, observing from a distance, sighed and then approached us.

"It's time to get to work."

"Work?"

Astina, confused, questioned Robert's statement.

"We're here to investigate Levian's spellbook."

Astina, not knowing the purpose of our visit, was understandably puzzled.

"Uh, what's the plan?"

Hearing my question, Astina turned to Robert for answers.

"Now that you're here, Astina, I could use your help."

"...Are you planning to take advantage of us without offering any anything?"

"If you don't want to help, feel free to leave."

Robert responded to Astina with indifference.

"Ha... Alright, I understand. I'll help. But..."

Astina then looked at me and Luna.

"What about them? What will they do?"

"Luna knows this area well. It would be efficient for her to investigate the surrounding territories, with Rudy assisting her."

Astina frowned, not entirely convinced by Robert's plan.

"Just do as you're told."

"...Understood."

Astina agreed, though she clearly had reservations.

"Luna, focus on surveying the territories for any signs of old man Levian while you're out there. I'll speak with your parents and search the mansion. Someone familiar with the mansion might overlook details because it's all too familiar to them."

"Yes! Got it."

Luna replied enthusiastically to Robert's instructions and quickly glanced at me.

It seemed like she was excited to have some time alone with me.

I felt tempted to tease her, to say, 'Did the professor send you to work or to have fun with me?' and give her a playful flick on the forehead.

But then a thought crossed my mind—had Robert arranged this on purpose?

I remembered his odd comments in the carriage about starting a harem.

No way...

He must've just assigned us to investigate.

Still...

"This is a place I used to play around a lot when I was a kid."

"Back in your mischievous days?"

"Ah, no! Well, yes, I was mischievous, but..."

Luna and I began our stroll, watching Robert and Astina head into the mansion.

Though our purpose was to explore, it felt more like we were leisurely hanging out, with Luna sharing stories of her childhood.

We roamed open fields to small hills, covering every inch of the territory.

Luna was excited to show me her childhood playgrounds.

I couldn't help but smile at her adorable demeanor.

"Wow, I can't believe this is still here!"

"What is it?"

Luna exclaimed as she touched a large tree, bearing a prominent scar.

"When I was a kid, I was playing around, riding a cow, and it charged right into this tree!"

"Playing... riding a cow? And it ran into this tree?"

"Ah... cough, cough! Well, yes, but I was just a kid."

Examining the tree closely, I noticed the bark was slightly peeled, and there were two indentations that looked like they could have been made by a cow's horns.

Judging from Luna's story, it seemed like the cow's horns had indeed hit the tree.

"There was a cow farm nearby, and I borrowed one..."

"You stole a cow?"

"It's not stealing! I just borrowed it... and I returned it afterwards."

Luna's voice trailed off as she realized what she had just admitted.

"Anyway, let's check out some other places!"

"...Okay."

Just how mischievous was she as a child...

The more I heard about Luna's childhood, the more unimaginable it became.

Leading the way, Luna looked back at me and said,

"Ru-Rudy... about the letter earlier, my dad misunderstood because he secretly read my mom's letter. So don't worry about what he said! It was all a misunderstanding!"

"Oh."

Her words made me recall the earlier situation, causing my face to flush as I remembered her open confession of feelings for me.

"Th-That's good to know."

"Don't get me wrong... wait, no."

Luna paused, reflecting for a moment, then changed her expression and continued,

"It's not a misunderstanding! If you become my husband, you will be my dad's son-in-law!"

"What?"

Suddenly, Luna shifted her approach, coming closer to me.

"If you just become my son-in-law, it wouldn't be a misunderstanding to my dad, but a fact!"

"But, I haven't decided yet?"

At my response, Luna pouted.

"Do you want my dad to be mistaken? Are you saying it's okay for him to misunderstand?"

Her tone was challenging, as if she was asking if I was ready to deal with her father's misconceptions.

"No, that's not it. It really was a misunderstanding. Everything's clear now."

"Uh..."

Luna turned her head away, looking frustrated.

"Then my dad will be disappointed!"

"...Huh?"

"He was so happy about the prospect of having a son-in-law... and now suddenly he won't?"

Luna threw me a sly glance as she spoke.

"Rudy, you've done something wrong."

"..."

Is it really my fault?...

Though I felt wronged, I just nodded since Luna said so.

What exactly does she want, saying something like that?

She was definitely eager, almost picking a fight.

She seemed to have something she wanted to do by picking a fight.

"That's right. It's my fault."

Luna's demeanor brightened up as I accepted responsibility.

“So you admit you were wrong?”

“Yes, yes. I was wrong.”

Suddenly, Luna reached out her hand to me.

“Then, you need to pay for your sins!”

“...Hmm?”

“Ho-hold my hand. Let’s walk holding hands.”

I looked at her outstretched hand, realizing her playful and challenging demeanor was just a way to get me to hold her hand.

“Alright. I’ll hold your hand.”

Her eyes widened in surprise.

“Really?”

Holding hands didn't seem like such a big deal to me.

Perhaps I’ve become more open to the idea after that incident with Rie.

Regardless, I was willing to hold Luna’s hand.

Without saying anything more, I took her hand in mine.

“Eh...”

“Hmm...”

Her hand was soft and warm.

“Wait, my hand is sweaty...”

“If you let go, then it's over.”

“Eek...!”

Luna, on the verge of releasing my hand, suddenly gripped it tighter.

“So if we keep holding hands, we’ll be together forever, right?”

“Try and see.”

And so, Luna started walking beside me, holding my hand.

I initially thought holding hands was trivial and agreed to it without much thought, but it turned out to be quite special.

The warmth from her hand transmitted to mine.

It felt like we were a couple, and my heart was racing.

I wasn’t sure how much strength to use or where to look.

It seemed I wasn’t the only one feeling this way.

“Uh...ah...”

Luna's eyes were twirling around while holding my hand.

She was leading the way, but I wondered if she actually knew where she was going.

“Miss Luna?”

In this dizzying situation, someone spoke to us.

It was a middle-aged man who looked like a normal farmer.

“Oh... um, hello sir. It’s been a while!”

Luna seemed to know the man and greeted him.

“When did you get back? The lord has been talking about you every day, saying how much he misses you, Miss Luna.”

The farmer spoke with a bright face.

Seeing him talk so lightly about the lord, I could feel how close Luna's father was with his subjects.

"But still...."

The farmer shifted his gaze towards me, glancing at our interlocked hands.

"Ha, even if you've returned, the young master must be feeling bitter! Bringing back such a handsome boyfriend like this!"

"Ah...."

Luna, with eyes wide in surprise, followed his gaze to our entwined hands.

She hesitated for a moment as if she was about to let go, but then she stopped.

She lifted her head and stared straight at me.

"If I let go...."

It seemed like she remembered my words about it being over if she let go, and she gripped my hand even tighter.

"Wow... It feels like just yesterday Miss Luna was playing and riding the cows at our house, and now she's brought back a boyfriend... It's quite a nostalgic feeling."

"Oh, Mister!"

Ah....

So what he said before was true.

"The marks are still on that tree, aren't they? That mischievous Miss Luna, really... Phew! But it's a relief to see she's grown up so well and beautifully.

Oh, and not just that..."

"Uwaa! Mister!!"

I thought some exaggeration was mixed in, but it looks like it was all true.

I wonder what kind of childhood she had...

Watching the farmer shiver as he recounted Luna's childhood made it seem like it was indeed an extraordinary one.

When he tried to continue with another story from her childhood, Luna frantically waved her hands to stop him, not forgetting to hold onto mine while doing so.

Seeing this, the farmer grinned contentedly.

"Hehe, it's good to see. Oh my! Come to think of it, I believe I've interrupted you two! I should be going now. Ha ha ha."

"Goodbye, take care!"

Despite the farmer being a commoner, Luna responded to him with polite language.

After bidding him farewell, she pressed her lips together tightly and looked at me.

"Uh.... Now I can't marry anyone else..."

"No, no. If we hadn't held hands, this wouldn't have..."

"I don't care! Uh...."

Blushing, Luna covered her face with both hands, all the while still tightly gripping mine.

"Is this about Levian?"

Luna's father had a significantly surprised expression upon hearing Robert's words.

Clearly, he was aware of who Levian was.

It was Luna's father who had passed the magic book to Luna.

Moreover, he had also allowed Levian to stay in their territory.

However, the strangest part was that he had not reported this fact to the empire.

"You are aware that this person was a great wizard, right?"

Levian was not just any wizard known to a select few.

Any noble would be expected to recognize his name, such a prominent figure he was, having left behind numerous accomplishments.

"...I am aware."

Luna's father replied, meeting Robert's gaze squarely.

"There is no need for caution. We are here to help."

"To help?"

"The magic book that Luna possesses. It is undoubtedly a magical tool of tremendous power, and its existence has become known to the world."

The fact that Luna held such a magic book had become known to a select few.

However, since Luna was at the academy, and there were always people to protect her when she went out, no one had dared to touch her.

"...Indeed, there was an incident recently where someone from the capital came to visit our territory."

"We are here to protect Luna from them."

Robert spoke with a serious expression.

"Is protecting Luna all you are here for?"

"...Of course not."

"Then why are you seeking out traces of Levian?"

Taking a moment, Robert opened his mouth to speak.

"I was a disciple of Levian."

"A disciple?"

"It's a bit of two things; seeking revenge, and fulfilling my duty as his disciple."

Robert spoke calmly, but his hands were tightly clenched into fists.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 159: Railer Territory (8)

Deep in the forest.

"Where are we..."

Without complaint, I followed the path into the forest.

I didn't have a specific destination in mind, nor was I familiar with the surroundings.

So, I let the journey unfold as it would.

"Hmm... Wasn't it here? It should be, right? Did Dad clear it out?"

Luna was searching through the bushes, mumbling to herself.

"Ah, right! Here it is!"

Her face lit up as she found what she was looking for, then she turned to me with a bright smile.

"What is this place?"

"Do you remember? Professor Robert was looking into something about Grandfather Levian."

Luna reminded me as she parted the bushes to show me.

"This is where Grandfather Levian used to stay!"

A small, fragile-looking hut stood before us, as if a gentle push could topple it over.

It was made of worn fabric and wood, and cobwebs adorned its corners, signifying long neglect.

"But why is this still here?"

Levian had died when Luna was about 9 or 10, which meant this hut had stood here for around a decade.

"There wasn't a reason to tear it down... Plus, Grandfather's things are here!"

Luna said with a cheerful tone, beckoning me through the underbrush.

She tugged at my hand, urging me to follow her inside.

"Cough, cough! Ugh... So dusty!"

As Luna lifted the tent fabric, a cloud of dust billowed out.

She flapped her hands, trying to clear the air.

"Soft Wind."

I cast a spell to sweep the dust away from us.

"Ooh... Hehe, thank you."

Luna said with a grin, then pulled back the tent cover completely.

"Wow."

The hut was barely large enough for one or two people.

Inside, various items were neatly arranged: a few books, various items, and a thin cloth on the floor, making the space livable for one person.

Luna stepped inside, and I followed, peeking over her shoulder.

"Nothing has changed."

She said, her smile tinged with nostalgia.

"But why are these things still here?"

"Hm? Oh, I just never thought about cleaning it up..."

Luna replied, shrugging.

I was puzzled.

Usually, a deceased person's belongings are stored or rehomed, but everything here remained untouched, as if deliberately preserved.

I picked up one of the books, curious.

"..."

As I opened it, Luna's hand stopped me, her grip firm.

"Luna, could you let go...?"

I asked, trying to be gentle.

She looked at me, her eyes sharp.

"I haven't let it go yet!"

"Understood. I'll just look through this quickly and then give it back."

"Hmm! Fine! I'll let go then!"

Satisfied, Luna loosened her hold.

I gave her a small smile before focusing on the book again.

This book, left here and forgotten, was intriguing.

Any item that once belonged to Levian was valuable, no matter how trivial, because people cherish items once owned by noteworthy individuals.

"Let's see..."

I carefully dusted off the cover and turned the page.

"...What's this?"

I was expecting something profound, but to my surprise, the book contained very basic magical spells.

The book wasn't penned by Levian; it was just a well-printed volume.

Something felt off, so I kept turning the pages.

"Fireball, Wind Cutter, Water Ball, Wind Blaster."

It was a basic textbook, the kind used when one first learns magic.

By now, the spells were so elementary to me that I can use them without referencing the book.

Looking for something unique, I scrutinized the pages but found only simple content.

The book was old and lacked several parts compared to the material I had studied.

"Why would Levian have this book here?"

I was genuinely perplexed.

"Oh, that book. I remember seeing it a long time ago."

"So you haven't been here since you were a kid?"

"Yeah! Didn't I tell you? There was a magical beast encounter near here, and it was dangerous. Dad said I should stay away."

Her explanation made sense, but then it struck me – shouldn't this hut be moved?

If magical beasts were around, wouldn't they damage these relics?

On our way here, it seemed unlikely for such creatures to get close unnoticed.

There were soldiers patrolling, and the flat terrain outside the forest provided clear visibility.

The more I thought about it, the more questions popped up.

The soldiers seemed to be protecting the forest, and they deliberately did not touch the books.

But why?

This basic spellbook could simply be stored at the Railer Mansion, right?

And why would a wizard of Levian's stature keep such a simple book with him?

My suspicion was slowly turning into certainty.

"Luna, can you do me a favor?"

"Hmm?"

She looked at me, head cocked.

"Can you check if there's any magic or mechanisms in this spellbook?"

"Well..."

Luna had more expertise with magical items than I did, so she was the right person to ask.

She flipped through the book, checking it over.

"It doesn't seem to have any mechanisms..."

Luna then pulled a book from her bag and opened it to a page on analysis magic.

The book didn't look like a magical tool, but appearances can be misleading, so she decided to test it.

“Activate.”

A bright light shone from her book, and the spellbook absorbed it.

A magic circle then burst forth and expanded around the book.

“...Huh?”

Luna's brow furrowed.

“This is... a magical tool, isn't it?”

Her comment made me smile.

“What kind of magic is it?”

“It looks like it might be illusion magic.”

She examined the magic circle with focus.

“Can you undo it?”

“It looks like I might be able to.”

She scrutinized the magic circle and picked up the spellbook.

Then, quite unexpectedly, she dropped it onto the ground.

Thud—

“Huh?”

“Did it work?”

Luna opened the book once more.

“Hmm... No, that didn’t do it.”

She tapped the book thoughtfully and looked at me.

“Rudy, could you hit this book hard for me?”

“Strike the book?”

“It seems there's a specific way to solve this... but it might take time to figure out.”

“And until then?”

“This book is tied to illusion magic. Illusion magic typically breaks when the caster or the object is directly affected.”

“...Ah.”

Luna meant that rather than analyzing the illusion, we should physically disrupt the magical tool to break the spell.

Rather than meticulously unraveling each knot, it's easier to just cut them all at once.

“Sounds like a plan.”

I grinned, took the book, and stepped out of the hut.

“Luna, step back a bit, will you?”

“Okay!”

Luna's attempt hadn't dispelled the magic—obviously, a stronger impact was necessary.

Yet, I couldn't risk damaging the book.

So, I collected just enough mana in my hand, neither too little nor too excessive.

I tossed the book to the ground and, with a precise motion, punched down towards it.

“Hup!”

Thud—

My fist made contact with the book.

The force was moderate, aimed to shock but not destroy.

“Wow.”

The book's exterior began to quiver, the surface transforming before my eyes.

“The magic’s been broken.”

Luna scampered over to me.

I lifted the book, now altered, and read the new title etched on its surface.

“...Necronomicon, production diary?”

I raised an eyebrow in surprise.

Back at the Railer mansion,

"Levian sought asylum in the empire..."

"I don't know every detail. I was only following Levian's last wishes. He claimed it was the only way to keep Luna safe, so I obeyed."

Luna's father's words caused Robert to frown.

"To protect Luna?"

"The empire believes Levian fled here."

"Hm?"

Robert was visibly skeptical at this abrupt change of topic.

Luna's father clarified,

"Levian didn't come here on the run."

These words made Robert's expression stern.

The prevailing belief was that Levian had run away with the magic book.

Confusion swirled in Robert's mind.

Luna's father shook his head, watching Robert's reaction.

"That's not the story Levian shared with me. Upon his arrival, he immediately sought me out. He needed a place out of sight, away from prying eyes. Then..."

He paused, seeming hesitant to continue,

"He instructed me to give this book to Luna after his experiment was done."

"An experiment?"

Robert was puzzled about this so-called experiment.

And then it clicked—if the book before him was the same...

"Is that what Luna has?"

"Yes. He said that he would be dead by the time the experiment was finished, so he asked me to pass it on to her."

"Ah."

Levian hadn't eloped with the magic book after all.

Nor was the book a product of some secretive lab.

This revelation struck Robert forcefully.

He had assumed the magic book had been created and then stolen, but the truth was different.

The magic book wasn't created beforehand, and Levian hadn't run away—he had come to this land of his own accord.

With Levian gone before concluding his experiment, those left behind couldn't complete the magic book.

The experiment's head had vanished.

'Dead by the time the experiment was finished...?'

Complex thoughts flooded Robert's mind.

Amid his contemplation, Astina, who stood beside him, interjected.

"But what does it mean to keep Luna safe?"

"Didn't Levian mention he had a purpose for coming here?"

Luna's father's statement made Astina nod.

"The Saint... no, the former Saint Beatrice. Levian said he sought this place out after speaking to her."

"...Beatrice?"

At the mention of that name, Astina's eyes grew wide, laced with astonishment.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 160: Railer Territory (9)

[Throughout my career, I've earned esteemed titles like Archmage and Sage, amassed a wealth of knowledge, and even contributed new insights to the realm of magic. Yet, I haven't grasped all the knowledge in the world.]

[One question has always haunted me: Is death truly inescapable for us? Does a person's story simply end with death? I reckon every wizard must grapple with this notion at least once.]

[A wizard is someone who turns the inconceivable into reality. Driven by this conviction, I embarked on my research.]

"Hmm..."

Luna and I were deeply engrossed in Levian's research journal, captivated by its contents.

The journal delved into the pursuit of human immortality and resurrection, subjects closely tied to the taboo of necromancy, a magic outlawed within the empire.

It raised the question: Had Levian, a Royal Wizard, truly ventured into this forbidden territory?

I read on.

[The Fred and Astria families have lent their support to my research. The Freds, with their prowess in magical innovation, and the influential Astrias provide all that we need.]

[However, we have decided to proceed with our research in a direction different from necromancy. Necromancy requires death to give life, which

is not what I desire.]

"A research path diverging from necromancy?"

This was a puzzling revelation.

As documented, necromancy was frequently explored in the context of immortality and resurrection, but such explorations had always been met with failure.

Resurrection spells yielded only a semblance of life, not a true revival.

A reanimated shell is a far cry from a living being.

As for immortality, one could only extend their life by taking it from others, which differed from the true meaning of immortality.

Necromancy was widely perceived as the pinnacle of such studies.

However, Levian chose to discard this approach, convinced that the true life and rebirth could not stem from necromancy.

Life borne from the end of another was a mere continuation of the cycle he sought to break.

That was Levian's conviction.

We continued to sift through the journal.

It was devoid of personal details, concentrating on research milestones and discoveries.

Levian's research primarily centered around magical tools.

Magic operates on the principle of equivalent exchange: expending mana to weave spells.

Crafting magical tools inevitably requires mana stones.

With mana stones at hand, one can create magical tools.

Levian's thesis proposed that life could be sustained with mana stones.

This resonated with me.

Imagine the marvel if life could be secured through mana alone.

The mana stones in this world are being produced in such abundance that they are almost inexhaustible.

They line the depths of mines in great clusters, and that's just one source – slaying magical beasts yields mana stones formed within their bodies, akin to gallstones.

In essence, mana stones are an almost limitless resource here.

With a steady influx of mana stones, Levian's research advanced quickly.

The Fred family provided the necessary stones, and in exchange, Levian devoted himself to the study of magical tools and the essence of life.

The Astrias funded these expenses.

Although unusual for a Royal Wizard to align with noble houses like the Astrias and Freds, Levian had never shown any political motives.

However, something was strange.

No matter how much I read through the journal, the research wasn't progressing.

Despite the high-quality mana stones supplied by the Fred family, none were strong enough for Levian's magic circle, designed for the intricate task of resurrection.

Not once had it been successfully activated, even in preliminary tests.

Nevertheless, Levian was relentless, tirelessly refining the magic circles for the magical tools and delving into the art of mana stone processing — a field he was less familiar with, yet approached with unwavering dedication.

[One day, the Fred family delivered a peculiar mana stone unearthed from a northern mine. It was unlike any I'd seen before.]

[The stone's capacity for mana was remarkable, as was its ability to draw in mana from its surroundings.]

[Utilizing this stone, I crafted a magical tool. To my astonishment, it functioned; the magic circle ignited with life. After a year of relentless effort, I had finally made a breakthrough.]

"Does this mean... it worked?"

Luna's eyes widened with the realization.

Progress in research is typically incremental.

Even if initial attempts falter, one expects gradual improvements.

The magic circle's mana demands and the stone's mana output should be carefully balanced to optimize performance and efficiency.

Yet here we had an anomaly: a magic circle that, despite its initial demand for a significant mana input and failure to work all this time, had suddenly sprang to life, working perfectly.

"Doesn't this look strange no matter how you look at it?"

"Uh... I've never seen research like this before..."

Luna, seasoned in magical tool research, voiced her skepticism.

Given her level of involvement in research, she must have certainly read hundreds of research journals by now.

"This could be deemed... a miracle."

"A miracle, indeed..."

A sudden miracle.

It's suspicious.

We were not the only ones who felt this way.

[It was strange. The magic circle, once resistant to our efforts, now responded perfectly with each attempt. I have never heard of such a mana stone.]

[The Fred family assured us it was a yet-to-be-commercialized find. Perhaps I'm just too old to accept new changes?]

[For now, I decided to positively accept this development and press forward with my research.]

The research took strides once the Fred family supplied the unique mana stone.

[Resurrection magic's cornerstone lay in the principles of healing magic. We hypothesized that maximizing healing magic could be the key to reclaiming life.]

[After two and a half years, our efforts were close to fruition. We had achieved the revival of deceased animals.]

[Of course, we did not consider using this on humans.]

[We couldn't predict the potential consequences or the condition in which a person might be restored, so we proceeded with caution.]

Then, tragedy struck close to Levian.

[Robert's grief led to disaster. He tried to use necromancy to save his wife but ended up losing his son. He couldn't resurrect his wife and lost his nearby son as well.]

[We just needed a bit more time. If he had waited until this magic tool was completed.]

Robert's accident.

[I was aware that he was experimenting with necromancy, but I never imagined he would act so recklessly. He learned much from me and pursued further studies independently.]

[How could he not see that necromancy is a path that only begets more death? I feel more disappointed than sorry for him.]

"This means..."

"Professor Robert lost his son in an attempt to resurrect his wife..."

I didn't know much about Robert's past.

Nor was I aware that his wife had died so young.

The reason Robert turned to necromancy was to bring back his wife.

However, the resurrection through necromancy was incomplete, and it seemed he lost his son as a result.

As I read on, confusion settled in.

Why would this account be in the research journal for the Necronomicon?

What does this have to do with the magical tool Levian is developing?

I had my doubts.

[For a royal wizard like Robert, even execution wouldn't be unimaginable.]

[I confronted him first. After that, I began to trace the origins of his necromantic knowledge. He must have acquired it somewhere. My investigation revealed that he learned it in Ephomos, the underground city of the impoverished.]

[Knowing this, I approached the Emperor with a proposition. We would seize all of Robert's possessions but won't punish him further. Instead, I proposed to discreetly deal with the situation by purging Ephomos.]

[As I was preparing to clean up Ephomos, Perrian Astria came to me. He opposed the purging of Ephomos.]

Perrian Astria must be my father.

Although, I've never seen his face.

I tilted my head in confusion.

The Astria family is against the cleanup of the slums?

In my mind, the Astria lineage was corrupt and degenerate.

A family fixated on dominating the empire.

Yet now, they were defending the slums?

This defied my understanding.

[Despite the risks, I decided to proceed. Perrian was oblivious to the agreement between the emperor and me. I must act before he finds out.]

[I began the purging of Ephomos. I detained the necromancers and drove out the inhabitants of the slums, trying to minimize casualties. Force was reserved only for those who resisted.]

[In the final stages of the Ephomos operation, I noticed something strange. A mana stone discovered within the necromancers' laboratory. It was imbued with an astonishing concentration of mana.]

[It bore an uncanny resemblance to the mana stone supplied by the Fred family. Unless my senses or my own mana deceived me, this mana stone was undoubtedly identical to that provided by the Freds.]

[A thorough search of the lab unearthed a staggering number of corpses. Too numerous to count. Recalling the mana stone, I meticulously reviewed all the research documents in the lab related to that stone.]

[This mana stone was derived from the amassed bodies within the lab. Specifically, from people who were still alive. It was a man-made mana stone. Each mana stone contained hundreds of lives. The enormous amount of mana it harbored now made sense.]

“A mana stone... crafted from living people...?”

“...We should keep reading for now.”

I tried to calm Luna down as I spoke.

[I confronted the Fred family with the mana stone. They confessed without hesitation. It was indeed their doing. The empire's lack of oversight over the underground city allowed for countless unnoticed deaths, which the Freds exploited.]

[They orchestrated the mass production of mana stones through the necromancers. Was this why Perrian Astria tried to stop me?]

[I fell into self-loathing. My research, which was on the verge of transcending the boundaries of necromantic resurrection magic, had succeeded by employing necromancy itself. While I admonished Robert, I was unwittingly wielding the same dark power.]

[No. I am worse than Robert. I accused him of being led astray by his curiosity, which cost his son his life. But at least Robert's intent was pure—he wanted to save his wife. My own pursuits lacked such nobility. The adage 'curiosity killed the cat' was truly meant for me.]

[The magical tool is nearing completion. In a year or two, it could be presented to the world. But should I continue this research? This research...]

The journal entries that followed degenerated into indecipherable scribbles.

The journal's last entries appeared to mirror his unraveling mind.

Words scrawled with shaky, haphazard strokes.

“...Is this where it ends?”

If Levian is in such a state, the research couldn't continue.

With Levian at the helm of the magic circle's development—the crux of the project—any further progress was unlikely.

I turned a few more pages, my frown deepening with concern.

Suddenly, I stumbled upon a page where the handwriting was clear and deliberate.

[I met Beatrice.]

[I have made my decision.]

[Such tragedies must never happen again. I must put an end to all this research. So, I decided to listen to Beatrice. I will embark on a new line of research, drawing upon the necromantic practices I've studied and those employed by the Fred family. This diary is the reason why I decided to create this magical tool—The Necronomicon. A magical tool that can even harness the powers of gods.]

[The basis of magic is equivalent exchange. I will put my life on the line for this magical tool.]

A great wizard's life in exchange for a magical tool that can wield the powers of gods.

Levian decided to make this exchange.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 161: Railer Territory (10)

[A spellbook that enables the use of all magic. I will henceforth refer to it as the Necronomicon.]

We have read the entire journal.

Yet, not all our questions have been answered.

There was mention of Beatrice, but details were little.

It simply stated that following Beatrice's words, the journey led to the Railer territory.

There, upon arrival at the Railer domain, research began in a humble hut.

To be precise, it was about manifesting the results of completed research.

Levian created the spellbook with his life, much like how the Fred family had crafted mana stones from people.

The culmination of his work was the magic tome that Luna now possessed.

A tome inscribed with the magics he'd dedicated his life to studying, enabling the wielding of all spells, and also an object imbued with the life of a great wizard.

"Both are back, I see."

Upon our return to the Railer Estate, Robert greeted us.

Both Robert and Astina wore grave expressions.

"Have you managed to learn anything important?"

"I'm not sure if it's good news, but yes, we have."

We began to inform them about Levian's actions, explaining why he created the magic tome that Luna held, and how he managed to do it, in great detail.

As he listened to our story, Robert clenched his fist so tightly that his fingernails seemed to dig into his skin, threatening to draw blood.

I couldn't tell if his emotion was sorrow or anger; it seemed a tangled mix of both.

We finished our part and looked at Robert, who, lost in thought, didn't immediately respond.

After a moment, he lifted his head.

"I apologize for the trouble."

"It's fine."

We assured him with a smile.

"But what did you hear from the Railer mansion?"

At my question, Astina spoke up.

"We've heard about why Levian came here and what happened afterward. It appears to align with your story."

"What happened afterward?"

Astina nodded at my question and continued.

"Just as you said, Levian died after creating the magic tome here. But, as you're also aware, the reason he left that tome to Luna is a mystery."

Astina pulled a letter from within her robes.

"This is a letter Levian left for Luna's father."

I took the letter that Astina handed to me and unfolded it.

[Upon my death, give the magic tome in front of you to Luna. That book will save not only Luna but also others. I entrust this to you.]

The letter was brief.

The handwriting was much more degraded than what we had seen before.

The letters were pressed down as if with great effort, yet they sprawled erratically, suggesting a lack of control in the hand that wrote them.

"Baron Railer said that Levian mentioned Luna right from the start of his visit, claiming it was at the request of the former saint, Beatrice..."

Beatrice...

Her name was connected to my presence here and now Luna's situation.

"Luna's father, to conceal Levian's visit, left his belongings in a hut and erased his traces. It seems wiser to leave them undisturbed since the testimonies of the locals who claimed to have seen Levian aren't concrete evidence."

"That was a wise decision. Trying to hide it outright could have raised more suspicion."

"Exactly. Getting rid of everything completely would have increased the chances of discovery."

Even the powerful Astria ducal house couldn't just scour a provincial domain like this for Levian...

However, if there had been signs of someone trying to erase their tracks or hiding something, it would have raised suspicion.

But if there is obvious evidence, it could actually lessen any doubts.

Especially if that evidence was nothing more than rumors among the local populace.

It seemed Luna's father was also worried, as he had soldiers stationed nearby.

They were tasked with preventing people from entering the forest where Levian's belongings were found.

Officially, they were there because of a recent incident where Luna had been in danger, though it seems they hadn't aroused any suspicion with their presence.

"By the way, have you heard anything about what Beatrice said?"

"Luna's father seemed unaware as well. I'll have to look elsewhere for information on that."

"Hmm..."

After all, there were already plans to investigate Beatrice, so not knowing at this moment didn't seem to be a problem.

It's always better to act sooner rather than later, but rushing could lead to mistakes.

I thought it was necessary to allow for some leeway.

Once the situation seemed to be under control, Astina turned to look at Luna and me.

Then, with her arms crossed and a frown that said she was displeased, she asked,

"Given the circumstances, I've been holding off asking, but how long do you plan on holding that hand?"

"Ah..."

Caught up in serious conversation, I had forgotten all about it.

I looked at Luna with an awkward expression.

Luna, with a satisfied smile, said,

"Rudy promised he would keep holding on."

"Rudy did?"

Astina turned her gaze to me, questioning.

"It might sound strange, but..."

"Does it?"

Astina's gaze was icy as she looked back at me.

"No, it's just that... there's a reason. I said I would hold on until Luna lets go..."

"What?"

An intensity I had never seen before in Astina's eyes was directed at me.

It wasn't magic, but my face tingled as if scorched by a spell.

"Yes, that's what was said."

Astina's attention returned to Luna.

"Luna, could you come with me for a chat?"

"...Me?"

Luna tensed up at the request.

"Let's go talk after you 'let go' of the hand."

Let go.

It seemed Astina's words were a response to the previous mention of holding hands until Luna decided to let go.

"I don't want to! Absolutely not!"

Luna reacted vehemently to such a suggestion.

Astina's eyes twinkled even more at Luna's response.

"Luna?"

The smile that crept on her face, with veins popping on her forehead, was more menacing than anything.

Luna was visibly frightened, frozen like a rabbit in front of a predator.

Yet, Luna didn't let go of the hand.

Seeing Luna refuse to comply, Astina, unable to maintain her composure any longer, raised her voice.

"Let it go."

"No, I don't want to!"

Luna declared resolutely.

It seemed like a childish squabble, but the two were dead serious.

Astina took a step forward, glaring at Luna.

"Let go."

As Astina approached, Luna clung to my shoulder in fear.

"Ru-Rudy! Help!"

"Oh?"

Astina uttered an exclamation as if amused, but her expression was far from interested.

"Rudy, are you going to stop me?"

"No, it's not that..."

Astina's menacing tone made me break out in a cold sweat.

What should I do in a situation like this?

Panicking, I took a step back, while Astina closed in on me.

Clunk—

Suddenly, the door of the room we were in burst open.

A woman with golden hair came rushing in.

"Gasp!"

With a sharp breath, she hurled herself towards Luna.

"Eh?"

"Hmm?"

Caught off guard, Luna's grip loosened, and she stumbled backward, releasing my hand.

"Luna, I've missed you so much~."

The woman said smugly.

"Huh? Wha?"

Luna looked baffled, alternating her gaze between the woman embracing her and her own hand that was just freed.

The released hand and...

"Rie?"

The woman holding her was Rie.

Rie looked at Luna with a smile as if oblivious to everything.

"What's wrong? Something happened?"

Rie asked, her smile innocent, but her face was full of slyness.

It was clear she had intended to separate me and Luna.

"Rie, Rie!!"

Luna exclaimed as if she was wronged.

"Hmm? What's the matter? Sorry~ I was just so happy to see you!"

Rie spoke with an exaggerated smile.

Luna stamped her feet in frustration, an expression of utter injustice on her face.

"This... this is invalid!"

"Invalid? What is?"

But it's not like one could reason with someone pretending to be ignorant.

Especially not someone with Luna's temperament.

"Ugh..."

Luna could only pout, unable to retort to Rie.

"Rie."

At that moment, Astina, who had been watching, spoke up.

"Well done."

Astina said, giving a thumbs-up with a hint of admiration.

That night.

After dinner, I stepped out into the mansion's front garden with Rie.

Since Rie had come aboard the same ship as us, it was necessary for her to hear the information we had uncovered.

Although we received sharp looks from Astina and Luna when we excused ourselves, they let us go without a word when we mentioned it was about business.

"Ah, I've already heard all about it."

"...What?"

"How do you think I suddenly appeared? I timed it just right."

Confused by Rie's comment, I gave her a puzzled look.

"I've been listening almost from the beginning, but the mood seemed off, so I stayed outside. It would have been strange to just barge in at that moment."

...

Considering she had caused Luna to release my hand upon entering, I wonder if she might have been eavesdropping...

"Then you could've just said you overheard us."

The reason Astina and Luna let us go so easily must have been because they knew Rie needed to hear this story, but wasn't this situation somewhat odd?

Rie then smiled and spoke.

"Hehe, why would I?"

Clinging to me suddenly, she grabbed my arm.

"Missing out on a perfect opportunity to be alone together? I'm no fool."

Her forwardness caught me off guard, and my eyes widened.

"Hey, hey, someone might see us..."

"Oh! So it's okay if we're somewhere no one can see us?"

"Don't twist my words."

Rie stepped back slightly, then with a charming smile, looked around us.

"Shall we go somewhere out of sight? If we go to such a place..."

As she scanned the surroundings, our eyes met.

She was a short distance away, but still in front of me.

Close, but not too close.

Our eyes locked, and I couldn't help but recall our last encounter.

The memory of our previous kiss flushed my cheeks.

I wasn't the only one affected.

Rie, seemingly reminded of the same moment, was startled as our eyes met and she stopped her speech.

The seductress from moments ago was nowhere to be found; instead, a blushing, shy girl stood before me.

Rie quietly came to my side and suggested,

"...Shall we, maybe, just take a walk before going in?"

"...Let's do that."

She obediently turned to walk beside me through the garden.

"Uh..."

A few minutes passed in an awkward silence before Rie, her embarrassment seemingly subsided, finally spoke up.

"So, what do we do now?"

"Do what?"

I was taken aback by her question.

Even now, thinking about marriage—

"Where are we going now? Are we returning to the Academy?"

Ah.

Realization hit me, and I clamped my mouth shut.

She was asking about our next steps.

I felt a bit embarrassed, but I managed my expression and began to speak.

"Professor Robert asked someone he knows for a favor, so I think we might stop by there on our way."

"Hmm..."

Rie nodded as if she understood.

Then, as we started walking again,

Suddenly, I felt warmth at my side.

"...What's this?"

Looking down, I saw Rie's hand burrowing into my side.

"...What!"

When I made a strange face, Rie, on the contrary, let out a loud exclamation.

And then her hand wrapped around my arm, locking arms with me.

"...Hey, we're far enough away that no one will come by here."

Rie blushed, but spoke as if it was nothing.

"If you can hold hands with Luna, then arm-in-arm should be okay!"

"...That was different."

"I, I'll let you walk like this with me just for a bit! Then I'll forgive you!"

"...Okay."

"Hmm!"

Rie smiled contentedly and clung to my arm.

Is this really okay...?

Feeling both pleased and confused, I sighed.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 162: Rescue Operation (1)

In the quiet and dark room, the sound of ice clinking against a glass could be heard.

Within it was strong whiskey, and Robert stared intently at the glass.

"What on earth were you trying to do, Levian?"

Robert swirled the glass with alcohol in hand, pondering deeply.

The stories he had heard upon his arrival at the Railer territory.

What had Levian heard from Beatrice to make such a choice?

Was it because of the sacrifices at Ephomos?

Or because he was involved in necromancy?

Could it have been atonement for such matters?

If it were atonement, there were plenty of other choices.

He could have offered support to those who were banished from Ephomos or use the name of a great wizard to overthrow families like the Astria or the Fred.

But Levian had not done so.

What was his intention in creating such a spellbook?

There were other questions too.

'Heh, you might just be the most exceptional of my disciples. I have high expectations for you.'

Levian often said this out of habit.

'A disciple is like a child to their teacher, even more so for an old man like myself.'

The same Levian had exiled him from the empire.

When he had lost his son, Levian had seemed like an enemy.

But upon reflection, there seemed to be no reason for that.

Robert just needed someone to blame.

The thought that it was all his own fault was unbearable.

But knowing the truth brought a sense of self-loathing.

Levian had exiled Robert to save him, even going as far as doing things he would not normally do.

"What am I, of all people, to say."

Bringing the glass to his lips, Robert let out a sigh.

The next morning, we packed our belongings and prepared to leave the estate.

Having gathered the necessary information from the Railer territory, there was no reason to stay.

Luna's parents came out to the mansion's front to see us off.

"Dad, Mom. I'll be going now!"

"Take care, Luna. Write to us often."

"We'll be on our way."

"May your paths be filled with light."

Luna's mother said with a smile, bidding us farewell.

As we all began to board the carriage, an interruption came.

"Hem hem... Rudy Astria?"

Luna's father cleared his throat, approaching me.

"I apologize for the misunderstanding the other day."

"No, it's fine,"

I said with an awkward laugh.

"Still, I've taken a liking to you."

"I also..."

"I'd like to meet you next time as a prospective son-in-law!"

"...What?"

Luna's father stood there, stern-faced, giving a thumbs-up.

"Oh, no."

"Rudy Astria, get in the carriage."

Robert called to me from behind.

"Right, we'll meet again soon, prospective son-in-law."

"Rudy Astria."

"Ah... no."

Unable to say anything else to Luna's father due to Robert's summons, I returned to the carriage.

Inside, it was just Luna and Robert, as it had been when I first arrived.

Luna cocked her head in curiosity as I entered the carriage.

"What did Dad say?"

"...Nothing. It wasn't important."

As I tried to brush it off, Luna squinted her eyes at me.

"Hmm..."

"It really was nothing..."

Seeing that I insisted, Luna broke into a smile and spoke.

"Okay! I'll trust you!"

While it wasn't something I couldn't talk about, I suspected bringing it up would lead to comments like 'Even my parents approve!' and the like.

Better to leave it unsaid.

Looking to change the subject, I turned to Robert.

"Professor, where are you planning to go now?"

We were supposed to be returning to the Gotram territory, where the Mercenary Guild and Jack were.

However, I had told Jack I would return in about five days, and it hadn't been that long yet.

"We'll just go to Gotram territory. There's nothing else to do, is there?"

"I suppose not."

"Once there, we can live it up on that fellow's money. After all, it's practically money I made."

"Ahaha..."

And so, we set off for Gotram territory.

"Hmm..."

"Is this the place?"

Rie frowned as she looked at the building.

The mercenary guild, which had also been used as a pub, had its doors firmly closed.

Luna tilted her head and spoke up, puzzled.

"Uh... did they close up for the day because of some business?"

"Would someone close down a guild just because they have personal matters to attend to...?"

I said to Luna.

Even if one is the head of the guild, it would be unlikely for them to shut down the entire establishment.

"It's more likely that something has happened, right?"

Astina surveyed the surroundings calmly.

The passersby looked at us standing in front of the guild with curious gazes.

Rie looked around at the onlookers and then approached a lady.

"Hello there."

"Oh, yes... But who might you be...?"

"We're just people who have some business in the territory. I'm curious, do you know why the mercenary guild is in such a state?"

Rie asked with a friendly smile.

The lady hesitated for a moment before speaking.

"Thi... the head of the guild has caused some trouble, I heard. The Lord took him away this morning."

"The lord? But why is the guild's door closed?"

"I'm not sure myself... Maybe the guild committed some sort of crime?"

"The guild..."

As Rie was having this conversation, the surrounding people's attention focused even more intensely on us.

Robert, observing the situation, guided us.

"For now, let's go inside and think."

We found an inconspicuous inn and entered a room.

"What's going on?"

Rie said, her expression clouded with concern.

"We don't know. But wasn't he only getting information? How could they respond so quickly?"

The task Robert had entrusted to Jack was to gather information on Ephomos.

It was a matter of finding the necessary information.

Jack was a veteran who had climbed his way up to the head of the mercenary guild after spending a long time on the battlefield.

Could such a person be caught only within a few days of gathering information?

It was puzzling.

One might consider that some mishap could happen, but for the other party to notice so quickly and capture him seemed too odd.

Jack was not a figure under surveillance, merely a mercenary guild head.

Essentially, his position was no different from that of a street gang leader.

Robert pondered for a moment before speaking.

"There could be a few reasons."

"Reasons?"

"One possibility is that the fellow dug around in something sensitive enough to provoke a swift response. However, I consider this unlikely. Jack is savvy enough to avoid such blunders."

"Hmm..."

It was unlikely he was foolish enough to get caught for something trivial.

If he had truly been a fool, he never would have risen to the position of guild head.

Luna cocked her head in curiosity.

"Does that mean the lord of the territory has noticed something?"

"It may not necessarily be the territory lord who has found out,"

"Then, the empire?"

"No."

I spoke with certainty.

It was unlikely for the empire to respond so quickly, especially to an incident in a distant territory—I was confident about that.

Could it mean that the territory lord had unilaterally captured the mercenary guild head?

That didn't make sense either.

The mercenary guild head was said to be a figure not even a territory lord could easily meddle with.

Moreover, since even the empire had little details about Ephomos, it was difficult to figure out what information Jack was digging up.

Of course, if he searched the Astria family mansion, where information about Ephomos was hidden, they would obviously notice.

He would probably be caught on the spot.

The claim that the territory lord had captured him was thus disproven for such reasons.

Robert spoke softly.

"It must be the Rebels."

I agreed with him.

The information we had been trying to find was about Ephomos.

And the reason we were trying to find it was also because of the Rebels.

That person who had come to the academy, the one who used necromancy.

We were gathering information to find out more about him.

Considering those involved in the outer territories with Ephomos and those who could respond quickly, the Rebels were the only plausible group.

We were well aware that the Rebels were joining forces with the nobles on the outskirts.

It was a similar incident to what had happened during our first year at the academy.

"But even if they're the enemy..."

Rie said as she flopped onto the couch.

"What do we do now? Attack the lord?"

Astina shook her head.

"We don't have enough justification for that. On the contrary, we might be the ones who end up getting attacked. There's also no evidence linking this territory's lord to the Rebels, is there?"

"That's why we're deciding what to do now."

"We rescue Jack. We need to know what information he's managed to gather."

Robert rose from his seat and said,

"So, how do you propose we do this?"

"They say he was taken this morning, and if we delay, we don't know what will happen to him. Therefore, we ambush tonight."

Luna's eyes widened at these words.

"...An ambush!"

Luna, who exclaimed with sparkling eyes, quickly covered her mouth with her hands.

"...It's nothing."

Does she like this kind of thing...?

Robert turned his head with an impassive expression and looked at us.

"First, let's go buy robes to disguise ourselves. Since we're attacking at night, everyone should get some rest now."

"Understood."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 163: Rescue Operation (2)

A man walked down the corridor, fiddling with his mustache.

This man was Pierro Gotram, the lord of the Gotram territory, holding the title of baron.

Although he managed the Gotram lands, he was not satisfied with just that.

'Finally, the opportunity has arrived'

As a lord on the outskirts, Gotram harbored ambitions, aspiring to succeed and manage a larger territory one day.

Such outskirt lords were so weak that they could hardly stand up to a head of a mercenary guild.

He craved power, but becoming a grand noble was out of reach due to his lacking capabilities.

His solution was to collaborate with the Rebels.

In every crisis, there was an opportunity.

He believed that if the Rebels could overturn the empire, he would be able to seize substantial power for himself.

As the Rebels started to gain traction, Gotram wasted no time in forming an alliance with them.

However, establishing a cooperative relationship didn't immediately bring the opportunity he was hoping for.

Despite his willingness to support the Rebels, his outskirt territory's limited power meant there was little he could do.

But then, the opportunity he was waiting for finally arrived.

A letter from the Rebels.

The message instructed him to capture Jack, the head of the mercenary guild in the Gotram territory.

Reading the letter, Gotram could not help but shout for joy.

He had the chance to get rid of a thorn in his side and aid the Rebels at the same time.

It was a win-win situation.

Without hesitation, he took action.

With the support of the Rebels, he captured Jack and sent a letter back to them.

In response, he received news that someone from the Rebels' headquarters would come to visit.

"Ahem."

Gotram cleared his throat as he entered the room to meet the representative from the Rebels.

Inside, he found a man with heavy dark circles under his eyes.

"Good day. I am Pierro Gotram, the baron and Lord of Gotram."

He introduced himself, trying to make a good impression.

The man, however, looked at him bluntly without showing any interest.

"I have successfully captured Jack, as you instructed. He is now imprisoned below, ready for you to take him away at any time."

He was really trying his best to make a good impression on the representative.

In contrast, the man from the Rebels' headquarters looked back at him with vacant eyes.

'After all, he is just a commoner.'

Even if he was from the headquarters, he was still a commoner, and he was sure the man would be overwhelmed by the noble treatment.

Gotram clapped his hands, looking towards the door.

Soon, various lavish dishes were brought in.

"The job is done, let's enjoy ourselves! Even though we are an outskirts territory, we've prepared a lot, knowing that someone from the headquarters would be visiting. Hahahaha!"

Gotram continued to fawn over the man.

All the while, the man from the Rebels' headquarters, Daemon—who could use necromancy—looked at Gotram with disdain.

He frowned, unimpressed by the display in front of him.

'Such a rat.'

He gave off a pathetic, rat-like impression.

Daemon clicked his tongue.

To think that a guy like this holds the title of a Lord.

It was utterly pathetic.

“I don’t need this. I’m staying the night and will take the guy with me tomorrow morning, so make sure you prepare for the transfer.”

“Ah... I will prepare everything to the best of my abilities!”

Lord Gotram’s face almost crumpled at Daemon’s arrogant attitude, but he managed to hide his expression as best as he could.

However, Daemon saw right through him.

Fawning over him to his face, but ready to stab him in the back at any moment.

It made him feel nauseous.

‘Ha... If it weren’t for Ephomos, I wouldn’t have come here.’

Daemon looked at Baron Gotram and gestured toward the door.

Gotram, looking puzzled, caught his gesture.

Daemon said quietly,

“Get out.”

“...Ah, understood.”

Baron Gotram lowered his head to Daemon’s threatening tone and obediently left the room.

Daemon watched him leave.

“Worthless scum.”

To think that this kind of guy is strutting around, calling himself a noble.

If you don’t have ability, you should at least have loyalty.

He betrayed the empire that granted him his noble status and clung to the rebels.

‘Just endure until this is over.’

The rebels had no intention of accepting such men.

They were just pawns to be used and discarded.

When everything was over, they planned to eliminate them all.

Those who had committed crimes would be beheaded, and those who were unnecessary would be expelled.

It was a natural step toward creating a new world.

Daemon brought his hand to his neck.

He lightly pulled out the necklace he was wearing and looked at it.

Hanging from the necklace was a ring, its shine faded.

“...Just wait a little longer.”

Daemon spoke to the ring, his words filled with determination.

"A commoner, how dare he. Argh..."

Lord Gotram, trying to suppress his anger, walked along the corridor.

Although he was part of the rebel leadership, his current status as Baron Gotram held more weight.

He was not pleased about having to speak politely and bow his head to someone else.

"That guy... once all this is over, I might be in a position above him."

Despite the man being a part of the rebel leadership, Gotram had spent more time in the political field.

There was no way that someone with such rude manners could survive in politics.

Even if Gotram might lose in a physical fight, he was confident in the political battles.

"We'll see about that later, whether you secure your position or I secure mine."

With a sinister smile, Baron Gotram moved towards the underground prison.

Although it was infuriating, he knew he had to bow his head to that man for now.

His plan was to nicely wrap up the Mercenary Guild head and hand him over.

While Baron Gotram was thinking about this, a loud explosion came from outside.

Bang!

Simultaneously, screams could be heard.

"What the...?"

Surprised by the sudden noise, Gotram's eyes widened.

A soldier was running towards him from a distance.

"Lord, my Lord!"

"What is going on?"

"Sir, it's an ambush! Some strange guy has entered the mansion!"

"A strange guy?"

Baron Gotram frowned.

Could it be someone coming to save that guy, Jack?

"How many are there?"

"Th... That..."

The soldier hesitated at the lord's question.

"Can't you speak faster?"

"... Just one."

"... What?"

Lord Gotram's annoyance surged upon hearing this.

He was already angry because of the rebel guy, and now a single person has attacked, causing all this commotion.

"Then capture him quickly and throw him into the underground prison! We have soldiers from the central here to support us, don't we?"

He mentioned soldiers from the central as support, but in reality, they were rebels.

Since he couldn't openly bring rebels into his territory, he had made up an excuse for the lower-ranked people.

"Th... Those soldiers are also joining the fight."

"What?"

The rebels were helping too.

Soldiers from the territory were also fighting.

"Then you're saying you've captured him?"

"No, sir! The one who attacked is too strong! We need support right away..."

"But it's just one person! It's only one person!"

"He... He's a wizard. The soldiers can't cope with him because he's a wizard! If this continues, the damage could get worse."

"Tch. Then send other soldiers..."

Lord Gotram started to say he would send support but then stopped mid-sentence.

"Is there only one intruder?"

"Uh..."

Upon hearing this, the soldier stopped his speech.

There was only one person confronting them in front of the mansion, but it was uncertain how many more might be present.

"Haha..."

Lord Gotram chuckled as he watched the hesitating soldier.

"Tell them to reinforce the security in the underground prison immediately."

The guy in front of the mansion was a decoy.

Their real intention must be to sneak out Jack from the underground prison.

He had no intention of falling for their trick.

"But, if we strengthen that area, the damages will be..."

As the soldier spoke, Lord Gotram's eyes widened in anger.

“Are you arguing with my orders? Do you have a death wish?”

“...No, I’m not. I’ll go deliver the message right now.”

As the soldier was about to leave, he was stopped.

“Wait a moment.”

Lord Gotram turned his head to look at the soldier.

The soldier looked back at Gotram with a slightly cold expression.

“Is there something you want to say?”

Gotram felt a chilling sensation running down his spine.

'Am I not feeling well?'

However, he didn't think that this feeling was caused by the soldier.

Shaking his head, he spoke.

"Tell the guest in the guest room at the end of the corridor as well. An intruder who intends to capture the criminal has appeared."

Gotram spoke with a smile.

The rebels would be sensitive to any information that Jack might have discovered.

If Jack disappears, it’s the rebels who would be in trouble, not him.

It was certain that he would come help.

He didn’t know the true capabilities of the person in that room, but regardless, it didn’t matter.

If they failed to protect Jack, they could just blame Daemon.

If they succeeded, all the better.

Secretly, Lord Gotram hoped that Daemon would suffer a great blow.

“Understood...”

After responding, the soldier started to run out of sight.

Lord Gotram watched him leave with a sinister smile.

‘I’ll just hide somewhere else and show up after everything is over. After all, their target is Jack.’

With that thought, Lord Gotram looked for a place to hide and walked away.

As Lord Gotram disappeared, the soldier, who had received orders from him, was moving quickly.

The soldier ran down the corridor, then stopped to look around.

Confirming that no one was around, he slowed his pace.

The soldier stopped, looked at the place where Lord Gotram had disappeared, and smirked.

“...What an idiot.”

As the soldier muttered to himself, his appearance gradually changed, and he transformed into a blonde woman.

A blonde woman in a robe.

It was Rie.

The illusion magic that Luna had cast had worn off, and she had returned to her original form.

"Why is Astina taking so long to get things started?"

Her illusion almost reverted in front of the Lord.

Rie looked outside the window with an annoyed expression.

Outside, Astina, clad in a robe and wearing a mask, was visible.

She was dealing with the soldiers using basic magic.

“More importantly, there is a guest...”

Rie didn't know who the guest was, but she suspected it might be someone from the Rebels.

Looking outside, she saw some soldiers who didn't belong to the territory.

These soldiers, dressed more shabbily than those from the territory, were however, performing better in battle.

The lord claimed they were from central, but just by their clothes, it was clear that these weren't soldiers from the central forces.

From that, she thought the guest might be someone from the Rebels leading those soldiers.

‘First, I should join up with Rudy.’

Rie turned around and started running toward the underground prison, a smile playing on her lips.

Chapter 164: Rescue Operation (3)

"Hmm..."

"Identify yourself!!!"

Astina stretched and walked forward.

'By this time, they should all be ready.'

She surveyed her surroundings.

Having broken through the main gate, many soldiers stood before her.

Because she needed to conceal her identity, she couldn't use her telekinetic magic.

But there was no need for that—not for these small fries.

"Wind Blaster."

A fierce wind howled through, like a tempest.

"A wizard!!!"

"Agh!!!"

The soldiers' eyes bulged at the sight of Astina's magic.

Wizards were elite talents, welcomed everywhere.

Such beings were rare in these rural parts.

The soldiers were in disarray, unprepared for an ambush by a wizard.

"There's only one of her! Stay calm and handle this!"

"Pfft!"

Astina couldn't help but laugh at their command.

These soldiers knew not the terror of a wizard.

A single wizard could take on hundreds, even thousands.

That was the might of a wizard.

There was a clear distinction between them and the common people.

Furthermore, the level of any countryside wizard compared to Astina was like heaven and earth.

Astina was a wizard who could wipe out thousands with a mere flick of her finger.

These soldiers were no match for her.

"Everyone, keep your cool. She's a wizard, so there will be an opening when she casts her spells. Aim for that."

In the midst of the soldiers' panic, some composed figures could be seen.

They wore different attire from the rest—shabbier, yet they responded to the wizard with seasoned calm.

Astina, observing this, posed a question.

"Who might you be?"

The shabbily dressed soldiers did not answer.

They clenched their jaws, ready to charge at her.

"Hmm..."

Astina regarded them with a leisurely gaze.

"I'll know once I've taken you all down."

Her task was simple.

Attract attention and defeat all the enemies before her.

Nothing more.

Astina, smiling, began to speak.

"10 seconds."

She spread her hands wide, showing them to the soldiers.

"Try to last 10 seconds."

"What?"

It might have sounded arrogant, overbearing.

But Astina was sincere.

Her judgment was objective, unemotional.

She knew these men couldn't last 10 seconds against her.

That was the objective difference between Astina and the soldiers.

After her statement, Astina immediately began her incantation.

"Wind Blaster."

Behind the Gotram mansion, on the path to the underground prison.

"Who, who goes there?!"

Bang—

It was a single punch.

Robert sent the soldier flying far off.

"This is no ambush. This... isn't an ambush..."

Luna murmured, her face sullen.

I shared Luna's sentiment.

The plan was simple: place Astina up front to draw the gaze, and we slip into the prison amidst the distraction.

Rie would sow confusion among the lord's forces to prevent them from responding properly.

That was the strategy.

But now, looking at the situation, I wondered if it was even necessary.

Our foes couldn't touch us.

We didn't even bother to hide.

We walked in boldly and overpowered them with ease.

We hadn't hidden ourselves since crossing the mansion's wall to the prison.

If the enemy can't stop us, why bother concealing our approach?

Luna seemed to have expected something more from the ambush, but now she wore a face of slight disappointment.

I opened my mouth, forcing a smile.

"At least it looks like things will be easy. I was worried for nothing."

The idea of staging an ambush to rescue someone had weighed on us.

But as the situation unfolded with such ease, relief washed over me.

Robert cast a look of mild disdain my way.

"What did you expect from an attack on a mere countryside noble?"

As we continued to converse and move forward, some soldiers emerged.

"Ugh... Aaahh!"

"The enemy...!"

They fled at the sight of us.

A wise decision, in its own way.

No matter how much they resisted, they couldn't hope to win against us.

But Robert didn't let them escape.

"Where do you think you're running off to?"

He pursued the soldier swiftly and swung his fist.

The fleeing soldier, showing his back, had no chance to avoid the attack and was smashed against the wall.

It was a merciless strike.

Although it was a logical decision since fleeing soldiers could cause problems, after witnessing such scenes repeatedly, pity for the soldiers began to seep in.

"Perhaps we didn't need a strategy after all..."

"Strategies are always crafted to prepare for the worst-case scenario. How do we know if some of the Rebels aren't here?"

"...Then shouldn't you, Professor, have taken the front?"

Astina might be strong, but she was not on Robert's level.

The front was where the focus was, where the strongest enemy would surely appear.

"Sending Astina out front wasn't because she's the strongest among you."

Robert looked at me.

"It's all about playing our respective roles."

I tilted my head, contemplating his words.

Continuing our descent, no more soldiers could be seen as we went further down.

Eventually, the stairs led us to a vast space where the soldiers were congregated.

At first, I thought perhaps they had split into two paths in their flight, but that wasn't the case.

Did they believe they had a fighting chance in this spacious area?

The mood, however, wasn't one of hopeful strategy.

All their faces were brimming with confidence.

"There must be something here."

It was obvious to anyone looking.

An unpleasant energy could be felt emanating from the end of the space.

Clank— Clank—

From behind the soldiers, someone was approaching.

This figure was clad in black full plate armor, holding a sword that gleamed with darkness.

"There's... a strange sensation."

Luna hesitated as she looked at the person.

I felt I knew what she was sensing.

Powerful Wizards or swordsmen exude mana.

A large, overwhelming presence of mana...

In contrast, this person's mana had a different quality.

It was sticky and dark, so repulsive it furrowed our brows.

It was difficult to pinpoint the exact nature of the feeling, but it was undeniably distasteful.

As Luna and I grimaced, Robert opened his mouth to speak.

"It's a Death Knight."

"What?"

"A creature resurrected through necromancy."

Robert began to walk forward.

"Seeing a Death Knight as a guard here, it seems Jack has dug up some accurate information."

After stating this, Robert turned to look at me.

"Rudy Astria, watch and learn."

"What?"

Suddenly, the Death Knight charged at us with incredible speed.

It swung its sword horizontally, aiming directly at Robert.

"Professor...!"

Before I could shout out a warning, Robert had already moved.

He twisted his body to dodge the blade and slipped inside the Death Knight's guard.

"I'll show you how to counter necromancy right now."

He spoke and then targeted the Death Knight's arm.

"Target their joints."

If one had gotten inside a person's guard, targeting the torso would have been efficient.

But Robert chose differently.

He aimed for the bending part of the arm that held the sword.

With a powerful punch, he struck the seam of the armor.

Crack—

The sound of shattering metal resonated through the air.

The Death Knight's armored arm was shattered to pieces.

It was well-known that armor seams were vulnerable.

However, this was different from breaking the armor of a living person.

The connected joint easily crumbled, and the arm itself was gone.

A person's arm wouldn't just disappear like that, not with skin and flesh and bone.

The sword, propelled by momentum, flew far away.

Reacting to this, the Death Knight raised its leg, attempting to strike Robert with its knee.

"Secondly, creatures resurrected by necromancy do not feel pain,"

Robert stated as he effortlessly blocked a knee strike, his movements showing he predicted the attack.

"They don't feel pain, so regardless of what happens, they will persist in their assault."

He continued, pushing away the Death Knight's knee and swiftly pivoting, his leg rising in a high arc aimed precisely at the Death Knight's head.

With a fluid motion, there was a sickening crunch as the helmet shattered under the force, revealing the crumbled skull within.

Robert then stepped back, but the battle was far from over.

Despite its head being crushed, the Death Knight remained undeterred, still moving.

"Finally."

The Death Knight, despite its ruined form, charged toward him once more.

This time, Robert manipulated his mana and invoked,

"Hand of the Abyss."

The Death Knight's advance came to an abrupt stop as black hands emerged from the ground, grasping its legs.

These hands multiplied, extending to ensnare the Death Knight from legs to body, to arms, and finally the head, pulling it toward the ground.

With the Death Knight immobilized by the dark appendages, it emitted a bizarre sound.

Robert then placed his foot atop the Death Knight's chest, crushing the armor to reveal the contents inside.

Visible among the remains were ribs, possibly human, and at the heart's position, a black orb-like object.

Touching the orb lightly, Robert explained,

"Thirdly, all beings resurrected by necromancy possess a core. That is the core."

Looking at us, he elaborated,

"Once that core is destroyed, this creature can no longer move. It's the most straightforward and effective method."

"...Then why didn't you destroy it from the beginning?"

"To teach you. Plus destroying it immediately would alert the necromancer who cast the spell."

Despite its struggle, the Death Knight was helpless.

Robert gazed intently at the well-crafted Death Knight.

"It's better made than I expected. Is 'he' here?"

"...A well-made Death Knight?"

I mused, finding it oddly easy to defeat.

I was slightly confused but assumed Robert must be correct in his assessment.

"Could it be a necromancer from Ephomos?"

"It might not be. I suspect there's another necromancer among the Rebels, though I doubt they could create something of this standard."

Robert said, then turned his attention forward.

Before us stood soldiers shaking with terror.

Having seen Robert toy with and then smash the Death Knight, their fear was understandable.

Robert glanced at the soldiers and clenched his fist, then chuckled.

"Let's not be a nuisance. Just take a hit and go down quietly."

It was a remark both kind and ruthless.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 165: Rescue Operation (4)

"What's this guy up to?"

Daemon had not yet fully comprehended the situation.

He wasn't overly concerned when he learned that the head of the Mercenary Guild had dug up some information.

With his power, he could easily suppress the Mercenary Guild, so he thought if someone came to rescue the captive, he could easily thwart them.

But the person outside was not of that caliber.

A wizard who had hidden their appearance with a robe and had taken down all the soldiers.

The magic they wielded was unremarkable, but the mana seeping from their body indicated they were no ordinary wizard.

They were concealing their true power.

Therefore, even Daemon couldn't rashly intervene.

Daemon clicked his tongue in frustration.

"I'm going to hear it from the leader when I get back."

Not only the soldiers at the mansion but also the rebel soldiers he had brought were down.

He had brought only the most agile and skilled soldiers as his elite force.

However, they were no match for that wizard.

Each fallen comrade was a painful loss for the rebels.

Still, he couldn't make his move.

There could be hidden allies, and victory over that wizard was uncertain.

A necromancer fights with an army prepared in advance.

This kind of battle was unfavorable.

Even if he couldn't save the soldiers, it was right to prioritize his own safety.

It was Daemon's oversight.

He had erred by not anticipating the appearance of such a skilled adversary and by creating an opening from trying to handle things quickly.

"It's better to plan for the future."

There was no benefit in engaging with such an opponent.

It was best to remain safe until the dust settled.

"Death Knight."

As Daemon manipulated his mana, he commanded.

"Bring the head of the Mercenary Guild to me."

He sent a command to the Death Knight in the underground prison through mana.

He planned to escape swiftly, avoiding confrontation with the intruder.

The battle was a victory as long as the others didn't get information about Ephomos from him.

Daemon made his exit through the back.

He waited for the Death Knight behind the mansion.

But something was off.

The Death Knight did not arrive.

It was well past the time he should have been there.

"Huh..."

He could tell that things had gone seriously wrong.

Had the underground prison already been breached?

"I can't just stay put."

Daemon's arrival here was his own action.

Not even Aryandor, the leader, nor the other executives were aware of it.

Ephomos was unrelated to the rebels and so he acted alone.

He must not get caught here.

Daemon's capture alone would deal a great blow to the rebels.

Daemon clenched his jaw with regret.

"I should have killed him immediately after he got captured."

Not executing Jack instantly was his blunder.

His arrogance had been in trying to take the man back to the Rebels to extract information.

Daemon made a decision.

He must flee first.

The core of the Death Knight remained intact.

However, its lack of response indicated it was certainly bound by some restraint.

Someone was knowledgeable about necromantic magic.

They had acted discreetly to avoid detection.

Then, there was no point in fighting; the odds were against him.

But Daemon didn't intend to just run away.

At the very least, he had to eliminate the one who held the information.

He reached into his pocket.

Inside, there was a single black orb.

Daemon placed the orb on the ground and began to chant.

"Rise, the dead... entwine and rise once more."

His mana was drawn into the soil.

"Death Golem."

Bones began to rise, weaving together from the ground.

Daemon observed the forming golem and commanded.

"Kill the head of the Mercenary Guild."

In the underground prison...

"Heh heh heh... Kuhuhuhu... I thought I was a goner for sure..."

Jack was a mess of tears and snot as he clung to Robert.

"Don't stick to me, damn it. We've got to get out of here, now."

Robert, clearly irritated, pushed Jack away with his foot.

Luna and I couldn't help but laugh at the sight.

Jack didn't seem to have any serious injuries.

A small bruise on his face and marks on his arms from being tied up were all that was evident.

I took a look around the prison.

It seemed to be somewhat tidied up.

The Death Knight was immobilized, and the soldiers were all downed.

All we had to do now was escape.

"So, now we..."

Boom—

That's when it happened.

As I was about to speak, a deep rumbling resonated through the prison.

"What's that?"

The ceiling shook, and dust began to fall.

There had been a large impact from outside.

I could hear someone running quickly toward the prison.

"Rudy!! Are you there??"

"Rie?"

Her voice echoed down the staircase.

"Hey!! Get up here!!! There's big trouble!!"

Rie sounded incredibly urgent.

At her call, we all rushed outside.

There stood Rie, with a scowl on her face.

"What's going on?"

Without answering, Rie reached out her hand.

"Over..."

"Gravity!"

Astina was floating, using her telekinesis.

In front of her was a massive entity.

It was a monster resembling a large face, formed from intertwined skeletons, with several arms jutting out, moving in bizarre ways.

Moreover, its size was so immense it nearly rivaled the mansion itself.

"What is that?"

"I don't know. It just appeared and started smashing everything."

The half-demolished mansion was visible.

"Astina's been keeping it from moving toward the village but..."

I removed the mask covering my face and rolled up my sleeves.

"We can't just leave it be."

"I'll help!"

Luna also took a spellbook from her bag.

Just as we prepared to confront the situation...

"Hm?"

The giant creature turned its body.

"...Why does it seem to be looking right at us?"

"It does seem to be... doesn't it?"

"What?"

As we stood perplexed, a strange noise emanated from the creature.

"Graaaaah...!"

The monster suddenly pivoted and began advancing towards us.

It closed the distance rapidly.

"Why is it suddenly coming at us?"

"I don't know! Just block it!"

I asked, and Rie, frowning, began to manipulate her mana.

A small flame burst from Rie's hand, which she hurled at the approaching monstrosity.

I was also moved to act, channeling my mana.

"Finger of the Demon!"

A colossal pillar burst forth from the ground, an attempt to stop the monster in its tracks.

Boom—

Rie's spell hit the creature dead-on, causing a significant explosion.

The pillar I had conjured was placed precisely in the monster's path.

"Graaaaah...!"

Yet, it proved futile.

The creature seemed unaffected by Rie's magic, and the pillar I erected broke like a twig against its movement.

As we prepared to cast another round of spells, Robert, standing beside me, reached out his hand.

"Stop. Don't waste your mana."

"What?"

He glanced over at Luna and Rie.

"Luna, Rie. Take Jack and get to the back."

"What?"

"But we can also..."

Robert frowned at the two of them.

"You won't be of help. And can't you see what that monster is targeting?"

The rampaging creature, having been indiscriminately destroying, now turned its focus towards us.

It had a target among us.

The most likely candidate was Jack, given that the enemy didn't even know who we were.

"Just protect Jack. And..."

He then turned to look at me.

"Rudy Astria, follow me."

"Me?"

In Robert's grasp was a staff of indeterminate origin.

It was of a peculiar length, neither long nor short, about the size of a human arm, white and without any adornment.

Staff in hand, Robert lunged towards the monster.

Without a second thought, I followed Robert towards the creature.

As Robert charged, the monster moved its arm to knock him away.

"Huh!"

Robert targeted the arm moving towards him, pointing the staff's tip forward like a blade.

The tip of the staff illuminated brightly.

With that illuminated tip, Robert stabbed at the monster's arm that was trying to hit him.

Zzzt!!!

Upon contact with the staff, the monster's limb disintegrated.

One of its giant arms decomposed upon mere contact with the staff, with neither a forceful impact nor an explosion.

"What in the..."

I watched, my eyes wide in shock.

Robert, having destroyed the arm, descended to the ground and then looked up to shout.

"Astina!!!! Stop its movements!"

"Understood."

Astina responded to Robert's call to action.

After hearing her reply, Robert turned to look at me.

"Rudy Astria, did you see that?"

"I saw it."

"I'll breach the monster with this staff. You go in and smash the core inside."

"There's a core inside it?"

"Didn't I tell you during the lesson? A core exists. We can't hold back such a massive body, so we must aim for the core."

I nodded at Robert's explanation and opened my mouth to speak.

"Understood. But..."

"What's wrong? Out with it."

"What is that staff?"

I pointed to the white staff in Robert's hand.

"It's my staff for handling monsters like this one."

Robert said, tapping the staff lightly.

The sight felt like that of a teacher instilling fear in students with a ruler.

But this was a staff?

It looked nothing like the staffs I was familiar with.

There were no mana stones in sight, nor did it seem to be a conduit for casting spells.

Many questions arose, but now was not the time for them.

Robert looked at me and opened his mouth to speak.

"Then, do you think you can do it?"

I smiled slightly.

"Is there another option? If my teacher instructs, I act."

Robert snickered at my response.

"Then follow me."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 166: Rescue Operation (5)

Hundreds of bones and clumps of mud formed a monstrous body, from which dozens of arms protruded.

The arms were no different in composition from the body.

They tried to swat away Robert, who was charging towards them.

However, it was futile.

"Gravity."

The arms trying to block Robert were knocked away by Astina.

Simultaneously pushing the arms away, she used other magic.

"Pressure Field."

Astina immobilized the monstrous body to prevent it from moving.

The monster thrashed in response to Astina's magic, but it couldn't break free.

Robert charged straight towards the restrained monster.

I followed behind him.

Robert held out the staff in his hand.

Then, he used a spell.

"Finger of the Demon."

A black pillar rose from the ground.

It did not erect straight up but formed a path leading towards the monster.

Robert climbed atop the pillar and started running.

That's when he reached near the body of the monster.

"Rudy Astria, I don't know where its core is. I'll pierce through its body; you find the core."

"Understood."

I responded to Robert's words.

Robert gripped the staff tightly and thrust it towards the monster.

As the tip of the staff touched the monster, cracks began to spread across its entire body.

"Rudy."

At Robert's call, I manipulated my mana.

At the very least, find the core.

If possible, destroy it.

I repeated it in my mind several times.

The crack created by Robert gradually widened, and the entire body began to disintegrate.

Crash!

As the monster's body shattered into pieces, the mud and bone fragments that constituted its body scattered around.

I opened my eyes wide in awe of that power.

What on earth was the capability of that staff to unleash such a formidable power?

Could Robert alone win with this?

However, there was no time to be astonished by Robert's abilities.

Finding the core, as Robert had mentioned, was the priority.

I focused and looked around.

Unlike the Death Knight, which had its core in the center of its body, the monster's core was not visible in the center.

That meant the core must be somewhere within its body parts.

I scanned the surroundings.

I had to find where the strong mana was concentrated.

I recalled the feeling Luna and I had when we encountered the Death Knight.

I needed to find mana that gave off a sticky and unpleasant feeling.

However, the mana was spread throughout the entire body.

Since mana was what constituted and moved its body, that was a given.

Nevertheless, I had to find it.

Find where it felt the most distinct.

Find where the strong mana was.

That's when a hand was placed on my shoulder.

It was Robert.

He was breathing heavily.

Having shattered that gigantic body, he seemed to have used a lot of mana.

Even in his fatigue, he did not hold back his advice.

"Focus. Feel the mana."

"Don't rely on your sight. Find it with your own senses."

I continued to concentrate while listening to Robert's words.

As I focused and scanned my surroundings, I looked at a skull lying far away.

The skull felt different from the fragments around it.

There was no concrete evidence.

It was just a feeling.

I quickly moved my mana.

"Dark Spear."

A black spear slowly formed in my hand.

It was a spell I could use quickly.

Robert opened his mouth as he saw this.

"Have you found it?"

There was no time to answer.

I immediately threw the spear at the skull.

The spear flew at a high speed.

However, it did not reach the skull.

"Ah...!"

The bone fragments beside the skull transformed into a hand and grabbed the spear.

Robert also smiled as he saw this.

"So it's that one."

The bone fragments that blocked the spear started to gather around the skull again.

The bones, along with the dirt on the ground, started to clump together again, transforming into a giant body.

"Is it regenerating?"

"That's right. Since it can't use magic or other abilities, it has excellent recovery capabilities."

I nodded as I saw this.

Robert caught his rough breath and spoke again.

"The core is not a hard substance. It's an object condensed with mana. Think of it as attacking to break a mana stone."

"Remember the sensation of finding the core. And find out to what extent it can block magic. I'll break through it no matter how many times it takes."

I shook my head and smiled at his words.

This advice was enough.

Now was the time to repay Robert for his teachings.

"I think it will be enough in the next attempt."

I had no intention of troubling Robert numerous times.

Robert looked at me with sharp eyes.

"...Are you prepared to say such a thing?"

"Of course."

I was confident.

I would mobilize all the knowledge I had accumulated so far.

I would pour them all into this attempt.

I would not think about mistakes.

I would only aim for success.

Of course, with Robert, Astina, Luna, and Rie around me, I could afford to make many attempts.

My acquaintances would give me another chance.

However, I shouldn't rely entirely on them.

Although I have several attempts now, it might not be the case next time.

There will often be times when only one chance is given.

I have already failed once, and this is my second chance given.

So, failure is not an option.

I will finish it this time.

Robert once again picked up his staff and loosened up his body.

As he prepared again, I took a deep breath.

“Phew!”

I brushed off my sleeves and recalled what just happened.

Remember the sensation.

I felt a distinct mana in the surroundings, different from just a moment ago.

It came with a flash of realization, as if I had just discovered something new.

I must remember this feeling.

I decided to take on the challenge with the mindset that this could be my last attempt, thinking that everything would be over if I failed.

In front of me, a monster was squirming as it regenerated.

Robert fiddled with his staff a few times.

Then, as a small light appeared from the staff, he looked at me.

“Ready.”

“I’m ready as well.”

Hearing my response, Robert took the lead and walked forward.

The monster in front of us now had more mud than bones in its composition, squirming like slime.

Instead of the arms that appeared before, there were now tentacles made of mud surrounding it.

The tentacles tried to block our way, just like before.

Astina, seeing us move, used her magic again.

But, unlike before, it wasn’t easily blocked.

Even when pushed back with telekinetic magic, the tentacles flexibly evaded the magic and targeted us, as if they had learned from our previous encounter.

“Astina! Focus on immobilizing its main body, not the tentacles!”

Robert shouted, looking up at the sky.

The creature’s body had become more flexible as it mixed with the mud.

Fixing its flexible body in place was a tough task, hence the need to concentrate on one thing.

I roughly understood Robert’s intention, but Astina seemed slightly offended, furrowing her brow.

“Understood.”

After speaking in a voice tinged with frustration, Astina flew upwards.

Then she moved a massive amount of mana.

“Gravity Field.”

Seeing this, Robert prepared to run forward.

“Dodge everything and proceed.”

I gathered mana in my legs, pushing my physical abilities beyond their normal limits.

“Huff...!”

Robert dashed forward, moving faster than me.

I followed a bit more slowly.

I concentrated even before Robert began to break apart the monster’s body.

Although its body was tightly packed, there surely was a core somewhere within.

And this core felt distinctly different from the other parts of its body.

I focused, looking at the whole while searching for the part.

Concentrating, I aimed to pierce through at a single point.

“Rudy Astria!”

Robert broke through the tentacles and reached the monster in an instant, with intense light emanating from his staff.

“Give it a try.”

As the staff touched the monster, its body cracked like before, splitting into parts.

Despite the urgent situation, I closed my eyes.

I scanned the surroundings, not with my eyes, but with my senses.

I read the flow of mana, finding the sticky, dark flow of mana.

And then...

“I’ve found it.”

I read the location precisely.

Top right.

Next to the third tentacle from the top.

I opened my eyes and confirmed the exact location.

Then, I dashed forward.

Gathering mana in my legs, I burst forward.

I had to pierce through its body shattered and scattered around.

“Ugh...”

But my speed was too slow.

The amount of mana I could use at once was limited, so I couldn't invest too much in my legs.

I made a quick decision and shouted.

“Priscilla!”

And so, I chose Priscilla.

Using Priscilla doesn't consume a lot of mana as long as I don't use the elemental's power.

Then, blue smoke gathered in front of me, and a wolf with a mix of silver and blue appeared.

Without a moment to speak, I climbed onto Priscilla's back.

“What are you doing...?”

“Run! It's to the top right of that monster!”

Priscilla looked bewildered, but there was no time to explain.

As I shouted, Priscilla moved as instructed.

“I am a elemental, not a mount.”

Of course, she didn't forget to grumble.

Despite her protest, she was much faster than my running speed.

The rift that Robert created was gradually widening, and it was almost time for it to completely crumble.

I tapped on Priscilla's back and spoke.

“Priscilla, we need to go up.”

The monster's body was as tall as a three-story building.

There was no footing around, so Priscilla couldn't jump up.

"Phew..."

Priscilla sighed at my words.

"I will lift you as high as possible."

"Thanks. I'll take you for a long walk when this is over."

Priscilla sharpened her claws and charged at the monster.

Using the momentum from her run, she climbed up the monster.

As we quickly ascended, the monster's body started to crumble.

Its body was made of mud, so it scattered and couldn't be used as a foothold.

The part Priscilla was stepping on disappeared.

I then moved my feet to Priscilla's back.

"Here goes."

"Alright."

We moved in sync, as if we had agreed upon our actions beforehand.

I used Priscilla's back as a stepping stone and pushed myself up.

Then, I gathered mana in my feet and jumped.

At the same time, Priscilla pushed me forward.

Directly towards the direction where I could feel the core.

Bang—

“Ugh...”

With a slight groan from the impact, Priscilla fell to the ground.

“Don’t forget about the walk.”

She fell to the ground, her body dispersing like smoke.

Thanks to Priscilla’s push, my body was propelled into the air.

In mid-air, I gathered mana in my hand.

No, to be precise, I gathered mana in my index finger.

The core wasn’t that big.

From what I heard from Robert, it was definitely protected by mana.

Then, I must pierce through a small point.

I will pierce through the core, which is heavily protected by mana, at one point.

Gathering mana at my fingertips, I waited for the right timing as the core was falling.

Amidst the soft, muddy ground.

A small skull appeared.

It was clear as day.

It’s coming closer.

Right in front of me.

And then,

“In one go.”

I pierce through.

As soon as the skull reached in front of me, I concentrated on one point of my finger.

I thrust my arm forward.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 167: Head (1)

Dawn breaks.

A bright light spreads across the once-dark surroundings.

The mansion lies half in ruins, with mud and bone fragments scattered around in disarray.

"What a mess,"

Astina remarked, landing gracefully from the sky.

"At least the monster didn't reach the village."

The village remains untouched, with only the lord's mansion and its surroundings affected.

"Hey! Are you okay?"

"Rudy!"

Luna and Rie rush over from behind.

"Yeah, I'm fine."

I reply, managing a smile for them.

"Did you push yourself too hard? Are you hurt anywhere?"

"Hm? Not really."

The monster wasn't as strong as we thought, so I wasn't seriously injured.

Of course, it's likely because Astina skillfully thwarted the monster's attacks.

Then Robert gives me a light pat on the back.

"Good job."

He says, smiling warmly.

After dawn, the area around the mansion became bustling.

"Help me clean this up!"

"Got it!"

With the villagers' assistance, we set about clearing the debris of the collapsed mansion and removing mud.

Though we wondered if it was our responsibility, the situation demanded it.

When the monster demolished the mansion, the lord hiding inside perished.

Since he was a lord condemned to death for colluding with the rebels, there was no sentiment of mourning.

Though it was unclear how much this outskirts lord knew, interrogating him might have yielded valuable information.

It was a regrettable loss.

But first things first, we had to manage the lord's territory.

We needed to clean up the wreckage and handle the aftermath.

Rie, leveraging her status as a princess, had already mobilized the villagers and soldiers for the task.

So, we began restoring the ruined mansion and tidying the surroundings.

But Rie couldn't stay in this territory indefinitely.

"Should we ask Luna's parents to step in?"

Luna's eyes widened at Rie's suggestion.

"Usually, a neighboring lord takes over in such situations."

"I know, but..."

When a lord dies suddenly or lacks a successor, a neighboring lord typically assumes the duties.

However, that wasn't the end of it.

Often, the lord who serves as regent ends up receiving the territory, especially in outlying areas like this.

"Wouldn't managing two territories be too taxing?"

Luna voiced her concern.

I responded with a smile to her worry.

Most would rejoice at the prospect of gaining a territory, but Luna was more concerned about her parents.

"With Jack there, the workload shouldn't be too burdensome."

"Besides, the central government will handle the recent incident. They'll only need to manage the usual lordly duties. There's no need to worry."

Rie and Robert reassured Luna.

"I can handle it! I'm a native of this territory, so I know it well!"

Jack declared confidently, thumping his chest.

Robert looked at Jack with a mix of disdain and amusement.

"What can you really do? At best, you're just a local troublemaker."

"Oh, you don't understand. In small towns like this, the role of a troublemaker is crucial."

"Fine. Try it your way. But still..."

Robert crossed his arms and fixed Jack with a stern gaze.

"What exactly is this critical information you've uncovered that led to all this? You mentioned direct rebel involvement, which sounds important."

"Oh, that?"

Jack grinned, flashing a row of white teeth.

"I've stumbled upon some incredible information."

"Incredible information?"

"It's about the connection between the trashy Wizards of Ephomos and the Astria Duke Family!"

At that revelation, we all widened our eyes in surprise.

And then, everyone except Robert and Jack turned to look at me.

Robert, gazing at Jack, asked,

"What kind of connection are we talking about?"

Jack let out a derisive snort,

"Those Astrias, they're nothing but trash! Do you have any idea what they've been up to?"

"So, what exactly did they do?"

Jack, arms folded, looked upwards as if deep in thought.

"Well... Levian disbanded Ephomos, right? And chased you out? It was then that the fleeing residents and necromancers of Ephomos were taken in by the Astria family."

"Not just the necromancers, but the residents too?"

"Yes, they didn't take in everyone, but they certainly took a good number of them."

Jack said with a voice filled with outrage,

"Do you know what they did with those residents? They used them all for experiments and killed them! I'm telling you, it's outrageous! Handing them all over to the necromancers as experimental subjects."

"Mana stones, maybe..."

Robert muttered, his expression turning grim.

Levian had dismantled Ephomos, and I had wondered where all those residents went.

It turned out they were all hidden by the Astria family.

It was hard to say whether Levian knew about this.

It seemed more likely that he didn't.

If he had, neither the Empire nor other noble families would have stayed silent.

"That despicable Astria family. Just hearing about them makes me want to kick their backsides. If those guys were in front of me..."

"Enough, that's enough."

"Why should I stop? They deserve much worse! We must expose them! Just the sight of 'Astria' grinds my gears!"

We should annihilate the entire family..."

I forced an awkward smile at this.

I should have disclosed my family name when I introduced myself.

What should I do now...

I was completely unaware of the atrocities committed by the Astria family.

Everything being discussed happened before I entered this body, so naturally, I was ignorant.

These were events I couldn't have stopped even if I had wanted to.

Therefore, I didn't take Jack's words to heart.

It wasn't personal, after all.

But it seemed not everyone around felt the same way.

Everyone, except for Jack and Robert, was glancing at me warily.

"Those Astrias..."

Then Luna cautiously spoke up, "Um..."

"Yes?"

"Rudy is here, you know..."

"Rudy? Oh right, his name is Rudy. What about it?"

"He's... from the Astria family..."

"Uh?"

Jack's eyes widened at that revelation.

He swallowed hard, then cautiously asked,

"Is he... like from a vassal family under the Astrias or something?"

I wondered if I should have kept it hidden...

"No, I am Rudy Astria, the second son of the Astria family."

Silence ensued.

After a brief commotion...

Jack tearfully pleaded for forgiveness from me, begging not to be killed.

It was only after I assured him that I had no significant ties with the Astria family's actions that he finally calmed down.

My position was indeed a bit precarious.

Although I was part of the Astria family, I had no real influence or control within it.

However, this detached position seemed to be an advantage at the moment.

It meant I didn't have a part in the family's wrongdoings.

"Time to head back, right?"

With Luna's parents and Jack handling things here, it was time for us to return.

There was plenty to do with the information Jack had provided, along with many other tasks.

The end of the break was approaching, and we had to get ready for the upcoming assessments.

There were also staff-related matters to look into.

"Ah."

A question suddenly struck me.

"Professor Robert?"

Robert, who was walking ahead, turned around.

"Yes?"

"I wanted to ask about the staff you used during the battle with the monster."

"Oh, this one?"

Robert said, pulling out the staff from his cloak.

It was short enough to fit inside his clothing.

"May I take a closer look at it?"

"Sure."

Robert tossed me the staff.

It was a white staff, its material a mystery to me.

I looked up at Robert curiously.

"How did you make this?"

"It's essentially a chunk of mana stone. This staff has the ability to break non-living objects in one strike."

"Really?"

"It's pointless to explain it all here."

Robert had a point.

"Understood."

I handed the staff back to him.

There would be time for a detailed explanation once we were back at the academy.

Recalling Robert's use of the staff in battle, I pondered deeply.

Had I been too rigid in my understanding of staffs?

They were not just devices to aid in casting magic but tools to assist the wizard themselves.

This realization became clear after observing Robert's combat style.

I smiled to myself.

"I'll need to completely redesign my staff when we return."

I was planning to overhaul my staff entirely – not just a mundane, conventional staff, but one uniquely mine.

"Let's go back,"

Robert called out and started walking towards the carriage.

As we walked,

"Rudy Astria. You'll be quite busy when we get back."

Astina approached me with a smile.

"Yes, there's a lot to do. Dealing with Astria family matters... and crafting a proper staff..."

"Hmm?"

Astina looked at me, her expression curious.

At her response, I tilted my head in confusion.

"Isn't that what you were referring to?"

"You... haven't seen your grades yet?"

"...What?"

Astina let out a sigh.

"First semester grades. They were released on the first day of the break. Didn't you check?"

"Ah."

Now that she mentioned it, I hadn't really checked my grades.

We left with Robert right as the break started... I hadn't had the time to look into it.

"But why would that make me busier?"

Astina smiled.

"You're the top student. You have to take over the duties that come with being the first in rank."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 168: Head (2)

On a dark night.

"I can help you."

Evan remembered what Jefrin had said.

"How exactly do you intend to help me..."

He was sitting in the dormitory, clutching his head in frustration.

Studying just didn't seem to click.

Even when he tried to train, a flood of distracting thoughts hindered him.

Evan had grown stronger.

He was now as strong as any student at the academy.

Yet, he was far from satisfied.

In fact, he found himself longing for his first year.

A time when he didn't compare himself to others, focusing solely on his own growth, on his pure efforts...

"How did it all come to this..."

Evan let out a deep sigh.

The next day.

"Ah..."

A woman stretched with a bright expression.

She was loosening up her body, moving around.

Although her demeanor seemed cold, her eyes held warmth as she gazed at the academy.

"Don't engage in intense exercise. Your wounds might get worse."

"Understood."

Responding to Cromwell's advice, the woman nodded.

The woman, Yaniel, with her silver hair fluttering, replied.

Cromwell, watching her, smiled and then spoke.

"Ah, and Principal McDowell wanted me to pass on a message."

"Yes?"

"He said to come and boast to him once you get good grades."

Hearing this, Yaniel fell silent.

McDowell had protected her, even when she was acting as a spy.

He had helped her, even to the point of losing his arm.

"...Please tell him I'll give it my best."

Determination was etched on Yaniel's face.

"Right, here's your dorm key. I've already unpacked your things, so you can use that room."

"Thank you."

After expressing her gratitude to Cromwell, Yaniel moved on.

In front of the dormitory, workers were busily moving around.

They carried furniture and various documents into the dorm.

Yeniel looked on, puzzled.

"Does someone actually bring such personal belongings to the dormitory?"

The dorm was already filled with fine furniture.

It was rare for someone to bring in their own personal furniture.

"Oh, that needs to go to the research lab."

As Yeniel observed the furniture, she noticed a girl organizing the area.

It was Yuni Von Ristonia.

Yeniel tilted her head at the unfamiliar face.

When Yeniel had left the academy, it was during her first year's second semester.

She didn't recognize the faces of her juniors.

Yeniel approached Yuni.

"Excuse me, what's all this?"

"Who are you?"

Yuni looked at Yeniel, confused.

"Bringing furniture... to the dormitory?"

"Yes, but why?"

"All of it?"

"No, some is going elsewhere. How could we possibly fit all this in the dorm?"

"Where's the rest going?"

"...To the second-year top student's research lab."

There were two types of cargo.

One was Yuni's belongings from the royal family, and the other was Rudy's for the research lab.

Yeni's eyes widened at this information.

"The top student of the second year changed?"

"Yes, it changed last semester. But... who are you?"

Yuni eyed Yeni suspiciously.

The change in the second year's top student was a well-known rumor throughout the academy.

It was suspicious that someone within the academy didn't know.

"Who's the new top student of the second year?"

"...It's a secret."

Yuni looked at Yeni with suspicion.

Upon seeing the situation, Yeni clenched her teeth.

Who was this child, and what had happened at the academy in her absence?

Until the second semester of the first year, Evan had been the top student.

'Could it be Rudy Astria?'

However, after observing the luggage nearby, she shook her head in doubt.

Yeniël was well aware of Rudy Astria's character.

'Rudy Astria suddenly bringing so much luggage to his own dormitory?
And having this kid do it?'

Yeniël was under a misconception.

Most of the luggage actually belonged to Yuni.

Yuni had brought her own belongings because she wasn't satisfied with the dormitory's furniture.

In reality, Rudy's luggage consisted of only a few documents.

More precisely, these documents belonged to Professor Gracie's research lab.

Professor Gracie's lab was small, so it shared space with Rudy's top student research lab, and Yuni, a member of Gracie's lab, was merely moving them.

Yeniël had no way of knowing this.

'Who is this...! Some strange person has appeared while I was away...'

Yeniël's mind was racing.

She feared that something major had happened at the academy in her absence.

'I need to meet the others... What on earth has happened at the academy...!'

Yeniël frowned as she looked at Yuni.

Yuni, noticing Yeniël's stern gaze, frowned back, clearly displeased.

In Yeniël's mind, an image formed of an unknown character seizing control of the academy.

A scene with Rudy and Evan both defeated and fallen.

'Let's wait for a better opportunity... Now is not the time!'

Yeniél didn't say anything to Yuni.

She simply turned her head and walked toward the dormitory.

Yuni watched Yeniél's retreating figure.

"What kind of person is she?"

"Ah..."

Professor Gracie stretched leisurely in her chair.

"Nothing beats the life of a professor."

Recently, Gracie was enjoying a period of bliss.

Professor Robert was on vacation, Professor Mcguire had gone to the capital for a conference, and Professor Cromwell was preoccupied with his own tasks.

There was no one to bother Gracie.

Her only task was overseeing the staff research spearheaded by Rudy Astria.

This research was drawing to a close, so there wasn't much left for her to do.

Rudy had set everything up so well, and with so many talents around, Gracie's role was just to provide guidance.

Although Gracie had found the semester quite challenging, now she was more content than anyone.

With the vacation period, no students or professors around, her days were relaxed, spent enjoying coffee at the academy.

"Maybe I'll pick up some bread on my way home today."

Knock, knock—

As Gracie was savoring her happiness, there was a knock on her office door.

"Yes~,"

she said, smiling towards the door.

Rudy stood there.

"Hello."

"Rudy, you're here! Would you like some coffee?"

It had been a week since Rudy returned from the Railer territory.

Since then, they hadn't seen much of each other due to his responsibilities with the handover of his top student role and student council work.

However, he had been diligently attending to his duties in the lab, so there was no reason for concern or complaint.

From Gracie's perspective, Rudy was like a goose that laid golden eggs.

Since Rudy became the top student, her lab had become a focal point for students.

Rudy had always been famous, but his association with Gracie's lab wasn't widely known until he took up the top student role.

Rudy's research, especially in the challenging field of black magic and magical tools, had generated significant academic interest.

As a result, Gracie inadvertently received attention in the academic community and favorable reviews within the academy.

This only elevated Gracie's reputation.

More students expressed interest in becoming her teaching assistants, and the number of students interested in her classes increased.

Gracie couldn't possibly dislike Rudy, the student who had boosted her reputation.

Rudy closed the door and entered the lab.

"No coffee, thank you. I've already had some. It's been a while, Professor. I should have visited the lab sooner."

Waving off his comment, Gracie said,

"Oh, I know you're busy. No problem at all. Did you just come to say hello?"

"No, Professor, I actually have something important to discuss with you."

"Is it something serious?"

"If you consider it serious, then yes, it is."

Gracie shrugged nonchalantly.

"Sure! Tell me anything! I'll do whatever I can to help!"

Professor Gracie, for the first time in a while, decided to demonstrate the generosity of a professor.

She confidently squared her shoulders, signaling her readiness to take on any task.

Rudy, watching her posture, gave an awkward smile and then carefully began to speak.

"That research we're currently working on..."

"Oh, the one about the staff? It's going well, isn't it? It seems like it will be completed soon?"

"...Yes, that one."

Rudy hesitated briefly, then spoke with a slight smile.

"I think we need to start it all over again."

"...What?"

Gracie's eyes widened in disbelief.

"Start over? But, we're almost done, aren't we? The magic circles are well-crafted, and they seem to be functioning. You want to redo all that?"

"...Yes, I believe we need to start over."

"Why? Why would we need to redo it? Haha..."

Gracie's eyes flickered nervously.

This research was eagerly awaited by the academic community.

It had been progressing for a semester and was showing promising results.

A presentation about this research was even scheduled for the end of the summer break.

"But we're not starting from scratch. We'll keep the magic circles we've already put in place."

"Then, what exactly are you changing?"

"We're planning to modify the exterior and add some functionalities."

The confidence in Gracie's eyes, who had initially declared she'd do anything, visibly diminished.

"Can't we just finish this research first and then conduct additional studies?"

"That's not possible. We need to use it for the joint practical in the second semester, so it must be prepared beforehand."

"But... the cost... and we hardly have any time left..."

"Oh, I heard there's an academic presentation scheduled for the end of the summer break. Is that correct?"

"Yes, there's an academic presentation..."

"Hmm..."

Rudy rubbed his chin thoughtfully, then lifted his head.

"It should fit perfectly with that timing."

"...Perfectly?"

"Yes, I've brought a research plan I developed with Luna."

"You made a research plan?"

Gracie hastily took the plan and her eyes widened in shock as she read it.

"You plan to complete this schedule? What about sleep? Aren't you going to rest?"

"Where's the time for rest? I'm considering cutting down on sleep to make time for studying and training."

"Ah..."

"Ah, and about the cost, I have research funds from becoming the top student, so I'll use that to cover it."

Gracie's expression turned gloomy.

If Rudy were doing this alone, she might not have been so concerned.

But her name was clearly listed in the plan.

If they were to proceed with this research, not only Rudy but also Gracie would have to spend all day at the academy.

"We'll have to pull all-nighters and live in a state of exhaustion, just like during the semester."

"Hey... it's vacation time... It's summer... I should be going to the beach with friends... having fun..."

"I've already had plenty of fun at Luna's estate."

"..."

"Then, we'll proceed as planned."

"Oh, no..."

When Gracie hesitated to hand over the research plan, Rudy looked at her with cold eyes.

Then he reached out and took the research plan.

"It's decided."

"Ah..."

Rudy then took the research plan from Gracie and walked out of the research lab.

"I'm counting on you."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 169: Head (3)

In the Astria Mansion, within the office.

Ian Astria was seated at his desk, immersed in his work.

Suddenly, a knock echoed through the office.

Knock, knock—

Setting aside the documents he was reviewing, Ian called out.

"Enter."

The butler bowed to Ian.

"What's the matter?"

"A guest has arrived, seeking an audience with the head of the family."

"The head of the family?"

Ian wasn't the head of the family at the moment.

He was performing the duties as the heir, but the true head was still his father.

Ian's brow furrowed.

"Who is this person who suddenly wants to meet my father?"

"I'm not certain. They brought the Astria family crest, so I allowed them in."

"The family crest?"

The Astria family crest wasn't given out lightly.

It was reserved for those whom the family was indebted to or of significant importance.

"Did they have any identification or anything else?"

"No, they didn't respond to my questions."

"Hmm..."

Possession of the family crest implied the individual was of importance to the Astria family.

Even without identification, the butler wouldn't have dared turn them away.

"Very well, let them in."

Upon Ian's instruction, a figure entered from behind the butler.

Enshrouded in a robe, their face concealed by a hood, the figure remained mysterious.

"I'll bring some tea."

Having shown in the guest, the butler bowed and exited the office.

"Please, have a seat here."

Ian gestured to the seating area in front of his desk.

"My father is currently at the Astria estate, so I am receiving guests in his stead."

Despite this explanation, the guest remained silent.

Ian looked intently at the guest before cutting to the chase.

"From where did you acquire our family's crest?"

"...Perrian. It was given by that person."

The guest's voice had a grating quality to it.

It was unpleasant to the ear.

Moreover, Ian bristled at the casual manner in which they referred to his father, the Duke of Astria.

Glaring at the person, Ian pressed on.

"So, what brings you here?"

"Hmm..."

The figure slightly lifted their hood to gaze at Ian.

Though the hood was raised, the person's face remained obscured, hidden behind a scarf.

Continuing to stare at Ian, the visitor finally spoke.

"I've lost information regarding Ephomos."

"...Ephomos?"

Ian's frown deepened.

He had never heard of Ephomos.

Ephomos had vanished when Ian was still a child.

Thus, he had never fully heard the tale.

"I don't understand what you're referring to."

"Hmm..."

The guest let out a sigh.

"Where might Perrian be?"

"Don't so casually use my father's name. More importantly, what are you talking about with Ephomos?"

The guest, still fixing Ian with a steady gaze, opened their mouth to speak.

"I am Daemon, a necromancer of the rebels."

"...What?"

Ian's eyes widened in disbelief.

This was the same name as one of the rebel leaders who had invaded the Liberion Academy.

"I am here due to a contract your father made with us. But since you seem unaware of its details, discussing it further appears pointless."

"My father... made a contract with the rebels?"

"No, the rebellion started after the contract with your father. Anyway, there's nothing more to say."

The figure stood up.

"If you don't want the Astria family to face ruin, you should inform your father quickly."

"What?"

Ian felt a surge of anger.

After speaking, the figure walked towards the door.

"Spatial Control."

As Daemon reached for the door, a barrier materialized in front of him.

Ian had blocked his way with space magic.

"So, a rebel dares to infiltrate the Astria family and thinks he can escape?"

"...Ha!"

Daemon laughed, as if amused by the absurdity.

Unperturbed, Ian focused his mana again.

"Capturing you half-dead will be a fine achievement for the Astria family."

"You can't even discern friend from foe."

"Spatial Slash."

As Ian chanted, the space horizontally split open, aiming precisely at the figure's legs.

Thud. The legs were cleanly severed, and the figure fell.

"Khehehe..."

However, no scream was heard.

No blood flowed from the legs.

Daemon opened his mouth, as if to mock Ian.

"Didn't expect me to be prepared for this, did you?"

Ian approached and removed his mask.

Revealed was a half-rotten face.

"An undead."

"Let's meet again later. Even if you don't know, your father will need us."

With those words, the figure collapsed, as if mana had been severed.

Ian stared intently at the body.

"Ian sir, I've brought the tea."

The butler's voice came from outside.

"Come in."

After entering with the tea, the butler looked down.

"What in the world...!"

His eyes widened at the sight of the body on the floor.

"How did this happen?"

"It doesn't matter. Clean it up."

"Understood."

"Oh, and one more thing."

Ian sighed and then spoke.

"I'll be visiting my father. Prepare for the journey."

"Rudy, here you are."

"Ah, thanks."

"Hehe, no problem."

I was in a research lab with Luna.

Coming to this lab with Luna brought back fresh memories.

I often used this lab at the beginning of my first year...

We were organizing our belongings in the lab.

It wasn't much, so the two of us managed just fine.

It's been about a week since we returned from the Railer territory.

I had started to slowly work on my staff project.

With Professor Mcguire currently away from the academy, Luna had also agreed to help me.

Astina and Rie seemed to be focusing on their magic studies these days.

Rie had been training her magic, perhaps troubled by what Robert said during our last encounter with the monster, and Astina was learning telekinetic magic from Cromwell.

Seeing them so focused made me worry if I was hindering Luna's studies.

Luna assured me that it was fine as she was studying diligently on her own.

Still, feeling a bit guilty, I planned not to rely on Luna's help in the latter part of the project.

I figured Luna's tasks could be handled by Professor Gracie.

With these thoughts, we were nearly done organizing the lab.

After finishing,

Luna and I sat down.

"So, what are we going to do now?"

Luna asked, tilting her head curiously.

"I have something in mind..."

I walked over to my bag and pulled out a piece of paper.

Then, I spread the paper out on the desk.

"...Eh?"

Luna looked at the paper, puzzled.

"This isn't a staff, is it?"

"It doesn't look like a staff, but its function is similar."

"Hmm... Can we really make it like this?"

"Professor Robert said it would be fine."

Luna stared at the paper with a perplexed expression.

"But... this is..."

She then picked up the paper.

"These are gloves."

"Right?"

The staff I intended to create...

It was actually in the shape of gloves.

To be exact, it was closer to a magical tool than a traditional staff.

After observing Robert's fight, I concluded that it didn't necessarily have to take the form of a staff.

I had three abilities I used in battle: dark magic, Priscilla, and martial arts.

Here, I pondered.

Which ability would benefit most from the support of a magical tool?

However, I didn't really have a choice in the matter.

Priscilla wouldn't become stronger with the use of a magical tool, as she grew stronger with more mana and mental strength.

Since dark magic could be supported with an ordinary staff, I considered how to enhance my martial arts.

That's why I chose gloves.

I thought they were the best form to augment martial arts.

"Hmm..."

Luna intently examined the gloves, then puckered her lips thoughtfully.

"Attaching the mana stones seems like it's going to be really tough..."

"Don't worry about that."

"Huh?"

I chuckled.

"That part has been taken care of by Professor Gracie."

After all, Gracie was known for taking things easy.

I acknowledge her hard work during the semester, but that's not an excuse for laxity.

Besides, such idleness wasn't really beneficial for Gracie either.

Engaging in research could lead to self-improvement, potentially increasing her salary, and bringing the joy of expanding knowledge.

All of this was actually for Gracie's own good.

Eventually, she would understand my intentions and appreciate them.

Luna looked at my contented expression and seemed sympathetic.

"Poor professor..."

"..."

With that, we commenced our research.

While Gracie was tasked with creating the main mana stone, we had to work on mana stones for auxiliary abilities.

Clunk.

As we delved into researching mana stones, the lab door opened.

"Oh, you seniors are really dedicated."

It was Yuni.

She was holding a beverage in her hand.

"Are you almost done with your work?"

"Yes, there wasn't much left to do."

Yuni distributed the drinks among us.

Luna, receiving her drink, smiled brightly.

"Thanks, Yuni! You're the best!"

Luna said while affectionately ruffling Yuni's hair.

Blushing, Yuni responded.

"No, it's nothing."

"What do you mean nothing? You're so adorable."

Luna hugged Yuni and nuzzled her cheek, finding her absolutely cute.

"Uh..."

Yuni appeared uncomfortable and unsure how to react, a situation we see seen quite often recently.

Ever since the rebel invasion incident, the relationship between Yuni and Rie had significantly improved.

Yuni would follow Rie around, showing a cheerful demeanor.

A while back,

Yuni brought various pieces of furniture from their royal home, which Rie found out.

Seeing this, Rie assigned Yuni a task.

The task Rie gave her was to socialize more with the people around her.

Though Yuni wasn't bad at interacting with others, there were occasional misunderstandings, mainly due to her upbringing as a princess.

Rie advised Yuni to minimize such incidents and try to gain the favor of those around her.

Since then, Yuni had been striving to behave like an ordinary student, actively trying to be liked by others.

She did things like buying drinks, as now, and was careful with her actions.

After hearing this, Luna began to praise Yuni generously, believing that encouragement was crucial in such matters.

"It's okay now! I have to report on my tasks too!"

Yuni squirmed out of Luna's embrace.

"Alright, alright~."

Luna released Yuni with a pleased smile.

"Uh... I'll give my report now."

"Okay."

Yuni handed me the documents she had brought.

The task I had assigned to Yuni was to secure a contract for mana stones.

We needed more mana stones in the lab, so it was necessary to make a separate contract.

For this, we utilized Yuni's status as a princess.

Originally, I had asked Rie to handle this, but according to her, Yuni needed this experience, so she delegated the task to Yuni.

"I managed to get medium mana stones for 4 gold each, and large mana stones for 10 gold each. I requested no more than 10 of the large mana stones."

"How about the payment?"

"We agreed to pay in cash. They will deliver the goods as they become available."

"Hmm..."

I smiled, satisfied with the outcome.

"Good work."

"It's just the basics..."

Yuni started to speak in her usual manner but then stopped herself and opened her mouth again.

"Th-thank you..."

"Uh..."

Luna, seeing this, smiled joyfully.

"You're so cute!!"

She hugged Yuni tightly.

"Aah!!"

Only after being thoroughly cuddled by Luna did Yuni later finally manage to escape her embrace.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 170: Head (4)

The hot sun blazed down, creating a stifling atmosphere.

Sweat soaked Robert's back.

He stood in front of a mansion, shielding his eyes from the sunlight with one hand.

This mansion belonged to Jason Ophillius, the Empire's Finance Minister.

A butler came out from the mansion and bowed to Robert.

"Please come in. They are waiting for you inside."

"Alright,"

Robert replied briefly and followed the butler inside.

The mansion, despite belonging to one of the Empire's two duke families, was surprisingly modest.

It was even smaller than some counts' houses and lacked any significant decorations.

The butler led Robert to an office.

As Robert opened the office door, he saw two men inside.

There was the stern-looking Jason Ophillius and McDowell.

"Are you Robert, the professor who sent me a letter?"

Robert nodded.

"Yes, but..."

He glanced at McDowell sitting beside him, his brow furrowing in surprise.

"Professor Robert, it's been a while,"

Greeted McDowell with a smile.

Robert noticed McDowell's missing right arm.

Ophillius chuckled upon seeing Robert.

"Ah, sorry about that. When I mentioned meeting Professor Robert, McDowell insisted on joining."

"Why is the principal here?"

"As you can see, I'm not in good health and have sought the minister's assistance,"

McDowell said, motioning to his missing arm.

"About that arm..."

"Ah, didn't Cromwell tell you? He must have kept it a secret from everyone. The man has no sense of flexibility,"

McDowell laughed heartily.

"Let's keep the pleasantries short. We can have such discussions after the main topic,"

Ophillius suggested, gesturing for Robert to sit.

Robert sat opposite them.

"So, you have something to say about the Astria family?"

"My mentors, Levian and Ephomos, and the Astria family,"

Upon hearing this, Ophillius's previously smiling face turned serious.

"You came to talk about their connection?"

"Where did you hear this story?"

"I've gathered it from various sources. While researching my mentors, I came across this information."

"Does anyone else know about this?"

"A few of my students,"

Robert replied.

"Which students?"

Ophillius asked, with McDowell smiling in response.

"Rudy Astria?"

Robert nodded.

"Aside from Rudy Astria, there's Princess Rie, the Persia family heir, and the daughter of the Railer Baron family."

"Hmm... The Railer Baron family? Where is that?"

Ophillius narrowed his eyes suspiciously.

"The Railer Baron family resides in the western outskirts. Their house may not be prominent, but they have a student of exceptional ability and character, so there's no need for worry."

"If Professor Robert says so, then I believe it. Let's continue the discussion."

Robert nodded and pulled out several papers he had brought.

"These documents summarize the incidents caused by the Astria family."

Minister Ophillius scanned the papers.

"Is there any evidence?"

"Not yet. However, finding the necromancers and mana stones the Astria family is hiding will serve as evidence."

According to information gathered by Jack, the Astria family was still creating mana stones from humans.

It implied that the Astria family was still secretly harboring necromancers.

Uncovering the location of these wizards would end all this.

It could potentially bring down the Astria family itself.

However, they must not be completely destroyed.

The best solution would be for Rudy to inherit the family.

If Rudy took over, they could gain control of the noble faction under the Astria family.

Minister Ophillius finished reviewing the documents Robert had given him and looked up.

"So, what brings you to this old man?"

"Please help me. I'll find the evidence. Just use this information to pressure the Astria family."

Robert gazed intently at the minister as he spoke.

Minister Ophillius, seeing Robert's determination, smiled.

"I've become skeptical about making changes as I've aged, but I always welcome doing the right thing. I'm not sure how much help this old man can be, but I'll do my best."

At the Liberion Academy's training ground, a massive explosion echoed across the wide field.

Bang—

"This isn't it..."

Rie murmured.

Clutched in her hand was a staff, a gift from the royal family.

It was specially crafted for her, optimized for chain explosion magic—a commonly used spell, making its construction relatively swift.

But Rie was dissatisfied.

Although the staff increased her magical power and improved her skills, it still wasn't enough.

She had clearly seen the prowess of the rebels.

She had also witnessed Rudy's future abilities.

Her current skills didn't come close to matching theirs.

The gap in power was undeniable.

"What should I do..."

Rie pondered.

Her growth in magic was not slow; in fact, she was advancing at an astonishing pace.

But catching up to those who had already far surpassed her was challenging.

Slumping to the ground, she picked up a notebook and pen.

"Indeed... relying solely on chain explosion magic is insufficient..."

Despite her disheveled appearance as she sat and scribbled notes, Rie was undeterred, fully devoted to her magic.

Frowning, she brought the pen to her forehead, discontent with everything she had trained and researched so far.

"Even if I manage to get through the joint assessment between first and second years... what comes after is what worries me..."

The upcoming assessment after summer vacation was not her main concern.

She was preoccupied with the enemies that lay ahead.

Rie was in a dilemma.

'Magic, after all, is limited by the amount of mana one possesses... The maximum power one can unleash is predetermined...'

Lifting her head, she spoke a single word,

"Sylph."

Instantly, a gust of wind swirled, and a green-hued hawk materialized before her.

Rie's greatest strength lay in her ability to use elementals and magic simultaneously.

Until now, her focus had been predominantly on magic, but to surpass the limitations of magic, she realized the necessity of elemental assistance.

If she could synergize the two, she could display a power far greater than her current magical abilities.

"But, the problem is how to handle this..."

Rie had never delved deeply into the realm of elementals before.

Each individual had their limit in elemental affinity, and there was no known method to increase it.

Thus, the limit of her elemental abilities was already clear.

However, with magic, there were no such boundaries.

Her growth felt tangible as it was proportional to her efforts.

That's why she had focused more on magic.

Indeed, continuous growth in magic seemed right, but to become stronger immediately, seeking the help of elementals was necessary.

"But... to start studying elementals now..."

Rie pursed her lips and gazed thoughtfully at Sylph.

"Ah, right!"

While gazing at Sylph and contemplating elementals, something suddenly came to Rie's mind.

There had been a time when she intensely focused on elementals, even scouring through royal elemental masters' records and numerous papers for insights.

Rie hurried to her bag and pulled out her notebook.

Flipping through the pages, she found what she was looking for.

These were notes made when she had to seal Priscilla.

Months earlier, Rie had researched Priscilla at Rudy's request.

While Luna created a magic circle to seal Priscilla, Rie developed one to weaken the elemental's power.

However, due to an unexpected turn of events, the magic circle was rendered unnecessary.

Studying the notes, Rie sought answers within them, as she had never pondered over elementals as much as she did then.

Reading through the notebook, she found several intriguing points.

She immediately got up and headed to her room to find her research materials on elementals.

"Ah..."

After hours of revisiting her research, Rie found the answer she was looking for - the key to becoming stronger.

She leapt to her feet, invigorated by her discovery.

"If I do it this way..."

Gurgle—

"Ah..."

Her stomach growled, signaling that it was time to eat.

She glanced outside; it was already a dark night, and dinner time had long passed.

"...I should find something to eat."

Rie tidied her hair and stepped outside.

She preferred not to have maids around while conducting research, as they were more often a distraction than a help.

Thus, she began looking for a maid to prepare her meal.

"I'm hungry... and my eyes are sore..."

Exhaustion had built up in Rie's body.

Fatigue led to negative thoughts creeping in.

Though she felt she had roughly figured out how to use elementals, she doubted whether it would work effectively.

Lost in these thoughts while walking, she suddenly stopped.

"Huh?"

It was late, yet someone was approaching.

A familiar face.

"Rudy?"

"Where are you going at this late hour?"

Rudy approached Rie with a concerned look.

Rie's eyes widened, and then she smiled broadly before running towards him.

"Hey! What..."

She threw herself into Rudy's arms.

"What's this? Hey, why suddenly?"

Rudy was taken aback by her actions.

Rie, not paying any attention to his reaction, opened her mouth.

"I'm tired. Really exhausted."

"Ah, but why are you acting like this?"

Rudy looked around to see if anyone was watching and tried to gently separate from her.

"Ugh... just a moment longer!"

Even as Rudy tried to pull away, Rie held on tightly with all her strength.

"Haah..."

Hearing Rie's words, Rudy exhaled a sigh and gently patted her back in a resigned manner.

"Everything will be alright. Whatever it is..."

Rudy's words brought a smile to Rie's face.

She then relaxed her arms and stepped back.

"That's enough now."

"So, what was this all about?"

He looked concerned, as if wondering if something was wrong.

"No, it's okay now. I've resolved it."

Rie smiled satisfactorily, feeling reassured and energized by Rudy's comfort.

"I'll be busy for a while, so don't come looking for me. I can't focus when you're around because my heart flutters."

"No, but..."

As Rie spoke assertively, Rudy could only stutter in response, unable to find the right words.

"I'm going now."

Rie walked away with a smile, leaving Rudy behind.

"...What just happened?"

Rudy looked on, puzzled, as he watched Rie's retreating figure.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 171: Head (5)

Our research was progressing at a rapid pace.

I felt my health deteriorating, but I didn't pay much attention to it.

The benefits seemed to far outweigh the cost to my health.

We were only making magical tools, but I was learning a lot.

There were many challenges in trying to incorporate the properties of a staff into a glove and adding other abilities.

As I worked through these obstacles, my knowledge expanded, covering various magical knowledge to the specifics of magical tools.

This extensive magical knowledge grew over several weeks of research.

Gradually, the outline of our project began to take shape.

“Ughhh...”

Gracie, clearly exhausted, let out a strange sound and slumped over her desk.

I handed her a cup of coffee and chuckled.

“Don't push yourself too hard. Our academic presentation is just around the corner.”

Gracie, looking wronged, got up.

“How can you say that! I’m doing my best! I hardly sleep and don’t even drink!”

“Yes, yes. You’re doing very well.”

“Then let me rest a bit. Just for two days... or even just one...”

Gracie pleaded with a distressed face.

However, I firmly responded,

“No. Please continue as you have been.”

“Aaahhh... I’m the professor... why... why...”

Gracie moaned and slumped back over her desk.

This scenario had repeated so often that I had become somewhat accustomed to it.

I knew she would grumble for about ten minutes before getting back to work.

Ignoring Gracie’s sullen face, I looked at the clock.

“Luna is late...”

Luna was recently juggling work in our lab and in McGuire’s lab.

I was more worried about her than Gracie.

I had heard that the workload in McGuire’s lab increased after he returned from the conference.

Managing that along with our lab work was nothing short of superhuman.

“Hmm...”

After some thought, I came to a decision.

“It’s time to start using Kuhn...”

I had brought Kuhn into the student council at the beginning of the semester for this very reason.

Kuhn could use both alchemy and magic.

This ability was perfectly suited for magical tools.

Currently, as Kuhn was still a first-year and I had some spare time, I was assigning him tasks related to magical tools, but I planned to delegate more to him once I became a third-year.

His ability to use both alchemy and magic was perfect for magical tools.

I sometimes wondered if I was using the student council members too much for my own purposes, but it didn’t seem to matter much.

I always ensured they were rewarded for their hard work.

Just then, the door to the lab opened.

“Haah... Haah... Rudy! Sorry! The professor had something for me to do!”

“Oh, Luna, you're here?”

Luna appeared to have rushed over, breathing heavily and with her hair in disarray.

“Luna, do you want to sit here for a moment?”

“Huh?”

Luna, looking bewildered, sat down in front of me.

Sitting face to face, I noticed the deep dark circles under her eyes, which only solidified my decision.

“Luna, I think it’s better for you to focus more on your own work now.”

“What?”

Luna looked at me in surprise, then waved her hands.

“No, no! I can do it. If I just reduce my sleep a little more...!”

“You should start preparing for your own work now. There’s the combined first and second year assessment coming up, and you’ll need some personal training for that.”

“But, what about the work I’ve been doing...”

“Oh, can you hand that over to Kuhn?”

“Kuhn? Kuhn is going to join the research?”

“I haven’t told him yet, but I think he’ll agree.”

Hearing this, Luna’s expression fell.

“It’s not because you’re lacking. Without you, the research wouldn’t have progressed this far. I’m just worried about you.”

“Alright, I understand...”

Luna didn’t insist further.

She seemed to know that she was reaching her limits.

However, she appeared regretful that she couldn’t see the research through to the end.

“I’ll finish up the research. It’s pretty much done anyway.”

“Okay... Thank you.”

With that, Luna left the research lab, looking disheartened.

Luna left the research lab and sat down on a bench.

It was a rare moment of leisure for her, but her mood was far from cheerful.

She understood Rudy's decision.

Her physical condition was not normal; continuing the research could lead to her collapse.

Yet, she wanted to continue, desiring to be of help to Rudy.

“No... if I collapse, I’ll just be a burden to Rudy...”

She realized that her falling ill would only hinder him.

Rudy, by nature, couldn't focus on his work if someone around him was in trouble.

Luna was well aware of this.

“What can I do now?”

Luna pondered, gazing at the sky.

The approach of autumn was evident in the blue expanse above.

The end of summer vacation was coming.

“Once summer vacation ends...”

As Rudy had mentioned, the joint assessment for first and second years was soon.

Other challenges awaited her – battles to fight and more research to undertake.

“Then...”

Luna glanced at her bag, which contained her magical tome.

While the tome's powers were extraordinary, her ability to wield them was lacking.

She could use various abilities, but they lacked strength.

In a recent fight, she felt helpless, merely watching without being able to contribute.

‘For Rudy.’

This thought crossed her mind.

Working on Rudy’s gloves had sparked many ideas in her.

Researching the gloves had enhanced her understanding of Rudy’s abilities and revealed his weaknesses.

“Defense.”

Luna murmured softly.

It was Rudy’s most significant shortcoming.

Nodding in determination, she decided what skill she needed to develop.

As she was making this resolution, a yawn escaped her.

Tears welled up as she yawned widely.

“First... I need to sleep...”

With a small smile to herself, Luna walked back to her room.

In the principal's office of Liberion Academy, Cromwell sat reading documents at his desk.

He wore glasses and seemed deeply focused.

Though McDowell's health had somewhat improved, Cromwell was still performing the duties of acting principal.

Sifting through the papers, Cromwell sighed upon reading a particular document.

"Who should I assign this task to...?"

It was concerning the upcoming joint assessment for first and second-year students.

He contemplated handing it over to Gracie but then shook his head, dismissing the idea.

Although Gracie was capable and efficiently handled assigned tasks, her experience as a professor was still limited.

The joint assessment was an event of utmost importance at the academy, involving both first and second-year students, numerous teaching assistants, and professors.

It was a responsibility too great for Gracie.

The most obvious choices were Robert and McGuire.

However, Robert had been extremely busy lately, often disappearing on some unknown business, making it impossible for Cromwell to ask.

"Maybe I should hand it over to McGuire..."

McGuire appeared busy too, but relatively more available than the others.

"Hmm..."

Cromwell pondered briefly before lazily scribbling McGuire's name on the document.

"McGuire has plenty of experience as a professor; he'll handle it."

Knock, knock—

Just as he finished writing McGuire's name, there was a knock at the door.

"Come in..."

Before he could finish his sentence, the door swung open.

"Cromwell, are you here?"

It was McGuire.

Cromwell removed his glasses.

"Perfect timing. I was just handling some paperwork related to you."

"Related to me? What could that be?"

"Yes, it just came up."

"Again, dumping work on Robert and me?"

Cromwell, who was a perfectionist, couldn't stand seeing other professors handle tasks carelessly.

So during his tenure as acting principal, he had delegated most of the work to his trustworthy friends, Robert and McGuire.

"But not this time."

McGuire declared as he approached Cromwell's desk and handed him a document.

"What's this?"

"My travel request."

"What?"

Cromwell's eyes widened in surprise.

"It seems my research at the recent conference was impressive. Looks like I'll be away on a trip until early next semester."

Cromwell read the document, an official letter from the conference.

"This seal..."

"Yes, it's been approved by His Majesty the Emperor. I wanted to decline, but if His Majesty calls, I have no choice."

Mcguire spoke with a sly smile, clearly not reluctant at all.

The research conference provided immense support, making life quite comfortable for the lead researchers.

Accompanied by elite royal wizards and virtually unlimited funding, the level of research conducted there was in a different league compared to what was done at the academy with teaching assistants.

Cromwell pressed his temples, clearly troubled.

Mcguire, noticing this, narrowed his eyes.

"...Were you about to assign me the joint assessment?"

Cromwell averted Mcguire's gaze.

"Hey! You were planning to dump that on a friend? Do you know how tough that assignment is?"

"Then who should I give it to? Robert seems busy too."

Mcguire chuckled.

"You could do it yourself."

“What? I did it last year. Besides, I’m not a professor anymore; I’m the vice principal.”

“If there’s no one else, you have to do it. That’s how it works,”

Mcguire teased.

“No, I can’t...”

“That sounds like a good idea to me.”

A voice came from the door.

Robert and McDowell were standing there.

“Principal? Are you feeling alright?”

Cromwell stood up abruptly, his eyes wide.

“I’m feeling quite well now. Time to get back to work, I suppose.”

McDowell smiled.

“Then let’s have Vice Principal Cromwell take on the joint assessment.”

“Me?”

Cromwell looked at McDowell in surprise.

“Ha ha, there’s no one more qualified than you at the academy. I’d like to ask this favor of you.”

“But... my duties as vice principal...”

“For the duration of the joint assessment, I’ll handle the vice principal duties. You just focus on your research and the assessment.”

Cromwell looked at McDowell, speechless.

“There’s a lot of promising students in the first and second years. For a good assessment, it’s best to have a skilled professor. Ha ha ha!”

“Well, that’s true, but...”

McDowell, still smiling, clapped Cromwell on the shoulder.

“I’m counting on you.”

Cromwell, usually rational and logical, couldn’t refuse such a direct request from the principal.

“Alright... I will do it.”

Robert and McGuire burst into laughter at Cromwell’s resigned acceptance.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 172: Head (6)

Summer vacation was gradually drawing to a close.

In a few days, school would reopen, and the research project was finally coming to an end.

Gracie left to prepare for an academic presentation, while Rudy and Kuhn remained in the lab to finish up.

"How did you manage to do all this?"

Kuhn exclaimed in astonishment.

Despite joining the research in its final stages, Kuhn's face was marked with fatigue.

He had stepped in on the day Luna had to leave the project.

Yet, there wasn't much left for him to do.

He had planned to take over Luna's tasks, but she had already completed everything, leaving nothing for him to do.

His role was limited to assisting Rudy and Gracie.

However, even this assistant role was not easy.

There was much to learn, and as a first-year student, he felt he was not up to par.

Nonetheless, he did his best to help Rudy.

As the research progressed, Kuhn couldn't help but be impressed.

There were nights they had to work through and times they barely had time to eat.

Yet, the hardships he endured seemed trivial.

Gracie and Rudy had put in far more effort than he had.

Kuhn was taken aback by their dedication.

It was almost unbelievable.

"Isn't it kind of fun? It's exhausting, but there's a sense of achievement too,"

"It seems to be more than just a bit tiring, though."

In truth, the research was largely completed by Gracie and Rudy.

Of course, Luna's contribution was significant as well.

Still, the success of the project was mainly due to the efforts of Rudy and Gracie.

Kuhn could only express his admiration for Rudy.

This was a different kind of respect than he had for Rudy as the student council president.

What level of ability did Rudy possess?

It was not just about talent.

Often, when faced with such hard work, one might desire to play or take a break.

But Rudy didn't.

He faced the hardships head-on.

If there was a deadlock or a challenge, he confronted it directly without compromise.

This was no easy task.

There were times he wanted to give up or avoid the situation.

Facing tasks head-on is painful.

Continuing to lead the work could be time-consuming and require an unknown amount of effort.

Yet, Rudy pressed forward.

All Kuhn could do was admire him.

He began to understand why the professors and seniors were interested in Rudy.

Rudy came over to Kuhn and patted him on the back.

"Well, it's all over now. You've worked hard too, Kuhn."

"Oh, no. It was all you and Professor Gracie."

"What do you mean? It's thanks to you, Yuni, Luna, and everyone else involved that we made it to the end."

Rudy said with a warm smile.

Talent, effort, character.

What does Rudy lack?

As Kuhn was deeply moved by Rudy's image...

'I should maintain a good image, so I can continue to make use of him...'

Rudy sighed internally.

Bringing in Kuhn was a good move, but honestly, he wasn't very useful.

What help could he expect from a first-year student?

Especially one who joined in the middle of the research, his usefulness was even less.

In fact, Rudy had more trouble teaching Kuhn various things.

Yet, Rudy managed a smile.

Having taught him this much, he planned to make use of Kuhn later.

"Let's just tidy up and then go rest."

"Understood."

Kuhn, touched, began to diligently clean up the lab.

As they were about to finish...

"Oh, you're still here."

Yuni had arrived at the lab.

"Yuni, did the presentation go well?"

"Yes, Professor Gracie was surprisingly good at presenting."

Yuni had gone to the academic presentation with Professor Gracie, having been part of the research since its early days.

"Uh... Ah..."

A strange noise came from behind Yuni.

It was Gracie, looking almost like an undead.

How she managed to present in that state was a mystery...

It was fortunate that the academic presentation was held at the academy.

Had it been in the capital or another city, Gracie might have collapsed.

Gracie entered the lab, looking exhausted but smiling with relief that it was over.

Yuni, after watching Gracie for a moment, clapped her hands as if struck by an idea.

"Ah, now that the presentation is over and school is about to start again..."

She smiled.

"Shall we have a party?"

"Professor Cromwell, won't you come along?"

"I'm buried in work... It's impossible to find even a moment."

"In that case..."

Astina, having heard from Rudy about the party in Gracie's lab, asked Professor Cromwell to at least make a brief appearance.

However, Cromwell shook his head, too busy with preparations for the upcoming joint assessment.

"Well, then I'll head off."

"Thanks for your help."

After receiving Cromwell's gratitude, Astina made her way to Gracie's lab.

"Do you have any idea how tough it was!"

"Riku! Slow down with your eating!"

"Mmmph!"

Even before she reached Gracie's lab, Astina could hear the bustling noise from inside.

She entered with a smirk.

Inside, many people were enjoying themselves.

Riku, Ena, and Luna were playfully eating, while Gracie, beside them, was drinking and causing mischief.

Kuhn and Emily were quietly enjoying snacks, and other students were present too.

"Oh, Astina, you're here?"

Rudy approached Astina with a greeting.

"Everyone seems to be having fun."

"Yes, with the start of the term right around the corner, we're making the most of the last days of the holiday."

As Rudy approached Astina, Rie also came closer, causing Astina to give her a sharp look.

"Sticking to him like glue, aren't you?"

Rie retorted to Astina's comment.

"What's it to you! It's natural after not seeing each other for a while!!"

"Ahaha..."

Rudy chuckled awkwardly at the exchange between Rie and Astina.

"Professor Cromwell isn't coming?"

"He's busy with the joint assessment preparations."

"By the way, I heard you've been helping with the preparations too, Astina..."

"It's not exactly helping. More like learning magic and just lending a hand."

As Rudy and Astina talked, Rie's eyes narrowed.

She then pulled Rudy's arm towards her.

"Come here."

"Eh?"

As Rie led Rudy away, Astina laughed.

"So, you think you're at a disadvantage when playing fair?"

"What... What?"

Stunned by Astina's provocative tone, Rie's eyes widened.

"If not that, then why are you taking Rudy away?"

"Eek..."

Rie, stopping in her tracks, stepped forward to confront Astina, their eyes meeting in a charged standoff.

In the midst of Astina and Rie's tense exchange...

"Rudy~"

"Huh?"

Someone quickly ran up and clung to Rudy's back.

"Hehe... nice..."

Luna's speech was slurred.

Startled, Rudy turned around to find Luna hugging his back and nuzzling her face against him.

Her face was adorably flushed.

"Luna?"

"What, what!"

"Hmm?"

The trio was surprised by Luna's behavior.

It was unusual for Luna to embrace Rudy in such a crowded place.

She wasn't one for such spontaneous actions.

Sensing something wrong, Rudy gently pushed Luna's shoulders back, creating some space between them.

"Uh... Rudy..."

Luna, with half-lidded eyes, reached out, trying to embrace Rudy again.

When Rudy leaned down to her level, he could slightly smell alcohol.

"Luna, have you been drinking?"

"Hehe... just a bit?"

Luna replied with a goofy smile.

Rudy quickly turned to look at Gracie, the only one drinking there.

Gracie was in a mess, encouraging the students to drink in her slurred speech.

"Drink, drink! It's not like you can drink outside of here!"

But it seemed Luna was the only one affected.

"Ahaha... Professor, maybe you should go in..."

Ena was doing her best to restrain Professor Gracie, probably to prevent further incidents after seeing Luna's drunken state.

As Rudy moved to intervene,

"Rudy~"

Luna attempted to hug Rudy again.

"Luna!"

"Stop her..."

Rie and Astina quickly grabbed Luna.

Rudy sighed, watching the scene unfold.

Some time passed, and the party came to an end.

Astina, due to the overly noisy and chaotic scene, decided not to clean up immediately and sent everyone to their rooms.

Luna was taken to her room by Ena and Riku, while Astina herself took care of Gracie, putting her in her room.

Astina briefly left Gracie in the professor's dormitory and returned to the lab.

"Ended up taking care of everyone instead of enjoying the food."

Astina sighed, regretting not being able to enjoy the party from the start.

"It's my fault for arriving late..."

She smacked her lips in disappointment and headed back to the lab.

"Better clean up now to spare the kids the trouble tomorrow."

Although Astina hadn't stayed long at the party, she intended to tidy up Gracie's lab for the sake of the others, knowing how hard Rudy, Rie, and Luna had been working lately.

Astina was reminded of her own second year, when she had worked tirelessly.

Even after meeting Rudy, she had devoted herself to her studies in magic, academics, and student council duties.

She was aware of their pain and effort, more than anyone else.

With a faint smile, Astina opened the door to the lab.

"Hmm?"

Upon entering, she saw Rudy sitting in a chair, actually dozing off.

Astina had told him to go back to his room.

"Haah... I told you to just go back."

Despite sighing, a smile formed on her lips, noticing a broom and towels next to him.

It seemed he had tried to clean but was too exhausted and fell asleep.

Astina could easily guess what had happened.

"You must be tired from all the research. And to think you even tried to clean up."

She quietly approached Rudy, crouching down to his level.

He looked peacefully asleep, like a child.

"Pfft."

Amused by this unusual sight of Rudy, Astina chuckled softly.

he playfully poked his cheek with her finger.

"I hope everything works out well."

Her words were for herself as much as for Rudy's future.

"I'll do my best, so you do your best too."

Astina said, smiling.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 173: Head (7)

It was early morning, and the students were bustling about.

Some were visibly tired, while others chatted excitedly with friends they hadn't seen in a while.

It was the morning of the school's opening ceremony.

Summer had passed, and autumn's arrival painted the surrounding trees with rich hues of fall foliage.

The blue sky seemed higher than ever.

Among the busy students, one man stood out with a dark aura.

It was Evan.

His mood was notably gloomier than anyone else's, not a typical demeanor for a student.

Dark circles under his eyes and tightly shut lips added to his forbidding presence, making him seem unapproachable.

"There he is..."

"Ah... the former top student..."

The students whispered and cautiously avoided Evan.

He was used to such murmurs.

Since his admission, he had faced criticism for being a commoner who achieved the top rank.

Despite various slanders against his character, Evan remained stoic.

But now, his anger was hard to contain.

Evan had always been the top student, a position that had been a pillar of strength for him.

But now, that pillar had crumbled.

He was no longer the top student, but the second.

Though still a high rank, it felt like a weak support for Evan.

With a clenched fist, Evan walked forward, the whispers of those around him piercing his heart like daggers.

What might have been insignificant words to others were painful to Evan, who was already hurting.

'What did I do wrong..... I was just trying to live a normal life.....'

As he walked, Evan noticed a silver-haired woman moving cautiously, hiding against a wall and scanning her surroundings.

"Yeniel?"

He was surprised, almost in disbelief.

"Ah! Evan!"

"Yeniel... where have you been all this time?"

Yeniel had been the only other support for Evan besides his rank.

She had disappeared without a word for months, and he had waited for her, hoping for some contact.

Despite searching for rumors or any news of her, Evan found nothing.

It was as if she had never existed.

But now, here she was, in front of Evan, as if nothing had happened.

Yeniel approached Evan, who was standing there dazed, with a smile.

"Evan, it's been a while."

"Yeniel, what happened? Where have you been all this time?"

"Ah... I had some... matters to attend to."

Yeniel said with an awkward smile.

"Matters? You mean with the Rebels...?"

Before Evan could finish saying 'Rebels,' Yeniel quickly moved to cover his mouth.

"Shh. You know you shouldn't talk about that so carelessly."

"Oh... Sorry."

"It was just some minor stuff. Nothing serious."

Yeniel smiled as if it was nothing.

Evan felt a bit uneasy.

"So, are you back for good now?"

"Looks like it. Unless something comes up, I plan to stay."

"That's good to hear..."

Evan let out a sigh of relief, glad that Yeniel wouldn't disappear again.

Yeniël, seeing Evan's reaction, looked slightly puzzled before clapping her hands.

"Oh, right. There's something I want to ask."

"What do you want to ask?"

"Who is the top student now? I heard you lost your position."

"Oh."

Hearing Yeniël's words, Evan's heart sank.

The comfort he felt upon seeing Yeniël was replaced with turmoil.

"Why do you ask?"

Yeniël stared intently at Evan, her eyes filled with suspicion.

But that look disappeared as quickly as it had come.

"Just curious, you know? I've been away from the academy for a while, so I'm wondering what's changed."

Yeniël said with an effortless smile.

'That look in her eyes just now...?'

Evan was slightly puzzled by Yeniël's expression but dismissed it, thinking he might have seen it wrong.

"So, who is the top student now?"

With Yeniël's gentle tone, Evan cautiously spoke.

"Rudy... Astria."

"Rudy Astria?"

Yeniel furrowed her brows and fell into thought.

Seeing Yeniel like this, Evan felt a surge of anxiety.

If Yeniel disappeared too, he would have nothing left.

He couldn't let this continue.

He had to... regain his top position.

That's the only way...

Evan bit his lip.

"Yeniel?"

"Hmm?"

Yeniel, lost in thought, looked up at Evan's call.

"I've been investigating something recently."

"Investigating something?"

Yeniel tilted her head, puzzled by Evan's abrupt statement.

"If you promise not to tell anyone, I'll share it with you."

Evan said with a kind smile.

Yeniel stared at Evan for a moment before mirroring his expression.

"Of course. What are you investigating?"

Evan looked around cautiously and then leaned in closer to Yeniel, whispering.

"Can you tell me about the Rebels?"

I found myself in an incredibly awkward situation.

"Let's get straight to the point."

Yuni's eyes were sharp as she glared at me.

Lately, she had become more sociable and her expressions softer, but right now, she was sharper than when I first met her.

Swallowing hard, I opened my mouth to speak.

"Alright."

Thump—

Yuni slammed her hand on the desk in front of me.

"What's your relationship with my sister?"

"...Yuni."

I looked at her with a troubled expression.

"Let's discuss this in the student council room or a lab, not here..."

We were in a second-year liberal arts classroom.

Everyone around us was staring intently.

It was no surprise that a first-year student raising her voice in a second-year classroom would draw attention, especially since I was the student council president and had just become the top student, talking about the Empire's first princess with the second princess...

I dreaded the kind of rumors that might spread.

"So, what is your relationship?"

"Haah..."

Yuni's discovery of my relationship with Rie dated back to a party before the school year.

I considered myself lucky it took this long for her to find out.

Rie's blatant actions had been numerous.

"Did everyone have a good break?"

The liberal arts professor entered the classroom.

He was puzzled to see the students looking elsewhere instead of at him.

"Students...?"

At the professor's words, Yuni turned her head.

"Oh, isn't that Yuni, a first-year student?"

"Yes, that's right."

Yuni responded with a nonchalant expression.

"We're about to start class. Shouldn't you be in your classroom?"

The professor tried to kindly suggest her departure.

Yuni, however, ignored his hint, looked around, and sat down near me.

"I'll audit the class."

The professor was baffled by Yuni's declaration.

"Isn't there a class for first-years now?"

"No, there isn't."

Of course, there was.

A first-period class on the first day of school for first-years.

Yuni brazenly gestured for the professor to proceed with the class.

"Ahem... Alright, let's begin the lesson."

The professor started the class.

Yuni didn't listen to a word he said, just kept glaring at me.

I was so distracted by her stare that I couldn't focus on the lesson.

Luckily, it was the first class, so not much progress was made.

After the class ended, I quickly packed my things.

And before Yuni could approach me...

"Whew...!"

Thud!

I started running.

How could I possibly explain things to her?

Running away seemed like the only option.

"Hey, hey!"

As I dashed out of the classroom, Yuni looked on in surprise.

"Senior!!!!!"

Yuni reacted faster than I expected and started chasing after me.

After a long chase, I finally managed to shake her off.

I thought she would give up after a bit of running, but she was surprisingly persistent.

"Haah... Haah..."

I hid in a corner of the academy and slowly caught my breath.

It seemed my stamina had dropped significantly since I hadn't been training lately.

"She shouldn't be following me anymore..."

"Who says I'm not following?"

"What the—!"

Startled by the voice beside me, I jumped.

There was Yeniel, squatting next to me.

"Yeniel?"

It was a welcome sight.

Rather than being surprised, I was relieved to see her.

I had heard she was severely injured by the Rebels and thought she might not be able to attend classes anymore.

Seeing her here, it probably wasn't as bad as I feared.

However, her expression was not very pleasant.

"Hmm..."

She looked at me with a furrowed brow and a suspicious gaze.

I opened my mouth, puzzled.

"It's you, Yeniel, right?"

"Yeah, can't you see?"

Yeniel responded with a prickly tone.

I was happy to see her, but I wondered why she was acting this way.

"Who's that girl you're hiding from? What's going on?"

"Ah... It's a complicated situation..."

I smiled awkwardly.

"Never mind that. I just have something to tell you."

"Something to tell me?"

As I looked at her quizzically, Yeniel spoke up.

"Evan is trying to make contact with The Rebels."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 174: Head (8)

Upon hearing Yeniel's words, a single question came to mind.

"Why?"

Why is Evan seeking to meet with the Rebels?

No matter how much I thought about the connection between Evan and the Rebels, nothing came to mind.

For what reason is Evan searching for the Rebels?

Usually, there's some intention behind wanting to meet someone.

I couldn't understand his intentions.

When I expressed my doubts, Yeniel sighed.

"Do you remember what I said before?"

"What you said?"

"Before I went to the Rebels, I had mentioned something."

I distinctly remembered Yeniel talking with Astina before she left for the Rebels.

Among the conversations they had about Evan...

"Was it about Evan acting strangely?"

"Yes, I've had an uneasy feeling since then. Now, it seems to have worsened."

"Hmm..."

Lately, I hadn't paid much attention to Evan's state.

Maybe I never did.

In my mind, Evan was almost like a hero who could do anything.

The Evan I saw in the game faced all dangers around him and accomplished whatever needed to be done.

He endured bone-crushing efforts to protect those around him.

When I was at my lowest, the memory of such a comforting Evan was vivid in my mind.

Thus, when I first arrived here, my sole focus was on survival.

Thinking or worrying about Evan seemed like a luxury.

I was too preoccupied with my own survival to spare thought for someone with heroic qualities.

However, my thoughts changed after the last Rebel attack incident.

The story I heard from Haruna.

The world I saw was just an illusion shown by Beatrice.

Those events hadn't actually happened.

They were possible, but not a certain future.

The Evan here was just a normal adolescent boy.

Just a regular student who was also the top of his class.

It seemed contradictory to be 'ordinary' and 'top of the class,' but he was both.

So, I regarded Evan as a slightly more talented student.

I wasn't disappointed anymore, even if Evan didn't show the qualities I knew from the game.

After all, he was just a normal student.

But this strangeness was a different matter.

I only knew the heroic Evan, not the ordinary human Evan.

I didn't know what he wanted or how he would grow as a regular person.

The clear thing was that my presence wasn't completely unrelated to his change.

My actions had definitely influenced him in some way.

I sighed and opened my mouth.

"Do you know why Evan ended up like this?"

"I don't know for sure. I haven't always been around him. I only know what I've been told."

At Yeniel's words, I smiled.

"Thanks, really."

"Hmm..."

Yeniel tilted her head, looking puzzled.

She had been staring at me with a strange look for a while now.

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

"Nothing's changed, yet..."

Yeniel muttered softly.

I wondered what she meant by that.

After staring intently at me for a moment, Yeniel finally turned her head away.

"Anyway, I'll make sure Evan doesn't meet with the Rebels. See you later."

"Ah, about that."

"Hmm?"

"Just leave it be."

"...What?"

Yeniel furrowed her brow.

"I've come up with a pretty good plan."

I said, smiling.

"Is this enough?"

Cromwell surveyed the papers he had plastered all around his room.

They were plans for the joint assessment of the first and second years.

He had pondered deeply over this particular joint assessment.

How should it be structured to provide the students with a valuable experience and earn favorable evaluations?

After much contemplation, Cromwell arrived at a conclusion.

The traditional practice of forming teams did not allow for an accurate assessment of each student's individual abilities.

In a team of three, there's always a chance that someone might just ride on the coattails of others.

It was an insufficient method to evaluate each student's individual prowess.

Therefore, Cromwell decided to make this evaluation an individual event.

But that wasn't all.

While previously the students in teams would compete against each other, this time he created an opportunity for cooperation.

He considered sociability as part of a person's competence.

One might argue that forming teams for evaluation was a valid approach.

However, the sociability that comes with pre-formed teams could be a matter of luck or various other reasons.

True cooperation skills would be assessed only after the evaluation began.

It was about quickly befriending and collaborating with those around you once the evaluation kicked off.

"This should work fine."

Cromwell thought, putting down his pen.

He had finished preparing the evaluation earlier than expected.

The individual skills assessment and midterms weren't ready yet.

Since the joint assessment would only proceed after these, he had indeed finished quite early.

Cromwell smiled contentedly at his completed work.

Recently, the vice-principal's duties were being managed by Principal McDowell.

It was a promise made when he was assigned the joint assessment.

Thus, Cromwell had become a job-holding unemployed person, free as a bird.

Though still a professor, he was now enjoying a life even more leisurely than that of a retiree.

"Maybe I should enjoy some drinks today."

Just as Cromwell was indulging in these pleasant thoughts, there came a knock.

Tap tap—

A knock sounded at Cromwell's door.

"It's Rudy Astria. May I come in?"

Cromwell raised his eyebrows.

He had a bad feeling.

Whenever this guy was involved, things tended to go awry.

And it wasn't just Cromwell who thought this way.

Gracie, Robert, McGuire—all the professors Cromwell was close to shared the same sentiment.

To the professors, Rudy Astria was like a bomb that unpredictably triggered numerous incidents.

"Come in,"

Cromwell said.

Rudy opened the door and entered.

"Professor, it's been a while."

"Cough... Yes, it has. Since winter break, right? I heard you became the top student. Congratulations."

"Ah, thank you."

Cromwell scrutinized Rudy Astria's expression.

His expression was unchanging, impassive.

The way Rudy entered didn't suggest urgency.

Cromwell felt a bit relieved.

Just knowing it wasn't an emergency was satisfying enough.

"So, what brings you here?"

Cromwell asked.

At Cromwell's question, Rudy smiled.

"It's about the Rebels."

"...What?"

Thud—

Cromwell abruptly stood up from his seat.

Of all times, why now?...

Just when he thought he could relax, the mention of the Rebels made his heart sink.

They were the most troublesome and problematic group lately.

To think Rudy would bring up such a headache-inducing matter.

Rudy seemed slightly taken aback by Cromwell's intense reaction.

"Oh, it's not that the Rebels have attacked us right now. It's just something related."

"Haah... And what would that be?"

He couldn't leave the students or others in danger.

Having heard such a story, as a vice-principal, he had to take action.

No matter how troublesome, it wasn't something to weigh against people's lives.

"Do you know Evan, the former top student of the second year?"

"Evan, you say."

Cromwell was well aware of him.

He had been paying attention to Evan since the last joint assessment of the first and second years.

He was interested in Evan's mana control technique and had been keeping an eye on him.

Evan's mana control had yielded incredible results since his first year.

The ability to slice through and nullify others' magic was something only Evan could do.

Even professors in related fields hadn't mastered such a skill.

Evan's other achievements were also quite remarkable.

His eco magic was developing differently from others.

Ecological magic, typically involving the growth of plants or using animals to cultivate the surroundings, was taken a step further by Evan, who could handle not only flora and fauna but also special elementals.

Special elementals were usually contracted using something other than elemental affinity.

However, Evan could handle them without a contract.

This was a new discovery for eco magic.

It shifted the idea that elementals, along with plants and animals, could also be part of ecology.

Despite such discoveries, Evan was always alone.

He severely lacked social skills.

McDowell had also mentioned something about him.

Evan was always in a gloomy state, never approaching anyone first.

He seemed like someone waiting for something... an odd fellow indeed.

Mulling over his thoughts about Evan, Cromwell spoke.

"What about him?"

"Has Evan ever been involved with the Rebels?"

Cromwell had heard many reports about the Rebels recently, but he had never heard Evan's name mentioned in relation to them.

"I'm hearing this for the first time."

"Hmm... According to what I've heard, it seems Evan has some connection with the Rebels."

"A connection? Are you suggesting he's joined the Rebels?"

"It doesn't seem to be that, but there are signs he's trying to make contact with them."

Cromwell stroked his chin thoughtfully.

"So, what are you suggesting? That we should monitor him?"

Rudy smiled.

"You always understand quickly."

"It's impossible within the Academy. Such actions are against the Academy's principles. However,"

There was still a way.

"We can keep an eye on any movement he makes towards the Rebels or attempts to communicate with them."

Rudy nodded, appearing satisfied.

"That would be enough."

"Alright... And,"

"Yes?"

Cromwell pressed his fingertips against his forehead.

"What else have you brought? Continue."

The matter concerning Evan was honestly trivial.

It was something that could be handled swiftly.

He wasn't already in contact or planning anything; it was merely a suspicion that warranted surveillance.

It was unlikely that someone like Rudy, a walking bombshell, would come only with such a minor issue.

Certainly, there was something more peculiar...

"There's another matter I'd like you to prepare for."

Cromwell's eyes widened.

Here it comes.

"...What is it?"

"When Evan tries to make contact with the Rebels."

Rudy lifted one corner of his mouth.

It was a sly smile.

"I'm thinking of using it as an opportunity to catch them."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 175: Head (9)

Yuni glared at the wall with a sulky expression.

Ever since she realized that the atmosphere between Rudy and Rie was unusual, she spent her free time brooding like this.

"Yuck... my sister..."

Jealousy, or something like it, was growing inside Yuni's heart.

Just when she had finally started to get along well with her sister, Rudy had come between them.

She wondered what he had done to cause this.

Rie, who was prickly with others and kept her distance, acted differently around Rudy.

She looked at Rudy with a dazed expression.

"Well... someone as remarkable as Rudy..."

Yuni had been around Rudy since her admission.

From the student council to the laboratory, they had spent time together.

That's why Yuni knew Rudy's capabilities well.

She understood why Rie might be drawn to Rudy.

"But, not now!"

If not now, she wouldn't be able to spend time freely with Rie.

Once Rie became a third-year, she would be away from the academy for a semester, and after graduation, both being princesses, they wouldn't be able to move around freely.

So, the only time Yuni could spend freely with Rie was now.

She didn't want to lose these moments to someone else.

Also, she wanted to see for herself if Rudy and Rie were a good match.

If she thought they didn't suit each other, she planned to prevent Rudy from getting any closer.

After much contemplation, Yuni lifted her head.

"Yes, I'll do what I can as a sister."

Yuni nodded firmly, humming an affirmative 'Hmm!'

The next day.

Yuni went straight to Rudy.

"Senior."

"...Gasp."

Rudy's eyes widened upon seeing Yuni.

He then immediately prepared to run.

Yuni quickly grabbed hold of Rudy.

"Senior! Don't run away, let's talk!"

"I don't think I have anything to say..."

"I do."

Yuni looked around.

"If you don't like crowded places, shall we go somewhere else to talk?"

"Proposing a bet?"

"Yes. Let's bet on something involving my sister."

I wondered what she was going to say, but her proposal was more absurd than I expected.

I stared at Yuni, who wore a confident expression.

"Why should I do that?"

"Are you not confident? Or is your affection for my sister not that strong?"

Yuni spoke arrogantly, as if trying to provoke me.

But it didn't feel like a real challenge.

"But Rie would hate something like that, wouldn't she?"

Knowing Rie's personality, she would be annoyed if someone made a bet involving her, likely retorting, 'Who are you to use me for your bets?'

Yuni pondered for a moment and then furrowed her brows.

"Now that I think about it..."

It seemed Yuni had the same realization.

After a moment of contemplation, she looked at me.

"Then let's keep it a secret and still have the bet."

Her persistence was quite fitting.

I sighed.

What am I going to do with this princess...

"So, what's the bet exactly?"

I decided to hear Yuni out, at least.

After all, as long as I win the bet, it should be fine.

When I asked, Yuni pointed her finger at me.

"The joint assessment for first and second years! Let's see who ranks higher. That's our bet."

"The joint assessment?"

I couldn't believe it.

I had secured the top position in my class.

Compared to other students, I had more experience and was theoretically superior.

Being in the top of my year, I couldn't imagine competing with Yuni.

I smiled slyly.

"Do you really think you stand a chance against me?"

"We won't know until we try. But,"

Yuni raised her index finger.

"If we directly compare ourselves, there's a high chance I'll lose. So, let's base it on our year rankings."

"Year rankings..."

Yuni was currently second in our year.

The top position was held by Diark Verdès, a magic swordsman.

Despite studying both magic and swordsmanship, he proudly held the top spot in our year.

I had heard he was getting along well with Borval, though I hadn't seen him in a while.

"Fine, let's do that. But what happens if you lose or we tie?"

It would be unfair if only I stood to lose something.

Yuni looked puzzled, as if she hadn't thought that far.

"I didn't think about that."

Yuni wasn't known for thorough preparation in such matters.

In this regard, she was the complete opposite of Rie.

Or not.

Rie also acts impulsively sometimes...

Are they similar, then?

"Alright, so for when you lose, I get to set the condition?"

"Yes, sure."

"If you're proposing a bet, you should be prepared for the same conditions."

I looked at Yuni and smiled.

"If you lose, you'll stop approaching Rie."

Yuni's eyes widened as I laid out the condition.

"Me too?"

It was the condition she would fear the most.

Her proposing this bet was probably driven by her desire to monopolize Rie's attention.

I could see right through Yuni's intentions.

With such a condition, she'd likely back out without needing to follow through with the bet.

The loss would outweigh what she hoped to gain...

But Yuni's response was unexpected.

"...I'll do it."

"What?"

"I said I'll do it!"

I was taken aback.

"I'll decide for myself if you're suitable for my sister."

Yuni said this firmly, clenching her fists.

I found this interesting.

I had assumed she was driven by mere possessiveness over Rie, but it seemed she had other motives.

Given her determination, I was willing to compromise.

"Then we just need to agree on what happens if we tie."

"Yes, what should we do?"

After pondering for a moment, I spoke up.

"Let's call it even. If we tie, it'll be as if it never happened."

Yuni smiled, seemingly pleased.

"Sounds good. Let's do that."

After saying this, Yuni turned to leave.

"Train hard until the joint assessment."

"Sure, you too."

I waved at Yuni as she walked away.

"I guess I need to put in some effort too."

I had a prior commitment before meeting Yuni today.

It was an appointment to train for the joint assessment.

I had made gloves for the assessment, but their practicality hadn't been proven yet.

I only knew they were usable.

Therefore, an experience close to real combat was necessary.

There's a big difference between using something in practice and in actual combat.

A technique that works in practice might fail in combat.

It was important to identify such details.

For that, I needed a strong opponent who knew my weaknesses.

With these thoughts, I soon arrived at the training ground.

The training ground, located on the outskirts where few people came.

I chose this place not because I didn't want to reveal my abilities or attract attention, but to prevent bystanders from getting hurt.

As I entered the training ground, I heard a voice.

"Oh, you're here."

My opponent was none other than Astina.

She knew me well and was among the strongest people I knew, aside from the professors.

Lately, Astina had been enjoying her leisure time.

It seemed she had already completed her thesis for graduation and met all other requirements with room to spare.

Now, all she had to do was wait until graduation.

That's why I sought out Astina.

As I approached her, I started to speak.

"I apologize for being late. I was delayed by some work."

"It's fine. I know you're busy. I just came here early to train."

Lately, Astina had been practicing her magic alone.

With her free time, she was focused on enhancing her own abilities.

That's why I had asked for her help, knowing she was focused in her training.

For both Astina and me, sparring with each other was the fastest way to improve.

However, there was a problem.

Astina's abilities were particularly well-suited to counteracting mine, which was concerning.

My biggest weaknesses currently were defense and mobility.

The only way I could move quickly was by enhancing my legs.

And my defensive skills were almost nonexistent.

In contrast, Astina possessed abilities that were excellent for pushing opponents back and maintaining distance.

Her capabilities were just too challenging for me to face.

Although I had more than enough power to break through an opponent, I lacked the means to reach them.

At the very least, I needed to advance while defending or move at a speed that the opponent couldn't react to.

I hadn't met either of these conditions.

While such tactics might work against weaker opponents, I wasn't confident against stronger ones.

I hadn't yet had the chance to properly fight someone that strong.

In a way, this was a good opportunity.

It was a chance to find a way to penetrate the defenses of a strong opponent.

Astina looked at me and smiled.

"You have a lot on your plate with the student council and other responsibilities. Are you sure you can afford to train with me?"

"The lab work should be on hold for a while, and the student council work isn't that tough."

Astina shook her head at my response.

"That's not what I mean. If I take you on seriously, there's a chance you might get hurt. Wouldn't that hinder your other activities?"

"You don't need to worry about that. If I was afraid of getting hurt, I wouldn't have approached you. Just do your best against me."

"You seem quite confident."

"Would I say this if I wasn't?"

At my words, Astina's smile grew wider.

"Alright then, let's get started."

Astina threw off her outer garment and untied the ribbon around her neck.

"Please, do your best."

I put on the gloves I had brought and replied.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 176: Individual Skills Assessment 2 (1)

Time flew by, and autumn arrived.

Then, the day everyone had been eagerly awaiting approached.

It was the Individual Skills Assessment, held before the Joint Assessment.

At one of the academy's open spaces, the so-called highlight of the Individual Skills Assessment, the Destructive Power Test, was taking place.

In the center of the open space stood a person and a scarecrow.

It seemed the assessment had just been conducted, as dust clouds were rising around them.

The onlookers expressed their admiration upon witnessing the scene.

"Indeed... This year's first-year students are of a high caliber."

"It's a pleasure to the eyes. To see such an assessment from first-year students."

"This is comparable to the current second-year students..."

Such comments were heard all around.

Diark Verdès stood in the center.

Verdès, a scion of the Verdès family, a magic swordsman, and the top student, was the center of everyone's attention.

Diark lived up to the immense expectations placed on him.

In fact, he exceeded them.

Diark smiled satisfactorily.

'It was perfect.'

He seemed to have performed even better than he did usually in practice.

Diark, shining as the top student of the first year, demonstrated his skills brilliantly.

Moreover, the technique he used, a combination of sword aura and magic, was immensely destructive.

The ground around him was cratered from his technique, and the scarecrow in the center was tattered.

'Borval senior...! I did it!'

Diark mentally celebrated while looking around.

At the edge of the arena, Borval was smiling contentedly.

The ability Diark used was a technique inspired by Borval's ability, interpreted in the style of a magic swordsman.

Diark wanted to show Borval, who had helped him develop this technique, that he could be number one.

After a short wait, the announcer exclaimed loudly.

"7620 points!!! An overwhelming first place!!! A record high score."

'This should be enough...'

Diark checked the score of the second place.

Even with the highest score, the gap with the second place was crucial.

Currently, Kuhn was in second place.

Though Kuhn had just performed impressively in the assessment, he was no match for Diark.

Kuhn had scored in the 4000s.

The gap was nearly double.

However.

'The variable is...'

There was just one first-year student who possessed the ability to threaten Diark.

Yuni Von Ristonia.

The person who had outsmarted Diark in the student council president elections.

Recently, Diark had been enjoying watching Rudy tame Yuni, but he still had an unresolved grudge.

This was a debt Diark himself wanted to settle, not to be paid by someone else.

For now, Diark stepped out of the open space.

As soon as he left the open area, Diark Verdès ran towards Borval.

Borval, with no particular expression, was sitting, his large muscles taking up two seats, and his axe occupying another, effectively hogging three seats by himself.

Approaching Borval, Diark opened his mouth, a look of pride on his face.

"Senior, did you see that?"

Borval nodded.

"It seemed your abilities were stronger than usual today."

Diark smiled at Borval's remark.

"Indeed, did you notice? I felt in great condition today and decided to use a bigger technique."

Borval slightly furrowed his brow.

"You shouldn't use your abilities so recklessly. It's important to control them, using only as much as necessary. Remembering the exact amount of mana and the sense of how you usually use it is important in real combat."

"Ah..."

Diark nodded, seemingly moved by Borval's words.

"You're right, senior. I shouldn't use my abilities indiscriminately just because I'm in good condition."

Using too much mana when feeling strong could create vulnerabilities.

Mana could be depleted too quickly, or one might even use more mana than they could handle.

Hence, in real battles, it was crucial to use mana in accordance with one's usual pace.

As Diark looked dejected, Borval punched him lightly in the chest.

"Still, it was an impressive technique."

After saying this, Borval turned and walked away.

Diark, wide-eyed, bowed his head towards Borval's retreating figure.

"Thank you!"

As Borval walked away, he slightly raised his hand.

"Ha ha..."

Diark smiled, pleased with the high score he had received.

With such a score, even Yuni would find it difficult to win against him.

Smiling, Diark was about to enter the building when he saw Yuni Von Ristonia inside.

"Yuni Von Ristonia..."

Yuni's face was scrunched in a frown.

This frown was different from her usual expression.

When Yuni frowned, it usually conveyed annoyance or irritation, but this time, it was a look of unease.

'Did she watch my match?'

Diark thought Yuni might have felt daunted after seeing his performance.

'It's possible.'

The technique Diark had displayed was satisfactory even to himself.

It wasn't just practical but also flashy and powerful.

Diark, intending to mock Yuni, walked towards her.

"Yuni Von..."

Before he could finish, Yuni, without turning to look at him, suddenly ran off somewhere.

"...Huh?"

Diark looked puzzled.

He had planned to provoke her, but she ran off so abruptly that he couldn't bring himself to chase after her.

'Where is she going?'

Diark stared intently in the direction Yuni had run off to.

"...The restroom?"

The Individual Skills Assessment.

This activity, conducted before the Joint Assessment, tests the students annually in great detail.

Especially for the first-year students, as it's their first assessment, the examination is even more thorough.

The tests start with mana-related assessments and include various physical examinations.

These are designed to detect any unknown diseases early and provide treatment, thereby preventing the loss of talented individuals due to untreated ailments.

I looked at the long line of first-year students.

“There are so many...”

The line was not diminishing quickly.

Of course, some students left the line for the Destructive Power Test, the highlight of the individual assessment, but the line never really shortened.

“It looks like it’s going to take 2-3 hours just to get through one test...”

“Just relax. It’s a good time to rest.”

“Yeah, you’re right.”

I replied to Rie, who was standing behind me in line.

Rie and I were queuing for the same assessment.

Standing in line alone might have been boring, but having Rie there made it less so.

“By the way, are you well-prepared for the Joint Assessment?”

Rie tilted her head and asked.

“Kind of? I mean, I didn’t train specifically for the assessment. It was more like my usual training routine.”

“I heard you’ve been training hard with Astina lately.”

Rie narrowed her eyes.

“Just training, right?”

“...What else do you think I did?”

“If it’s true, then never mind.”

Rie spoke with a nonchalant expression.

What’s bothering her...?

Training is something anyone can do.

Lately, Rie seemed to have become more jealous.

“What have you been up to lately? I asked around but no one seems to know. You also haven’t been around.”

“If you were curious, you should have come to see me.”

“You told me not to look for you.”

“Well, yes, but what if you really didn’t come? You should at least show your face occasionally. Don’t you know a girl’s heart?”

Rie stamped her feet behind me as she spoke.

“Alright... I’ll come to see you next time.”

Pleased, Rie smiled contentedly.

“That’s good. You’re so nice, Rudy.”

Rie tiptoed and patted my head.

People around us stared blatantly.

My face turned red with embarrassment, being so overtly affectionate in front of others.

How do couples manage to do this kind of thing?

“So, what kind of training have you been doing alone?”

I quickly changed the subject, fearing strange rumors might spread if we continued like this.

“Oh, I wasn’t training alone.”

“Hmm?”

“Serina helped me.”

I tilted my head in confusion.

“Serina came to the academy?”

“Yeah, she’s part of the Royal Secret Service. They can move freely if ordered. I asked if Serina could help me for a while.”

Serina had a history of causing trouble at the academy.

"Can she really just come and go as she pleases?"

"Don't worry, I've got permission for all of it. My lodging is outside the academy, and I only came in briefly from time to time."

Rie seemed to read my mind and answered my unspoken question.

"Alright, I trust you managed it well. So, did you focus on training Elemental Magic?"

"Um... Sort of?"

Rie replied noncommittally.

I looked at her intently.

"Didn't you train in Elemental Magic?"

"Well, yes, but it’s a bit complicated..."

"Complicated how?"

Rie chuckled and playfully patted my back.

"It wouldn't be fun if I just told you. You’ll see it later."

"Okay, got it."

There would be an opportunity to showcase our abilities in the open area anyway.

It was better to witness it directly than to probe further now.

As we were chatting, a loud announcement rang out.

"Student Yuni Von Ristonia, please come to the open area."

"Is it Yuni's turn?"

It was time for Yuni to display her abilities in the open area.

As I said this, Rie frowned.

"What's wrong?"

"Hmm... I saw Yuni earlier... she didn't seem to be in good condition."

"Not in good condition?"

"She's been acting strangely recently. Uncharacteristically intense about her studies... I'm worried."

Hearing this, I felt a pang of guilt.

I couldn't bring myself to tell Rie about the bet I had made with Yuni, who had asked to keep it a secret.

There was no need to stir up trouble.

"Ahaha... It's good to be diligent. She's probably just trying to get good grades."

"That's true, but... Yuni has a sort of trauma. It's not good for her to be so tense..."

I tilted my head, confused.

"What do you mean?"

"Yuni isn't usually the type to get nervous, but when she does, she tends to make mistakes..."

Although I initially worried about Yuni's trauma, Rie's explanation made it seem less concerning.

"Mistakes... Everyone makes mistakes when they're nervous."

"No... it's not just any mistake..."

"Hmm?"

Rie scratched her cheek awkwardly, her explanation unclear.

"Do you want to go watch if you're so concerned?"

"No, Yuni might get even more nervous if I go. I just hope she overcomes it on her own."

Rie gazed towards the open area, her expression growing darker.

Chapter 177: Individual Skills

Assessment 2 (2)

It was when Yuni was very young.

Back then, Yuni, still a child, made a big mistake in front of many people.

She really needed to use the bathroom, but with so many people waiting, she had to forcefully hold it in.

And eventually... she made a mistake.

At that time, Yuni was so young that the people around her didn't make a big deal of it, but the incident left her traumatized.

Whenever she felt nervous, she needed to use the bathroom, and it was the same no matter how many times she went.

"Ugh..."

Yuni stood in line with a frown on her face.

She was waiting for a physical examination.

Even if she felt unwell, she had to get the examination done.

Sitting in the bathroom for a long time wouldn't change much, so she was trying to get the examination done.

But...

'I just went a moment ago...'

Yuni was squirming.

It hadn't even been an hour since she last went to the bathroom, but she felt the urge to go again.

'No... it's not really that I need to go...'

Yuni repeated this to herself several times.

But that didn't make her body listen.

She just held on to her skirt, trying to endure.

"Hmm...? Yuni?"

At that moment, Luna approached Yuni.

"Oh... Luna."

"Yuni! Long time no see!"

Luna greeted Yuni with a bright face.

Then she stared intently at Yuni.

Yuni looked pale and was squirming.

Seeing this, Luna gasped.

"Um... Yuni."

Luna carefully approached Yuni and spoke.

"You can step out for a moment... They'll still do the examination even if you're a bit late."

Anyone could see that Yuni was uncomfortable.

Luna spoke quietly, considering Yuni's feelings, but Yuni shook her head.

"It's, it's not that... I'm just feeling a bit unwell..."

"Do you want me to take you to the infirmary?"

Yuni firmly replied to Luna's question.

"No, it's okay."

She was biting her lower lip.

"It's something I need to overcome."

Normally, Yuni didn't know what nervousness was.

With her nature of taking things lightly, there wasn't much that could make her nervous.

But this time was different.

She had to score well.

The score from the individual assessment would be reflected in the joint assessment.

Yuni wanted to do her best.

She didn't want to lose even a single point.

A mistake here could mean not being able to be with her sister, Rie, for one or two years.

A brief mistake could result in not being able to spend time with the sister she had just become close to.

Such pressure weighed heavily on Yuni.

Luna looked at Yuni with a worried expression.

Then, after a moment of contemplation, she spoke.

"Ah, this should do."

Luna removed her outer garment.

"Huh?"

Then, she bent over and tied her clothing around Yuni's waist.

"Keeping your stomach warm is important! Ah, if only I had a blanket or something..."

Luna clicked her tongue, seemingly dissatisfied with only being able to tie her clothes around Yuni.

Her face conveyed a desire to do more.

Yuni bowed her head in gratitude to Luna.

"...Thank you, Senior."

The fact that someone cared for her this much was deeply appreciated.

It was a warmth she hadn't felt before.

As Yuni bowed, Luna smiled warmly and gently stroked Yuni's head.

"It's natural for a senior to take care of a junior who is unwell!"

Luna's smile was comforting.

Just seeing it made Yuni feel reassured and warmed.

Luna stroked Yuni's head a few more times, then looked around.

Seeing no one nearby, she whispered to Yuni.

"Take care of yourself on those days. Keep warm. And here, take this."

Luna handed Yuni a small envelope.

It contained candy.

"Ena gave me this candy... it has pain-relieving effects. Eat this, it's grape-flavored so it should taste good!"

"Ah..."

Luna was slightly misunderstanding the situation.

She thought it was 'that time of the month' for girls.

Yuni quickly realized this misunderstanding.

"Ah, Senior... it's not that..."

"Luna! Come quickly!"

"Ah, okay! Yuni, do your best!! Good luck with your assessment!"

Before Yuni could clarify the misunderstanding, Luna was called away and quickly disappeared.

Yuni watched Luna leave, then looked down at her palm.

There was the candy Luna had given her.

It was a piece of candy, crumpled in paper.

Candy was a luxury item, difficult for commoners and lower nobility to afford.

As a royal, Yuni could have it anytime, but Luna probably couldn't.

Especially a medicinal candy like this was even more precious.

Yuni clenched the candy tightly in her fist.

'Luna took such care of me... I have to be strong too.'

Yuni clenched her teeth in determination.

Time passed.

"Yuni Von Ristonia, please come to the field and wait."

Having completed her examination and waited, it was now Yuni's turn.

She had to step out onto the field for her assessment.

Yuni started walking.

As she approached the field, the pressure intensified.

'I just went to the bathroom a moment ago...'

Yuni's legs trembled.

She gripped Luna's clothing tightly.

Her senior had given her so much support.

She had to be strong.

'Ugh...'

Yuni walked forward, her legs trembling.

As she continued, she finally reached the vicinity of the field.

The assessment coordinator approached.

"Yuni Von Ristonia... you have arrived."

"Ah, student Yuni has come..."

The coordinator turned towards Yuni upon hearing her voice and immediately looked concerned.

Yuni's face was beyond pale, turning almost blue, and she seemed unable to control her trembling body.

Her legs shook as if she were a newborn fawn.

"Yuni, are you unwell?"

The coordinator, startled by Yuni's appearance, approached her with concern.

"No... I'm alright."

"Your condition doesn't seem good... Maybe you should go to the infirmary..."

"No, really... I'm fine."

Despite Yuni's assurances, her condition did not seem to improve.

'It's nothing. Just do it. Like you always do... just follow the practice...'

Yuni bit her lower lip.

She just needed to endure it for a bit longer.

Just a little longer...

But gradually, the pressure in her lower abdomen intensified.

She began to feel not just the urge to use the bathroom, but actual pain.

Yet, she tried to move forward.

Yuni looked towards the field she was supposed to enter.

There were many people around the field.

All those people were looking towards the center of the field.

The place where Yuni needed to be.

"Ah..."

She could feel their gazes.

Some were filled with anticipation, but among them, there were cold, judgmental stares.

Yuni only noticed the cold eyes, which triggered her trauma even more.

Usually, Yuni didn't care about her surroundings to avoid such feelings.

Paying attention to others made her body tense and triggered her past traumas.

When she didn't think about anything, her mind was at ease.

This was Yuni's way of surviving.

Ignoring those around her and maintaining her own pace.

But now, that was impossible.

She could see the eyes of the people outside, and inside, the bet she made with Rudy was pressuring her.

The tension wrapped around her body.

Yuni grimaced and bent over.

Her head started spinning.

The world seemed to shake, and everything around her blurred.

It was more than just wanting to use the bathroom; she was being pushed to a mental corner.

"Yuni! Student Yuni!"

The coordinator tried to support Yuni.

As they reached out to grab her, Yuni brushed their hand away.

"You look really unwell..."

"I'm fine... really, I'm okay..."

Yuni held her abdomen as she spoke.

If she missed her turn, she would receive a deduction in her score.

Even if it was a health issue, she would have to take the assessment with a deduction.

But the pain in her abdomen was growing.

Yuni grimaced with pain and then a thought crossed her mind.

"Ahh... that's right. The candy Luna gave me..."

Yuni reached into her pocket.

The candy Luna had given her earlier was now in her hand.

'It has pain-relieving effects...'

With her abdomen aching, she hoped the candy would provide some relief.

She unwrapped the paper around the candy and popped it into her mouth.

The sweet taste spread through her mouth.

However, there was no significant change.

Her abdomen continued to ache, and her legs trembled.

"Next student, please!"

Then the announcer's voice was heard.

The turn of the student in front of Yuni had ended.

It was now Yuni's turn to enter.

"First year student and the second princess of the empire! Yuni Von Ristonia!"

Upon hearing the announcer, Yuni lifted her bowed upper body.

Despite her pain and poor condition, she had to proceed with the assessment.

She couldn't run away.

But her legs were frozen.

She wanted to walk forward but couldn't move.

The gazes from outside were terrifying.

Her trembling legs wouldn't obey her commands.

"Why can't I..."

Yuni made a sad face and looked down at her legs.

Then she muttered to herself.

"You can do this... Yuni Von Ristonia..."

Yuni hit her legs with her fist.

It wasn't a strong punch.

Rather, it was a feeble attempt, lacking strength.

Even after hitting her legs a few times, they wouldn't move.

Yuni spoke in a desperate voice.

"You can do this..."

Thump—

She felt a touch on her head.

"Yes, you can do it."

A voice was heard.

Yuni turned around.

There stood Rudy.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 178: Individual Skills

Assessment 2 (3)

"I wonder if she's okay."

I was walking quickly.

Having heard Rie's words, I couldn't just ignore them.

It was Yuni who had suggested the bet, but I too had a responsibility since I had accepted it.

I didn't want to see Yuni fall apart.

The best Yuni was just being Yuni.

"If that's the case, why didn't you tell me sooner..."

Had I known, I wouldn't have agreed to the bet.

There was no need to overcome any pain right now, no matter what it was.

It was important for Yuni to maintain her condition, as her performance would directly affect her grades.

Feeling guilty for putting her in the worst condition in such a situation was inevitable.

"Now, the next student, please!"

The announcer's voice rang out, and I arrived at the corridor where Yuni was.

I saw Yuni up ahead, trembling.

It was an unfamiliar sight.

Yuni was usually a strong-hearted and indifferent person.

Seeing such a person trembling made me sigh.

It seemed like my fault somehow...

"First year student and the second princess of the empire! Yuni Von Ristonia!"

It was Yuni's turn to go out.

She was supposed to walk down the corridor as per the proceedings, but she couldn't move forward.

Her legs weren't moving, as she tapped them with her fists.

Though she wasn't saying anything, I could almost hear her shouting at her legs to move.

I slowly approached Yuni.

"You can do this... Yuni Von Ristonia... You can do this..."

She was muttering to herself in a trembling voice.

I placed my hand on her head.

"Yes, you can do it."

"...?"

Yuni turned around with a puzzled look.

Her eyes were glistening.

It seemed like she was on the verge of crying.

"What are you doing here?"

"Ru, Rudy?"

Surprise was evident on Yuni's face.

I raised both my hands.

I gently grasped Yuni's cheeks.

I pulled her cheeks recklessly.

"Huh??? What are you doing..."

"You're clumsy."

Yuni's eyes widened as I spoke firmly.

"What?"

Yuni flared up while I still held her cheeks.

Ignoring her reaction, I continued.

"But that's only when compared to second years like Rie and me."

I pointed outside.

"Compared to those outside, you are extraordinary."

"That's..."

"You're a princess. Of high status. You are incomparable. Plus, you're ranked second in the first year. You achieved that while helping out in Gracie's lab."

"No, what are you suddenly talking about?"

I patted Yuni's back hard.

And I laughed.

"Don't be nervous."

"Yuni student! Please come out!"

The announcer called out.

"Hey, they're calling you. Hurry up."

"Uh, wait! Senior!"

"Save what you want to say for after."

As I pushed her back as if to hurry her, Yuni walked out with a puzzled look.

"Why did he suddenly come here?"

Yuni touched her still-tingling cheek, utterly bewildered.

It was strange for someone, her opponent at that, to show up just to recite her strengths.

His actions left her puzzled.

After spouting some odd remarks, pinching her cheeks, and then pushing her out, she felt completely disoriented.

"Hmm?"

However, her tension eased a bit.

She wasn't in perfect condition, but there was definitely an improvement.

'...Is this the effect of the candy?'

Yuni rolled the candy in her mouth.

Luna had mentioned its pain-relieving effects, but like most medicines, it could have other effects too.

'Could it be a sedative effect?'

Yuni sighed in relief.

Anyway, this was good.

Now that she had calmed down, it was best to finish quickly.

"Yuni student, please start whenever you're ready," the announcer's voice came.

"Whew..."

Yuni exhaled deeply.

She recalled Rudy's words.

These people in front of her knew nothing.

She was different from her past self.

In the past, those in front of her had been superior, but not now.

In terms of skills, potential, or status, she was not inferior.

'Just watch my superior self.'

Yuni smiled and began.

"Yuni Von Ristonia. I'll start now."

She closed her eyes.

Mana began to flow.

'Just do as I've always done.'

Crackle—

A small spark flickered above Yuni's head.

'Just as the professor taught me.'

Yuni extended her finger towards the scarecrow in front of her.

Electricity began to swirl around.

Small static charges caused her hair to stand on end.

Yuni had spent her time in Gracie's lab during the first semester and the holidays.

She did odd jobs and assisted with research, experiencing significant growth in a short period.

She had progressed in magic, now able to use intermediate spells.

But staying in Gracie's lab meant she had no one to teach her intermediate magic.

That's when Gracie caught her eye.

As a professor, Gracie's teaching skills were beyond doubt, and being there daily meant Yuni could ask questions directly.

Of course, she wasn't without other options.

She could have learned from another professor using her princess status.

But with Gracie there daily, she saw no reason to seek lessons elsewhere.

The intermediate magic Yuni learned was Gracie's lightning magic.

"Scatter mana around..."

Yuni murmured softly, raising her finger towards the sky.

"Strike down...!"

"Lightning Strike!"

The mana surrounding Yuni converged on her fingertip.

The mana transformed into static electricity, swirling around her finger.

As Yuni slashed her finger towards the scarecrow, the gathered electricity shot out.

It formed a strong electrical charge, whipping out like a lash.

Crackle-Zap—

The electricity from Yuni's hand perfectly struck the scarecrow.

Just like she had practiced.

Exactly as she had prepared.

A direct hit.

The scarecrow was precisely hit by Yuni's technique, currents of electricity coursing through it.

Yuni stared blankly at the scene.

"It worked, it's done."

She didn't know what score she might receive, but the corners of her mouth lifted in satisfaction for executing as planned.

But only for a moment.

"Wow!!!"

"Lightning magic? I didn't know the princess could use such magic."

"This is impressive..."

Voices from the crowd reached her.

"Ah..."

Hearing those voices, the same feeling from earlier began to return.

"I, I need the bathroom..."

She couldn't stay here any longer.

"Yuni student?"

Yuni quickly turned around.

And started running.

If she stayed here... she might make a mistake.

A disaster could ensue.

"Yu, Yuni student! Your score hasn't been announced yet, where are you going!!"

Yuni ignored the announcer's words and ran towards the bathroom.

"I did quite well."

I smiled contentedly, looking at the first-year score chart.

Yuni had boldly secured second place for herself, just narrowly behind Diark in first.

If her condition had been a bit better, she could have easily taken the top spot.

Though Yuni was the one evaluated, I felt a pang of disappointment.

Still, second place was good enough to aim for the top in the joint assessment.

"Anyway."

I shifted my gaze.

"Isn't it time to start?"

As I spoke, the announcer's voice echoed.

"We will now begin the second-year individual assessments."

The evaluation wasn't just for first years.

Second years had to be assessed too.

And the first candidate was...

"Rudy Astria, please wait in the corridor."

It was me.

I had already checked the order and was waiting in the corridor, monitoring the first-year scores.

"Yuni did well, and now..."

It was my turn to perform.

I had a goal.

I wanted to surpass Astina's score when she was a second-year.

This time, I realized something.

Astina was even more impressive than I had thought.

Despite only a year's difference, I felt a significant gap.

The gap felt more tangible after fighting her directly.

But it wasn't unreachable.

I had set my sights on a target.

Catching up to Astina right now was impossible.

So, I planned to slowly reach that goal, starting by catching up to Astina as she was in her second year.

"Rudy Astria, the second son of the Astria family and top student in the second year! He showed a shocking performance as a first year, and now we are excited to see what he will bring this time!"

I walked out slowly into the corridor.

Many faces were visible outside.

"It's been a while since I've been here..."

I hadn't been able to look around leisurely like this when I was a first-year.

I was too tense and focused on what I had to do.

But now, it was different.

My condition was at its peak.

Between student council work, lab duties, and sparring with Astina...

A few days of rest from these demanding tasks made me feel restless, eager to move.

'I want to start moving right away.'

"Rudy student, just let us know when you're ready."

"Yes, I'll start right away."

I responded promptly to the announcer.

Eager to move, I gathered my mana and looked up.

At the end, Astina was looking at me indifferently.

Seeing her, I couldn't help but smile.

I fiddled with my gloves.

The mana stone on the back of the glove reacted to my mana, emitting a small light.

'It's 40,000 points.'

I recalled Astina's score from her second year.

With that thought, I let out a smile.

"It's easy enough."

I dashed forward.

The wind brushed through my hair, giving a pleasant sensation.

Mana gathered in my gloves, sending a tingling sensation from my hands up my arms.

As I sprinted forward, the scarecrow came into view. I pulled my arm back.

Twisting my waist like hitting a punching machine, I drew my arm as far back as possible.

"Inhale!"

Then with all my might.

With the greatest strength.

Boom!

I slammed the scarecrow to the ground.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 179: Individual Skills

Assessment 2 (4)

"Did you see that?"

I smiled and faced Astina.

"What's so great about surpassing my second year score?"

Astina spoke as if it was nothing, but she was smiling.

My score was 70,000 points.

It was a score that far exceeded Astina's when she was in her second year.

Astina, still smiling, turned her head slightly.

"It seems like it's time to manage your expression."

"Ah... Hmm."

I touched around my mouth with an awkward expression.

Below, Luna was climbing up, her face devoid of strength.

"Sniffle..."

"Why the long face when you did well!"

Next to Luna was Rie.

Rie was holding Luna's hand, helping her up.

She looked like a mother leading her daughter.

Astina smiled and looked at Luna.

"Luna, well done."

"Astina! At times like this, you shouldn't say 'well done' but rather scold for not doing better."

Rie spoke sharply.

"Luna didn't mean for it to happen, maybe we should just let it be..."

"No! When you do something wrong, you need to be scolded."

"Sniffle..."

Luna shrank under Rie's scolding.

She huddled and looked miserable.

"I'm such a fool... I'm such a fool..."

Luna had made a mistake during the assessment.

Her attack didn't hit the target properly, and the score was... disappointingly low.

The reason for this actually lay with me.

After my assessment, the ground was left in a mess.

My attack had created a pit in the ground and stones had scattered around.

The professors did their best to fix the ground, but they couldn't do it properly due to the need to proceed quickly with the assessments.

Luna, who was next, tripped over an uneven stone while trying to cast her spell.

As she fell, the spell was released and barely grazed the target.

If it hadn't hit the target at all, she might have had a chance to try again...

It was both ridiculous and regrettable.

"Anyway, individual assessments don't significantly affect your score, so don't worry."

Astina approached Luna with a warm smile and stooped down a bit.

"There are still opportunities ahead."

Luna's clothes were covered in dust and dirt from falling, and Astina began to brush it off.

"Sigh..."

Rie sighed and looked at Luna.

It seemed that even Rie had spoken out of concern for Luna, knowing how hard she had tried.

But I had a lingering question.

"Luna, about the spell you used... did you choose that spell on purpose?"

"Ah..."

The spell Luna had chosen was not particularly remarkable.

The magic was a wind attribute spell that had been enhanced several times.

It was simply a spell that created a lance of wind and hurled it swiftly.

While its power was considerable, if asked whether it was Luna's best effort, I could confidently answer 'no'.

Luna, who primarily uses magical tools, could have come up with more unique ideas...

In fact, the telekinetic magic tool she used in her first year was more impressive.

"Was it, intentional? Or, maybe it couldn't be helped..."

"...What?"

Rie glared at Luna again.

Thunk—

Rie approached Luna and gave her a knock on the head.

Luna held her head and let out a few tears.

"Rie...!"

"If you didn't give it your best, accept the results! You shouldn't just rely on luck!"

"I had my reasons though..."

Luna muttered, pouting her lips slightly.

"We'll end up really fighting if this goes on. Stop it, Rie."

"Hmph..."

Rie turned her head, clearly displeased.

"Rudy, you should go and finish the rest of your assessments. Didn't you say you're not done yet?"

"Ah, yes. I understand..."

Although I was worried about Rie and Luna's situation, I still had to complete my assessments.

"I'll be back then. Those two..."

"Yes, I'll look after them."

The way she said it felt like leaving kids with a babysitter, but with Astina there, I doubted they'd get into any trouble.

"Alright... I'm counting on you."

"Ouch..."

I fiddled with my finger from which blood had been drawn.

"Isn't there something like a needle around...?"

Here, they didn't use needles to draw blood.

Instead, a cut was made on the finger with a knife to extract a few drops of blood.

It was a crude method but efficient.

Since the blood tests weren't in-depth, a large quantity of blood wasn't necessary.

Most tests were conducted using magic, and the blood was only examined for its mana content.

Since not much blood was needed, a sterilized knife was used to make a quick cut, foregoing any special tools.

It was faster and cost-effective.

But, slicing your finger with a knife was more painful than expected.

It's like stubbing your little toe hurts more than getting hit hard elsewhere.

It was a similar concept.

I wrapped my finger with a cloth and headed towards the open field, quickening my pace.

It was Rie's turn now; her name had just been called.

I was curious about what Rie had learned from Serina and what abilities she would use.

While I could guess, seeing it firsthand was different.

Only by seeing it could I understand the principles behind her abilities.

"I might be a bit late..."

Just when I was undergoing the test, it was Rie's turn.

I couldn't just say I'd come back later for my test, so I was hurrying as fast as I could.

"What's this?"

Arriving at the open field, I looked around.

In the center of the field, flames were rising.

"An explosive magic spell?"

It was the explosive magic that Rie usually used.

I thought she would use spirits after being trained by Serina...

"Student Rie! 27,300 points!"

It was a high score.

Did she achieve that score with just her magic?

But that didn't seem quite right.

Next to Rie, a green-colored hawk, Sylph, the intermediate wind elemental, was flying.

The ground near the flames bore scars.

It looked as though it had been sliced with a blade.

"What happened here?"

"Hey! Rudy!"

While I was muttering to myself, Luna called out to me.

Her expression was better than before.

I asked Luna.

"Luna, what did Rie just do?"

Luna looked troubled.

"Ah... well..."

"...?"

I tilted my head in confusion as Luna hesitated.

Luna pointed towards the center of the field.

Rie was looking in our direction.

She had her index finger raised to her lips.

As if to say, 'be quiet'...

"Rie told me... not to tell Rudy..."

"Why?"

"She's annoyed. She said you should have come sooner if you were really curious."

Why would she need to hide it...?

Rie's expression in the field suggested she was just in a bad mood and didn't want to talk.

I sighed.

Luna seemed like she wasn't going to tell me anything, probably because Rie had persuaded her.

After being scolded by Rie, Luna probably just nodded in agreement.

I could pretty much picture the scene.

But there was another way.

"Where's Astina?"

"She said she saw enough of your test and just left. Said there wasn't much else to see..."

"Not even Rie's assessment?"

"Yeah, she said she felt like moving around after watching us perform our abilities and just left."

"..."

My plan was thwarted.

Maybe she left early, thinking Rie and Luna wouldn't fight...

"So you should have moved faster, right?"

As I was sighing, Rie walked up behind me, chiding me.

"How could I come faster when I was in the middle of a test?"

"You could have watched me and then taken your test."

"I prefer to get things over with quickly."

Rie glared at me.

"See, I told you. She's annoyed."

"...Alright, I'm sorry."

"If you're sorry, hug me. Then I'll tell you about my ability."

"...What?"

Suddenly, Luna, who had been sitting beside us, sprang up.

"No, no! Not with people around! Oh, no!"

Luna quickly stood up between us.

"If that's what it takes for her to talk, I'll tell you!"

"Ugh..."

Seeing Luna's fierce reaction, Rie clicked her tongue.

"Fine. Let's just drop it."

"Good!"

"Let's sit down. We're attracting attention."

"...Ah."

There weren't many people around, but after Luna's outburst, everyone was staring at us.

Luna's cheeks reddened with embarrassment.

"Sorry, sorry."

She muttered quietly and quickly returned to her seat.

"But is there anything else to see? Seems like we've seen everything."

As Rie walked back to her seat, she shrugged nonchalantly.

"It's still good to check out everyone's abilities. To see what they can do and how much they've grown."

Most of the people sitting around had the same thought process.

The joint assessment was about analyzing each other's capabilities and deciding how to act.

"Do we really need to? After all, you're the top and there's no one else to match you..."

Rie was about to sit down when she suddenly widened her eyes, looking at the field.

"...What's that?"

I followed her gaze, turning to look at the field.

In the field was...

"Evan?"

Evan was standing there, but that wasn't what was surprising.

"Why is the field suddenly..."

The field, which had been just dirt, was now sprouting blue flowers and grass.

And behind Evan, a large tree had appeared.

Evan held his sword.

White lights rose from the surrounding grass, flowers, and the tree.

These lights began to converge on the sword.

As they gathered, the sword was enveloped in a blue glow.

Evan charged towards the target dummy.

And then.

A massive burst of light enveloped the field.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 180: Individual Skills

Assessment 2 (5)

"Second place again?"

I received the second-place ranking in the individual assessment.

But I wasn't disheartened.

Just moments ago.

Evan had unleashed a massive technique.

The ground around us shook, and a bright light enveloped the area.

After everything settled.

Evan staggered and almost collapsed.

People nearby quickly moved to take Evan to the infirmary.

It seemed like the backlash from using such a large-scale technique had caught up with him.

I was dumbfounded watching this.

Normally, such techniques aren't used in individual assessments.

While it is an assessment, it's essentially a scouting exercise.

One doesn't reveal their full strength.

The individual assessment is merely a stepping stone for the joint assessment.

Since the joint assessment carries more weight in scoring, focus should be there.

Revealing all one's cards during the individual assessment can lead to poor scores in the joint assessment.

It leaves one completely analyzed.

However, Evan's technique this time was an exception.

The intense light that wrapped around the clearing made it difficult to discern how the technique was activated.

Fortunately, it was clear that using that technique resulted in backlash for Evan.

"But how do I counter that...?"

The area behind where the scarecrow stood was completely blown open.

The wall erected to contain the power had been breached.

Seeing this gave a rough idea of the scale of Evan's technique.

Could I break through that wall?

Directly hitting the wall would be easy, but it's impossible to do so with power escaping elsewhere.

Then could I counter that technique?

No certain answer came to mind.

Yet, I smiled.

Right.

This is the level I need to be at.

A competitive spirit ignited within me.

In this joint assessment, I planned to face Evan head-on.

Of course, if Evan showed any signs of contacting the Rebels, I'd immediately suppress him, but otherwise, I'd let him be.

It was the least I could do, a trap laid for capturing the Rebels.

Setting that aside.

"There's nothing I can do about coming in second..."

I hadn't used mana to the point of collapsing.

I thought it more efficient to have enough mana to continue train than use an excessive amount of mana.

With my best effort in the joint assessment, I could easily overturn the ranking.

Of course, my pride was hurt.

I felt envious that Evan could demonstrate such power, considering all the hard work I had put in so far.

But all these feelings fueled my motivation.

I had a reason to become stronger.

To beat Evan.

To completely defeat him.

To the extent that the Rebels wouldn't even come to mind.

It was a short-term, clear goal.

I smiled.

"Let's give it a try."

Evan hadn't planned to use that technique originally.

After all, the individual assessment didn't hold much significance.

But watching Rudy's attempt changed his mind.

He wanted to win.

Desperately so.

That's why he resorted to a secret technique instead of his intended one.

It was the most powerful technique he could muster.

'The conditions weren't ideal, though...'

Evan's ecological magic was stronger when surrounded by plants.

He had reached the level where he could even spontaneously grow grass with mana, but naturally grown plants allowed him to use even bigger spells than artificially created ones.

"Evan!"

Just then, Yeniel burst into the infirmary.

"Evan, are you okay?"

"Uh... I don't think I'm in bad shape."

Evan tried moving his body.

He had been dizzy from overusing mana just before, but he was starting to feel better.

"More importantly... Do you know how I ranked?"

Evan had been brought to the infirmary before the assessment officially ended.

He hadn't been able to check his rank or score.

Yeniel sighed upon seeing him.

"You came first. Scored nearly 90,000 points."

Only then did Evan smile.

"That's a relief..."

"It's just an individual assessment. Why go all out with such a technique?"

Yeniel chided him.

"As long as I'm first, it's fine."

But Evan just smiled, satisfied.

"Being first here could put you at a disadvantage in the joint assessment, you know?"

"If I come first there too, by beating Rudy Astria..."

Upon hearing Rudy Astria's name, Yeniel's expression hardened.

"Evan, there's something I've been wondering."

"Hmm?"

"Why are you so intent on being the top student?"

The reason to be the top student.

Why he needed to be first.

Evan had never questioned this before.

He pondered for a moment before responding.

"...To become stronger. The privileges of being top student and..."

Before Evan could finish, Yeniel interjected.

"What will you do with more power?"

"More power... for what?"

Evan couldn't think of an answer.

What to do with the strength he sought.

'Why am I trying to become stronger?'

It was a fundamental question.

Evan had simply been following the academy's directives, striving to be at the top in its competitive system.

When he first entered the academy, he had the reason of tuition fees, but even that was no longer a concern.

He had saved enough money that tuition wasn't an issue.

Nor was he particularly desperate for the privileges of being the top student.

In fact, those privileges felt overwhelming to him.

There were many benefits that Evan had never used.

Just having a space to train and study was enough for growth.

The large number of benefits didn't contribute much to his development.

As Evan fell into confusion, Yeniel spoke up.

"In my view, you've lost your way. You lack a genuine goal of wanting to be the top student. It seems like you're just obsessed with the competition."

"Obsessed with the competition..."

"Rudy Astria."

At the mention of that name, Evan's eyes widened.

"It looks like you're just feeling inferior to Rudy Astria."

Evan clenched his fist, feeling something boiling inside him.

"Evan, you..."

"Yeniel."

Evan interrupted Yeniel.

"...Yes, I feel inferior to Rudy Astria. You're right, it's not about wanting to be the top student as much as wanting to beat Rudy Astria. Is that wrong? Can't that be my purpose?"

Evan vented his frustration.

He revealed what had been inside him.

Something he had never told anyone before.

But.

"No, that's not okay."

Yeniel denied his words.

"If what you were doing was just child's play, it wouldn't matter. But you're not ready to take responsibility for your power. You don't even know where your sword should be pointed."

"But..."

"Evan."

Yeniël looked him straight in the eye.

"Then what will you do if Rudy Astria suddenly disappears?"

Evan stopped, mouth agape at Yeniël's question.

If Rudy Astria was gone...

"If Rudy Astria gives up everything and vanishes."

Yeniël asked again.

"What will you do then?"

"I'll survive."

After the individual ability assessment ended, Yuni emerged from the bathroom, wiping away the cold sweat.

All the tension had dissipated now that everything was over.

She was satisfied with her score.

Though she hadn't ranked first, it was still an achievement worth smiling about, especially since there were more assessments to come.

"Uh... Yuni?"

"Seniors? You're all here?"

As she walked out of the bathroom, she ran into Rudy's group.

"Yuni, are you okay?"

Rie was the first to show concern for Yuni.

Rie examined Yuni with a worried expression.

"I wasn't feeling great earlier, but I'm okay now."

Yuni smiled at Rie, reassuring her.

She didn't want to cause Rie any worry.

"I was really worried because you looked unwell today."

"It's okay because you worried about me, sister!"

Seeing Yuni's bright face, Rie also smiled.

"Usually, you only get nervous when something's going on. Looks like it was nothing serious this time."

At those words, both Rudy and Yuni felt a pang of guilt.

Normally, Yuni wouldn't have been nervous in such a situation.

She didn't typically get nervous just because many people were watching.

She became tense only when there was a reason, and then, in the presence of many people.

But she couldn't tell Rie the truth just yet.

'Sister... I'll tell you later.'

Yuni apologized silently to Rie and moistened her lips.

"Still, you did really well on the score."

Rudy joined the conversation with a smile, trying to change the subject.

Yuni laughed at Rudy's remark.

"Right? I did score well~. And I even got the same rank as Rudy."

Rudy glared at Yuni playfully.

"Why are you picking on me all of a sudden?"

"Pick on you? Coming second is still a great achievement, right?"

Yuni was right.

Second place was indeed an excellent achievement, but for Rudy, it held a different meaning.

He had always been second, after all.

Yuni knew this, and Rudy realized she was aware.

"Oh... Taking care of you only to hear such words..."

"You took care of me, senior?"

"Weren't you nervous? I came to see you myself."

Yuni tilted her head, puzzled.

"How is that taking care of me? Was that even helpful? The real help came from Luna~."

Yuni smiled and looked back at Luna.

"Ahaha..."

Yuni approached Luna, loosening the clothes tied around her waist.

"Thank you, senior. This was really helpful."

"I'm glad it was useful."

"Huh..."

Rudy watched the scene with an incredulous look.

"Oh, and the candy you gave me! I enjoyed it so much! Ah... Now that I think about it, I should thank Ena too."

"Ah... Right. That candy..."

Luna responded with an awkward smile.

"That candy really worked wonders! When I was about to start my assessment..."

"Yuni... Ena told me... that was just a regular candy. It doesn't have any pain relief effect or anything like that... I was about to tell you earlier."

"...What?"

Yuni tilted her head in confusion.

"I was sure... after eating it, I felt better... It even seemed to have a calming effect..."

Yuni spoke, her face a mix of puzzlement and disbelief.

"Ena said it was just an ordinary candy she made. Nothing special in it..."

A question mark popped up in Yuni's mind.

She had intended to thank Ena profusely, believing the candy to have been incredibly effective.

But to hear that it was just a regular candy without any medicinal properties.

"Then why did I feel better...?"

Yuni mused to herself, still tilting her head, lost in thought.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 181: Direction (1)

Gracie's Research Lab.

"It's too much... everyone is just too much..."

Gracie was once again muttering words of despair today.

"Professor Cromwell...! Professor Mcguire...! Professor Robert!!!"

Robert had extended his vacation since the holidays and had not yet returned.

Mcguire was busy with research at an academy in the capital.

As a result, Cromwell had tasked Gracie with something.

-Midterm exam, you come up with the questions.

It was unfair.

The exam questions that Robert and Mcguire should have handled were all assigned to Gracie.

This midterm exam was the one before the joint assessment, so there were fewer questions to prepare.

Still, the increase in workload was saddening.

Gracie had been living comfortably, having completed her research during the holidays.

Now, suddenly burdened with work, she found it hard to even pick up a pen.

Gracie gritted her teeth.

'Right, I won't just take this lying down...'

Gracie had been continuously mistreated by the professors for the past half year.

If she has to continue this professor job for decades, she might just die.

It was time to find a way to survive.

Gracie opened a drawer.

Inside was a massive amount of documents.

The contents were Liberion Academy's exams for the past five years.

Documents with the contents and solutions of all subjects' exams.

'I did well to get this from Astina...'

Gracie had secretly obtained these documents.

Originally intended for reference, but in her current state, it wasn't going to end at just referencing.

'After all, the questions are all the same...'

Exams are a way to ask students if they know the content.

Even if the questions are different, as long as the intent of question is the same, it shouldn't matter.

Gracie began to smirk and copy them onto the exam paper.

"Hmm~ Hmm~"

Gracie hummed a tune, praising herself for coming up with such an idea.

However, Gracie had overlooked something.

The fact that she wasn't the only one with the documents, and even if one doesn't understand the content, they could still have the answers to them.

Gracie, under great stress, had missed these minor details.

The novice professor Gracie, unaware of what was to come, continued to diligently write down the exam questions.

"Good work today."

I wiped the sweat off with my sleeve and looked at Astina.

"Yeah, you too."

Astina was smiling pleasantly.

It was a few days before the midterm exams, but I was training.

Right now, the joint assessment was the most important thing.

The midterms for the second semester had a smaller scope and less impact on grades.

The joint assessment was much more significant.

I had an intense discussion with Astina.

I explained Evan's techniques to her and pondered countermeasures.

However, the results were disappointing.

Astina, an exceptional wizard, couldn't understand my perspective during combat.

She was a user of telekinetic magic, capable of moving, attacking, and defending.

Ultimately, we started sparring without finding a proper countermeasure.

I chose to experience things physically rather than just sit and discuss.

Astina countered me with techniques similar to those used by Evan, which had a large range.

Astina stared at me intently and then spoke.

"So, did you understand anything?"

"...Not at all."

Maybe because my opponent was Astina, I couldn't even touch the hem of her sleeve.

I was like a dog chasing chickens.

"Don't worry, Evan is not as tough as me."

She was right.

Evan couldn't move as fast as Astina when using techniques.

"If I had at least managed to touch a strand of your hair, it would've been a little comforting... But now, I guess we can't even spar."

"That's not necessarily the case. If you come up with any ideas, we can still spar from time to time."

Astina was going to be busy for a while.

She had plans to craft a staff since she had some time.

Creating her own magic circle and researching meant she wouldn't have leisure time for sparring like now.

Anyway, I also needed time to think on my own, so it wasn't a big problem.

After wiping off her sweat, Astina packed her things.

"Well, I should be going now."

"Already? Why don't you rest a bit more?"

"No. If I'm going to rest, I'd rather do it comfortably in my room. Resting in this sweaty state will only make me tired."

I watched Astina for a moment, then spoke.

"Besides making a staff, have you been up to anything else lately?"

"Hmm? Why do you ask that all of a sudden?"

Astina tilted her head, seemingly puzzled by my question.

"It's just that, other than when we spar, it's hard to see you around."

Rie, Luna, and others seemed to have more free time after the holidays, often eating together and talking.

But Astina was different.

Even roaming around the Academy, it was hard to catch a glimpse of her.

I hadn't worried much about it initially, thinking it was just part of her solo training routine, but it was starting to concern me.

Staying holed up in a room and training incessantly can be exhausting.

Meeting people occasionally was essential for maintaining efficiency in both research and training.

"I'm not particularly busy with anything."

"Then, please, show your face around sometimes. Everyone is worried about you."

I said this with a playful smile.

Astina chuckled at my words.

"I'll try to, when I have the time."

With that, Astina disappeared outside the training grounds.

"Hmm..."

I watched her retreating figure intently.

Something had been off about her since our last encounter.

Looking at Astina, I couldn't shake off a feeling of unease.

It seemed as though she was deliberately keeping a distance from us.

Otherwise, it would be impossible not to cross paths with her in the Academy.

After pondering for a moment, I brushed off these thoughts.

"She'll manage on her own."

Even if there were troubles, she would overcome them soon enough.

After all, she is Astina Persia.

Yet, despite trying to reassure myself, I couldn't shake off the feeling of unease.

In the Astria territory.

"Is that really true?"

Ian stood before his father, Perrian Astria.

"Yes, it's true."

Ian's eyes widened at his father's confirmation.

It was hard for him to understand that the Duke family would dabble in necromancy.

The Astria family was already powerful without resorting to such magic, a ducal house of the empire that bowed to no one, capable of even keeping the emperor in check.

Why would such a family stoop to such deplorable acts?

Ian couldn't make sense of it.

"I intended to tell you when you inherited the family."

Perrian clicked his tongue.

Ian had never defied his father, but this time, it was hard to hold back.

"I don't understand, Father."

It was a vulnerability that could lead to the downfall of the family.

And if the rebels were involved...

A lineage of ducal rule spanning several generations could collapse in an instant.

"We must sever ties with them now. If the emperor's faction catches wind of this...!"

"Ian."

Perrian looked at Ian, who was losing his temper.

"You don't understand anything."

Thump.

Ian slammed his hand down on the table in front of him.

"It's you who doesn't understand, Father!"

"Hmm..."

Perrian pursed his lips and then stood up.

"Follow me."

"What?"

Ian furrowed his brow at his father's words.

Perrian, unfazed, moved on.

They arrived at a vault within the mansion.

Perrian naturally reached out to the vault.

A light began to emanate from it, spreading out to form a magic circle.

Click.

The sound of the vault opening echoed.

It was a vault bound by a magic circle.

"What is this vault?"

Ian looked suspiciously at Perrian.

Perrian didn't answer but opened the vault.

Inside were only manastones, nothing else.

"This is..."

Ian's eyes widened at the sight of the manastones.

Perrian chuckled at his reaction.

"These are manastones created through necromancy."

Treating them like treasures, Perrian took out a handkerchief and reached into the vault.

He retrieved a manastone from its depths.

"The amount of mana..."

The mere presence of the manastone emanated an overwhelming aura.

It was just a manastone, but its power surpassed even the finest quality stones.

The amount of mana was unbelievable.

Ian couldn't trust his eyes.

It was more mana than even a royal wizard would have.

This level of mana is enough to use high-level magic, usually reserved for great wizards.

Ian was speechless.

Perrian laughed at Ian's dumbfounded expression.

"Now you see. This is the result of dabbling in necromancy."

Perrian put the manastone back in the vault.

"What happens if other nobles or the emperor himself finds out? With these powerful manastones, the Astria family is untouchable."

Seeing the manastones, Ian understood what Perrian meant.

If used properly, these manastones could obliterate a city in no time.

In other words, the Astria family could destroy the empire if provoked.

"We only have two of this level for now, but given time, we'll be beyond reach."

Perrian smiled.

Ian's expression hardened.

"Why go to the lengths of creating such dangerous items? The Astria family already possesses great power. Such risky items are..."

If these manastones were used not in a border city but in the capital's heart...

They could obliterate the capital itself.

The problem was that these manastones were not produced by the Astria family but by necromancers.

The Astria family could very well become victims of their own creation.

"Tsk..."

Ian's words made Perrian click his tongue.

"Are you content with the Astria family's power? My son?"

"What... are you saying?"

"You're thinking too small. It's shameful to call you my son."

Perrian pointed upwards.

"The Astria family can ascend even higher. We are a family capable of using space magic, said to be wielded only by gods. Why should we remain under a powerless emperor?"

"Father?"

"Do you not understand why I entrusted you with the family's affairs?"

Perrian was still fit to be the head of the family.

He had no reason to retire, neither in age nor health.

"I will become the emperor."

He had been preparing in the Astria territory.

Preparing for a revolution...

"Then, the rebels..."

Ian's words made Perrian click his tongue again.

"They are irrelevant. I only recently learned that some of the necromancers were rebel leaders. Our prestigious family would never align with such insignificant beings."

Perrian dusted off his handkerchief and put it away.

"Now go. Do not interfere with your father's work."

Ian just stood there even after Perrian had left.

He just stared at the vault containing the manastones

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 182: Direction (2)

In the Academy's vice-principal office, Cromwell sat reviewing exam questions.

Usually, one professor does not review another's exam questions.

It's seen as overstepping and disrespectful, even if a professor might make a mistake.

However, Gracie was having her questions reviewed by Cromwell.

"What's going on here..."

Cromwell never intended to review the questions.

It started when Cromwell was compiling the exam papers from various professors.

One question, previously set by Cromwell himself last year, caught his eye.

It was so familiar that he recognized it at a glance.

This prompted Cromwell to review other questions.

"I asked for questions, not for copying..."

"I'm sorry... so sorry,"

Gracie apologized repeatedly, looking distressed.

Cromwell sighed, unable to be harsh with such an apology.

He realized his own fault too.

"I was too harsh on a new professor..."

Cromwell knew Gracie, so he didn't treat her like a new professor.

Though she often complained and seemed clumsy, she handled her tasks well, feeling like a veteran professor.

"It's my mistake..."

Cromwell had given too much responsibility to a new professor.

Even someone as resilient as Gracie could break down.

Cromwell skimmed through the questions and laid the exam paper on the desk.

"Is the midterm in 3 days?"

"Yes... I'll redo the questions in these 3 days!"

"No, there's no time to redo and prepare the exam papers. We can't afford that."

Gracie looked despondent.

"I'm sorry... I'll take responsibility."

"Take responsibility?"

"I'll... resign from my professorship."

"What?"

Cromwell stood up abruptly.

"No, Gracie! You did nothing wrong! It's my fault for overburdening you. I'll take responsibility."

"No, it's my fault. I should be punished..."

"No!"

Cromwell was firm.

If Gracie was punished, she wouldn't be able to teach for a while, which was unacceptable.

"I'll take responsibility. We'll use these questions."

"What?"

"These copied questions are from McGuire and Robert. If we don't raise the issue of plagiarism, it can be overlooked. Many professors set similar questions, so it won't become a serious problem."

Cromwell organized the papers in front of him.

"Let's drop this matter. I said I'll take responsibility."

Gracie was moved by Cromwell's stance, yet she had her doubts.

Why was Cromwell reacting this way, not even scolding her?

'Gracie is a slave... no, a talent that can't be easily let go.'

Gracie didn't know Cromwell's thoughts and was just grateful he was protecting her.

On the day of the midterm exams, I slowly walked towards the classroom.

The hallway was bustling with students.

Usually, there's a palpable tension in the air on exam day, but today it seemed unusually relaxed.

Perhaps because midterms aren't as pressure-packed as final exams, even my classmates and I feel more at ease.

Yesterday, we all gathered for a last-minute study session.

Using the study guides I had, we quizzed each other as a final review.

Even Luna and Rie seemed more light-hearted than usual, though there was some nervousness, likely due to the upcoming joint assessments rather than the midterms.

"I just want to get this over with and focus on training,"

I muttered to myself as I continued towards the classroom.

"Hey, you're here?"

Rie greeted me as I entered.

"Looks like we're in the same exam room, huh?"

"Yeah, it's the first time we're taking an exam in the same classroom,"

Rie replied with a bright smile.

"You seem well-rested. Did you sleep okay?"

"There was no reason I wouldn't. I've pretty much finished studying, and I wasn't worried. I'm feeling so confident I might even nab the top spot."

Rie said with a shrug, her playful tone lightening my mood.

"Everyone, start wrapping up your preparations. The exam starts in 10 minutes,"

Announced a professor at the front of the room.

"Yeah, good luck with your exam."

"You too, don't let me steal the top spot from you."

Rie said before heading back to her seat.

A little while later, the professor said,

"Alright, let's start the exam."

We received our papers and started to read through the questions.

"...?"

While reading, I came across a question that was eerily familiar.

No, it was identical to one we had reviewed the night before.

Initially, I thought it might just be a similar question, but even the choices were the same.

Perplexed, I looked up and caught Rie's eye.

She seemed to have noticed something odd as well.

"Please, no looking around. It's exam time."

"Oh, right... Sorry."

We both murmured and returned to our papers.

Seeing Rie's reaction confirmed my suspicion that something was off.

I quickly scanned through the exam.

To my astonishment, several questions from our study guide were on the test.

This was bizarre.

Was this some kind of dream?

I pinched my cheek.

Despite the pain, the situation remained unchanged.

Well, there was nothing else to do but solve the problems.

Though I wondered what the professors were thinking in setting such questions, I couldn't help but chuckle.

The only issue was that I wasn't the only one who had seen the study guide.

Could such an exam really differentiate students' abilities?

While I was concerned, all I could do was my best.

The day after the exams, I found myself staring intently at an apology notice pinned to the bulletin board.

"I knew it would come to this..."

After discussing with Luna and Rie post-exam, we were convinced that the exam was a mess.

Upon revisiting the study guide, we realized that the choices in the exam questions matched those in the guide.

Eventually, Cromwell had to issue an apology to the students.

The notice was filled with odd phrases about the lack of communication and misunderstandings, but in summary, it all boiled down to Gracie's mistake.

Many professors were out on business, and Gracie had ended up shouldering their burden.

My gaze drifted from the apology notice to the adjacent board.

There, the students' rankings were listed.

[1. Rudy Astria 1. Rie Von Ristonia 1. Luna Railer

The day after the exam, I was staring at the list of top scorers, still in disbelief.

"There were 38 perfect scorers."

It seemed that everyone who had the study guide ended up tying for first place.

"This is ridiculous..."

"I know, right..."

"What's this?"

Startled by the sudden voice, I turned around to find Yuni standing behind me, hands clasped behind her back.

"Senior, hello?"

"You scared me there."

"I did make some noise coming here. You just didn't notice because you were so focused in your thoughts,"

Yuni said, raising her hands in a gesture of innocence while smiling.

"Anyway, this is a real mess, isn't it?"

Yuni commented, pointing to the second-year rankings.

"Indeed... it's a complete mess."

I continued to gaze at the rankings.

"Huh?"

Something struck me as odd.

A name that should have been there was missing.

Evan's name.

Among those who had tied for first place, I couldn't find Evan's name anywhere.

I widened my eyes and scanned the rankings.

[41. Evan]

Lowering my gaze, I finally saw Evan's name.

"Hmm..."

Evan was in a low position.

Seeing this ranking made me feel uneasy.

Should I be happy about this?

Many had benefited from having the guide, but it had caused others to suffer.

I had been lucky to avoid this fate, but my name could easily have been in that lower position.

'Luck is part of skill,' they say, but this type of luck didn't feel very satisfying.

"The joint assessment is going to be a battlefield..."

Cromwell's apology hinted that the joint assessment would be more challenging to offset the skewed midterm results.

It meant that even if there was a significant difference in the midterm rankings, it could be overturned in the joint assessment.

"The joint assessment is going to be even more intense. Still, I bet I'll win."

Yuni said confidently.

"Are you sure you can win?"

The joint assessment is an activity involving both first and second years.

With the second-year rankings in disarray, it was clear there would be a desperate struggle.

In such a fierce battle, it's the first years who stand to lose the most.

Who knows what the second years might do to earn points in the joint assessment.

They might target the first years.

The format of the joint assessment hadn't been announced yet, but it was clear that the first years were feeling uneasy.

However, Yuni didn't seem particularly bothered.

"Actually, I'm starting special training with Professor Gracie today."

"Is Professor Gracie even in the right state of mind for that?"

After all the chaos of the exam...

"Professor Cromwell told her to lay low for a while. So, she's using the time to help me with my magic."

That made sense.

Gracie wouldn't have been able to handle this situation alone.

Cromwell stepping in gave her some breathing space.

I nodded.

"Alright, then. Let's give it our all in the joint assessment."

"Sure, good luck, senior."

Yuni said and walked away.

I was about to head off for my own training.

"Hmm..."

Before leaving, I glanced back at the list again and looked at Evan's name.

Winning this way didn't feel right.

But there's still a chance to compete fairly in the joint assessment.

Still, there was a lingering bitterness in my mouth.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 183: Direction (3)

[Joint Assessment for 1st and 2nd Year Students]

The assessment is primarily individual.

However, the actions to be taken during the assessment are not specified.

The duration is three days and two nights, held in the Gotrin Mountains.

Individuals can earn points through combat in the mountains, and these points determine their ranking.

There are two ways to gain points: incapacitate another student in combat or capture magical beasts in the mountains.

Points are assigned based on the strength of the beasts, and scores are awarded according to contribution.

If a student incapacitates another, they can earn points proportional to that student's individual assessment rank and the points that student had earned.

If a 2nd-year student incapacitates a 1st-year student, they can only earn half of the points the 1st-year student had.

Once a student is incapacitated, they cannot participate further and their score is finalized.

Yeniel looked over these rules.

"It seems well thought out."

Everyone was paying attention to how the assessment would be conducted, as the 2nd-year midterms lacked differentiation.

This method would satisfy most.

The 2nd years also had the penalty of only receiving half the points for attacking 1st years, and the individual format would increase differentiation in the assessment.

Yeniel reviewed the other rules and came to a conclusion.

"It's practically saying to cooperate..."

Points are distributed based on contribution when capturing magical beasts.

Acting alone is less beneficial.

While solo action might seem advantageous, to score high in this assessment, one must cooperate with others.

Hunting magical beasts together may not yield high scores in the short term, but it's more efficient in the long run.

When hunting alone, it's inevitable to encounter other students.

In such cases, if the opponent has a team, you might face a one-against-many battle.

Defeat in such a situation essentially means the end.

No matter how many points you earn from beasts, you're just giving them away to others.

Considering all these aspects, forming a team early in the assessment is crucial for success.

It ensures safety.

If someone is alone by the mid-phase, they become prey for other teams.

From a team's perspective, the likelihood of accepting a lone individual into the team mid-way is low.

It's hard to tell if a person who didn't form a team early on betrayed their own team or has been hunting others.

Moreover, it might be more advantageous to capture an individual and gain points than to accept them into the team.

There were several strategies to secure the first place in the assessment.

However, these were not strategies just anyone could implement.

They required either special abilities or overwhelming power.

Such methods of victory were reserved for exceptional individuals, not something an ordinary person could achieve.

"If someone could do it..."

Two people immediately came to mind.

Rudy Astria and Evan.

They were exceptional cases.

Predicting their actions was nearly impossible.

Especially with Evan's current state, which was concerning.

The last time they spoke, he seemed as lost as a navigator without the North Star, clearly unsettled.

But there was nothing Yeniel could do about it.

Although she was concerned about Evan, Yeniel doubted that she could bring about a change.

A few words from Yeniel were unlikely to change Evan.

People don't change that easily.

Evan needed to experience and feel things himself before he could change.

"Setting Evan aside for now,"

Yeniel mused.

"What should I do?"

This time, even Yeniel was particularly focused on their performance.

McDowell, the principal, had instructed her to bring back good results, and Yeniel intended to follow through.

If possible, even aiming for the top spot.

"Interesting."

I was looking over the rules for the joint assessment.

"At least this time we don't have to fight each other! We just have to catch all the magical beasts!"

Luna said cheerfully beside me.

"It would be great if it were as Luna says..."

But that was unlikely.

Defeating people would be more beneficial for gaining points, but when considering overall rankings, reducing the number of competitors was more effective.

In fact, defeating people could be more advantageous for increasing points.

Towards the latter half, catching a weak player who has accumulated points from beasts could yield higher scores compared to fighting.

"Luna! Shall we decide where to meet up? Let's get together and catch a ton of beasts!"

"Should we?"

Still, I was relieved that I wouldn't have to fight people I knew.

There was no reason to confront Rie or Luna.

Both Rie and Luna were high-ranking, and I felt uncomfortable facing them.

With these rules, there was no need to fight Luna or Rie.

"Then let's tell Rie too! Decide on a place to meet! And tell other people!"

"Don't gather too many."

Luna was excitedly making plans, which made me anxious.

It felt like we were deciding who to take on a picnic...

"Of course! I'll only tell people we know!"

"Alright..."

Although I felt uneasy, I couldn't afford to worry about that.

I had other things to do.

"Firstly..."

I fiddled with the booklet distributed by the academy.

It was a beast encyclopedia.

It detailed what beasts would appear in the joint assessment, their characteristics, and how many points they were worth.

My task was to figure out which beasts would be the most efficient to catch.

Catching people might be good, but I didn't particularly want to do that.

Unless they were causing harm to me or others, I didn't want to attack people who were living peacefully.

"Well, I guess I should get going."

"Huh? Going where?"

"I can't keep standing in front of the bulletin board."

"Right..."

"I'm going to my room now to train and study the beasts."

As I said that, Luna made a peculiar face.

It was an expression mixed with dissatisfaction.

I looked at Luna, tilting my head in confusion.

"Is something wrong?"

"Well... Rudy?"

"Hmm?"

"Rie and you... everything's fine recently?"

Luna looked anxious, fidgeting with her fingers.

It was an obvious question.

I smiled at Luna.

"There were... some issues?"

"There were?"

Luna's eyes widened in surprise.

"What happened?"

"Just rolling around here and there with each other..."

I said in a playful tone.

"Rolled around?"

Luna mumbled quietly to herself in disbelief, "That's impossible," and "Now that I think about it, last time too..."

"Rudy..."

Seeing Luna's pout, I couldn't help but laugh playfully.

"Just kidding. We've been struggling a bit with magic-related stuff recently."

"Magic?"

"Yeah, Rie and I were discussing teleportation magic. We had some disagreements, so things got a bit heated."

Hearing this, Luna scrunched up her nose.

"Rudy!"

"Why are you asking such a question? You trying to slyly probe was the naughty part here."

Luna pouted her lips at my remark.

"So, nothing really happened then?"

"You know how busy we've been lately. What could have happened?"

"But, what was that about?"

"What?"

"When Rie asked you to hug her during the individual assessment. It seemed too natural. Almost like you've hugged her before..."

A twinge of guilt hit me at her words.

Is a woman's intuition really this scary?

I laughed awkwardly.

"Did it?"

"Hmm... never mind then."

Although Luna looked suspicious, she let it go.

"Anyway! I'm still trying to win you over, Rudy! You know that, right?"

"Win me over?"

That was something from when we went to the Railer territory.

It was only supposed to last until we returned from the Railer territory.

Honestly, I hadn't taken those half-joking words too seriously.

"It didn't end when we returned to the academy?"

"It's overtime. It didn't end back then."

So it's overtime until she succeeds?

Practically like an endless rain dance until it rains.

But it didn't really matter to me.

It wasn't uncomfortable, and her antics were actually amusing.

"Alright, give it your best shot."

"But! If you start liking me too much, you have to tell me, okay?"

I laughed at her silly statement.

"Got it. You should head back and train too."

"Okay! See you tomorrow!"

I waved at Luna as I headed to the dormitory.

Entering my room, I opened the booklet containing the names of the beasts.

I had skimmed through the booklet as soon as I received it.

There were beasts I recognized from our Magical Beast Studies class and some I had never seen before.

I flipped through the book to its last section.

The beast listed at the end.

Beside its name, several red warning notes were written.

"It feels like this one will just pop up near the end..."

It was typical for a creature with such warnings to make an appearance.

I smiled.

"This is going to be interesting."

The name of the beast at the very end of the book.

It was the Red Dragon Hatchling.

So, there were two goals for the joint practical.

The highest scorers in both categories.

Catching the Red Dragon Hatchling among the beasts.

And catching Evan among the students.

That was my plan.

Chapter 184: Direction (4)

Dozens of students were standing in the auditorium, huddled together and chatting.

As each name was called, one by one, they left the auditorium.

"Let's meet there then."

"Okay! You have to come there at least on the second night!"

"The seniors might just leave, but not us."

"If we can't make it, we can't. Anyway, we'll have to gather on the third day whether we like it or not."

Like the others, we were gathered and chatting.

Starting with Luna and Rie, then Kuhn and Emily, and Locke.

And then.

"When will I ever be invited to such a grand gathering?"

"You could make it if you try, Riku. Stop playing around."

Ena and Riku too.

It seemed like everyone we knew was invited.

I wondered if we had gathered too many people, but based on what we learned about the Red Dragon, it seemed we wouldn't have too many, only perhaps too few.

The Red Dragon was not an opponent to be taken lightly.

It would take all of us, including Astina, to stand a chance.

Even then, it wasn't a guarantee of victory.

Regardless of being a Hatchling... the offspring of a Red Dragon, its majesty was undiminished.

A dragon's skin can deflect all magic and blades, and the breath it emits can burn down mountains.

Even if it's just a Hatchling, it could still unleash half of that power.

But that didn't matter much.

If you know your enemy and yourself, you will never be defeated.

I had thought about myself and those around me, and diligently researched the dragon.

I had even devised a plan.

I wasn't sure how it would turn out, but it was a plan with a good chance of success.

I smiled and looked around.

Then I noticed someone who was usually there was missing.

"By the way, isn't Yuni participating?"

It was unlikely that Luna hadn't asked Yuni.

Yet, she was nowhere to be seen.

"Ah, Yuni said she'd observe the situation and decide. She said it's hard to give a sure answer."

Was it because I was part of this group?

I thought that shouldn't matter.

After all, we were competing based on our academic year and rank.

I turned to look at Rie.

"Is Yuni not feeling well...?"

"She seems fine. And she wouldn't get nervous over something like this. It's an event that lasts for days without an audience."

Rie shrugged her shoulders.

Indeed, if she wasn't feeling well, she'd be more inclined to join, having supportive people around her.

Then what was the reason?

Just then, the announcer's voice rang out.

"Yuni Von Ristonia, please board the carriage."

"How can I achieve first place?"

Yuni had pondered this deeply.

Her skills were certainly exceptional.

Armed with the theories learned in the lab and the lightning magic taught by Gracie, she felt confident against any first-year student.

However, this assessment was such that even with outstanding skills, one might not secure the top spot.

It required the support of fellow students and a bit of luck.

Among the first-years, she was strong, but if the second-years were included, she would be in the upper-middle tier.

If a powerful second-year targeted Yuni, she would lose.

Not only would she miss the top ranks, but she could also plummet to the very bottom.

In such a case, perhaps it would be better to heed Luna's advice.

That might be a more stable approach.

However, Yuni was not satisfied with this.

In Rudy's group were Kuhn and Emily.

Kuhn, a talent ranking third among the first-years.

If she was in the same team, she might be overshadowed by Kuhn.

To secure the top spot, she had to take a slightly different, albeit riskier, approach.

"Even if I join Luna's group later... I can't start off with them from the beginning."

She needed to earn as many points as possible on her own.

That was the only way to score higher than Kuhn or Diark.

"Now the question is, what should I do from here?"

Yuni gazed up at the sky.

She was in a forest dense with trees.

Even though it was autumn, many trees were still green, interspersed occasionally with trees shedding their autumn leaves.

The scent of fallen leaves and earth enveloped her.

Yuni had arrived at the mountain where the joint assessment was to take place.

Then, a voice from behind spoke.

"Yuni, you may proceed directly to the assessment."

"Ah, yes... I mean, understood."

Yuni initially responded informally before quickly correcting herself.

The staff member smiled at Yuni's cute mistake and boarded the carriage they had arrived in.

Then, the carriage traveled to the mountain.

"How did they make a path through the mountain?"

Yuni looked in wonder at the trail leading up to the mountainside.

Trees had been cut to create a neat pathway.

"This isn't the time to worry about that."

Yuni shook her head.

The first-years had arrived at the mountain earlier than the second-years.

Limited carriages and the inability to teleport all students to the mountain at once meant that the disadvantaged first-years started the evaluation first.

With no second-years around, she had to earn as many points as possible.

Rustle—

At that moment, a sound came from the bushes in front of Yuni.

She quickly turned her head towards the sound.

"A magical beast?"

Yuni watched the bushes warily, a look of surprise on her face.

Then, a small creature burst through the undergrowth.

"...A rabbit?"

A rabbit with fluffy fur appeared.

Yuni gazed impassively at the rabbit.

Then, she manipulated her mana.

Crackle—

Static electricity formed around her head.

"There shouldn't be a rabbit like this in such a place."

The rabbit was actually a 'White Rabbit,' a type of magical beast.

It was clearly listed in the Bestiary.

This mountain was home to numerous magical beasts.

A mere rabbit couldn't survive here.

The White Rabbit's eyes turned red.

Its fur bristled, revealing sharp teeth and claws.

"Grrrr..."

"Spark."

Yuni used her magic, and small electric currents shot out from her hand.

“Squeak!”

The White Rabbit dodged Yuni's magic by rolling away.

Seizing the opportunity created by the White Rabbit's dodge, Yuni used another spell.

"Fire Ball."

“Eek!”

The Fire Ball hit the White Rabbit.

Small flames clung to its body, and it rolled on the ground.

However, it didn't collapse completely.

Despite being hit by the Fire Ball, the White Rabbit got back up.

“Squeal...! Squeak!!!”

But it didn't continue the fight.

Making strange noises, the White Rabbit quickly began to flee.

‘Did I use too weak a spell?’

Choosing the Fire Ball was a decision to conserve mana, considering the 3-day duration in the mountains.

However, it was Yuni's mistake to allow it to escape.

‘Should I chase it?’

Each of these magical creatures represented points, so she needed to defeat them.

Yuni moved to chase the fleeing White Rabbit.

But she didn't need to go far.

Rustle—

“...?”

She had just started chasing when she heard noises from the surrounding bushes.

Rustle— Rustle— Rustle—

It wasn't just one or two.

White rabbits with white fur started to emerge from the bushes.

That's when Yuni realized.

White Rabbit: Not very strong individually but highly reproductive.

Hunts in groups.

Requires caution when faced alone.

Those were the words from the Bestiary.

Dozens of White Rabbits surrounded Yuni.

“Grrr... Grrr...”

The White Rabbits made strange noises, as if mocking Yuni.

“...Hmm.”

Yuni looked around nonchalantly and then smirked.

“Missing one score brought many more at once? Is this the ‘blessing in disguise’ Rudy talked about?”

Yuni waved her hand in the air.

Strong static electricity formed around her, gathering in her hand.

With a satisfied smile, Yuni said,

“Chain Lightning.”

After arriving at the mountain, I looked around.

Surprisingly, the surroundings were quiet.

Unusually quiet.

Firstly, I scanned the area.

I needed to decide quickly where to move.

This evaluation was to last for three days and two nights.

During this time, I would have to camp in the mountains.

And that too, under the threat of enemies lurking around...

Surely there were those planning to earn points through surprise attacks.

For some, it was more advantageous to face people than magical beasts.

Take Yeniel, for example.

Having lived the life of an assassin, Yeniel would likely opt for such a tactic.

Therefore, finding a base was essential.

A place where I could easily protect myself at night.

A cave would be good, or even an open area.

I was confident in a fair fight, no matter the opponent.

“More importantly...”

I looked up at the trees around me.

I could feel manas moving above the trees.

Were the instructors monitoring?

I didn't notice it in my first year, but lately, I've become more sensitive to mana.

It made sense, considering even a Red Dragon Hatchling could appear.

If even one student were to lose their life, it would cause an uproar...

Lost in these thoughts, I was about to move when I heard it.

“...Rudy Astria.”

I heard my name being called.

A man appeared before me.

“...Who are you?”

I looked puzzled at the unfamiliar man.

It was absurd that someone I didn't know was calling my name as if waiting for me.

“I'm Rockefeller, the eldest son of the Count of Tronia!”

The man proudly declared his lineage.

But even with his declaration, I didn't recognize him.

How could I remember every student in the Academy?

I had trouble remembering the names of those helping the student council.

“So what? Is this some kind of introduction?”

I frowned and spoke.

“Well... Ah...! Fine, let's assume that.”

Rockefeller, as he introduced himself, extended his hand toward me.

“Join our team, Rudy Astria.”

“...What?”

“You know it's advantageous to form teams with people nearby, right?”

Hearing this, I understood the situation.

I guessed why it had been so quiet around.

“If I don't join your team?”

Rockefeller smiled as if he had anticipated my response.

“Then we'll have to take your points.”

As he spoke, I felt mana around us.

Some of the manas I had felt earlier flickered.

It seemed odd that there was so much mana, but it appeared that many were lying in ambush.

“Being the second-ranked in the individual evaluation... your points must be quite valuable.”

“Ah...”

They were waiting where the carriages dropped us off, planning to ambush anyone who wouldn't join their team.

The carriage route into the mountain was limited.

So, waiting at that spot meant they could ambush students without a team.

They had found a loophole in the rules.

It was ridiculous.

"Hey, I have a question."

"...What?"

"What were you thinking, waiting until the last to be here? You knew who would be on the last carriage, didn't you?"

The last to leave the Academy.

That included me, Evan, Rie, and others among the top second-year students.

"Do you really think you stand a chance?"

If it were a battle among the top-ranked students, maybe.

But not a single one of us would fall to these small fry.

"Instead of scheming like this, you should have hunted more magical beasts."

I manipulated my mana.

"Or, you should have ambushed without talking."

As I said this, the guy started to backpedal.

Then he shouted.

"Everybody, attack!"

"Too late, idiot."

I channeled mana into my feet and stomped on the ground.

In an instant, I reached Rockefeller.

"Starting with you, then?"

I smiled and raised my hand.

The mana stone on my glove twinkled.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 185: Direction (5)

"Sigh..."

I took a moment to catch my breath and looked around.

About a dozen people lay defeated on the ground.

Had I started off too leniently?

More attacked me than I had anticipated.

Some of them were quite skilled.

I tried to conserve my strength as much as possible.

It was early in the assessment, so I couldn't afford to use too much power.

As a result, small wounds appeared on my arms and legs.

That was the cost of minimizing mana use.

'I'm not sure if this is an advantage...'

,

These injuries wouldn't hinder my fighting, though.

There was no problem moving my arms or legs, and I wasn't bleeding much.

The real issue was something else.

I had spent too much time dealing with them.

Although I had earned a decent score, the sun was beginning to set.

Without a proper team and staying up all night in this situation, my mana, physical, and mental strength would surely not recover, a definite problem for tomorrow.

To avoid impairing my ability in tomorrow's battle, I needed to quickly establish a base.

'The problem is where to find such a place...'

Without further delay, I started moving.

'My clothes are all dirty now.'

Yuni frowned and dusted off her clothes.

They were grimy from extensive use of magic.

"Ouch!"

Pain struck while she was dusting, causing her to yelp.

She hadn't noticed during the fight, but there was a wound on her left forearm.

It wasn't bleeding profusely, so she left it as it was for now.

'More than that, it's so uncomfortable.'

Sweat had soaked her back from the intense movement.

After some thought, Yuni reached a decision.

'Maybe I should look for a stream?'

Having earned a substantial score, she shifted her focus to survival.

She needed to find food and water.

The best places for that were valleys or streams.

As a user of lightning magic, Yuni could easily secure food with a single spell at a stream.

Besides, she could also take the chance to wash up, making the stream an ideal destination.

Yuni slowly started walking.

'If things keep going like this, it'll be pretty good.'

But she couldn't let her guard down.

The nature of this assessment allowed for comebacks in the latter half.

If one aimed for the top spot and accumulated enough points, even a large gap could be overturned.

Or, the scores of those in lower ranks could combine to surpass the first place.

Given the mountain's vast size and the risks involved in fighting, people would likely avoid each other, but she couldn't completely rule out encounters.

'I need a big enough lead so that even if the lower ranks all start grouping, it won't matter.'

This was why Yuni had said she wouldn't join any groups.

Being in a group would limit the increase in points.

And with Rudy's group having strong members, it was disadvantageous for Yuni to be in a group, especially when capturing magical beasts, as points were awarded based on contribution.

While she pondered this, she gradually heard the sound of running water.

She had already checked the map of the mountain, so finding key locations like a valley wasn't difficult.

Pushing through the bushes towards the valley, she noticed something.

"Hmm?"

There was a figure by the stream.

A woman was bent over, drinking water.

'An enemy?'

There was no one else around.

That meant she was alone.

She didn't seem alert, probably not having noticed Yuni yet.

Yuni began to channel her mana.

"Ah..."

Just then, the woman finished drinking and straightened up.

Yuni stopped channeling her mana and spoke out.

"...Emily?"

"Huh?"

It was Emily, Kuhn's girlfriend.

Startled by the sudden noise, Emily looked in Yuni's direction.

"It's Yuni!"

Emily got up excitedly, a smile on her face.

Yuni lowered her hand, which was ready to cast a spell, and opened her mouth to speak.

"Drinking water so carelessly, what if someone attacked you?"

"Ah... I was just really thirsty and drank in a hurry."

Emily smiled awkwardly.

They had been together in Gracie's lab, but they weren't particularly close.

Yuni, by nature, didn't approach people she wasn't interested in.

Emily was aware of this.

Yet, Yuni's words seemed almost concerned, which puzzled Emily a bit.

Yuni emerged from the bushes.

"Oh? Yuni, did you come from a fight?"

Emily's eyes widened upon seeing Yuni's disheveled clothes.

"Yeah, ran into a pack of rabbits."

Emily hurried over to Yuni.

"Are you hurt anywhere?"

She began inspecting Yuni's body for injuries.

"Ah."

Emily suddenly realized her actions might be too forward.

Normally, she took care of her friends, and in this unfamiliar environment, seeing Yuni brought relief, making her to act as she usually did with her friends.

"Sorry, sorry."

Emily stopped and stepped back.

"Why are you apologizing?"

Yuni tilted her head, puzzled by Emily's behavior.

"Well, it's just that..."

Emily gestured awkwardly with her hands.

She didn't want to seem too friendly suddenly, fearing it might be perceived as an act for the assessment.

Unaware of Emily's thoughts, Yuni raised her arm, revealing a blood-stained sleeve on her forearm.

"I got hurt here."

"Oh...?"

"You know healing magic, right?"

Emily was surprised that Yuni, who had barely remembered her name and face after a week in the lab, knew she could use healing magic.

"Okay, got it."

Emily approached Yuni cautiously and examined the wound.

It wasn't too severe, but if left untreated, it could scar.

"Just a moment..."

Emily opened her bag, strapped around her waist.

"I can't heal it completely, but I'll make sure it doesn't get worse."

She took out antiseptic and a white cloth.

Then, she led Yuni to the stream.

"Let's wash it with water first."

To remove any dirt or debris, they rinsed the wound with water before Emily sprinkled some antiseptic on the cloth.

"This might sting a bit."

"Ow...!"

As Emily applied the cloth to the wound, Yuni grimaced.

After cleaning the wound, Emily began to channel her mana.

Mana gathered in her hands and she placed them over Yuni's injury.

Yuni relaxed her face, feeling the warmth of Emily's mana.

"Healing."

A greenish glow circled around Emily's hands.

The wound that hadn't properly clotted began to heal gradually.

While it didn't completely disappear, the throbbing pain subsided.

Yuni looked at her wound curiously and moved her arm around.

"It doesn't hurt?"

"Yeah, for now I've only managed to stop the bleeding and alleviate the pain. I'm still not skilled enough to completely heal it..."

"How do you do it?"

"Huh?"

Yuni looked at her with curious eyes.

Emily, a bit flustered, slowly began to explain.

"Well... healing magic works through the control of mana... You can do it to..."

"Really?"

Yuni nodded in satisfaction.

"Thanks, really."

"Oh, no need to thank me! That's what friends are for."

Yuni, without much reaction, walked towards the stream and bent down to drink some water.

Emily watched her, somewhat baffled.

It was their first time being together like this, and it felt awkward yet unexpectedly kind compared to their usual interactions.

After drinking, Yuni took a handkerchief from her pocket and wiped her mouth.

"By the way, where's Kuhn?"

"Huh? Kuhn?"

"You're always with Kuhn, right?"

"Oh... I haven't met him yet today. I was planning to stay low and then quickly head towards the summit."

"The summit?"

Yuni put the handkerchief back into her pocket.

"Yeah. We planned to meet with Luna and Rie at the 'Big Boss Rock.' You know, that huge rock at the top."

"Big Boss Rock?"

"Yeah, that big rock up there at the peak is called 'Big Boss Rock.' That's where we decided to meet."

Yuni frowned as she looked at the rock Emily was pointing to.

It was the same rock she had used to orient herself when she arrived here.

"Such a name..."

Yuni commented and then stood up.

"Then let's stick together."

"Huh? You mean you'll come with me?"

Emily recalled what Luna had said.

Yuni had declined the invitation to join them, saying she preferred not to come.

"So you've changed your mind?"

"No, I'm not going to join. It's just that it's dangerous at night, so let's stick together."

Emily's eyes widened at Yuni's proposal.

"You mean you'll protect me?"

At Emily's words, Yuni wrinkled her nose.

"No, it's just more efficient if we're together."

Emily smiled at Yuni's response.

Being with someone like Yuni would be better than being alone.

Emily wasn't fast or particularly strong in combat, so it was a nice offer.

"Alright, then shall we look for a place to stay?"

Emily spoke with a voice full of cheer.

Yuni and Emily managed to find a shelter before sunset, settling in a small cave near the valley.

As the twilight set in, Yuni placed the fish she had caught on the ground.

"Here, I've brought some fish."

"Thanks, Yuni! I've also started a fire."

Emily had gathered fallen leaves from around and made a small campfire near the cave, which was quite compact.

Yuni looked at the fire, then around them, with a puzzled expression.

"Is something wrong?"

"No, it's just that I've been hearing sounds of a fight since a while ago."

"Sounds of a fight?"

Indeed, there had been faint noises, but they seemed distant, so Emily hadn't paid much attention.

"It sounds like it's getting closer."

"Should we put out the fire?"

Crack—

Suddenly, a loud crashing sound echoed nearby, like a tree breaking.

It was quite close.

Thud—

"Aaah...!"

A scream followed.

"What's that?"

Yuni quickly gestured with her hand, signaling to stay still.

'What's happening?'

She glanced back at the fire.

"We should run."

Though leaving their shelter felt regrettable, it felt like the right decision.

"The fire...?"

"Leave it..."

Thud— Thud—

The sound of heavy footsteps approached rapidly, making a thunderous noise.

Then.

Bang—

Two figures burst out from between the valley and the forest, one seemingly chasing the other with a sword.

"Ah..."

Bang—!

The pursued figure slammed against the valley wall, kicking up a cloud of dust.

The other landed gracefully in the valley.

Yuni and Emily watched the scene in shock.

The identity of the person who hit the wall was obscured by dust, but the other's face was clear.

A man with black hair, wielding a sword, surrounded by a greenish glow.

Instantly, Yuni and Emily recognized him.

"Evan..."

The person standing boldly, having pushed the other away, was none other than the top student of the second year.

It was Evan.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 186: Direction (6)

It felt hollow.

His eyes were focused, yet there was an emptiness within.

Yuni clenched her teeth hard.

'If I fight, I lose.'

It was an obvious fact.

Even in perfect condition, defeating Evan was impossible.

She pondered if it might be possible to escape by using up all her mana.

"Yuni Von Ristonia... Emily... is it?"

Evan looked at the two and spoke.

Emily's eyes widened, surprised that Evan knew her name.

"How..."

She wasn't a celebrity at the academy, yet he knew her name.

It would have been one thing if he had just said her name, but his hollow eyes while speaking it sent chills down her spine.

"Ugh..."

Just then, a person who had been smashed against the valley wall began to rise.

Extracting himself from the embedded wall, he slowly walked out.

It was Diark.

With a grimace, blood trickled down from his head.

Diark, wiping the blood from his forehead, looked towards Yuni.

"Yuni... right?"

"Yes."

Yuni looked back at Diark.

His clothes were torn, and there was a large sword wound on his stomach.

In contrast, Evan was without a single scratch.

Her fleeting hope of possibly escaping was diminishing.

Even after such a fierce fight, Diark hadn't managed to inflict even a scratch on Evan.

Yuni thought about how to escape this situation.

But Evan gave no opportunity.

He raised his sword, and green lights from the surrounding trees began to converge.

Yuni quickly made a decision.

"Emily, heal Diark!"

"What? Uh?"

Crack—

Yuni activated her mana.

With Diark and Emily injured, they stood no chance against Evan.

There was no way to create an opportunity to escape.

Yet, she confronted Evan.

"Spark!"

Yuni launched several small currents at Evan.

"No!"

Diark shouted at that moment.

"If you use magic directly..."

Yuni didn't respond and continued her magic, charging towards Evan.

Her plan was to attack first, as electric magic was not good defensively.

"Hmm..."

Evan deflected the approaching currents with his sword.

'Done...'

Yuni inwardly smiled.

He couldn't deflect the current with his sword.

If the current touched the sword, it would travel through it, paralyzing him.

Yuni maneuvered her mana as she watched.

But Evan was not so easily overcome.

After deflecting Yuni's Spark, he quickly charged towards her.

"Ah...?"

He wasn't paralyzed.

Evan's characteristic.

Magic nullification.

A skill that nullified all magic.

Yuni was unaware of Evan's ability.

She didn't know that Evan's sword could not just block mana but completely obliterate it.

As Evan approached Yuni, he lifted his leg.

"Weak."

His raised leg glowed green as he struck Yuni squarely in the abdomen.

"Ugh...!"

Bang!!!

Yuni was kicked away by Evan, flying off into the distance.

"Yu, Yuni!!!"

Emily cried out in alarm.

Diark then grabbed Emily's wrist.

"Focus on healing! I need to step in."

"Ah... ugh... Healing!!!"

Emily nodded at Diark's words and cast her spell.

"Argh..."

Yuni, clutching the area where she was hit, struggled to her feet.

"It hurts..."

Yuni, who had lived a sheltered life, had never experienced such a powerful attack.

It was an excruciating pain that brought tears to her eyes.

Still, she staggered to her feet.

Being kicked was better than being stabbed.

If she had been stabbed by the sword, she wouldn't have been able to get up again.

Yuni clenched her teeth and stood up.

'I can't fall here.'

Despite the pain, she had to move.

She had to respond to her opponent.

It was a desperate situation, and it hurt terribly, but she endured and stood up.

She couldn't just collapse here in vain.

"Yuni Von Ristonia."

Then Diark spoke.

His expression was better than before, probably due to Emily's healing.

Drawing his sword, Diark stepped forward.

"I'll take the front, you follow up with an attack."

There was no talk of forming a team or anything else.

It was obvious that they had to join forces to stand against Evan.

Yuni took a deep breath and looked ahead.

"Got it..."

Evan watched them indifferently.

Then he spoke.

"Next time, I'll make sure you won't get up."

Light leaked from the surrounding trees again.

Green lights gathered, brighter than before.

Crack—

The roots of the nearby trees burst out of the ground.

They moved as if alive.

The roots surrounded Yuni, Diark, and Emily, preventing their escape.

"Uh..."

Even in this desperate situation, Yuni moved her mana.

She tried her best despite the hopelessness.

Diark did the same.

"Here I go."

Diark, infusing his sword with sword aura, charged at Evan.

At the same time, Yuni also activated her mana.

"It won't work."

Evan charged back at Diark, who was rushing towards him.

"Ugh..."

Diark tried to stop his advance when Evan charged back at him.

However, Evan did not slow down.

The sword approached from the front.

Diark raised his own sword to block it.

Evan, seeing Diark raise his sword, swiftly withdrew his.

Then, he ducked and kicked Diark's lower body.

"Ugh...!"

The direct kick to his leg drained its strength, and Diark collapsed to the ground.

'The magic is still...'

Yuni's electric attack flew towards Evan.

Evan smoothly continued his motion, watching the approaching electricity.

He quickly raised his torso and brought his sword to meet the electricity.

"...What?"

As the electricity touched Evan's sword, it disappeared as if it had never existed, leaving no trace behind.

Confirming the magic had vanished, Evan lifted his foot and kicked Diark.

Diark was sent rolling across the ground by Evan's kick.

"...Is it over?"

Evan looked indifferently at Yuni, raising his sword.

The sight of Evan with his sword raised brought an overwhelming sense of intimidation.

Though she knew they wouldn't lose their lives in this assessment, the fear was great.

The thought of potentially losing her life filled her mind.

"Ah..."

Yuni tried to move her mana, but her body wouldn't respond.

Her face paled, and her legs trembled uncontrollably.

As Evan stared at her, he raised his sword high.

'No, this can't be happening.'

The moment that sword comes down...

It's the end.

Right here.

Just as Yuni was paralyzed with despair,

"Hey."

A voice suddenly called out.

It was a familiar voice.

"...?"

Startled by the unexpected voice, Evan stopped his downward strike and turned to the side.

A figure emerged from beside them.

"What are you doing?"

The voice was filled with anger.

A man emerged from the debris of the destroyed trees, walking towards Evan.

"Ha...!"

Evan looked at the man with a mix of wonder and annoyance.

There seemed to be a sense of welcome, mixed with rising anger.

Yuni looked at the suddenly appearing man.

"Se, senior?"

"That's enough of bullying these kids. Didn't I make a rule about that? What are you doing?"

The man, running his hand through his hair, spoke with an air of irritation.

It was Rudy Astria.

"Ha... Haha... Rudy Astria!"

Evan, ignoring Yuni and Diark, pointed his sword at Rudy.

"I've been looking for you."

Evan said, seemingly pleased.

Rudy looked at him with a disbelieving expression.

"If you were looking for me, why involve the others?"

Evan paid no heed to Rudy's words and took a fighting stance.

But Rudy just looked at Evan with disdain, making no move to engage.

"Ru, Rudy."

Yuni spoke, surprised by Rudy's nonchalant attitude.

Then Rudy slightly turned his head and raised his hand slightly.

It was a gesture that seemed to say, 'Don't move.'

"What, what's...?"

"Yuni."

Emily, who was behind her, grabbed Yuni.

Emily brought her index finger to her lips and whispered softly.

"Just do as the senior says..."

"Huh?"

"Look at Rudy."

Following Emily's direction, Yuni saw that Rudy was covered in wounds.

He looked as if he had already been in a fight.

"We can't fight because he's protecting us..."

Yuni muttered to herself.

Then, she thought.

So, he already knew about this situation and came prepared?

What's his plan?

Can he really win with those injuries?

Against such an opponent?

Yuni's mind was a whirl of thoughts.

Seeing Yuni stop her actions, Rudy smiled and looked at Evan.

"So, you found me? Why aren't you attacking?"

"Rudy... Astria!!!"

Evan, with his sword glowing in a green light, charged at Rudy.

Rudy saw Evan rushing towards him and jumped back a considerable distance.

Evan's sword, followed by swirling green lights, chased after Rudy.

And it wasn't just that.

The trees near Rudy started moving, attempting to grab him.

"That's right, come out like this."

Rudy spoke as if he was leisurely, but his expression was strained.

Rudy didn't confront Evan head-on and kept backing away.

Gradually retreating into the forest, he started to disappear from Yuni's sight.

"Yuni, now's the time!"

Emily grabbed Yuni's hand.

"We have to run. Now that Rudy has drawn his attention..."

"..."

Yuni bit her teeth and looked in the direction where Rudy had disappeared.

Then, she pushed Emily's hand away.

"...Yuni?"

"I'm going to follow them."

"Follow them? Yuni, Rudy intentionally distanced himself... If we go now, we'll just be a hindrance..."

"No, there might be something I can do to help."

Yuni started walking forward.

Despite feeling a tremendous sense of helplessness when facing Evan.

Despite being wrapped in fear.

She had to move.

Rudy was risking his injured self to save them.

'If Rudy senior falls back now...'

Then...

"Emily, take him and run."

Yuni pointed at Diark, who was lying on the ground.

"Yu, Yuni!"

Ignoring Emily's call, Yuni, with trembling legs, started running towards the direction Rudy had disappeared into.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 187: Direction (7)

Evan's eyes blazed with fury at the sight of Rudy.

Rudy had appeared out of nowhere, provoking Evan, and now seemed to be taunting him as he fled.

Rudy continuously evaded without even trading blows, always retreating.

Despite the multitude of tree trunks targeting him, Rudy nimbly dodged them, moving swiftly in every direction.

It appeared as though Evan could catch him, but Rudy always managed to escape by a hair's breadth.

This frustrating cycle of near-captures and escapes gradually fueled Evan's anger.

Rational thought gave way to rage.

"Damn it, Rudy Astria... Fight me fair and square!"

Rudy turned towards Evan upon hearing these words, his lips curling in a mocking sneer.

"Rudy Astria!!!"

Evan gritted his teeth in frustration.

He exerted more mana to manipulate the trees, but Rudy, unyielding, broke through the branches and evaded capture.

Evan realized something as he watched Rudy's retreating figure.

'Just chasing him won't end this.'

He shifted his mana, aiming to immobilize Rudy.

The surrounding trees responded to Evan's mana.

'Time for a grand move... targeting the legs.'

Green light radiated from the trees, converging on Evan's sword.

This was Evan's nature magic*, a spell that harnessed the power of nearby trees as a substitute for mana.

He planned to use a spell of immense scale to target Rudy's legs.

As the mana gathered from the trees, a wind blew.

"Huh?"

A sudden breeze, unexpected in the densely wooded mountain.

Even if there was wind, it would only lightly affect the nearby trees.

It was an unnatural wind.

"What's this?"

He doubted Rudy Astria would have cast a spell while fleeing.

Just to be sure, Evan extended his sword into the wind.

If it were magic, his sword should have dissipated it.

But the wind blowing towards Evan persisted.

"It's not magic?"

The wind felt too purposeful to be a natural occurrence, especially since it was blowing solely towards him.

Evan's brow furrowed in confusion.

Rudy was growing more distant, and a strange phenomenon was unfolding before him.

Now wasn't the time to ponder this peculiar breeze.

Evan refocused, attempting to draw energy from the surrounding trees once more.

As the green lights converged towards him, a small red light approached from afar.

It wasn't the green light Evan was gathering, but a red one, tiny in size and moving towards him with an unnatural, undulating motion.

Evan suddenly realized something.

The breeze that kept blowing towards him was carrying a flickering light.

He instinctively knew he shouldn't let this light come closer.

But it was too tiny to interact with using his sword.

As he pondered alone, the undulating red light grew increasingly brighter.

Evan's eyes widened at the sight.

It's going to explode.

He knew it instantly.

He stopped his actions and lifted his sword to shield himself.

The small light intensified in color, its form blurring.

And then, in an instant...

Boom!

It expanded rapidly and exploded.

Strong winds and flames erupted.

"Argh..."

Evan managed to control the extent of the explosion with his sword, a fortunate outcome.

However, the wind caused by the explosion shattered rocks and trees, sending fragments flying.

These fragments pierced Evan's body.

"Argh..."

Evan winced in pain as small stones embedded themselves all over his body.

But he couldn't afford to stay still.

Several more red lights, carried by the wind, approached him.

He had to avoid them.

They were too small to be sliced with his sword.

Moreover, even if he could control the flames of the explosion, he couldn't control the resultant wind.

'What kind of technique is this?'

Evan was bewildered.

He had always believed he could control anything with his sword.

But now, he couldn't block these with his sword.

Lack of experience.

Evan, having not encountered such situations before, couldn't understand what was happening.

He decided that he first needed to dodge the incoming wind.

As he prepared to move away from the wind...

Hiss...

The wind caught fire.

It was as if someone had lit the fuse of a bomb, the wind itself ignited.

"Ah."

And then.

Boom!!!

The wind resulted in a tremendous explosion.

A loud explosion resonated.

'Rudy...!'

Yuni realized it came from the direction Rudy had gone.

Her legs were weak, yet she pushed herself to run as fast as she could.

Finding Rudy and Evan was difficult; they were nowhere in sight.

Driven by an unwavering determination to find Rudy, Yuni ran forward, not even sure of her direction.

Her breath was heavy, almost suffocating her.

Her mind and body screamed for her to stop.

Her mind argued that going there wouldn't make any difference to Rudy, and her legs felt like they couldn't run any further.

Yet, she continued to move forward, regardless of her internal protests.

She had intended to surpass Rudy and prevent him from meeting Rie.

She had been so focused on defeating him.

However, Rudy had been supporting her since the individual assessment, even coming to her before the assessment to boost her morale.

Even now, his support was evident.

She realized how close she had been to failing, and her actions filled her with shame and regret.

She felt she owed it to Rudy to help him, especially now that he might be injured.

The thought of Rudy facing Evan while hurt, and possibly failing the assessment, was too much for her to bear.

'I have to do something, even if I fail...'

"Yuni."

She heard a voice just as she was determined to continue forward.

Someone called her, urging caution.

"Going any further is dangerous."

Yuni stopped and turned around, questioning.

"...Sister?"

It was Rie, holding a staff radiating bright light.

"Rudy is safe. Don't go any further,"

Rie said with a comforting smile.

Seeing her sister like this brought tears to Yuni's eyes.

"Why are you here...? Is Rudy in danger...?"

Yuni looked around, confused and concerned.

Rie gently placed a hand on Yuni's head.

"Rudy is drawing Evan away and will be back soon."

Yuni's face showed confusion at this explanation.

"So he lured him away... Was this planned?"

"It wasn't fully planned, more like improvised."

Yuni, tears in her eyes, looked puzzled.

Rie smiled at her reassuringly.

"Why are you about to cry? It's nothing serious."

"No, it's just... Senior... I mean..."

Rie embraced Yuni warmly.

"It's okay."

"...I won't cry."

Yuni wiped away her tears and hugged Rie tightly.

"That was a close call."

I watched the forest burning from the explosion Rie had caused.

Such devastation would surely prevent Evan from continuing the fight.

I never planned to engage Evan in combat from the start.

I was originally searching for shelter when I heard a loud noise nearby and decided to investigate.

There, I witnessed Diark and Evan fighting.

I observed the battle to understand the situation.

It was a one-sided affair.

Diark tried to create openings to escape, but Evan aggressively pursued him, intent on killing him despite Diark's evident reluctance and weaker strength.

Evan cornered Diark all the way to a nearby valley where Yuni and Emily were.

Evan even attacked Yuni and Emily, choosing them over more profitable monster hunting.

He wasn't interested in dialogue.

I almost rushed in when I saw this, but I paused to think carefully.

I needed a strategy to handle Evan.

In this environment, I was at a severe disadvantage.

The trees around us were a source of Evan's strength.

The forest, surrounded by trees, was the perfect battleground for Evan.

Facing Evan in my current state, having used much of my mana, was almost certainly impossible.

Defeat was inevitable.

My agility was insufficient for luring Evan away and then evading him.

I could move short distances quickly but lacked the stamina for sustained running.

I needed a different plan.

-What are you doing?

That's when Rie contacted me.

More precisely, it was Sylph, Rie's spirit, who came to me.

Rie had also heard the commotion of Diark and Evan's fight and had come to scout.

Together, we devised a plan.

I would lead Evan as far as possible while Rie would launch a powerful attack using her new ability.

Trusting her word, we put the plan into action.

'What kind of technique did she use?'

I pondered, looking at the flames.

An attack delivered without revealing herself, and it was more powerful than her usual.

I shrugged.

I could just ask her later.

I smiled.

Then, as I was about to move on, I looked back towards the burning area.

"Evan, we'll meet again later."

Now wasn't the right time to fight.

I needed to create the right environment.

Establish conditions where victory was possible.

I would return then.

*I was watching my friend play runescape and realized eco-magic should actually be called nature magic... sorry took me looking at a nature rune to realize there was a better term available...

Toggle New Ads

Chapter 188: Direction (8)

“Are you hurt anywhere?”

“Senior...”

I smiled and waved at Yuni and Rie.

Yuni frowned and looked at me, while Rie smiled.

Rie slowly walked towards me and checked my body.

"Are you hurt anywhere?"

“Just a little? The injuries aren’t that serious.”

I couldn’t avoid all of Evan’s attacks due to low mana.

I had to escape while maintaining a safe distance, so some minor injuries were inevitable.

“Look...”

Then Yuni came up to me.

She looked at the injuries I had.

It was surprising to see Yuni, not Rie, acting like this.

“Sigh... Really...”

Yuni looked at me with annoyance.

“Why did you try to save me? It was just bad luck that I met a strong opponent. I should have just failed the assessment and that would be the end of it! It was just an unavoidable accident... due to bad luck...”

Yuni looked upset, rambling as she gazed at my wounds.

I smiled at her.

“If it’s bad luck to meet such a guy, it’s good luck to meet me. Just think of it as good luck.”

“Are you an idiot? Senior, don’t you think about your own benefits?”

"...Just living to help others is good enough."

“...Huh?”

Rie tilted her head at Yuni’s behavior.

She squinted, as if something was strange.

Yuni’s behavior was odd, but there was no reason for such an expression.

It wasn’t strange to become emotional after a significant event.

I looked around, wondering if someone else was nearby.

But there was nothing in sight.

Why is she making that expression?

I asked Rie.

“Is something wrong?”

“...No. Nothing at all.”

In response to my question, Rie shook her head.

Yuni, looking confused, poked at me.

“Anyway, let’s go back to where we were. Emily is there, so you can get some treatment.”

“Oh, right. Emily knows healing magic.”

That worked out well.

Getting treated by Emily and increasing our numbers would reduce the danger at night.

“Shall we move then?”

“Yes, Senior.”

Rie kept looking at me with suspicion.

I looked back at her.

“Rie?”

“...Ah, yeah. Shall we go?”

...Why is she acting like that?

I was puzzled, but I started walking to join Emily and the others.

“Yuni...! Rudy...!”

Emily was hiding near the valley with Diark.

It seemed they hadn't gone far because Diark was injured.

“Emily, are you okay?”

Yuni slowly approached Emily.

“Yes, I'm fine thanks to Yuni's protection... But...”

Emily looked at Diark, who was sitting in front of her.

“Has senior arrived...”

Diark, wrapped in bandages, looked quite pitiful.

“Can you continue the assessment in this state...”

"We have to try as much as we can. We can't just give up."

It seemed Diark was satisfied just to have not been eliminated.

In fact, it wouldn't have been surprising if he had been eliminated after being attacked by Evan earlier.

Evan's strikes could be fatal for first-year students.

Still, Diark had managed to hold on, likely because he was not just a wizard but a magic swordsman with physical enhancements.

“Yes, you’ve had a tough time...”

I patted Diark’s shoulder a few times.

This guy was also aiming for the top rank among the first-year students.

He must be heartbroken about this unlucky situation.

Yet, seeing his determined demeanor made me want to support him.

“Shall we prepare to spend the night?”

I couldn’t do much to help, but I thought of creating a comfortable environment for them.

The first to respond to my suggestion was Yuni.

“I’ll go to the stream. I can quickly catch something like fish.”

“Oh, would you do that?”

I was a bit surprised to see Yuni being so proactive, but I didn't stop her since she volunteered.

“Then shall we also get ready?”

We needed to make a space to sleep in and make space for a bonfire.

It would be too uncomfortable to sleep on the bare ground without anything.

We needed to gather leaves or something to make a bed-like structure.

“Rudy, come with me. Emily should stay and take care of Diark.”

“No, it's okay! You can go without me. Take Emily with you...”

Diark quickly responded to Rie's suggestion.

Rie looked at Diark with cold eyes.

“Is that so?”

Diark sensed the threat and gently laid down.

He lay down gently, but his movements were swift and concise.

Then he suddenly groaned.

“Ah, ah... I suddenly feel unwell... I need to lie down...”

“Is that so? Emily? Could you take care of Diark?”

“...Yes.”

Diark and Emily quickly reacted to Rie's words.

It was curious that they reacted like that without Rie having to do much.

They were quick-witted, indeed.

“Rudy? Shall we go?”

Rie spoke to me with a smile in her eyes.

Seeing Rie like that, I sighed.

“Don’t be too hard on the kids...”

“Hm? What’s wrong? Is something the matter?”

Rie gave a sly smile and tilted her head, pretending to be clueless.

Since I wasn't really asking the kids to do anything but rather telling them to rest...

“It’s nothing. Shall we go?”

“Sure!”

Rie left the shelter with a bright face.

We had to go a bit away from our campsite to gather short branches and leaves.

As we walked away from the shelter, Rie spoke.

“It’s getting darker.”

“Yes, it is. Let’s gather quickly and return.”

After hearing my response, Rie sighed and spoke again.

“In a forest with no one around... and with the weather turning dark... it feels a bit cold and eerie.”

“...Right. Let’s gather quickly...”

Before I could repeat my earlier response, Rie quickly turned her head.

“That’s not what I’m hoping for.”

It was cold, dark, and spooky, so we should hurry back and light a bonfire, right?

“So, what do you want?”

“Sigh, you can be so clueless.”

Rie sighed and reached out her hand to me.

“Give me your hand.”

“What?”

“Hold my hand.”

Rie extended her hand towards me confidently.

I stared at her and then firmly said,

“No.”

I felt like I had been pushed around too much by Rie lately.

I couldn’t just keep doing everything she asked; it would spoil her.

Rie's eyes widened at my firm refusal.

“... You mean no?”

She stepped back as if she couldn’t believe it, her face full of disappointment.

“Why not...”

Gone was her confident demeanor, replaced with a pitiful look as she gazed up at me.

“Ugh...”

Seeing the usually assertive Rie with such an expression weakened my resolve.

How could anyone remain unaffected when someone as attractive as Rie looks up with such an expression?

I pressed my lips together and turned my head away.

I mustn't give in here.

This was just a trick of Rie's.

I turned my head sharply.

“Let’s... gather some branches...”

I resisted well...

Just as I was about to turn and walk away,

Rie grabbed my sleeve.

She looked up slightly with a sad expression.

“Hold it...”

She repeated.

“...”

My resolve wasn't that strong.

“♪~♪.”

Rie hummed a tune while holding my hand.

One should know when to refuse, but...

How can I say no when she makes such a face and asks?

So, I ended up holding Rie's hand as we went to collect branches.

However, there was a problem.

To pick up branches, I needed to let go of her hand.

It was obvious that Rie wouldn't just let it be if I simply released her hand.

I glanced at Rie, with the branches right in front of me.

"We can't pick up the wood if we keep holding hands..."

I hinted subtly to Rie.

But Rie was unfazed.

"Sylph."

She immediately summoned a spirit to gather the surrounding leaves and branches.

In no time, Sylph had collected all the leaves and was holding them.

I thought we didn't need to come out here if she was going to do this, but it was clear her aim was just to be alone with me, so I didn't say it out loud.

But Rie overlooked one thing.

"Now that we've gathered everything, shall we go back?"

"...!"

After all, our purpose of coming out was to collect leaves and branches.

Now that we had everything, there was no reason to stay outside any longer.

“...The breeze is nice. Why don't we walk around a bit more?”

“It's dangerous outside. What if we encounter other people or beasts?”

“With you and me here, what's there to worry about?”

Rie spoke confidently, but I couldn't spoil her any further.

“No. It'd be a headache if we run into a strong beast. Let's go back and rest. Tomorrow is going to be very busy.”

I didn't mention Sylph since it didn't use much mana, but we needed to conserve as much mana as possible.

We have a busy schedule starting from tomorrow morning so we need to conserve both mana and physical strength.

At my words, Rie tilted her head.

“What's happening tomorrow?”

“Yes, there's a slight change in the plan. I'm moving some things forward.”

“Moving things forward?”

My plan.

A plan known to Rie, Luna, and everyone.

“Tomorrow, we're going to hunt the Red Dragon Hatchling.”

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 189: Direction (9)

The dragon is known to be the strongest among magical beasts, inhabiting mountains, seas, and grasslands without preference, making nests and living there.

It manages the beasts around its nest to protect it and gather food.

Although it may seem no different from other beasts, the dragon differs significantly—it can communicate with humans.

Possessing superior intelligence and rationality compared to other beasts, dragons, however, cannot coexist with humans.

Despite being able to communicate, they cannot engage in meaningful 'conversations' with humans.

The lifestyles of humans and dragons are completely different.

Dragons live a life similar to animals, reigning over other beasts not out of care but by the principle of strength.

Weaker beasts follow dragons not for protection but merely because of the dragon's strength.

From a human perspective, this might seem barbaric: the strong survive, and the weak perish.

Dragons do not intervene if their weak subjects kill a powerless human.

This way of life has led dragons and humans to run parallel but separate paths.

Humans trying to converse with dragons were not understood, and the actions of dragons were incomprehensible to humans.

Failing to understand each other due to differing natures and ideologies, conflict was inevitable.

Thus, dragons almost vanished from the empire due to ongoing conflicts, easily eliminated as they did not cooperate with each other.

When a dragon appears somewhere, it is promptly exterminated by a specially formed squad.

The presence of a dragon here is surprising.

According to the professors, it's a hatchling, so a dragon must have nested recently.

“Tomorrow, right away?”

Emily asked in surprise.

“We were going to catch it anyway. Why are you surprised now?”

“You said on the third day... it's sudden to fight now.”

“It doesn't matter if we fight on the second or third day.”

I moved the schedule up a day because of Evan.

If we fight the dragon, the commotion will be noticeable to everyone on the mountain.

If Evan hears this and attacks us, it will lead to significant damage.

We can't handle both Evan and the dragon simultaneously.

However, Evan is currently injured.

Rie must have severely injured Evan, rendering him unable to move recklessly.

This was an opportunity to seize.

"Then we should get up early tomorrow morning,"

Rie suggested, to which I nodded in agreement.

"Let's go to bed early then. The night watch will proceed as already planned."

Saying this, I glanced at Yuni.

Yuni, without a word, laid down.

Was she planning to act alone as usual?

I was curious but decided to lie down too.

Running around the mountain all day had left me exhausted.

The night deepened.

The next morning, we got up early and prepared, though there wasn't much to prepare for.

We didn't have much to take with us or any need to tidy up the surroundings.

However, Emily had something to do.

"Take this medicine after meals, change the bandages to prevent the wound from worsening, and apply this ointment,"

she instructed.

"Thank you,"

Diark said as he received the medicine from Emily.

We wanted to take Diark to the peak, but it was impossible in his condition.

Aware of this, he approached me first to discuss it.

After receiving a few necessary medicines from Emily, he decided to part ways with us.

"Don't move around too much. It might aggravate your wound,"

Emily advised.

"I understand. Thank you,"

Diark responded.

Emily then prescribed the medicine and stood up.

"I guess it's time to leave."

"Yes, let's go,"

I replied, looking at Yuni.

She was smiling and chatting with Rie.

I called out to her,

"Yuni."

"Yes?"

she responded, tilting her head to my question.

"Are you coming to the summit with us?"

"Oh, the summit? Wasn't that obvious? Why ask such an obvious question?"

Yuni shrugged her shoulders, her usual annoying smile on her face.

She looked better than yesterday, which was a relief, but her attitude still made me want to knock some sense into her head.

"When did you ever do anything on your own?"

"Eh, that was then. I'm going now, aren't I?"

"Fine, do as you please."

I nodded my head and rolled up my sleeves.

"Shall we go then?"

We began our trek towards the mountain's summit.

We agreed to meet Luna and the others near a big rock close to the summit, so our path was not much different from the one leading to the top.

On our way to the summit, we encountered several magical beasts, none of them particularly strong, so we dispatched them quickly, as if they were merely a meal.

Walking briskly, we finally reached the vicinity of the 'Big Boss Rock' at the mountain's summit.

"Hey! Rudy's here!"

Luna called out, waving her hand.

Locke and Kuhn were also there.

I smiled and looked around.

"Haven't Rika and Ena arrived yet?"

"No, not yet. It would be nice if they could arrive before lunch..."

Luna said this with a smile, then turned her gaze away.

I was surprised to see Yuni standing next to me.

"Yuni! You came too!"

"Yeah, it just happened that way. We met and came together."

"Really? That's great!"

Luna, delighted, grabbed Yuni's hand, causing Yuni to blush slightly.

"Did you have any trouble on the way? Any injuries?"

"Nope! I met Kuhn right at the start and came here safely!"

"That's good."

"Hehe."

Luna scratched the back of her head and laughed.

As she did, she glanced behind me.

"...!"

"Uhuhuhu..."

Behind me stood Rie, grinning slyly.

"Ru-Rudy, don't tell me..."

Luna's eyes widened in shock.

"Luna~~!"

"Uh... slow... down..."

That's when Ena and Riku's voices were heard.

"Oh, oh! Riku, Ena!"

Luna looked back and forth between Ena's group and me, perplexed.

"Luna! Can you take this?"

Ena was holding a large bag, likely filled with medicinal herbs.

"Uh, oh! Sure! Rudy... I'll see you in a bit..."

Luna rushed to help Ena with the bag, still casting suspicious glances my way.

Then Rie walked up to me.

"Huhu..."

"Why are you smiling like that?"

"It's my victory, isn't it? I'm the one who's with you."

"Don't say it like that..."

I sighed, looking at Rie.

It seemed like it was time to sort things out.

I couldn't keep up this situation forever.

I needed to come up with a plan.

I shook my head.

This wasn't the time for such thoughts.

When Ena and Riku had climbed up to the rock, I spoke up.

"Looks like everyone's here now..."

I shared my plan with everyone.

The critical steps needed to capture the Red Dragon.

It was a plan I had already discussed, but I reiterated it to reinforce it.

As I was explaining, Riku cautiously raised her hand.

"But... how exactly are we going to deal with the dragon's wings?"

The most crucial part of my plan was targeting the dragon's wings.

If the dragon could fly, our options would be severely limited.

So, the first thing we had to do was break its wings.

"Locke will take care of the wings."

Everyone's gaze turned to Locke, who was sitting nonchalantly on a rock, nodding his head.

I had discussed it with him beforehand, and he seemed prepared in his own way.

"And Luna, can you do what I asked?"

"Yes! No problem!"

"Good."

I nodded and looked at everyone.

"Remember what I told you. We're here to earn points, not out of some sense of duty. To score high in this evaluation, we need to avoid injuries as much as possible. If there's a risk of serious injury or a dangerous situation, run away immediately. It's okay if the plan falls apart; the priority is to escape. Think of your own benefit."

Everyone smiled at my words.

"Let's go then."

Together, we headed towards the summit of the mountain, towards the Red Dragon's nest.

Inside a large cave, there lay a being.

This being, wrapped in red scales, was a Red Dragon.

Young and not as large as a typical dragon, its majestic presence was still apparent.

The dragon was dreaming about the past, specifically a memory of its mother being captured and killed by humans.

The dragon stirred and lifted its head.

"Is it the sound of humans?"

Lately, there had been sounds of humans roaming the mountains, but the dragon had paid no mind.

Dragons typically don't act unless it concerns them directly.

Trying to sleep again after the unsettling dream, the dragon found rest elusive, unsure if it was the dream or the nearby humans that disturbed it.

Then, the sound of footsteps approached.

The dragon couldn't ignore the intrusion this time.

"Arrogant humans."

Its massive body caused the cave to rumble as it stood up and stepped out.

"Wow, it's huge."

"It's like a building moving..."

"Stay calm, Luna."

Outside the cave stood three humans - two women and a man.

The dragon scanned them.

"Only three?"

They seemed young and inexperienced, hardly the formidable opponents the dragon expected.

Disappointed, the dragon thought,

'I'll just send them away and go back to sleep.'

It didn't want to waste energy on such trivial intruders.

As the dragon was about to speak, one of the women summoned a wind spirit,

"Sylph."

The man then crouched down, and the spirit generated a strong wind beneath him, launching him at incredible speed towards the dragon.

The tiny human figure flew up to the dragon's face.

The dragon's eyes widened in shock.

"What the..."

The man, now in the air, punched the dragon's nose with tremendous force.

Chapter 190: Direction (10)

Dragons are covered in scales of unbelievable toughness.

Even a normal sword cannot leave a scratch on these scales.

The scales are not only tough but also highly resistant to magic.

There are still ways to wound a dragon, despite such strong scales.

One can either attack with enough force to penetrate the scales or target areas without them.

“Huff...!”

I struck the dragon's nose.

Even in armor, there are gaps to exploit.

The dragon, though covered in scales, did not have them over its nose.

“Gurgh...!”

Blood spurted from the dragon's nose as it screamed, its eyes widening in shock.

I immediately shouted, seeing its reaction.

“Rie!”

At my call, wind enveloped the dragon.

The wind, like threads, began to entwine around the dragon's body.

“Krr...?”

The dragon struggled in confusion.

“Burn fiercely.”

As Rie murmured, the wind caught fire.

The wind, wrapping around the dragon, fueled the flames.

The fire on the dragon's body blazed intensely.

It was a technique Rie had prepared and honed.

This was a spell to enhance an elemental.

But it wasn't just about strengthening the elemental's power.

The wind created by the elemental could only manipulate and sharpen the air.

It was limited by the nature of the wind.

This magic broke that limitation.

It allowed partial weakening or strengthening of the elemental, giving free control over the form of the wind.

Moreover, it could alter the wind's nature, maintaining its form but changing its essence.

Like now, sending fire through the wind.

“Kr... Kra...!!!”

The dragon panicked as it caught fire.

Even with scales, there were gaps.

The flames crept into these gaps, tormenting the dragon.

The dragon thrashed in agony.

“Humans!!!!”

Its thrashing caused sparks to fly, dimming the flames.

“Stick to the plan.”

“Yes!”

“Got it.”

Hearing Rie and Luna's response, I turned around.

We needed to reach our positions before the dragon regained its senses.

Rie used Sylph to move elsewhere, while Luna and I started running towards the back.

“Damn it!!!!”

The dragon raged at the sight of us.

But it couldn't follow.

If we hid ourselves towards the forest, the trees would conceal us from the dragon's view.

I quickly moved and looked at Luna.

"Luna, are you ready?"

"Yes!"

We walked a bit and then looked ahead.

It was a pit we had prepared earlier.

We jumped into that pit.

As soon as Luna entered the pit, she opened her magic book.

"Huff..."

Luna took a deep breath and moved her mana.

A strong light leaked from the magic book.

A large magic circle appeared in front of Luna.

Not just that.

Besides the large magic circle in front, smaller magic circles appeared around Luna.

"Think you can escape me!!!"

The dragon's roar was heard.

It was as expected.

It's coming now.

Since we were out of its sight, it would try to burn the entire direction we ran to.

Breath.

Depending on the dragon's type, the breath varied, but knowing what type of dragon this was, I knew the nature of its breath.

Being a Red Dragon, it spewed fire.

Luna's magic circles were prepared for this attack.

Magic circles with maximum fire resistance.

Magic circles that Luna had created day and night.

I trusted Luna and waited quietly.

"Activate!"

A small hemisphere appeared and enveloped Luna's body.

An enormous sound roared around us.

As the sound echoed, we saw red flames in front of us.

The flames covered the protective shield around us.

Gooong—

The shield vibrated intensely.

But it did not break.

It was withstanding the impact of the breath.

Seeing this, I immediately shouted.

"Locke!!!!"

During its breath attack, the dragon cannot move its body.

To spew such intense flames from its mouth, it needs a solid base.

The dragon presses its body to the ground to withstand the recoil of the breath.

That was our moment.

Our magic couldn't bind the dragon's body.

We might be able to tie its legs, but we couldn't control its wings.

So, we needed to create a situation where it couldn't move on its own.

Locke appeared behind the dragon.

He had been atop the cave before we lured the dragon out.

Locke fell onto the dragon's back, holding his sword forward.

"Northern swordsmanship..."

Blue sword aura enveloped Locke.

The sword aura gathered in the extended sword.

"Blue Bird."

Locke, falling from above the dragon, precisely aimed for its wings and pierced through them.

"Kr...!"

The dragon almost screamed, but it swallowed the sound as it was using its breath.

"Ugh...!"

Luna seemed to struggle to counter the breath, her expression contorted.

"Luna, just hold on a little longer!"

"Just a bit more...!"

A few seconds later, the flames subsided.

At the same time, the protective shield disappeared.

"Haa... Haa...,

Luna, breathing heavily, collapsed to the ground.

Looking around, I could see how much stronger Luna had become.

The trees behind us had vanished as if a highway had been plowed through them.

The end was out of sight.

“Luna, great job.”

I reached out to help Luna stand.

Luna, getting up with my assistance, quietly said,

“Did I... do it?”

I smiled at Luna's words.

This entire operation was possible because of Luna.

It was her confident assertion that she could block the dragon's breath that allowed us to plan this.

“You did really well. Truly.”

“Hehehe...”

“Luna, senior!!”

Then, from a distance, Emily came running.

I handed Luna, whom I was supporting, over to Emily.

“I'll go and finish this. Take a break a little away from here. Emily, please take care of her.”

“Okay. We'll go to a safe place.”

“Rudy... be careful.”

After passing Luna to Emily, I walked towards the dragon.

The aftermath of the breath made it seem like a great battle had already taken place, but it was just the beginning.

Until now, it was just a strategy to prevent the dragon from escaping.

We hadn't defeated the dragon yet.

Walking a bit further, I saw the dragon glaring with wide eyes.

“Human... how dare you...”

The dragon spoke to me in a voice filled with rage.

It seemed a bit weakened from using its breath.

“What’s so daring about it? What’s so different between you and us?”

“Do you think the status of humans and dragons is the same? Pitiful humans.”

The dragon stepped forward.

“Deceitful and petty, fragile enough to break upon the slightest touch, humans and dragons are as different as heaven and earth.”

I snorted at the dragon’s words.

“Yeah, different. How can a lizard-headed creature like you be the same as humans?”

“What?”

“Dragons, barely surviving to the point of near-extinction, and humans, ruling the entire landmass. There’s no comparison.”

The dragon gritted its teeth at my words.

A murderous intent pierced my body.

“No use talking.”

I thought the same.

“Rudy.”

Then, I heard Rie's voice.

Yuni, Locke, Riku, Ena, Kuhn – all were ready for battle.

What seemed like many at first felt insufficient in front of the dragon's massive body.

But I was confident.

I trusted my comrades, and they trusted me.

We could catch this little lizard ourselves.

I extended my hand.

“Priscilla, Behemoth.”

In front of me appeared a small elephant and a wolf with an enormous body.

“Pwooooh!!”

As Behemoth roared, the ground gripped the dragon's legs, swallowing them like quicksand.

“Grrr...”

The dragon struggled to escape the muddy ground.

“Electric Shock!!”

In the meantime, Yuni used her magic.

“Activate.”

Kuhn also activated his magical device, which contained telekinetic magic.

This device, created with the advice of Astina and Luna, pressed the dragon further into the mire.

The dragon sank deeper into the mud due to the telekinetic magic.

“Cough...”

The dragon, assaulted by Yuni's magic, continued to sink into the mud.

Having been grounded by Locke who had previously made a large hole in its wings, the dragon could not fly away.

Its efforts to escape with its legs were futile as it had sunk too deep.

At that moment, Riku received a large barrel from Ena, dipped her hand in it, and shouted,

“Cloud!!”

Upon Riku's command, the liquid transformed into smoke, which rose above the dragon's head.

The smoke gathered, forming a cloud-like structure that began to rain down a strange liquid.

“You curs...!”

The dragon, sensing the suspicious liquid raining down, struggled to escape its position.

Its flailing sent mud flying towards Kuhn and Yuni nearby.

“Get away from there!”

Yuni and Kuhn quickly moved out of the way.

As their attacks stopped and the dragon's thrashing intensified, it began to break free from the mud.

“Sylph, bind it.”

Rie responded swiftly.

She enchanted Sylph to create wind, which tangled around the dragon, restraining it.

However, it wasn't enough to bind the entire body.

While its legs and body were restrained, the dragon still had its tail free.

Just as the dragon's tail was about to sweep the area, Locke, with blue sword aura enveloping his blade, lunged forward.

The blue aura pierced deeply through the scales of the tail.

“Graaah!!”

The dragon screamed in pain, thrashing violently.

Rie did her best to keep the dragon bound, shouting,

“Rudy! We can’t hold it much longer!”

“Got it.”

I gathered mana in my hand and looked at Priscilla.

“Priscilla, freeze it.”

“Understood.”

Priscilla's cold aura enveloped the dragon.

Crack...!

The liquid Riku had sprayed on the dragon gradually froze.

The dragon tried to break the ice encasing it.

“Grr...?”

Despite its struggles, the ice did not shatter.

The liquid Riku had used was no ordinary substance; it had the strength to withstand the dragon's thrashing without breaking when frozen.

“Phew...”

I gazed at the dragon as it continued to freeze over.

The jewel in my fist glowed brightly, emitting a strong vibration.

“Hu...mans.”

The dragon, seeing its body increasingly freeze, had an expression of disbelief.

Yet, it did not give up.

The dragon started to gather flames in its mouth, intending to fire one last breath attack.

“No way.”

I stomped on the ground, facing the dragon.

“Whoosh...!”

Just as the dragon was about to release the flames from its mouth, I, with mana filled in my fist, struck the dragon's jaw.

“Crash!”

The impact on the dragon's jaw forced its head to tilt upwards.

Whoosh! The breath it was holding spewed out into the sky.

I fell towards the ground, watching this unfold.

“Rudy!”

Rie ran towards where I was falling.

Sylph, beside her, blew wind in my direction.

Whoosh—

The wind acted like a cushion, softening my fall.

“Thanks, Rie.”

“Why did you have to jump like that...!”

“Ahaha...”

It was a relief that we managed to block the dragon's breath.

We looked at the dragon.

The dragon tried to thrash as much as it could, but it was futile.

“These humans, so powerless on their own...!”

The dragon shouted at us, but it was just a cry.

Its body continued to freeze, leaving only its mouth able to move.

I looked at the dragon.

“Dragons became extinct because they couldn’t do that.”

Unlike the dragon, living in its self-proclaimed superiority, acknowledging one's shortcomings and supporting each other was the survival method for those lacking individually.

I lifted the corners of my mouth.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 191: Direction (11)

The fight was over.

The dragon's body was completely frozen.

However, its face did not freeze, probably due to the heat from its breath.

The dragon lay there motionless, its face peeking out from its frozen body.

Rie looked intently at the dragon, then shifted her gaze.

"What are we going to do with it now?"

"We have to kill it, what else?"

Priscilla was maintaining the freeze, but we couldn't just leave it like this forever.

If we don't pay attention, the ice might melt, and the dragon could break free.

Rie responded to my words, licking her lips.

"How are we going to kill it?"

"..."

I was deep in thought about this.

I had thought about capturing it, but not about killing it.

Maybe I should keep hitting it on the head.

But then, I shook my head.

Even with a mana-infused fist, it wouldn't be enough to penetrate the dragon's scales.

It didn't seem like that would kill the dragon.

"I'll try piercing its head."

Locke approached us, drawing his sword.

"Is that even possible?"

"I did it once before with its tail, why not a second time?"

Having pierced its tail with his sword earlier, he thought there was a possibility.

"Hiccup..."

Suddenly, there was a loud noise from the dragon's direction.

The dragon, which had been arrogant, thinking we couldn't kill it, now had its pupils shaking wildly.

I looked at Locke.

"Let's try it once."

"Okay, then..."

"Hey, hey!"

The dragon called out to us urgently.

We quietly looked at the dragon.

It hesitated and then spoke softly.

"Please spare me."

Even a dragon, a symbol of arrogance, did not want to die.

I looked at the dragon and smiled.

"I don't think so."

There was no reason to spare it.

Its entire body was a huge magic artifact.

The dragon's heart, scales, and claws were items worth a territory's budget.

These days, dragons are nearly extinct, and these items are hard to come by.

I didn't have enough generosity to give that up for a stranger lizard.

Also, I wouldn't get points if I didn't kill it.

It's about the evaluation and the money.

There was no benefit for me in sparing it.

Instead, it could be a future nuisance.

"Locke."

"Please, really, I'll be good. I won't bother humans, I'll live quietly in the mountains. I won't do anything, I'll do as humans say. Just spare me, please... Sob..."

The dragon spoke rapidly, pleading for its life.

With a desperate voice and tears streaming down, the dragon pleaded.

Rie looked at the dragon with a look of disbelief.

"...Do dragons usually do this?"

"...I wouldn't know."

The dragon was pathetically begging for its life in front of me.

I felt as if my image of dragons was shattering into pieces.

"Hmm..."

I pondered internally, calculating the situation.

Is there any benefit to sparing its life?

How can I ensure it doesn't betray us if we let it live?

I decided to think it over slowly.

"Rudy! Is it over?"

Then, from a distance, Luna and Emily approached.

"Sort of?"

"Wow... when you look at it closely, it's really big."

Luna looked up at the dragon, then tilted her head in confusion.

"...Is the dragon crying?"

"Sob... Sob..."

"...It's crying for its life."

Luna covered her mouth with a shocked and sympathetic expression.

I felt like this was going to be a real headache.

"Rudy..."

"No."

I cut off Luna's words, responding firmly.

But Luna puffed up her cheeks in response.

"It's pitiful. It's just asking to be spared!"

"How many people has it killed?"

"...I, I've never killed anyone."

The dragon spoke softly.

"See, it says it hasn't killed anyone."

"...We don't know if that's a lie or not."

"It's not a lie! I'm a young hatchling! My mother was also friendly with humans!"

"...A dragon friendly with humans?"

I had never heard such a thing.

If there had been a dragon trying to befriend humans, it would have been a topic of discussion in the magical beast studies.

But there was no such record.

"When I was in my mother's lair, I befriended a few humans! It's true!"

The dragon said this and then quietly bowed its head.

"However... my mother was killed by those humans."

I looked at the dragon skeptically.

I wondered if it was lying, trying to exploit Luna's sympathy.

But that wasn't the important part.

"If we don't kill it, we won't get any points."

We had wasted a lot of time trying to capture the dragon.

Fortunately, no one was seriously injured, so we could still fight others, but catching up with others' scores would be difficult.

"Are we going to settle for a low rank?"

"...If we get the points, will you spare it?"

Luna glanced at me, asking cautiously.

"...I'll think about it."

Then Luna raised her hand high.

"Teaching assistant! You're watching, right?"

Luna shouted into the void.

"Please come out for a moment!"

A few seconds after shouting, a teaching assistant emerged from the forest and walked towards us.

"Did you hear our conversation?"

"Yes... I did hear it."

The assistant scratched their head.

It must have been a tricky situation for the academy as well.

"The dragon is begging so desperately, don't you feel sorry for it?... If we can reform the dragon, it's essentially the same as dealing with a magical beast, so shouldn't we receive points?"

"...Firstly, I don't think it's my place to decide. I'll ask Professor Cromwell."

The assistant pulled out a square box from their pocket and brought it to their ear.

A light emitted from the box, and they spoke.

"...Yes, Professor. Yes. Have you seen the situation? Yes. Uh-huh... Understood."

The assistant nodded several times and closed the box.

"Professor Cromwell says that it's not about killing the magical beast, but assessing if we can handle one, so points will be awarded. However, the management of the dragon is up to the students. If you can't manage it, legal punishments may apply."

"Really!"

Luna clapped her hands happily.

She then looked triumphantly at me.

"So, we're good now?"

"I can... live?"

I looked sharply at the dragon.

Leaving such a treasure alive...

And we are to manage it?

On the other hand, there was also the question of whether we could even kill the dragon.

We didn't know for sure if it was possible.

Would the dragon still be so compliant after we attempted to kill it and decided it wasn't possible?

We also might lose the points if we aren't able to tame it.

After much thought, I looked at the others.

"What do you all think?"

Rie then spoke up.

"There's no need to kill unnecessarily. We are humans, not magical beasts."

Her words seemed exemplary, but her expression was one of annoyance.

She probably found it difficult to kill the dragon and wanted to finish the matter quickly.

Yuni looked at Rie, then turned to me and raised her hand.

"But if we spare it, how do we manage it? If we release it and it just flies away, we'll be penalized."

"We'll need to cast a restricting spell."

It could be done in the same way Principal McDowell placed a restraint on Yeniel.

Thinking it best to strike while the iron is hot, I looked at the assistant.

"Assistant, could you ask Professor Cromwell to prepare a contract tool for imposing a restraint?"

"Yes, I'll arrange it."

It would be too late if we waited until after the assessment, so this much help should be possible.

"Does this mean we are sparing the dragon?"

"Yes."

It was a pity that we couldn't replace its heart or other important parts with magical tools, but there was no other option.

More importantly, I wondered how we could utilize the dragon.

If we put a magical restraint on it, we would have to find a way to make use of it...

I looked at the dragon, licking my lips.

"Then, you're going to spare me?"

"Yes! Dragon, you're going to be spared!"

"Thank you... Thank you so much."

"Ah, but before that."

I extended my hand towards the dragon, realizing I had forgotten something.

"...Yes?"

"Thinking about it, I recall the words you said earlier?"

"..."

"What were they again? Deceitful? Petty? And something about being nothing on your own...?"

"I'm sorry... I spoke thoughtlessly to the humans..."

I crossed my arms and looked at the dragon, curious to see how far it would go with its words.

The dragon, sensing my gaze, continued.

"...Jumping around aimlessly, even less than a mere bug, a worthless lizard... Don't mind the words of this trash-like dragon. I spoke those words

due to my far inferior knowledge compared to humans... Sob..."

Seeing the dragon, known for its pride, utter such words made me smile.

As I smiled broadly, Rie and Yuni glared at me.

"Are you a pervert?"

"Hmm~? Senior, do you like that sort of thing?"

I coughed at their comments.

"Cough, I'm just accepting the apology I'm owed."

And so, we decided to spare the dragon.

After the contract was completed, the dragon, having sustained significant injuries, entered its lair and fell asleep.

We slowly started packing up the gear we had prepared for capturing the dragon.

Luna, while gathering her things, stopped and looked at me sitting quietly.

"What are you going to do now, Rudy?"

"I plan to stay around here."

Having captured the dragon, we had amassed a substantial amount of points.

Apart from Luna, Rie, and Locke who were here with me, my score was incomparable to the others.

Additionally, I had run into many students before arriving here, creating a significant gap in points between me and the others present.

Thus, I was just waiting for one person.

I was certain he would come here.

The fact that there was a dragon at the mountain's peak was known to all the students.

Only a few could actually capture this dragon.

He would know.

He would know that I had fought the dragon.

Curiosity alone would bring him here to see what kind of battle had taken place.

I looked at everyone and smiled.

"I'll be waiting here for Evan."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 192: Direction (12)

"You're going to fight him again after battling a dragon?"

"Then we'll stay here too."

"Rudy! What kind of trouble are you getting into now!"

Everyone chided me in their own way.

I sent them all away.

Fighting alongside them would be helpful, but it was meaningless.

The reason I wanted to fight Evan was not to steal his points.

I looked at Priscilla, who was sitting beside me.

"Priscilla, can you do it?"

"As long as that elephant fights properly."

Priscilla pointed to Behemoth, who was rolling around in the distance.

"Pwoohh."

Behemoth seemed pleased with the mud he had created, rolling around in it.

"Priscilla, go play for a bit. You like walks."

"Is that okay?"

"Why not, Evan won't be coming now."

Even if he did, Priscilla could quickly return, so it wasn't a big issue.

"Just don't use your powers too much. I'm tired too."

"Got it. I'll just walk around nearby."

Priscilla walked away with a pleasant smile.

I looked up at the sky.

The sunset was slowly setting.

With all the trees gone, the red sunset was clearly visible.

I was mentally exhausted from using Priscilla's abilities to fight the dragon.

Freezing the dragon's entire body, it seemed Priscilla also used her abilities significantly for the first time in a while.

I try not to use Priscilla's abilities when I fight.

I knew all too well the fate of those who had used Priscilla before.

It was well documented in books, and Cromwell had warned me several times.

But Priscilla wasn't a bad entity.

She was just like a dog... no, more like a puppy.

She liked walks and readily helped with anything I asked.

The previous contractors simply didn't use Priscilla properly.

If asked whether I know how to use Priscilla well, I would shake my head.

I wasn't sure to what extent I could use Priscilla, and it was difficult to gauge her limits.

Mental exhaustion wasn't something you could calculate numerically.

It had to be sensed intuitively.

Priscilla seemed unaware of these limits as well.

"To use Priscilla better... I need to understand this too."

She was so obedient and her abilities so useful that I called upon her in almost every fight.

Priscilla had now become a significant part of my strength.

I needed to learn how to use not just my abilities but all of Priscilla's as well.

I should learn about spirits, but the only person around me who handled spirits was Rie.

The problem was that I couldn't learn from Rie.

Priscilla and ordinary spirits were practically different entities.

I pondered deeply and then remembered someone.

Serina.

Didn't Rie say she received teachings from Serina not long ago?

I heard she was staying near the academy.

Serina's mother was definitely a former contractor of Priscilla.

Then, could Serina know something about Priscilla?

But...

Serina wasn't the one who contracted, it was her mother, so I wondered how much help she would be.

Still, once this assessment is over, I should ask her.

There's no one else to ask about Priscilla but Serina...

Though I was making various plans on my own, there was something else I needed to do first.

Dealing with Evan.

It wasn't something I needed to do right away.

I was just resting and waiting for Evan.

Evan was sitting in one spot, meditating.

He was healing his body by absorbing energy from the surrounding trees through nature magic.

Then, a loud explosion was heard from the top of the mountain.

The sound was followed by half of the mountain burning.

Fortunately, the opposite side of the mountain burned, so Evan was not greatly affected.

However, it was highly irritating.

Such a commotion at the mountain's summit meant someone fought a dragon.

Only one person could fight that.

'...Rudy Astria.'

Always someone who takes actions that astonish everyone.

Among the students, he was likely the only one who would think to catch a dragon.

His abilities, too, were capable, and he was the only person bold enough to make such a choice.

Did Rudy Astria catch the dragon?

He didn't know.

He had to see it with his own eyes.

As these thoughts filled his mind, something boiled inside Evan.

Some might call it jealousy, others inferiority complex.

Regardless, the result was the same.

Evan picked up his sword.

'Tomorrow, I go to the top of the mountain.'

If Rudy Astria was defeated by the dragon, he would catch it.

If victorious, he would find and overcome Rudy Astria.

He wasn't sure what it meant, but he had to do it.

He wanted to be the top student.

Yeniel told him to wield the sword with conviction, but changing his mind suddenly was impossible.

To stand above Rudy Astria.

That was Evan's goal, his ideology, the only purpose in his life.

Rudy had done nothing wrong.

He wasn't a bad person.

Evan knew this.

He even knew that he was the strange one.

Yet, Evan took up the sword.

He had no choice but to direct it at Rudy Astria.

As Yeniel said, Evan's sword has no meaning if it's not aimed at Rudy Astria.

Without aiming for the top, he would lose his way.

He wasn't driven by a greater cause or conviction.

Even if it was disgraceful, even if he was pointed at, there was only one thing to do.

He could only hope.

If he became the top student and defeated Rudy Astria, then he might find another goal.

See the next place.

And... become an ideal person like Rudy Astria.

Evan's goal was Rudy Astria.

Both as a target to be surpassed and as an ideal to aspire to.

Rudy Astria was enviable.

A person respected by everyone around him.

Someone with the courage to risk danger for others.

A person with such skills and character.

That's why.

"I will surpass Rudy Astria."

It was all about striving to exceed Rudy Astria.

If he could surpass him, a different perspective might be revealed.

But, if even after defeating Rudy Astria, or if he fails and still can't find his path,

Then there would be no reason to stay at the academy anymore.

He would have to leave and find a new goal.

As Yeniel said, a lost sword only cuts down the innocent.

The next day, Evan headed to the mountain's summit.

The trees along the path to the summit were all burned down, and the ground was charred black.

There were also signs of intense fighting, with the ground deeply gouged in places.

'What happened to the dragon?'

Evan looked towards the summit.

With all the trees burned down along the path, the view was clear.

However, there was no sign of the dragon.

If yesterday's fight resulted in a victory over the dragon, its corpse should have been visible.

'Did they lose?'

The thought didn't last long.

In the distance, he saw a person sitting on a small rock, accompanied by a small elephant and a silver-furred wolf.

"It's been a while since we've faced each other like this, Evan,"
said the blond man, smiling in greeting.

"It's our first time having a conversation like this. Rudy Astria,"
Evan said to Rudy.

The two had never talked before.

The only interaction they had was during the last joint assessment when they collided.

"Did you earn many points?"

"Not as much as you, who caught a dragon, but I earned enough."

Seeing Rudy sitting there unharmed amidst the destruction, it was clear he had caught the dragon.

Rudy's expression changed from a smile.

"You didn't just bully kids and steal their easy points, did you?"

"What concern is that of yours?"

"Why harass other students with your abilities? You could have caught an enormous number of magical beasts."

"I dealt with whoever was in front of me."

Their conversation wasn't awkward, though they had never spoken before.

It felt like talking to a long-time friend.

Rudy stood up.

"I respect you, Evan, and think there are things to learn from you."

He knew the extent of Evan's efforts to become stronger and claim the top position.

Rudy himself had reduced his sleep and exerted bone-grinding, blood-spilling effort for good grades.

Evan was no different.

Evan's abilities were unique, but not a talent.

Uniqueness doesn't mean talent.

It was more of a curse.

Instead of following a path laid by others, he had to forge his own.

While carving his own path, Evan also balanced regular studies.

This wasn't a matter of talent.

It meant investing his time, foregoing rest and comfort, and enduring.

"But now, I think you're straying a bit off course."

Evan said nothing in response.

Rudy clenched his fist, channeling mana.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 193: Direction (13)

Rudy quickly reached Evan.

Their eyes met up close.

'Let's fight.'

'I'll defeat you.'

In that brief moment, they communicated through their eyes.

Evan swung his sword widely.

Clang.

Rudy blocked the sword with his hand.

Even if the sword's blade was sharp, it was nothing compared to the magical tool Rudy had painstakingly created.

Rudy grabbed the blade and smiled.

"Still using that sword, I see."

Andrei's sword.

It was the sword Rudy had given to Evan.

Despite its incredible ability to nullify magic, Rudy had handed it over to Evan.

Thanks to this sword, Evan had developed a higher-level technique to cut through the flow of mana.

Evan was unaware of this fact.

Evan pressed Rudy with his sword.

In terms of strength, Rudy was not inferior and did not falter.

As they reached a standoff, Evan spoke.

"Elementals."

Green light swirled behind Evan.

The light gradually took shape.

Deer, rabbits, horses.

The light transformed into animal forms.

Special elementals roaming the mountains.

Evan could borrow their power without directly contracting with these special elementals.

Dozens of elementals stood behind Evan, showing hostility towards Rudy.

Rudy had anticipated this situation.

Elementals and nature are inseparable.

In such a forest, he predicted the presence of numerous elementals.

Once Evan learned to handle special elementals, it was clear he would use them.

"Behemoth, Priscilla."

"Pwooooh."

"Is that an order to block all of them?"

Priscilla and Behemoth, who were behind Rudy, sighed.

The dozens of elementals behind Evan felt like a small legion.

Although they might be weaker individually since Evan had not directly contracted with them, their sheer number was overwhelming.

"Just hold them off."

Rudy glanced back and spoke.

Priscilla smiled at his words.

"It's demotivating to be asked to just hold off when we need to fight."

Cold air rose around Priscilla.

The chill began to freeze the surrounding ground.

Priscilla looked down at Behemoth beneath her.

"Hey, elephant, are you ready?"

"Pwooooh!"

With that response, Behemoth rolled its foot.

Crack. Although it was a small foot roll, the surrounding ground began to split.

The splitting ground, dividing into several paths, grew larger as it advanced.

Its effect reached Evan and Rudy in front.

As the ground where Evan and Rudy stood began to split, they both leaped backward.

The split progressed, reaching the elementals behind them.

Caught off guard by the sudden ground split, the elementals couldn't react quickly.

Short-legged and slow-moving elementals fell into the split ground.

"Freeze."

Seeing the elementals fall, Priscilla froze the split gap, preventing them from coming out.

Thanks to the dragon burning the surrounding forest, Evan and the elementals couldn't exert their full power.

'This won't do.'

Evan quickly decided.

He moved his mana, sending it into the ground.

His mana spread around, and green light swirled on the ground.

"Forest."

With Evan's command, sprouts emerged amidst the green light.

Sprouts grew, flowers bloomed, and trees rose.

A spell he used during the individual assessment.

It was magic that instantly created a forest around him.

However, it wasn't as vast as the forest he had created during the individual assessment.

This spell energizes the seeds buried in the ground, causing them to grow rapidly.

But the dragon had burnt the land, leaving few seeds remaining.

Moreover, since Priscilla had frozen the ground, the weaker seeds couldn't break through the ice and failed to sprout.

A considerably small forest was formed.

Rudy watched and laughed.

"I was wondering when you'd use that."

Rudy moved his mana.

Light seeped from his gloves.

However, it was different from when he used his fist.

When he charged directly into combat, the gem on the back of his hand shone, but now, the glove itself emitted light.

Specifically, the circuits on the glove glowed.

"Hellfire Ascension."

As Rudy spoke, black flames spread around him.

The black flames approached the forest created by Evan and began to consume it.

The flames that had spread around converged towards one place.

That place was where Evan stood.

Evan didn't just watch.

Though unfamiliar with dark magic, he knew something powerful would happen if those flames gathered.

Holding his sword, he gathered the mana of the forest.

A sword aura-like energy appeared from his sword.

Evan pulled the sword inward and swung it.

The surroundings turned green.

The flames subsided, and the surrounding flowers and grass grew fresher.

The roots and leaves of the plants covered the flames, making them disappear.

It felt as if life was swallowing death.

Countless life forces devoured Rudy's flames and the ice created by Priscilla.

The split ground started to reconnect with the roots of the plants, and the elementals that had fallen below climbed out using those roots.

"Ah..."

Rudy watched in awe.

Life had been bestowed upon the land destroyed by the dragon.

Roots took hold in the ground, turning the barren land fertile again.

Then, a tree behind Evan began to grow.

It grew so tall that it almost reached the sky, engulfing the surroundings.

"Rudy Astria."

The elementals that emerged from behind Evan walked forward.

They, who had appeared as ordinary animals, now radiated power.

With more plants and stronger natural forces, the elementals' power also increased.

"Now, let's finish this."

Hearing Evan's words, Rudy looked at the tree behind Evan.

A tree slightly smaller than the dragon.

It was an enormous tree.

If someone were to stand in front of this, they would feel utterly insignificant, overwhelmed by its immense vitality.

Yet, Rudy moved forward with a smile.

"Let's see what you've got, Evan."

Evan, observing Rudy's advance, curled his lips upward.

He gathered energy in his sword.

The massive tree behind Evan shone brilliantly.

"Attack."

The elementals behind Evan charged towards Rudy.

Behemoth and Priscilla also moved forward simultaneously.

Behemoth attempted to split the ground, but the tangled roots of the tree prevented it.

Priscilla created several ice chunks and started hunting the elementals with her sharp teeth.

She wanted to use her ice powers but refrained, fearing it might burden Rudy.

As Behemoth and Priscilla couldn't fully utilize their abilities, the elementals reached Rudy.

Rudy confronted them, mana in hand, snapping the neck of a deer and blocking a horse's kick.

It felt like battling dozens of animals, only these were stronger than ordinary ones.

While Rudy dealt with the elementals, Evan raised his sword.

A massive mana swirled around Evan's blade.

It was the same technique he used during the individual assessment.

"Phew..."

Rudy took a deep breath.

"Just have to endure it once."

Evan swung his sword.

A green light enveloped the surroundings.

A vast swarm of light.

Evan created an even larger swarm of light than in his individual assessment.

Rudy was renowned for his ability to move swiftly for short distances, so Evan used a larger technique to prevent him from escaping its range.

Kwagagagagak!

The green light, which had just been bestowing life, now ravaged the surroundings.

A massive explosion occurred.

The light destroyed even the trees it had created, enveloping the vicinity.

Evan was certain.

Rudy couldn't have escaped.

"Phew... Phew..."

Exhausted, Evan adjusted his mana, remembering how he had lost consciousness during the individual assessment.

Still, the use of such a significant amount of mana left his body drained.

Evan exhaled roughly, looking ahead.

The swarm of light gradually faded.

Thud—

Then, a sound of feet kicking the ground was heard.

"Ah?"

Rudy burst through the light, lunging forward.

His clothes were mostly torn, blood flowed from his head, and his entire body seemed burned, reddened as if scorched.

Yet, he charged forward.

Rudy had pondered a lot about Evan's technique.

This contemplation wasn't done alone; he had asked Rie, Luna, Astina, Gracie, and others.

How to block Evan's technique.

How to avoid it.

Despite deep thought, no answer emerged.

With the joint assessment approaching, learning new magic was not feasible.

Therefore, Rudy chose a frontal assault.

He received the technique head-on.

Strengthening his body with mana to endure as much as possible.

If Evan used the same ability as in the individual assessment, Rudy would try hard to dodge, but he didn't expect it to be easy.

Certainly, Evan must have thought of a way to counter this.

So he won't avoid it.

Instead, he thinks about what comes after.

Evan's eyes widened at the sight of Rudy suddenly charging towards him.

He assumed a defensive stance to block the approaching Rudy.

Green mana acted like a shield in front of Evan.

However, Rudy didn't approach Evan directly.

Instead, he bypassed Evan and headed towards the large tree behind him.

The tree, as big as a dragon, became Rudy's target.

Rudy clenched his fist.

Intense light emitted from the jewel in his hand.

It was a brilliance he had never seen before.

Rudy struck the tree with his fist.

The tree growing behind Evan was a manifestation of Evan's mana itself.

It wasn't a separate entity like the surrounding plants.

Despite Rudy's strength, it seemed impossible to damage that unharmed tree.

Or so it should have been.

"An opening."

Rudy's fist pierced through a gap in the tree.

On the way back from the Railer family, Rudy learned about mana flow from Robert.

Since then, Rudy had been able to read all the mana around him.

But knowing the flow didn't mean he could do much about it.

It's common knowledge that a wizard's mana gathers at the heart, but who doesn't know that the heart is a person's weak point?

Who doesn't know that the core of a magic tool is at its center?

Few possess skills like necromancy, where the core can move around.

Most of the time, even knowing where mana gathers doesn't mean you can destroy it.

However, the current situation was different.

The tree was Evan, and Evan was the tree.

Their flow was identical.

They were interconnected.

Rudy read that flow.

If he could break the tree, he could disrupt Evan's mana flow.

In a normal state, the flow would be stable, making it hard to find a gap, but Evan was using powerful magic.

Thus, the mana flow in the tree was unstable.

Rudy found a gap in that unstable flow.

Inserting his hand into a normal flow would have swept him away, but striking at the gap in an unstable flow could sever it.

Rudy thrust his fist into the gap of the flow.

Thud—

The tree resonated loudly, and at that moment, the movements of the surrounding elementals stopped.

Simultaneously, Evan's mana wavered.

"Cough..."

Evan exhaled deeply.

He felt as though he had been hit in the chest, struggling to breathe.

The tree shook violently.

Though his body wasn't physically hit, Evan's mana was disrupted.

Just as Evan erased magic by cutting mana flow, Rudy had also pierced through the mana flow.

From the point Rudy pierced, cracks began to form.

Thus, the tree broke apart, and pieces of the shattered tree fell from the sky.

"Rudy... Astria..."

Evan looked at Rudy, astonished, as if he had never considered such a technique.

Rudy's skill involved manipulating mana flow, a tactic characteristic of Evan.

Evan never expected anyone else to use this technique.

Although there were papers on mana flow, there was no information on the ability to manipulate it.

"How's the punch?"

Rudy shouted as he fell from the sky and raised his fist again.

He didn't miss the moment when Evan was shaken.

"Ugh...!"

Evan barely managed to lift his sword again.

His mana was greatly disturbed, but if he couldn't withstand Rudy's attack now, it would mean defeat.

Evan gathered mana in his sword.

Roots from the surrounding trees sprang up.

Simultaneously, green-colored mana enveloped Evan's sword.

The roots, along with Evan's sword, aimed at Rudy falling from the sky.

"Evan."

Rudy smiled.

"Once, you were almost like a hero to me."

Rudy spoke, holding his fist.

Evan didn't understand what he meant.

That was only natural.

Rudy was referring to a time when he observed Evan in a different world.

In a world where Evan was a hero.

Rudy admired the Evan of that world.

In Rudy's heart, Evan was a superhuman.

That's why Rudy thought he could never replace Evan.

However, the Evan in reality was different from Rudy's thoughts.

Evan was just an ordinary boy, no different from himself.

He worked hard to cultivate his abilities, experienced failures, and wasn't particularly sociable.

Evan wasn't a superhuman or a hero.

He was just a boy struggling and making tremendous efforts.

This was the same for Rudy.

He wasn't a hero or a superhuman.

He was just someone struggling to protect those around him.

Although Rudy saw a future where he came closest to being a hero or superhuman, that too wasn't actually the case.

Even in that position, he couldn't protect everyone.

Realizing this, Rudy made a decision.

He wasn't replacing Evan's position nor was he a hero.

He couldn't overcome everything alone without the help of those around him.

Rudy understood his role.

'My role is to enable everyone to do what they must.'

And now, it was time to return Evan to his original place.

"Put your all into your sword."

Black flames surged in Rudy's fist.

Simultaneously, the mana stone on the back of his hand emitted an intense light.

"I'll put my all into this fist."

Mana around Rudy stirred violently.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 194: Direction (14)

A massive explosion occurred.

Rudy's fist collided with Evan's sword, and the forest Evan had created was devastated.

Smoke billowed up.

Black sparks flew around.

Thud. Thud.

With a slight pause, the sound of ash being trampled on was heard.

"It's my victory... Evan."

Rudy, wiping the blood flowing down his head, spoke.

"Kuh..."

Evan lay on the ground, groaning.

At a glance, Evan seemed less injured than Rudy.

However, he had internal injuries, blood dripping from his mouth, unable to get up.

Rudy looked down at Evan.

Next to Evan lay his broken sword.

"Rudy... Astria..."

"With no direction and no conviction, you can't beat me."

It was a matter of willpower.

When Evan and Rudy last clashed.

Rudy suffered external injuries, while Evan was shocked by mana.

It wouldn't have been strange for either to fall.

However, their wills were different.

Rudy endured the pain attacking his body.

Even if it felt like his body was breaking, even if he wanted to escape the pain.

He punched out.

Evan was defeated by that will.

Evan's mana faltered before Rudy could escape the pain.

Evan thought to himself.

What is this guy, really?

He seemed strange from afar, but even stranger up close.

Even with great strength, one can fear the future and doubt their own will.

Rudy did not.

He pushed forward with a straight will and pure conviction.

The difference between himself and Rudy felt even more pronounced.

Evan, aimlessly driven only by the desire to beat Rudy, felt different in his will from Rudy.

Evan had the word 'defeat' in his heart.

He repeated to himself that he shouldn't lose, but also wondered if it would matter if he did.

Evan wanted victory for the sake of victory.

He didn't think he had to do anything with his victories.

At the same time, he didn't believe any particular outcome would result from defeat.

Evan looked at Rudy with empty eyes.

"You... what exactly..."

What makes his will so strong?

What goal does he have, what is he looking at?

As Evan harbored these questions, Rudy sat beside him.

"Sigh, you really have a tough life."

Rudy sighed, looking at Evan.

"Stop wandering aimlessly, and find a proper place for yourself. What's going to change if you just sulk in the dark? Study and train at your own pace, and make friends, socialize a bit."

Though Rudy said this, these words were also meant for his past self.

Evan, as he was now, seemed no different from his past self.

He appeared to be running aimlessly forward, without any particular goal in sight.

"Don't get involved with those weird rebels or anything."

“...What?”

Evan's eyes widened at Rudy's words.

His investigations into the rebels were something Evan had conducted very secretly.

“If you think you align with the rebels' objectives, I won't stop you, but from what I see, you and the rebels don't really match.”

The rebels aimed to change the world.

They were willing to do anything for the future peace, even if it meant sacrifices now.

Such objectives didn't suit Evan.

Rudy felt the same way about himself.

Both of them just wanted their close ones to live peacefully and stably.

Rather than achieving sudden big changes, they preferred maintaining current peace, even if it meant changing things slowly.

Evan looked at Rudy, who lay there lazily, and said,

“What do you know about me to talk like that?”

“Probably more than you think?”

“We haven't even had a proper conversation until today.”

“Often talking doesn't really mean you know someone, does it?”

“Ha...!”

Evan laughed incredulously at Rudy's words.

Rudy knew he had been in contact with the rebels and claimed to know him well?

Evan silently glared at Rudy and then spoke.

“Are you gay?”

“You crazy...”

Rudy clenched his fist and looked at Evan.

“You need to be hit more, huh? Want more?”

“...No, that’s enough.”

After asking such an absurd question, Evan took a deep breath.

It had been a while since he had laid down so leisurely.

While lying there comfortably, Evan asked Rudy,

“Rudy Astria, you said you know a lot about me.”

“Yeah.”

Evan quietly clenched his fist.

“So, what should I do now?”

Evan had keenly felt the difference between himself and Rudy during this encounter.

Rudy had a goal and was working towards it.

That’s why his will was exceptional.

It was something Evan could not dare to surpass.

No matter how hard he tried, he felt he could never surpass that will, nor could he take the top position.

So, what should he do now?

He had nowhere else to go.

Thus, Evan asked Rudy, grasping at straws.

Rudy frowned at Evan's question.

“What kind of question is that?”

“You said it yourself. Living aimlessly without conviction. I have nowhere to go.”

Rudy tilted his head, puzzled.

“Do you really need somewhere to go?”

“What?”

“Just enjoy life, you fool. Relax a bit. Just go with the flow, and you’ll find your answer. You’re not powerless, nor worried about the future. Just take it easy, and if you see someone struggling, help them out. You’re not some great person who needs a strong conviction.”

Evan narrowed his brows.

“You were talking about convictions, weren’t you?”

“That meant you couldn’t beat me because you lack conviction, not that you necessarily need to have one.”

Rudy spoke lightly.

There was no point in elaborating on convictions and goals here.

What Evan needed was time.

Time would bring him his own convictions and goals.

Feeling it himself is better than being told a hundred times.

In fact, telling too much might even lead to someone's downfall.

So, what Evan needed was time to think and rest.

Evan, who had always aimed for the top without any real purpose, must have been exhausted.

Taking a break from that burden and resting would surely bring some answers.

What comes next was not Rudy's job.

It was something Evan had to do himself.

“Well, then.”

“Hmm?”

Rudy stood up and looked at Evan.

“Now, just take one hit.”

“What?”

"That's the only way I can get your points."

Rudy grinned.

“I'll go easy on you, so just pass out in one hit, okay?”

“Ah, no. Why can't I just forfeit instead of being hit?”

“If you forfeit, I can't take your score.”

“You're going to be first anyway, do you need my score?”

“You never know. Some impressive guy might have scored higher than me.”

Rudy raised his fist.

“Here I go.”

“No!”

Rudy swung his fist, hitting Evan on the head.

“Cough! You crazy...”

“What, you didn’t pass out? Let’s do it again.”

Thump!

“Gah... You...”

“Hey, just pass out already.”

Thump!

“Agh!!”

“Pass out, will you?”

After about ten hits, Evan finally lost consciousness.

His forehead was reddened with bruises, and a few lumps were visible on his head.

Looking at the fallen Evan, Rudy had a pleased smile on his lips.

“Ah, that was refreshing.”

It was Rudy's own form of revenge.

A retaliation for all the frustrating actions Evan had taken until now.

And the headaches caused by Evan's attempt to contact the rebels.

Still, since Evan hadn't caused any major disasters, Rudy let him off with a few slaps and bumps.

Thus, Evan was carried away by the instructors and eliminated from the assessment.

“But when will this end?”

The sun was gradually setting.

Without a watch, it was hard to tell the time, but it seemed like it was reaching the end.

“I should just rest...”

Rudy staggered, looking for a sunny spot to sit on a rock.

Whoosh—

Just then, a small stone flew towards him.

"Ah?"

Rudy noticed the incoming stone.

But.

Thump—

He couldn't dodge it.

Having used too much mana and being in a disheveled state, he could only watch as the stone approached him.

The stone hit Rudy squarely on the head, and he immediately...

“Damn it...”

Collapsed.

“What?”

The culprit who threw the stone was none other than Yeniel.

Yeniel stepped forward and looked down at Rudy lying at her feet.

“.....”

She hadn't expected him to collapse so easily from such an attack.

Yeniel had only come to check.

She had come to the mountain intending to challenge Rudy since McDowell had instructed her to achieve good results.

Of course, she had thought of taking advantage of the fierce battle that had occurred at the summit, but she hadn't planned on winning so easily.

Yeniel looked down at Rudy, clicked her tongue, and muttered to herself.

"Well, he's down, so he's down."

Beep—

Just as Yeniel was speaking to herself, a loud sound echoed through the mountain.

"The joint assessment for first and second years is now concluded."

“What’s he doing?”

Cromwell watched Rudy's situation with an incredulous look.

Who would have thought Rudy, who withstood a dragon ravaging half the mountain and Evan using an unbelievable technique, would collapse from a mere stone?

“If you win a fight, you should run away or do something.”

It was entirely Rudy’s fault.

Even if it hadn’t been Yeniel, whoever arrived there would have ended up in the same situation.

Rudy was a fool for letting his guard down after defeating Evan.

“That’s just unbelievable.”

The instructors around Cromwell shared the same expression.

Rudy’s performance during the assessment had been bold and wise, impressive enough to move even the instructors.

But what good was that?

Cromwell, feeling exasperated, spoke.

“So, Yeniel is the winner. The principal will be pleased.”

Having said that, Cromwell stood up and looked at the instructors.

“Take care of the students. Treat the injured ones. And send a good healing wizard to that foolish Rudy. So he doesn’t feel too aggrieved when he sees his injuries after waking up.”

“.....Yes, understood.”

With that, Cromwell and the instructors headed towards the mountain where the joint assessment took place.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 195: Jefrin (1)

After the joint assessment ended, Evan met with Yeniel and had a conversation.

It wasn't a profound discussion.

Just ordinary talk about each other's well-being.

They talked about what happened during the joint assessment.

The determination he felt from Rudy Astria.

It was different from Evan's.

Rudy didn't hesitate.

There was no doubt in his actions.

He was confident in what he was doing and acted accordingly.

"Having fought him directly, I now understand what you meant."

"So, what are you going to do now?"

Yeniel asked, and Evan responded with a smile.

"Just take a break. But that doesn't mean I've given up on the top position. I'll still aim for it."

The fight with Rudy hadn't changed Evan significantly.

He changed just a little.

His problems were far from resolved.

He still didn't know where to go or what goals to pursue.

However, Evan felt relieved.

For someone like him who had never discussed his concerns or himself with anyone, the fight and conversation with Rudy lightened his heart.

It felt like a festering inflammation had finally been drained.

"You've changed a bit."

Yeniel noticed this too.

The change in Evan's expression was evident.

And now.

Evan stood in front of the hospital room where Rudy Astria was, holding a fruit basket.

He thought of apologizing since he was the one who injured Rudy, but since Evan himself was injured by Rudy, he felt no need to apologize.

The reason Evan wasn't hospitalized despite being injured was because most of his injuries were internal.

Compared to external injuries, there wasn't much the hospital could do for internal injuries.

If his organs were damaged, medication would suffice, and mana would naturally recover over time.

After some contemplation, Evan prepared to enter.

“Ahem...”

He cleared his throat and raised his hand to knock.

“You idiot!!!”

At that moment, a loud voice came from inside the room.

Evan frowned and opened the door.

“Rie! Rudy is a patient!!”

“Better to ask us to stay around! Idiot!!”

“No, I thought that’s what would happen!”

“How pathetic, senior.”

Rudy was sitting up in bed, leaning back.

In front of him, Rie was furiously pacing, Luna was trying to calm her down, and Yuni was laughing at Rudy.

“Rudy Astria?”

Evan, seeing this, called Rudy's name.

Everyone's eyes then turned to Evan.

“...Evan?”

They all looked at Evan with puzzled expressions.

However, Rudy looked at the fruit basket in Evan's hand and smiled.

"Are you here for a visit?"

"...Yes, though it seems at a bad time."

"No! You came at a good time."

At that, Rie glared at Rudy sharply.

Rudy ignored Rie's scorching gaze and reached out towards the front of the bed.

"If you've come for a visit, sit down."

Evan placed the basket in a corner of the room and sat down on a chair.

"It looks like everyone is close."

Rudy glanced at Rie and commented.

"You seem to be in good condition."

"I received a lot of healing magic before arriving at the hospital, so there wasn't much to treat."

Rudy shrugged with a subtle expression.

"Leaving that aside."

Rudy stared intently at Evan.

"Have you sorted out your thoughts?"

"Somewhat. I don't know where to go yet, but I've realized what I shouldn't do."

Evan spoke, seemingly relieved, and Rudy seemed satisfied.

"Your expression looks much better than before."

"Does it?"

Evan's face now had more variety.

Different from before, when his face seemed to carry the weight of the world's worries, casting a shadow over it.

There was more diversity in his expressions, and the dark circles under his eyes had diminished.

The changes were a result of his worries fading and him sleeping better.

Evan briefly chatted and then stood up from his seat.

"Since you seem alright, I should leave."

Evan had come to offer condolences since Rudy had lost the first place to Yeniel.

Seeing that Rudy's expression didn't seem too bad despite losing first place, Evan felt there was no reason to stay.

"Ah, Evan. Take this."

As Evan was about to leave, Rudy handed him an envelope that was nearby.

"...What's this?"

"Open it in your room alone. Don't talk about its contents with anyone else."

Evan looked at the envelope with curiosity.

Seeing his expression, Rudy waved his hand a few times.

"It's nothing big. Just a small favor."

Evan narrowed his eyes and looked at Rudy.

"Alright. If it's not too difficult, I'll consider it."

"Good, try to accept it if possible. It'll be a big help to everyone."

Evan nodded at Rudy's words, then left the hospital room.

Returning to his room, Evan stared intently at the envelope Rudy had handed him.

He took out a letter opener and carefully opened the envelope.

Inside was a paper that resembled a letter.

Evan took out the paper and skimmed through its contents.

"...What?"

Evan looked at the contents in disbelief.

The message written on the paper:

Rudy was planning to target the Rebels.

"...He says this isn't a big deal?"

Evan uttered to himself in disbelief.

There was a man walking down the street, his hood up, scanning his surroundings.

"Hey! Don't run!"

Nearby, three or four children were playing, and a woman, who seemed to be their mother, was scolding them.

"Hey, you there!"

"Hahaha! Try and catch me!"

The children ran around without looking ahead.

"Ah!"

One of the children, running forward, bumped into the man.

"Oh, I'm so sorry."

The children's mother, seeing her child bump into the man, quickly rushed over.

As she apologized and looked up at the man's face.

"...Gasp."

She gasped upon recognizing him.

The man was Aryandor, the leader of the Rebels.

Even a common woman knew his face due to the widespread wanted posters from the Empire.

This area was under Rebel control.

To these people, the leader of the Rebels was like the Emperor himself.

An untouchable figure.

"I'm so sorry. Are you okay?"

The mother was at a loss for words, unsure of how to act.

'The leader of the Rebels is said to be a ruthless being.'

That was the impression given by the wanted posters distributed by the Empire.

Unforgiving and cruel, someone to flee from at first sight.

Aryandor didn't respond but reached out to the child.

"Please, just spare my child...!"

Just as the mother was about to scream,

"Look ahead when you walk. It's dangerous to run like that."

Aryandor said, smiling and helping the child up.

He then dusted off the dirt from the child's clothes.

The mother watched in disbelief.

"Are... are you okay...?"

"It's normal for kids to run around and bump into things. I'm fine."

Aryandor looked at the child.

"The child seems to be a bit hurt from the fall, so go to the Rebels and ask for medicinal herbs. They will give you some."

The mother's eyes welled up with tears upon hearing this.

Before the Rebels took over this territory, there had been many stories of children clashing with the nobles.

Even for minor accidents, the nobles had imposed harsh punishments on children.

Yet here was Aryandor, lifting the child himself and offering medicine.

"Th-thank you."

"No need to thank me. It's just the right thing to do."

Aryandor smiled and said.

"Leader."

Then, a girl approached from behind.

Dressed like a witch, with a pointed hat and carrying a staff, it was Jefrin.

"What is it?"

Jefrin spoke quietly.

"A letter has arrived from Evan."

Aryandor's expression hardened.

"...Let's go back and talk about it."

As Aryandor moved to leave, the mother bowed respectfully.

"Thank you!"

Aryandor simply smiled in response.

Jefrin watched Aryandor with a curious tilt of her* head.

"Who is that person?"

"Just a commoner. Speaking of which, it seems there's a lack of space for children to play. They could get hit by carriages if they play in the streets like this. Tell them to create a separate play area."

Hearing Aryandor's words, Jefrin nodded.

Such orders weren't unusual, so she didn't react much.

"So, what's this about a letter from Evan?"

"He's under suspicion. He's asking us to come and get him."

"Come and get him?"

"It's difficult for him to escape the academy's scrutiny."

At Jefrin's words, Aryandor furrowed his brow.

"What do you plan to do?"

In the past, Aryandor would have looked into the future upon hearing such news.

However, he could no longer use that ability.

Even when Aryandor saw the future, events never unfolded as predicted, especially when it involved the academy.

Among all the futures he had seen, Evan was the most troubling.

Yet, the fact that Evan was willing to join the Rebels was too good an opportunity to pass up.

That's why it felt so unsettling.

"How many assassins do we have available?"

"Only three or four."

"Send only them."

"Just the assassins?"

Assassins were good at hiding but not particularly strong.

If someone powerful from the academy pursued Evan, they wouldn't be able to shake them off.

"Isn't this a great opportunity? Shouldn't we send someone more capable?"

"It's dangerous."

"If it's dangerous, shouldn't we send stronger people?"

Despite her argument, Aryandor showed little reaction.

Jefferin bit her lip, then tapped her chest.

"Then I will go."

"You? Going there?"

"If someone pursues us, I can use illusion magic to lose them. There shouldn't be any problems."

Aryandor found it odd that Jefrin was so eager to go.

She was usually indifferent to her surroundings, focusing solely on her magic research.

Yet, here she was, insisting on going herself.

Aryandor didn't understand but decided to respect her wish.

"If that's what you want, do so. However, you'll be responsible for your actions."

At Aryandor's words, Jefrin smiled.

"Understood."

*Alright I am sorry, I dunno why but Jefrin just happens to be my biggest weakness. So later chapters tell me Jefrin is indeed a girl. So Jefrin will be once again referred to as female...

If all of sudden Jefrin's actually a guy... I might have to hang it up.

Toggle New Ads

Chapter 196: Jefrin (2)

Everyone in the student council room was busily moving about.

Kuhn and Emily were transferring documents, while Rie worked quickly with her hands.

Even students who weren't part of the student council were helping out.

The reason for this hustle and bustle was the approaching end of the semester.

After the final exams, there's a transition period before the new student council takes over.

At Liberion Academy, the student council's term always ended with the final exams.

To avoid handing over a pile of unfinished work to the next council, they had to get ahead on tasks during this transition period.

So, the student council was swamped with an avalanche of tasks.

Starting from various odd jobs to managing dormitory facilities, and preparing the handover for the next council.

There was a mountain of work to be done.

"Maybe it would be better to work during the winter break instead,"

Kuhn mumbled, a sentiment everyone agreed with.

But agreement didn't mean slowing down.

There wasn't even time to discuss it.

At that moment, Yuni entered the student council room.

"Did you call me?"

"Yuni, you're here!"

Rie's face brightened up.

She had asked for her help, seeing that Yuni had been rather idle lately.

"Thanks, Yuni."

"Oh, it's nothing if you asks."

"Then, could you help with these tasks?"

Yuni took the documents from Rie and looked around.

"...But where's Rudy?"

At Yuni's question, Rie flinched slightly.

"Rudy has other tasks, so he's somewhere else right now."

"Busy? What's he busy with?"

Yuni's question made Rie glance around.

With so many people in the student council room, it was hard to speak freely.

"He's preparing something else."

Rie spoke vaguely.

Yuni put down the documents on the desk.

"Then wouldn't Rudy also be busy? Is there anyone else helping him?"

"Don't worry. It's a task the professors agreed to help with."

Rie reassured her, sending Yuni a subtle look.

Something was off.

Yuni had never shown such concern for someone else.

Rie had felt this strangeness in Yuni since the joint assessment.

An unusual kindness, uncharacteristic of Yuni.

While typically indifferent to others, she showed particular interest in Rudy.

It was too strange to ignore.

Yuni's change coincided perfectly with certain events.

She was comforted by Rudy during the individual assessment and rescued by him during the joint assessment.

Though Rie didn't know the details, the situations didn't seem promising.

Given Rudy's past actions, suspicion was warranted.

'Could it be that Yuni... has feelings for Rudy?'

Rie looked at Yuni doubtfully.

Of course, the relationship between Yuni and Rudy hadn't changed much.

From the beginning, Yuni always followed Rudy around, and her attitude towards him hadn't changed much either.

Despite her doubts, Rie couldn't let her guard down.

Already feeling uneasy, Rie was busy in her own right, and so was Rudy.

Amidst this, there were major obstacles like Luna and Astina.

Luna, not being as busy as the vice president Rie, could meet Rudy whenever he was free.

Same with Astina, but Rudy was too occupied to spare time.

Since becoming second-year students, they hadn't hung out leisurely.

Busy schedules and Rie's constant monitoring of Luna prevented it.

Fortunately, Astina hadn't shown much activity.

She wasn't particularly busy.

Though she had family duties, her father was handling them.

Astina focused solely on training.

Rie found it odd that Astina, who usually took the opportunity to approach Rudy during busy times, showed no such movements now.

Despite constant surveillance by elementals, Astina just shuttled between the dormitory and the training ground.

This focus allowed Rie to concentrate on student council work, but the current situation was problematic.

Yuni, who had only just grown close to her at the academy, showing interest in the man Rie liked?

This could become more intense than fighting for the Royal throne.

Yuni had some interest in the throne but lacked passion.

If Yuni truly fell for Rudy, she would be unpredictable.

Yuni had never been so focused or dedicated to anything.

With no particular likes or hobbies, what if she genuinely desired something?

The thought was unbearable for Rie.

The idea of someone who never gambled getting addicted once they started was similar to how Yuni might behave.

"?"

Lost in her thoughts, Rie was brought back by Yuni's curious gaze.

"So, where's Rudy now?"

Exhaling deeply, Rie beckoned Yuni closer.

Yuni approached, and Rie whispered softly.

"Rudy isn't at the academy right now, so you can't see him."

"Not at the academy...!"

As Yuni reacted loudly, Rie quickly covered her mouth.

"It's confidential. Shh."

"...Okay."

"Ah... Also..."

Rie almost asked what Yuni thought about Rudy but held back.

"Never mind."

"Huh?"

Unable to ask, Rie was suddenly pulled by Yuni.

"What's going on? Why did you stop talking?"

"No, it's nothing. Oh, right. You seemed to be hiding something about Rudy and me. What was it?"

Rie quickly changed the topic.

"Oh, that? I had made a bet involving you."

"...Me?"

"Yes, we bet on who would win you, but it ended in a draw."

Yuni ranked second in the joint assessment.

She ended up with the same rank as Rudy.

The top spot for the first year was narrowly claimed by Kuhn.

The bet with Rudy ended up being nullified, just as they had discussed initially.

"So, I get to be here with my sister like this~."

Yuni smiled as she looked at Rie.

Seeing her smile, Rie couldn't help but smile too.

"Um... Rie, sorry to interrupt this warm moment, but..."

Then Kuhn cautiously spoke up.

"There's a lot of work pending... You need to hurry. There are documents that need to be submitted today..."

"Sigh... Alright."

Rie refocused on the paperwork, and Yuni continued reading the documents she was given.

While reading, Yuni hummed a tune and muttered to herself, barely audible.

"I wonder where Rudy is~."

In a dark space.

There, Jefrin and a few others were gathered.

"In a week, we head to the academy."

Jefrin was preparing a group of assassins for their mission.

"Our task is to bring a student from the academy to this place. It's not particularly difficult. However, since the student is well-known at the academy, we might be interrupted."

Jefrin tapped the floor with the staff in her hand as she walked.

"Our mission is to bring that person here, so let's focus on that."

Jefrin also distributed a few more documents.

These documents listed important figures at the academy.

"Fortunately, the principal is currently unwell, and the vice-principal will be traveling to the capital tomorrow. So, we don't need to worry much."

This information had come in a few days ago.

Responding to the Emperor's call, Vice-Principal Cromwell was heading to the capital.

The reason was a major meeting concerning internal affairs of the empire.

There was a significant internal division within the empire.

The Royal Chancellor Ophillius was strongly opposing the Astria Duke family.

It was almost time for Rie and Rudy's graduation.

A period when the successors to the Emperor's throne and the Duke's position could be determined.

All eyes were on the Astria Duke family.

There were questions about whether Ian was the right successor to the Astria Duke family.

While the head of a family usually decides on the successor, it wasn't entirely up to them.

The successor needed the agreement of the family's vassal houses and the Emperor's approval.

However, such matters were typically routine, and no one paid much attention.

Nobody opposed unless something utterly nonsensical happened.

Meanwhile, the Royal Chancellor Ophillius was discussing whether Ian was suitable for the position in the Duke's family.

Specifically, it was about giving Rudy a chance to compete for the empire's sake.

Rudy had been consistently showing remarkable achievements, and Ophillius argued that it made no sense to simply hand over the successor's position to Ian without considering Rudy.

This had led to a state of unrest in the empire.

While the division within the empire was beneficial for the rebels, in some ways, it was not good.

The mana stones used by the rebels mostly came from necromancers who were protected by the Astria family.

To continue receiving a stable supply of mana stones, Rudy should not inherit the Astria family.

However, for now, these circumstances were more advantageous.

With attention focused on the capital, it was easier to capture Evan.

"We will hide in the city near the academy and contact Evan. Then, we will escape to the forest in front and ride horses hidden there to another city."

Jefferin slowly laid out the plan and adjusted her hat.

"The operation begins in a week. Everyone, be ready by then."

"Understood."

After all the explanations, the assassins present left the room.

As the assassins left, Jefferin, looking tired, sat down in a nearby chair.

"Ugh..."

As she sat down, Jefferin expressed pain.

She clutched her heart and started gasping for breath.

A few minutes later, her breathing returned to normal.

However, there was something slightly odd.

Jefferin's hand had transformed into that of an old person, wrinkled and aged.

"This damned body... acting up again."

Jefferin stared at her hand and spoke.

She stood up and opened a drawer.

Inside the drawer were numerous potions.

She took one out and poured it into her mouth.

Jefferin's hand returned to that of a young girl.

"How long can I last like this?"

She muttered despairingly, but she had no intention of collapsing easily.

She had to persevere and survive until she obtained the research on immortality conducted by Levian.

To do so, she needed the leader of the rebels, Aryandor, and that was why Jefrin was cooperating with the rebels.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 197: Jefrin (3)

I was outside the academy.

Despite being busy with student council work, there was a reason I was here.

"That's not how you do it."

"Isn't this close enough?"

"No, not at all. Do it again."

The person admonishing me was Serina.

Priscilla placed her hand on my shoulder.

"Do your best."

Should it be considered a wolf's hand or paw?

It felt odd to be comforted by a wolf.

I was currently learning about elemental magic.

After the joint assessment, I had consulted with Cromwell.

The plan was to collaborate with Evan and draw in the rebels.

It was a strategy to diminish the power of the rebels.

However, Cromwell's absence from the academy was a problem.

He had gone to the capital for a meeting.

Originally, McDowell should have attended the meeting, but due to his condition, Cromwell went instead.

Cromwell and I had looked for a professor who could help us.

Someone knowledgeable about the rebels and capable of facing them.

The ideal person for such a task was Robert, but he was not currently at the academy.

He had taken a leave of absence for this semester.

Thus, the person I sought help from was Professor McGuire.

With Cromwell heading to the capital, McGuire, who was at a conference, returned to the academy.

The academy had a rule that a certain number of professors couldn't be away simultaneously.

If too many professors took leave or went on business trips, some of those who were out had to return.

Having too few professors in the academy posed a security risk and burdened the remaining faculty with work.

I couldn't expect much help from McGuire.

Being a research-oriented professor specialized in magical tools, he could only provide support with magical tools and was not capable of direct combat.

Research professors lacked both the physical endurance and experience in combat, performing worse in battle than Astina or me.

I had thought about asking Gracie for help, but Cromwell strongly opposed it.

Gracie was already in poor condition due to the midterm incident, so asking for her assistance was a bad idea.

Cromwell promised to return as soon as possible, but I couldn't rely solely on that.

Still, what had happened had happened.

I had to find a solution to the problem.

I wasn't sure who the rebels would send, but since they were attempting to recruit students directly from the academy, it was likely to be a formidable opponent.

So, I sent a letter to Astina.

Originally, I wanted to meet her in person, but she declined the meeting.

Not knowing the reason, I had no choice but to send a letter.

Astina readily accepted my request.

The next thing I did was to seek out Rie.

I entrusted the student council work to her and explained my situation in detail.

"Can I get some help from Serina?"

With dark magic, the current situation was a bit tricky.

I can't expect quick growth in magic within a short amount of time.

So, I chose elemental magic.

I had never properly learned elemental magic, so even a little learning could lead to significant growth compared to other skills.

"It's been a while, Rudy Astria. I've heard from Princess Rie."

That's how I came to meet Serina.

Dressed in black, befitting her royal secret service role, and her blue hair neatly tied up, she had changed much since the last time I saw her.

Initially, her impression was good.

Even though she once tried to kill me, she seemed different now.

She had even saved Luna and me, so there was no reason for me to dislike her.

However.

"Hmm... That's not how it's done."

Serina was not a good teacher.

"Think of it as handling mana. It's not Priscilla taking it directly from you, but you passing it to Priscilla."

"So... how do I do that..."

Already tired from continually using Priscilla, Serina's nagging was giving me a headache.

What exactly is mental strength, and how am I supposed to use it like mana?

Serina explained the method she learned from her mother.

The most efficient way to use Priscilla was not for her to draw out my energy, but for me to share it with her.

Even hearing this, I couldn't understand.

Priscilla is an elemental controlled using my mental strength.

To tell me to share my energy with Priscilla meant dividing my mental strength.

Can a person's mind be divided and shared like that?

Mental strength wasn't an energy I could handle like mana, and I had never felt it as an energy.

I merely relied on my senses and tried to do as Serina said, but it wasn't easy.

As I frowned, trying to figure it out on my own, Serina handed me a warm cup of tea.

"Let's take a break. This isn't something that gets better with more time."

"Yeah, thanks."

I took the tea from Serina and brought it to my lips.

"It'll be hard to do it in a week, as you said. Even my mother took a long time."

"Then, doing this will allow me to perfectly control Priscilla?"

"I'm not sure about perfectly. But you'll be able to control her enough to prevent a rampage."

"Not rampaging..."

That raised a question.

Why did Serina's mother pass away?

If she could control Priscilla to the extent of preventing a rampage, weren't there other ways?

As I harbored my doubts, Serina spoke first.

"My mother caused her own rampage."

I widened my eyes at Serina's words.

"She triggered it herself?"

To trigger a rampage meant she faced certain death by her own volition.

Who could she have possibly fought to be willing to face death?

Then Priscilla spoke.

"The opponent was incredibly powerful. She couldn't retreat, not with Serina behind her."

If Priscilla spoke so, it meant the opponent was indeed formidable.

I was curious.

"Who was the opponent?"

"I don't know... I only know that the opponent overwhelmed her with tremendous swordsmanship."

"Swordsmanship?"

"I've been investigating the incident lately."

Serina opened up.

"I found something about the last message left by my mother."

Serina pointed to a clock while speaking.

"Time. That was my mother's last message."

There was only one person that came to mind.

Aryandor, a wizard and swordmaster who wielded time magic.

As far as I knew, he was the only one who combined time and swordsmanship.

Serina must have been aware of this fact too.

"But I don't think the leader of the Rebels is the culprit."

"Because of the timing?"

"Yes, even considering appearance, it seems unlikely for someone of that age to possess such skills at that time. It doesn't quite add up."

The issue was the timing.

Serina's mother passed away about 10 years ago.

It was around the time Robert was exiled from the empire, and Levian fled.

Aryandor appeared to be in his late twenties or early thirties.

So, 10 years ago, he would have been around my age.

Serina's mother was a royal elemental, a formidable force that no one could ignore.

It would have been difficult for Aryandor to match her skills at that time.

Moreover, it would have been strange if he possessed such skills then.

That was when Ephomos fell apart, Levian disappeared, and there were almost no notable figures in the empire.

If Aryandor had killed Serina's mother, a royal elemental, back then, he would have harbored resentment against the empire from that point.

It would have been odd not to form the Rebels then.

That was a time when many grew resentful of the empire.

The empire had swept through the lower classes, which was expected.

If he had resentment against the empire, finding like-minded allies and overthrowing the empire would have been easier then.

There was no reason to act now.

Therefore, the conclusion was one.

There exists someone else who can wield time magic besides Aryandor.

That reminds me, it was puzzling.

Where did Aryandor learn time magic from?

Time magic couldn't have just appeared out of nowhere.

The biggest question was, if time magic already existed, why didn't the empire know about it?

If there were such a powerful magic user, the empire wouldn't have just let it be.

They would have arranged for a good house, like the Astria family, to keep them close to the empire.

Time and space had that much value.

Then, I remembered someone.

The Saint.

The Saint could use dimensional magic that dealt with both time and space.

However, the Saint's dimensional magic fundamentally differed from Astria's space magic and Aryandor's time magic.

Dimensional magic could not influence the current time and space.

It could only observe the future or other spaces.

Moreover, it was hard to consider the Saint, given the use of swordsmanship.

"My head hurts."

What was supposed to be a relaxing time became more complicated.

"I'll keep looking into it as much as I can, and if I find something out, I'll let you know," Serina said.

I nodded in agreement and resumed training in elemental magic.

"Please find my sister. Then I'll do anything."

Aryandor recalled the past.

His own impoverished and dying time.

It was after he was separated from his sister, who lived with him in the burning Ephomos.

Aryandor wandered the capital in search of his only family, his sister.

While wandering the capital, Aryandor met someone.

And Aryandor's life completely changed.

He learned time magic and swordsmanship from that person.

He became a swordsman with tremendous abilities.

"Become a being that changes the world. When you've changed the world, I'll come back to you."

Those were the last words of 'that person' who taught him magic.

Aryandor parted ways without knowing that person's face, identity, or anything else.

He only left with a few names and the promise to come back later.

The list that person handed to Aryandor was said to contain individuals necessary to change the world, and Aryandor set out to find them.

The first person he met was Jefrin.

Jefrin was regarded as a great wizard of the empire, comparable to the grand wizard Levian of the same era.

Such a wizard was dying old and sick on the outskirts of the empire.

The empire had abandoned Jefrin.

In her youth, she was provided with great treatment and environment, but as she aged and fell ill, Jefrin was exiled to the outskirts.

There was no one to care for Jefrin.

Lying on an old bed, Jefrin said,

"I need to... surpass him... somehow surpass Levian..."

Jefrin was consumed by feelings of inferiority and hatred.

As a wizard born in the same era as Levian, she felt inferior, and she despised the empire that had abandoned her.

Aryandor reached out to her.

He granted her youth with time magic and delayed her illness with various potions.

However, time magic was not omnipotent.

Changing her appearance did not mean her insides were altered too.

Jefrin was dying.

There wasn't much time left.

To survive, Jefrin needed the magic of eternal life that Levian had researched.

Thus, Jefrin began to help Aryandor, seeking to acquire Levian's magic hidden somewhere in the empire and to bring down the empire she loathed.

"Leader."

While contemplating these thoughts, Jefrin entered Aryandor's room.

"I'm leaving now."

Aryandor looked at Jefrin.

"Take care."

"Understood."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 198: Jefrin (4)

Jefrin was always plagued by a sense of inferiority.

It was because Levian, another royal wizard, was always beside him.

If Jefrin was a genius born once in a hundred years, Levian was a once-in-a-thousand-years prodigy.

No matter how hard he struggled, Jefrin could never surpass Levian.

Even when others said Jefrin was on a similar level as Levian, it only disgusted him.

Levian and Jefrin were not on a level where comparison was possible.

Jefrin knew this better than anyone.

Yet, he kept trying.

To surpass Levian, to reach his achievements.

His inferiority complex drove Jefrin to grow.

He stayed up nights researching, producing numerous research achievements.

Thus, he became a great wizard revered by the empire's wizards.

However, as he continued to burn the midnight oil and push his body to the limits, it was inevitable that he wouldn't remain healthy.

Jefrin started to fall ill with various diseases, and as he aged, his condition progressively worsened.

Just as Jefrin's health began to deteriorate, Levian disappeared.

Neither the empire, Jefrin, nor anyone else knew why Levian had vanished.

With Levian gone, Jefrin took the top position as the royal wizard.

There was no longer anyone among the royal wizards who could be compared to Jefrin.

When such a situation finally arrived, it felt utterly hollow.

He had always strived to surpass Levian, but in the end, he didn't surpass him with his own abilities but reached his position for other reasons.

After Levian's disappearance, Jefrin's health continued to decline.

He could barely use magic properly, and even getting up became difficult.

As his condition worsened, the empire suggested he retire.

Given Jefrin's physical state, he couldn't even continue his research, let alone other duties, so he was advised to await death comfortably in the outskirts of the empire.

It was essentially an exile.

Jefrin could not object to this.

He had no one around him.

Not a single student, which any skilled wizard was supposed to have, nor any family member.

Jefrin had always lived for himself, focusing solely on his growth.

Therefore, when he became old and sick, there was no one around to speak for him.

Jefrin was sent away to the outskirts of the empire without a word.

Beside him, he only had the great fortune he had amassed during his time as a royal wizard.

But he couldn't use the money properly.

Jefrin, always absorbed in his research, didn't know how to indulge in luxury.

He just bought a small cabin on the outskirts of the empire and hired someone to take care of his illness.

Jefrin, unlike the end befitting a great wizard, died alone and forlorn in the outskirts of the empire.

As he was about to face his end, Jefrin encountered Aryandor.

When Jefrin met him, Aryandor was just a teenager in his late teens.

It was Aryandor who saved his life.

He rejuvenated Jefrin's aging body with time magic, a spell Jefrin had never seen in his life.

However, Jefrin was not completely revived.

He regained his younger body, but was still afflicted with various illnesses.

Additionally, the state of his mana remained unchanged.

Though he appeared younger on the outside, the condition of his insides could not defy his age.

Jefrin's life was briefly extended, but he couldn't solve the fundamental problem.

It was then that Jefrin learned about the magic of immortality, which necromancers and Levian had been researching.

Hearing about this magic sparked various thoughts in him.

Could he surpass Levian if he continued to live?

He could achieve the lifelong goal he had held.

Jefrin felt hope.

Thus, he joined the Rebels.

He helped Aryandor, who had saved him, striving to continue living.

However, as time passed, Jefrin began to give up on his goal.

The magic that promised eternal life turned out to be nothing but an illusion.

The research was incomplete, and Levian, who had been conducting it, had disappeared, causing the flame of hope to slowly extinguish.

So, Jefrin changed his goal.

He decided to give his all to the Rebels.

To help Aryandor until his death.

It was during this resolve that he met Evan.

Evan, steeped in inferiority and seemingly on the verge of breaking at the slightest touch, reminded Jefrin of himself.

Jefrin felt a sense of kinship.

He had looked at the world through similar eyes as Evan since his youth.

That's why he tried to bring Evan into the Rebels.

It was merely out of sympathy.

Jefferin thought if he had met Aryandor a little earlier, instead of trying to surpass Levian, he could have had a different goal and his life would be different now.

He intended to give Evan a new purpose, not to lead him down the same path as himself.

Jefferin dismounted his horse and spoke to the assassins beside him.

"We're almost there. We've agreed to meet at the cabin near the forest. Hide nearby."

"Understood."

Jefferin flipped his hood over his face to conceal it.

The assassins dispersed into the surroundings, hiding their presence, and Jefferin slowly walked towards the cabin ahead.

Inside the cabin was Evan.

Like Jefferin, Evan was also wearing his hood.

"It's been a while, Evan."

"It has been a while."

"Did you have any trouble getting here?"

"Fortunately, I was able to escape unnoticed."

Students couldn't leave the academy at night unless it was for family or clan matters.

Therefore, Jefferin had forged documents in advance and sent them to the academy, facilitating Evan's escape at night.

Thanks to that, Evan was able to leave easily.

"Then, let's get moving."

"Understood."

As Jefrin and Evan were about to leave the cabin, Evan's hood was slightly lifted, revealing his eyes.

"...?"

A firm gaze.

These were not the eyes Jefrin had seen when he first met Evan.

They were not filled with despair and inferiority, but were just ordinary, steady eyes.

"Wait a moment."

Jefrin reached out his hand towards Evan.

"First, I need to confirm if it's really you. Take off that hood."

At Jefrin's request, Evan frowned.

He was puzzled by this sudden demand.

Wondering if taking off the hood would cause any significant trouble, Evan flipped it back.

"...What?"

This Evan looked completely different from the last time Jefrin had seen him.

There was no trace of the despair-ridden, motivation-less feeling or the eyes filled with anger due to inferiority.

Instead, they looked perfectly ordinary.

'Did I see him wrong that time?'

That seemed impossible.

Even if his current physical state wasn't normal, he wouldn't make such a mistake.

So, were the eyes he saw back then an act?

That didn't make sense either.

The eyes of Evan he had seen before couldn't be faked.

They were fundamentally different, something that couldn't be found in an ordinary person.

Jefrin asked,

"Who are you?"

"...What do you mean by that?"

Evan expressed his confusion at Jefrin's words.

His appearance hadn't changed; he was still himself.

He couldn't understand the intent behind Jefrin's question.

Jefrin quickly judged the situation.

Was there a reason to take this now-ordinary-looking Evan with him?

In terms of ability, Evan was a guy Aryandor had to be wary of, so there was no need for suspicion there.

But, could this guy betray the Rebels?

Could he truly become one with the Rebels?

That was a different matter.

The Rebels were a group of somewhat broken individuals.

They lacked or missed something that normal people didn't.

That's what allowed them to do anything for their cause.

Even things that ordinary people couldn't imagine, they could do without hesitation.

'I was foolish.'

He had felt a sense of kinship after briefly seeing Evan and made a foolish decision.

Evan was described as a great threat by Aryandor.

Instead of trying to recruit Evan as an ally, Jefrin should have come to kill him.

That would have been the right decision.

He felt pathetic for feeling a sense of kinship based on one encounter and trying to take him in as an ally.

Taking this guy with him could only lead to a high chance of betrayal.

An ordinary person would not just stand by after seeing the actions of the Rebels.

It would only endanger them.

Nevertheless, Evan was a capable individual, so Jefrin knew he had to kill him right there.

There was no reason to leave a potential future problem unresolved.

"Evan, I'm sorry to have called you out here, but this is where it ends."

Jefrin started to mobilize his mana.

Evan's eyes widened at this.

"Gasp...!"

Quickly, Evan drew his sword from his waist.

Boom!

As soon as Evan drew his sword, a huge explosion occurred.

The cabin shattered into pieces under the force of Jefrin's magic.

"Ugh... what's happening, all of a sudden...?"

Evan emerged from the explosion.

He hadn't done anything that could have been perceived as betrayal.

Yet, the sudden attack left him no time to react.

Already at a disadvantage without his original sword, which had been destroyed in the joint assessment, Evan suffered burns on his arm, unable to use its magic-nullifying ability.

"He's still not down."

Jefrin slowly emerged from the rubble of the destroyed cabin, a fierce killing intent swirling in his eyes.

"Why are you doing this all of a sudden?"

"It's simply because you've become useless."

Evan glared at Jefrin.

The last time he saw him, Jefrin had seemed almost childlike.

His actions were light, but now, he was completely different.

Although the face under the hood looked like a girl, the eyes were empty.

They were the eyes of someone who had been through dozens of battlefields.

“Cough...”

Jefrin, approaching Evan as if to kill him, suddenly clutched his heart.

“Again, this...”

‘This is my chance...’

Evan, clutching his burned arm, turned and ran.

“Catch him.”

Though it was a faint voice, the assassins responded and moved.

They began to chase after Evan.

Evan, fleeing from the assassins, used magic.

“Nature's Healing...!”

Fortunately, the cabin had been in the woods.

Blue light emanated from the trees in the forest, converging on Evan.

The light gradually began to heal his arm.

“Cough...”

However, Evan was still not fully recovered from his internal injuries.

Before his arm was completely healed, his mana refused to cooperate.

Pain as if his intestines were twisted assaulted him.

But he couldn't stop; standing still meant certain death.

Although things hadn't gone as planned, escaping the area was his priority.

As he ran, he lost sight of the assassins and Jefrin.

“Are they hiding?”

Under normal circumstances, he might have used the mana of the forest to locate them, but he couldn't afford to do that now.

Unless it was to block an attack, using mana felt too risky.

“Evan.”

Just then, a voice called out.

“...Rudy Astria!”

A blonde man emerged in the distance, revealing himself.

It was Rudy Astria.

Seeing him, Evan stopped in his tracks.

"It's serious, Rudy Astria. Jefrin suddenly attacked me."

Evan quickly explained the situation.

However, Rudy, without saying a word, walked towards him.

Evan felt something was off.

"...Rudy Astria?"

He scrutinized the figure before him.

There was a sense of discordance about it.

Evan swiftly raised his sword.

"...An illusion?"

The figure was unmistakably Rudy Astria, but it lacked Rudy's distinctive aura.

Despite wearing gloves on his hands and the same attire Evan had seen earlier, something about him didn't feel quite right.

Especially the way he moved, stepping silently and cautiously, resembled the gait of an assassin.

Evan recognized this manner of walking, as it was similar to how Yeniel moved.

The assassin disguised as Rudy Astria pulled out a dagger and threw it at Evan.

Evan deflected the dagger with his sword and started running again.

‘Are they showing me a figure that I would feel safe around?’

The applications of illusion magic are endless.

It can make the caster appear as anything they desire or show different figures to different observers.

First, he needed to get away.

The plan he had made with Rudy was to attack when they were relaxed and mounted on their horses.

Since an explosion had just occurred, they would surely come this way.

Evan needed time until Rudy arrived.

So, he ran.

He ran to buy time.

A few minutes into his run, something felt off.

He kept feeling like he was going in circles.

‘Is this also illusion magic...? Did they cast it over the entire forest?’

Continuously seeing the same surroundings, his sense of direction became vague.

It was hard to tell whether he was really going in circles or just imagining it.

“Ugh...”

He needed to break the illusion.

Evan tried to recalibrate his disoriented sense of direction by manipulating mana.

“Evan.”

“Evan.”

“Evan.”

Before he could use the magic, he saw around a dozen figures of Rudy Astria around him.

‘Is this also an illusion...? Or is it making the assassins appear differently?’

The confusion compounded, further disorienting Evan.

“Evan... You must die.”

“Evan, you're not needed.”

Figures with Rudy Astria's face uttered strange words as they walked towards him.

“Ha...”

Evan let out a laugh at the sight.

"You guys have got it all wrong."

Seeing the face now, Rudy Astria's was indeed the most comforting to Evan.

But that didn't mean Evan would be deeply hurt by hearing such words from Rudy Astria.

Having realized something during the joint assessment, Evan decided to break away from Rudy Astria and follow his own path.

Evan, determined to walk his own way, wouldn't be provoked if the real Rudy Astria said such things.

Not being greatly influenced by Rudy Astria and finding his own goals was Evan's way.

'I'll just face them.'

Evan looked at his adversaries with steady eyes and calmly manipulated his mana.

He charged at the figures of Rudy Astria with his sword in hand.

He wielded the sword enveloped in mana gathered from the forest.

He cut down the figure of Rudy Astria.

“Huh?”

But, unlike before, the figure resembling Rudy Astria was not an assassin.

Even as Evan cut through them, they disappeared like smoke, with no sense of impact.

However, not all were illusions.

Among the several figures of Rudy Astria, daggers flew towards him.

Amidst the illusion, there were real threats.

“Ugh...”

Evan did his best to fend off the daggers while cutting down the Rudy Astria figures.

But he couldn't keep it up indefinitely.

Thump—

“Ugh.”

Pain inflicted by the mana coursed through his body.

His movements were being hindered.

Evan doubled over in agony.

The assassins didn't miss this opportunity.

As Evan was about to collapse, they rushed in.

“Ha...”

As Evan felt multiple pains and saw them rushing in, he lifted his head in resignation.

Looking up, someone was falling from the sky, also bearing Rudy Astria's face.

“This is the end.....”

“Evan.”

The Rudy Astria figure falling from the sky called out his name.

“You held up well.”

“Huh?”

The Rudy Astria figure from the sky moved his mana.

“Finger of the Demon.”

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 199: Jefrin (5)

"Rudy, have you been well all this time?"

"Why don't you show your face more often? What have you been up to recently?"

"I've just been training alone."

10 minutes before Jefrin arrived.

I met with Astina.

It was a bit late for our meeting, but since there wasn't anything to prepare beforehand, it didn't really matter.

We hid atop a tree and chatted.

"You've heard about the plan, right?"

"Yeah, but it doesn't seem like much of a plan, actually."

Astina was right.

The real issue was luring the rebels here, not handling them, unless Aryandor himself showed up.

This place was a city right in front of the academy.

There were more than enough people to call for help.

So, having successfully drawn in the enemy, it was as if everything was already over.

"But lately, you seem a bit off."

"...Me?"

"Yes, I've been wanting to ask you..."

Boom—

That's when a massive explosion occurred.

I abruptly stood up from my seat.

The explosion had happened at the cabin where Evan and the rebels were supposed to meet.

This was no time for idle chat.

"Astina!"

"I know. Gravity."

Astina immediately manipulated her mana to lift both herself and me into the air, speeding towards the location.

Arriving near the cabin, all we saw were its charred remains.

"What happened here?"

"I'm not sure, but let's see."

I looked towards the forest.

It couldn't have been Evan who caused the explosion.

Knowing we were at a distance, he wouldn't do something so reckless.

Especially since he was already injured.

"Did the rebels attack first?"

I couldn't be sure of the reason, but looking towards the front of the forest, I could guess who had come.

There lay a magical device.

Its appearance was similar to the devices used by the rebels when they attacked the academy.

So, the visitor's identity was somewhat apparent.

"Jefrin?"

Such stationary magical devices needed precise coordinates to be set up, not something just anyone could do.

Of the rebel leaders we knew, only Jefrin had the capability to use such devices.

Unless they had recruited new members, Jefrin was the only one who came to mind.

"We should look for Evan first."

Astina said so, ready to enter the forest.

I grabbed her arm.

"We can't. We don't know what might happen in the forest."

If there were already devices set up, it meant illusion magic was in play.

Entering recklessly could lead to unpredictable consequences.

"Let's look for Evan from the sky."

"From the sky?"

Astina tilted her head at my suggestion.

Searching for someone on the ground from above the trees seemed like a nonsensical idea.

I was well aware of that.

But that was when searching with the naked eye.

I had another method.

"There's no time to explain."

"...Understood."

Astina lifted me into the air again.

At the same time, I closed my eyes.

What I had practiced most was sensing the flow of mana.

When returning from the Railer family to the academy, Robert taught me to sense the flow of mana to overcome necromancy spells.

Robert never teaches anything frivolously.

He is a mentor who imparts truly necessary skills at the right time.

So, he must have believed this ability was crucial for me and taught it accordingly.

Since returning to the academy, I hadn't slacked off a single day and had honed this skill.

I read the overall flow of mana.

I couldn't discern distant spaces, but I could check for people under the trees.

Without hearing any sound.

Without seeing anything.

Mana moves.

I read its movement.

There were people there.

As I read the mana, something strange happened.

A strong mana reaction emerged from the west.

It wasn't coming from a person.

The trees were moving the mana.

Evan's magic.

A technique that draws mana from trees.

I quickly caught on.

I opened my eyes, which had been shut, and looked in the direction where I had sensed the mana.

Normally, Evan's power would have made the trees glow brilliantly, but there was no such sight.

I couldn't see it with the naked eye, but I definitely felt the movement of mana there.

"...Astina. Could you head west?"

"West?"

Astina changed her flying direction to the west.

Arriving where the mana had moved, I looked at Astina.

"I'll go down."

"What? I'll come down too."

"No, you can't. Just in case, it's better for Astina to stay outside. There's no benefit in us all entering an illusion spell together."

Although Astina was stronger and it might be better for her to go down, I couldn't stay in the air forever.

Astina staying behind to keep watch from above was the better option.

"Then, I'll be back."

"Rudy Astria."

Astina suddenly grabbed my arm.

Then she bit her lower lip.

"No, never mind. Take care and don't get hurt."

Holding onto me and not saying much, I tilted my head in confusion.

But it wasn't the time to pry, so I just nodded.

"I'll go."

Astina released the magic that was lifting me, and I fell downwards.

Entering the forest, I saw Evan surrounded by people.

"Hm?"

The people surrounding Evan all had my face.

"What's that about? It's unsettling."

I frowned and looked at Evan.

He seemed resigned, staring up at the sky.

"Evan."

I called out to him, then chuckled.

"You've held up well."

I moved my mana.

First, I needed to distract their attention.

"Finger of the Demon."

Black pillars fell from the sky.

The people below, hearing my voice, scattered around.

But spreading out didn't mean they could avoid all my magic.

Several of them, bearing my appearance, were hit directly by my magic and vanished like smoke.

"An illusion?"

That meant among those who dodged, there were illusions too.

It would have been more troublesome if all those below had been real people, but knowing they were illusions, there was less to fear.

"Rudy Astria...!"

"Stay hidden and don't move."

I barked at Evan and took a deep breath.

I focused.

I needed to distinguish between illusion and reality.

Perfect illusion magic is said to be indistinguishable from reality, but there was a crucial difference.

Among the visible people, the illusions had a faint flow of mana.

Illusions couldn't have the same mana as humans.

For an illusion to have as much mana as a human, the amount allocated would need to be immense.

Creating so many illusions was impossible.

"Two on the right... three on the left, one above."

I read the flow, pinpointed the number of people, and moved.

I didn't give away the fact that I could discern illusions.

I would take them all down before the enemy grasped the situation.

I dashed off the ground.

My movements were concise.

Only as much as needed.

Minimizing the number of attacks.

Thump—

I kicked off the ground.

"Ah."

"One down."

I struck one in the stomach, then moved my legs again.

"Two, three, four."

The enemies had no time to react.

No matter how much they relied on illusion magic, they were mere assassins.

Ordinary-level assassins.

Their way of fighting always involved exploiting gaps from outside their target's line of sight, so they couldn't grasp my direct movements.

"Last one."

"Ugh...!"

I took down the last one and stared at them intently.

Seeing them collapsed with my face was unsettling.

"I need to dispel this quickly."

I pulled out a small box from my pocket.

A magical device prepared by McGuire.

It was designed to dispel illusion magic.

McGuire, unable to help directly, had prepared devices to counter such situations.

A device to dispel illusions.

It was prepared to counter Jefrin.

I pushed the device towards them.

Their appearances began reverting back to normal.

I examined their faces.

"None here."

Jefrin was not among them.

I narrowed my brows and looked around.

There was no one who could be Jefrin in the vicinity.

Did he really just send these assassins?

It was unlikely that anyone other than Jefrin could cast such an illusion spell.

I looked at Evan.

"Evan, were these the only ones who came?"

Evan, gasping for breath, shook his head.

"No! Jefrin is still out there."

I nodded and immediately looked up to the sky.

"Astina! Look for any horses or carriages nearby!"

"Got it. I'll check."

"Evan, rest here. Priscilla."

I summoned Priscilla and spoke.

"I'm going after Jefrin."

Jefrin was hiding in one part of the forest.

"Ha... Ha..."

She could feel that the illusion spell she had cast on the assassins was being dispelled.

Jefrin realized that Rudy Astria and Astina had arrived near the cabin.

She had deliberately left the magical device there to find out if they were coming.

But it wasn't as if Jefrin could simply escape.

She looked at her hands.

They were becoming wrinkled and shriveled.

The spell Aryandor had cast on her was wearing off.

Aryandor had cast a time spell on Jefrin, but it was Jefrin's mana that maintained it.

As Jefrin's mana gradually depleted, her body returned to its original state.

Jefrin slumped to the ground.

Her physical strength was depleted, and her mana was unstable.

It was only a matter of time before she was captured.

"Ha... That was foolish."

Jefrin lamented.

It wasn't worth coming all this way just to bring back one person with whom she felt a sense of kinship.

With her physical condition already not good, she should have taken better care of himself.

'Regretting now won't change anything.'

Jefrin gritted her teeth.

Even if she had remained with the rebels, there wouldn't have been much she could do.

There's no reason to live if it's just about barely clinging to life.

'Better a meaningful death than such a worthless life.'

Jefferin pulled out a potion from her pocket and swallowed it.

Her hand returned to its original state.

With a fierce killing intent, Jefferin rose to her feet.

"I'll need at least one companion for the road."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 200: Jefrin (6)

"Rudy, I think it's around here."

Priscilla lifted her head, sniffing the ground.

"Yeah, I can sense it too."

A strong flow of mana was in the vicinity.

Multiple spells were at work.

"Has she given up on fleeing?"

Then, Astina, who had been scouting from the sky, descended.

"There were no signs of a cart or horse nearby, and no other movements either."

"Thank you for your efforts."

We looked ahead.

A powerful mana was felt there.

It was so intense that anyone could feel it without even trying to sense the flow.

Priscilla looked at me and spoke.

"Rudy, are we going in?"

"...We have to."

I had already contacted the academy.

I wasn't sure how long they would take, but Gracie or McGuire would come here.

However, we couldn't wait for them.

We had to catch Jefrin quickly.

If she's entrenched here, someone might come to help him.

She was right in front of the enemy's base; it's impossible to escape alone without help.

It was one of two possibilities.

Either she was making a desperate last stand or waiting for someone's help.

I prepared for the worst-case scenario.

I didn't want to lose such a chance.

"Astina."

I looked at Astina.

"Let's go. We can't wait."

Astina, seemingly sharing my thoughts, didn't say much and started moving.

"Oh, wait a moment."

I stopped Astina in her tracks and extended my hand.

She looked at my hand, puzzled.

"What's this?"

"Hold it."

"...What?"

Astina's expression, which had been stoic until now, changed.

"Let's hold hands."

"Why hold hands?"

"To avoid confusing each other for the enemy if we enter the illusion spell. If we're holding hands, we won't get separated."

Astina cleared her throat and then tightly grasped my hand.

I felt the warmth from her hand.

She looked at our clasped hands and smiled.

"Your hand is bigger than I thought."

"Is it?"

I smiled at Astina and headed forward.

"Let's go in."

"Alright."

Together, we advanced towards the illusion magic, with Priscilla following behind.

As we stepped towards the magic's origin, the surroundings started to change.

The green leaves clinging to the trees began to wither, and the leaves disappeared.

The area grew darker than usual, and an eerie aura enveloped us.

Despite wearing plain clothes and a hood to cover our faces, it felt colder.

"An illusion spell?"

Astina seemed to feel the cold too, shivering slightly.

Seeing this, I held her hand even more firmly.

Our bodies were cold, but our hands shared warmth.

"Priscilla, how about you?"

"I'm a spirit, so I don't really feel things like cold."

It was hard to tell if the chill was real or part of the illusion.

"We might have to endure it for a while. It's better to save mana..."

If it's an illusion spell, using magic wouldn't warm our bodies as it manipulates sensations, possibly rendering it ineffective after a slight initial warmth.

It was better to conserve mana and quickly defeat the enemy.

"Yeah. Let's finish this quickly and get out."

Relying on the warmth of our hands, we walked forward.

"Huh?"

Suddenly, a stairway resembling an altar appeared ahead.

There sat a woman.

She wore a witch's pointed hat, sitting cross-legged.

She was a woman of mature beauty.

Different from the appearance I had seen before, but I could tell she was Jefrin.

"Welcome~. Did you have any trouble getting here?"

Jefrin waved at us with a seductive smile.

"There's nothing around to make it difficult."

"Oh? Weren't you cold? It must have been quite chilly."

Jefrin stood up.

"This space was created with the help of necromancers. It's not just ordinary cold. It's combined with several abilities."

I narrowed my eyes.

It was unclear whether this cold was due to a real drop in temperature or a sensation created by an illusion.

Even if I could determine it, it wouldn't make much difference.

Human sensations are not something we control but automatically and relatively judge.

Seeing Astina, who seemed to feel the cold more than I did, it was easy to tell.

To Astina, who hadn't experienced much cold, it seemed to feel intensely cold.

"Astina, let's finish this quickly."

"Right."

Astina raised her hand.

"Gravity."

The surrounding trees were uprooted, and stones erupted and floated in the air.

The stones and trees flew towards Jefrin.

"I haven't finished talking yet. You're quite rude, aren't you?"

Jefrin didn't lose her smile even as the trees and stones flew at her, just slightly twisting her body to dodge.

But she didn't completely avoid them.

A tree branch grazed Jefrin's cheek.

"Huh?"

Simultaneously, I felt a sting on my cheek.

I sensed something odd and touched my cheek.

"...Blood?"

I looked at the blood on my hand and then at Astina.

Blood was also flowing down her cheek.

"Astina! Stop!"

"Hmm?"

Astina stopped her magic at my call.

Various things flying towards Jefrin fell to the ground.

However, Astina's attacks had already happened several times.

"Ugh..."

Both Astina and I were wounded, bleeding.

The wounds on our bodies matched exactly with those on Jefrin's body.

Jefrin, wiping the blood from her cheek, spoke.

"You see, you should listen to the whole story."

"The same wounds are inflicted on us?"

The location of Jefrin's wounds matched ours.

This alone made the situation clear.

Our attacks were harming us as well.

It seemed like a spell crafted by Jefrin.

"If you want to kill me, you'll have to die too~."

Jefrin spoke leisurely.

"Or, freeze to death."

As Jefrin said this, the cold intensified.

The stronger cold made my body shiver.

"Ugh..."

As the cold grew more intense, Astina frowned.

Then Priscilla approached Astina's side.

Priscilla wrapped Astina in her warm fur.

Looking at Priscilla, she too bore wounds in the same locations as ours.

Even as a spirit, currently materialized, she could be wounded.

I looked at Astina.

Though shivering from the cold, her condition didn't seem too bad as she hadn't used much mana yet.

She was in a state fit for battle.

I pondered slowly.

There was a clear contradiction in Jefrin's words.

She imposed two choices on us: endure the cold or kill her and die together.

If I were here alone, I might not know what choice to make.

Conserving strength and securing victory would mean attacking Jefrin.

If all this were an illusion, attacking the opponent might break the illusion.

It could just be an action inducing fear, and she might be preparing another move.

First, the best way to understand the situation was to attack the opponent.

But, it looked like a trap.

What if these wounds and the cold were real?

What if Jefrin deliberately incited us to attack her?

Despite much deliberation, no clear answer emerged.

"...Forget it."

There was no reason to ponder this much.

Astina kept shivering in the cold, and by the time this situation ended, professors from the academy would arrive.

"Shall we just take a brute force approach?"

"What?"

"That altar... or rather, everything around here."

I smiled.

"Can you destroy it?"

I could distinctly feel the flow of mana here.

The mana flowing throughout this entire land.

The whole land was functioning like a magical device.

While it seemed plausible to think an illusion spell was at play here, I thought further.

Sensing mana flow isn't just about feeling the mana.

It involves understanding the situation and the opponent.

The opponent is an illusionist.

An illusionist we have already faced once.

The effectiveness of an illusionist's magic diminishes significantly after the first encounter.

So, there was a chance that Jefrin had set a trap.

The mana spread around wasn't due to the illusion magic but was actually utilizing the entire land as a magical device.

That's what I assumed.

But even if that wasn't the case, it didn't matter.

If this was an illusion spell, there would be a magical device at its center.

Destroying everything around would also destroy that device.

After a moment of contemplation, Astina nodded.

"Let's do as you say."

Astina moved her mana.

"Hoo..."

Rumble—

As Astina raised her hand, the surroundings reverberated.

The earth itself seemed to shift.

The ground began to split open, and the shockwaves reached the altar.

Whatever the opponent was planning, it didn't matter.

The fact that I had been contemplating was only about what to do after causing a commotion, not about breaking the current situation, which wasn't difficult.

With Astina's overwhelming power, she could suppress all other forces.

"..."

Jefferin's eyes widened as she watched the crumbling altar and splitting earth.

I looked at her and smiled.

"Hey, you gave us a choice, right?"

I shrugged.

"What will you do now? Will you try to stop us? Or just stand there and watch?"

Chapter 201: Jefrin (7)

The altar crumbled and the ground around it split open.

"Huh..."

Jefrin looked on with a disbelieving expression.

The space she had enchanted with her magic was not small.

It was large enough to encompass an entire corner of the forest.

Jefrin had engraved magic into the ground of that vast area.

Now, Astina was destroying it all.

Jefrin's spell wasn't an illusion.

It was a spell that caused every living being in the area to suffer the same damage if someone attacked her.

A magic circle created with the help of necromancy.

She had added the illusion of cold to confuse her opponents.

Her plan was to force them into a desperate situation, making them kill her and die alongside.

Of course, this wasn't her only preparation.

She had anticipated that if the opponents remained calm, they might dispel the magic in this area.

Therefore, she had used various tricks to deceive them.

But all that was futile against overwhelming power.

Even though she had prepared multiple contingencies to prevent the dispelling of her magic, destroying the very ground where the magic was inscribed left her no room to maneuver.

'I can't let it end like this...'

Jefrin controlled her mana.

She began to release the time magic Aryandor had cast on her.

The time magic had made her younger in exchange for continuously consuming her mana.

That was why Jefrin, once a great wizard, couldn't exert her full power.

As Jefrin slightly released the time magic, she appeared more mature than her current form.

If the original Jefrin was a teenage girl, now she looked more like a woman in her thirties.

'The mana is returning.'

Feeling the increase in her mana, Jefrin immediately directed it towards Astina.

Flames formed around and flew towards Astina.

However, the attack didn't reach its target.

"Priscilla."

At Rudy's command, Priscilla stepped forward.

Priscilla created an ice wall, shielding them.

Jefrin's magic was effortlessly blocked by Priscilla's simple action.

But Jefrin did not give up.

"You brats..."

Jefrin moved her body directly.

She surrounded herself with illusion magic, splitting into dozens of figures.

Then, she rushed towards them.

Rudy watched Jefrin's approach and casually gestured.

Following his cue, Priscilla created ice spears that flew towards the charging Jefrin.

Even though she had split into dozens, Priscilla targeted all the approaching figures.

"Argh...!"

Jefrin twisted her body to dodge the ice spears.

The illusions she created with her magic also moved as much as they could, but not all could evade.

The illusions hit by the ice spears vanished with a blur of smoke.

The dozens of illusions were now reduced to half, and as Priscilla moved again, another half disappeared.

"Invisible..."

This time, Jefrin used an invisibility spell.

Jefrin blurred her form, hiding her presence.

Then Rudy closed his eyes.

'What's happening?'

Jefferin looked puzzled as Rudy suddenly closed his eyes.

She attempted to rush at Rudy.

"Priscilla, over there."

As Jefferin prepared to charge, Rudy accurately pointed to her location.

Priscilla launched ice towards where Rudy pointed.

'How did he know?'

Despite being invisible, Rudy had precisely located her.

Jefferin gritted her teeth and dodged the incoming ice spears.

She couldn't approach.

Nor did her magic seem effective.

The fact that Astina and Rudy were holding hands was also a problem.

She couldn't create confusion by making them fight each other.

To deceive with illusion magic, the environment had to be right, but the environment she had prepared was already destroyed by Astina.

Using instant illusion magic at this point would only momentarily deceive the opponents without being truly effective.

'Beaten by mere brats...'

Jefferin's appearance began to change.

From a woman in her 30s to her 40s, then to her 50s.

Wrinkles deepened on her face, and her back bent.

She was reverting to her original appearance.

The mana had returned, but her movements became more difficult.

"You... brats..."

Jefferin shouted with all her might, but her voice was frail and cracked.

She gasped for air and collapsed to the ground.

The surroundings were a mess.

The altar where Jefferin stood had crumbled, and the ground was split, making it hard to find a solid footing.

"Hoo..."

As the situation seemed to conclude, Astina stopped her magic.

Rudy, still holding Astina's hand, walked forward.

"That's enough, Jefferin. Surrender, and we can spare your life."

"...My life?"

Jefferin laughed hollowly at Rudy's words.

"If you spare me, what will you do? Ask about the rebels?"

Rudy didn't respond directly.

Jefferin had lived as long as she could.

She had far exceeded the average lifespan.

Of course, she feared death.

More precisely, she feared what would happen after death.

Jefferin's first life, as a wizard, was a failure.

Far from surpassing Levian, she ended up alone and abandoned by the empire.

Although praised as a great wizard, it was a life devoid of meaning.

But Jefrin's second life was different.

She lived to the fullest as a rebel, helping Aryandor.

This life was much more valuable than her decades as the empire's wizard.

Following the rebels' ideology, she killed corrupt nobles and helped the commoners beneath them.

She had taken many lives, but she also saved many.

She witnessed those saved by her actions.

Their lives became peaceful and prosperous.

Gratitude filled the air, ringing in her ears with heartfelt thanks.

The sincere appreciation of the people resonated deeply within Jefrin, giving her a new purpose.

‘It's a pity I won't see such a world.’

It was a world she had longed to see.

But, what truly frightened her was not missing out on that world, but the possibility of it never coming to pass.

Jefrin had seen people striving to create that world, reminiscent of how she had once strived to surpass Levian.

Having failed once, she knew too well the weight of their potential failure.

“There are things scarier than death.”

At her words, Rudy and Astina's expressions hardened.

Jefferin laughed at Rudy's face, manipulating her mana.

Her body aged rapidly.

“Urgh...”

Rudy's eyes widened in shock.

“Priscilla! Block it!”

Priscilla moved swiftly, trying to freeze Jefferin in her tracks.

Jefferin began to freeze from her toes upwards, yet she laughed.

“Such things... cannot stop me. Urgh...”

Blood spilled from Jefferin's mouth.

Her mana became tumultuous.

Not self-aware, but she let go of the controlled mana, letting it rage wildly.

Rudy recognized the phenomenon.

A mana explosion from black magic.

A phenomenon where magic fails and mana becomes uncontrollable.

Jefferin had deliberately triggered this event.

Rudy moved his mana, knowing he had to act.

“Finger of the Demon.”

Thud—

“Ah...”

Rudy's magic pierced Jefrin's abdomen.

It didn't kill her instantly.

Jefrin looked at the spike that had pierced her, then laughed.

Rumble—

A black circle formed around Jefrin.

It grew larger, engulfing its surroundings.

Quickly, it approached Rudy and Astina.

“We need to escape...”

The speed was too fast to react.

“Hold on tight, Rudy!”

Astina firmly grasped Rudy's hand as they were swept into the black orb.

After being engulfed by the black orb, Rudy opened his eyes.

He saw nothing but darkness.

His body, his hands, even Astina, who was swept away with him, were invisible.

Rudy felt something was wrong and spoke.

‘What's happening?’

His voice didn't reach his ears.

“...?”

No sense was perceptible.

Smell, touch, taste, sight, hearing.

Nothing felt alive.

Rudy pondered slowly.

Jefferin's last actions.

She had deliberately caused her mana to explode.

The only mana rampage I knew of was caused by dark magic, so I had no idea how this one had been triggered.

However, having witnessed Luna's rampage before, I knew what it felt like.

So, what exactly had happened now?

It seemed like magic that blocked senses had been activated, but it was difficult to pinpoint exactly what kind of magic it was.

A blockage of the senses...

No.

Was it something that caused confusion in the senses?

Hallucination magic interfered with a person's senses.

Such magic was indeed possible.

'The problem is how to resolve this...'

I tried to think calmly, but a strange feeling began to overwhelm me.

Not feeling any senses at all was enough to make one anxious.

Just a few hours in this state could drive a person mad.

Being able to think meant... could I still use magic?

I tried to mobilize mana.

I felt the flow of mana within my body.

Feeling the movement of mana calmed me a bit, as I had felt nothing else.

'My physical senses are blocked, but my mana isn't...'

I was certain that this phenomenon was caused by hallucination magic.

Hallucination magic interfered with senses, not mana.

The question now was how to escape from here.

I recalled the situation where I was engulfed in a black sphere.

Astina had grabbed my hand and wrapped us in a circle.

So, was I still holding hands with Astina?

I read the flow of mana.

A massive flow of mana was right beside me.

'Astina...'

It seemed like we were lying down together.

'Fortunately, it looks like there's no problem yet...'

Astina's mana was still stable.

She appeared to be calmly assessing the situation.

But that didn't mean I could relax.

'If this is hallucination magic, then it must have a core.'

Escaping hallucination magic involved either breaking or touching its core.

However, that core was likely Jefrin's body.

I slowly expanded my area of mana reading.

As I widened the range, I sensed two mana sources.

One was probably Jefrin, and the other seemed like Priscilla.

'Is the fluctuating mana... Jefrin...?'

One was stable, while the other's mana flow was in disarray.

So, I had to attack the disrupted one.

But I had no way to attack.

The magic I used mostly involved directing it in a specific way.

However, currently, I was lying down, and it wasn't easy to determine that direction.

Normally, I would extend my hand in one direction or visually confirm the exact location before using magic.

If I got the coordinates wrong, I couldn't predict where the magic would go.

Misusing magic could also engulf our bodies in its wake.

'Then...'

I concentrated and quietly said,

'Priscilla.'

At that, Priscilla's voice echoed.

"Rudy, are you okay? I can't feel anything. How about you?"

"Yeah, I can't feel anything either."

Being able to communicate with Priscilla brought me a sense of stability.

I pondered for a moment before speaking.

"Is there a way to solve this?"

"Yes, there's something you need to do."

It was about handling spirits, something I had practiced with Serina.

What we practiced was sharing mental strength.

To share mental strength, I needed to have a proper connection with Priscilla.

Sharing each other's minds.

We could already communicate through thoughts, but we practiced sharing more than that.

We trained to transfer images or information in our heads, but I had never successfully done it before.

However, now it felt like it might work.

With all senses blocked, I felt more connected to Priscilla.

"Transferring information..."

I passed on my thoughts to Priscilla, with whom I was connected.

Like handing over an object.

I focused and transferred the information to Priscilla.

"Huh...?"

"Did it work?"

"...Attack that mana?"

Priscilla had received what I was thinking and spoke my thoughts.

"It seems to be working."

"I can feel it. It's a strange sensation."

"Then, I'll leave it to you."

Priscilla's ability, unlike dark magic which is difficult to handle and has a fixed scale, allowed for fine adjustments.

Priscilla could use ice as if it were her own body.

"Let's try it."

Listening to Priscilla, I moved my body.

I wasn't sure exactly how my body was moving, but I moved as much as I could, feeling the flow of mana.

I moved as close as possible to Astina, who was lying next to me.

Priscilla's attack might spread and reach Astina.

I could withstand the attack to some extent, but Astina couldn't.

So, I tried to cover Astina with my body.

"Here I go, Rudy."

It felt as if Priscilla's body was my own, and I could feel my mana moving.

It was a feeling of unity.

"Ah..."

Is this what it feels like to share mental strength?

I could feel exactly how Priscilla was moving her mana, from the amount to the method.

Priscilla's ice slowly approached in the direction of Jefrin.

"...Stretch out there!"

The ice, moving slowly, stretched out towards the direction of Jefrin's mana.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 202: Jefrin (8)

It was a dark space.

Nothing could be felt.

Astina slowly pondered in that darkness.

She realized, like Rudy, that this magic was related to hallucinatory phenomena and wondered what to do about it.

As she pondered, she felt a warm heat on her hand.

"Hmm?"

This time, she heard her own voice.

Touch and hearing had returned.

But it wasn't completely back.

It was like the numbness from anesthesia was still partially there.

"Uh..."

As her sense of touch was returning,

Squeeze—

Something was pressing down on Astina's nose.

"...What's this?"

Astina cautiously opened her eyes.

In her blurry vision, she saw a mix of white and gold.

Her sight gradually returned.

"Ah?"

It was Rudy who was pressing on her nose.

"Ah... Ahh...!"

However, the manner in which he was pressing was problematic.

Rudy, with his eyes closed, was lying on top of Astina.

His face was right in front of Astina's eyes.

It was Rudy's nose that had been pressing on hers.

They lay there, noses pressed together in this awkward position.

The situation became awkward due to the prominent hill on Astina's chest.

Rudy's body was lifted slightly because of her chest.

Thus, their noses were touching, and had Astina's chest been smaller, it would have been their lips instead.

"Uh...!"

Astina's face turned red.

Although she often showed a confident senior figure in front of Rudy, she was a girl who knew nothing about men.

"Se...nior."

That's when Rudy opened his mouth.

Rudy's breath touched Astina.

"Ah..."

Not just her face, but Astina's ears also turned red as if they were about to burst.

Even then, she couldn't take her eyes off Rudy's face.

Rudy, still not fully conscious, tossed and turned.

He moved his body to the side, positioning his face next to Astina's head, almost as if embracing her.

"...Just for a moment."

Astina tightly closed her eyes and raised her hand, then hugged Rudy tightly.

"Hmm..."

Astina cleared her throat as if nothing had happened, but she couldn't hide her expression.

Her lips curved into a delighted smile, and her hand gently stroked Rudy's back.

During that brief moment of happiness,

"How long are you planning to stay like this?"

"———!!!!"

Startled by the sudden voice, Astina quickly pushed Rudy away and sprang to her feet.

Standing in front of her was a wolf shining with silver fur.

"Pr...Priscilla?"

"Sorry to interrupt your pleasant time, but we need to clean up, don't we?"

"Pl, pleasant time? I was just trying to make Rudy comfortable after his hard work..."

"That's enough of that. Catch that guy."

Priscilla gestured with her head towards Jefrin.

Astina, her face still red, covered it with her hand and looked in that direction.

Jefrin lay on the grass, aged and defeated.

Surrounded by chunks of ice, her punctured belly was sealed with ice.

"Is she alive?"

"She's breathing, but it doesn't seem like she'll last long."

Astina gazed intently at Jefrin.

She lay sprawled on the ground, aged.

Dust and dirt clung to her body.

"This isn't how she should meet her end, considering all she's done."

Astina approached Jefrin, taking out a small mana stone.

When she brought it to her, her wounds slowly started to heal.

Astina, with a cold gaze, turned to Priscilla, who was looking at Jefrin, and spoke.

"Priscilla, can you check if any professors are nearby? If not, bring them here as quickly as possible."

"Understood."

Astina had no intention of letting Jefrin meet such an end.

Priscilla arrived with McGuire at the place where Astina was.

McGuire looked at Jefrin, lying on the ground.

"It seems you were successful."

"Yes, Rudy managed to do it."

Astina greeted McGuire, laying Rudy on her lap.

"How is Rudy...?"

"His condition doesn't seem too bad. He just hasn't regained consciousness yet."

"That's good to hear."

McGuire nodded and looked at Jefrin.

"She doesn't look like she'll last much longer."

Jefrin was barely breathing, gasping for air.

"Even if we save her, it won't make much difference. She went into mana overload on her own, so her mind must be half gone."

Mana overload was essentially a suicidal act.

If mana overload is caused by other magic, the body's defense mechanisms provide some protection.

But deliberately causing a mana overload bypasses these mechanisms, damaging not just the mind but the entire body.

Jefrin was, in essence, more dead than alive.

"Still, I don't plan to let her go easily."

The conversation Astina couldn't have in front of Rudy.

The Rebels had invaded the Academy, and Rudy had spoken of the possibility of his death.

Astina had laughed it off then, but she had pondered it deeply.

The Rebels killing her.

It might not happen, but it wasn't something to be ignored.

She had to prepare.

Astina trained to defy fate.

In doing so, she distanced herself from those around her.

She avoided Rudy, whom she cherished.

In another timeline, Rudy had changed for the worse after her death.

To prevent that, Astina distanced herself from Rudy for a while.

Distance in body leads to distance in heart.

She would do her best against the Rebels, but she also had to consider the possibility of not escaping death.

Even if she died, she stepped back to ensure Rudy wouldn't fall apart.

Luna and Rie accompanying Rudy was unavoidable.

Astina, thinking that she would be in their place if she could just survive this ordeal, endured patiently.

She was focused solely on finding a way to oppose the Rebels.

And now.

Astina had formed a definitive plan.

With Jefrin captured, Astina saw a possibility.

The Empire was currently embroiled in internal strife.

The Rebels were active, but not a major concern for the Empire.

For her own protection, the Empire's assistance was essential.

There was something she needed to do to create this situation.

"Then, I leave Rudy in your care."

Astina handed Rudy to Priscilla and lifted Jefrin with magic.

"Astina, where are you going...?"

"I'm heading to the capital."

"The capital?"

Astina pointed at Jefrin and looked at Mcguire.

"I intend to put this woman on the execution block."

Despite it being the time for Jefrin's return, she hadn't shown up, and they learned she had been captured.

The Rebel leaders convened a meeting.

"What do you plan to do, leader?"

"..."

Aryandor held his head in his hands.

The Rebels were unaware of Jefrin's whereabouts.

They knew she was defeated at the Academy, but her movements thereafter were a mystery.

They wondered if she had escaped and searched around the Academy, but to no avail.

"For now, we wait..."

Waiting was all Aryandor could do.

"Leader!!!"

A man suddenly burst into the meeting room.

"There's going to be a public execution in the capital of the Empire...!"

"A public execution?"

"It's... It's Jefrin's public execution...!"

At these words, Aryandor's eyes widened.

"What are you talking about? Jefrin disappeared less than a day ago. It doesn't make sense..."

The Empire generally advocated non-violence.

They upheld the principle of reforming rather than killing.

Of course, many were killed behind the scenes, but to the common people, this was the stance they projected.

Still, a public execution meant extensive deliberation and a compelling reason to proceed.

But it had only been a day since Jefrin's disappearance.

The idea that all these events transpired in such a short time was implausible.

It takes a full day just to travel from the Academy to the capital.

The details of how this unfolded were puzzling.

"Leader, what will you do?"

"...I will go alone."

The Rebels were at a critical juncture.

With their influence spreading, they couldn't afford to spare other leaders.

"Contact Daemon in the capital."

Daemon was currently in the capital due to matters involving the Astria family and the necromancers.

Aryandor planned to meet Daemon, observe the situation, and if an opportunity arose during the execution, attempt to rescue Jefrin.

However...

"Sigh..."

Aryandor arrived in the capital just in time to witness the execution.

Before the execution platform, there was a large crowd.

Public executions weren't a common occurrence, so many had gathered out of curiosity.

On the execution platform, an aged Jefrin knelt, covered in wounds, with Astina standing in front of her.

But that wasn't all.

Beside Astina stood Cromwell and the Empire's Chancellor, Jason Ophillius.

Nearby were Ian Astria and several nobles.

It was a gathering of the Empire's central figures.

The security was too tight for Aryandor to breach alone.

"Leader, have you arrived?"

Daemon, hooded, approached the prearranged meeting spot.

"What's happened here?"

"I heard that during a meeting of the Empire, Astina Persia arrived and brought about this situation."

"Astina?"

"Yes, she brought Jefrin from the Academy to the meeting."

Aryandor gazed at Astina, standing highest amongst the surrounding nobility.

Her presence there among the high nobility implied she had achieved a significant feat.

"That girl captured Jefrin...?"

As Aryandor muttered to himself, the time for the execution arrived.

Astina stepped forward, unfolding a scroll in her hand.

"The accused, a member of the Rebel faction and its leadership, conspired against the Empire's core and committed numerous atrocities. Thus, she is sentenced to death for the crime of national treason."

Her statement was concise and deeply summarized.

Treason was one of the most severely punished crimes in the Empire.

Lengthy explanations were unnecessary.

Astina read the charges and set the scroll down.

She then looked at the crowd in front of her.

"This criminal orchestrated a national rebellion, killing over a hundred people alone."

Astina continued.

"Not only that, but with his magical artifacts and soldiers, she killed countless more. Under the pretext of purging corrupt nobles, thousands of families were destroyed. Some lost sons, others husbands, and still others fathers. Those people were innocent. They were merely defending their families against the Rebels."

Astina extended her hand.

"To the Rebels listening somewhere, I ask: Do you really believe the world you're trying to create justifies killing innocent people? Can you claim to be better than the corrupt nobles you've killed? Is the world you're building truly ideal?"

Astina had investigated the Rebels to protect herself and those around her.

And she was prepared.

She could explain to the Empire the danger posed by the Rebels and the contradictions in their actions.

She had prepared in advance, seizing this opportunity.

Astina had barely kept Jefrin alive and headed for the Empire.

Instead of a normal carriage, she used magic to fly at high speed and arrived at the Empire.

This challenging journey was to participate in the ongoing conference in the Empire.

Astina attended the conference of the Empire and pleaded the case she had prepared.

She argued that now was not the time for the Emperor's faction and the nobility to fight.

The Rebels were planning to bring down the Empire.

It was not the time to just watch.

As a result, this moment had arrived.

Astina's efforts were not in vain.

Hearing her words, both the nobility and the Emperor's faction resolved to deal with the Rebels first.

"This act will be a declaration of war, a direct confrontation between you, the Rebels, and the Empire. People, do not be deceived by the Rebels sharing a bit of food. They are murderers who killed your families, your neighbors. The bread they give you is made from the flesh of your family, the wine from their blood. These are not goods sprung from the earth. Never forget that."

Astina, with piercing eyes, looked at the crowd and declared.

"Astina Persia..."

Aryandor gritted his teeth as he looked at Astina.

Then he turned his gaze to Jefrin beside her.

Jefrin looked even more haggard and miserable than when he first saw her.

She was practically half-dead already.

As Aryandor watched Jefrin, a soldier standing next to Astina shouted.

"The execution will proceed!"

Hearing this, Aryandor turned away.

Daemon watched Aryandor's reaction.

"Are you leaving?"

"Yes."

Aryandor clenched his fist tightly, repeating a name in his mind.

"Astina Persia."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 203: Final Exam 2 (1)

After the battle with Jefrin ended, I was able to return to the academy with Mcguire's help.

Fortunately, I wasn't severely injured, so there was no need for a hospital stay.

The problem was that my senses weren't returning quickly.

I heard that Astina and Priscilla, who suffered the same technique from Jefrin, recovered their senses quickly, but mine were slow to return.

According to the doctor, it varies from person to person, so some may recover slowly.

However, the good news was that it wasn't all my senses that failed to return; it was just my vision that was somewhat unclear.

Of course, not being able to see properly has its inconveniences, but I was better off than some.

"Hmm..."

Luna looked at me with a face full of dissatisfaction.

"...What's wrong?"

"I came to take care of you, so don't use that thing and just let me support you...!"

"...Then you'll have a hard time."

"Still..."

I didn't feel the need to be supported, even though I couldn't see well.

A technique I realized while fighting Jefrin.

I was able to share senses with Priscilla.

With Priscilla's vision, I could figure out what was around me, so even though I couldn't see, everyday life wasn't a problem.

Thus, I used Priscilla like a guide dog.

"Just help me with the notes or something. Priscilla often dozes off during class, so I can't take notes properly."

"I don't need to attend such classes, do I?"

The semester hadn't ended yet.

Final exams were coming up, and I had to prepare.

Already having lost the top rank to Yaniel in the joint assessment, there was a risk of losing the top overall score.

In this situation where I couldn't see properly, I couldn't afford to neglect my studies.

"Okay... I'll take care of the notes."

"Shall we go to class?"

"Yeah!"

We were about to head to class.

"Ah?"

That's when I tripped over a step I hadn't seen.

Thud—

Caught off guard by the unexpected step, I stumbled forward, hitting my head against the wall.

"Ow...!"

I rubbed my head where it had hit the wall.

"Rudy! Are you okay?"

"Oh no, sorry, Rudy."

"...It's okay, it happens."

Even though I could see through Priscilla's eyes, I couldn't see every blind spot, like this step.

Luna glared at me, rubbing the bump on my head.

"See? That's what happens when you don't take my support."

"It's not... like this happens often."

Then Luna grabbed me.

She draped my arm over her shoulder, assuming a supporting posture.

"Just do as I say!"

"...Okay."

I gave in to Luna's firm attitude.

There was one reason why I was reluctant to be supported like this.

"...Gasp."

"Are those two... Rudy and Luna?"

Murmurs from the crowd.

With a white wolf leading the way and Luna clinging to me, all eyes were on us.

Being the center of attention was already a given for me, so it was inevitable that rumors would spread in such a situation.

"Are the two of you... dating?"

"Well, it's only natural... someone like Rudy would have a girlfriend."

"And come to think of it, Luna is always with Rudy."

I silently walked past the people making such comments.

Indeed, I didn't care much about the words of those I didn't know.

The problem lay elsewhere.

"Ruuuudyyyyy?"

A blonde woman approached, squinting her eyes in annoyance.

Rie was glaring at me, veins popping on her forehead.

She looked back and forth between Luna and me.

"You said you could see with Priscilla's help, right? How?"

"...I can see, sort of."

"Priscilla can't see everything, so I'm helping him!"

Luna said proudly.

Her assertive stance made Rie glare at me more intensely.

"Rudy??? You told me you didn't need any help, but you need Luna's help?"

"Ah... no, there seems to be a misunderstanding..."

Then Luna pressed herself closer to me, as if protecting me.

"No, it's not Rudy's fault! He was walking so unsteadily, I had to help him."

A scenario where the interfering sister-in-law is more annoying than the scolding mother-in-law.

Luna's explanation only sharpened Rie's gaze.

"Then I'll help him."

"...What?"

Rie suddenly clung to my side.

"Gasp!"

"Hey, playing both sides?"

As Rie pressed against me, the onlookers grew more agitated.

"Luna can't support him alone, right?"

"No, no! Rudy isn't hurt in the legs, there's no need for two people to support him!"

"Oh, is that so? Then you can go, Luna. I'll support him."

"Eek..."

Luna glared at Rie.

On my right was Luna, and on my left was Rie.

Stuck between them, glaring at each other, I was the most uncomfortable.

"I'll be the one to support him."

"For what reason. There's no need, right?"

"Re...reason. You don't have one either!"

"Yes, I do."

Rie smirked.

"I'm going to marry Rudy."

".....!!!!!!!"

I was shocked at Rie's words.

We were not alone, but in a corridor filled with other students.

We were not seven years old to casually say 'I'm going to marry someone~.'

"Princess Rie is going to..."

"Is the Astria family going to be connected to the royal family?"

The surrounding students were astounded.

"Hey, you can't say that here!!"

I whispered to Rie, making sure no one else could hear.

We had agreed not to discuss such matters carelessly anywhere.

Discussing something as serious as marriage in the academy could lead to nothing good.

I was worried about how far the rumors circulating here might spread, possibly even reaching the capital.

"Why? You lied to me, so this is your punishment."

"It's not a lie, I tell you."

Then Luna clenched her fist and spoke up.

"I'm going to marry Rudy, too."

She said this, her face turning beet red.

"Ah..."

The attention from those around us was pouring in.

Even though I was using Priscilla's vision to look around, I could feel their gazes, a mix of admiration and disdain.

Men looked at me with a mix of respect, while women regarded me as if I were trash.

"Cough..."

I coughed awkwardly and pondered.

I needed to find a way to resolve this situation.

"...What are you seniors doing?"

At that moment, Yuni slowly emerged from the crowd.

Rie waved her hand at Yuni.

"Ah, Yuni, perfect timing. Say hello to your future brother-in-law."

"...Brother-in-law?"

Yuni looked at Rie, confused.

"No! Yuni! You mustn't call him that!"

Luna reacted vehemently.

"Why not, Yuni? Hurry and greet him."

"Yuni, don't do it!"

"It's my brother, he should listen to me, right?"

"What are you both doing..."

Yuni sighed and looked at them.

"There are too many people here. Let's go somewhere else."

"Yes, Yuni is right."

I was impressed by Yuni's sensible reaction, quite a change from the days when she would blurt out strange confessions to me.

We followed Yuni to the student council room.

"So... you were fighting over who would support Rudy?"

Yuni looked at us with a deadpan expression.

"It wasn't exactly because of that, more like a combination of..."

"It's because of Luna."

Rie and Luna grumbled like scolded children in front of Yuni.

"Let's do it this way."

Yuni addressed us.

"I'll support Rudy. That should settle it, right?"

"Rudy? Why would you?"

Rie raised her voice in protest.

"If sister and Luna keep fighting over it, it'll be worse. So, it's better if I do it."

"Ah, but... uh..."

Rie hesitated, as if wanting to say something.

"You, Yuni, have classes! If you take Rudy, you'll have to go out of your way."

If Yuni escorted me to class, it would take twice as long.

She would have to take me to my class and then go to her own.

"It's not a big deal. I owe Rudy a lot, so I can do at least this much."

"But, still..."

"Alright, that's settled. Now, everyone go to class. It's almost time for them to start."

Though Luna and Rie seemed slightly displeased, they nodded.

It seemed Luna preferred Yuni over Rie and vice versa.

I also thought it was better, as it avoided any more conflicts between the two.

But what about the rumors circulating around the academy...

"Senior, shall we go?"

Yuni offered me her hand.

"Yes, okay."

Raei Translations

"Don't tell Rudy."

"He'll find out eventually. Is there a reason to delay?"

"If he finds out, he'll surely worry. It's better to delay and lessen the worry."

Astina, dressed in a white suit, spoke to Cromwell.

"Alright, I understand. Take care."

"You too. Travel safely."

Astina waved goodbye to Cromwell as he departed in his carriage.

She watched until the carriage disappeared from her sight.

"Now, it's time to begin."

Astina didn't return to the academy with Cromwell; she stayed in the capital.

She was appointed as the Deputy Commander of the Royal forces against the Rebels.

The reason Astina, young and still not graduated from the academy, was given such a role was due to her achievements reported at the meeting.

She had captured Rebels, a first at the academy, and had represented central nobility in the North.

Her detailed explanation about the Rebels at the recent meeting had earned her respect, leading to her appointment as Deputy Commander.

This position was exactly what Astina had aimed for.

With Jefrin's execution drawing the Rebels' attention to her, they would try to do something about Astina.

But as long as she sat in the Deputy Commander's seat, she would be safe.

To target Astina in her role as Deputy Commander would mean challenging the entire Royal army.

'It's time to start.'

Astina walked towards a mansion.

A mansion where lilies bloomed in all seasons.

"It's been a while. Ian Astria."

"Is this the first time since last year at the academy?"

It was the Astria family mansion.

Chapter 204: Final Exam 2 (2)

Ian and Astina sat across from each other, facing one another.

Astina was the first to speak.

"I regret the outcome of the last meeting."

The content of the meeting held in the central region.

The discussion revolved around Rudy and Ian, primarily focusing on whether Ian should be the uncontested successor.

The conclusion of the meeting granted Rudy a chance to compete, considering his achievements thus far.

Ian narrowed his eyes as he looked at Astina.

"Do you really regret it?"

Everyone knew of Astina's close relationship with Rudy.

So, it seemed absurd to Ian that Astina was expressing regret.

Of course, Astina wasn't actually regretful.

Why would she express regret when Rudy had just been given a chance to inherit the family?

But she had her reasons for saying so.

"I spoke as a colleague with a common goal."

Ian had been appointed as the Commander of the Royal forces against the Rebels.

Although young to be a Commander, Ian had been a promising figure from his academy days, receiving much expectation from the Empire.

Right after graduating, he had taken over his family's affairs on behalf of his father and enjoyed overwhelming support from the nobility faction.

Ian was old enough and deserving of such a position.

Though Ian as the Commander and Astina as the Deputy Commander might seem like a weak combination, the Royal army was full of veteran nobles, not necessarily involved in frontline battles.

Ian nodded without much change in expression.

"Alright, let's go with that. Now, shall we get to the main point?"

Ian spread a map in front of Astina.

"It seemed like you knew a lot about the Rebels last time. I'd like to hear what you think should be done?"

Astina looked at Ian.

His eyes didn't seem to be testing her; he genuinely seemed curious.

Though they might become enemies later, for now, they were allies.

Just as the saying goes, 'the enemy of my enemy is my friend,' Ian and Astina shared a common enemy in the Rebels.

Collaboration was necessary.

"Then let me explain."

Rudy, wearing glasses, sat at his desk.

He turned his head while studying.

Behind Rudy was Yuni sitting.

"Aren't you supposed to study too?"

Yuni had spread her study books in front of her but was only staring at Rudy.

Rudy wondered why she was behaving like this.

Yuni shrugged nonchalantly.

"I can study here, too."

"Still, your concentration must be different when we're together compared to when you're alone."

It had been a few days since Yuni decided to assist Rudy.

Rudy's vision had improved enough to see clearly with his glasses, yet Yuni continued to stay close by his side.

Even though Rudy insisted he was fine, Yuni ignored it and kept visiting him.

"After the joint assessment, I heard the final exams are going to be easy anyway."

"True, but with relative grading, we still need to study hard. Besides, isn't Professor Gracie suffering because you're here with me?"

Professor Gracie's lab had been struggling since the last performance report, even with a few teaching assistants.

It was time to start new research, and with both Rudy and Yuni absent, Professor Gracie was having a hard time.

Talking to Yuni about it seemed pointless; she did as she pleased, and Rudy couldn't scold in his condition.

"Next year, when you're in your third year, we won't be around anymore, so Professor Gracie should start preparing for that."

Yuni's comment wasn't entirely wrong.

Professor Gracie should be able to conduct research without Rudy and Yuni soon.

Rudy was slated for social practice outside the academy next year.

As for Yuni, who had been reluctantly brought into the lab by Rudy, it was time for her to leave as well.

She wasn't planning on pursuing a research career, so staying in the lab wasn't feasible.

"That reminds me, other students must be worrying about their career paths too."

Rudy mused, taking off his glasses.

Yuni frowned at this.

"Put your glasses back on, senior."

Rudy, puzzled by her sudden request, asked,

"Glasses?"

"Once your vision fully recovers, you won't need to wear glasses anymore. Enjoy wearing them while you can."

Rudy was bewildered by her reasoning.

"What are you talking about?"

"It's a rare sight to see you with glasses. I want to see it more,"

Yuni explained.

"So, you just want to see it?"

Rudy didn't understand the appeal of his glasses but decided to go along with Yuni's request.

As Rudy put his glasses back on, Yuni began smiling broadly.

"Senior, you actually look pretty good with glasses, you know?"

"Thanks, I guess,"

Rudy replied, feeling a bit awkward.

He then reflected on his earlier thought about others' future paths.

Rie was destined for the throne, and Locke would likely take over his family's responsibilities in the north.

Rudy's thoughts then drifted to Luna.

The Railer family that Luna belonged to was relatively insignificant, just a small territory in the countryside.

It seemed more beneficial for her to focus on becoming a wizard rather than on inheritor training.

As Rudy contemplated the futures of those around him, another person came to mind.

"By the way, I haven't seen Astina around lately,"

Rudy remarked.

He hadn't seen Astina since the Jefrin incident, and with no rumors circulating, he assumed she was just busy with her own matters, especially

with graduation preparations underway.

"Astina?"

Yuni questioned.

"Yeah, what's Astina up to these days? Still training like before?"

Rudy hadn't heard anything significant from Luna or Rie either, just that Astina was busy.

"Senior, haven't you heard the news?"

"News?"

"Astina has been appointed as the Deputy Commander of the Royal Army against the Rebels. It seems she might not even be able to attend the graduation ceremony."

Rudy's eyes widened in surprise at this new information.

"What are you talking about?"

"You really didn't know?"

After losing his senses, Rudy hadn't wandered around and mostly met with Luna, Rie, and Yuni.

Since no one mentioned it, Rudy had no way of knowing.

"Astina, suddenly..."

Rudy sank into deep thought.

He had always been concerned about Astina.

He remembered seeing her death in the future when he became a third-year student during the winter break.

Reducing and checking the Rebels' power was his attempt to prevent that future.

Learning that Astina was now directly confronting the Rebels caused him a lot of concern.

"Yuni, do you know how the Royal Army plans to move, anything about that?"

"No, I don't know that much. That kind of information is confidential."

"Right..."

Astina was a thoughtful person.

There must be a plan behind her actions, but Rudy couldn't completely let go of his concerns.

"I need to go there right after the final exams."

"Where to?"

"To the capital, of course."

Mobilizing the Royal Army to respond to the Rebels wouldn't happen immediately.

Soldiers had to be conscripted, and strategies had to be planned.

Astina would likely remain in the capital during this time.

Rudy was determined to help Astina in any way he could.

"I'll have to wrap up the student council work quickly then."

Though the student council term officially ended after the final exams, Rudy needed to conclude other matters to head to the capital with peace of mind.

He had to go there anyway for his third-year, but he planned to make that trip sooner.

"Senior going to the capital..."

While Rudy was pondering, Yuni also seemed lost in thought.

Knock, knock.

At that moment, they heard a knock at the door.

Rudy tilted his head, puzzled.

There were no classes scheduled for the afternoon, and he was studying in the dormitory.

Other students and professors should be in class, so he couldn't think of anyone who might visit.

"Who is it?"

Rudy's question was met with a voice from outside the door.

"From the Royal Palace. Is Rudy Astria present?"

A voice asked from outside the door.

"The Royal Palace?"

Rudy quickly opened the door, curious.

Standing before him was a person clad in a formal uniform, clearly a knight, evident by the sword at his waist.

A companion, appearing to be an attendant, stood behind, holding a small box.

"Good day. Are you Rudy Astria?"

The knight asked.

"Yes, that's me,"

Rudy responded, prompting the knight to bow slightly.

"Greetings. I've come to deliver the results of the recent central meeting."

"The meeting results?"

"The matter concerning the heir to the Astria family."

Rudy nodded, aware of the meeting about the Astria family's succession but not particularly surprised by the visit.

"Please come in,"

Rudy invited the knight into his room.

"Ah?"

The knight appeared surprised to see Yuni sitting comfortably inside.

"Hello?"

Yuni greeted casually, waving her hand at the sight of the royal attire.

Although it might seem disrespectful to some, as a member of the Royal Family, Yuni's casual behavior towards the knight, who was essentially an attendant to the Royal Family, was not problematic.

"Oh, don't mind her. She's just here to help with some work,"

Rudy explained.

"Ahem, understood,"

The knight cleared his throat and signaled the attendant, who then placed the box in front of Rudy.

"What is this?"

"Documents containing the results of the meeting."

Upon opening the box, Rudy found a scroll of moderate size inside.

He unrolled it and began to read.

"The heir competition."

"Yes, the Royal Family wishes for you, Rudy Astria, to engage in a proper competition with your brother."

After reading through the scroll, Rudy noticed something peculiar at the end.

"Ah?"

"Have you finished reading?"

"Yes... but..."

"I will now convey the Royal Family's command."

The knight took the scroll from Rudy and stood up.

"The Royal Palace commands Rudy Astria to return to the capital upon the completion of the term and receive training in spatial magic. Following that, you are to engage in a legitimate competition for the heirship with Ian Astria."

This was the content of the scroll from the Royal Palace, instructing Rudy to learn spatial magic in the capital.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 205: Final Exam 2 (3)

"Finally, you found out..."

Rie spoke to me with a calm face.

"I'm sorry, it was a request from Astina, so I couldn't just go about it carelessly."

"...It's okay,"

I couldn't blame Rie or Luna for not revealing something that Astina had asked to be kept secret.

Considering it was a rumor that was quite famous in the Empire, the fact that Astina tried to hide it suggested she knew I would find out eventually.

Rie patted my shoulder, which was shadowed with worry.

"There's no need to worry that much. The position of the Deputy Commander of the Royal Army isn't that dangerous."

Her words were true, but from another perspective, the Deputy Commander was the second target of the rebels.

It was a position safe yet vulnerable to threats.

The rebels would go to any lengths to capture the commander.

"I'm more worried about the people around Astina..."

Even if it wasn't Astina, those around her could be threatened.

Not just us, who had become close at the academy, but Astina's family could be targets too.

We might be safe within the academy, but Astina's family was a different story.

The Persia family, despite being a viscount family, did not possess strong powers, excluding Astina.

They weren't a family that rose through magic or swordsmanship, despite being a viscount family.

The Persia family had earned their status through administrative work.

When I visited the Persia territory last time, the enormous size of the commercial city there proved this point.

It was a commercial city more bustling than the capital.

That's why I was more worried.

From the rebels' perspective, capturing the Persia territory meant they would be ready for war in terms of supplies.

With many merchant companies there and their warehouses, it was an ideal environment to seize supplies.

"The Empire won't be unaware of this. They will probably send soldiers or wizards to protect the Persia territory."

"Right? The Empire isn't foolish enough to overlook such an important stronghold."

The Persia territory, a target for both Astina and supplies, was indeed a crucial point.

However, its distance from the capital was a concern.

Rie tapped the book in front of her.

"Worrying like this won't change anything. We can't do much right now. Focus on your studies for now. The final exams are just around the corner. Astina probably didn't tell you about her matters so that you could focus on your own. But now that you know, what are you going to do?"

I nodded at Rie's words.

"...You're right. I need to concentrate on my own tasks."

If the rebels really were planning to attack the Persia territory, the Empire would catch wind of it.

There was no harm in worrying later.

As I nodded and composed myself, Rie smiled.

"Besides, can you see well now?"

Rie waved her hand in front of my eyes.

"I can see somewhat. It's not like my old vision yet, but it should return soon."

"Hmm... Then you don't need glasses?"

"Glasses?"

"Ah, no. I heard you wear glasses when studying."

"...Were you listening to conversations in my room?"

The only time I wore glasses was in my room.

During class, I sat in the front row so there was no need to wear glasses, and when I was walking around, Yuni was always by my side, so there were no major issues.

I only wore glasses in my room when my vision was poor, and it hurt to read.

"How could I not be bothered when you say you're alone in your room with another girl?"

"Another girl? That's your sister."

"Even if she's my sister, a girl is still a girl. And Yuni has been bothering me too..."

"Yuni bothers you?"

As I tilted my head in confusion, Rie shook her head.

"No, it's not like that. Or, rather, don't you wear glasses outside?"

"No, it's uncomfortable."

"Ugh..."

Rie clicked her tongue, looking somewhat disappointed.

"What's the big deal about wearing glasses? It's not that serious."

"Usually, you want to see every aspect of someone you like."

"Ahem..."

I turned my head slightly at Rie's unexpected remark.

After a moment of thought, I glanced at my bag beside me.

"If you really want to see..."

Although I didn't wear glasses outside, I carried them just in case I needed them for something I couldn't see.

I took out the glasses case from my bag and put on the glasses.

"Wow..."

Rie gasped in admiration when I put on the glasses.

Was there a reason to like it that much?

Yuni had a similar reaction; perhaps liking glasses was a trait in this family?

"It shouldn't make that much of a difference."

"No, it changes a lot. Your whole impression changes."

"Really? How so?"

"When you don't wear glasses, you have a bit of a delinquent vibe, but with glasses, you look like a smart delinquent?"

"..."

That's still saying I look like a delinquent.

But I didn't intend to deny it.

Even I thought my face had a delinquent look.

With blond hair and sharp eyes, I naturally had a fierce look.

Rie leaned her chin on her hand, staring at me with a foolish smile.

"Hehe, I like the glasses."

"But you said I look like a delinquent."

"Well, that doesn't mean you are one. That's enough for me."

As Rie continued to smile and stare, I gradually felt embarrassed.

When my face started to turn red, I quickly took off the glasses.

"What, why did you take them off?"

"I showed you, that's enough."

"Show me more!!"

Ignoring Rie's tantrum, I quickly put the glasses back in their case.

"That's it. I won't show you."

"So stingy, over something like that..."

Rie glared at me, grumbling.

"By the way, why hasn't Luna come? She said she would join us."

We were in the library to study.

Although Rie had barged into this plan made by Luna, Luna, who had arranged the meeting, hadn't shown up.

"Luna is having a talking with Professor Mcguire."

"Professor Mcguire?"

"I'm not sure why. Should I find out?"

"No, it's okay. If it's important, Luna will tell us."

I said this as I looked towards the library's door.

"You still haven't submitted your career aspiration form, have you?"

"Yes..."

Professor Mcguire spoke to Luna, who was sitting in front of him.

"The semester is about to end, you need to submit it quickly. That way, the academy can decide what to do."

"Yes... I know..."

Luna, with a dejected face, fidgeted with her fingers and looked only at the floor.

"You don't need to make such a face; I'm not scolding you."

Mcguire had come to the academy after a long time and was attending to various duties.

During his work, he heard a piece of news related to Luna.

It was about Luna not submitting her career aspiration form.

While everyone else had already submitted theirs, Luna was the only one who hadn't.

Mcguire had called Luna to hear her reasons.

"...I've been having a lot of concerns lately."

"Concerns?"

As soon as he heard that, Mcguire thought, 'Rudy Astria.'

In the year Luna had spent with Rudy, there weren't many times she had such concerns.

When she was in such a contemplative state and he asked her about it, she would say, 'This is about someone I know...'

She used to talk about love stories as if they weren't her own.

Mcguire thought it might be a similar story this time.

"Go ahead, tell me about it. I'll listen to everything."

Mcguire said with a kind smile.

"I don't know what to do these days... Even though our family isn't well off, I wonder if it's better to inherit it. But I also want to study more about

magic."

"..."

"And even if I study magic, the problem is how and where to study... Just studying isn't feasible since our family doesn't have money..."

"I'm... sorry."

"Excuse me?"

Mcguire had assumed it would be a sweet, romantic dilemma like 'I want to be someone's wife, but how do I go about it...'

However, Luna's concerns were serious future-oriented issues that any student might have.

Mcguire chided himself for having almost responded with a generic 'Do what your heart desires.'

He smiled with his eyes and gestured with his hand.

"No, it's okay. Continue, please."

"Yes... I know that doing what I love is best, but reality doesn't allow us to live just by doing what we love."

"That's true."

However, Luna's interests and talents coincided.

Luna's favorite and best skill in magic was constructing magic circles.

Not only did she have immense talent, but her current skills were not inferior to those of practicing wizards.

"Luna, you could continue focusing on constructing magic circles."

"But... if I do that, our family..."

"There's no need to inherit the family right away."

Mcguire smiled and patted Luna's head.

"I used to have a lot of concerns like that when I was young. But lessons in succeeding the family or managing a territory can be learned slowly. You can take over the family later. But not with studying. The younger you are when you study, the more growth you can achieve. When you get to my age and try to start something new, your body aches, and you just want to stick to what you're used to."

Although it's said that learning never stops, it's not always the right thing to do.

When you get older, your mind becomes rigid, and it's harder to accept new things.

Mcguire felt this acutely when he recently attended a conference.

He just wanted to stay at the academy comfortably, doing what he had been doing.

Even so, Mcguire had endured and stayed at the conference.

"Don't worry about money with your level of skill. Someone will want to hire you, even if it means they have to sponsor you."

He wanted to suggest that Luna stay at the academy.

If Luna stayed, she would be an extremely valuable addition to the faculty.

Many professors at the academy also came from families with territories.

A lordship could be managed by a deputy while holding a professorship.

There was no need to always be present in one's territory.

However, he couldn't make such a suggestion.

Luna wanted to see more and experience more.

Mcguire did not want to hinder Luna's growth for his own selfish reasons.

After all, Luna was his student.

It was natural for a teacher to wish for their student to grow and become a greater person.

"So, what should I do...?"

"There are many conferences in the world. There are those sponsored by private families, or you could join the Royal Wizards. But you don't need to decide right now. That's why there's an internship, to help alleviate these concerns."

"But..."

Even as Mcguire said this, Luna's expression did not brighten.

"You can do anything, Luna. I've seen that in you as my student."

Mcguire tilted his head slightly, smiling kindly.

"Is that an answer for you?"

"Yes... But...!"

Luna clenched her fists tightly and looked at Mcguire.

Mcguire wondered if there was some concern he was unaware of.

Despite his well-intentioned advice, it might not apply to Luna's situation.

He looked at Luna carefully, and she blurted out:

"If that happens, I'll be separated from Rudy for too long... Wouldn't it be better to receive the family education and be free to move around? I heard that conferences restrict freedom a lot...!"

She spoke passionately.

"..."

"The others go to their families for education and have the freedom to move around! What if Rudy..."

"...Luna."

"Yes?"

"Have you considered staying at the academy?"

Mcguire thought it would be better to have her educated by his side than to have her harboring such foolish thoughts.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 206: Final Exam 2 (4)

In the academy's vice principal's office.

Cromwell sighed while going through documents.

The last image of Astina he had seen flickered before his eyes.

"Was it right to leave her like that..."

Astina was mature.

She had been sensible since she first entered the academy.

She never showed a childlike side to anyone, taking on everything alone, whether it was student council work or other matters.

Certainly, she must be carrying some burden now.

After some contemplation, she must have thought the best way to counter the rebels was to form an Royal army.

As a mentor, he had failed to notice any of his student's concerns.

Even though Astina trained alone at the academy and occasionally visited him, he hadn't noticed even the slightest hint.

Astina was undoubtedly strong.

Whether considering physical or mental strength, this conclusion wouldn't change.

However, that didn't mean Astina was invincible.

She too could feel stress and sometimes fear like any human.

Her decision to confront the nobles of the empire and stand against the rebels must have been influenced by some incident.

She must have believed that facing and opposing the rebels was the best response to the situation.

Otherwise, there would have been no reason for Astina to confront the rebels directly.

It was too dangerous, both politically and for Astina as an individual.

Cromwell didn't think the Royal army would lose, but what might happen to Astina was uncertain.

Having fought Aryandor himself, Cromwell was even more worried.

Astina's speech in the capital had a significant impact.

It gave the commoners, who were receiving aid from the rebels, another chance to rethink, and it raised awareness among others.

The rebels wouldn't just leave Astina alone after she made such a statement.

They could attack her in revenge for killing Jefrin in public or for political reasons.

Since Astina had united the empire again, killing her, the focal point, would boost the rebels' morale.

She was too attractive a target for the rebels.

In this situation, what pained Cromwell the most was that there was nothing he could do.

As the vice principal of the academy, he had influence in the political sphere, but he had to act too passively.

He was always part of the academy and one of its representatives.

He couldn't show his political inclinations or move freely.

Especially in such a significant event as opposing the rebels.

"How pathetic..."

Cromwell lamented his own powerlessness.

Knock, knock.

Just then, there was a knock on his office door.

"Come in..."

Cromwell started to say, but before he could finish, the door opened.

He could have called it rude, but there was only one person who would enter his office like that.

"It's been a while, Cromwell."

The person who entered the room was Robert, dressed in casual clothes, his hair carelessly combed.

Cromwell stood up abruptly upon seeing him.

"Robert...! You're back?"

At Cromwell's words, Robert smiled.

"Yes, I've finished up what I needed to do. Thinking about my vacation time ticking away made it unbearable to stay out any longer."

"Good, you're back. Come, sit down and let's talk."

Cromwell gestured kindly towards a sofa in the front.

Robert flopped onto the sofa Cromwell had pointed to.

"Ah, yes. I'm terribly exhausted."

He looked at Cromwell while lying back half-way.

"Any problems at the academy?"

"There's more work outside than here."

"You know more about outside matters than I do."

Cromwell had his own network of informants and was not short of information, but he didn't have the same experience as Robert, who had spent about half a year outside.

Robert, called a legend in the mercenary world, had more acquaintances outside the academy than within.

And there was a big difference between seeing and feeling things firsthand and just hearing about them.

Information could become unclear as it was passed along, and the content could be distorted.

"Did Rudy get into any trouble?"

Cromwell gave a wry smile at Robert's question.

"Like accidentally coming second in the joint assessment, or suddenly drawing in and capturing the rebels? Nothing much other than that."

"That's quite a lot for the short time I was away."

It would have been big news for any ordinary student, but for Rudy, it felt insignificant.

"At least there hasn't been any sword fighting."

"...Sword fighting?"

"With all those strong women around him. I thought there might be some sword fighting in my absence with his indecisive attitude."

"Women issues..."

"Ah, that indecisive boy. I wonder how he's doing."

Robert said this with a smile, clearly showing his fondness for Rudy.

"But Robert, have you heard about the Astria family lately?"

"Rudy entering the heir competition?"

"You know about it."

"Of course, I know. Someone had to work to make that happen."

Cromwell's eyes widened at that.

"I said I was going to investigate the Astria family. What did you think I meant?"

"Wasn't that related to necromancy?"

"I did other things too. I came across various matters while investigating necromancy."

"Ha ha..."

Cromwell laughed, but he couldn't laugh wholeheartedly.

He felt the contrast between himself and Robert.

Robert had actively worked for Rudy's sake, while he could do little for Astina.

He felt keenly that he was an inadequate mentor.

"What have you been doing?"

"Me? Just the usual. Taking care of academy affairs..."

"Astina seems to be in a difficult situation."

Robert hit the nail on the head.

He always did.

Seemingly casual, he was more perceptive than anyone else.

"Do you plan to just leave her be?"

"...There's nothing I can do right now."

"If you say so, I won't argue."

Robert stood up.

"Don't regret it later. I'm speaking from experience."

"...Thanks, I appreciate it."

"Anyway, I didn't come here to talk about that."

Robert approached Cromwell and pulled out a small bead from his pocket.

"Look at this with the principal."

"...What is this?"

"It's a secret about the Astria family."

More precisely, it was about necromancy, though Cromwell didn't elaborate.

"Weren't you finished with your work?"

"It doesn't seem like the right time to attack. I value my life too."

Robert had found where the necromancers were gathering.

But he couldn't attack right away.

The rebel leadership and Daemon, a necromancer, were nearby, as was Perrian Astria, Rudy's father and the current head of the Astria family.

He couldn't face both the master of spatial magic and the necromancers.

"But why give this to me?"

Cromwell knew whom Robert was cooperating with.

Jason Ophillius, the empire's chancellor.

Handing it over to him would practically end it all.

The aftermath would be handled by the empire.

"Something feels off."

"Off?"

"It stinks. Really stinks."

It was odd to distrust Robert, but to say that the empire's chancellor smelled fishy was strange.

Jason Ophillius had supported McDowell and served the emperor's faction for decades.

There was no reason to distrust him.

If the chancellor had ulterior motives, the empire's balance would have been shattered.

His power was maintaining the balance between the emperor's and the nobles' factions.

It was puzzling to hear such doubts about someone so pivotal.

"Anyway, I'm not certain or basing this on any evidence, so don't worry about it."

"Okay. But what now with this?"

Robert shrugged.

"We'll attack when an opportunity arises."

"You mean us?"

"Who else would handle this?"

"Why not leave it to the empire? They'll take care of it."

"To cause division between the emperor's and nobles' factions in this situation? Planning a three-way battle?"

There was no need to create division in the midst of the conflict between the rebels and the empire.

"Just keep it between you and the principal for now. Just in case."

"...Understood."

After hearing Cromwell's response, Robert walked towards the door.

"Then I'm off to rest."

Robert waved his hand and left the vice principal's office.

Cromwell watched him go and then stared intently at the bead Robert had handed him.

On the day of the final exam.

I warmed up my body.

I wasn't thinking about anything else.

For now, I set aside my usual worries and focused only on preparing for the exam.

"In the magic circle... the formula is..."

I went over what I had memorized one more time.

Although the final exams after the joint assessment were said to be easy, I couldn't be complacent.

I needed to score high here.

I had lost to Yeniel in the joint assessment, so I had to outdo her score somehow.

Luckily, Yeniel didn't do well in the midterms.

As I walked to the exam hall, reciting from the book.

"Hey, you'll trip if you keep going like that."

A familiar voice called out.

I looked up and to the side, where a man with a spotty beard stood.

"Professor Robert?"

"Studying a bit now won't make much of a difference. Don't trip and ruin your condition. Just head to the exam hall quickly."

Robert chuckled and advised me.

I hurried over to him.

"When did you arrive? Why didn't you let me know?"

"Why would I contact you about coming here? Just greet me when you see my face."

I laughed at Robert's casual response.

"I wanted to learn more dark magic before heading back to the capital, but it was a shame you weren't around."

"What would you learn from me now? You're just studying on your own."

"Ha ha..."

"Anyway, I have something to tell you, so come to my office after your exam."

"Something to tell me?"

"Don't be curious now. Just do well in your exam."

Robert patted my back and walked away.

'...Something to tell me?'

I pondered briefly, then shook my head.

As Robert said, I could hear it later; there was no need to be curious now.

The exam came first.

I walked quickly to the exam hall and entered.

Then I opened my book and murmured to myself.

"I'm aiming for the top rank."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 207: Final Exam 2 (5)

"The final exams are now over. You all have worked hard this semester."

The exams had ended.

I was somewhat taken aback by the higher-than-expected difficulty of the exams, but it felt like business as usual.

I looked out the window.

The weather had turned quite cold, and I could see that people's clothing had gotten thicker.

The leaves had fallen from the trees, leaving only bare branches behind.

It felt like just yesterday winter had passed, yet here it was again, bringing with it a fresh sense of nostalgia.

"The student council is over now, too."

With the end of the final exams, the semester had come to a close, which also meant the end of the student council.

I remembered relying heavily on the student council's help, whether it was for studying or other assistance.

After meeting with Professor Robert, I decided to stop by the student council room.

I planned to tidy up my stuff and express my gratitude to the other members.

Being involved in many unusual activities myself, the others in the student council had it tougher than me.

Especially Rie, thanks to whom I could move around freely.

Without Rie, the student council wouldn't have functioned properly.

Eager to talk to the student council, I quickly made my way to Professor Robert's lab.

As I approached Robert's lab, a voice reached my ears.

"Professorrrrrrrrrrr! You really came back! I'm so glad!!!"

It was a familiar voice.

But having not heard it in a while, it made me smile.

As I opened the door, I saw Gracie, making a fuss over Robert, and Robert himself looking at her with an air of disdain.

"How much I suffered in your absence, Professor..."

"Hello, Professor Gracie."

"...Huh?"

Gracie, who was in the middle of her passionate speech, turned to look at me.

"What are you doing, Professor? You're not a child."

"Uh..."

Gracie blushed and grabbed her head at my comment.

Robert burst into laughter at her reaction.

"For once, you're saying something sensible. Gracie, you're a professor now, behave like one."

"Ugh... I was just excited to see you. That's all."

Gracie stammered her reply, and Robert sighed.

"Grow up a little."

"Yes..."

Gracie, scolded by Robert, glared at me.

"Besides, Rudy Astria! You! If you're all better, you should be attending the lab!"

"Me?"

I looked at Gracie, puzzled.

"Do you know how much work has piled up in the lab!"

"...Professor, do you not know anything?"

"...Huh?"

"I'm now a third-year student."

"Is that so? A third-year..."

Realization dawned on Gracie, and her eyes widened.

"Oh..."

Typically, students belonging to a lab participate in research internships within the academy during their third-year social practice.

But there's no reason for me to be doing this, right?

"Since you're here, I might as well tell you now. I'll be heading to the capital in a couple of days. Thank you for everything you've done for me."

I felt that it was actually Gracie who owed a debt of gratitude, but I made the customary farewell.

"Right... your family..."

Gracie seemed to recall something about my family, standing there with her mouth agape.

"But, weren't you pushed out of the succession battle? I thought that's why you..."

"I just joined because we were short on funds."

I wondered if I had told Gracie too little about myself.

We were always busy working together, but I had never shared personal details.

"Then you should have at least mentioned it..."

"I thought you knew since it was around the final exams."

"So... you're leaving, and Yuni too..."

Gracie muttered to herself, then seemed horrified.

"What am I going to do now!"

"It's only been a few seconds since I told you to act mature."

Gracie looked at Robert with a gloomy expression.

"But..."

"As a professor, you should know how to stand on your own two feet. You can't depend on the students for everything."

Robert clicked his tongue several times and waved Gracie off.

"If you're done, leave. I have something to discuss with Rudy."

"You're too much! Professor! You should at least offer some comfort to this novice professor!"

"Why would I say such a thing? If you want consolation, go to Cromwell. He's your mentor."

"Ah..."

With her shoulders slumped, Gracie walked away weakly.

"Understood... I'll see you later then."

"Yes, see you in a bit."

Gracie then tilted her head in confusion.

"In a bit?"

"There's a dinner tonight. All the other professors will be there, aren't you coming?"

"Oh... I forgot about that."

"Let's have a drink and talk there. It's not appropriate to behave like this in front of the students."

Robert gestured towards me as he spoke.

It seemed he only scolded Gracie because I was present.

Even though I'm deeply involved with the professors, the student-professor relationship remains unchanged.

Gracie nodded vigorously at Robert.

"Yes, yes! See you later!"

"Alright."

After Gracie left the room.

Robert watched the space where Gracie had disappeared for a moment.

"Ah..."

Then, he let out a deep sigh.

"Such a bothersome fellow."

"Still, she works hard. Please be kind to her."

"Yes, it's been a long time since someone like her joined the academy..."

The reason Gracie was struggling with her professor duties was because she did everything meticulously.

She didn't shirk her duties, managed her own work, and even helped other professors, so it was natural she was busy.

"Usually, other professors only focus on their own work, often neglecting other responsibilities.

In such an environment, it seemed that even Robert was inclined to take care of someone like Gracie.

"By the way, what did you call me for?"

"Nothing major. I just wanted to discuss the Astria family with you."

"The Astria family?"

I laughed awkwardly at that.

Even though it's the Astria family, I knew very little about it.

I had been at the Astria household for only a week since my arrival here.

In the game too, there wasn't much detail about the Astria family, so I didn't have much to say.

"Do you know the current status of the Astria family?"

"...Only what you've told me. About the Astria family's connection with necromancers..."

"Yes, the necromancers. There are three reasons why the Astria family stands as a central ducal house in the empire. First, the necromancers."

Robert raised one finger.

"The necromancers supply the Astria family with mana stones, which are used to create powerful magical tools. This helps the family sustain its resources. And secondly, the Astria family's spatial magic. I won't go into detail on that."

Robert put down his hand and lifted a stack of papers onto the desk.

"Lastly, the families around the Astria family. They support the Astria family, making it difficult for the empire to act rashly against them."

There isn't just one or two families supporting the Astria family.

One-third of the empire's nobility, a significant faction, supports the Astrias, preventing the emperor from easily meddling with them.

"There are two things you need to do in the capital. First, learn spatial magic. Second, win over those noble factions for yourself."

"...Win over the noble faction for myself?"

I was surprised.

I have long been marked as a supporter of the emperor's faction in the central empire.

How would I manage to attract the noble faction under these circumstances?

"Don't overthink it. These people aren't united under some noble cause; they're just together for their own interests. It should be easier to persuade them."

I nodded.

In essence, I was to convince them that supporting me was more beneficial than backing the current Astria family.

This thought somewhat eased my mind.

"The challenge is how to entice them."

"Exactly."

The benefits they could gain by abandoning the original Astria family and supporting me.

Is there something like that?

The Astria family has been garnering the support of the nobility by advancing noble interests over those of the commoners.

Exploiting the common folk for a world that favors only the nobles.

Could I offer a benefit greater than the Astria family without exploiting the commoners?

As my expression darkened with these thoughts, Robert snorted dismissively.

"If you can't think of anything, why not use what you're good at?"

"Something I'm good at?"

A few things came to mind.

I had been making progress with black magic, and I was confident in my understanding of mana control, rivaling even the professors.

Recently, I had been diligently studying elementals.

Were these what he meant?

But what Robert suggested was completely unrelated.

"Win over one of the noble ladies. You're exceptionally skilled at charming women, aren't you? Gain support through a strategic marriage."

"What are you talking about?"

I was already dealing with complications in my relationships with women.

Was he suggesting I make it even more complicated?

Seeing my reaction, Robert chuckled.

"I'm joking. But seriously, think about how to win the support of the noble faction."

"I understand... I'll give it some thought."

"The necromancy-related matters, I'll handle them. You focus on your tasks."

Hearing Robert say this was reassuring.

As I nodded, Robert's expression turned serious.

"And remember this one thing. Ian Astria is not your enemy."

"My brother?"

Ian's reputation and achievements were too significant to be dismissed.

He was regarded as one of the most talented in the empire.

Seeing my puzzled look, Robert elaborated.

"I'm not saying he's insignificant. He's capable, but he can't step out of the shadow of your father. You'll understand what I mean once you're in the capital."

"I appreciate the advice. I'll keep it in mind."

I bowed to Robert and gave a grateful smile.

"Yes, and sort out your affairs with women. It's unbecoming for a man to dither."

"I'll keep that in mind too."

I nodded awkwardly and bowed to Robert.

"I'll visit when I have time, Master."

"That title again..."

Now, he just chuckled and shook his head whenever I called him 'Master'.

With that, I left Robert's office and headed towards the student council room, just as I had planned before visiting the lab.

"Will Rudy ever show up? My legs are starting to cramp..."

"He should be here soon..."

"Didn't you say something to him?"

"Well, it wouldn't be a surprise if I had..."

Despite the lights being off, voices could be heard in the student council room.

It was Luna's surprise.

She had informed Rie earlier to prepare a surprise for Rudy.

With the end of the final exams and the conclusion of the student council activities, Luna planned a party to celebrate their hard work.

The problem was that they hadn't informed Rudy.

Rie, who had been in on the preparations, assumed Luna would have told Rudy since she was keen on organizing the event.

Busy wrapping up student council matters and preparing for final exams, they hadn't paid attention to this detail.

"Should we tell him now?"

"Shall I fetch him?"

Kuhn, who was hiding nearby, popped his head out and suggested.

Rie pondered for a moment, then sighed.

"Everyone, come out. My legs are aching."

Locke crawled out from under a desk, Emily and Kuhn emerged from the cleaning cupboard, and Luna squeezed out of the storeroom.

"We can't keep doing this, not knowing when he'll come..."

Rie, feeling slightly disappointed that Rudy hadn't come straight to the student council room after the exams, let out a sigh.

Luna looked down, feeling guilty.

"...Sorry."

"It's not just your fault. I should have checked too. Let's stretch a bit and think..."

Thud— Thud—

As they spoke, footsteps were heard outside.

Everyone's eyes widened at the sound.

"Hide!"

They quickly concealed themselves again.

The footsteps stopped outside the student council room, and the door opened.

As the person entered, everyone silently counted.

"One, two... three!"

Bang—

"Rudy, great job!"

"Rudy, well done!"

"Rudy...?"

They all jumped out, setting off small fireworks.

However...

"...Luna? Sis? Kuhn?"

The person at the door was Yuni.

Yuni looked bewildered as she gazed at everyone.

Confetti from the fireworks stuck to her hair.

"...Ah."

Rie held her head and sighed deeply.

"...Sorry, everyone."

Luna looked back at the others, her voice wavering.

Yuni squinted slightly and looked at them all.

"If you all make that face, I'll feel hurt."

Just as Yuni wore a sulky expression,

"...What's going on?"

Rudy peeked his head in from behind Yuni.

Everyone let out a deep sigh.

"It's a total mess."

"Indeed..."

"Sorry..."

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 208: Final Exam 2 (6)

I smiled and looked at the dejected kids.

I couldn't be upset that they wanted to throw a party for me as a way of saying thanks for my hard work.

"Thank you, everyone. What have I done to deserve all this?"

"No, Rudy, you've done so much for us."

"Rudy's efforts are well known to us!"

"...Yeah, I did everything."

Luna and Kuhn shook their heads as they spoke, but Rie had a sulky look on her face.

I smiled at Rie.

"Right, Rie, I really appreciate it."

"...Hem hem!"

As I spoke to Rie, she coughed and blushed.

Just as we were creating a warm atmosphere,

"Seniors, if you're done talking, could you please help me?"

An uninvited guest who couldn't join our conversation.

There was Yuni.

Yuni was wrapped in colorful paper due to the fireworks that others had set off.

She was flailing her arms, struggling to get it off.

"Sorry Yuni.... I'll help you."

Luna began to carelessly cut the paper with scissors.

I chuckled at that sight and looked outside.

"It really does feel like it's all over now."

"That's right. The student council is truly done now."

The place that was always piled with paperwork was now completely empty.

Only personal belongings remained, leaving it bare.

I picked up the nameplate in front of my desk.

"I guess I should take this too."

As I looked at the nameplate, something came to mind.

I opened the drawer of my desk.

Inside was another nameplate.

Astina's nameplate.

I had planned to return it to Astina but completely forgot about it.

I wiped the nameplate with my sleeve.

"I should return this."

Holding the nameplate, memories of becoming the student council president came flooding back.

"It's a bittersweet feeling."

"You're right. It was kind of fun, wasn't it?"

Emily said.

Rie gasped in horror.

"I would refuse if asked to do it again. It's a miracle I managed to handle this much paperwork while studying...."

"Wasn't it somewhat fun, though?"

At Kuhn's question, Rie's eyes sharpened.

"...What was fun about it?"

"...Staying up all night with the seniors to handle paperwork?"

"Ahaha...."

Luna scratched her cheek and let out an awkward laugh.

Rie glared at Kuhn and Emily with spiteful eyes.

"Then you two go out as the student council president and vice president. Then it'll be fun with the juniors."

"That's a bit...."

"...Absolutely not."

The fact that the positions of student council president and vice president were several times more strenuous than other student council roles was something even Kuhn and Emily knew.

Even though the two of them said it was fun, they clearly didn't want to do it again.

"So, are you two not planning to join the student council again?"

"It doesn't seem like there's any reason to. I never planned to be part of the student council in the first place."

That's right, Kuhn only joined because I persuaded him with various benefits.

He wouldn't do it alone without a good reason.

I turned my head and looked beside me.

"What about you, Yuni?"

Yuni tilted her head at my question.

"Me? What about me?"

I stared at Yuni for a moment before speaking.

"...Never mind."

It was clear that Yuni wouldn't want to be the student council president.

She had always been uninterested in such matters, not to mention the Emperor's position or anything similar.

"Then who will be in the next student council?"

"Diark might do it, don't you think?"

Kuhn responded to my question.

"Diark, huh..."

He had always been interested in the student council.

He ran in the last election but couldn't participate due to various circumstances, so he might take part this time.

He was a diligent guy, so he would probably make a good student council.

I smiled at Kuhn and Emily.

"When the next council comes in, make sure to hand over everything properly."

"Me? If Rudy does it..."

"I'm planning to go to the capital."

Kuhn's eyes widened.

"Are you going there to study to be a successor?"

"More precisely, to compete for the position."

"Congratulations on making it...!"

Everyone knew it was difficult for me to secure a successor position.

But the fact that I could at least compete brought congratulations from Kuhn.

Emily looked at Kuhn and then glanced around.

"So, does that mean we're the only ones left to hand over to?"

Everyone's gaze shifted to Luna.

It was known that Locke and Rie were going away for special training.

But no one had heard anything about Luna.

"Ah... I..."

Luna hesitated before speaking.

"I'm thinking of going towards becoming a Royal wizard."

"Royal wizard?"

"Yes, I thought it would be better to have people I know around..."

Luna didn't have any relatives in the capital.

Being from a noble family in a remote area, it would take a lot of searching to find even one blood relative.

So her mention of knowing people probably referred to me and Rie.

It wasn't a bad choice.

Rie and I could offer considerable support to Luna.

And with the frequent visits of professors to the capital, she wouldn't feel lonely.

"It seems like a good choice."

Luna beamed at my words.

"Right? Professor Mcguire recommended it."

"So everyone is really leaving..."

Kuhn and Emily looked at us with a hint of sadness.

"But it's not like we're graduating. We'll be back after a semester. And if there's time, we might drop by."

I smiled and stood up.

"Then let's say our goodbyes for now. You all worked really hard this past year."

"...You too, Rudy."

"Everyone really did a great job."

It was a year that was long in some ways and short in others.

There were many fun moments, and tough ones too, but it was a year worth its while.

A year of meeting and getting close to many people, of learning many things.

With that, we exchanged our last greetings at the student council with bright smiles.

After exchanging goodbyes with everyone, Rudy and Kuhn were walking towards the dormitory.

"Kuhn, thanks for your help."

"It's nothing. I'm happy to help."

Rudy had been too busy to pack his things, leaving a lot of his belongings at the student council office.

So, Kuhn was helping him move his stuff.

As they quietly transferred the items, Kuhn broke the silence.

"It's going to feel empty without the seniors."

"Empty? You have Emily, don't you?"

"Emily and the seniors... they're different."

Rudy chuckled.

"Don't worry. Good juniors will come in. It'll be fine."

Rudy himself had felt a sense of loss when Astina left.

But good juniors came in, offering help and making his days fun.

Kuhn, smiling, cautiously broached a subject.

"Senior, I have a question, if you don't mind..."

"What's on your mind?"

"It might be a bit rude, but... Can I ask you one thing?"

Kuhn's face was serious as he spoke.

"Senior... Who is your favorite senior?"

Rudy broke into a cold sweat and turned his head away at the question.

Realizing he might have crossed a line, Kuhn quickly apologized.

"...Sorry. I shouldn't have asked that."

"No, it's okay. These things happen."

Rudy couldn't bring himself to answer the question.

Instead, he posed a different one.

"Kuhn... I have a slightly sensitive question too. Is that okay?"

"Sure. You can ask me anything."

Rudy hesitated before speaking.

"You're dating Emily, right?"

"Yes, that's correct."

"Then... how did you confess? If you don't mind me asking?"

Rudy blushed as he asked.

"A confession?"

Kuhn was surprised.

He had thought Rudy, of all people, would have some experience in romance, but his current expression suggested otherwise.

"...Hmm. My case is a bit unique, so I might not be the best to answer."

"Unique how?"

"Emily and I grew up together, so there wasn't a formal confession."

"What?"

Rudy was taken aback.

"So, you're not officially dating?"

"It's not that. A confession isn't always necessary to start dating."

"You didn't confess... but you're dating?"

Rudy found the concept baffling.

"It's just that we both knew we liked each other, so there was no need for a formal confession. A confession is just a way to confirm each other's feelings."

"I see."

Rudy replied, still a bit flustered.

"If it bothers you, perhaps gifting something she likes while confessing might work."

"Hmm..."

Rudy wore a slightly uncomfortable expression.

Kuhn watched Rudy with a wistful smile.

'If it were Luna or Rie, they would be overjoyed even with a simple word of confession.'

A grand confession wasn't really necessary.

Kuhn didn't know much about Astina, but he knew well about those two.

'But... to which senior is he planning to confess...?'

Kuhn gazed at Rudy, lost in thought.

It was impossible to tell what Rudy was thinking.

'I hope we can all see each other again when we return to the academy...'

With that thought, Kuhn continued moving the luggage.

---Toggle New Ads

Chapter 209: Astria (1)

I had finished packing all my belongings and was ready to head to the capital.

There had been brief departures from the academy before, but preparing to leave for good brought on a wave of new emotions.

There was no place as comfortable as here...

I was surrounded by familiar people, and my actions were free.

Now, outside the academy, I would have to be cautious with every move.

A single misstep could lead to unforeseen trouble.

At the academy, the Astria name made actions easier, but in the capital, my name might become a hindrance.

Being the center of attention only added to this.

Early in the morning.

I picked up my luggage and stepped outside.

I planned to leave without delay since I had to depart anyway.

It was so early that only the chirping of birds could be heard, and no one was in sight.

Yet, the fresh breeze was uplifting.

"Rudy, is that you?"

Then, a coachman in the distance approached me.

"Yes, it's me."

"I'll take your luggage."

The coachman quickly ran over, taking the bags from my hand and loading them onto the carriage.

Perhaps he recognized my name, or maybe it was just the briskness of a coachman from the capital.

After loading my bags, the coachman looked at me.

"Shall we depart immediately, or is there somewhere you'd like to stop by first?"

I glanced briefly at the academy.

I contemplated visiting Robert or Cromwell one last time, but then shook my head.

It was doubtful they'd be at work at this time, and without anything specific to say, there seemed no point in stopping by.

"Let's go now."

I spoke briefly and boarded the carriage.

The inside of the carriage was comfortable.

Renting an expensive carriage meant plush seats and a space comfortable enough to rest.

The front window of the carriage opened, and the coachman peeked in.

"It'll be a long ride, so feel free to sleep. The carriage is enchanted with vibration control magic for a comfortable rest."

"Ah, okay."

"Then, we'll be departing now."

Time passed, and I slowly stirred from my stiffness.

It felt like a significant amount of time had passed, yet we had not yet arrived at the capital.

Despite the carriage being as comfortable as possible, the confined space had left my body feeling cramped.

I moved slightly to ease the stiffness and then slumped back into the seat.

"I should have taken out a few books."

Once I had loosened up, I realized there was nothing much to do.

Since I had packed the books separately, I would need to stop the carriage to get them out.

Not knowing exactly where we were, and considering that stopping the carriage would only delay our arrival, I decided against it.

I looked towards the window the coachman had opened earlier.

With a soft clatter,

"Ah, you're awake?"

As I opened the window, the coachman addressed me.

"Yes, I am. How much longer until we arrive?"

"About an hour more to go. And please, feel free to speak informally. I'm just a humble commoner."

I shook my head at the coachman's words.

"There's nothing insignificant about being a commoner. We are all similar, after all."

"Ha, thank you for saying so," he responded skillfully, perhaps used to interacting with nobles.

"I'm a bit bored; would you mind keeping me company with some conversation?"

"Of course, it would be my pleasure."

I smiled at his response and continued the conversation.

"Do you know the current state of the capital?"

"The capital, you say... It's quite chaotic. With the rebels and the empire clashing, some people are even preparing to flee."

"I see... And what about the nobles?"

This coachman seemed to interact with many nobles, given his job of driving a carriage primarily for them.

It would be natural for him to hear stories about the nobles during his travels.

I planned to gather some information.

The coachman glanced at me cautiously before speaking.

"Ha, how could I know what the nobles are thinking?"

"You can speak freely. I'm not one to fuss over such matters."

"Well... from what I've heard in my line of work, it seems the nobles are also busy. Preparing for war, or deciding which side to align with."

His voice grew softer.

"Caught between the rebels and the empire?"

"Oh, no. How could someone serving the empire choose the rebels? I was referring to factions within the empire."

Factional movements...

Such movements would undoubtedly lead to turmoil.

The balance between the noble faction and the emperor's faction, which had been maintained until now, could collapse.

For me, however, this was somewhat good news.

As a contender for the Astria family's succession, I needed to pull the Astria subordinate families, who were part of the noble faction, to my side.

I directly asked the coachman.

"Do you know anything about the movements of the families under Astria?"

The coachman quickly shook his head.

"I wouldn't know such things. How could a commoner like me be aware of the nobility's affairs?"

A strong denial often implies the opposite.

I was just probing, but his response suggested he knew something.

I cracked a sly smile.

"Twenty gold coins."

"...Pardon?"

"I'll give you twenty gold coins. How about you share what you know?"

Twenty gold coins was a sum comparable to the price of this carriage.

It was an amount a commoner might never see in a lifetime.

He might be reluctant to speak for fear of jeopardizing his livelihood as a coachman, but this amount could be worth the risk.

"Ah... well..."

The coachman's eyes flickered with indecision.

"I'll keep our conversation confidential. Why don't you tell me?"

To the coachman, my smile might have seemed like a devil's temptation, but I didn't mind.

After hesitating, he finally spoke.

"Well... this is just something I overheard... Do you know the Mayer family?"

"Yes, I'm aware of them."

A count's family under the Astria name, quite influential in their own right.

"I once served the young lady and the head of the Mayer family. During that time, I overheard them arguing loudly about something..."

It was... about supporting you."

"The Mayer family?"

I was puzzled.

The Mayer family was a well-known, loyal family to the Astria name.

For them to consider supporting me, an outsider? It was good news but felt a bit odd.

"Are you sure about this information?"

"Yes, sir! I heard it myself... So then..."

I maintained my smile.

"Let's settle it once we arrive."

"Th-thank you."

Though the information was somewhat ambiguous, it gave me something to ponder.

The Mayer family...

As I contemplated, a doubt arose.

Could they have been acquainted with the original Rudy Astria?

Even if the original Rudy Astria behaved recklessly, he might have had close connections.

Could I possibly benefit from the original Rudy Astria's relationships?

While this thought brought some reassurance, it also stirred unease within me.

After all, the family members knew me as the original Rudy.

If my changed demeanor became too apparent, I wondered how they would react.

"Ah, we're almost there."

As I mulled over these thoughts, the capital came into view.

Upon arriving at the capital, I headed straight to the Astria mansion.

As the carriage entered the grounds of the Astria estate, I was greeted by an unwelcome scene.

Ian Astria was standing at the front of the mansion, flanked by several nobles.

It almost felt like they had come out to welcome me.

I had informed them of my arrival time in advance, but I didn't expect them to be waiting like this.

I thought they would just be preparing lunch or something.

Besides, wasn't Ian supposed to be busy?

I heard he secured the position of commander in the Royal army, so seeing him idly at the mansion was exasperating.

It was already lunchtime, and the thought of dining with him made me worry about losing my appetite.

The carriage came to a stop inside the mansion, and I stepped out.

"Rudy, it's been a while."

Ian greeted me as I disembarked from the carriage.

"Yes, it has been a long time, brother."

As I returned the greeting, the nobles beside him chuckled.

"It's nice to see siblings getting along so well!"

"Indeed. So many families have discord among siblings, but it's perhaps for this reason that the Astria family continues its legacy!"

I frowned at the nobles' remarks.

What have we done to be considered close?

Is a simple greeting all it takes to be seen as having a good relationship?

Seeing them interpret such basic interaction as flattery was baffling.

The coachman who accompanied me probably could have flattered better.

"Well then, Rudy, let's go inside for a meal," Ian suggested.

I nodded in agreement.

"Yes, that sounds good."

I followed Ian into the mansion.

Chapter 210: Astria (2)

We entered the mansion and took our seats in the dining room.

"Have you been doing well at the academy?"

Ian asked me while we were eating.

"Thanks to your concern, I've been managing,"

I replied to Ian with a subtle expression.

Although I was hungry, the dining situation was too uncomfortable to hide my expression.

Why did this guy suddenly set up such a meal?

Eating alone with Ian would be uncomfortable enough...

The nobles seated around me.

About a dozen nobles were joining Ian and me at our dining table.

Even a cursory glance at their faces was enough to recognize who was who.

Maybe it was due to studying about nobles at the academy, but their presence was hard to ignore.

Ian put down his food and looked at me with a smile.

"Now that I think of it, I heard you've finally become the top student this time."

I grimaced internally.

There was an edge to his words, 'this time.'

As if he had always been the top student, but now it was finally my turn.

Was he trying to embarrass me by calling me here?

Still, I held back.

"It's my fault for realizing things late, but I plan to graduate as the top student, so don't worry."

"Well, make sure you don't bring shame to the name of Astria,"

Ian said.

I gritted my teeth at his words and looked around.

Seeing me hold back, the nobles looked at me with faces of surprise.

Yes, it would be better to show these nobles my changed self.

As I scanned the faces, one person caught my eye.

Count Mayer.

The man I had heard about from the coachman.

He was a middle-aged man with sharp features and black hair.

Despite his age, his robust appearance showed he was a warrior.

The Mayer family was famous for their swordsmanship.

Once called the Sword of the Empire, they were a prestigious family, but lately, their influence had waned.

It wasn't just because the empire heavily supported magic, but also because the Mayer family had not produced any remarkable talents.

The head of the family was getting old and couldn't show the prowess of his prime, and his heirs couldn't match his skill, leading to their inevitable decline.

Thus, to survive, the Mayer family had attached itself to the noble Astria family.

It seemed they had judged that they wouldn't survive if they remained neutral as before.

Considering this situation, it was an excellent opportunity to bring them to my side.

They were not originally related to the Astria family but joined them for political survival.

Though I might be seen as a less stable ally compared to Ian, the Mayer family would surely be deeply considering it, thinking of the honor they could regain if they succeed.

Currently, I have no close allies, so the rewards when I secure that position will be immense.

I closely observed Count Mayer before turning my head away.

It seemed better to speak with him separately later, rather than initiating conversation now.

Turning towards Ian, I opened my mouth.

"Speaking of which, shouldn't you be managing the Royal army?"

"I stopped by briefly for a family meal. With Astina here, there shouldn't be any problems."

I was startled at the mention of Astina's name.

Ian didn't miss my reaction.

"Weren't you somewhat close to Astina? I remember you two being together when I visited the academy."

"Yes, I helped Astina when she was the council president."

"Oh, I heard about that. Astina said she was indebted to you."

"How is Astina doing?"

"She's fine. The Royal army is still in the preparatory stage, so it's not too busy."

At that, my eyes sparkled.

"Then, may I visit you sometime?"

"To see me?"

"I'm curious about the state of the Royal army and would like to observe."

In truth, my visit wasn't to see Ian but Astina.

I wanted to ask about her plans and see her face to check if she was okay.

Additionally, I was curious about whether the Royal army could counter the rebels.

Ian responded firmly to my request.

"That might be difficult. Given the situation, we're maintaining strict security."

"I see."

I swallowed my disappointment.

If not now, perhaps there would be an opportunity later.

With that hope, I held back my words.

Thus, our meal continued.

It was a quiet dinner, devoid of significant conversation.

As time passed, the uneasy meal concluded.

The nobles and I followed Ian as we rose from our seats.

Ian seemed ready to leave, heading towards the courtyard.

"Rudy, it's good to see you after such a long time. We may not meet often, but let's have meals together occasionally."

"Yes, if you wish, Brother..."

The meal ended without much else said.

Why did he invite me for a meal when there was no particular reason?

I wasn't keen on such pointless gatherings.

Despite his apparent dislike for me, why did Ian arrange this meal?

As I pondered, Ian spoke up.

"Ah, and keep next week free."

"...?"

As I looked puzzled, Ian continued.

"Next week, Father intends to teach you spatial magic. I wanted to pass on that message."

"Ah..."

I remembered the scroll I had received from the royal family.

The inheritance of spatial magic.

Hearing those words unexpectedly lifted my spirits.

The food that had been stuck in my throat until the meal seemed to go down smoothly now.

"Understood. Thank you,"

I replied to Ian with a broad smile.

If Ian had come just to convey this message, I wondered how bitter he must feel inside.

So, I smiled even wider, as if to tease him.

"Well, I should be going now,"

Ian said, offering his farewell before climbing into his carriage.

As Ian left, the other nobles also bid me goodbye and started boarding their carriages.

I turned away from the nobles and began to walk.

"Spatial magic..."

I had already witnessed the power of spatial magic with my own eyes.

The spatial magic used by my future self.

Its power was beyond imagination.

However, I was uncertain if I could wield that ability properly.

"If my future self could use it properly, it means I should be able to use it too,"

I mused, talking to myself as I headed towards my room.

"...Rudy?"

A female voice called out from behind me.

Turning around, I saw a woman with black hair in armor, looking chaste and gazing at me with warm eyes.

Her armored appearance gave her the air of a knight.

Who is she?

I asked, tilting my head in curiosity.

"Who might you be?"

I knew it was impolite to ask such a question to someone I might know, but it was better than pretending to recognize her.

It's ruder to be caught faking familiarity.

"You are Rudy, aren't you!"

Despite my rude question, the woman smiled even brighter.

"Yes, it's me! Karen Mayer."

Her voice was laced with excitement.

It was surprising to see her act this way.

Surely she must have known the previous Rudy Astria.

Why would she show such an attitude?

I was astonished that someone who got along well with the notorious Rudy existed.

No, more than that, her use of the Mayer family name implied she was a lady of the Mayer family.

I quickly assessed the situation.

If she already harbored a fondness for me, it would be easier to draw the Mayer family to my side.

I needed to befriend this person.

"Ah, my apologies. I had completely forgotten. I offer my apologies to the lady."

I bowed my head, apologizing formally.

I executed the etiquette I had learned at the academy flawlessly.

As I raised my head, pleased with my response, the expression on Lady Mayer had turned cold.

Her face now bore the sharp and icy impression similar to Count Mayer's I had seen earlier.

The warm gaze from moments ago was nowhere to be found.

"Ah...?"

Did I make a mistake?

Confused by Lady Mayer's sudden change of expression, I felt bewildered.

It was certainly proper etiquette.

Yet, her expression had changed abruptly despite no unusual action from my side.

I couldn't fathom what might have caused it.

'Did I make some mistake...?'

"Karen."

Just as I was about to ask Lady Mayer, Count Mayer appeared behind us.

Count Mayer's eyes widened upon seeing me.

"Ah, you were with Rudy. I hope my daughter hasn't caused any trouble."

"...No, nothing at all. Did you enjoy your meal?"

"Yes, thank you."

The Count responded briefly to my routine question.

It didn't feel like he deliberately kept it short.

He seemed naturally unaccustomed to making smooth, diplomatic remarks.

"Then, I shall take my leave."

Count Mayer bowed his head to me and gestured to Karen.

Karen, however, continued to glare at me despite her father's presence.

"Karen."

"...Yes, Father. I'm coming."

Only after Count Mayer repeated himself did she finally move.

I could breathe easier only after Count Mayer and his daughter were out of sight.

"It feels like something has gone wrong..."

What exactly was the original Rudy Astria's relationship with them?

I grasped my head in confusion.

Karen Mayer and Count Mayer boarded the carriage together.

"We're departing now,"

The coachman announced, and as the carriage started to move, Count Mayer spoke.

"It's been a while since you met Rudy, hasn't it?"

"...Yes."

Count Mayer noticed Karen's less than enthusiastic response and tilted his head curiously.

He continued,

"I've been thinking."

Count Mayer believed he knew Rudy well, especially since his daughter Karen had spent time with Rudy from a young age.

"The current Rudy Astria seems trustworthy. He has completely changed from what the rumors suggested."

The Rudy he knew before was the epitome of a troublemaker.

In fact, he had wanted to prevent his daughter from associating with Rudy, but he let it be due to the wishes of Karen and the Astria family head.

But now, Rudy was entirely different.

He knew how to show respect, keep his temper, and had reportedly achieved good grades at the academy.

Such behavior was unimaginable for the Rudy Count Mayer knew.

'That troublemaker turned into a decent person. Or perhaps, he's just grown up.'

Count Mayer looked sternly at Karen.

"As you wish—"

"He's changed..."

Karen interrupted Count Mayer.

"He's not the Rudy Astria I knew before."

Karen's eyes sharpened as she spoke to the Count.

Count Mayer nodded at her words.

"Yes, he's changed..."

"That's not the Rudy I know!!!"

"...What?"

Count Mayer looked incredulous.

"The Rudy I knew wasn't like that! The Rudy I know! Rudy is!!"

Karen, tears welling in her eyes, was agitated.

Count Mayer wondered what she was talking about.

"My dear... calm down first."

"How can I be calm! Rudy is!!!"

"Well, we can't be sure he's changed. We haven't had a proper conversation yet."

The commanding presence Count Mayer exhibited at the Astria estate was absent.

Instead, he appeared as a father unable to sway his daughter.

At Count Mayer's words, Karen stopped her outburst.

"Maybe... maybe he's just acting..."

"Yes, dear. The carriage is shaking; please sit down."

"...Yes."

Count Mayer cleared his throat and spoke again.

"Then what you mentioned earlier..."

"I'll put it on hold for now. If Rudy has changed, it all becomes meaningless."

Count Mayer sighed at Karen's response.

"What are you planning to do then?"

"...I will meet Rudy myself."

Karen's sharp eyes gleamed.

"I need to see it with my own eyes."

Chapter 211: Astria (3)

The sun was high in the sky.

Dragging my heavy body out of bed, I slightly parted the curtains and stared blankly out the window.

"I overslept....."

At the academy, there was always something happening every day, so I never slept in late.

However, knowing there was nothing scheduled for the next day, I ended up oversleeping.

Of course, it was partly because I had gone to bed late last night.

I stayed up until late at night, studying about spatial magic.

I planned to study in advance before my father returned to teach me spatial magic.

However, I was surprised by the lack of information on spatial magic.

There were historical books and others praising its abilities, but none explaining how this magic works and how to use it.

I thought it was natural for the academy not to have books on spatial magic because it was a secret of the Astria family, but even the Astria family's library didn't have such books.

It's been four days since I came to the capital from the academy.

Despite my search during this time, I found nothing.

"Maybe it's hidden somewhere else....."

That seemed like a reasonable assumption.

It made sense to handle spatial magic, arguably the Astria family's greatest weapon, with care.

I sighed, realizing I had gone through unnecessary trouble.

I sighed.

Knock, knock.

There was a knocking at my door.

"Are you awake?"

I heard the maid's voice from outside the door.

"Yes."

As I responded, several maids entered my room.

They opened the tightly shut curtains and brought me a wet towel and drinking water.

Although I wasn't used to such treatment, it didn't feel uncomfortable, so I naturally accepted it.

As I took a sip from the cup the maids brought, one of the maids spoke up.

"Young master Rudy, Miss Karen Meyer is waiting for you in the reception room."

".....What?"

I was surprised by the maid's words.

Karen?

Why would she suddenly come?

It's basic etiquette for nobles to seek permission from each other before meeting.

A young lady from a count's family wouldn't be unaware of this fact.

"Did she come on urgent business?"

"It doesn't seem like that. She has been waiting for over two hours."

"Two..... hours?"

I made someone wait for two hours because I overslept?

Even though we didn't have an appointment, I felt terribly sorry.

"Why didn't you wake me?"

"I'm sorry. Miss Karen Meyer asked us not to wake you."

"She said not to wake me? Did she say anything else?"

The maid hesitated for a moment before speaking.

"She..... smiled and said she's used to waiting."

"....."

She smiled and said she's used to waiting.....

I looked into Karen while staying at the mansion.

Karen had been Rudy's childhood friend since they were young.

In high-ranking families like the ducal house, it's common for children to spend time with peers from families of similar status.

For Rudy, that friend was Karen.

From what I gathered, Karen and Rudy weren't particularly close.

Rudy often bullied Karen, yet she still visited the Astria family to see him.

Still, I couldn't understand why Karen gave me that look.

Shouldn't a childhood friend be happy if the other decides to lead a righteous life?

It didn't feel like she was trying to use me, a delinquent.

Karen's warm gaze during our first meeting seemed genuine.

After much thought, I concluded that Karen's behavior resulted from suddenly seeing a changed childhood friend.

It's awkward when someone you know changes abruptly.

They no longer seem like the person you knew, creating a sense of distance.

So, my approach was clear.

In front of Karen, I needed to appear as if I was gradually changing.

Instead of changing suddenly, showing a slow transformation would let Karen get used to the new me.

"Well, I'll head to the reception room then."

"Understood."

I changed clothes and headed to the reception room where Karen was.

"Young master Rudy."

Karen greeted me.

Last time we met, she was dressed like a knight in armor, but now she wore typical noblewoman's attire.

If it were me in this situation, I would have apologized, seeming remorseful.

"Yeah."

I responded curtly.

My expression showed no sign of regret. I had to act.

"Young master Rudy...!"

As I acted, Karen smiled as if pleased.

I pushed further.

"Coming without an appointment. Have you no manners?"

The real Rudy would have likely criticized the other person's mistake rather than admit his own.

After saying this, I observed Karen's expression.

Ah.

Karen smiled awkwardly.

There was happiness in her expression, but it was subtly uncomfortable.

Had I been too harsh?

"Tha... I..."

"Young master Rudy."

I was about to shift gears and apologize, but Karen interrupted me.

"You can call me 'you' like before."

'You'?

She's suggesting informal speech?

Maybe...

"What right do you have to order me around?"

I spoke to Karen again, behaving like a brat.

"I'm, I'm sorry."

Karen apologized to me, but her expression subtly showed happiness.

So, it wasn't my scolding that upset her, but rather my not using 'you' that made her unhappy.

I may not understand what Karen is thinking, but for now, I have to play along with her.

Maintaining good relations with the Meyer family was crucial, and Karen served as the important link between us.

I glanced at the maid.

"I'm hungry. Prepare a meal."

Such an imperious demeanor, disregarding the guest.

It was clear that Karen had already eaten.

I paid her no mind.

"Oh, um..."

The maid looked flustered, glancing at Karen for a cue.

I quickly weighed my options.

Would it be ruder to invite her to dine with me, or better to leave her be?

"Oh, I've already eaten, so..."

Before I could decide, Karen, noticing the maid's hesitation, responded with a smile.

I made a snap decision.

"Are you refusing to join me for a meal?"

"No? No, I'll join you for the meal..."

"So, you mean to let me eat alone?"

It's a kind of torture, forcing a full person to eat.

Pleased with my rascally decision, I grinned.

Hearing my words, Karen quickly responded.

"I'll join you! Please prepare a serving for me!"

"Yes... Alright..."

The maid replied reluctantly, clearly puzzled by my sudden change in behavior.

Since this was not the main house but a mansion in the capital, these maids were new to me.

I had been kind to them since my arrival, so their confusion was understandable.

Still, I needed to act this way.

I resolved to treat the maids even better in the future to manage my reputation.

After a while, the meal was served in the reception room.

"Let's eat."

I started eating the food laid out before me.

The Astria family's cuisine was exceptionally high-quality, incomparable to what I had at the academy.

Eating this meal, which I couldn't appreciate when dining with Ian, was now an immensely satisfying experience.

I looked at Karen while eating.

Karen held her utensils and just toyed with her food.

As I suspected, she had already eaten.

Observing her, I spoke up.

"Don't you like the food?"

Karen shook her head vigorously.

"No, not at all! It's delicious!"

"Then why aren't you eating much?"

I pretended to be oblivious.

"Should I call the chef...?"

As I glanced towards the maid, Karen exclaimed loudly.

"It's so delicious I wanted to savor it! It's, it's really good!"

Karen grabbed her utensils and started piling food into her mouth.

She stuffed the food in, her expression betraying the discomfort of eating when already full.

Seeing Karen's reaction, a sense of guilt began to creep up on me.

Had I gone too far?

On second thought, there was no need to behave to such an extent.

It would have sufficed to just verbally act like a ruffian.

Yet, retracting my words now wouldn't be something a ruffian would do.

I had to keep her from eating comfortably without making it too awkward.

I looked at Karen.

"Your food looks tastier than mine."

A ruffian always covets what others have, even if it's something trivial.

It was somewhat a textbook move.

Which noble would envy another's meal?

I was about to smile smugly, satisfied with my performance, when...

".....What?"

Karen's eyes frosted over.

It was the same look she had given me before, questioning my behavior.

I was taken aback.

I thought I had acted correctly.

I didn't expect such a reaction.

Where had I gone wrong?

I swallowed my confusion and thought calmly.

My actions were surely ruffian-like.

It didn't seem like I was at fault.

So, the problem was with doing this to Karen.

Taking her food.

Why should she be upset when I'm offering to rid her of the food that was troubling her?

Then it hit me.

The 'troubling' food.

Could it be...

I turned away from Karen's icy gaze and looked at the maid.

"Prepare double the portion of what Karen is eating. I'll take her food."

"Double, sir?"

"Ahh...!"

The maid was flustered, and Karen's eyes widened in surprise.

A mix of shock and joy was evident in her expression.

Why?

Was this the right move?

I looked at Karen, bewildered.

"Double... double the portion..."

Karen murmured to herself, seemingly in awe.

I was increasingly perplexed by what Karen was thinking.

As I sighed, exasperated.

"Young master Rudy!"

Bang!

A maid burst into the reception room in a hurry.

I frowned at her sudden intrusion.

"What impudence. Can't you see we're having a meal?"

Yes, this situation was better.

In such a scenario, whether a ruffian or a normal person, one could react similarly...

"A guest... has just arrived!"

"...A guest?"

I looked puzzled.

Karen observed me.

"Did you have an appointment today?"

This was a problem.

Especially while I was with Karen.

I had to act like a ruffian in front of Karen and show a normal demeanor to the other guest.

It was impossible to exhibit such contrasting behaviors in front of two different people.

".....Who has come?"

"Th-That's..."

The maid, before she could finish her sentence, looked to the side and gasped in surprise.

She then turned and politely greeted the newcomer.

I was wondering what was going on.

My question was quickly answered.

I saw the person walking towards the reception room.

"Senior, I've arrived."

Yuni walked into the room where we were.

Chapter 212: Astria (4)

"Senior, I've arrived."

Behind Yuni were maids, looking flustered and trying to stop her.

She seemed to have barged in without proper guidance from a maid.

I was taken aback at Yuni's appearance.

I had heard no news of her coming.

More than that, it was puzzling that she was in the capital.

Rie had tasks remaining at the Academy and was scheduled to leave a week after me.

I had thought Yuni would come with her, but here she was, right before my eyes.

However, knowing the guest was Yuni brought some relief.

It would have been troublesome if it were a noble unfamiliar with me.

With Yuni, I could later explain the situation, which was fortunate in this regard.

But the issue was how Yuni would act.

If Yuni caught on to my behavior and questioned it...

Still, I trusted Yuni.

She had changed lately, becoming more perceptive and socially adept.

If I gave her a signal, she would surely catch on.

I looked at Yuni and quickly made a gesture.

I glanced at Karen beside me, then widened my eyes to signal Yuni.

Yuni caught my gesture and furrowed her brows.

"What are you doing?"

Yuni looked utterly clueless, gazing at me.

The trust I had quickly turned to despair.

"Hmm?"

At Yuni's words, Karen looked at me.

I quickly changed my expression to a nonchalant one, pretending nothing was wrong.

Karen glanced at me, puzzled, then turned her attention back to Yuni, examining her closely.

"Could it be... Princess Yuni?"

"Hmm? And who are you?"

Karen immediately stood up and greeted Yuni with respect.

"Apologies. I am Karen Mayer, the eldest daughter of the Mayer family. An honor to meet you, Princess Yuni Von Ristonia, the flower of the empire."

Despite her peculiar personality, the greeting was impeccably polite.

Yuni, hearing Karen's introduction, pondered for a moment, then clapped her hands.

"Ah! The lady preparing to become a knight!"

"Yes, that's me."

Yuni, notorious for not remembering faces and names, surprisingly recalled Karen.

Whether it was because Karen was preparing to be a knight, or because the Mayer family was part of the noble faction, Yuni remembered her.

"Nice to meet you."

Yuni smiled with her eyes and waved at Karen.

It was a normal greeting, but a sense of unease grew within me.

"But why are you with senior?"

"...What?"

"Huh?"

Their eyes and mouths were smiling.

Yet, the atmosphere felt chilly.

It was the first time I had seen Yuni emit such an aura.

"Why are you here?"

"Ah... I heard Rudy had returned... just wanted to see him..."

"What business do you have seeing senior?"

"That... we were close since childhood... so..."

"Being close as children means you're still close now? Or is senior so idle that he dines with just anyone?"

"It's not like that..."

Under Yuni's pressure, Karen's voice grew increasingly meek.

Believing I couldn't leave the situation as it was, I opened my mouth.

"Stop it there."

"...Senior?"

"Isn't that enough?"

As I was about to scold Yuni,

"No, it's not!"

Karen interrupted.

"I'm the one at fault, so it's only right for me to be reprimanded!"

Her face was slightly flushed with excitement.

Karen looked at Yuni.

"Princess! You can reprimand me more!"

"...What?"

"I deserve to be scolded! Everything you said, Princess, was correct!"

Yuni flinched and stepped back, then looked at me with fear in her eyes.

"Senior... what's with her?"

I had no answer.

I didn't understand it myself.

"Have you eaten yet?"

"...No, not yet."

"Then sit down. Since we're eating, let's eat together."

"...Okay."

Yuni sat at the table, her eyes filled with terror as she looked at Karen.

Fear of the unknown.

While I was somewhat familiar with such behavior, for the young Yuni, it seemed to be a shock.

I sighed and was about to call the maid.

"Let's have the meal..."

Before I could finish, the door to the room opened again.

"Young master Rudy... the meal you requested..."

"Ah..."

The meal I had ordered for Karen arrived.

Stew, bread, and salad.

Exactly double the amount Karen initially received.

Yuni looked at me with a puzzled face.

"Senior... is someone else coming?"

As Yuni spoke, Karen raised her hand.

"It's, it's for me!"

Karen, who clearly had already eaten, left Yuni confused.

"You've finished eating, haven't you?"

"No! Young master Rudy definitely said to eat double..."

Karen stopped mid-sentence.

She seemed to realize what she was doing.

"...But, Young master Rudy... I don't think I can eat all of this. I'm too full..."

Karen turned her gaze to me.

Her eyes begged not to be punished.

"...Yuni."

"...Yes?"

"Eat that."

"...That? It's too much."

"Eat what you can..."

"Ah..."

Karen let out a sigh tinged with regret.

She couldn't say it out loud and just looked at me.

Her eyes conveyed a message.

That food was meant for her.

I ignored Karen's pleading gaze.

My conscience couldn't bear it.

And then,

"What's this... Scary..."

Yuni trembled in fear at the sight of Karen.

After the meal,

Karen returned to the Mayer mansion.

Initially, she was reluctant to leave, but after being admonished a few times by Yuni and me, she left with a satisfied look.

Yuni, sitting across from me, asked.

"What's with that person?"

"She's the daughter of the Mayer family."

"I know that. But why does she have such an expression when being scolded?"

I couldn't bring myself to answer that.

I didn't have precise information, just speculations.

And I didn't want to expose Yuni to such depths.

"Okay, let's say that behavior is possible. But what's her relationship with you, Senior?"

"Me?"

I answered without much thought.

"A bridge to the Mayer family?"

It didn't feel right to call Karen a childhood friend since I knew so little about her.

If Yuni started probing into this, it would surely become a headache.

Better to imply that we weren't close in the past.

"Hmm? But she said she was your childhood friend."

"You said it yourself. Just because we were close as kids doesn't mean we are now."

"Right? The present is what matters?"

Yuni seemed satisfied with my answer and smiled pleasantly, then continued.

"So, what am I to you?"

I replied without hesitation.

"You're you."

"...What's that supposed to mean?"

Yuni is Yuni.

She's quite unique, so in my mind, 'Yuni' has become its own concept.

Yuni pouted her lips and grumbled.

"You know, like 'the woman who shakes my heart~'. When she's around, my heart pounds~."

"That's definitely not the case, so don't worry."

"Tch. You're too blunt. That hurts."

Yuni scrunched up her nose.

"Even if it's not to that extent, appreciate that I give you special treatment."

I couldn't guarantee that this special treatment was entirely positive, but considering her a good person, it seemed alright.

Yuni seemed displeased and glared at me.

"If you keep talking like that, I won't tell you why I came."

"Why did you come?"

I tilted my head.

"Now that I think about it, why are you here? You could have at least told me. I would have prepared."

"I can get that treatment at the royal palace. Whatever you offer would just be uncomfortable."

Yuni sighed and looked at me.

"So, what am I to you, Senior?"

"...A good younger sister?"

"Is that all?"

"You are you. What more do I need to say? Isn't this better compared to some ordinary relationship?"

After hearing my words, Yuni pondered and then her eyes widened.

"So, I'm someone with an incomparable relationship to you?"

"..."

It seemed a bit twisted, but if only considering the meaning, it wasn't far off.

I didn't quibble over it.

If she remained upset, it would take time to appease her...

"So, to you, I'm that kind of person, right?"

"Yeah, let's go with that. So why did you come?"

"Your answer is a bit unsatisfactory. But I'll be kind and let it slide."

Yuni smirked mischievously and leaned closer to me.

I stepped back slightly at Yuni's approach.

Yuni came closer and spoke in a soft voice.

"Right now, you haven't been able to meet Astina, have you?"

"How did you know that?"

I was trying to gather information to meet Astina, but all my attempts had turned into nothing.

I couldn't even request a meeting with Astina, and sending a letter was just as difficult.

I wasn't sure where the problem lay, but it looked impossible to meet Astina through ordinary means.

Yuni spoke confidently.

"It's obvious. That's why I came."

"You?"

"Even though I'm just a princess."

Yuni puffed out her chest.

"I'll arrange a meeting for you."

Chapter 213: Astria (5)

A few days after my conversation with Yuni.

"Rudy, it's been a while."

"It has, Father."

My father, Perrian Astria, had arrived at our mansion in the capital.

His splendid golden hair, a testament to the Astria bloodline, stood out.

Despite being middle-aged, he looked remarkably young with his tall stature and vibrant golden hair.

"It's your first visit since you went to the academy, Rudy."

Perrian gestured towards me and then embraced me warmly.

"I should have visited sooner, Father, even with my busy schedule."

"Don't make excuses,"

Perrian chided, prompting smiles from those around us.

To outsiders, we must look like a loving father and son, but the reality is quite different.

Does this man really care for Rudy, just because he's his son?

I think not.

He seems to care for his sons, but in reality, he doesn't pay much attention to either me or Ian.

Perrian isn't at an age to retire yet.

At 50, he's still at his prime in the political arena.

Usually, nobles occupy their positions well into their 60s or even 70s.

But Perrian's desire to retire is due to a secret in the Astria territory.

Necromancers.

The Astria territory harbors necromancers, as Robert has discovered.

Perrian's interest lies solely there.

His retirement is a legitimate way to stay in the Astria territory.

If the head of a family like Astria moves, all nobles take notice.

If Perrian doesn't pass the family to Ian and stays in the territory, it could draw attention to their secret.

By entrusting most of the family matters to Ian, the focus shifts to him.

A retired head usually doesn't attract much attention.

Perrian gained his freedom easily through retirement, freeing himself from any obligations.

No one pays him mind now, so his reputation remains unaffected regardless of his actions.

Even if someone notices something wrong, they dismiss it with, 'He's retired, don't bother about it.'

While I pondered, Perrian asked with a smile,

"Is something the matter?"

"No, nothing..."

"Then let's go inside."

Perrian entered the mansion with a smile.

"Ha, to think Rudy is already learning spatial magic. It feels like just yesterday he was crawling around."

Our destination was the underground library within the mansion.

A place with spatial magic?

Suspicious of a library underground, I thoroughly searched it before Perrian's arrival.

Despite my efforts, I found no trace of spatial magic.

Even when I tried reading the flow of mana, hoping it might be concealed by magic, I found nothing.

Where could it have been hidden?

I watched Perrian's back with suspicion.

"But,"

He suddenly spoke, as if he had eyes on the back of his head.

"Yes?"

"You seem to have changed a lot recently."

Perrian glanced over his shoulder at me.

I responded with a smile.

"One can't remain immature forever. Realizing the shame in my past actions, I've made efforts to change."

"Is that so? As your father, that makes me happy."

His lips smiled, but his eyes did not.

They bore into me, cold and sharp.

It was clear; I was a thorn in Perrian's side.

Mainly due to the people around me and the events unfolding.

Robert, investigating the Astria family.

Astina, declaring war against the rebels.

The Prime Minister, aiding us.

It wasn't just them.

Everyone around me had turned against the Astria family.

Gradually, they were tightening the noose around its neck.

Even Perrian, retired from politics, must have felt it.

The current situation was proof.

He was in the uncomfortable position of having to pass on the knowledge of spatial magic to someone practically his enemy.

Still, his ability to maintain composure was admirable.

"Here we are."

Perrian reached out his hand towards a wall.

An ordinary wall.

I checked for mana flows, but felt nothing.

It wasn't a magically concealed wall.

Then, as Perrian reached out, a vortex appeared on the wall.

It grew larger, revealing a new space beyond.

"Follow me,"

he gestured.

Spatial magic.

Perrian had just used spatial magic.

But it was hard to tell where this new space led.

I stepped into the space, finding a small library.

There were only a couple of bookshelves, and a small safe in the corner.

"Ah..."

I read the titles on the bookshelves.

Religions and Deities.

The Relationship Between Time and Space.

History of Astria.

The Underbelly of the Empire.

Books I had never heard of before.

Their titles alone made me apprehensive about their contents.

"Don't touch the books,"

he warned.

"I understand,"

I replied.

The risk of taking a book seemed greater than any potential benefit.

If the risk outweighed the return, it was best not to act.

Perrian opened the small safe in the corner.

Then he took out a bottle containing pills.

"What are those...?"

I asked.

"They are pills. They protect the mind."

Perrian handed me two of the pills.

"Take them."

"Me?"

"They're harmless. Take them. Or don't, if you prefer not to."

He warned me, as if challenging my trust.

If he wanted me dead, he had the means to do so.

As the head of the Astria family, he certainly had the power to kill me, though I wouldn't go down without a fight.

But there seemed no reason for him to prepare these pills just to kill me.

I placed the pills Perrian handed me into my mouth and swallowed them.

"But what effect do they have?"

"I told you. They protect the mind."

"Why do you need to protect my mind?"

"Spatial magic is the essence of the Astria family's spirit. And now, I will transfer that spirit to you."

"What does that mean..."

Before I could finish my sentence...

"Ah..."

Suddenly, my head started spinning, my vision blurred.

I couldn't control my body properly, and a wave of nausea overcame me.

Unable to steady myself, I collapsed to the ground.

Perrian, watching me intently, reached towards my head.

"Now, I will transfer it to you."

My vision darkened.

My stomach churned.

My head spun.

My body felt heavy with all sorts of discomfort.

"Ugh..."

"Young master! Are you alright?"

"Ugh..."

As I started to retch, a maid beside me handed me a bucket.

"Ugh... Ugh... Ugh..."

I continued to retch into the bucket.

However, nothing came out except for stomach acid, which only made the pain worse.

"Ugh... What in the world..."

I remembered entering a space with Perrian and taking the medicine he gave me...

Then I lost consciousness.

"What's happening... Ugh..."

The continuous retching left me in agony.

If only there was something to vomit, it might not have been so painful, but retching up just stomach acid was excruciating.

"Young master... perhaps you should rinse your mouth."

"Th... thanks."

I rinsed my mouth with the water the maid handed me and spat into the bucket.

The maid took away the bucket and offered me a cup.

"This is warm tea. It should help settle your stomach."

"Alright..."

Following her suggestion, I sipped the tea.

Drinking it helped calm my body and ease the stomach pain.

As my mind cleared a bit, I began to assess the situation.

"What happened?"

"You entered the underground library with the head of the family and then were found unconscious."

"Right... So, where's my father now?"

"The head of the family has already returned to the estate. He left this letter for you to read when you woke up."

"A letter?"

I took the letter from the maid.

In summary, the letter stated that he had passed on the knowledge of spatial magic to me and that I should now train it.

Ian would assist me with the training.

It would be painful for a while, so I should stay in bed.

That was the gist of it.

"Passed on spatial magic?"

There were too many things that didn't make sense.

Moreover, Ian teaching me magic?

That seemed impossible.

I couldn't even meet the Royal army under the current circumstances.

Ian wouldn't come to the mansion just to teach me magic.

And what did he mean by 'passed on'?

Typically, passing on magic means thoroughly teaching both the theory and practice.

But I had only been lying in bed all day, not doing anything.

Perrian didn't leave any magic books either.

And to learn from Ian?

I kept scanning the letter with a sense of futility.

"What is this... Ugh..."

"Get the bucket! The bucket!"

The maid quickly handed me the bucket as I started to retch again.

I vomited the tea I had just drunk.

"Ugh..."

I couldn't seem to grasp the spatial magic, and the physical pain brought tears to my eyes.

Feeling utterly helpless, I murmured to myself.

"What's going on here..."

Chapter 214: Astria (6)

".....Hmm."

Yuni looked at her reflection in the mirror, taking in her attire.

"This looks good enough."

At Yuni's contented smile, those behind her exhaled sighs of relief.

"So, you'll go with this dress?"

"Yes, this one."

The maid observed Yuni intently.

The dress was more modest and cute than flashy, fitting for lower nobility young ladies.

It suited Yuni well, but it was vastly different from her usual attire.

Yuni typically wore more elaborate and mature-looking dresses.

Being younger than her rival, Rie, a contender for the Royal throne, she chose her dresses to not fall behind in appearance.

However, the dress Yuni now donned was more suitable for a young girl.

It was almost like casual wear and accentuated Yuni's cuteness.

Undoubtedly, this dress complemented Yuni much better than her usual choices.

Her personal maid cocked her head in puzzlement.

Yuni had always disliked such cute dresses.

Her every action and choice of clothing were influenced by Rie, aiming to match her.

What had prompted this change of heart?

Yuni seemed to be searching for clothes that showcased her at her best.

She moved around, examining her reflection in the mirror.

'She has changed a lot,' the maid thought.

Having been by Yuni's side since childhood, she had always noticed the smallest changes in her.

But never had she witnessed such a drastic transformation.

The harshness had left her eyes, replaced only by the innocence seen in her younger years.

Whatever had happened at the Academy, it was a positive change.

"Miss Yuni, I will add some accessories for you."

"Yes, pick something pretty."

"Certainly."

The maid chose a fitting accessory from those prepared and approached Yuni's hair.

"By the way, who are you meeting today?"

"A senior I met at the Academy. They've been very helpful, so I've decided to help them in return today."

The maid's eyes widened at Yuni's words.

Yuni never openly acknowledged receiving help due to her strong pride.

Yet, here she was, speaking so casually about it, which was surprising.

'This person must be the one who changed Miss Yuni....' the maid thought, smiling warmly.

Though she didn't know if the person was male or female, she believed they must be someone good.

Yuni wasn't easy to care for.

She always did as she pleased, never voicing her discomforts.

Being able to help Yuni meant understanding her well.

"Dressing up like this suggests..."

It was probably for a man.

If it were for another woman, Yuni would have preferred a more comfortable outfit instead of dressing up.

Of course, it could be otherwise, but her intuition, honed by years as a maid, told her it was a man.

Especially since rumors had been circulating about Rie having a man in her life recently.

Now, with Yuni giving off an aura as if she too had a man in her life, the passage of time felt starkly evident.

It felt like a mother sending off her daughter to marriage, but seeing Yuni's current situation, she was more overjoyed than lonely.

"Miss Yuni."

"Hmm?"

"Now is the time for you to find your own happiness! Not swayed by others, but happiness that's truly yours!"

Yuni looked at her with a puzzled expression.

"What do you mean?"

"You'll understand my words as you grow older!"

It was a word of encouragement for Yuni, who had always been chasing after Rie's shadow.

However, there was something she was overlooking.

The person Yuni was going to meet was Rudy...

And who Rie was fond of...

'I wonder if the senior will like this.'

Unaware of her concerns, Yuni was beaming with a bright smile.

The day of my appointment with Yuni arrived.

"...Senior, are you alright?"

"No..."

My stomach churned, and the headache wouldn't ease.

I considered postponing my meeting with Yuni due to my poor health, but eventually decided against it.

I had made many efforts, but entering the Royal army had been impossible.

I didn't know what efforts Yuni had made, but they must not have been easy.

I couldn't disregard Yuni's efforts just because I was feeling a bit unwell.

Yuni looked at me with worried eyes and then clenched her fist.

"Then let's meet quickly and return. If it becomes too much, I'll make sure you don't overdo it, so be ready."

"Alright. Thanks."

Yuni, looking spirited, boarded the carriage with me, and we set off.

Contrary to my worries that the swaying of the carriage would worsen my nausea, the ride was surprisingly smooth.

Whether it was a royal carriage or Yuni had arranged for a good one, I couldn't tell, but I was able to relax comfortably.

As I half-reclined, Yuni broke the silence.

"Ian... why are you meeting that person?"

"My father left some business unfinished, so I'm going to hand over the follow-up work."

"...What do you mean?"

I had received the transmission of spatial magic from Perrian.

However, I couldn't use it.

I didn't even know what was transmitted or the content of it.

All I knew was that I had 'received' it.

With just this knowledge, there was nothing I could do.

Even though I had experienced some future events as my future self, I couldn't apply it now.

Without the basics, reaching advanced levels was impossible.

I needed fundamental education.

Perrian had clearly instructed me to learn from Ian, so I was seeking him out.

"Why did you dress up like this, though? You could have worn something more comfortable."

I squinted at Yuni.

Although she wore a simple dress, which could be considered ordinary, our destination was practically a training ground.

It was a place where conscripted Royal soldiers trained, and commanders occupied.

A place more fitting for a uniform or casual attire than a dress.

"Oh... Senior, I thought you weren't very observant, but how did you notice I dressed up?"

"..."

Yuni misunderstood my intent.

When I mentioned dressing up, I was referring to the dress itself, but Yuni took it as meaning she had put effort into her appearance.

"So, do I look pretty? Is this the style you like?"

Yuni twirled her dress and lifted the corners of her mouth.

"Yes, you look pretty. Well-dressed."

Continuing the conversation would only exacerbate my headache and nausea, so I let the conversation drift without much engagement.

"Hmm~. Alright. I'll make sure to come in a similar style whenever I meet you, Senior."

"Okay... Thanks."

"Princess, we're almost there."

While we were exchanging idle chatter, the carriage arrived at the location of the Royal army.

Outside the capital's walls, right in front was a small building of a very unique design.

It was closely attached to the wall, with an empty plaza in front of it.

On this vacant plaza, numerous soldiers were engaged in training.

Initially, I thought being outside the city walls might pose security or enemy threats, but seeing the situation, it seemed my worries were unfounded.

Despite its small size, the building was heavily guarded with many soldiers around, making it impossible to infiltrate.

The reason for their stationing here began to make sense.

Inside the city, there would be insufficient space for training, and the presence of nobles would disrupt the soldiers' training routine.

Stationed outside, all these problems were solved.

"Who goes there?"

As the carriage approached, a soldier came up to us. Yuni opened the window and looked at him.

"I am Yuni Von Ristonia, the Second Princess of the Empire."

At Yuni's words, the soldier's eyes widened, and he quickly bowed.

"My apologies. Please, go right in."

Following the soldier's guidance, the carriage moved into the encampment.

"But how did you manage to set up this meeting? I tried everything and couldn't manage it."

"There's a special way to do it."

"...And what is that way?"

"Um... It's a bit complicated to explain right now... Oh, but Senior, you already know about it. I just played a little trick with that matter."

I tilted my head in confusion.

A matter I knew about that could grant access here?

No part of it seemed to make sense to me.

Did Yuni have some sort of leverage over the nobles?

"Princess, we've arrived at the building."

"Ah, right. Thanks. Here."

Yuni extended her hand to me.

"Let's get down."

"Am I some princess now? Why the escort?"

"You're unwell. I can at least help you out this much. If you don't want it, just say so."

There was no reason to refuse her help, especially when I was struggling to keep myself upright.

"...Alright. Help me out."

"If only you were this cooperative from the start."

Yuni teased me with a mischievous smile and extended her hand.

I accepted her help to get up.

"Ugh..."

However, Yuni couldn't fully support my weight.

As I wobbled with dizziness, I nearly collapsed onto her.

"Yikes... Senior, why are you so heavy?"

"If you're going to complain, don't bother helping."

"Hey, I'm offering my help here. Don't make me feel bad."

Yuni grumbled playfully as I took her support to get out of the carriage.

Then, as we were getting out.

"...Rudy?"

I lifted my head at the sound of my name.

A woman with neatly tied red hair and wearing a uniform was staring at us in surprise.

"...Astina?"

Astina was looking at us with a surprised expression.

Chapter 215: Astria (7)

"Oh my, Astina. Hello."

Yuni greeted with a bright smile.

"Oh..."

Astina looked at Yuni with an interested expression, but her gaze carried a sharp edge.

Just being nearby made my body tingle.

The sight of Yuni half-embracing me was more than troubling, it was serious.

To resolve the situation, I quickly separated from Yuni and spoke up.

"Astina, it's been a while..."

"It's been a while? It doesn't seem like it. Was it just a few weeks?"

"Ha ha... Isn't that long enough? How have you been?"

"I've been fine. You seem to have been doing well too,"

She said sharply.

"I've been unwell, dizzy and..."

"Then you might need a more comfortable place."

Astina reached out her hand towards me.

Then she spoke.

"Gravity."

"Huh?"

"Senior?"

I was taken aback by the sudden magic.

I floated in the air, and Yuni, beside me, looked bewildered.

Astina, with a kind smile, turned to Yuni.

"The little miss has her own matters, doesn't she? Someone is waiting for her inside."

"Li, little miss? No, more importantly, I was going to go with Rudy. He needs to be there too..."

"You didn't tell us that."

"I said I had a companion."

"You said you had a companion, not that they had to be with you in the conversation."

"Ugh..."

Yuni stepped back at Astina's words.

"I'll take good care of your companion, so you go do your thing."

"No."

Yuni answered firmly.

"Rudy also has something to say to the commander. It's more efficient if we handle our business together."

Is she referring to Ian as the commander?

Why did she come to meet Ian?

Before I could express my confusion, Astina spoke.

"Efficient?"

Astina approached Yuni with a cold air.

"This is a military place. There are things more important than efficiency here. It's different from the academy and the royal palace you're used to."

After saying that, Astina looked at the soldiers around us.

"Escort the princess to where the commander is."

Having given the orders, Astina began to lead me inside the building.

"Hey, senior! Rudy!"

As I moved further away, Yuni cried out in despair.

I couldn't look after Yuni in such a situation.

Although I was grateful to Yuni for bringing me here, I couldn't dare to stop Astina.

I floated into the building, suspended by Astina's magic.

Astina placed me beside her, giving me a sharp look.

"Did you come to brag about having a girlfriend or something?"

"Of course not..."

"Then what brings you here? You said you were unwell."

"Could you please put me down? I won't run away."

At my request, Astina sighed and gently lowered me to the ground.

Once on the floor, I opened the bag I had brought with me.

"First, please take this."

I took a box out of the bag, and Astina frowned as she looked at it.

"What's this?"

"Please open it."

Inside the box was Astina's nameplate.

Astina Persia, President of the Liberion Student Council.

The letters were precisely engraved.

"What if you had lost it? That would have been careless."

Astina's eyes lingered on the nameplate, filled with longing, and her lips curved into a pleased smile.

"I had completely forgotten about it."

"Will you keep looking angry even after I've taken the trouble to bring this to you?"

"When have I ever looked angry?"

A warm smile spread across Astina's face.

Seeing Astina smile like that made me feel good too.

I didn't mind the imposing Astina, but she looked best with a calm smile like this.

With a smile still on her face, Astina narrowed her eyes at me.

"But, you didn't come here just to bring this, did you? Especially not when you're unwell?"

Her frown was there, but the atmosphere was different from before.

"Of course not. I came to talk about various things."

"Really?"

Astina laughed playfully at my response.

"I bet you were more pleased to see a certain face there."

"...Huh?"

"You might be good at winning over girls, but understanding their hearts is another matter."

"...Winning over girls?"

"Enough of that. If there's business, let's get to it."

Astina opened the door to a room marked 'Deputy Commander's Office.'

The room was plainly furnished with just a desk and a table for guests, devoid of any other decorations.

It was typical of Astina not to add decorative items, but the emptiness felt stark.

Astina sat down at the guest table in front.

"So, what did you come to talk about?"

I sat opposite Astina and began.

"I wanted to check on your well-being and perhaps offer some advice on any troubles you might have."

"Well-being is one thing, but troubles?"

"Is it wrong to come for advice?"

"There's nothing wrong with it, but to come all this way?"

Astina seemed perplexed, fidgeting with her lips.

I continued with a smile.

"More importantly, how have you been?"

"That's the same question you asked earlier."

"But I didn't get a proper answer. Do you find your role in the Royal army suits you?"

"It's just so-so. I thought I would fit in well with the military, but its oppressive atmosphere doesn't really appeal to me."

"The rebels will be targeting you, Astina."

I shifted the tone, speaking earnestly.

Astina's expression hardened at my sudden serious remark.

"I know."

"Did you join the Royal army because of what I said about the future? Is that why you made this choice?"

"The rebels are a threat to the empire. You know that as well as I do. Someone had to do it."

"But it didn't have to be you, Astina."

I looked at Astina with concern.

"Did you make this choice because I said you might die?"

"Yes..."

"It could have been something that never happened."

"But it could have."

"Weren't there other options?"

"I believed it was the best way."

"Because of me?"

I asked cautiously.

"Did you make this choice because if a situation arises where you could die, it would put me in danger too? And because I would try to change the future, is that why you did this?"

The reason Astina joined the Royal army.

Considering her character, it was easy to understand.

Astina would not burden others, even if she collapsed from overwork.

She feels responsible for the issues of those around her and gives her best to help.

That's who Astina is.

Being in the Royal army meant we couldn't help her directly, and it was harder to reach out to her.

Protected by the empire, but in a position where she had to confront the rebels head-on, she was at greater risk.

Yet, Astina chose to join the Royal army.

She confronted the rebels head-on and took the position of deputy commander.

She chose a path where she faced greater danger, but it made those around her safer.

Being in the Royal army meant there was nothing we could do to help directly.

"It's an overestimation of your importance. I made this choice for my own safety."

I swallowed the words I was about to say.

Further discussion would only confuse Astina.

Knowing only the outcome of the future, I couldn't say more to Astina.

But, I wanted to convey the commitment I had made after seeing her future.

"Astina, just remember this."

I had already seen Astina's future and made a promise to myself.

"If you're ever in danger, Astina, I will come to your rescue. I will save you, no matter what."

Astina looked surprised at first, then blushed and averted her eyes.

"You flirtatious guy. It's because you say things like that, women get attracted to you."

"Flirtatious? I..."

Astina, grumbling a bit, looked at me and smiled warmly.

"Still, hearing you say such things does reassure me."

Astina took a deep breath.

"For you, who speaks like this, I promise I'll never let myself die."

"Don't worry, even if you're in danger, I'll be there to stop it."

"Thank you, I'm counting on you."

Astina shifted her posture and looked intently at my face.

"So, shall we talk about your concerns? I can't stand being in debt, so I'll help you resolve your worries."

"My concern..."

I hesitated for a moment.

Did I speak too hastily about having a concern?

If I talk about my worries here, won't that just burden Astina?

Then Astina glared at me.

"You're not planning to just resolve my concerns and keep yours to yourself, are you?"

"Is that being underhanded?"

I let out a wry laugh at Astina's words.

I thought about glossing over my concerns, but it didn't seem like Astina would let it slide that easily.

Or maybe she'd try to figure out my worries without my knowledge.

It would be better to speak frankly here.

I opened my mouth quietly.

"It's about the Astria family."

Astina looked at me with keen interest.

Chapter 216: Astria (8)

"Are you saying you're giving up your claim to the throne?"

"I thought about it alone at the academy, and I just really don't want to do it~. So, I decided not to."

Yuni spoke with a lively tone, but to Ian, it sounded like a bolt from the blue.

Ian grasped his head and looked at Yuni.

"Did Rudy put you up to this?"

He knew that Yuni and Rudy had a good relationship at the academy.

Now that she had brought Rudy to the army, Ian couldn't help but suspect him.

Yuni opened her mouth with a puzzled look.

"Rudy has nothing to do with it."

Yuni's decision to give up the succession was because she thought Rie was more suited for the emperor's position.

As she pondered this, Yuni furrowed her brow.

"...Maybe not? It seems there might be a little connection."

Rudy's influence was not entirely absent in her decision.

She chose to give up after seeing many people superior to herself and understanding their efforts.

Seeing people put in tremendous effort every day, she decided to give up, with Rie and Rudy being examples.

In a way, Rudy was not entirely unrelated.

But Ian had no way of knowing this.

He only knew the result without understanding the process in the middle.

He saw it merely as an action by Rudy to keep him in check.

Ian clenched his teeth.

'Rudy Astria...'

His plan to make Yuni a puppet emperor and sit atop the empire himself was unraveling.

But the impact wasn't significant yet.

Rather, the greater impact was entering the competition for succession with Rudy.

Ian's worries deepened.

'At this rate...'

He didn't know what his father would do.

Ian had seen Perrian's plan.

Mana stones condensed with the mana of tens, hundreds of people.

Using these mana stones for magic, the capital of the empire could be blown away.

Ian just wanted to rise to the top of the empire through official means.

What meaning would there be in sitting atop a crumbling empire?

Essentially, that would not be gaining the empire but building a new nation on top of a fallen one.

That was not what Ian wanted.

So, he planned to take over the empire in his own way and show it to his father.

If he took over the empire, there would be no need to destroy it.

But his plans were increasingly going awry.

At this rate, he would lose the justification and means to stop his father.

Ian stared intently at Yuni.

"So, are you planning to announce your renunciation of the succession officially?"

"Officially?"

Yuni tilted her head.

She hadn't thought that far.

Yuni's reason for making such a statement to Ian was an action she took because Rudy wanted to enter the army.

It wasn't a planned move.

"Hmm... I guess I have to do it? It's something I'll have to face eventually, right?"

Ian stroked his chin at Yuni's nonchalant shrug.

"Delay it a bit."

If he couldn't make Yuni a puppet, taking the head of the family's position would be meaningless.

With Rie and Astina, along with others, combining their strengths, they were no less powerful than the Astrias.

So, the timing had to be pushed back.

Without an official announcement, she could still change her mind later.

And if she doesn't, he could force her to change it.

How to do it could be decided after securing the head of the family's position.

"After the head of the Astrias is decided, then make the official announcement."

"Sure, whatever... It doesn't matter to me."

Yuni nodded.

Even if the timing was delayed, she had already told the people around her, and there was nothing Ian could do if she decided to announce it anyway.

So, in front of Ian, she just agreed to some extent.

"Well then, since my business here is done, I'll be going. Good luck with the succession competition!"

Yuni briskly stood up and waved her hand.

As she opened the door, two people were standing in front of it.

Yuni narrowed her eyes and glared at them.

"...Isn't that Rudy, who left me behind?"

"What could I have done there? Did you expect me to fight with Astina?"

In front of Yuni were Rudy and Astina.

They had come to find Ian after finishing their conversation in Astina's room.

Seeing them, Ian pressed his temples, looking extremely tired after hearing Yuni's shocking statement.

"Weren't you here to see Astina?"

"No, I also had business with my brother."

"Are you talking to me?"

Rudy slowly entered the room.

"Sit. I'll at least offer you a cup of tea."

"No, thank you. It's not something that needs a long conversation."

"Suit yourself. So, what is it?"

Rudy stood confidently in front of Ian.

"I've received training in spatial magic from father."

Veins throbbed on Ian's forehead.

"Did you come here to brag?"

"No. Father had something to say after the training."

"Father did?"

At Ian's question, Rudy opened his mouth.

"He said I should learn spatial magic from you. So, I thought you would teach me."

"Ha."

Ian looked at Rudy with an incredulous face.

The audacity was unbelievable.

Did he think Ian would teach him just because he came here?

It was preposterous.

Spatial magic is the spirit and pillar of the Astria family.

Mastering it proves the legitimacy of a successor and provides a standard for comparison with heads of the family from other generations.

Who would teach something so crucial to their rival in competition?

Ian was about to flatly refuse, losing his composure, but then he paused, pondering.

Refusing here would provide Rudy with an excuse to seek training elsewhere.

Since the empire demanded a fair competition for succession, any unfairness could lead to objections.

"I'm currently occupying the commander's position, so I can't teach frequently."

He devised an alternative plan.

"Once a month, I'll visit the mansion to teach."

Teaching Rudy once a month was the idea, but he had no intention of teaching properly.

Although his father had passed on spatial magic, Rudy wouldn't be able to use it.

Spatial magic wasn't an easy art, and without proper training, even if it's passed on, the basics would remain elusive.

Passing on Astria's magic wasn't just transferring knowledge, but about the fundamental conditions needed to use the magic.

Just like being allowed to use a sword doesn't mean one can wield it properly, spatial magic couldn't be used without proper training.

Furthermore, the once-a-month condition was set to keep an eye on Rudy.

On the off chance Rudy miraculously managed to handle spatial magic, Ian would be there to respond by visiting once a month.

Rudy frowned at Ian's words.

He couldn't argue though.

It wasn't reasonable to ask for more education from a rival who was also the commander.

"Understood. Could I at least get some books related to spatial magic?"

"There are no books on spatial magic, nor should they be created."

"...What?"

"Spatial magic is only verbally passed from user to user. There's absolutely no record of it."

Rudy looked at Ian in disbelief.

"What happens then if all the users die? Does spatial magic just vanish?"

Ian didn't respond to that.

He got up from his seat.

"I have other matters to attend to, so I can't stay any longer."

Ian said and walked towards the door.

"I'll drop by next week. Until then, ponder over it yourself."

"...Understood."

Rudy watched Ian with a dissatisfied expression, clearly unhappy with the arrangement.

After Yuni and Rudy left, a noisy commotion erupted among the soldiers.

It was a natural reaction given the sudden visit of the duke's heir and the empire's princess.

Astina was trying to quell the commotion as much as possible while returning to her room.

"Deputy Commander!"

A soldier hurried towards Astina.

He was in charge of overseeing the military's entries and exits.

"What's the matter?"

"Well... a gift has arrived for the Deputy Commander."

"A gift?"

"It was sent by Astria, who visited today."

Astina tilted her head in confusion.

"Why didn't you send it to my room? Why bring it to me?"

"...It's not just one or two items, ma'am."

Puzzled, Astina walked towards the entrance.

There, two carriages awaited her.

"What is this about?"

"Well... these are the items sent by Astria, but..."

"What items are we talking about?"

"Some furniture and plants. A rocking chair, Sansevieria plants, and also some disposable items like candles. Here's the inventory list; would you like to see it?"

The coachman earnestly replied and handed over the list of items.

Astina slowly read through the inventory.

"Why would he send all this..."

"And he asked me to give this to you..."

The coachman pulled out a neatly folded note from his pocket.

It was a small note, carefully stored in an envelope.

[Your room seemed quite bare. I've sent a few things you might need. Consider it a token of my gratitude for solving my problem. Please accept them.]

It was a brief letter.

A pleased smile stretched across Astina's face as she read the note, reading it over several times.

Realizing where she was, Astina coughed a few times and looked at the soldiers in front of her.

"Move these things to my room. I'll tell you later how to arrange them."

"...Yes, ma'am!"

The soldiers, used to seeing Astina's stern demeanor, were taken aback by her smiling face.

"Handle them with care."

"Yes, ma'am!"

As the soldiers began to move the items, Astina looked back at the note, smiling contentedly to herself.

Chapter 217: Astria (9)

I sat at my desk, gazing at an envelope.

Lately, I've been receiving many letters.

Some were from people hoping to curry favor with me in case I inherited the Astria family estate.

While others were inviting me to their mansions to get to know me better.

I've been getting all sorts of letters.

I mostly ignored them.

If they were from people related to the Astria family, I would have paid attention, but no such letters came.

The Astria family's people have been aligned with Ian for a long time.

Knowing the family situation, none showed interest in me.

Those already in a pact with Ian wouldn't bother sending me letters.

Besides, it wouldn't look good for me to be exchanging letters with them, given Ian's precarious position.

So, only mediocre opportunists sent me letters, while substantial figures stayed away.

However, this letter was different.

Astina may be young, but she's been in a similar position as mine since childhood.

Having strived hard for the heir's position, I thought she might have some good advice.

And indeed, Astina suggested something valuable.

A gathering of Liberion Academy alumni.

She recommended that I attend.

Connections through school, locality, and blood have always been the strongest ties.

Though not an alumnus yet, there was no reason I couldn't go.

After all, it's a place frequented by former academy attendees.

Some might even be interested in hearing from a yet-to-graduate student like me.

Especially since I've just finished my duties as the student council president - a fresh talent for them.

I could share a lot about the academy and be welcomed.

If only I weren't Rudy Astria...

Among the alumni are several notable figures.

They had no reason to approach me.

Getting politically entangled with me would only be a headache for them.

But among them, there was someone I could approach.

"Go to that gathering and look for Yurik Astria," Astina had advised.

Yurik Astria.

He was my uncle.

Perrian Astria's brother, a collateral noble, having lost in the competition for succession.

"Will he help me?"

"I can't guarantee it, but it's not impossible. He was in a similar position as you."

When persuading people, appeal to emotions rather than logic.

One of the basic principles of marketing.

Now is the time to sell myself to people.

Having someone with a similar experience and a blood relation was enough to stir emotions.

"Master Rudy, it's time to start getting ready."

"Understood."

I rose from my desk and began dressing.

The gathering place for the alumni was a ball.

Not a small ball like those at the academy, but a grand one attended by numerous nobles.

The ball wasn't just for alumni; it also included people brought by the graduates.

Thus, it was going to be a large-scale event.

I started dressing for the occasion.

"It seems we're a bit late in preparing. Weren't you supposed to go with someone else?"

"It's fine. There's no need to arrive exactly on time."

People like Ian or my father often attend such balls from the very beginning.

For higher nobility, arriving early was considered a virtue.

I carry the name of Astria, but in reality, people might not even know I'm attending.

In that case, it's better to arrive a bit late and attract attention.

The maids couldn't have known my thoughts.

Neither Ian nor my father had ever been in my situation.

"Do the people you're going with know about this?"

"Yes, I've already informed them."

The person I planned to go with was Luna.

I had considered going with Rie, but knowing that the princess's presence would draw more attention to her than to me, I decided to go with Luna instead.

Dressed, I headed to the waiting carriage.

"Let's go to the Royal Magic Tower."

"...The Royal Magic Tower?"

The coachman's eyes widened at my instruction.

"Bu-but you can't enter the Royal Magic Tower without prior permission!"

I frowned.

"...Do you think I wouldn't know that?"

"Ahem! My apologies!"

This coachman was different from the one I met last time, displaying an impudent attitude.

Perhaps because he's from our family's staff?

Being employed directly by the estate, he seemed to somewhat disdain me.

Maybe it's time to deal with the people here at the estate.

Currently, neither my father nor Ian lives here.

And it's likely to stay the same while I'm here.

That means I need to turn the people inside into my allies.

An internal enemy is more frightening than an external one.

"What now?"

"...Excuse me?"

"Aren't we going to depart?"

"Y-yes, right away!"

I sighed.

A few minutes later, the carriage was swiftly nearing the Royal Magic Tower.

Though called a tower, it wasn't actually one.

In fact, the term 'Magic Tower' referred not to a specific tower but to a facility where wizards conducted their research.

Surrounding it were trees, their bare branches signaling winter.

As we approached the Magic Tower, a few guards were conducting checks.

“Um... Master Rudy?”

“I know.”

At the coachman's remark, I opened the window.

A guard stood before it.

“Who are you?”

“I am Rudy Astria. I'm here to meet someone at the Magic Tower.”

The guard, with a businesslike demeanor, picked up a piece of paper.

“Could you please tell me the name of the person you're meeting?”

“Luna Railer. She's an academy student here as an apprentice to the royal wizards.”

The guard's eyes widened.

“Oh! You're here to meet Miss Luna! My apologies!”

“What?”

“Please, go right in! Miss Luna is waiting for you!”

I was puzzled at the guard's welcoming attitude.

Why did it feel like they were rolling out the red carpet?

Was it just my imagination?

But as I entered the Magic Tower, my doubts turned to certainty.

“Rudy, it's been a while...”

Luna, dressed in a white gown with floral ornaments in her hair, radiated an almost fairy-like aura.

She had the kind of appearance that captivated everyone's attention.

However, my gaze drifted more towards the people around her.

“Go Luna!”

“Luna, be careful... If any strange guys approach, run away...”

Among them were an elderly grandfather and what looked like a researcher in his thirties.

“Please, everyone, go inside!!”

Luna, her face flushed, was yelling at them.

“Luna, what's the matter... Have we done something wrong?”

“Is it... puberty?”

“No, it's not that! I'm about to leave with Rudy...”

“Come back early... And don't even think about touching alcohol!”

They were fussing over Luna like worried parents.

In just a few days, she had fostered a family-like atmosphere, which left me feeling bewildered.

As I watched the scene with a baffled expression, an elderly man approached me.

“You must be Rudy...”

“Yes?”

“You're confident you can protect Luna, right? Especially in such a dangerous place?”

“Dangerous place?”

I was going to a ball, frequented by well-known families.

There was nothing dangerous about it.

“We're just going to a ball...”

“That's what I mean! Do you know how dangerous a ball can be! Standing alone in a corner nibbling on cake! Becoming the laughing stock of the nobles! The mental shock is like smelling someone who hasn't showered for a week!”

“Ah... Right.”

It seemed balls were terrifying events for introverted wizards.

“Rudy, let's go! Hurry!”

Luna grabbed my arm and pulled me along.

As she was about to board the carriage, she paused to look back.

“...I'll be back soon!”

“Heh heh!”

“To hear such a farewell... It's been a while...”

The grandfathers beamed with joy at Luna's ‘I'll be back soon.’

“Let's go, Rudy.”

“Yes, let's.”

“It seems like you're getting along well with the people at the Magic Tower.”

“Am I really getting along well?”

“Of course. You've just arrived, and you're already fitting in so well.”

The grandfathers' fussing was a bit much, but it was clear they cared deeply for Luna.

I had been quietly worried about Luna becoming a royal wizard.

Royal wizards, although part of the same institution, often act individually.

I wondered if Luna, coming from a strong individualistic culture, would adapt well.

But seeing her now, my worries seemed unfounded; she was adapting better than I expected.

“But more importantly! You're meeting your uncle today, right?”

“Yes, my uncle...”

“Am I presentable enough? They say first impressions are crucial...”

“Hmm?”

“Oh... I'm so nervous... I need to make a good impression on your uncle... That way, your family will hear good things about me...”

Luna seemed as if she was preparing for a meet-the-family type of event.

I hadn't explained much to her, so her interpretation was unexpected...

“Luna... I don't know much about my uncle.”

“Huh?”

“It’s almost like meeting him for the first time.”

“Meeting your uncle for the first time?”

Her eyes widened in surprise.

“I might have seen him when I was very young.”

“How can that be? We see our relatives almost once a month...”

“Every family is different. I don’t know the details.”

My guess was that it had something to do with succession.

When a child isn’t chosen as the heir, they are often ostracized to prevent further disputes.

It may seem harsh to cast out one’s own child, but in reality, it’s often for the best for everyone involved.

As the head of a family, having a sibling within the household could be a source of conflict.

Thus, the options are often to harm or exile them.

From a father’s perspective, exiling a child who isn’t the heir is a way to save both children.

Luna tilted her head, puzzled.

“So why are you suddenly meeting your uncle?”

I slowly answered her question.

It’s part of the process of inheriting the family position.

I need to bring the Astria vassals to my side.

Although my uncle is considered a collateral relative, that's only if he were an ordinary noble.

My uncle is...

"He's someone with extensive connections. He's friendly with many people and is quite well-known in social circles."

For a noble who didn't become the head, this was an unusual path.

He has friendly relations with many people, including those in politics, without any political agenda.

I planned to seek help from my uncle's network.

"Oh..."

Luna frowned, looking at me.

"A sociable Rudy..."

She bit her lip, mumbling to herself with evident distaste.

"A blonde delinquent..."

"He's older and part of the noble society, so he won't be like that."

I too had imagined my uncle like Luna did, but I firmly denied it.

"We'll see what he's like when we meet him."

I looked out the window.

Outside, the ballroom was slowly coming into view.

Chapter 218: Astria (10)

"Wow..."

Luna, in awe, looked around the ballroom corridor.

Her eyes wide open, Luna's demeanor resembled that of a puppy exploring a new place.

The building's interior was adorned with decorations too valuable to be estimated in money.

I was amazed myself, so I understood why Luna was acting this way.

"Luna, let's start heading in."

"Uh, okay!"

Luna, who had been gazing around, quickly came up behind me.

"This place is really incredible... I wonder how much they spent."

"Indeed..."

The ballroom is located in the center of the capital.

Considering the land value here and the decorations in the ballroom, it was clear a astronomical sum was spent on it.

Although it was not a big issue since the ballroom is operated directly by the country, not built by any particular family, the extravagance was still astounding.

As we walked around admiring the place, we arrived at the entrance of the ballroom.

"Welcome!"

A waiter holding a small tray approached us at the entrance.

"Are both of you on the guest list?"

"Yes, Rudy Astria and Luna Railer."

Though there was a guest list, the question was somewhat redundant.

All graduates of the Academy were invited.

Including the students.

They had a list of all those people, but it wasn't practical to check everyone.

In any case, at the ballroom, people usually interacted only with those they knew, so it didn't really matter if someone unknown entered.

Moreover, for Academy graduates to come here intending to cause trouble was practically a suicide mission.

That's why the ball was open and welcoming.

The waiter, after noting our names, opened the doors to the ballroom.

"Please go in. Have a great time."

As the doors opened, a bright light enveloped us.

Inside, there were numerous people and dazzling decorations.

On the tables were cakes and various desserts, and people were gathered, holding wine glasses and chatting.

"Hmm?"

"Who are those kids?"

Some people tilted their heads in curiosity upon seeing us.

They looked at us, intrigued by the unfamiliar faces.

"Who are you?"

"Are you this year's graduates? No, the graduation ceremony hasn't happened yet, so you're not, right?"

"Well, that aside, you're so cute! What are your names?"

Contrary to what I heard about the place not welcoming strangers, people started to gather around us.

Perhaps they were welcoming new faces because it was the graduation season?

I couldn't be sure.

The problem was...

"What's this..."

"Oh dear, this little lady seems scared."

"We won't hurt you. We're your seniors."

Luna was surrounded by women who appeared to be in their thirties.

Luna stepped back, seemingly frightened by the sudden attention.

I stood in front of her protectively.

"Ru, Rudy."

"She's a bit scared,"

I explained.

"Oh my, is he your boyfriend? Ho ho, he's cute too."

"This boy is adorable too~. Shall I gobble him up?"

Startled by the seniors' remarks, Luna clung tightly to my arm and pulled me back.

"No, you can't. Rudy is..."

"Oh, look at them!"

"She's trembling with fear but claiming the boy as hers? Too cute~."

"Uh, no, it's not like that..."

Luna was at a loss, overwhelmed by the ladies' teasing.

While it was nice to be the center of attention, this situation was becoming uncomfortable.

What I needed was to connect with one or two individuals who could introduce me to my uncle.

With so many people crowding around, it was just a waste of time and made it harder to slip away.

"Hmm..."

A man in the crowd studied me intently.

He was a neat-looking man with glasses.

"Do I know you? Why do you look familiar?"

"As if you'd know him! You're in your thirties. How could this young-faced boy have been at the Academy with you?"

"Well, I might have seen him on a Homecoming Day or something."

The man started to grumble at the woman's teasing.

Then he looked at me again, suddenly clapping his hands.

"...Astria?"

"What?"

"Why bring up that family now? It's spoiling the mood."

"It must be the Astria family's..."

As the man spoke, all eyes turned towards me.

There was a sense of curiosity about Luna's and my sudden appearance.

"Who are you?"

I answered the question.

"My name is Rudy Astria. And this is Luna Railer."

"Ah..."

"..."

It was like a stone had been thrown into a still pond, creating ripples.

Some faces turned pale, while others quickly stepped back.

"That's... the Astria family we know of..."

"Rudy Astria, isn't he that notorious second son?"

"Hey, that was just a rumor. He's competing with Ian Astria for the heir position. A real deal."

Whispers of both praise and sarcasm filled the air.

But everyone's visible reaction was the same.

The people who had been joking around began to step back, distancing themselves from us.

"Uh..."

Luna looked both relieved and perplexed as people dispersed.

It was a natural response, given that people distanced themselves just from our introduction.

Before everyone left, I managed to catch one person.

"Excuse me, I have a question."

"So, sorry. I'm actually very busy!"

The person I grabbed made an excuse and quickly pulled away from me.

All the people who had gathered around us began to distance themselves, warily watching me.

"...This is troublesome."

So many people had crowded around us, only to disappear in an instant.

I understood to some extent.

Although this was a gathering of graduates, it was at the heart of the political arena.

They avoided getting close to me, not wanting to fall out of favor with Ian Astria.

There were nobles from the Emperor's faction, but none who truly believed in me.

Even though I had become known as a supporter of the Emperor's faction within the Astria family, the Emperor's faction supported the Emperor, not every member of it.

Getting close to me would be risky for them, especially if Ian ended up inheriting the family.

While I understood their behavior, it still felt disappointing.

After all, I had worked hard at the academy, yet there was no one to support me.

"Isn't everyone being too harsh...?"

Luna seemed to agree, pouting her lips.

"How can they change their attitude just because of a name?"

"What can we do? It's the situation."

Regardless of the situation, our task remained unchanged.

I didn't know my uncle's face.

He wasn't at the main house, but at a mansion in the capital, so there was no portrait of him.

We needed to find my uncle, but...

"Luna, shall we split up and look for him?"

It might be a burden for the socially awkward Luna, but it was necessary.

If I stayed, people would just run away.

I had to trust Luna.

"Leave it to me...! I'll give it a try!"

Luna, realizing this, clenched her fist and responded.

I smiled at Luna's cute determination and continued.

"We'll look for my uncle and ask the people around."

"Can we really find him?"

"It's somewhat possible. The Astria family's hair color is not common."

The Astria family's notable feature was their blond hair.

The gold in the hair of the royal family and the Astria family was closer to a true golden color, unlike other blondes.

Such radiant blond hair was rare in other families.

"So... we're looking for a sociable person with blond hair!"

"Yeah, he should be in his fifties."

"Got it! I'll do my best!"

So, we split up and asked around.

But no one was willing to help us.

Having already attracted attention once, the rumor quickly spread throughout the ballroom.

Even though we were just looking for one person, people refused to answer.

I understood why the Wizard Tower considered this a fearful place.

People drew lines so sharply.

Despite our sense of camaraderie as members of the academy, people kept their distance.

Even the most ordinary people avoided approaching us, as if no one of that kind existed here.

It was a gathering of those with abilities and much to lose.

What had Ian Astria done to make everyone tremble with fear?

It was unbelievable.

We momentarily stepped out of the ballroom to catch our breath.

"Rudy... I'm sorry..."

"It's not your fault, Luna."

We had split up and asked around for about an hour but got no answers.

Even Luna was being ignored, as the rumor had spread that we entered together.

"And how come we haven't seen a single blond man?"

"I found one or two... but they looked too young to be your uncle..."

I had been confident we could identify people by their hair color.

But the absence of anyone resembling our description was disconcerting.

"Maybe he didn't come today..."

"That would be the worst-case scenario..."

It dawned on me that there was a possibility my uncle hadn't attended the ball.

"Shouldn't have revealed my name..."

Mentioning my name had been a mistake.

I didn't realize people would shun us to this extent.

As I sighed, Luna patted my back.

"It's not your fault, Rudy! It's the people who run away just because of a name who are to blame!"

Luna placed her hands on her hips and glared towards the ballroom.

"Cowards! Ostracizing Rudy! What did Rudy do to deserve this!"

Luna's scolding brought a smile to my face.

"Right, it's their fault, not mine."

I took a deep breath and looked around.

"Let's continue our search."

The situation wasn't ideal, but what could we do?

We had to do our best in the given circumstances.

"I'll check around the center of the ballroom. Luna, can you cover the second floor?"

"Got it! Then..."

As we were talking, someone approached us.

"You're Rudy Astria, right?"

"...?"

Luna and I turned towards the voice.

It was the bespectacled man who had recognized me earlier.

"Sorry about earlier. I have my own situation, so I couldn't talk to you with everyone watching."

"Ah..."

It seemed he had waited for us to leave the ballroom.

"You're looking for Yurik Astria, right?"

"Yes, yes! That's right!"

Luna nodded vigorously at the man's words.

"But coming here blindly, without any information. Wasn't that a bit reckless? If you knew a little about him, you could have found him easily."

"You're right."

It was an unavoidable situation.

We had come right after hearing Astina's advice and the ball was soon after.

I had no intention of making excuses.

The man, seemingly pleased with my acceptance, smiled and pointed towards the ballroom.

"Go back into the ballroom and look for someone without hair."

"...Bald?"

I widened my eyes in surprise.

"Yes, Yurik Astria is bald. That should make it somewhat easier to find him, right?"

My uncle wasn't blond; he was bald.

I was taken aback by this unexpected revelation.

Luna, equally surprised, opened her mouth and quietly muttered to herself.

"Bald... delinquent..."

"He doesn't look like a delinquent, though."

"Oops..."

Luna quickly covered her mouth with her hands.

"Anyway, with this information, we should be able to find him, right?"

I nodded at the man's words.

"Thank you so much. This is a huge help."

"Well, I must be going now."

The man waved his hand and started walking back towards the ballroom.

"Wait!"

I called out to stop him.

"Sorry to ask, but... what's your name? I'd like to repay you someday."

The man chuckled.

"You're not like the typical Astria family member, are you?"

"Pardon?"

"My name is Wuying."

Wuying?

The sudden mention of such an Eastern name made me tilt my head in confusion.

I had heard of Eastern names, but they were very rare.

While I was still pondering this.

"I should go now. Staying here will only raise suspicions."

The man who introduced himself as Wuying quickly disappeared towards the ballroom.

"Wuying...?"

But how did he know about me?

With a puzzled expression, I watched the man's retreating figure.

Chapter 219: Astria (11)

“Hmm...”

Luna looked at my head with a perplexed expression.

“It’s not hereditary.”

“Is that so?”

“My father and grandfather both had thick hair.”

Even though medicine hasn’t advanced much in this world, some medical conjectures are possible.

People here are aware that if a certain disease appears in a family, other members are likely to develop it.

This includes hair loss.

“So, did he shave his head on purpose?”

“Most likely.”

Unless my father and uncle were half-brothers, it couldn’t be attributed to baldness.

“I wonder why he shaved it...”

Shaving one's head doesn't offer many advantages.

People are visually oriented, naturally drawn to neat and stylish appearances.

Not to say bald people are unattractive, but it's not typically a favored look.

Being different has its pros and cons; it can attract ridicule, especially in social circles where a bald person is rare.

The most puzzling part is the rumor that he's sociable.

What kind of person could he be...

"Ah...! Rudy!"

Luna grabbed my sleeve.

"Isn't that him?"

She pointed towards a man with a shining bald head, dressed in a suit, and surrounded by a crowd.

He had a rotund belly, and not a single hair on his head.

Though it's common for middle-aged men to gain weight, his appeared quite excessive.

Yet, I knew he was my uncle.

Despite his weight, his distinct facial features resembled those of the Astria family.

"Be careful, Luna."

"Yes!"

I made my way through the crowd surrounding my uncle.

As I got closer, I could see him clearly.

From afar, his plump and bald appearance made me wonder if he was a corrupt noble.

However, up close, it was clear that my concerns were unfounded.

Despite an appearance that could seem shabby, his eyes were full of life.

Unlike the greedy eyes of corrupt nobles, his were sharp and clear, rare in middle-aged individuals.

Seeing him laugh heartily, I felt a sense of fondness for him.

“Hello.”

“Ah, hello!”

Luna and I approached my uncle and greeted him.

“Hmm? And who is this young lady...”

“Uncle, it’s a pleasure to meet you. I am Rudy Astria.”

My uncle’s eyes widened upon hearing my words.

His gaze quickly sharpened.

“Did you come here knowing who I am?”

“Are you not Yurik Astria, my uncle?”

“Yes. That’s correct.”

His response to hearing my name was edged.

“What brings you here? Do you have something specific to discuss?”

“I’ve come to greet my family. Isn’t that reason enough?”

I smiled, but Uncle's expression remained unimpressed.

“I’m hardly your family, am I? Can a member ousted to the collateral branch really be considered part of the main family?”

“Though relegated to the collateral branch, we are still connected by blood, are we not?”

“I don't see it that way. The collateral branch is a separate family from the direct lineage. We've had no interactions, so it's as if we're strangers.”

The surrounding people's gaze fell on me.

The division of the Astria family into direct and collateral lines was well-known.

The Astria collateral branch is notably less esteemed than other families.

The Astrias have never supported them, and it's common in political circles to disregard the collateral branch.

Given the situation, it was only natural for people to view my visit to Uncle with skepticism.

“Uncle, may we talk privately?”

“It seems our conversation has concluded, hasn't it?”

“I have much left to say.”

“I have nothing. I don't see any value in engaging with you. Besides, conversing with someone at the heart of politics would only tire me out.”

Yurik, renowned in social circles, deliberately stayed out of politics.

He had no noble title and didn't work for the empire.

His life seemed rather aimless.

Such an existence might explain why he had many acquaintances.

Once involved in politics, one invariably makes enemies.

Yesterday's ally could be tomorrow's adversary.

Yurik, having stepped back from politics, was neither friend nor foe, making him approachable.

But his inner thoughts were different.

“Don't you wish for revenge?”

Uncle's eyes widened in surprise.

“Will you continue living this way?”

Not just Uncle, but also those around us, paused at my words.

Yurik Astria.

His story was well-known in political circles. Yurik, not lacking in ability or connections, lost to my father, Perrian.

Betrayed by nobles who had promised to support him, the tides quickly turned against him in the race for succession.

Before his capabilities could be fully assessed, the decision favored Perrian.

Yurik, who had prepared his whole life for this moment, was ousted without proper evaluation.

“What makes you so confident to say such things?”

“We are family, aren't we?”

I smiled.

Every Astria is filled with ambition, and Yurik was no exception.

According to Astina, Yurik Astria was waiting for an opportunity.

It could be a chance to seize power or to take revenge on those who thwarted his ascent.

Whatever it was, I was certain he could be of help to me.

“Won't you consider helping me?”

After the ball ended.

"Rudy... didn't you sound too confident? Maybe you could have been a bit gentler in your approach..."

Luna asked worriedly beside me.

"Perhaps showing confidence is better. It's like inviting someone to cross a narrow bridge; the proposer shaking in fear doesn't really help, does it?"

"Maybe..."

I too was not without concerns.

Uncle's last words.

'Let's end this discussion here.'

It could be interpreted as a rejection.

Luna was probably worried because of that response.

But I hadn't given up hope.

There were many people around us.

Some were close to Uncle, but others could have their own hidden agendas.

So, I thought he was just delaying his answer.

Answering there and then would only serve to pass information to the enemy.

I had done what I needed to do, so all that was left was to return to the family estate and wait for a letter from Uncle.

If Uncle decided to help, things would proceed smoothly.

But even if he chose not to, I just had to do what was necessary.

I couldn't give up everything just because Uncle wouldn't help.

"...But I am still anxious."

"Huh?"

Luna looked puzzled at my muttering.

"It's nothing. More importantly, thank you. For helping me find Uncle."

"Ehehe, it was nothing. You've helped me out much more."

Luna waved her hand dismissively and laughed, but I felt a sense of guilt inside.

I had brought her to the ball, only to have her spend all day looking for someone.

I looked at Luna.

She shone in the winter moonlight, wearing her white dress.

We came all dressed up only to end up searching for people.

I extended my hand to Luna.

"Huh?"

"Aren't you a bit disappointed?"

"Umm... Yeah. It would have been better if we had a more positive outcome."

"Not that. I mean something else."

I caught Luna's hand.

"Aren't you disappointed that we came to the ball and did nothing?"

"Wha, what?"

Luna looked bewildered as I firmly held her hand.

I led her.

"Where are we going?"

"Just follow me."

I moved with Luna towards the garden behind the ballroom.

"Wow..."

There, magical lights blended with the natural moonlight and fireflies, creating a mesmerizing scene.

I chose a spot in the center of the grassy area and let go of Luna's hand, then extended it again with a formal gesture.

"Miss Luna Railer, would you like to dance with me?"

As I spoke, Luna's eyes began to twinkle.

"Dance? Suddenly? No, no. I'm not good at dancing... Besides, here? All of a sudden?"

I just smiled and extended my hand.

Luna, flustered, looked at me, then bit her lip and blushed.

"Please, be gentle."

"What is this, a duel? Of course, I'll be gentle."

Seeing Luna shyly offer her hand made me chuckle.

"But, I really can't dance."

"It's okay. Neither can I."

Though I said that, I had learned a bit since dancing with Astina two years ago.

Not that I could dance at a professional level.

I only knew enough to make do.

I took Luna's hand and placed my other hand on her back.

Luna wrapped her arm around my waist and pressed close.

"Ah..."

Even just getting into position, Luna's face turned red.

I looked at her fondly and stepped forward.

Under the moonlight, we moved our feet in time with the sounds of the night.

We started off decently, but as we went on, our steps began to tangle.

Luna and I were like little children, clumsily stepping around.

"Ahaha..."

"I did say I wasn't very good."

"I know."

We danced with smiles on our faces.

It was an awkward dance, but that didn't matter.

For a moment, we put aside our worries and simply moved to the rhythm, entrusting ourselves to each other.

Deep into the night, when even the crickets had fallen silent, a bright light leaked from one room.

Inside, a blonde girl was present.

Rie Von Ristonia, the First Princess.

She fiddled with her pen while staring at a book.

Though Yuni had renounced her claim to the throne, making Rie the de facto heir, she didn't cease her studies.

Ascending to the throne was just one goal.

She needed to be well-prepared to govern the empire effectively.

Thus, there was no time to relax.

"This is tough..."

Rie furrowed her brow, struggling with her studies.

Knock, knock.

A knocking sound interrupted her, not from the door but the window.

Rie turned towards the sound.

'What could it be at this hour?'

As she spoke, the window opened, and a man entered.

"Greetings to the Empire's Sun."

"Do you have urgent news? You could have waited for the regular report."

Rie looked at the man.

He was in a black outfit, masked, with a serpent and sword emblem representing the Royal secret service.

"I came to discuss a matter with you."

Hearing this, Rie's eyes sharpened, and she adjusted her posture.

"Is it that urgent?"

"No, not urgent."

"Not urgent, but you need to tell me now?"

The man nodded and removed his mask.

"Today at the ball, I met young master Rudy."

The man was Wuying, who had met Rudy earlier that day.

Wuying was a member of the Royal secret service, and furthermore, he was its leader.

"Why was Rudy at the ball?"

"He was there with Lady Luna."

"What?"

"I saw them dancing together in the garden."

"What???"

"The atmosphere was quite pleasant."

At the mention of Rudy, Rie's face, which was ready to bloom into a smile, suddenly turned cold.

"Tell me more."

Chapter 220: Astria (12)

Everyone has their Achilles' heel.

It could be a weakness or perhaps a trauma.

For Yurik Astria, it was people.

Yurik couldn't trust people.

It hadn't always been that way.

When he was younger...

No, until the competition for succession, he was more trusting of people than anyone else.

He trusted Perrian, his brother competing for the succession, and the nobles around him.

Even when warned that politics was a mire to be wary of, Yurik couldn't understand.

It didn't seem to apply to those around him.

Yurik simply focused on honing his skills.

He thought that a capable person could stay out of politics.

He believed he could act in politics as he did within his family.

But it was not so.

It was all an act.

Perrian, who seemed kind and good-natured.

Perrian habitually told Yurik not to behave like other families or predecessors, but to compete fairly on merit.

However, as the time for deciding the successor approached, Perrian completely changed his attitude.

The primary criterion for deciding a successor was the support of the nobility.

One needed the support of the numerous families under the Astria banner.

And when the support was evenly split, other factors would be considered.

Yurik never got to that stage.

The families that had promised to support him all sided with Perrian.

They were nobles who clung to Perrian and only offered sweet words to Yurik.

“There’s no process in competition, only the result remains.”

With those words from Perrian, Yurik was ousted from the family.

He had nowhere to appeal his injustice.

Even the few nobles who had supported him to the end merely pitied Yurik for being deceived.

After being expelled from the family, Yurik immediately shaved his head.

He couldn’t bear to see the hair that connected him to that filthy and vile family.

Thus, Yurik severed his ties with Astria.

“Is Yurik here?”

At that moment, a man entered Yurik's mansion.

“It’s been a while. Count Mayer.”

It was Owen Mayer, Karen’s father and the head of the Mayer family.

“Just call me Owen, like old times.”

The two had been friends since before the Mayer family came under the Astria family.

The Mayer family's entry into the Astria family came after Yurik was expelled.

That decision was made by Owen’s father, the previous Count Mayer.

However, Count Mayer felt a sense of responsibility for being under the family that had ousted his friend Yurik.

Even if it was a necessary decision for the survival of his family, he couldn’t bring himself to face Yurik.

“Has it been 10 years since we last met like this personally?”

Count Mayer said, reminiscing about the past.

“Haven’t we seen each other a few times at balls?”

“That was just passing by and seeing each other’s faces. We never really talked properly.”

Yurik chuckled at Count Mayer’s words.

“So, what brings you here after over 10 years?”

“I just thought of my friend and decided to visit.”

“Is it because of Rudy Astria?”

Yurik’s expression hardened suddenly.

He couldn’t trust people.

Not even a friend he hadn’t seen in a long time.

“It seems so.”

Count Mayer didn’t have a reason to come otherwise.

The Astria family was in a busy period.

A lot of changes happen when a generation changes, and they need to be prepared for it.

His visit at such a time allowed Yurik to make some guesses.

The news of Rudy and Yurik meeting had already spread widely across the Royal capital.

It seemed Count Mayer had heard the news and come.

“Did you come to tell me to reject that guy’s proposal? Did Perrian tell you to do so?”

“No, it’s the opposite.”

“...The opposite?”

“I plan to support Rudy.”

“What?”

Yurik looked at Count Mayer in disbelief.

“You're going to support Rudy Astria, even though Ian is already on a clear path? Are you planning to gamble your family's future?”

“Haha, I am not that bold.”

Count Mayer smiled warmly.

“I believed I had a good eye for people. I thought I could understand someone after seeing and talking to them. But as I grew older and reached this age, I felt my judgment fading.”

When Count Mayer first saw Rudy, he thought him insignificant.

Even when his daughter Karen praised Rudy, he didn’t believe her.

He thought it was just a child's perspective and didn’t take it seriously.

But Rudy was different from the impression he had initially made.

“I have decided to trust my daughter’s judgment. I believe her eyes are more accurate now than mine were when I was younger.”

“...You’re deciding the fate of your family based on that?”

Karen wasn’t the heir of the Mayer family.

The Mayer family had an eldest son who was supposed to inherit the family.

Yet, to think Owen was trusting the words of a daughter unrelated to the family's affairs was absurd to Yurik.

“Father is weak when it comes to his daughter.”

Count Mayer’s laughter was filled with warmth.

Yurik couldn’t understand him.

“It’s a choice that could determine the fate of your family. You’re being swayed by emotion...”

“It’s not just based on my daughter's words. I've also pondered over this decision.”

While Owen was indeed a doting father, he wasn’t so blinded by his daughter's words as to cloud his judgment.

“I said I came here thinking of a friend.”

“...”

“Seeing Rudy now reminds me of you. How you used to chase your goals.”

Yurik, who always did his best even in unfavorable situations and loved people.

It was regrettable to see how broken Yurik had become.

“If you help Rudy, it could be a great help. You could share your network and knowledge of spatial magic.”

“Ha! It’s been decades since I last used it, and now I can’t even use spatial magic. And you think my network, built while I was being betrayed, would be helpful? Do you still believe in people after seeing what happened to me?”

“We don't know that. People might be more ready to help you than you think.”

Count Mayer said this and stood up from his seat.

"The world has more kind-hearted people than you think."

With those words, Count Mayer left the room.

Yurik picked up a bottle of liquor and drank directly from it.

"Damn it..."

"..."

"Hmm..."

I picked up the cutlery in the chilly atmosphere.

"Shall we eat?"

"Eat if you want to."

Sitting in front of me was Rie, giving me a cold stare.

I, clueless about what had happened, just fiddled with the cutlery in front of me.

Gurgle.

A rumbling sound came from my stomach.

At that, Rie let out a deep sigh.

"You can eat if you're hungry. I won't complain about that."

She spoke in her usual warm tone.

"Then..."

I let out a sigh of relief and picked up the cutlery.

"The reason I'm angry is that you didn't make that proposal to me."

"Cough..."

I choked on my food but managed to keep it in my mouth.

"Did you hear about it?"

My actions at the ball had spread quickly across the capital.

My attempt to seek help from my uncle.

But the part that seemed to anger Rie wasn't the contact with my uncle.

It was more about why I quietly went with Luna.

That I didn't tell her about it.

It seemed like that was what she was implying.

"Do you think I only know rumors?"

Her words pricked my conscience.

Dancing with Luna in the garden late at night.

Could she possibly know about that?

With Rie's resources, it was entirely possible.

"Haah... What I'm angry about isn't that you went with Luna."

Rie glared straight at me.

"It's that you tried to hide it."

"I'm sorry."

Rie sighed at my response.

"What am I going to do with our womanizing husband..."

"I'm not a womanizer."

As I defended myself, Rie flinched and looked at me.

Then, she soon broke into a grin.

"Why?"

"You didn't deny being called a husband?"

"I'm not your husband yet."

Rie smiled happily.

"Not yet, huh. You could just call yourself my husband. No need to be shy."

"You should be the one feeling shy."

Rie got up from her seat with a coy smile.

"I'd like to stay longer with my husband, but I'm busy and have to go."

"Why don't you eat something first?"

"No, it's okay. I usually skip breakfast. And I need to get back quickly."

I looked puzzled at her words.

"So, you came here just to say that?"

"Of course. Keeping an eye on the husband is important, especially in the beginning."

"We're not even newlyweds..."

Rie smiled at my words and waved her hand.

"Anyway, don't try to hide anything from me. I know everything."

"Understood..."

Rie then walked towards the door.

Just as she was about to leave through the door, Rie turned her head to look at me.

"Shouldn't a husband give a kiss when his wife leaves for work?"

"...Just go."

Rie smiled playfully at my response and left through the door.

After Rie had gone.

Just when I was about to have a proper meal.

“Young master Rudy...!”

A maid burst in through the door.

“...Please open the door gently.”

I frowned, feeling like I couldn't have a proper meal today.

“It's... A letter has arrived! From Yurik Astria!”

My eyes widened at her words.

Chapter 221: Astria (13)

Yurik sat in his mansion, waiting for Rudy.

As he sat in silence, his mind was filled with nothing but doubt.

Rudy was the son of his brother Perrian.

The son of a man who had betrayed him, Rudy could betray him at any moment.

That thought never left his mind.

"Good day to you."

After some time, Rudy arrived at Yurik's mansion.

"Yes."

Yurik responded to Rudy's greeting with a short one of his own.

'He looks quite polished on the outside.'

Rudy's greeting was perfectly respectful.

Yet, Yurik was not pleased.

Anyone can look decent on the outside.

It's easy to hide sinister plans behind a façade.

Yurik gestured towards the front.

"Have a seat."

"Thank you for inviting me."

"There's no need to thank me. I didn't invite you because I'm considering your proposal."

"Still, you gave me the opportunity. I'm grateful for that."

As Rudy smiled broadly at Yurik, Yurik scoffed.

"Let's get to the point."

Without any delay, Yurik continued.

"I can't help you."

His words were firm.

"You must feel it too, looking at this mansion and at me."

Yurik's mansion was extremely shabby.

There was only one maid serving as a housekeeper, and even she was an old woman.

A rundown mansion with no family or servants.

Though related to the Astria family by a distant branch, the mansion was all he had in terms of wealth.

"I don't know what you want, but I've already lost all my power. I have no wealth, and it's been over ten years since I gave up on magic. My body has decayed."

His body, uncared for, had grown fat, and he looked utterly shabby.

He used basic magic to survive in such a place, but it had not improved since the past; rather, it had regressed.

Ever since being ousted from the family, he hadn't read a single book on magic.

Consequently, he had forgotten even what he once knew.

'All I have left are a few people.'

Having been betrayed by his brother, he feared for his life.

So, Yurik built connections to survive.

At least with people around, his brother, the head of the Astria family, wouldn't dare kill him carelessly.

But that didn't mean he trusted those people.

'Even those connections could betray me at any time.'

Without significant abilities or background to keep people close, Yurik now had nothing.

Currently out of politics, he didn't know what would happen if he re-entered and tried to help Rudy.

Those people enjoyed talking with him, not meeting him to become companions in politics.

"So don't waste your time..."

"I don't think so."

"...What?"

"As you said, Uncle, you don't have anything now. But the fact that people are still around you means they trust and follow you. They are people who would follow you even if you return to politics."

At Rudy's words, Yurik let out a wry laugh.

'I see why Owen thought he reminded him of myself.'

It was not a pleasant smile but a bitter, mocking one.

Yurik had once thought like Rudy.

Nobles who supported him when his chances of being the successor were slim.

He firmly believed in them.

And then he was betrayed.

"People trust too easily."

"That trust is the foundation of my strength," Rudy said confidently.

"Let me give you a piece of advice. Trusting people too much will eventually lead to betrayal."

"If that happens, I'll just get back up again."

"But can you really say that after being betrayed by someone you trusted?"

Betrayal by a trusted person hurts more than one might think.

So much so, that it's hard to get back up.

"Even if they take everything you have?"

"My original goal was survival."

Rudy smiled faintly.

"I just thought I needed to survive by any means necessary. Struggling to do so, I gradually gained allies. I received help from them, and I helped them in return. Through that, my thinking changed."

Rudy's priority had always been survival.

Of course, to survive, he needed people around him, so he gathered allies, even if it meant a loss for him.

But now, it was different.

"What's the point of pushing people away with suspicion? What's the meaning of surviving alone after doubting everyone?"

Rudy already knew how to survive.

He had done so in the future and managed to live.

But using that method resulted in everyone's death.

The academy burned down.

That scene was still vivid in his mind.

At that moment, he realized his feelings.

It felt worse than death.

What was the point of having great power and surviving if he lost everything?

It felt like losing everything.

"Even if I am betrayed, I will continue to trust and move forward with the people around me. And for their sake, I will grow stronger."

A life for those around him.

In a way, it was also a life for himself.

I exist because of the people around me.

That's true happiness.

Living for others was ultimately living for oneself.

"From my perspective, I can only advise you not to push away those around you too much, just because they might betray you. As you said, Uncle, the people around you are those who stayed even when you had nothing. It won't change much if you choose a different path."

Yurik stared intently at Rudy.

He seemed like a pure child, yet also like a saint.

"So you're saying you'll trust those around you, even if you're betrayed?"

"Yes."

"What will you do when you're betrayed?"

"I'll think about it when it happens."

"The consequences could be severe."

"I don't want to live in doubt. I have many powerful enemies around me. It's hard enough to understand them, let alone doubting my allies. How can I win like that?"

Yurik let out a hollow laugh.

'He said I was similar to him.'

Not at all.

Rudy was different from his past self.

He liked people, trusted them, but he never thought like this.

It was, in a way, a blind faith.

Just a naive fool who had never even considered betrayal.

But Rudy had a purpose.

For Rudy, the people around him were the goal itself.

Protecting, trusting, and being with his people was Rudy's purpose.

Yet, Yurik didn't completely trust Rudy.

He wasn't sure whether Rudy's words were sincere or just fabricated to get his help.

But still.

"What kind of help do you want from me?"

Yurik's heart had slightly opened.

At least he wanted to observe Rudy's actions to see if his words were genuine.

In the early dawn, as the snow was falling heavily.

Crackle.

The sound of a campfire burning.

Surrounding it were various documents in disarray, and behind them, a large map was spread out.

Aryandor was half-lying on a sofa, fiddling with a dagger.

"Is that guy still lurking around the Astria family's vicinity?"

"It seems he's not moving much now. He hasn't given up, but it's true that he's put things off for now."

In front of him stood Daemon, who had been guarding the necromancers near the Astria family.

"Then I guess it's time for me to return."

"Yes, as long as he doesn't move, I plan to stay here."

"No, there's no time to stay here."

Aryandor stood up.

"Proceed with the plan immediately."

"What do you mean?"

At Daemon's question, Aryandor pointed behind him with the dagger in his hand.

Behind Aryandor, a large map was spread out, with an X marked on one region.

"Astina Persia."

As Aryandor uttered that name, Daemon's expression turned cold.

The one who killed Jefrin.

Daemon wasn't particularly close to Jefrin, but they were comrades.

"Do you plan to attack?"

"Yes."

"The consumption of troops will be significant."

"That's why I called you."

Daemon was a necromancer.

A wizard who could create an army by himself.

It was the reason why the rebels could continue to lead to victory despite having fewer troops compared to the Empire.

Aryandor stood up and thrust the dagger into the map.

The dagger landed on Astina's hometown, the Persia territory.

"You and I will go."

"It won't be easy. Even if the leader himself goes..."

"I know. Troops have moved towards the Persia territory."

"Right. It's a commercial city, so they moved to protect it."

"And possibly to protect the people around Astina Persia."

Whatever the reason, it was true that many soldiers were deployed in the Persia territory.

"There's no need to occupy the Persia territory."

Aryandor pulled the dagger out of the map.

"We're just going to issue a warning."

He smiled and fiddled with the blade of the dagger.

Chapter 222: Spatial Magic (1)

I stared at my hands in the mansion's study.

"...Unable to use spatial magic?"

That was what I had been told after securing Yurik's help.

Yurik, after some contemplation, seemed somewhat convinced.

It made sense that I couldn't have learned spatial magic before attending the academy, and since I hadn't graduated yet, it was only natural that I couldn't use it.

The problem was that there was no way to learn it.

Ian had agreed to teach me, but that was only a nominal promise, a means to comply with the policies set by the empire in the last meeting.

It was as good as not keeping the promise, but I couldn't object.

Legal disputes could prove my point and earn proper treatment, but they took too long.

By the time they concluded, Ian would likely have become the head of the family.

"Then I'll teach you."

"Excuse me?"

"I too know how to use spatial magic. I can't use it now, but I can teach you the basics."

The secret of the Astria family.

Spatial magic related knowledge was a secret unknown to other families, even to the emperor.

Knowing it was the Astria family's Achilles heel, no one dared to learn about it.

Of course, even if they wanted to, the lack of related materials made it impossible.

"Spatial magic is a spell that anyone who has Astria blood has tried at least once. But once the head of the family is decided, all that ability is taken away."

Hearing this, I realized what my father's transmission meant.

The transmission of spatial magic was essentially a permission.

Permission to allow the use of spatial magic.

As my uncle said, the moment Ian becomes the head, this permission disappears.

And then, Ian would be the only one left who knows how to use spatial magic.

Anyway, I was able to gain basic knowledge of spatial magic from my uncle.

It was an unexpected gain.

But that didn't mean all my problems were solved.

My uncle could only teach me the theoretical aspects, not much practical help.

Now it was my turn to put in the effort.

I had to grow based on that basic knowledge.

"...Let's give it a try."

I started gathering mana in my hands.

'The basics of spatial magic start with recognizing space.'

The words my uncle had said.

I mulled over those words.

"Points and lines... and then space."

Points come together to form a line, and lines come together to form a space.

This was the basic principle of spatial magic.

It was hard to understand what that meant.

But knowing something is different from knowing nothing.

I just had to try.

Even if I failed, by continuously trying, I might gain something.

Thinking of 'points, lines, space,' I moved the mana.

"Point..."

A small light emerged from my hand and floated into the air.

It was mana that would serve as a point.

I created a few more of these points.

I connected the dots in sequence, creating lines, and with 12 lines, I formed a cubic space.

"..."

I looked at the hexagon I had created.

"Is this right?"

Could this be considered a space?

It wasn't spatial magic, just a box made of mana.

It was a box created following the order of points and lines, but it was too ordinary.

I just stared at the box.

The next day.

"Is this how it's done?"

Today was the day Ian would teach me spatial magic.

Unexpectedly, Ian arrived at the mansion early in the morning.

Ian stared intently at the box I had made.

"What's this?"

"The basics of spatial magic."

"...This?"

Ian looked unimpressed.

As if to say, 'Is this what you call spatial magic?'

He made no effort to hide his disdain.

"I created points, lines, and space with mana."

If he's so dissatisfied, he should teach me.

I had made this space trying my best, and this is how he reacts?

Ian nodded after hearing my explanation.

"You understand the basics of space."

"My uncle taught me."

I didn't hide the fact that I had made a deal with my uncle.

Well, to be precise, my uncle and I hadn't fully allied yet.

My uncle decided to watch the situation before joining forces with me.

It was actually better for Ian to think that my uncle and I had decided to fully cooperate.

Putting some pressure on Ian was advantageous for me.

Ian frowned, seemingly uncomfortable with the fact that I was collaborating with my uncle.

"Why don't you learn from your uncle then?"

"It's been a long time since he used spatial magic, so I can't learn properly from him."

"Is that so? But I'm also getting busy and might not be able to come."

"What do you mean by that...?"

"You should understand what I mean by this much."

The rebels had started to move.

That seemed to be what Ian was implying.

"Let's be frank. Teaching you isn't important. Dealing with the rebels takes precedence over you. You would agree with that, right? You don't like them

either."

"...Right."

The rebels were a common enemy.

Our fight is between the emperor's faction and the nobility.

Essentially, it's an internal dispute.

"If the rebels have started to move, it's natural that I can't teach you. I might not have come today at all."

If the rebels were on the move, it wasn't a problem if Ian couldn't teach me.

For both me and Ian, as part of the empire, the rebels come first.

"Then why did you come today?"

"To form a temporary alliance."

"Excuse me?"

"I'll teach you a bit about spatial magic now. In return, declare that we won't harm each other while dealing with the rebels. Then I'll also cooperate with you."

Ian is currently the commander of the Royal forces against the rebels.

If the rebels were on the move, Ian would be absent from the Royal capital for a while.

It seemed Ian wanted to prevent me from striking behind his back while he was away.

However, his offer to teach me spatial magic was surprising.

Spatial magic was Ian's greatest weapon.

Was he willing to use it as a condition?

"Aren't you afraid that I might betray you?"

"I prefer not to waste energy unnecessarily. I'd hate to see the empire crumble because of you."

"I wouldn't destroy the empire."

"Your actions could indirectly cause someone else to ruin it."

"The rebels?"

"Do you think my enemies are limited to you and the rebels?"

Ian's words made me laugh.

"Maybe you should try making fewer enemies."

"As someone aiming for the top, it's inevitable to have many enemies. Anyone I've suppressed becomes my enemy."

Ian was indeed my enemy, but I had no intention of destroying the empire.

In a way, he was purely ambitious for the top.

However, I couldn't support his methods.

I stood opposed to Ian's nature of eliminating anyone unnecessary to the empire or obstructive to him.

Yet, for now, it was right to follow his words.

"Fine. Let's form a temporary alliance."

We had a common enemy in Ian's words.

Dealing with the rebels took precedence over confronting Ian.

It would be difficult if Ian took over the family, but other paths existed.

However, if the rebels took over the empire, the situation would be hopeless.

The level of danger was different.

So, it was right to follow Ian's words.

Ian nodded at my response.

"We won't write a contract. We both know such contracts are meaningless."

There were contracts that bound the other party with mana, but they were essentially pointless.

We both had excellent wizards around us who could easily break any contract.

Ultimately, if someone betrayed the other, it meant mutual destruction.

So, we had to rely on each other's conscience.

"You know what will happen if you show any suspicious behavior, right?"

"Don't worry about that. Please take good care of Astina."

The most concerning thing, given the rebels' movement, was naturally Astina.

It seemed likely that the rebels' movement was aimed at targeting Astina.

After all, the most bothersome person to them would be Astina, who had killed the rebel leaders and rallied the Royal army.

I extended my hand to Ian.

Ian, with a displeased expression, shook my hand.

"Behave yourself while I'm gone, focusing on the rebels."

I smiled wryly and responded to Ian's words.

"If you teach me spatial magic well, there shouldn't be any problems."

Ian sighed and extended his hand.

"Alright. I'll teach you the basics of spatial magic."

Ian straightened his clothes as he walked down the corridor of the Royal army's building.

He thought a lot while walking.

He had heard about Rudy contacting his uncle, but he never imagined they would really collaborate.

His uncle was virtually non-existent in Astria.

Ian had thought his uncle could be a problem later, but being a well-known figure in social circles, it was difficult to deal with him quietly.

Though his uncle hadn't stepped into politics and didn't belong anywhere, Ian became anxious upon learning about his collaboration with Rudy.

After all, his uncle had a wide network and knew how to use spatial magic.

With the rebels starting to move and unusual activities around Rudy, Ian had to make a decision.

Which to deal with first.

He concluded that the rebels were the priority.

That's why Ian proposed a temporary alliance with Rudy, offering spatial magic as a condition.

Initially, he thought of threatening Rudy, but knowing his character, persuasion seemed more effective than threats.

It was a good card to play for persuasion.

The basics of spatial magic.

Once his uncle started teaching, Rudy would grasp the basics of spatial magic anyway.

His uncle, originally knowledgeable in spatial magic, wouldn't find it difficult to teach the basics.

But Rudy wouldn't go beyond the basics.

So, it was better for Ian to teach him the basics himself.

If Rudy was going to learn the basics anyway, it was more beneficial for Ian to teach him and get something else in return.

'Rudy is in check, at least for now.'

Ian reached the door at the end of the corridor.

He opened it.

'Time to eliminate the rebel scum.'

Upon opening the door, several people were inside.

People in uniforms.

Astina and the staff belonging to the Royal army were naturally present, along with other figures.

The owner of the Royal Magic Tower and the representative of the royal wizards, the Royal Chief wizard, Joaquin Lisderon.

Serina's father and the representative of the elementalists, the Head Elementalist, Keln Rinsburg.

The empire's Prime Minister, Jason Ophillius.

There were also the princesses Rie and Yuni.

And even the Emperor himself.

All the heavyweights of the empire were gathered.

Among these formidable figures.

There was one person sitting, pale-faced.

"Why on earth am I here..."

This was Gracie, the youngest professor representing the academy.

Chapter 223: Spatial Magic (2)

“Thank you for coming all this way. Let's get right to the main topic.”

Ian hung a large map on the wall for everyone to see.

“As you all know, the rebels have made their move.”

The location of the rebels was in the south.

Covering a vast granary region in the south, it was situated on the outskirts of the Empire.

“Originally, the southern region was limited by the Verdès territory, preventing further expansion.

However, this time, they have changed their direction.”

The capital of the Empire was located in the center of the Empire's territory.

To attack the capital, one had to break through the Verdès territory.

The Verdès territory, guarded by the prestigious Verdès family, had always been a place of reassurance.

However, the rebels had now shifted their path.

“The rebels are now heading east, towards the Liberion Academy.”

The largest territory in the east of the Empire was actually where the Liberion Academy was located.

Always bustling with students, professors, and other staff, it had developed commercially and was virtually a demilitarized zone, making it a safe haven that attracted many people.

“I’ve already informed Principal McDowell of the Academy, and the Academy is now in a defensive stance.”

This was the very reason Gracie was here.

People in high positions like Cromwell and McDowell were all preparing to counter the rebels.

So, it was safer to send Gracie, the junior professor, to a secure place.

Although Gracie had shown exceptional performance with Rudy and Yuni as assistants, she was not ready to prepare for war.

The Emperor opened his mouth upon hearing this.

“Could the rebels merely be feigning an attack on the Academy?”

“Your Majesty is correct. We have prepared for the possibility of a large rebel force moving towards any territory. Surrounding territories are all in a state of combat readiness, so they can immediately assist if another territory is attacked.”

Ian then placed pins on the map, indicating these territories.

Rie, who had been watching, raised her hand.

“Princess Rie, please go ahead.”

“Isn't there a possibility that the enemy diverts our attention with a large force and then captures other territories with a smaller one?”

If forces are redirected to counter the rebels on the outskirts, the inner territories become vulnerable.

“Even if they attack from behind, it's essentially meaningless, Princess. By doing so, the rebels, even if they capture a territory, will only end up surrounded by the Empire's forces from both the outer and central regions.”

Even if the rebels capture a territory, it can be quickly retaken, resulting in greater losses for them.

“There’s no need to attack just to capture a territory.”

Rie calmly countered Ian's statement.

“What do you mean by that?”

“The Persia territory.”

The Persia territory was a region located in the southeast.

The rebels were separated from the rest by a mountain range, marking a natural boundary.

Ian frowned.

“Princess Rie, you know we can't move troops in that direction.”

“But that very point could be what they're exploiting.”

Ian, visibly annoyed, ran his hand through his hair.

“Don’t be unreasonable. We’re engaged in war here, not personal feelings. I wish you would not let personal sentiments cloud your judgment.”

It was a well-known fact that Rie had persuaded Astina at the Academy, turning the neutral Persia House into an ally of the Emperor.

Their close relationship was no secret to those present.

However, Rie's considerations were not emotional.

“My thoughts are not driven by personal feelings. As you all know, the Persia territory is a massive warehouse storing grain from the south and a market handling its distribution. Imagine the consequences if it suffers major damage.”

War is not fought by troops alone.

If you have troops, you need food.

Besides, part of the mission is to provide relief to civilians affected by the war.

In the current war, the objective isn't to attack a territory but to defend against attacks.

Damage is inevitable.

Even if we completely defeat the rebels, there will be no spoils of war to gain.

But for Ian, the Royal army's commander, such considerations were unnecessary.

His only goal was victory.

Even if the rebels inflicted damage on the Persia territory, the loss of troops was a certainty.

As long as Persia territory isn't captured, it's more advantageous to inflict troop casualties.

Even if some citizens starve to death, the war itself can still be won.

“So, Princess Rie, are you suggesting we deploy troops near Persia territory, not where the large rebel force is moving?”

Ian's sarcasm was met with a sly smile from Rie.

“The Astria House will provide the means of transportation.”

“...What?”

“Spatial magic. We’ll supply magical artifacts inscribed with spatial magic around the territory, allowing key personnel to be transported directly to Persia territory.”

Spatial magic, a specialty of the Astria House.

Only the head of the house could use this magic, but there was a way to enable others to use it too.

Magical artifacts.

If the head of the Astria House created these artifacts, others could use them too.

“Are you suggesting the Astria House provide these magical artifacts now?”

“Perrian Astria, the current head of the Astria House, isn’t particularly busy with other matters. So, he could create these artifacts for our use.”

“Princess Lia...”

“Hmm...”

Rie's suggestion stirred the room.

Spatial magic artifacts were items the Astria House had never released before.

They weren't nonexistent, but they came with astronomical prices, and even if one could afford them, the House was not inclined to sell.

From the Astria House’s perspective, there was no financial issue necessitating their sale, so there was no reason to offer them.

“We should use a different method.”

Ian sharply interrupted Rie's words.

Rie laughed incredulously at him.

“Didn’t you say it yourself, Commander? This is war. Isn't it biased to let personal feelings influence decisions?”

“There are plenty of ways to win without that method. It's an overinvestment.”

“How can you equate investing in people's lives to a matter of money?”

“Even lives have their value. If there were weapons in the Persia territory capable of defeating the rebels, I’d protect it, but it’s just food. And not even a growing area, but a distribution center.”

“If that distribution is disrupted, not only the people in Persia territory but also those in the north and west could starve to death.”

“That's a concern for later. Right now, winning the war is the priority.”

Ian and Rie's voices grew increasingly louder.

Yet no one around them dared to intervene.

On one side stood a potential leader of the nobility, on the other, a future Emperor.

Getting involved in a clash of titans could be dangerous.

Amidst this silence, someone cautiously raised their hand.

“Um...”

It was Gracie, raising her hand timidly.

The others were shocked to see Gracie, the junior professor of the Academy, attempting to interject in their argument.

“Uh, what if the people from the Academy also help defend the Persia territory...?”

“Professor Gracie?”

“Can the Academy do that?”

Gracie smiled awkwardly.

“Well... the Persia territory and the Academy are connected by a mountain range, so there's actually a fairly accessible path...”

Rie frowned at Gracie's words.

“But even so, if we wait until we hear of an attack, won't it be too late?”

“Professor Cromwell... No, Vice-Principal Cromwell could move quickly. It might be possible with him...”

Ian nodded with a satisfied smile.

“Vice-Principal Cromwell is trustworthy. Isn't he also your mentor, Astina?”

Astina nodded, her expression complex.

“Still, we must prepare in advance since we don't know the extent of the enemy's forces.”

“Are you saying you don't trust Cromwell? You were also trained by him, weren't you? Is such an expert not enough?”

Just as Ian and Rie were about to resume their argument, a man next to them raised his hand.

“Let's stop here. This seems to be enough.”

A middle-aged man in a neat robe and wearing glasses.

Keln Rinsburg, the head elemental.

“I understand the concerns of Princess Rie, and I get what Ian is saying. Arguing like this won’t solve anything, so may I make a suggestion?”

Ian nodded.

“Go ahead.”

“I will go to the Persia territory.”

Keln smiled.

"I can move quickly to the territory using elementals. Therefore, I will wait in the Persia territory, and if a battle breaks out in a nearby territory, I will move there."

“Is the Head Elementalist himself going?”

Rie asked, surprised.

The Royal Head Elementalist and the Head wizard were famous for their reluctance to move.

They were figures who seemed almost uninterested in worldly affairs.

They possessed great power but didn’t interfere in politics, only appearing in the academic world, where they focused on research.

“However, I would like to have one person to assist me. As I've aged, I find it difficult to move around on my own.”

Rie smiled and nodded.

“Yes, we will assign a maid from the palace to serve you...”

“No. How could I go to a battlefield with someone who can't defend themselves?”

“...Excuse me?”

“Assign my daughter, Serina Rinsburg, to me. As family, she is most convenient, and being powerful, she will have no problems handling any situation.”

People whispered among themselves at Keln’s words.

“Serina Rinsburg... wasn’t she the one who almost killed the second son of the Astria House?”

“I heard she’s imprisoned...”

The people were unaware that Serina was currently part of the royal secret service.

The names in the secret service were always highly classified.

However, Keln seemed to know exactly where Serina was.

Rie looked at Keln, her expression confused.

“I can't do anything about that...”

That’s when the Emperor spoke up.

“I will permit it.”

“Heh, Your Majesty, don’t forget to reduce her sentence if my daughter contributes to the war effort.”

“I understand. Don’t worry about that; just focus on the war.”

“Thank you, Your Majesty.”

Reducing her sentence meant releasing her from the secret service.

While Rie found it beneficial to use a talented individual like Serina in the secret service, she had no say once the Emperor made his decision.

“And.”

The Emperor shifted his gaze to Ian.

“What is the head of the Astria House doing? As you said, the Empire is in a state of war. Why is Perrian Astria cooped up in his house?”

“My father has delegated the duties of the head to me...”

“There must have been a council meeting. You are a contender for the succession, not the confirmed successor. It's acceptable for you to take on some duties of the head, but not all of them.”

The Emperor narrowed his eyes and stood up.

“Inform Perrian Astria to return within three days.”

“...Understood, Your Majesty.”

Ian bowed his head in response.

Even if the Astria House held a high status, it was still a ducal house under the Emperor.

Until now, the Emperor had turned a blind eye to certain matters, but he wouldn't let this situation slide.

“It seems this is the only matter worth discussing, so let's conclude the meeting. Report the rest in writing.”

“...Understood.”

“Oh, and.”

The Emperor looked towards Gracie, who was standing to the side.

"I heard you're the junior professor, quite a bold one at that. Much better than the nobles who just watched the fight unfold."

"Me? Yes?"

Gracie displayed a bewildered expression at the sudden praise directed at her.

"Thinking that someone like you teaches at the Academy brightens the future of the Empire. I trust you'll do well both in this war and in your future teaching."

"Your Majesty, I am immensely honored!!!"

Gracie bowed her head in surprise.

The Emperor nodded with satisfaction and then headed out of the conference room.

"Well, I shall take my leave now."

"Professor~ You were amazing today~."

"What, amazing?... I don't even know what I said there..."

"Hey, you were really cool when you just raised your hand and said, 'Stop everything!'"

"When did I ever say that?"

"What? You don't remember?"

"I didn't actually say that!"

After the meeting,

Gracie and Yuni were chatting nearby.

"So, will you be staying in the capital for a while?"

"No, I'm going to be moving with the Royal Army..."

"With the Royal Army?"

"Since the Academy is in a dangerous situation, someone from the Academy needs to represent our position to the Royal Army."

"That sounds tough~."

"We have to endure it... Others will have it even harder."

Gracie felt grateful to Cromwell.

The Academy was now entering a state of war, a tremendously dangerous situation.

In the midst of it, Cromwell had extracted the youngest professor, Gracie, to the safest place.

Being a spokesperson for the Royal Army was an incredibly important position from the Academy's perspective.

The spokesperson had to understand the situation on the front and negotiate for appropriate reinforcements based on their position.

Yet, the Academy had sent Gracie there.

This move was to prevent the junior professor Gracie from being exposed to the war.

It was evident that the professors cared for Gracie, despite how hard they made her work.

"Professor."

That's when Astina called out to Gracie.

"It's time to leave. You should start packing."

"Ah, okay! Yuni, I'll see you later."

"Take care."

Yuni smiled warmly and waved at Gracie.

After exchanging farewells with Gracie, Yuni turned and walked away.

Hidden from view, Rie was there.

"You could have at least said goodbye"

"Was there any need to do that?"

Rie replied with a blank expression to Yuni's comment.

"Ah! Are you upset because I interrupted you earlier?"

"Absolutely not."

"Seems like you are~."

"I'm not."

Rie narrowed her brows in response and looked in the direction Gracie had left.

However, she wasn't looking at Gracie.

Her gaze was fixed on Astina, who had called Gracie.

'It should be alright.'

Rie watched Astina's retreating figure with a complex expression.

Chapter 224: Spatial Magic (3)

At the Astria mansion in the capital.

I sat blankly in the mansion, staring at the ceiling.

'Think of recognizing the points and lines, the space, rather than creating it from scratch.'

Recognizing the space.

What does that even mean?

No matter how much I mulled over Ian's words, they were hard to understand.

According to Ian, the box I created was merely an object formed within the space we inhabit.

It was not space itself but a mere clump of ordinary mana.

Then, what exactly is space?

No, I didn't even need to go that far.

I couldn't even create a single point at present.

Trying to understand space from there was impossible.

I had no choice but to follow Ian's instructions.

Still, the silver lining was that Ian had taught me quite well.

He demonstrated spatial magic directly and explained the theoretical aspects.

His clear explanations made the theory easy to grasp.

But practice was a different story.

'The world is space, and this space is essentially made up of countless points. You need to perceive and feel these points.'

'Spatial magic is not creation. It's a magic that connects existing points in the world, creating lines from these points, and then forming space by connecting these lines. And drawing a boundary between reality and the created space. That's what spatial magic is.'

Although I could understand these words, I couldn't put them into practice.

"What a headache..."

Continuously pondering gave me a literal headache.

How can one perceive what is invisible?

I stared into the void, wondering if I could see the points.

"...I see it. It must be visible. It has to be."

I muttered to myself, glaring into the void.

But that didn't mean they would become visible.

My eyes started to hurt from straining them too much.

"Ugh..."

I rubbed my sore eyes.

Staring into the void wouldn't make them visible...

How can I see the points in space?

Humans have things they can and cannot do with their five senses.

Perceiving space is beyond what can be sensed with the five senses.

Naturally, it was impossible to see with the eyes.

"With the eyes... With the five senses, it's impossible..."

A way for a person to perceive and feel without the five senses.

"...Mana."

I remembered the fight with Jefrin I had before.

An incident where I could sense and understand my surroundings even when all senses were gone.

Reading the flow of mana.

Maybe there's a similarity between reading the flow of mana and perceiving space?

As far as I knew, mana was the only thing that could be perceived without the five senses.

But perceiving mana and space were distinctly different.

Mana is not everywhere.

It needs a center, like a person or a magical tool.

However, points in space exist everywhere.

Perceiving mana was different.

So, do these two concepts follow entirely different paths?

It wasn't like that.

It was still a conjecture, but I considered it a higher level of perception.

Recalling what Ian had explained about perceiving space, it didn't seem much different from perceiving mana.

Then...

"The flow of mana?"

I immediately sought out my uncle.

Pondering alone on such matters was futile.

There were no relevant books available, after all.

Thus, it was better to ask someone knowledgeable.

Studying alone is one thing, but having a teacher makes a world of difference.

Since my uncle had agreed to teach me spatial magic, I had no hesitation in approaching him.

"What I've been contemplating is that perceiving the flow of mana doesn't seem different from perceiving space. It feels like observing something more finely detailed than mana's flow?"

"...Did you come here just to ask that?"

"Yes, haven't you agreed to teach me spatial magic?"

Yurik looked at me incredulously.

"And you came at this hour?"

It was late at night.

Long past sunset, and nearing bedtime.

"I couldn't find an answer on my own. Plus, you're busy during the day, aren't you?"

I initially planned to visit the next morning or during the day, but my uncle was unavailable then.

So, the only feasible time was at night like this.

"May I ask again, then?"

"The relationship between mana's flow and space, is that it?"

"Yes. You know about the flow of mana, don't you?"

"I don't know how to use it, but I understand it theoretically. The flow of mana..."

Yurik pondered, stroking his chin.

Even though he had long given up practicing magic, Yurik was once a notable figure in the magical world.

He may not be up-to-date with modern magical academia, but he certainly knew more basic theoretical knowledge than I did.

After a moment of thought.

"It seems different, yet not."

"...Could you explain that, please?"

"The realms of perception are different. Mana involves perceiving the space we currently inhabit. It's the reality we feel with our sight, touch, and other senses.

But the part you perceive in spatial magic is entirely different."

"What do you mean by that?"

"Let me give you an example."

Yurik paused briefly, then began to explain.

"Imagine there's a piece of paper with invisible grid lines. Our real world is like a graph drawn on these invisible lines, following certain principles and interactions."

Yurik continued his explanation.

"Mana is similar to this. If I were to give an example, it's like an invisible graph. If magic is used, the graph becomes visible, but until then, it can't be seen. We can only predict how it might be drawn."

"So, is space like the grid lines?"

"Exactly. As I said, space is a realm connected by points and lines. The graphs, which we call reality, can't influence these grid lines. They are merely drawn over them."

I furrowed my brows.

I had somewhat anticipated this.

"So, perceiving mana and space are not entirely different, are they?"

"No, haven't I already said it? The gridlines exist even if invisible, and the graphs, following certain principles, are already drawn in reality."

"What does that mean?"

"To see the gridlines properly, you must face reality squarely. Perceiving the flow of mana is about how the graph will be drawn. Being able to read the flow of mana means you already understand the gridlines of space. You can accurately draw the invisible graph."

It seemed like something I could grasp, yet I was completely lost.

I looked at Yurik with a confused expression.

"Don't overthink it. Feel it as you would the flow of mana. Just think there are already drawn gridlines and look at reality that way."

"...Understood."

Graphs and gridlines...

It was hard to explain, but I began to see the contours of spatial magic.

Reading the flow of mana, creating my own coordinates...

I smiled.

"Thank you for your time this late. I'll be going back now."

"What? Won't you come in for a cup of tea?"

We were at the entrance of the mansion.

Yurik seemed hesitant to let me stand there and tried to invite me inside.

"No, I need to get back quickly."

I couldn't afford to linger here.

I needed to precisely draw the vague outlines of spatial magic I had glimpsed.

"Then, I'll be going."

Thinking of experimenting on my own, I quickly moved away.

"Heh..."

Behind me, Yurik was left with a look of disbelief.

"We shall start the deployment ceremony."

A loud voice rang out.

"Do we really need to go this far?"

"It's essentially for show. The commoners probably don't even know what's happening right now. It's like saying, 'Don't be scared, we have this much military power.'"

Rie and I chatted while watching the ceremony.

Ian, being the commander of the Royal Army, stood at the forefront of the troops, and since my father was in the Astria territory, I had to attend as the representative of Astria.

Thus, I sat right next to Rie, representing the Duke of Astria's family.

"Isn't this just giving information to the rebels?"

"Astina already led some soldiers ahead. The ones deploying now are just the rearguard."

"Is that so?"

As we continued our conversation.

"Heh, you two seem to have a good relationship."

The Emperor, who was behind us, spoke up.

Rie and I were seated right in front of the Emperor's VIP section, so he must have noticed our conversation.

"Ahaha, we haven't seen each other in a while, so we had a lot to catch up on."

I replied with an awkward laugh to the Emperor.

The Emperor looked at me with a pleased smile.

"Yes, when you're used to seeing each other every day at the academy, being apart must leave you with much to talk about."

"Exactly."

The Emperor stroked his chin thoughtfully, then looked at me and smiled.

"You may visit the palace occasionally. I'll permit it, so feel free to come by."

I bowed politely to the Emperor.

"Thank you for the offer, but I'm quite busy and likely won't have much time to visit... I apologize."

"Hmm, feel free to visit whenever..."

"Your Majesty."

As the Emperor was about to continue, Rie spoke up.

"This is an official occasion. Let's refrain from personal conversations."

"Cough."

Chastened by Rie's remark, the Emperor coughed awkwardly.

At moments like this, they seemed less like royalty and more like an ordinary father and daughter.

Rie then turned her gaze from the Emperor to me.

"By the way, how's your progress with spatial magic?"

"So-so. I think I've got a sense of it."

After my conversation with my uncle, I had started to get the hang of it.

I still couldn't use spatial magic, but I could faintly see the gridlines my uncle had mentioned.

"That's good to hear."

Despite saying that, Rie's expression wasn't great.

"...Is something wrong?"

"This worries me..."

The Royal Army responding to the rebels.

The deployment of those soldiers.

There was only one thing she could be referring to.

"Astina?"

"Yes, the rebels are targeting Astina."

I smiled at Rie.

"Don't worry. I've prepared everything."

Rie glared at me.

"That's exactly why I'm worried."

"Huh?"

"I'm afraid you'll do something dangerous on your own."

I was puzzled and tilted my head.

"Weren't you worried about Astina?"

"I am, but knowing your personality, you won't just sit still if you know Astina is in danger."

"..."

"This isn't an academy matter; it's a war, so I can't take direct action."

Rie sighed.

"I won't tell you not to rescue Astina if she's in danger. Just be careful. Think of escaping if you encounter danger."

Her eyes were full of concern as she looked at me.

"Be careful. Don't get hurt."

Chapter 225: Spatial Magic (4)

In front of Liberion Academy, at the Tusen Gorge.

Soldiers and professors were present there.

Since the Academy didn't have a lord, the professors themselves had to defend it in times of war.

However, due to not being a combat group, there was a shortage of soldiers and weaponry.

Still, there wasn't a major problem.

Dozens of professors were at the Academy, each an expert in their field.

Not only were these exceptional individuals guarding it, but the surrounding terrain also protected the Academy.

Numerous gorges and mountain ranges surrounded the area.

Originally, this location was chosen to facilitate outdoor training for the students.

This geographical feature turned the Academy into a natural fortress.

It limited the paths for large armies to move and made it advantageous to fight at the chokepoints.

Even with few soldiers and limited weapons, it was still a safe place.

However, it was also a highly coveted location for the enemy.

For the rebels, capturing such a fortress, even at great sacrifice, could turn the tide of war in their favor.

Thus, the professors were in a state of high alert.

Cromwell approached McDowell, who was overlooking the gorge from above.

“Principal McDowell, I've returned.”

“How are the students and civilians?”

“We've sent most of the students back to their homes, and the residents are safely sheltered inside the Academy.”

The Academy had experienced attacks by rebels before.

Hence, they weren't complacent.

Although the army had to pass through the gorge where the professors were, there could be other methods of attack.

Like the previous rebel attack, where they had used Bone Dragons.

If all professors were stationed in the gorge, they couldn't respond to such an attack.

Therefore, they had evacuated the residents of the village in front of the Academy and stationed some professors there for safety.

“What about the message from the Empire?”

“You mean the instruction to go to Persia's domain in case of emergency?”

“Yes, is it feasible?”

“It's possible, but... are you sure you'll be alright, Principal?”

Principal McDowell had lost an arm to Aryandor.

He couldn't display the same authority as before.

“I'll be fine. The Royal army is already heading this way, isn't it?”

Ian's rear guard was currently moving towards the Academy.

Astina's vanguard was guarding the Verdès domain in the south, while Ian's rear guard was responsible for the Academy area, as per the current Royal strategy.

“Honestly, it's not easy. While moving there is possible, what happens after the move is the problem. If the rebels really come to Persia's domain... Depending on who comes, it might be challenging to perform effectively.”

Cromwell recalled Gracie, who had suggested such a plan.

He wasn't too upset about being overestimated, but considering the war situation, it wasn't a good judgment.

"Still, there's no need for great concern. After all, isn't the Empire's head elemental also there?”

“...Understood.”

Worrying wouldn't change anything.

It was a decision already made in the meeting, so they had to follow through.

Then, from below, a soldier shouted.

“Principal McDowell! The Royal army is almost here!”

“Understood. Time for us to go and meet them.”

“Yes, let's go.”

Cromwell and McDowell descended to meet the Royal army at the bottom of the gorge.

Verdès Domain, the ramparts.

Astina stood atop them.

From there, she could only see the vast plains, not even an ant in sight.

However, her expression was filled with worry.

“What’s bothering you?”

At that moment, someone approached Astina from behind.

It was Diark Verdès, the only son of the Verdès family.

Astina and Diark weren't originally acquainted, but they had become close surprisingly quickly.

The reason was a shared topic of conversation about Rudy.

Diark, having received help from Rudy during the joint assessment, felt amiable towards Rudy's acquaintances.

He believed in reciprocating the help he received, even if he couldn't repay Rudy directly, he should be kind to those around Rudy.

“How can I not worry when the war is looming so close?”

“Still, thanks to Astina, all preparations are complete, aren’t they?”

“I might have just lit the fuse on a bomb waiting to explode.”

“But...”

“No matter what anyone says, I am the one who hastened this war.”

Diark was about to speak when Astina cut him off.

“However, many people share this responsibility with me. My close ones are involved too.”

Astina was afraid.

She feared that her actions, taken for her own survival, could harm or even kill those around her.

Could she endure it if such a thing happened?

The thought of surviving at the end, atop a pile of bodies, was revolting to her.

And what if Rudy died in such a situation?

Rudy had assured her that he would come to save her.

At the time, it was a joyous thought, but as time passed, she increasingly hoped he wouldn't come.

She sometimes wished to die alone rather than involve others.

“Is there something wrong with Rudy?”

Diark's sudden question made Astina's eyes widen.

“What are you talking about? Rudy is in the capital, isn't he? This place is on the outskirts of the Empire.”

“When you talk about Rudy, there's a unique expression on your face.”

“What?”

“You wear the same expression when you think of Rudy.”

Diark laughed happily and said to Astina.

“...Don't tell others.”

“How can I tell others when I don't even know what it's about?”

Astina let out a sigh.

"Rudy is a concern, but not entirely. It was more about the overall worry regarding the war."

"Then, you might not need to worry about Rudy."

Diark spoke with confidence.

"What do you mean?"

"From what I've observed, Rudy isn't someone we need to worry about."

"You mean he's different from us?"

"No, he's one of us, but a real maverick. He's so intense that it's almost like venom oozes out of him."

Diark continued.

"Rudy lives a different kind of day than we do. He sits in the library all day, then goes to the training ground to practice magic alone, and when he returns to his room, the light never seems to go out."

Diark had been closely observing Rudy at the Academy.

Initially, it was out of curiosity about how a genius lived.

However, watching Rudy's life led him to a different conclusion.

Rudy was not a genius.

"There's a saying that most magic is about talent, isn't there? That it's a field only for geniuses born into the right families with inherent mana and various other factors. But seeing Rudy, I wonder if I'd be in the same position even with the same elements.

He lives a life that would make one sick just by watching. If that's what it takes to be a genius, I'd rather not be one. Even if I were asked, I couldn't do it."

“How does that translate to not worrying about Rudy?”

“If such a person sets out to do something, would they really fail? Would they fall when faced with danger? Rudy has already been preparing tremendously since his time at the Academy. He’s someone who can overcome anything.”

Rudy didn’t have a natural talent for magic.

If he had, his life might have been different from the start.

He could have easily mastered magic without anyone's help, and when he decided to surpass Evan, he might have even become the top student.

But Rudy didn’t do that.

He was just an ordinary person.

However, his efforts were not in vain.

He gained strong abilities and was prepared to overcome any situation.

“So, if we just trust and wait, he’ll surely overcome it on his own.”

Astina thought of Rudy’s face upon hearing Diark’s words.

“...Maybe, trusting and waiting is what I should do.”

Astina smiled to herself as she looked into the distance.

Then, she turned to Diark.

“Where is the Marquis of Verdès now?”

“My father? He should be inside the castle with his staff.”

“Is that so?”

“...? Where are you going?”

“I just remembered somewhere I need to visit.”

“A place you need to visit?”

“Persia Domain.”

Astina smirked.

“I need to go and see the situation there.”

“So, is everything ready now?”

“Yes, it is.”

Daemon responded to Aryandor’s question.

“Tell the soldiers to pull back as there might be a counterattack.”

“Understood.”

Daemon handed a prepared scroll to the bat on his shoulder.

"Then, let's be on our way."

Aryandor laughed.

As he did, a massive movement stirred behind him.

The undead with their enormous bodies.

They began to move.

The location where Aryandor and Daemon stood was in front of the mountain range of Perses' domain.

The Royal army was unaware of one crucial fact.

This mountain range was not a place for ordinary people to traverse.

It was too rugged and twisted, making it impossible to navigate carelessly.

However, Aryandor had cunningly exploited this to his advantage.

In fact, he had been preparing for this for quite some time.

Since people didn't travel through here, it was possible to prepare for war.

An undead army created with necromancy.

Daemon's undead army had been hidden in this mountain range.

The treacherous terrain provided ample hiding places for the undead, allowing for the concealment of a large force.

"Go."

And now, that undead army began to move.

Chapter 226: Spatial Magic (5)

In the Persia territory.

"How does one even come to a place like this?"

Soldiers were talking atop the city walls.

"How could we possibly understand the thoughts of our superiors?"

"Don't you sometimes think we're better off than those people? It's ridiculous. With mountains like these standing between the rebels and our territory, do they really know nothing?"

"Watch your words. Things visible from a high place are different from those seen below."

"And there are things only visible from below. Speaking as if war is upon us, while keeping us on constant guard."

"At least the pay is generous."

"Generous? That money vanishes after a few drinks."

"That's because you drink too much."

As the soldiers leaned against the wall, chatting leisurely.

Tap tap tap tap.

They heard footsteps approaching.

"Is it the captain? Stand up."

"Yes, yes. Understood."

The grumbling soldier quickly resumed his vigilant stance.

A man approached the soldiers rapidly.

"Loyalty, there's no sign of troubl..."

The man who approached wasn't the captain.

"Sigh..."

It was Keln Rinsburg, the Royal Head Elementalist rumored to have come from the capital.

"Loyalty! To the Head Elementalist..."

But Keln paid no mind to the soldiers.

He ignored the two soldiers and walked past them.

"What..."

Keln looked shocked as he approached the end of the wall.

"Elementalist, sir! It's dangerous at the edge of the wall!"

A soldier, looking alarmed, tried to stop Keln.

"Don't worry about it."

Keln didn't even glance at the soldiers, focusing only on the mountains.

'Something is coming.'

During his stay at the castle, Keln sensed something unusual.

The rustling sound of elementals in the mountains.

As the Royal Head Elementalist, Keln could sense the emotions of elementals not bound to him.

The emotion felt by the mountain elementals was fear.

He didn't know exactly what they feared, but it was a bad sign.

"Sylpherion."

As Keln spoke, the wind gathered, forming the shape of a giant bird.

It was Sylpherion, a high-ranking wind elemental.

"What's happening?"

"Go to that mountain and check what's going on. And Sylph."

A small bird appeared beside Sylpherion.

It was Sylph, a lower-ranking wind elemental.

"Sylph, go to the Persia lord. Inform them of the situation."

"Understood!"

The soldiers looked bewildered at Keln's urgent actions.

"My lord, what is happening?"

As a soldier asked, Keln turned his head.

"War is beginning."

"Professor, have you been well?"

"Well? It's been a continuous struggle."

Cromwell greeted Ian with a calm face.

"I haven't seen you in a long time, Principal. I heard your health wasn't good, are you alright?"

"Haha, I can't just lie in bed because I'm unwell. Please, have a seat."

McDowell extended his hand towards a chair in front with a hearty laugh.

Ian sat down and looked at McDowell.

"Have you heard about the current war situation?"

"Yes, I've read all the materials you sent over."

"Then it'll be easier to discuss. Have all the students of the academy been sent back to their homes?"

McDowell shook his head.

"Not all of them. With the empire in turmoil, students living far away couldn't return. But since it's the vacation period, there aren't many left."

"How many students are still here?"

At Ian's question, Cromwell spoke up.

"About ten or so. The remaining students are being protected along with the residents, so there's no major issue."

"Do you have a list of these students?"

Upon Ian's question, Cromwell handed over a document.

"Some stayed because it's dangerous to return home during the war, and some stayed out of their own will."

As Ian read through the document, he narrowed his eyebrows and pointed to two names.

"What about these kids?"

The two names were Evan and Yeniel.

Next to their names, it was written that they participated in the war.

"These two students volunteered to participate in the war."

"Where are these students now?"

"They move independently. They said they have tasks to attend to."

Ian put down the document and spoke.

"Send them back to the academy or their homes immediately. We can't allow students to participate in the war. Individual movements not even officially sanctioned by the military? That's unacceptable."

"These students have outstanding records at the academy. Yeniel comes from a lineage of rebel assassins, and Evan has been the top student at the academy several times. This decision was made based on their background."

"I am the commander of the Royal Army. I will not permit this."

"Ian Astria."

As Ian's tone heightened, McDowell spoke up.

"Is it because of the responsibility? Then let me take responsibility."

The responsibility that comes when students are injured or killed was more serious than imagined.

Even though Evan and Yeniel were not from prominent families, any harm to academy students would cause a significant reaction from the empire.

It would not only be awkward for the academy, but also leave a major scar on Ian's achievements as the commander of the Royal Army.

If the commander of the Royal Army, who came to protect the academy, allowed students to get hurt by the rebels, he would undoubtedly bear the responsibility.

That's why Ian was vehemently opposed.

"And do you think they won't participate just because we oppose it? They're stubborn, so it's safer to keep them where we can manage."

Ian looked intently at McDowell as he spoke, then nodded in agreement.

"If the Principal insists, I will comply. However, I will not assume any responsibility."

"Do as you see fit."

McDowell said this and then glanced at the ceiling with a slight smile.

"What's the matter?"

"Nothing. Let's continue discussing the war."

They continued their meeting.

Having both faced the rebels directly, they could provide Ian with detailed explanations.

In their discussion, a critical issue arose: Aryandor's time magic.

This was the biggest headache.

If the enemy could attack and then reverse time, they could continue the war indefinitely.

Worse, they could do so while erasing their own memories, leaving only the rebels with knowledge of their tactics.

"Does that mean time could already have been reversed?"

"Possibly. We can only hope it hasn't."

The magical device Luna obtained during the last rebel attack was analyzed, revealing it could erase everyone's memories.

The device, combining Jefrin's illusion magic and Aryandor's time magic, could manipulate both memory and time.

Though Jefrin was dead and no more such devices could be created, the number remaining was unknown.

So, it was possible they were already in a reversed timeline.

A situation where all Royal Army members lost their memories, and time was reversed.

This was the worst-case scenario for the Royal Army.

"Our first priority should be to unravel Aryandor's time magic. We need to determine whether we're in a reversed timeline."

Ian stroked his chin thoughtfully at McDowell's words.

Time and space were somewhat similar realms of magic.

However, without having faced Aryandor directly, Ian couldn't know the specifics.

"If I encounter Aryandor, I'll take him on. Perhaps I can find the answers there."

"Understood. Let's plan for that."

Just as they were about to move to the next topic...

"Commander!!!"

"What's the matter?"

Ian's aide burst into the tent where they were meeting.

"We've received a request for assistance from the Persia territory!!"

"Rebels? How could the rebels..."

"I'm not sure of the details. It's not an attack yet, but the Head Elementalist urged us to send word quickly."

"How large is the force?"

"It seems to be a significant force. What will you do?"

Ian made a swift decision.

"Proceed as planned. Professor Cromwell will go first, followed by the troops. Also, check the movement of the academy's forces."

"Understood."

Ian heard his aide's response and then looked at Cromwell.

"Professor, I'm counting on you."

Cromwell clenched his teeth at this.

The situation seemed to involve a large enemy force.

Flying from the academy to the Persia territory to face such a force?

They might manage to handle the lesser foes, but facing Aryandor or other leaders was out of the question.

Then, McDowell spoke up.

"Ian, can't you transport someone using spatial magic?"

He was asking whether Ian could move others using spatial magic, an idea inspired by the time when future Rudy used it to transport Rie and Yuni.

"There are limits to spatial magic. I lack the skill to transport others as of yet."

"I see..."

Cromwell sighed upon hearing this.

"Then I shall leave immediately."

"I'll assess the situation and follow promptly."

As a user of spatial magic, Ian could transport himself there directly.

However, if the enemy deployed a pincer attack, their current location might be jeopardized.

Even Ian couldn't continuously use spatial magic, especially over distances like between the Persia territory and the academy.

Therefore, they needed to gauge the rebels' movements before deciding whether to assist the Persia territory.

"Gravity."

Cromwell used magic to levitate and started moving towards the Persia territory.

McDowell watched him ascend.

"Be careful out there."

"Understood."

Cromwell promptly headed towards the Persia territory.

"Then."

Ian stood up and looked at his aide.

"Let's get moving."

Cromwell clenched his teeth as he flew through the air.

He regulated his mana usage, flying as fast as he could.

It sounded contradictory, but he was trying to maintain a balance.

Soon, he reached the vicinity of a mountain range.

'If I follow the mountain range...'

The Persia territory lay somewhere in between.

"Hmm?"

Just as he was about to follow the mountain range, he spotted a huge object in the distance.

A giant creature covered in red scales.

"...A dragon?"

It was a Red Dragon, sitting squarely on the path along the mountain range.

Cromwell's eyes widened at the sudden appearance of the Red Dragon.

And a flurry of thoughts crossed his mind.

Was this dragon prepared by the rebels?

Or was it just a coincidence?

He couldn't afford to fight this dragon now.

He needed to reach the Persia territory as soon as possible.

Cromwell tried to pass by quietly.

"Professor."

"...?"

Someone called out from the direction of the dragon.

"Professor. Over here."

A man stood atop the giant dragon's head.

A man with black hair, wielding a sword.

It was Evan.

Chapter 227: Spatial Magic (6)

"Professor, I've been waiting for you."

Evan greeted Cromwell with a smile.

"You are... no, that dragon is..."

It was the Hatchling they had seen during the joint assessment.

"Get on for now. We don't have time to delay."

"Grrr."

As Evan gestured, the Red Dragon made a sound of displeasure.

Thump!

Evan slapped the dragon's head with his palm.

"Hey, this professor is stronger than you."

"...Anyway!!! I am not something to be ridden!!!"

"Got it. Just this once, please."

"Grrrr..."

The Red Dragon grumbled, but offered its back to Cromwell.

"Huh..."

"Let's go now."

As Cromwell mounted, the dragon spread its wings.

"Hold on tight. I won't notice if you fall off."

"Alright."

Rudy had mentioned taming the dragon, but Cromwell hadn't expected it to become this docile.

Of course, it might be due to magical constraints, but looking at Evan and the dragon, they seemed to get along reasonably well.

"This dragon... no, why are you here?"

"I said I would join the war. So, I came to assist you."

"No..."

Cromwell furrowed his brows, feeling frustrated.

There were more than a couple of oddities.

"Rudy Astria asked me to assist in the war."

"...What?"

Cromwell's eyebrows knitted together at the sudden mention of Rudy Astria.

"He asked me to help the Persia region. And to bring along Yongyong."

"...Yongyong?"

"That's this guy's name."

Evan chuckled and patted the dragon's body.

"Don't call me by such a name!!!!!!!"

The dragon roared, but Evan paid it no mind.

"Besides, how did you know I would be coming here?"

"Yeniel was nearby and contacted me."

"...She was undercover?"

"According to Yeniel, Principal McDowell didn't say anything..."

Cromwell, preoccupied with many concerns, hadn't noticed Yeniel's presence.

However, McDowell had sensed it and, pretending not to notice, allowed Yeniel to listen in on the war situation.

McDowell believed in the potential of the students.

Variables that could change the unfavorable situation created by Aryandor's time magic.

It might be shameful as an adult, but he entrusted this to the students.

And McDowell was doing what he must as an adult.

Thus, Cromwell and Evan headed towards the Persia region.

Astina headed towards the Persia region.

As the deputy commander, she had planned to stay in the Verdès region, but staying there was meaningless.

Most of the rebels were in front of the academy, and it would take a long time for that force to move to the Verdès region.

Even if there was a surprise attack, Astina could quickly regroup her troops, so there was no major issue.

Thus, Astina transferred command to the head of the Verdès family and went to the Persia region.

Astina headed for the Verdès region for a reason.

It was to confront her fate head-on.

Herself facing death in the Persia region.

Originally, she had tried to avoid that future.

She had tried to flee from that future.

To avoid that outcome, she just needed to be absent from that place.

But could she overcome fate like that?

Could she witness a good outcome?

It was questionable.

Was it enough just to survive?

Was it enough just to barely cling to life and remain in this world?

The answer was clear.

Merely surviving held no meaning.

Should she survive alone, only for her family's domain to fall into ruins?

In Astina's heart, her domain was etched deeply.

Those who moved vigorously from dawn, transporting goods throughout the empire.

She couldn't ignore them.

"Astina, it's because of these people that the empire thrives," her father had said.

Those who were diligently fulfilling their roles.

Creating a space for them had been her father's goal.

Thus, her father built the empire's largest commercial city.

And now, it was Astina's turn to carry on that goal.

To protect them all.

Astina had struggled to see good results.

She fought against her destiny and resisted oppression.

Thus, she rose to a position that no one could ignore.

But if she ran away now.

If she fled to survive.

It would be like denying her own life.

In truth, knowing the future changed nothing.

There was nothing to worry about.

Hadn't she lived the same way until now?

Facing the tempest of fate head-on, overcoming it with her own strength.

That was Astina's life.

As Astina neared the Persia region.

Thud.

Boom.

Ominous sounds came from the mountain range.

The sound of giant footsteps and trees being crushed.

Then, the culprits of these sounds revealed themselves.

Golems entangled with giant skeletons and corpses.

Underneath them were zombies and skeletons.

An army created by necromancy.

The vast army, too large to see its end, headed towards the Persia region.

A situation where any ordinary person would flee.

Yet, Astina smiled.

As she had anticipated, the rebels were targeting the Persia region.

'Just do as I always have.'

As always.

Overcome and move forward.

"Gravity."

Astina used magic and soared into the sky.

Philip, the head of the Persia family and Astina's father, donned his armor and ascended the castle walls.

"What is this....."

Philip had never experienced war.

He had been managing the domain, but Philip had left the combat aspect to the surrounding families.

Being proficient in administrative tasks and less knowledgeable in combat, it was a wise decision for Philip.

However, it was time for Philip to step forward.

As the lord, staying cooped up in his manor during war would surely demoralize the soldiers.

That's why Philip was on the ramparts.

"Lord, please stay calm. The soldiers are watching."

Thankfully, Keln, the Head Elementalist, was by his side.

"Lord, you must protect yourself at all costs. Your presence alone will continue to boost the soldiers' morale."

"...Understood."

"I will leave my daughter near you, so you won't be in danger."

Keln introduced his daughter, Serina, to Philip.

"I am Serina Rinsburg."

"Please, take care."

Yet, Philip couldn't remain calm.

The overwhelming force of the undead legion descending from the mountains was intimidating.

Seeing monsters whose heads reached the ends of the walls and grotesque skeletons swarming, he felt nauseous.

His face turned pale with worry about the war.

"But... can we win?"

Their numbers were too many.

He had expected some attack, but not an army of this magnitude.

"We'll have to see. In war, 100 soldiers can beat 1000 at times."

"But, then..."

"However, Professor Cromwell is on his way, and the Royal army has promised to come to our aid. We just need to hold out until then."

Normally, victory in war meant overpowering the enemy with strong force, but now, they just needed to hold out.

Fitting for the empire's granary, the fortress had ample food supplies, making it ideal for a siege.

'But, we must not be complacent.'

In fact, the legion created by necromancy could be dealt with easily.

It was the creatures lurking behind that were frightening.

What kind of beings with what abilities might emerge from within the legion.

That was the biggest variable.

However, Keln did not share these thoughts with Philip.

There was no need to induce fear in someone already trembling.

After all, Keln himself had to lead the battle.

It was time for the Head Elementalist, experienced in many battles, to show his dignity.

"Sylpherion."

As Keln spoke, a giant bird appeared above his head.

Large enough to cover the fortress.

Comparable in size to a dragon.

From Sylpherion's body, a blue wind spread out.

"Ah..."

"Is that... a high-level elemental?"

The soldiers gaped at the sight.

A high-level elemental they might never see in their lifetime.

The sight of such a elemental wrapping the fortress in blue wind was awe-inspiring.

"So..."

Keln looked at the approaching undead legion, ready to signal the start of the war.

"...Hmm?"

But he was suddenly struck dumb by the appearance of someone unexpected.

"Why... are you here?"

The person who appeared before him was Astina, the deputy commander of the Royal army.

Astina, having used magic to lift herself, appeared in front of the castle.

"Ah, Astina!"

Philip exclaimed her name upon seeing her.

Astina turned her head slightly upon hearing Philip's words.

"Father, I'm here."

Then she smiled.

"I will protect our domain."

Astina manipulated her mana.

Koogung...

The ground itself seemed to rumble.

Astina's mana was moving the very earth.

"Kruck...?"

"Grrr."

The undead legion too felt the strangeness and began to hesitate in their movements.

Astina shouted towards the undead legion.

"There is no place here for filthy beings who refuse death."

With those words, the vibrations grew stronger.

"This land belongs to those who are living in the present, the busiest people of the empire."

The stones on the ground began to stir.

"So, I will send you creatures back to where you originally belonged."

Astina extended her hand.

"Gravity."

Chapter 228: Spatial Magic (7)

The ground split apart.

Just like when she fought with Jefrin, Astina overturned all the land around her.

The undead were hit by Astina's magic, unable to respond.

They fell into the fissures and were buried under the overturned earth.

Astina sent them back to the earth where they originally belonged.

The soldiers and Keln Rinsburg, atop the fortress, stared blankly at this spectacle.

They knew Astina was skilled in magic, but they hadn't expected this extent.

A girl, who had just come of age, was dominating the battlefield.

Someone frowned upon witnessing this scene.

"Why is that person here?"

From a mountain, Aryandor narrowed his eyes as he looked down at the battlefield.

Aryandor had thought his side would lead at the beginning of the battle.

It was a natural assumption, given they had initiated a surprise attack.

Daemon bowed his head to Aryandor.

"I apologize. I failed to assess the situation correctly."

Aryandor, hearing Daemon's apology, scanned the battlefield.

"Still, it doesn't seem to be a major variable."

There was no one on the battlefield who could be considered a variable except for Astina.

Perhaps reinforcements would arrive, but that was within Aryandor's expectations.

"It's better for that person to come than others."

Aryandor's strategy was to demonstrate that the Empire couldn't protect Astina.

Unable to target Astina, the Vice Commander directly, they aimed for her territory, the Persia Estate.

However, Astina's direct presence in her estate wasn't entirely bad for Aryandor.

"Are the others moving as planned?"

"Yes, the main force is proceeding as ordered."

Daemon pointed at a bat, with flesh torn in several places, and said,

The main force of the rebels seemed ready to invade at any moment.

However, they had no intention of attacking.

They were merely feigning an attack to prevent reinforcements from reaching Persia.

"Let's change our strategy slightly."

"How would you like to change it?"

Aryandor drew his sword.

"I will go to the battlefield myself."

"Astina..."

Philip, the head of the Persia family, gaped at Astina.

He knew his daughter was achieving good results with her magic, but he hadn't expected such power.

His small, delicate daughter was no longer there.

Only an incredible wizard, dominating the battlefield with her dignity, remained.

"You have raised your daughter well."

Keln couldn't hide his admiration.

Surprised and proud, Philip responded,

"Yes, she has grown so much without me realizing."

"This war seems to be turning in our favor, thanks to her."

Keln smiled and extended his hand.

"Everyone, continue the attack! Don't miss the opportunity created by Astina!"

Keln commanded the elementals as he shouted.

The soldiers responded to Keln's call.

They shot arrows and rolled stones.

Astina's setup on the battlefield was bolstered by added force.

Most of the undead fell to Astina's magic, and those who broke through her spells were taken down by the soldiers.

"We can win this...!"

"Trust in Lady Astina!"

As the battle visibly tipped in their favor, the soldiers' morale soared.

However, victory was not yet assured.

From the forest, a massive being emerged.

Astina gazed at this entity.

'Sooner than I expected.'

A Bone Dragon.

With its huge, bony body, it entered the battlefield.

But Astina's thoughts were not on the Bone Dragon.

It was the figure standing on its head.

It was Aryandor.

Aryandor rode the Bone Dragon towards Astina.

"Is this our first face-to-face encounter?"

"I wish I never had to see the face of someone like you."

Aryandor's lips curled up at Astina's words.

"Those from the academy are all cheeky."

"Well, it's because of who you are. Educated people have a keen eye for worthlessness."

Astina mocked Aryandor.

Her provocation aimed to keep him from heading elsewhere.

If he went towards the fortress instead of her, it would lead to tremendous sacrifice, so it was better to draw his attention to herself.

"You're more talkative than I heard. Or is this a provocation?"

Aryandor saw through Astina's actions.

Provocation was not her strong suit, revealing an awkwardness in her behavior.

However, even reading this, he did not attack elsewhere.

"Don't worry. You are my target."

With that, Aryandor smiled and touched the head of the Bone Dragon.

"But, if my attack misses and others die, it can't be helped."

As Aryandor spoke, the Bone Dragon inhaled.

The act of opening its mouth and inhaling.

A technique known as a dragon's secret skill.

'Breath.'

Astina recognized it instantly.

Though she had never faced a dragon, she possessed common knowledge about them.

'Do I dodge?'

No, she couldn't.

As Aryandor said, a blind attack would strike the soldiers in the fortress.

She had no choice.

"Then I'll block it..."

"Astina Persia."

Keln called out Astina's name.

"Step back."

As Astina turned around, she saw Keln on a giant bird.

"I'll handle this."

Simultaneously, a green-colored breath emerged from the Bone Dragon's mouth.

Each dragon's breath had a different form.

The Bone Dragon's breath was a poison that melted everything.

"Sylpherion."

Keln didn't need to command; Sylpherion acted on its own.

The green breath, covering the battlefield, approached.

To block the breath, Sylpherion wrapped the battlefield in wind.

A huge spherical barrier formed, and the breath enveloped this barrier.

"Sigh..."

However, the attack was not over yet.

Aryandor raised his sword and charged towards the barrier.

It was as if he was slicing through the shield that blocked the breath.

"Anti Gravity."

Astina cast her magic.

Anti-gravity.

Aryandor's body, flying towards the shield, was repelled into the air.

Aryandor, floating in mid-air, curled his lips and raised his left hand, the one not holding the sword.

"Time Back."

He used time magic.

Aryandor's body, previously floating, vanished in an instant.

"Huh?"

He reappeared at the same spot where he had been slicing the shield before.

Time regression.

He had used time magic to change his position.

As Astina was caught off guard, Aryandor adopted a horizontal slashing stance.

"Northern Swordsmanship."

A blue flame, symbolizing the North, enveloped Aryandor's sword.

"Blue Flame."

Aryandor swung his sword horizontally.

The blue flame on his sword flew towards the shield, covering it along with the breath.

"What..."

Keln was shocked to see the sword energy.

The Northern Swordsmanship was a technique passed down through the Lucarion family.

It was impossible for Aryandor to know it.

But the current situation was more pressing.

"The Northern sword energy is blue, but it burns everything, even wind."

As soon as Aryandor spoke, fire began consuming the wind.

The shield was eroded by fire, creating a hole, through which the Bone Dragon's breath leaked.

"I'll block it."

Astina quickly manipulated her mana.

"Anti Gravity Shield."

She created an anti-gravity field near the breached shield.

Before the breath's energy dissipated, she judged it more efficient to push it away.

Astina's magic repelled the breath and blue flames covering the shield into the air.

Aryandor, back on the Bone Dragon, looked at Keln and Astina struggling to block the attacks and laughed.

"Aren't you struggling too much from the start?"

Astina stared at Aryandor.

She knew he was a magic swordsman, but was taken aback to see him using Northern Swordsmanship.

How was he able to use that technique?

Yet, her surprise didn't stop there.

Aryandor raised his sword again.

"Royal Swordsmanship."

This time, a golden wave enveloped his sword.

It was a technique passed down among Royal knights.

The sword energy he wielded was indistinguishable in its finesse.

"What..."

Following the Northern Swordsmanship, now the Royal Swordsmanship.

Ordinary swordsmen learn one swordsmanship and refine it until death.

While it's not unheard of for swordsmen to learn multiple techniques, Aryandor was in a different league.

The techniques he used were not easily learned, and there were few who could teach them.

The Northern Swordsmanship, for instance, was known only to the Lucarion family, the guardians of the North, and the Royal Swordsmanship was a technique passed down to the top knight of the Empire.

Astina was incredulous at Aryandor's ease with such swordsmanship.

'This isn't the time to worry about that.'

She shook her head and moved her mana again.

She had to block the attack.

The problem was that she didn't know which technique he would use next.

Even with a single swordsmanship style, there are multiple techniques.

But with multiple swordsmanship styles in play, devising a counter-strategy was impossible.

Seeing Astina's confusion, Keln quickly spoke.

"Block it as before. Think of the next move."

They didn't know whether the enemy would target their rear or themselves.

The only option was to block the whole area.

Astina looked down.

The soldiers were beginning to falter as Keln and Astina were distracted.

If they lost focus, victory was far from reach, let alone holding their ground.

But...

"I understand."

She couldn't come up with a counter-strategy.

At the academy, besides Locke and Yeniel, she had never faced anyone with outstanding swordsmanship.

She had no choice but to rely on Keln, who was more experienced.

"Sylpherion."

As Keln was about to create another shield,

Aryandor attempted to strike down with his sword.

"Imperi..."

However, his sword did not descend.

Aryandor, holding his sword, suddenly stopped mid-strike and shifted his gaze.

He then scoffed.

"They're coming too quickly."

With that, Aryandor kicked off the Bone Dragon and leaped into the air.

"Huh?"

Astina's eyes widened at Aryandor's sudden action.

Then, a voice reached her ears.

"Bite."

Along with the voice, a tremendous wind swept by her side.

A massive dragon covered in red scales.

This dragon swept past Astina and lunged at the Bone Dragon.

"...?"

The suddenly appearing Red Dragon bit the neck of the Bone Dragon and forced it to the ground.

Thud!!!!

Though smaller in size than the Bone Dragon, the Red Dragon's velocity enabled it to pin its opponent to the ground.

"Dragons...?"

Dragons were creatures hostile to humans.

While the Bone Dragon, being a product of necromancy, obeyed human commands, other dragons did not.

Dragons, who would typically scoff at humans fighting each other, had joined the fray.

While Astina's thoughts were racing,

"Gravity."

A voice came from the sky.

It was Cromwell, the mentor who had taught her psychokinesis.

Chapter 229: Spatial Magic (8)

“Gravity.”

Cromwell used his magic as soon as he appeared.

His target was Aryandor.

As Aryandor leaped off the bone dragon and landed on the ground, the earth beneath his feet collapsed.

However, Aryandor didn't just succumb to the attack.

He began dodging Cromwell's strikes with dazzling movements.

He kicked off the upheaving earth to leap into the air, slicing through the incoming boulders with his sword.

Without using time magic, he evaded the attacks solely with his physical prowess.

“You old man, I thought you'd be panting by now, but you're brimming with energy.”

At Aryandor's taunt, Cromwell laughed.

“Even if I lose all my hair, I can still handle someone like you.”

Though he said so, the reason Cromwell could freely use magic was simple.

He had arrived here riding a dragon, which made this possible.

Had he flown here using magic, he wouldn't have been able to utilize his power effectively.

“But, I don’t intend to fight you. I have a different opponent in mind.”

Aryandor said this, looking up at Astina hovering in the air.

“So, I’ll find you another opponent.”

Suddenly, a giant fist flew towards Cromwell.

“Barrier.”

Despite the sudden appearance of the fist, Cromwell easily deflected it with his magic.

“Hmm?”

Cromwell looked in the direction from which the fist had come.

There stood a man with a drowsy expression, the giant hand behind him having aimed at Cromwell.

“A necromancer, huh.”

A familiar face.

It was Daemon, a user of necromancy.

“Gravity.”

Recognizing his opponent, Cromwell immediately cast his magic.

The ground around them shifted, enveloping his adversary.

‘...He doesn’t dodge?’

Daemon stood still as the earth swallowed him, and Cromwell looked on in disbelief.

However, Cromwell didn't let his guard down.

It seemed unlikely that a leader of the rebels would be defeated so easily.

As Cromwell anticipated, more fists flew towards him.

But this time, there were several.

Several fists, each as big as a giant's, targeted Cromwell.

“Gravity Shield.”

Cromwell quickly cast a spell, shielding himself from all directions.

The fists were blocked by the barrier and couldn't reach Cromwell.

What was strange was that the barrier didn't seem to take much damage.

‘...An illusion?’

Visible to the eye, but lacking substance.

This sensation was that of an illusion.

And if it was this type of illusion...

‘Jefrin.’

It was similar to the illusion magic used by Jefrin.

He made the opponent aware from the beginning that they were facing an illusion.

Illusion magic shines brightest when the opponent is unaware it's an illusion, but Jefrin's approach was different.

She intertwined multiple illusions to blur the line between illusion and reality.

By making the opponent aware of the illusion, she induced a more defensive stance in them.

However, Jefrin was dead.

Now, despite Jefrin's absence, her influence was still perceptible.

"Who is using this magic?"

It was implausible to think that Daemon was the one using it.

A wizard who had honed necromancy to the extent of enveloping a fortress couldn't be expected to also know Jefrin-style illusion magic.

Moreover, using both illusion and necromancy simultaneously would consume a significant amount of mana, making it unsustainable for long.

Even if he knew how to use it, it would be like a path to self-destruction.

“Ahaha~.”

Then, Cromwell heard laughter.

It was the echo of a girl's laughter, sounding like Jefrin's voice.

And then, appearing before Cromwell, was the figure of a girl.

She was wearing a pointy hat fit for a witch - it was Jefrin.

However, she was not in her usual state.

Her face was ravaged, her clothes torn, looking almost as if she was on the brink of death.

There were clear marks of a noose around her neck.

“Necromancy, huh.”

The undead created by necromancy have abilities dependent on the corpse used.

If a skilled swordsman is turned into an undead, they can utilize the techniques they used in life, and the same goes for wizards.

An undead created from the corpse of a wizard can use the magic that the wizard used while alive.

"Those Royal fools. If they knew there was a necromancer, they should have taken better care of the bodies."

Cromwell clicked his tongue, quickly assessing the situation.

Even if Jefrin's body was revived with necromancy, it couldn't possibly utilize all her original abilities.

He had to exploit this weakness.

'Finish this quickly... and protect my disciple.'

As long as Daemon was targeting him, Cromwell couldn't ignore it and just pass by.

He glanced at Astina, who was confronting Aryandor.

'Just hold on a little longer.'

Then, he began to manipulate his mana.

"Gravity."

"It seems there's no one left to protect you now."

Cromwell was dealing with Daemon, and the dragons and Sylphion were holding off the bone dragon.

Aryandor and Astina faced each other head-on, without anyone else's interference.

“Now, I will kill you. Tear your body to shreds and sprinkle your blood over Jefrin’s grave. So that Jefrin can rest in peace.”

Astina sneered at Aryandor's words.

“Raise a body and then let them rest in peace?”

Far off, Cromwell was seen confronting Jefrin.

Having witnessed Jefrin's death up close, Astina immediately realized that it was Jefrin resurrected by necromancy.

The idea that those who raise the dead would fulfill their vengeance was absurd to her.

“That's nothing but a corpse. Jefrin would also want her body to be used efficiently.”

Astina stared intently at Aryandor.

“Such a contradictory bunch.”

Crying for peace while waging war.

Raising the dead, yet wishing for the deceased to rest in peace.

It was all a chaotic mess.

“I guess I need to correct that way of thinking.”

Aryandor burst into laughter.

"Presumptuous, aren't you?"

Aryandor immediately drew his sword.

"You can never win against me."

Astina's lips curled up in response to Aryandor's words.

In a normal situation, Aryandor might have been right, but Astina had her own strategy.

She manipulated her mana, which was immensely powerful.

Yet, nothing happened.

Seeing this, Aryandor tilted his head in confusion.

"Got some tricks up your sleeve, I see."

He chuckled softly, gathering sword energy.

"No matter your strategy, you can't win. The power difference between us is overwhelming."

"Don't you think overcoming that power difference is what strategy is all about?"

Aryandor didn't react to Astina's sarcasm and continued to gather sword energy.

Golden sword energy swirled around his blade, rippling like waves.

The golden energy he had displayed earlier was not an illusion.

It was the golden sword energy used in Royal swordsmanship, clearly visible now.

But that didn't change what she had to do.

"Royal swordsmanship."

'Here it comes.'

Astina moved her mana.

"Golden Sword, Dragon Star Fall."

The golden wave converged on his sword at once.

The ordinary silver-colored blade turned golden.

Simultaneously, Aryandor raised his sword high.

And then he struck down.

The gathered golden light radiated in the direction of his strike.

It resembled a giant golden light falling to the ground.

A wave of golden light spread around them.

‘He’s targeting only me.’

The attack fell towards the ground where Astina stood.

If it only targeted Astina, who was on the battlefield, it wouldn’t affect the soldiers on the fortress.

Astina quickly soared upwards.

By flying up, she could avoid the falling sword energy.

As Astina rose, the golden wave enveloped the ground.

‘This isn’t the end.’

Aryandor was no longer visible as the ground filled with the golden wave.

A bright light from below obscured her vision.

‘Focus on the sound.’

In such a situation, she couldn’t rely on her sight.

Bang!

“Hmph...”

Astina heard the sound of a leap and immediately activated her telekinesis.

Aryandor, wrapped in sword energy, leaped from the ground.

“Invisible Hand.”

Astina used her telekinesis to grab Aryandor's sword.

“Is it enough just to grab the sword?”

Aryandor let go of his sword.

If he held onto it, he could be captured too, so he released it.

Without his sword, Aryandor maintained the momentum towards Astina, clenching his fist.

His fist precisely aimed at Astina's abdomen.

“A swordsman letting go of his sword?”

Astina laughed, seeing Aryandor targeting her.

Stones quickly sprang from the ground, three times the size of his fist.

She used telekinesis to launch the stones from the ground.

The stone was faster than Aryandor's approach towards her.

Thwack!

“Ugh!”

The stone struck Aryandor, and he was thrown sideways by the impact.

Astina, flying with magic, was unscathed as Aryandor's punch fell to the ground.

But then...

“Time... Back.”

Aryandor used time magic.

His body returned to the same place it was before the stone hit him.

He leaped towards Astina, who was still in the air.

The situation was the same as before.

“How arrogant.”

Wham! Aryandor's fist hit Astina's abdomen.

“Ugh!”

Astina let out a pained sound.

Her concentration broken, the magic keeping her airborne was dispelled, and she began to plummet towards the ground.

“Gravity...”

Just before hitting the ground, Astina used her magic to lessen the impact.

However, the battle was far from over.

Aryandor, once again, soared towards the falling Astina.

“Time Back.”

He used time magic again.

This time, he altered the position of the sword that Astina had previously seized with her telekinesis.

The sword reappeared in Aryandor's now empty hand.

He directed the sword downwards, falling towards Astina.

“Anti... Gravity!”

She tried to reverse gravity, attempting to send Aryandor flying upwards.

“Time Back.”

Aryandor used time magic once more.

Suddenly, Aryandor's body wasn't where it should have been in the air.

Astina quickly turned around.

‘The ground.’

The exact spot where they had confronted each other earlier.

Time magic was almost omnipotent, but it had its drawbacks.

Even if you rewind time, you only return to the location or action where you were in the past.

So, when Aryandor used time magic, Astina could somewhat predict his actions.

“Trying to unravel time magic, are you?”

As Astina turned around, she saw Aryandor.

However, the problem was his appearance.

The golden wave of energy was gathered on his sword.

The same sword energy he had used just moments ago.

“But even if you figure it out, you can't beat me.”

He didn't just change his position with time magic; he rewound time to before he used his last move.

While Astina's state and her surroundings remained unchanged, his position and sword energy were reset.

“Golden Sword, Dragon Star Fall.”

Aryandor swung his sword, sending the gathered energy towards Astina.

“Gravity...”

Astina tried to use her magic, but the sword energy was faster.

The massive golden wave engulfed her.

Crash!!

“Ugh...!!!!”

The wave, like hundreds of swords, grazed her body.

Astina, just before sustaining serious injuries, concentrated and activated her magic.

“Barrier...!!!!”

A protective magic enveloped her like a sphere.

Though it was a weak barrier and couldn't block all the attacks, it diverted the sword energy enough to minimize harm to her body.

The golden wave that had scraped Astina soon dissipated.

Thud!

Astina fell to the ground from mid-air.

Her body bore dozens of wounds.

Fortunately, none were serious.

Astina wiped the blood flowing from her wounds and picked herself up from the ground.

She tried to rise to her feet.

Aryandor watched her struggle and smirked.

"This is the result of deliberately inducing time magic."

From the beginning, Astina had intended to draw out Aryandor's time magic.

When Aryandor first used Royal swordsmanship, Astina had taken to the air.

Normally, she would have tried to escape from the golden wave that covered the ground.

But Astina didn't make that move.

Instead, she chose to counter Aryandor's attack.

"Thinking you could unravel time magic when you couldn't even decipher my swordsmanship?"

Aryandor was several steps ahead of Astina.

He had already read her thoughts.

Yet, he played along with what Astina wanted.

He judged that he could win even then.

"Neither McDowell nor Cromwell could unravel time magic. Do you really think you can?"

McDowell, Cromwell.

Both had faced Aryandor.

McDowell lost an arm, and Cromwell, who fought with the information gleaned from that encounter, achieved no significant success.

“Did you grow overconfident hearing praise at the academy? Thinking you can defeat me?”

“Haah... Haah...”

Astina, exhausted, forced herself to stand.

“Let that arrogance be your downfall.”

Aryandor, holding his sword, took steps towards her.

Astina, watching him approach, gasped for breath and spoke.

“You know...?”

“What?”

“That there’s something to learn even from someone weaker than you...”

“Nonsense in the face of death.”

Aryandor ignored Astina’s words and stepped forward.

Then, mana stirred from Astina.

“Ugh?”

Aryandor, moving slowly, suddenly felt immense pressure.

He couldn't move forward.

His body was forcefully pressed down.

“What is this...”

A focused gravity field.

It was a spell Astina had prepared earlier.

This magic wasn't solely her own creation.

In her second year, Luna had used a magical tool in a personal evaluation.

It was a spell that focused gravity on a point, pressing down a scarecrow.

Inspired by that spell, Astina had developed her own.

“And... just because I’m weaker than the professors doesn’t mean I can’t beat you.”

Astina’s lips curled into a smirk.

“I’m not alone.”

Aryandor sensed killing intent at those words and moved his mana.

“Time...!”

“Too late.”

Just then, a voice sounded from behind Aryandor.

He turned to see the face.

“Rudy... Ast...”

Crack!

Before Aryandor could finish speaking.

The fist pierced through Aryandor's chest.

He looked at the person who had thrown the punch.

It was someone who shouldn't have been there.

A man with the distinctive golden hair of the Astria family.

It was Rudy Astria.

Chapter 230: Spatial Magic (9)

"Aryandor...!"

When Rudy appeared, it was the moment he saw Aryandor being captured.

The flow of the fight, the condition of the opponent, the opponent himself.

He knew nothing about the situation.

Yet, Rudy reacted.

Astina lay in front of him, smiling as she fell.

And there was Aryandor's back in view.

Rudy threw a punch.

Aryandor's body was pierced through.

Just as one would pierce a piece of paper with a finger, Aryandor's body was pierced.

Aryandor fell to the ground.

"Ha... You came too late, didn't you?"

Astina said with a smile.

Though she said that, there was no specific promise between Rudy and her.

The only promise was that Rudy would come to save Astina.

Yet, Astina had set a trap.

She captured Aryandor and planned to harm him.

"I just need to set the trap."

Astina staged a situation where she appeared in danger.

She pretended to unravel time magic.

Aryandor was lulled into complacency, failing to grasp her intentions.

Aryandor might have understood Astina's intention, but not my trust.

Blind trust in a situation without promises or plans.

Even if Aryandor had realized this, he would have scoffed.

In a way, it was a foolish trust.

Yet, Astina believed.

It was okay even if there was no direct promise with Rudy.

Because he said he would come himself.

Because he said he would come to help in the most dangerous situation.

Astina, who had overcome everything alone until she met Rudy at the academy, changed.

Rudy was less capable than her, but she learned many things from him.

She learned to cooperate, realizing there were problems she couldn't solve alone.

By dividing tasks with her colleagues, she learned trust.

And so, Astina was no longer alone.

"I waited. Rudy."

Astina smiled foolishly.

"No, senior. Why are you in such a state..."

Rudy, not fully grasping the situation, rushed to Astina.

"Didn't I capture him well?"

"That's not the problem... What if I had been late?"

"I know Rudy Astria keeps his word. He said he would come to rescue in danger, so I planned accordingly."

Astina calculated every variable and situation in her plans.

One might say this plan wasn't calculative, but Astina had meticulously planned even this situation.

While trust can't be quantified, in Astina's calculations, the probability of Rudy coming was 100 percent, making it a perfect plan.

"More importantly, how did you get here? The way you appeared seemed like spatial magic. Can you use spatial magic now?"

"That... The magic I used wasn't mine. I borrowed some power to use it... But that's not important right now..."

Rudy was overwhelmed, worrying about Astina and checking on Aryandor.

"Yes, let's check on him first."

"Can you move?"

Astina's body was covered with numerous wounds.

There were no fatal wounds, but the sheer number was too many.

Astina responded with a smile instead of an answer.

"Yes, let's go for now..."

Rudy supported Astina and approached the fallen Aryandor.

Aryandor lay there with a pierced chest.

The ground was soaked with Aryandor's blood, like a flood had occurred.

With so much blood lost, he would die even if the chest wound healed.

Rudy leaned down and touched Aryandor.

"He seems to be still alive."

His breath was faintly present.

However, it seemed he would die if just a little more time passed.

"Then, I will finish this."

Astina reached out her hand.

"Are you going to kill him?"

"We have to. Who knows what might happen if we try to take him to the capital alive."

Hearing Astina's words, Rudy stepped forward.

"Then, I will do it. You're low on mana, aren't you?"

Astina shook her head.

"No, I started this fight, so I will finish it."

Astina was the one who provoked the rebels and brought them here.

Therefore, she wanted to end this war herself.

Rudy felt uncomfortable leaving the task to Astina, but he couldn't bring himself to intervene seeing her expression.

"Then, please proceed."

Astina nodded and moved her mana.

"Gravity."

Crack—

Just as Astina was about to use her magic to crush Aryandor's head, his body shone brightly.

"Huh?"

"What is this..."

Astina and Rudy looked at his body in disbelief.

Dozens of tattoos engraved on his body.

Tattoos that they couldn't see with the naked eye were now visible.

"...Magic circles?"

They were indeed magic circles.

Magic circles in the form of tattoos.

Rudy immediately shouted as he recognized their form.

"Astina!!!"

"The attack..."

Astina was using her magic, but it didn't affect Aryandor.

A protective shield from Aryandor's magic circles was guarding him.

Rudy grasped the situation and surrounded his fist with mana.

Light emanated from Rudy's glove, and he swung his fist at Aryandor.

His fist broke through Aryandor's shield and approached his body.

Boom!

Rudy struck down at the corpse, and simultaneously, a strong light engulfed both Astina and him.

"Ugh..."

"What..."

Rudy and Astina shielded their eyes from the intense light.

"Huh?"

That's when Rudy sensed something strange.

A feeling of the space twisting.

This strangeness wasn't just a feeling.

"Ah..."

As the intense light faded, they looked where Aryandor had been.

Aryandor's body had vanished like a ghost.

And then...

"Indeed, dying doesn't feel good."

From behind Astina and Rudy, a man approached, touching his chest where he had been wounded.

It was Aryandor.

"How did Rudy Astria get here? I heard he was definitely in the capital."

The wound in his chest had disappeared, and his clothes were unscathed.

Astina and Rudy looked at him with a sense of futility.

Aryandor looked at them and laughed.

"Why do you look like that? As if you've seen a dead man."

It was certainly Aryandor, who had nearly died.

Could he really return to his original state even in such a situation?

"Still, I'll give you credit. McDowell fought all day and only managed to kill me twice, but you've already killed me once. Perhaps you're even better than McDowell."

Aryandor was using his body as if it were a magical tool.

Despite being unconscious, he was able to use magic and defy death.

"Using your body like that will wear it out, won't it?"

"Do you think your body and mine are the same?"

Aryandor's body.

While his time magic and swordsmanship were outstanding, the most unique aspect was that he was a magic swordsman.

A magic swordsman could use both the physical abilities of a swordsman and the mana manipulation of a wizard.

It seemed this trait allowed him to perform such impossible feats.

"Besides, last time you conspired with the saint. Or was it from the very beginning? Another being from a different dimension."

Aryandor said this, looking at Astina beside him.

Astina showed no disturbance at Aryandor's words.

"So you already knew? I thought it would be a shocking revelation, but it's boring."

Aryandor looked at Rudy with a leisurely expression.

"The question is how you got here... Surely, only spatial magic could enable such an appearance. Have you already learned spatial magic?"

Rudy's method of arriving here.

It was indeed spatial magic.

But Rudy couldn't use spatial magic at the moment.

He had only succeeded in perceiving space and hadn't tried anything beyond that.

If he were to use spatial magic, this battlefield would be his first time.

'I can't use the magical tool again...'

How Rudy got here.

It was thanks to a spatial magic tool from the Astria family.

He had 'stolen' that tool, unobtainable even with astronomical sums of money, from the Astria family's vault.

No one present could know this fact.

Who would think that he had stolen a magical tool from the Astria family?

'It's best to stay quiet for now.'

Rudy let Aryandor continue to misunderstand.

If Aryandor thought he could use spatial magic, he would be more cautious.

Just as time magic showed transcendent abilities, spatial magic had similar levels of capability.

The question was whether they could win even with such tactics.

The fact that the opponent could resurrect even after being killed was a tremendous pressure.

'But I did sense something.'

Rudy recalled the distortion in space he felt when magic was activated in Aryandor's body.

He had experienced this distortion once before.

Back when he was in his future body, Aryandor used magic, and Rudy had felt a similar twist then.

The relationship between space and time.

It felt like he had grasped a clue to this mystery.

Now, there was only one thing left to do.

"Rudy Astria, you are truly entertaining..."

Just as Aryandor was about to speak, Rudy brushed back his hair.

"Why so talkative?"

"...Talkative?"

Aryandor's expression hardened at Rudy's words.

"Always babbling. How can a man talk so much?"

Rudy said this as he manipulated his mana.

"Stop with the words and come at me, kid. If you're scared, just run away."

"Hmph."

Aryandor looked at Rudy with a cold gaze.

"So you don't want to prolong your living moments even a little bit."

He reached out, picking up a sword that had fallen to the ground.

"I'll kill you."

"Yes, that's more like it."

Rudy smiled.

Then, as if on cue, they both charged towards each other.

Chapter 231: Spatial Magic (10)

At that moment, at the Academy.

"He's not coming."

McDowell stood high up, watching the rebels in front of him.

They seemed ready to attack at any moment, but they were not making a direct move yet.

"Is this a diversion...?"

Still, he couldn't afford to underestimate them.

The moment he lowered his guard, the rebels might launch a full-scale attack, potentially causing significant damage.

Therefore, he had to be ready for battle at all times.

After all, even the rebels couldn't keep their soldiers moving indefinitely.

Being human, they too would tire.

They couldn't keep up the appearance of imminent attack for long.

So, until then, he had to maintain vigilance.

The problem was...

He had no information about the situation in the Persia territory.

He had expected some form of communication, but nothing had come through.

Whether they were too busy fighting or the rebels were blocking the information...

Regardless of the situation, it was clear it wasn't good.

If victory had been certain, they would have already informed him.

"But it's not like we can offer help in our current situation."

For ordinary soldiers to reach the Persia territory, even on horseback, would take 4 to 5 hours.

A knight with enhanced physical abilities could get there faster, but they wouldn't be fit for battle upon arrival.

Thus, the only one who could quickly move to the Persia territory and continue the fight was Ian Astria, a user of spatial magic.

However, his duty was as the commander of the Royal army.

The commander couldn't leave his post, especially where the main enemy forces were concentrated.

Therefore, McDowell had to think of another strategy.

A way to help without going to Persia.

McDowell pondered this while intently watching the rebels.

Then, a thought struck him.

"Is anyone there?"

"Yes, Principal."

At McDowell's call, a soldier bowed his head.

"Go down and call the commander of the Royal army, Robert, and McGuire. Tell them I've asked for them; they will come."

Space and time.

In some ways, these were entirely different realms, yet in others, they were deeply connected.

Just a while ago, he had physically felt it.

When Aryandor used time magic, some change occurred in the spatial realm.

It was a dire situation, so he hadn't seen it clearly, but he understood that space and time were somehow interconnected.

Now, the problem was what to do next.

How to counter his time magic.

No.

First, it was his swordsmanship that was the problem.

"Royal swordsmanship..."

"Khuh..."

I twisted my body, dodging Aryandor's sword energy, and retreated a good distance.

From Northern swordsmanship to Royal swordsmanship.

And other techniques from prestigious families and various useful skills mercenaries employed.

Judging by his appearance, Aryandor seemed to be in his early thirties.

Ian's skills were no different from Aryandor's.

For someone his age, the sheer amount of techniques he used was unbelievable.

Of course, the problem was not only the variety of techniques, but also his use of time magic.

I was dumbfounded.

Even those called geniuses only learn one of the techniques Aryandor used.

Although their proficiency might be superior, Aryandor could use those techniques to a similar extent.

Being able to use a variety of techniques to such a degree of completion was inconceivable.

Especially if done alone.

I wasn't sure how far he could take the application of time magic, but as far as I knew, it only allowed for a slight reversal of time or foreseeing the future.

It was implausible to think he learned all those techniques just by seeing into the future.

If it were that easy, everyone would simply watch and mimic others' swordsmanship.

There is a law to secret techniques.

They involve certain methods passed down through generations, learned based on those methods.

So, Aryandor must have known that method to have reached such a level.

This raised a question.

Who helped Aryandor?

Someone who knew all those sword techniques.

Someone who could help him learn them quickly.

Someone with an incredible skill like time magic.

Whether it was the same person or different people, I couldn't tell.

I was just listing the necessary elements.

But, knowing this now was pointless.

Survival was the priority.

"Priscilla."

With her silver fur fluttering, Priscilla appeared.

As soon as she appeared, Priscilla grumbled at me.

"The stench of decay is overwhelming."

She seemed to be referring to the beings resurrected through necromancy.

Being an elemental in the form of a wolf, Priscilla had a sensitive sense of smell.

"For now, there's no time to grumble."

I spoke to Priscilla and then looked back at Aryandor.

At that moment, Aryandor's expression hardened.

"...An ice elemental?"

He seemed shocked.

As if he saw something he shouldn't have.

Priscilla and Aryandor?

They seemed unrelated.

I looked at Priscilla.

"Hey, do you know him?"

"...I've never seen him before."

Priscilla hadn't appeared when the rebels attacked.

Because I was in my future body, there was no chance for the current Priscilla to appear.

So, it was natural for Aryandor and her not to know each other...

That's when a thought flashed through my mind.

The connection between Priscilla in the future and Astina's death.

I clearly remember hearing that Priscilla made a mistake when Astina died in the future.

I turned to look at Priscilla.

"...What's wrong?"

If Astina died because of Priscilla's mistake, then not making that mistake meant Astina could be saved.

I didn't know what that mistake was, but it implied there was a possibility.

"Hey, Priscilla."

I lightly tapped Priscilla's paw.

"I trust you."

"What are you talking about?"

After saying that, I turned my gaze back to Aryandor.

Aryandor looked flustered upon seeing Priscilla.

I immediately charged at him.

"Kuk..."

Aryandor stumbled backward as I approached rapidly.

I seized the opportunity.

Mana surged into my fist.

Boom!!!!!!

"Kuk!"

My mana-infused punch hit Aryandor, who tried to block it with his sword.

But he faltered.

Although he managed to block my punch with his sword, his body was still within the blast radius of the mana explosion.

Aryandor sustained minor injuries and retreated.

"Gravity."

Astina continued the attack.

Despite being injured, Astina could still use magic from behind.

Stones around Aryandor levitated under Astina's spell, aiming at him.

Priscilla joined in.

Ice formed around them.

Rocks and ice shards flew towards Aryandor.

"Northern swordsmanship."

Aryandor, enveloped in blue sword energy, sliced through the incoming projectiles.

However, Aryandor was already shaken.

There is a flow to every attack.

Aryandor, once unsettled, could only block some of the attacks.

Most of them grazed past his body.

Small cuts appeared on Aryandor's body.

I aimed to continue this momentum.

"Hellfire."

Dark magic.

Black flames gathered around Aryandor.

Now, Aryandor had one thing to do.

Reverse the situation with time magic.

But my prediction was off.

"...Ha!"

Aryandor, surrounded by sword energy, looked at me and laughed.

Before the dark magic could activate, he swung his sword broadly.

His sword traced a large arc above his head.

Following its trajectory, a blue sword energy appeared.

"Blue Half Moon."

Blue sword energy erupted around Aryandor.

The blue energy swallowed the black flames I had created.

It not only consumed the flames but also incinerated everything else flying towards him.

Aryandor walked out from within the blue flames, wiping the blood on his face with his sleeve, looking at me with cold eyes.

"Where did that elemental come from?"

I responded to his question with another question.

"Where did you learn those sword techniques?"

Upon my question, Aryandor remained silent.

Seeing Aryandor's attitude, I smirked slightly.

His demeanor gave me some certainty.

Priscilla is the key.

She has some connection with Aryandor.

And then there's the time magic.

Aryandor clearly had the opportunity to use time magic but chose a different way out.

He left his wounds as they were.

Not using time magic to that extent ignited a determination in me.

I'll make him use time magic.

It wasn't an easy task, but that was okay.

I walked towards Aryandor.

Aryandor was strong.

A magic swordsman who used various sword techniques and even time magic.

In the past, I would have resorted to tricks.

Either relying on someone's help or planning a strategy in advance.

But now, I was different from before.

I had grown a lot.

I had faced death threats and fought many stronger opponents.

I had studied magic extensively and acquired various abilities.

I even created magical tools specifically for myself.

I had almost completed all the preparations I could.

So, I said, "I'll make you use your time magic at least once."

I looked at Aryandor and smirked.

I gathered as much mana as possible into my fist.

There were no traps or strategies.

Without any gimmicks.

Just pure strength.

Mana gathered, and a blue aura formed around my fist.

The aura grew larger.

From the size of a fist to the size of a human head, then to the size of a human body, and even larger.

It kept growing.

"Try taking this."

The blue mana that had gathered in my fist.

A pure concentration of mana.

No other applications were involved.

Still, I was confident.

The mana vibrated loudly, resonating around me.

Looking at the mana, I smiled and said, "If you can't take it, use your time magic."

I then thrust my mana-filled fist forward.

Boom!!!!!!!!!!

"Huh..."

Aryandor looked at the scene incredulously.

Pure mana was tearing everything around it apart.

Aryandor raised his sword to block the attack, but then lowered it.

And just as the mana was about to reach Aryandor.

"...Time... Back."

Aryandor used his time magic.

Chapter 232: Spatial Magic (11)

I recognized reality.

The phenomena and beings before me, even the flow of the air, I took it all in.

I confirmed everything.

Then, I looked deeper.

The flow of mana and phenomena invisible to the naked eye.

I felt them not with my eyes, but with my entire body.

I began to sense the entire space around me.

From the slightest movement of mana to the movement of a single ant.

I became aware of the entire space.

And then, I divided the space within that image.

Space into planes, planes into lines, lines into points.

As if marking coordinates in the space I occupied, I divided the entire space.

In this way, I saw the most basic framework of the world's space.

The basis of spatial magic is spatial perception.

This is how I perceived space, looking intently at Aryandor.

"Time Back."

Boom...!

At that moment, space twisted.

Like space bending, all the coordinates twisted.

There was also a loud resonance.

Feeling that resonance, I stared intently at Aryandor.

"...Gone?"

Aryandor's form had simply vanished.

Not that he moved quickly or underwent any other change.

His form just disappeared.

As I was startled by this, a voice came from beside me.

"Rudy Astria, what is this..."

The voice belonged to Priscilla.

"What kind of feeling is this? Exactly..."

Sensory sharing.

Priscilla and I shared senses, so she too could see the space I was observing.

I hadn't even considered that aspect.

But theoretically, there was no reason it couldn't happen.

Priscilla had seen the flow of mana I could perceive, so there was no reason she couldn't perceive the space as well.

"I'll explain later. For now, where is Aryandor..."

"Aryandor is..."

As I tried to find Aryandor, Priscilla pointed behind me.

Aryandor was looking at me with a rotten expression.

"We need to finish this quickly."

He uttered, lifting his sword.

His body appeared perfectly normal.

The time magic had already been used.

Confused, I looked at the coordinates.

Then, the coordinates returned to their original positions.

What in the world had happened?

The space shook, and Aryandor's form disappeared.

Is this spatial magic?

The most incomprehensible part was the disappearance of Aryandor's form.

No matter how one moved, a form can't just disappear.

Even if someone dies or moves extremely fast, their form doesn't vanish from space.

That was something completely against the principles of the world.

Aryandor, sword in hand, rushed towards me.

It felt like he intended to end this quickly, having shown me the time magic.

I stepped back and twisted my body.

Aryandor's swinging sword barely missed the front of my head.

"Rudy!"

Astina tried to use Gravity to press down on Aryandor.

However, Aryandor swiftly escaped from that spot.

The greatest drawback of Gravity.

Quick attacks were difficult to execute directly, limited to moving objects rather than delivering direct hits.

"Annoying ones first."

Aryandor, who had retreated, suddenly dashed toward Astina, kicking off the ground.

"Priscilla."

Just as Aryandor charged, Priscilla stepped in front of Astina.

Despite Priscilla's imposing figure intervening, Aryandor seemed unfazed.

"If you block the way, I'll just cut through both."

Aryandor, his sword wrapped in golden waves, swung it fiercely.

The golden light enveloping the sword engulfed both Astina and Priscilla.

Priscilla, seeing the golden light, pulled Astina into her embrace.

"You'll get hurt if you come out."

Dozens of waves crashed down upon Priscilla.

Although sword strikes hit Priscilla's body, her robust form meant she only sustained minor injuries, avoiding major damage.

As I launched an attack on Priscilla, I immediately kicked off the ground.

"Aryandor...!"

I charged at Aryandor, mana surging in my fist.

Aryandor lightly dodged my punch and counterattacked with his sword.

His blade sliced through my leg.

"Gah..."

Yet, I did not relent, throwing another punch.

My fist, charged with mana, hit Aryandor's abdomen directly.

"Ugh..."

Even though my punch hit Aryandor's abdomen, he only stumbled slightly.

The physique of a magic swordsman.

Having achieved physical enhancement as a swordsman, he could stand even after taking my punch.

Aryandor changed his gaze and looked at me intently.

"Are we really doing this?"

Without retreating, Aryandor swung his sword again.

His blade struck my body, and I threw another punch in return.

A fierce brawl.

Aryandor didn't back down, swinging his sword, as I continued to launch punches.

With minimal movement, I dodged his attacks while striking back.

Abdomen, arm, leg.

In just a moment, dozens of sword wounds appeared.

As I threw punches, I thought to myself.

Aiming for one hit.

The motion of throwing a punch is smaller than swinging a sword.

So, there's a chance to exploit an opening.

Then, Aryandor swung his sword diagonally from the right, using its length to create distance between us.

But I pressed forward.

"Guh..."

As I pushed forward, blood burst from my shoulder, and intense pain surged through me.

An opportunity created amidst injuries.

I couldn't miss it.

I reached out with my right hand towards Aryandor's face, pulling back my left hand.

I gathered mana in my retracted left hand.

Sacrifice flesh to seize the bone.

Aryandor tried to lower his sword to block my punch, but mine was faster.

"Ugh...!"

My fist connected squarely with Aryandor's abdomen.

This time, the sensation was different from when I hit him there before.

The sensation of not only the abdomen but also the ribs breaking was distinctly felt in my hand.

Aryandor was sent flying far away by my punch.

"Haah... Haah..."

I watched Aryandor rolling on the ground, gasping for breath.

The wound on my right shoulder was deep.

Yet, Aryandor's injuries appeared even more severe.

"Cough, hack..."

Aryandor coughed painfully.

I looked at him and smirked.

"So much for the leader of the rebels... I thought you'd be unbelievably strong, but you're weaker than I expected."

When we fought without using magic, just physically, he was an opponent I could handle.

This realization hit me as I took several of his sword strikes.

Aryandor's defense was clumsy.

Focused solely on offense.

He swung his sword, taking hits with his body.

There were many reasons for this.

Having time magic, he might not have developed the habit of defending, thinking he could just reverse any impact.

Or, with the robust body of a magic swordsman, he might have believed he could withstand any hits.

Yet, this worked to my advantage.

Just now, if Aryandor had switched to a defensive stance while swinging his sword, he could have minimized his own damage while only injuring me.

But Aryandor couldn't do that.

Even his attempt at minimal defense was inadequate to stop me.

Aryandor propped himself up with his sword on the ground.

"Haah... Haah..."

He leaned on his sword to stand up.

Aryandor stared intently at me and also glanced at Priscilla.

Then he laughed.

"You, spatial magic... You can't use it, can you?"

Spatial magic?

"Time Back."

As I pondered, Aryandor used his time magic.

The space twisted just like before.

And Aryandor's form vanished.

"I've been thinking a bit about how you got here. Clearly, you used spatial magic back then."

Aryandor's voice echoed from afar.

Then he walked towards us.

Completely recovered.

"But something was off. Even if you were conserving mana to counter my time magic, it was strange."

Aryandor let out a cold laugh.

"Using spatial magic to travel short distances doesn't consume much mana. Plus, you've been using other techniques without worrying about mana efficiency."

He pointed his sword at me.

"I thought you quickly mastered spatial magic after learning it in the future, but it seems not. Even now. If you had mastered spatial magic after seeing my time magic once, you would've blocked it, right?"

I stared at Aryandor.

What exactly is happening?

There's too little information.

What was Aryandor afraid of, and what has he realized now?

"I've been overthinking and acted foolishly. No. I overestimated you. Rudy Astria. You're not the kind of person who can handle seeing time magic just once."

As Aryandor spoke, Astina opened her mouth.

"Rudy, stay calm."

Astina approached me.

"Think about it. If he's talking like that, it means the solution to his time magic is already in your hands."

Aryandor burst into laughter at Astina's words.

"Right. Since I reacted that way, it's only natural. But then, what now? He can't use those weapons in his current state, can he?"

Aryandor raised his hand.

"Time Back."

"Ah..."

Then Aryandor's figure disappeared.

"Rudy! Above!"

Priscilla shouted at that moment.

Above mine and Astina's heads.

There was Aryandor.

He fell towards us, sword pointed downward.

He was targeting Astina.

"Ah..."

"Senior...!"

I pulled Astina towards me.

Then, channeling mana into my hand, I struck at Aryandor's sword.

Clang—

Aryandor's sword energy clashed with my mana, creating a splitting sound.

Aryandor grinned.

"Time Back."

Again, Aryandor's figure vanished.

"Rrrgh!!!"

Priscilla rushed behind me.

This time, Aryandor appeared behind us, ready to swing his sword.

"Anti Gravity...!"

Priscilla blocked Aryandor's sword, and Astina cast her magic.

Astina's magic lifted Aryandor's body, but he shouted once more.

"Time Back."

"Ah..."

He used his time magic several times in quick succession.

This time he appeared far away.

"Why don't you try blocking it even once if you can use spatial magic?"

Aryandor walked towards us with a sneering smile.

I grasped my painful shoulder and furrowed my brow.

What's going on?

The space is warping, and there's a big resonance that ordinary people can't feel.

And then there's Priscilla.

What exactly is Priscilla's role in all this...

"Rudy Astria."

As I pondered, Astina spoke.

"You can do it."

Astina looked at me with firm eyes.

Then she approached me.

"My brain, my calculations say you can do it."

Astina pulled my head towards hers, our foreheads touching.

"It's not because I like you that I show this trust. It's because you can do these things that I like you."

I opened my eyes wide at Astina's words.

It was the first time Astina had said she liked me.

I had suspected it, but such a sudden declaration left me disoriented.

"You can do it, right, Rudy?"

Astina smiled.

Aryandor looked at us with a baffled expression.

"Ha... Then give it a try."

Aryandor raised his hand.

"Time..."

The warping of space.

The shaking space.

And Priscilla.

I looked at Priscilla.

"Priscilla."

"Back."

"Stop him."

Chapter 233: Spatial Magic (12)

Aryandor used time magic and thought to himself, 'Astina, she's the first target.'

He planned to move with time magic and attack Astina.

Astina had always been Aryandor's target, and there was no reason to leave her be as she was boosting Rudy Astria's confidence.

"Time Back."

"Stop that guy."

At that moment, Rudy's voice was heard.

Aryandor sneered.

Having witnessed the time magic but failing to realize its nature immediately, Rudy's success was improbable.

After all, Rudy Astria was an ordinary person.

When he moved time,

Boom—

Aryandor felt something obstructing him.

Despite sensing something odd, he attempted to proceed.

Click—

The view didn't change.

He was still standing in his original position, and the view remained the same.

"Huh?"

Aryandor was certain he had moved time around Astina's vicinity.

But, time hadn't moved.

'He realized it?'

That was impossible.

It was almost a confirmed fact that Rudy couldn't use spatial magic.

If Rudy didn't understand the theory of spatial magic, there was no way he could counter time magic.

To counter spatial magic, one had to use both spatial magic and Prisilla simultaneously.

Combining different techniques required understanding of both.

But how...

"Did it work?"

Rudy looked at Aryandor with a puzzled expression.

Aryandor, who used time magic, was still in the same place.

"Prisilla, what happened?"

"...I, I don't know?"

Neither Prisilla nor Rudy understood the situation.

Although Prisilla had used her powers, she hadn't acted knowingly.

It was possible because of her sensory sharing with Rudy.

Rudy had memories of using spatial magic in the future.

When Rudy lost his senses, Prisilla continued to be connected with him, possessing his sensory aspects.

These unintended events overlapped.

They couldn't be called mere coincidences.

Rudy's close relationship with Prisilla, his experience with the future body, and his start of perceiving space were not entirely his efforts, but wouldn't have happened without them.

Aryandor gritted his teeth.

"Saint..."

However, the glue that bound everything together was indeed the saint showing the future.

'We must end this now.'

But the situation wasn't in Rudy's favor.

He was severely injured in the shoulder, unable to use his right arm, and Astina's condition wasn't good either.

They had to end it now.

Having found a counter to time magic, he couldn't let him escape.

If they met later, he would undoubtedly become their worst enemy.

Aryandor shifted his target from Astina to Rudy.

"He can't be left alone."

"Time Accelerator."

As Aryandor cast the spell, Rudy shouted out.

"Prisilla!"

"No, not twice."

Prisilla exclaimed in panic.

At that moment, Aryandor rapidly approached Rudy.

Time acceleration.

This time, instead of altering time, he merely increased the speed of his own body.

'Now, I can't use time alteration.'

A different application of time magic.

Rudy could only counter time-altering spells like 'Time Back.'

Anything else was beyond his reach.

Therefore, Aryandor had to use only the magic Rudy couldn't counter.

It was important to kill Rudy, but not giving him any hints was equally crucial.

Fully understanding how to counter time magic at this point would make Rudy dangerously powerful.

As Aryandor was about to swing his sword, Astina manipulated mana.

"Gravity Field...!"

With the opponent moving swiftly, she expanded the area affected by her magic.

Gravity exerted across the entire space where Aryandor could move.

Although weak, it was enough to slow Aryandor down.

"Argh...!"

Aryandor, struggling against the gravity, tried to swing his sword at Rudy.

"Ugh..."

However, there was a problem.

Using magic over a wide area also affected Rudy with gravity.

Still, it was fine.

Rudy mainly used his fists, but at his core, he was a wizard.

There was no need to physically counter Aryandor.

"Behemoth...!"

"Bwooosh!"

A baby elephant appeared near Rudy.

Behemoth, the demon controlling iron and earth.

As Aryandor swung his sword, the iron melted away.

Suddenly, Aryandor's sword disappeared, leaving him swinging at the air.

"Prisilla."

Followed by Prisilla's attack.

Ice formed around Aryandor, attempting to capture him.

Yet, Aryandor continued to charge at Rudy.

Rudy, clutching his wounded shoulder, leaped backward.

'The enemy has no sword... But...'

Rudy recalled something he had learned at the academy.

A true swordsman can swing a sword even without one.

Aryandor, despite his legs being caught by gravity and ice, shook them off and walked forward.

"I will kill you."

Red light glowed in his eyes, and light wrapped around his hand.

A red sword aura.

The aura gathered, forming the shape of a sword.

"Damn..."

Rudy felt pain in his shoulder and clenched his fist.

He had to strike Aryandor, even while he was caught.

Rudy pretended to retreat, then stepped forward.

"Inhale..."

As he gathered strength in his fist to strike.

Clang!

A sword plunged down between Aryandor and Rudy.

A black greatsword with eyes on its hilt caught the attention of both Rudy and Aryandor.

"What..."

"...Daemon?"

Aryandor uttered these words as he turned around.

There stood Daemon, with a sullen expression.

The sword that had blocked Aryandor and Rudy floated back to Daemon.

"Commander, you must return."

"What?"

"Our base... it's under attack."

The rebel's main base.

The soldiers in front of the academy were being assaulted.

Aryandor's eyes widened at the news that the soldiers, who were only supposed to feign an attack, were actually being attacked.

"What are you talking about?"

"The academy has launched a counterattack. You must go there quickly."

Thud!

As Daemon spoke, Cromwell approached from behind, carrying the body of Jefrin.

"Who said you could leave?"

Daemon ignored Cromwell and looked at Aryandor.

"If you give the order..."

However, Aryandor responded differently.

"It can't be."

Holding the red sword aura in his hand, he looked at Rudy.

"I must eliminate him."

"Commander...!"

Crack.

"Our rebel soldiers are..."

"Gravity."

Cromwell cast a spell on them both.

"Argh..."

"Inhale..."

Both strained under the intense pressure.

"Who said I'd let you go?"

Daemon glared at Cromwell.

Then, a strong wind sound came from above.

"Groooar—!!!"

A massive figure flew in with a bizarre noise.

Bone Dragon charged at Cromwell.

"Anti-Gravity."

Cromwell used reverse gravity to deflect Bone Dragon's trajectory.

Bone Dragon narrowly missed, but its attack released Aryandor and Daemon from the gravity spell.

Daemon then gestured towards Cromwell.

"Groooar!!!!"

"Screeech!!!!"

Undead attacking the castle changed direction and started assaulting Cromwell.

"Ugh..."

Cromwell frowned as a Lich cast a spell and a giant Golem attacked.

Then, a voice echoed from afar.

"Professor, move away."

From that direction, dozens of trees grew rapidly, and a green light gathered around a man.

He then released the light.

A technique deadly to the symbol of death, the undead.

A powerful life magic, manipulating vast life forces.

There stood a wizard skilled in ecology magic.

Evan.

Evan imbued his sword with the essence of life, sweeping away the surrounding undead.

Simultaneously, a huge dragon spread its wings behind him.

"Khuuup..."

Inhaling deeply and then releasing a breath.

It was the Red Dragon's breath.

Flames swept around, consuming everything in their path.

Seeing the situation, Daemon became anxious.

"Commander... you must go."

"No, I can't. If we leave like this..."

"Our people are dying...! And with this situation here. This is our only chance..."

They were running out of opportunities to escape.

Cromwell's abilities, coupled with the presence of the Head Elementalist in the distance, complicated the situation.

Additionally, there was the Red Dragon and Evan.

The circumstances on the battlefield were not favorable.

Aryandor clenched his fist.

He wanted to tell Daemon that the death of such people was insignificant.

After all, the end of the rebels and Aryandor himself was imminent the moment time magic was unraveled.

The empire, unaware of time magic, allowed the rebels to hold out.

A reckless attack could lead to being swept away by time magic.

Therefore, killing Rudy here was imperative.

It was far more valuable than the deaths of those other individuals.

However, Aryandor couldn't voice this now.

He had already established his public objective as protecting the people and promoting equality.

Even if his actions contradicted this outside, he couldn't afford internal discord.

At the very least, the leaders had to be unconditionally on his side.

"...Alright, I'll return."

Rudy, hearing this response, smiled.

Aryandor looked at Rudy with eyes filled with rage.

In the next fight, Rudy would undoubtedly have the upper hand.

This realization, coupled with the fact that he had to leave now, fueled his anger immensely.

"Then I shall leave."

"I said you aren't going..."

Cromwell, unaware of the fight between Rudy and Aryandor, attempted to stop them.

But then.

A gigantic mouth emerged beneath their feet.

It resembled a fish snapping up food floating on the water's surface.

Suddenly, a mouth from the ground engulfed both Aryandor and Daemon.

The monster swallowed them and quickly retreated underground.

"What..."

Everyone present widened their eyes at the abrupt occurrence.

The two had vanished underground.

Cromwell immediately tried to track them using mana.

However, there were too many mana movements.

It felt like monsters were released beforehand to distract attention.

Moreover, the undead on the surface began moving erratically.

Some started attacking fiercely, while others fled into the distance.

"Curses..."

Cromwell looked around.

Rudy and Astina were almost in no condition to fight.

He had to protect them for now.

As Cromwell frowned at the situation,

Rudy, still on the ground, grinned.

"See you later, you bastard."

Chapter 234: Past and Future (1)

Aryandor quickly returned to the rebel base and surveyed the surroundings.

Most of the rebels had been injured and were resting.

Ian and McDowell.

Ian's spatial magic only reduced the scale of the leaders' onslaught, and McDowell, despite losing an arm, displayed powerful magic.

The rebellion's secret weapons, Aryandor and the necromancy of Daemon, had been absent, leading to this situation.

The rebel leaders clearly recognized this as a failure of Aryandor's strategy.

Yet, they did not rebel against Aryandor.

The anger among the leaders over Jefrin's death was not insignificant.

The leaders, who had been together even before the rebellion was properly formed, knew each other's circumstances well.

They had lost something crucial to the Empire.

Thus, their bond was deep.

In this situation, with Jefrin dead, they believed they would have made the same choice.

Therefore, there was no rebellion against the failure of the strategy.

However, they needed to quell the dissatisfaction among the soldiers.

"Aryandor saved us... we owe our lives to him..."

Thus, the leaders portrayed Aryandor as the savior of the soldiers.

This wasn't entirely untrue.

The Academy's forces retreated when Aryandor, who had been in the Persia region, arrived at the battlefield in front of the Academy.

However, they cunningly hid the fact that if Aryandor had been on the battlefield from the start, the losses would have been much less.

Such wordplay couldn't completely soothe the soldiers, but it did allow for some damage control.

"So, what shall we do now?"

In this state, the leaders gathered for a meeting.

The morale of the soldiers was a problem, but there was a more pressing issue.

"How can there be a counter to time magic?"

The first to speak was Daemon, who had gone to the Persia region with Aryandor.

The reason the rebels could stand against the Empire.

It was thanks to necromancy and time magic.

Necromancy filled the gaps in their troop numbers, and time magic enabled them to counter powerful wizards and warriors.

Without either, the rebels couldn't have stood against the Empire.

They were neither superior in forces nor in talent to the Empire.

The rebels had relied solely on these two abilities.

And now, one of those trusts had been shattered.

The believed-to-be-invincible time magic had a counter.

Time magic, instead, became Aryandor's weakness.

Aryandor, relying on time magic, had focused his abilities on offense.

Without time magic, even Ian, Cromwell, McDowell, or any Academy graduate fought as equals to a novice.

The leaders' trust in their abilities was shattered.

"I don't know exactly."

"If you don't know, that's it?"

"Daemon, restrain yourself. Fighting won't give us the answers."

Venderwood, who was beside Daemon, stopped him.

Daemon calmed down and took his seat.

Venderwood turned his head and looked at Aryandor.

"Aryandor, I may not be wise as a former slave, but I understand the gravity of our current situation. Do we have any solutions or countermeasures?"

Venderwood had previously encountered the future Rudy in battle.

He had let go of Rie and Yuni, who were almost captured at the Academy, and had been defeated by Rudy.

With such a figure possessing a counter to time magic, the possibility of the rebels losing to Rudy alone loomed large.

"There is no solution at the moment."

"Aryandor..."

Aryandor stood up.

"But, I will try to find one."

With that, he walked out of the tent.

Venderwood sighed and spoke.

"...Let's end the meeting here."

Aryandor went outside and returned to his personal tent.

He then began writing a letter.

'I heard from 'that person' that Priscilla had disappeared.'

'That person' had dealt with Priscilla's previous contractor, and Serina, who was supposed to be the next user, failed to acquire her.

But how did Rudy Astria come to possess that elemental?

It was the worst possible scenario, an unacceptable situation.

Having a elemental near a user of spatial magic was bad enough, but a user contracting directly with one was the worst-case scenario.

Time magic was not a perfect technique.

There were many countermeasures to it.

However, recognizing those countermeasures as such was not an easy task.

Since others had not faced time magic, it was certain they would win before discovering it.

But spatial magic was an exception.

Even without facing time magic, one could physically sense it through spatial magic.

Time and space must approach each other's realms when used.

Neither spatial nor time magic is a technique of the current dimension.

They are magics used in the unseen dimensions of space and time.

The core of the world, two abilities used in similar dimensions.

When time changes, a twist in space occurs, and when space changes, a twist in time happens.

Each can sense the use of the other's ability.

The problem is, even if one can sense the other's ability, they cannot reach into the other's realm.

Time has its unique realm, and so does space.

Whether it's time or spatial magic, one cannot interfere in the other's realm.

Only those who have inherited the ability can access these unique realms.

Time magic must be passed down from a time magic user, and spatial magic from a spatial magic user.

Having inherited spatial magic does not allow one to interfere with the realm of time, and those who have not received the inheritance cannot even see that realm.

The reason space and time were called the realms of gods was precisely this.

'However...'

Just because one cannot see or reach into these realms does not mean the abilities are without flaws.

Even if time's realm is twisted, the ability must still be brought into reality.

This was the only vulnerability of time and space.

If one could block the application of these abilities before they affected reality, then no matter how powerful the ability, it would be meaningless.

Priscilla had played this role.

A person who knew spatial magic also had the means to counter it.

It was indeed the worst-case scenario.

'But the ability was not used perfectly.'

There was still a chance.

A chance to change this situation.

Aryandor finished writing the letter and manipulated mana.

"Time Regression."

The contents of the letter then disappeared completely.

Time Regression.

He slowly reversed time to make the contents vanish.

However, this magic was not continuous.

If the spell was broken, the contents would return.

The reason for using this magic was to maintain confidentiality.

An ordinary person couldn't undo this magic.

Thus, the letter would remain empty as long as the Time Regression persisted.

Aryandor took the letter with the vanished contents and headed toward the cage in the tent.

The person Aryandor was sending this letter to would understand.

The person who had taught Aryandor time magic.

He sent it to that person.

Aryandor put down his pen and sighed.

'Then I must make my own moves.'

The sound of birds chirping seemed to announce the morning.

However, it felt as if someone had drawn the curtains, blocking the sunlight.

Pain emanated from my shoulder, which didn't move well.

It seemed someone had bandaged it.

But last night, I clearly...

“Did I just fall asleep like that...?”

I opened my eyes.

Then I saw my shoulder, neatly bandaged.

“Did you sleep well?”

A voice came through.

“Astina.”

Astina, smiling, was in front of me.

“How could you just go to sleep while bleeding so much? Even if you received magical treatment, you should still sleep with bandages on.”

“Ahaha...”

I laughed awkwardly.

After the battle ended, I received magical treatment and, relieved of tension, fell asleep as soon as I saw the bed.

“Did you stay here all night?”

“You might have gotten worse.”

“Then why not leave a doctor...”

“How could I treat my savior like that? As the lord of the territory, I must take care of you.”

Astina smiled kindly.

Talking like this made it clear to me that I had changed the future.

I had succeeded in saving Astina.

I don't know how I did it, but I managed to counter time magic and saved Astina.

Although I failed to capture Aryandor, I was deeply moved by the fact that I had saved Astina.

“Thank you for saving me, Rudy.”

At Astina's words, I smiled.

“It was possible because others helped.”

Evan, Cromwell, and others like Astina herself.

It was possible because everyone was there.

Astina shook her head to my response.

“I'm not talking about yesterday.”

“Huh?”

“I mean a story from much earlier.”

“Earlier, you mean...”

“The story in the capital.”

Astina began to reminisce about that time.

“I was terrified. I pondered dozens of times about what would happen if I died, and I constantly worried about how to handle that situation. Since the time you said you would become strange if I died, I tried to stay away from you. Even when Luna and Rie were by your side, even when I had time to see you at the Academy, I did not approach you.

I did that so you could continue living normally even if I died.”

Astina continued.

“But I struggled anyway. I tried desperately to survive, to keep my life. I researched various ways to counter Aryandor's time magic and increased my strength. Still, I was lacking. That's when I joined the Royal army. I thought a lot there. Even if I died, you would continue living as yourself. I tried to accept that reality.”

Then Astina smiled and looked at me.

“That's when you came to me. And you told me to trust you. That you would definitely save me.”

Astina gently placed her hand on mine.

“Rudy, thank you. I owe my life to you.”

Her voice trembled, conveying her emotions genuinely.

Astina must have had many thoughts.

Who wouldn't tremble in fear at the thought of their own death?

The fear of death.

Doubt about oneself.

The surrounding circumstances.

All these factors must have pressured Astina.

Perhaps my telling Astina that she dies might have added to her burden.

Maybe it would have been better for Astina if she had not known about the future and I had just saved her.

Nevertheless, Astina stood strong.

She trusted me and believed in herself.

“All I can do is be grateful to Astina for holding on till the end.”

I said with a smile.

Then Astina sighed.

“At times like this, you can just accept the thanks. No need to deflect it as someone else's merit. But.”

She soon burst into a bright smile.

“I like that about you, Rudy.”

In the Royal Capital's meeting room.

“Ian Astria, you really did well. It seems you've greatly weakened the rebels' morale.”

“It's an overstatement, Your Majesty.”

“Overstatement? You inflicted significant damage on the rebels. With this, we can be at ease for a while. And Astina Persia, you too did a great job.”

“Thank you. It was possible because many helped.”

“Haha, speaking of which, Rudy Astria helped a lot, didn't he? It seems like just a few days ago he was in front of me, and now he's there...”

“Is he alright?”

“Yes, he is resting well.”

“Haha, Astina Persia. Thank you for answering, but I was asking someone else.”

The Emperor turned his head and looked to the side.

That place was the seat of the Duke of Astria.

Originally, it was where Ian sat, but now someone else was seated there.

Perrian Astria, the father of Rudy and Ian, was the one sitting.

“Do you know where Rudy Astria is now?”

Perrian Astria responded.

“I'm not sure.”

“So, you mean to say that a duke, even during a war, is not in the capital, and while his sons are achieving such feats, he doesn't show his face. And he doesn't even know where his injured son is. May I ask what you have been doing all this time, Perrian Astria?”

“I apologize, Your Majesty.”

Perrian bowed his head to the Emperor.

“I asked what you have been doing.”

“What would a retired noble do? I was just enjoying my hobbies and staying in my mansion.”

“Are hobbies more important to you than war?”

“No. I believed my sons would handle things well on their own, as they have grown so capable.”

The Emperor looked sharply at Perrian.

“You are still a duke of the Empire. Declaring retirement doesn’t mean you are retired!”

“I apologize, Your Majesty.”

The Emperor rubbed his forehead with his hand.

“Normally, I would have liked to severely punish the Astria family, but I won't, considering your sons. Until one of them officially takes over the family, stay in the capital.”

“I will heed your command.”

Perrian quietly accepted the order.

The Emperor then turned his head to look at the Prime Minister, Jason Ophillius.

“Prime Minister Ophillius, award Rudy Astria and Ian Astria separately, and keep Perrian Astria under surveillance for a while.”

“Understood, Your Majesty.”

“Then, let’s conclude the meeting here.”

With that, people in the meeting room rose from their seats.

“Ahem, ahem.”

“Is it time for a generational shift, perhaps?”

The nobles who had risen from the meeting were chatting among themselves.

It was gossip about Perrian.

Perrian, who had been scolded by the Emperor and almost punished, had his reputation thoroughly damaged.

However, his expression remained unchanged.

Even when he heard such snide remarks, he was indifferent.

The nobles thought he reacted this way because he was retiring anyway, but Perrian had other thoughts in his mind.

Necromancy in the Astria territory.

He was contemplating research related to it.

‘I can listen to such talk a hundred times over. As long as that research progresses properly.’

With these thoughts, Perrian left the room and headed towards his mansion.

At that moment.

“Finally, I can leave this place. Damn those children.”

A person was walking down a dark path, cursing under his breath.

A man cloaked in a hood, his body and face concealed.

His body was caked with blood and dust.

He was a man who had fought in the war between the rebels and the Royal army.

He had used much of his energy, and due to non-stop running, his stamina was greatly depleted.

'But I can't miss this opportunity.'

Now was an excellent chance.

Perrian Astria was away from his post.

Daemon of the rebels was too busy with his own affairs.

With the rebels defeated, they would have no time to pay attention to anything else.

Thus, there was no one to guard this place.

The man in the Astria territory was Rudy's mentor, Robert.

He had just arrived at the Astria territory, where necromancers were gathered.

Chapter 235: Past and Future (2)

"Can you wait a little, Astina?" was my response to Astina's confession.

It might have seemed like a lukewarm answer.

It was a statement that could disappoint the other person and leave a lingering discomfort in my heart.

However, in the current situation, I couldn't accept the confession.

I had to take over the Astria family and find a solution to the time magic.

There were many other things waiting for me.

So, now was not the time.

"Well, I'm used to waiting anyway."

"But the longer it takes, the more anxious people become."

"This isn't just about me. Others feel the same."

"After I inherit the Astria family, I will come to see you again."

Leaving these words behind, I parted ways with Astina.

Astina went to attend a meeting in the capital, and I returned to the Astria family.

"Anyway....."

Rustle, rustle—

Sand and piles of stones caught under my feet.

In front of me, a collapsed wall was visible.

"What should I do about this....."

The library was in a complete mess.

The wall was broken, and stones were scattered around.

Since I was the one who had broken this wall, I could only sigh.

The reason I broke this wall was to enter the vault of the Astria family.

The Astria family vault, which I entered when Perrian taught me spatial magic.

In fact, I had many questions about that space.

Where exactly was this space?

Although Perrian had entered it using spatial magic, it didn't seem like a space created by such magic.

If it was a space accessible only by spatial magic, we wouldn't have had to come all the way to the library and then to a seemingly predetermined wall.

So, I suspected there was another space behind this wall.

Ultimately, my hunch was right.

They had created another space behind the wall and then blocked the path with another wall.

It seemed like it was made this way so that members of the Astria family could enter the vault using spatial magic.

But, why was it so recklessly destroyed?

That's because I broke it in haste.

To save Astina, I needed something.

I stole a magical device engraved with spatial magic from the Astria vault.

Stealing the device was fine.

Thanks to that, I could save Astina, and everything turned out well in the end.

The problem was that Perrian was coming to this mansion.

I'm not yet the head of the family or the legitimate heir.

If it's discovered that I robbed the family vault in such a situation, I would face a serious punishment.

I couldn't afford to receive such a penalty during the intense competition for succession.

"Is anyone there?"

As I called out, a maid came down to the library.

"You called for..... Oh!"

The maid's eyes widened at the sight of the library's condition.

It was a natural reaction for the maid to be shocked upon seeing the library, typically a quiet and sacred space, now disorderly with piles of stones.

I pointed around and said to the maid,

“This needs to be cleaned up.”

“Understood. How should I clean it up?”

The maid didn't ask why this had happened.

The previous maids would have asked and informed Perrian, but the current maids were all loyal to my orders.

I had dismissed those who did not follow my orders and brought in new maids.

This was something I managed to do while still part of the family.

Since neither my father nor Ian remembered each maid individually, it was possible.

I had given a generous amount of money to those I dismissed and warned them not to inform the family, so I could replace the maids without any issues.

“First, gather the rubble separately and cover the broken wall with wallpaper,”

I instructed, doing the best I could under the circumstances.

Though I would have to rebuild the wall with stones while Perrian was away, I planned to make it minimally visible as he was returning soon.

“I understand. I’ll call some maids and servants to handle it,” the maid said, calculating what was needed without further instructions from me, which I found very satisfying.

“Give extra rewards to those who work on this. Get it done as quickly as possible.”

“Understood.”

The maid then began to organize the removal of the rubble.

While the library was being tidied, a maid rushed towards it.

“Yo, Young master Rudy...!”

“Master has arrived...”

“Already?”

There had surely been a meeting at the royal palace.

I had thought he would chat with the nobles and return later, but my prediction was off.

I looked around.

The library had just begun to be tidied and was still in the early stages of cleanup.

“What to do...”

After pondering the maid’s words, I moved.

“Let’s go upstairs for now. Clean this up as fast as you can. I’ll keep father occupied in the meantime.”

I quickly walked up to the first floor, where I saw Perrian standing outside the mansion.

I cleared my throat, straightened my clothes, and approached Perrian.

“Father, I hope you have been well.”

Perrian looked at me, his gaze indifferent.

“Ah, Rudy.”

His eyes seemed to say I was of no interest to him.

“I’ve decided to stay at the mansion for a while.”

“At this mansion?”

“Yes, until I have permission from His Majesty the Emperor.”

“I see...”

Hearing this, I racked my brain.

I had to keep Perrian here.

I needed to think of a topic to engage him in conversation, but nothing came to mind. I had to have had conversations with Perrian to initiate one.

Moreover, Perrian was an enemy. I couldn't delve into sensitive or friendly topics.

Perrian wouldn't immediately head to the library, I assumed.

However, my expectation was quickly proven wrong. When a servant fetched some documents from the carriage, Perrian reached out for them.

"Give those documents to me," he said.

Receiving the documents, Perrian headed towards the library.

"Father?"

I called out.

"Hmm?"

I promptly caught up with Perrian.

"Are you going to the library?"

"Yes, I have some work to take care of."

"Then, why not use the office? I haven't been using that room, so it's well-organized."

"The office?"

Perrian showed a subtle reaction, seemingly hesitant to go there.

It wasn't an atmosphere of suspicion towards me, but I noticed the documents in his hand.

What were those documents about?

I recalled that Ian and I were sharing the responsibilities related to the Astria family.

With Ian occupied with the Royal army, it was clear that there shouldn't be any separate documents for me to handle.

Realizing this, I didn't miss a beat.

"Are those confidential documents?"

I watched Perrian's expression closely as I spoke.

A flicker of disturbance.

Seeing this, I quickly continued,

"The library is a bit messy right now. I've been practicing spatial magic there, and maids and servants are coming and going. Perhaps it would be better to use the office."

Upon hearing this, Perrian nodded.

"Yes, that sounds like a good idea."

I exhaled a sigh of relief upon hearing Perrian's agreement.

Did I manage to buy some time...?

"But," Perrian added, halting his steps towards the office and looking at me,

"I received a letter from the Mayer family."

"The Mayer family?" I echoed, puzzled.

"It concerns a marriage proposal."

"A marriage proposal?"

"The letter mentioned it's about time for you to marry, given your age."

I was baffled, dozens of question marks popping up in my mind.

"But why would the Mayer family... No, why to you, Father..."

"Karen Mayer," Perrian said, handing me a letter.

"Your childhood friend, the eldest daughter of the Mayer family, Karen Mayer. They wish to discuss a marriage arrangement with her."

The territory of the Astria family.

"Cough..."

"Only because the Astria family protected you, you managed to stay alive. Did you really think you were a match for me?"

Robert stood over dozens of people lying at his feet.

Blood was splattered everywhere, and the items used for research were all destroyed.

"Ro... Robert...!!!" a man with some strength left shouted at Robert.

Robert furrowed his brows and touched his ear.

"You don't need to shout. I can hear you perfectly well."

"You... How could you do this!!! After killing the necromancers, you should've lived quietly in hiding, not come back to kill us twice!"

"I never killed any necromancers. In fact, it was you who killed people around me."

Robert's indifferent words caused the man to seethe with rage.

"There's a limit to how much nonsense one can spout. You, using necromancy, got us caught by the Empire, causing us all to lose our homes and families. Now, living as dogs for the Astria family, you're going to finish us all off."

"Lost your homes and became dogs of Astria? What a dog's drivell."

Robert took a step towards the man.

His eyes emitted a murderous aura, and the man stumbled backward, overwhelmed by the intimidation.

"Why do you think I was caught by the Empire? Do you think I turned myself in for using necromancy?"

The man choked as Robert grabbed him by the collar.

"It was your scheme. You experimented on me. Thanks to your experiments, the Empire discovered my use of necromancy."

The man gasped for air, screaming in distress, while Robert, sighing, threw him aside.

"Your antics cost me my son. And now you, claiming to be dogs of Astria, are killing other people's families. Isn't it ironic? You lament about losing your families and homes, yet it's all your own doing."

"We did it to survive... to stay alive under the Astria family..."

"So, if someone orders it, it's okay to do it? Should the person who ordered it bear all the responsibility?"

"It was to survive..."

"To survive, huh?"

Robert sneered at the man and raised his fist.

"If you have to kill innocent people to survive."

He then struck down at the man.

"Just don't live. Bastard."

Chapter 236: Past and Future (3)

Robert looked around him.

"Please, save me..."

He had killed most of the necromancers, but a few remained.

Those who didn't resist, trembling with fear.

Robert did not kill those who did not resist.

There was no need to kill those who had already lost the will to fight.

He approached one of the women.

"Please... spare my life..."

"Have you been in contact with Perrian Astria?"

"What?"

Perrian had returned to the capital, but he wouldn't just leave this place alone.

He intended to make sure the laboratory was running as usual.

"Are you in contact or not?"

As Robert repeated the question, the woman in front of him nodded her head up and down.

"Yes, yes! We have been in constant contact!"

"Who was in charge of that role?"

"That... that person over there..."

Robert looked where she was pointing.

It was the man he had just killed.

He used to be in charge here, but now he was in no state to rise again.

Robert sighed.

"Then there's no choice. You'll take over the communication."

"Me?"

"Yes, Perrian must believe that everything here is still running normally.
Can you do that?"

"I'll do it!"

"Also, clean up everything here. Release all the people you've captured, and burn all the experiment records."

"The experiment records...!"

"Don't like it?"

Robert looked at her with a menacing gaze.

"I'll do it!"

"Good. And don't think about escaping from here. The moment you try to leave, you'll die."

"Understood!"

Robert said this and moved on.

'No one will come to check this place other than Perrian.'

Unless Perrian was insane, he wouldn't have informed his associates about such an incident.

If someone mentioned they were harboring a necromancer, they would be arrested immediately.

So as long as they exchanged letters properly, there was no way to know the state of this place.

As Robert stepped outside.

A woman was waiting for him.

"Hello?"

The woman, her eyes covered with black cloth.

She was the saint, Haruna.

"Why are you here?"

Robert narrowed his eyes at Haruna.

"It would be inappropriate to go inside, wouldn't it? Even if I can't see the brutal scene, I can guess what's happening from the sounds and smells."

Haruna smiled and tapped her covered eyes.

"That's not what I'm asking."

"Just a joke~. It's a bit awkward if you react like that."

Robert furrowed his brow.

"Drop the tasteless jokes. Why are you here? There's even less reason for a saint to be here alone."

"I've been traveling alone these days. Given the situation, it's too dangerous for the temple people."

"The current situation?"

"Aryandor. He must be grinding his teeth thinking about me."

The temple had become corrupt.

Aryandor, the leader of the rebels, could go as far as take the life of the saint if the temple was paid enough.

Robert nodded in understanding.

"Alright, being alone is one thing. But why are you here?"

"Well... I came to tell you some stories about the past and the future, Robert."

"To me?"

"About Levian and Rudy. I'll tell you their stories. And then."

Haruna smiled.

"After you've heard everything, you can write the current story."

As soon as the study was somewhat organized, I dressed appropriately and boarded the carriage.

"Head to the Mayer family."

Normally, when visiting another family, it's polite to inform them in advance.

But there was an issue with following that procedure.

'There was a promise I made with Count Mayer in the past, wasn't there?'

Something Perrian had said.

That I, in the past, had promised to marry Karen.

Count Mayer had mentioned it to Perrian because of that promise.

My head began to throb.

Although it was a story from my childhood, noble marriages often involve engagements from a young age, so it wasn't something to be dismissed lightly.

Therefore, I had to hurry to the Mayer household.

If I waited, Perrian might proceed with the wedding.

From Perrian's perspective, it would be more advantageous to marry someone from the Mayer family rather than someone close to me.

So I had to reach an agreement with the Mayer family before Perrian could proceed without anyone knowing.

"Young master Rudy, we have arrived."

With the coachman's words, I stepped out of the carriage.

Then Count Mayer rushed out to the front of the carriage.

"Young master Rudy? What brings you here..."

The robust middle-aged Count Mayer, though charismatic, wore a bewildered expression.

"Count Mayer, good to see you. I apologize for visiting without notice. I came to discuss something important."

"Something to discuss?"

"About a marriage proposal."

As I said this, Count Mayer's expression hardened.

"Would you come inside? I don't have anything prepared, but let's have a cup of tea."

"Yes, thank you."

I followed Count Mayer into the mansion.

"About the wedding... What did you come to discuss?"

I closed my eyes for a moment and then looked at Count Mayer.

"I want to cancel this marriage engagement."

"...The engagement?"

Count Mayer's eyes widened.

"Is there... a problem? With our Mayer family... or, perhaps Karen..."

His voice was full of panic.

Usually, canceling an engagement implies a significant issue with the other party.

I understood why Count Mayer was so alarmed.

"There's no problem with the Mayer family or Karen."

In fact, in this situation, I was the problematic one.

Count Mayer had only proceeded with an existing engagement, and I was trying to stop it.

"Then how about postponing the engagement for a while?"

"I think it would be better to cancel it. For Karen's sake, and for the Mayer family's... Oh, but that's not to say I intend to snub the Mayer family."

I am well aware of how earnestly you've been helping me."

"That's not the reason."

"What?"

"Our Karen is very fond of you, Young master Rudy. It seemed she had made up her mind after seeing you this time. That's why we wanted to proceed with the engagement again."

I wondered if I should not have acted in front of Karen.

It seemed my poor acting had come back to haunt me.

This made me think that people say not to lie for a reason.

"So, please reconsider canceling the wedding. This is not as the head of the Mayer family, but as a father asking you."

I returned to my family home and stared at the ceiling.

Upon reflection, time would solve this problem.

Karen was fond of the original Rudy Astria, not me.

The situation arose because I had acted in front of her; now, I just needed to stop acting.

So, I made a separate agreement with Count Mayer.

When Karen gave up on me, that's when we would cancel the engagement.

After all, time would take care of it.

When I met Karen, I would just need to show her the real me.

"Well, that issue is somewhat resolved, and now..."

What remained was to train in spatial magic.

I had gained some understanding of spatial magic.

I grasped the framework of space and could see new realms.

Yet, I lacked the ability to apply it.

The spatial magic I knew involved things like spatial slicing or teleportation.

Applying spatial magic meant influencing this framework.

Spatial slicing could be predicted as cutting through this framework.

But how does teleportation work? That was my biggest question.

In fact, teleportation and time magic didn't seem very different.

The concept of 'transferring' was the same in both.

I slowly recalled my fight with Aryandor.

Aryandor used time magic, and his form disappeared.

This concept of 'disappearing' was the issue.

Typically, in teleportation magic, the form doesn't disappear.

One might be visually deceived into thinking it has disappeared, but in a situation where one is aware of spatial magic, that shouldn't happen.

So what had Aryandor done to cause such an event?

No, let's not look too far ahead.

I need to understand the basics first.

Spatial magic is not a magic that occurs in the physical world.

It's magic that influences an invisible realm.

I mustn't forget that aspect.

"So spatial slicing is..."

Literally magic that slices through space? But I couldn't think of a way to slice through space.

I could only perceive space but did not know how to influence it.

"I wonder if I should visit my uncle..."

Then a fact suddenly struck me.

Perrian.

Perrian was in this mansion.

If there was someone here who could teach me spatial magic, there was no need to seek out my uncle.

Moreover, Perrian was someone who could actually use spatial magic.

He could show me examples, making him a better teacher than my uncle.

With this in mind, I moved towards the office.

Chapter 237: Past and Future (4)

"Spatial magic?"

Perrian narrowed his brows.

"Yes, could you please teach me spatial magic?"

"Didn't I tell you to learn from Ian?"

"But, Ian is currently with the Royal army, isn't he? It's impossible."

At this, Perrian crossed his legs and glared at me.

"So, what do you expect me to do?"

"Excuse me?"

"Persuading Ian is a trial in itself, and it's something you should strive for. How can it be a trial if you come to me and ask for a solution?"

That made no sense.

"I'm merely asking for the assurance of basic educational conditions. Are you saying I should consider this my trial and overcome it?"

"Yes. Competition has always been different from the start. Trials vary from person to person. You just happened to face your trial at the beginning."

"But."

"Besides, if I help you here, wouldn't that contradict the fairness you mentioned?"

"You didn't teach me spatial magic."

"That's in the past. Currently, I'm offering no help at all."

I sighed deeply.

"Understood. I'll take my leave now."

I had much to say, but I held back any further words.

Continuing the conversation was pointless anyway.

Dialogue should be with someone who understands.

Speaking more in the face of non-understanding only hurts my own mouth.

Leaving Perrian's office, I clicked my tongue.

"What kind of tasks could he possibly have..."

The documents heading to Perrian were difficult to understand since he personally handled them.

Still, I guessed they might be related to necromancy.

That reminded me, what was Professor Robert doing?

If I get a chance, I should personally visit the Astria territory, where I heard they had necromancers.

Now seemed like the perfect opportunity.

Perrian was in the capital, and the rebels would be busy with their own affairs.

"It's unlikely that the professor would miss such an opportunity."

Still, I couldn't help but wonder.

If Robert was occupied with something else, he might not notice.

I smirked and headed to the library.

I prepared a letter, detailing the current state of the Astria family and the rebels.

Then, I handed it to a maid.

"Send this to the academy as soon as day breaks."

It was my form of revenge.

"And try to find out about the documents my father is handling."

"Are you referring to Lord Perrian...?"

"No need to force it. Don't touch things like letters. Just try to find out from the trash or while cleaning."

It was clear that the content would be about necromancy, but I intended to uncover other clues as well.

His documents couldn't be solely about necromancy.

There must be a plan starting with necromancy.

It was necessary to find out about the people involved in the plan and its contents.

I gritted my teeth and looked up.

"Let them have a taste of their own medicine."

After finishing my tasks, I resumed studying spatial magic.

Studying, in this context, meant simply perceiving the entire space and experimenting with various things.

I tried infusing mana into the space I perceived and fumbling to touch it directly.

However, no solution emerged.

How could I influence the space?

Our mana exists in the real world.

The space I was perceiving wasn't the real world.

I stared blankly into space for a few minutes.

"...Huh?"

Suddenly, I felt a slight twist in the space.

I stood up, sensing this distortion.

"What's this?"

I thought Perrian might be using spatial magic, but the magic wasn't occurring at the Astria mansion.

"In the sky?"

I felt the magic high above in the sky.

But it wasn't a strong presence.

A slight twist in space.

There were only two things I knew that could influence space: spatial magic and time magic.

Spatial magic naturally affects space, and when Aryandor used time magic, it also caused a twist in space.

So, it was one of these two options.

But among those who knew spatial magic, none could fly through the sky.

Ian and Perrian, having methods of transportation using spatial magic, had no need to learn magic to fly.

Besides, Perrian was currently in the mansion.

Ian's whereabouts were unknown, but it seemed unlikely he was flying in the sky.

I narrowed down the possibilities, focusing on the distortion.

The distortion didn't stay still.

It moved rapidly.

Eventually, the distortion circled in the air before descending.

It stopped within the Royal palace.

And then the distortion...

"Disappeared?"

It vanished without a trace.

Puzzled by this strange movement, I tilted my head.

Had I sensed it wrong?

Or, was this a common occurrence?

No one in the Royal palace knew time or spatial magic.

Perrian was with me, and Ian was at the Royal army's base near the capital.

Could it be Aryandor?

Was Aryandor inside the Royal palace?

If so, it wasn't something to be taken lightly.

"The Royal palace..."

I recalled what the emperor had said last time.

I could visit the palace to see Rie.

If Aryandor had infiltrated near the palace, Rie could be in danger.

So, it seemed wise to warn Rie during a brief visit to the palace.

"I should stop by tomorrow."

Muttering to myself, I surveyed the space again.

For several minutes, I looked around, but no change occurred in the space.

"What in the world is going on?"

The next day.

I woke up in the morning and headed straight to the Royal palace.

Upon arriving at the palace gates.

"Why have you come to visit me first?"

Rie greeted me with a playful scolding.

"I just wanted to see your face, check if you're doing well."

"...Did you come to ask for another favor?"

"It's not like I always come asking for favors."

"Hmm~."

She seemed to grumble a bit, but her face showed that she was pleased to see me.

"So... are you going to stay with me today?"

"That's fine. I don't have any other plans."

I planned to walk around the palace with Rie.

There might still be traces of yesterday's event.

Hearing my words, a smile formed on Rie's lips.

"Rie, I haven't eaten yet."

I said, holding my stomach, and Rie chuckled.

"Alright. Let's have something to eat then..."

"Senior~~~!"

As Rie and I were about to go to the dining area, Yuni ran towards us from a distance.

"Oh, Yuni..."

As I raised my hand to greet her, Rie stepped forward.

"Yuni? Didn't you say you were busy these days? You must have a lot to study, and there's a lot to learn while Professor Gracie is at the palace, right?"

Rie narrowed her eyes and fired off questions like a machine gun.

Yuni gave Rie a sly look and smiled.

"Being busy usually means being busy on normal days. I can spare a moment, can't I?"

"But why spare that time now?"

"Because someone dear has come?"

...Weren't they close?

Surprised by their sudden quarrel, I tilted my head.

Why is Rie reacting so sensitively all of a sudden?

"Did something happen between you two?"

"Nothing happened~."

"Nothing happened."

Yuni and Rie said simultaneously.

Their words only made me more suspicious.

What had they been doing in the palace?

While I pondered, Rie pulled at my sleeve.

"Forget that, you said you were hungry. Let's go eat."

"Are you going to eat, senior?"

"Yes, yes."

"Yuni, you've eaten already, right? Maybe you should wait in your room?"

"No, I'll just watch you eat for a bit."

Both of them were quite headstrong.

Seeing them face off like that made me sweat.

"Why are they acting like this..."

"It's none of your business. Let's just go eat. You said you were hungry."

I was dragged along by Rie's hand.

As we neared the dining hall, I saw a man approaching from a distance.

"...Ian?"

"Hmm?"

Rie turned her head towards where Ian was upon hearing my words.

"...Why are you here?"

"Oh, there was a meeting related to the Royal army last night. Seems like he's heading back after an all-night meeting?"

A meeting at the palace all night?

Then what about the magic that occurred yesterday?

Ian, seemingly not noticing me, walked away into the distance.

"Anyway... it seems the meeting ended a while ago... Never mind. Let's go eat."

"...Okay, understood."

I followed Ian with my eyes, then let Rie lead me by the hand into the dining hall.

'It was definitely around here.'

Hours had passed since the meeting ended.

Yet Ian hadn't left but was still roaming the palace grounds.

He had certainly felt a strange current nearby.

'What was that energy, and why was it felt inside the palace?'

The meeting had somewhat concluded and everyone was resting when a strange energy was perceived in the palace.

A distortion in space.

For Ian, it was the first time feeling such an energy.

'Such a sensation doesn't happen with spatial magic.'

Then there was only one explanation.

Time magic.

The only methods to influence the spatial realm are through space and time.

Thus, it was reasonable to assume that time magic had occurred.

But why here?

Why time magic in this place?

Ian looked around.

This area was inside the palace, a location where lower nobility couldn't enter.

'Aryandor? No, that doesn't make sense.'

Yesterday, there was a significant meeting about the Royal army at the palace.

McDowell and Cromwell were there, along with the most powerful figures of the empire.

Infiltrating such a situation would be like suicide.

'Another time magic user?'

This had also come up in the recent meeting.

Who taught Aryandor time magic?

As the situation eased, people began to consider these possibilities.

But the occurrence of time magic inside the palace meant another time magic user was inside.

'A traitor...'

But that seemed too strange.

If the empire's internal information had been continuously leaked, the rebels would have waited until good information came out before acting.

However, the rebels moved without regard for such things.

'What on earth...?'

No matter how much he pondered, the answer did not come.

His concerns only deepened.

Chapter 238: Past and Future (5)

The meal was nearing its end.

Initially, the constant tension between Rie and Yuni made the food stick in my throat, but as time passed, I got used to it and was able to finish my meal normally.

After eating, I set down my utensils and looked at Rie.

"What have you been up to lately?"

"Well, I'm swamped. Between learning Royal studies, studying magic, and with the war going on, I barely have time to breathe. Plus, I have some other things I'm working on."

"Other things?"

Then Rie pointed at me with her finger.

"Something about the Astria family heir."

I was surprised to hear Rie was concerned about the Astria family affairs.

"Your father is rushing the succession race. If that happens, your chances of losing increase significantly. You haven't solidified your support base yet, and your spatial magic is still unrefined."

"...That's true."

"Don't worry. I'm not just helping you for the sake of it. I'm considering the overall political situation. If the Astria family easily falls to Ian, it would put me in a difficult position as the future emperor."

"Difficult?"

Certainly, if I inherit the Astria family, the emperor's position would be significantly strengthened.

But there seemed no reason for her to be troubled if I didn't become the head of the family.

The noble faction and the emperor's faction within the Astria family had always been in conflict.

Nothing would change, and it wouldn't be a big problem.

"Soon, there will only be one ducal family left in the empire."

Rie's words made me tilt my head in confusion.

"Why? What about Duke Ophillius?"

I didn't know much about Duke Ophillius, but I was aware that he was a central figure in the emperor's faction.

"Duke Ophillius is retiring soon. Without a successor."

A successor.

The ducal family had no one to inherit it.

"What about Duke Ophillius's son?"

"Duke Ophillius doesn't have children. Not even an adopted son. He might have relatives, but in reality, they couldn't wield the same power if they inherited the family."

This was news to me.

"Most people probably don't know this. Duke Ophillius never talks about such matters, and being a deep thinker, people assumed he had a plan."

"Then why..."

"I talked with my father separately, and he said he was considering passing it on to one of the relatives. It seemed like a decision made because he didn't want to appoint an unsuitable person as the successor..."

Expectations for the Ophillius family were high.

Being a central family of the emperor's faction and one of the only two ducal families in the empire, it was natural.

In such a situation, since Duke Ophillius hadn't married, he should have brought in a capable adopted son to meet the expectations.

But there seemed to be no one who caught his eye, leading to the current situation.

"So, what happens now?"

"If he doesn't find a suitable person among his relatives, Duke Ophillius will be the last of the Ophillius family."

"..."

"It might be for the best. Imagine if some unsuitable person took that place and started abusing power. It would only be a headache."

Rie shrugged nonchalantly as she spoke.

"Anyway, it looks like you'll definitely have to inherit the Astria family now."

"I'm the senior, so I guess I'll have to inherit it~," Yuni interjected from the side.

I was indeed trying my best to be in a position to inherit it, but it felt like a huge burden was placed on my shoulders.

"Besides, have you noticed anything unusual about your father's movements? Anything related to necromancy?"

"We're trying to find out, but it seems difficult to uncover."

If we made any strange accusations here, it could lead to an internal war.

Perrian believes we are unaware of their necromancy.

If they realize we know, it could immediately spark an internal conflict.

"Hmm..."

Rie sighed and stroked her chin.

"Setting that aside, what was discussed in yesterday's meeting?"

"Oh, that too."

Rie clapped her hands.

"Time magic was brought up in yesterday's meeting."

"Time magic?"

"Who taught Aryandor time magic and swordsmanship. Where did it originate?"

Time magic?

"...By any chance, who brought it up?"

"Your brother. Ian Astria."

I narrowed my brows.

The distortion of space that occurred here yesterday.

Ian, who brought up such a topic at that time.

I thought deeply.

There was a meeting at the Royal palace yesterday, so people wouldn't have been wandering around.

It was unlikely that someone sneaked in.

It was a gathering of the empire's power players; an intruder wouldn't stand a chance.

Then...

"Rie, Yuni."

I cautiously opened my mouth.

"Can you find out who attended yesterday's meeting?"

The person who used time magic must have been among those who attended yesterday's meeting.

"You've worked hard today."

"Ha, haven't you worked harder? Coming all this way."

"No, not at all. Duke Ophillius, you are getting on in years, after all."

McDowell and Cromwell were talking at Duke Ophillius's residence.

"That's true... That's why these days, even a single meeting leaves me sore all over. Hahaha."

Duke Ophillius laughed as he spoke to McDowell.

Despite being well over 70, he remained in politics.

The two great ducal families of the empire: the Astria and the Ophillius families.

If Duke Ophillius, without an heir, retires from politics, it would disrupt the empire's balance.

That's why he remained in his position as a chancellor, at least until a successor was found.

But it was already too late to find and appoint a successor now.

Unlike the Astria family, the Ophillius family hadn't really passed anything down.

While the Astria family had always been responsible for the empire's military power, the Ophillius family represented the empire's spirit.

The Astria family passed down spatial magic to their children, but the Ophillius family only had a spiritual legacy.

In the current situation, whoever becomes the successor will not be recognized as the Duke of Ophillius.

Suddenly inheriting the family, it was hard to claim that they carried on the spirit of Ophillius.

The spirit of Ophillius was an endless loyalty to the royal family, the charisma to lead the nobles of the empire, and the wisdom that seemed to know everything. To possess all these was to embody the spirit of Ophillius.

Now, finding such a capable person was not easy.

Therefore, those around were deeply regretful.

If Duke Ophillius retired from politics, the spirit of Ophillius would cease to exist.

The spirit that had loyally assisted the emperor and even earned the respect of the noble factions.

"I should probably retire soon myself."

"Even if you say so, you're still healthy, aren't you?"

"Healthy? I'm nothing but an old man with the day after tomorrow on his mind."

Duke Ophillius chuckled in response.

"Tired from the overnight meeting, I'll retire now. McDowell, please show Cromwell to a place to rest."

Despite being a ducal residence, the Ophillius estate was modest, with only one maid.

Therefore, McDowell had to personally guide Cromwell.

"Understood. Please go in."

Duke Ophillius, receiving their greetings, entered his room.

Once inside, he took a letter from his pocket.

"Hmm..."

The letter was addressed to Aryandor.

Duke Ophillius stared at it for a moment before throwing it into the fireplace.

'Aryandor.'

As he repeated the name, wrinkles deeply furrowed Duke Ophillius's face.

'The future cannot be changed.'

Thinking this, Ophillius moved towards his bed.

Knock, knock—

A sound came from the window.

Turning his head, Ophillius saw a man outside.

Slowly, he walked over and opened the window.

"What brings you here, Robert?"

Robert stood at the window.

Despite the height of the second floor, such a height posed no problem for Robert.

"You could have just entered the estate, I would have opened the door. Why come this way?"

Robert, stepping through the window, bowed his head.

"I apologize. There are people below who shouldn't know I'm here."

"Cromwell and McDowell?"

"Yes, those two."

Ophillius looked puzzled.

Robert was known to be on good terms with both of them.

Yet, he had come for something that needed to be kept secret.

"So, what brings you here?"

At Ophillius's question, Robert spoke.

"I've come to know the truth."

"...The truth?"

"More precisely, the past."

Robert spoke with a steady gaze.

"Aryandor, he's the one you raised, isn't he?"

At Robert's words, Duke Ophillius's expression hardened.

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"What evidence do you have to make such a claim?"

"The spirit of Ophillius."

At this, Robert pulled out a piece of paper.

On it was a drawing of a pocket watch.

"Where is this now?"

"You suddenly show me a drawing of a pocket watch and ask me this?"

"Isn't this the watch carried by the Ophillius family heads? The older nobles might know, but I'll refrain from saying more."

Robert slammed his hand on the desk, pointing to the watch.

"But where is this watch now?"

Ophillius couldn't bring himself to speak.

As Ophillius remained silent, Robert spoke up.

"That watch, Aryandor has it, doesn't he?"

"I have no idea what you're talking about."

Then Robert lifted the paper with the pocket watch drawn on it.

"Principal McDowell would know. Shall we go together?"

"McDowell?"

Robert let out a small laugh.

"Have you ever seen Principal McDowell's flash magic?"

"I haven't seen it..."

"That's why Aryandor recorded the flash magic in the pocket watch. He's not even from the Ophillius family, but he seems quite diligent in his records. Haha."

The spirit of Ophillius.

It wasn't something like a character trait passed down through blood.

It was the past recorded through time magic and all the information – this was the true spirit of Ophillius.

A family that remembered thousands, tens of thousands of past events and responded to everything.

That was the Ophillius family.

"You know things you shouldn't. How much do you know, and who told you?"

Robert couldn't have witnessed the fight between McDowell and Aryandor.

If Robert had been there, McDowell wouldn't have lost his arm.

Yet, he knew Aryandor had used the pocket watch.

To this, Robert calmly replied.

"I heard it from the saint."

"What is the saint thinking? Telling you such a story means..."

"I don't know what she is thinking. I just heard the story."

"Huh..."

Ophillius sighed and sat down.

"So, you know the entire past?"

"Yes."

"You came to kill me?"

"That's not it."

Ophillius looked puzzled.

"Didn't you say you heard about the past?"

"Yes."

"That it was me who killed your son and the wife of the head elemental?"

"That's correct."

Ophillius wore a look of defeat at Robert's words.

"I don't understand the saint's thoughts, nor yours."

"If I were to follow my heart, I'd pierce through your neck right now. You're the one who caused my son's death. But..."

Robert smiled sadly.

"I have people around me who need to continue moving forward into the future. You know what would happen if I killed you here."

"Is it because Aryandor would become stronger?"

Time and spatial magic.

This continuation revealed a significant downside to both time and spatial magic.

The reason only a few had monopolized these powers wasn't due to a desire for exclusivity.

The more people who shared these powers, the weaker they became.

If only one person used these abilities, they could wield their original strength, but as more people did, each individual's power diminished.

Therefore, Robert couldn't kill Ophillius.

If Ophillius were to die, Aryandor's monopolization of time magic might become unmanageable.

Although it was somewhat possible to counteract now, without Ophillius, stopping Aryandor could be impossible.

"I choose the future over my revenge," Robert declared.

"Why have you come here then?" asked Ophillius.

"I have a request," Robert replied.

"A request?"

"Survive. Survive until everything is over. If you think you must atone to me and others, forget about your dignity and just live."

Ophillius looked at Robert incredulously.

"Is that a request you make to your enemy?"

"You needn't worry about that."

Robert turned and walked towards the window.

Ophillius, who knew thousands of futures through time magic, couldn't fathom what Robert was thinking.

"Robert, I may not know what's on your mind, but let me give you one piece of advice as someone who handles time," Ophillius spoke.

Robert turned his head.

"Don't try to defy the future. There are countless possibilities, but most are already determined. If you live only for the future, the present will disappear."

Even though Rudy could use time magic, he couldn't see the future anymore due to the intervention from another dimension.

Yet, he knew the future wouldn't change much.

New interventions might alter it, but they couldn't change the entire future.

At best, it would only change one person's fate.

"I know whom you trust, but an individual can't change the whole," Ophillius advised.

"It's okay,"

Robert replied nonchalantly, turning his head away.

"He's not just an individual."

With that, Robert leapt out of the window.

I returned to the mansion, deep in thought.

"A time wizard among the empire's key figures..."

My list of tasks had grown.

Finding a hidden time wizard was a daunting addition to dealing with spatial magic.

The problem was that this time wizard didn't seem to be aiding the rebels.

'If that person was really helping the rebels, wouldn't they have caused chaos during Aryandor's attack? Or perhaps led the rebels to a favorable battle?'

I agreed with Rie's speculation.

Despite everything, the individual's dangerous nature remained unchanged.

Regardless of intent, this person had raised Aryandor and even used time magic in the Royal palace.

It was imperative to understand who this person was and their intentions.

I looked at the list of people who were present when the time magic occurred.

The Empire's head wizard, head elemental, the Principal and Vice-Principal of Libereion Academy, the Prime Minister, and others with influence in the Empire were all gathered there.

Of course, Perrian was not included.

Being out of politics for a long time, Perrian knew little about the current state of affairs and seemed to have been excluded.

Among them, those who might have the ability to use time magic were the Empire's head wizard and the Prime Minister, Jason Ophillius.

They were old enough to have raised Aryandor and were unknown to me in detail.

Yet, these two were known for their loyalty to the Empire.

This was especially true for Prime Minister Ophillius, and the head wizard had long served the Emperor at the wizard Tower.

"But I can't just suddenly go looking for the head wizard or the Prime Minister..."

Both were extremely busy individuals.

Even if they had dozens of bodies, meeting me seemed unlikely.

"...Wait a minute."

Suddenly, Luna came to mind.

She was currently in the Royal wizard Tower.

With Luna, maybe I could meet the head wizard?

As I contemplated this and prepared to act, a sense of self-reproach hit me.

First Rie, now Luna.

It felt like I was going on a tour, constantly seeking help.

In that state, I clenched my fist.

"...I can repay it twice over later."

With a gambler's mindset, determined to pay back what I owed, I headed towards Luna.

"Rudy!!"

As I waited in front of the Royal wizard Tower, Luna burst out of the entrance.

I hadn't contacted her directly but asked the guards to call her, so she came out herself.

"Luna, sorry for calling you out of the blue."

"Ehehe, no, I was free anyway. Seeing Rudy's face makes me happier!"

Luna smiled brightly at me.

"Yes, you can go in now," the guard said, and we entered the wizard Tower.

"I heard Astina was in danger. Rudy, you got hurt trying to save her, are you okay now?"

"Yeah, I received healing magic right away, so I'm fine now. How have you been, Luna?"

"Hmm! I made my own magical tool and submitted a paper! I'm the first in the wizard Tower to write a paper so quickly after joining!"

"Wow!"

Luna had always been adept at paperwork since our Academy days.

With her talent in magic circles, it seemed she had achieved such a feat.

"What kind of magical tool did you make?"

"A device to bind wizards! There was already an existing device, but I made the magic circuit more efficient!"

"More efficient?"

"Yes, I made it so that even with lower-quality manastones than the ones originally used, it could achieve the same efficiency!"

Luna rummaged through her bag and pulled out two small rings.

The rings resembled handcuffs and were designed to bind a person's arms.

"So, if you wear these handcuffs, you can't use mana?"

"Yes! Let me show you."

Luna, with a confident attitude, slipped the handcuffs onto her own arms.

Then, she attempted to manipulate mana.

I read the flow of mana and tilted my head in confusion.

"The mana is still flowing?"

"Yes, but that's okay. It prevents the use of magic."

Luna explained and then shouted an incantation.

"Fireball!"

Mana flowed towards Luna's hand.

Fizz—

The mana trying to escape Luna fizzled out disappointingly.

"In the past, mana flow itself was blocked to prevent the use of magic, but what I made disrupts the conversion of mana into magic!"

Although I didn't understand exactly how she modified it, it was clear that she had achieved something remarkable.

Luna had grown in her own way. She had been outstanding during our Academy days, but now she was influencing the entire Empire.

A smile formed on my face seeing Luna's progress.

"That's impressive."

Luna, perhaps embarrassed by my praise, bowed her head and scratched her hair.

"But how do we unlock this now?"

The sight of Luna scratching her head with the handcuffs on felt somewhat odd.

There must be a way to unlock them.

I hadn't seen anything like a keyhole when I looked earlier.

"Oh, there's a separate unlocking spell for that..."

Luna said this while looking at the handcuffs.

The person wearing the handcuffs was Luna, and the one who knew the unlocking spell was also Luna.

"Ah..."

Luna stared blankly at the handcuffs for a few seconds, then slowly raised her head, making a pitiful face at me.

"Ru, Rudy... Can you unlock this for me..."

"..."

Luna's skills might have changed, but her personality was still the same.

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Luna and I both bowed our heads.

"I'm sorry....."

"Ahaha..... That can happen."

The handcuffs were finally removed after Luna visited another wizard.

It took some time, but it didn't hinder our progress.

"Suspecting the head wizard?"

"It's a suspicion..... but I came to check, just in case."

The candidates we had considered were the Empire's head wizard and the Prime Minister.

Anyone nearby would say it's foolish.

Considering what the two have sacrificed for the Empire, it seemed implausible.

But still, we couldn't not investigate.

They could have been feigning loyalty to the Empire while engaging in questionable activities.

"So..... should we ask the head wizard directly?"

".....That's not possible."

Whether that person is a user of time magic or not, they would respond the same.

A real time wizard wouldn't just admit, 'Yes, I use time magic~', would they?

"Then?"

"There's the head wizard's private library."

"Yes, that exists. But how do we get in....."

I pulled out a small necklace from my pocket.

The necklace had a transparent orb emitting a mysterious light, but it was cracked.

"What is that?"

"A magical tool that enables spatial magic."

It was the tool I used when going to rescue Astina.

It was only used once, but it was in terrible condition.

It seemed it would break with even the slightest touch.

Even well-crafted tools seemed unable to withstand spatial magic.

Luna, holding the necklace, looked at it blankly then frowned.

"Isn't this..... broken?"

"It seems almost unusable, but it might work for short distances."

There was still mana left in the necklace.

It seemed capable of use, but unlikely for long distances like last time.

"So, what do we do.....?"

"I'll go into the private library alone. Luna, you get the head wizard to open the door. I'll sneak out in the meantime."

Given the state of the necklace, it seemed it could only be used once more.

So, when exiting, someone's help would be necessary.

"Me, lure the head wizard into the private library? More importantly, can you sneak out when the head wizard enters?"

"We have to try. If the door is open, I think I can find a way out....."

I couldn't give a definitive answer.

It might be possible with a normal vault, but this was the Empire's head wizard.

Unknown magics could be set up there.

"This seems too reckless....."

"It's okay. The tool might not break in one use, and if it does, there's another way."

"Another way?"

"I'll claim the tool activated automatically due to its poor condition."

".....Will that work?"

"Since no one knows about spatial magic, they can't outright say it's a lie."

No tool for spatial magic exists, even in the Royal Tower of Magic.

So, even if I made up some excuse, there would be no way to verify whether my words were true or not.

I didn't believe the head wizard of the Empire, who was on our side, would do anything to me.

If there was nothing incriminating against me, I wouldn't be pursued.

"Shall we try then?"

With that, I separated from Luna and headed towards the upper floors of the wizard Tower.

According to Luna, the head wizard's library was located at the very top of this tower.

My destination was deeper inside, the head wizard's personal research lab, beyond the library.

While high-ranking individuals could enter the library, the research lab was off-limits to everyone except the head wizard.

It contained materials that the head wizard was personally researching.

These materials were national secrets and almost treasures.

If they fell into the wrong hands, the magical documents, dangerous if misused, were piled up in a room that no one but the Emperor could enter.

Usually, high-ranking families store their documents in their personal residences.

The head wizard, although a noble of high standing, was an honorary noble without a domain.

As a nominal noble without a proper mansion, it was certain that all his valuables, including personal items, were in his lab.

Thump-thump—

"Is this the place.....?"

I knocked on the ceiling.

I was in the library directly below the head wizard's research lab.

It was a library used by the Royal Wizards, accessible to everyone, but I had struggled to get here.

It wouldn't be good if it was discovered that I, not an Royal wizard, was wandering around alone, so I came here without attracting attention.

Closing my eyes, I focused upward, sensing the flow of mana and the space around me.

The room above the ceiling was enveloped in mana.

I wasn't sure exactly what kind of magic it was, but it seemed designed to prevent external intrusion.

However, such magic was not a major concern for me.

Ordinary people would definitely have to pass through this magic as it covered the entire wall.

But, with teleportation magic, I could enter without passing through the wall, so it wasn't an issue.

I held the necklace in my hand and looked upwards.

"Teleport."

Suddenly, a strong light emanated from the necklace.

It enveloped me, and my surroundings shifted.

Numerous bookshelves and books appeared.

Although I was already in a library, this room was different.

Unorganized books were stacked on the side, and some books were heavily coated with dust.

It seemed disorganized because it was inaccessible to most.

"I'm in."

Clang—

But then, the magical tool shattered.

I had anticipated this, but still, seeing it break made me sigh.

Is Luna my only hope now.....?

I wondered if I had put too much pressure on her.

But I couldn't just stand still.

I put the broken tool in my pocket and looked around the room.

Compared to the library I had just been in, shabbier books caught my eye here.

I browsed through them as I moved forward.

Then, another bookshelf appeared.

The room was like a maze, and since the entire top floor was the head wizard's area, I had expected some empty space, but it was packed with books.

Not all of them were printed; some seemed to be handwritten, possibly by previous generations of head wizards.

As I meandered around, I stumbled upon a door.

One looked like an exit, and the other...

"Is that the research lab?"

I cautiously approached the room, and out of curiosity, I read the flow of mana again.

"Ah..."

Mana spread like a spider's web.

Inside the room, dozens of mana strands extended.

It was as if the mana was filling the room like yarn in a spool.

If I entered now, I'd be discovered immediately.

"There's no way the head wizard didn't prepare for this."

A person like the head wizard would undoubtedly know about spatial magic.

The magic in the lab seemed to be a countermeasure against spatial magic.

While I could get into the library, the inner lab was off-limits.

The head wizard seemed to be saying just that.

What should I do?

I had read the mana flow before entering the library, but from outside, it was too faint to detect.

The flow was weak, indicating the magic wasn't strong, but the sheer quantity was overwhelming.

It would take ages to dismantle them one by one.

I stood in front of the room, pondering over the flow.

Just then, as I was deep in thought...

".....Rudy Astria?"

Suddenly, a voice came from behind me.

There was no sound of approach.

Where did it come from?

I quickly turned around.

Behind me stood a man resembling me, a bit taller, with blonde hair.

It was my brother, Ian Astria.

".....?"

I stared at Ian, puzzled.

"Why are you here?"

".....Why are you here?"

I asked, glancing around.

Nothing else had changed.

".....Did you come in using spatial magic?"

"Yes. How did you get here? You can't use spatial magic yet, can you?"

I couldn't let Ian find out about the magical tool; it was stolen from a vault.

"I made my own arrangements."

".....Hmm."

Ian looked at me skeptically, then scanned the area.

"Doesn't seem like you had permission to enter."

"Isn't that the same for you?"

"Why did you come here?"

"Why did you come?"

I parroted his question, and Ian ran his hand through his hair.

"We won't gain anything by staying here for long. Answer me quickly."

"You first. If we're caught here, it's worse for you, isn't it?"

Ian scowled and glared at me before speaking.

"The head wizard is suspected of using time magic."

Hearing this, I felt that my suspicions held some credibility.

"Is it because of the time magic incident in the palace?"

"You know about it?"

"If so, there's no need for further explanation."

Our goals aligned.

The head wizard's research lab.

I extended my hand towards the lab.

"Can you handle the magic inside?"

I didn't think highly of Ian, but his magical skills were superior to mine.

Having followed the elite course since the academy, Ian's current abilities were beyond my estimation.

Ian walked towards the front of the lab.

"Hmm..."

He briefly examined the room, then spoke.

"It's not impossible."

Why say 'not impossible' instead of just possible?

I narrowed my eyes and looked at Ian.

"That means it's going to be difficult."

As if reading my thoughts, Ian added and extended his hand.

"Let's go inside."

"Right now?"

As soon as I spoke, Ian opened the door to the research lab.

Chapter 241: Past and Future (8)

".....?"

My eyes widened and looked around the room.

The first thing that caught my eye was dozens of portraits.

Portraits on the wall and the writing next to them.

In the center, there was a picture of Perrian Astria hanging.

"What is this?"

I narrowed my eyes and read the letters written next to it.

[Where do you intend to use necromancy?]

Reading that made me feel like I had been hit on the back of the head.

I quickly looked at the portraits next to it as well.

There were portraits of Daemon, the leader of the rebels, portraits of a teacher defeated by Robert in the past, and portraits of family heads related to the Astria family like the Fred family.

This was a relationship diagram between the Astria family and necromancers.

"They were investigating necromancy?"

I hadn't imagined it.

It wasn't only Robert who was digging into the Astria family's background.

A head wizard was also digging into the Astria family's background like us.

I looked at Ian, putting my surprise behind me.

Ian was surprised like me, but it was clear this wasn't the first time he had seen something like this.

"Did you know?"

"I didn't know the head wizard was investigating this."

That meant Ian was aware that necromancy was being studied.

"How did you know?"

"I found out by chance. More importantly, see if there is anything about time magic."

Ian, touching the wall.

He was commanding me, unable to take his hand off the wall.

"Understood."

I immediately entered the room.

After that, I quickly looked around the desk and drawers.

But I didn't find any evidence.

Knowing that they were investigating the Astria family, one could say the suspicion of being a time magic user was cleared.

The time magic user was someone who was hiding the fact that they were a time magic user and had raised Aryandor.

I wasn't sure of the exact intention, but I thought that person wouldn't do anything beneficial for the empire.

"There is nothing worth mentioning. It's all about the Astria family....."

".....Then come out quickly."

Ian yelled at me, clearly struggling to control his magic.

I tried to quickly leave the room.

At that moment, Ian raised his eyebrows.

Ian quickly took his hand off the wall and turned around.

Then he stretched his hand forward.

"Where do you think you're going?"

"Rudy....."

Behind Ian, there was the head wizard pointing his staff at Luna.

I looked at the clock next to me, surprised by the sudden appearance of the head wizard.

It wasn't time for my appointment with Luna yet.

The appointment with Luna was in an hour.

Yet, even though it hadn't been 30 minutes, the head wizard had arrived.

"How did you know?"

"You wouldn't investigate the Astria family without being prepared for Astria's spatial magic, would you?"

Ian wouldn't have used magic carelessly.

That means the head wizard knew we had entered from the start.

"Are you not going to lower that hand?"

The head wizard tapped Ian's head with his staff.

Ian carefully lowered his hand that had been stretched out.

"Then answer my question. If you don't tell the truth or even move your mana slightly, your head will fly off immediately."

"Understood."

"When did you know that Perrian was harboring necromancers?"

"Not long ago."

"How did you find out?"

"My father told me directly."

"So, are you saying you're also part of it?"

"No."

"Hmm..."

The head wizard smacked his lips after hearing Ian's answer.

"Even if Rudy is one thing, you're the problem."

"You don't have to worry about that. I didn't come here for that reason."

"Then why did you come?"

"I suspected you were a time magic user."

"...Time magic user?"

When Ian said that, the head wizard's eyes turned towards me.

"...I thought the same."

"Ha... How could you both have such a misunderstanding? Didn't Robert tell you anything about me?"

"...Professor Robert?"

I tilted my head at the sudden mention of Robert's name.

"Robert and I were disciples of Lord Levian together."

"...What?"

"How long I've been with that guy. If I tell him about this, he would laugh his head off."

The head wizard and Professor Robert...?

I widened my eyes at this new information.

The head wizard looked much older than Professor Robert.

His beard was bushy, and his face was lined with deep wrinkles.

"Don't worry, there are many who can vouch for me."

"Understood... But we..."

The head wizard lowered his staff and gestured to us.

"Both of you, follow me. Luna, you come too."

"Yes...!"

Luna, who had been fidgeting in the back, nodded at the head wizard's words.

"I won't disclose that you came here. But that doesn't mean I won't do anything."

The head wizard tapped the desk with his staff.

"Whether or not someone becomes the master of Astria doesn't concern me much. However, I am opposed to anyone inheriting the Astria family in its current state. I don't know what thoughts and ideologies you have, but I don't think adults would reject such a great power in front of them."

"What do you want us to do?"

At Ian's words, the head wizard smiled.

"Collaborate. To take down your father."

My eyes widened and I looked at Ian.

Ian's eyes narrowed and glared at the head wizard.

"What do you mean by collaborate?"

"Exactly as it sounds. Combine your strengths to uncover the secrets of Astria. And when everything is over, then you may compete."

"Please, be more specific."

"Ian, teach Rudy Astria spatial magic. Rudy Astria, tell those around you to fully support Ian."

"Collaborate amicably as brothers."

Thump—

"That's ridiculous."

Ian said, slamming the desk.

"What do you suggest we do if it's ridiculous? Do you want to go to jail?"

"Do you think teaching spatial magic and collaborating are equivalent?"

"There are more capable people around Rudy Astria than you think. Enough to help you win the succession battle perfectly."

"As you know, even if things continue as they are now, I am winning the succession battle. Are you saying to risk it all for this?"

"Are you worried?"

The head wizard glared at Ian while stroking his beard.

"Are you worried that Rudy Astria will learn spatial magic perfectly, and you'll fail to utilize the people around you? Are you doubting your abilities?"

"...No. It's because the value of the help from those around me and spatial magic are as different as heaven and earth."

"I think they are of similar value. Think about the people around Rudy. Astina, Rie, and even the professors at the academy helping you."

"Those people won't necessarily become mine, will they?"

"That depends on how well you do. How would they know whether to help you without seeing your abilities and character?"

Ian frowned.

"Do you think the people around Rudy will help me properly?"

"I think if Rudy just speaks up they will. Rudy Astria, what do you think?"

"I'm not sure, but I'll talk to them."

This was a no-loss deal for me.

I could learn spatial magic and stop Perrian Astria.

Ian, dissatisfied, said,

"Do you really need to teach me spatial magic? Aren't there many other ways we can collaborate?"

"That's something you'll come to know as you investigate Perrian."

The head wizard pulled out a bundle of papers from under the desk.

He pushed the bundle towards us.

"Investigating Perrian becomes much easier with spatial magic."

Turning the pages, a lot of documents related to Perrian unfolded.

Documents on how he tried to hide necromancy and related activities, and about those places.

"Perrian uses spatial magic to dig out spaces behind walls or near the mansion. He creates secret spaces without leaving any trace."

The mansion in the capital had a vault, similar to what the head wizard described.

"You can't normally discover such places. That's why spatial magic is needed."

"...Then, what does it mean for Rudy's acquaintances to help me?"

"You have a different task."

"A task?"

"Things involving political pressure and military power. I'll leave that to you."

The head wizard said this and laughed.

"I'll provide the exact details separately. Explaining here will only waste time. I'll send the documents secretly, so wait for them when you return. And Luna?"

"Yes?"

"Help me out a bit."

Chapter 242: Past and Future (9)

A dark night.

I put on my hood and left the mansion.

There was not a single person on the street, and the only light came from the moon.

Chirp chirp—

In the quiet space, only the sound of insects could be heard.

There, a small cabin with lights on was visible.

It was located on the outskirts of the capital, to the extent that one might wonder if such a place even existed there.

I opened the door to the cabin and entered.

"Have you arrived?"

Inside was Ian Astria, sitting in a chair.

I had come to meet Ian to learn spatial magic.

A few days after meeting the head wizard.

I wrote letters to everyone around me, including Rie and Astina.

The content of the letters was to cooperate with Ian Astria.

I couldn't write the details, but everyone responded to my request after I sent letters saying I would explain in detail later.

"Are my friends being of any help to you?"

"The number of people nitpicking at my side has just increased, which is annoying."

Even though he said that, work was progressing smoothly.

Rie and Astina were helping, and McDowell, who was still in the capital, was also helping him.

The empire was abuzz with talk about him these days.

It was strange that people from the Emperor's faction were helping Ian all of a sudden.

"How is it going?"

"When passing through the capital, it was decided that the Royal army would inspect the luggage. It seems that other things are also progressing well."

What Ian had planned was direct pressure on Perrian.

Perrian had no choice but to stay at the mansion by the emperor's order.

To research necromancy magic, he had to move related luggage to the capital.

Ian used the excuse of blocking the passage of the rebels to have the Royal army search the luggage.

This meant that it would be impossible to bring in items related to necromancy magic through other people.

However, inspecting the luggage wouldn't prevent everything.

If Perrian tried to bring in the luggage using spatial magic, there was no way to stop him.

That's where my role was needed.

If he tried to leave the mansion using spatial magic, I would follow him using spatial magic.

I would check what Perrian was doing and what luggage he was bringing in.

If he had created a hidden place using spatial magic, I would check that place and inform others.

But for that, I first needed to learn spatial magic...

"The blocking of passage through the empire starts in a week. I barely managed to convince your friends to delay."

"Ahaha....."

I thought it must have been Rie.

Rie had the personality to start things right away once decided.

Thanks to her willingness to follow Ian's instructions, they managed to adjust the timing appropriately.

"Then, let's end our chat here, and I'll teach you spatial magic right away."

"Understood."

Then Ian used spatial magic.

A small hole appeared next to Ian, and he put his hand into that hole.

"This is the material I've compiled about spatial magic."

What came out of the hole was a document about spatial magic, written in Ian's handwriting.

I looked at the material and widened my eyes.

"Isn't it forbidden to leave records about spatial magic?"

"Then, is it acceptable to commit an act of filial impiety towards my father? After all, it's all the same if everything here is burned."

It was somewhat peculiar when Ian spoke like that.

For now, I started to skim through the material Ian had given me.

"You're not supposed to read it now. Since I can't stay here long, study it after I've left."

"...What?"

He was giving it to me to study?

"There's only a week left. You must learn to use spatial magic within a week. And you should also be able to use some small applications of it. So, I will teach you directly."

I widened my eyes.

Ian was seriously planning to teach me.

I had received some instruction from Ian before.

When he taught me the basics of spatial magic, he made it really easy to understand.

Because Ian's understanding of magic theory was exceptional, even I, who knew nothing about spatial magic, could easily learn it.

The fact that Ian was going to teach me directly meant that he intended for me to use spatial magic properly.

"Then, I will teach you how to use spatial magic."

Ian placed a blank sheet of paper in front of me.

"Seeing how you figured out time magic usage last time, it appears you can properly perceive space."

"Yes, I can."

"But you haven't been able to use spatial magic yet."

"Yes, that's correct."

Then Ian drew a small square on the paper.

After drawing the square, he started to mark small dots in it.

"Let's start then. This is the space you are perceiving. Right?"

"Yes, that's correct."

Ian drew a small circle inside the square.

"Let's consider this circle as you. Do you properly understand the reality and spatial realms?"

"Yes, events occurring in reality cannot affect the spatial realm, but events occurring in the spatial realm can affect reality. Is that correct?"

"That's right, events in reality cannot affect the spatial realm. However, it's different when permission to enter the spatial realm is granted. We, the Astria family, have been passed down the knowledge of spatial magic. Therefore, even a person existing in reality can affect the spatial realm."

Ian continued his explanation.

"But that doesn't mean you can make significant changes to the spatial realm. You can't even scratch it. This place isn't meant to be tampered with

by beings from reality. Even though we can handle the spatial realm, it means there are limits."

This raised a question for me.

"Then, what about spatial severance magic? Isn't it about tearing space? How is that done?"

Ian narrowed his eyes at my question.

"I'm not explaining it now. Save your questions for the end; just listen for now."

"...Understood."

"As you said, spatial severance or teleportation might seem to us like acts of tearing or damaging space. However, spatial magic is not like that."

Ian connected the dots drawn in the square with a line.

"Now, the square appears to be divided into two."

"Yes."

Saying that, Ian began to draw lines haphazardly.

"Imagine dividing this square into dozens of pieces. Then, move these divided spaces according to the rules of space."

"...Move them?"

"Just as the empire follows its laws, in the spatial realm, we must follow the rules of the spatial realm. The rules of space are simply about moving the divided spaces like a puzzle. So, we can't use any method other than moving the spaces divided according to the rules of the spatial realm."

"Dividing and moving space..."

"Think of it as dividing a room. We are the administrators who can move these divided rooms. We change the space we are in with the space next to it, and make adjacent spaces separate. That's what spatial magic is."

Reality is divided into rooms in the spatial realm, and those rooms are moved.

Since it happens in the spatial realm, it makes possible what is impossible in reality.

There, the spaces are clearly divided like rooms, but in reality, they are invisible, so they appear to disappear and move instantly, making reality appear to be torn.

Trying to understand a realm invisible in reality felt like I could grasp it, yet it remained elusive.

"Let's continue. If you don't understand, I'll explain again later, so keep listening."

"Understood."

And so, Ian's explanation continued.

Ian's explanation was easy to understand.

I could grasp it theoretically, but the content was so complex that I couldn't apply it practically.

It's natural to find it difficult when you're trying to go into practice after listening to theoretical lectures that others would hear over several months, all at once.

Still, I had to succeed.

After practicing alone for a few minutes,

Ian tapped the desk lightly.

"I'll have to go back now. If I stay here any longer, I might get caught."

"Ah. Understood. Please go back now."

Ian began to hastily gather his things.

"I'll have some time in about three days; I'll check on your magic then."

"Understood."

The magic I needed now was teleportation.

I didn't need any other magic at the moment.

Though he said he'd have time in three days, the fact that we were meeting at such late hours made it nonsensical to talk about having a scheduled time.

He had scheduled it that way, judging that I could learn teleportation within three days.

Even though he spoke in a dismissive tone, he was treating me quite humanely.

He was being considerate in his own way, and I felt respected.

Seeing Ian like this made me curious about something.

The current situation.

Ian is trying to push Perrian out.

But, given the relationship between Ian and Perrian, could he really do that?

Perrian actively supported Ian, and Ian followed his father.

This fact hasn't changed much even now.

If Perrian hadn't trusted Ian, he wouldn't have shown him necromancy magic.

Yet, Ian is trying to act against Perrian.

To me, that man doesn't feel like a father, so that's that, but it's not the same for Ian.

Perrian treated Ian as a father, and Ian treated Perrian as such.

Could such a relationship crumble overnight?

Just because the head wizard found fault?

I couldn't understand what he was thinking.

"Then, I should be going."

Ian picked up his belongings and headed towards the door.

I watched Ian's back as he left.

"Brother."

"...What is it?"

"What do you think about pushing father out?"

"...What kind of out-of-the-blue question is that?"

"...No, it's nothing. Just a sudden question that came to mind."

Ian opened the door to the cabin with an indifferent expression.

"It's just something that needs to be done."

Ian said that and went outside.

Chapter 243: Past and Future (10)

"Rudy, what do you want to do?"

"Heh, since we've also received help from the guy, we should do as he says."

McDowell said, looking at Cromwell, who was frowning.

"That's true, but... It would have been fine if Rudy had asked for help in inheriting the family, but he's asking us to help Ian."

"He must have his reasons for asking for help. He must be unable to speak because there's a special circumstance."

Originally, the academy did not interfere in politics at all.

Whether it was the principal or an ordinary professor, they never got involved in political matters.

Yet, McDowell was now exerting influence in politics.

The Royal army's inspection and search of goods and people.

McDowell had actively supported this.

Even though it was Ian's opinion, everyone around Rudy had also shown their active support.

"It looks like he's planning something, asking others for help as well."

"Hmm... Alright. I'll be heading back for now. Please take care of Rudy Astria."

"Understood."

Neither the vice-principal nor the principal of the academy could afford to be away for a long time.

Cromwell was preparing to return to the academy.

After packing some of his belongings, Cromwell stepped outside and looked around.

"Spring is about to come."

Flower buds were starting to form on the trees, and green leaves were present.

Winter was passing, and spring was approaching.

The academy had a lot to do when spring came.

They had to prepare for the admission of new students, and before that, there was the graduation ceremony for the third-year students.

"It's going to be busy."

With that, Cromwell sighed and was about to depart for the academy.

"Cromwell."

Then, a voice was heard from behind.

"...Robert?"

As Cromwell turned around, he saw Robert wearing a hood.

"Why are you here... No, what about the necromancers?"

Robert approached with a smile.

"The necromancers have been dealt with."

"Then you should have contacted us. Or, does anyone else know?"

"No one knows. If it got out to too many, Perrian Astria might find out, so we're keeping it hidden for now."

"I see... But, why are you here... No, what have you been doing all this time?"

It had been more than a fortnight since Robert had gone to deal with the necromancers.

It shouldn't have taken that long to deal with the necromancers.

"I went to see my wife and son."

His wife and son.

That meant he had visited their graves.

"Ah..."

Cromwell did not ask further.

The fact that Robert's son had died due to necromancy was well known to Cromwell, a close friend of his.

Since the Astria territory was also near the cemetery, he accepted it and moved on.

"Will you return with me? I'm about to head to the academy."

"No, I came here because I have things to do."

"Things to do, you say?"

"More importantly, do you have a cigarette?"

Cromwell gave Robert a puzzled look upon hearing his question.

In the past, Robert was a smoker but had quit smoking after his son's death.

"I do have some."

"Then give me one."

Cromwell, tilting his head, took out a cigarette from his pocket and handed it to Robert.

"Why are you stingily giving me just one?"

Grumbling, Robert snatched the pack of cigarettes Cromwell was holding in his other hand.

"I'll borrow these."

"...What are you, some delinquent borrowing stuff?"

Cromwell clicked his tongue and put a cigarette in his mouth.

"I'm leaving now."

"What...?"

Cromwell thought Robert wanted to smoke together by asking for the cigarette, but Robert had already started walking away.

"See you at the academy. Buy me a drink if you do."

Cromwell watched Robert walking away with a look of disbelief.

"Tsk. Heartless."

Cromwell muttered to himself and lit the cigarette, then just watched the rising smoke.

"Why isn't this working?"

I had been continuously using magic, considering the theory of spatial magic that Ian had mentioned.

Yet, it wasn't working properly.

Theory is theory, and practice is practice.

Even if I had grasped the theory to some extent, it was not easy to use it successfully.

"Still, it's better than when I first learned dark magic."

I don't even want to think about when I first learned dark magic.

Back then, I suffered from all kinds of curses.

Compared to that, spatial magic was relatively better.

Even if I failed, I wasn't cursed or in pain.

The problem was the time constraint.

I was given a week.

Now, only four days are left.

Three days have passed, but there has been no significant progress.

I've never felt this stuck before.

In reality, I've been studying spatial magic for over two months, not just the three days since I learned from Ian.

Though many things have happened in the meantime, that's just an excuse.

Most of the events only lasted a day or two while I was studying.

So, it wasn't like I didn't have time.

I spent most of my time learning spatial magic and put in the effort.

Feeling this powerless made me think of one thing.

'Talent.'

I had never thought about talent before.

I overcame everything with effort.

That doesn't mean I thought I had no talent.

I must have had talent to have come this far.

But now, I'm facing a huge wall.

I don't deny the existence of talent.

Surely, factors like the environment one grows up in create differences between people.

In my previous life, I gave up on many things because of this.

I was someone without talent.

I was someone who couldn't make it work.

However, coming to this world changed that mindset.

Effort can overcome the lack of talent.

Once you start blaming talent, there's no more growth.

That's what I thought.

Looking back now, I wonder if I said such things because I had talent.

I made an effort because I had talent, and I could say such things because I had talent.

And now, it seemed like I had hit a wall of talent.

There seemed to be a limit to my talent, and I wondered if this was it.

Of course, in the future I saw, I was using spatial magic.

If you ask whether the future me is completely the same as the current me, I couldn't answer.

There were similarities, but the me from that world and the current me are clearly different people.

I had no idea what environments the future me had gone through or how I had lived.

"Young master Rudy Astria."

As I was sighing, a maid came down to the study.

"A man named Robert is looking for you, Lord Rudy."

"...Professor Robert?"

My eyes widened.

There was no reason for Robert to be in the capital.

I quickly ran to the front of the mansion.

"Professor?"

"It's been a while, Rudy."

Indeed, Robert was in front of the mansion.

"What brings you here... At this time?"

It was already almost dusk.

Dinner time had passed, and it was the time when early sleepers would have already gone to bed.

Robert pointed towards the mansion and smiled as he spoke.

"If you're not going to keep standing here, shall we go inside?"

With a bewildered expression, I nodded.

"Ah, yes... Please come in."

I led Robert into the mansion and guided him to the study.

"Doesn't this mansion have a reception room? Why lead me through such a mess?"

"I thought you usually don't care about such things... I led you here because my father is in the mansion."

I checked to make sure no one was around and quietly said to Robert.

"You and the necromancers have a bad history, don't you?"

I had led him to the study because it wouldn't be good if the professor and my father faced each other.

"More importantly, did 'that matter' go well?"

'That matter' referred to the necromancers in the Astria territory.

I had written a letter to Professor Robert.

Even if I hadn't written it, Professor Robert would have known it was the best opportunity to catch the necromancers.

Robert touched his ear as if my question was bothersome.

"Never mind that. How's your magic study going these days?"

Never mind that...

Though I was very curious about it, I answered the question he asked.

"Just so-so. I'm in a slump... or maybe I've hit a wall of talent..."

"A wall of talent? Pfft."

Robert burst out laughing after saying that.

"Why are you laughing..."

"What wall of talent. What nonsensical talk."

"Have you never felt such a wall, Professor Robert?"

"Of course, I have. No, many times. I've lived many more years than you, so naturally, I've felt it."

"Then why laugh?"

"Because it's not a wall of talent."

I narrowed my eyes and glared at Robert.

"Then what is it?"

"It's just a process. The process of everything. Haven't you experienced such things often? Before you learned dark magic from me and even after that."

Before learning dark magic from Robert...

Certainly, it was a grinding experience.

I had kept trying dark magic to pass the tests Robert set.

Back then, it was essential for survival, so I really did it as if it was a matter of life and death.

"But isn't it different now compared to then?"

"How so?"

"That was when learning basic dark magic, and now it's..."

Spatial magic.

Spatial magic, which is really used by only a few people.

I might not have the talent for it.

"Do you know how much talent you have?"

"...I don't know."

"Then what's the problem?"

"...What?"

"Just do it. If you're not going to quit, just do it."

"But..."

"You don't know how much talent you have. No one does, really. So are you going to quit? Give up? No, you're not. If you're going to continue, then stop digging yourself into a hole and just do it. If you still fail, then think about why. Was it because of lack of time, lack of effort, or really a lack of talent?"

Robert said that and then tapped my forehead.

"Think later. Now is the time to focus on what you have to do."

With that, Robert stood up.

"...Professor?"

"You have an appointment, right?"

My eyes widened at his words.

Looking at the time, it was nearly time to go to the cabin to meet Ian.

"How did you know?"

"I can roughly tell. Now, I'm off."

"There's still time. How about a cup of tea..."

"What tea? When have I ever been one to sit and drink tea."

Robert snorted and walked out.

"Huh..."

I wore a baffled expression at his sudden visit and just as sudden departure.

He had always been like that, but seeing him after a long time brought a fresh sense of nostalgia.

Still, a smile formed on my lips.

It felt like I had found the direction I had lost.

"Take care, Master."

I bid farewell to Robert's departing figure.

Robert walked out, only raising his hand without turning back.

Chapter 244: Past and Future (11)

"Come on, come on! You can line up here! Don't push!"

It was the line to enter the capital of the Empire.

A checkpoint had been established to enter the capital.

"That person..."

"Oh, if it's a man with blonde hair, isn't that him?"

There was someone who attracted the attention of the people in the long line.

Ian Astria.

The commander of the Royal Army stood prominently where the gatekeepers were.

With him standing in front of the city gate, the soldiers were also tense and disciplined, and the people entering opened their luggage without complaints.

This was exactly what Ian had intended.

If discipline was lax from the beginning, the outcome would be predictable without even looking.

Luggage checks were not being conducted properly, and if one was a noble, their luggage wouldn't even be opened.

Therefore, it was necessary to properly implement checks from the start to maintain discipline.

Ian stood there quietly, watching people enter.

"The operation is going well, but..."

Ian watched the line while thinking something else.

"I wonder what happened to Rudy."

Ian had not heard from Rudy since meeting him four days ago.

Rudy was unable to use spatial magic just four days ago.

He understood the basic theory but had difficulty implementing it.

Ian had many thoughts upon seeing this.

He wondered if it was too much to ask to use spatial magic within a week.

Even for Ian, it had taken more than a month to learn properly.

Nevertheless, there was no time to relax.

The head wizard had said that there wasn't much time left.

The leeway made for Rudy was a week, considering the circumstances.

"If Rudy can't handle spatial magic, do we need to prepare another method?"

The operation had already begun.

Blocking the passage to the capital was just the beginning, and the subsequent actions were already underway.

Rudy's help was essential to properly carry out the rest of the operations.

If Rudy couldn't provide proper assistance, the strategy would need to be slightly adjusted.

"Did I gamble too much?"

Pushing aside his father.

Ian had many doubts about this action itself.

To Ian, his father was the strongest and most magnificent.

Father, always dignified as a Duke of the Empire.

Yet, he had taken a stand against him because he judged that his father was no longer the same.

The spark inside his father's eyes had already disappeared.

His eyes were filled only with desire.

Ian didn't necessarily think that desire was bad.

Desire makes people grow and reach higher places.

However, his father had gone off track somewhere.

No matter how much he respected and followed him, the actions his father intended to take had to be stopped.

"Commander."

At that moment, a woman approached Ian's side.

A woman wearing a red uniform.

The woman was Astina.

"Now, I'll take over from here. Why don't you go and have a meal? We've prepared food in the barracks."

"...Understood. Thank you."

"Also, there's a message from Rie. She says things are going well."

"Things, huh..."

Ian's expression was subtle.

"Is there a problem?"

"It's about Rudy Astria. The issue is with him."

Then Astina spoke calmly.

"Then there shouldn't be a problem."

"...How do you know?"

"I know him well. I've had many of the same concerns as you, Commander. But, I often realize those worries are needless and feel foolish afterward. So, we just need to do what we have to do."

Ian furrowed his brow at Astina's words.

"Hmm... That's excessive trust."

"Because he has never betrayed such trust."

"Alright, I understand. I'll be going back."

Ian moved on.

Although Astina had such faith, Ian intended to prepare for the possibility of Rudy's failure.

With that, he went to the barracks for a meal.

"Good work!"

"Yes."

Ian passed the soldier guarding the front of the barracks and entered.

Inside, a meal was prepared, and there was a letter on top of it.

Ian picked up the letter puzzledly.

"...Hmm?"

Ian looked at the letter and then went outside.

"Is there a problem?"

"Did anyone come in?"

"Only the maids who prepared the meal, no one else. Is there something wrong?"

"...No."

Ian went back inside the barracks and stared intently at the letter.

"What's this?"

Ian immediately opened the letter.

The letter contained precisely one sentence.

[This is Rudy Astria. Enjoy your meal.]

"This is troublesome."

Perrian stroked his chin as he looked out the window.

Outside the window, the street was quieter than usual.

"Blocking the rebels' entry... The rebel scoundrels are making things difficult."

Perrian was bringing various materials into the capital.

Magic activated by mana stones created through summoning magic.

The documents he had been dealing with at the mansion were related to that.

All the documents were related to creating magic.

They were sent by necromancers and wizards outside the capital.

"Almost finished. Installing the magic shouldn't be a problem, but bringing in the magical tools will be."

Right now, in front of the capital, soldiers were not only checking luggage, but Ian and Astina were also there.

Both were exceptional wizards.

When bringing in magical tools, they would surely sense something was off.

Although they couldn't always be there as the commander and deputy commander of the Royal Army, caution was still needed.

"Should I ask Ian to do it?"

But that was problematic because there were too many eyes around Ian.

Now Ian had become too prominent a figure to be used carelessly.

Then, there was only one conclusion.

"I must go there myself."

Perrian gathered mana.

He hadn't used spatial magic much recently, so his skills had become a bit rusty.

Still, it wasn't to the point where he couldn't use it.

"Teleport."

As Perrian uttered the activation word, his view changed.

He arrived in a small room.

Perrian opened the door of the room and stepped out.

"...Perrian?"

As he came out of the room, he saw about a dozen wizards.

The place Perrian had arrived at was a workshop where wizards gathered.

A small workshop outside the capital.

It looked ordinary from the outside, but this place was a workshop where research was conducted using mana stones provided by Perrian.

"Is everything proceeding normally?"

As he asked, a person who looked like a high-ranking wizard ran over from a distance.

"Yes! Perrian, we are proceeding as ordered."

"How far has it progressed?"

"It's almost at the finishing stage. But regarding entering and exiting the capital..."

"I won't take any more reports on that. Since it's in the final stage, you can handle it yourselves."

"We can manage to a certain extent, but for things like the final magic circle..."

"I'll take care of that myself. Just do what you can."

"Understood."

Perrian looked around.

"How long do you think it will take?"

"A week... No, if we hurry, it might be possible within four days."

"Good, I'll trust and leave it to you."

Perrian was about to leave after receiving the report.

That's when the high-ranking wizard grabbed him.

"Perrian. There's something strange."

"Strange?"

"The ones providing the mana stones have been acting oddly lately."

"...Mana stones?"

Perrian narrowed his brows.

If it was about those supplying mana stones, he meant the necromancers.

Perrian hadn't noticed anything unusual in the reports the necromancers submitted to him.

After all, their reports were merely about how many people they had kidnapped and how many mana stones they had produced.

"The supply of mana stones is decreasing. And yesterday, we didn't receive any mana stones at all."

"Mana stones? I was told in the report that they were supplied?"

"No, we didn't receive any at all. We don't even know where they are, so we were just waiting."

"...What are they doing? Did they plan an escape because I'm not there?"

Perrian became annoyed.

"I'll take care of that part myself. For now, just do the tasks assigned to you."

"Understood."

The necromancers were acting strange...

'Thinking of joining the rebels?'

The only place that would take in necromancers was the rebels.

Only a family like the Astria could hide necromancers, as other families wouldn't even attempt to contact them.

'I'll have to check.'

"This is the final document. It's not much different, but there are some modifications, so it would be helpful if you read it."

"Alright."

Perrian took the documents handed over by the high-ranking wizard and manipulated mana.

"Teleport."

And then, Perrian disappeared.

"Now, did everyone hear that? We have four days left. Can we complete it by then?"

"Understood..."

The surrounding wizards spoke in a lifeless voice.

They had all been pulling all-nighters, enduring for over two weeks.

They were pushing forward with the work as fast as possible, under Perrian's orders.

'Ugh... My eyes hurt...'

'It feels like I can't even produce mana properly anymore...'

While the wizards were internally voicing their complaints.

Thud—

The sound of footsteps echoed.

That room was Perrian's private room.

It was the room Perrian used to come here through spatial magic.

"...Did you forget something?"

The high-ranking wizard, who had been responding to Perrian, tilted his head and looked towards the room.

Then.

Boom!

A huge explosion occurred near the room.

Most of the wizards couldn't react to the explosion and were swept away by it, falling to the ground.

However, the high-ranking wizard barely managed to use magic to block the explosion.

"What... What is this?"

The high-ranking wizard looked bewildered.

Then, a voice was heard.

"Everyone, stop moving."

It was a voice they hadn't heard before.

"If you move even slightly, whether it's your mana or your body, know that you will die."

As the smoke from the explosion cleared, the figure of a man appeared.

He had the same hair color as Perrian but looked much younger.

He wore gloves with mana stones embedded in them and was accompanied by a silver-colored wolf.

It was Rudy Astria.

Chapter 245: Past and Future (12)

It had been a hellish week.

I hadn't been able to sleep properly, skipped meals, and devoted myself to studying.

I don't think I have ever studied this hard before.

I did my best, just as Robert had advised.

And so, a week passed.

I succeeded in using spatial magic.

No, to be precise, I was able to use spatial magic on the 6th day.

On the 7th day, I used the technique that Ian had explained to me.

The technique Ian taught me was coordinate analysis.

It was a technique to find out where Perrian went when he used spatial magic.

I went through hell to use these two techniques, spatial teleportation and coordinate analysis.

It was a week I never wanted to experience again.

Still, the reward for this came quickly.

A wizard was tied up and collapsed next to me, and another wizard was kneeling and glaring at me.

And around me, magical research materials were scattered everywhere.

I asked while reading the messed-up research materials.

"So, what were you doing here?"

"You think I'd tell you?"

Most of the wizards had fallen at the first attack, but this wizard had resisted until the end.

Of course, I could easily defeat this wizard too.

For some reason, he had fallen without being able to use magic properly.

The magic he used was high-level.

However, the application of mana was a mess, and he had collapsed on his own before he could cast a spell.

It felt like he was already out of energy before I even faced him.

"Hmm..."

I read through the documents that had fallen to the floor, one by one.

I can't draw magic circles myself, but I had spent a long time beside Luna, who was good with them.

I've only been by Luna's side for two years, but those two years were enough for me.

After reading some of the documents, I looked at the wizard in front of me.

"You guys don't know anything?"

"What?"

I smiled broadly.

"You were just making it as told, without knowing what this magic tool would become."

That was the conclusion I drew after reading the documents.

"Do you know what this magic tool is used for?"

I pointed to the magic tool in front of me.

A magic tool as big as a person.

But this magic tool was really useless.

Not figuratively, but this tool was literally useless.

Since the wizard didn't answer, I spoke instead.

"That's an amplifier."

A magic tool amplifier.

The main magic circle hadn't been inserted into it yet.

This tool would only activate when a central magic circle is inserted into it.

Until then, it had been just a large piece of scrap metal.

"So, you must not have connected the middle circuit properly."

I showed the document I was holding to the wizard.

The document was a part of the blueprint for the central part.

The circuits on the side, excluding the central part, were perfect.

The mana stone's efficiency part was well constructed, and the circuit that amplified it was perfect.

However, there was no circuit leading to the center.

Surely, there should have been a main magic circle in the middle part, but even the circuit connecting to that part was completely empty.

That meant they had no idea what was supposed to go in the middle.

Of course, it could be that I was misunderstanding something just by looking at this document.

Still, the reason I had asked was to probe him.

"Ugh..."

The wizard in front of me frowned.

True to being a research wizard, he couldn't lie.

"Looks like I'm right."

I picked up a few documents and stood up.

These guys didn't know what Perrian was planning to do.

Then, there was no more reason to stay.

"So, shall we all go together?"

"...What?"

"To prison, where else?"

I smiled broadly.

"...What happened here?"

Perrian arrived at the Astria territory with a dumbfounded expression.

The place where the necromancers had gathered was in total disarray.

The number of wizards had drastically decreased, and all related documents had disappeared.

Moreover, while there were still necromancers present, they were not the ones who had held significant positions.

Only the insignificant ones remained.

"I'm sorry..."

"I asked what happened."

"...Professor Robert came."

"Robert? Why would he suddenly?"

Perrian naturally thought it was the work of the Emperor's faction or the rebels.

It made sense for the Emperor's faction to interfere with his work, and for the rebels, taking necromancers away would be a significant gain.

But the sudden mention of Robert's name was puzzling.

"He had been investigating the necromancers for a while."

"Why would he do that?"

"Remember the incident that happened with necromancy before? When Ephomos fell..."

"Ah, that incident?"

The incident where Robert's son died because of necromancy.

It was an event Perrian had considered insignificant, so he had dismissed it from his mind.

"Did he come for revenge?"

"It seems so."

"And you were defeated by such a person?"

"..."

"Pathetic and hopeless."

Perrian clicked his tongue and stroked his chin.

If it was the Academy, then they were closer to the Emperor's faction at the moment.

People like McDowell and Cromwell were close to Chancellor Ophillius, and despite the Academy's neutral stance, it ultimately followed the Emperor's will.

"Maybe he didn't come just for revenge."

Perrian looked around.

If he had come purely for revenge, there would be no reason to leave this place like this.

Leaving even a little bit meant it was to deceive him.

"So, you guys sent the letter."

"Yes... otherwise, he said he would kill us..."

Perrian stared at the wizard in front of him and extended his hand.

"Spatial Severance."

"...Huh?"

A gap in space appeared around the wizard's neck.

The necromancer reporting to Perrian was immediately decapitated, his head severed from his body.

"Ugh..."

"Huh..."

Blood spurted from the neck like a fountain.

The necromancers around widened their eyes and stared at the scene.

"Make the mana stones again."

When Perrian said that, the wizards murmured among themselves.

Then they quietly spoke up.

"We don't have the manpower to capture people anymore... and all the documents have disappeared..."

"Do you want to die too?"

"...Sigh."

"Pathetic creatures."

Perrian said that and turned his head.

He was looking towards where the vault had been.

Originally, it was a place where mana stones, filled with vast amounts of mana, were stored.

The vault had been emptied.

'That was a close call.'

However, there wasn't anything important inside.

Perrian had never trusted the necromancers from the beginning.

He had taken the mana stones with the most mana when he went to the capital.

'It was almost complete.'

The death of the necromancers was not a big issue, but the biggest problem was that this place had been exposed.

There hadn't been any reactions from the surroundings yet, but it would probably happen soon.

'Robert came here about 2 weeks ago.'

That meant there was still time.

Perrian had not been caught at the scene.

The only evidence was that necromancers existed in the Astria territory and the testimonies of the necromancers.

That meant a lengthy process would follow.

Capturing a duke of a country was not that easy.

'Ian will probably drag out the time.'

Ian already knew about this matter.

So, he thought that Ian would handle it calmly.

Moreover, if the necromancers started moving again, the public's attention would be drawn to the necromancers.

It would take some time to stop them.

Anyway, since the capable necromancers were dead, there was no use for them.

So, he planned to use them as bait and then discard them.

'I don't have time to be doing this.'

Completing the magic tool would take a week, but he planned to finish it in four days.

Even if various things delayed it, the fact that time was running out did not change.

"Then, I'll be going back."

Perrian said that and returned to the capital.

The necromancers looked at each other at the spot where Perrian had disappeared.

"What should we do?"

"...We don't have any other way to live, do we?"

Following Perrian's orders wouldn't guarantee survival.

If they did so, Robert would surely kill them all.

And if they didn't take any action, Perrian wouldn't just let them be.

"It's time for us to face the consequences of our actions."

They nodded in agreement, sharing the same thought.

Ian stood quietly, waiting for someone, and frowned when he saw a woman approaching him.

"...Why did you come?"

"Do you have a problem with that?"

Rie brushed her golden wavy hair aside and smiled brightly.

"Wasn't there anyone else?"

"There were others, but none as trustworthy. At least one of the two of us should be someone reliable, don't you think?"

"This is absurd."

Ian turned his head away from Rie and walked forward.

Rie followed him.

The same armbands were worn on the arms of both as they walked.

These armbands bore the symbol of the royal family, a golden dragon, and a sword with ornate patterns.

It signified that they were special investigators appointed by the royal family.

"I hoped that someone competent would come."

"I'll manage fine on my own, so you better do your part properly."

They stopped walking, each annoyed with the other.

In front of them was the Astria family's mansion.

Chapter 246: Past and Future (13)

".....What the hell is this, Ian?"

"I've come as a special investigator of the Empire. Perrian Astria, I am arresting you on charges of using necromancy and for treason."

Ian handed Perrian some documents.

The contents of the documents were the same as what Ian had stated.

The Emperor's seal and signatures from various nobles were on them.

It meant that the content had already been approved in a meeting.

Perrian's eyes widened as he looked at the document.

It would have taken a lot of time for such a document to be issued.

The noble faction and the Emperor's faction had to negotiate to come to such a conclusion.

Many procedures were required before such a document could be approved.

It was a speed that Perrian's mind could not understand.

Of course, the reason it could be issued so quickly was due to many things that had been accumulated over time.

Luna and the head wizard personally organized the documents and handed them over to Ian and Rie, and Ian and Rie had talked in advance before the meeting took place.

When the leaders of the Emperor's faction and the noble faction presented the same opinion at the meeting, the nobles below them just followed their will.

Thus, when the intentions of the Emperor's faction and the noble faction were united, the process was expedited.

There were no delays, and the documents were processed quickly, proceeding through all the procedures at an unbelievable speed.

Perrian could not have predicted such an abnormal situation.

"Damn it... Ian Astria!!!"

Perrian yelled at Ian, his veins bulging.

Ian calmly extended the handcuffs to Perrian.

"I am here as a special investigator now. Please behave accordingly."

"Do you think you'll succeed as the head of the family by doing this? Do you know what will happen if I speak to the other nobles?"

"Father is a suspect now. No one in the Empire would listen to such a person."

Ian answered firmly.

Perrian scoffed at him.

"You think you can survive politically by siding with those of the Emperor's faction? You're just going to end up as a dog chasing chickens, discarded by them..."

Click—

"Now, criminal, please keep your mouth shut. Shall we proceed with the investigation? Or are you going to keep chatting?"

Rie handcuffed Perrian in front of her with a smile.

"Ha... Princess, do you think I'll end like this? Do you think this will just pass quietly? You've made a mistake."

"Yes, yes. Let's continue this conversation in jail."

Rie dragged Perrian away.

Ian licked his lips as he watched Perrian's back.

Rudy approached from behind.

As they had come to search the Astria residence, Rudy was also there.

"Isn't this more or less over now?"

"No, if it was over, we would have finished it long ago. The problem starts now."

"From now?"

Rudy tilted his head in confusion.

"We've caught the necromancers and the wizards who were making magical tools. What more could there be?"

"That's the problem, not knowing what else there is."

"Huh....."

Rudy made a complicated expression.

"He's someone who doesn't trust anyone. Cutting off his surroundings means nothing. It's not over unless you uproot everything."

"Hmm....."

Rudy thought that the man himself might be the root, but since Ian knew more about him, Rudy just nodded.

"What will you do now?"

"We need to search for documents and such in the mansion. But....."

Ian pointed ahead.

"Why is it like this?"

".....Did father smash it in a fit of anger? Does he smash walls or something when he suddenly gets angry?"

The place Ian was pointing at was a safe in the study.

The wall was smashed.

It was a wall that Rudy had smashed.

It had been mostly repaired, but traces of it still remained.

"Smashing walls, huh..... Tsk."

Rudy clicked his tongue and pretended as if nothing had happened.

Royal Palace, Conference Room.

"Ian Astria, Rie. Have you returned?"

In front of Ian and Rie was the Emperor.

The meeting consisted of the Emperor, the Chancellor, and a few high-ranking officials of the empire.

"Yes, we have collected all the documents and evidence hidden in the mansion."

"Good, you've done well. Ian Astria, I really appreciate you taking the initiative to proceed with the work, even though the opponent was your father."

"It's nothing."

"So, what about the documents that were found?"

"There was no precise evidence. Most of the letters were vague, and there was absolutely no documentation linking necromancy to the Astria family."

".....You mean there was none?"

The Emperor widened his eyes at Ian's report and looked at Rie.

"That's correct."

"Then, doesn't that mean Perrian is innocent?"

"For now, we have a letter sent directly by the necromancers yesterday. It's a letter that details their crimes and Perrian's involvement."

"But that hardly seems like conclusive evidence."

"Yes, but we still have a reason to hold him. More importantly, it's not about finding decisive evidence right now. We need to take away the weapon that Perrian possesses."

"Weapon?"

Ian had seen the weapon that Perrian possessed.

"The mana stones created by the necromancers. We need to collect the one that contains the most powerful mana."

Finding that mana stone was the most crucial task.

It was a weapon that could potentially blow up the capital itself and was at the center of the plots Perrian had been scheming.

"So how do you plan to find this mana stone? We've searched the mansion and the places where the necromancers were, but it hasn't turned up."

To this, Ian responded.

"Spatial magic."

".....Spatial magic?"

"Important documents are likely stored in a separate space created with spatial magic."

"A separate space..... So, can you open this space?"

"That's impossible."

"Then what will you do?"

"I can't open it now, but....."

Ian lifted the corners of his mouth.

"If the person who created that separate space opens it, it's a different story."

The Empire's underground prison.

'Ian... you betrayed me?'

Perrian was grinding his teeth there.

'All of you will kneel before me. Everyone.'

There was a reason Perrian was caught so easily.

When Rie and Ian came to capture him, Perrian could have resisted.

He could have escaped using spatial magic or other spells.

However, he stayed still because he could still proceed with his plans even while being captured here.

Rather than resisting and getting injured, it was better to be caught quietly and buy time.

"Ugh!"

Then, someone collapsed and entered the prison in front of Perrian.

This person was a high-ranking wizard under Perrian's command, who had been making the amplifier.

".....Why are you here?"

"Pe, Perrian sir?"

The high-ranking wizard, locked in the cell opposite Perrian, widened his eyes.

"I asked why you are here."

"So, sorry. Right after you were taken, some guy attacked us."

"Which guy?"

"That..... someone with the same blond hair as you, sir. Right after you were taken, he suddenly appeared....."

'Right after I was taken?'

"Tell me in detail."

"After you were taken, there was a noise from the room you used to use. I thought you had come back, but then another guy suddenly appeared."

That meant he used spatial magic.

Perrian narrowed his brows.

Spatial magic and blond hair.

'Ian Astria.....'

Was he watching all along?

It was unpredictable when exactly he had planned to betray.

Moreover, Ian was supposed to be at the capital's entrance, how did he follow with spatial magic?

Perrian had too many questions.

Before resolving these questions, looking at the high-ranking wizard's face, he suddenly looked shocked.

"Then..... where did the amplifier go? If you are here, then the amplifier is.....?"

".....It was taken by them."

".....What? Then where is it now?"

"I know it was brought here, but..... I don't know exactly where."

"Brought here?"

This place was the Empire's underground prison.

The amplifier was brought here.....

Is it here as evidence?

If it's them, they would've already realized it's an amplifier.

Having shown Ian the mana stone created with necromancy, he probably guessed their intention.

The strange thing is that they haven't destroyed the amplifier even now.

They should have destroyed the amplifier as soon as they found it.

"Hmm....."

Perrian stroked his chin.

The amplifier contained a lot.

It was an amplifier deeply imbued with the essence of magical tools.

With the magical tools he had created, ruling the empire was not just a dream.

Was Ian getting greedy?

That was the most likely guess.

'Then, Ian must be looking for the mana stone.....'

But even if he searches, he will never find it.

Ian won't be able to.

'If the amplifier is here..... I need to create an opportunity. And then, get the amplifier back.'

If it weren't for Ian, escaping from here would be easy.

None of the others would be able to follow with spatial magic.

Perrian stared intently at the high-ranking wizard in front of him.

"Do, do you need something?"

"Hmm..... I can use you."

".....Me?"

Perrian fiddled with his handcuffs a few times and then stretched his hand towards the high-ranking wizard in front of him.

"Dying for me should be considered an honor."

"Wh, what do you mean....."

Perrian extended his hand and smiled.

Chapter 247: Past and Future (14)

"Do you want me to use magic?"

"Do you know about these handcuffs?"

Ian showed me the handcuffs.

"Ah, aren't those handcuffs that control magic? I read the paper published by Luna recently."

"Luna? Ah, the one who recently joined the Magic Tower, right?"

"Yes, they add interference when using magic, making it impossible to use."

"That paper hasn't been out long, right? It's unlikely that it's already being used. The new handcuffs made are supposed to address the issues present in these handcuffs."

"...Yes?"

"Originally, these handcuffs play a role in disturbing mana. They shake the mana inside wizards, making it impossible to use magic."

"Isn't that the same thing?"

"No, it's different. The handcuffs made by Luna are magical tools that completely prevent the use of magic. However, the existing handcuffs are magical tools that prevent the use of mana."

"But don't you need to use mana to use magic?"

"That's not entirely wrong, but you know the exception, don't you?"

The exception...

A way to use magic without using mana.

"...Necromancy?"

"Yes. Necromancy. It allows you to use magic at the cost of your own life force. Making mana stones from human life is an example of that."

"But why bring that up all of a sudden?"

"It's closely related. Can't you use necromancy?"

"...Then."

"There's opening thanks to these handcuffs. An opening to use necromancy."

Kugung—

"What's happening?"

The soldiers fell into a state of confusion.

This was clearly the Empire's underground prison.

A place where the most heinous criminals of the Empire were gathered, maintained with strict security.

Something odd was noticed in such a place.

The ground shook violently.

"Everyone, to your posts! The criminals must not be released under any circumstances!"

With Duke Perrian captured, everyone was focused on the underground prison.

They must not show any slack.

'It really happened, didn't it?'

The warden of the prison, who was in charge of the overall operations of the underground jail, looked around.

Perrian had been put in jail, and Ian had sought out the warden.

'It's supposed to be like this...'

The warden shouted to the guards around him.

"Everyone, don't panic! Just do as we prepared! Quickly escape!"

"Ah, understood!"

The warden began to lead the other guards.

"Head guard! Immediately request assistance from the Royal Army and notify the royal family."

Since it was unclear who had caused this incident, it was necessary to inform the Royal Army, the largest military force of the current Empire.

Even if it was a rebellion, the Royal Army was needed.

Since the Royal Army wasn't far from the capital, they would arrive quickly.

"Understood."

"Where is the deputy warden?"

"The deputy warden has not come out yet! He is believed to be in the special prison area!"

"Special prison?"

That was where Perrian was imprisoned.

The deputy warden was located in the place dedicated to managing only the wizards among the criminals.

"Some guards went to rescue the deputy warden..."

As the warden tried to speak, the vibrations grew stronger.

And the ceiling of the underground prison began to tilt more and more.

"Ugh..."

The warden frowned and looked towards the underground prison.

Kugugung!

"Let's escape for now! It's going to collapse like this!"

As the warden shouted, the other guards also moved quickly.

"Everyone, escape! Don't worry about the prisoners! Save yourselves first!"

If the underground prison collapsed, they would have to worry about the prisoners escaping, but the guards' survival was the top priority.

Being underground, there would be no chance of survival if the building collapsed.

Even if the prisoners died, the guards had to escape.

"Save us too!"

"You despicable bastards!!!!"

As the guards escaped, the trapped prisoners screamed.

The ceiling continued to collapse due to the large vibrations.

"Save... Huh?"

"Hey, look! This is bent!"

As the ceiling collapsed, the prison bars began to bend.

"This is our chance! Escape!"

"Quickly!!"

The prisoners squeezed their bodies through the bent bars.

The prisoners who barely escaped were busy getting out while the rest were still struggling to do so.

"Hahaha! Freedom! Freedom!"

"Let us out too!!"

The underground prison turned into a chaotic mess with screams and cheers mixing together.

As the prisoners tried to escape from the prison, one of them pointed towards the back.

"...What is that?"

"A monster?"

A monstrous creature, larger than a human, was behind them.

It resembled a human but had torn muscles and flesh in a horrifying appearance.

"Run away!!"

The monster ran towards the escaping prisoners.

"Aaaah!"

The monster caught one person and began to tear their flesh to eat.

The prisoners who had come out shouting for freedom were killed by the monster.

Fortunately, there was only one monster.

It wasn't a situation where everyone would die since there was only one monster.

The prisoners who were initially in despair regained their composure.

"Let's escape! Leave those guys behind!!"

While the upper floors were facing this chaotic situation.

"What on earth is happening?"

The deputy warden was in the special prison.

It was the special prison where the biggest vibration occurred.

The ceiling collapsed severely, and the deputy warden was barely keeping himself safe under the desk.

Just as he was unable to grasp the situation, the sound of his door opening was heard.

"Is the deputy warden there! Deputy warden!"

A voice was heard.

The deputy warden poked his head out from under the desk towards the door.

In front of the door stood Perrian Astria.

"Deputy warden! There you are!"

Perrian quickly ran towards him.

"Unlock these handcuffs immediately."

"What? What are you talking about?"

The deputy warden swallowed his saliva upon seeing Perrian.

Just a few days ago, he was sitting as a duke, but now he was a criminal.

He was a dangerous individual worthy of being locked in the underground prison, so the deputy warden looked at him apprehensively.

"Right now, a strange monster is rampaging outside. Hurry and unlock this."

"I can't do that...! More importantly, where did this monster come from...?"

"A wizard could have implanted a tool into their body. Even if these handcuffs block the body's mana, they might not control the mana from an implanted magical tool."

"So, are you saying a wizard turned into that monster?"

"I'm not sure of the reason myself. More importantly, unlock these handcuffs quickly! Otherwise, all the criminals in the underground prison might escape!"

The deputy warden looked at Perrian with suspicious eyes.

Should he trust this man?

"Don't look at me with those eyes. I've lived my life as a Duke. I've been loyal to the Empire. Even though I'm imprisoned due to some misunderstanding, my loyalty to the Empire remains."

Perrian spoke as if he was pouring out his frustrations.

"If we leave it like this...!"

"Ah, alright. I'll unlock it."

According to Perrian, if the people in the special prison were released, the Empire would fall into great chaos.

Among those who used magic to commit crimes, the individuals locked in the special prison were tremendously vicious criminals.

The deputy warden reached out to Perrian's handcuffs.

Click.

The deputy warden moved mana, and Perrian's handcuffs were unlocked.

"Duke, I entrust this to you."

The deputy warden unlocked Perrian's handcuffs and looked into his eyes.

Perrian's eyes had grown cold.

They shined differently than when he first entered the room.

"...Duke?"

"Deputy warden, thanks for unlocking me. But."

Perrian straightened his body that had been bent over and extended his hand towards him.

"Where is the amplifier?"

A sharp smile appeared on Perrian's lips.

"If we were just a bit later, it would have been a disaster."

Perrian looked at the amplifier in front of him with a smile.

He approached the amplifier and swept off the dirt that had fallen on it.

"It could have been broken."

In his arms was the deputy warden, looking no different from a corpse.

He couldn't move a single finger, covered in blood.

"Leaving such precious equipment in a place like this. Those uncultured fools."

Perrian raised his hand and used spatial magic.

He cleared the stones that had fallen on the amplifier with spatial magic.

"They don't even know how precious this equipment is. It's something I spent years creating. Tsk."

Perrian clicked his tongue as he checked the condition of the amplifier.

Although it was good that he escaped using necromancy, the amplifier was in bad condition due to the stones that fell from the ceiling.

"I'll have to take it for repairs."

Perrian opened a subspace with spatial magic.

The subspace was a small hole, but it swallowed the large amplifier.

"Deputy warden, thank you for your guidance."

Perrian smiled at the deputy warden lying on the floor.

Then, he used spatial magic again to hide his presence.

"Well then."

Perrian used spatial magic to head to a laboratory near the Astria family's territory.

It was a laboratory he hadn't used much recently, but since it was where he first created the amplifier, it had the equipment needed for repairs.

Perrian opened the subspace again, intending to take out the amplifier.

"...?"

He tried to use spatial magic to retrieve the amplifier, but nothing appeared before him.

Only a black hole opened, without any response.

"Did I use too much mana?"

He had used mana to escape from the underground prison and to travel to the Astria territory, so he did use a lot of mana.

But it shouldn't have been enough to prevent him from opening the subspace.

Perrian furrowed his brows and stared at the open black hole.

The very presence of the black hole meant that the subspace was open.

However, no object was coming out of it.

Perrian tried to take out other objects from the subspace as well.

Still, there was no response.

Perrian swept his hair back, annoyed by the situation not going his way.

And he looked into the subspace.

"What?"

There was nothing inside the subspace.

Not the amplifier.

Not the stacked documents.

Nothing at all.

Chapter 248: Past and Future (15)

Everything went according to plan.

We were able to raid Perrian's subspace as Ian had hoped, and thanks to a heads-up, the guards avoided death.

The deputy warden was seriously injured, but I managed to get him out quickly, saving his life.

Of course, the destruction of the underground dungeon was a major problem.

We couldn't determine who among the prisoners had died or escaped, and managing the criminals that needed to be locked up was challenging.

However, a bigger problem awaited us.

"...Gone?"

The mana stone containing the powerful mana Ian had seen inside Perrian's subspace wasn't there.

Naturally, we expected to find the mana stone in the subspace, but there was no trace of it.

"Was the mana stone kept separately?"

"Let's keep looking for now. With so much stuff, it's possible we just haven't found it yet."

Despite being filled with enough items to fill a room, it was unlikely that more than five people looking would miss it.

If it were filled with mana, its presence would have been felt.

Yet, we didn't feel such strong mana here.

We searched the room several times over, as Ian suggested.

"Ian Astria. Shall we stop now? If we haven't found it after all this, it probably means it's not here."

When Rie spoke to Ian, he sighed and nodded.

"Alright. Let's start by organizing the information we have here."

It was only after Ian said this that some degree of organization began.

The people who had been searching for the mana stone left, leaving me, Rie, and Ian at the site.

The three of us read through the documents Perrian had collected and analyzed the magical tools he had been trying to create.

After a while,

Rie yawned, feeling stiff.

Then she looked at me and spoke.

"I've skimmed through it, but I still don't really understand."

"Understanding this could help us understand Perrian's plans."

"That's true. But still, that mana stone is the most important thing, right?"

At Rie's words, I nodded, and Ian added,

"Even if that mana stone were only used to cause an explosion, it could blow up the capital. So, taking this amplifier doesn't mean it's all over."

"Hmm..."

I read through Perrian's documents while listening to Ian.

"Shouldn't we hurry and catch Perrian then?"

"If attack too strongly, we don't know what the other side will do. It's better to assess the situation slowly first."

Hearing that, I looked at Ian.

"Is it because of the possibility that Perrian might detonate the mana stone in the capital?"

"Yes, imagine if the mana stone were to explode in the capital. Some people might survive, but would the rebels just stand by?"

The attack of the rebels following the disappearance of the capital.

An unprepared fortress and soldiers without a command structure would not stand a chance against the rebels.

"Couldn't we stop the explosion? Like, using spatial magic to send the mana stone flying when it's about to explode."

"The opponent is the head of the Astria family. Do you think he would not have thought of that?"

Rie looked at us with a dumbfounded face.

"Then we'll need a strategy to win them over."

"If that were possible, we would not be going through all this trouble..."

The opponent was someone who holds a ducal title.

What could be offered to such a person to make them listen.

"That doesn't mean there's no chance at all."

I tilted my head at Ian's words.

"My father is already like a cornered rat. If we leave him be, he would bite us."

"It's a plan years in the making. He must have wanted something to have devised such a plan. If the mana stone explodes, his plan would crumble overnight. Do you think he would make such a choice just because the amplifier is gone?"

It was a valid point.

"First, we find out my father's plan. We can decide what to do after that."

"Ha... Alright."

With that, we began to go through Perrian's documents one by one.

After several hours of reading, the plan gradually became clear.

"What is this?"

Rie frowned, indicating her displeasure.

She was holding a plan.

"Taking everyone in the capital hostage?"

That was what the document contained.

Taking everyone hostage.

But it didn't stop there.

Taking everyone in every castle, every domain within the empire hostage.

That was Perrian's plan.

"...This isn't just taking hostages."

Ian joined in.

I nodded in agreement.

"It's not just hostages; he plans to make slaves of the entire empire."

Perrian installs an amplifier in the capital.

Then, using the mana emanating from there, he takes the entire capital hostage.

Using those hostages, he creates something similar to the mana stone installed in the capital and installs it in other castles as well.

This is how he plans to take the entire empire hostage.

However, these people aren't just hostages but slaves because they are being exploited.

The magic Perrian intended to inscribe on the mana stone was...

"Life Drain."

A necromancy spell that absorbs the mana, the life force of others, and converts it into one's own life force.

It's a spell that those who sought eternal life in the past used.

However, the problem with this spell was that one had to be stronger.

One had to defeat someone and absorb their life force.

So, those who sought eternal life through this method were killed by someone stronger than themselves.

Perrian intended to eliminate this risk.

A magical tool that could exploit the life force of others at will.

A spell that could steal a person's life force just by entering the range of the magical tool.

That was Perrian's plan.

"Damn it..."

Perrian was sitting, seething with anger.

All his collected data and the results had been stolen.

If he had the documents, he could have simply secluded himself and remade everything from scratch, but without them, he had no choice but to worry.

"Starting over from scratch..."

That was madness.

The documents Perrian had accumulated began when he was in his twenties.

Back then, he was healthy, and his mind was quick.

The current aged Perrian was in a different league.

With his ducal title gone and his body aging, starting the research over would only lead to him aging to death.

All Perrian had was the mana stone created with necromancy and his physical body.

He had to somehow come up with a plan.

Whether that meant retrieving the amplifier that had been stolen from him.

Or thinking of a different application for the mana stone.

He had to do something.

The first thing that came to Perrian's mind was the rebels.

Using the rebels to retrieve the amplifier.

Or, having the rebels create an amplifier.

But he couldn't proceed with such a plan.

Perrian was practically the enemy of all necromancers at this point.

The high ranks of the rebels had deep connections with necromancers, so he couldn't just approach them carelessly.

In the past, his ducal title meant the rebels couldn't touch him lightly, but in his current state, he would just be captured by them.

The chances of being robbed of the mana stone by them and killed were high.

However, Perrian had no other choice.

The only thing he could do alone was to threaten others with the mana stone.

But doing such a thing would only ensure his survival at best.

If he had wanted to live an ordinary life, he wouldn't have chosen this path to begin with.

It was a gamble he made, even risking the ducal seat he once held.

The dice had already been cast, so there was only one decision for Perrian to make.

"I will... sit at the highest position."

He wouldn't back down.

He intended to proceed with his plan as planned.

Even if it meant bearing the risks of allying with the rebels.

Perrian immediately wrote a letter.

Perrian, had used the rebels' distribution network when he provided them with mana stones made by necromancers.

He had received help from the rebels to transport mana stones from the Astria domain to where the amplifier was being made.

He could have used a normal distribution network, but he didn't want to risk ordinary people coming into contact with necromancers.

Furthermore, if mana stones continued to be transported from the Astria domain, which had no mines, people would become suspicious.

To avoid such risks, Perrian maintained his connection with the rebels.

After sending the letter to the rebels, Perrian stroked his chin.

'Now that I think about it, those guys... their situation has been pretty bad lately, hasn't it?'

The rebels had suffered a significant defeat against the Royal army and recently had been lying low, showing no signs of movement.

Then, could it be possible that they didn't know about the necromancers?

The Astria domain is quite far from where the rebels are located.

If they hadn't been keeping an eye, they might not know about the necromancers.

He also found out quite late that the necromancers had been killed by Robert.

'Maybe I can still take the initiative?'

Rumors about the necromancers hadn't spread at all in the capital.

People in high positions might know, but he wondered if such news had reached the rebels.

If the rebels had a way to obtain such high-level information, they wouldn't have suffered a major defeat against the Royal army.

"There's still a chance."

Perrian muttered to himself, clenching his fist.

Deep in the forest, where not even the moonlight could penetrate through the trees, making it impossible to see even an inch ahead, two men walked into such a forest.

They recognized each other's presence and stopped.

One of the men spoke.

"Perrian Astria. It's been a long time."

"Isn't this the first time we've met? Aryandor."

"I've seen you from a distance."

Perrian and Aryandor smiled at each other.

Chapter 249: Past and Future (16)

"So, what brings someone of your rank to sit with us today?"

Aryandor asked with a smile.

Perrian frowned at Aryandor's words.

"Does it sound like I'm mocking you? If so, I apologize."

Perrian scrutinized Aryandor's expression.

It was hard to tell what he was thinking.

"How much do you know?"

Perrian asked directly.

Staying any longer would benefit neither of them.

"I am aware that you were captured and that you escaped from the dungeon."

"Then, this will be quick. How about forming an alliance?"

"An alliance?"

Aryandor's expression hardened.

"An alliance with you, who has lost everything?"

"I haven't lost everything. I still have the mana stones created by necromancy. You're not exactly in perfect condition either, are you?"

"Our damages are not beyond repair. How bad is your situation if you've come to us?"

Aryandor scoffed at Perrian. Under normal circumstances, Perrian would have stormed off, but he was in a position of need.

The rebels could benefit from having Perrian, but they wouldn't be at a loss without him.

But Perrian wasn't one to back down easily.

"Have you forgotten that I have necromancers at my command?"

Perrian gambled. He didn't know the exact condition of the necromancers.

The royal family was aware of the necromancers, so he was reluctant to go to their location.

Yet, with no rumors spreading, he aimed to exploit the information gap.

"Necromancers, you say..."

Aryandor stroked his chin, staring intently at Perrian.

"You wouldn't want to see them all die, would you?"

Perrian smiled. The rebels had an unusually strong obsession with necromancers.

It could be because they had a necromancer among their leadership, but the obsession seemed deeper.

"Let's start by handing over the necromancers,"

Aryandor said with utter seriousness, unaware of the necromancers' situation.

"Necromancy is my last weapon. Do you think I'd hand it over easily?"

"Hmm... What do you want?"

Aryandor took the bait.

"Ian Astria. He must be captured."

"Ian Astria?"

"A subspace created with spatial magic was robbed. He's the only one who knows how to use spatial magic, so he must have the items."

"Are you certain?"

"Yes. He took the items..."

"No, I mean, are you saying Ian Astria is the only one capable of using spatial magic?"

At Aryandor's words, Perrian narrowed his eyes.

"What are you implying?"

"Don't you have two sons?"

"Ah, you mean Rudy Astria? That kid..."

Perrian was about to dismiss the idea but then his expression wrinkled.

'Rudy can use spatial magic?'

Now that he thought about it, it was indeed strange.

The theft of the subspace had occurred during the chaos in the underground dungeon.

It was likely that when the amplifier was placed in the subspace, its coordinates were checked, and the items were taken.

Could Ian Astria have accessed the subspace during the disturbance in the dungeon?

Ian was a commander of the Royal forces.

If there had been a commotion in the dungeon, he should have been commanding people outside of it.

Could he really have slipped away to where the amplifier was hidden during that time?

It wasn't entirely impossible, but there were definitely awkward points.

"I think Rudy Astria is responsible for this. What do you think?"

It had been only about two weeks since Rudy had come to him asking to learn spatial magic.

At that time, he had known nothing.

And now, he was already using spatial magic?

Perrian pondered and then realized something.

The amplifier.

How had they managed to take the amplifier?

Ian knew about the necromancers but not about the amplifier.

Perrian had avoided going directly to that place to keep the existence of the amplifier a secret.

He had kept its location hidden by handling documents and had only recently visited the place once using spatial magic.

That was at the mansion he used with Rudy.

"Ah...! That was it."

"So, our goals align to some extent."

Aryandor smiled and looked at Perrian.

"Our target is Rudy Astria. How you handle him is of no concern to us. If you promise to kill him, we'll offer you our full support."

"Oh? And what does this support entail?"

"We'll send one of our leaders to you, along with a magical device created with time magic."

Perrian grinned.

The rebel soldiers, mostly untrained commoners, were no match for the Royal army, but their leadership was a different story.

Even the deceased Jefrin and the necromancer Daemon had remarkable abilities, making one wonder how they were recruited.

"Understood. I'll send you the meeting location separately."

"Then, I look forward to our meeting after this matter is resolved."

Aryandor and Perrian shook hands and returned to their respective places.

"Thank you for the information on necromancy. It really helped progress things."

A man sat in front of the empire's head wizard, Franz.

"It was nothing."

It was Robert.

Though both were disciples of Levian, they weren't close. Robert wasn't one to foster friendships, so they merely knew of each other.

Yet, their current meeting was due to necromancy.

"I shared information about Ephomos as a form of repayment for your help with necromancy."

Ephomos.

A few months ago, Robert had investigated Ephomos while traveling to the Railer domain with Rudy.

The person who had provided the mercenaries with information on Robert's behalf was none other than the head wizard, Franz.

From there, the two formed a cooperative relationship.

Franz provided information on necromancers and their investigations, while Robert personally visited the scene.

Given his position as a head wizard, which didn't allow for much freedom of movement, Franz had utilized Robert for these tasks.

"Your student thought I was the one using time magic. You could have given him a hint that we were working together."

"Why should I report every little thing to him? He's not my superior. He'll figure it out on his own."

"Thanks to your student, things went smoothly. He's exceptionally talented in magic. To learn spatial magic in such a short time..."

"Talent? It's just a coincidence."

"If such coincidences keep happening, they're not coincidences but inevitabilities. Isn't he making a name for himself at the academy? That must be the level of a genius."

"Genius, my foot. The kid is anything but a genius."

One would expect Robert to be pleased by such praise for his student, but he showed no sign of it.

"Do you really think so?"

"Yes, the world doesn't call someone a genius just because ordinary people can't understand them. He's just a fool who works harder than others and doesn't know how to compromise with himself."

"Hmm..."

From the listener's perspective, this sounded more valuable than being called a genius. It acknowledged the person's effort, not just their talent.

"Anyway, setting Rudy aside, why have you come all of a sudden?"

It was unusual for Robert to make such a visit.

Originally, he had been cautious about his research on necromancy being discovered, but it was also because of his personality, which didn't favor face-to-face discussions.

"You saw Levian's last moments, didn't you?"

"Nobody saw his last moments. Even those in the Railer domain said they didn't see it."

"I'm talking about before that. Before he went to the Railer domain."

"I was nearby then."

"What expression was he wearing at that time?"

"Hmm... expression... That's difficult."

It felt like the disappearance of Ephomos was just yesterday, but it had been nearly 20 years since that event.

It was hard to recall an expression from that time.

"If you can't remember, that's fine."

"No, I do remember vaguely."

Franz had been close to Levian, almost like a star pupil.

He had a faint memory of his master's last appearance.

"Very sad... No, it was a complex expression. A mix of sadness and regret? Something like that."

"Sad, huh..."

As Robert pondered this with a stroke of his chin, Franz let out a resigned laugh.

"Did you come all this way just to ask that?"

"I dropped by to ask that, among other things, and to see how you're doing. It wouldn't hurt for fellow disciples to check in on each other."

"It's funny hearing that from you. So, that's all you came for?"

"Not entirely."

With that, Robert handed him an envelope.

"What's this?"

"Just some information I've gathered that might be needed."

Franz looked at the envelope with a curious expression.

"Should I open it now?"

"No."

"Huh... well, then. When should I open it?"

Robert stood up from his seat.

"You'll know when."

Chapter 250: Past and Future (17)

Taking Perrian's belongings and figuring out his intentions was a good start.

"But if we don't know where the guy is, it's all meaningless."

"Even if we find out, there's nothing we can do. What's the point of knowing now?"

Rie responded to my grumbling.

Rie, Ian, and I were analyzing Perrian's data, trying to predict his next move.

While the head wizard and others continued to track Perrian, they hadn't made any significant progress.

I looked over at Ian, who was still reading through the documents beside me.

"What do you think will happen now?"

"If I knew that, we wouldn't be in this situation."

"You've been by my father's side for years; you must have some idea."

"Yes, I do know that he won't give up that easily."

"Hmm..."

"He'll show up soon, whether to take back the amplifier from us or for some other purpose."

"What other purpose?"

Rie questioned Ian's statement.

"Revenge on those who messed up his plans. That's all I can think of right now."

"Isn't there a chance he's making another amplifier?"

"My father is nearly 60, without a dukedom, and the surrounding environment isn't favorable. It's unlikely."

"So, you're saying he will appear before us one way or another."

Then Ian was the most at risk.

Perrian harbored the greatest grudge against him, and since Perrian didn't know I could use spatial magic, he would assume Ian had the amplifier.

He would target Ian for some reason.

"It might be wise for you to lay low for a while."

"There's no need for that. Even if my father appears before me, I'm stronger than him. Plus, I'm in a place where the Royal army is gathered, so a surprise attack isn't possible."

"Still, it doesn't hurt to be cautious."

"Don't worry about me. Worry about yourselves. No one knows who he'll target."

"Yes, understood."

"Speaking of which, it's getting late."

The sun was setting, and it was time to return.

"Are you staying here any longer?"

"No, we should be heading back too."

"Rudy, how about having dinner at the palace?"

I shook my head at Rie's question.

"I need to practice spatial magic when I return, and I study some other things."

"If that's what you want..."

Rie was disappointed, which was unusual for her.

Typically, she would have insisted, but her easy surrender left me feeling uneasy.

"Rudy, how about staying at the royal palace?"

"What?"

Ian's sudden suggestion took me by surprise.

"The Astria mansion is empty; isn't that dangerous? There's no one there to protect you, and the security is inadequate. The royal palace would be safer, wouldn't it?"

Rie's eyes sparkled at Ian's suggestion.

"You actually make sense for once."

"When have I ever spoken nonsense?"

"Staying at the palace, huh..."

"There's plenty of room in the palace for magic research, right? And if you ever need anything, you can always ask the royal wizards or someone else."

It was a good idea.

It was safe, and it would be beneficial for my magic studies.

It might be a bit of an imposition, but when it comes to saving one's life, a little inconvenience is acceptable.

Even though Ian was most likely to be targeted, there was still a chance I could be targeted too.

If the details of what happened became known, it would definitely come back to me.

Ian might have planned it, but I was the one who carried it out.

"Then I'll go back to the mansion to pack some of my things."

"Great! Then I'll tell them to prepare a meal at the palace!"

Rie, delighted, spoke with an energetic smile.

"I'll head back then. Both of you, take care. If it gets dangerous, I'll come right away, so just stay alive."

After Ian left, I too returned to the mansion to pack my belongings.

"Ah... staying at the royal palace for a while..."

"So, you should take a break and leave only a few people to manage the mansion."

"A break? But it's our job to manage things here."

I planned to send all the mansion's staff on a break.

If things went wrong while I was at the royal palace, Perrian could come looking and harm people.

With no one staying at the mansion, two or three people could manage it, so there was no need to keep everyone here.

"I'll pay your salaries as usual, so take a break. You must be worried with everything that has been happening recently."

Given the war between the empire and the rebels, they surely had concerns about their hometowns.

I thought this would be a good opportunity for them to see their families and reduce their worries.

"Thank you... We'll discuss amongst ourselves who will stay and let you know."

I nodded at the maid's words.

"Then I'll also pack your belongings."

"Oh, yes. Thank you."

I smiled at the maid and went down to my study.

The maids said they would take care of my clothes and other items, but I had to pack the magic-related items myself.

"Is this enough..."

I packed only the most essential items.

If I needed more, I could always come back briefly.

The royal palace wasn't far from the Astria mansion.

"Once the remaining staff is decided, I'll send a letter."

"Alright, everyone, take a good rest."

I bid farewell to everyone and boarded the carriage.

"Shall we head to the palace?"

"Yes."

The coachman drove towards the palace following my command.

As I felt the carriage went on its way, I heard the coachman's voice from outside.

"...Hm?"

"Is there a problem?"

Crash!

What followed wasn't the coachman's voice but the sound of the carriage jolting.

"Ugh!"

The carriage suddenly tried to stop, and I was thrown forward.

Thud!

I fell forward, hitting my head against the front wall of the carriage.

"Ugh..."

I tried to get up, placing my hands on the floor, and opened my mouth to speak.

"What happened..."

Crash!!!

Suddenly, there was a sound of something tearing apart.

The top part of the carriage was being sliced open.

"What?"

The roof of the carriage was cleanly sliced off.

Had I not fallen forward, my head would have been where the cut was made.

"Damn..."

Without a moment's hesitation, I leaped out of the carriage.

Crash— Bang!

Just as I suspected, the carriage was cut in half.

I muttered to myself while looking at the scene.

"Perrian..."

He was the only one who would ambush me like this.

But the nature of the attack was the problem.

A sword strike?

It was impossible for Perrian to use a sword strike.

Sword strikes were the exclusive domain of swordsmen.

Though it's possible to mimic something similar with wind magic, that was clearly a sword strike.

I looked towards where the sword strike had come from.

"What were you planning to do if you killed him? Killing that guy isn't enough. You need to steal the item."

"My goal is to kill him."

"We're allies for now. Your goal is my goal."

There stood two people.

One was Perrian Astria.

The other, a swordsman wielding a massive sword.

"Venderwood...?"

A leader of the rebels and someone I had defeated in a different future.

The swordsman with the great sword was Venderwood.

Hearing my words, Perrian looked at me.

"Rudy, it's been a long time."

"Long time my ass. Your greeting with a sword strike was well received, so spare me your bullsh*t."

I cursed at Perrian, who was smiling, and took my stand.

"You tricked me nicely. Spatial magic. You can use it, can't you?"

I scanned the surroundings.

It didn't seem like there were other people around, but Venderwood in front of me was the problem.

If it were my future self, I could easily defeat him.

But if you ask whether I can beat him now, I can't give a definitive answer.

And with Perrian there too?

Victory was impossible.

Unable to properly use spatial magic, there was no way I could take on both of them at the same time.

"No answer to father's question, huh?"

"Is someone trying to kill their son really a father? You're just a beast. No, even beasts don't kill their offspring. You're worse than a beast."

"Heh, you do have a way with words."

Perrian reached out his hand towards me.

"Whether you can use spatial magic or not, we'll see in a fight."

The space started to shift.

I quickly judged the movement.

Perrian was attempting spatial severance.

I threw myself to the side.

Then, the place where I had been standing cracked.

Space split open, creating a black rift in the surroundings.

"So, you can sense the spatial domain to some extent."

I calmly took a deep breath.

Joining forces with the rebels, they came looking for me after hearing I could use spatial magic.

"Are you planning to demand the amplifier?"

"Oh, you're more reasonable than I thought."

Perrian stepped forward.

"Hand over the amplifier, and I'll grant you a painless death."

I let out a hollow laugh.

"Not even offering to spare my life, but promising death if I hand it over? Why would I just give it to you?"

"Is that so? Then it seems you'll need to lose an arm or a leg before you hand it over."

At Perrian's words, Venderwood stepped forward.

The towering figure, over 2 meters tall, wielding a great sword, exerted immense pressure.

"Don't kill him."

"Understood."

Venderwood nodded.

"Haah..."

It was clear that I couldn't win against both of them at the same time.

So, there was only one thing to do.

Hold out.

Since the Astria mansion and the royal palace are close, if I don't show up, Rie will notice.

Surely reinforcements will come.

I just need to hold out until then.

"30 minutes..."

Just close my eyes and hold out for 30 minutes.

Just 30 minutes.

Thinking this, I began to manipulate my mana.

Chapter 251: Past and Future (18)

Venderwood rapidly approached, wielding his greatsword.

Despite his large size, his speed was impressive. I dodged to the side and extended my hand.

"Flames of the Abyss."

I aimed for his arm.

Venderwood, with fluid motion, sliced through the flames.

"Spatial Severance."

As he cut through the flames, Perrian unleashed his magic.

I threw myself to the side, attempting to avoid Perrian's spell, but Venderwood was already upon me.

Dodging both attacks at once was impossible.

"Priscilla!"

A silver wolf appeared in front of me.

Priscilla bit down on Venderwood's greatsword with her massive jaws.

"So, rolling around the academy has taught you well. However,"

Perrian began, manipulating mana as he spoke,

"you are only as good as a student."

Perrian reached down to the ground.

"Undead Rise."

Skeleton hands emerged from the ground, followed by dozens of skeletons.

"Behemoth."

As I chanted the incantation, a magic circle appeared on the ground, and a small elephant emerged.

Previously only reaching my knees, its magical growth now matched my height.

The Behemoth's trumpeting caused iron to burst from nearby carriages, flying towards the skeletons at its command.

"Hmm..."

Perrian, stroking his chin, let out an impressed gasp.

Priscilla blocking Venderwood and the Behemoth taking down the undead suggested I could maybe hold out for the 30 minutes.

"Bone Spear."

At Perrian's command, bones gathered and formed several bone spears around us.

These spears flew towards me, guided by Perrian's gestures.

"Hell's Thorns!"

Black pillars erupted from the ground, impaling the incoming spears.

"Spatial Severance."

Perrian cast another spell simultaneously.

I threw myself aside to dodge, rolling onto the sandy ground.

I saw Venderwood, previously obstructed by Priscilla, charging towards me.

"Damn it, Priscilla!"

I shouted her name as I rolled to the side.

"I know!"

Priscilla, using ice to grasp Venderwood's ankle, charged towards his shoulder.

Despite her efforts, her magic couldn't stop his advance.

I had thought her attack would impede him, but the sound of bone and flesh crushing under Priscilla's bite filled the air.

Venderwood hadn't blocked her teeth; even as his shoulder was torn away, flesh and bone ripping, he continued his charge towards me.

"Ah..."

I was reminded of Venderwood's ability.

His form, enduring even when mirroring my future self, flickered in my mind.

Despite injuries or being torn into dozens of pieces, he possessed a regenerative ability that allowed him to recover.

Then...

Thud!

"Ugh!"

I was kicked squarely by Venderwood as he charged at me.

Lying on the ground, the impact of his kick sent me flying.

Venderwood raised his sword, intending to strike me while I was airborne.

"Damn it... Behemoth!"

"Roar!"

The Behemoth undermined the ground beneath Venderwood's feet as he swung his sword towards me.

The earth split open, causing Venderwood to lose his balance.

Clutching his sword, he glanced down at the Behemoth.

Venderwood immediately pushed off the ground.

"Roar!"

Thud!

Venderwood moved swiftly, reaching the Behemoth in an instant, and swung his sword at the creature's body.

The powerful swing split the Behemoth's belly.

The Behemoth vanished like smoke.

Though it was a summoned creature and wouldn't truly die, the reduction in our fighting force was problematic.

Venderwood, having cut down the Behemoth, lifted his sword and looked towards me again.

The shoulder Priscilla had bitten began to heal slowly, returning to its original state.

"Rudy, are you okay?"

Priscilla helped me up from where I had fallen on the ground.

It felt like I had a rib or two knocked out of place from Venderwood's kick, but with body reinforcement, I figured I could manage to hold on.

"As long as it doesn't turn into a war of attrition, I think we can hold out."

If we press the enemy and both sides start accumulating damage and fatigue, we're at a significant disadvantage.

They have skeletons to expend at will and even a swordsman who heals himself.

A war of attrition would clearly be in their favor.

And they knew it as well as we did.

Our plans would not go as intended.

Venderwood charged at me again, a reckless dash.

"Priscilla, I'll leave him to you."

I asked Priscilla to take care of Perrian and stepped forward.

I could see Venderwood charging at me.

He is undoubtedly strong.

But in close combat, I am not inferior.

"I'll dodge everything."

There's no way to conserve energy.

Minimizing injuries was crucial.

I charged towards Venderwood as he came at me.

Unfazed, Venderwood swung his sword broadly.

I ducked slightly, avoiding the greatsword, and moved inside Venderwood's guard.

In close quarters, fists are more advantageous than a greatsword.

I drove into Venderwood, striking his abdomen.

"Ugh."

I felt his ribs break under my hand.

I didn't stop there and continued to strike.

Concentrating mana in my hand, I hit what are considered important spots.

Thump, thump, thump—

Such blows would turn an ordinary person into mush.

A punch filled with mana could shatter hard steel.

Yet, Venderwood neither fell nor was sent flying.

He merely stepped back slightly, enduring the hits.

Even if his body continued to heal, it didn't lessen the severity of the pain and impact.

Despite this, Venderwood withstood it.

"Gasp!"

Venderwood, despite being hit by my strikes, slammed the hilt of his greatsword towards me.

I quickly stepped back to avoid the blow.

As I moved back, Venderwood swung his sword, sending a wave of dark energy towards me.

"Ugh!"

Caught while retreating, I had no time to fully evade.

I raised my arm in an attempt to block Venderwood's sword strike.

The strike sliced through my arm. Though my arm was filled with mana and thus not severed, it left a deep gash.

"Rudy!"

I heard Priscilla's voice at that moment.

Bone spears appeared before my eyes.

"Damn!"

Caught off guard by Venderwood, Perrian's attack followed.

I had thought Priscilla would handle Perrian, but she was overwhelmed.

I had to make a quick decision.

I couldn't block all the spears.

Could I throw myself elsewhere?

Doing so would just invite Venderwood to charge at me again.

There was only one option left.

"Teleport!"

I tried to use spatial magic to escape elsewhere.

"So, you do know how to use spatial magic."

"Ah."

I tried to leave the area, but the magic failed to activate.

It was as if the spatial domain had frozen, immobilizing me.

The spears pierced my arms and body.

Intense pain engulfed me.

"Ugh..."

I gasped out in pain.

"Not much to you, after all."

"Rudy!"

Priscilla rushed to my front, shielding me.

Perrian, mocking Priscilla, walked up to me.

"Finally thinking of fetching the amplifier?"

"Damn... The spatial magic..."

"Didn't Ian tell you? Spatial magic users can block each other's magic."

Ian's words came back to me.

He hadn't suggested using spatial magic to escape when Perrian attacked.

He said he would come for me.

Ian knew I couldn't escape.

"Just... tell me properly... Damn..."

I cursed, barely standing.

My body was covered in blood.

The blood loss made my head spin, and my body felt cold.

Focusing was difficult.

Mana wouldn't flow properly.

"Are you going to keep fighting? With that body? Or, are you waiting for someone else?"

Perrian taunted me.

"You can't do anything alone. Pathetic."

His taunt wasn't wrong.

I've always depended on others, surviving by being together.

"So what?"

"What?"

"I live by playing my part within a group."

"The weak always say that. And their end always comes when they're separated from the group."

Perrian laughed at my words.

"How could someone like you even be compared to Ian? I don't get it. Ian's betrayal is trouble, but you're just scum. How could you possibly be from the Astria family..."

As Perrian continued his rant.

"...Huh?"

"You talk too much."

A blade was visible in Perrian's chest.

A sword had pierced through him.

It was Venderwood's sword.

Venderwood's greatsword had pierced through Perrian's chest.

"...What?"

"Cough... Ugh... What is this...?"

"Aryandor ordered the killing of Rudy Astria when he was almost captured."

"Ah... Aryand... Cough..."

He couldn't speak properly, likely because his lung was pierced.

Venderwood pulled the sword from his chest.

Then, Perrian collapsed to the ground.

"Aryandor wanted me to convey this."

Venderwood spoke to Perrian, lying on the ground.

"This is revenge against Ephomos and the necromancers."

Chapter 252: Past and Future (19)

Venderwood stared intently at Perrian, who lay defeated on the ground.

"Ugh...ugh..."

Perrian, still conscious, gasped for air.

"Where's the mana stone then? The one created by the necromancers."

"Ugh..."

While they exchanged words, I assessed the situation.

With Perrian down, the restrictions on spatial magic were lifted.

Yet, I couldn't use spatial magic.

Lacking experience, I couldn't focus properly to use it without concentration.

Bleeding profusely and the throbbing pain from the wound where the spear had pierced made it impossible to concentrate properly.

Standing was all I could manage at my best.

"I'll ask again. The mana stone. Where is it?"

"You think...you can survive...after this...? Cough..."

Perrian barked out, coughing up blood.

"Still got a lively mouth."

Venderwood pressed his foot down on Perrian.

"Ugh...haha..."

Perrian let out a rough breath and chuckled.

Then, a strong mana presence was felt.

Venderwood, sensing something odd, stepped back.

"What's this?"

The strong presence of mana was unmistakable.

It was impossible for such mana to emanate from someone dying.

Perrian pushed himself off the ground to stand.

A bright light pierced through his clothes from his chest.

A glowing object, pierced by the sword through his clothes, was faintly visible.

"The mana stone?"

The mana stone was embedded in his chest.

It was the very mana stone we had been searching for.

"Did you think...I would fall just like that?"

The wound on his chest slightly healed.

Life Drain.

He had embedded the mana stone in his own chest, using his body as a magical tool.

"You think I came unprepared?"

Perrian looked at Venderwood with a faint smile.

Venderwood narrowed his eyes, pointing his sword at Perrian.

"What do you plan to do in that state?"

"You, you have a regenerating body."

Perrian reached out towards Venderwood.

A red glow leaked from his eyes.

"I'll take some of that vitality."

Perrian lunged at Venderwood with a push from the ground.

Venderwood swung his sword at the approaching Perrian.

"What's happening here?"

I watched the situation bewilderedly.

Priscilla nudged me.

"Rudy, they're fighting. Now's our chance to escape."

I was doubtful of Priscilla's suggestion.

Is it right for me to run away here?

Can I even escape?

"No, I'll watch for now."

"What? Are you crazy?"

"Their primary target isn't each other. It's me."

It wasn't a matter of whether to run or not.

If I ran, I'd die.

There was no escape.

Even if I tried to escape on Priscilla, Venderwood would catch us.

All I could do was wait for someone to come.

Then, a strong wind blew towards me.

The pressure from Venderwood's sword strike caused a gust of wind.

"Ugh..."

I shielded myself from the wind with my arms and watched their fight.

The battle was one-sided.

Perrian was a wizard, and Venderwood a swordsman.

Normally, Perrian would maintain distance, while Venderwood would charge in, but the situation was reversed.

Perrian tried to grab Venderwood to use Life Drain, but Venderwood dodged and countered with sword strikes.

Severely wounded and forced into close combat, Perrian was at a disadvantage.

"You...!"

Perrian staggered, shouting at Venderwood.

"What's an old man with a pierced chest trying to do, flailing like that?"

"I won't forgive you. I won't forgive...!"

Perrian was desperate.

Despite his efforts, he couldn't even touch Venderwood.

Even using spatial and necromancy magic, he couldn't catch Venderwood's movements.

Meanwhile, the light from the mana stone grew stronger.

As Perrian's condition worsened, the mana stone's light intensified.

I narrowed my eyes at this sight.

Crack!

"Agh!!!"

Then, Venderwood's sword struck Perrian squarely in the stomach.

Perrian flew back, tumbling to the ground, while Venderwood stared down at him.

"Let's end this now."

I kept watching.

Something was off.

As Perrian's wounds deepened, the mana stone's light grew stronger.

Yet, the mana stone did not provide any other benefit.

It didn't appear to increase mana or heal wounds.

Then, Ian's words came to mind.

'If that mana stone explodes in the capital, it would obliterate the city.'

"Ha ha..."

Despite the dire situation, Perrian smiled.

Even with severe injuries and unable to fight back.

"Priscilla...!"

"Understood."

Priscilla, sensing my intention, immediately moved.

"What are you doing?"

Priscilla blocked Venderwood, who was approaching Perrian.

I spoke up.

"I have no love for that man, but killing him now is a bad idea."

"What?"

"The mana stone embedded in his chest. If he dies, it will explode."

Hearing this, Venderwood took a closer look at Perrian.

The mana stone's light was intensifying.

Normally, mana stones shine only when exerting power, not continuously.

This indicated the mana stone was activating.

If Perrian dies, the stone would explode.

It was a warning.

"Even if it heals most wounds, there's a limit, right? If you don't want to die, leave it be."

"Hmm..."

Perrian laughed maniacally.

"Ha ha ha! Yes, kill me and the mana stone explodes. Kill me and you all die. Go on, kill me! Ha ha ha...cough!"

At Perrian's words, Venderwood looked at me.

"You're right. But."

Venderwood approached Perrian without hesitation.

"I think I'd prefer to detonate this mana stone and destroy the capital."

"What?"

Venderwood was crazier than I had thought.

He prioritized the rebels' cause over his own life.

"Move aside."

Venderwood charged at Priscilla.

Priscilla summoned ice around her and launched it, but it was all swept away by Venderwood's sword.

"Priscilla!"

Priscilla tried to resist as much as she could, but couldn't muster much strength.

My mental energy was already depleting, preventing me from using any significant techniques.

Priscilla was sliced and sent flying to the side.

"Ha ha...?"

Venderwood passed Priscilla and reached right in front of Perrian.

"Then die."

"Ah...ah..."

Perrian, unable to even scream, tried to crawl away from Venderwood on the ground.

"Right, time magic..."

Perrian recalled something, rummaging through his pocket and pulling out a clock.

"If I use the time magic artifact..."

As Perrian touched the clock, a strong light leaked from it.

And then.

Boom!

A massive explosion erupted from the clock.

Shrapnel flew everywhere, and Perrian's head was gone.

That was Perrian's end.

"Did you really think it was a genuine time magic artifact?"

"Ah..."

I couldn't close my mouth upon seeing this.

It was a pitiful end, unbecoming of someone who had held a ducal title.

"The mana stone..."

Then, the mana stone began to emit an even stronger light.

"So, next is."

Venderwood, unconcerned with the mana stone, looked at me.

"You need to die as well."

"What? If that thing explodes..."

"It doesn't matter. We're all going to die anyway, but Lord Aryandor specifically said you should die by my hand. You're too much of a wildcard."

Venderwood walked towards me.

"Rudy...!"

Priscilla, who had been slashed by Venderwood, got up and charged at him again.

"Annoying."

Priscilla, unable to manipulate ice, was easily cut down by Venderwood.

"Pr, Priscilla...ack..."

As Priscilla was forcibly recalled, a sinking feeling overwhelmed me.

The cost of reverse summoning.

While creatures like Behemoths dying wouldn't exact a heavy toll, the reverse summoning of a spirit inflicts severe internal injuries.

My already poor condition worsened.

"So..."

I could see Venderwood approaching with his greatsword.

And in the distance, the mana stone ready to explode.

"..."

I couldn't do anything in that state.

Spatial magic.

Spirit magic.

Dark magic.

Martial arts.

I was incapable of any action.

Is this what it feels like when everything collapses and is lost?

"Ugh..."

I wanted to resist Venderwood with all my might, but my body refused to cooperate.

If things continued this way, everyone would die.

The people quietly living in the capital.

The nobles.

My acquaintances.

Everyone would die.

I clenched my fist.

This couldn't happen.

I must resist somehow.

Even if it meant squeezing out every last bit of mana from the ground.

I must think of some way.

However, no method came to mind.

All I could see was Venderwood approaching me.

I was powerless.

Just as Perrian had said, I was a weakling.

If there's no one around, I can't do anything.

"Ah...?"

Then, a sound came from Venderwood.

Thud.

I felt a sensation above my head.

White smoke appeared beside me, and the smell of tobacco stung my nose.

Boom!!!!

A loud explosion sounded.

It was a really loud noise, but it wasn't from Perrian's mana stone.

I wasn't sure if I was crying, but my vision blurred.

After wiping my eyes with my sleeve, I could see ahead.

Somehow, Venderwood had been sent flying far away and was rolling on the ground.

As I stared blankly at that scene, a voice came from beside me.

"What are you, a kid? Stop your sniveling."

I turned my head to look beside me.

There was a man, Robert, with a white cigarette in his mouth and one hand resting above my head.

Chapter 253: Robert (1)

Robert looked at Rudy.

The moment for decision had come.

"You're not a kid, what's with the whining?"

Robert patted Rudy's head.

'I believe in this guy.'

Robert didn't want to make Rudy like himself.

Or perhaps, it was for his own sake.

To avoid any more regrets, Robert had come here.

Robert was an orphan.

He barely survived after being abandoned in the capital.

To avoid starving, he begged; to survive, he clung to adults.

Fortunately, being abandoned in the capital was a blessing in disguise.

Near the capital was Ephomos.

It overflowed with orphans like him, and there were people willing to take care of them.

Though "taking care of" might sound kind, in reality, these people exploited the orphans.

They made them pickpocket to line their own pockets, providing the orphans with just enough bread to live on.

While living day by day through pickpocketing, he encountered magic.

Necromancy.

It was a magic that orphans in Ephomos could easily come across.

The very people who made the orphans pickpocket were necromancers.

They used the money the orphans made from pickpocketing for their research.

Every day, as Robert pickpocketed and contributed to them, he learned magic by watching from the corner of his eye.

He learned the basics of magic this way and practiced it.

Though young enough to survive through pickpocketing, he thought that learning necromancy was essential for surviving the future.

He lived by pickpocketing in the morning and learning magic in the evening.

During such a life.

"What are you doing?"

"Excuse me?"

"My wallet. Give it back."

He encountered Levian, a middle-aged man.

"Ugh... Wind Blaster!"

Robert used magic to try and escape from Levian.

"Oh..."

Levian was impressed that a child who was pickpocketing could use magic properly.

"What do you do?"

"I'm a wizard."

"...What?"

Despite trying to escape with magic, Robert couldn't get away from Levian, who was an accomplished wizard at the time.

Levian smiled and approached Robert.

"How about learning magic from me?"

Levian saw potential in Robert.

It was unthinkable that a child living off the streets and pickpocketing could have learned proper magic on his own.

Yet, since Robert had used magic, Levian believed that with proper instruction, he could become an even greater wizard.

Thus, Levian took Robert back to the capital, kept him nearby, and observed him for several days.

Confirming his initial judgment was correct, Levian made an offer to Robert.

"You should enter the academy."

"...The academy?"

"If you go there, you'll be able to learn a lot. About magic, about being human, and even what it means to have friends."

With a smile, Robert responded.

"I refuse."

Robert was aware of the academy.

He knew it was a place for nobles, where attending cost a fortune.

He'd rather save that money to live on his own.

"Haha, such a bold one. But,"

Levian said with a broad smile to Robert.

"Did I give you a choice?"

Robert was then captured by Levian's magic and sent to the academy.

Tied up with ropes, he was loaded onto a carriage and sent to the academy with just a letter.

"Mmph!"

"...What's this?"

"A letter from Levian."

[Turn this one into a proper person. Professor McDowell.]

"Huh..."

Robert was thus left in the care of Professor McDowell at the time.

Given Levian was a royal wizard, Professor McDowell couldn't possibly refuse his request.

"What's your name?"

Professor McDowell asked as he untied Robert.

"...Puhah! Who are you?"

"McDowell. Call me Professor McDowell."

"Professor? Anyway, send me back to the capital. If there's any money Levian paid, please return it."

"Money?"

"This academy's expensive, isn't it? So, Levian must have paid for my tuition. Please give that money back."

"There's no such thing."

"What?"

"If there's no money, I can't attend, can I?"

"Why ask me? I wouldn't know."

Levian had not given any money to Robert.

If he had provided tuition fees, Robert could have taken the money and run away or come back with it.

To prevent this, Levian didn't support any tuition or fees.

Professor McDowell, understanding the situation somewhat, said,

"That doesn't mean there's no way."

"There's a way?"

"The academy has a very good scholarship system. There's an entrance exam the day after tomorrow. Score well on it, and you won't need to pay anything."

"...I have a question."

"What is it?"

"If I get the money, can I run away?"

"...Haha."

After some thought, Professor McDowell spoke,

"Alright. If you top the exams, I'll give you the money. But if you score anything less, you're staying at the academy."

"Top the exams..."

Robert thus took the entrance exam for the academy.

His goal was the money.

He planned to top the academy, receive the scholarship, and then run away.

Robert was confident he could top the exams.

After all, the academy was filled with nothing but noble brats.

He couldn't possibly lose to them, having learned magic the hard way.

However, that was a misconception.

[

Charles Cromwell 2. Robert 3. Elena 4. George Mcguire

...

]

"What?"

Robert secured second place.

He scored higher than anyone in practical magic, but his weakness in theory placed him second.

1 Charles Cromwell 2. Robert 3. Elena 4. George Mcguire

So, it was impossible for him to secure the first place.

"Huh..."

McDowell thought his heart would sink.

Especially since Robert, expected to rank low, had managed to secure second place.

"Did you say McDowell?"

"Call me Professor McDowell."

"Whatever the title. I have a question."

"Uh-huh?"

"That Cromwell bastard. Who the hell is he?"

That was the first encounter between Robert and Cromwell.

The first defeat Robert felt.

Whether noble or commoner, he simply beat them in magic skill.

Robert had thought himself the best in magic among his peers.

After all, his abilities were recognized by Levian, a royal wizard.

Yet, he couldn't believe he had lost.

"...What the f*ck are you doing?"

"I should be asking you. Who are you? Coming out of nowhere, swearing at me."

Robert went straight to Cromwell to pick a fight.

Then, a woman intervened between the two.

"Don't fight, you two!"

"...And who is this?"

"I'm Elena... But, regardless, you two should get along! Stop fighting!"

She was Elena, a commoner like himself who had proudly secured third place.

Robert looked at Elena curiously.

After looking at Elena, Robert turned back to Cromwell and shouted.

"Just so you know, first place is mine."

"Ha! Struggle all you want. You won't be taking first place from me."

And so, their rivalry began.

Both of them strove hard to secure first place, improving their skills significantly in the process.

Because of this fight, Robert never thought about returning to the capital again.

He was solely focused on studying to defeat Cromwell.

"The valedictorian spot is mine..."

"That's bullsh*t. I've been first more times than you, how could that be possible?"

"What?"

"You two, again! It's graduation day, why are you fighting!"

Their rivalry continued until the day of graduation, becoming a well-known spectacle within the academy.

Robert and Cromwell fought, and Elena intervened.

It had become such a routine event that even the professors no longer paid it much mind.

"Elena, just leave them. It's not like it's their first day fighting."

Mcguire, always present, enjoyed watching their quarrels.

These four were always seen together.

The four of them, competing and growing together, were the focus of everyone's attention.

"So, Robert, what will you do after graduation?"

"After graduation? Probably head towards becoming a royal wizard. Levian is there, after all."

"And Cromwell? Professorship?"

"Yeah, there's still a lot I want to research at the academy."

"What about you, Elena?"

"Me...? Hmm... What to do..."

"Elena, how about heading towards being a royal wizard? It's actually the best place for a wizard without a family name."

"Is, is that so? What about you, Mcguire? Where will you go?"

"I'm probably heading towards a professorship. I've always wanted to be a professor since the old days."

As he said this, the corners of Elena's mouth twitched upwards.

"Well, guess I have no choice then!"

"...What do you mean, no choice?"

"I have to take care of Robert! If I don't, he'll just keep getting into fights with others!"

Robert looked at Elena bewilderedly.

"I'm not some brawler. Don't take it so lightly, think about it seriously."

"I was being serious!"

"Elena, you've got your work cut out for you."

"Tell me about it."

"What's that supposed to mean?"

Amid their conversation, a loud announcement was made.

"Now, we will announce the valedictorian of the 12th class of Liberion Academy. The valedictorian is... Charles Cromwell. And the salutatorian is Robert. There will be an award for the two of you. Please come forward."

"...Are you kidding me?"

"A fair and wise ranking, indeed."

Robert and Cromwell said simultaneously.

Then, Robert bristled.

"In our third year, my grades were..."

Just as they were about to fight, Mcguire pushed them from behind.

"Go on, both of you. Are you going to keep fighting even on graduation day?"

"Ugh..."

Grumbling, Robert and Cromwell went forward.

"Robert..."

Elena looked at Robert's back with pity.

"Elena, you don't need to worry so much."

"Huh?"

"This is actually better for him."

Mcguire said with a smile to Elena.

"Because Cromwell took the top spot, Robert will become stronger. He'll become an even better wizard."

"Really?"

"Just keep watching. By Robert's side."

Elena and Mcguire watched as Robert and Cromwell walked forward.

"Don't get complacent just because you did a bit better in school. I'll soon surpass you as a wizard."

"We'll see about that."

Thus, they bickered back and forth, finishing the graduation ceremony.

Cromwell and Mcguire stayed at the academy, while Robert and Elena headed to the empire's capital.

Becoming royal wizards was quite easy for Robert and Elena with their skills.

Robert was the salutatorian of the academy, and Elena had consistently ranked third.

They supported each other, honing their skills, and both became outstanding wizards.

"Robert, you're getting on in age. Aren't you thinking about marriage?"

"What kind of bullsh*t is that?"

"Hey, even as a royal wizard, should you be using such vulgar language?"

"What does it matter how I speak?"

Robert continued his magic research under Levian as planned.

They got along well, bickering just like when they first met.

"I'd like to see my grandchildren someday, Robert."

"Then ask your own son."

"You know I don't have a son."

"Why are you telling me to get married then? I'm too busy studying magic."

"You have a partner, don't you?"

"...Partner?"

"Elena is there, isn't she?"

"...?"

As they were talking, Elena burst into the room.

"Robert!! Let's have dinner together tonight! I've finished my work!"

Elena looked back and forth between the two puzzledly.

"...Is there something going on?"

"No, nothing special..."

"Elena. What do you think about Robert?"

As Levian asked with a pleased smile, Elena tilted her head in confusion.

"Like a good friend... we've spent a lot of time together..."

"No, I mean as a partner."

"What?????"

Elena's face turned crimson red.

"Partner? Partner? As in the partner I'm thinking of... Suddenly?"

"I really dislike beating around the bush."

As Levian said this, Elena fidgeted with her fingers.

"That's... I don't hate the idea..."

"Really?"

Hearing this, Levian pushed Robert's back.

"You two planned to have dinner, right? Off you go then."

"...What? I still have work to do. My research isn't—"

"That can wait. You can ask others for help."

"As if there's a dark wizard among the royal wizards..."

Then, a black hand emerged from Levian's shadow, lifting Robert and Elena out the door.

"Old man!"

"Go enjoy your meal."

Levian smiled, watching them leave, and then closed the door to his study.

Robert looked at the closed door with a bewildered expression.

"Ro, Robert... What should we do...?"

"Let's just go have dinner for now."

And so, they got up and left the Magic Tower.

Levian watched them leave the Tower from his study.

"Good times..."

Levian smiled contentedly.

Chapter 254: Robert (2)

After that incident, love blossomed between the two.

Thus, they got married, and Elena was soon carrying the fruit of their love.

However, their happiness was short-lived.

"Elena..."

Robert took Elena's small hand in his.

Elena's hand, once warm, was now growing cold.

"Robert... I'm sorry. I... I..."

"No, don't say it. You don't have to..."

Suddenly, the door burst open!

Levian rushed in.

"What's happening here? The healing magic isn't working."

"Le... Levian."

"I don't understand. After giving birth, magic doesn't affect Elena. It's like pouring water into a bottomless pot..."

"Move."

Levian pushed aside the healer and manipulated mana.

"Lord Levian... Do you not understand what's happening here..."

Elena spoke, gasping for breath.

Levian shook his head.

"No, that can't be it."

This wasn't something that only happened to mothers.

It was a phenomenon seen in those gravely injured or dying.

Despite pouring in healing magic, the mana would drain away, indicating the person's self-healing capabilities were depleted.

Even with healing magic, it essentially aided the person, not directly saving them.

Without self-healing, pouring in healing magic was meaningless.

"Elena, just hold on a little longer. I..."

"No... I know both of you did your best."

"Elena!!"

With the last of her strength, Elena grasped the hands of Levian and Robert.

"Please take care of our child..."

"Elena... Elena..."

"Please... Robert. Promise me."

"Oh, no. Elena, I..."

Elena's grip weakened.

Robert's eyes widened as he cried.

He couldn't even give her a proper response.

He only cried as she passed, unable to answer her.

That's how Robert had to let Elena go.

"Robert, are you feeling any better now?"

"What can I do? Elena is gone. All I have left is Richard. I have to get up for his sake."

Though the pain in his heart and the memories with Elena lingered, time cruelly moved on.

Robert couldn't stay in his sorrow forever.

He had his son, Richard, and had to live on for him.

Robert tried to act as if nothing was wrong, letting time pass.

It was then that Levian approached him.

"Robert. Why don't you take a break?"

"Huh?"

"I'll look after Richard for a bit. You go clear your head."

"With him...?"

Turning to where Levian pointed, there was Cromwell.

"It's been a while, Robert."

"Ah..."

"Take a short trip with Cromwell to the academy, see the world a bit. It'll help you clear your head."

After much thought, Robert nodded.

"I'll be back in a week. Please take care of Richard during this time. I'll write a letter to the nanny in case you're busy..."

"Don't worry about that. I wouldn't just leave a child I consider like my own grandson."

"Thank you."

Robert said his goodbyes and left with Cromwell.

They didn't speak as they boarded the carriage.

The carriage headed towards the academy.

During the ride, neither of them spoke; only silence filled the air.

"I was a terrible husband."

Robert broke the silence first.

"..."

"I couldn't even respond to Elena's last words, just cried. I should have said something, anything, as a proper farewell... I..."

Thump!

Cromwell slapped Robert's back as he vented.

"Such responses don't matter. What matters is that you do as Elena wished, as she wanted."

"..."

"You're a father now. Not a student of the academy, not a royal wizard, but a father. Is that how a father behaves?"

Cromwell said this and opened the window.

Outside, the academy's lights were visible.

"Still, it's okay to be sad for now. For a moment, you don't have to be a father, just my dear friend."

"..."

Robert quietly nodded at Cromwell's words.

"Leaving already? Why not stay a bit longer?"

At McGuire's words, Robert smiled.

"I'm worried about my son."

"Next time, bring your son along for a visit."

Cromwell said to Robert as he was about to leave.

Just then, a man approached them.

"What are you all doing here?"

He was dressed in very luxurious clothes.

Robert narrowed his eyes at the man.

"Who are you?"

"Ah, my apologies for the late introduction. I'm Ophillius."

"Ophillius?"

Cromwell nudged Robert.

"Jason Ophillius. The Chancellor of the Empire."

"...The Chancellor?"

Robert's eyes widened.

"I've heard a lot about you. Robert, wasn't it? Famous as Levian's disciple."

"Thank you. My name is Robert."

Robert extended his hand to Ophillius.

Cromwell looked at Ophillius shaking hands and asked.

"Are you heading back now?"

"Yes, I've finished my discussions with McDowell. Are you also returning to the capital?"

"Ah, yes."

Ophillius said with a friendly smile to Robert.

"Then let's go together. It'll be boring alone. I'll provide the carriage."

Robert found himself in a slightly awkward situation.

Still, hearing that the Chancellor of the Empire was well-acquainted with Levian and was reputed to be a good person, Robert put aside his doubts.

Since there was no carriage available, it seemed best to accept Ophillius's offer to share his.

"Alright, let's go together."

With Robert's acceptance, Ophillius smiled.

"Then, have a good trip."

"See you later."

Robert bid farewell to Cromwell and boarded the carriage with Ophillius.

"Shall we head to the capital then?"

"Yes, to the capital..."

"No, wait."

Ophillius interrupted Robert's agreement to head to the capital.

"Let's go to Ephomos instead."

The coachman, upon hearing this, made a subtle expression but nodded.

"Ephomos, you say? ...Alright."

Robert was puzzled by Ophillius's decision.

Before Robert could ask, Ophillius explained.

"I have some business to attend to in Ephomos. I'll get off there, and you can continue on to the capital."

Robert considered this for a moment.

He realized he hadn't been to Ephomos since he was a child.

"No, I'll also stop by Ephomos."

"In Ephomos? Do you have some business there?"

"Not exactly..."

"Hmm... Alright. It doesn't matter to me."

And so, the carriage drove on.

"Nothing's changed here."

They arrived in Ephomos.

"I'll go and attend to my business then. Beware of pickpockets here."

"Sure, go ahead."

Robert watched Ophillius leave and then looked around.

From the place he stayed...

"This is where I met Levian."

...to the place where he had met Levian.

Robert remembered the time he had stolen Levian's wallet.

The thought made him laugh.

Stealing the wallet of someone who was a royal wizard of all people.

It was a ridiculous situation.

As he aimlessly observed Ephomos,

Thump!

Someone hit Robert's pocket and ran.

He looked at the person who bumped into him with disbelief.

It was a scruffy-looking child.

"The technique hasn't changed, has it?"

Robert smiled and chased after the child.

"Aaaaah! Please, spare me!!!"

"I won't kill you. Just make you wish I had."

Robert chased the child and raided their hideout.

Ephomos hadn't changed.

Necromancers were gathering children and teaching them to pickpocket.

"Tsk..."

Robert clicked his tongue and looked down at the necromancer at his feet.

"I'll give you anything you want, just please..."

"What could you possibly offer me? You're just scum, aren't you?"

"No, no! If you look at this data..."

The necromancer pointed towards a desk.

Robert looked at the documents laid out there.

"...Resurrection magic?"

"Yes! We can resurrect people with necromancy! According to our research..."

The necromancer mumbled something, but Robert wasn't listening.

At the mention of resurrection magic, Elena's face came to Robert's mind.

"Can it be used right away?"

"What?"

"Can you use it right now?"

"We can't right away... because we lack the skills... Just give us some time."

"Hmm..."

Robert, after intently looking at the documents, lifted his foot off the necromancer.

"Th-thank you..."

"Pack up all those documents."

"What?"

"Hand over all the documents. I'll look into them."

"You're going to research..."

"Don't like that idea?"

"No, not at all!"

The necromancer quickly got up and stuffed all his documents into a bag.

Robert took the bag of magical documents and stood up.

"I'm leaving. Make sure to improve by the time I return. And know that if I come back and find you treating those kids like this, you're dead."

"Understood!"

With the documents in hand, Robert returned to his home in the capital.

"Dada!"

"Wow, do you already recognize your father?"

Upon returning home, Robert found Levian holding Richard.

Robert immediately took Richard into his arms.

"Your mood seems better."

"Yes, seeing a friend and the world has improved my spirits."

"That's good."

Levian smiled and moved to leave.

"Are you going? Stay for dinner..."

"No, you and your son need time together. I should be going."

As Levian was about to leave, something caught his eye.

"What's in that bag?"

Robert, who had left empty-handed, now had a bag with him.

"Oh, just a souvenir. I went to the academy after a long time..."

"A souvenir?"

Levian narrowed his eyes.

He looked at Robert suspiciously.

Robert slightly turned his head, avoiding Levian's gaze.

"Alright then. I'll be off."

"Yes, go ahead."

Levian felt something was off but decided there was no need to pry into something Robert wanted to keep hidden.

Chapter 255: Robert (3)

"Dad!!! Look at this!!"

"Hmm?"

"I can use magic!!!"

"You can?"

Years passed like that.

Richard grew up fast, and he was already over 10 years old.

"Look! Fireball!"

Then, flames appeared in Richard's hand.

Robert's eyes widened.

It was rare for a 10-year-old to use magic.

Moreover, Robert had never taught Richard any magic.

"How did you learn magic?"

"I learned from a book on Dad's desk!"

"Desk?"

Magic learned on his own.

Robert remembered his own childhood.

He too had learned magic on his own.

Seeing that Robert didn't say anything, Richard's expression soured.

He had touched Dad's desk without permission.

"That... touching Dad's desk was..."

Just as Richard was about to apologize to Robert,

"Richard, you're a genius!"

Robert smiled brightly and ruffled Richard's hair.

Richard beamed at Robert's praise.

"Yeah! I'm a genius!"

"But still, you shouldn't touch Dad's desk carelessly. There are many dangerous things."

"Okay! I understand!"

With that, Robert stood up.

It was time for Richard to go to bed.

Richard lay in bed, covered himself with a blanket, and spoke.

"Dad, when I grow up, I want to be your apprentice."

"Apprentice?"

"Yeah! I want to be a wizard like you."

"I don't think that's a very good idea..."

The magic Robert used was dark magic.

The perception of dark magic wasn't very good among the public.

Even though Levian did a lot to change that perception, it couldn't change overnight.

"I'm going to be a wizard like Dad!"

".....Let's talk about that later."

For now, Robert dodged the topic.

'He's still young. Hopefully, he'll change his mind later.'

"Now go to sleep."

"Okay, Dad, sleep well too."

Robert then put Richard to sleep and walked down to the basement of the mansion.

"It's almost finished."

Research on resurrection magic.

The research was nearing completion.

In fact, the research on the magic itself was finished, but there was a lack of mana to be infused.

"How much mana stone is needed..."

No matter how expensive the mana stone inserted, the magic did not activate.

The magic just greedily consumed the mana stones without any change.

".....Sigh."

Robert sighed and continued with his research.

The next day.

Thump—

Robert, dozing off, banged his head on the desk.

Seeing Robert's state, Levian looked worried.

"Robert, you seem to be in bad shape these days."

"Ah....."

It was no wonder he wasn't well, researching necromancy at night and working as a royal wizard during the day.

Levian kept an eye on Robert.

"Robert, come outside for a moment."

"Understood."

Levian stepped outside with Robert and lit a cigarette.

Robert then took a cigarette out of his pocket as well.

"Didn't you tell Richard you quit smoking?"

"How can I quit overnight?"

"It's a promise you made to your son, isn't it?"

"That's why I don't smoke in front of him."

"I see... Anyway, what have you been up to these days?"

"What do you mean?"

"I've been hearing things. You've been visiting Ephomos more frequently."

Upon hearing this, Robert's expression hardened.

"Robert, I know what you're doing."

Levian said this and sighed.

"I know you miss Elena deeply. But you shouldn't resort to necromancy. Think about why the empire has banned necromancy. It's not magic that creates miracles; it defies the natural order."

"I understand."

"I believe you'll make the right decision."

Levian said this and went back into the Tower alone.

Robert watched Levian's back and muttered quietly,

"I'm sorry, Master."

He bowed his head in the direction Levian had gone.

Robert extinguished his cigarette and went inside the Tower.

"Are you on leave?"

"Yeah, I'm going to take a short break."

"Uh... um..."

"I have plenty of leave left. Just use that."

"Understood... But, shouldn't you at least inform Lord Levian..."

"It's fine. I'll handle it."

"Understood."

With that, Robert headed to Ephomos.

"I've almost finished my research. But why isn't it working? It should work according to the theory."

"You know why, Lord Robert. It's because there's not enough mana."

"Not enough mana? I'm using the highest quality mana stones."

"Can a human life be equivalent to a mana stone?"

"So, what should I do?"

The necromancer stroked his chin and stood up.

"Alright... I'll give you our treasure. It's because you've helped with the research."

"Treasure?"

The necromancer then opened a safe in the laboratory.

"This is the mana stone."

A mana stone filled with tremendous mana.

It contained more mana than the highest quality mana stone.

"Where did this come from?"

"I can't tell you that."

Robert stared intently at the necromancer.

"Even if you look at me like that, I can't tell you. I would die!"

"Alright, I won't ask if you're giving it to me."

Robert accepted the mana stone from the necromancer.

"Then I'll come back later."

"Yes, please be careful."

Robert returned to his mansion with the mana stone given by the necromancer.

"Dad?"

Richard's eyes widened when he saw Robert.

It wasn't the usual time for Robert to return.

Richard, puzzled but happy, exclaimed,

"Dad! What's happening? At this time..."

Robert smiled,

"Richard, Dad took some time off."

"Really? So you'll play with me?"

Robert hesitated for a moment, fidgeting with the mana stone in his pocket.

However, he pushed aside his concerns,

"Yes, let's enjoy today to the fullest!"

"Really!"

"Yes, what shall we play?"

Robert began to play wholeheartedly with Richard.

They played until sunset, and as it turned to evening, Richard's eyes began to droop.

"Richard, should we go to bed now?"

"Mm... I want to play more with Dad..."

"Dad took a longer leave, so we have tomorrow too. Let's play again tomorrow."

"Really?"

"Really."

With that, Richard dashed into his bedroom.

Peeking out from the door, Richard said,

"Then I'll go to bed early and play with Dad from tomorrow morning."

Robert laughed,

"Alright, let's play to our heart's content from tomorrow morning."

"Okay! Goodnight, Dad."

Watching Richard enter the bedroom, Robert smiled but then his expression turned serious.

He sighed deeply, reaching into his pocket to look at the mana stone he had received earlier.

Robert then headed to the mansion's basement.

A huge magic circle laid out in the basement was the result of Robert's research.

"Please... Elena..."

Robert placed the mana stone at the center of the magic circle.

Suddenly, the magic circle began to emit a strong light.

The circle, which hadn't moved even with the highest quality mana stone, finally activated.

Tears started to well up in Robert's eyes as he watched the magic circle move.

Finally, he could see Elena... bring back Elena's form...

However, things didn't go as smoothly as expected.

The magic circle suddenly began to vibrate intensely.

"What's that?"

Feeling something was wrong, Robert grabbed onto the wall.

A strong pressure emanated from the magic circle.

Suddenly, a black object started to emerge, looking like an arm.

Then, a massive mouth appeared.

The arm began to grab everything around, indiscriminately seizing desks, chairs, and magical tools, and feeding them into the mouth-like part.

"What the..."

Robert was shocked.

The magic circle started to devour everything.

It was hard to understand what was happening.

Then, the black arm approached Robert.

"Ugh... Behemoth!"

With a roar, Robert quickly summoned Behemoth and cut down the arm trying to grab him.

'It has to stop.'

Something was clearly wrong.

Despite following the theory exactly, the outcome was bizarrely unexpected.

"Ugh... It must stop..."

Robert responded to the arm with dark magic as best as he could.

But he had no idea how to stop the magic.

'I have to destroy it.'

It was not the time to think about research materials or anything else.

Leaving this magic unchecked could endanger the mansion... and possibly Richard.

Robert poured all his mana into trying to destroy the magic circle.

That's when he was focusing.

"Dad?"

"Ah..."

Richard appeared at the door.

"What's this...?"

"Richard! No! Run away...!"

Then the black arm grabbed Richard.

"Ah..."

Robert let out a cry.

He had to sever that arm.

Richard... Richard...

"Those who defy the will of the gods..."

Robert was solely focused on destroying the magic circle.

"Descend."

Then, a black object appeared behind Robert.

A demon.

He had summoned a demon into his own body.

"Protect... Richard..."

"Dad!!!!!"

The black arm tried to swallow Richard, and the demon summoned behind Robert tried to stop it.

The magic circle put Richard into its mouth, and the demon thrust its arm directly into the circle.

Then a bright light appeared.

Boom!!!!

With a huge explosion, the black object slowly disappeared, and Robert rushed to the center of the magic circle.

"Richard! Richard!"

Breathlessly, Robert searched for Richard in the aftermath of the explosion.

Then, crying came from the center of the magic circle.

"Dad... It hurts... It hurts..."

It was Richard, screaming in pain.

Robert ran towards him.

Richard had severe injuries.

"Richard... It's okay... It will be okay..."

"Dad... It hurts so much..."

Tears came to Robert's eyes as Richard cried out in pain.

"I'm sorry. I'm sorry... I'm sorry."

"Sorry...? Why are you sorry, Dad... Don't cry, Dad..."

Richard said to Robert through tears.

"Dad... Don't cry... Don't cry... Ah..."

"Ri, Richard. Stay, stay with me. Ri, Richard."

Robert shouted at Richard, who was losing consciousness.

However,

"..."

Richard could no longer say anything.

"Ah... Ri, Richard... Richard..."

Bang!

As Robert was crying out Richard's name, a man entered from behind.

"Robert! What's happened here! What's this vibration..."

It was Levian.

Levian was shouting at Robert and then saw Richard in his arms.

"Robert. What on earth have you done!!! Robert!!!!!!"

Levian yelled loudly at Robert.

"Didn't I explicitly tell you not to do it!! Necromancy!!!! Necromancy!!!!!!"

At the shouting, Robert turned around.

"Ma, Master..."

Levian said with an angry face.

"No, you are no longer my disciple."

Then, soldiers entered from behind Levian.

"What's going on here! This is..."

The soldiers looked around and asked Levian.

"Take him away."

"Him? But he's a royal wizard..."

"He is no longer a royal wizard."

Levian looked at Robert with a murderous glare.

"He's just a criminal who used necromancy."

Levian took Richard from his arms and had Robert taken away.

That was the last time Robert saw Levian.

Robert was imprisoned in a dungeon.

Then, one day, he was released from it.

"What is this?"

"By the emperor's command. You have contributed much to the empire, so you are released. However, you are stripped of your title as a royal wizard and any honorary positions given by the empire. Instead, you are granted freedom to atone for your sins."

"Freedom...?"

The soldiers threw Robert outside and returned to the dungeon.

Robert looked up at the sky.

He had no idea what to do next.

Elena was dead, Richard was dead, and he was abandoned by Levian.

He aimlessly wandered the battlefield.

Just to survive. Or rather, to forget the deeds he had committed, he kept fighting.

One day, after a battle, he took out a cigarette from his pocket.

Robert stared at the cigarette, then crumpled it.

He wondered what he was doing... What all this was for...

"What are you doing, Robert?"

A voice was heard.

Robert, looking at the crumpled cigarette, raised his head.

Then, he saw a middle-aged man.

Despite being aged and wrinkled, he recognized him.

"Cromwell..."

"What are you doing, Robert?"

"I..."

Whack!

Cromwell clenched his fist and struck Robert's face.

Robert fell to the ground and looked up at Cromwell.

"Is this what you wanted? Is this what Elena wanted? Do you think Richard wanted to see you like this? Get a grip, Robert."

"Cromwell..."

"Isn't it time you came to your senses? It's been 5 years. Five years since Richard died. And yet..."

"I don't know... what I should do now. What I want. I... I..."

Cromwell stared at Robert.

Then, he extended his hand.

"Come to the academy."

"What?"

Robert looked incredulous.

"Come to the academy."

"That's ridiculous..."

"I've already got permission from Principal McDowell. So, stop arguing and come. To the academy."

Robert was dragged by Cromwell to the academy.

He ended up taking a position as a professor at the academy.

Robert worked there, if only to honor the man who brought him, Cromwell.

Even when random thoughts surfaced or strange feelings arose, he focused solely on his work.

During his years as a professor,

Robert met Rudy.

With the mana stone about to explode,

And Vendewood thrown far away,

There sat Rudy, powerless and slumped.

Robert looked around at them.

He had seen this situation before.

'I have shown you both the past and the future. Now, what is your choice?'

It was something Saint Haruna had told him.

She had shown him both his past and future.

In the past, he had bid farewell to his wife with tears.

Sent off his son with screams of agony.

And let go of his master without a word.

Robert had been a poor husband.

A poor father.

A poor disciple.

"Rudy."

Yet,

At the very least.

"You were my best disciple."

He wanted to be the best master.

"Professor?"

Robert walked forward.

Behind him, a demon appeared.

Robert said to the demon,

"Destroy this mana stone."

"What's the price?"

"My life."

"Understood."

Rudy's eyes widened.

"Professor?"

Rudy tried to get up and run towards Robert.

Robert slightly turned his head to look at Rudy.

Robert was smiling brighter than ever before.

"Take care, Rudy."

Chapter 256: Robert (4)

It happened in an instant, before I could even grasp what was going on. The mana stone that was about to explode vanished, and Robert collapsed.

I don't remember much after that.

I definitely heard Ian and Astina's voices... and it felt like someone was carrying me.

"Rudy? Are you awake?"

As I slowly opened my eyes, trying to gather my thoughts, Luna was sitting in front of me.

"How long have I been lying here?"

"About three days... Can you wait a moment? I'll call the others."

"Okay."

Luna got up and left the sickroom.

I blankly stared at her retreating figure, but what I was truly curious about wasn't how long I had been unconscious.

I was certain I had met Professor Robert.

The image of him smiling lingered before my eyes.

It wasn't my imagination.

Professor Robert was definitely...

The door to the sickroom opened, and Luna came back.

"Rudy..."

Seeing Luna's face, tears started to flow from my eyes. Luna came closer without saying a word.

"Rudy, it's okay. Everything is okay."

"Professor Robert is..."

I couldn't finish my sentence as it was interrupted by my sobbing.

Luna quietly hugged me. My heart ached, and a vague feeling became a harsh reality.

"Professor Robert is no longer with us."

I didn't know much about Professor Robert's family.

Yet, I knew Professor Robert had stories about his family.

"Do you remember what Robert said to you in the beginning?"

"...The beginning?"

Robert said that he didn't take disciples.

"Robert didn't want to create people he had to take responsibility for, or people who would take responsibility for him. He couldn't bear the sorrow of losing his family and the sorrow of being abandoned by his mentor. To avoid going through that again, he didn't try to make connections with people."

"..."

"That's when you came along. There was Borval, too, but he was different. The relationship between him and Robert was more professional than that of a mentor and disciple."

Cromwell said this and took a bottle of alcohol out of his bag.

"He took you as his disciple. There wasn't any special reason. He liked the way you worked hard.

You really struggled like hell at the academy, didn't you?"

He brought the bottle to his mouth and gulped down the alcohol.

After drinking, he wiped his mouth with his sleeve and spoke.

"To Robert, you were a commitment, a disciple, and a son."

"..."

"Robert wouldn't have wanted you to be so sad and downhearted. He wouldn't have wanted you to have regrets. He would have wanted you to stand up proudly."

Cromwell poured the alcohol over the gravestone and looked at me.

"It's time to get up now. Shouldn't we start moving? You have many people around you, not just Robert."

I had many thoughts during the week I spent in the sickroom.

If I had been stronger, more cautious, or if there had been something else, could Robert have lived?

However, there are no "ifs" in reality.

I have lived my life doing my best, facing reality head-on.

If I crumble here because Robert is dead, it would be no different than destroying everything I've built up.

As Cromwell said, there's still a lot left for me.

If Robert were here, he would have scolded me and slapped me on the back, asking if I was going to fall apart over something like this, if this was how I was going to end things.

I must live. I cannot fall apart here.

"You were my best disciple."

Remembering Robert's words, I looked at Cromwell.

"I am a disciple of Professor Robert. I cannot fall apart here."

"Right."

Cromwell smiled upon hearing my words.

Cromwell and I flew through the sky and arrived at the academy.

"Take these things with you."

Cromwell handed me a few items. They were Robert's belongings.

"Is it okay for me to take these?"

"I can't take them, can I? Most of them are related to dark magic,"

Cromwell said with a smile.

"...Thank you."

"What's there to thank me for, giving you luggage to carry?"

"I'm thanking you for something else."

Cromwell's words were a great help.

Robert wasn't the only thing in my life.

Although Robert played a significant part in my life, I still had a lot left.

The Astria family and the rebels of Aryandor.

And the people who believe in me and are waiting for me.

I'm greedy. I couldn't give up any of it.

"Then, go rest now."

"Aren't you going to take me? After bringing me here."

Cromwell laughed at my playful tone.

"It's difficult to take you by magic, but I can catch a carriage for you. Go to the front of the academy."

"Thank you."

I smiled and went outside. Outside the academy, countless cherry blossoms stood out. The rich scent of flowers was in the air. Soon, new students will enter.

Someone's life has ended, but someone else's life is about to begin.

I stretched out.

"Maybe I should see the faces of the other guys."

Though third-year students like Luna and Rie might not be around, it was about time for second-year students like Yuni and Kuhn to start returning to the academy.

"Hey, young master of the Astria family."

As I was thinking this and walking forward, someone called out to me.

"...?"

In front of me stood an old lady with her hands clasped behind her back.

"You've been busy lately, haven't you? Not even coming to eat."

This grandmother was the owner of the restaurant Robert used to take me to, a place that served cheonggukjang.

Surprised to see her after a long time, my eyes widened.

"How about a bowl of food?"

The grandmother pointed with her cane to a shabby building, where her shop was located.

"Just recently, that damned Robert came to pay off his debt and said one thing before he left. 'I've paid off everything, so give my disciple a meal sometime.'"

The grandmother chuckled and gestured for me to follow her with a wave of her hand.

"Have a bowl of food before you go. I'll make it tasty for you."

Hearing the grandmother's words, I smiled.

"Yes, I'll have a bowl before I leave."

Chapter 257: Family Head Contest

(1)

"Senior, came?"

"Wasn't he talking with Professor Cromwell earlier?"

"Then where did he go now!"

At Kuhn's words, Yuni stomped her feet in frustration.

"Where he is now..."

"Got it."

Yuni nodded and went outside.

"Rudy!! Where are you!!"

Yuni shouted here and there, wandering around the academy.

During her search, someone grabbed Yuni.

Startled, Yuni looked at the person who grabbed her.

"Rudy!!"

"What, you're making a fuss all over the place. Why are you shouting like that?"

"If you're at the academy, you should at least show your face."

"I was actually planning to stop by after eating."

"Then you should have eaten with me."

"It's way past lunchtime. Haven't you eaten?"

"No? Of course, I've eaten. Who hasn't eaten at this hour?"

Rudy looked at Yuni with a bemused expression.

Yuni thought she was speaking normally, but concern was evident in her eyes.

News about Rudy had reached Yuni as well.

Rudy, who was considered to have a strong mentality, was struggling with the loss of someone very close to him.

Even Yuni, who usually lived without worries, couldn't help but be concerned about Rudy.

Rudy had protected and helped her when she was in danger.

Yuni thought it was her turn to help.

"Senior, I've made up my mind."

"Made up your mind?"

"I've decided to run for student council president."

Rudy's eyes widened at her words.

Yuni's only flaw was her extreme nervousness in front of many people.

She had always failed when she truly tried her best.

Yuni was well aware of this.

"As you know, I can't stand in front of people. But I'm going to be the student council president."

"No... It's better not to overdo it..."

"No, I will overdo it."

Yuni walked boldly forward.

Approaching Rudy, Yuni looked up at him.

"Instead, please overdo it too, Rudy. Stand up, even if it's hard, and become the Rudy you used to be. It might be forceful, but please listen to my insistence this time."

Yuni spoke like a whining child, but her words, meant to help someone else, sounded nice.

Rudy placed his hand on Yuni's head.

"Thank you, Yuni."

A smile appeared on Rudy's lips, warmed by Yuni's kind heart.

The stubborn Yuni of the past was no more.

There was a Yuni who knew how to care for others and sometimes took the initiative.

"Are you agreeing to my request?"

"Yes, if you're going that far, how can I stay down?"

Yuni beamed at Rudy's words, then suddenly shut her mouth tight.

"Then, do you want to make a bet with me?"

"A bet?"

"The last bet ended in a draw."

She was referring to the bet they made during the joint assessment.

"What's the bet?"

"I bet on whether I become the student council president."

Yuni said with a triumphant face.

"Alright, let's hear this bet."

Rudy nodded eagerly.

"The loser has to grant a wish to the winner."

"A wish..."

Hearing Yuni say that, Rudy felt a wave of anxiety.

Who is Yuni, after all?

A little devil who surprises everyone with her unpredictable actions.

This proposal should have been outright rejected...

Yet, he couldn't turn down someone who was taking on a new challenge for his sake.

"Don't like it?"

Yuni asked cautiously.

That made me feel even weaker.

"Alright, let's give it a try."

"Really?"

"It's a bet after all. I'll only grant it if you become the student council president."

"Of course~."

Yuni stepped back.

"Just watch. Whether I become the student council president or not."

"Alright, give it your best shot."

Rudy and Yuni smiled at each other.

After meeting Yuni, I returned from the academy to the capital.

The capital was in chaos in my absence.

Rie and Luna scoured the capital looking for me, and Astina left the Royal army to search for me.

"I'm sorry... I should have said something before leaving."

"No, no! It's us who made a fuss. Ha, ha..."

"Still, I'm glad you're safe."

We met at the Astria family mansion and chatted.

Sending everyone from the Astria mansion on vacation had left it empty, but it was actually better for gathering since it was sure to be noisy wherever this group went.

I told them everything from the beginning.

Why I disappeared and what I had been doing convinced them to some extent.

Not everyone felt the same, though.

Luna and Astina sighed with relief and smiled as if to say it was okay.

"Uh..."

Rie just glared at me without saying a word.

She had been doing this for minutes, and I found myself at a loss for words, especially as she was on the verge of tears.

"I'm sorry, Rie."

"Just try disappearing like that one more time. Really..."

Rie said with a choked-up voice.

"It's a relief you seem a bit better now."

"Yes, I think I know what I need to do now."

"So, what will you do now?"

What I needed to do was already decided.

"I'll inherit the Astria family, defeat the rebels, and..."

One more thing was added to the usual tasks.

"I will find out why Professor Robert ended up like that."

I pondered over the death of Robert.

Robert had noticed the danger I was in.

He even predicted his own death.

The evidence was overwhelming.

Professor Robert knew everything about the situation as soon as he arrived where I was.

It was as if he had predicted his own death and settled all his affairs accordingly.

He even paid off his tab at the restaurant, not wanting to inconvenience anyone, and had somewhat organized his belongings.

This wasn't just a series of coincidences.

There was a cause behind these events.

Reading the future, a situation where cause and effect didn't align.

To my knowledge, there was only one person capable of creating such a situation.

"I need to find Saint Haruna."

Until now, I hadn't paid much attention to Haruna.

There was a promise made with Haruna when the rebels attacked the academy.

To never worry about her and not seek her help.

I would overcome everything with my own power and move towards the future.

This was a conversation we had when it was just the two of us.

I had many questions about this.

If Haruna truly acted to save the world, why wouldn't she use her abilities to save it?

She was the only one in this world who could read the future.

Even using time magic to come to this world, I couldn't see the future.

So, why didn't Haruna actively use her abilities?

Despite these questions, I hadn't sought out Haruna.

I hadn't asked.

Because that was the promise.

However, given the current situation, I couldn't not ask anymore.

The reason I hadn't asked until now was because Haruna had helped me at the cost of her own sight.

Even if such a person had influenced someone close to me, I couldn't just stand by.

"So, should I start looking for the saint now?"

"No, there's no need to waste manpower."

Haruna can see the future.

Trying to find her in conventional ways would only be futile.

"For now, we just need to continue with our tasks."

"Without looking for the saint?"

"The rebels and the order are currently unable to find the saint."

I can't be sure if the rebels are looking for Haruna, but from Aryandor's perspective, Haruna would definitely be a thorn in his side.

He would be trying to find her somehow.

Additionally, the divine order to which Haruna belongs was also looking for her.

Even though the order's power has waned, the number of people within it cannot be ignored.

Yet, there has been no news.

No one has been able to find even a trace of Haruna.

Finding a person in the empire is nearly as difficult as finding a needle in a desert, but not finding even a trace meant something significant.

"So, we just sit around and do nothing?"

"That's not what I'm saying."

If that was the plan, I wouldn't have said anything.

"If we're dealing with someone who predicts the future, we need to create a situation they can't help but walk into, even if they foresee it."

They must step into the trap, knowing it's a trap.

Create a situation so compelling that, despite the risks, they must come to check it out.

It won't be easy, but I wanted to make it possible.

"To do that, we need to know about the saint."

Rie said in a blunt tone, glaring at me.

"Rie, can you do it?"

"It's not a matter of can or cannot."

Rie pulled a chair next to her, crossed her legs, and sat down.

"I've already done it."

I smiled at Rie.

"I thought you might have."

Back when Rie and Haruna first met, during our first year and when Astina was the student council president.

It was likely that Rie had already investigated Haruna.

She's not one to let such matters slide.

"Then let's use that information to set a trap."

We all put our heads together and began to plan.

Chapter 258: Family Head Contest

(2)

Today's friend may be tomorrow's enemy.

Upon hearing of Perrian's death, Ian was getting ready to make his move.

News of Robert's death had reached Rudy, who remained quiet.

But that didn't mean Ian had any reason to console Rudy or wait for him.

With Perrian gone, the Duke's position was now vacant.

Someone needed to fill it quickly for the sake of stabilizing the political situation.

Ian was moving for that very purpose.

"Do you think Rudy is capable of inheriting the title?"

"Hmm..."

"Don't be coy, speak your mind."

Ian was in the midst of a meeting with his close associates from the Astria family.

"It's not unlikely..."

"Why do you think so?"

"Because the internal political situation of the empire has tilted towards the Emperor's faction with the disappearance of the former head."

"It's not because of my lack of ability?"

The nobleman Ian was speaking to waved his hand dismissively.

"That's absurd. Your abilities far surpass those of Rudy Astria. If it were purely about ability, you're the rightful heir."

"Is that so? Then."

Ian looked the nobleman straight in the eye and spoke.

"What do you think will happen over time?"

"Ah..."

"What about comparing Rudy and me 10, 20 years from now?"

"That is..."

The nobleman couldn't give a definite answer.

Ian smiled at this hesitance.

"Of course, you wouldn't know. Humans can't see even an inch into their future."

"But... We believe you are the superior one. That's why we are here."

"Thanks for saying that."

Ian was pleased with the noble's honest words.

"We all feel the same way."

"The position of the head of the family belongs to you, Ian."

The nearby nobles agreed.

Hearing this, Ian stood up.

"Thank you, everyone. Let's conclude the meeting here."

Ian smiled and left his seat.

Walking out of the room and through the hallway, Ian's smile gradually faded.

"The head of the family..."

Ian's plans had never changed.

To become the head of the Astria family and rise to the highest position in the empire.

However.

As Ian pushed Perrian into a corner, he watched Rudy and observed his surroundings.

They were not so different from himself.

All striving for a higher position.

From afar, he thought they were no different from him.

But getting closer revealed a new scene.

They were not just striving for high positions.

They were looking beyond.

Reaching a high position was merely a step, not the goal.

Thinking this, Ian wondered about Perrian.

If Perrian had achieved immortality and the empire using mana stones and amplifiers, what would he have done?

No need to consider others.

'If I were to ascend to the Duke's position, what then? What should I do next?'

Questions were the only things floating in Ian's mind.

"Sorry for leaving you alone for a bit. I brought some tea."

"If you need any snacks, just say the word. I'll bring them over."

"Do you like the tea? If not, I can get a different kind."

I smiled warmly at the person in front of me, offering the best kindness I could muster.

Despite my goodwill, the person in front of me was extremely uncomfortable.

"Ru, Rudy. Since it's just us, you can act as usual..."

"This is my usual."

I was extending hospitality to Karen.

It had been a few days since I returned to the capital.

I was making various efforts to inherit the Duke's title.

Practicing spatial magic, meeting people who would support me, doing various things.

During this time, one person came to visit.

Karen Mayer.

I was surprised to see her.

I had clearly told Count Mayer that I had no intentions of marriage or anything else, yet here she was.

I thought quickly.

I needed to make this person detach her feelings from me.

So, I treated Karen with all the kindness I could muster.

Showing the utmost courtesy I was capable of.

That was the method I chose to push Karen away.

"Ru, Rudy..."

"Is there something wrong? Are you feeling ill? Or is there some food you can't eat?"

"Rudy..."

"Hm?"

Karen just repeated my name, saying nothing else.

As expected, she was at a loss for how to react to my kindness.

After shuffling her feet for a few minutes, Karen stood up.

"I'll come back... next time."

"Sure, you're welcome anytime."

I sent Karen off with a smile and returned to my room.

"Ha..."

I like to think I'm not a bad person, but offering excessive kindness was exhausting.

I sighed and looked at where Karen had disappeared.

"What should I do?"

I felt sorry for Karen, but I had no feelings for her.

She was merely a bridge I intended to use to approach the Mayer family.

Thinking this way, I was truly despicable.

But there was a tiny bit of injustice.

How could I have known that Karen harbored such feelings for me?

I intended to use Karen, but I never planned to harm her.

I just wanted to keep our relationship strictly business.

"Also, what would Rie say..."

I sighed and stood up.

Dealing with Karen was troublesome, but for now, I had other things to do.

The struggle for the head of the family position.

I need to think about this.

Normally, securing the position of the head of the family involves many steps. The family's internal members evaluate the candidates and compete fairly.

However, such evaluations was meaningless now.

With Perrian's death, someone needed to quickly take the Duke's position.

There were rebels outside, and we needed to create a stable situation internally.

The question was, how do we evaluate someone?

We couldn't take as long for evaluations as before, nor could we conclude everything with a vote among the internal members.

We needed something for the two contenders to compete in.

But we couldn't just have a brawl like children.

If they fought normally, someone could get hurt or even die, which could weaken the empire's strength and be a disgrace.

Therefore, we needed a fair fight under specific rules.

Recently, an answer emerged through a meeting of the empire.

Whoever accumulates greater achievements.

It was decided to compete in this way.

Over a certain period, accumulate achievements and evaluate them.

This was the best option for the empire as well.

We could win battles against the rebels or stabilize the internal chaos caused by them.

Evaluating someone based on their achievements allowed us to assess various aspects of that person, making it a good proposal for both us and the empire.

Then the inevitable question arose.

What kind of achievements should I accumulate?

Ian had the Royal army with him, but I was alone.

Though I had some people to help me, I didn't have an army.

"Achievements..."

I began to ponder this slowly.

What do I have that's superior to Ian?

In terms of spatial magic or other magical abilities, I'm inferior to Ian.

Even politically, I'm below him.

The only advantage I had was 'information'.

I knew various things about the rebels.

I had faced Aryandor's time magic and knew about the other leaders as well.

Besides information about the rebels, I also had much knowledge acquired from the academy.

So, I had to use that information to accomplish something.

"Rudy Astria. Are you there?"

Just then, a voice was heard from outside.

I immediately went outside upon hearing it.

Since there were no servants, I had to go out myself.

"Rudy Astria. How have you been?"

As I went outside, I saw the figure of Franz, the head wizard.

"What brings you here?"

"Haha, just stopping by."

The head wizard of the empire visited my mansion without any particular reason.

I was puzzled by the situation.

I didn't have a deep connection with Franz.

Apart from the time we cooperated, I had hardly ever seen his face.

"I came because I have something for you."

"For me?"

Franz took a small letter out of his pocket.

"It's something Robert left behind."

"Professor Robert?"

I took the letter with wide eyes.

"It's the last letter he gave me, but it looks like it's something you need, so I came."

I looked at Franz with a bewildered expression.

Chapter 259: Family Head Contest

(3)

Haruna doesn't know everything.

Even if she can see the future, she can't see all possible futures.

Haruna cannot control the future.

She is someone who can see the future, not someone who can control it.

Yet, everything is proceeding according to her plan.

“.....”

I quietly looked at the letter.

The last message left by Professor Robert.

It was almost like a will, containing such words, and all I could do was tilt my head in confusion.

“I thought it might be related to Haruna, but.....”

Why did Professor Robert write this letter?

Just reading the content makes it feel like he's warning us to stop Haruna's plan.

Does that mean Haruna's plan will harm everyone?

“No.....”

Robert was a straightforward person.

If Haruna were someone who would harm us, he would have clearly written a warning.

The mere fact that he wrote this means there's significance to it.

“Hmm.....”

I stroked my chin and read the letter over and over again.

Ian sat in the Royal Army's office, chin in hand.

"Capturing the tail of the rebels."

He was searching for traces of the rebels to build his achievements.

The dilemma he had been facing hadn't been resolved.

But pondering it forever is pointless.

Time would solve the dilemma, and Ian was just doing what he needed to do.

Ian is a commander of the Royal Army.

The Royal Army was created to counter the rebels, so investigating them was his duty.

If he managed to counter the rebels, the achievement would be his.

After all, he was the one who investigated and gathered the information that led to countering the rebels.

He might share the achievement with a few members of the Royal Army, but the greatest credit would undoubtedly go to Ian.

"Now is not the time for strange worries, focus on what needs to be done."

Ian decided to think about his duties after receiving the position of the family head, rather than worrying about it now.

Ian slowly read through the documents in front of him.

"Commander."

Someone entered his room.

It was Astina.

Astina, with her red hair neatly tied back and dressed in uniform, entered his room.

"You're here."

"Yes, I've brought the documents."

Astina handed over the documents she was carrying to Ian.

Normally, delivering such documents was a task for someone of lower rank, but the documents were so important that Astina delivered them herself.

Ian skimmed through the documents Astina handed over.

"There's no significant movement from the rebels."

"So, they only moved to kill Perrian."

"And possibly to kill Rudy as well."

Rudy could be considered Aryandor's only weakness.

It was only natural for the rebels to target him.

"Is that all there is to it?"

Targeting Rudy and Perrian.

It might seem like something Ian could overlook, but it raised another question for him.

"Killing Rudy would certainly open up a great possibility for those bastards. But did they send a leader just for that?"

Killing Rudy would indeed bring a significant advantage if their plan succeeded.

However, they couldn't ignore the risk of failure.

"If their goal was solely to kill Rudy, there are many other ways to do it. They didn't proceed with those because failing would have been too costly for them."

They were willing to take risks for something they desperately wanted.

Not just to kill Rudy, but to find a way to solidify their victory.

"Are you talking about the mana stone?"

At Astina's question, Ian nodded.

The mana stone that Perrian had.

They wanted to obtain it.

According to Rudy, they pretended to cooperate with Perrian and then ganged up on him.

Killing Rudy was their top priority.

There was no room for argument about this.

Yet, killing Rudy and the importance of that mana stone were of similar importance.

They betrayed Perrian almost immediately after draining Rudy's strength, when he was off guard.

If the mana stone wasn't that important, they could have waited to seize it after killing Rudy.

But they moved first.

"What if they had waited to kill Rudy?"

"Perrian would have used the mana stone and the amplifier to cause trouble."

"For them, Perrian causing trouble would have been a hindrance. If he used life drain to suck the mana and life force from people in the capital, their path to victory would practically disappear."

Both Rudy and Perrian were obstacles to their victory.

And the mana stone Perrian had would be a great help to them.

"Didn't we interrogate the necromancers who surrendered recently?"

"Yes, I've included the documents about that as well."

"The mana stones created by the necromancers were heavily used by Perrian himself, but a portion of them went to the rebels."

Ian pointed to the documents he had been looking at earlier as he said this.

"Then where did all those mana stones go?"

They are preparing for something using the mana stones.

Some of the stones were used for Daemon's necromancer legion, but that couldn't be all.

According to the necromancers' statements, about 5,000 mana stones went to the rebels.

That was the total amount received over a few years.

Compared to the amount of mana stones used by the empire itself, it was a small amount. However, if all of it was used for combat purposes, it was a significant quantity.

The empire used many mana stones for various facilities.

"Didn't you see the necromancer legion that attacked the Persia territory last time?"

"It didn't seem like a legion created with at least 5,000 mana stones."

"I also attacked the rebels when you were attacked, but it didn't feel like they used 5,000 mana stones for magical tools."

Ian stood up from his seat.

"So, it's settled then."

"Shall we track the mana stones?"

Ian nodded.

"I'll take a few people and search. You should get moving too."

"Understood. I'll move out immediately."

Astina agreed, then turned to leave.

"Astina."

At Ian's call, Astina turned her head.

"Act properly. Don't move just for Rudy's sake."

Astina smirked at that.

"I wouldn't do such a thing. At least I know how to separate personal matters from official duties. Besides, we have priorities that come before Rudy inheriting the dukedom."

Something more important than the dukedom.

It was a bold statement.

The dukedom is the highest position in the empire, second only to the emperor.

No wealth or honor could match it.

Yet, there was something more important?

It was hard for Ian to understand.

Something more significant than that...

"Then I'll take my leave."

Astina saluted Ian and left.

"Something that comes before the dukedom..."

Left alone, Ian muttered to himself quietly.

"Hey, Rudy, you're here?"

Rie greeted me with a smile.

She had her hair braided to the side and wore a white dress.

Because of the outfit, or perhaps because Yuni wasn't there, she appeared softer than before.

"Shall we take a walk and talk?"

"I'd like that."

I walked with Rie through the palace gardens.

The garden was full of vibrant flowers, signaling spring.

Rie slowly walked through the garden before speaking up.

"Have you thought about Haruna?"

"Yeah, I've thought about this and that."

"So, what are you going to do?"

"I have a rough plan, but I'm still debating whether to go through with it."

"What's there to debate? Tell me, and I'll take care of it for you."

"It's not that it's difficult to implement."

Rie tilted her head in confusion.

"What is it?"

"I'll tell you later. If I decide to go through with it. Anyway, I didn't come here for this."

"Right. Wuying, come out."

"...Wuying?"

I remembered hearing this name before.

As someone walked up from behind, I realized who it was.

"Ah... last time..."

"Rudy Astria, good to see you again."

It was the man who had helped me when I was looking for Uncle Yurik.

"Why is he here?"

"Hm? You two have met before?"

"We have, but why here..."

As I spoke with a puzzled look, Wuying slightly bowed his head.

"I didn't properly introduce myself last time. I am Wuying, the head of the Royal Secret Service."

"The Royal Secret Service?"

I remembered something I had forgotten.

The fact that Rie knew I went to the ball with Luna.

He must have been the one who told her.

"How did you think I found my information?"

"Hmm..."

The source of Rie's information was indeed the Secret Service.

At the academy, I got used to her using elementals to overhear various things, so I thought we would gather other information in the same way.

It did seem odd, though.

If Rie really listened to every sound to gather information, she would have to do that every day.

Considering Rie's busy schedule, she couldn't possibly have the time for that.

"Let's get back to business, anyway."

"Here, take this paper. It contains the information you requested."

"Ah, yes..."

I took the paper Wuying handed me and read through it.

It contained information related to mana stones.

The focus of my investigation, aimed at building my achievements, was related to mana stones, specifically magic engineering.

One question that no one had posed so far.

When McDowell and Aryandor fought, McDowell lost an arm, and Aryandor lost a leg.

Yet, Aryandor had a leg.

A prosthetic made through magic engineering.

Initially, I didn't question it, but seeing the mana stones created by the necromancers sparked a thought.

The rebels have an expert in magic engineering.

He received a large amount of mana stones and is preparing something.

So far, besides Aryandor's prosthetic, there have been no magic-engineered items from the rebels, despite having fought a significant battle.

"I've asked about magic engineers at the Magic Tower, and the documents include possible locations for this person. Check it out."

"Thank you so much, Rie."

Rie's lips twitched at my sincere thanks.

"How would you live without me?"

"I couldn't do without you."

"You'd be lost without me, wouldn't you?"

"Yes. I'd be lost."

"...What?"

"How could I live without you?"

When I spoke plainly, Rie's eyes widened.

"What are you talking about?"

"Exactly what I said."

"Explain further. What you mean by what you said."

I smiled and gathered the documents.

"Thank you, Rie. I'll be going now."

"No, wait. Explain what you meant."

I moved my mana and approached Rie.

"Huh?"

As I approached, I kissed Rie on the forehead.

"Wha???????"

Rie looked at me as if she was malfunctioning, unable to say anything.

"See you next time."

I enjoyed Rie's stunned expression as I used spatial magic to teleport away.

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(4)

Ian surveyed his surroundings.

This place was quite far from the capital, closer, in fact, to lands held by the rebels.

"Commander, there's nothing here!"

"Then let's go further down."

Rugged terrain and dense underbrush made the eastern part of the empire, known for its harsh landscape, even more forbidding, seemingly uninhabitable.

That made it an ideal location for a hideout.

"How far do you intend to go..."

"Ugh... I'm soaked through."

The soldiers grumbled as they searched the area, where a misstep could send one tumbling down a cliff, making it dangerous. With the thick underbrush, it was hard to see where the cliffs were.

Continuing to clear the brush and push forward, it was understandable that the soldiers were complaining.

Ian watched the soldiers for a while before speaking up.

"Let's take a break. But don't let your guard down even while resting."

"Oh! Finally..."

"Thank you!"

The soldiers brightened at Ian's words. For those who had traversed the harsh terrain, this rest was like nectar.

While the soldiers rested, Ian looked around, deep in thought.

'Is this really the right place...'

Research facilities for magic engineering are usually built in accessible locations because the things produced through magic engineering differ from regular magical tools.

Research on regular magical tools is based on deep studies of magic, whereas magic engineering focuses on mass production and efficiency.

Therefore, a typical magic engineering lab is attached to a factory, and having access to transportation is crucial for distribution.

This place was the most likely candidate among those Astina had predicted.

Although it was speculated that it could be within a territory held by the rebels, since Ian couldn't enter rebel-held lands, he had no choice but to hope this was the place.

Rustle—

Then, Ian heard the sound of brushing grass behind him.

Without missing a beat, he quickly turned and reached out his hand, thinking it was an enemy.

He was about to use magic but stopped upon seeing the person's face.

"...Rudy Astria?"

"...Huh?"

Rudy, too, was about to cast a spell but stopped upon recognizing Ian.

"...What are you doing here?"

"Why are you here?"

The two stared blankly at each other before sighing.

It had to be the same reason that brought both of them, who were supposed to be in the capital, to this place.

"Mana stones?"

"Yes, exactly."

"Did Astina tell you?"

"No, I asked Rie for information."

"Why?"

"The recent incident and Aryandor's bridge."

"The bridge?"

"Aryandor's bridge, isn't it made with magic engineering? So..."

"...No need to say more."

Ian wondered if Astina had told Rudy but concluded it was a pointless suspicion.

There was no reason to think that Rudy wouldn't come to the same conclusion he had.

Regardless of how it was discovered, information about the mana stones had led to this place.

Finding this location wasn't that difficult.

This place was near where the rebels first made their move.

If one were to think of a place where the rebels could gather strength and hide, it would be hard to consider anywhere but here.

Rudy saw the soldiers resting behind Ian.

"Did you come with the Royal Army?"

"Yes, I'm searching the area with the soldiers. Would you like to join us?"

Ian intended to make use of Rudy.

While there were enough soldiers to conduct a thorough search, there were times when the soldiers could be a burden.

It was impossible to send soldiers to cliffs or dangerous places, so Ian had to go alone when searching those areas.

Having Rudy meant they could search together, making it more efficient.

Of course, they might have to share any credit.

Finding the rebels would be a joint effort, not just Ian's alone.

The reason for wanting to search together was also because of the possibility that Rudy could find it on his own.

If Rudy found it without him, it would be the worst-case scenario.

"Yes, that's fine."

From Rudy's perspective, it wasn't a bad proposition either.

It was much better to search together than alone.

Rudy joined the Royal Army and began searching the area.

"Rudy Astria. Found anything?"

"Do you think it would be that easy to find? But why do you keep staying close to me?"

Ian stayed close to Rudy as they searched the area.

He considered the possibility that Rudy might find something and hide it...

"Rudy Astria. Can I ask you something?"

"What is it?"

"What do you think about the position of Duke Astria?"

"The Dukedom...?"

Rudy pondered while stroking his chin.

After a brief moment of contemplation, he answered lightly.

"A tool. A tool for achieving the results I want."

"A tool..."

It was somewhat the expected answer.

Yet, hearing it directly from him felt strange.

A position that was his entire life was merely a tool to the other.

Was this correct?

Ian felt his life become meaningless and was filled with rage.

"Commander."

Before Ian could say anything, a soldier approached him.

"What is it?"

"We've finished searching the area around here. However..."

"However?"

"We can't go any further towards the cliff, so we came looking for you."

"Can't go any further? Did you look for a way back?"

"We can go down to the bottom, but we couldn't determine what's on that wall side."

"Understood. Let's go. You guys keep looking around the area we were exploring. And..."

Ian looked towards Rudy.

He looked to suggest they go together, but Rudy was already on the move.

"Let's go."

"Alright."

Ian and Rudy followed the soldier.

"Here it is."

Looking where the soldier pointed, they saw a sheer cliff.

"Let's go down."

"...How do you suppose we do that?"

"How else are we going to descend the cliff?"

Ian stretched his leg towards the bottom of the cliff, stepping on protruding parts and lowering his body further down.

"To tackle the cliff like that..."

Rudy furrowed his brow.

"Got any better ideas?"

Neither Rudy nor Ian had any other options.

They didn't have telekinesis like Astina, nor could they use elementals like Rie.

Although they possessed spatial magic, it wasn't feasible to use it blindly here.

"Understood."

Rudy braced himself and extended his leg downwards.

"If you fall, use spatial magic to move."

After enhancing their bodies with magic, Ian and Rudy began descending the cliff.

It was their first time scaling a cliff, but they didn't face much difficulty.

Using magic to chip away at the cliff and create ledges, they just had to lower their feet onto these ledges.

It was terrifying.

Stepping into the void where the bottom wasn't visible was scary.

Even though using spatial magic or body strengthening meant they wouldn't die or get injured, fear was still fear.

Yet, they boldly stepped forward.

"Shall we rest a bit now?"

"Scared?"

"Not scared at all. I just mentioned it because you're slowing down."

"If you're scared, we can rest."

"Then, let's continue."

Neither admitted their fear.

Admitting fear was something their pride wouldn't allow.

Though they could rest if they stepped back a bit, they continued descending.

After a while.

"Huh?"

"Thinking of resting now?"

"It seems we might be able to."

Rudy pointed below.

A large ledge on the wall of the cliff was too big to be just a ledge; it felt almost like new land.

"We might have found it."

Rudy and Ian jumped towards that land. Landing there, they were greeted by green grass.

"Grass like this?"

This wasn't a natural formation.

It should be a dense underbrush, not covered in grass like a lawn.

"Over there."

They then saw a house in front of them.

"How did they build a house here?"

Rudy smiled slyly.

"It looks like we've found it."

In the capital of the empire, at Duke Ophillius's mansion.

Creak— Creak—

The sound of a rocking chair squeaking could be heard.

Jason Ophillius was sitting on it, reading a book.

Quietly reading, Ophillius closed the book and placed it on the small table beside him.

Then, he spoke.

"What brings you here?"

As he said this, the door to Ophillius's room opened.

In the doorway stood a man wearing a hood.

"I received no reply to my letter, so I came."

The man removed his hood as he spoke.

He had black hair.

It was Aryandor.

"I didn't reply because it wasn't worth replying to. Do you not understand that?"

"It seems, Master, you don't understand, which is why I came."

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"So, what are we going to do now?"

"What do you mean?"

"Are we going in, or are we calling for reinforcements? That's what I was asking."

Rudy didn't hesitate and replied immediately.

"Of course, we're going in. If there's someone inside, they'll know we're here anyway. We can't just leave."

Ian nodded in agreement.

"Then let's go right now."

As Ian started to move, Rudy paused for a moment.

Ian turned to look at Rudy, who hadn't followed.

"Is something wrong?"

"...No."

Rudy shook his head and followed Ian towards the cabin.

Creak—

The door of the cabin made a squeaking sound as if it were old.

They extended their hands and carefully entered.

"It's dark."

The inside of the cabin was ordinary.

There was a sofa in the living room and a fireplace that had gone cold.

The kitchen had a dining table that could accommodate several people.

And the cabin wasn't just a single floor; stairs leading down to a basement were clearly visible.

Ian walked over to the sofa and ran his finger over it.

"It has been used."

Dust clung to Ian's fingers.

It didn't seem like it hadn't been used for years.

If it hadn't been used for years, there would be signs of bugs, but it was surprisingly clean.

Rudy headed to the kitchen and looked around.

"There are signs of use on the dishes too."

There was dust, but it didn't feel old.

And there were several dishes, indicating that more than one person had been living here.

After looking around the interior, they found nothing unusual beyond these everyday details.

"Let's go down to the basement."

Following Ian's suggestion, they went downstairs.

"Ah?"

"...This is ridiculous."

There was a large space in the basement.

It was so big that it made the cabin above seem laughable.

There were many books and signs of research.

"It looks like we found the right place."

"How did they even make this?"

They looked around.

"Who's there?"

At that moment, a man walked out.

He was wearing a robe like a researcher.

Ian and Rudy quickly reached for their weapons.

"Identify yourself."

The man spoke as if he found the situation absurd.

"Shouldn't you be the ones identifying yourselves? You're the ones who entered someone else's house."

Ian and Rudy looked at each other, then spoke up.

"We are investigators from the Empire. Who are you?"

They asked the man, keeping their identities hidden.

"I'm called Raven. What does the Empire want here?"

"We're investigating the rebels. If you're not part of the rebels, then cooperate with our investigation."

"Huh, is this how the Empire conducts investigations these days?"

"It's an investigation about the rebels. If you don't cooperate, we'll use force."

Raven then raised his hands.

"Sure, investigate all you want."

Rudy and Ian were puzzled by the man's confident attitude.

After hesitating for a moment, Ian stepped forward first.

"I'll do the investigation."

Rudy kept his hand extended toward Raven, and Ian went down the stairs.

"To think that you guys from the Empire have come all this way to investigate. Really..."

Raven clicked his tongue and grumbled as Ian looked around.

Ian searched for any signs of the rebels as he inspected the surroundings.

However, he found no traces of the rebels.

After all, there wouldn't likely be any clear evidence of rebel activity.

Unless there was a letter from Aryandor or a member of the rebels present, finding such evidence would be difficult.

Still, there were plenty of documents related to magical engineering, and seeing an anvil in a corner, like in a blacksmith's shop, confirmed it was a magical engineering laboratory.

But determining if this person was affiliated with the rebels was difficult.

Ian stopped his investigation and looked at Raven.

"Why are you here?"

"Why do you think? Is it strange for a researcher to be in a lab?"

"What I mean is, why is the lab here? Shouldn't a magical engineering lab be in a more populated area?"

"If I put the lab somewhere conspicuous, it would only attract pests. It was too bothersome, so I set it up here. Is there a problem?"

"Pests?"

"You know, the nobles. I came here to avoid those pests who covet what I make."

"So, how do you leave this place?"

"I use that thing."

Raven pointed toward a corner.

There was a pair of shoes placed there.

These weren't ordinary leather shoes but looked like they were made of metal, like iron shoes.

"What's that?"

"These are shoes made with magical engineering. They're enchanted with wind magic, so you can safely jump down from here and also climb up. These shoes, I mean. I deliberately twisted the mana circuits when making them. By causing the circuits to overload intentionally..."

Raven suddenly started explaining the principle behind the shoes.

As a researcher, he spoke quickly and blurted out unnecessary details once he got onto a topic he was familiar with.

Ian rubbed his head as if it were a headache, but Rudy, who was standing above, had his eyes sparkling.

"Wow... Doesn't that strain the mana stone? Surely the stone won't be able to withstand it."

As Rudy showed interest, Raven excitedly waved his fist.

"That's why I used magical engineering to reinforce the mana stone! If you look at the mana stone here..."

Rudy came down the stairs and looked at the shoes.

"You've done a good job."

"Thank you. You know a lot about magic."

"Yes, a wizard would know at least this much."

Rudy examined the shoes closely and then turned to look at Raven.

"Can I try these on?"

"Yes, go ahead."

Rudy put on Raven's shoes and attempted to move.

"Wow, these are quite heavy."

"Yes, they're magical engineering products, so they're supposed to be heavy."

"How do they work?"

"Ah, there's a device on the side of the shoe."

Ian sighed and watched Rudy curiously.

"What are you doing...?"

"Wow!"

Following Raven's instructions, Rudy touched the device and began to float upwards.

"Don't activate it too strongly. A strong wind could damage the lab."

"Ah, got it."

Rudy floated up for a bit, moved around, and then came back down.

"This is really fascinating."

"Ha, I'm glad you think so. I have more items to show you. Would you like to see them?"

Raven opened a storage area in the back, revealing various magical engineering devices.

"Ah, yes. But can we look around the lab a bit more first?"

"Of course, take your time."

Rudy began to survey the lab.

Ian watched disapprovingly.

There were no signs of the rebels anyway.

It was a waste of time not to investigate this man instead.

Investigating his past might reveal any connections to the rebels.

Ian approached Rudy, who was looking around, and whispered.

"Let's stop now."

"What?"

"We're taking him back to the Empire."

"Taking him?"

"If we dig into his past, something is bound to come up."

"There's no need to do that."

"What?"

Rudy smiled and looked back at Raven.

"The lab is smaller than I expected."

"Small?"

"What are you talking about?"

Raven and Ian looked at Rudy incredulously.

"Is this all your stuff?"

"Yes, that's everything."

"No other storage?"

"..."

"That's strange."

Rudy smirked.

"A lab like this should have lots of mana stones, but there's no place to store them. Who are you keeping all these things for in a space no one visits? And what about all the dishes upstairs?"

"Friends visit sometimes. And I get mana stones from the village as needed."

"What about the iron and other materials? All by yourself?"

"Yes."

"I see. So you transport all that iron with these shoes? And your friends too? Up this mountain where even a carriage can't come?"

Raven narrowed his eyes and glared at Rudy.

"What are you trying to say?"

"I took a look at the grass outside earlier."

"Grass?"

"It was well-maintained, but there were some pressed-down marks."

"Oh... Is that so?"

"Those marks were like."

Rudy extended his hand towards Raven, manipulating mana.

"The footprints of a dragon."

To research magical engineering, transportation needs to be developed.

Good transportation doesn't necessarily mean having commercial areas nearby or well-paved roads.

It simply means having a conducive environment for transport.

"You used a dragon for transportation, didn't you?"

The grass in front looked like it served as a runway.

The dragon landed there and transported all the equipment.

The magical engineering devices prepared for demonstration.

A lab that was somewhat off.

Household items that were neglected but hadn't been used in a long time.

There were more than a few oddities.

"Shall we search a bit more? A little more digging and things might become clear."

Rudy smiled.

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"What do you think, should we keep going?"

Rudy asked with a smile, to which Raven sighed.

"Let's stop."

"Hmm?"

"You're right. I am a rebel."

Rudy was puzzled by Raven's straightforward confession.

Despite admitting to being a rebel, Raven lacked the will to resist.

"What were you making here?"

"Can't you tell? It's related to magic engineering."

"There are so many magic engineering items. What exactly were you making?"

Raven smiled at Ian's question.

"Do you think I would just tell you that?"

Ian frowned and looked around.

When he had searched the room earlier, he couldn't find any research materials.

Most of the stored materials were too ordinary.

They were not weapons or any special devices, just mundane, everyday items.

The important materials were no longer there.

It felt as if someone had anticipated their arrival.

Rudy walked up to Ian's side.

"It seems we won't find anything else here."

There was no sign of the mana stones created by necromancy, nor any documents on their use.

The items had already been passed to the rebels, and the documents had been burned.

This raised an inevitable question.

Why was this guy still here?

If he knew someone was coming, it would make sense to flee beforehand.

Yet, Raven stayed.

"Hmm..."

Ian quietly observed Raven.

After a moment of contemplation, he spoke.

"Let's take him with us."

Ian used spatial magic to open a subspace.

A pair of white handcuffs appeared, and he secured them on Raven's wrists.

Rudy and Ian took Raven outside the building.

They joined the soldiers and handed Raven over to them.

"What will you do now?"

"Hmm..."

Ian pondered for a moment then looked at Raven.

So, it ends this easily...

It left him feeling uneasy.

To hand over someone who could be part of the rebel leadership so easily?

Ian stared at Raven, then turned to Rudy.

"What about you?"

"I suppose I must return to the Empire using spatial magic."

"Then stay here for a while."

"What?"

"I have a plan."

Ian said this and headed towards a carriage.

"A plan?"

Rudy, puzzled, followed Ian.

"Just as planned."

Raven smiled as he was being taken away by Ian and Rudy.

The rebels' plan was for Raven to be taken all the way to the capital.

After completing all the magic engineering devices, Aryandor had told Raven something.

"They'll be coming here soon."

The Empire had obtained information on necromancers.

So, they would realize that the mana stones created by necromancers had also fallen into rebel hands.

They needed to prepare for it.

"Rudy Astria and Ian are going to make a move. You need to be ready for them."

"Prepare, you say?"

"Get caught by them on purpose. Don't resist. And then infiltrate the capital."

Instead of avoiding capture, the plan was to get caught deliberately.

That was their strategy.

To make this happen, Raven intentionally made his disguise sloppy.

He acted in a way that invited capture because being too obvious would have raised suspicion.

Rudy and Ian fell for it nicely.

Without any doubt, they were taking him to the capital.

Since they got nothing from the building, they would likely interrogate him for information.

This meant there would be no danger until they reached the capital.

But then.

Raven lifted his head and looked around.

Several Royal soldiers and Ian and Rudy were with him in the carriage.

Everything had gone according to plan, but something felt off.

The carriage window opened, and Ian called one soldier over.

Raven saw this but couldn't hear their conversation from the back of the line, tied up as he was.

"Don't worry. We'll get you out as soon as we reach the capital."

Raven mulled over Aryandor's words.

Everything would be a success once they reached the capital.

"Why do I feel so uneasy?"

"We'll take a break up ahead! Everyone, slow down!"

The soldier talking to Ian shouted to the others outside.

The distance between the Empire and where Raven was captured is quite long.

It made sense to rest occasionally, but the timing for this break seemed too soon.

They had just rested after coming down from the mountain, and now, an hour later, they were resting again.

"What are they trying to do?"

The soldiers stopped their horses and settled down nearby.

Raven, still tied up, sat down on the ground.

"Where is this?"

Raven quietly surveyed his surroundings.

It was hard to figure out where they were since it wasn't a proper road.

The question was why they stopped here.

Raven cautiously watched as Ian approached him.

Ian looked Raven over and spoke.

"Are you uncomfortable anywhere?"

"If I say it's uncomfortable, will you unlock these handcuffs?"

"Of course not."

Ian said that and then grabbed Raven by the nape.

"What?"

"Come with me."

"What? Where are we going? What is this..."

"If you don't move, I'll force you."

"Ugh..."

Raven tried to move his legs as best as he could, but he couldn't walk properly while tied up.

Ian dragged Raven, who was almost lying down, across the ground.

Ian threw Raven onto the ground.

"Ugh...! What are you trying to do?"

Raven, thrown onto the ground, glared at Ian.

Ian then kicked Raven.

"Ugh!"

"Who told you to open your eyes like that?"

Raven glared at Ian in pain.

"Let's start the interrogation."

"What... what?"

Thump!

"Ugh..."

Ian kicked Raven in the stomach again.

"From now on, answer only the questions I ask."

Raven had thought the interrogation would happen in the capital.

He never expected to be interrogated on the way there.

Ian pulled a dagger from his belt.

Raven chewed his lip, pondering.

What should he do?

He was wearing mana control handcuffs, but there was a way to escape here.

He could use a magic engineering device hidden inside his body to blow off the handcuffs.

But doing so would ruin Aryandor's plan.

While Raven was thinking, Ian finished preparing and approached him.

"Let's start with a question. Where is Aryandor right now?"

"...What?"

Thrust—

"Aaaagh!!!"

Ian stabbed Raven's thigh with the dagger without hesitation.

"Answer only the questions I ask."

"Ugh... How would I know where the leader is..."

"You don't know?"

Thrust—

"Aaaaaagh!!!"

Ian stabbed Raven's thigh with the dagger again.

"Then we'll continue until you talk."

Raven truly didn't know where Aryandor was.

He guessed Aryandor might be near the capital, but he wasn't sure.

Aryandor had said he would come to the rescue, but he didn't know if Aryandor would personally come.

"I'll ask again. Where is Aryandor?"

"How would I..."

Thrust—

"Ugh..."

Ian was relentless.

He stabbed the thigh of his opponent, who claimed not to know, with the dagger, showing no pity or remorse.

After repeating this several times, Raven's thigh was a bloody mess.

"Heal."

Ian used healing magic on Raven.

Once the wound was somewhat healed, Ian called a soldier.

"Take care of him. We're moving out again."

"Understood."

"We'll keep repeating this until you talk. I hope you'll tell us before we arrive."

"Ugh..."

The soldier helped Raven to his feet.

'Is he insane...?'

Raven would have understood if Ian had questioned him about magic engineering devices or related matters, but Ian only asked where Aryandor was, with no other questions.

And to conduct such an interrogation in the middle of nowhere...

Raven was dumbfounded.

'Continuing like this until I talk?'

Raven had spent his life moving from one research position to another.

He had never experienced such pain in his life. His spirit was breaking.

'First, I'll watch the situation. And...'

If the torture becomes too severe...

No...

Should he follow Aryandor's wishes?

Raven's spirit was breaking under the torture, a new experience for him, but remembering Aryandor's orders, he couldn't fall apart here.

'I must... endure as much as I can...'

If he kept enduring, Aryandor would come to rescue him.

If he endures the painful torture and holds on, Aryandor will surely come.

No, he must come.

"Ugh..."

Raven spent the night biting his nails.

Chapter 263: Family Head Contest

(7)

Aryandor raised his sword.

With a light swing of the sword he held high, Ophillius' head fell to the ground.

"Hmm..."

Aryandor looked down at Ophillius' head on the floor.

After a brief moment, Ophillius' head vanished from his sight, and Aryandor's view changed.

"No matter how much you struggle, you can't escape."

Ophillius said to Aryandor with a calm face.

It was the same situation as ten minutes ago.

Aryandor had killed Ophillius several times now.

He had beheaded Ophillius multiple times and torn his body apart, only to return to this moment.

Aryandor glared at Ophillius and asked, "What are you trying to do to me?"

"Didn't I tell you? I can't die like this."

"So, you plan to suffer in this eternal moment forever?"

"Haha, that wouldn't be so bad."

"Have you finally gone mad?"

Despite being trapped in a loop, what was happening didn't feel like an illusion.

Ophillius had died numerous times, feeling the pain firsthand.

It was pain beyond what a person can bear.

Torture usually involves inflicting pain that doesn't lead to death, but Ophillius was experiencing pain beyond that limit.

Even as time reset, the pain was not forgotten; the situation just repeated.

He kept dying and coming back to life.

No matter how strong someone's will is, staying sane is impossible.

Yet, Ophillius kept his sanity and laughed.

"It's not me who's mad. Aryandor, you're the one who's insane, so everyone else seems mad to you."

"Ha...!"

Ophillius was cornered.

The fight between Aryandor and Ophillius was a battle with no chance of winning.

Despite dozens of battles, Ophillius' head had been swiftly taken every time.

Yet, he mocked Aryandor with ease.

There was a reason for his confidence.

"Do you think you can keep doing this endlessly?"

"Are you waiting for Rudy Astria and Ian?"

The reason this situation was possible was because Ian and Rudy were away from the capital.

With the two who could use spatial magic away, Aryandor could invade the capital and cause this chaos.

If they returned, they would notice the situation.

He just had to hold out until then.

But that didn't mean things would be easy.

"Do you think I came here without any plan?"

Aryandor had prepared Raven to buy time.

He had pushed Raven into a corner to delay the time it would take for them to reach the capital.

He had never intended to save Raven in the first place.

He had just thrown in a significant piece to buy time.

Ian and Rudy had a high understanding of time magic.

Rudy is compassionate, and Ian seeks the maximum benefit in everything.

Humans judge others based on their own personalities.

Considering all this, they might think the situation is a trap or that Raven is being used to lure them in.

However, Aryandor had no affection for him.

He might have had affection for objects, but not for people.

If there were something more important than saving them, he could abandon them at any time.

And things wouldn't go as Ian thought.

Ian would think that Raven, being one of the leaders, made them important.

That wasn't wrong.

Raven was a talent not easily found.

But if asked whether that was important in the current situation, it was questionable.

He had already served his purpose.

Using Raven to kill Ophillius was more important.

With all these plans in mind, Aryandor took action.

Although Aryandor could no longer see the future, as someone who understood time, he could make such predictions.

"Why bother with all this trouble? How about we just stop now?"

"That would be difficult. I have made a promise. Even in this situation, as the Empire's Chancellor, wouldn't it be shameful not to keep even a small promise?"

Ophillius laughed happily.

"A promise? Don't we have one too? When I become a being that can change the world, you said you'd let me meet my family."

"I said to become a being that can change the world, not one that destroys it."

"Haha... And you picked me up, a person who can see the future?"

"Just because I can see the future doesn't mean I can see all futures. I took care of you, believing in the small futures I could see."

"That's ridiculous. So, if I had been a good person, would I have been able to save my sister?"

Ophillius's expression hardened at Aryandor's words.

"...What are you talking about?"

"Did you think I didn't know?"

Aryandor held his sword and stabbed Ophillius's shoulder.

"Ugh..."

"That my sister became a saint, before the current saint, it was Beatrice."

Despite the pain from the stab wound, Ophillius's confusion did not fade.

Aryandor wasn't supposed to know about her death.

That was the future.

Specifically, all the futures Ophillius saw when he could see the future were like that.

A slight deviation.

A future that deviated from the majority of futures.

The future Ophillius hoped for and believed in had twisted in the worst possible direction.

"And you hid that...!"

With a voice filled with anger, Aryandor beheaded Ophillius.

As Ophillius's head fell to the ground, the situation reset to the beginning.

"Cough..."

Ian looked at Raven, who was exhausted from pain and letting out a hoarse voice.

A day had passed.

They continued to interrogate him approximately every two hours while moving.

Yet, Aryandor didn't come.

Ian started to feel something was off.

Was Aryandor not planning to rescue him?

Judging this in just a day might seem premature, but decisions had to be made quickly and accurately.

Ian realized that the ongoing interrogation and movement were causing significant delays.

The arrival time in the capital was getting pushed back, and the distance to the capital wasn't decreasing.

'There must be a reason he's not coming to rescue him.'

Raven's situation of hiding alone was suspicious from the start.

He wasn't conducting any research there; he was just killing time.

It was clear there was some trap, but what it was, was hard to determine.

Ian stared at the fallen Raven for a moment before standing up.

"Take him. We're moving."

"Understood."

A soldier watching from a distance came over and helped Raven.

'We better keep moving towards the capital.'

Continuing the interrogation seemed pointless.

Raven must know important information, but he showed no signs of talking. If Aryandor was really scared of Raven spilling the beans, he would have come to rescue him by now.

There must be another reason he hasn't come.

That was Ian's conclusion.

Aryandor might have a different location to attack, or perhaps he has an entirely different plan that doesn't involve an attack.

"Over there."

"Did you call?"

"Tell everyone to move faster from now on. We'll reduce the number of interrogations, so don't slow down until I say so."

"Understood."

The soldier took the order and returned to his position.

After making sure the formation was ready, Ian slowly returned to the carriage.

'What are you thinking, Aryandor?'

While Ian was deeply pondering,

There was someone genuinely curious about Aryandor's thoughts.

"Aryand...or..."

A person unable to fully regain consciousness, suffering.

It was Raven.

Having been tortured several times a day, his doubts about Aryandor grew.

'Are you coming? Or... when we arrive at the capital...'

Raven and Aryandor had discussed that he would be rescued upon arrival in the capital.

However, in his current state, he doubted he could last until then.

Ian did cast healing magic to ensure he wouldn't die, but that only made the pain worse.

If he could at least lose consciousness, he might escape the situation momentarily, but the healing magic prevented that.

'I can't bear this any longer, Aryandor.'

The plan was one thing, survival another.

While the plan might be important, enduring this pain made the success of the plan meaningless.

'These bastards are cruel. We might not even head to the capital.'

Aryandor hadn't explained anything to Raven.

Not knowing the plan, his doubts deepened.

'Their schemes could mess up the operation.'

Then Raven would suffer in vain, the operation would fail, and it would all be meaningless.

Raven looked at the handcuffs on his wrists.

Although he had a way to unlock them now, once inside a proper prison, that method would become useless.

'But even so...'

Sabotaging Aryandor's operation would be like turning his back on the rebels.

Of course, Aryandor might admit his mistake and accept it, but that seemed unlikely.

Raven closed his eyes and recalled the past.

The promise with Aryandor.

'If you help me, I'll create a place for you to belong.'

Raven had been satisfied until now.

Life in the cabin with the rebel guys was what he had wanted.

People were truly deceitful.

He couldn't forget those times and thought they were happy, but avoiding the pain right in front of him took precedence over protecting that place.

'I'll run away.'

The convoy transporting Raven moved, and Raven steeled his heart, waiting for the right moment to escape.

Chapter 264: Family Head Contest

(8)

Ian was sitting in a carriage, scribbling something on a piece of paper.

The operation they were originally supposed to carry out had effectively been stopped. So, he had to come up with a different plan and was jotting down those ideas on the paper, pondering over them.

Suddenly, space warped in front of him, and Rudy appeared.

"...Rudy Astria?"

"Ah, I got here in one piece."

"Why are you here all of a sudden? Weren't you supposed to stay back there?"

"What am I supposed to do in an empty lab?"

"Didn't I tell you the plan?"

"The plan isn't going as expected."

Ian had thought that this plan needed to be concluded within a day at the least. It involved capturing a high-ranking talent who was even being tortured. How could their leader remain idle?

Aryandor exceeded Ian's expectations. It wasn't so much that Aryandor surpassed him; it felt more like Aryandor was an unfathomable being. It wasn't about the depth of thought but rather that Aryandor had a completely different mindset.

This plan was based on Ian's common sense. It couldn't possibly apply to Aryandor, who existed beyond that common sense.

"Since the plan has already collapsed, it was pointless to stay there. It doesn't look like things will proceed normally even after this much time has passed."

Rudy was right. They already knew Aryandor was not acting normally. There was no reason for Rudy to remain there.

"Yeah, you're right."

Ian readily admitted it. Thinking he understood Aryandor was a mistake. Ian had received a lot of information and analyzed Aryandor's actions, thinking he had a good understanding of him. However, that was arrogance.

Ian looked at Rudy in front of him. He had known Rudy as family for a long time. If he couldn't even understand Rudy, how could he understand Aryandor, whom he had barely met?

"So, what will you do now?"

"I'm still thinking about it."

That said, his mistake wasn't anything big.

Instead, this small mistake allowed him to learn more about Aryandor in detail.

Ian thought about these mistakes as he tried to devise a new plan. Rudy nonchalantly nodded and opened the window.

"Where are we, by the way?"

"You came here without even knowing where it is?"

"I thought it might be around here and searched the area."

"You came without a plan."

Rudy shrugged nonchalantly. Ian sighed and spoke up.

"We're on the road from the eastern Per Mountains to the capital. We should see the Fenden Plains soon."

As Ian said, the carriage moved a bit, and a vast plain appeared.

"So, are you planning to go straight to the capital?"

"For now, yes. There's no need to delay."

There was no need to stop and interrogate further. Ian's goal was to draw in Aryandor.

The plains continued all the way to the capital, making it impossible for anyone to launch a surprise attack. If they couldn't lure Aryandor, there was no need to proceed with the interrogation.

"Still, it's not like we're returning with nothing, so there's no problem, right?"

From the empire's perspective, they had already achieved a significant victory by capturing a high-ranking member of the rebels without a single wound.

However, Ian's worries stemmed from his desire to maximize the benefits from this situation.

While they were carrying out the empire's mission to capture rebels, Rudy and Ian were also competing for the position of family head. Without a fierce battle with the rebel leadership, this smooth operation didn't allow for showcasing their differences.

Ian wanted to achieve greater results with his plan to prove he was superior to Rudy.

More capable.

That's what Ian wanted to say, but...

'I can't twist the situation to my advantage.'

If he really wanted to make a name for himself here, he could delay his travel to the capital and continue with the interrogation or even choose not to go to the capital at all. Yet, he did not take such actions. He was merely considering the best course of action.

"Well, if nothing happens, we'll just have to be satisfied with how things are."

Ian nodded lightly.

Rudy looked puzzled at Ian's attitude.

Ian narrowed his eyes and asked Rudy, "Is there something wrong?"

"...No."

Rudy didn't say much more and continued,

"Then, I'll be returning to the capital. Since I'm just escorting, there shouldn't be any problems."

"Did you come here just to say that?"

"I just thought it was the best thing to do after seeing the situation."

Rudy was right. There was no need to keep Rudy here unnecessarily.

"Yeah, that's probably for the best. Contact me if anything happens."

"Understood. Then I'll be..."

There was a small click.

Yet, Rudy and Ian heard it clearly. They instinctively sensed danger.

Ian shouted quickly, "Get down!!"

BOOOOOM!!!

A massive explosion sounded right behind the carriage where Ian and Rudy were.

The carriage they were in was caught in the explosion.

"Ian, sir!!"

Soldiers a bit away from the carriage were shocked by the explosion. Although they couldn't see through the flames, it was clear the carriage was swept up in the blast.

The soldiers ran towards the explosion, trying to get inside.

"Huh?"

The soldiers, getting closer to the site of the explosion, stopped in their tracks when they saw someone inside.

Raven stood in the midst of the flames, unharmed despite being surrounded by fire.

The soldiers stared blankly at Raven before snapping back to reality, spurred by the sight of the destroyed carriage in front of him.

"Save the commander!"

The soldiers rushed towards Raven.

Raven turned his head.

The soldier in front froze as soon as their eyes met.

A sense of terror enveloped him.

Despite only making eye contact, he felt chills all over his body.

As the soldier attempted to step back in fear, Raven moved towards the soldiers.

It happened in an instant.

Raven reached the soldiers at an incredible speed, leaving them unable to react or resist. He grabbed the neck of the closest soldier.

The soldier screamed, but Raven hadn't grabbed his neck tightly.

Not tightly doesn't mean he was gentle; it just means he didn't break the soldier's neck.

The soldier, caught in Raven's grip, screamed in pain and glared at him.

"You... bastard..."

Raven looked at the soldier with a faint smile.

"Feel the same pain I did."

The soldier gasped for air, his face turning red. Despite struggling as much as he could, it was futile. He couldn't resist, only flailing his limbs.

Raven watched the suffering soldier with a smile.

Then, a low voice echoed, "Spatial Severance."

A small gap appeared near Raven's arm.

"Hmm?"

A gap formed on the hand and shoulder holding the soldier, and Raven's arm was cleanly severed.

The soldier fell to the ground thanks to the arm being cut off.

Raven, stunned, looked at his severed arm before turning towards the source of the voice. Ian was there.

"What, you're fine?"

It seemed like Ian had completely avoided damage.

There were slight traces of soot on his clothes and some burns on his arm, but nothing serious.

"What's the point of resisting now?"

"Do I really need to answer that?"

Ian narrowed his eyes.

Raven's demeanor had changed.

When they first met in the lab, he had the aura of a researcher—businesslike, with a bit of enthusiasm in his field, a typical researcher vibe.

Now, that aura was gone. Even with his arm severed, he was indifferent, speaking in a languid tone.

"Why didn't you just die quietly?"

"You were the one who was so loud when you tried to kill me."

"Don't you think struggling would only make it more painful?"

Ian laughed incredulously.

"If you had the ability, you wouldn't have been caught, right?"

"Is that so? I don't think that's the case."

"Arrogant, even without an arm."

"Arm?"

Raven looked towards his severed right arm.

Stones and dirt from the ground began to gather towards his arm, shaping into the form of an arm.

"Now I have it."

"Is that so? Then I'll just have to remove it again."

Ian extended his arm. Raven didn't just watch.

"Try then."

"Sure."

Suddenly, a voice came from behind.

From behind, space twisted.

Rudy appeared behind Raven.

"Ah?"

"But, I wasn't planning on stopping with just an arm."

Raven's eyes widened.

He hadn't seen Rudy at all for a day.

Yet, suddenly, Rudy appeared here.

Before Raven could react, Rudy aimed for Raven's heart without hesitation.

Rudy's arm pierced right through Raven's heart.

"You shouldn't let your guard down."

Raven, with his body pierced, looked at the arm through him and then raised his head.

He stared straight at Rudy and said, "Looks like that's my line."

Raven lifted the corners of his mouth.

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Rudy's hand had definitely pierced through the heart.

He felt the sensation in his hand.

Raven didn't move an inch.

Instead, he smiled.

Seeing his face made Rudy shiver.

"Damn..."

Rudy quickly tried to pull his arm out.

But it wasn't easy to pull away.

Raven's skin, his body that had been pierced, tightly gripped Rudy's arm.

"Thinking of leaving just like that?"

Raven grabbed Rudy's arm with his hand.

"Since my arm got cut off, yours should too, right?"

"Ugh..."

Raven's grip on Rudy's right arm was strong.

It was stronger than any human could manage.

Despite reinforcing his arm with mana, Rudy felt pain.

'Mana reinforced...? No... the heart was definitely...'

Rudy had definitely burst the heart.

For a wizard, the heart does more than just pump blood.

It stores mana and distributes it, allowing for magic use.

With the heart burst, using magic should have been impossible.

Ian quickly assessed the situation and charged at Raven.

"What's a wizard doing coming close?"

Raven lifted his stone arm towards the charging Ian.

When his stone arm touched Ian, it emitted a strong light.

The stone turned into dust and scattered in the air.

Ian immediately reached out his hand towards Raven.

Rudy moved at the same time.

He gathered mana in his free left hand.

Ian and Rudy both attempted to attack Raven together.

Raven moved quickly, assessing the situation.

He twisted his body, pulling out the arm embedded in him, and ducked.

Rudy's arm, which hadn't moved until then, suddenly came free easily.

By ducking, Rudy and Ian ended up charging at each other.

"Get out of the way on your own."

"Ugh...!"

Ian kept moving forward, and Rudy twisted his body to avoid him.

Had Rudy's reaction been slightly slower, they would have collided.

Raven watched them miss each other and dodged to the side.

"Damn... That was close. 'Get out of the way on your own,' he says."

"It's better for one person to dodge than for things to get messed up trying to avoid each other."

"Then you could have dodged."

"You move better than I do."

Ian and Rudy started glaring at each other.

"Both of you seem pretty relaxed."

Raven narrowed his eyes and spoke to them.

They both looked at Raven, who made such a comment.

"How is that guy still standing?"

"I have no idea."

He had a huge hole in his body and was missing an arm.

It wouldn't have been strange if he were dead from such injuries.

There was no blood coming out of his body, nor did he seem to feel any pain.

"He's like a machine."

He was like a machine.

A machine without pain or emotions.

"Was he like that when you tortured him?"

"No, he was normal back then."

At a certain point, he completely changed from a person.

Not only the body but also the mind.

"Suddenly changing..."

It was not his real body then.

If he hid his real body with an explosion, that would make sense.

However, there was no other presence around.

Even when Rudy scanned the surroundings with mana, he couldn't find anyone hiding.

There was only an overwhelming presence coming from Raven.

Based on the mana alone, he felt like a different person from when they first met.

"Can something like this even be possible?"

"Discussing it won't give us an answer."

Ian moved forward, manipulating his mana.

"Fighting might give us more details."

Sparks flew near Raven.

Then, dirt gathered from the ground and stuck to his arms.

The dirt formed something resembling gauntlets.

But these were no ordinary gauntlets.

Gauntlets the size of a person replaced his arms.

First, they needed to figure out what that magic was.

"I'll go."

"Understood."

Rudy stepped forward, and Ian stood behind him.

They moved in sync without needing to speak.

Rudy charged at Raven immediately.

Raven knew of Rudy's abilities, but Rudy didn't know his.

Yet, it wasn't a big problem.

In close combat, Rudy was as good as Aryandor.

He was confident, even without knowing the opponent's abilities.

Raven swung his dirt-made gauntlets at the charging Rudy.

Despite the large gauntlets, his movements were fast.

Still, Rudy read his movements.

Even if fast, the large fists made their movements obvious.

Rudy pulled back his stepping foot and raised his arm.

He blocked one gauntlet and dodged the other.

Moving as little as possible.

He blocked and dodged Raven's attacks with the mindset of not giving his opponent any opening.

There was a slight numbness in the arm that blocked the gauntlet, but it was not a problem.

Seeing his attack didn't work, Raven continued his assault.

His attacks were fast.

Too fast for a normal person to react to, and even difficult for a swordsman to counter.

Yet, Rudy dodged all of them.

Not even a scratch appeared on his body.

Rudy, who had neglected physical training while studying and practicing spatial magic, hadn't lost his skills.

His body, endlessly trained since the academy, didn't lie about his efforts.

'Dodge to the left. For the next attack, step back briefly, then move in.'

Rudy noted every small movement and planned his next action.

There were slight errors in his movements.

It was a natural result, given his break from training.

Rudy gradually reduced these errors.

Continuing the attack would eventually create an opening.

While Rudy blocked Raven's attacks, Ian looked for that opening.

"Spatial control."

At Ian's voice, Raven tried to step back.

But he couldn't move back.

He was trapped.

An invisible wall blocked Raven's back.

"We can't just let him escape."

What Ian used wasn't an attack.

It was a move to block the enemy's retreat.

"Spatial Severance."

He immediately used magic afterward.

With his back blocked, Raven only had the side to escape to.

There was no time to think deeply.

He had to make a quick decision.

Raven threw himself to the right.

But whether to the right or left, both were dead ends.

"Phew..."

Rudy, standing in front, took a deep breath.

He gathered mana in his fist.

The movement of mana stirred the wind around him.

Raven, unable to properly position himself after throwing his body, frowned.

Crackle...

Raven quickly used magic.

But Rudy wasn't one to miss an opportunity.

"Ha!"

There was no need to get closer.

Rudy threw his punch.

The wind pressure from the mana engulfed Raven.

Simultaneously, the mana gathered in Rudy's fist was released, creating a massive mana storm.

Crash!

"Argh..."

Raven's body was briefly swept by the mana storm, resulting in numerous injuries.

To avoid this, Raven used magic.

He removed the gauntlets from his hands and placed his hands on the ground.

Then, sparks flew from Raven's hands, and his body was propelled into the sky.

It was as if the ground was pushing Raven away.

Seeing this, Ian laughed.

Rudy laughed as well.

It was exactly as the two had planned.

Rudy would block the opponent's movement, and Ian would look for an opening.

Though they had never coordinated before, their thoughts aligned.

And so did their actions up to this moment.

Ian reached out his hand towards Raven.

In mid-air, there's no escaping an attack.

Unless one uses telekinetic magic or something similar for aerial movement, there's no way to dodge.

Of course, there's the option to defend against an attack.

But the answer to that was quite simple.

Make an undefendable attack.

"Spatial Severance."

Raven had no means to block spatial magic.

It was a technique that left him with no choice but to dodge.

A black rift formed in the center of Raven.

Spatial Severance is a spell that's easy to dodge due to its activation time.

But when hit squarely by such an easily dodged spell.

Crack.

It was powerful magic.

Raven, hit directly, was swallowed by the rift in space.

The name of the spell itself was "Severance," but Spatial Severance was more about blowing away a certain space.

Since Raven was in the center of that rift, his body vanished.

Thud... Tinkle.

Parts of Raven's body fell from the sky.

His body was gone, but parts like his head or legs remained and fell to the ground.

"Ugh."

Rudy narrowed his eyes at the gruesome sight and turned his head.

"So much for his big talk."

"Want to say that after fighting 2-on-1?"

"He was overconfident even before the fight began. I could have won alone."

"Sure you could have."

Rudy sneered and laughed.

"Commander!"

At that moment, the soldiers shouted.

Crackle... Fizz.

The sound of sparks accompanied the soldiers' voices.

Rudy and Ian turned their heads towards the direction of the sound.

Dirt was clumping together with the sparks.

"What's that?"

"..."

That magic was definitely Raven's.

Raven's body had been blown away by spatial magic.

Yet, Raven's magic was still activating.

"What a headache."

Ian ran his hand through his hair.

The dirt kept gathering, and like a golem, the form grew larger.

"What will you do?"

"We fight. Are you planning to run?"

"Of course not."

Rudy rolled up his sleeves and walked forward.

"Let's go then."

"Yeah."

Rudy and Ian walked towards the golem.

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Boom!!

As Rudy swung his fist, the golem's face blew off entirely.

"Dissolve."

Simultaneously, Ian used magic.

The part of the golem's leg where Ian placed his hand crumbled into the dirt and shattered.

The dirt, returning to its original state, fell to the ground.

Without its legs, the golem began to tilt as it lost its balance.

But it didn't fall.

As the legless golem tilted, dirt gathered at its feet, and in an instant, new legs formed.

Rudy narrowed his eyes and approached Ian.

"Really tough. How long do we have to do this?"

"His mana can't be infinite."

"Then he should have fallen by now. Why does he look perfectly fine?"

Rudy and Ian had been attacking the golem for hours already.

They tried slicing the body with spatial magic and chipping away at it with other attacks.

No matter how much they attacked, the golem didn't fall.

Sand continued to gather, repairing its body, and if left alone, the body even grew larger.

It only got stronger, never showing signs of weakening.

After hours of continuous mana consumption in battle, Ian and Rudy were gradually getting exhausted.

As they grew more tired and their opponent didn't budge, they felt increasingly drained.

Rudy clenched his fist.

"I don't think we can go on like this."

"Then what do you suggest we do? Run away?"

"Absolutely not. Considering we'd have to fight again later, it's better to finish it now."

So far, all the rebels they observed were strong in prolonged battles.

Aryandor uses time magic to heal, and Venderwood regenerates his body.

The Golem in front of them also possesses a similar ability, so it's clear they'll be a problem later.

"So, what will you do?"

"A war of attrition would be disadvantageous for us."

Rudy looked up at the golem's body.

Its body, growing larger.

If left alone, it would reach the size of almost a castle.

"Surely, Raven is supplying it with mana."

"That's right."

"Then shouldn't we just take down Raven."

It was easier said than done.

"A guy who lived even after being blown apart. You think we can kill him?"

"If he were a normal person, it would be natural to die when blown apart. It's also natural for mana not to be supplied when the heart is burst. He has a specialty doesn't he?"

Rudy slowly considered.

How he was still alive.

What his specialty was and how he used it.

"Are you talking about magnetic magic?"

Ian had also noticed.

Magnetic magic.

The magic that uses the force to attract and repel objects.

Like using a magnet, it could be applied in various ways.

With sparks flying as magic was used, and by utilizing attraction and repulsion, they notice upon closer observation.

"Including magnetic magic, he utilized a certain part of magic engineering as well."

To maintain a body, organs and various functions within the body are necessary.

The heart has its own role, and the lungs have theirs, sustaining life.

But what if there were something that could replace those roles?

Normally, one would have to attach various machines to perform the functions of the body, but it might not be strictly necessary.

He maintains his life using magic engineering products.

With magnetic magic, it could be made possible.

Magical tools could take on the role of organs, and something like biological signals could be sent through magnetic magic.

Magnetism itself made it possible to create tools that could replace the functions of the body.

There might be academic doubts about whether this is possible, but that was the only way he could live.

"However, he didn't have any magic engineering products on him."

"You don't know that. He could have implanted them inside his body."

There was one likely place for that.

If he can maintain his consciousness and use magic even after being blown apart.

"His head?"

He implanted a magic engineering product in his head.

He's prolonging his life with that product.

This was the most plausible theory.

"Then, if the mana in the magic engineering product is completely depleted, he would die. Are you suggesting we keep up the war of attrition?"

"Not exactly. The point is that he has a device that sustains his life."

There exists a core within him.

Rudy had encountered such beings before.

Undead revived through necromancy.

They also had cores made with mana stones.

If one considers that Raven's golem might also have such a core, it was somewhat manageable.

The problem was that it was a slightly different situation than the undead...

"I can read the flow of mana to roughly locate where the core is."

"You can't know for sure?"

"That golem itself is already an entity tightly bound by magic. It's as if currents are continuously flowing, spreading mana throughout its entire body."

The golem itself is maintained by magnetic magic.

Mana flows throughout its body, and if that mana is cut off, it would immediately fall apart.

Therefore, it was harder to find the core than with necromancy.

"Does that mean you can roughly know?"

"Yes, I can at least point out its approximate location."

As Rudy answered, the golem swung its fist at him.

Rudy glanced at the fist and lifted his foot.

Boom!!!

Rudy kicked the golem's fist, causing a loud noise.

The golem's arm exploded from Rudy's kick, and sand scattered around.

Rudy then turned to Ian, who had been watching, and asked,

"So, what will you do?"

"Why do you keep asking that?"

Rudy kept asking Ian.

It was as if he was testing Ian.

"But you are the commander here, aren't you?"

Ian furrowed his brow.

Rudy wasn't just asking these questions because he was simply a commander.

"So, what will you do?"

Rudy asked, looking at Ian.

"....."

Ian pondered.

It wasn't really a question that needed pondering.

Ian could break through that golem.

He specialized in control magic.

Not just suppressing objects, but controlling and manipulating them.

The ability to disassemble, combine, and alter compositions.

Ian was good at spatial magic because he had learned such magic.

Essentially, spatial magic is about controlling space itself.

Merging spaces, moving them, controlling them.

It was very similar to how control magic is used.

However, Ian had a flaw despite knowing how to use such magic.

He lacked breakthrough power.

To kill an opponent, a significant final technique was needed.

But Ian didn't have such a technique.

While techniques using spatial magic compensated for this, it didn't create new techniques out of nothing.

Ian simply never felt the need for such techniques because he never had to properly fight someone of equal skill.

Ian was always above everyone else.

But, as Rudy suggested, breakthrough power was essential.

It wasn't just about destroying the core; effectively, Raven inside the golem had to be dealt with in one go.

Therefore, the best choice was for Ian to block the golem while Rudy made the breakthrough.

Ian slightly turned his head and looked at the soldiers.

Numerous soldiers were watching this situation.

If Ian blocked the golem here, and Rudy finished the situation, all the credit would go to Rudy.

'What will you do?'

Rudy's words echoed in his head.

Ian thought.

What will I do?

Which option should I choose in this situation?

"Huff....."

Ian took a deep breath.

Then he looked at Rudy.

"I'll break through. You kill Raven."

Ian had made his decision.

He chose the best option available.

Rudy asked Ian.

"Are you sure about this?"

"What do you mean?"

"You know what I mean."

Ian's lips curled up.

"Do you think I'll lose the Duke position over such a trivial amount of credit taken by you?"

Ian had been contemplating.

Rising to the position of a Duke, what should he do?

Is it okay to just aim for the Duke position?

He hadn't found an answer to these questions yet.

But Ian didn't care.

He would do his best to rise to the Duke position.

He would think about what comes after that later.

Once he reached that position, wouldn't a different landscape be visible?

He was immersed in the tasks at hand right now.

He will do his best here.

He will do the best he can with what he was capable of.

Thus, he heads towards his goal.

"I am Ian Astria. The person who will become the Duke of the empire doesn't cloud his judgment for such trivial reasons. And I won't lose to someone who thinks of the Duke position as merely a tool."

He had reached his own answer.

Ian appeared more confident than ever before.

Rudy smiled at that sight.

"Good."

"Don't make any mistakes."

"I won't."

The two walked forward.

Chapter 267: Family Head Contest

(11)

"What the hell are they doing?"

Raven, trapped inside a golem, furrowed his brow.

The duo that had been relentlessly attacking him suddenly started acting strangely.

"It's better for me if it goes like this."

Although only his head remained, Raven could survive by dragging out time.

The reason Raven could stay alive was thanks to the magical engineering device embedded in his head.

This tool compensated for all the bodily functions.

His research, buried in a remote area, focused on the human body.

Aryandor's ability to perform almost as well as before, despite losing his leg, was a result of Raven's studies.

Moreover, Raven didn't just study the human body; he researched the bodies of all living beings.

He sought ways to enhance the corpses used in necromancy and created magical engineering products for this purpose.

Such ongoing research allowed Raven to survive, even as just a head.

"When they're tired, I'll escape immediately."

Raven's goal wasn't to kill those two; it was his own survival.

Even without a body, he could live.

Just as Aryandor's prosthetic was made through magical engineering, so could a body be made, and as long as the mana stone in the life-extension device embedded in his head was replaced regularly, he could continue to live.

"If I survive, I'll have to go into hiding for a while."

He couldn't reveal himself until the rebels were gone.

Raven possessed a lot of confidential information about the rebels.

The research he conducted was the very purpose of Aryandor.

If exposed, it would be clear what needed to be done to stop the rebels.

If Raven survived here, he would undoubtedly become the rebels' primary target.

That didn't mean he intended to side with the Empire.

He couldn't be sure that joining the Empire would ensure his safety.

It would be a stroke of luck if he asked them for help and wasn't tortured.

So, for Raven, fleeing and living quietly was the best option.

As he planned his escape, Raven looked towards the capital of the Empire.

"Aryandor..."

It was a hopeful thought.

Even if he had decided to betray him, he wondered if Aryandor might come to rescue him.

But there was no sign of Aryandor coming.

The man who had reached out to a despised magical engineer from the Empire.

Raven shook his head.

That was all in the past.

Aryandor had abandoned him, and he needed to focus on the present.

Raven looked at Rudy and Ian in front of him.

"Hmm?"

The two of them were acting strangely.

Ian approached the golem, and Rudy stepped back.

"What are they trying to do?"

The physical capabilities of Ian and Rudy were vastly different.

Ian had never been on the front lines, whereas Rudy had magic optimized for combat on the front lines.

For the two of them to switch places was practically insane.

"Time to get ready."

The two were plotting something.

Raven intended to exploit such a situation.

Ian stood still, looking up at the golem.

"I can't dodge every attack with my abilities."

Ian couldn't move like Rudy did.

Even with physical enhancement, he couldn't freely control his enhanced body.

But he still had to do what needed to be done.

Even if he was attacked, even if the opponent tried to block him, he had to fulfill the promise.

"Phew..."

Ian took a deep breath and opened his eyes wide.

"Here I go."

Ian manipulated his mana.

His body disappeared in an instant.

Space warped in front of the golem, and Ian appeared.

Spatial teleportation.

He had moved through space to reach the front of the golem instantly.

The golem, anticipating this, immediately swung its fist.

"Disassemble."

Ian extended his hand towards the incoming fist.

As Ian's hand touched the golem's fist, it exploded with a 'bang!' and disintegrated.

Seeing the golem's fist disappear, Ian turned his head and used another spell.

"Move."

Ian's body, which was falling, was teleported back in front of the golem.

"A little more to the right!"

Rudy shouted at Ian.

"I know."

The place Rudy mentioned was the golem's right side.

Ian was currently in front of the golem's solar plexus.

He needed to move a bit more.

"Control."

Ian touched the golem's hand and used his magic.

Zap...

Then, the earth that made up the golem's body moved, and a platform was created for Ian to stand on.

He controlled the opponent's magic as if it were his own.

Ian continued to create platforms he could advance on.

From the golem's solar plexus to its right side.

Ian immediately ran across the platforms he created.

"Rudy Astria!"

Ian shouted as he ran.

"I know."

Rudy pulled his fist back.

Ian clenched his teeth and tried to reach the part Rudy had mentioned.

Crack.

However, it wasn't easy.

The golem's body wobbled, and spikes protruded from that part.

It had transformed its body to create spikes.

"Cough..."

Ian couldn't react.

No, he saw it happening but couldn't move his body.

The spike pierced Ian's abdomen.

"F*ck..."

A curse flew out of Ian's mouth, who usually spoke like a noble.

Pain emanated from his abdomen.

Ian touched the spike.

"Disassemble..."

Then, the spike made of sand disintegrated and fell to the ground.

With the embedded spike gone, Ian moved his legs again.

There was no time to cry out in pain.

The golem didn't stop there.

It continued to produce spikes on Ian's path, trying to block his way.

Ian twisted his body as much as he could to dodge the spikes, but he couldn't avoid them all.

Many thoughts ran through Ian's head.

Did he need to move forward in this condition?

Perhaps it would be a better judgment to retreat and regroup.

Ian clenched his fist.

He cast aside such thoughts.

Wasn't this what he intended to do?

Wasn't this much anticipated?

Ian moved forward.

He advanced despite the thorns scratching his body and the sand blocking his path.

Using spatial magic and control magic, he cleared the way ahead.

"Rudy Astria!"

Ian shouted.

Hearing his voice, Rudy immediately took action.

He kicked off the ground and propelled his body into the air.

"Disassemble!"

At the same time, Ian, having teleported to the promised spot, used his magic.

Zap... Zzzzzzap!

The sparks flying around were all dissipated.

The thick sand that was covering the surface and blocking the inside was cleared away.

It all turned to dust and disappeared.

As it cleared, the sight of Raven, with only his head remaining, was revealed.

"Found you."

With a murmur, Rudy gathered mana in his fist.

"Ugh..."

Raven, seeing Rudy in front of him, gritted his teeth.

He tried to use magic to repair the golem's abdomen.

But the sand didn't move.

Ian, in front of the golem's abdomen, was controlling the golem's body, preventing Raven from manipulating the sand.

"Eradicate it."

"Shh!"

At Ian's command, Rudy swung his fist.

Mana burst from his fist.

It was different from the air pressure before.

The mana didn't disperse around but focused on one point.

Like a flash.

Like a thin spear.

It shot forward.

"Ah..."

Boom!

The shot mana pierced through Raven.

Not just Raven, but it also pierced through the back of the giant golem.

Raven, with his head pierced through, looked into the distance with a blurry vision.

"Aryandor..."

Until he lost consciousness, Raven gazed at that distant scene.

But Aryandor did not come.

"Ugh... Walk carefully."

"My condition is a mess, how can I consider yours too."

"You're in bad shape, but at least your mouth is alive."

"That's the same for you, isn't it?" Rudy was supporting the injured Ian as they walked.

The ground was covered with the remains of the golem that had been defeated, scattering the dirt.

After defeating Raven, the golem had completely collapsed, and its dirt had spread around.

At their feet lay Raven's head, barely recognizable in form.

"Is he dead?"

"We'll have to check to know for sure."

Rudy, supporting Ian, sat him down on the ground and approached Raven's head.

As expected, there was a tool embedded with a mana stone in his head.

"Hmm... Seeing that the tool isn't broken, he might still be alive."

His head was clearly pierced through.

So, it was hard to call it a head anymore, but the magical device was still intact.

Not knowing Raven's abilities precisely, it was hard to tell if this meant death.

"Do we take him with us like this?"

"No, it's unlikely he'll cooperate anyway, so just detach the device from his head and take that."

"Understood."

With that, Rudy wrapped up the task.

Ian managed his wounds and sat in the carriage.

Rudy, seeing Ian aboard the carriage, knocked from outside.

"What is it?"

"I'll be returning to the capital first."

"You're not asking for my opinion this time?"

Rudy shrugged at Ian's comment.

"Now that everything is finished, why bother asking for opinions?"

"All operations conclude only when we reach the final step of the plan."

"You're quite strict. So, are you not going back?"

Ian lifted the corners of his mouth.

"I'll go slowly, you go ahead."

"...Understood."

Rudy frowned as if wondering why he even asked in the first place.

Simultaneously, Rudy began to manipulate his mana.

"Then, I'll head back first. See you in the capital."

"Alright."

Rudy used his mana to travel to the capital, and Ian told the soldiers outside the carriage.

"We're also heading back."

"Understood!"

Ian started moving towards the capital with a satisfied smile.

Chapter 268: Saint Haruna 2 (1)

"Well, I'm not sure if I'll do well, but now that it's decided, I'll give it a try."

The blonde girl standing on the podium said in an arrogant tone.

The students below buzzed at her words.

"Is that right...?"

"A princess saying something like that..."

All the murmuring came from the first-year students.

They were puzzled by the speech, having heard from the seniors that she was a good person, but then seeing her behave like this after becoming president.

However, the reaction from the second-year students was different.

"That's just how she is."

"She may talk like that, but she does her job properly."

The opinion among the second years was very positive.

The atmosphere was that she was much better than those who only talk big.

"That was Yuni Von Ristonia."

The student council elections at the academy had ended, and Yuni had ultimately taken the president's seat.

Yuni was able to sit in the president's seat thanks to the active support of the second years.

When Rudy was at the academy, Yuni followed him around and did various tasks, from errands in Gracie's lab to student council work, without discriminating.

Despite being a princess, her willingness to do such menial tasks in the past had earned her a very good reputation among the second years, resulting in her taking the president's seat.

Yuni finished her speech and slowly stepped down from the podium.

"Hehe..."

A slight smile formed on Yuni's face.

"She's happy about becoming president; she'll do well, right?"

"Probably?"

The students took comfort in Yuni's smile.

None of them had seen Yuni naturally smile like that before.

Seeing her smile like that because she became president made them think she must have been ambitious about the position and that she would work hard.

However, Yuni's smile was not because she was happy to become president.

'I won, senior.'

The bet she had with Rudy.

If she became president, he would grant her a wish.

Yuni was happier about winning the bet with Rudy than the fact that she became president.

'So... I should go back to my room and tell Rudy...'

"Yuni, where are you going?"

Kuhn called out to Yuni as she was about to head back to her room.

"Oh~. Isn't it our vice president?"

Kuhn was serving as the vice president in Yuni's student council.

He had no intention of doing student council work again, but he felt anxious when he heard Yuni was becoming president.

Kuhn knew the original personality of Yuni.

Until now, Rudy had been there to control Yuni, but now Rudy was not present.

They had to lead the academy with the people here.

So, Kuhn reluctantly decided to play the role of restraining Yuni.

"So, where are you going?"

"...To the dorm?"

"Aren't you going to do student council work?"

"Huh?"

Kuhn grabbed the back of Yuni's neck.

"Thinking of slacking off on the first day?"

"No, what work on the first day? On the first day, there's..."

"No time to relax. We're swamped with work."

"Oh, no. Just for a moment!"

"What moment. Hurry up and follow me."

Thus, Yuni was dragged to the student council room by Kuhn, her neck firmly in his grasp.

"Ugh, I'm exhausted."

Dragging my weary body, I returned to the capital and back to the mansion.

Having barely slept properly for days and wandering through strange mountains, it was only natural to feel exhausted.

Still, one task had been completed.

We had caught one of the rebel leaders, and the battle for succession...

"Oh? Has Young Master Rudy returned?"

A maid welcomed me as I entered the mansion.

All the maids who had been on leave had returned.

I smiled and waved at them.

"Nothing happened to you all, right?"

My casual greeting caused the maids' expressions to harden.

"Well..."

"Was there a problem?"

"Oh, not with us, but... there was a problem in the capital."

"In the capital?"

As I tilted my head, the maid continued.

"Chancellor Ophillius has disappeared."

"Chancellor Ophillius?"

My eyes widened.

That he had disappeared.

A chill went down my spine.

"How long has he been missing?"

"It's been four days now. He disappeared right after you and Ian left."

I frowned.

He had suddenly made a move?

Jason Ophillius.

The Empire's Chancellor.

I had suspected him of being a time magic user.

My suspicion began in earnest after learning that the royal head wizard was not a time magic user.

Considering the evidence and the incident, I suspected Chancellor Ophillius might be the time magic user.

Of course, there were so many other things that I couldn't delve into it properly...

"What is the Empire doing about it?"

"For now, they're spreading wanted posters everywhere and searching. The Chancellor is old and not a wizard..."

To the public, Chancellor Ophillius was known merely as a civilian exceptional in administrative tasks.

He had never been seen using magic, nor was he a swordsman.

"Alright, I understand. I'll go in and rest."

"Understood. I'll prepare a bath for you."

As I headed to my room, I stroked my chin in thought.

My first thought was whether Chancellor Ophillius had joined the rebels.

If so, why join the rebels now?

If the Chancellor had been with the rebels from the beginning, their power would have been much greater.

Chancellor Ophillius, though not skilled in magic or swordsmanship, was recognized solely for his administrative capabilities.

He was a hero to the common people, practically the spirit of the Empire.

If such a person claimed the Empire was corrupt and headed to the rebels, the people's hearts would have completely turned.

Nothing remains in a place that has lost the support of its people.

If the rebels managed to occupy some land and establish a new state, all commoners would surely turn to them.

Yet, he had not done so.

Had he now gone to the rebels?

Without even declaring his intentions?

It's unlikely he would do something so inefficient.

"Then..."

I looked out the window towards the Royal Palace.

The next day, Ian entered the capital.

As soon as I heard the news, I headed to where the Royal army was stationed, assuming Ian would have gone there first.

Upon arriving, I stared blankly ahead.

"..."

There was Rie.

"Rudy Astria. Good timing. Take this guy off our hands."

Astina, the deputy commander of the Royal army, sighed and spoke. It made sense for Astina to be here, but why Rie?

I asked Rie with a puzzled look, "Why are you here?"

"If Ian returned, I figured you would come."

"...So you came to see me? A personal matter?"

Rie shook her head at my question.

"Not entirely personal. There is a personal reason, of course."

Ian sighed at this exchange.

"I'm tired of this. Everyone out."

"Yes, yes. As if we wouldn't leave on our own."

Rie glared at Ian as she spoke.

"Anyway, what brings you here?"

"Chancellor Ophillius."

My expression hardened at Rie's words, as did Astina's and Ian's.

"Have you found Chancellor Ophillius?"

"What do you mean? Has something happened to Chancellor Ophillius?"

Rie narrowed her eyes and glared at both Ian and Astina.

"Now you ask for cooperation after not offering any?"

Astina sighed.

"If you had started with that, we wouldn't have acted this way."

Rie slowly walked over and casually sat down in a chair.

"Anyway, no time for jokes, I'll get straight to it. It seems Chancellor Ophillius was attacked."

I silently nodded, the conclusion I had reached alone yesterday matched.

Astina asked, "Attacked? Any evidence?"

"The lack of evidence is the evidence itself. Would Chancellor Ophillius suddenly disappear? Where could a perfectly healthy person have collapsed? Or, could he have joined the rebels?"

"That's what I think."

At my words, Astina furrowed her brows.

"What are you talking about, Rudy Astria?"

"If he was attacked, what method would leave no evidence?"

Astina tilted her head at my words.

"Attacked without leaving evidence..."

"No, it's not that no evidence was left."

Rie grinned broadly.

"Exactly, my husband. You caught on quickly."

"Husband...?"

"Cough..."

At Astina's reaction, I coughed and looked at Rie.

"You're asking me to check if time magic was used?"

"Yes. Since you're a spatial magic user, you might find some traces."

I nodded.

"Then let's go right away. Can we go now?"

"Yeah, with me here, we don't need special permission."

"Then..."

"I'll come too."

"I'm also going."

As Rie and I were about to leave, Astina and Ian also rose from their seats.

"...What are you two coming for? Ian Astria, didn't you say you were tired?"

"If it's about using spatial magic, I might be more helpful, right?"

"I'm going as the deputy commander of the Royal army. If the rebels really did attack the Chancellor, we need to respond accordingly."

Their reasons had their own logic.

I turned my head to look at Rie.

"Rie."

"...Alright. Let's all go together."

We followed Rie.

Chapter 269: Saint Haruna 2 (2)

Rie led us toward the Ophillius mansion.

As we arrived near the Ophillius mansion,

"Rudy."

Noticing Ian was somewhat far away, Rie called out to me.

"Hm?"

"Is it really okay to bring Ian along?"

"Why wouldn't it be?"

Rie narrowed her eyes and looked at me.

"You know the competition for the head of the family is ongoing. You could be letting Ian snatch away the merits you could earn here."

"Ah, if it's about that, I don't mind."

At my response, Rie tilted her head in confusion.

"What do you mean by that?"

"Exactly as I said. Anyway, let's go inside."

While we were talking, we had arrived at the Ophillius mansion.

A few soldiers were in front, and it was noisy inside as if an investigation was underway.

Rie ignored such people and walked into the mansion.

Though it was a bit audacious, I naturally followed her in.

Thud!

"Who are you? You cannot pass here without permission."

Then, a soldier thrust a spear in front of Rie.

Rie glared sharply at the soldier's action.

"Ah...!"

The soldier widened his eyes upon seeing Rie's face.

"My apologies! Princess... Please, go ahead. I'm very sorry!!"

Despite not saying much, the soldiers bowed their heads repeatedly at Rie.

The bowing soldier then looked back at us following Rie.

"May I ask... who are the people behind...?"

"Among them are Rudy Astria, the second son of the Astria family, and the commanders and deputy commanders of the Royal army. I've permitted their entrance, so it should be fine."

"Understood."

Following Rie's words, the soldier bowed his head.

"Let's go in."

"Can we really just walk in like this?"

I asked, feeling uneasy.

Though it wasn't a lie, was this approach really okay?

"I'm the main person in charge of this case, what problem could there be?"

"You're the main person in charge?"

"Even though I may look approachable, I'm the first princess. The princess who will soon become the emperor. I can certainly handle an incident of this scale."

She had a point.

Despite being a princess, Rie wasn't just a flower in a greenhouse.

She had experienced many incidents, had ample experience, and the capability to resolve them.

I wasn't sure about her current progress in magic training, but she was definitely competent to handle such an incident without issue.

"Sorry I underestimated you. You really are something."

"Hmm!"

Rie was pleased with my compliment and smiled.

Thus, we entered the mansion.

"Your Highness, it's an honor to meet you."

Then, the investigators inside bowed to Rie.

"Any progress in the investigation?"

"None. It's been at a standstill."

"Is that so? Then step aside. I've brought people who will investigate in your stead."

The investigator, looking bewildered, turned to look at us following Rie.

"Ah... those people..."

"Got it, now clear the way. Send the soldiers away."

"Understood."

The investigator, along with the soldiers who were inspecting the mansion, exited the premises.

The not-so-large Ophillius mansion felt quite empty once everyone involved in the investigation had left.

"It feels sparse for a duke's mansion."

Astina's comment was met with a nod from Rie.

"I've heard from others that it has always been like this."

"Others, as in the servants?"

"Not just the servants, but also other visitors to the mansion, both."

Following Rie's response, Astina nodded and looked around.

"Hmm..."

Ian, after observing the surroundings, closed his eyes.

He was trying to sense the spatial domain.

Inspired by Ian, I followed suit, taking a deep breath and focusing.

Then, I delved into the spatial domain.

It wasn't certain whether spatial magic had been used to manipulate time.

However, it wasn't entirely impossible either.

If the spatial domain had been tampered with through time magic, traces of such interference could be detected.

I surveyed the space within the mansion.

The area around the living room showed no abnormalities.

I expanded my search to various locations: the kitchen, the library, and the bedrooms.

"...Ah."

During my search, I found it.

Scars left in the spatial domain.

Just as a severe wound on a human leaves a scar during the healing process, if the spatial domain had been distorted, it would leave behind scars.

These scars would disappear after a certain period, but they would remain for at least a month.

"Did Aryandor visit?"

Ian seemed to have also noticed the scars in the spatial domain.

"That seems most likely."

It was improbable for Minister Ophillius to have suddenly used time magic.

Even if Ian and I were absent, there was no reason to boldly utilize time magic like this.

If we were to return, this act would be immediately discovered.

Rie, observing our reactions, posed a question.

"Then, can this serve as evidence?"

"Moved somewhere using spatial magic... Something like that?"

"They moved?"

"If there's an impact on the spatial domain, it means the space itself was tampered with."

The conclusion was that a place was moved to using time magic.

This was all we could ascertain.

The specific location or the reason behind such a choice was unclear, but it was certain that Aryandor had been here.

Ian, upon confirming this, looked at me and Rie.

"So, what do we plan to do with this information?"

"We need to find them, of course."

"And if we find Minister Ophillius, what are the chances he's still alive?"

"Practically..."

None.

Minister Ophillius is essentially powerless.

He lacked any combat-related abilities.

Such a person wouldn't last a few seconds against Aryandor.

"Still, we need to search for him."

"Instead, Aryandor might use him to set a trap."

"But, there's still a chance that Minister Ophillius is alive, right?"

Though uncertain, there's a very slim chance.

If he really is a user of time magic... he might be able to hold on somehow.

"Are you saying he can hold on until we find him?"

I couldn't respond to that.

Quite some time has already passed.

Moreover, we currently have no evidence at all.

We don't know where Minister Ophillius is or what condition he's in.

Gathering such evidence, even a time wizard couldn't hold on.

They'd give up, both physically and mentally.

"We need to find him as quickly as possible." "How?"

The method to find Ophillius with the evidence we have now.

Such a method does not exist.

However, we didn't necessarily need our evidence to find him.

"We'll have to ask someone who knows where Aryandor is."

Ian furrowed his brows.

"A person who knows where Aryandor is? If there was such a person, we would have already used them."

"We didn't know where that person was at that time."

"So, you know now?"

"We still don't."

Ian snorted as if it was absurd.

"Are you trying to play a game with me?"

"No. I don't know where that person is, but..."

I smiled.

"I've found a way to summon that person."

The next day, a huge commotion erupted at Liberion Academy.

"The head of the Astria family has been decided!"

"No, why did Rudy suddenly give up?"

The reason was a special issue spread throughout the empire.

Rudy Astria, the second son of the Astria family, had declared he would give up the position of family head.

This news was quite shocking to the academy.

Just yesterday, there was news that Rudy had captured the rebel leadership.

Though Ian was involved in the capture, the credit was more heavily attributed to Rudy.

In such circumstances, Rudy gave up the position of family head.

All students couldn't shake the question from their minds.

"Is it because of Minister Ophillius?"

With the empire's two dukes absent, Rudy sacrificed himself because of this.

This was the most plausible speculation among the students.

As the students were exchanging all sorts of conjectures,

"...So you don't know either."

Cromwell was talking with Yuni, having called her.

Not only the students, but they too were confused by these rumors.

The professors were also puzzled about what was happening.

In the capital, he was striving to become the head of the family.

If he suddenly gave up like this, there must be some reason.

Still, since Yuni was in constant contact with Rudy among the current second-year students, they thought she might know something.

"Yes, I'm just as confused."

"Sigh... Alright. Are you having a hard time with the student council president duties?"

"It's tough every single day. I wish I could quit if possible. I wonder how Rudy managed to do this for a year. Is there no way to quit?"

"...No. You can go now. Take care."

"Yes."

Yuni left Cromwell's office, licking her lips in disappointment.

While everyone was making a fuss about Rudy, Yuni wasn't particularly interested.

It wasn't as if Rudy was forced to give up; he chose to do so on his own.

There must be a reason for it.

Rudy had made a promise to Yuni.

Not to be discouraged by Robert's death and to rise again.

Thus, this wasn't really giving up.

It must be a stepping stone for the next phase.

Yuni had no doubts about it.

More than these rumors, Yuni was more worried about having to go to the student council room and work again today.

"Maybe I should escape just for today... I want to take a break..."

Even as she thought this, Yuni's feet were heading towards the student council room.

Every day she grumbled and seemed like she might quit the next day, but surprisingly, she was earnestly committed to her work.

"I'm here..."

Yuni opened the door to the student council room with a drooping head and a listless voice.

"Yuni's here."

"Oh, you came?"

The student council room was in a noisy state.

"Why is it so noisy..."

Yuni, puzzled, lifted her head.

In front of her,

"Are you here?"

Rudy was sitting in the student council president's seat, smiling brightly.

Chapter 270: Saint Haruna 2 (3)

I used spatial magic to arrive at the academy.

The place I arrived at was the student council room.

I moved there upon hearing the news that Yuni had become the student council president.

".....Rudy?"

Someone called me as I arrived.

Turning around, I saw Kuhn.

"Ah, Kuhn. It's been a while."

".....Is it really you, Rudy?"

"What, is there a fake me?"

Kuhn brightened up at my playful words.

He approached me with a smile.

"How are you here? I thought you were busy."

"I've become a bit more free now. Hasn't the academy heard?"

"Ah....."

A shadow fell over Kuhn's smiling face.

"Why that face? It was my choice."

"What?"

"What's with that? Did the rumor spread weirdly?"

I tilted my head in confusion.

I was sure I had spread the rumor that I had quit myself.....

"I thought you quit for a different reason. Weren't you trying to become the head of the family?"

"Ah, it's not like that. It's not like I suffered a huge loss and quit."

"You didn't?"

Kuhn was puzzled when the student council room door opened.

Is it Yuni?

As I turned towards the door, I saw 3-4 students.

I tilted my head at the unfamiliar faces.

"Uh.....?"

"Vice president? Who is this....."

"Vice president?"

"Ah. I am currently holding the position of vice president."

"Ah, it's a bit late but congratulations."

"What's there to congratulate me on? You know how hard this job is."

"I can't very well say I'm sorry to hear that, can I?"

As I chatted familiarly with Kuhn, dozens of question marks appeared over the heads of the students who had entered the student council room.

"Vice president, who is this person?"

".....Ah?"

Then one student's eyes widened.

"Ru, Rudy Astria?"

At the student's words, the eyes of the surrounding students also widened.

"He's older than you guys, and a former student council president. Add honorifics."

".....Is, is it really? Are you really 'that' Rudy?"

I didn't quite understand what 'that' meant, but I nodded anyway.

"Are these the first-year students who just enrolled?"

"Yes, that's right. We are first-year students affiliated with the student council."

I looked at them and smiled.

"Nice to meet you. I am Rudy Astria, the former student council president."

"Gasp....."

Upon my introduction, the fellows didn't know what to do and gasped for air.

"Oh, the person I saw in the newspaper yesterday is right in front of me....."

"Am I, am I dreaming?"

"Ah....."

Their reactions varied.

Even I would probably react similarly if I saw someone from yesterday's newspaper, but it was somewhat awkward to be on the receiving end of such reactions.

"I, I'm a fan of Rudy! I've heard so much about the achievements you've accumulated at the academy! The stories of when you faced the rebels still send shivers down my spine even now!"

"Ah, thanks for that."

"Being the second son of a ducal family, you must be incredibly busy, right? How come you're at the academy....."

"Just had some business here. Oh, and speaking of which, Kuhn. Since I entered the academy using magic, don't I have to be listed in the entry logs?"

"That won't be necessary. You haven't officially graduated yet."

As I talked with Kuhn, the students' eyes widened even more.

"Could it be..... if you entered using magic, did you use spatial magic.....?"

"Yeah, that's right."

"My God....."

The students began to make a fuss.

Some declared it a great honor to see a user of spatial magic in person, while others spouted all sorts of nonsense.

"So..... how do you use spatial magic?"

"That's a family secret, so I can't tell you. Just know it's not a magic that can be used casually."

"Amazing, to use magic that can't be used casually....."

"Ah, yeah..... Thanks."

As the students continued to fuss, I started to feel tired.

Keeping up with their energy was difficult.

"Rudy, didn't you say you had business to attend to? If you keep staying here....."

"Ah, it's fine. I came to meet Yuni."

"Is that so? Then, please take a seat and wait. I'll bring out some tea."

Kuhn said this and gestured towards the president's seat.

".....That's the president's seat."

"You used to sit there every day."

I glanced at Kuhn and then sat down in the president's seat.

Better to sit in a familiar spot than in a stranger's.

"Wow....."

"Last year, Rudy was sitting in that seat....."

"Incredible....."

As I sat down, the students let out another round of admiration.

It was just sitting down; I didn't get what was so amazing about it.

While compliments were nice the first or second time, constantly receiving such reactions was just exhausting.

"I'll go brew some tea."

"Ah, vice president! Let me do it....."

"No need. You must have a lot of questions for Rudy. Use the time to ask them while I make tea."

".....Sigh. Thank you."

I watched Kuhn walk away.

Receiving questions had become part of the routine.

I sighed and looked at the eager first-year students.

"Alright, go ahead and ask your questions."

"Thank you!"

So, while Kuhn went to make tea, I began answering the students' questions.

I explained about life at the academy and the academy's evaluation system, and also talked about the characteristics of the professors and incidents that happened at the academy.

After bringing the tea, Kuhn handed it to me with a smile.

"You seem to be getting along quite well with the kids."

"Getting along well..."

I wanted to say I was dying of exhaustion, but seeing the kids' eyes shining with anticipation, I couldn't bring myself to voice those words.

"More importantly, when is Yuni coming?"

Kuhn glanced at his watch.

"It's about time she should have been here... If she's much later, I might have to go fetch her."

"...Fetch her?"

"Yes, I often end up having to do just that."

"Hasn't Yuni only recently become the student council president?"

"It was the same when planning for the election. But she's once caught, she does work hard, so no complaints there."

"That's good to hear."

At least Yuni works well after she's pinned down.

Having shared a laboratory with Yuni, I knew this all too well.

"Shall we go fetch her then?"

"Let's wait a little more..."

The door to the student council room swung open mid-conversation.

"I'm here..."

Yuni was at the door.

"Yuni's here."

"President, hello!"

"President! There's someone waiting for you!"

The kids greeted Yuni, chattering away.

Yuni frowned and looked up.

"Why so noisy..."

Then, Yuni and I made eye contact.

I smiled broadly and waved.

"Have you arrived?"

"...Senior?"

Yuni's eyes widened.

Then, she narrowed her eyebrows and rubbed her eyes a few times.

"Am I so tired that I'm seeing things?"

"Do I look like a hallucination?"

"...Is it really you, senior?"

I got up from my seat.

"Talking here might be a bit much; let's go somewhere else."

I looked at Kuhn.

"I'm borrowing Yuni for a bit. A day should be fine, right?"

Kuhn momentarily wore a displeased expression but then nodded.

"If you could answer some questions about the handover documents later, then sure."

"...You've grown a bit of a backbone."

"We've got to milk what we can, right?"

I chuckled.

The kid I first brought in had been reluctant to do anything with the student council, but now he felt like a proper member.

"Alright, I'll help."

"Then, have a good time."

Kuhn smiled.

I walked out with Yuni, strolling through the garden.

"Did you come after receiving my letter?"

"Letter?"

"You must not have received it. Then again, a letter wouldn't reach you in just a day."

Yuni clicked her tongue and looked at me.

"So, what brings you here? You've been up to some strange things, I've heard. Is there something you need help with?"

"Huh?"

I tilted my head, puzzled.

Yuni narrowed her brows.

"You're not here to ask for help with something?"

What's she talking about?

"Not at all. We had made a bet, remember?"

"A bet? So, you came here because of a bet? But, didn't you say you hadn't received the letter?"

I wasn't sure what was written in the letter, but I guessed it was something about asking me to come to the academy.

"Since I heard you became the student council president, I thought I'd come and grant your wish."

"Did you really come here to see me?"

"Um... Yes?"

I started to say something else but then swallowed my words and nodded instead.

There was another reason for my visit, but seeing Yuni was part of it.

Yuni's reaction was better than I had expected.

"You came all this way to see me? Really?"

Her eyes sparkled, and she leaned closer to me.

I pushed Yuni slightly back and nodded.

"Well... Yes, but... Anyway. So, what's your wish?"

Yuni, smiling brightly, grabbed my wrist.

"Let's go for now."

"...Where to?"

I started being dragged away by Yuni without getting an answer.

"Hey, at least tell me where we're going... No, what's your wish?"

"You'll find out if you follow me. Let's go."

Yuni led the way with a happy smile, not losing her cheerful demeanor as she walked.

Seeing Yuni so happy made me smile too.

"Alright, let's see what you've been wanting to do."

I followed Yuni, saying that.

Chapter 271: Saint Haruna 2 (4)

"I thought you were taking me to some grand place, but here?"

The place was a bakery in front of the academy.

It was a bakery that Rie and Luna often visited, so I was familiar with it.

"Is that not okay?"

"There's nothing wrong with it."

"Shall we decide where to go next, then?"

Yuni said with a bright smile.

I looked at Yuni, licking my lips.

"So, what's your wish?"

"Ah! I just remembered there's a place I want to visit!"

"What is your wish?"

"How about the restaurant in front of here? My sister and Luna said it's delicious."

"....."

Even when I asked, Yuni didn't respond.

She just smiled broadly, saying only what she wanted to say.

I sighed.

Eventually, she would talk on her own.

For now, I thought it was best to just go along with Yuni.

"What restaurant is in front?"

"You know, the restaurant we went to for your birthday."

"Oh, that place?"

She was talking about the restaurant we went to during our first year, reserved by Astina.

Thinking about it, this bakery was also one that I had visited with Rie.

I prefer going to places I know.

"I'll make a reservation."

Since there was still some time left until dinner, I decided to make a reservation and look around the area.

As I was about to get up, Yuni grabbed my arm.

"Where are you going?"

"I said I'm going to make a reservation."

"Tsk! Where are you wandering off to alone! If we're going, we should go together!"

Yuni spoke as if she was scolding a child.

"So, what now?"

You couldn't dine at that restaurant without a reservation.

It was a busy restaurant and, due to its policy, reservations were absolutely necessary.

"Why not go together? Why do you want to go alone?"

".....Alright."

I nodded with a puzzled face.

I thought she would prefer it if I said I'd go alone...

Considering Yuni's usual reactions, her response left me bewildered.

"But let's go slowly, okay?"

"Alright."

There was still time until dinner, so it seemed okay to take it slow.

However, that was a mistake.

"I'm sorry. The reservations are fully booked, so it might be difficult to dine today. Would you like to book for tomorrow or the day after instead?"

We headed to the restaurant after eating what we ordered at the bakery, but we couldn't make a reservation.

The restaurant was so famous that the reservations were filled up before dinner time.

I sighed and looked at Yuni.

"I want to eat here today."

Yuni spoke to me as if there was no problem at all.

"What can we do if it's already fully booked?"

"Just mention your name, right? No, should I mention mine?"

I sighed again.

"Then someone else won't be able to eat."

"Tell them to eat tomorrow."

"Can't we eat somewhere else? There are plenty of other restaurants."

"No, we can't."

Yuni was firm.

She had been smiling all day, but now her expression was serious.

I really didn't want to do this...

I turned my head and looked back at the restaurant.

"Um..."

"Ah, yes. Have you decided?"

"Is there... no one you can call immediately, no special anniversary today? I'll pay 5 times... no, 10 times the amount, so could you please push the reservation to tomorrow..."

".....What?"

"I really can't help it... Is there no way?"

The staff member looked at me, flustered.

Then, a man walked out from inside the restaurant.

"What's going on! Hurry up and come inside to help!"

"Ah, Master."

Since they called him Master, he must be the chef of the restaurant.

"What? What's the problem?"

The chef stood in front of me, looking annoyed.

"This customer wants to make a reservation. But we're fully booked right now..."

"The reservations are closed, what do you want to do? Today's reservations are..."

"But, they asked if it's possible to make a reservation even if they pay 10 times the amount."

Then, the chef furrowed his brows.

".....10 times?"

"Yes, 10 times the amount would be paid to whoever changes their reservation for us. We'll pay a similar amount to the restaurant as well."

Hearing my words, the chef furrowed his brows.

".....Is it for one person?"

"No, for two."

The chef looked at me and then at Yuni, who was standing a little behind.

Suddenly, the chef looked resolute.

"We have to change it....."

".....What?"

The chef put his hand on my shoulder and looked me in the eye.

"Let me handle this, I'll change the reservation somehow. This could last a lifetime if we mess this up. I have to... ahem. Anyway, let's change it right away."

"Ah... Thank you."

I smiled awkwardly.

If he's going to step up like that, it works out for me.

"Could you tell me your name?"

".....My name?"

"Yes, I need to write it in the registry."

I hesitated for a moment before speaking.

"Rudy Astria."

".....What?"

Both the chef and the staff member looked at me with incredulous faces.

"That... the one we know?"

"Yes, that's right... Please don't tell others."

I preemptively spoke up, worried my name might be used to snatch away someone's reservation spot.

The chef nodded vigorously.

"Of course. We will definitely make room. For the peace of the empire...!"

".....?"

Was this really about the peace of the empire...?

Regardless of the reason, I was grateful they made room for us.

"We'll make room somehow, so just come at dinner time."

"Ah, yes. Thank you. Ahaha..."

I nodded and turned back towards where Yuni was.

"Senior, what happened?"

"Ah, they said they'd make room. No need to worry."

"You should have just said your name earlier."

"It's not because of my name. They just decided to make room out of consideration."

At that, Yuni made a pouty face.

"Senior, you're so stubborn about weird things."

"It's called having a conscience."

"Anyway, let's look around. I have a few things I want to see."

"Things you want to see?"

I followed Yuni.

The place Yuni went to was a small market.

Not a place with luxury items, but a cheap street market.

Is there some kind of romance to this place?

"Senior! Look at this! Fish!"

"My, what a pretty lady. Miss! I'll give you a discount, buy some!"

"Really? Senior! He said he'll give us a discount!"

"What are you going to do with it?"

"Umm... Maybe it'll be useful somewhere?"

"No, it won't. Let's go. Sorry, hope you sell a lot."

"Eh~~."

I led Yuni away to another spot.

As we moved, Yuni's eyes sparkled.

She looked at everything in the market as if it were fascinating.

"Is this your first time here?"

"Yes, what would I have to do here? Have you been here before, senior?"

".....Maybe once?"

This was my second time visiting the market, as I usually went to the same places.

I had been attending the academy for two years, but every day had been busy.

I think the last time I came to the market was to buy a birthday gift for Luna.

I'm pretty sure I bought a robe.

Which Rie ended up burning in a joint exercise...

"Senior! Look at this! This!"

"Yeah, yeah."

While I was pondering, Yuni might have interpreted my response as disinterest because she quickly moved on to looking at other things.

Yuni, excited, pulled on my sleeve.

"Senior, please buy this!"

Yuni pointed at some skewers in front of us.

They were skewers emitting a pleasant aroma.

Normally, I would happily buy them, but...

"Hey, we're going to eat later. If you eat that now, you'll be too full for dinner."

"Eh~. That's not how it works. That's that, and this is this."

I narrowed my eyes and looked at Yuni, then licked my lips.

"Two, please."

"Thank you!"

I bought two skewers and handed one to Yuni.

"What's this? You say that and yet you're eating, senior."

"I'm fine. I was worried because you don't eat much."

"I could eat a lot if I really wanted to."

"Sure, you could."

I bit into the skewer.

The sweet sauce soaked into my taste buds.

"Delicious, isn't it?"

"Is it?"

At my words, Yuni took a big bite of her skewer.

"Mmm!!! Delicious! Is this what commoners eat?"

Yuni exclaimed in admiration as she continued eating her skewer, which disappeared in no time.

"Let's try other things too! More!"

"....."

Aren't we really going to miss our dinner at this rate?

I was worried since we had made a reservation at a restaurant by paying 20 times the original price.

But thinking that Yuni might not have this kind of experience again, I started buying all the food she wanted.

"Senior, this too! And this!"

"Got it. Here you are."

I paid for everything Yuni wanted.

".....Hmm?"

In the midst of this, I sensed a strange presence from an alleyway nearby.

I saw a person in a hood looking at us and then hiding deeper into the alley.

I laughed at the sight.

Looks like they've come.

"Senior!"

"Ah, okay."

I smiled and moved back towards Yuni.

".....Senior, I can't eat a single thing."

"You said you could eat. Force it down."

"If I eat all this, I might actually die."

I sighed.

Yuni only nibbled at the appetizers and left the rest of the food untouched.

We had eaten too much at the market.

"And it doesn't taste good. I was so looking forward to it because I heard it was delicious."

"When you're that full, nothing tastes good."

I said, shoveling the food into my mouth half-heartedly.

I was quite full too, but leaving all the food felt rude, so I was stuffing it into my stomach.

"Senior, are you a pig? How can you eat all that and still eat more?"

".....I'm so full I could die, but I'm forcing it down."

"Why? Let's just leave if we're full!"

"Right, let's do that."

Even the smell of food was becoming unbearable. Apologies to the chef, but leaving the food seemed like the right thing to do.

Although we couldn't eat much, I made sure to thank the chef before we left.

Yuni and I then left the restaurant without having properly eaten.

Outside, the sun was setting, casting shadows everywhere.

I escorted Yuni to the front of the academy.

As we arrived near the academy, Yuni walked ahead with her hands clasped behind her back, then suddenly spun around to face me.

"Senior, today was really fun."

Yuni said with a bright smile, which made me smile too.

"As long as you had fun."

Hearing my response, Yuni grinned mischievously.

"So, can I tell you my wish now?"

At this, I chuckled.

I had somewhat expected this, given that she hadn't answered when I told her to mention her wish earlier.

"Go ahead, tell me."

As I readily encouraged her, Yuni wrinkled her nose.

"Eh, what's this? You're supposed to get angry and say, 'That wasn't your wish?'"

Yuni mimicking my voice somehow felt cute to me.

I put on a conceited smile to tease her.

"I've already figured out all your moves."

"Ah, no fun. Then I'll have to try harder to be unpredictable."

"Do that. So, what is your wish?"

"My wish?"

Yuni stepped closer to me with her hands clasped behind her back.

"Senior, I like you. Will you go out with me?"

Yuni said this with a playful expression.

"Is that your wish?"

I shrugged my shoulders.

How many times have I heard those words?

It's been the same since I became the student council president.

What kind of joke is she trying to pull this time...

"But this is real."

".....What?"

"I really do like you, senior."

"....."

Just minutes after claiming I had figured out her actions and wouldn't be surprised, I was faced with the most startling confession.

"You..."

"I know. My sister likes you too~ Luna senior likes you, and Astina likes you. I know I have three competitors."

Yuni took a step back and smiled brightly.

"Even so? I like you, senior. Now that I've got a wish, why not give it a try?"

"....."

"But, I don't think this feeling will change. It's been a while since I started feeling this way. At first, I thought it was just a crush, but it's not. I just really like you, senior. A lot."

"Yuni."

"So, I told my sister. Now she and I are competitors. I might give up the throne, but I didn't want to give up on Rudy."

But now, I'm equal to my sister. I've been everywhere she went with you.
And starting today, we're dating, right?"

Yuni said this and waved at me.

"Ah! It's gotten quite late. I might miss the dorm curfew. So, starting today, is it day one? Senior?"

With those words, Yuni ran towards the academy.

It was too dark to see clearly, but I felt like Yuni's face was flushed red.

"....."

I blankly stared at the place where Yuni disappeared.

Rie, Luna, Astina... and now Yuni...

I took a deep breath.

Right, what can I do?

Once all this is over...

I somewhat collected my thoughts and looked behind me.

"Come out now. There's no one here."

A woman in a hood emerged from the darkness.

"Did I come at a bad time?"

"Well, yes. But that doesn't mean I'm going to turn back, does it?"

The woman lifted her hood and looked in my direction.

Or rather, she turned her head towards me.

She couldn't see in front of her because a black cloth covered her eyes.

It was Saint Haruna.

"Then let's talk."

Haruna said with a smile.

Chapter 272: Saint Haruna 2 (5)

Haruna and I moved to a place where we wouldn't run into other people.

"Have you been well?"

Haruna asked with a smile.

"I'm not sure if I've been well. I've been swamped with work."

"Is that so? That's unfortunate. But,"

Haruna's expression suddenly turned fierce, glaring at me menacingly.

"Why didn't you take over as the head of the family?"

To which, I responded with a question.

"Was it you who passed the information to Professor Robert?"

"You were supposed to inherit the family, weren't you?"

"I'll ask again. Did you push Professor Robert into a corner?"

Our conversation stalled.

Haruna sighed.

"Let's have a proper conversation."

"If you answer my question, I'll answer yours."

I wasn't planning to back down.

If someone had sacrificed those around me once, it meant they could do it again.

Having such a person around meant that people close to me could start disappearing one by one.

I was not willing to tolerate such a situation.

"I regret what happened to Professor Robert."

"Regrets or whatever. Did you do it?"

Haruna nodded.

"Yes."

Clench.

I gritted my teeth.

"You... You drove Professor Robert to..."

"If I hadn't spoken to Professor Robert, you would be dead."

"Weren't there other ways? You could have told me about it, or prevented this situation altogether."

"There was no other way for this one."

"So you're saying that Professor Robert had to die?"

"Yes."

She was firm.

That only fueled my anger further.

"Professor Robert! What did Professor Robert do wrong? All I had to do was become stronger, tell me the future properly. How could you just..."

"Have you heard of the butterfly effect?"

"...The butterfly effect?"

"A small butterfly's wings might cause a faraway storm. Aren't you afraid of the things that could happen if I told you the future and took different actions?"

"So, you're saying you didn't intervene to cause Professor Robert's death?"

"It was the way to minimize the shock. And I didn't force him to sacrifice. The choice was Robert's."

"Choice?"

I was puzzled.

What had Haruna done to Professor Robert?

"All I did was show Professor Robert the past and the future. And the decision he made was his sacrifice."

I narrowed my brows.

According to Haruna, she hadn't asked Robert to sacrifice himself.

The sacrifice was entirely Robert's decision.

But does that make it okay?

Haruna had read the future and knew that Robert would make such a decision.

She had led Robert to that decision.

"So you're saying you're not at fault?"

"If we're talking about fault, then yes, it's my fault. However, it was a necessary action."

"A necessary action?"

"Astina. Saving her changed many futures. Your growth was delayed, and the overall situation changed."

I clenched my fist.

"Then let me ask you. Has everything gone according to plan now?"

"If you hadn't given up your position as the head of the family, it would have."

"So you're saying that if I had taken the position as the head of the family, everything would be resolved? We could defeat Aryandor, no one would die, and we could peacefully conclude everything?"

"..."

Haruna couldn't answer my question.

Robert's last words.

Haruna didn't know all futures.

Just because she could see the future didn't mean she could control it.

She might change the lives of individuals, but changing the whole world was impossible.

Still, I didn't think it was right to blame Haruna for Robert's death.

Although she had forced Robert's sacrifice, the crime wasn't hers alone.

The real cause of Robert's death was the rebels, not Haruna.

"Haruna, I remember that you helped us. If you hadn't come to the academy, it would have been hard for Rie, Yuni, and also Astina to survive."

That was why I was having this conversation.

Haruna had indeed helped us a lot.

She had helped at the academy, and by informing us about Astina's death, Astina was able to live.

I am truly grateful for this.

But it was difficult to accept the death of others.

"I will do my best to change someone's death. But don't induce someone's death."

"I'm sorry."

Haruna bowed her head to me.

I sighed.

If the professor were here, he'd probably laugh it off, saying, 'Why fuss over such nonsense?'

I didn't scold her further.

"So, why are you here?"

Haruna looked up at me, puzzled.

"You must have a reason for coming."

"Ah... It's about the position as head of the family."

"The position as head of the family?"

Haruna's puzzled look disappeared, replaced by a serious expression.

"Aren't you looking for Chancellor Ophillius?"

I nodded.

The reason I didn't accept the position as head and came to the academy was to draw Haruna here.

"Chancellor Ophillius is probably already dead."

"What?"

"That's the future. And Aryandor will absorb his time magic, gaining even greater power. By that time, you won't be able to stop Aryandor either."

"So you're saying if I take the position as head, I can stop him?"

"Yes, because then your family's spatial magic will be completely yours."

Aryandor, having absorbed the entirety of time magic, posed a significant threat.

To face him, one must possess the entirety of spatial magic.

"So, are you certain that Chancellor Ophillius is dead? Not in the future you saw, but in this reality."

"I can't be sure. Anyway, about the spatial magic..."

"Then, in the future you saw, where is Chancellor Ophillius?"

"What?"

"If Chancellor Ophillius is alive, then it doesn't matter. That means I can also face Aryandor."

"But Chancellor Ophillius is..."

"This situation isn't from the future you saw, right? Then that future could have changed as well."

Chancellor Ophillius.

I don't know much about him.

However, I don't think he's the type to give up easily.

He was someone who carried the weight of many people on his shoulders.

He never passed his burden to others.

He was someone who bore it alone and moved forward.

"Where is Chancellor Ophillius now?"

"Ha... Ha..."

Chancellor Ophillius had died countless times.

Well over a hundred times.

He had died so many times that it was hard to keep count, and his mind wasn't clear anymore.

"How about giving up now?"

Aryandor came again to kill Ophillius.

Ophillius stared blankly at his sword.

Perhaps dying this time would bring some relief.

Ophillius kept waiting.

He waited only for Rudy or Ian to return.

Yet, they never came.

Something went wrong.

Aryandor laughed at such an expression on Ophillius's face.

"Do you finally sense something is wrong?"

"How... What happened?"

"Ophillius, do you know where you are?"

"Where...?"

Ophillius looked around.

It was the same place he had been seeing.

His mansion.

Nothing was unusual.

Aryandor slowly approached the window.

Then, he drew the hanging curtains aside.

That's when the dim outside scenery was revealed.

Buildings in ruins and streets devoid of people.

"...Ephomos."

This was the destroyed city beneath the capital, Ephomos.

"It took quite an effort to build a mansion identical to yours here."

"How... How am I here...?"

"Do you know where this place is?"

"Place?"

"The place where you and I first met. Where you saved me, that place."

Before Ophillius could use his time magic, Aryandor had already cast his magic.

Thus, he moved the space.

To the place where they first met in the past.

Ophillius hadn't noticed.

Not using time magic much, Ophillius had become dull to such sensations.

"So, what will you do now? Plan to hold out as long as you can?"

Aryandor lifted his sword with a smile.

In a situation of despair, people feel more disheartened when they fall into an abyss from a hopeful situation than when despair arrives without any warning.

Ophillius was no different in this respect.

He knew there was a possibility someone could come to save him, but those people couldn't reach this place.

No one would expect it.

If they realized he had been moved through spatial magic, they would search the rebels' stronghold, not thinking to look right beneath the capital.

"It's darkest under the lampshade," they say, not realizing it was right under the capital.

"Heh..."

Ophillius let out a hollow laugh.

"So, how about dying now?"

"Yeah... That seems to be the only way."

Ophillius stood up as he spoke.

At this, Aryandor's lips curled into a smile.

"Good decision. Then, let's proceed with the magic..."

"But."

Ophillius felt despair.

But he hadn't given up.

"I have no intention of giving you power."

"What?"

Ophillius mobilized his mana.

"I must pay for my sins."

Ophillius made a vow.

To someone who knew his past, to Robert, he had promised.

He had vowed never to die.

Ophillius had committed many sins.

He had tried to change the future by committing those sins.

All those attempts were in vain.

Seeing now that Aryandor knew about his sister, Beatrice, it was indeed the worst situation.

Ophillius, trying to bring about the best situation, had led it to the worst.

"Ugh... You bastard!"

Ophillius's body began to fluctuate.

Time twisted.

"Aryandor, I'm sorry. I wished you could have lived a better life."

It was Ophillius who taught Aryandor swordsmanship.

It was Ophillius who taught him time magic.

Would it have been better if he hadn't taught him those things from the start?

Would it have been better if he had told him about his sister, Beatrice?

Would the situation have been better if he hadn't killed Serina's mother and sealed Priscilla?

Or, if he hadn't killed Robert's son...

Many thoughts crossed Ophillius's mind.

But now, he couldn't change the past.

The only thing humans can change is the future.

"Let me say one last thing."

A fluctuating door opened on Ophillius's side.

He was heading to a rift in time.

A place where space, time, or anything else does not exist.

If he went there, he could preserve his life.

However, he couldn't escape from there.

He would have to stay there quietly until his lifespan ended.

This would undoubtedly be painful.

But he couldn't die here.

He slowly walked into the rift in time.

As Ophillius walked toward that place, he turned back and smiled.

"Aryandor, live your life."

"Ophillius!!!!!"

And so, Ophillius disappeared into the rift in time.

Chapter 273: Saint Haruna 2 (6)

"Where are we?"

"On the way to Ephomos."

Haruna and I quickly moved towards the capital.

The way here wasn't difficult.

"We need to hide well here. If anyone comes, just say my name."

"Understood."

I was able to come here by utilizing the Red Dragon, Yongyong.

I wondered why it was named so, but since Evan decided on it, I just let it go.

"But, is this the only way in?"

We were outside the capital.

In front of the castle was a strange cave.

"There is a way in from the capital, but we can't actually enter the capital, can we?"

"Into the capital?"

I quickly realized the reason.

There were checkpoints to enter the capital now.

The checkpoints in place to capture Perrian Astria were still in operation.

Haruna couldn't enter the castle like this.

She was currently doing her best to hide her appearance.

The reason I went to the Academy was to create a situation where Haruna could reveal herself safely.

The Academy was a more troublesome place for the rebels than the capital.

The capital, being such a large castle, was difficult to manage every part of it.

On the other hand, the Academy was smaller, and with McDowell and Cromwell vigilantly watching, the rebels couldn't just come as they pleased.

"How far do we have to go?"

"We'll be there soon."

We walked deep into the cave.

It seemed endless, but soon we could see the end.

"...It's blocked?"

The problem was that the end was blocked.

I looked at Haruna puzzledly.

"You have to break through."

"Break through?"

"With Ephomos gone, they blocked the entrance completely, so you have to break through to get inside."

I looked at the ceiling.

Using great force in the cave could bring the ceiling down...

It was hard to know how much it was blocked, so precise control of power was necessary.

I touched my chin and then the wall.

"Can you break through?"

"...It seems a bit much to force our way through."

Punching through could definitely bring the ceiling down.

Then there was an option.

To use spatial magic to break through.

That also carried its risks.

Using Spatial Severance might touch something important and cause damage.

So...

"Behemoth."

I had Behemoth, a demon of earth and metal.

Although it looked like an elephant, it was quite useful.

"Pwoo!!!"

Thump!

When I summoned Behemoth, suddenly a large body appeared.

"What, what's this!"

Certainly, when I summoned Behemoth before, its body was very small.

It was about the size of my waist before, but now it was bigger than my body.

The large body of Behemoth filled the cave, rumbling ominously.

As its body touched the ceiling, the cave started to resonate.

I quickly slapped Behemoth's body, urging it to shrink.

"Hey! Hey! Shrink your body! Do it quickly!"

"Pooh?"

Behemoth tilted its head but began to gradually reduce its size.

As Behemoth shrank to about the size of my waist, the ceiling stabilized to its original state.

That was a close call... We could have been crushed under the cave.

I looked at Behemoth, my heart still racing.

"Hey! Keep your size like this normally. Unless I say otherwise, maintain this state."

"Pooh..."

Behemoth seemed somewhat displeased.

Ignoring that, I pointed towards the blocked path.

"Can you break through that?"

"Pooh!"

Behemoth moved its trunk, and the wall in front of us started to wobble.

The stone, which appeared solid, turned to mud, and a path began to open.

After a few minutes, a clear path was opened.

"Let's go."

"Understood."

I led Behemoth and Haruna forward.

A few steps ahead, a remarkable sight unfolded.

An underground city.

Yet, a destroyed one.

That was exactly the vibe.

All the buildings were destroyed, and not a single person was in sight.

"...But what is that?"

In this ruined city, one house stood out as discordant.

A house built in the center of the city.

While all other houses were destroyed, this one remained intact.

At the same time, an unsettling feeling emanated from it.

Time magic.

Time magic was being used there.

"Haruna, stay here. I'll leave Behemoth with you."

Haruna wasn't combat-ready.

If Aryandor was there, he wouldn't leave Haruna alone.

It seemed right for me to go there alone.

"Understood."

Leaving Haruna behind, I ran towards that place.

Arriving at the front of the house, I cautiously opened the door and entered.

"Huh?"

I was puzzled.

Entering through the door, I saw a familiar sight.

"...The Ophillius mansion?"

The house was built exactly like the Ophillius mansion.

Then, the truth of the situation dawned on me.

I quickly ran upstairs.

The bedroom was where time magic had been used in the Ophillius mansion.

So, if I go to the bedroom...

I opened the door to the bedroom on the second floor.

There was a man inside.

A man looking into the void, seemingly in despair.

It was Aryandor.

As I entered, Aryandor turned his head.

I immediately mobilized my mana.

However, Aryandor showed little reaction.

"It's already too late."

"What?"

Ophillius is nowhere to be seen.

Nor is there his corpse.

"What have you done?"

Aryandor said nothing.

He just walked towards the window.

"You can't escape."

Aryandor looked at me blankly, then laughed.

"You think you can stop me?"

"There's nothing I can't stop."

He's someone I've already fought once.

If a fight broke out here, and if Haruna saw and asked for help, I might be able to capture him.

The problem was figuring out the current situation.

Where did Chancellor Ophillius go? Did Aryandor kill him?

If so, his power...

According to Haruna, Aryandor, having obtained all time magic, is now beyond my reach.

But handling new power requires time to adapt.

If I don't give him that time...

Aryandor looked at me and then spoke.

"Rudy Astria."

"...?"

"Do you have any interest in making a deal with me?"

"What?"

Is this guy insane?

A deal?

I almost cursed out loud but held it back.

"What kind of deal?"

I thought I might as well hear him out.

Perhaps he's had a change of heart.

"I'll send you back to the world you originally came from."

"What?"

"You know this isn't the world you were in. Essentially, you were brought here against your will. So, I'm saying I'll send you back to where you originally were."

"Are you crazy?"

I couldn't hold back my curse at his words.

This guy must have really lost it.

"I know how to send you back to your original world."

"I know that, as*hole."

Clearly, in the future, I used spatial magic to return to my original world.

So, wouldn't I find out how after this is all over?

"No, you don't."

Aryandor said with a flat, emotionless gaze.

He looked like a real madman talking like that.

"What's the method then?"

At my casual question, Aryandor answered easily.

"Every user of time, space, and dimensional magic except for one must die. The one remaining will have the power to travel dimensions."

"Ah?"

My eyes widened.

All users of time, space, and dimensional magic must die?

Then, the future me...

I started to understand the situation.

By that time, everyone was dead.

Aryandor, Haruna.

That's why I was able to move.

"So, you're saying you'll die?"

"Yes. I'll make sure to die."

"..."

In exchange for me returning to my original world, Aryandor dies.

Is this the right choice?

If I choose this option, everything ends.

This confusing situation, the danger to everyone.

"What do you think? Will you accept my offer?"

"Hmm..."

I looked at Aryandor.

...It wasn't going to be that simple.

I smirked.

"F*ck off."

There's no way this guy would make such a tempting offer, and I had no intention of killing Ian and Haruna.

I'd welcome his own suicide with open arms, but this obviously looks like a trap.

"Spatial Severance."

Aryandor twisted his body to dodge my magic.

"Hmm... Don't you want to hear the whole story before deciding?"

"Do you think I'd trust you?"

I've seen the end of those who've cooperated with this guy.

He discarded his own leaders like trash and even killed Perrian, his ally.

Would he really cooperate with me, his enemy?

Unless I was a fool, I wouldn't accept such an offer.

Aryandor looked genuinely puzzled.

"Once you return to your world, what happens to this one doesn't matter to you, does it?"

"Whether I return or not isn't the issue. It's blatantly obvious you'll betray me. Hey, how about I make you an offer? If you die right here, I'll accept your proposal. So, will you die?"

When I said that, Aryandor smirked.

"But, I was actually serious about the offer."

"Then die for me."

"That's problematic. There are still a few things I need to do."

I flipped Aryandor off.

"Then f*ck off. I'll kill you without sacrificing anyone."

"Sure, give it a try. I'll cheer you on."

Aryandor responded mockingly and manipulated his mana.

His surroundings fluctuated.

"Time magic... Priscilla!"

"You still can't block time magic, can you?"

Aryandor was mocking me.

"Rudy."

"Priscilla."

I focused on Aryandor's form.

I just need to use the same sense of technique as before.

The sense of freezing space.

The feeling of making it immovable.

Remember that feeling.

"See you on the battlefield, Rudy Astria."

"Ugh...!"

I align my senses with Priscilla.

I show Priscilla the domain of space.

So, the movement of space...!

"Take care."

Then, Aryandor's form disappeared.

"...Shit."

I cursed and looked at the place where Aryandor had vanished.

Well... If it were that easy, I would've gone straight to the rebels...

Not being able to suppress that technique is why I can't defeat the rebels.

I sighed.

The rebel's headquarters.

As Aryandor arrived, the necromancer, Daemon, approached him.

"Have you returned?"

"Yes."

Daemon followed Aryandor and began to speak.

"There's a lot that has piled up."

"Is that so."

Aryandor listened to Daemon's story with indifference.

"Raven has been captured..."

Aryandor showed no interest in Daemon's words.

He had other concerns.

'He's starting to be able to use it.'

He looked at his hand.

He had just returned to this place using time magic.

But it wasn't easy.

Rudy's attempt to block the time magic had worked to some extent.

He had tried to use time magic to return to the rebel's headquarters, but he ended up somewhere completely unrelated.

Although he hadn't completely blocked the magic, he had succeeded in partially suppressing it.

'If this drags on any longer...'

It meant defeat.

The rebels no longer had the upper hand.

"Aryandor?"

At Daemon's call, Aryandor turned his head.

"There are many issues internally as well..."

"It doesn't matter."

"...What?"

Aryandor stood up.

'Aryandor, live your own life.'

Aryandor pondered the last words of Ophillius.

His answer was already decided.

'This is my life.'

Aryandor looked at Daemon and spoke.

"Prepare for war."

At those words, Daemon's eyes widened.

"War?"

"Before Rudy Astria masters his abilities. We will go to war."

Aryandor spoke with a murderous look in his eyes.

Chapter 274: Saint Haruna 2 (7)

After letting Aryandor get away, I returned to where Haruna was.

As soon as Haruna saw me, she ran towards me.

"What happened? What about Chancellor Ophillius...?"

"The Chancellor wasn't there. I have no clue what happened."

"He wasn't there?"

"Yes, only Aryandor was there."

If Ophillius had been killed by Aryandor, there would have been some trace of it.

Either his body or signs of a struggle.

But there was nothing there.

Not even a trace of Ophillius's blood existed.

It was also impossible to know what had happened there.

Time magic had been used so extensively that it was hard to tell how it was used.

"Was there... anything else strange?"

"He said something odd."

I explained to Haruna what had happened.

About the method to return to our original world and that Aryandor had suggested it.

Haruna listened closely to the story, then sat down.

"Could you wait a moment, please?"

"What is it?"

Haruna didn't answer my question and closed her eyes.

Then, an unknown power began to emanate from her body.

I could instinctively recognize the energy.

"...Dimensional magic?"

After a while, Haruna stood up.

"What did you do?"

"I looked into what happened."

"Is that even possible?"

"Not completely, but to some extent, yes."

"So, what happened? What about Chancellor Ophillius?"

Haruna hesitated before speaking.

"I don't know if it's good news... or if it's regrettable..."

"Hm?"

"Chancellor Ophillius is not dead."

"He's not dead?"

"But, he's in a state as good as dead."

What does that mean?

As I looked puzzled, Haruna stood up.

"There exist gaps in the world. In time, in space, in dimensions. There are gaps."

"Gaps?"

"Our world seems interconnected, but it's actually not. We only see and live in the connected parts."

"So, what does that have to do with anything?"

"Chancellor Ophillius has headed towards that gap."

"So..."

"He might be alive, but in a state that's not truly living. As I just said, we can only live in a continuous world. Entering such a disconnected place would render him in a state of being both existent and non-existent."

Being existent and non-existent.

It was a contradictory statement, but I understood what it meant.

"Did he make that choice not to pass his power to Aryandor?"

"From what I've seen, yes."

I had a mixed expression on my face.

Should I call it fortunate or not...

If you asked me whether Ophillius was a good person, I couldn't answer.

He was a user of time magic, and the fact that he had raised Aryandor remained unchanged.

I didn't know much about Ophillius.

What he had done in his life, or what his relationship with Aryandor was, I had no idea.

I wondered.

Who exactly was Ophillius?

What kind of life had he led?

"Haruna."

"Yes?"

"Tell me about Chancellor Ophillius. It's time I knew. What exactly is Aryandor trying to do, and what's the relationship between Ophillius and Aryandor?"

"It's going to be quite a long story."

"That's fine. It's a story I need to hear at some point."

That's how I began to hear the story from Haruna.

The Royal Palace.

High-ranking nobles gathered, and even the Emperor and Rie were present.

Among those people, Ian Astria stood at the center.

"Let's begin the appointment ceremony."

Rudy had announced Ophillius's death, and the date of the ceremony had been moved up.

Leaving the ducal position of the Empire vacant for too long wouldn't be beneficial.

Quickly seating Ian in the ducal position was necessary to stabilize the empire's public sentiment and to respond to the rebels.

The Emperor descended from his high seat and picked up the prepared crown.

"Ian Astria is hereby recognized as the head of the Astria family."

Though the appointment ceremony usually required several steps, the situation of the Empire necessitated a simplified process.

As the Emperor placed the crown on Ian, the surrounding nobles applauded.

The nobles clapped their hands and murmured among themselves.

"So, what happens to the empire now?"

"With Chancellor Ophillius dead, is it the era of the Noble faction?"

Those of the Nobles faction smiled, and those of the Royal faction trembled with anxiety.

With one of the two dukes gone, it was thought that the balance of power would tilt towards the Noble faction.

"Khh..."

"Finally..."

It was time for Ian to receive the crown and speak.

He stood in front of the nobles, looking around.

"I've gone through many processes to get to this position. I received help from many nobles along the way, and I have no intention of forgetting this assistance."

The words made the Noble faction's corners of their mouths rise.

It sounded to them as if he was promising to repay the Noble faction.

However, that smile didn't last long.

"But now is not the time for us to fight each other. Noble faction and the Royal faction, we don't have the time to worry about such things. We have a very dangerous enemy before us. The rebels. We must stand against them."

"What is he talking about?"

"Stand against the rebels...?"

The Nobles faction looked at Ian with puzzled eyes.

"I will not distinguish between the Noble and the Royal faction. I will give positions and rewards according to people's abilities and will no longer allow factional fighting.

"If there's factional fighting, I will not stand idly by."

Those words were a shock to the Nobles faction.

They had thought it would be their era, but Ian had no intention of supporting the Nobles faction.

"I believe the reason such rebels could emerge is because of the rotten nobility. Therefore, I will take this opportunity to cut out the rotten parts and right the Empire."

With those words, Ian's speech came to an end.

The nobles murmured among themselves, but Ian didn't care about that.

Anyone who couldn't agree with his words was no better than trash.

There was no reason for someone with proper abilities to disagree with Ian, whether they were part of the Royal faction or the Noble faction, whether they came from a good family or not, whether they had flattered Ian or not.

If they had abilities, they could hold important positions.

This way, he could attract all the talents.

And they would do their best to show their capabilities.

To reach higher positions.

To achieve better results.

Ian finished his speech and walked alone through the corridor.

While walking, he entered a room in the palace.

"Did I do it right, Rudy Astria?"

"It was good."

Rudy was there.

"It seems the political situation will flow as you desire."

"It's not just what I want, is it?"

The reason Ian had given such a speech was because of a deal with Rudy.

Rudy had offered a deal in exchange for giving up his position as head of the family.

Initially, Ian refused the deal.

Not because he disliked the deal, but because he wanted to compete on equal footing.

He didn't want to be seen as someone who cowardly took the ducal position due to his brother's concession.

He wanted to compete fairly and become the duke.

However, Rudy was firm.

By giving up his position as head, he would not only bring Haruna into play but also found it better to move freely rather than being tied to the ducal position to counter the rebels.

Only after explaining that giving up the ducal title was not out of consideration for Ian but for a better outcome did the deal go through.

Of course, the contents of the deal were minimal.

Getting to keep using spatial magic and help with a few tasks.

It was practically a request to maintain the status quo.

After discussing with Rudy for a while, Ian casually asked.

"So, what's next?"

"First, we plan to examine the magical artifacts we've collected."

"Magical artifacts?"

"Ah, those magical engineering items."

He was referring to the item attached to Raven's head.

"You're going to investigate it?"

"Yes, Luna is currently trying to dismantle and examine the device, but we're not sure what we'll find."

Ian looked intently at Rudy.

"Did you hear something from Haruna?"

"Yes, to some extent."

Rudy had heard about the past from Haruna.

Of course, it wasn't the exact details.

Haruna didn't know the entire past either.

She had only heard a vague outline.

"I'll explain everything once I know the details."

"Alright, then take care."

Rudy stood up and left the room, and Ian watched his back as he left.

Although Ian had secured the ducal position, Rudy seemed to be at a higher place than himself.

"I thought there was nothing above the ducal position..."

Ian chuckled to himself.

He had succeeded in securing the ducal position, but there was no time to be satisfied or enjoy it.

He had to strive harder.

To not be lesser than his younger brother, he had to move forward.

"It's going to be busy for a while."

Ian gathered his things casually and stood up from his seat.

Chapter 275: Beatrice (1)

"Luna, have you been well?"

"Yes! Rudy, you've been well too, right?"

I went to the Magic Tower to greet Luna.

Then, Franz, the Empire's head wizard, walked up from behind.

"Rudy's here?"

"How have you been?"

"Would an old man's life suddenly change? As usual, I've been busy with my research. Now, take a seat."

Franz extended his hand towards a chair in front.

I sat down and looked at the table in front of me.

I had been curious about it since earlier.

The snacks laid out on this table.

"...What's all this?"

"Ha, just some snacks. Prepared them for you to enjoy with tea."

Franz spoke as if it was nothing, but the snacks in front of us were not just any ordinary level.

They were almost like something you'd see at a party.

Cookies and cakes piled up like Towers, almost overwhelming in their abundance.

And they were not cheap snacks either.

At a glance, they were obviously from a high-end bakery.

"Help yourself."

Franz said with a hearty laugh.

What is this old man thinking?

Franz, who could be considered the owner of the Magic Tower, was treating me.

"I don't particularly enjoy sweets..."

"Is that so? Then, do you prefer snacks that aren't sweet? Do you have a favorite bakery?"

"No, I don't particularly enjoy snacks in general. Just a cup of tea would be..."

Then Franz turned his head towards the door.

"Is someone out there?"

"Yes! Master of the Tower!"

As if he had been waiting, a man entered.

"Bring out the finest tea in the Tower!"

"Understood!"

The man quickly moved out, closing the door behind him.

I smiled awkwardly at his attitude.

It was puzzling to be welcomed this warmly when I was no longer the heir to Astria.

It had been strange from the beginning.

When I tried to enter the Magic Tower, the guards greeted me with respect.

Every wizard I met greeted me with a smile.

Now, when there's no benefit to be had from me...

"By the way, you came to see the item Ian passed on to you, didn't you?"

I nodded vigorously.

Talking about work was more comfortable than continuing in this awkward situation.

"Is the analysis finished?"

"It's not finished, but you'll be able to get the information you want. Someone who has seen it in use is here, so analyzing the information should be easy."

"Can we go see it right away?"

"Let's. It's better to finish work and then rest."

Following Franz's words, we stood up from our seats.

As we were moving, I pulled Luna to my side.

"...Huh? Rudy?"

"Luna, what's going on?"

"What do you mean?"

"Why are they all doing this to me?"

I looked around.

The wizards around me smiled brightly at me, as if they were welcoming me.

"I don't know...?"

"Really...?"

Luna pondered for a moment, hand on her chin.

Then, clapping her hands, she looked at me.

"Now that I think about it, it is a bit strange."

"Strange how?"

"People kept giving me snacks and asking about Rudy."

"About me?"

"Since Rudy is so amazing, I thought it made sense they'd ask me. But now that I think about it, it's weird."

"What's weird?"

"The snacks were too delicious...!"

"You always liked snacks. Didn't you just eat them because you were hungry?"

"Is, is that so? Anyway, they tasted better than usual!"

"Really...?"

More delicious snacks...

Asking about me and offering tributes to Luna...

Whatever was happening in the Magic Tower, it was clear there was something suspicious going on.

As Luna and I conversed, we quickly arrived at the laboratory.

Franz handed me a report from the lab.

"Here are the documents we've researched. They're well organized, so it should be easy to understand."

"Thank you."

I began to skim through the report.

The report speculated not only on the capabilities of the magical device but also on the intentions of the rebels.

What could be done with this magical device, and where they intended to use it.

The details were thoroughly noted.

I quietly recited the contents of the report.

"...A tool that substitutes for the human body."

This magical device could sustain life even if the body disappeared.

As long as the mana stone is replaced, one could live without a body, not dying.

Of course, this doesn't mean one can live forever.

Although the device can substitute for the body, it cannot substitute for the mind.

Over time, the mind would wear out.

While not actual death, it would be close to death.

"Can this device be used to create an army?"

"It's impossible to reach that level. This magical device prevents death but doesn't enhance individual strength. Plus, its weaknesses are clear, so it can't be distributed to soldiers."

"Weaknesses?"

"If the device itself is destroyed or if the person's head is blown off, survival becomes impossible. Also, this device enables 'survival,' not the ability to regenerate the body."

"I see."

I listened to Franz's explanation and looked back at the report.

A tool that can substitute for the human body.

The rebels don't actually need such a device.

Aryandor is a user of time magic.

Venderwood has the ability to heal the body to an almost unlimited extent.

Daemon can utilize corpses with necromancy.

It was clear how this tool could be of use to the others.

Therefore, this tool was not meant for the rebels.

Aryandor's purpose.

Why he incited a rebellion and for what purpose remained a mystery.

I heard about it from Haruna.

His sister, Beatrice, was the former Saint and the one who summoned me.

Aryandor lives for her.

Although she has already vanished and died, Aryandor dedicates everything to her.

The resurrection of Beatrice.

That was Aryandor's ultimate goal.

The methods and intentions behind such a goal were unknown.

Still, knowing his goal provides an advantage in understanding him.

The magical device Raven researched was undoubtedly created for the resurrection of Beatrice.

Two elements are necessary to resurrect someone.

One is the person's body, and the other is their spirit.

Beatrice has died, and it's unknown where her body is.

Given the time since her death, even if her body were found, it wouldn't be in its normal state.

Therefore, something to substitute for her body was needed to resurrect Beatrice.

I was confident this magical device was created to substitute for Beatrice's body.

Then the question arose.

How do they intend to resurrect Beatrice's spirit?

Thinking with modern science in mind, a brain would be necessary to resurrect a spirit.

A person's spirit returns with their brain.

But, is such a thing possible?

Even in modern times, not everything about the brain is understood.

Could replicating a dead person's brain be possible in this world?

In a world of ordinary science, it might be impossible, but here, there is 'magic.'

I pondered slowly.

What magic could be used to replicate a dead person's spirit...

Recovering a dead person's memories is impossible even with necromancy.

Necromancy doesn't actually resurrect the dead but uses their bodies like puppets.

Even with a corpse, it's impossible to revive a person's memories.

"Hmm..."

As I furrowed my brows in thought, Luna looked at me with concern.

"Is something wrong?"

"It's nothing..."

I tried to say it was nothing.

Luna glared at me as I spoke.

"You always say it's nothing."

"Cough..."

"I know there's something bothering you."

Luna said this and came closer to me.

"So, let's think about it together. I don't want to pretend I don't know you're troubled anymore."

"..."

"I've really become strong. Maybe not as strong as Rudy, but I won't just fall over with a flick anymore. I'm confident I can survive, no matter who I fight or who attacks me."

"So, let's think about it together."

I looked at Luna dumbfoundedly.

While I had been striving and growing, Luna had been growing too.

The once naive and cute Luna was now asking me to rely on her.

"Huh?"

I smiled and placed my hand on Luna's head.

"Ah! What...! Rudy!"

Then, I tousled her hair vigorously.

Her neatly combed hair became a bit disheveled.

Luna looked at me with surprise.

"Thanks. I'll explain everything."

I was grateful to Luna.

Grateful for her saying this and proud of how she had grown.

I took Luna's hand.

"Ru, Rudy?"

"Let's talk over dinner."

I held Luna's hand and walked out of the laboratory.

"Rudy Astria?"

Franz looked at us puzzledly.

"Ah, thank you for the report. I'm planning to leave now. May I go with Luna?"

"Ah, yes..."

Franz wore a confused look, but I ignored it and walked out.

"Ru, Rudy! People are watching..."

Luna gestured around us.

Other royal wizards opened their eyes wide at us.

I walked through them, taking Luna with me.

"Let them see."

What if they do?

It didn't matter.

That's how I led Luna out of the Magic Tower.

After Rudy left the Magic Tower.

"Head Wizard!!"

Many wizards gathered around Franz.

"Did you see that? Luna and Rudy Astria..."

"I saw it... Hmm..."

"Their relationship seems to be very good. Seeing Rudy leading her..."

"Hmm... I saw it too, I know..."

"Then...! Could it be...!"

Franz shook his head.

"I didn't even get a chance to bring it up."

"Ah..."

"What a missed opportunity...!"

The surrounding wizards exclaimed.

Their plan was to attract Rudy to become a royal wizard.

Rudy was an immense talent.

From his time at the academy to now fighting the rebels, he has shown incredible abilities.

Yet, people only watched him.

After all, he belonged to the Astria family.

But now, it's different.

Rudy has essentially become a free agent, able to join any side.

With such a tremendous talent unaffiliated, now was the opportunity.

The Magic Tower did not miss this timing.

They did their best to appeal to Rudy.

"If the Head Wizard doesn't make an offer, it all means nothing!"

"...Did I know he would leave like that? Still."

"Still?"

"He's Rudy Astria, after all. Do you think he doesn't know why we acted this way?"

Rudy Astria was astute.

Rudy was known to anticipate moves several steps ahead, not just when dealing with the rebels, but also when facing Perrian or Ian.

"So..."

"He's probably assessing the situation. Seeing if we are people who can handle him."

"Oh..."

The wizards nodded at Franz's words, finding them to have a point.

"He's a clever one. We just need to focus on our work. Then Rudy Astria will come to us in his own time."

"Indeed... We will trust and follow the Head Wizard."

"Good."

With that, the wizards returned to their posts, leaving Franz alone.

Cold sweat ran down his back.

'Rudy Astria wouldn't know.'

Franz felt that admitting he missed the timing to speak would diminish his dignity, so he brushed it off.

He knew a lot about Rudy.

There were stories he heard from Robert and things he had seen himself.

Rudy Astria was astute, but there was a screw loose somewhere.

A lack of everyday awareness.

He was strangely oblivious in certain situations.

His gentle nature didn't make it overly apparent, but when you spent time with him, there were moments where things seemed off.

Franz had skirted around the issue to maintain his dignity, but...

"I'll have to make him an offer in person later..."

For now, Franz had managed to sidestep the situation, but if he couldn't get a proper response from Rudy later on, he was sure to catch flak from the others.

So, he planned to make the move later.

Chapter 276: Beatrice (2)

"Tell me about Aryandor."

After losing Aryandor in Ephomos, I asked Haruna.

What does Aryandor want?

What has happened so far, and what will happen in the future?

Haruna explained this to me.

"Aryandor's goal is the Academy."

"The Academy?"

"Do you know why Saints appear at the Academy every year?"

The Saints come to the Academy every Homecoming Day.

They don't come because they have nothing better to do or because they're idle.

"For the Saints, the Academy is a very important place."

"So, why is it important?"

"Because it's the place where a Saint meets her end."

Haruna answered my question calmly.

"The end...?"

Instead of directly answering my question, Haruna asked another.

"Rudy Astria, haven't you seen the end of this world when you were somewhere else?"

I pondered Haruna's words slowly.

When I saw this world as a game.

It was what she was referring to.

"What was the end of this world like?"

I contemplated for a moment.

The end of this world.

The last scene I saw, in essence.

"The annihilation... of the Academy."

"Yes, everyone at the Academy dies. But, what happens after that?"

I don't know what happened next.

The last scene I saw was simply the massacre at the Academy, and then it ended.

Haruna nodded when I didn't speak.

"That must have been the end."

What I saw was from Evan's perspective.

Evan, too, was a part of the Academy. With everyone at the Academy massacred, Evan also died.

So, the last thing I saw was indeed the end.

"However, there is no problem. Aryandor also disappears after seeing that end."

"What?"

"Aryandor will kill everyone at the Academy and then commit suicide. That's the end of the story."

"What are you talking about?"

Aryandor commits suicide?

Why on earth?

I had thought that after defeating the Academy, the next target would naturally be the Empire.

The rebels' goal is essentially the Empire.

They gathered to overthrow the Empire and create a new world.

So, they should have moved towards the Empire for that goal.

"You should know that his purpose does not align with the rebels'."

Aryandor's goal is the resurrection of Beatrice.

He is with the rebels only for that, not sharing the same purpose.

Even so, the rebels' goal cannot be ignored.

Why would he commit suicide after achieving his goal?

It made no sense.

"Aryandor succeeds in resurrecting Beatrice. He uses some power where the Saints meet their end. But, the problem was what happened after Beatrice was resurrected. Beatrice couldn't accept the situation. She couldn't accept a situation where many people had died and many more would have to die."

"So, Aryandor couldn't accept that situation?"

"Exactly. After Beatrice was resurrected, she immediately committed suicide. Aryandor couldn't bear it since the person he sacrificed everything for died right before him."

"So, that's the end of it."

"Yes, without Aryandor, the rebels are nothing. They become a group that can be dealt with by the Empire."

Hearing that, I briefly cocked my head.

"So, can't we just let Aryandor resurrect Beatrice?"

Essentially, that would bring an end to the whole situation.

The resurrection and eternal life of a person might be taboo according to the Empire, but the lives of those currently living are more important.

The moment we try to stop the rebels, the sacrifice of numerous people becomes inevitable.

So, if we temporarily open the Academy to allow Beatrice's resurrection...

"If it could be resolved that easily, Rudy wouldn't have come to this world in the first place."

"Does that mean that method won't work?"

"Yes, because this world is completely different from the one Rudy has seen."

"Of course..."

My arrival must have changed the timeline itself.

No...

Thinking about it felt a bit strange.

The reason I came here.

If such a situation were possible, there would be no reason for me to come.

When I had talked with Haruna before, she had mentioned it was a plan that started from Beatrice's time.

"This worldline is the worst of them all. It's the worldline where Beatrice dies before meeting Aryandor, and Aryandor takes on a different purpose."

I walked, recalling the story I had heard from Haruna.

After leaving the Tower with Luna, we entered a restaurant.

Luna looked both bewildered and happy, yet worried at the same time.

"Was it okay for us to leave work? Others will surely think it's strange... Then, my grades..."

It was currently the first semester of the third year at the Academy, and we were doing field training.

Our performance in the field was evaluated by the people we worked with, and that directly affected our grades.

Luna was conscious of such evaluations.

Seeing Luna like this, I smiled.

"You haven't been slacking off, so one day off should be fine."

If those people thought to ruin Luna's evaluation over this one incident, I would be ready to turn the Tower upside down.

After all the work Luna had done so far...

She had already made significant contributions to the Tower, and considering how fast she processed paperwork, it was clear she had achieved too much to count on fingers.

After all, this field training evaluation was not only important in itself but also in determining what the student would do after graduating from the Academy.

The Tower would surely not want to lose Luna.

To ruin Luna's evaluation in such a scenario?

Would Luna enter the Tower then?

Absolutely not.

For the future, the Tower would surely give Luna a good evaluation.

"Let's take a break today. It's been a while since we had some rest. Both for me and for you."

"Ehehe... It's nice to have a rest with Rudy after so long."

"I feel the same."

"But, weren't you going to explain something to me?"

There was that, too.

"It won't be a long story."

I summarized the story I had heard from Haruna briefly.

The situation we were in and what Aryandor intended to do.

I cut out the deeper details and just recited the main points.

I slowly talked about the things that had happened to me while Luna was away and what needed to happen now.

"Such things..."

Luna furrowed her brow and nodded.

Having said all that, I felt a sort of relief.

The things I knew weren't deep secrets.

But they were also not something I could share with just anyone.

I always kept such matters close to my chest.

These issues were for me to ponder on my own, and I would seek help from others only when necessary.

Even if others knew, they wouldn't be able to offer a proper solution, and their opinions might differ from mine.

However, looking at the situation now, I wondered why I had always kept to myself.

Luna simply listened and empathized.

She didn't offer a solution, just listened.

Yet, my heart felt lighter.

Just by voicing my thoughts, even without finding answers, I felt relieved.

"You've had it tough, Rudy."

Luna said, as if to comfort me.

Hearing her words, I made up my mind.

"And there's something I haven't told you yet."

"Something you haven't told me? Besides everything you've just said?"

"Yes."

Until then, only those involved in the matter like Haruna, Astina, or Aryandor knew about it.

But it was something I eventually had to share with the people around me.

"I am not Rudy Astria."

"Huh?"

Luna cocked her head.

"Not Rudy? Then... is there another Rudy? The Rudy I've been seeing and the Rudy in front of me are different people?"

"The me you've seen is indeed me, but... it's complicated to explain. Basically, the original Rudy Astria is a completely different person, and I... entered this body when I came to the Academy."

"Uh, that's complicated. So, you're saying you're not Rudy, but... the Rudy I know is the real Rudy. Then, you're the original Rudy now..."

Luna scratched her head, trying to sort it out.

Though her attempt at clarification was more confusing, she wasn't wrong.

After trying to make sense of it on her own, Luna looked at me.

"So, the Rudy I've seen and the Rudy now are the same person, right?"

"That's correct."

"Then it doesn't matter. Whatever the past Rudy was like, the Rudy I know is the Rudy now."

At Luna's words, I smiled.

It was just the kind of reaction I expected from Luna.

Even as I anticipated her reaction, a part of me was still unsure, but her expected response brought a smile to my face.

"Thank you."

"There's no need for thanks. It's just obvious."

I was truly grateful for Luna's reaction.

She might have said it was obvious, but it wasn't.

It was only obvious because it was Luna.

I really liked that about Luna.

Clap!

As I finished speaking to some extent, Luna clapped her hands as if to conclude the conversation.

"So, is that everything for today?"

I smiled at Luna's gesture.

"It looks like it."

"Then let's eat to our hearts' content! Today, we rest as much as we want!"

Luna beamed with a bright smile.

It was a smile that melted away all the fatigue accumulated over time.

"Yeah, let's enjoy ourselves to the fullest."

We weren't at some resort.

We had simply entered an ordinary restaurant and sat down for a quiet meal.

There was nothing else we had to do for the day.

We could think about tomorrow's tasks, well, tomorrow.

That alone made it a very sweet break for us.

Chapter 277: Beatrice (3)

The stronghold of the rebels.

"Daemon, is everything going as planned?"

"Aryandor."

Daemon raised his head.

He was amidst the corpses, creating new undead.

Aryandor had ordered preparations for war, and Daemon was making all the necessary preparations for this purpose.

"Is there something you need from me? Any orders?"

Daemon asked as he walked out from among the corpses.

Aryandor shook his head in response.

"I came here because I had business. And also, I found myself reminiscing about the old times."

Daemon and Aryandor did not first meet while forming the rebels.

They first met in Ephomos.

Both were orphans.

Orphans without parents, power, or anything at all—just weak and vulnerable.

Of course, back then, they didn't know much about each other.

Aryandor was just a street orphan, and Daemon survived by running errands for necromancers.

Since they lived in different environments, they only knew each other by face.

Their proper meeting was entirely coincidental.

Aryandor was being educated by Ophillius, and Daemon was captured along with the necromancers along by the Astria family.

When they had grown somewhat, they met in the marketplace.

Daemon was out on an errand, and Aryandor was wandering with Ophillius.

Upon discovering Daemon, Aryandor saved him.

More accurately, Ophillius snuck him away.

And together, they started the rebellion.

Daemon looked up at Aryandor.

"By old times, do you mean when we were in Ephomos?"

"Yes."

Aryandor and Daemon would sometimes talk about their time in Ephomos.

There was always one story that never got left out.

Aryandor would always talk about his sister.

Initially, the identity of this woman was unknown, but recently, he realized Aryandor's sister was Saint Beatrice.

He had seen the research and its results.

Daemon realized what he was trying to do upon seeing this.

And suddenly, questions began to arise.

When Aryandor first started the rebellion, Daemon thought Aryandor had two goals.

A purpose to change the world and a personal goal for himself.

Back then, he didn't know what the personal goal was, but now he had figured it out.

This revelation brought doubts about whether Aryandor would continue with the rebellion's goal.

If Aryandor's goal was not for the rebellion but for himself, what would happen?

Jeferin died, and Raven died.

One by one, those around them, who had been with them, were dying.

Certainly, sacrifices follow a cause.

If they could achieve what they wanted, such sacrifices could be endured.

But if Aryandor is only thinking of his own objectives...

Daemon quietly looked at Aryandor.

"Anyway, I came here because I have something else to tell you. I will be away for a while."

Daemon furrowed his brow in response.

"Isn't it usual for you to go? Are you planning to be away for a long time?"

"Not for long. And I'm not going anywhere far, just nearby. Just make sure no one can come near that area. In the meantime, you finish preparing for

the war."

"...Understood. But may I ask."

"Hm?"

"May I ask what you will be doing?"

Daemon knew what it was about.

Yet, he asked the question.

What exactly is Aryandor going to do?

What kind of task is he going to undertake?

To this, Aryandor replied.

"Preparation. Preparing to end all of this."

"Then, I'll go."

With Ian's words, I looked at Priscilla beside me.

"Priscilla, are you ready?"

"Yes."

Seeing their response, Ian immediately manipulated his mana.

"Teleport."

At that, I looked straight at Priscilla.

"Ugh!"

Priscilla let out a grunt, Ian's figure disappeared and immediately moved to the side.

"..."

"This time, it didn't work."

I sighed.

Currently, I am training to control space.

When Aryandor used time magic last time, I failed to block it.

I hadn't trained at all back then, so it couldn't be helped.

But, next time won't be the same.

If I meet Aryandor again, I must not fail.

To ensure that, I am training with Ian.

"Maybe we should take a break."

"Should we?"

My head was throbbing after numerous attempts.

I had forgotten over time, but using Priscilla consumes mental energy.

Now I've gotten somewhat accustomed to it, so I can control it to some extent, but that doesn't mean the mental energy consumption disappears.

Ian walked over to me as I was resting.

"You've somewhat adapted, though."

It's been three days since we started this training.

It's not like there haven't been any results during this time.

I haven't been able to completely block spatial magic, but I've managed to distort the coordinates somewhat.

As we trained, the number of successful attempts increased, but I can't be satisfied with just that.

I need to be able to block it whenever I want.

The problem isn't just distorting the spatial magic; it's how much time it will take to completely block it.

Neither Ian nor I have infinite time.

We don't know when Aryandor will make his move.

Even if we manage to block Aryandor's time magic, claiming a perfect victory would be difficult.

Aryandor will surely prepare for me as well.

Even if I can perfectly control my abilities, he will prepare to ensure victory.

I have to work twice as hard as him.

To control his time magic and to surpass his other abilities as well...

"Commander."

Astina approached the training ground where Ian and I were.

"What is it?"

"A letter from the royal family."

Astina handed the letter to Ian.

Ian opened the letter and read it slowly.

As he read, his expression grew more distorted.

"Is this all?"

"They left a message saying you should come to the palace once."

I cocked my head and asked.

"What's going on?"

"It seems the trash is starting to stir."

"Trash?"

"Who else? The rotten nobles that have festered and spoiled through and through."

"Have they made a move?"

Ian's speech when he rose to the rank of Duke.

He said that regardless of the faction or position, if someone has the ability, they would be placed in a high position.

And if they lack ability, they would be demoted from their current position.

Ian was talking about those individuals.

But was there a need for such an expression?

It was expected that the nobles would rebel.

"After all, we expected this, didn't we? Just let it be..."

"The problem is, these guys are trying to join the rebels."

At this, I frowned just like Ian.

"...Rebels?"

"There have already been signs of traitors moving. It looks like others are trying to join them too."

I already knew there were domains that had joined the rebels.

The domains closer to the center were dealt with by the Royal army or the original forces, but those on the outskirts of the empire had not been sorted out.

It could be seen as a bad situation.

The individuals inside were plotting to betray.

However, discovering this now was rather fortunate.

An internal enemy is always more dangerous than an external one.

Before fighting the rebels, it's necessary to sort these guys out.

"I should start moving soon. Rudy, what will you do?"

Ian would be away dealing with these individuals.

Without him, I couldn't train in spatial magic, so I had to cultivate other abilities.

I looked at Astina, who was beside Ian.

"Are you going with him, Astina?"

To this, Astina shook her head.

"I will likely be managing the Royal army."

"So, you'll be staying?"

Astina chuckled lightly.

"Are you asking to spar?"

Astina wasn't just playing around with the Royal army.

In fact, her abilities had likely improved even more than before.

I smiled and rolled up my sleeves.

Now that I can handle spatial magic and Astina has grown, the dynamics of the fight have changed.

It had been a while since my last duel with Astina, so I was somewhat looking forward to it.

"Then..."

Contrary to my expectations, Astina extended her hand as if to tell me to stop.

"Now is not the time."

"What?"

"What are you, a brawler? Just jumping straight into a spar."

I wore a puzzled expression at Astina's words.

Ian casually picked up his things and stood up from his spot.

"Anyway, you two talk it out. I'll head off first."

"Ah... Yes. Please go ahead."

I briefly greeted Ian and then turned my attention back to Astina.

"Do you have something to do?"

"No, my work is almost done. What's left is mostly minor tasks."

"So..."

Astina looked at me with a kind smile.

"Do you think we can have a duel in such a cramped place?"

"...Where is this?"

I looked around with a confused gaze.

It was a place I had never seen before.

All I could see were trees and stones, and since we flew here with Astina's magic, it was hard to guess the location.

"It's just a mountain near the empire."

Astina, who had finished preparing, was walking towards me.

I was surprised by the sudden change in Astina's outfit.

"...Did you change here?"

Astina narrowed her eyes and looked at me.

"It's clothes I was wearing underneath. What are you thinking?"

"You were wearing that underneath?"

Astina was now dressed in a plain tee and short shorts.

Shorts...

She had been wearing a skirt until just now, which meant those were undergarments.

If you didn't know any better, you'd think they were just ordinary short pants, but knowing they were undergarments...

I suddenly felt embarrassed.

"...What are you staring at!"

"Oh, no, it's nothing."

I hastily put on an awkward expression and coughed.

"Anyway, a place like this should allow us to fight properly."

The sky was open, and there was nobody around.

Even if we used our full power, there was no risk of damaging nearby objects or hurting anyone.

"Can we go all out?"

"Would I have brought us here if I intended to take it easy?"

"If you get hurt, it's not my fault."

"Worry about yourself."

Astina and I smiled and began to manipulate our mana.

Chapter 278: Beatrice (4)

Astina moved as soon as she finished speaking.

Mana swirled around her, and I furrowed my brow.

"Rudy, let's give it a shot," Astina said with a smile.

"Gravity Field."

A strong gravity field emerged around us.

Not only the leaves attached to the trees but also the thin branches fell to the ground.

I felt the gravity on my body as well.

My body became heavier, and my legs wouldn't move.

The force was incomparable to when we had sparred before.

I felt the weight and thought to myself.

She wasn't planning on going easy.

Then, I didn't need to go easy either.

Not that I was planning on going easy anyway.

"Behemoth, Priscilla."

"Whoosh!"

"Huh?"

I summoned both of them right away.

They represented my full power.

Priscilla looked at me with confused eyes.

"What are you trying to do..."

"It's like a game. Just go with it."

I stomped on the ground.

Even though Astina's magic was holding me, moving quickly wasn't a problem.

Astina stretched her hand towards me as I ran towards her.

"Reverse."

Then, my body floated up.

Gravity worked in reverse.

Suddenly, I was flying into the air, and Astina moved her mana again.

The ground behind Astina split.

The ground shattered, and rocks flew towards me.

"Behemoth."

I used Behemoth in response.

Rocks were nothing to me.

With Behemoth, I could manipulate rocks, dirt, and even metal as I wished.

"Whoosh!"

The rocks flying towards me disintegrated with the sound of Behemoth.

"Priscilla."

At the same time, I called Priscilla's name.

Priscilla created ice in the air towards me.

The ice appeared like a step near my feet, and I kicked off of it.

Astina was slightly startled by my movement but quickly grasped the situation and used magic.

She flew into the air to avoid me.

I wasn't going to miss this opportunity.

Priscilla immediately created a platform under my feet, and I kicked off of it, changing direction.

I jumped towards Astina, who had risen into the sky.

"Rudy,"

Astina, seeing me flying towards her, smiled.

"I wasn't just playing around."

Astina clenched her fist.

Then, a black dot appeared behind me.

"Huh?"

My body, heading towards Astina, was drawn towards that dot.

Pressure was applied to my body.

It wasn't just me feeling it.

The dirt on the ground, trees, rocks.

Everything was drawn towards that dot.

I tried to escape, but escaping wasn't my first priority.

Since all the objects around were being pulled towards that point, I had to block the ones coming towards me.

"Behemoth! Priscilla!"

Behemoth disintegrated the stones coming towards me, and Priscilla blocked in front of me with ice.

"Ugh..."

I could block the flying stones, but not all of them.

A branch pierced through Priscilla's ice, scratching my body, and the dirt created from the disintegrated stones obscured my vision.

I couldn't just keep taking hits like this.

"Teleport."

I used spatial magic to try to get out of the area.

"Huh?"

But I couldn't fully escape.

I tried to get completely out of the black object's range, but I ended up in a strange place.

What the hell happened?

The black object pulled me in again.

Confused, I felt my body being drawn in.

Astina smiled and continued her attack.

"Ignition."

A very basic spell.

Yet, a huge flame was created.

Astina didn't need to send that spell flying.

The black object pulled the flame towards it.

My body and Astina's ignition spell both headed towards the black star.

It was clear that Astina's spell would collide with me.

Seeing this, Astina spoke.

"Is that all?"

Her tone was taunting.

Yet, I wasn't angry.

That was her way of telling me to give it my all.

Her taunt was actually her way of saying it was okay to attack her.

She was being considerate.

"Phew..."

Because this was a spar, I had been holding back a bit.

Even if I tried to fight with all my might, my subconscious held me back.

We could seriously hurt each other if we weren't careful.

Motivated by Astina's words, I decided to go for it.

"Spatial Severance."

I cast a spell on the incoming flame.

The space split, and the gap swallowed the flame.

It missed again.

I accurately targeted the flame with Spatial Severance.

Yet, it slightly missed.

Luckily, the flame disappeared, but it wasn't good.

I had to figure it out.

Why was this happening?

Just now, even trying to escape with spatial magic, the destination was odd.

And this spell didn't work exactly as intended either.

I focused.

I observed the surroundings.

Thinking about why this happened and how to deal with it.

The only thing that changed between then and now was the black object pulling me in.

How could it affect the spatial domain? An ordinary person can't influence spatial magic.

So...

"Coordinates..."

The anomaly wasn't in the spatial domain.

It occurred in the coordinates of the real domain.

I had seen Professor McGuire's magical device before.

A device that causes coordinate confusion in the opponent, preventing them from using magic correctly.

That black object seemed to be causing such a phenomenon.

I had heard that strong gravity can warp space, but I wondered if gravity of that level could also do so.

One thing was clear, regardless.

That black object was causing confusion in the coordinates.

Couldn't it be destroyed?

Eliminating it would be the best situation.

I glanced at Astina and took a deep breath.

"Priscilla."

Reading my thoughts, Priscilla created ice near me.

This ice wasn't for blocking attacks.

Ice was created in the direction of the black object.

I kicked off this ice to create distance between the object and myself.

"Ignition. Wind Blaster."

Noticing something odd, Astina used magic towards me.

Flames created by Ignition rode the wind towards me.

The gravity created by the black object accelerated it.

I glanced at the attack and clenched my fist.

I aimed.

The attack, the black object, and even Astina were aligned in a straight line.

Mana gathered in my fist.

And I pulled back my fist.

"Haaah!"

Exhaling a shout, I thrust my fist forward.

Boom!!!

The mana in my fist exploded, sweeping objects in its path.

"Uh..."

Astina's eyes widened.

She had grown a lot, but so had I.

My mana had increased since before, and I handled it more comfortably.

Astina had not seen an attack of this scale.

Unanticipated by Astina, she was swept away by the storm of mana.

In that situation, I saw the black object.

Crack...

The black object couldn't withstand the storm of mana.

Simultaneously, I rushed forward.

"Ugh... Gravi..."

"Too late."

I pulled back my fist.

And thrust it again.

Astina's eyes widened.

"Again...?"

Not only had Astina not seen an attack of this scale.

She didn't know I could use it multiple times.

Another storm of mana burst from my fist.

And swept around Astina.

"Will you continue?"

"...Seeing the state of things, you're asking if we should continue?"

Astina pointed to the surroundings in disarray.

I scratched my cheek and laughed awkwardly.

"Ha ha..."

After my attack, there was an explosion on Astina's side.

Still, Astina wasn't seriously injured.

It was thanks to her magic blocking my attack simultaneously.

The problem was what followed.

When Astina blocked the attack, she reversed her own gravity to push the attack away.

This time was no different.

Astina couldn't push away all the attacks, but she managed to push away most of them.

This is where the problems began.

The mana storm I created was pushed away and fell below.

The surroundings were a mess... no, they were utterly devastated.

As a result, we had no choice but to stop fighting.

"About this place... Is it okay to just use it like this?"

"There couldn't possibly be land near the capital that you can just use however you want..."

I looked around.

Certainly, when we arrived, the area was lush with trees, but now all the trees were destroyed.

Moreover, the ground was dug up and turned lumpy.

"But, I thought this land didn't matter, isn't that why we came here?"

"I didn't know you could use such techniques; that's why we came."

"Ah..."

Cold sweat ran down my forehead.

"Then... Shouldn't we do something about it? We can't just leave it like this and run away..."

There are few in the empire who could wreak such havoc on a mountain.

There's no one else who could create the appearance of a storm having swept through, not just burning or cutting down trees.

The moment the land's owner decides to reveal themselves, getting caught is only a matter of time.

So, we had to either come to an agreement or something.

"We do need to come to an agreement, but..."

"Who owns this land? Since I caused this, I should at least go and apologize..."

"No... It's largely my fault for causing this, so I'll go."

"No, it's my responsibility since I used the technique..."

"No, it's because I deflected that technique..."

After a not-quite-argument, it was decided that we would go together to meet the owner.

"But, who is the owner of this land?"

"It's owned by the Order."

The Order.

That meant a religious group that worshipped the main god, Karua.

I was surprised by this unexpected revelation.

"If it's the Order's land... Why did we suddenly come here..."

I've heard countless times that the Order was corrupt.

People in the magical academic circles always thought poorly of the Order, seizing any opportunity to criticize them.

And I've heard it numerous times from Haruna, so in my mind, the Order was marked as a corrupt organization.

"Ah, don't worry. That person is quite decent. They're also associated with the family."

"Family?"

Though I had many questions, I followed Astina to the Order for now.

Chapter 279: Beatrice (5)

"Here."

The place Astina and I arrived at was a temple in the capital.

The temple, adorned with white marble, was beautiful, and its appearance under the sunlight was sublime.

If I hadn't known about the clergy, I would have exclaimed in admiration.

However, now I thought about how much money had been spent to build this building.

How much money must those religious groups have to build such a temple?

From the architectural style to the location of the land, it was evident a lot of money had been splurged.

"Let's go in."

I followed Astina into the temple.

As we entered, a priest greeted us.

"Hello. What brings you here?"

"We've come to see a high priest."

Astina had a brief conversation with the priest, and I stepped back to look up at the ceiling.

Angels descending from the sky and humans welcoming them.

And a woman standing at the forefront.

She was a sacrifice presented before the angels.

What does this mean...

Just a decoration carved out?

"Rudy."

Astina, having finished her conversation, walked over to me.

"Did it go well?"

"Yeah, he's inside. Let's go in."

I followed Astina into the room.

Inside, an old man was sitting.

His face was deeply wrinkled, and he looked so old that he moved with difficulty.

"High Priest Johann, how are you?"

"Astina, it's been a long time. How is your father?"

The grandfather greeted Astina with a kind smile.

Despite his age, he had a gentlemanly appearance.

"Yes, he's doing well in the fief."

"That's good to hear. May Karua's blessing be upon you. But what brings you here, Miss Astina?"

"Oh, I came to talk about that land you mentioned last time."

Astina spoke to High Priest Johann about the incident we caused.

High Priest Johann was taken aback but soon let out a resigned laugh.

"Ah... Training can lead to such outcomes... Now, the aftermath is the problem."

"I will take care of it with my family. It's my responsibility since I caused it."

"No. I'm the one who said you could train on that land, so this old man will take responsibility. Ah..."

"I'm sorry."

"No need. It must be Karua's will. But, who is this behind you?"

High Priest Johann pointed at me standing behind Astina.

"Hello. My name is Rudy Astria."

"Oh, Rudy Astria? Are you...?"

High Priest Johann looked at me with wide eyes.

Then, he carefully opened his mouth.

"Are you the Rudy Astria of the Astria family I know of?"

"Yes, that's correct."

"I see..."

High Priest Johann licked his lips.

I tilted my head, wondering if there was something going on.

"Do you have something to say?"

"No, it's just fascinating to meet someone I've only heard about in stories. Ahaha."

It didn't seem like that was all...

"How do you know the clergy, Astina?"

I had never heard that Astina was a follower.

Nor had I seen her praying alone.

If anything, Astina didn't seem to like the clergy much.

Always believing in her own power and living in reality, it was unlikely for someone who is a wizard to favor an invisible god.

In response to my question, Astina smiled and answered.

"Our fief has some connections with the temple."

"Connections?"

"You know our fief is a commercial city, right?"

"Yes, I know that..."

"Because there are a lot of people coming and going, many of them follow religions. So, our fief and the temple have developed a sort of connection."

Her words meant the connection wasn't because Astina or her father were followers, but more of a political reason.

"So, you got to know High Priest Johann through such reasons?"

"Something like that. He's a good person, unlike other clergy members, so we got to know each other better."

It felt almost like insulting the clergy in front of one, which was a bit embarrassing.

I glanced at High Priest Johann.

"Ahaha, it's okay. Even within the clergy, there can be those who are lacking."

"Regardless, High Priest Johann has helped a lot in expanding our territory. He even helped to establish a small school for nurturing talents and facilities like orphanages, all at his own expense. Back then, we were just a small fief unable to offer any compensation."

"Ahaha, I only did what Beatrice commanded. Any thanks should be directed to Beatrice."

Beatrice?

My eyes widened.

The saint of the previous generation and the one who summoned me.

I had heard stories about that person, but aside from Haruna, I had never met anyone who actually knew her.

And Haruna didn't speak much about her, only in a business-like manner, as if discussing history.

Curious, I asked.

"Do you know much about her?"

"Eh? Are you talking about Beatrice?"

"Yes, I'm quite curious about her."

"If you're curious..."

"It's about who she was. I'm quite interested in her."

I knew somewhat about Beatrice's death.

Her sudden disappearance and the emergence of the next saint, Haruna, had been discussed at the academy.

I couldn't say I knew much about her life.

Since people weren't interested in the clergy, they also didn't know much about the movements of the saints.

Upon hearing my words, High Priest Johann displayed a somewhat sad smile.

"Do you understand what the position of a saint really entails, Rudy?"

A saint is supposed to represent the clergy and be a girl who has received God's will.

Technically, it means someone like Haruna, who inherited dimensional magic.

But I didn't answer directly, instead throwing the question back somewhat to gauge his thoughts.

"A saint is someone who has received the greatest blessing from God, isn't it?"

That's how the clergy described saints.

However, High Priest Johann shook his head.

"A saint is someone who has received a curse from God."

"Excuse me?"

A curse?

"You know that a saint can see the future, right?"

"Yes, I'm aware of that much..."

"Some might see the ability to foresee the future as a blessing, but seeing the future is no different from a curse."

"So, are you saying God cursed the saints?"

"What may be a gift of goodwill to some may also be a curse to others. If truly it was a blessing bestowed by God, then He should have also given the saints the power to change that future."

High Priest Johann said this and then looked up at the ceiling.

"Beatrice did her best to struggle against such a curse. She tried to use the future she saw to prevent even the smallest sacrifices. But not all events in the world can be stopped. That's why she spent many nights in tears, blaming herself for not being able to prevent what she foresaw..."

High Priest Johann said this and then laughed hollowly.

"For some, seeing the future might be a blessing. But for some... at least for Beatrice, it was a curse."

One cannot control all futures.

We can only choose our futures.

Saving one might lead to the deaths of many, and saving many might require the sacrifice of an individual.

If there was a choice where no one dies, that would be ideal, but the world isn't so accommodating.

"The future is not something that humans can handle. Knowing the future, whether you conform to it or try to overcome it, both are incorrect."

Knowing this, Beatrice still tried to overcome it.

To conform to the future or to try to overcome it, both are wrong...

"Rather than explaining in detail about Beatrice, it's best to describe her as 'one who tried to overcome.' She tried to overcome everything. The past, the present, and the future. Ahaha, the position of a saint is truly a painful one. Truly..."

One who tried to overcome.

That remark implied a failure to overcome.

"Thank you for the wise words."

I was left pondering.

"Ah, don't mention it."

Did Beatrice truly fail?

Did she ultimately conform to the future?

Was she unable to overcome it?

"Rudy, let's head back."

"Understood."

I didn't dwell on it further.

Or rather, even if I did, I couldn't have found an answer.

This answer...

I had to create it myself.

After Astina and Rudy left, High Priest Johann remained alone in the room.

'High Priest Johann, please take good care of Haruna.'

He recalled what Beatrice had said.

That little girl had entrusted him with an even smaller girl.

Johann had interfered with the search for Haruna in the temple.

So that Haruna could escape.

To prevent her from being caught by the temple.

And to keep her hidden from others.

Johann himself could no longer find Haruna.

He thought it was for the best.

"What power does this old man have..."

Johann knew there was a connection between Rudy and Haruna.

Yet, he did not ask about Haruna.

He simply wanted to offer help to Haruna through that boy.

'There are things that those who cannot see the future can do.'

Believing that his intention was understood.

He looked towards the place Rudy had disappeared.

Chapter 280: Completion (1)

"Heh, have you been well?"

"Yes... Nothing much has happened."

"Heh, that's good to hear."

"Prepare a cup of tea for Master Franz."

"Ah, got it."

Franz, the Empire's head Wizard and owner of the Magic Tower, visited the Astria residence.

"What brings you here?"

"Heh, do we need a reason to see each other?"

I frowned at Franz's remark.

Surely, the position of the Empire's head Wizard is too busy for idle visits.

Why would he come without any reason?

More importantly, what is our relationship, to begin with?

No matter how I thought about it, Franz and I weren't particularly close.

"How's your magic training going?"

"Yes, I've actually found something to train on."

After sparring with Astina, I pondered.

I was definitely superior in terms of abilities.

But that didn't mean there was nothing I could learn from Astina.

A new ability.

Astina polished a new ability.

This new ability allowed for considering various scenarios in combat.

The opponent had to think of multiple counters, giving the user the upper hand in attack choices.

This made me realize the need for a new ability.

I slowly thought it through.

Just dealing with spatial magic and fist-fighting seemed lacking.

What came to mind was the dark magic I had been neglecting lately.

Robert is gone now.

There's no teacher for dark magic, but his documents remained.

Thus, I began studying from the materials Robert had left.

Though many were difficult to understand, I researched on my own.

"Dark magic... It's a challenging path, but being Robert's disciple, I believe you'll do well."

"Thank you."

"Young master Rudy, I've brought the tea."

"Ah, thank you."

I brought the tea the maid had served to my lips.

Franz tasted the tea and quietly opened his mouth.

"The tea tastes good."

"It's nothing special."

"Heh, perhaps it tastes better because of the company?"

What the hell did he eat to say that?

Is it senility because of his age?

Why has he been acting like this since the last time?

I didn't voice those thoughts.

I just cursed him with my eyes.

Franz, noticing the look in my eyes, cleared his throat.

"Cough cough, so you've been researching on your own lately?"

"Yes, looks like I've reached the point where I need to study alone."

"Heh, you might not need a teacher anymore, but having someone to assist in research could be beneficial."

"I don't think I particularly need it."

Of course, having help would be nice.

That's why professors at the academy have assistants, after all.

But, what I'm doing is closer to training than researching.

Creating something new wasn't the goal; it was about interpreting and mastering existing materials.

Do I really need someone's help for that?

"Heh, you don't know what you're missing."

"Excuse me?"

"If you were just learning techniques, it might not mean much, but to properly apply those techniques in combat and use them alongside your existing skills, you'll need support from others."

Applying techniques in combat.

That means training is necessary.

Having someone to spar with would definitely make it easier.

Incorporating my spatial magic, Priscilla, and close combat into it...

Having someone to assist with all that would surely be beneficial.

"But it's not like I can just receive help from anyone. And who would help..."

The people around me are busy with their own affairs.

At least, those in the capital are.

Then, an idea struck me.

"I know someone who can be of help!"

Thump!

"What?"

Franz jumped up, eyes wide.

I looked at Franz, bewildered.

"Is something wrong?"

Franz cleared his throat and sat back down.

"Ah, no. The person who can help you..."

"There's a guy at the academy just killing time. He could be of help."

"Cough cough. So, a student?"

"Yes, a student, but a capable one at that."

"Ah, so just one person."

I tilted my head.

What does he want?

"That's for a sparring partner. You'll also need people to collaborate with in research. And a place for training."

"...Hmm. You're right."

Currently, I can research at the Astria residence in the capital, but there's no proper place for training.

Haven't they seen me demolish a mountain with my abilities?

Most places can't handle the full extent of my power.

Franz smiled at this.

"How about coming to our Magic Tower?"

"...The Magic Tower?"

Hearing that, I understood Franz's intention.

Is he trying to lure me to the Magic Tower?

"If it's the Magic Tower, we can fully support you. We can provide a proper training facility. Plus, Luna is there too. Being together, you could compete and enhance each other's abilities."

Franz laughed happily.

At that, I lifted the corners of my mouth.

"So, you're saying I could just borrow the facilities?"

"Heh... I really wish I could, but that would mean I'm giving someone special treatment."

"Then?"

"You could join the Magic Tower temporarily. Ha! Now that I think about it, I've brought a contract related to that."

It felt awkward.

Franz had clearly come prepared to lure me in.

"How about becoming a temporary member of the Magic Tower? Since you're not affiliated with any place, there shouldn't be a problem."

Franz pushed the contract towards me.

I smiled and pushed the contract back towards Franz.

"Aren't I still affiliated with the academy? And wouldn't the academy provide a training space if asked?"

"Oh, you plan to go to the academy for training? Once the second semester starts, you'd naturally return there, but shouldn't you enjoy the freedom while you can?"

"Being part of the Magic Tower wouldn't exactly mean being free, would it?"

It was clear he intended to abduct me into the Magic Tower.

I had heard about such cases at the academy.

Some magic groups shove contracts at academy students and bind them in what's essentially slave agreements.

Due to the lack of social experience, many students end up in unfavorable contracts.

Usually, it's the smaller groups that engage in such practices.

You'd think a place like the Royal Magic Tower wouldn't engage in unfair contracts, but for me, even a standard contract was essentially a trap.

Capable of using spatial magic.

Recognized by the royal family.

Son of the Astria family.

Achieved significant accomplishments at the academy.

And so on.

My credentials were unmatched by anyone.

"I can offer you a certain level of autonomy. Can't I provide that much?"

Franz pushed the contract towards me again.

"Does it say that here in the contract?"

"Ah, that's not written here! Didn't I say? This contract was 'just' 'somehow' brought along. Heh."

In other words, he was planning to take advantage of me.

"Then write it down first. Sign it too."

Franz's smile widened.

"Right, right. It should be written down."

Franz pulled the contract towards him and picked up a pen.

Before he could write anything, I spoke up.

"Write it like this. Won't pass off strange research. Will respect personal research. Will provide special rights that no one can infringe upon."

"...What?"

That meant I wouldn't work for the Magic Tower's interests.

I would do the research I wanted, come in when I felt like it, and no one could bother me about what I did.

"Don't like it?"

This would be the kind of contract I'd be happy with.

"Cough cough cough."

Franz hesitated with his pen for a moment.

I looked at the pen and stood up from my seat.

"If you don't like it, there's nothing I can do. Then I'll be going..."

"Where do you think you're going?"

"Didn't I say? I'm going to the academy."

At this moment, I am the superior party, and the Magic Tower is the inferior.

Whatever happens, I have the upper hand.

"Ah, fine. I'll write it."

"Ah, and also provide a personal research lab."

"A personal research lab...?"

"Also... could you hand me the contract for a moment?"

I pulled the contract towards me from in front of Franz.

And then, I flipped the page.

"Increase my salary by about four times, and as I just mentioned, remove this attendance rule. A contract duration of 10 years? That's downright scoundrelly. Let's make it 3 years."

"Ah... Ah..."

Franz was at a loss for words at my statement.

I modified the contract myself.

After making all the changes, I passed the contract back to Franz.

Franz was aghast as he looked over the revised contract.

"You want all of this?"

I nodded and smiled brightly.

"Don't like it?"

"No, it's not that..."

If he didn't like it, too bad.

Franz was the one at a disadvantage.

With trembling hands, Franz tried to sign the contract.

As he was about to sign, he looked up at me.

I smiled with my eyes, watching Franz.

"Is there a problem?"

Hesitating, Franz carefully began to speak.

"Could we add just one clause to the contract?"

"I'll listen and then decide."

"..."

"Please, speak."

"Could you make it so that it looks like you approached me for this contract... like you were the one who asked me..."

Franz wanted to save face.

"Is this the place?"

A man walked towards the Magic Tower.

He was sure the letter had directed him here, but he wondered if this was the right place.

Why would he be here?

Despite his questions, the man approached the vicinity of the Magic Tower.

"Please stop for a moment. What's your business here?"

A guard at the Magic Tower questioned the man.

"Good day. I have this..."

The man then pulled out a letter from his pocket.

The letter was from Rudy Astria.

"Ah, a letter from young master Rudy. You may enter. Young master Rudy is waiting for you in Room 202, his personal research lab."

"Personal research lab?"

To get a personal research lab in the Magic Tower, one had to climb to a high rank.

One would typically need to be in their 30s or 40s to even consider getting a personal lab.

It was baffling to hear that Rudy had not only joined the Magic Tower but also acquired a personal research lab without any prior notice.

The man nodded and entered the Magic Tower.

Inside, lavish decorations greeted him.

He made an awkward expression and climbed the stairs.

"Room 202..."

Upon reaching Room 202, as the guard had mentioned, there was a large sign posted.

'Rudy Astria, Senior Researcher.'

It wasn't just a borrowed personal lab; it was indeed his own.

Just a few weeks ago, he had heard that Rudy had renounced his heir position, yet now he was in the position of a Senior Researcher.

Being a Senior Researcher meant a position that required immense effort to attain... a position like a fantasy for wizards.

At that level, it wasn't just a path to success; it was as if he had already achieved it.

The man opened the door with a bewildered expression.

"Oh, Evan. You're here?"

The man was Evan.

Evan, who had been training in magic alone at the academy.

Rudy had predicted Evan would have nothing to do and called him here.

"...What on earth have you been up to?"

"Let's explain that slowly, but you're not busy, right?"

"Well, I guess not."

"Then sign this."

Rudy handed a paper to Evan.

"What's this?"

"It's a contract that temporarily affiliates you with the Magic Tower. If you sign, you can freely come and go as you please within the Magic Tower."

Evan looked incredulously between the contract and Rudy.

"And what am I supposed to do after signing this?"

"Nothing much."

Rudy stood up, stretching his shoulders.

"Time to train."

Chapter 281: Completion (2)

"What is all this?"

Evan's eyes widened as he looked at the materials laid out in front of him.

I laughed at his reaction.

"These are the materials I'm going to study."

Specifically, they were related to dark magic.

The materials were piled up like a mountain.

"Then why did you call me here?"

"I told you. It's for training."

I had no intention of getting Evan's help in learning dark magic.

After all, Evan knew nothing about dark magic.

Trying to help would only make him a burden.

What Evan was needed for was practical training.

"I'll learn the magic on my own, so just spar with me."

A sparring partner.

That was Evan's role.

With everyone around me busy with other tasks, I needed someone to spar with, and Evan immediately came to mind.

He was idle at the moment, and considering his skills, he was a fitting choice.

"So, what am I supposed to do while you're learning magic?"

I tapped the contract Evan had signed.

"You should've read the contents carefully before signing."

"What? That was to allow entry to the Magic Tower..."

"Did you think that was all? With the paper being this thick?"

Evan's eyes widened as he looked at the contract.

He had signed it without giving it much thought.

"Even if it's a paper handed to you by someone you know, you should still read it carefully."

"You...!"

I burst into laughter at Evan's surprise.

"Don't worry. I didn't do anything strange."

I handed the contract back to Evan.

He slowly went through the content.

The conditions were fairly good.

"It just states that you're a temporary researcher. You can use the Magic Tower's resources as long as you share your research findings. You retain the ownership of the research itself, so you don't have to worry about sharing."

"Hmm..."

Evan skimmed through the contract before setting it down on the desk.

"...Aren't you going to read more?"

There was still much to discuss.

Like the salary... and benefits...

I had taken great care to include many details.

As a senior researcher, I had exerted all the power I could muster to create these terms.

Instead of backstabbing such a foolish person, I had taken great care of him.

Yet.

To just toss aside my brilliant work like that?

"I'll assume you took care of everything well."

"Hmm..."

Maybe I should've added some strange clauses to the contract.

Hearing that made me somewhat want to smack him on the back of his head.

"So, I just stay here and spar with you, then?"

"Exactly."

I sighed and nodded to Evan's question.

The work discussion had to come first.

"How long?"

"A month."

"A month, huh... What happens after that?"

"Oh, there's something."

After a month, there would be an event.

There was a fittingly sized event at the Academy.

A day when many seniors return to the Academy.

And the day the saint comes to the Academy.

"There's Homecoming Day."

'The Academy is the place where saints meet their end, the 'home' of the saints.'

Homecoming Day wasn't a term created with seniors in mind.

It was the day saints return to their home.

That was the essence of the Academy's Homecoming Day.

'The rebels will act then.'

I didn't fully understand Aryandor's objective.

I knew they would act then, but I didn't know how.

Yet, I planned to go to the Academy.

It was where Haruna, Aryandor's biggest headache, would be.

And where his sister, Beatrice, lay sleeping.

It was the place Aryandor would come to, according to the future Haruna had seen.

Honestly, I wanted the most capable in the Empire and its soldiers to protect the Academy.

But that wasn't possible.

If we did that, Aryandor would change direction and target the Capital.

There's no need to target the Academy first.

The fall of the Capital would be a greater loss for us.

Therefore, we must prepare.

We had to create a force capable of not losing to Aryandor.

Move the maximum amount of troops we could.

To achieve victory over Aryandor.

"Got it. I'll keep that in mind."

Having heard all I had to say, Evan was about to leave the room.

"Where are you going?"

"You told me to study my magic while you're learning yours."

"Ah, right. But."

I stood up and lifted the corners of my mouth.

"Come to think of it, I had something to entrust to you."

At that, Evan tilted his head in confusion.

"...A task?"

"Yes, there's something urgent..."

Everything I had said today was the truth, but this last statement was a lie.

It was revenge for him casually tossing aside the carefully crafted contract.

Evan was now in the place where Ian, the commander of the Royal forces, was staying.

The task Rudy had given him was to deliver a letter to Ian.

Though it seemed like a minor annoyance and an easy task, it was anything but simple.

It was impossible to enter through the main gate, and entrusting the letter to someone else felt too risky.

Therefore, Evan decided to infiltrate the Royal forces himself.

Reaching the place where the commander of the Royal forces stayed was no easy feat.

The security of the Royal forces was extremely tight, and Evan had to go through a lot of trouble to reach Ian.

After all the trouble to get to Ian...

"Rudy Astria sent you?"

"...Yes."

Evan, out of breath and weary, looked at Ian in front of him.

"Why would someone who can use spatial magic send you?"

"Spatial magic?"

Ian briefly skimmed through the letter before tossing it into the trash can.

"Just tell him I got it."

Evan looked at Ian with an incredulous expression.

"...Is that all?"

"What else...?"

Hearing that response, Evan let out a deep sigh.

"Understood... Then."

Evan turned to leave.

That's when Ian spoke up again.

"Oh, and."

Evan turned back to see Ian smirking mischievously.

"Rudy asked me to ask you if you thought it was a nice, real world experience?"

"Real world experience..."

Big brother and the little brother...

Evan cursed inwardly.

"Then I'll really be going now..."

"Ah, don't bother sneaking out. Just walk out through the main gate. I'll tell the soldiers."

"..."

"There's no need to get the same experience twice, right?"

Thus, Evan was able to leave with the soldiers' kind guidance.

"Ah..."

A rundown neighborhood.

Children were gathered, and there were only a few priests around as adults.

"Hey!!! Be careful!!!"

Thud!

Suddenly, a girl running tumbled to the ground.

A young child standing there looked at her, puzzled.

"...Saint?"

The girl called a saint quickly got up.

"Are you hurt? Let me see!"

"You seem to be the one who's hurt, Saint."

The child looked at the knee of the girl called a saint.

Blood was streaming down her knee.

Yet, the girl paid no mind to her knee.

She was only concerned about the child in front of her.

"I'm fine! But you, are you hurt anywhere?"

"No..."

"Phew... That's a relief."

A girl quietly watching the scene was Haruna.

"...Is this a dream?"

Haruna looked at the girl being called a saint.

That girl was the saint, Beatrice, who had already died.

"How many years ago was this..."

It seemed like more than ten years had passed.

It was only a minor knee scrape...

But now, seeing this scene in a dream, Beatrice's knee was quite badly scraped.

Yet, Beatrice was smiling brightly.

Always thinking of others before herself, that person was Saint Beatrice.

Such a foolish person she was.

As the scene ended, it swiftly changed.

Beatrice was standing in front of Haruna with sad eyes.

"Haruna, a saint is a guide. Watching over the world to ensure it follows the right path, and occasionally guiding it."

"Being a guide is a dangerous position. Sometimes you have to bear responsibility."

"But, when the world is on the right path, when people have reached the correct place. The sense of achievement, the joy at that moment, is truly indescribable."

"Haruna, I hope you too will feel this joy someday."

With those words, the dream ended.

Haruna opened her eyes and got up from the bed.

"A guide..."

To Haruna, Beatrice was as good as a mother.

Haruna was born in a rural village and grew up in a less than favorable family environment.

Her father was always violent, and her mother paid no attention to Haruna.

It was Beatrice who saved her from such circumstances.

Beatrice always took care of young Haruna and taught her how to survive in this Empire.

Haruna learned from Beatrice how to survive as a saint and learned dimensional magic.

The day she learned dimensional magic, the first future Haruna saw was the end of the world.

Aryandor was destroying the Empire, killing everyone, and bringing about the apocalypse.

Shocked, Haruna asked Beatrice about this future.

"You've found out, after all..."

At that moment, Beatrice looked sad.

Her eyes were more sorrowful than ever before.

"You don't need to worry. I will... I will try to change it somehow. Somehow..."

However, Beatrice couldn't resolve it.

Despite sacrificing everything, she couldn't make a change.

"I'm sorry... I've passed the responsibility onto the remaining children..."

She spoke of responsibility, but in reality, she had sacrificed herself to create an opportunity.

In a future where there was no chance, she gave one.

This opportunity could not be missed.

It had to be seized by any means.

Haruna got out of bed.

"A guide."

Today was four days before Homecoming Day.

It was the day Haruna would head to the Academy.

Chapter 282: Completion (3)

Boom!

A large explosion occurred.

From the smoke, two people emerged.

"Ugh..."

"..."

The ones who came out of the smoke were Evan, swallowing a groan, and Rudy, wearing a smile as if he found it amusing.

As soon as Rudy burst out of the smoke, he activated his mana.

"Fog."

Then, black smoke spread around Rudy.

Evan responded in kind.

"Grow."

Suddenly, a tree, lush with leaves, grew significantly around them.

Evan hid himself inside the tree.

'Where is it?'

Evan touched the tree, focusing all his senses.

Since the smoke obscured his vision, he listened intently for any sign.

While he was concentrating, he felt a strong movement of mana from afar.

Evan drew his sword.

"Suck!"

The storm of strong mana quickly enveloped Evan, and he brought his sword to meet it.

As the mana storm touched Evan's sword, it disappeared with a bright light.

Not all of it vanished, but he was able to eliminate the mana coming directly at him.

Having blocked the attack to some extent, Evan thought about his next move.

He gathered mana into his sword.

A green aura collected around Evan's sword, and he observed the situation.

Rustle.

That's when he sensed a slight movement.

Evan immediately swung his sword in that direction.

The green mana transformed into a sword strike and flew towards it.

"Ah."

Where the sword energy flew, a wolf with silver fur was revealed.

'It's not Rudy?'

As soon as he made that judgment, a black figure appeared behind Evan.

Holding a scythe, wearing a black hood, it was a demon controlled by Rudy.

Clank, chains shot out from the black figure, binding Evan's body.

Evan struggled, trying to cut through the chains.

"Shall we continue?"

The smoke where the voice came from slowly cleared, and Rudy walked out from there.

Behind Rudy was the shape of a demon, and he had already gathered mana in his hand, ready to attack.

Evan sighed upon seeing Rudy like this.

"Let's stop."

"Okay."

Rudy smiled and waved his hand a few times.

Then, the chains binding Evan were released.

Evan, touching the area the chains had been, looked at Rudy in front of him.

"Now I can't even tell who's the demon."

"What demon."

Rudy chuckled at Evan's words.

It had been about a month since Evan and Rudy started training at the Magic Tower.

Rudy had learned the dark magic left by Robert.

Of course, Evan also underwent various forms of growth.

He delved deeper into nature magic and, with the support of the Magic Tower, explored the unique magic nullification that only he could use.

Despite these efforts, Evan couldn't surpass Rudy.

He marveled at Rudy's rapid advancement.

It had only been a month of research at the Magic Tower.

In just a month, Rudy experienced significant growth.

Not that Evan envied the stronger Rudy.

Rudy's strength was acquired at the cost of great pain.

His power stemmed not from innate talent or mere effort but from pushing his body to its limits to gain it.

The primary drawback of learning dark magic was this very process.

When a spell failed, it resulted in a curse, inflicting severe pain.

The more powerful the magic used, the more intense the pain.

Rudy practiced his magic fearlessly, oblivious to such repercussions.

Consequently, Rudy's body was severely damaged, and Evan witnessed his suffering.

Rudy honed his magic through curses and pain, heedless of the consequences.

From an outsider's perspective, it was a pitiable sight.

The silver lining, however, was Rudy's remarkable growth.

But that didn't mean he had become proficient in dark magic at an expert level.

He had only mastered about ten spells to a degree that they could be utilized in real combat.

While this might not sound impressive, when combined with other forms of magic, it significantly expanded his combat strategies.

"Let's take a break now," Rudy suggested, tossing a towel to Evan and sitting down on the floor.

Evan caught the towel and wiped the sweat from his forehead.

"Was that the last one?" Evan asked.

"Yeah. I probably won't learn any more,"

Rudy replied, having decided on the spells he needed to learn from the moment Evan arrived.

And today, he had mastered the last of them.

"So, what do we do now?" Evan asked.

"Now it's time to start moving," Rudy declared.

As he said this, Luna approached from a distance.

"Rudy!" she called out.

Rudy greeted her with a broad smile.

"Luna, you're here?"

"Yeah, have you finished training?"

"Somewhat," Rudy replied.

Luna nodded and pointed behind her.

"Ian's here," she announced.

Ian was standing there.

"The rebels have moved."

"Has the main force moved?"

"Not just the main force, but all the nobles on the outskirts of the Empire have mobilized."

"The others" referred to the nobles who had been on the outskirts of the Empire.

"So, how will the Royal army move?"

"The Royal army will split into two groups, led by me and Astina. I'll deal with the nobles on the outskirts, and Astina will handle the main force."

"So, is Astina heading towards the Academy?"

"No, she isn't."

I tilted my head in confusion.

"Didn't you say Astina would confront the main force?"

"We don't yet know where the rebels' main force will move. Astina will station near the Persia territory and follow the rebels as they move."

It wasn't a wrong approach.

We were somewhat predicting that Aryandor will head towards the Academy, but there's no solid evidence to back this up.

Even if Haruna has seen the future, there's no guarantee it will unfold exactly as seen, with most of the evidence being circumstantial at best.

"And it's not like the Academy will crumble without the Royal army, so this strategy might be better."

The Academy has many professors, and both Evan and I, among others, are planning to go there.

We have plenty of talented individuals ready to fight.

Moreover, the terrain towards the Academy from the rebel side is extremely harsh.

If they try to force their way through, they'll take significant losses.

The Academy could not only hold out against the rebels until Astina arrives but might even manage to win against them.

Of course, things rarely go as predicted.

Surely, the rebels will have some sort of plan.

But predicting those plans now was not possible.

Hence, the idea was to draw as much of the Royal forces as possible.

Having a larger force allows us to respond to unexpected moves...

But we couldn't fuss over it here.

Ian must have thought it all through already to devise this plan.

I had no choice but to nod in agreement.

"Understood. I will keep what you said in mind."

"If the Academy is in danger, I'll use spatial magic to get there if necessary. And if there's trouble at the Academy, forces from the capital will be deployed, so there shouldn't be a big problem."

"Understood. Then we'll proceed as planned."

"Right."

Ian smiled and nodded.

Then he glanced at his watch.

"It's about time to go."

Ian got up from his seat.

I looked back at Luna and Evan behind me.

"Let's go now."

"Yes!"

Ian then moved to step out first.

He paused for a moment in his steps.

Then he turned around.

"Rudy Astria."

"Yes?"

Ian looked at me intently before posing his question.

"Aryandor, can you win against him?"

I've learned a lot over this time.

I've done a lot to be able to defeat Aryandor.

So, can I beat Aryandor?

To that question, I couldn't respond with a confident win.

I've fought Aryandor several times before.

In those battles, I never clearly won once.

While the outcomes of the fights were favorable, I never won in the fights themselves.

But.

That doesn't mean.

I've ever truly lost either.

"I'm not confident in winning. But."

So, there was one thing I could be sure of.

"I'm also not confident in losing."

"Is everyone ready?"

The rebel's stronghold.

There, numerous people stood armed, and behind them stood giant golems.

But that wasn't all.

In the sky flew monsters like dragons and gargoyles, and in front were undead creatures like skeletons.

"The will of God is with us, and we will win. Those of us who win will change the world!"

It might seem absurd to talk about the will of the God surrounded by undead, but no one murmured in dissent.

Everyone here was united with a single purpose.

To change the world.

To bring down a world dominated by nobility.

Though all were united in this purpose, just one person had a different intent.

"Aryandor."

"Yes."

Aryandor stood at the very front of the people.

"Let's go."

With Aryandor's voice, the troops began to move.

Chapter 283: Completion (4)

"Ah, geez..."

Yuni, as always, let out a sigh while walking through the academy garden.

"How long has it been since school ended and yet again..."

Yuni was preparing for the Homecoming Day.

She set up various facilities and placed them in the necessary positions, checked the list of events to be held, and measured the appropriate budget for them. In addition to this, she also spent time inspecting the spaces to be used.

"At least it's smaller than other years, so I guess you should be thankful for that."

Kuhn, who was next to Yuni, scolded her for her grumbling.

At Kuhn's words, Yuni snorted.

"Thankful, my ass. That's the problem."

The reason this year's Homecoming Day was scaled down was because of the rebels' movements.

It was difficult for alumni to return to the academy, and with the professors busy preparing, the event size was significantly reduced. Originally, the event could have been canceled, but it was proceeding as usual.

"Why not just cancel it? It was canceled last year, after all."

"Last year, the rebels directly invaded, that's why."

"They could come this year too."

"That's true but..."

Kuhn couldn't argue against Yuni's words. Looking at the rebels' actions so far, they always had an obsession with the academy.

Their forces were stationed near the academy, so there was a sense of unease.

"Should we just say not to do it?"

".....Hmm."

Yuni clearly didn't want to work, but suggesting to stop didn't seem like a bad idea.

Preparing for such an event might be less important than preparing for the rebels.

But then, what was the point of stopping now?

There were only four days left until Homecoming Day.

The preparations were practically completed. Canceling the event at this point wouldn't do anything.

"Let's go talk to Vice-Principal Cromwell, at least..."

"Talk?"

At that moment, a voice came from behind them.

".....Vice-Principal?"

Behind Yuni and Kuhn, Cromwell was standing tall.

Cromwell approached them with a smile.

"Is there any problem with the event? Talk?"

"No, it's not that... But, what brings you here, Vice-Principal?"

"Can't a Vice-Principal walk around the academy?"

"That's not it but..."

"Heh, don't worry. I didn't mean anything by it. I was just checking to see if the preparations for the event were going well. Don't worry."

"Ah..."

Kuhn, hearing Cromwell's words, looked around cautiously.

He wanted to bring up the event, but standing in front of Cromwell, he couldn't decide what to say.

'Proposing to just cancel the event outright might look problematic...'

While Kuhn was thinking that,

"Vice-Principal. What about canceling the event?"

Yuni blurted out abruptly.

Kuhn, flustered, waved his hands.

"No, if you say it like that..."

Cromwell brushed off Kuhn's reaction and looked at Yuni.

"What's the matter?"

"With the possibility of war, doesn't it seem odd for us to be giggling among ourselves? Practically no one will come anyway. Wouldn't it be better to use these resources elsewhere?"

".....Yuni?"

Kuhn was taken aback by Yuni's logically structured argument.

Was it really just her aversion to work that led to this suggestion, or did she genuinely hold these beliefs?

That was unclear.

Nevertheless, what Yuni said was also what Kuhn had wanted to say.

It was a question he had subtly raised to Cromwell when the event was first announced, but Cromwell hadn't given a definitive answer.

He simply instructed to hold the event as planned.

Kuhn watched closely to see how Cromwell would respond.

"Hmm... For now, both of you follow me."

"Yes?"

"There's something I need to say about that. You'll understand if you follow."

With a puzzled look, Yuni and Kuhn hesitated but decided to follow Cromwell, hoping for an explanation.

".....Senior?"

Yuni and Kuhn's eyes widened.

The place Cromwell led them to was the vice-principal's office.

Inside, Rudy was sitting.

Rudy smiled and waved his hand.

"Have you arrived?"

"Rudy... and that person is..."

But that wasn't all.

The woman sitting next to Rudy, wearing a priestess's attire and a black eye patch, was Saint Haruna.

"Hello. Are you the current student council members?"

Haruna smiled and greeted them.

"How did this happen..."

The Saint was expected to come for Homecoming Day, but Rudy was not.

The Empire was in a tumultuous state right now.

They naturally thought Rudy would be heading to the front lines.

He was a highly regarded talent in the Empire.

With such a person at the academy, many questions arose.

"You said it, didn't you? Shouldn't we prepare for the war? We're not just fooling around. Everything we did was necessary."

"But, but. Just calling Saint Haruna and Rudy seems..."

Rudy may be strong, but preparing for war requires more than just strength.

A war needs numerous soldiers and commanders, not just a few powerful individuals.

This left Kuhn feeling that just the two of them were insufficient.

Cromwell shook his head at Kuhn's doubt.

"It's not just the two of us coming. What's the name of the event we're hosting?"

"Homecoming Day... So..."

"A lot of people will come home to the academy. What we sent to the alumni wasn't an invitation to an event but a letter asking for help."

"What? Why go through all that... You could have just called in the troops from the start."

"Moving troops always requires caution. It's much better if the other side doesn't know. Besides, preparing for the event allowed us to make several preparations. With the students gathered here, there's no need to evacuate separately, and the items we've placed can be used for protection."

Cromwell wasn't interested in the event itself.

He was just looking towards the future.

And exploiting it.

To create a more advantageous situation by making the opposition complacent.

He was preparing for that.

Then Yuni tilted her head.

"So why is the Saint here?"

"Hmm? Since it's Homecoming Day, naturally..."

"No, if we're really preparing for war, shouldn't the Saint be evacuated to a safe place? It's dangerous if she's here when they attack."

Yuni's doubt wasn't unwarranted.

Cromwell had acted under the assumption that the opposition would attack.

Then, shouldn't the Saint, who lacks combat ability, be sent to a safe place?

Haruna shook her head in response.

"I came here to do my job."

"Your job?"

"There's a place I need to protect."

"Deputy Commander."

As Astina walked along the sacred wall, she turned her head.

Behind her was a soldier.

"What's the matter?"

"It seems they're beginning to move."

"Which direction?"

"Towards the academy."

As expected, the rebels were moving towards the academy.

"Pass the message to Commander Ian, and we'll move out."

"Understood."

After speaking to the soldier, Astina headed towards the barracks.

The soldiers outside the barracks were all looking in Astina's direction.

'The beginning, then.'

Astina scanned the soldiers looking at her.

"Listen up, everyone. The rebels have moved. They're heading towards the Liberion Academy, and we're going to protect it."

"Understood!!!"

The soldiers responded with a resounding voice.

These were soldiers who had been with her for about half a year, dear to her heart.

Astina bit her lip briefly before speaking again.

".....What we're engaging in is war. The person next to you might die, and you might die too. But, it's not a meaningless death. Because you fight, the citizens of the Empire, our families, will survive. So, on their behalf, I say thank you."

Some soldiers were visibly moved by Astina's words, but most burst into laughter.

"Deputy Commander! Saying it like that makes it sound like we're already dead!"

"Deputy Commander is so meticulous yet clumsy. Why say something like that now?"

The soldiers chuckled and teased Astina.

Astina smiled at them.

In a situation where they could be tense and afraid, they were laughing.

"Alright, sorry. Then tell this inexperienced Deputy Commander what needs to be done."

"Aren't there simple words you can use? Easy words."

"Easy words?"

"Really, you're so dense."

The soldiers suggested a few words to Astina.

With a burst of laughter, Astina cleared her throat again.

"Fine. Here goes."

Astina raised her fist to the sky and shouted.

"Let's kill all those bastards! We're going home!!!!"

It was a straightforward statement.

It wasn't the kind of phrase you'd expect from the usually stern Astina.

The soldiers laughed, seeing Astina utter such refreshing words.

"Deputy Commander."

Then, a soldier approached Astina and handed her a helmet.

"Alright, let's go."

Astina mounted her horse, leading the barracks' soldiers towards the academy.

Chapter 284: Completion (5)

Kuhn, Yuni, and I followed Haruna.

And the place we arrived at was.

“...Why have we come here all of a sudden?”

A place very familiar to us.

It was the student council room.

Haruna looked at us with a smile.

“I will be here during the war.”

“What?”

“Hmm?”

I, too, tilted my head at her words.

Although I had heard that Haruna had something to protect, I was puzzled to hear that it was located in the student council room.

“What's here?”

“You won't be able to see it with your eyes.”

“Hmm?”

Haruna stretched her hand towards the ceiling.

Then, the surroundings started to ripple.

“What, what’s this?”

“This is.....”

Kuhn and Yuni widened their eyes at the sight.

This must have been their first time witnessing such a scene.

But I knew.

“...Spatial magic?”

It certainly resembled spatial magic, but it looked fundamentally different.

Something was happening in the spatial domain, but it felt different from what we were used to.

It was as if the world was turning upside down.

The rippling space gradually changed, and a place other than the student council room began to appear.

I narrowed my eyes and looked at Haruna.

“Where is this?”

“This is the Holy Land of Terasant. The place where the Saints face their end, as I mentioned.”

Surrounded by numerous jars.

So, these are.....

Haruna walked towards the jars.

“These are all the remains of Saints. They have been cremated and stored here.”

“This place...”

“It’s a location created with dimensional magic. The student council room serves as its door.”

“The student council room?”

Why the student council room of all places?

The student council room couldn’t exactly be called a safe space.

If it were truly a safe place, the vice principal's or principal's office would have been a better location.

“I also don’t know why the door is here. It was simply the will of our ancestors.”

“Ancestors?”

“Do you know how this academy was founded, Rudy?”

I wasn’t very familiar with that.

I only knew that it was an academy built in the early days of the empire.

“In the past, magic, religion, and politics were united in strength. They were equal groups. That’s why the order was so powerful, and why this academy emphasizes equality. It’s also why spatial magic is called a divine power.”

Despite differences in status, they supported each other, speaking informally and growing their abilities.

Was that the reason?

Because everyone was equal in the past?

I had no idea there was such a reason behind the aspects I hadn’t paid much attention to.

“However, as time passed, these three paths diverged, some aspects merged, and some devolved. But as I just mentioned, traces of these three being

together are still found in many places.”

Haruna stretched her hand forward.

"The traces left in this academy are right here. The place where the Saints' bodies are stored, the Holy Land of Terasant."

Thinking about it made me start to see other aspects.

“So, is that why a Saint comes every Homecoming Day?”

“Yes. Of course, they come for reasons other than predicting the future.”

“Do they come to check if this sanctuary is well?”

“Yes. It’s good to have a quick understanding.”

I recalled thoughts from past Homecoming Days.

Why a Saint comes every year to predict the future.

It was a bit strange from the start.

Why would a Saint come if they couldn't provide a proper prediction of the future?

I wondered if there was some kind of deal between the Church and the academy, but I had no idea about this past.

“Anyway, Aryandor will probably target this place. Because it also contains the remains of Lady Beatrice.”

That raised a question in me.

“But, why leave the remains here? If Aryandor comes here, wouldn’t it be to obtain those remains?”

Haruna shook her head.

“Rudy, have you not seen the power of these remains?”

“...Me?”

When did I ever.

I had no clue about such a thing.

“Remember the incident when we brought back your body from the future?”

“...Ah.”

“This place provides the best environment for a Saint to exert their abilities. It allows them to do things they normally couldn’t.”

“Why would the remains have such power...?”

“The Saints do not lose their power even in death.”

“Even in death?”

“A Saint’s body is connected to Saints in other dimensions. The basis of this connection is these remains. Based on this ability, they can see the future and the past. These remains need to be preserved so that Saints from other dimensions can see our dimension, and I can exert my proper abilities.”

The basis of dimensional magic.

That was what these remains were.

Crossing dimensions to scan the future and the past, and connecting different dimensions was this place’s role.

“We can’t just eliminate this place. We have to protect it at all costs.”

“...”

Then Yuni put a hand on my shoulder.

“Just protect it, right? Then there shouldn’t be any problem.”

Her words made me chuckle as if it was nothing significant.

Yuni was right.

We just need to prevent Aryandor from coming here.

“Yeah, we just need to protect this place. But, can Aryandor enter here?”

“Yes, this place can be entered using spatial, temporal, and dimensional magic as keys.”

I nodded and smiled.

“Got it. Then I’ll make sure he can’t even get close. That should do it, right?”

At that, Haruna smiled.

“Yes, that will do.”

I left the place Haruna had explained and headed towards where Cromwell was.

During the move, I suddenly noticed something odd.

People outside were moving in an organized manner.

I watched those people before entering the vice principal's office where Cromwell was.

“Have you returned?”

“Yes, I’ve roughly grasped the situation.”

“Good, then we should also prepare.”

“Prepare, you mean...”

“They’ve made their move.”

Was this about Aryandor moving?

And the people moving outside...

“Are we ready for war?”

“Yes, we will block them at the canyon like last time.”

The canyon that the enemy must pass through if they come from the rebel side.

Geographically, it’s an advantageous place for us.

But there was a problem.

“What about the soldiers?”

“We’ve prepared to a certain extent. But it’s still vastly insufficient.”

Last time, the Royal army was already stationed at this place.

The problem now was the lack of soldiers.

“We need to buy time until Astina arrives.”

“In an unfavorable situation?”

“Still, there’s no need to worry too much. We have many capable people, and we have a corresponding plan.”

“A plan, you mean...”

“It’s crucial not to let the enemy into the canyon. If the rebels enter the canyon now, it will be breached quickly. They will push through with their bodies using the undead.”

The canyon could maximize damage to the enemy, but it wasn't a place that could be completely blocked.

There was no wall built there, and we couldn't physically block it ourselves.

If we lured them into the canyon, we could inflict significant damage, but we couldn't fully leverage the terrain's power.

"So, you plan to stop them in front of the canyon?"

"Yes."

"But..."

Is stopping them in front of the canyon a good plan?

That was also doubtful.

Fighting a frontal battle with our limited number of soldiers was suicidal.

"Don't worry. I have prepared a separate method."

"...A method?"

"Anyway, we're moving to the canyon. I'll explain the strategy in detail later."

"Yes, understood."

A method...

"I really hate this. I truly hate it. Really, really, truly."

"Haha, if people could avoid doing things they hate, then no one would do anything."

"But why do I have to do this... There are many more capable people than me..."

A vast plain.

A daunting canyon lied behind.

And far off, a cloud of dust rises.

Despite the great distance, I could see the entities there.

An undead legion, leading with giant golems and bone dragons.

It was the rebels.

The fact that they were the enemy was truly daunting.

“This task should be for Professor Cromwell or Professor Mcguire... Not just them, there are other professors too. I’m just a first-year professor... What was Professor Cromwell thinking, assigning this to a rookie professor who’s only been here for a year...”

“Haha, he must trust you a great deal to assign you this task.”

Two people stood at a distance from that dust cloud.

The strategy planned by the academy was simple.

The strong ones block with overwhelming force.

From the academy's personnel, two were selected.

The user of electric magic, first-year Professor Gracie Lifegold.

The user of flash magic, Principal McDowell Cliver.

A combination of the academy's most senior and the youngest professor.

“War, huh... I’ve never done anything like this...”

“Everyone has a first time.”

“Have you ever done it, Principal?”

“Haha, a few times, yes.”

“What, what was it like the first time you did it...”

“It was similar to how you feel now. And when it ended, it was truly terrible. The ground was rivers of blood, and bodies piled up like mountains. I can’t even remember how many times I threw up.”

“Heeek...”

“But.”

McDowell smiled kindly.

“Thanks to that, the people behind me were able to be safe. A lot of blood was shed in that war, but I was able to protect my people.”

“...”

“Someone has to do it, right? What would happen if you got scared here and now?”

Gracie turned to look back at the canyon.

Past this canyon is the academy.

If those monsters ahead enter the canyon, then the students, the professors, and the civilians living there will all die.

“You’re a professor, aren’t you? You have to protect the students, the academy.”

“...Right.”

Gracie clenched her fist.

And then looked ahead.

The approaching army was visible.

She was scared.

Her legs were trembling, and cold sweat was running down.

The thought that she might die here today crossed her mind.

But she couldn't back down.

Because backing down would truly be the end.

"Can you do it now?"

"I have to... I'm a professor, after all."

Gracie's mana surged.

Her hair turned white, and blue lightning swirled around her.

McDowell nodded at the sight.

"Then I'll go first."

"Yes, I'll follow you."

McDowell extended his hand forward.

"Flash, beam of light."

A giant light leaked from his hand, and thus the war began.

Chapter 285: Completion (6)

The vanguard of the rebels advanced, leading with the undead.

Leading them was Venderwood.

Since both the undead and Venderwood could recover even after taking damage, they were organized as the vanguard.

As Venderwood advanced, he gradually began to see the canyon coming into view.

Venderwood glanced at it indifferently.

"We must break through here."

Both the rebels and the Academy thought the same.

At this time, whether or not the canyon could be penetrated would significantly influence the outcome.

Both camps were aware of this and had formulated their strategies.

"Advance!!"

Venderwood commanded the undead loudly.

It was then.

"Hm?"

A strong light leaked from afar.

And then.

Before Venderwood could even react to the light, it pierced through the rebel side.

Kwaaaaang!!!

The light struck precisely the middle of the undead legion, turning the undead there into dust.

Venderwood muttered to himself as he saw the vanished undead.

"A flash magic spell....."

Since he had already predicted some degree of response from the Academy, there was no reason to panic.

Venderwood looked at the situation with cold indifference.

After all, what was lost were the undead.

They knew no fear.

Even if those beside him melted away, they could still advance, and from the rebels' perspective, the loss of undead was preferable.

The main force of the rebels was not the undead but the human soldiers behind them.

Those united by hatred for the Empire.

They were a strong unit with a clear motivation, having experienced many victories on the outskirts of the Empire.

Although they were not well-trained soldiers, their extensive combat experience meant they were no less capable than the Empire's soldiers.

So, the loss of these undead was not a fear.

They would advance despite the losses.

Venderwood drew his sword and shouted once more.

"Advance!!"

And the one who shouted himself also charged forward.

Since no soldiers were visible in front of the canyon, there would only be one or two Wizards.

If he could rush out and block them, the undead could enter the canyon.

Fzzzt—

A strong spark was seen in the distance.

A woman with silver hair.

It was Gracie.

"Lightning Strike."

Gracie used magic against the approaching Venderwood.

Lightning flew towards Venderwood, but he did not dodge.

He simply raised his arm to block it.

Kwajjik!

Gracie's lightning struck Venderwood squarely.

However, it did not stop Venderwood's movement.

Venderwood's ability was self-healing.

Gracie's lightning blasted his arm off, but his ability regrew it.

"What is that....."

Gracie looked incredulously at Venderwood, who was recklessly charging at her even as his arm was blown off.

It was an unbelievable situation, but Gracie couldn't just stand by idly.

Gracie reached out to the sky.

"Thundercloud."

As Gracie chanted the incantation, the clouds began to slowly move.

The clear sky now bore clouds moving as if a giant dragon was stirring, forming a majestic cluster.

With the clouds gathered, Gracie waved her hand.

"Strike down."

Along with her words, Gracie lowered her hand.

Sparks flew from the gathered clouds, and lightning struck towards Venderwood.

Boom!

It wasn't just once.

Dozens of lightning bolts targeted Venderwood.

"Ugh..."

Venderwood moved quickly upon seeing the lightning.

Even though he could recover from the lightning, there was a limit to his healing.

There was no good reason to willingly take the hits.

But he couldn't dodge every attack.

The speed of the falling lightning was too fast for him to see and react.

So, he took the minimum number of hits while advancing forward.

Gracie was astonished at the sight.

"How can such a creature exist..."

Venderwood was struck by lightning several times.

His arm was blown off, and his body melted away to reveal his ribs.

Yet, he did not die.

He showed no fear.

It felt like facing an undead.

"Gracie. Step aside."

At that moment, McDowell Cliver, who was behind Gracie, stepped forward and moved his mana.

A strong light emanated from McDowell's hand.

The light targeted Venderwood precisely.

"Ugh!"

Venderwood stopped in his tracks upon seeing it.

That attack looked dangerous.

Venderwood filled his feet with mana to change direction.

And he lifted the sword he was carrying on his back.

A greatsword as large as a human.

Venderwood filled this massive sword with mana and swung it towards the direction of the incoming light.

Kwaaaaaaang!

After seeing the explosion, McDowell turned his head.

"Gracie."

"...Ah, yes, Principal."

"I'll block the movement of the undead army. Can you handle that fellow?"

It was time to block the movement of the undead legion.

The old McDowell might have considered facing both the legion and Venderwood at once.

But the current McDowell couldn't do that.

McDowell was missing his right arm.

Due to an incident where it was cut off by Aryandor, he still couldn't exert his original abilities.

"You don't have to defeat him. Just blocking his movement will suffice."

At McDowell's words, Gracie nodded as if she had made up her mind.

"...I'll try."

"If anything happens, I'll come to assist immediately." "Understood."

After hearing Gracie's response, McDowell walked towards the undead legion, and Gracie looked towards Venderwood.

The place where Venderwood was had black smoke rising from the explosion, and he walked out from within that smoke.

McDowell's magic was potent; the wounds on Venderwood's body hadn't fully healed.

"The stronger the power, the slower the healing..."

Gracie noted that information as she glared at him.

Venderwood briefly met Gracie's gaze before looking around.

"You're alone."

"...I can stop you by myself."

"Do you really think so?"

Venderwood lifted his greatsword.

"If you don't want to die, move aside."

Instead of a word of refusal, Gracie prepared her mana for an attack.

Venderwood gave a murderous smile and spoke.

"Then you'll have to die."

Venderwood charged at Gracie with his greatsword, and Gracie surrounded her hand with electricity and stretched it towards Venderwood.

'Pierce through.'

'Block it.'

With those conflicting thoughts, their attacks collided.

"It has begun."

Daemon, leading the rebel's main force, judged the situation from the explosion he saw in the distance.

'This battle needs to be quick to be advantageous.'

He knew that the Royal forces were dealing with rebellions elsewhere.

The movement of the main force was preempted by activities in other areas, forcing Ian's hand.

But not all forces were diverted there.

More than half were with Astina, stationed nearby.

Even so, the current situation favored the rebels.

The undead moved faster than regular humans, preventing the enemy from reacting freely.

The rebels planned to use this advantage to gain the upper hand.

However, the moment the situation drags on, it becomes disadvantageous for the rebels.

Once Ian manages to quell the outer rebellions, he'll surely move here.

And if the Royal forces and Astina arrive, it'll undoubtedly become a tough fight for the rebels.

Daemon looked at Aryandor in front of him.

He wondered what Aryandor's plan was for orchestrating such a strategy.

'It's not like he has a special trick up his sleeve.'

As the war drags on without engaging, the rebels are increasingly at a disadvantage.

The Empire was uniting against the common enemy of the rebels, while the rebels faced issues with supplies and cohesion.

Thus, launching a total war at this opportunity was better.

At least then, there would be a chance for victory.

At that moment, Aryandor looked back.

"Daemon."

"Yes, Aryandor."

"Speed up the movement of our forces."

"Speed it up?"

It wasn't impossible.

But it wasn't a good method either.

Behind Daemon were human forces, different from the undead.

They had physical limits and emotions.

Without proper food provision, increasing the marching speed would surely lower the morale of the troops.

Moreover, an army exhausted from forced marches could not be expected to fight properly.

It would have been a better decision for Aryandor or Daemon to move and support Venderwood's undead legion rather than speeding up the army's movement.

"Move at an unpredictable speed to catch them off guard."

Daemon did not respond to Aryandor's suggestion.

"Daemon?"

Prompted by Aryandor, Daemon finally spoke.

"...That seems difficult."

Daemon had never objected to Aryandor's commands before.

It was because of his trust in Aryandor.

However, Aryandor now seemed to have lost that trust.

"Are you refusing my order?"

"If you provide a valid reason, I will follow. But I cannot do so without any reason."

Aryandor, after a moment of silence, spoke.

"Do you think our forces can defeat the Royal and Academy forces?"

"...What are you saying?"

"Do you think the current rebels, including us, can win this war against those on the other side? Against Ian Astria, Rudy Astria, Cromwell, and others who have made a name for themselves in the Empire?"

Daemon looked at Aryandor incredulously.

"Isn't it our job to make them win? To increase our chances of victory even by a little, to strategize and make our soldiers win, isn't that what a commander is for?"

"Our role is to win this war, yes. But winning this war doesn't necessarily mean we have to use the soldiers."

Daemon furrowed his brows.

"What are you saying?"

"Even if we lose the frontal battle, we can still win the war."

"What are you planning?"

"What do you think our goal is?"

"To change the Empire. Do you share the same thought, Aryandor?"

Aryandor nodded.

"Yes, to change the Empire. I think the same. To completely, utterly change the Empire itself."

A shiver ran down Daemon's spine.

It was because of the madness lurking in Aryandor's eyes as he spoke.

"What are you intending to do?"

"Do I need to spell it out? Haven't we always agreed that if there's a goal, the means don't matter?"

"..."

There was no rebuttal.

Everyone had agreed to this.

That it was acceptable to use someone's life for a goal.

Even those not present had agreed to this fact.

"...Understood. I will follow your will."

Daemon silently turned and shouted orders to the troops behind him.

"Increase the speed of our movement!"

"Yes, that's a good decision."

Aryandor smiled and patted Daemon on the shoulder.

Chapter 286: Completion (7)

"Is it Professor Gracie and Principal McDowell?"

"Yes, those two are holding them back."

Both Professor Gracie and Principal McDowell are among the academy's strongest.

They were among the few talents in the academy who were more confident in combat than in research.

However, it wasn't easy for them to hold back the undead legion.

The undead legion's ability to push forward was one thing, but they also don't feel fear.

For humans, showing a few strong abilities might make soldiers hesitate, but such tactics don't work on the undead.

They lack intelligence.

They only follow the commander's orders, driven by hatred for the living.

They would keep moving forward towards the canyon, regardless of their comrades falling beside them.

I looked at Cromwell, who was beside me.

"Can they hold them off? Should we send reinforcements now?"

"Don't worry. Do you think we have no plan?"

"So, is there anything to do until the main forces arrive?"

"No, there's nothing. Everything is already prepared."

Cromwell said that and led me away.

Cromwell led me to the top of the canyon.

"Oh, Cromwell, you're here?"

"Professor McGuire?"

McGuire greeted us at that spot.

"Is everything ready?"

"We've been preparing for days. Of course, it is."

McGuire raised his thumb and smiled.

I tilted my head in confusion.

"Preparation for...?"

"Ah, that."

McGuire pointed behind him.

"...Why is this here?"

"If we can use it, we should. Just borrowed it for a moment."

Behind McGuire was a huge amplifier.

The amplifier made by Perrian Astria was set up at the top of the canyon.

Sparks flew around it powerfully.

Just being near it could result in death by electrocution.

Yet, Venderwood charged at Gracie.

"Lightning...!"

A giant bolt of lightning emerged from Gracie's body and aimed at Venderwood's sword-bearing right arm.

Zap—

Venderwood's arm melted from the lightning, leaving only the skeletal remains.

Without flesh, the great sword was dropped.

Unfazed by the loss of his arm, Venderwood flowed like water.

He spun his body, grabbed the great sword with his left hand, spun again, and swung the sword at Gracie.

"Ugh...!"

A small cut appeared on Gracie's face.

'He doesn't stop attacking even when hit...'

Venderwood continued his attack without hesitation, even after receiving an attack that melted his arm.

Gracie was clearly aware of this but was still taken aback.

Surely, after being hit by such lightning, one's body should at least stop.

The electricity spreading through the body would tamper with the muscles, causing them to lose strength.

Yet, Venderwood moved.

'What kind of freakish body structure is this...!'

"Discharge...!"

Gracie released the electricity in her body.

The burst of electricity exploded around her, and Venderwood narrowed his eyebrows and stepped back to avoid the attack.

'First off, he's not a wizard.'

That much was certain.

He was wrapped in sword energy, and with unbelievable physical abilities, he was a swordsman.

This raised an inevitable question.

What was Venderwood's ability?

Venderwood couldn't feel pain.

His body kept healing, and there was no restriction in his movement.

It felt like fighting an undead.

The natural physical reactions that should happen simply didn't.

It felt as though a different power was controlling his body.

'Did he implant a magical device in his body? But if so, it should have broken when Principal McDowell attacked earlier...'

Gracie recalled information about Raven she had learned some time ago.

That person controlled his body with a magical device implanted in his head.

He wouldn't die even if his body was destroyed, and from what she had heard, the device could also control pain.

Could Venderwood be related to that?

Gracie glared at Venderwood standing in front of her.

He was getting back into position.

'So, what should I do...'

A body that doesn't exhibit natural physical reactions.

Natural physical reactions...

To counter that...

"Ha!"

Venderwood kicked off the ground and charged at Gracie.

He swung his giant sword, as large as a person, at a fast speed.

"Ugh..."

Gracie tried to block the attack with the electricity wrapped around her hand, but the swift sword strikes began to leave small cuts on her body.

She started to feel little pains.

Thigh, arm, cheek.

They weren't fatal wounds, but the damage was accumulating.

The small injuries stung as if warning her to be careful.

It was okay for now, but if she accumulated more injuries, it might become difficult to move.

'Just a moment...'

That's when it clicked in Gracie's mind.

Pain is a warning the body sends to a person.

It's a signal to recognize injury and move more carefully, more safely.

Then.

Gracie extended her hand towards Venderwood.

"Electric Shock!"

Zap—

Strong electricity burst from Gracie's hand.

Venderwood blocked the attack with his sword, and the impact pushed him back.

Gracie immediately placed her hand on the ground.

"Electric Field."

Zzzt—

Electricity spread from Gracie to the ground.

The sand on the ground stirred due to the electricity.

"Hmm?"

Venderwood narrowed his eyebrows, observing Gracie spreading the field.

Even though the field was activated, it wasn't particularly threatening.

Only the sand on the ground stirred slightly; there wasn't a strong current running through the ground.

For an ordinary person, this amount of electricity could slow their movements, but Venderwood's body could ignore such electricity.

Venderwood, while assessing Gracie's magic, glanced at the undead legion.

The legion was being held back by McDowell, but not completely stopped.

-Grrrr...

"Damn it..."

A bone dragon with a massive body was pressuring McDowell.

McDowell had tried several flashes of magic against it but couldn't subdue it.

With the dragon holding McDowell back, the other undead could advance easily.

'Now's the time.'

Venderwood readied his sword.

McDowell couldn't stop the legion because of the bone dragon.

The legion had now reached the front of the canyon.

If he kept Gracie occupied now, the undead legion could enter the canyon.

"Huff..."

Venderwood exhaled deeply and looked at Gracie.

Gracie surrounded herself with electricity.

Her hair began to shoot upwards due to the sparks.

Zap—

Unlike the sparking sounds around, Gracie became calmer.

White light shone from her eyes, and the electricity in her hand began to form into the shape of a spear.

She extended her hand forward.

Gracie took a stance with the spear made of electricity.

Venderwood instinctively felt the danger of that spear.

If hit directly by that spear, he might not recover as easily as before.

But it didn't matter.

He just had to avoid it.

He was confident he could.

Venderwood's reaction speed was far superior to Gracie's.

The reaction speed of a swordsman compared to a wizard was incomparable.

"Huff..."

Gracie charged at Venderwood with the spear raised.

'Slow.'

Gracie's physical abilities were nothing special.

Venderwood easily stepped back, dodging Gracie's spear.

However, the role of the spear wasn't just to cut.

A strong current formed along the path of the spear Gracie had swung, and the electricity struck Venderwood's body.

The electricity entered Venderwood's body.

But that couldn't stop Venderwood's movement.

Ignoring the electricity, Venderwood charged at Gracie.

Venderwood's sword created a huge arc, aiming for Gracie.

Gracie stepped back and swung the spear again.

The electricity attacked Venderwood once more.

Venderwood, hit by the attack, advanced again.

As Venderwood advanced, Gracie was gradually pushed back.

'This should be enough...'

Venderwood glanced towards the canyon.

The undead army attempted to charge into the canyon, and McDowell tried to stop them. Gracie also noticed this.

"Ugh..."

Gracie let out a slight groan upon seeing the situation.

Venderwood didn't miss this.

With his great sword, Venderwood charged at her swiftly.

Here, Gracie had to choose.

Whether to attack the undead legion or to block Venderwood's attack.

Venderwood silently laughed at the thought of victory, no matter which decision she made.

Then, Gracie quietly uttered, "Got you..."

Crackle—

Electricity sparked from Venderwood's body as he charged.

At the same time, the electricity from the ground connected with the electricity coming from his body.

"What...?"

Venderwood's eyes widened.

Suddenly, electricity flowed, and he couldn't move his body.

Gracie laughed.

"People feel pain for a reason."

The electricity that Gracie had scattered with the spear earlier had been accumulating in his body.

Instead of just shocking him and ending it, she stored the electricity in his body.

Normally, a person should feel something off about this.

But he didn't feel it.

He didn't realize the electricity was accumulating in his body, nor did it spread and dig into his muscles.

'Of course, a normal person would have died from the accumulation of electricity in their body...'

With that thought, Gracie released all the electricity inside Venderwood's body at once.

The electricity seeped into Venderwood's muscles, thinly slicing through his muscle fibers.

Thus, Venderwood couldn't move.

Even though his healing ability was remarkable, he couldn't immediately recover from his entire body's muscle fibers being cut at once.

Gracie pulled back her spear.

"My spear isn't meant for swinging."

Aimed at Venderwood.

"It's for throwing."

She threw it with all her might.

"Pierce through. Astrape."

The spear Gracie released

Swept through the surroundings at an incredible speed and

"Ah."

Pierced through Venderwood's heart.

Bang!

A tremendous explosion of electricity occurred.

'Ha...!'

Venderwood thought as he watched his body burn.

That he had won anyway.

That the undead legion entering the canyon far away would bring victory to them.

However.

'All according to plan!'

Gracie laughed, watching the undead legion enter the canyon.

Chapter 287: Completion (8)

"Is it done...?"

McDowell, facing the dragon, watched the undead legion enter the canyon.

The legion moved in groups.

Under normal circumstances, this situation would have signaled the Academy's defeat.

If it had been according to the original plan, that is.

The Academy's initial strategy involved only Gracie and McDowell fending off the undead legion.

However, there was a problem with this plan.

The bone dragon and Venderwood needed to be stopped.

Gracie managed to stop Venderwood, while McDowell stopped the bone dragon.

Then, the moment arrived.

McDowell raised his hand high into the sky.

A small light emanated from McDowell's hand.

The light soared high into the sky.

Bang!

It burst with bright light.

Simultaneously, a strong mana spread around.

A quivering energy enveloped the body.

The undead legion, rushing into the canyon, gradually came to a stop.

"...Huh?"

The undead soldiers stopped and looked at their comrades beside them.

And then.

Crack.

"Krarak!!!"

They attacked their own comrades.

The undead began showing hatred towards each other and started fighting.

Entangled and intertwined in the narrow canyon, they trampled and killed each other.

Screams, as if being torn apart, and the sound of bones breaking echoed across the battlefield.

McDowell looked at this scene and smiled.

The Academy's plan was to lure only the undead into the canyon.

Undead are beings that harbor hatred for life.

They possess no intelligence, only hatred.

Cromwell exploited this.

He cast a group hallucination spell on the undead, making them perceive their comrades as living beings.

Using an amplifier brought from the Empire, he spread the hallucination spell across the entire battlefield.

Caught in the narrow canyon and tangled up, unable to escape, the undead killed each other.

This was Cromwell's plan.

However, this plan had a flaw.

It would be useless if there were beings capable of controlling the undead, and meaningless if there were beings that could break through the canyon alone.

Thus, from the beginning, McDowell and Gracie targeted those who could thwart their plan.

They stopped Venderwood, who could control the undead, and the bone dragon, who could exert the force of an army alone.

While stopping them, they acted as if they were preventing anyone from entering the canyon.

"Krarak!!!"

"Haha..."

Gracie sat on the ground, watching the undead fight each other.

"I guess we get to breathe a bit...?"

Until the enemy's main force arrived, until the Royal army came to their aid, they had bought some time.

Gracie thought so.

Then.

"Do you think... it will go as you wish..."

Suddenly, a raspy voice came from behind her.

A figure with a pierced heart and melted flesh.

Venderwood was rising from the ground.

"He's alive?"

Venderwood had taken a direct hit from Gracie's fatal technique, 'Astrape.'

'Astrape' was not just an ordinary skill.

As evidence, there was Venderwood, burnt and mangled beyond recognition, melted down.

Despite taking a direct hit from such a technique, Venderwood rose.

'I don't have the strength to face him anymore...'

Small spells could be used, but they were insufficient against Venderwood.

"Damn..."

However, Venderwood's condition was not normal either.

His body wasn't healing.

Only bones were barely coming together, and a few pieces of flesh were attached enough to sustain life. He couldn't continue to fight.

But, in this situation, just maintaining life was an advantage for Venderwood.

"Legion!!!"

Venderwood yelled with all his might.

He controlled the undead fighting each other.

Sending them into the canyon would mean victory for the rebels.

"Advance..."

"Bastard...!"

Then, a small light flew towards Venderwood.

The light pierced through Venderwood's vocal cords.

"Gurk..."

McDowell's magic.

Hastily used, it didn't have great power, but it was enough to silence him.

McDowell quickly used mana to attack Venderwood again.

But, he faced a different opponent.

"Grrr..."

"Oh no..."

The bone dragon charged at McDowell.

With the dragon's huge body charging, McDowell couldn't use other magic.

McDowell threw himself to the side to dodge the bone dragon and cursed.

'If only my arm were fine...'

If Venderwood controls the undead, it's a defeat.

He knew he could heal, but he never imagined his regeneration to be that strong.

Moreover, the bone dragon in front of him was a problem.

It was much stronger than before.

It must have been enhanced in some way.

McDowell dodged the attack and shouted loudly.

"Gracie!!!! Block it!!!!"

"Eugh..."

Gracie barely managed to get up and moved her mana.

The sparks that had spread around were long gone, and with her mana depleted, Gracie could only use small techniques.

"Electric..."

Gracie used the weakest electric magic.

"Damn..."

Venderwood took the attack head-on.

Venderwood, who had easily dodged Gracie's strong attacks effortlessly before, had to let the attacks connect.

"Legion."

Venderwood poured all his healing power into recovering his vocal cords.

He focused solely on healing to give commands while a desperate fight unfolded on the battlefield.

Cromwell, inside the canyon, sensed something was off.

"What's going on?"

Despite the plan going as intended, Gracie and McDowell had not signaled victory.

Something had gone wrong.

Rudy, who was nearby, tilted his head in confusion.

"What's happening?"

Cromwell looked at Rudy, who was helping control the camp, then turned away.

"Rudy, stay here. I'll be right back."

"Huh? Professor?"

Cromwell used magic to fly into the sky.

He flew quickly towards the battlefield.

"....."

He soon arrived at the battlefield and scanned the surroundings.

The undead legion trapped in the canyon was killing each other.

McDowell was still fighting the bone dragon, and Gracie was sitting, defeated, on the ground.

And then.

"Legion!!!!!!!"

He saw Venderwood, whose vocal cords had recovered.

"Sigh..."

Cromwell quickly made a decision... no, he reacted reflexively with his mana.

If that bastard shouts, if he controls the undead legion, it would be unstoppable.

The inside of the canyon was not yet ready for battle.

The original soldiers were prepared, but their numbers were far too few, and they lacked a proper commander.

They couldn't face that massive legion.

"Gravity."

Cromwell used telekinesis magic to send a small stone flying towards Venderwood.

The stone was small, but it flew quickly because of its size.

"Huh?"

Venderwood spotted the stone flying towards him.

It was coming at a tremendous speed, but Venderwood's dynamic vision allowed him to see it.

A stone flying straight for his throat.

'I can't shout...'

He saw the stone, but there was no time to dodge or speak before it hit.

And he also had no confidence in recovering after being hit by the stone.

'Aryandor...'

Venderwood resignedly repeated Aryandor's name.

Then.

Thud.

A small, bouncing sound was heard.

".....?"

Someone appeared in front of Venderwood and blocked the stone thrown by Cromwell.

"Ah... Aaah..."

Gracie, sitting on the ground, saw the man.

Cromwell, floating in the sky, and McDowell, fighting the bone dragon, both of their eyes widened.

"There was no need to risk your life to break through."

The person who appeared was Aryandor.

Cromwell clenched his teeth hard.

'Aryandor here all of a sudden...'

He was supposed to be leading the main force.

And he suddenly shows up with the vanguard?

There was no way Aryandor could have known about the vanguard's situation.

Yet, Aryandor appeared here.

"Gracie! Get out of the way!!!"

Gracie was right in front of Venderwood.

Cromwell shouted as he flew towards her.

"Ah..."

But Gracie couldn't move as Cromwell had shouted.

Aryandor quickly drew his sword and swung it.

Blood sprayed.

Gracie was cut.

"Gracie!!!!!!"

Cromwell immediately used telekinesis magic.

He sent dozens of giant rocks flying at Aryandor.

Aryandor, finding it laughable, swung his sword and cut through the rocks.

At the same time, he shouted.

"Legion. Stop."

The undead that had been killing each other stopped their movements.

"Aryandor!!!!!!"

"Greetings, Vice Principal Cromwell."

Cromwell quickly reached Gracie's side.

And stood in front of her, facing Aryandor.

'Blood...'

Gracie's body wasn't cut through, but she had a large sword wound on her abdomen.

A tremendous amount of blood was flowing, and leaving her like this was far too dangerous.

He wanted to take her and flee, but Aryandor was standing in the way.

Cromwell clenched his fist as he looked at Aryandor.

"How did you know to show up?"

"Do I have to tell you that?"

Aryandor said with a sneer.

But Cromwell wasn't one to be easily intimidated.

"If you're here, do you think the main force would be alright?"

Cromwell hadn't failed to consider this situation.

He had even considered the scenario where Aryandor would suddenly appear on the battlefield.

The main force without Aryandor wasn't as strong as one might think.

So, if Aryandor came here, it meant that the Royal army wouldn't be moving towards the Academy, but the rebels' main force would be attacked instead.

Despite Cromwell's threat, Aryandor just shrugged his shoulders, showing no particular emotion.

"Well, we'll see about that later."

Cromwell was puzzled.

What was he thinking? How had he gotten here, and what was happening with the main force?

Despite these questions, he was thinking about how to save Gracie, who lay injured.

"Vice Principal Cromwell."

As Cromwell was engulfed in confusion, Aryandor smiled.

"How about we step back for a moment?"

"...What?"

"Don't you want to save the girl below? I also want to preserve Venderwood and the undead legion. So, let's both step back and regroup."

Cromwell looked at Aryandor with disbelief.

Aryandor wore a ruthless smile.

"Not interested?"

The situation wasn't favorable for either side.

If the fight continued, the Academy's side would be breached through the canyon, and the rebels' main force would be swept away.

The battlefield would surely become chaotic, and the fight would turn into a dangerous tightrope walk.

This situation, while not welcomed by the Academy, actually favored the rebels.

Their forces being weaker than the Empire's, even a standoff was advantageous for them, suggesting they were managing to steer the fight in their favor.

But, to retreat?

Cromwell bit his lip and pondered, then picked up Gracie from the ground.

'What are you thinking, Aryandor?'

With these thoughts, he bit his lip.

Here, no matter how much he disliked Aryandor or how incomprehensible his thoughts were, he had no choice but to accept the proposal.

"Let's do that."

"Well thought out, Vice Principal Cromwell."

At this, Aryandor smiled.

Chapter 288: Completion (9)

"Ugh..."

"Professor Gracie, are you conscious?"

Gracie slowly opened her eyes in response to my question.

"Where is this..."

She regained consciousness while tossing and turning.

"...Huh? Rudy Astria?"

I was surprised to see Gracie opening her eyes wide.

Then, she looked around.

"Did I fall asleep while writing a paper? I think I had a strange dream...
Something about Aryandor standing in front of me..."

"It's not a dream. You're fine, considering you're talking nonsense."

"Eh?"

Cromwell let out a sigh of relief seeing Gracie like this.

"Good. You're alright."

Astina looked at us with a dumbfounded expression.

"...You call this being alright?"

Gracie widened her eyes at Astina standing in front of her.

"If this isn't a dream... No, why is Astina here...?"

Cromwell slowly began to speak.

"Astina just arrived. The Royal Army came to check on your condition briefly."

"The Royal Army has arrived... But how did I..."

Gracie had received a severe sword wound in the middle of the battlefield.

Right in front of Aryandor, the enemy leader, no less.

In a normal situation, she wouldn't have been able to retreat and would have faced death.

Gracie looked puzzled, as if none of this made sense to her.

"I had a talk with Aryandor."

"Did you make some kind of contract? How did you..."

"I don't know. It was Aryandor who made that proposal."

We couldn't understand it either.

About a day had passed since that battle.

The Academy managed to fend off the enemy without losing any soldiers, allowing them to catch their breath.

However, many questions remained.

Clearly, the battle would have been advantageous for the rebels.

Yet, they didn't push on.

They even gave the Royal Army time to join forces with the Academy.

"Let's withdraw now. Professor Gracie should rest as well."

"Are you leaving?"

Gracie tried to get up at Astina's words.

"Ouch!"

She immediately clutched her stomach and fell back onto the bed.

"Are you okay?"

"Ugh..."

Cromwell then spoke to Gracie.

"Gracie, you can rest. You're not in a condition to get up."

"But..."

"It's okay. You've done what you could. You can rest now."

Gracie bit her lip and nodded at Cromwell's words.

Leaving Gracie behind, we left the tent where she was staying.

Astina looked around and asked Cromwell.

"What's the situation now?"

"It's practically impossible to lose now. The Royal Army has arrived, and we're hearing news of victories from the Empire's outskirts."

The nobles who had rebelled at the Empire's outskirts were being dealt with decisively by Ian's forces.

"It won't be long before Ian can join us on this front."

"With Rudy here, Aryandor's time magic shouldn't be a big problem either."

Cromwell pointed at me, standing next to him.

"What the hell are they thinking?"

"I have no idea. It would be comforting to think of them as a ragtag bunch, but they must have some sort of plan."

Cromwell pointed towards the direction where the rebels had set their formation.

The rebels, positioned a distance away from the canyon, did not make a single move.

Even though the main force of the rebels had not yet arrived, their lack of movement was strange.

"It feels like they're waiting for the Royal Army."

Cromwell nodded in agreement.

"Indeed. Though I have no clue what they're thinking."

Cromwell and Astina fell into silence, lost in thought. I opened my mouth towards the two of them.

"Let's focus on doing our best for now. Just in case, let's also keep an eye on our rear."

The sanctuary Haruna showed us.

We needed to be cautious about that place, just in case.

After all, that was the bastard's target.

"Understood. For now, I'll inform the professors about the rear. We'll decide on our next steps once the battle starts. If Aryandor does not show up on the battlefield, Rudy and the troops will focus more on that side. If he does, we'll concentrate on the front."

"Understood."

"Aryandor was with the main force?"

I frowned and looked at Astina.

"Yes, Aryandor never left that spot."

"Are you saying there are two Aryandors?"

"I don't know. What we saw could have been a double or perhaps an illusion created by magic."

It was hard to believe it was just an illusion.

Surely, the Royal Army would have used magic to verify the authenticity of Aryandor's presence, monitoring him closely.

They could have set up the main force as an illusion and attacked from another location.

Now that I think about it, it was a bit strange.

If Aryandor moved from the main force to the vanguard, how?

Even using magic, it's impossible to announce every move during battle.

Especially since there was no one at that location capable of using such magic.

Only an army made up of undead was there.

"Using a double for oneself..."

If they had placed a double in the main force to execute some plan, they should have done it long ago.

But Aryandor didn't do that.

Instead, they backed off.

"There's no way to find out anything now..."

"Let's do what we can, as I said earlier. What's the use of worrying about something we can't find the answer to?"

I smiled, and Astina let out a chuckle.

"Yeah, you're right. Let's do what we have to do."

Astina and I said this as we walked above the canyon.

"Aryandor was?"

"Yes."

Compared to the Royal Army, the rebels, who joined the vanguard late, were organizing their ranks.

Meanwhile, Daemon went to find Venderwood, who was resting.

Venderwood had not healed all his wounds, but he had managed to pull himself together.

"Aryandor was with me the whole time. But what do you mean by that?"

"I saw him use time magic and wield a sword."

"Does that mean the Aryandor outside is a fake?"

At Venderwood's words, Daemon ran his hand through his hair.

To this, Venderwood calmly responded.

"I'm just telling you what I saw."

With that, Daemon had nothing to say.

Venderwood was always a stoic person.

He's someone who completely trusts Aryandor without any doubt.

If ordered to die, he would die; if ordered to live, he would live.

Being a slave originally, that mentality was deeply ingrained in him.

"Putting that aside, how are you feeling? Can you fight?"

"I can't fight properly, but I can still move."

"The upcoming battle will be all-out. Can you hold your ground there?"

"I will."

Daemon closed his mouth at the response 'I will' instead of 'I can'.

Venderwood's condition was not normal.

Although Daemon didn't particularly like Venderwood, it was a fact that his strength was beneficial to the rebels.

Losing such a force right before a total war would be devastating.

"I've never asked you for anything, but I'll ask you this one thing."

Daemon reached out his hand to Venderwood, who was sitting.

"Will you fight... until the end?"

Venderwood stared at Daemon's hand, then grabbed it and stood up.

"There's no need to ask that. Just command, and I will act."

"Thank you."

There were many questions about Aryandor, but now they were facing a major battle.

No matter how suspicious Aryandor was, facing the Royal Army was the priority.

In that sense, Venderwood's words were incredibly reassuring.

"Daemon."

At that moment, Aryandor entered the tent where Venderwood and Daemon were.

Aryandor was fully dressed in full plate armor, ready for battle.

"Let's start moving now."

"Understood."

As they stepped outside the tent, countless soldiers, armed and ready, were waiting.

Undead and many people.

It's unknown how many of these people will survive.

The force might be insufficient to break through the canyon guarded by the Academy.

Yet, they had to go.

Only by breaking through there could they win.

Despite his doubts about Aryandor, he was still the only key that could lead them to victory.

If he reaches the Academy, they can win, so they had no choice but to move forward.

Daemon looked at Aryandor.

They had fought and won many battles together, defeating corrupt nobles and rescuing the oppressed people under them.

So, this time too.

He would willingly sacrifice his own life if needed.

He hoped to bring victory to the people in front of them.

"Aryandor. Shall we go?"

Daemon did not ask about what Venderwood had said.

What's the point of asking now?

They hadn't talked about it on the way here either.

They had decided to trust and follow Aryandor for this battle.

So, there was no need to raise any objections.

"Yes, then."

Aryandor put on the helmet set beside him.

Then he walked forward, through the soldiers.

"Let's go."

Chapter 289: Completion (10)

Right at the edge of the canyon.

A dense crowd of people stood on the vast meadow.

No, to be precise, it wasn't just people.

Skeletons clattering their jawbones and bone dragons of enormous size, among other various types of undead, were also present.

I crouched at the top of the canyon, looking down at the scene.

"So damn many of them."

"Even if there are many, we have the upper hand in terms of terrain."

Cromwell, standing behind me, said with a laugh.

I looked at Cromwell.

"Professor Cromwell, have you ever experienced war?"

"Yes. Chased around that guy Robert a few times."

"Have you faced a war of this magnitude?"

"No. There's probably no one alive who has experienced a war of this scale."

The largest scale war within the Empire.

It was certain to be brutal.

From the start of the war until its end.

Blood of many would flow, and screams of agony would be heard.

"Is it possible to negotiate and not fight now?"

"If that were possible, we wouldn't have come this far."

I knew this fact.

Even after the Empire sent many proposals for negotiation, there was no answer or counterproposal; instead, the messenger's head was sent back.

I clenched my fist and stepped forward.

"I'll try to end this as quickly as possible."

There was only one way to solve all these problems.

Aryandor.

If that person died, we could end this war.

We could reduce the number of deaths.

Pooo—

The resonant sound of a horn bellowed.

The massive rebel army moved.

"Rudy, I'm counting on you."

"Yes, leave it to me."

Cromwell then went down.

From the top of the canyon, I focused on just one person.

"Aryandor."

It was time to end this fight.

"Advance!!!"

The rebels, led by the undead, moved forward.

Daemon commanded them, looking up at the canyon.

The Royal troops were waiting above the canyon.

A strategy of entering where the enemy opens its mouth.

There would be many sacrifices, but if they could break through, victory was assured.

If they could break through... that is.

"Go!!!"

"Kaaaah!"

"Krk...!!"

Thud thud thud!

With Daemon's shout, the undead charged.

Not just skeletons but also large undead shook the ground with their charge.

The Royal troops above the canyon swallowed their saliva, watching the undead's charge.

And they silently waited.

"Vice Commander."

"Not yet."

Astina was quietly observing the charge.

And when they reached the front of the canyon.

"Attack!!!!!"

She shouted loudly.

At the same time, other soldiers also shouted.

"Attack!!!!"

"Attack!!!"

A barrage of arrows and spells swirled through the air.

"Argh!!"

"Fireball!"

"Fire Field!"

Arrows poured onto the bodies of the undead, and magic covered them.

The battlefield, quiet just moments ago, turned into a hell of fire.

But that didn't stop their advance.

The undead marched forward, even as the path ahead turned into a sea of flames.

Though their bodies burned and fell, they pressed on.

"Rrrr!"

Then, one undead charged forward.

This undead had incredibly large hands for its size.

"Raa!"

Using its large hands, the undead pushed the burning corpses aside, clearing a path.

With a way through, the undead started running forward again.

"Fire!"

But the Royal troops weren't just watching.

Some soldiers shot arrows at the undead that had broken through.

"Raaaghh!"

Despite being hit by a few small arrows relative to its size, the undead thrashed violently.

And then.

Boom!!!

An explosion occurred, turning the surroundings into chaos.

Daemon grimaced at the sight.

The arrows fired by the Royal troops were enchanted.

Such arrows, costly as they were, were not used carelessly. Yet, the Royal troops used them boldly from the start.

"Are they saying they won't let us get close at all?"

Daemon stretched his hand forward.

"Bone Wall."

A wall of bones rose from the side of the canyon.

The arrows and spells falling from above were blocked by this wall.

But only for a moment.

Astina, who was above the canyon, jumped down.

"Gravity."

Crash!

Using her magic, Astina pressed down on the wall.

The wall shattered, and fragments fell below.

"Raa!"

The walls, meant to block the attack, fell onto the undead, and the charging undead were pressed to the ground.

"Move all you want, but you have to get through our attacks first."

Astina, flying in the sky, said to Daemon.

"Bone Spear."

Without responding, Daemon immediately used magic.

Bone spears flew into the sky, aiming at Astina.

But they didn't reach her.

The spears flying swiftly towards Astina were all pushed away as they got near her.

"Did you think that would hit?"

Daemon quietly uttered after watching Astina.

"Ogre."

Astina looked puzzled by the meaningless word, but soon realized what it meant.

"Already using that guy?"

"If the Vice Commander has appeared, we should also provide a matching welcome."

Far away, a bone dragon flew high.

The creature took a deep breath.

"But, you're not the only ones with a dragon."

Then, from the direction of the canyon, another dragon soared into the sky.

Rudy had called forth a Red Dragon, named Yongyong.

Yongyong inhaled deeply and aimed its mouth towards the bone dragon.

And at the same time.

—!

It unleashed its breath attack.

The poison breath from the bone dragon clashed with Yongyong's fire breath, creating a massive collision.

The clash generated a huge shockwave, and the attacks started to scatter around.

The Empire's side was hit by fire breath, while the rebels were hit by poison breath.

"Oh, it's coming...!"

As the soldiers were shocked by the giant attack, one person from each side of the Empire and rebels jumped out.

"Gravity Barrier."

"Royal Swordsmanship. Moonlight."

On the rebels' side, Venderwood used his sword energy to slice through the breath, and on the Empire's side, Cromwell stepped forward to block the attack.

Astina smiled upon seeing this.

"Using Royal Swordsmanship against the Royal troops..."

Daemon responded.

"Are the most hypocritical ones speaking?"

"Hypocritical? Do you really not know who the truly hypocritical ones are?"

"It's you. You nobles who are busy protecting your own positions while claiming to protect the people."

Astina was taken aback by Daemon's words.

"Us? When have we ever been busy protecting our positions? Ridiculous. If anything, you're the ones obsessed with blood."

After becoming the Vice Commander of the Royal troops, Astina had done everything possible to prevent this war.

She had even considered negotiating with the rebels, offering them land and the chance to become an independent region.

But, the rebels rejected everything.

And not just any rejection.

They mocked the Empire by sending back the heads of the messengers.

They were instigating war without proposing anything to the Empire.

"Ha...! Have you ever tried to listen to us? Not even pretending to consider it, you just wage war?"

That's when Astina realized something was off.

"Not listening...?"

"You who have never proposed negotiations or sent emissaries..."

"What?"

Astina's eyes widened.

'Something's wrong.'

"Could you possibly..."

"Royal Swordsmanship."

Then, a voice came from behind.

"Crescent Moon."

A massive sword strike flew towards Astina.

"Ugh...!"

Astina moved her body using telekinesis.

'Aryandor...'

Aryandor was there, where the sword strike came from.

Holding a sword, Aryandor stepped forward and spoke.

"Daemon. There's no time for chatter."

"Understood."

Daemon briefly bowed his head and moved his mana.

"Ugh..."

Astina frowned.

A massive mana began to move.

It wasn't a small spell they were trying to use.

With that amount of mana...

'I need to block it...'

Just as they were moving the mana.

Thump!

A sound of someone kicking off the ground echoed from above the canyon.

Despite the noisy battlefield, both Daemon and Astina looked up upon hearing the sound.

A man was leaping down from above the canyon.

It was Rudy Astria.

"Ugh..."

Seeing Rudy, Daemon immediately redirected his mana.

If Rudy Astria approached while he was casting a spell, he would surely be at a disadvantage.

"Bone Wall! Barrier!"

Daemon used magic to shield himself.

Then he prepared another spell.

'If he breaks through the shield...'

He intended to counterattack immediately with magic.

However.

"...?"

Rudy, coming down from the canyon, wasn't heading towards Daemon.

Ignoring Daemon, the soldiers around, and everyone else, Rudy dashed towards one person.

"Aryandor!!!!!"

"Ha..."

Aryandor made a disbelieving face as he saw Rudy charging towards him.

He was in the middle of the battlefield, surrounded by soldiers.

Rudy, paying no heed to such things, headed straight for Aryandor.

"Northern Swordsmanship."

Aryandor quietly held his sword and faced Rudy.

"Inhale..."

Rudy too inhaled deeply and filled his fist with mana.

"Bluebird."

Aryandor launched a blue sword energy forward, and Rudy extended his fist, exploding the mana forward.

Chapter 290: Completion (11)

Two forces collided: a blue sword energy and a silver-colored mana.

It was the power of Aryandor and Rudy clashing.

Astina watched the scene.

"Rudy's power..."

Rudy's mana pierced through Aryandor's sword energy. It was much stronger than Aryandor's attack.

"Has he grown this much in a month? No..."

Even though Rudy's power had increased, such strength seemed impossible.

His opponent was Aryandor. Astina, having seen his power firsthand, sensed something was off. Rudy's newfound strength couldn't possibly overwhelm Aryandor to this extent.

"Is Aryandor's power weaker?"

Not only had Rudy become stronger, but Aryandor's power also seemed weaker from before.

Astina wasn't the only one feeling this way.

"Aryandor?"

Daemon too was shocked by the scene.

Aryandor was being overpowered by Rudy, which made no sense.

Rudy was dangerous not because he could beat Aryandor but because he could block Aryandor's time magic.

Everyone thought Aryandor was originally the stronger one. This situation was abnormal.

Aryandor's power was weaker than usual, despite him sustaining no injuries for a month. There was no reason for his power to suddenly decline.

Was he deliberately holding back? That too made no sense.

Taking Rudy's attack head-on would harm both the soldiers around and Aryandor himself.

Ignoring the attack just to save some strength was foolish.

"What's happening here..."

Daemon, bewildered, snapped back to reality.

"We need to block the attack."

If Aryandor's attack failed, Rudy's would engulf the surroundings, harming both the soldiers and Aryandor.

Daemon reached out, attempting to manipulate mana, when a man burst forth from behind Aryandor.

"Royal swordsmanship, Half Moon."

The man, wielding a large greatsword, pushed back Rudy's attack. It was Venderwood.

After blocking Rudy's attack, Venderwood approached Aryandor.

"Aryandor, are you alright?"

"Yes, thanks to you."

Rudy landed and looked at Venderwood and Aryandor.

"?"

Rudy tilted his head, confused.

Everyone felt something was off, but Rudy, who had launched the attack, felt it most acutely.

His attack wasn't that strong. Aryandor should have easily countered it.

In previous fights with Aryandor, Rudy felt like he was up against an insurmountable wall. Despite attempting attacks and counters with powerful techniques, Rudy never felt he could win.

But this Aryandor was different.

He was just ordinary.

I couldn't feel Aryandor's unique aura.

Rudy thought of something.

Two Aryandors.

It was a conversation he had with Astina.

"How could Aryandor be in two places at once, with both the advance party and the main force?"

Then, Aryandor drew his sword.

"Royal swordsmanship, Full Moon."

Rudy clenched his fist.

Aryandor's golden sword energy flew toward him. It was weak.

"Ah!"

Rudy exploded with mana, pushing away Aryandor's sword energy, and charged in.

"Block him!"

As Rudy rushed toward Aryandor, the surrounding soldiers tried to stop him.

"Priscilla, Behemoth."

"A summon!"

"Block him! We have to stop him!"

As the soldiers moved, Rudy spoke again.

"Behemoth, return to your original size."

"Puu~."

Boom—

"Ah...?"

"What is that?"

With Rudy's words, Behemoth's body grew larger.

Its body was big enough to rival that of an original dragon.

A giant elephant appeared on the battlefield.

"Run away!"

"No! Block it! We must block it!"

The soldiers were in total disarray, unable to even think of stopping Rudy.

In that chaos, Rudy only looked at Aryandor.

"Ah..."

Rudy again filled his hand with mana and looked ahead.

As he was about to punch Aryandor, Venderwood appeared by Aryandor's side.

"Move."

"You can't get through."

After a brief exchange, Rudy manipulated mana.

"Spatial Severance."

"!"

Spatial Severance was a technique that required casting time.

It was an easy technique to avoid.

But the Spatial Severance happening right in front of them now was unavoidable.

Several rifts formed around Venderwood.

Under normal circumstances, Venderwood could have avoided them, but his injuries were too severe to escape this attack.

"Cough..."

Rudy quickly overcame Venderwood and headed toward Aryandor behind him.

"Aryandor."

"Come on, then."

Aryandor, standing behind, smiled and directed his sword at Rudy.

Aryandor's sword energy and Rudy's punch swung at each other.

Boom!!!

The collision of sword energy and mana caused an explosion.

The sand on the ground was blown away, creating a dust storm.

As visibility was obscured, Rudy spoke.

"Lich."

Clink, clink.

Suddenly, the sound of chains.

Behind Aryandor, a demon wrapped in chains and holding a giant scythe appeared.

The demon quickly moved the chains.

The chains moved towards Aryandor, attempting to bind him.

"Swing the White Sword."

The sword swung as if it split into dozens of blades.

The sword energy, enveloped in dozens of swords, cut through all the chains surrounding Aryandor, who then looked at Rudy in front of him.

"Royal swordsmanship..."

And as he was about to swing his sword,

Rudy asked,

"Who are you?"

As soon as Aryandor heard Rudy's words, he swung his sword.

"Quick Blade."

Aryandor's swiftly moving sword grazed Rudy's cheek.

Seeing this, Aryandor, with a sneer, said to Rudy,

"Do you not even know who's standing in front of you?"

Rudy gestured towards Aryandor with his chin.

"Take a look at your legs and tell me."

Aryandor looked down.

The armor around Aryandor's legs was slightly damaged.

That part of the leg...

Should have been where Aryandor's prosthetic leg was, yet there was a perfectly intact leg there.

"When did it get broken?"

"Well, I guess you don't need to answer that."

Rudy turned around and shouted loudly,

"Astina!!!"

Startled by the sudden shout, Astina's eyes widened.

Before she could respond, Rudy shouted again,

"It's a trap!!!"

"What?"

As Rudy shouted, Aryandor charged at him.

At the same time, he said,

"Help Venderwood."

"Understood."

Simultaneously, two people rushed at Rudy.

Seeing this, Astina moved quickly.

"Help Rudy!"

Astina shouted as she tried to move.

But someone moved before her.

"Rudy Astria!!"

Cromwell flew down from above towards Rudy.

"Gravity."

Cromwell pressed down both Aryandor and Venderwood at the same time.

"Ugh..."

"Go, Rudy. I'll take care of this."

Rudy nodded to Cromwell, who had come to his aid.

"Please."

Rudy left Cromwell in charge and retreated.

"Rudy! What's happening?"

"I must go ahead."

"What do you mean? Where are you going?"

"To the Academy. I need to go to the Academy."

"What?"

Astina looked at Rudy with surprise, then clenched her mouth tightly.

"Alright. I understand."

Astina nodded without asking for any explanations.

There was no reason to hold him back when he was so insistent.

"Then we'll take care of things here."

"Are you sure you can?"

"Who do you think I am?"

Astina said with a smile.

It was a more reassuring smile than ever before.

"Thank you."

"Thankful? Please."

Rudy said as he hugged Astina.

"Ru, Rudy?"

Astina's eyes widened in surprise at the sudden embrace on the battlefield.

"What is this? This is war..."

Rudy released Astina, who was stammering with laughter, from his embrace.

Astina, her face flushed red, couldn't hide her flustered expression and blankly stared at Rudy.

"I'll see you after this is all over. Take care. I won't let it go if you get hurt."

Leaving Astina behind, Rudy immediately moved on.

"..."

Astina blankly looked in the direction Rudy disappeared to and then smiled warmly.

"Don't you get hurt either."

Muttering to herself, Astina turned around.

Behind her were countless troops.

Astina reached out to the sky.

From her hand, a small flame burst forth and exploded in the sky, signaling like a flare.

It was part of the plan prepared by Cromwell and Astina.

They were meant to be the last resort, but she decided to call them a bit early.

After sending the signal, Astina stepped forward.

"Then, I should make my move too."

Bang!

A firework exploded in the distance.

Someone was watching it.

"Isn't it a bit early?"

"Problems happen in war all the time."

"Why should I, a princess, have to follow orders?"

"In a war, there are no princesses. Just individuals."

"You're talking back a lot more than usual?"

"..."

"Fine. Let's just do as we're told."

The woman who spoke was Rie Von Ristonia, the Empire's first princess.

And the man following her was Locke Lucarion, the guardian of the north from the Lucarion family.

"Let's go!"

At Rie's command, the soldiers behind her moved to follow her.

Chapter 291: Completion (12)

"Block him, Daemon,"

Aryandor said upon seeing Rudy heading towards the academy.

"Bone Spear."

Following this, Daemon attempted to stop Rudy's movement using mana.

However, he couldn't stop Rudy.

"Gravity."

Astina pressed down on the spear flying towards Rudy.

"Don't you have someone else to fight?"

Astina asked with a smile.

"Ugh..."

Astina glanced at Aryandor.

Seeing Aryandor react like that confirmed it was definitely a good situation.

But that didn't change the situation on the battlefield.

With Rudy gone, there could be a gap.

I signaled the hidden troops, so we could hold on, but the disruption to the original plan was problematic.

Daemon felt the same.

He knew Aryandor was up to something, but he never imagined the enemy would realize it first.

'But.'

The primary goal for the rebels was to break through the canyon.

Even without precise knowledge of the inside, the situation was clearly good.

'To maintain this situation.'

Daemon made a quick decision.

To keep the situation on the battlefield, Cromwell and Astina had to be held back.

That way, the undead could dig through the canyon.

Daemon reached towards the ground.

"O beings at life's end, receive my power and become one with me."

The ground then began to stir.

Bodies around started gathering towards Daemon.

Astina frowned at this sight.

Though she didn't know what magic it was, it was related to necromancy.

It had to be blocked.

"Gravity Field!"

Astina tried to block the stirring bodies around with magic, but Daemon shook his head.

"It's no use."

Bodies were gathering.

Not just the bodies of those who had died on the battlefield, but also those beneath the canyon's ground and nearby.

All started to rise.

Even as Astina tried to block with magic, the bodies resisted, twisting their bones to stand.

'Is he creating undead?'

Normally, creating undead like this wouldn't be significant.

Such undead are numerous but lack quality, easily annihilated in an instant.

However, something was off.

"Bones and flesh shall become one, and their bodies shall come to me."

Daemon continued his incantation.

The gathered corpses melted as if they had entered a furnace, gradually merging into one large mass.

"What the hell..."

"Monster?"

The soldiers widened their eyes at the sight.

The corpses melted and became one, forming a large body that began to lift Daemon high off the ground.

The mass gradually took on a human form, resembling a giant.

"That is..."

Astina recognized something like this.

It was similar to the undead caught by Professor Robert on their way back from visiting the Railer family with Luna.

A monster with a huge body that kept regenerating.

"It was similar."

"There shall be one death."

Daemon finished the incantation.

"Rising Titan."

A giant appeared in the middle of the battlefield.

It was a monster made of corpses and clumps of earth and dirt, clinging to Daemon as if they had become one.

"This seems stronger than what we saw before."

Astina sighed.

Thanks to Professor Robert, she knew how to fight this kind of monster.

A monster that keeps regenerating even when its body is cut.

Therefore, its core had to be targeted.

"Astina! What's going on here?"

Cromwell, who was dealing with Aryandor and Venderwood, stepped back and asked Astina.

"It's a monster created by a necromancer."

"Necromancy?"

"This is going to be a headache."

It was impossible to stop it alone.

Well, to be precise, it could be stopped, but it couldn't be killed.

But leaving it alone was not an option either.

This was a battlefield.

People would continue to die, and this giant would use them as nourishment to grow even larger.

So, it must be destroyed.

"Professor, can you help?"

"I could help, but..."

Cromwell looked down.

He saw Venderwood and the fake Aryandor.

Although Aryandor was a fake, he was far stronger than ordinary soldiers, and even the professors could not stand against him.

"Shouldn't we leave them to those guys?"

Astina pointed to the meadow far away on the opposite side of the canyon.

Soldiers coming from where the rebels had come, on the other side of the canyon.

The northern army led by Rie had arrived on the battlefield.

"Can we trust them with this?"

"Yes, they are reliable."

"What about the back then?"

The outside of the canyon was one thing, but the inside was also a problem.

As the undead continued to enter, someone was needed to stop them.

"Isn't Professor Mcguire there? And him."

"Him?"

"The one who is extremely effective against the undead."

The technique that is extremely effective against the undead.

The one who possesses it.

That was Evan.

Evan's nature magic was the polar opposite of necromancy, capable of dealing lethal damage to the undead.

Cromwell nodded after hearing Astina's words.

"Alright, we'll do as you say."

Astina smiled at Cromwell's response.

"Listening to your disciple won't do you any harm."

"Yeah, let's see how great my disciple is."

With that, Cromwell and Astina looked at the giant in front of them.

In front of the academy.

A man looked up at the academy from its entrance.

"Is there a barrier put up?"

The man was not alone.

Another person, with their face hidden under a hood, was with him.

They stood at the entrance of the academy, unable to enter because of the barrier.

"Who's there!"

A middle-aged man came out from the inside of the academy as he saw someone lurking around.

"Hmm...?"

"I asked who you are! Reveal your identity!"

The middle-aged man demanded, on guard.

Thump!

"Can you lift this barrier?"

The man standing in front of the academy asked, tapping the barrier with his hand.

"What?"

The middle-aged man looked at him as if he were absurd.

As he stared at the man's face, the middle-aged man's eyes widened.

That face was all too familiar and should not have been seen.

"Aryandor?"

The middle-aged man quickly began to manipulate mana, adopting a defensive posture.

"Oh, when guests arrive, one should think about how to treat them. Aren't you supposed to be a professor or something? Haven't you learned that?"

Aryandor said with a sneering smile.

"How can you be here..."

The middle-aged man knew there was a war going on in the canyon and thought the academy would be safe.

He was greatly mistaken.

If Cromwell had not activated the academy's barrier in advance, the inside would have been a mess.

The middle-aged man, somewhat relieved, looked at Aryandor.

"But, I really don't want to waste my energy here, so could you open this barrier?"

"Nonsense! Get lost. This is not a place you can enter!"

"Hmm... No reward for it, is that it? How about this? If you open the barrier, I'll let you live."

The middle-aged man couldn't keep up with Aryandor's self-absorbed talk.

What on earth was he talking about?

The middle-aged man then raised his hand to the sky.

A red light emanated from his hand.

It was a signal prearranged with the people inside the academy.

'But who is that person behind him?'

The middle-aged man was more concerned about the person behind Aryandor than Aryandor himself.

Even though the person's identity was hidden by the hood, it gave off an ominous feeling.

The middle-aged man shook his head, thinking over the situation.

He needed to come up with a plan for Aryandor.

'He cannot enter.'

The middle-aged man, sweating, looked at Aryandor.

Seeing him stand in front of the academy like that, he couldn't easily break through the barrier.

Of course, breaking through the barrier shouldn't have been possible.

The barrier Cromwell had erected was a legacy passed down through generations.

It was a relic left by ancestors to protect the academy.

No matter how powerful Aryandor was, he shouldn't have been able to enter through a barrier created by the collective effort of dozens of ancestors.

However,

"Hmm... Are you saying you won't open the barrier even after what I said? Then."

Aryandor moved his hand towards the barrier, manipulating mana.

"When I enter, you'll be the first to die."

"...What?"

Aryandor's mana stirred, and the surroundings flickered.

"Time Back."

And then,

The barrier disappeared as if it had never been there.

"Hmm, it seems like the barrier was made with magical artifacts after all?"

Aryandor stepped forward into the academy.

He naturally entered the inside as if nothing had been blocking the way from the start.

The person in the hood followed him inside.

"Ah... Ah..."

The middle-aged man trembled and stepped back.

"As promised."

Aryandor drew his sword.

"You'll be the first to die."

Chapter 292: Completion (13)

"Attack!!!"

Rie, at the rear of the rebels, shouted to the soldiers.

As she shouted, she wondered,

'Is this really okay?'

Originally, Rie's role was to encircle the enemy completely.

When the rebels failed to break through the canyon ahead, they planned to capture all the fleeing enemies.

Though the order was issued a bit early, capturing all those troops seemed like a tough task.

"We'll have to reduce their forces as much as possible,"

Rie said, looking at Locke beside her.

"Understood. Let's do that,"

Locke replied, then dashed forward, running faster than the soldiers and shouting,

"For the Empire's eternal glory!"

"Glory!"

Locke led the troops, boosting their morale.

Thus, the northern soldiers collided with the rebel troops.

"Argh!"

"Block them!"

The rebel soldiers shouted, trying to stop them, but the northern soldiers' strength was overwhelming.

Ordinary soldiers fought like knights, each against three or four enemies.

"Is that the level of a soldier?"

"It's magic tools! They're equipped with magic tools!"

The reason for their strength was precisely the magic tools.

The magic tools provided by the Empire's Magic Tower.

Armors engraved with strengthening magic, swords with lightening magic, and various other magic tools were at their disposal.

With the already experienced Northern Army equipped with magic tools, they became soldiers worth a hundred men each.

"Princess...!"

Seeing this, Venderwood walked towards Rie, who was standing far away.

"Capture the commanders!"

The Northern Army rushed towards Venderwood.

"Interference."

Venderwood swung his sword at the approaching soldiers.

"Argh!"

"Block!"

Even though they were equipped with magic tools, ordinary soldiers couldn't stand against Venderwood.

Locke saw the soldiers being cut down by Venderwood's sword and immediately ran towards him.

"Northern swordsmanship, Blue Blade."

A blue sword energy flew towards Venderwood.

Venderwood swung his great sword, wrapped in sword energy, cutting through the blue blade.

"...The guardian's son?"

The guardian referred to Locke's father, the guardian of the north.

Locke responded,

"I am now the guardian."

Though Locke hadn't officially inherited the Lord's position, he was virtually no different from a Lord.

He took care of the domain's affairs and was equal or superior in strength to his father.

The reason he hadn't inherited the domain was merely because he hadn't graduated from the academy yet.

"Is that so."

Venderwood held his sword with a calm face.

"Then come at me, guardian."

Locke prepared to charge with his sword.

Then,

"Hey."

"...?"

A voice came from behind Locke.

That was Rie's voice.

Venderwood furrowed his brow.

Rie was supposed to be quite a distance away.

He hesitated for a moment, surprised she had gotten so close so quickly.

"What's the matter?"

"You, what did you say?"

"?"

"Didn't you tell the soldiers to advance? Why are they getting held back by this guy?"

"But..."

"I'll take care of this guy."

Rie, manipulating her mana, looked at Venderwood.

"I owe this guy one."

When the rebels attacked the academy, Rie had been defeated by Venderwood.

As a result, Yuni had been put in danger.

Rie hadn't forgotten that.

She constantly played it back, dwelling on the feeling of defeat and training hard.

Just as Rudy had changed, so had Rie, all to get back at this guy.

"What are you doing?"

Rie hit Locke on the back.

Locke, looking puzzled for a moment, then ran towards where the soldiers were. Rie watched Locke run off into the distance and then turned her head.

"You said you were a slave, right?"

Venderwood, confused by Rie's sudden question, nodded anyway.

"Yes, as you know, I'm a Princess and soon to be Empress. Normally, just meeting me should move you to tears. But let's skip all that today."

Rie rolled up her sleeves and threw off cumbersome decorations to the ground.

"Forget about status and all, just throw everything aside and fight."

Red light gleamed in Rie's eyes.

Venderwood flinched at the sight of Rie smiling.

She was different from before.

Rie wasn't on the throne yet and was still young.

Yet, she had an overwhelming presence.

And that wasn't all. She exuded the air and composure of a veteran warrior.

"I wonder if you know how much I've wanted to fight you."

Rie stretched her arms to the sky and manipulated her mana.

"Light that illuminates the world, come to this place."

Rie's mana rose to the sky through her arms.

Red energies twirled upwards, forming a large flame above, like the sun.

Rie whispered,

"Helios."

Venderwood stared blankly at Rie's flames.

Rie then said to Venderwood,

"Let's settle the score for hurting my sister."

Meanwhile, at the academy.

"Block them!"

"Protect the students! Evacuate them!"

An emergency signal went off at the academy. The students were sent to safety, and the professors came forward, risking their lives.

"How long do you plan to hold out? Do you think holding out will let you do anything?"

Aryandor faced the professors with a relaxed expression.

The professors were no match for Aryandor.

Most professors remaining at the rear specialized in research.

This was because the professors capable of fighting were already on the battlefield.

"What will you do?"

The professors spoke quietly while facing Aryandor.

"Can Professor Gracie fight?"

"It doesn't look likely. Her condition is currently not good. And even if Professor Gracie was in her normal state, this guy..."

The professors had already unleashed several attacks on Aryandor.

However, Aryandor hadn't fallen.

In fact, he hadn't even received a scratch.

The professors' attacks were all nullified by Aryandor's time magic.

Aryandor's attacks were not weak either.

His attacks, involving dozens of sword techniques, were unpredictable and each strike was lethal.

The professors, quick to judge, had already concluded the outcome of this fight in their minds.

Defeat.

The word filled the professors' heads.

Still, they had to hold out.

It was uncertain whether they could afford to do so on the battlefield, but they had to wait for reinforcements.

As the professors were thinking this, Aryandor spoke up.

"Let me make you an offer."

The professors listened.

"Saint Haruna is here, isn't she?"

Silence fell on the professors' side.

"Just tell me where she is, and I'll spare your lives and those of the students hiding far away."

Everyone's lives could be spared.

By sacrificing just one person.

"How about it? It's quite an enticing offer, isn't it?"

Aryandor smirked coldly.

Sacrifice Haruna.

Then everyone's lives...

Upon this, the professors fell into a dilemma, but one of them spoke up.

"We refuse."

"What?"

Aryandor looked at the people beside him.

They, too, stared back at Aryandor with stern eyes.

"So you're saying you all choose to die?"

Aryandor spoke with a face that couldn't understand.

Yet, the professors' opinion did not change.

Aryandor ground his teeth.

"So you're pretending to be noble? You're not like that. Sacrificing one for the sake of everyone..."

Aryandor began to say something incomprehensible and then closed his mouth.

"So... you've decided to make that decision."

He drew his sword.

"Then die. All of you."

After Aryandor and the professors began their fight,

"Saint, will you just stay here?"

"Yes."

"But... Aryandor is coming...!"

"I can't leave this place."

A slight argument was happening in the student council office.

This conversation was between Haruna, who was determined to protect the sacred place, and Yuni, who was trying to convince her to escape.

Yuni tried everything to make Haruna flee, but Haruna wouldn't budge.

So, Yuni could only pace anxiously.

"We could escape now and plan later..."

"There won't be a later. Once this place is overtaken, it's over."

"What?"

After pondering Haruna's words for a moment, Yuni asked,

"Did you see the future?"

"I won't talk about that. Staying here is the best option for now."

Yuni sighed deeply and sat down after staring at Haruna for a while.

Seeing Yuni sit, Haruna quietly said,

"How about you run away, Yuni?"

"How can I run if you don't? I'd surely get a scolding from my senior if I ran away now."

Haruna asked,

"Are you afraid of getting scolded?"

"I'm not afraid of being scolded. Getting scolded by my senior is almost a daily thing. But I'm really scared of my senior disliking me."

Yuni shuddered at the thought, and Haruna smiled gently.

"You must really like Rudy."

"Of course. But I wonder if that blockhead senior knows how much I care about him."

"He knows. Very well. It's just that the timing doesn't allow for expression."

"Really? To me, it seems like he's just clueless."

"Well, I can't say he isn't clueless."

Yuni and Haruna continued their chat, sitting on the floor. This conversation somewhat eased the tension.

"Ah! Since you can see the future, why don't you take a look? We're going to keep hiding here anyway. What happens between me and senior in the future?"

"The future, you say."

"Ah, right. You said you can't see the process... Just the outcome, then! Will we be holding hands, going on dates, maybe even kissing..."

Haruna listened to Yuni with a stern face, then smiled gently.

"I think we're a little too relaxed."

"Eh? Are you changing the subject?"

"If I start looking into personal futures like that, there'd be no end to it."

"That's stingy of you, Saint. You've looked into your own future, haven't you?"

"I have... And that's why it shouldn't be done."

"...What?"

Thud.

Then, a rumbling sound was heard.

Haruna quickly moved to cover Yuni's mouth with her hand.

"Mmph...!"

"Let's be quiet for a moment."

Haruna listened attentively to the sounds outside, remaining silent.

"Where... Haruna... must find..."

A faint voice was heard.

It was Aryandor's voice. Aryandor had arrived on this floor.

'But he doesn't know we're here.'

Aryandor didn't know where the entrance to the sanctuary was.

That's why he was searching for Haruna.

Using the Saint, there was a way to find the sanctuary.

After holding their breath for a few seconds, no more sounds came from outside. Haruna sighed in relief and let go of Yuni.

"...Did he leave?"

"It looks like it..."

Suddenly, a tremendous explosion occurred.

The entire floor's rooms were split in half. The walls crumbled down, and all the rooms were exposed.

"What the..."

If they had been standing up even slightly, they would have been split in half.

More than that, the sheer power left them speechless.

The sword's force had sliced the entire floor in half, and they were astounded.

"Ah. Found you."

Then a voice was heard.

It was Aryandor's.

"Why are you trying so hard to hide? You were bound to be found eventually."

Aryandor, covered in blood, seemed to have killed many people on his way here.

"Uh..."

Haruna stepped back, biting her lip.

"Do you know how long I've been searching for you? It's been over five years already."

Aryandor broke through the walls and entered the student council office where Haruna was.

'Too fast.'

She hadn't expected to be found this quickly.

'I must hold out somehow...'

Haruna thought.

Was there a way to escape Aryandor in this place?

Haruna didn't have the ability to fight.

Physically, she was far inferior to Aryandor.

Even if she ran, she would be caught quickly.

So then... what to do...

As she pondered,

"Excuse me. Following someone around for 5 years? That's stalking. It's a crime, you know."

Yuni, who was beside Haruna, stepped forward.

Aryandor tilted his head in confusion at Yuni's appearance.

"...And who are you?"

Haruna was too terrified to speak properly.

Yet, this small girl stood up boldly.

"Y-Yuni... W-we need to r-run..."

"It's okay. I don't abandon friends."

Yuni turned back, smiling, and said,

"I'll protect you..."

Despite her words, Yuni's legs and hands were trembling.

Aryandor narrowed his eyes in disbelief.

"You think you can stop me?"

"Why are you using informal language from the get-go? You're quite rude."

Aryandor was taken aback by Yuni's response.

"If you just hand her over, I could spare your life?"

"Do you really think I would do that?"

"Choosing death even when you have a chance to live?"

"No, what I chose isn't death. I'm simply doing what needs to be done. As the Student Council President, I have a duty to protect everyone inside the academy."

Aryandor lifted his sword.

"So, being the current Student Council President means you're the second Princess."

"You know about that?"

"I'm curious what expression Rudy Astria will make when you die."

At that, Yuni's expression hardened.

"...Hearing about Rudy from you really puts me in a bad mood."

"So, what are you going to do?"

Yuni manipulated her mana.

"I'll fight."

Aryandor smirked.

"Go ahead, try."

"Stop right there!"

Suddenly, a woman's voice came from the other end of the corridor.

"Am I... too late? Oh, maybe not?"

The woman spoke with a slightly flustered voice.

Her entrance was clumsy for what was quite a dramatic arrival.

Yuni looked towards the source of the unexpected voice.

"Huh?"

The owner of the voice coming from the end of the corridor was.

"Hey! Yuni! Are you okay?"

It was Luna Railer, an apprentice wizard from the Magic Tower.

Chapter 293: Completion (14)

Luna couldn't originally participate in the war.

Unlike Astina or Rie, she had no responsibilities to bear.

She was merely an apprentice wizard, the heir to a very small territory, and a student at the academy.

With such status, she couldn't take part in the war.

Moreover, the Magic Tower recognized her as a great talent.

If Luna were to be seriously injured in the war, it would be a significant loss for the Magic Tower.

So, from the Empire's standpoint, it wasn't beneficial either. So the Magic Tower prevented Luna from going to the battlefield.

A few days before the war started,

Franz, the Empire's head wizard, summoned Luna.

"...You called for me?"

"Luna, you look down."

"How could I not be when all my friends are fighting?"

Luna appeared unusually dispirited.

Part of the reason for her semi-imprisonment was the fear that she might flee to the battlefield.

Though confining her might seem excessive, she had repeatedly caused a commotion by asking to be sent to the battlefield, so everyone considered it a justified measure.

Tap tap.

Franz tapped his fingers on the desk, observing Luna, then spoke quietly.

"Do you want to go there that badly?"

"...?"

Franz sighed and handed her a piece of paper.

"This is..."

"A request for assistance from the Empire. They want us to supply equipment to the Northern Army."

Luna was puzzled by his statement.

"To supply that equipment, someone from the Magic Tower must go, right? Do you understand what I'm implying?"

Luna brightened at that.

"Can I, can I go?"

"What's so joyful about going to a battlefield..."

"I can protect my friends."

Luna smiled brightly.

Seeing her smile, Franz also smiled.

"Should I go right away then?"

"No, promise me one thing before you leave."

Franz's expression turned serious as he spoke.

"Stay at the back at all times. I know your strength well. Your magic is meant to protect, not to kill.

So, absolutely, absolutely stay at the back!"

"...Understood."

Luna agreed, but she intended to assess the situation and go to the battlefield to assist Rudy.

However.

"Red alert!"

"...What? What's that?"

"An intruder seems to have breached the academy.... Luna, you should run..."

While Luna was addressing some faculty matters at the academy, Aryandor attacked.

Hearing this, Luna had a flash of insight.

'Did Franz predict this...!'

"Where are you going, Luna!"

"Heinz, please run away quickly! I have somewhere I need to be!"

Leaving the faculty member behind, Luna stood up and immediately started walking.

"I heard Yuni was at the academy..."

Luna intended to go help Yuni.

Since Yuni is the Student Council President, she wouldn't have run away immediately.

'Should I head to the Student Council Office first?'

While Luna was on her way,

Boom!

A loud noise echoed through the academy.

Luna reacted to the sound.

"That's..."

It was the main building where the Student Council Office was located.

Luna felt her heart sink.

And she ran.

Worried that Yuni might be there, she arrived at the building.

Upon reaching the floor with the Student Council Office, she heard a voice.

"Go ahead, try it."

It was Aryandor.

Luna widened her eyes and took out Levian's Spellbook from her bag.

"Stop right there!!!!!!"

She shouted to stop the opponent.

Aryandor turned his head at Luna's voice.

Seeing Aryandor covered in blood made her realize others might have already been seriously harmed.

Luna cautiously spoke up.

"Am I too late? Or not?"

Luna said with a lack of confidence.

As various thoughts crossed her mind.

"Huh?"

"Oh! Yuni! Are you okay?"

Yuni appeared.

Seeing Yuni unharmed, Luna sighed in relief.

It seemed Yuni hadn't fought with Aryandor yet.

'If I had been a bit later, it could have been disastrous.'

But it's okay.

I wasn't too late.

Luna glared sharply at Aryandor.

"Stop bothering them, and fight me instead."

Luna said this and glanced behind Aryandor.

She saw a person wearing a hood.

The person was wearing a large robe, so their physique wasn't clear, but from their height and the faint outline of their body, they appeared to be female.

'Who is that person...?'

But there was no time to figure it out.

"Are you Luna Railer?"

Aryandor rushed towards Luna at a fast pace.

Luna infused mana into the spellbook.

"Barrier."

Ping—

The barrier clashed with the sword, and Aryandor's sword was blocked by Luna's barrier.

Aryandor furrowed his brows.

"Blocked?"

The magic Luna used was a standard barrier spell.

It usually wasn't the strongest.

Yet, it blocked Aryandor's sword.

Aryandor then looked at the spellbook in Luna's hand.

Levian's Spellbook.

The spellbook he had created at the cost of his life.

"Royal swordsmanship."

Upon seeing the spellbook, Aryandor immediately enveloped his sword with sword energy.

'This was originally a spellbook I had given up on.'

Initially, he planned to use that spellbook, but after finding another method, he had given up on it.

Despite this, the spellbook in front of him wasn't something to be discarded lightly.

"Full Moon,"

'I'll snatch it first.'

Aryandor's sword cut through the surroundings in a circular motion, accompanied by a golden wave.

——!

The barrier and the sword clashed violently.

Waves spread around, causing a strong wind.

After the wind subsided, Aryandor looked at the barrier.

"Interesting, it still blocks?"

Aryandor was amazed that the barrier, uncracked by his attack, held up.

He had planned to pierce the barrier with his swordsmanship, but Luna's barrier didn't budge.

The spellbook could engrave magic circles and use them at will.

The barrier Luna created was the result of her research, the most fortified barrier she could make.

That's why it could withstand Aryandor's sword.

Although Luna could protect herself this way, staying passive wasn't the answer.

Aryandor turned his head, looking back.

"Do you think staying still like a turtle will work?"

Behind Aryandor were Yuni and Haruna.

"Uh...."

Luna flipped the pages of the spellbook and infused it with mana again.

"Grow!"

At Luna's shout, plants grew out of the building.

Giant vines rapidly approached Aryandor.

"Do you think this will work?"

Aryandor, seeing the vines, effortlessly swung his sword.

As Aryandor swung his sword,

Luna quickly ran towards Yuni.

"Where do you think you're going?"

Aryandor wasn't one to let that slip by.

He swung his sword at Luna, who was running towards him.

The sword aimed precisely at Luna's heart, speeding towards it to pierce...

"...?"

Surely, he had thrust the sword at Luna, but there was no contact.

Then, that form lightly passed by the sword towards Yuni.

"Illusion magic?"

Aryandor quickly turned his head.

Luna hadn't moved from her original spot.

It had only appeared like she moved due to the illusion.

By the time Aryandor was delayed by this twice,

Luna was preparing a spell.

"The guilty shall receive their deserved punishment."

Luna was filling the spellbook with mana.

The movement of mana caused her hair to flutter.

Aryandor found this ridiculous.

'Not just surviving... she intends to win?'

The professors in front of the academy were only trying to hold out, not thinking of winning.

But here was this girl, not even graduated from the academy, believing she could beat him.

"Divine Punishment!"

Then, a huge lightning bolt fell from the sky.

—!

The lightning bolt that pierced through the building struck Aryandor squarely.

"Kuh! Time Back."

Aryandor immediately used time magic.

He was unharmed and had moved behind Luna.

"But to think you only plan to win against me..."

Aryandor said this as he attempted to swing his sword at Luna.

However, he couldn't move his sword.

It was because Luna's magic had been activated instantly.

"...!"

Aryandor's eyes widened.

He wasn't using magic at that moment.

This meant he had been lured here after Luna had already prepared her magic.

Aryandor muttered in a low voice.

"Unbelievable..."

Luna smirked and looked behind her.

In her hand was a square box.

This box was a magical device used in past individual assessment practices.

It was a device designed to focus Astina's telekinesis magic, specifically gravity magic, to a single point.

"I already know your abilities."

Luna had anticipated this.

She expected Aryandor to use time magic after being hit by her magic.

And that he would definitely move to the best position to kill her.

That's why she had set the coordinates of the magical device to behind her and used the magic as soon as Aryandor moved.

Aryandor was pressed down by the force and collapsed on the spot.

"Time... Kuh!"

He tried to use time magic, but his body was pressed down.

It was a pressure he had never felt from Astina or Cromwell.

He knew there was a difference in power between using magic normally and using magic with magic circles, but it was surprising to experience pressure strong enough to prevent the use of magic.

Luna flipped the page of the spellbook again and infused it with mana.

As she was about to use magic again.

"Luna senior! It's dangerous!"

"Eh?"

The person behind Aryandor.

The person wearing the hood, holding a dagger, charged at Luna.

Yuni noticed and immediately used magic.

"Lightning Chain!"

Strong electricity engulfed the person in the hood.

The person was struck by the electricity and flung away.

"Ah."

As the person was sent flying by the magic, the hood came off.

Yuni, Luna, and Haruna all recognized the person's face.

It was Aryandor's sister, known to be a key figure, so they had all seen her face at least once.

"...Beatrice?"

The person's face was that of Saint Beatrice.

"Kuh...!"

At that moment, Aryandor moved.

He took advantage of the moment Luna was distracted.

"Quick Blade."

He moved quickly and escaped from the spot where Luna had set the magic.

Luna widened her eyes at this.

"Finger of the Demon!"

She used the spellbook to cast magic as quickly as possible.

"It's useless."

Aryandor said, seeing the black pillars rising towards him.

"Time Back."

Luna reacted quickly.

If he reverses time...!

She saw Yuni and Haruna behind her.

These two were in danger.

But to cast a barrier...

Crash!

"...?"

A sound came from Aryandor's direction.

Aryandor, struck by the black pillars Luna had summoned, rolled back and fell.

"Huh???"

He had definitely used time magic.

Yet, he neither moved locations nor healed his body, and simply rolled away, hit by Luna's attack.

"Did I make a mistake?"

It was unlikely for Aryandor to err, but there was no other reason he couldn't use time magic unless he made a mistake.

Luna looked on, puzzled.

Tap.

As she watched Aryandor, a warm sensation hovered over Luna's head.

"How can you get distracted during battle? No matter what happens, you must focus on your opponent."

"...Ah."

Luna turned around.

And she saw the face of the person behind her.

"Ugh...."

"Don't worry. You can be distracted now."

What caught Luna's eyes was.

"I'm here now."

The smiling face of Rudy.

Chapter 294: Completion (15)

"Aryandor, you've been here all this time?"

"Did you know all along?"

Aryandor, touching the area where he had been hit, spoke.

I looked at Aryandor in front of me, then turned my gaze to the side.

A person with Beatrice's face.

I narrowed my eyes.

Looking at that person, I realized what they had done.

Research conducted by the leadership of the rebel forces.

The abilities they used.

Though Serina's case was a bit different, most were related to the human body.

That's when I thought.

His goal is Beatrice.

Could it be he aims to revive Beatrice?

Of course, it's uncertain how the term 'revive' will apply here.

Can bringing back just her mind truly be considered revival?

If the body lives but the mind is different, is that resurrection?

If he revives her in such a way, what would his purpose be?

Many thoughts crossed my mind, but the conclusion was the same.

The revival method he wants is to create a body and put Beatrice into it.

I may not know the purpose, but the desired outcome was clear.

And that outcome was right before my eyes.

Human cloning.

The Aryandor I had met and Beatrice in front of me.

This was the only explanation for the two of them.

"Still, it's not too late."

I smiled and looked at Luna next to me.

"Good job, Luna."

"Ehehe."

Luna scratched her head at my words.

"Now, cover our backs. I'll take care of him."

"Okay! I'm counting on you!"

I sent Luna behind me and clenched my fist.

I looked at Aryandor.

He had a completely different vibe from the Aryandor I had met earlier.

It felt distinctly like the Aryandor I originally knew.

Aryandor pushed himself up from the ground.

"Did Haruna tell you the future?"

"No, just my judgment."

"That's ridiculous. If that was really me there, you all would have been wiped out. You think coming here made a difference?"

"Maybe? Even if you were there, I doubt it would have been a wipeout. The people there are quite strong."

The battlefield included not just Astina and Professor Cromwell but many others.

Even if I had briefly stepped away, I doubted there would have been any major change without my presence.

If Aryandor hadn't been here, I could've just used spatial magic to return quickly.

In the end, my senses were correct.

Since he himself said that his counterpart was fake, there was no need to verify.

"But do you think anything will change because you came?"

"A lot has already changed. And your body isn't in normal condition either."

Aryandor couldn't get past Luna.

While Luna had become stronger, his physical condition was odd.

The mana flowing through his body was tangled in a complex, messy way.

This meant that, while his body could move, he wouldn't be able to properly wield his sword energy.

"Did creating clones tangle up your mana?"

Mana entanglement usually results from a penalty due to mana overload.

Having trained in dark magic myself and experienced its backlash, I was well aware of this.

"Sharp tongue."

Aryandor pointed his sword at me.

"Yeah, I've spoken too much. Sorry. Now, let's."

I dashed forward swiftly.

Aryandor filled his sword with mana.

I did the same with my fist.

He had the same idea.

Dominate the opponent from the first move.

"Come forth, Belphegor."

As I spoke, the figure of a demon appeared behind me.

Different from the demon Professor Robert used, but one capable of similar power.

I took a deep breath and raised my fist.

Aryandor did the same with his sword.

"Royal swordsmanship."

A golden light shone from Aryandor's eyes.

"Moonlight."

We both launched our attacks simultaneously.

A massive sword energy burst from Aryandor, and mana exploded from my fist.

—————!

After a bright flash.

Boom!!!

An explosion occurred.

Since it was inside a building, the building crumbled, sending debris flying.

I was unharmed because I countered the attack.

"Ugh!!"

Looking back, I saw Luna had protected Haruna and Yuni with a protective spell, so they were fine.

However, a large dust cloud obscured our view.

"Sigh..."

I took a deep breath.

And focused.

Feeling the flow of mana.

The next attack would come from.

"The right."

I widened my eyes and stretched my hand to the side.

Aryandor was precisely there.

I dodged Aryandor's sword aimed at me and grabbed it.

"Found you."

"Think it's over just because you found me?"

Aryandor, looking at his captured sword, spoke.

He quickly released the sword.

And kicked towards my stomach.

Thud!

"Ugh!"

A swordsman releasing his sword?

I took an unexpected hit directly to my stomach.

Aryandor clenched his fist and approached me quickly.

I gritted my teeth, ignoring the pain in my stomach.

"Alright, let's do this."

I threw Aryandor's sword to the side and clenched my fist.

I was confident in my punching skills.

I threw my fist straight at Aryandor.

At the same time, Aryandor also threw his fist, hitting my face.

Receive minimal hits, deliver maximum damage.

Aryandor and I exchanged punches, taking hits from each other's attacks continuously.

I didn't have time to fill my fist with a large amount of mana.

I just kept launching attacks one after another.

Aryandor, being a magic swordsman, had a sturdy body, but mine was not.

However, by infusing my fists with mana, I could deliver stronger hits than my opponent.

It was essentially a clash between a spear and a shield.

And the outcome was...

"Ugh..."

My victory.

Aryandor staggered and stepped back.

I looked at Aryandor and spat blood-mixed saliva onto the floor.

"Why would a swordsman discard his sword?"

I smirked at Aryandor.

But my situation wasn't entirely good either.

Even though I had reinforcement magic on me, reducing the impact to a minimum, my face and body still hurt.

Of course, Aryandor was in a worse state.

"Huff... Huff..."

Aryandor, wiping the blood off his face, looked visibly exhausted.

He was clearly in bad shape.

"Why don't you use time magic?"

I was fully prepared to block it.

Thanks to practicing with Ian, I had learned how to counter time magic to some extent.

The fact that it worked during my fight with Luna proved I had mastered it quite well.

Then, Aryandor's sword flew at me from the side.

"What...!"

Looking to the side, there was a woman with Beatrice's face.

She had picked up the sword I had thrown away.

"Huff..."

I sighed and looked at Aryandor.

He couldn't freely use time magic in his condition.

Aryandor quietly raised his hand.

The gesture was one he made every time he used time magic.

I frowned.

"Time Back."

"Priscilla."

—!

I immediately blocked the time magic.

Seeing that his time magic was blocked, Aryandor quickly raised his head.

"Time magic won't work."

With my words, Aryandor flashed a cold smile.

"Do you really think so?"

Then his mana surged.

"...?"

Using mana like that...

Aryandor's mana was tangled.

Forcing tangled mana to move like that would lead to immense pain.

Yet, Aryandor moved his mana.

"Time magic..."

I tried to block his magic, as if it were obvious.

Aryandor's bitter smile.

Seeing that smile, I felt uneasy.

With such a method of mana manipulation...

I had used that kind of mana manipulation before.

Just a moment ago, when I cut through Venderwood.

I used spatial magic multiple times to tear his body apart.

Then.

"Ugh!"

I immediately prepared my mana.

He planned to use time magic dozens of times.

There's only one reason for using mana in such a way.

If he can revert his physical state by turning back time, then he wouldn't receive any penalty.

Since he damaged my body, he plans to turn back time to return to his original state.

"Ha... You're not yet familiar with that technique. But, I am. It's a spell I've used dozens, hundreds of times."

Aryandor's surroundings began to ripple.

"Priscilla!"

"There's too many!"

Dozens of time magic spells were being activated at once.

If even one of them was executed, time would reverse.

I concentrated and started erasing the magic.

But... there were too many.

I couldn't erase them all.

Such unfair magic...

Using mana to reverse time.

Using physical energy to reverse time.

And there's no penalty for it.

How can such magic exist?

Is that why it's called divine magic?

I thought this as I tried to erase the time magic.

But then, a thought occurred to me.

The term "divine magic" is a name given by humans.

As Haruna said, it was a nickname created when religion, politics, and magic all combined their powers.

Then...

This is ordinary magic.

Magic that involves an equivalent exchange between mana and magic.

Then, there must be something he loses.

What exchange allows him to reverse time?

I pondered this, thinking that if time reverses, I would lose.

The contemplation was brief.

Then, Beatrice's face caught my eye.

Human cloning.

The human body.

The body's state is reversed.

It definitely returns to a past state.

That's when I questioned.

Why could he continue to remember?

If his body returned to the past, shouldn't the memories of this fight disappear too?

With this doubt, I looked at Aryandor.

The gesture Aryandor was making with his hand.

It looked like he was flicking his fingers to use it.

But, I thought the opposite.

Could that be a distraction?

I shifted my gaze from Aryandor's hand.

To Aryandor's other hand.

I looked at his hand.

It was in his pocket.

I took a breath.

That's it.

"Time..."

"Transfer."

I gave up on erasing the time magic and used spatial magic instead.

It wasn't moving my body.

But something on the opponent's body.

Moving that object.

"...!"

Then Aryandor's eyes widened.

"What's this?"

Then, a pocket watch landed in my hand.

This was the item that had been in Aryandor's pocket.

I had transferred the object into my hand.

I looked at Aryandor.

He had attempted to use time magic, but now all his magic was stopped.

I smirked.

"Ah, sorry. I have a habit of looking for the trick first whenever I see magic."

I grabbed the chain of the pocket watch and swung it side to side.

This was it.

"So, is this how it works? Time magic."

This was the trick behind the time magic.

Chapter 295: Completion (16)

I glanced at the pocket watch in my hand, causing Haruna to widen her eyes.

"The Spirit of Ophillius..."

I quickly looked behind me.

"Haruna, do you know about this?"

"There's no exact name for it, but it's called the Spirit of Ophillius."

"The Spirit of Ophillius?"

"It's a device used by time magic users to record the past. I don't know the details of its use, but your guess was probably right, Rudy."

The past...

It felt like the pieces of the puzzle were falling into place.

A device to record the past.

It was used to cover the flaws of time magic.

Like spatial magic, time magic wasn't divine magic.

It was magic used by sacrificing memories.

Only hidden by magical tools, it was no different from ordinary magic.

Aryandor was grinding his teeth, glaring at me.

I smirked in response.

"Try using time magic."

He wouldn't be able to use time magic.

Even if he could turn back time, he would forget that I learned the trick of time magic.

Fighting me in that state, knowing everything already, would surely lead to my victory.

I laughed.

I had completely sealed off time magic.

He was tangled in mana and couldn't unleash his full power.

"How about you give up now?"

I suggested surrender to him.

Even now, people are dying on the battlefield.

If he surrenders, we can quickly clean up the battlefield and reduce casualties.

"You wouldn't want the rebels to be annihilated, would you?"

"Annihilated...?"

At my words, Aryandor bowed his head.

"If you surrender willingly, I'll spare the lives of the rebels."

"..."

Of course, I had no intention of sparing Aryandor.

With so many rebel soldiers, it wasn't possible to punish them all, but I planned to make an example of the leadership.

"What do you say?"

Aryandor quietly raised his head in response.

"Ha ha..."

Aryandor smirked and laughed like a madman.

"Laughing?"

"Such nonsense. As if I would accept such a proposal."

I looked at him incredulously.

"Even if it means saving your comrades... Such a proposal?"

"Comrades? Who are the comrades?"

"What?"

"They are tools. Tools for achieving my goals. Have you ever seen someone sacrifice for tools?"

Tools?

The people who were with him were just tools?

Veins throbbed on my forehead.

"You're even more of a piece of sh*t than I thought."

"They probably think of me as a tool too. The rebels and I were just companions with the same goal for a while. And."

Aryandor's eyes were filled with madness.

"I don't think I've lost this fight."

He stretched his hand to the side.

Beatrice was beside him.

"Ugh..."

As Aryandor reached out, light emanated from Beatrice.

This made Haruna's eyes widen.

"We must block it!"

I felt it too.

I didn't know the exact reason for cloning Beatrice, but there was definitely a reason he had brought her clone.

I had no intention of letting his plan succeed.

As I dashed forward quickly, Aryandor retracted his hand and blocked my path.

"Kuh!"

Aryandor's sword clashed with my fist.

He grimaced and was pushed back slightly.

I yelled out.

"Luna!"

"Got it!"

Luna understood my intention and quickly opened her magic book, pouring mana into it.

"Point Explosion!"

A small flame ignited in front of Beatrice, about to explode.

Aryandor, seeing this, turned around.

He wrapped his sword in sword energy and sliced through the rising flame.

I immediately charged at Aryandor.

"Opportunity."

Aryandor, having turned around, had no chance to block my attack.

I infused my hand with mana and struck Aryandor down.

Boom!

Aryandor was slammed into the ground.

"Cough!"

He spat out blood.

I glanced at him briefly before turning away.

At the end of my gaze was Beatrice.

The air around us changed.

Even the aura emanating from Beatrice had changed.

"What have you done..."

Before I could finish my question,

Beatrice manipulated mana.

And the words that came out of her mouth made my eyes widen.

"Time Back."

The words from Beatrice's mouth were the incantation for time magic.

Beatrice disappeared.

She reappeared behind Luna.

The sudden use of time magic left no room for defense.

"Ugh!"

Beatrice attempted to stab Luna with a dagger.

"Luna!"

"Ah!"

Yuni quickly moved and pushed Luna away.

Thanks to her, they avoided Beatrice's dagger.

"Using time magic?"

Aryandor had imparted time magic in that brief moment.

That was the only explanation for this situation.

I couldn't understand him.

He cloned Beatrice, whom I thought was his goal, and used her like this.

I was sure his objective was the resurrection of Beatrice.

I thought he caused all this to resurrect a family member he cherished, but the current situation didn't seem like it.

Someone who cherished people wouldn't have called the rebels tools.

"Rudy!"

That's when Haruna called out.

"Understood!"

Luna and the others couldn't possibly face Beatrice, who was using time magic.

"Time Back."

Beatrice attempted to use time magic again.

"Priscilla!"

I used Priscilla to block her magic.

Beatrice, seeing her magic blocked, looked at me and raised her dagger, which was swirling with sword energy.

Using both time magic and sword energy in her body, she was essentially Beatrice yet not Beatrice.

"Royal Swordsmanship."

Beatrice charged at me with her dagger.

"Full Moon."

I attempted to counter her attack.

Then, I saw Aryandor passing by me.

He had gotten up from where he had been the moment I diverted my gaze.

His sword was aimed at Haruna.

"Damn!"

I couldn't catch Aryandor, who had passed by in an instant, because Beatrice was blocking me.

"Ugh!"

Haruna twisted her body trying to dodge Aryandor's attack, but she couldn't completely avoid it.

Her shoulder was slashed by his sword, and blood spurted out.

The blood that burst forth shone brightly, despite being red, ordinary blood.

Aryandor, seeing the light, opened his mouth.

"...Is this the place?"

Seeing this, I immediately ran out.

"Cough!"

I quickly approached Aryandor and grabbed his neck, applying pressure.

"Choke... Cough..."

Aryandor struggled as if in pain, his face turning increasingly red, yet he was still laughing.

"Ugh... Cough!!"

Aryandor flailed in that state and then used his leg in a counter-move to target my other hand.

Snap!

"Ah...?"

In that hand, I was holding Aryandor's pocket watch.

Aryandor's kick hit the pocket watch precisely, and my eyes widened.

Throb!

Suddenly, a great shock hit my head.

Information was flowing in.

Numerous pieces of information struck my mind, causing a headache from the overload.

Feeling dizzy with so much information coming in, I let go of Aryandor, and he fell from my grasp.

"Cough..."

Aryandor gasped for air after being released from my grip and looked behind.

"Here! This is the place!"

Aryandor shouted to Beatrice.

"Rudy...!"

Haruna, bleeding from her shoulder, also shouted at me.

His mention of "place" meant he had found the entrance to the holy site.

I focused, trying to ignore the dizziness and pain, and looked at Aryandor.

And I filled my hand with mana.

Despite the influx of information and accompanying pain, I ignored everything and focused solely on Aryandor.

Beatrice ran towards Aryandor.

At the same time, I also stepped towards Aryandor.

"I won't let you escape."

I threw my punch forward.

Mana burst out.

——!

"Kuugh..."

My mana pierced through Aryandor's stomach.

As the mana tore through his abdomen, blood gushed from his mouth.

Seeing this, I staggered.

I must kill him for sure...

I can't leave any chance for retaliation...

With that thought, I tried to attack Aryandor once more.

But, I couldn't extend my fist.

My mind was flooded with jumbled information.

Even when I tried to use mana, my body wouldn't move.

I looked at Aryandor until the end.

Aryandor's body slumped.

I saw him falling to the ground, bleeding out.

Watching him, I lost consciousness and fell.

"...?"

I opened my eyes.

I looked around.

This place wasn't the academy.

I couldn't see Luna, Yuni, or Haruna, who were with me.

I lifted my head.

It was raining from the sky.

And then, I saw a boy and a girl ahead.

"You're my sister, right?"

The boy with black hair said to the girl in front of him.

And the girl, looking at the boy, opened her mouth with sad eyes.

"Aryandor..."

I widened my eyes.

Aryandor?

Looking closely at the girl.

"...Beatrice?"

It was the appearance of Saint Beatrice.

Chapter 296: Completion (17)

I blankly stared ahead.

Aryandor and Beatrice looked younger than the faces I knew.

Where am I?

I pondered deeply.

Just moments ago, I was fighting Aryandor.

But why am I here all of a sudden?

Then, a thought crossed my mind.

The pocket watch Aryandor had touched.

Surely, when it was hit, all sorts of information flooded into my head.

Is that why I'm seeing this scene now?

"How have you been... up until now?"

"I've been good. I've made a lot of friends... and saved many people..."

Then, Aryandor and Beatrice in front of me started talking.

They continued their conversation as if they couldn't see me standing right in front of them.

"It was hell for me. Being pushed around in the streets, striving hard working my body... And in doing so, I kept searching... I strived to continue

my search.

I..."

Beatrice hugged Aryandor.

"I'm sorry... I should have come sooner. I'm sorry."

After holding him for a moment, Beatrice let go.

Then, she reached out her hand to Aryandor.

"It's okay now that I'm here. It's all right now."

With a sad smile, Beatrice spoke.

"Let's go together. To a quiet place in the countryside... Let's live comfortably, just the two of us. You can meet someone you love, get married, and live comfortably... quietly... Let's live like that."

I tilted my head in confusion at that.

Beatrice made such an offer?

Was I witnessing something strange?

If such an event had happened, wouldn't the current situation be different?

I silently observed.

Aryandor quietly looked at the hand Beatrice offered him.

Then, he raised his head and looked into Beatrice's eyes.

"Sister... I now know the future."

"Yes, I know all about you learning time magic... and knowing the future..."

"So."

Aryandor interrupted Beatrice.

"I know what will happen later."

Aryandor clenched his fist.

"No matter what I do, no matter what happens, within a year, you will die."

"Aryandor."

"I've seen thousands, tens of thousands of futures. But in none of those futures did you survive. People demanded your sacrifice, and you accepted it. And those things were all trivial. You died for really minor things. I cannot accept that future."

Beatrice then closed her mouth tightly before finally speaking.

"Aryandor, everyone dies eventually."

"But, that doesn't have to be at a young age, before one's natural lifespan is up. Especially not for strangers one has never met before."

"No, if that life can help someone. If it can save someone. Then isn't it right to use it for that? Especially if it's a life that's going to end anyway."

"And then,"

Beatrice placed her hand on Aryandor's shoulder.

"Have you ever seen a future where I come to find you?"

"....."

"Even if you look at tens of thousands of futures, you can't know everything. That's the nature of the future. You might see a future where you die tomorrow, but you can't know if you'll really die tomorrow, the day after, or not at all."

Beatrice locked eyes with Aryandor.

"You shouldn't let such futures determine your life. The future is just a reference."

"No, I disagree."

Aryandor spoke firmly.

"I plan to change the future entirely. And your words just now have confirmed my belief."

"What?"

Aryandor smiled.

A bitter madness swirled in his laughter.

"We'll start over. A world where you don't become a Saint. A world where you don't have to sacrifice. That's the world we'll create."

"What are you talking about?"

This time, Aryandor reached out his hand to Beatrice.

"We're starting over. With dimension magic, it's possible. Creating a different world. Restarting this world is possible."

Beatrice's eyes widened.

"I don't understand what you're saying."

"We'll turn back the time of this world. To before we parted. To that time in Ephomos. And then, you won't become a Saint, and I won't learn time magic from Ophillius. If we go back to that time..."

Beatrice opened her mouth.

"Then what about now?"

"If we turn back time, now will cease to exist."

"So you're saying to erase the present itself?"

"Yes. We don't need a twisted world like this. A timeline where your death is certain and I'm broken."

"Aryandor..."

"Sister. Take my hand."

Aryandor smiled again, extending his hand once more.

"With a bit more research, it's possible. Maybe even now. Especially if you help, we can speed up the process."

Thwack!

Beatrice slapped Aryandor's hand away without hesitation.

".....?"

Aryandor looked at Beatrice, puzzled.

"Sister?"

"You're seriously mistaken about something."

"What do you mean? This is the way for all of us to be happy. A way to overcome this fate, this future..."

"That's not overcoming; it's avoidance."

Beatrice looked at Aryandor with a sad expression.

"Aryandor, it's not too late. Even now. If you go down that path, many people will die. Everyone around you."

"I know. But if we turn back time, all those people will come back. Everything will be reset to its original state. No, they might even live better lives. I know everything and can change those people's lives..."

"Then, can you truly say those people are themselves?"

The two were already walking different paths.

Beatrice opened her mouth with a pleading voice.

"Aryandor... this is the end... take my hand."

Aryandor looked at Beatrice and then turned away.

"If that's what you wish, Sister. I will leave."

His voice was cold.

He didn't look back.

"Aryandor..."

Aryandor went his own way, and Beatrice was left sitting on the ground, crying.

I quietly spoke up after watching them.

"So Beatrice is..."

Suddenly, everything in front of me became blurry.

"...So it ended up that way."

"Is that so..."

The surroundings changed.

It looked like a small study.

In front of me were Beatrice and an old man.

"...Levian?"

It was Levian, the man who had handed over the spellbook to Luna.

"We've reached the worst-case scenario."

Then, a phrase came to mind.

Levian's diary I saw in the Railer domain.

Levian had mentioned meeting Beatrice there.

The details weren't specified, though.

Levian looked at Beatrice and spoke.

"So, are we proceeding as planned?"

"Yes, we must. I've made up my mind after all."

A decision?

"It might be very painful. It's something no one has ever done before."

"I'm aware. But can I just summon someone... to suddenly fall into another dimension. I just feel sorry. It feels like I'm passing my responsibility onto them..."

I widened my eyes.

Summoning someone from another dimension.

They were talking about me.

"What will you do, Levian?"

"I have my preparations to make. I have my own sins to atone for."

Levian held a book in his hand.

The book was the spellbook used by Luna.

"Then I shall take my leave now."

"Thank you."

"What are you thanking me for? I'm the one who should be thankful."

Levian smiled with his eyes.

The warm wrinkles around his eyes made him look very kind.

After seeing that, my consciousness began to blur.

"Uh..."

My head was throbbing.

I grabbed my head and got up.

"Rudy!"

"Rudy! Are you okay?"

"Senior!"

Various voices were heard.

I opened my eyes and saw Yuni, Haruna, and Luna in front of me.

I quickly grasped the situation and asked.

"...How long have I been out?"

Haruna answered.

"It hasn't even been 5 minutes."

"Aryandor?"

"Beatrice supported him and took him inside the sanctuary."

The last scene I remembered was Aryandor being stabbed in the abdomen.

If Beatrice had supported him and taken him away, he was seriously injured.

I regained my composure and looked at the pocket watch in my hand.

The pocket watch appeared to be cracked from Aryandor's forceful strike.

However, the information it recorded was already in my head.

Countless pieces of information floated around in my mind.

From Aryandor's objectives, the futures he saw, to other details.

"I need to go... to the sanctuary."

I got up from my spot and steadied myself.

Then, I looked beside me.

Haruna was there.

"Haruna."

"...Yes."

"What are the chances of me winning in the futures you've seen?"

Haruna's expression hardened at my sudden question.

I asked Haruna again.

"How likely is it?"

After pondering for a moment, Haruna smiled.

Then she confidently said.

"100 percent."

It was a lie.

It couldn't possibly be 100 percent.

I was curious about what she would say, but her answer was so absurd that it made me laugh.

In truth, the future didn't matter much to me.

Whatever the future holds, I can overcome it.

I've always done so.

"If it's 100 percent, then there's no problem."

I loosened up a bit and reached out my hand to Luna.

"Luna, can you help me?"

"Huh?"

Luna looked at me, puzzled.

"I think I'll need your help."

Hearing my words, Luna smiled and nodded.

"Yeah! Okay."

"Senior... Are you sure you're okay?"

Yuni, who was beside me, asked with a worried look.

I nodded.

"Just a bit dizzy, but not enough to stop me from fighting."

Although I had used up mana, my physical condition wasn't too bad.

"Yuni, please inform the others about the situation. Luna and I will head into the sanctuary."

"...Okay, I understand."

I reached out and patted Yuni's head.

I stroked her hair a few times and smiled.

"Take care."

"Okay..."

Then, I turned around.

"Luna, shall we go?"

"...Yeah."

Hearing Luna's response, I activated my mana.

Chapter 297: Completion (18)

I took Luna's hand and moved mana.

The surroundings flickered, and the space shifted.

Luna, observing the changing space, asked me,

"How can I help?"

"Spellbook. We need to use the spellbook."

"Spellbook?"

Luna looked at the spellbook in her hand.

"That's the key to our current situation."

This spellbook perfectly adhered to the laws of magic.

The First Law of Magic: Equivalent Exchange.

The fact that this book could activate a magic circle by simply inputting mana advanced that law further.

A book that makes anything possible with mana alone.

That was Levian's spellbook.

"I'm going to use this book to eliminate time magic."

"...Time magic?"

Before answering Luna's question, we arrived at the sacred place.

A giant temple.

Dozens of jars were placed around it.

"...Have we arrived?"

And in front of it, Aryandor was sitting, bleeding from a stomach wound.

I looked down at Aryandor, who was in no condition to fight.

Yet, he used his sword like a cane to stand up as we approached.

"Rudy Astria. You understand the situation now, don't you?"

Aryandor looked at me with a smile.

"Yes. Now the whole picture is starting to come together."

"Ha... Then you know what the situation is."

I glanced sideways.

Beatrice was there, absorbing the energy around her.

His plan.

It was to bestow dimensional magic upon Beatrice.

A being with both time and dimensional magic.

Add my spatial magic to that.

Then Beatrice, or rather, this vessel, would become a perfect being capable of interfering with dimensions.

Dimensional magic, spatial magic, time magic.

All three have flaws.

Spatial magic can't move to dimensions where one didn't exist.

Time magic can't see or interfere with dimensions where one didn't exist.

Dimensional magic can see all dimensions but can't interfere directly.

Interference requires a corresponding price.

However, all these downsides disappear when the abilities are combined.

If one possesses all these abilities.

If one can use spatial, time, and dimensional magic altogether.

All downsides vanish, and everything becomes possible.

Even changing the world world itself.

"It's over, the vessel is already accepting the power."

The vessel.

Beatrice is the vessel.

She has intelligence but lacks a mind of her own.

This was done to make it easier for her to accept abilities.

Necromancy.

Magic that resurrects the dead.

More precisely, it's not about bringing them back to life but using the corpses to harness their power.

The body of Beatrice is engraved with magic, serving as the source of necromancy.

She was meant to absorb the power of dead bodies here to learn dimensional magic.

I laughed at Aryandor's overconfidence.

"What over? This is just the beginning."

"The moment it started, it ended. You've seen the pocket watch's information, haven't you?"

The information from the pocket watch.

I definitely obtained it.

I saw the current future there.

In tens of thousands of futures drawn, Aryandor was winning in all of them.

"So what?"

Regardless of who's here or what situation unfolds, even if Aryandor wins, that's their problem.

I don't need to care about the affairs of other dimensions.

The 'me' in this world is a completely different person from the 'me' in other dimensions.

The way I've lived and everything I've experienced are all different.

That means the outcome will also be different.

I dashed forward quickly.

"Agh!"

Aryandor tried to block my attack, but in his severely wounded state, he couldn't.

He was sent flying far away by my punch.

Then Beatrice moved.

"Royal swordsmanship."

Beatrice attempted to use swordsmanship with a dagger, and at the same time, she used time magic.

"Full Moon."

Scattering golden sword energy.

At the same time, time magic activated.

The era of scattering the sword energy repeats.

It was as if the sword had been swung dozens of times, sending tens of sword energies flying at me.

"Spatial Severance."

Seeing this, I activated spatial magic.

Splitting space to erase the sword energies.

And the attacks I couldn't erase, I dodged by twisting my body.

"Fire Sphere!"

While I was dodging attacks, Luna behind me used magic.

A small flame appeared from Luna's hand, flying towards Beatrice and causing a large explosion.

Boom!

The explosion engulfed Beatrice.

Not only that, but it also reached the jars behind her.

The jars containing the relics of the Saints shattered under the explosion's influence.

"Gasp..."

Luna's eyes widened at the sight.

"Sorry...! What do we do now?"

I shook my head.

"No, it's fine. We had to destroy them anyway."

"...What?"

I filled my fist with mana.

And then I punched.

Boom!!!

Dozens of jars behind shattered.

The relics contained within fell to the ground and dispersed in white light.

Aryandor's eyes widened.

"...What are you trying to do?"

"Why? Is there a problem? Ah~ You haven't seen this future, have you?"

I smiled.

This was our way to victory.

I had many questions when Haruna first introduced me to this place.

Why not destroy it?

This place makes dimensional magic possible.

But do we need to protect it?

Initially, I thought maybe it could be useful to stop Aryandor.

However, after learning about Aryandor's goal and that vessel, Beatrice, through the pocket watch, I realized we couldn't stop them.

I looked ahead.

Beatrice, who had been caught in Luna's explosion, walked towards us, unharmed.

Not a single injury remained.

The ability to heal all wounds belonged to Venderwood.

'There's no ordinary way to stop someone like that.'

Beatrice can't be stopped by ordinary means.

She uses time magic, her body heals instantly, and she can't feel pain.

Even if we did our best to stop her, it was really easy for her to reach her goal, the sanctuary, and absorb power.

Just by arriving here and getting attacked, she could absorb power.

Then, a bigger question arises.

Why didn't Haruna destroy this place?

If Beatrice could inevitably reach this place, wouldn't it have been right to destroy the sanctuary?

They say we wouldn't be able to see the future if this place were gone, but isn't that better than Aryandor achieving his goal and turning back the world's time?

Then, a thought occurred to me.

What would they have done if we had destroyed this place from the start?

There's only one possibility.

They would have targeted Haruna.

If they had focused on Haruna, could we have protected her?

Ultimately, would she have died by their hands, and obtained power from Haruna's corpse.

But by leaving the sanctuary, Haruna gave them a choice.

To fight past me and others and target Haruna herself, or to enter this sanctuary.

They would naturally choose the latter.

If they fought to kill Haruna, they couldn't be sure of their victory.

There's no guarantee they would win against us, nor that they could obtain Haruna's corpse intact.

Then, an unavoidable thought comes to mind.

Did Haruna lure them here?

What Haruna said before coming here was a lie, but it wasn't.

A 100 percent chance of winning.

If Haruna knew the correct future, she wouldn't have said such a thing.

But saying this gave me one hint.

Head towards an unknown future.

To a future unseen.

To a future unfound.

"Stop him...!"

Aryandor pointed at me and shouted.

Beatrice rushed towards me as I was smashing the jars.

"Aryandor, now you understand why you couldn't see the future where we win, right?"

This sanctuary connects different dimensions, the future, and the past.

The Saints' relics contain dimensional magic, linking the future and the past with the present.

It allows people from the past to see the present and those in the present to see the future.

It acts as a medium allowing users of dimensional and time magic to see into the past and future.

So, what if all these relics are destroyed?

If this sanctuary disappears?

"It's a future you haven't seen."

A future unseen.

If all these relics are destroyed, our timeline becomes a future no one can see.

Boom!

I destroyed the jars.

Beatrice tried her best to protect them, but she couldn't stop it.

Nor could she reverse it with time magic.

Time magic can't interfere with other dimensions.

These Saints' relics distinctly influence other dimensions.

They allow other dimensions to see our world's future.

So, they couldn't be reversed with time magic.

"Luna."

I called Luna and summoned Priscilla at the same time.

"Uh...?"

"Priscilla, make a contract with Luna."

"...What are you talking about all of a sudden?"

Luna asked me with wide eyes.

"I said earlier, I'm going to eliminate time magic."

"But, how?"

"If you make a contract with Priscilla, you'll be able to feel the connection between you and me."

"Is that even possible?"

"We'll know once we try. And if you feel the connection, use my spatial magic as a sacrifice to eliminate that guy's time magic. I'll be holding the front in the meantime."

"Spatial magic?"

Aryandor, having heard me, widened his eyes.

"You..."

"What do you think of my plan? Not bad, right?"

I smiled at Aryandor and then turned around.

"Can you do it?"

"I'll try!"

"Good."

I nodded.

Now, we must stop her.

Prevent Beatrice from escaping.

We had to block her from leaving this space.

She needed to disappear along with this space.

I moved immediately.

Chapter 298: Completion (19)

Beatrice swung her sword towards us, aiming at Luna who was holding a spellbook.

"Your opponent is me."

I burst my mana to block Beatrice's sword.

Aryandor said nothing, just watched the situation.

"Full Moon."

Beatrice used her sword technique, releasing a burst of golden sword energy, and simultaneously used time magic.

Sword energies came at Luna from multiple directions.

"Behemoth."

A giant elephant, Behemoth, emerged from the ground, taking the brunt of Beatrice's sword energy with its massive body.

"Puuuh...!"

Behemoth staggered under the impact of Beatrice's sword energy but wasn't seriously injured and quickly regained its footing.

Beatrice continued her assault.

"Northern Swordsmanship."

Watching this, I manipulated my mana.

"Lich."

At my command, a skeletal reaper appeared behind Beatrice.

Clank—

Its chains wrapped around Beatrice, entangling her before she could use her sword technique.

"Luna, how much longer?"

"10 minutes... no, 15 minutes should do!"

I nodded at her response and looked forward.

Beatrice struggled to escape the Lich's grasp.

Then, I clenched my fist and directed it towards Beatrice's back.

"Huff!"

Mana exploded.

Kwaang!

Jars behind us shattered.

The number of jars decreased.

—!

As the jars shattered, the space echoed, and cracks began to form in the ceiling.

The more jars broke, the more the space itself started to collapse.

Aryandor looked from the cracking ceiling to me.

"Rudy Astria. What the hell are you doing?"

I replied,

"What does it look like? I'm making sure you're completely eradicated."

"Even if it means your death?"

"...Huh?"

Luna reacted to Aryandor's words, her eyes widening as she looked at him.

"What are you talking about?"

Aryandor, looking at Luna behind him, continued,

"When Beatrice's time magic and Rudy Astria's spatial magic disappear, and all these jars are gone, this dimension will collapse. Yes, then we will obviously die. But what about you? How do you plan to escape?"

The key to moving through this sacred place is space, time, and dimensional magic.

With that magic, one can come and go from this place.

"Are you saying you're willing to die with us? Is that it, Rudy Astria?"

Aryandor chuckled.

He wasn't wrong.

If space and time magic were to disappear together, I would have no way to leave this place with my own power.

Of course, with Haruna outside, she could get me out of here if she entered, but that would defeat the purpose.

The whole reason for luring them to this place was to separate Haruna and the others.

If Haruna entered, they wouldn't just let her go because they could prevent us from leaving if they wanted to.

This was also why they couldn't leave right now; if they tried to stop me from leaving, they'd be stuck here too.

But I had no intention of dying here.

I turned to look at Luna, who was looking back at me with an anxious expression.

"Luna, it's okay. I won't die."

"Rudy..."

"Have you ever seen me lie?"

"No..."

I smiled and patted Luna on the back.

"Trust me."

Seeing my smile, Luna pressed her lips together and nodded.

"If you're lying, you're really going to get it from me..."

"Of course. Oh, let me know when the magic is about to end. I have something to do."

Hearing my answer, Luna nodded and focused again.

I could feel the spatial magic inside me slowly fading away.

Beatrice must have felt it too, as she furrowed her brow.

Tied up by the Lich, Beatrice used her time magic.

Her body moved, escaping the chains.

I wanted to block her using Priscilla, but I couldn't.

The spatial magic was almost gone, and Priscilla was focused on connecting with Luna.

But there was no need to worry.

Beatrice broke free from the chains and ran towards Aryandor.

"Where do you think you're going?"

I gathered mana in my fist and charged.

Beatrice grabbed Aryandor and moved her mana.

The surroundings flickered.

It looked like they were trying to leave.

"Belphegor."

At the same time, I summoned a demon.

Behind me, the form of a demon appeared, and I raised my fist.

"Huff!"

Belphegor's power is to amplify mana.

I filled my fist with far stronger mana than usual and thrust it forward.

———!

Mana exploded, hitting both Beatrice and Aryandor.

".....!"

Aryandor was in no shape to withstand the attack, and Beatrice took it all by herself.

Their plan to escape was immediately thwarted, and Luna's magic was nearing its end.

I looked towards Aryandor, swept up in the explosion, then turned back.

"Rudy! It's almost done...!"

At Luna's shout, I smiled and reached out my hand.

"Yeah, thanks."

"...Huh?"

I reached for Luna, taking the spellbook in her hand.

"Ru...dy?"

"I'll be there soon. Go ahead."

Luna's surroundings shimmered, and she opened her eyes wide.

"What is that..."

Then, Beatrice burst out of the explosion.

I opened my mouth.

"Lich."

A skeleton that appeared in front of us blocked Beatrice's path.

"Rudy! Rudy! You idiot!!!"

Luna shouted, but her body disappeared right after.

I had sent her outside before the spatial magic disappeared.

As soon as Luna was out, I felt the spatial magic vanish.

"Ha... So, you really plan to end it like this?"

Aryandor pushed himself up from the floor.

Blood was flowing from his abdomen, and his legs trembled as if standing was a struggle, yet he was smiling.

"Yeah, die with me. If only you weren't here, if only you hadn't come. You have to take responsibility for the mess you made, by dying with me..."

I narrowed my eyes at Aryandor.

"What nonsense have you been spouting?"

"What?"

"Do I look crazy to you? Dying with someone like you?"

I've said it from the start.

I have no intention of dying.

Why does everyone make such a fuss...

I laughed.

"You're just a coward who gets scared and runs away before anything even happens. Do you think I'd die with a coward?"

I've seen what you're going through, but I don't pity you.

The only ones I pity are the people who stood by you.

Those who are being sacrificed even at this moment.

Those who fought for such a worthless cause.

I pity them all.

But not you.

You're just pathetic.

Aryandor looked at me as if I was absurd.

"So, how do you plan to get out of here?"

As he spoke, Beatrice turned around.

The few jars that were left.

Beatrice raised her sword towards those jars.

Bang!!!!

She shattered the jars, and the space began to warp.

I looked at Aryandor in front of me and frowned.

"Yeah, make that face. Were you waiting for Ian Astria or Haruna to save you? Thinking one of them would come to your rescue?"

Aryandor scoffed at me.

I looked down on him with pity.

"That look... that damn look... don't look at me with those eyes!!! Why does everyone look at me with those eyes..."

Ignoring Aryandor, I opened the spellbook Luna left behind.

Flipping through the pages, I spoke.

"Aryandor, do you know? Spatial magic, time magic, dimensional magic, all of it was made by humans. It wasn't anything divine."

"What?"

"Magic created by humans and the future shown by humans. You gave up on that. The future isn't something crafted by a God. That's why I think

you're pathetic. Even if it was made by a God, you shouldn't have given up. Especially if they were truly precious to you."

I opened a page in the spellbook and infused it with mana.

"No, time magic... the future... it's something humans can change..."

"You still don't get it."

I looked behind Aryandor.

Beatrice had shattered the last jar.

The dimension trembled.

Boom—

Cracks formed in the ceiling, and the entire space wavered.

I focused on Luna's spellbook, noticing the massive mana leaking out.

Then, a strong gravitational force emerged around me.

It was a concentrated gravitational force, gravity magic.

But it was a bit different.

Its power was much stronger.

I channeled my mana into the spellbook.

"Then, let me show you."

The strong gravitational force occurred around my body.

"...Huff."

I endured it with my body.

"What are you doing?"

I saw it.

Ordinary magic could affect space.

Astina's gravity magic.

Strong gravity can twist space.

Astina showed me this during our duel.

She couldn't handle it as spatial magic, but I'm different.

I have experience using spatial magic.

If there's a tremor in space, I can feel it precisely with my body.

I focused all my senses.

On the twist in space caused by gravity.

Focused on it.

"Ah..."

Aryandor just stared blankly.

"To leave this place, you just need to handle one of the three: space, time, or dimensional magic, right?"

I reached out my hand into the twisting space.

My surroundings wavered.

"That kind of thing... That can't possibly work... Such nonsense..."

"Didn't I tell you? It's all magic made by humans."

Being able to handle space or time magic isn't because of some divine selection.

Because it wasn't magic created by a God.

And everything made by humans has its flaws.

If I could create a similar twist to the one used to enter this place, couldn't I also leave?

I increased the gravity with my mana, creating a twist similar to the one when we entered.

"Ah..."

My surroundings wavered.

I looked forward.

At the crumbling dimension and Aryandor, who was in despair.

He didn't try to stop my magic, nor did he think of escaping the crumbling dimension; he just stared blankly at me.

Chapter 299: Completion (20)

I saw a familiar scene.

The desk I had used for a long time and the documents around it.

Of course, it wasn't exactly the same because everything was broken and in a mess.

A loud noise came from behind me.

"Hurry and do something! Rudy... Rudy!!"

"...Isn't that him?"

"...What?"

I turned around and locked eyes with Luna.

I saw Luna, her face a mess with tears.

Luna was holding onto Haruna's clothes next to her, crying.

"Hey, Luna. You're here."

"Eh...???"

Luna looked at me with a baffled expression.

"Didn't I tell you? I knew he'd manage on his own."

Haruna said, patting Luna's shoulder.

"Rudy?"

"What, you didn't believe me?"

I smiled at Luna.

"No, it's not that... It's just the atmosphere... sniff... I thought Rudy was going to sacrifice himself..."

sniff

"If I had to, I would."

I said, trying to approach Luna.

"Ah..."

"Rudy!"

But I couldn't move forward and collapsed on the spot.

My body had given out.

I had used too much mana, and the strong gravity I had faced head-on made my body feel damaged.

Luna quickly ran to me.

"Are you okay?"

"Yeah, I'm okay but..."

I wasn't about to lose consciousness, but I couldn't muster any strength in my legs.

"We need to... heal you..."

Luna grabbed the spellbook in my hand and hurriedly moved.

"Uh..."

But the spellbook didn't respond.

I stared at the book and muttered to myself.

"Did it overload..."

I didn't expect the book to stop working after I had put so much mana into distorting space with gravity.

It was a close call.

I could have been trapped there...

Of course, I was confident it would work.

It was an item made by Levian.

I didn't know it would be this risky.

But the outcome was good, so...

"Let's go get treated first..."

Luna supported me.

I glanced at Luna for a moment.

There was something I thought of before getting treated.

I cautiously looked at Luna and then spoke up.

"Treatment is fine but... there's a place I need to visit first."

"A place to visit?"

"The battlefield... I'm thinking of going there... Could you take me?"

"...What?"

Luna's teary expression hardened.

She looked at me angrily as if she were mad.

"Idiot! You're in no condition right now!"

"No, but the war has to stop. It's not like I'm going to fight."

If we don't hurry, meaningless sacrifices will only increase.

So, if I just go and announce that Aryandor is dead...

"You idiot! Fool! Going to the battlefield in this condition...!"

As Luna was shouting, a voice came from the corridor.

"Rudy Astria! Are you there?"

Luna and I turned our heads with puzzled looks.

Since the wall was already broken, we could clearly see the corridor just by turning our heads.

"...Brother?"

In the corridor, where the voice came from, was Ian Astria.

He had come in a hurry, gasping for breath, his clothes in disarray, and covered in blood.

"Rudy Astria. Are you okay?"

Ian ran towards me.

I looked at him, confused.

"Shouldn't you be on the outskirts?"

"The outskirts are done. The others were rushing me so much that I came here first..."

Ian looked around.

"No need to look. I've already taken care of Aryandor."

"What?"

"It's complicated to explain, but basically, he won't be coming out of there alive."

Even if he did manage to come out alive, if there was a way to do so, it wouldn't matter...

The last face of Aryandor I saw.

I showed him that the magic and the future he relied on could be changed at any time, that it was just ordinary magic.

I had directly denied his life.

He was a person who would not try again.

It was all his mistake, and he realized that he could have saved Beatrice but didn't.

He was defeated.

In battle and in his beliefs.

So, he won't struggle anymore.

No, he wouldn't even think of it.

He would just disappear along with the holy land, engulfed in despair.

Ian let out a sigh of relief.

"Is that so... Then, is it all over?"

His face relaxed a bit.

After all, Ian was the commander of this battle.

"Ah, but we need to go to the battlefield. We need to hurry there now."

"Oh, right. Then you rest."

"...What?"

"...Why?"

"I will go too. I will go and..."

"...What are you talking about?"

"What?"

"Your role was to stop Aryandor, wasn't it? Then you've done your part. The fight is practically over, why would an injured person like you want to go?"

I was taken aback by Ian's words, looking at him with wide eyes.

"The fight is over. It's all over. So, what are you planning to do by going there?"

I just stared blankly at Ian.

Luna, who was supporting me, wiped away her tears and spoke up.

"That's right, it's all over now. Sniff... You really did well. Truly..."

Sniff

Haruna, standing next to us, was smiling and looking at me.

Hearing those words, the tension gradually began to fade.

The war is essentially over.

Aryandor is dead.

Everything... all that had been done is over.

"...That's right."

I realized I couldn't let go of the tension, even though it was over.

It's always been like this.

Even after finishing a task, as long as I could move, I'd focus on the next one.

All for this outcome.

For this moment.

I smiled.

"Luna, can you help me sit down...?"

"Okay...!"

I sat down on the floor, leaning against the desk.

"Then, I'll be going now. The war needs to be wrapped up."

"Yes, please do."

Ian disappeared with those words, likely heading to the battlefield.

If he went, the war would certainly come to a close.

Announcing Aryandor's death and adding his forces to the mix would certainly tip the balance on the battlefield.

"Rudy, don't you need to be healed?"

"It doesn't seem urgent."

I wasn't severely injured; I had just used a lot of mana.

"Besides, your face is a mess. Want me to clean your nose here?"

I offered my sleeve.

Luna, startled by my action, covered her face.

"Yo, you can't say that to a girl! At least offer a handkerchief when you say something like that!"

"Why bother with that? Come here."

I brought my sleeve to Luna's face, which was a mess, and rubbed it vigorously.

The tears on Luna's face were wiped off, but the soot on my sleeve smeared all over her face, making her look like a puppy that had rolled in the mud.

"...Pfft."

"Don't laugh after doing this!"

Luna pouted and grumbled.

Her appearance, looking like a sulky puppy, made me laugh even more.

"Phahaha!!"

"Stop laughing!"

The door to the room burst open.

"Oh, Rie. You're here?"

Rie widened her eyes upon seeing me lying down.

"Hey! Are you okay? Are you hurt anywhere?"

"Nah, just hurt my leg a bit and exhausted from using too much mana."

"...That's a relief."

"What about Astina? She isn't hurt, is she?"

"Hurt? She's the deputy commander of the Royal Army, so of course, she's busy with the cleanup."

The end of the war didn't take long.

A few minutes after Ian left, we could hear about the rebels surrendering.

With the war over, people came to me, and I was moved to a room.

"Eh~ Senior. Why didn't you look for me?"

Then, Yuni peeked her face through the open door.

"Yuni, you're here?"

"Is that all? I'm a bit disappointed~."

"You weren't going to get hurt anyway."

"Still~ Is it so hard to mention my name once~?"

Yuni walked towards me with a playful smile.

"But, for a war hero, this hospital room seems pretty empty."

"Now that the war is over, what else is there?"

"Is that so?"

I looked at the two of them.

"But, you two are Princesses, right? Shouldn't you be going?"

"My sister insisted on seeing the senior's face so much that everyone was given a bit of time to come visit."

At Yuni's words, Rie's eyes widened.

"What, what? When did I! It was you who coaxed me into coming!"

"In the end, it was you who mentioned it~. And you were the one who threw a fit."

"I did not throw a fit! I just said there was something I needed to do briefly..."

I smiled at the two of them.

It got a bit noisy, but somehow it felt more settled.

It felt like people were telling me it's truly over now.

As I enjoyed this peace, something suddenly crossed my mind.

"Ah, Rie. I wanted to ask you something."

Rie, who was bickering with Yuni, tilted her head at my question.

"Something you want to ask?"

"How did the war end? What happened to them?"

I didn't expect it to end this easily just by announcing Aryandor's death.

I thought there would be at least some resistance left.

"Daemon? It seems he and Astina had a conversation while fighting. I vaguely heard that they were deceived by Aryandor? Something like that."

"...Is that so."

The rebels must have realized to some extent.

That Aryandor had no interest in them and had a different agenda.

No matter how much Aryandor tried to deceive and use them, they must have felt something was off from his actions and words.

The rebels would have had their suspicions.

"So, what happened to them?"

"The leaders, as well as the rest of the rebels, have been captured. They're discussing what to do with them now. I guess a couple of the leaders might not escape execution.

Well, Venderwood is as good as dead anyway..."

"Dead?"

"Not dead, but he won't recover anymore. He's pretty much half-dead."

"...Is that so? What about Daemon?"

"He's alive. Both of them have been sent to the capital, and it seems like they'll be executed after the meeting."

"...Is that so?"

After a moment of thought, I spoke up.

"Could I see Daemon, just for a bit?"

"Daemon?"

Rie narrowed her eyebrows at my question.

"Just for a moment. Just briefly."

Rie looked at me disapprovingly.

I smiled at her, and her expression softened, followed by a sigh.

"...Alright. But really, just for a moment."

Chapter 300: Epilogue (Complete)

"Let's enter."

"Sure."

The door creaked open.

We walked into the room.

It was the Academy's Vice Principal's office.

Inside, Professor Cromwell was organizing some documents.

Professor Cromwell was in good health, despite being bandaged in a few places. He moved around comfortably.

"Rie? ...Rudy?"

"Ha ha... Hello..."

Cromwell looked at us, puzzled.

There was a good reason for that.

It was because I was being carried by Rie.

To me, the sight of being carried by Rie, who was much smaller, was ridiculous.

But there was no other way to get here.

My legs were injured, and I couldn't use mana.

"What a sight... No, more importantly, what brings you here?"

Rie answered.

"Could we meet Daemon for a moment?"

"...Daemon?"

Cromwell furrowed his brow.

Seeing that, I spoke up.

"It'll only be for a short while. We're not up to anything strange."

"It's not hard to meet him, but I wonder if there's really a need."

"We just want to clear up some lingering issues."

I wanted to put an end to all this.

"Well, I won't stop you then."

Cromwell walked to the back of the Vice Principal's office.

There was a small room there.

When he opened the door to the room, there were bars.

It was a space normally used by the Vice Principal as a private room, but now it was being used as a temporary prison.

Looking inside, Daemon, blindfolded and gagged, with his body restrained, was visible.

He was covered in numerous wounds and was breathing heavily in pain.

"Rie, could you put me down?"

When I tapped Rie's arm, she looked at me with a pout.

"I wanted to stay like this."

"..."

"Cough."

Cromwell coughed and turned his head.

"Just for a moment."

"Hmm... Fine, I'll make an exception."

Rie, delighted about something, smiled brightly and put me down.

I sat on the floor and looked at Professor Cromwell.

He used magic, and Daemon's blindfold and gag were removed.

"Is this our first real conversation?"

I looked at Daemon and said.

Daemon frowned and quietly opened his mouth.

"Did you come to mock me?"

"Well, there's that. But I came for my own satisfaction."

"Satisfaction, huh. Fine, talk all you want. A stupid loser doesn't have a choice."

Daemon laughed bitterly.

I looked at him and said.

"I'm going to make the Empire the best country in history."

"...What?"

"Better than any other time before, the most comfortable and best place to live."

I thought the rebels' process was wrong, not the outcome they wanted.

"I will provide food and welfare to the neglected people on the outskirts of the Empire and give proper punishment to the corrupt nobles, creating the most ideal Empire."

I continued.

"Even those without money will have access to education, talented individuals will be given high positions, and there will be no discrimination or oppression."

Daemon narrowed his brows.

"Are you trying to comfort me?"

"Comfort? Like I said, I came to mock."

I laughed.

"I'm going to prove it. That all of you, who sacrificed countless people and tried to turn the world upside down, were wrong. That the world can be changed without such actions."

I didn't like their process or their beliefs.

The sacrifice of countless people.

I despised those who killed innocent people to change the world.

"These words are my last gift to you. A final gift for the pitiful you. Just watch how the world changes. Watch how I succeed in changing the world."

He's going to die soon.

He'll probably be executed in the capital of the Empire.

What happens after death, who knows?

Maybe there's an afterlife.

Of course, I said this, but honestly, it wasn't for him.

It was my vow.

My vow to change the world.

Daemon smirked.

"Go ahead, try. Prove it. Whether we were right or you were. I'll be waiting on the other side."

"Sure."

I laughed.

Thud!

"Rudy! Hurry up and come out!"

"We should have left earlier."

Two people rushed out of the carriage.

"Aren't we late?"

"It probably hasn't started yet."

As soon as the two came out of the carriage, they ran at full speed.

It was their first time back at the Academy in a while, but there was no time to enjoy the scenery.

"I'm going to get an earful from Rie and Yuni..."

"That's why I said we should go with Rie..."

"How can we? The research wasn't finished. But we're not completely late."

While running, the two saw a banner hanging far away on the Auditorium.

The 103rd Liberion Academy Graduation Ceremony.

Loud noises were coming from the Auditorium where the banner was hanging.

"Ah, ah. We will now commence the Graduation Ceremony. Will the Valedictorian of the Graduates please come forward?"

Yuni, who was backstage, looked around after hearing the announcer.

"When is senior coming?"

"I don't know. Sigh... I came here early because he insisted on leaving late. Luna said she would bring him on time."

Rie sighed at Yuni's words.

The announcer's voice was heard again.

"...Valedictorian?"

"...Shouldn't you go up?"

"Sigh..."

Rie sighed and walked up towards the stage.

-The 103rd Liberion Academy Graduation Ceremony.

Far in the distance, someone running towards the back of the stage was spotted.

"Uh... Astina."

"What's going on? Why is Rie going up?"

"Senior was late."

"Late?"

Then, a person walked towards Yuni and Astina.

"What are you talking about?"

"Gulp..."

"Ah."

Yuni and Astina broke out in cold sweat upon seeing the person's face.

It was Cromwell, the current Principal of Liberion Academy.

Cromwell, who was originally the Vice Principal, had become the Principal after the war ended.

Well, to be exact, he was forced into the position.

The previous Principal, McDowell, had dumped the position on him.

"I told you to drag them here on time if you had to..."

"Ahaha..."

"Hmm..."

Yuni laughed awkwardly, and Astina turned her head away as if she didn't know anything, sweating profusely on her back.

Cromwell was usually a kind and good person, but when he got angry like that, he became very troublesome.

Yuni and Astina looked at each other.

'We need to get past this situation.'

Following Yuni's cue, Astina nodded.

'Yeah, I'll get us through this.'

They communicated with their eyes, smiled, and Astina began to speak.

"Professor, being late doesn't mean what you think."

"What?"

Yuni continued.

"They arrived earlier but met someone they know..."

"They run into someone and that's why they're late for the Graduation Ceremony?"

"This is about the business Rudy is working on! It's related to that person. Of course, the Graduation Ceremony is important, but work is more important, right?"

As Yuni was explaining, Rie began her speech on stage.

"It's already been three years since we enrolled. We entered during the cherry blossom season..."

Rie started her speech.

Cromwell sighed as the Graduation Ceremony had already started.

"Are you sure they're coming soon?"

"Yes~ Of course~."

"Alright."

Cromwell responded and walked back to his seat.

He couldn't leave his place since the Graduation Ceremony was underway.

"Phew..."

"It looks like we've passed the crisis."

Yuni and Astina said, giving each other a small high-five.

"But will they make it before the ceremony ends?"

"I don't know about that."

"If they don't come..."

Astina looked at Cromwell with trembling teeth.

It was clear that dealing with Cromwell's nagging would be a headache.

"Ah, but. It doesn't seem like it."

Bang!!!

Two people burst into the Auditorium.

It was Luna and Rudy.

"Pant... Pant..."

"Are we, are we late?"

The eyes of everyone in the Auditorium turned towards them.

Yuni laughed awkwardly.

"Ahaha... That's quite the entrance, senior."

"Could've at least tried to come in quietly."

Astina grabbed her head as if it was a headache, and Rie, who was stalling for time on stage, paused for a moment at Rudy's entrance.

"Ah... Um..."

Then, after mumbling for a bit, she smiled brightly and said,

"Let me introduce him. The Valedictorian, Rudy Astria."

The Auditorium buzzed at Rie's words.

"Ah, that person is..."

"Oh..."

Rudy, noticing the reaction of the crowd, adjusted his attire and walked slowly.

Cutting through the crowd, he made his way up to the stage.

Reaching Rie, Rudy got poked in the ribs by her, and she quietly said,

"I need to talk to you later."

"...Thank you."

Rudy quietly thanked Rie and then grabbed the voice-amplifying magical device.

"Good day. I am Rudy Astria."

Rudy said, smiling brightly.

But sweat was running down his back.

He hadn't prepared.

He had completely forgotten.

That as the Valedictorian, he had to say something.

It was something that shouldn't have been forgotten, yet he had.

What to do.

He had blanked.

"..."

That's when Rudy remembered.

The speech he gave when he first enrolled...

After a brief moment of contemplation, he made his decision.

And then he spoke.

"My time at the Academy was really fun!"

What's the use of a long speech?

It's only boring.

Rudy thought so and smiled broadly.

"Thank you. This has been Valedictorian, Rudy Astria! That's all."

-End-

[raei: Heya, the next chap is just an author note, so I've posted it at the bottom instead. The next five chaps after this are side stories that I will be doing as well.]

Hello!

This is Yoon Maemi (윤매미), the author who became the Academy's second seat.

I was supposed to post a review yesterday, but it was delayed by a day, haha...

Finally, as of yesterday, I became the Academy's second seat.

The series is now complete.

Yesterday marked exactly one year since the start of last year's contest.

To think it's been a year since I started posting and reached the 300th episode... It wasn't planned, but it turned out that way.

Regardless of the numbers, I'm just happy to have finished it!

Writing this work for a year has been truly wonderful.

It received a lot of attention and even won awards in competitions...

Though it was tough, I can confidently say these were some of the happiest days of my life.

To share a bit more about the story, it's about Rudy's growth.

Rudy, who initially cared only about his own survival, gradually grew to care for his friends, then the people of the Academy, and eventually everyone in the Empire.

He worked hard and ultimately achieved his goals.

There was a lot of growth besides that.

He helped someone, and in turn, received help.

He received one-sided help from his mentor.

And he gave one-sided help to others.

This story is about others becoming more than just 'others.'

It's about choosing the 1% chance to save someone else, even if you can survive 100% on your own.

That's the conclusion of this story.

There were some hiccups along the way, but I'm glad I didn't lose sight of the path to completion...haha

Anyway!

About the side stories, I might post it irregularly.

After posting for a year, my body's a bit worn out, and I'd like to take a few days off to relax...

The side stories, coming after a few days off, will be so sweet it'll rot your teeth...!

That's the format all the side stories will take.

So, that's it!

Until now!

This has been Yoon Maemi (윤매미), the author who became the Academy's second seat!

Thank you!

Chapter 301: Side Story The Bustling Harem Marriage Operation (1)

Two months had passed since the Graduation Ceremony.

I had been staying at the Magic Tower since I graduated.

Before graduating, I had received the position of the Senior Researcher at the Magic Tower and had been conducting various research.

The Magic Tower was a good place for me.

I could work on politics, freely conduct research, and have a certain degree of freedom.

"Rudy, I've brought your coffee."

"Ah, thanks."

I received the tray from the apprentice wizard.

On the tray were two cups of coffee.

I took the tray and walked to my seat.

Oh, and there was another good thing about being in the Magic Tower.

Thud!

"Rudy."

"Ah, Luna, you're here? I just finished brewing the coffee."

It was being able to be with Luna.

After graduation, Luna had immediately received a research position.

She had made some achievements during the war and had done numerous things during her third-year apprenticeship, earning her a corresponding position.

Of course, besides Luna, it was easy to interact and meet with others.

From the standpoint of the Magic Tower, whether it was Astina, Rie, or Yuni, it was easy to meet anyone if I stepped forward.

"Mmm, the coffee smells great!"

"Right? It's coffee sent by Astina."

Luna and I had tea time like this every morning.

There was no specific work time in the Magic Tower, as many people researched throughout the night.

So, having a leisurely tea time before starting work wasn't a problem.

Luna sipped her coffee and looked out the window.

There was an awkward look in her eyes, but I just smiled and watched her.

Luna made up her mind and cleared her throat.

"Hmm! The weather is nice this morning too!"

"Yeah, it is."

I looked outside the window.

It was the transition period from spring to summer.

The flowers were blooming beautifully, and the weather was cool, perfect for walking outside.

"Right, right! How about we have dinner together tonight? I know a restaurant..."

"Ah... That might be difficult..."

I smiled awkwardly and shook my head.

Luna let out a regretful sigh and pouted her lips.

"Is something up? You seem busy these days..."

"A bit busy, yes."

"Busy... with work?"

"Somewhat busy."

I said quietly, with an awkward smile.

It had been a week since Luna had started making various excuses to ask me out for meals.

Since I had been continuously rejecting without giving any specific reason, Luna became suspicious.

Luna looked dejected and hung her head.

"I see... If you have work..."

Seeing her like that made me feel guilty.

Should I postpone my work?

But I couldn't just postpone it. There was a specific reason why I was working this hard.

"Alright... Then, I'll be going."

Luna said that and left my room.

"Sigh..."

I let out a deep sigh.

"Should I just tell her?"

I muttered to myself while looking out the window.

"Luna too?? You asked him on a date and got rejected?!"

Yuni narrowed her eyes as she spoke.

"Yeah... I've been asking for days, but he says no..."

"Sigh... What the hell is he doing that's so important?"

Rie sighed beside her.

"He must be busy with work these days... Well, that can happen..."

Luna said it could happen, but her expression said otherwise.

She looked pretty upset.

While the three of them were grumbling,

Tap. Tap. Tap.

"But why are we meeting here?"

Astina, sitting at a desk, asked.

Astina was frowning and tapping her fingers on the desk.

This was Astina's office in the Persia mansion in the capital.

"Well, we don't really have another place to meet, do we? Please, let it slide~."

Yuni said with a bright smile.

Although her demeanor was cute, Astina wasn't fooled by such charm.

She had been tricked by such words many times before.

Despite having graduated from the Academy two years ago, she ended up helping with student council work and dealing with various matters using the power of the Persia family.

She had been through quite a lot.

"We could meet at the Magic Tower or the palace."

"Rudy is at the Magic Tower, and the palace is too conspicuous."

"I'm sorry..."

Rie shrugged her shoulders and said to Astina, while Luna awkwardly smiled and bowed her head in apology.

"More importantly, what do you think, Astina! Do you think this is acceptable?"

Yuni exaggerated her gestures as she spoke.

At this, Astina sighed and opened her mouth.

"Rudy can't help being busy. Rie's coronation is coming up, after all."

Soon, Rie would ascend to the Emperor's throne.

When the coronation ceremony takes place, the Magic Tower, would take about a week off.

It was like a consolation holiday given by the Emperor.

So, it seemed Rudy was trying to get ahead on work that needed to be done during that period.

"Even so! Can't we even have dinner? We have to eat dinner anyway!"

At Yuni's outcry, Astina smiled.

"Well, that could be possible."

"...Hmm~?"

Yuni scrutinized Astina closely as she spoke.

"What's with that look?"

"Astina. Do you know something?"

"I have no idea what you're talking about."

"There's something fishy~. Something, something..."

Yuni stretched her neck towards Astina and touched her chin.

"What smell are you talking about?"

"I have a very accurate nose for this kind of smell, you know?"

Rie looked at Yuni with a blank expression.

"Since when have you been good at smelling that kind of thing?"

"You're supposed to play along at times like these!"

"Anyway, Astina, do you know something?"

At Rie's question, Astina shrugged her shoulders.

"You'll find out in time."

"See! I knew it! You do know something!"

Yuni was fuming at Astina's response.

Luna pondered Astina's words, tilting her head.

"Find out in time...?"

In the dark evening, I was wearing a hood and looked around. Seeing no one around, I quietly entered the cabin in front of me.

Inside was a middle-aged man. The middle-aged man smiled slyly as I entered.

"Rudy, you've arrived."

I narrowed my eyes at him and asked, "Is the item ready?"

"Hehe... Why do you ask? Follow me."

He gestured to me, and I followed him down into the basement of the cabin.

After descending the dark staircase to the basement, he reached out his hand.

"Please wait a moment."

He went to a corner and brought back a small box.

"Here is the item. It took quite the effort to prepare."

"Hehe... Thank you. May I check it?"

"Yes, go ahead."

I smiled and opened the box. Inside the box were five splendid rings.

"Ha ha ha! These are the rings I've put the most effort into!"

The man laughed happily, thumping his chest. I smiled broadly in response.

"Thank you. I really like them."

This place was the home of a craftsman of fine goods in the capital.

I found out about this place about a month ago.

I was talking to Astina at the time.

Originally, we met to talk about my personal affairs.

It was related to the commerce of the capital.

Astina, befitting the Lord of the commercial city of Persia, knew a lot about various commercial aspects.

While talking about business, I also learned about this craftsman.

Although his workshop was small, his skills were so exceptional that he was raking in money in the capital.

That's when I thought this place would be perfect.

And I immediately acted on it, entrusting this craftsman with a task.

The task was to make five rings.

These were essential items for the plan I was carrying out, so I invested a large sum of money, and now I was here to see the results.

The craftsman turned on a dim lamp and looked towards me.

"Wouldn't it be better to just turn on the light and meet? Why do we have to do it like this?"

"Ha ha... Since I attract a lot of attention from many people, I need to be a bit cautious."

"Ah, must be tough on you."

"Well, it is what it is..."

I scratched my head.

"Ah, you should check if the size fits."

"Yes, I should."

I picked up a ring with a small diamond embedded in it from the box.

After trying it on a few times, I slipped the ring onto my ring finger.

I smiled, satisfied with how it fit.

"How does it look?"

"It fits perfectly. Thank you."

"Hehe, I'm glad to hear that. But what about the other rings..."

"Ah, can I come back if there's a problem with those?"

I asked, smiling awkwardly.

The biggest issue at the moment was that I had the rings made without getting permission from the people involved.

"Yes, of course. Just give me a heads-up, and I'll take care of it right away! Hehe!"

The craftsman chuckled, patting his chest.

I smiled, gathered the rings, and put my hood back on.

"Thank you. I'll be back next time."

"Yes! Take care!"

After leaving, I looked up at the sky.

I pondered under the starry and moonlit sky.

"Ha... This should be okay, right?"

The reason I'm busy to the point of not being able to have dinner with everyone, making these rings, is because I have a plan.

Soon, Rie will be crowned as the Emperor.

After that, we'll all become busier.

I'll have my own things to do, and everyone will have their own tasks.

So, I decided to do something before the coronation ceremony.

The name of that plan is the Harem Marriage Operation.

It might sound a bit cringeworthy, but the operation name is very intuitive and explanatory.

Currently, there are four women around me.

All of them are attractive, and I like them all.

I can't choose just one.

So, I'll choose all of them.

It's not illegal to choose all four, right?

That was my decision.

I looked down at the ring in my hand.

"But, how do I explain that..."

I'm going to marry all of them.

I have to explain that to everyone.

Thinking about it made me feel incredibly overwhelmed.

Chapter 302: Side Story The Bustling Harem Marriage Operation (2)

A few days later, I went to the Persia mansion in the capital to meet Astina.

We had originally made a promise around this time.

The appointment was set for business reasons.

I had consulted Astina on the commercial aspects of a project I was working on, so it was related to that.

However, the real reason for making this appointment was different.

I made the appointment at this time to tell Astina about my intentions.

To be with everyone.

To put it bluntly, I aim to spread my affections widely.

I have confirmed their feelings.

Yuni, Rie, Luna, Astina - I already know how they feel.

But that doesn't mean they would allow me to be with everyone.

Everyone has a desire to monopolize the person they love.

"Has Rudy arrived?"

When I arrived at the Persia mansion, Astina came forward with a smile in her eyes.

She was wearing casual leather clothes.

Nobles usually don't wear such leather clothes, but it was comfortable for everyday wear, so it wasn't an inappropriate outfit for the mansion.

Of course, that didn't detract from Astina's charm.

The clothes clung tightly, highlighting her figure, and the casual atmosphere somehow stirred my heart.

"Hmm..."

Whether it was because I came to confess to her, or because of her figure-highlighting outfit, there was an awkward feeling.

"Don't just stand there, come inside."

Astina gestured for me to follow her inside. I nodded in response.

"What would you like to drink? Just coffee?"

"No, could I have something cold, please?"

"Because of the hot weather?"

"Ah... yes."

It wasn't because of the weather.

I just wanted something cold because my throat was parched.

What should I say?

I had prepared what to say, but I didn't know how to bring up the topic.

Astina moved to get it herself.

I was puzzled.

Why was she going herself?

Usually, she would have asked a maid to do it.

It was natural for the Persia family, which was almost a ducal family, to have maids for such chores.

But her going by herself just left me confused.

Astina brought back some hot tea for herself and water with ice for me.

"There are no maids in the house right now, so all I can offer is water."

"No maids?"

"Yeah, I gave them a little break."

"Even the maids for chores like this?"

"Yeah, everyone needs to rest. It was a bit much to give them time off during the coronation, so I sent them now."

"I see..."

After the coronation, Astina would also take a break, so she would need people to attend to her.

Astina, who always gives her best in everything she does, was taking her rest seriously as well.

"Anyway, this isn't what I came here to talk about, right?"

"Ah, yes. Shall we talk about work then?"

Astina and I started a serious conversation with documents laid out in front of us.

Talking about work made me feel a bit more at ease, but there was a hint of tension thinking about the hidden story I needed to bring up.

"Then, it's best to do it this way. Should the Persia territory support the food supply?"

"Right? We've always done it that way."

As time went by, we gradually wrapped up the work discussion.

"Thank you. This was very helpful."

"Sure."

The problem was that I couldn't find the right timing to bring up my topic.

Wouldn't it be too strange to mention love or marriage in the middle of a work conversation?

"Ha. Ha. Ha."

I laughed awkwardly and looked for Astina's reaction. Then, Astina looked at me with a pleased smile.

"Why do you look like that?"

Astina leaned her elbows on the desk and rested her chin on her hands.

She looked at me with warm eyes.

It was as if she found my hesitant demeanor amusing.

I carefully asked Astina.

"... do you know?"

"Ho-ho, know what?"

"Hmm..."

The one who taught me about jewel crafting was none other than Astina.

And if Astina, who runs a commercial territory, knew... she might have found out that I made a ring.

I looked at Astina with suspicion. Even as I stared, Astina just smiled broadly.

"So, don't you have something to say?"

"...Yes, I do."

"Then say it... no, wait. Just wait a moment."

Saying that, Astina started rummaging through her drawer. The item that came out of Astina's drawer was...

"...A recording stone?"

"Alright. Now you can say it. Ho-ho..."

Astina said with a big smile.

"Ah, no. Senior. Why the recording stone...?"

"If not this, then what should I use? It's a once-in-a-lifetime event."

"You knew, then..."

Astina shrugged her shoulders.

"How could I not know when you were asking so much about jewel crafting? In that regard, it was your mistake for not being more cautious."

Astina was unabashed.

Not that Astina did anything wrong.

It's not like her saying that would stop me from speaking my mind.

I swallowed hard and looked at Astina.

As I silently stared at Astina, she was somewhat awkward, her laughter subsided, and her face turned red.

I gathered my courage to speak, but the recording stone in front of me caught my eye.

"Could you please put away that recording stone?"

"No! Why are you hesitating so much! Just spit it out! This is frustrating...!"

"Ahem... Okay."

With that, I steadied myself again and began to speak.

"Astina."

"...Yes."

"...Would you marry me?"

As I said this, Astina's face turned as red as her hair.

The usually cool and composed Astina was nowhere to be found.

Instead, there was only a girl who had never been in love before.

"Ah, um, ahem, uh..."

Astina hesitated and lowered her head.

Then, she briefly looked up, our eyes met, and she quickly lowered her head again, only making a sighing noise.

"...You knew I was going to say this, didn't you?"

"I did know... but it's different when it actually happens...!"

"What's different...?"

"It's the mix of joy and embarrassment when imagination becomes reality..."

Astina spoke faster and more chatteringly than usual.

Of course, she still couldn't look me in the eyes. She just kept her head down and mumbled.

I watched Astina like this and quietly opened my mouth.

"Astina."

"Uh... Yes..."

Astina responded, and I spoke again.

"I love you."

"Uh..."

Astina shrank more and more. Seeing Astina turn into a little girl made me chuckle.

"Why do you keep reacting like that?"

"..."

Astina didn't say anything and covered her flushed face with her hands. She couldn't cover her beet-red ears and neck, though.

I teased Astina playfully.

"Senior, you have to answer."

"...Okay, I like it."

Astina replied in a voice that seemed to retreat into itself.

I teased her further.

"When you talk, you should look into the other person's eyes, Senior."

Astina quietly peered through her fingers. Her eyes were shaking, and it seemed like tears were about to form.

"Okay, I like it...!"

I smiled at Astina's reaction.

"Why are you so cute today when you're always so dignified?"

"Cute?"

"Yes, you're very cute. So cute, I want to bite you."

"Bite...???"

Astina's reaction to every word was cuter than ever before.

Of course, I might be biased, but what does it matter? Actually, I might even prefer it if she only looked beautiful in my eyes.

I wanted to enjoy this sight all to myself. Despite my wishes, Astina looked objectively beautiful at this moment.

Even in her plain leather clothes, even without any fancy decorations on her, she was more beautiful than ever before.

"What are you staring at like that!"

"What's wrong with it? I should etch this beautiful sight into my eyes. Oh, I don't even need just my eyes for that."

I looked at the recording stone laid out in front of me. I turned the recording stone, which was facing me, towards Astina.

"Look here."

"What, what... Put, put it away. Pu..."

"Come on, Astina wanted to capture my appearance too, right? I feel the same way."

Astina had dug her own grave.

"Smile now."

"Put it, put it away...!"

Astina flailed her arms, yelling at me. I just dodged her arms with a grin.

After teasing Astina for a bit...

"...Did you enjoy teasing me like that?"

"It's not about enjoying the teasing, but because you looked so pretty that I felt good."

"What... How can you say such things so easily...!"

"Right? It was a bit hard before, but once you do it, it becomes easy."

I had never expressed affection like this to anyone else.

Of course, being busy with other things played a part, but it also happened because I didn't keep at it.

But once I started, expressions of affection flowed. Or, maybe I had been holding back all along.

I had worried a lot and wondered if it was right for me to be with everyone.

Expressing affection to someone and then rejecting them would cause a lot of hurt. I was afraid of this.

"But it's nice. Saying it out loud feels somewhat refreshing."

"...But you."

Astina narrowed her eyes and looked at me. I tilted my head in response.

"Yes?"

"You didn't come here just to say that, did you?"

"...?"

I stared blankly at Astina and then widened my eyes.

I had been focused on confessing and had completely forgotten something important.

"A war hero like you shouldn't be so careless..."

"Ahem... That's something my wives can take care of."

"Wives..."

Yes. What I hadn't mentioned was whether it was okay to marry everyone together.

I originally planned to explain this while confessing, but I forgot because I was flustered.

I straightened myself up and looked at Astina again. Astina sighed and looked into my eyes. I asked with a smile removed from my face.

"So... can I be with everyone?"

Astina glared at me.

But it wasn't the look of someone who sees a person they dislike.

Though she was glaring, her eyes were filled with affection.

"Ah..."

"..."

"How would you feel if I dated another man?"

"...It would tear my heart apart. I would do whatever it takes to stop it."

I had already made up my mind about everything. I liked everyone. I had accepted that.

"So, how do you think I would feel?"

"...Probably similar."

"Similar, yes. But not to that extent."

At that, I widened my eyes.

"I knew to some extent. I was actually afraid of not being chosen. You could have chosen just one."

I looked at Astina with a bit of anxiety. Astina saw this and gave me a small smile.

"You don't need to make that face. My answer is simple."

"...?"

"Do as you wish. I won't actively stop you."

"...Really?"

"Yes. It doesn't seem like stopping you would work anyway. After giving it some thought, such a life might not be so bad."

Hearing that made me feel completely at ease. A warm feeling spread throughout my body.

"Astina!"

"Whoa!"

Feeling this, I rushed towards Astina.

"What is this...!"

Astina was tightly hugged in my arms, her eyes wide open.

Her face, which had just returned to its original color, reddened again.

I wanted to see Astina's expression, but I also didn't want to let go of the warmth of her body.

I quietly said, feeling Astina's warmth.

"Thank you."

My body was trembling slightly.

All the tension had been released, leaving me feeling a bit dazed.

Feeling this, Astina, who was surprised, raised her hand to my back.

"You must have been very anxious."

"How could I not be? I'm undertaking such a reckless challenge."

"Haven't you faced even more reckless challenges before?"

"This challenge was more nerve-wracking for me than those."

I said, laughing softly while still holding Astina. Astina gently patted my back.

"Give it your best shot. You still have 3 more to go, right?"

"Yes, I will try."

I stayed quietly in Astina's embrace for a while.

It was truly a comforting time while we were hugging. After a moment, I gently pushed Astina away from the hug. Then, holding Astina's hand, I spoke.

"I'll be going now."

"Are you busy?"

"Yes, there's a lot to prepare."

Astina gave a toothy smile. I brought my face close to Astina's. With a soft touch,

"!!!!!!"

It was a gentle bump.

Astina's eyes widened as she clutched her lips.

I smiled at her reaction and reached into my pocket.

"I have something for you."

Out of the pocket came a small ring.

A ring with a ruby, crafted by a jeweler, made especially for Astina.

I took Astina's hand and lifted it. Then, I carefully slid the ring onto her ring finger.

"Please, don't ever take off this ring."

I said and stepped back.

"I'll be going then."

I waved at a dazed Astina and headed out.

"Hehe..."

After Rudy left, Astina, lying on the bed, fiddled with her lips and looked at the ring on her hand.

She wore an uncharacteristically silly smile, continuously playing with the ring.

How many hours had passed? Astina, smiling contentedly, spoke up.

"Come in!"

She yelled out loud, but no sound came in response. Feeling something was off, Astina was about to yell again.

"Come in..."

That's when Astina realized.

There were no servants in the mansion. That's right.

Astina had forgotten one thing. The reason she had given all the servants a holiday.

Despite the empty house, Astina had just let Rudy go.

"This can't be..."

Astina rushed to the bathroom.

The bathtub was filled with water, warmed by a heat preservation spell. Everything was prepared for their first night together.

She had sent all the servants on holiday, despite the inconvenience.

The bathtub was ready with warm water.

And the master bedroom, unused by Astina, was beautifully decorated. Yet, Astina had just let Rudy go.

"This, this can't be...!"

Astina was caught off guard by Rudy's many advances and forgot her own plans.

Astina sighed deeply.

"...Is there no other way?"

The opportunity wasn't just for today.

Now that she was destined to be his wife, there would be almost endless time to be together with Rudy.

Astina soon looked at the bathtub with a small smile.

"The husband will take care of it."

The thought of taking the lead herself was fun, but imagining Rudy leading was equally entertaining.

"Since the bathwater is already made... I might as well use it."

With that, Astina undressed and stepped into the warm bathwater, and after the bath, she was able to sleep very comfortably.

However, there was a problem. The next day when Astina went to work.

"Ah, Lady Persia, welcome..."

Astina's female secretary was about to bow and greet her when her eyes saw something that should not have been seen.

The ruby ring on her ring finger.

It was on her ring finger. The meaning was...

The female secretary carefully lifted her head.

"Yes, good morning."

"!!!!!!!!!!!!!!"

The scent of roses wafting from her body and her face, more radiant than usual.

"Lady Persia...!!!"

"Hm?"

"Could it be... No, no, it's nothing."

Astina's secretary swallowed the words she wanted to say.

And thought to herself, 'Rudy and she have finally crossed the line! This is big news!'

Astina's secretary decided she needed to share this exciting news with everyone.

Chapter 303: Side Story The Bustling Harem Marriage Operation (3)

"The Duke of Persia has..."

"What? So, Rudy and she are an item now?"

"Shh! Shh! Keep your voice down."

"Oh, no. Then what about our Princess..."

"Hey! Hey!"

The maid who had spoken first pointed towards the corridor.

There, Rie was standing.

"Hem hem!"

"Did, did you cough? Good morning, Your Highness...!"

Rie stared at the two maids before speaking.

"It's not a good morning."

"Wha!"

"Gah..."

Though the maids looked shocked, Rie walked past them without another word.

Sigh...

Rie sighed.

She had already heard the rumors about Astina.

She couldn't know exactly what had happened.

All she knew was that they all had a conversation together.

While it seemed like no one else knew anything, Astina seemed to be in the know.

Had she known all along?

Had Rudy chosen Astina?

With these thoughts, Rie entered her office.

Then, she saw a letter on her desk.

"What's this then."

The letter on the desk was from Rudy.

It contained an invitation to dine together that evening.

Could it be...

Rie was overwhelmed with anxiety as she thought about the spreading rumors and the letter.

Was this meant to be a final goodbye?

That was the only conclusion she could draw.

Such thoughts made her heart ache.

'Maybe I should just not go.'

Would avoiding it make things any better?

Even with these thoughts...

Rie had no choice but to head to the place Rudy had set for their meeting.

Rudy had called Rie to a small restaurant in a quiet corner of the capital, away from the bustling preparations for the upcoming coronation ceremony.

"Huh?"

While waiting for Rudy, an unexpected person showed up.

"Unni?"

It was Yuni.

Rie was puzzled by Yuni's sudden appearance.

"Why are you here?"

"...Why are you here?"

They looked at each other, both with displeasure on their faces.

"I'm here because I have an appointment with Rudy."

Rie said, looking at Yuni.

Yuni was wearing a pink dress she usually wouldn't wear, as if trying to look good for someone.

Yuni narrowed her eyes and looked at Rie, then spoke.

"...Me too?"

"What?"

There was nothing about this in the letter.

Then why was someone else there?

The presence of another person at Rudy's meeting place upset them, but what really soured their mood was the rumor related to Astina.

Rie pondered deeply before her eyes widened in realization.

"Could it be..."

A dreadful thought crossed her mind.

Had he called them both here with the intention of settling everything at once?

Then, could Luna also be here?

As Rie was lost in thought,

"Oh, both of you made it?"

"...Rudy?"

"Ah, senior!"

Rudy, dressed sharply in a suit, appeared.

Yuni and Rie were surprised to see Rudy dressed up.

Rudy usually didn't dress up like this. He worked in research at the Magic Tower, and dressing up wasn't his style; he found it cumbersome.

"Shall we go in?"

"Huh?"

"...Why?"

Rie glanced around, looking puzzled.

"Did you only call the two of us?"

"Yeah. Ah, sorry I didn't tell you I invited two people. There was a reason."

Rudy bowed his head, sincerely apologizing.

The thought 'He didn't invite Luna?' crossed Rie's mind.

And seeing him genuinely apologizing.

Was this an attempt to cut us off?

Rie had many questions.

"Well, that happens. Shall we go in then?"

Yuni said this and clung to Rudy's arm.

"You, you!"

Rie was shocked by Yuni's action and looked at Rudy.

The Rudy she knew would have been flustered and pushed Yuni away.

"Let's go in."

But Rudy didn't do that.

He didn't push Yuni away and let her cling to his arm.

"????"

Rie was baffled by Rudy's behavior.

"Yep. ...Huh??"

Rie wasn't the only one with a confused expression.

Yuni, who had hooked her arm with Rudy's, also looked confused.

"Welcome."

As they entered the restaurant, a man who appeared to be the manager greeted them.

"A table has been prepared for you inside. Please, go ahead."

"Thank you."

Rudy responded with a bright smile.

Rie was puzzled by Rudy's demeanor.

Rie's face is well-known to everyone in the Empire.

Naturally, Yuni and Rudy were in the same situation.

Despite this, was it okay for them to be seen together by ordinary people?

If Rudy was to marry Astina, they shouldn't be seen together.

Dining with the future Emperor of the Empire and her sister?

And with the sister hooked arm in arm?

If they were really planning to marry Astina, such a scene shouldn't be shown to ordinary people.

'What is he thinking?'

"Please, this way."

The manager led them to a private room inside the restaurant.

A lavish meal was prepared there.

"Have a good time."

After greeting them, the manager left, and Rudy gestured towards the seats.

"Let's sit down."

Then, Yuni looked up at Rudy and spoke.

"I want to sit next to senior."

Yuni stated boldly.

And Rudy just shrugged his shoulders.

"Sure. Do as you please."

"Okay~."

'Hmm...?'

Rie looked at Rudy with a meaningful gaze.

"What? Something wrong?"

"No, nothing..."

Rie shook her head in response to Rudy's question but then stopped herself.

'Right, I need to figure out what Rudy is thinking.'

With that thought, Rie decided to speak up.

"No! I have something to say."

"Hm?"

Rie clenched her fist and looked at Rudy.

"I also want to sit next to you."

"Next to me?"

"Yes...! Next to you..."

Rie, although embarrassed, said what she needed to say.

Normally, Rudy would...

"Sure. Do as you wish."

"...Senior? Sister?"

Yuni reacted to Rudy's words.

Yuni looked back and forth between Rie and Rudy, her eyes wide with surprise.

"Did I suddenly enter another world? Or is this a dream?"

Yuni looked bewildered.

Rudy chuckled and tapped Yuni's head.

"What dream? Let's just eat."

So, the three of them ended up sitting side by side.

Yuni ate her meal with a puzzled face, glancing at Rudy and Rie.

Rudy ate with a pleased smile.

Rie was so lost in thought she couldn't even tell if the food was going into her mouth or her nose as she moved her utensils.

'What's going on? What is this? Is there something I don't know? Or is it really a dream, like Yuni said?'

As Rie was eating, Rudy stared at her intently.

"Hm?"

Rudy reached out to her.

He then tucked Rie's hair behind her ear.

"?!?!?!"

"You might eat your hair."

With warm eyes and a tender gesture, Rie's eyes widened.

Her face flushed hot, and her mind couldn't understand the situation.

After everything that happened with Astina...

Even trying to think about it calmly and objectively, it was a situation hard to understand. Rudy's affectionate actions brought Rie's thought process to a stop.

As Rie's eyes began to spin, Rudy looked at her warmly.

"Is something wrong?"

"No, no! Uh, nothing?"

"Really? Tell me if there's something. I'm worried."

"Gasp...!"

Under normal circumstances, such words from Rudy would have been enough to melt Rie.

Well, they still did.

"...Hehe. Uh..."

The corners of her mouth twitched, trying to form a foolish smile.

Despite her best efforts to control her expression, it didn't work well.

"...Unni, what kind of face is that?"

"What, what..."

The corners of her mouth were as raised as they could be, but kept trying to fall, creating a strange expression.

Even though Rie was making a strange face, Rudy's eyes were dripping with honey.

Yuni sighed as she looked at them both.

"I can't figure out what's going on here..."

In such an odd atmosphere, the three of them finished their meal.

"Oh, right."

After finishing the meal to some extent, Rudy looked back and forth between the two and started to speak.

"I've prepared something special."

"Prepared something?"

"Oh! Is it a gift?"

"Well, it is sort of a gift."

Yuni's eyes sparkled at Rudy's response.

"What is it? Is it something good?"

"Kind of? Just a moment."

Rudy got up from his seat and went towards a bag at one corner of the room.

'A gift...'

Yuni was filled with anticipation, but Rie harbored a sense of unease.

She was afraid that Rudy might suddenly drop a bombshell.

Rudy started rummaging through the bag, and Rie and Yuni watched him intently, each with their own thoughts.

"Here."

And what Rudy pulled out of the bag was

"A mask?"

It was a mask that could cover the face and a light hood.

Rie and Yuni stared blankly at it.

Rudy smiled and handed it to them.

"Here, put this on."

"This?"

"What are you planning?"

Rudy gestured with a meaningful look on his face.

"You'll see if you come."

Chapter 304: Side Story The Bustling Harem Marriage Operation (4)

"Wow..."

Yuni couldn't help but marvel as she looked around.

Rudy smiled at her reaction.

"Haven't had the chance to come out because of how busy it's been lately, huh?"

Rie opened her mouth in awe as she looked around.

"Here, have some skewers! Eat before you go!"

"It's not a festival without these...!"

"Hey you! Try this before you leave!"

The streets were bustling with a huge crowd and lively atmosphere.

Countless stalls were spread out along the roadside.

It truly was the scene of a festival.

"There's still some time left until the coronation ceremony..."

"I didn't know, but apparently, it's like this for almost a month."

The Emperor's coronation was the Empire's biggest event.

A major celebration that occurred roughly every 50 to 60 years.

People from every region would gather in the capital to witness the Emperor's coronation, a once-in-a-lifetime event, putting aside their work to enjoy the festival.

"Everyone's gathering to celebrate you becoming the Emperor. It wouldn't do if you didn't enjoy yourself."

Rudy, wearing a mask, was smiling, though his expression was hard to see.

"But, won't wearing this kind of outfit at the festival arouse suspicion?"

Rie asked, tapping her clothes and mask.

"With so many people coming from different regions, this level of oddity isn't even considered suspicious."

Every region brought its own crowd.

With each region having its own culture, and thus a variety of outfits, people didn't pay much mind to those wearing masks or hoods.

Rudy grabbed the wrists of Yuni and Rie, standing on either side of him.

"Huh?"

"Senior?"

Holding their wrists, Rudy led the way, saying,

"Shall we go have some fun?"

Rie and Yuni were pulled into the crowd by Rudy.

Despite the crowd, they didn't get separated because Rudy was holding onto their wrists tightly.

"Senior! Let's go see that!"

"Alright, let's go."

Yuni quickly adapted to the situation.

She looked around at the various stalls and gradually started dragging Rudy and Rie along.

"Look over there!"

"Yeah, yeah. That place?"

Yuni led Rudy and Rie to a souvenir shop spread out on the roadside.

"My Lord! Do you see anything you like?"

As the merchant welcomed them, Yuni smiled and browsed through the souvenirs laid out on the mat.

Then she said,

"I'll take everything here!"

"...What?"

"Everything! All of it!"

Yuni's declaration surprised not only the merchant but also Rudy and Rie.

"Hey, you should only buy what you really like."

"What? I like everything here."

"But... if you buy everything, how will you carry it? And others might want to buy something too..."

Rudy made this point, and the quick-witted merchant waved his hand.

"My Lord! I'll pack everything up for you. Just give me the address, and I'll have it delivered!"

"Oh! That sounds great!"

Yuni smiled brightly and looked at Rudy.

Rie made a 'hmpf' sound at his side.

"Ah..."

Rudy sighed and looked at the merchant.

It was unnecessary to lecture on such a day.

After all, buying everything from these street stalls wouldn't make much of a dent in Rudy's wallet, so he decided to indulge Yuni's request.

"How much is it?"

"Uh... Just 25 gold will do! Where should I send it?"

At the merchant's question, Yuni promptly responded.

"Just take it to the Royal palace."

"...What?"

"To the Royal palace. The knights will take care of it if you give it to them."

"???"

"....."

Rudy quietly approached the puzzled merchant and said,

"Just pack it up roughly and deliver it to a knight at the Royal palace. You know what I mean, right?"

The merchant's eyes widened as he nodded vigorously.

"Ah, understood. Thank you so much. It's an honor, should I at least greet..."

"No need for formalities. We're out incognito, after all. Oh, here's the money."

Rudy paid the merchant, bowing slightly as he did so.

As they moved away from the stall, Rie asked,

"But why buy stuff here? You don't need these kinds of things."

"They might come in handy somewhere~. Maybe for a disguise later on~. Right, senior?"

"Yeah, yeah. It's a good day for it."

"...Hmph."

Rie glared at Rudy, who wasn't siding with her, and Rudy awkwardly avoided eye contact with a forced smile.

Yuni watched the two of them and chuckled playfully.

"Unni, are you upset because senior took my side?"

"Upset? I'm not..."

"Ah, you are upset."

"I said I'm not!"

As Rie pressed her lips together muttering, Rudy smiled.

"Shall we go somewhere else?"

"Yeah..."

Rie responded to Rudy's suggestion and was about to move on when she felt something warm in her hand.

"Huh?"

Rudy's hand had slipped into hers.

Rudy, who had been holding onto their waists, now firmly held Rie's hand.

Rie looked at Rudy with a puzzled face, and Rudy looked back with a smiling face.

"Hmm..."

Rie blushed slightly and averted her gaze.

"Senior! Hurry up!"

"Okay, coming."

Urged by Yuni, Rudy looked at Rie.

"Shall we go?"

Rie didn't respond but moved along willingly.

After wandering around for a while, the crowd started to thin, and the street stalls began to close.

"Today was so much fun~!"

"Huh?"

Yuni clung to Rudy and said this, and Rudy cocked his head in response.

Rudy looked puzzled, prompting Yuni to ask,

"Why?"

"We haven't even reached the main event yet."

"It's not over?"

"Is there more to do?"

Rie joined in the conversation.

The shops were closing, and people were heading home.

It seemed like there was nothing left to do here.

"Come this way for a moment."

Rudy walked slowly, with Yuni and Rie following him.

He led them to a bench with a clear view of the sky.

"It's about to start."

"What is?"

"Just wait."

Rudy glanced up at the sky for a moment.

Just then,

"It's starting."

Following Rudy's words, small fireworks shot into the sky.

"Ah..."

"Fireworks?"

Boom——

The small firework exploded in the sky with a refreshing sound.

Fireworks. Literally, flowers of fire bloomed in the sky.

Bang! Bang!

Dozens of fireworks soared up.

Bright fireworks embroidered the dark sky.

Rudy smiled as he watched the fireworks, then turned to look at Yuni and Rie.

"Do you guys like fireworks?"

Both opened their mouths and nodded.

"That's why we're here."

Rudy knew from before that Rie liked fireworks, and it was natural to think Yuni, her sister, would enjoy them too.

Rie watched the fireworks bursting behind Rudy.

Then she turned her head to look at Yuni beside her.

Yuni was smiling softly back at Rie.

Rie's fondness for fireworks stemmed from a childhood memory.

Watching fireworks with their parents before any royal or political disputes began.

That memory deeply resonated with Rie.

A time when the family was close and harmonious.

Though various reasons had driven Yuni and her apart, those memories remained precious.

It was the most carefree and untroubled time in Rie's life.

The sound of fireworks echoed in their ears.

Despite the loud noise, it felt incredibly serene.

No voices could be heard, only the spectacular fireworks filled their view.

"This is nice..."

Rie whispered quietly.

Yuni leaned on Rie's shoulder.

"Really..."

As if they had never quarreled, they looked just like loving sisters.

Rudy smiled, watching them.

This was the moment Rudy had hoped for.

For some time, these two had been at odds, unable to get along.

Whatever the reason, there was nothing good about them being on bad terms.

So, he deliberately invited them out.

Wandering through the bustling market.

And finally, bringing them closer together by showing them the fireworks.

Rudy slipped his hand into his pocket, waiting for the fireworks to end.

As the fireworks were about to finish,

Rudy sneakily glanced at Rie and Yuni.

They were leaning on each other, looking at the sky.

Rudy slowly approached them.

"Hm?"

"It's over now..."

As Yuni and Rie were about to speak,
Rudy knelt on one knee in front of them.

"?!?!"

"What, what's that pose for...!"

"What do you think?"

Rudy pulled a small box from his pocket.

"Ah..."

Rie sighed upon seeing the box.

From Rudy's posture, it was clear what was inside.

A ring.

Nobody knew what had happened with the rumors about Astina, but given the current situation, it was certain there was a ring inside.

But who was its intended recipient?

There were two of them here.

Rie sneakily glanced at Yuni beside her.

If she were to receive the ring...

Or if Yuni were to...

Neither option was what Rie wanted.

Rudy, unaware of Rie's feelings or not, tried to open the small box.

Thud!

"...?"

"Unni?"

Rie quickly moved to stop Rudy's hand from opening the box.

"Not now... Don't do it..."

"...Huh?"

"Don't do it!"

"What are you talking about?"

Rudy was confused as his attempt to open the box was thwarted.

"Later... It doesn't have to be now. Let's talk first..."

"Oh, why? The timing is..."

"Just don't do it...!"

Rudy tried to remove Rie's hand,

And Rie tried to physically stop Rudy's hand.

Confused, Rudy quickly tried to open the box, but ended up dropping it.

"Ah!"

The box fell to the ground.

Bang!!!!!!!!

Just then, a very large firework exploded behind Rudy.

"...?"

"Huh?"

However, Rie and Yuni's attention didn't shift to the large firework.

Only the fallen box and the two rings on the ground were in their view.

"....."

Rudy looked back and forth between the rings and the fireworks with a dismayed face.

"Why... are there two?"

Rie exclaimed with wide eyes.

She couldn't make sense of the situation.

'Two, does one mean he intended to wear one himself? No, no... Normally, when giving such a ring, doesn't one not wear it themselves...?'

Rie's gaze shifted to the ring finger on Rudy's hand.

A ring was indeed snugly fitted on his ring finger.

Meaning, there were three rings present.

As Rie was trying to figure this out on her own,

'Damn it...'

Rudy looked at the rings with the face of someone who had lost everything.

Rudy missed the timing and even dropped the rings on the ground...

The romantic atmosphere turned awkward.

Yuni, with a confused expression, looked at the two before bending down to pick up the rings.

"What are you two doing?"

"....."

"....."

Then, she slipped one of the rings onto her ring finger.

"Wow! This is beautiful. So, this one is for..."

Yuni handed the remaining ring to Rie.

"Ah...?"

"This is yours, right, unni?"

"Uh, yeah..."

"Unni, try it on."

"Uh, okay?"

"Ah, really. Should I help you? Oh! Right, right. I shouldn't do it."

Yuni removed the ring she had put on and, with a bright smile, offered it to Rudy.

"It should be you who puts it on."

Rudy snapped back to reality at her words.

"Right. I should be the one to do it."

Gently, Rudy took Yuni's hand.

And he slid the ring onto her finger.

After putting on the ring, Rudy looked at Yuni's face.

"Aren't you going to say anything?"

Yuni teased with a smirk.

"Hmm..."

Rudy cleared his throat and looked directly into Yuni's eyes.

"Yuni, will you marry me?"

".....!!"

Yuni's expression turned from shock to one that looked like she was about to cry.

It was a face Rudy had never seen before. Yuni had always been sly and managed to handle everything with a sly grin.

He had not expected such a reaction from her.

"Yuni, are you okay?"

"I'm, I'm fine..."

Yuni stammered, her expression flustered.

Rudy smiled and approached Yuni.

"You look like you're about to cry."

"I wasn't going to cry!"

Yuni's voice was tinged with a cry.

"So, will you marry me?"

".....Yes. I'd be glad to. If you're asking, how could I refuse?"

Yuni tried to sound playful and sly as usual, but her voice, mixed with tears, lacked her typical ease.

She was just trying to appear as natural as possible, which was endearing.

Rudy smiled and said,

"Thank you. For accepting."

As Rudy was looking at Yuni,

"Hey..."

A voice came from the side.

It was Rie, her face flushed.

Avoiding Rudy's gaze, she extended her hand.

"Me too..."

Rie had now grasped the whole situation.

Rudy took Rie's extended hand.

"Even though you said not to open the box."

"...I didn't know, that's why."

Rie blushed at Rudy's teasing.

"Anyway."

Rudy, holding the remaining ring, knelt on one knee in front of Rie.

Rie, who was soon to become the Emperor, was used to seeing people kneel before her.

Vassals and knights had knelt before her several times, swearing their loyalty.

However, this moment felt entirely different from any before.

Her heart pounded as she found it hard to meet Rudy's gaze.

Rudy presented the ring to Rie.

"Will you marry me?"

Rie responded in a barely audible voice,

"...Yes."

Her voice was more tense than ever.

Rudy smiled and slipped the ring onto Rie's finger.

"Thank you,"

"....."

Just then, fireworks erupted behind Rudy.

Bang——!

Boom, boom!!

"Wow...!"

"Ah..."

It was the biggest firework display they had ever seen.

Rie and Yuni exclaimed in admiration again.

"I might have messed the start, but I somehow managed to finish it well..."

Rudy let out a sigh of relief, talking to himself.

Despite a somewhat messy proposal, it ended successfully.

After completing all their plans, Rie, Yuni, and Rudy were about to head back.

Rudy led the way, followed by Rie.

At the end, Yuni, who had been sitting till the last moment, stared blankly at the ring and then realized something.

"Senior, you gave one of these to Astina too, right?"

Rudy, who was leading, suddenly stopped.

"Oh, right. That rumor about Astina..."

Yuni's comment made Rie put all the pieces together.

The rumors about Astina.

And the truth behind those rumors.

"Ah..."

Rudy let out a regretful sigh.

He realized,

The brief interlude during the fireworks,

Why it was there, what he had planned to do during that time.

He had forgotten to explain everything due to Rie's sudden action.

"....."

"...Senior?"

"...Rudy."

Cold sweat ran down Rudy's back.

Quietly, he turned around.

Yuni and Rie were squinting, staring at him.

The next day,

At the Magic Tower, a girl was staring blankly up at the sky, puzzled.

"...What?"

That girl was Luna.

She was puzzled because of what she had heard people saying.

"Hey, Princess Rie and Princess Yuni got married."

"What? Both of them? With whom?"

"With the same person, they say."

"Really? That's quite unusual. So, are there going to be two weddings before the coronation ceremony? Didn't they say there's a wedding in the Persia family too? You know, the one who recently took the position."

"Oh, that person is marrying the same person too."

"...What?"

Luna mused over these words, then quietly bowed her head, clutching it and shouting,

"...What?????"

Chapter 305: Side Story The Bustling Harem Marriage Operation (5)

"Now, I just need to talk to Luna."

I had spoken to everyone except Luna.

Luna was the only person left.

I sat in the lab, looking towards the door.

Just a short walk through this door, and I would find Luna's lab.

But the closer the location, the harder it became to approach.

Luna and I saw each other's faces every day.

Because we interacted so routinely, I worried about how to start the conversation.

"It feels a bit too casual to just bring it up... But then, it seems too serious to suddenly make it a big deal..."

I thought hard about it.

How could I bring it up without it being awkward?

I couldn't come up with a good idea like I did with the others.

As for Luna's hobbies, all she did was research magic.

She didn't have any particular hobbies.

But if you ask what she likes, she enjoys eating?

Luna eats well, but she looks happier than usual when she eats something delicious.

"Maybe I should look for a good restaurant?"

Sitting still wouldn't give me any good ideas.

So, I decided to move around and look for one.

If I found a restaurant first and looked around the area, maybe something would come to mind.

"What happened..."

Luna had waited all day after hearing the rumor.

She didn't go to see Rudy; she just stayed in her lab alone.

But Rudy didn't come.

"Something... something must have gone wrong?"

Rudy was a perfectionist in work matters but often a klutz in daily life.

This time too, it must have been that Rudy forgot to tell her...

Suddenly!

"That can't be!!!"

Luna stood up abruptly.

How could she have forgotten something like this?

Of course, there was a misunderstanding.

Rudy was unaware of the rumors that he had gotten engaged to someone else.

The rumors started because he hadn't officially announced any marriage, nor was he seen going out with anyone.

"Sigh..."

Luna was left alone in a state of gloom.

Knock, knock.

"Lady Luna?"

"Who is it?"

"It's your maid, Cirelle. A visitor has come for you. I was informed at the front gate."

"A visitor?"

"They said it's Lady Riku and Lady Ena..."

Luna's eyes widened, and she hastily opened the door.

"Oh, it's really you! Where are you now?"

Luna ran quickly to the front gate.

There, Luna's close friends, Riku and Ena, were waiting.

"Riku! Ena!"

"Luna! It's been so long!!!"

"Luna, you haven't changed at all."

The last time Luna saw Riku and Ena was at the Graduation Ceremony, but it had been nearly a year since they had spent time together.

"How have you been!"

Ena responded with a smile to this question.

"I went back to the place I was interning at."

"Ah~! To the researcher side?"

Ena was dressed in a robe, typical for scholars.

Ena, who had always been suited for research, had become a researcher affiliated with the Academy's Alchemy Department.

"What about you, Riku?"

"I'm just traveling around~. After rolling around in the Academy, I needed some time off~."

"Sigh. Do you know how hard it is to get a job through the Academy's placement... Just go back to where you were interning."

"Pfft! I can't waste my youth in such a place! I'm going to enjoy being unemployed a bit longer!"

"Ahaha... That's so like you, Riku."

Luna laughed awkwardly at Riku and Ena's conversation.

"Speaking of which."

"Right, right! Luna!"

Both of them turned to Luna, their eyes filled with curiosity.

"“What happened with Rudy?””

Both asked simultaneously, as if they had agreed on it beforehand.

"Rudy's marriage news has been quite the talk lately, hasn't it?"

"Yeah. That's why I came."

"....."

Luna slowly looked at them and then made a gloomy face.

"What should I do?"

After guiding Riku and Ena to the reception room, Luna chatted with them.

From how she had been doing lately to why they came to visit.

The reason Riku and Ena came was somewhat obvious.

The famous story of Rudy's marriage among the nobility.

They rushed over after hearing the news.

"He didn't say anything to you?"

Riku and Ena looked incredulous after hearing the full story from Luna.

"What! How can that be! Where is Rudy now! I'm going to go straight to him and..."

"Riku, wait."

Ena calmed the fuming Riku and pondered.

"But why wouldn't he say anything to you?"

Luna quietly opened her mouth in response to Ena's question.

"I don't know either."

Luna's affection for Rudy wasn't something new.

Rudy hadn't responded to it and was planning to marry someone else.

That was the strangest fact.

"As far as I know, Rudy isn't that bad of a guy."

"That's true..."

"He might be a bit clueless, but not to the extent that such a situation would arise."

"Right..."

"I think there might be some misunderstanding."

Luna had somewhat guessed this might be the case.

"So, the rumor might be false?"

"It doesn't seem so. If it were really a false rumor, the royal family or the Persia dukedom wouldn't just sit quietly."

"Then...?"

"It seems you're indeed in a very disadvantageous and urgent situation."

It was a thunderbolt out of the blue.

"I guess I really..."

"But!"

As Luna was about to despair and tear up, Ena reached out her hand.

"It's also important that it's not over yet."

"...Not over yet?"

"Rudy hasn't confessed to you, but that doesn't mean he's rejected you."

If Rudy really didn't have feelings for Luna, he would have apologized before.

But he didn't.

This meant there was still a chance for Luna.

"So, Luna! What should you do in this situation!"

Caught off guard by Ena's sudden question, Luna tilted her head.

"What should I do?"

That's when Riku excitedly raised her hand.

"Miss Ena! I have the answer!"

"Yes, Riku! Let's hear it!"

"The answer is for Luna to make the first move!"

Ena smiled at Riku's response.

"Luna, you heard that?"

Luna bit her lip quietly.

Nothing changes if you just sit still.

You can't wait forever for Rudy's answer.

Gather your courage and make the first move...

"...I'll speak up first."

The next day.

"Luna?"

Luna went straight to Rudy's office.

"Ru, Rudy! Would you like to have dinner with me? Tonight...!"

"Oh, that works out perfectly."

"...Huh?"

"I found a nice restaurant. Want to go there?"

"Oh, yes! Tha, that sounds great. I mean..."

"Great, then let's meet in front of the Magic Tower after work. Okay?"

"Uh, yes!"

Luna was a bit startled by Rudy's suggestion.

Originally, she had planned to take Rudy to a restaurant she had found.

She intended to proceed with the plan at a nice place recommended by Ena and Riku, but she ended up nodding along when Rudy made his sudden proposal.

Due to Luna's nature, she didn't know how to refuse an offer, hence this development.

But it wasn't a complete derailment of her plan, so no big issue there.

After all, the choice of restaurant wasn't the most important part.

Time quickly passed, and it was time to leave work.

"Oh, Luna, you're here? Finished your work?"

"I, I did...!"

That was a lie. Luna hadn't managed to do any work during her shift.

With such a big event ahead, it was impossible to focus on work.

She just opened and closed the closet in one corner of the lab over and over again.

"Shall we go then?"

"Yes!"

Luna responded, fidgeting with her clothes.

The dress she was wearing had been chosen after much deliberation during work hours.

It was a dress saved for an important occasion, and wearing it felt somewhat uncomfortable since she hadn't worn it many times before.

Of course, the current situation added to this discomfort.

She had to confess to Rudy today.

That's why she kept fidgeting with her dress, wanting to look as pretty as possible.

"Here we are."

Lost in thought and adjusting her dress, they arrived at the restaurant Rudy had mentioned.

"This place..."

It was one of the most renowned restaurants in the Empire for its delicious food.

It was very famous, highly praised by high-ranking nobles.

"This place is incredibly expensive, right? And hard to book..."

"It's fine. I've already made the reservation, and money is not a problem."

"But still..."

Rudy smiled and pushed Luna's back gently.

"Let's go in. We're going to miss our reservation time."

"Uh, okay..."

Pushed by Rudy, Luna entered the restaurant.

"Wow..."

Luna exclaimed in awe.

The furniture inside seemed to be made of gold, shining brightly, and the soup and salad laid out were too beautiful to eat.

"Can we really eat this? It looks too precious to touch."

Rudy playfully messed up the food on his plate and took a bite.

"Wow, this is so delicious."

Watching Rudy, Luna swallowed her saliva.

Though the food was beautifully decorated, it was incredibly appetizing.

Luna closed her eyes tight and first touched the soup.

"...!"

The perfect temperature, the umami swirling in her mouth, and the subtle aroma of mushrooms spreading gently.

The small pieces of meat on top of the soup doubled its flavor.

After one spoonful, Luna began to devour the soup eagerly.

Rudy asked Luna.

"Is it good?"

"Mhm!"

Luna nodded vigorously, her mouth full of food.

"We'll prepare the next course."

As soon as they finished their bowls, the courses continued to arrive one after another.

"Mmm~~~!"

Luna ate with a blissful expression, indicating it was delicious, and Rudy smiled happily watching her.

Thus, they finished their meal.

"Did you enjoy the meal?"

"Yeah, I'm full..."

Luna smiled happily, rubbing her stomach.

Then, Luna realized why she was here and what she had to do.

"Ah..."

She had intended to at least mention marriage during the meal.

But the meal was already over.

She had been so engrossed in the food that time just flew by.

'What an idiot!'

Luna inwardly scolded herself, looking upset.

Seeing Luna's troubled expression, Rudy tilted his head.

"Luna, is something wrong?"

"No, it's nothing..."

Seeing her satisfied with the meal but then suddenly distressed was puzzling.

"Ha. Ha. Rudy, isn't the weather nice?"

It was odd.

Talking about the weather in a room without a single window.

And speaking in such a mechanically stiff manner made it clear.

Why is she acting like this...

Rudy slipped his hand into his pocket, fidgeting with the ring he had prepared earlier.

'Maybe today's not the day...''

Luna didn't seem to be in good condition, and attempting anything now wouldn't yield any good results.

"Ha. Ha."

Luna awkwardly laughed, possibly aware of Rudy's thoughts.

'Now that we've finished eating...'

Rudy looked at Luna's empty plate and started getting ready to leave.

"Shall we go now?"

"Go? Where to?"

"Home. We've finished eating, and it's awkward just sitting here."

"Oh, no!"

Luna abruptly stood up from her seat.

Rudy looked at her, puzzled.

Realizing her own reaction, Luna quickly tried to cover it up.

"Like Rudy said, it's awkward just sitting here... Let's, let's go somewhere else. Yeah! Somewhere else!"

"Somewhere else?"

Rudy had a place in mind for after dinner.

He had planned to give her the ring there, but since he intended to give it to her on another day, they couldn't go to that planned place now.

After a moment of thought, Rudy smiled at Luna.

"How about we take a walk outside?"

After settling the bill, Luna and Rudy stepped outside.

They walked the streets in silence.

Even though it was evening and the streets were dark, the moonlight was bright enough to walk without any problems.

During their walk, both of them were lost in their thoughts.

'What to do. What to do.'

Luna wanted to create a favorable situation, but in these circumstances, finding a good solution seemed impossible.

Rudy looked at her with a concerned face.

'...Why is Luna acting like this.'

Luna fidgeted with an anxious expression.

She neither looked at him directly nor opened her mouth to speak.

Rudy couldn't understand the situation.

He hadn't spread any rumors about marrying someone else, so he couldn't imagine that Luna had heard such news.

'We're walking because Luna wanted to...'

It seemed best to send Luna home.

She looked anxious for some reason.

"Luna?"

"Uh, yes!"

"The wind's getting chilly, should we start heading back?"

"Go back? Why? Is something wrong?"

"No, it's not that..."

That's when Luna thought.

'Rudy wants to go home...'

Would Yuni, Rie, and Astina be waiting at home?

Maybe they had already enjoyed their meal together.

Would Rudy end up eating twice? Misunderstandings led to more misunderstandings, and Luna became more confused.

And then.

"Luna?"

"Ugh... Mmph..."

She started to tear up.

"Lu, Luna. Why..."

"Wahh!!!"

Overwhelmed by her emotions, Luna burst into tears.

The situation was already too sad, and the thought of Rudy starting a married life without her was unbearably painful.

"Rudy! Don't leave me behind!"

Luna, with tears streaming down her face, rushed towards Rudy.

"Uh, what?"

Rudy was taken aback by the situation and looked at Luna, who had suddenly thrown herself into his arms.

Although he wasn't sure what had happened, he hugged Luna and patted her back.

"Sob... Sniff..."

"It's okay. Everything's going to be okay..."

As he comforted her, Luna gradually stopped crying.

"Shall we sit down for a bit?"

Rudy led the tear-streaked Luna to a bench and sat her down, then crouched in front of her.

"What happened today? You've been anxious the whole time."

"No, it's not... Sob. It wasn't anything..."

"Really? Can you tell me why you cried then?"

Luna looked at Rudy, who was gazing at her with genuine concern.

After bursting into tears like that, she couldn't just beat around the bush.

"...I heard a rumor."

Luna quietly began to explain.

Why she cried.

What she had heard.

"Already a rumor..."

After hearing the whole story, Rudy sighed.

"So, sorry... It's all my fault..."

At that, Rudy shook his head and spoke firmly.

"No, it's not your fault, Luna. If anything, it's mine. I should have been aware of such rumors spreading."

Understanding the whole situation made Rudy realize why Luna had acted that way.

Then, there was no reason to postpone things any further.

Rudy reached into his pocket, pulling out a small ring.

"I'm sorry. I've been too late."

"This is..."

"I wanted to say it in a better place, at a better time. But it seems too late now, so I'll give it to you now."

Rudy gently took Luna's hand.

"Can I really accept this? If you're doing this just because I cried..."

"Do you think I'd propose just because you cried?"

"I'm a crybaby... I'm not as bold as Rie or Astina..."

"That's you, Luna. And I like you just the way you are."

"My face is a mess right now..."

Rudy smiled, lifting his hand to wipe away her tears.

"A mess? You're only beautiful."

At those words, Luna pressed her lips tightly together.

"Sob..."

"Why are you trying to cry again?"

As he spoke, Rudy slipped the ring onto Luna's finger.

And said,

"I love you."

Hearing those words, Luna swallowed the tears that threatened to come out again.

And responded,

"I, I love you too."

It was a confession full of twists and turns.

Yet, the outcome was positive, and so Rudy's confession operation came to an end.

"Ahem."

The officiant, Cromwell, cleared his throat and called Rudy forward.

"Groom, Rudy Astria."

"Yes."

"Do you vow to love your brides forever?"

"Yes, I will love them."

Cromwell turned his head to look at the brides standing beside him.

"Bride, Rie Von Ristonia."

"...Yes."

"Bride, Yuni Von Ristonia."

"Yes~."

"Bride, Astina Persia."

"Yes."

"Bride, Luna Railer."

"Yes, yes!"

Cromwell called out to all the brides and let out a chuckle.

It felt somewhat like sending off sons and daughters in marriage.

Immersed in sentiment, Cromwell spoke.

"Do you vow to love Rudy Astria forever?"

Everyone in white wedding dresses looked at Rudy beside them.

At their husband Rudy Astria, clad in a black suit...

Rudy smiled at everyone and responded to the officiant's question.

"“Yes, we will love him forever.”"

"Then I declare in this ceremony that all of you are now united in marriage."

Applause and cheers erupted in the wedding hall following Cromwell's declaration.

However, those standing in front didn't hear such sounds.

They only had eyes for each other.

Rudy smiled at them all and spoke again.

"I will love you forever."

[raei: And that's it guys! My first ever novel translation complete! Thanks for everyone that stayed all the way. I unfortunately stopped reading comments halfway through because I just got so busy. Would probably help if I made something that just sent all new comments to me rather than having to go to chapter page each time. Another thing in my to do list I guess.

I also have a novel completing in 2 days and another in a month... I've been translating for a year now so it's nice to have some completed novels under my belt. I'm picking up some new novels I'll be releasing with the completion of this and my second novel so check them out if you're interested! One is a harem as well.

I hope you enjoyed the novel, the tl quality has come a long way... I wonder if anyone remembers the dumb mistakes I made in the first bunch of chaps... and then the huge confusion over Jefrin's gender...

Anyways, Raei out! (¯—¯)\`]